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虞薇 / 作品

我的爸爸来到了这个鬼域村，
却和我想像中的不一样……

Information

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Split Zone No.13

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Split Zone No.13 novel is a popular light novel covering Adventure, Fantasy, and Horror genres. Written by the Author Yu Wei. 323 chapters have been translated and translation of all chapters was completed.

Summary

When Li Shen's second personality acts out, her consciousness is sent to a strange place called Split Zone No.13. She is then informed that she can only return home after unraveling the truth.

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Chapter 1

1

If You're Gonna Die, Die With Style

I am Li Shen, female, 23 . It's been one year and 13 days since I've died .

That's right, you didn't misread that . What I'm saying is that I've been dead for more than a year .

One year ago, I was just a very ordinary schizophrenia patient staying at a psychiatric hospital . Today, one year later, I was another kind of thing .

Calling me a bloody witch wouldn't be undue . Like the sexy, flirty enchantresses in the online games that guys liked playing, my blood-red, floor-length dress perfectly outlined my figure . The long, red skirt flowed down to my ankles, swaying every which way as I moved . There was always a pair of red, 10cm heels on my feet, but still, I was able to run effortlessly under the night sky . Even without any wind, my red, wavy hair danced behind me .

On nights like these, I often ran through the streets, like an out of control cheetah . Sometimes, when I was very fast, it looked like a streak of red light flying by .

I'd grown used to using this type of passionate, wild running . Every night, I used this seemingly cruel yet beautiful method to release all the stifling feelings pressing down on me . Even though I wanted to escape, I've been unable to make sense of it all . But after a year in this place, deep down, I knew that I was no longer human . I might not be any kind of creature for that matter, not even the ones that only existed in myths and stories . I'd simply become a lonely, misty presence .

Every time I recalled that, a trace of helplessness and sadness passed over me .

On this day, as on days before, I ran crazily through the dark streets of the city . But in my mind, I couldn't help reflecting back on the scene one year ago, when I first arrived here .

One year ago, I was an ordinary third-year college student . If I had to give a reason for how I was different from everyone else, then it would be that I suffered from double identity schizophrenia . Though my personality had always been a bit out of the ordinary, my mental illness wasn't very serious . There were times when I was a bit strange, a bit obsessive-compulsive, or slightly more emotional than others, but these things didn't greatly affect my day to day life .

But one day, this illness that I'd mostly left on its own, suddenly turned my world upside down, like an evildoer who'd been plotting away in the dark .

That day, through whatever stimulus, my second identity suddenly erupted . In just one night, my person was taken over by this other identity, and I plunged a knife into the chest of a fourth-year student that I'd been crushing on for many years . Regarding what happened before and after the incident, I don't remember a thing . All I knew was that right after the knife in my hand stabbed my senior, I fainted . When I regained consciousness, I was lying down inside a psychiatric hospital .

My doctor was an explosively handsome biracial man, Chinese and American mixed though his features were a bit more Chinese . His hair was black, and his eyes weren't entirely blue, but because he was mixed, he still stood out against other people . As I admired his appearance, he told me that I'd personally killed my beloved senior . And then, I closed my eyes and everything seemed to go dark .

I'd loved him so much, and yet, because of my schizophrenia, I plunged a knife into his heart . Before I could tell him sweet words like, "I'll love you until the end of time, and we'll be together 'til death do we part," my mind decided to prove that "I'd love you even after your death . "

My memory of reality stopped around there . The two well-endowed nurses held me down in my frantic seizing, as the handsome doctor jabbed into my slender, pale arm with a large needle .

After the needle kissed my skin, I quickly lost consciousness . And some unknown time later, when I woke up, I was already in this ghastly place that I'm now stuck in .

I remember that when I woke up, I was standing in the middle of the city . I was standing up, just as I am now, and then I suddenly woke up .

I remember that when I woke up, I was standing in the middle of the city . I was standing up, just as I am now, and then I suddenly woke up .

The sky in this city wasn't blue, but gray . There was no sun, but the sky appeared to be lit up by some unknown source .

When I opened my eyes, all I could see was that there were people walking to and fro around me . The first person to walk into my line of vision was an old man .

He was an ordinary old man, except when it came to his head .

My eyes were on his head, and they slowly widened . A fear suddenly rushed into my heart, the kind of fear you'd feel if you woke up to see a monster in front of you .

My fear stemmed from the fact that he was missing the top of his skull .

That's right, his head was missing a piece, just like the Japanese woman who had her head chopped off in Kill Bill or like the man who had his head cut off by Hannibal in Hannibal . Because the man was shorter than me, I could even see the squirming brain inside of his exposed skull . There was blood too .

And so, naturally, I shrieked out, "Ah——!!" From my abdomen up to the top of my head, the sound quickly morphed into a dolphin's squeal, echoing through the street . Even I was alarmed by the sound . I felt the top of my

head start trembling, and I suddenly had the impulse to reach up, to check if my head was still intact .

My dolphin shriek was accompanied by another similar, but slightly deeper, shout, “Ah——!!” It was the old man screaming . Because his voice wasn’t as high-pitched as mine, my scream mostly drowned him out .

He seemed even more alarmed than me, like he’d seen a ghost while looking at me .

He seemed even more alarmed than me, like he’d seen a ghost while looking at me .

“Why are you screaming?! I should be the one screaming!” My whole body was shaking as I extended my hand, my trembling finger pointing to his head .

“No, no . I just haven’t seen a living person here in a long time, so I was a bit surprised . Young lady, don’t be afraid...” The old man’s eyes suddenly started to leak with, what appeared to be, tears as he looked at me pitifully .

My lips twitched and my entire body felt unwell . I didn’t know how I should have been interpreting his words .

As my body trembled and thoughts swirled around my mind, I seemed to suddenly realize something . Panicked, I raised my head to look around me . At the passing figures . The people .

And then I was overcome with a disorienting feeling of wanting to face-plant onto the ground .

They were various shapes, with various types of dress . Some were in period garb, others in modern clothing . Some looked like superhuman beings, and others looked like groups of zombies . There were even creatures that looked like human-animal hybrids . And were those vampires? Was that a large Avatar-like creature? There were many other things that I couldn’t have even imagined .

How should I say this? It's really impossible to describe everything . Everything that I could have imagined, and things that I would never have imagined, all existed here . It seemed like this was the intersection of various times and spaces, something formed under just the right conditions, a place full of strange things . But these creatures walked down the street like ordinary humans, some of them even looking at me with startled eyes as they passed .

Compared to the other creatures, this crown-less old man wasn't all that frightening . One might even call him a bit cute .

As my mind conjured up that adjective, I looked back at the old man's open skull, and a vomitous feeling climbed up my throat .

But I was able to suppress the sudden nausea . As I took a look around at the unexplainable scene before me, I reacted as any normal person would have .

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I raised up my left hand and gave my cheek a strong smack . The crisp sound rang in my ears and I cried out, "Fuck, that hurts!"

So, I wasn't dreaming .

But if I wasn't dreaming, what did this mean? I stared blankly at the old man as my mind tried to decide whether or not I should just drop to the ground .

"When people first arrive here, their bodies will glow . We haven't seen a living person here in awhile, so when I first saw you, I was just startled . It's nothing else, young lady . Don't be afraid . The leader will arrive soon to explain everything to you . " The old man seemed to be trying to comfort

me as he reached out a hand, and then I noticed that the top of his head started to slowly regenerate . By the time he finished speaking, his head had already grown back, and he looked just like an ordinary old man .

But that didn't comfort me . Rather, I was frozen in spot and my face was full of shock .

As the old man was about to say something else, a large sphere of light appeared . The light came from all around me and then it began to envelop me .

The sphere of light seemed to give me a sense of security in this strange place . I thought things over quickly and decided that either: (1) I was about to be transported home, (2) I was going to wake up, or (3) I must have died, and now I was being resurrected .

My imagination really was a testament to my intelligence . Regardless of the outcome, I couldn't help but laugh at the situation . Even the halo of light was so cliché . And then, in just a second, my surroundings had entirely changed .

Chapter 2

2

The Split Zone

The glowing light around me disappeared . The street I was standing on was gone . The old man was gone . And the strange creatures were gone .

I was now inside a large hall in some kind of building .

The hall was completely empty .

It was several hundred square meters in area, very spacious . The space above me looked endless, like this was a hollowed out building . Around me, there were just four walls . A large screen hung from the northern wall . In fact, it seemed to cover nearly the entire expanse of wall . I was standing not too far away from this wall . The other three walls were covered in shining white ceramic tiles . Even though I was a ways away from them, the brightness still pained my eyes .

Within these walls, the hall contained nothing . It was spacious, but completely lacking in signs of life .

I rubbed my eyes and then looked at the screen in front of me .

A scene suddenly appeared on the screen, like it was broadcasting a video . The perspective appeared to be from above, and the screen showed what appeared to be a hospital room .

A girl was lying on a bed, her eyes closed . And at the side of the bed, a couple sat crying—her parents .

My eyes widened, tears welling up in them .

With muddled vision, even before I could react, two figures suddenly flashed and appeared in front of me .

I looked carefully and saw two people .

Two men .

One was blond, and he looked mixed . I couldn't help but to remember my mixed doctor . Only, he had black hair . And not only was this man blond, he had a pair of blue-green eyes . His profile was the only thing that really looked Chinese .

As for the other person...

When I turned to look at him, my eyes had already cleared up .

My eyes were drawn to him, and in that moment, I even forgot about all the things I didn't understand about this situation .

He looked to be about the same age as me, and wore a black turtleneck, whose collar reached up to his chin, covering up his neck and a pair of black jeans . His hands were quietly tucked into his pants pockets . He had slightly long black hair with choppy bangs sweeping over his eyes . His eyes were dark, deep, apathetic, like black holes .

Seeing this young man, completely clothed in black, I couldn't help sputtering some nonsense, "A-are you a death god?"

The blond man scoffed at the question . He waved his hand in front of my eyes . "Hey, quit your jokes . He's like you, someone who's just arrived here . From your world of the living . "

What??

Our world of the living? My lips twitched again . What was I supposed to make of that sentence now?

Our world of the living? My lips twitched again . What was I supposed to make of that sentence now?

Before I could sort my thoughts, my attention was pulled back to the large screen on the wall . The scene was the same as before, but the parents at the side of the bed seemed to be crying harder now . Their bodies trembled and their eyes were filled with distress as they looked at the girl on the hospital bed .

A strong stabbing sensation swept across my heart . I pointed at the screen and looked at the blond man . “What’s going on? Am I dead or what? How is it that I can see myself there? Who are you guys, and where is this place?”

The blond man slowly withdrew his joking smile and looked at me with a deep, serious expression . His voice had lowered when he said, “I can explain it to you, but I trust that you wouldn’t be able to understand my words . Though, I don’t need you to understand . I’m simply here to tell you about living here . So, no matter what suspicions you may have, please remember that I’m not lying to you . ”

“You’re really long-winded . ” I stared at him coldly, my eyes unable to stop from glancing back at the image of my crying parents .

That’s right . The girl lying on the bed on that screen was me . The couple that sat beside me crying were my parents .

The blond man shrugged, seemingly unbothered by my reaction . “This place, that is, this city-like place under the gray sky, is called Split Zone No . 13 . This place is a different dimension where only people’s consciousness exist . ”

He paused and then gestured with his hands . “I’ll explain it as plainly as I can . In other words, this is a space that has yet to be discovered by humankind, and its inhabitants are those who suffer from schizophrenia . Schizophrenia produces increased brain waves, and under certain stimuli, these brain waves can increase tenfold . If a soul splitter in the split zone

detects and captures these abnormal brain waves, that person's consciousness is then brought here, to this place . ”

What and what now?

My brows must have been twisted up like a wrinkly beef ball . I stared at him blankly and shook my head to express my inability to understand .

His expression belied that this was a commonplace thing for him . Then, he carefully explained, “Let's put it this way . When someone with schizophrenia is stimulated by something, their brain waves will greatly increase for a time . Your consciousness—your soul, if you will—can then be captured and brought here by the rulers of this realm, a group called soul splitters . The person who captured your consciousness, to put it plainly, is like a bad guy who took your soul and dropped it into this world . Standing inside of this world right now is not your physical body, just your consciousness, your mind . And the sleeping girl you see on the screen is your true body in the real world, lying comatose inside of a psychiatric hospital . Do you understand?”

My expression was still wrinkled and blank as I tilted my head . “I seem to get it, but what kind of creatures are soul splitters? Why did they bring my consciousness here?”

“Why do soul splitters exist, and why do they bring people here? Those are questions that I am unable to answer . My responsibility is simply to tell you that you've been brought here by the soul splitters . Your consciousness will exist here, in a form of its choosing, while your body will remain in a coma in the physical world . As long as your consciousness remains here, your body will never wake, and so we often say that the people who have just arrived have died . ”

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your body will never wake, and so we often say that the people who have just arrived have died . ”

The blond man pointed at the screen, to my comatose body . His words implied that when your soul comes here, you are essentially dead .

“In other words, I’ve become a vegetable in the physical world?” I looked at the screen, at myself, in astonishment .

“You can think of it that way . However, doctors will definitely interpret it as being in a deep coma, and not as being in a vegetative state . ” The mixed boy nodded .

“How can I get back?” I almost seemed to have shrieked the question out .

The blond man pointed to my chest . “Look at the key in front of your chest . ” As he pointed, I looked down and discovered that there was now a golden key hanging from my neck .

“That’s called a splitting key . Every person that arrives in the split zone will slowly grow what’s called a split symbol, and then this key will appear around their neck . As for the split symbol, take a look at him . ” He pointed at the quiet, black-clothed young man at his side .

The black-clothed man slowly turned around . With his back to me, he slowly pulled down the collar of his sweater, revealing the back of his neck .

On the back of his neck, there was a crescent moon symbol that emitted a faint glow .

The blond man pointed his finger and made a circular motion around the crescent shape on the black-clothed man’s skin . “This is called a split symbol . Everyone in the split zone will form one within an hour of their arrival here . Everyone’s symbol is different, and it can be located anywhere on your body . When this symbol starts forming, your body’s characteristic glow will slowly fade away, and when the symbol has formed completely, you will become one of the “people” here . Since your splitting key has

appeared, I reckon that your split symbol will form soon . And when that symbol is complete, you will belong to this place . ”

My eyes widened, yet to react to the blond man’s words . The black-clothed man slowly fixed his collar, hiding away his split symbol . He turned back around and looked at me with indifferent eyes, as if looking at me, but also as if looking past me .

I couldn’t help following his gaze . I turned around and saw that there was nothing behind me . In the distance, there was just the other wall of the hall . But there seemed to be a door there, very far away from us .

When I turned back around, the blond man was looking at me with a trace of something in his eyes . Sympathy perhaps, but it also looked a bit like pity .

I couldn’t help following his gaze . I turned around and saw that there was nothing behind me . In the distance, there was just the other wall of the hall . But there seemed to be a door there, very far away from us .

When I turned back around, the blond man was looking at me with a trace of something in his eyes . Sympathy perhaps, but it also looked a bit like pity .

He looked at me and sighed . “I know that the situation must be difficult to understand, but you just have to remember, you’re dead, and that’s why you’re here . You may feel that this is like a dream, but as the days pass, you’ll slowly come to realize that it’s all real . ”

Though everything was very strange and really unbelievable, his words caused my heart to fall into an abyss, continually dropping down .

He paused a moment, and then he continued, “But, I’m also responsible for telling you, every person who arrives here has a counterpart, that is, the soul splitter who brought you here . Everyone has a different soul splitter, and the one who brought you here will have the same split symbol as you, located in the same place, having formed at the same time . You have to try to find them . ”

“Find them for what?” I couldn’t help asking .

The blond man fixed his eyes on me and said, “When you find this person, you’ll be able to leave . Or put more directly, when you find them, you’ll be resurrected . ”

My eyes suddenly widened . There was a chance to go home?

The blond man immediately answered my question, as if he had seen right through my thoughts . “When you find the soul splitter that brought you here and insert your key into their split symbol, your consciousness will return to the world you came from . ”

“Then, what if I can’t find them?” My body seemed to be trembling slightly now .

A mysterious expression crossed his face . “Then your consciousness will remain here forever, and your parents will keep your brain-dead body in the physical world, always carrying a certain aching within them, hoping that you will one day wake up . They will live a life of bitter pain until...”

“Enough!” I cut him off, unable to believe the frightening words I was hearing .

Chapter 3

3

Law of the Jungle

(t/n: In this translation, jiejie and gege may be used in place of “older sister” and “older brother” when addressing females/males older than oneself . It can show up either as the address or as a suffix to someone’s name .)

Thinking back on when I first arrived here a year ago, I couldn’t help finding it laughable . Back then, seeing a crown-less man had made me scream out loud . There was also the blond man who explained everything about this place .

Now though, I’d already been dead for a year, my consciousness relegated to Split Zone No . 13 .

I was currently dashing through the streets of this city, and as I regained my senses, I suddenly felt that there was a figure following behind me .

Even without thinking about it, I knew who it was . But just in case, I quickly turned around . At the same time, I grabbed the bow on my back with my left hand, and by the time I saw him behind me, I already had an arrow aimed .

He was dressed entirely in black, and his strong and healthy figure was quick to respond . He jumped up above my head, and as I looked up, I saw him smile jokingly down at me . I reached out an empty hand to grab his ankle, and then the both of us started falling .

He unceremoniously kicked away my hand, going off my momentum, and we both seemed to hit the ground at the same time .

My crimson skirt swept across the ground, my red heels landing steadily . My messy, red hair blew with the wind as I shot a look at the stalker before me .

He was dressed completely in black, as he's always done . He looked the same as he did one year ago, only he'd traded his black turtleneck for a black windbreaker . His hands were casually inserted into his jacket pockets . His slightly long, black hair danced in the wind, with his shining, black eyes fixed onto me .

“Nie Zun, it's already been a year . Can't you wear something with a bit of color?” I scoffed as I looked over him .

Nie Zun shrugged, his lips curving upwards just slightly . “Aren't you the same? Always wearing red, always running through the streets at night, like a maniac . Have I ever asked you to change?”

I raised one of my eyebrows . “It's not often that you're so lively . I didn't know you could say so much at once . ”

“Depends who I'm talking to,” he replied, with a charming smile .

His smile caused my heart to skip a beat . But immediately afterwards, I silently berated myself for being unable to resist a handsome man's smile . I looked spitefully at him, who was still uncommunicative and feigning a sullen expression after an entire year . And for whatever reason, this man was loitering around me today like the devil .

I was about to make an ironic response when a cute little girl suddenly appeared in front of me .

She was a newbie who'd just arrived yesterday . Laurel, her name was . They said that she was brought here after a serious case of Stockholm syndrome triggered schizophrenia .

Her appearance was a very pure and innocent one, and her character was also sweet and kind . I guess, because she reminded me of myself when I

was younger, I immediately took a liking to her . And she was in Westside, my territory, so of course I would do my best to protect her .

Laurel scurried over when she saw me . She pouted her little, red lips and looked at me sadly as she asked, “Ah Shen jiejie, I still don’t really get it, the way time works here, so I can’t get to sleep . ”

I pat her on the head, her fine and soft blond hair feeling nice beneath my fingers .

I carefully explained, “This place is different from the world we came from . One day is divided into sixty periods . You can think of them as sixty hours . Day lasts for thirty of these hours, and then night lasts for the other thirty . During the day, things are as you’ve seen . The sky is gray, but everything is clearly visible . When night comes though, like right now, the sky is completely dark, and we can see maybe ten meters around ourselves . No matter how you try to light things up, you’ll only be able to see as far as this district . ”

“Then, jiejie, how can you run through the night so quickly? You can’t see in front of you, but you’re still so fast . ” Laurel raised her head, her big, bright eyes shining towards me .

I smiled . “I’ve grown used to it . And when I run, I don’t only rely on my vision . I use all five of my senses . ”

“Like a bat?” Laurel asked, with a tilt of her head .

“Right,” I said, with a gently rub of her head . “But don’t worry . An hour in this place is much shorter than an hour in the world we came from . Once you get used to it, you’ll be fine . ”

“That big brother is really good looking . He’s always following you, Ah Shen jiejie . ” Laurel reached out her hand, attempting to grab onto Nie Zun’s clothes . And surprisingly, he didn’t try to dodge her . He simply shot her a shallow smile .

I scoffed . “That’s because he can’t leave me . ”

“Oh? Why can’t he leave you? Did he fall in love with you?” Laurel asked with amazement, her big eyes glistening .

In my mind, I couldn’t help rolling my eyes at the thought . Him, love me? Please . Two people who couldn’t wait for the other to die—what kind of love could there be between them? I looked over at Nie Zun’s cunning eyes, and a trace of hatred flit across my heart .

“If you’re going to roll your eyes, just do it in your head . If you actually roll them... In the dark night, a woman dressed in red rolling her eyes at you is really quite horrifying,” Nie Zun said leisurely .

I grew a bit embarrassed . Had I really been unable to contain my eye-rolling to my thoughts only?

I grew a bit embarrassed . Had I really been unable to contain my eye-rolling to my thoughts only?

When she heard Nie Zun’s words, Laurel started giggling . Seeing Laurel’s bright smile made me feel much better .

But her laughter was brief, and suddenly, she screamed . It was a little girl’s scream . I followed her gaze until I saw a green-haired snake woman, roughly as tall as a human .

I describe her as a snake woman because she had the lower body of a serpent, and her upper body appeared human . And that thick tail, or should I call it a snake leg... Wow . I really wanted to tell her to lose some weight .

Your appearance in this world was conjured up by your consciousness, so as long as your mental prowess was strong enough, you could change into any form you wanted . That’s the reason behind all the strange creatures in this place .

In this place, our mind’s capabilities equated to our strength, so we call it our mental force (MF) . Our abilities are quantified by this mental force .

When a person first arrives here, their mental force is measured by the leader—that is, the blond haired, mixed man . The upper limit of the MF measurement is 100, with most people having an MF between 10 and 20, or 30-40 if your mental force is a bit stronger .

The strength of one's consciousness can slowly be improved with time and practice, just like willpower . However, unless your willpower was extremely strong while you were alive, in the physical world—in other words, unless you were very strong before you came here—you could practice day and night, but your MF would only ever increase about 3 levels .

So, when you arrive to this place, your abilities have essentially already been decided .

Generally speaking, because one's mental force has a limit, and because the strength of one's brain waves has a limit, once you've set your appearance, it's difficult to change it . Moreover, we only have a certain amount of mental force, and to maintain a different appearance would require spending a portion of it .

One month after my arrival here, I'd grasped how to manipulate my mental force, but I'd only expended about 3 levels to make myself slimmer, more elegant, and to turn my hair red . Aside from that, I maintained a human appearance . I really couldn't understand those people who spent so much of their mental force to maintain a weird, monstrous appearance .

For example, the snake woman in front of us that needed to lose some weight .

I comforted Laurel, “Don't be scared . Her name is You Ji, and while she's far from being kind, she won't harm you . ”

“You Ji, look at your appearance . You're scaring the poor kid . Can't you turn into something more pleasant?” I looked over at her serpent tail .

You Ji extended her hand and stroked her green hair . She gave me a coquettish look . “I really liked snakes when I was still alive . Now that I

have the chance to use my mind to shape shift, it's only natural that I'd want to be melded together with a snake . ”

My lips twitched as I pointed to her spinach-like green hair . “A snake that can grow green hair is attractive to you?”

“Hngh . It's called being trendy . ” She rolled her eyes at me . Her eyes were still very charming though .

“Hngh . It's called being trendy . ” She rolled her eyes at me . Her eyes were still very charming though .

She looked at the still-frightened Laurel, and then she looked at Nie Zun behind me, slouched with his hands in his pockets .

Then her eyes returned to me . “You'd better be careful of Sly S . I don't know what kind of trick she's trying to pull, but she's been roping in a lot of strong people recently . Eastside is growing more restless by the day, and there are always corpses everywhere . There are some really dangerous people among the ones she's gathered . ”

I laughed lightly . “She's always done things strangely and without order . I figure that, as long as I don't offend her, she also won't take the initiative to bother me . ”

You Ji laughed along . “Oh, please . Doing things without order? Who could compete with Westside on that front? Who's as strange as you, coming and leaving without a trace? You know, you're the commander of Westside . Don't just live each day without a care, playing around, leaving Nie Zun and me to take care of things . I'm telling you because I'm worried that, even if you don't provoke her, she'll decide that someone as carefree as you would be easy pickings . ”

I nodded, to let her know I'd be careful . When I didn't say anything else, You Ji simply let out a sigh . With a flick of her tail, she left .

As You Ji disappeared from my sight after just a few steps, I found myself lost in thought .

Of course I knew about Sly S .

Northside's Blondie .

Southside's Si Luo .

Eastside's Sly S .

And Westside's Li Zhen .

Not too long after my arrival here, before I'd become the Westside commander, I was on a street in the Eastside . With my own two eyes, I saw the Eastside commander, Sly S, tearing a girl to shreds .

The girl had been screaming in anguish, but Sly S was expressionless . It was like she was simply ripping up a piece of paper . She pulled the girl's limbs off, one by one, and after the girl's limbs regenerated, Sly S would, once again, tear them off .

She seemed to have spent an entire day doing that .

Because only our consciousness existed in the split zone, any time our bodies were torn or wounded, they would regenerate and heal soon after . Our physical appearance was simply an illusion, and not our true physical shells .

But because our consciousness existed here, we were still able to feel pain .

In other words, when someone repeatedly rips you to shreds, you will feel the pain boring into you, but you'll be unable to escape it .

That was one of the frightening aspects of this world .

That was one of the frightening aspects of this world .

Every person in the split zone had something that could protect them—that is, their splitting key . At the same time, every person carried a weakness—their split symbol .

When someone inserts their splitting key into another's split symbol, that person will truly die . In whatever form they were in, they would die in this world .

And their body in the physical realm would be declared brain dead soon after .

While I couldn't believe everything about this world, you come to realize some things . And I'd already seen a lot of people die .

This place wasn't without rules though . Anyone who inserted their splitting key into an innocent person would, at the same time, hear the sound of a flute flow down from the gray sky above . As the flute sounded, their body would burst into a million pieces, like a beautiful shower of blood . You wouldn't be able to see any pieces of flesh, just bloody residue .

Those who assassinate another will die here, in this cruel fashion . They would feel that pain until the flute no longer sounded, and then their consciousness would also cease to exist in the physical world .

Of course, these are legends . While it's true that the killer will burst apart and die, whether or not one hears the sound of a flute... Well, I've never killed anyone, so naturally, I've never heard it .

All I know is that, when someone starts to burst apart, they will cry out in anguish before their death . Even if I've grown some guts in my time here, I still get chills when I hear the sound .

The only way to leave this place is to find the soul splitter that brought you here and insert your splitting key into their split symbol .

You may be wondering, then, why someone would use their splitting key on an innocent person instead of their soul splitter?

It's very simple, really . Being able to find your soul splitter in this place is harder than climbing to heaven .

Don't even mention finding the soul splitter that brought you here, I still haven't even seen a soul splitter in my time here .

People eventually grow tired of this place . They don't want their families to wait for them, to suffer as they care for a vegetable . And so, they choose to kill another and be destroyed with them .

In this place, you cannot kill yourself . If you want to die, you're either killed by someone, or you kill someone to suffer the consequences .

Every day, there are people who become fed up, so this is hardly a safe place . It's full of slaughtering and conspiracy .

Hiding our split symbol has become a daily source of concern for everyone here .

Chapter 4

4

Bad News

I grew tired from running around, so I returned to my room to sleep . I arranged for Laurel to live on the floor below mine . I lived on the 13th floor of the Westside Residence, and Nie Zun lived next door to me .

When a person lives in this place for a long time, they often forget that they're actually just an intangible soul, and they live like any ordinary person would . This place was about the size of a small city, and it was split into four districts—the Eastside, Westside, Southside, and Northside .

The Northside was Blondie's turf, and it included the split zone's center, the large hall that I first arrived at . As the head of Split Zone No . 13, Blondie lived there, taking care of all the administrative business .

Each district has its own residential building, thirty stories tall, extending across the district . Every room was the same size, sufficient for one person to live in . Everyone here, aside from Blondie, lived in the same type of room, regardless of status .

Life was very simple .

Every district had its own jurisdiction system too . Aside from the expansive residential building, each district also had a school and marketplace building .

There were only these three buildings in each of the districts .

Life here was rather dreary for most, so they could freely decide to enroll in school, either as a student or a teacher . Some people continually spent their time at school, learning many things, waiting for the day that they'd meet their soul splitter . When they returned to the physical world, their accumulated knowledge would be useful, and they wouldn't have just wasted all their time .

Personally, I felt their concerns were unnecessary . The passage of time here was different from the world we came from . While I didn't know the exact conversion, no one here died from old age . So, time must pass by much slower in this world than that one, and that meant we'd be unlikely to see our physical bodies die .

This place seemed like it would exist eternally .

Aside from going to school to learn, people here could go to the market to sell and buy things . The selling and purchasing of goods was more of a bartering system, as there was no currency here . If you needed something, you asked for it, and if the seller liked you, they'd give that thing to you . Or maybe you'd help them with something in exchange for the goods .

The items in the marketplace were all provided by the blond man . If one wanted to operate a business in the market, they could apply to their district commander . The district commander would relay the request to the leader, and if he approved, he would distribute goods to be sold .

Though our appearances were formed by our consciousness, we were unable to produce something from nothing .

Most people who used the market were those who had certain items they really liked . Others only occasionally visited out of boredom .

While each district here had its own administrative system, you weren't allowed to kill in this world . And because we did not die in this world, loneliness grew to become our biggest enemies .

Just think about it for a moment . When you truly have an unlimited time to do anything, perhaps you'll find that you don't know what you should do .

Everything ends up being the same . When everything is eternal and endless, things seem to lose all value . This is true of time as well .

But then, I awoke the next morning to panicked pacing downstairs, and then startling screams broke through the peace of the Westside .

I quickly grabbed my bow and arrow and opened the door .

Nie Zun was also exiting his room . His black hair was messy, and a pair of bewitching dark eyes swept over the area .

Following his gaze, I saw that a lot of people were rushing downstairs .

Seeing me exit my room, several people fearfully called out, “Commander, the 12th floor! The 12th floor! Something bad’s happened!”

No one seemed to be able to spit out a complete sentence, so I waved them away and ran downstairs, my bow on my back . Nie Zun followed behind me .

On the 12th floor, the corridor was jam packed .

Most of the people living in Westside had ordinary appearances, so I just tried to shove my way through the crowd . When they saw me, many moved to let me pass .

I finally made my way through, but the scene I saw before me caused me to stop in my tracks .

A bone chilling feeling crept up from the bottom of my feet to the top of my head .

The door to the room was opened . The furnishings inside looked just the same as every other room’s .

The only difference was that in the center of the room, there was a long and slender metal pole .

It was very long, extending from the ground up to the ceiling .

The pole had pierced through a female body .

Laurel .

Young Laurel's body was skewered onto the pole, traveling from her bottom, up and out the top of her head, into the ceiling .

Her body was covered in blood, and the room was covered in bloodstains .

Her body was covered in blood, and the room was covered in bloodstains .

Because the pole had stabbed through the top of her head, Laurel was nearly beyond recognition . There was a faintly discernible mark on her neck, a small butterfly symbol that would have once glowed dimly . It was no longer lit because there was now a key inserted into it .

That meant that someone had both tortured the girl and then killed her with a splitting key . That's why she'd died in such a tragic manner .

The bloodstains around the room were likely from the killer, after they burst apart . There was no way to identify them now .

Under my administration, it had been a long time since anyone had died such a wretched and bloody death .

My eyes couldn't move, fixed on the sight in front of me . Laurel's hair was no longer soft and beautiful, but was now matted with blood . Her big, opened eyes were covered in blood, creating an unsightly image .

An anger that I'd never felt before suddenly surged through me .

This was Westside, the Westside that had always been opposed to murder . Who would suddenly do such a hair-raising thing? Or had someone encouraged this activity?

Cruelty was, after all, the only delight to be had in the split zone .

People here were too lonely . I realized, not long after my arrival here, that this place was also very cruel .

The abilities that our bodies can make use of in this world rely on our mental force (MF) . That means that our mental force can be turned into physical strength .

For example, someone with 20 MF who used 10 of their levels to create a superhuman appearance, would have 10 levels remaining . If you wanted to have superhuman powers, like being able to jump 5 or 6 meters at a time, you would have to utilize more levels . If jumping 5 meters required 2 MF, when you jumped, you'd drop 2 levels, which would replenish when you landed .

This applies in a similar fashion when people fight . One's strength is dependent on the amount of levels they have to transform .

When trying to determine someone's strength, you cannot look at their appearance . Rather, you had to consider their willpower and their mental force .

People can choose to live ordinary lives here, and they can even eat . But you can also do nothing, if you'd please . Because our bodies here are formed from our consciousness, whatever you can think up goes . If you don't want to do anything you could very well lay in bed all day, and you still wouldn't die .

But the feeling of pain still exists .

That's why there are always people, who've grown too lonely, who decide to harm others for their own amusement .

This was a world where the strong preyed on the weak .

It was much crueler than the world of the living that we came from .

It was much crueler than the world of the living that we came from .

The only thing that was impossible here was to use your mind force to create things from thin air . Our mind force could only be used to enhance ourselves .

Items could only be bartered for in the market, and these items were provided solely by the blond man .

For the reason that this world is so merciless, it was split into four districts, led by commanders with high mental forces .

The Northside was a bit different from the other districts, as it was ruled by Blondie, who kept some mysterious people there . But the remaining three districts had their own sets of characteristics too .

The Southside was governed by a man named Si Luo . While I'd been here for more than a year, I'd yet to see him . The Southside was home mostly to people with an MF of 20 or lower, a very vulnerable group of people . For that reason, the Southside rarely had any murders or battles . They were all alike, weak .

But they say that, leaving Blondie out of the equation, Si Luo had the highest MF in the split zone, at 77 .

An MF of 77 was not only rare, he was the only one to have that one of that level .

That's why, even though the residents of his district were weak, people from other districts wouldn't easily encroach on them . For that reason, the Southside had also become known as the Promise Land . It was forever safe, and life there was simple and calm .

Contrary to that, Sly S's Eastside reeked of blood and murder, and was filled with violence and people out to plunder .

Those who lived in Eastside had higher than average mind forces . Any random person there would have an MF between 30 and 40 .

Ordinarily, a person's MF was between 10 and 20, which meant that Eastside was full of pretty strong people .

And so, the feeble had no way of surviving in the Eastside .

Sly S always had the appearance of a girl in a school uniform . She was a strange one, and her authoritative measures were as different from ours as black to white . She permitted an entirely destructive kind of lifestyle .

The remaining district, which was under my care, Westside, was the most half-baked of them all .

I was like a drink that people could never finish, halfway empty, sloshing around .

I don't know what Blondie was thinking when he decided, half a year ago, to make me the commander of Westside . My MF was only 52 .

While it was a relatively high value, it couldn't even begin to compare to Sly S or Si Luo's .

Sly S had an MF of 69, second only to Si Luo in the split zone . And me? I had a measly 52 .

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Nie Zun arrived here at the same time as me, and he was also present when Blondie greeted me at the center . He'd arrived just an hour before me . When he first arrived, his MF was already 67, much higher than mine . It was very well known in the split zone, but he rarely exerted his mind force for anything . And since he didn't seem skilled in fighting, Blondie didn't give him a job . On that point, I could understand .

But even You Ji's MF of 51 was just barely less than mine .

Though there weren't many with a high mind force, at the least, there were enough people with one around 60 . I really couldn't understand why I was made commander of Westside .

So, I'd always remained rather carefree . I didn't concern myself too much with the happenings in Westside, leaving You Ji to take care of it in my stead .

You Ji had drawn up the rules for Westside, and under her governing, Westside was a considerably calm place . Even if it wasn't the haven that Southside was .

Most of the people who came to Westside were like me, not too heavily invested in things, just muddling along here .

There were still a number of violent acts here, but I was blind to them . It was always You Ji who took care of it .

We couldn't just randomly ask others to reveal their split symbols for us to see, and we couldn't use force to pressure others just to find our soul splitter either . Blondie wouldn't allow for such a thing .

Hence the purpose of a district commander, to lay down the rules and regulate the inhabitants of their district .

But I was completely useless . I'd been a commander for half a year, yet I didn't even know all the rules about Westside, because I left everything to be handled by You Ji and Nie Zun .

But now, in front of my eyes, there was a once beautiful young girl who'd just been waiting to return home . After her cruel death, I decided that I couldn't continue on in such an apathetic and idle manner .

Perhaps it was my attitude of paying no heed to things and of giving up on life that led to Laurel's tragedy .

Sometimes, we feel that being weak isn't a big deal, because as long as you aren't bullied, you can go on living a feeble life forever . But one day, you'll come to realize that weakness isn't yours alone . When you are weak, you will bring harm to those you care about .

Because you are weak, you will be unable to protect those who are important to you .

Nobody wants to force themselves to become powerful, but there will always be someone you want to protect . And then, all we can do is force ourselves to change .

Because, whether you are weak or strong, it doesn't only affect only you .

I looked at Laurel's small corpse, my hand tightly clenching onto my bow . My nails dug into my skin, and as fresh drops of blood appeared, my skin began to quickly regenerate .

Chapter 5

5

Who's the Weakling?

With my bow on my back, I started running across the top of the Westside Residence .

The residential buildings were too big, stretching on as far as you could see . I clenched my teeth and added 5 MF to increase my speed .

Like a red phoenix, I ran, leaving behind the illusion of a blazing trail .

After running for who knows how long, all I could feel was the dark, gloomy sky above pressing down on me .

Then, I felt another tunnel of wind beside me . Of course . I glanced to the side, and there was Nie Zun, effortlessly running after me .

Even while running this fast, he still had on that loathsome smile hanging on his face .

Nie Zun's annoying voice rippled through my ears, "Hey, Li Zhen, are you trying to kill me by running this fast? You clearly know that we can't be more than 500 meters apart . Is this you asking me to elope right now?"

"I need to find You Ji . Is she at the school right now?" I asked coldly .

"You really must have liked that little girl . I've never seen you so serious before . " Nie Zun's voice was calm, at ease, as if a major event hadn't just occurred . "What? You're not planning on laying in bed all day long anymore?"

He pushed aside his bangs with his hand . In that same lazy and indifferent tone, he said, “I’ve been running after you a long time . Slow down . ”

That’s what I hated most about him . He was a devil that lacked any sense of humanity . There was never anything that could bother him .

I glared at him .

“Stop glaring at me . You’re going to fall off soon . ” Nie Zun suddenly stopped in his tracks .

I, on the other hand, was still running fiercely . I turned my head back when I heard him . Because I’d been so angry, and because I’d run so quickly, I’d made it to the edge of the residential building in just over ten hours . The school building ahead was ten stories lower than the residential building .

And so, because the dignified Westside commander didn’t have any brakes, she fell with an anguished wail .

Like someone without a parachute, I dropped down the gap between the thirty story residential building and the twenty story school building .

Thirty stories wasn’t a short distance . As I fell, I got to thinking . While I wouldn’t end up dead, I already started to recall the painful feeling of my body being smashed to pieces .

Living in this place, we grow accustomed to feeling pain that we wouldn’t have been able to withstand while we were alive . You didn’t die here after all . But the memory of the pain of my limbs being broken off when I last fell off of a thirty story building seemed to still exist within me . Previously, it had taken more than ten minutes to completely heal .

I had only one request . When I fall today, I just hope that my breasts were left intact .

The wind rang in my ears .

And suddenly, I felt something grab onto my ankle . My entire body was being held up as I floated in the air .

Floated... in the air...

Whoa!

I turned to look up at him . “Nie Zun, since when could you fucking fly?!”

Holding me in midair, Nie Zun slowly descended . During the frightening experience, his lazy expression remained unchanged .

He tossed me to the ground and responded lightly, “That trick, stopping in midair, cost me 30 MF, you know?”

30 MF seemed worth it... After all, even if we were able to jump very high, being able to suspend yourself in midair wasn’t something a human could do . Having a large mental force wasn’t enough . One had to train extremely hard to manage something like that .

Of course, being able to expend 30 MF at once wasn’t something that many people could do either . Though your mental force would be replenished once you landed, even something as ordinary as jumping a little higher than normal required MF .

And every time you had to use MF, you were also “charged” 1 MF . In other words, you had to pay to use your mental force .

And this 1 MF wouldn’t be replenished until the next day .

That’s why there was a limit to how often we used our MF in a day . And honestly, there were just too many things that required using MF in our daily lives .

Moreover, using up 30 MF for a single action left you vulnerable in that time .

I knew all that, but I wasn’t the least bit thankful to him . Had he called to me just a bit sooner, I wouldn’t have even fallen in the first place .

He was obviously just trying to show off .

Tch... What's the big deal . I shot him a look of disdain .

He wasn't looking at me though . Instead, his attention was drawn to the school building .

I followed his gaze and saw You Ji coming over to us .

Seeing her head of green hair in the light of day left me feeling quite stuffy .

“What kind of wind was blowing to bring you all the way to the school so early in the morning? You even dropped down in such a stunning fashion . While you were falling, I even caught a glimpse of your panties . ”

“What kind of wind was blowing to bring you all the way to the school so early in the morning? You even dropped down in such a stunning fashion . While you were falling, I even caught a glimpse of your panties . ”

You Ji looked at me with a mocking expression .

“Drop it . How much MF would you have had to use to see my panties while I was falling that quickly?”

You Ji swung her tail, covering her mouth with one hand as she laughed .

“Come on then . What kind of wind was able to push you out of bed?”

Recalling that I'd come here for official business, my eyes narrowed .

“Laurel's died . Cruelly . ”

You Ji's smile stiffened . She looked at me with an incredulous expression .

“What?”

I nodded gravely and motioned to Nie Zun .

Nie Zun pulled out a cellphone from his pocket to show You Ji the photos he'd taken of the scene .

You Ji took a look and frowned . “The death isn't a question of cruelty . Rather, it's just very strange . Why would someone do this to a child?”

Laurel just arrived to the Split Zone . She shouldn't have any enemies... unless they were targeting you?"

She looked at me suspiciously .

I was about to speak when a shadow blocked the light around me .

A large boom! sounded in the air . It seemed to have originated about 50 meters to our left, near the entrance to the school . Something had fallen and landed on the ground .

I soon realized what it was .

Because this scene was very familiar .

Something fell from the top of the school building, landing with a loud crash, splattering blood all around .

It was a person .

Without a moment's hesitation, I rushed over .

The head of the figure in front of me was bent crooked .

The lower half of his body was covered in blood .

Without any obstructions in the way, ending up like this from a twenty story fall wasn't so bad .

I vaguely recognized this person . He was a math teacher at the school . They said that he'd loved mathematics when he was alive, so after coming here, he'd continued studying it .

Why would he have suddenly fallen this way?

Why would he have suddenly fallen this way?

His body still hadn't started healing after a few minutes, so I crouched down and started examining his body .

Fortunately he'd maintained a human-like appearance . I quickly found a lightbulb symbol on his chest, a split key inserted into it .

I frowned . While this form of death wasn't pleasant, this kind of situation also wasn't out of the ordinary . We couldn't connect it to the strange incident this morning, not yet .

But I soon changed my mind .

When I turned over the man's body, the image I saw nearly made me vomit .

Despite all the blood, I could still see things squirming around on his back, like insects or something . They were white and oval-shaped, a bit larger than pupae . I'd never seen these creatures before . While they bit his back, you could see their black teeth gnawing .

His back looked to be nearly eaten off, as if these things had been feeding for a long time . There was an entire layer of skin missing, but you could still hear the sound of munching .

“What is this?!” Even You Ji couldn't help screaming out .

In the Split Zone, there only existed humans and humans that had shape-shifted with their mental force . Animals and bugs, and things like this, didn't exist here .

Moreover, these were creatures I'd never seen in the physical world either . They seemed to be some sort of bug, but even if they were, why were they here in the Split Zone? While the Split Zone a strange place, aside from our consciousnesses, nothing else was meant to exist .

“It's most likely that he'd been tortured by the venomous gu insect in his past life, and since he couldn't bear the pain any longer, he begged for someone to use their split key to put him out of his misery,” Nie Zun analyzed calmly . [t/n: about gu poison on Wiki]

This death was definitely intentional, but who was responsible for it?

Thinking of something, I got up to run .

But Nie Zun grabbed onto me . “If you’re looking for the killer, their corpse is on the roof . I just took a look, and the entire roof is covered in blood . After he pushed this guy off, he must have burst apart . ”

While everyone had a split key, it would only be useful to themselves and their corresponding soul splitter . To anyone else, it would just be like a scrap of metal . So, to kill another, they’d have to use their own key . That meant, if one person died, another one had to have exploded at the same time .

No matter how careless Nie Zun sounded, there was no reason to doubt his words, so I didn’t bother checking the roof . The murderer’s body would have already exploded to bits, and there would be nothing recognizable about it .

My heart was throbbing . Why had there been two murders in one day here in Westside? I hadn’t a single clue .

You Ji suddenly spoke up, “For such odd things like this to happen here, there must be a connection to Sly S . ”

That’s right . These kinds of things could only occur if that strange woman had done something . Unlike our Westside, Eastside was a place where violence ran rampant and anything could happen .

The three districts (ESW) each had their own boundary lines, all located to the right of their marketplace building . And each district had the same layout, with the residential building beside the school building, and the school next to the marketplace .

During the day, the district boundaries weren’t in effect . In other words, for the thirty hours of day, you could travel freely between the districts of the Split Zone . But, when night came, you couldn’t leave the district you were in .

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Despite the ability to freely travel across district lines, most people didn't seem to ever leave their district, as each district had its own life style . As for those who tried to cause trouble in another district, just thinking about Mr Blond's punishment made me shiver .

Mr Blond rarely made appearances . His Northside was also a very tranquil place, and nothing particular ever happened there, so I didn't make it a habit going there . I only went there when he called for me .

Actually, there was a reason that I didn't ever seek out the blond man . Only the three district commanders, as well as people he designated, could contact him . And the method to contact him made me shudder even more than thinking about how he punished people .

But, in such a situation, with all the strange things happening, I was forced to seek him out, using a method that made me want to kill myself .

So, I rolled my eyes, faced the sky, and cried out, "The most handsome, invincible, cutest, strongest, and greatest leader, I'm your fan! Please meet with me!!!"

That's right . This was the one and only method that he provided for us to contact him .

In the past, You Ji had been the one to call for him, and I'd been overjoyed watching from the sidelines . But now, the roles were reversed, and she was quite enjoying herself .

While we waited, and I wanted to roll my eyes endlessly, an image of the blond man's face appeared before me .

I didn't care what form he took, since I didn't know what kind of existence he led anyway .

But as I was opening my mouth, I realized that his blue-green eyes didn't carry the same gentle and warm demeanor that they used to .

My words caught in my throat .

Since I didn't say anything, he looked at me a bit indignantly . “Li Zhen, are you here to ask about the events in your district?”

I didn't know why he was angry, but the difference from how he'd always joked around with me in the past caused me to simply nod .

“You don't need to seek me out for such things . Why did I make you the Westside commander? In the past year, have you done anything to make Westside a peaceful place?”

“But Eastside...” As I started to refute, his expression grew furious, and I swallowed the rest of my words .

“I've told you before, that this place has its own rules, and every district has its own style of living . If Eastside was just like Westside, there would be no need for Eastside's existence . This isn't like the place you once stayed in . If you have time to concern yourself with Eastside's lifestyle, why don't you take care of Westside first?”

My stubborn temper was awakened now . “Why should I govern Westside? All I wanted was to find my soul splitter and leave this place . ”

He looked at me coldly . “Then go ahead and search . You clearly know that your soul splitter isn't in Westside, so why don't you try searching in another district? Or are you afraid?” He spat out angrily, “I was really wrong about you, you weakling!” Then his face disappeared from in front of me

I bit my lip and remained standing where I was .

Chapter 6

6

Prepare the Bow For Battle

When I returned to the residential building, there were still more than ten hours to nightfall .

The land area of each district was large, but each only had three buildings . This meant that it could take a lot of time to travel between buildings .

But that didn't matter . In this place, time was the one thing we had a lot of .

One day lasted sixty hours, thirty hours of day and thirty hours of night .

Neither day nor night ever exceeded their time allotment . After thirty hours, our vision would instantly decline .

This was the Split Zone, where we were perpetually in the dark, even when it was day .

It felt as if fog and darkness were the eternal things of this world .

I crossed my arms across my chest as I looked out the window .

Knock knock knock sounded from the door .

“Come in . ” I heard my voice resound, clear and cold .

I turned to the door and saw Old Man Fan, You ji, Nie Zun, and also the marketplace supervisor, Jie Pa .

I frowned .

Old Man Fan was the first person I met in the Split Zone, the crownless old man .

When I became the commander of Westside, I appointed him as the residential building supervisor .

I also appointed You Ji as the school building supervisor . In name, she held the same position as Jie Pa and Old Man Fan, but in reality, she was essentially co-commander . Because I didn't take care of anything, big or small, she had to pick up those duties .

I frowned as I looked at Old Man Fan's goopy, still-crownless head .

Why did this old man like this chopped-off Hannibal style so much?

“In a bit, I'm going to head over to Eastside, before the district boundaries lock . In other words, I will be staying overnight in Eastside . ”

I looked at the sixty-hour watch on my wrist .

Ten more hours left . If I ran at my fastest pace, I'd arrive at Eastside just in time, so there was no chance I'd be able to return tonight .

“You're all aware that this is the first time, since I became district commander, that I'll be leaving Westside for the night . While most people wouldn't dare kill a district commander, there will always be some level of danger . So, while I'm gone, watch over Westside well . You may as well skip sleeping tonight . Nie Zun's coming with me, so Jie Pa and Old Man Fan, listen to You Ji . ”

Jie Pa appeared to be a 27-28 year old man . He always wore a suit and a pair of black-rimmed glasses . They say that while he was alive, he was a very intelligent scholar with a doctorate degree . After his death, he was still very enthusiastic about scientific research . I appreciated how he looked like an ordinary person and how gentlemanly his mannerisms were . He was also very capable, keeping the marketplace neat and tidy .

“Go with an easy mind . Leave this place to us . ” Jie Pa bowed to me .

By comparison, Old Man Fan looked at me with misty eyes . “Ah Shen, be careful . You’re like a granddaughter to me . ” As he spoke, tears actually fell down his face . Oh, this blasted old man!

Seriously disgusted, I actually made an effort to roll my eyes .

“Leave this place to us . Don’t let any of the residents find out about your leaving Westside, or or it’ll just incite panic,” You Ji told me .

I nodded . “Don’t worry, I’ll take care of it . ”

I pulled my bow onto my back .

“Get rid of your appearance . You’ve already used your MF four times today, and you’ll have to use it again when you’re running . Together with the MF you consumed during the day, you’ll only have 47 MF left, and it won’t replenish until after the thirty hours of night . How do you expect me not to worry while you’re in a place like Eastside?” You Ji asked as she looked at me, heart full of worries .

You Ji was right . Though I only use up 1 MF to change my appearance, because all I do is change my figure slightly and turn my hair red, 1 MF was still 1 MF . I should get that back .

You Ji was right . Though I only use up 1 MF to change my appearance, because all I do is change my figure slightly and turn my hair red, 1 MF was still 1 MF . I should get that back .

So, I withdrew my mental force . My curly, red hair returned to its original long, straight, and black appearance, casually falling behind my shoulders .

“Tch . Still tiny without MF . ” Nie Zun shot a glance at my chest .

A wave of fury rushed over me . I grabbed the cup from the table behind me and threw it at him .

You Ji pulled out a set of black clothes from the large bag she carried .

“Put this on . A striking red dress, and you don’t even try to hide your symbol . Do you really think you’re the Split Zone’s top expert? You’re always going around like you’ve got some powerful backer...” You Ji grumbled as she glanced at the scorpion pattern on my left ankle .

I laughed lightly . Without rebutting, I accepted the black clothes from her .

They were ordinary black traveler’s clothes, along with a pair of flat, black boots .

“Do I look like an assassin?” I happily changed into the clothes and then walked back out of the bathroom, looking to the others .

My long hair fell straight, parted down the middle to frame my face on both sides . I stood in front of them, clothed in black, carrying my favorite bow .

“Looking like that, you might pass for an assassin in the real world, but in the Split Zone, you just look like any ordinary person . ” You Ji’s face was full of abandon . But, she still gave a flick of her tail, and then she bent over and stuffed two guns into my boots .

“Bring along more weapons . Two guns, twelve bullets . Maybe they’ll be of use . They’re the best . Over at Jie Pa’s, only one family has them . They’re covered in a spirit suppressor that causes paralysis for five hours . ”

Spirit suppressor, a type of drug that could suppress our consciousness . The ingredients probably weren’t complicated . It was something like a sleeping pill that caused the consciousnesses inside the Split Zone to fall into a deep sleep .

Because of our incredibly fast healing abilities, ordinary bullets didn’t have much effect on us . With our ability to endure pain, an ordinary bullet entering our body was akin to the feeling of a mosquito bite .

Most bullets coated with spirit suppressants could only cause someone to lose mobility for an hour or so though .

I nodded and packed them in . I dismissed the rest of the people with a wave .

You Ji gave me a final worried look before leaving with Old Man Fan and Jie Pa .

You Ji gave me a final worried look before leaving with Old Man Fan and Jie Pa .

Only Nie Zun and I remained in the room .

I looked over to Nie Zun, who still wore his black, high-collared windbreaker, his bangs covering his eyes . He was leaning against a wall, two hands stuffed into his jacket pockets, looking around lazily .

“You’re not planning on bringing anything with you?” I asked, my brows raising .

A smile appeared on Nie Zun’s lips . “Do you think someone with an MF of 67 needs to bring anything?”

True . Nie Zun was a bit different from others in that regard . Of course, his physical abilities had limitations, just as anyone else’s did, but he never wasted his mental force for his appearance . Today, he’d already run along with me and had to catch me from my fall . In total, he’d already used his mental force thrice, but even if he were to run again, he would still have 63 MF remaining, which meant it was true that he didn’t really have anything to worry about .

I couldn’t be bothered to say any more to him . Instead, I opened the window, letting the evening breeze flow into the room . I climbed onto the windowsill, about to head onto the roof to head over to Eastside .

Suddenly, my clothes tightened around my neck, like someone was pulling me from behind .

Nie Zun’s head appeared beside my head as he held me in place on the windowsill . “Let’s walk . Since you never train yourself, when something

requires more strength than you possess, you'll end up depleting your mental force . ”

He pulled me down from the window, and then turned to the door . “I told you that you ought to train more regularly . ”

In the end, I followed him out angrily . What else could I do when he was right .

I didn't often train, so if I had to exert even a bit of extra strength, I would have to expend my mental force .

“After we get back, you should start training,” he mocked with a glance back at me .

After we took the elevator up to the 30th floor, we started to fly across the rooftop .

The top of the Western Residence seemed to have become my personal traveling space . Because the residents of the district knew that I liked running across the top of the building, especially at night, they traveled on the streets to avoid being hit by me .

Although, that might not really be the reason . Maybe it was simply for the fact that ordinary people walked on streets and not on rooftops... After all, by traveling across a roof, you introduce the danger of falling off of it . (Passerby: That's only a danger for you, really . Normal people know to stop when they get near the edge .)

The nighttime wind whirled in my ears as Nie Zun and I ran . When I looked over at Nie Zun to see that smile still on his face, I couldn't help falling into a trance .

Many times, while I ran through the night with Nie Zun, I would start to feel like I was still just a third year college student in the real world . Of course, I'd quickly regain my senses, because this was definitely an incomparably strange place .

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But I would still try to fool myself .

Half a year after I came here, I was assigned to the post of Westside Commander . For the next half a year, I seemed to have spent every day practicing archery or holing up in my room to read .

Aside from those things, I rarely did much .

It's not that I had no desire to find my soul splitter . I just simply didn't know how .

Even though some people would use violence to force others to reveal their split symbols, you couldn't really just look at other people's symbols at your whim . And yet, soon enough, we realized that in this place, split symbols didn't repeat .

Slowly, people became accustomed to life here . Life was much the same in the real world anyway, but at least in this place, there were no societal pressures . And so, everyone eventually gave up searching for their soul splitter .

I didn't give up .

But neither did I have the courage .

What I was nearly certain of was that my soul splitter wasn't in my district . But even if they were, with so many people in such a large place, I wouldn't be able to find him anyway .

Soul splitters appeared no different from ordinary folk, except for the fact that their split symbol wasn't unique .

Although I knew that soul splitters existed, and that they existed in Split Zone No . 13, I still had no way of finding them . What made them exceptional though was that even if someone with a different split symbol inserted their key into them, the soul splitter wouldn't die .

After a person arrives in the Split Zone, they are only allowed a look at their life in the real world once a year . The time was arranged with Mr Blond, and he would escort you to the large hall in the heart of the realm . Then you'd be able to see your physical body in the real world .

For myself though, after seeing my parents crying and seeing my seemingly lifeless body on a hospital bed when I first arrived, I never asked Mr Blond to let me have a look again .

I admit it . I've been running away .

Chapter 7

7

27th Floor Elevator

We finally reached the district border after running for nine hours .

While Westside and Eastside were located to the west and east respectively, that wasn't all there was to it .

Beside Westside was a boundary forest . After passing through the forest, you would reach the district borderline, and on the other side of it, there was Eastside's forest . Only after passing through that forest would you finally reach Eastside's residential building .

Southside also bordered Eastside, by its merchandise market . I wasn't very certain about the distribution of Northside and Southside though, as I'd never been to Southside, and the only times I went to Northside was when I went to the Split Zone center . And each of those times, Mr Blond had brought me there in a flash of light .

The darkness of night would hit in less than an hour . After passing through the forest, we soon came across the long, white borderline that divided the two districts . The line was already starting to glow now .

The moment that the dark of night came, the borderline would give off a bright glow, which would form a barrier that people couldn't pass through .

I looked towards the Eastside Forest . Since it was still day, everything looked pretty clear .

But forests at the borderlines were always very thick, so you usually couldn't actually see through it .

I turned my head to look at Nie Zun, and the two of us made our way to other side of the boundary line .

With light steps, we stepped across into the Eastern Forest .

I bent over and reached inside my boot to touch my split symbol . I still had 47 MF remaining .

After I straightened up, I grabbed my bow and arranged my arrows on my back . My bow wasn't very large, and it was very light . The arrows were also thin and slender, so my bag could hold more than a hundred of them . I held the bow with my left hand and used my right hand to sweep aside the hair in my face .

Nie Zun stood with his hands in his pockets, unconcerned as usual .

I'd rarely seen him engage in hand to hand combat with anyone, and of course, I didn't understand what types of weapons he could use .

I didn't much care for his life, and in fact, I sometimes found myself looking forward to his death .

I coldly glanced at him once more .

Feeling my gaze land on him, Nie Zun smiled . He looked at me with a pair of bright eyes, before motioning for me to look ahead .

We'd already passed through the forest .

The residential building, along with the streets in front of it, appeared in my line of sight .

There were a lot of people on the street, but they weren't as I'd imagined . I'd thought that strange monsters would be rampant in Eastside . And although there were many fantastic creatures, a lot of people kept a human appearance .

The people here didn't look much different from the ones residing in Westside . Only, after seeing Nie Zun and me walk out from the forest, they cast unfriendly eyes our way .

The two of us didn't stare much longer, lest we attract even more attention to the fact that we were outsiders . So, we passed through street after street, and we soon blended into the crowd and arrived at the residential building .

As long as we didn't look like newbies with with no experience in the world, others wouldn't pay much attention to us . Moreover, I wasn't wearing my blood-red dress today, and everyone's understanding of the Westside commander was simply a body dressed in red, and nothing more .

The residential building had an entrance every few meters, but I had no understanding of Eastside at all . Fortunately, You Ji had mentioned that Sly S should be living in the first room on the 30th floor .

I exchanged a glance with Nie Zun, and then we walked into the Eastside Residence .

There were a ton of people inside the building, so a few unfamiliar faces wasn't really unusual . As long as we weren't glowing like a new arrival, no one cared about us .

Still, Nie Zun and I received several strange looks .

I didn't quite understand why . In any case, Nie Zun and I successfully made it into an elevator . There were also two others that got onto the elevator with us . One was a large and tall man, wearing a gray tank top and gray sports pants . His strong and muscular build made him look quite formiddable . The other had the appearance of a mummy, but he didn't look gross . Instead, he was kind of handsome . His face was bandaged, revealing only a pair of piercing, bright eyes . The only thing that made him look relatively strange was that green glow in his eyes . The bandages on his face also appeared to be stained with dried blood .

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All together, there were four of us in the elevator . After the door closed, the elevator started to move slowly .

The elevator itself was as ordinary as could be . As the elevator traveled upwards, a few people got on and off, but otherwise it was just the four of us, so it wasn't very crowded .

After we passed the 20th floor, the elevator seemed to stop less frequently . When we reached the 24th floor, the people who got on at the 20th floor got off .

The last one to get off turned back and gave me a pensive look .

I found it a bit curious, so I turned to the two guys who had gotten on the elevator on the first floor with us .

Before I looked at them, I wasn't concerned, but after I looked them over, I started to feeling uneasy .

Because at some point, the two of them had started looking at me .

When I glanced at them, they both continued to stare me down, without batting an eyelash .

I didn't know what to do, and then the elevator suddenly stopped with a crunch .

What was going on? This didn't seem to be an ordinary stop .

I frowned as I checked the display . It was the 27th floor .

The elevator had suddenly stopped, but the doors didn't open .

I knew something wasn't right, so I quietly grabbed my bow .

The muscular man standing closest to the elevator buttons suddenly said, "You guys aren't from here . "

My hand tightened on my bow, and I responded calmly, "How can you tell?"

My hand tightened on my bow, and I responded calmly, "How can you tell?"

The muscular man chuckled . His face twisted a bit and it looked both like he was and wasn't laughing . "Because everyone in Eastside knows that floors 27 to 29 are reserved for S Clan officials ranked C and higher . Most of the elevators will stop at the 27th floor, but even at the 26th floor, the two of you didn't look like you planned on getting off . You're not wearing anything that indicates that you're an S Clan official, which means that you must be from a different district with no understanding of our rules . "

"Since you two also haven't gotten off yet, that must mean that you live on the 27th floor or higher . So, why don't you guys have any ID that suggests you're part of S Clan?" I didn't panic .

The mummy suddenly laughed . "Every member of S Clan wears contact lens made from a special material . We have an S mark on the left side of our face that only someone wearing the contacts can see . "

No wonder people were looking at Nie Zun and me so strangely . Perhaps those people were part of S Clan? But how did they know that I wasn't just another resident of Eastside?

I was aware of S Clan though . They were a group formed by and named for that strange woman, Sly S . The group was comprised of those who were loyal to her, and perhaps you might call them her fans . They say that S Clan has seven ranks, A through G . The closer to the start of the alphabet, the higher your ranking and ability . I didn't know all the specifics about the

number of people in their clan . I just knew that there were only three people ranked A and seven ranked B .

Eastside's Sly S was the most famous woman in all of the Split Zone . When I first arrived, I'd heard about her .

I thought back to the first time I saw her . She wore a high school uniform and her hair was shoulder length with bangs . She looked like an obedient and good student, but she couldn't hide that strange atmosphere that emanated from her—Sly S .

Every time I thought of her, the air around me grew cold .

She rarely made appearances and she rarely spoke to anyone . Anywhere she went, there was always a group of people protecting her . It's said that those people swore loyalty to her . Before I arrived in the Split Zone, her power was already unquestionable . It's also rumored by some that the last commander of Westside died by Sly S's hands .

A lot of people followed her blindly, but no one really knew why . And she always wore that high school uniform, fashioned rather like Japanese school uniforms . Her face was always white as snow, and her eyes looked empty and lifeless .

Some say that she simply maintained the appearance she had when she died .

As for the type of schizophrenia that sent her here, no one seemed to know about it .

All I knew was that the first time I saw her and accidentally exchanged glances with her, those emotionless, lifeless, stagnant eyes sent a cold chill all across my body .

I didn't have too much time to think because the mummy suddenly pulled off a piece of his bandaging and turned to me for an attack!

I didn't move because Nie Zun had already extended his left hand from his pocket and stopped the attack .

Nie Zun was wearing a black glove on his hand .

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Nie Zun was wearing a black glove on his hand .

Well, he was wearing black gloves on both of his hands . He'd always been like that, never exposing any skin . He was always wrapped up from head to toe, like a dark zongzi . (t/n: a zongzi is like a big "rice dumpling"—Wiki article)

I'd always thought it was because he was scared of dying, so he wrapped himself up as to not expose his split symbol .

I was the only one who knew about his split symbol, since I saw it when we first met . Mr Blond had made him expose the crescent moon symbol on his neck to explain split symbols to me .

Even as Nie Zun's left hand stopped right in front of my face, his lips carried an unfazed smile . "If she dies, things will be hard on me . So, good sirs, if you must attack, please attack me first . "

His voice sounded clearly in the elevator .

The muscular man extended a hand to stop the mummy . He gave a nod to Nie Zun . "Apologies . It's not that we must use violence against you . It's just that even members of my family who are not part of S Clan cannot travel past the 26th floor . And well, the two of you are uninvited guests whose purpose we do not know . "

After the muscular man stopped him, the mummy also retracted his bandages .

The muscular man nodded to me . "Pretty lady, the two of you should head back . If you'd like to stay for a visit, we welcome you, but you cannot

travel past this point . ”

“I’m here to see the district commander . ” Without loosening my grip on my bow, I looked at the muscular man .

Glancing at the bow in my left hand, he finally nodded . “It’s a rare occasion that Westside Commander Li Zhen would pay a visit to Eastside . It’s obvious that you’re here to see our commander, but without the commander’s agreement, I still cannot allow you to travel any further . Apologies, Ms Li Zhen . ”

It wasn’t strange that he could identify me . After all, not everyone was as oblivious to the world around them as I was . As a member of S Clan, with at least a C ranking, he’d likely already learned about my appearance and choice of weapons .

Suddenly, I couldn’t help being annoyed at myself for recklessly running here without first learning more about Eastside’s rules and customs .

I looked at the elevator door . The muscular man held a hand against the gap in the doors .

This was the 27th floor, a place where only officers ranked C or higher could go . It was clear that the muscular man’s intent was that, unless Nie Zun and I returned to a lower floor, we wouldn’t be able to leave this elevator at all . What? Were the corridors of the 27th floor and above filled with unspeakable secrets?

Chapter 8

8

Body Double

I shot a charming smile at the muscular man . Stepping forward, I raised my right hand to touch his toned right arm . His left hand was still holding down the elevator button . (t/n: the muscular man will henceforth be called Muscle Man)

Seeing me move, the mummy pulled back his left leg and turned slightly, to face me . At the same time, Nie Zun's left foot moved slightly forward .

Muscle Man didn't move . I gave his arm a gentle rub .

“Since you know that I rarely pay visits, the fact that I'm here today means that there's a reason that I must see your district commander . Even if you won't let me see her, I can't just let things go . So, how about this? You tell me a way to meet your commander that doesn't put you in a tight spot . It's better than us resorting to violence, isn't it? After all, if we were to really fight, are you sure that you would win?”

I tilted my head and gave another pretty smile, slowly pulling back my hand .

Muscle Man was silent a moment, and then he looked to me with bright eyes . “Ms Li Zhen, let's do it this way . You and Mr Nie Zun return to the 26th floor and wait . I'll report to the commander and have her make a decision . What do you think?”

I felt somewhat unhappy at this . We were both district commanders, so what was up with the air of arrogance?

Well, fine, I'll tolerate it . This was their turf after all .

Sigh . Even though I was a district commander, I didn't feel like a leader at all . I always mixed with the other residents on the 13th floor . I spent half my day lying in bed, like a paralyzed patient . It was no wonder that Mr Blond was angry with me .

As I thought about this, Nie Zun and I were being escorted out of the elevator . We stood in front of the elevator doors on the 26th floor, waiting for the muscular man's response .

After the elevator doors closed, I turned to look at Nie Zun . His careless appearance seemed to have hit a limit . Perhaps he was tired because it was nighttime . He swayed slightly as he stood, as if he might fall asleep at any moment .

I was about to scold him for being so leisurely while we were in enemy territory, when he suddenly laughed at something behind me . "What is it?"

I started . Was there someone behind me? Even though my mental force wasn't very high, I was still pretty sensitive to my surroundings . Who could have gotten this close to me without my taking notice?

I hated this weak and feeble feeling . With a taut face, I stubbornly refused to turn around .

"It's like this . There's something I must report to you, but it didn't seem safe to do so in the confines of Westside, so I followed you and the commander here . Only, I was more than half an hour later than you two . I made it past the district border right at the last minute, so I was only able to find you now . "

This voice sounded very familiar, so I immediately turned around .

It was Jeppa . (t/n: Or Jie Pa, as I called him previously . But I'll be using Jeppa now .)

Jeppa was still dressed in a suit, standing behind me, looking ever like a perfect gentleman . He was looking respectfully towards Nie Zun, his eyes not covered by that pair of black glasses .

Startled, I said, “Jeppa?”

“It’s me, Commander . ” As always, Jeppa gave a bow to me .

“What are you doing here?” I asked . Then I turned to Nie Zun, who didn’t look at all surprised . Rather, he nodded to Jeppa . “Continue speaking . We’re waiting for someone now, so it might not be convenient to talk in a bit . ”

Jeppa understood . He got to his point and said, “I suspect that Ms Laurel didn’t really die . ”

My eyes widened . “What do you mean?”

Jeppa looked at me as he said, “As you’re aware, Commander, after a person dies, someone from the marketplace is designated to transport the body to the corpse pit near the forest . Then, in the real world, that person’s heart will stop beating . After their body grows cold there, the corpse in this world will disappear . ”

He paused and adjusted his glasses . “Before that happens though, after a splitting key is inserted into someone’s split symbol, they will die in this world, but their body form remains unchanged . Only in the final moments before their consciousness truly disappears from here do they return to their original form . I was suspicious, so I went to the corpse pit to find Ms Laurel’s body, and I watched it until it disappeared . In the final moments though, her body didn’t look like Ms Laurel’s, but rather some other 20 something year old girl . ”

He paused and adjusted his glasses . “Before that happens though, after a splitting key is inserted into someone’s split symbol, they will die in this world, but their body form remains unchanged . Only in the final moments before their consciousness truly disappears from here do they return to their original form . I was suspicious, so I went to the corpse pit to find Ms

Laurel's body, and I watched it until it disappeared . In the final moments though, her body didn't look like Ms Laurel's, but rather some other 20 something year old girl . ”

Jeppa continued, “There are three (t/n: ?) possibilities . First, Ms Laurel had been maintaining her appearance with her mental force . Second, someone used their mental force to make themselves look like Ms Laurel, and it was during that time that they were killed . ”

I frowned . The first situation was impossible . Because Laurel was still young, and her death hadn't come about from a very particular illness, she was entrusted to me by Mr Blond; she hadn't walked into Westside by her own choice . That meant that she wouldn't have been familiar enough with using mental force to put on a fake appearance .

But the second situation wasn't very likely either . While it was very easy to disguise yourself as someone else, you couldn't fake a split symbol . Everyone's split symbol gave off a faint light, a kind of light that we couldn't replicate . If the dead Laurel was a fake, how did we explain the butterfly symbol on her neck? I'd seen her split symbol before, and it was indeed a butterfly .

Seeing the doubts on my face, Jeppa continued, “Commander, split symbols come in a large number of varieties . Everyone's is different, and no symbol is repeated . However, that doesn't mean that there aren't symbols that look very similar . Even if the symbol on that girl's neck was a butterfly, it may have been a different butterfly to Ms Laurel's . Try to recall it . ”

Hearing Jeppa say this, I suddenly felt that something wasn't quite right . Because I'd been so enraged by Laurel's death, I hadn't considered the possibility that someone had disguised themselves as Laurel . I didn't really think much about it at all . But with Jeppa's words now, I tried to recall the symbol I saw on the corpse's neck . My memory is very strong, and it really did seem that the butterfly on the corpse wasn't exactly the same as Laurel's butterfly .

They looked similar, yes, but they were two different types of butterflies .

“Who would want to disguise as Laurel to get killed? What do they mean by that? And where’s the real Laurel?” I grew anxious . Because if what Jeppa proposed was true, then that meant there was a chance that Laurel was still alive .

Jeppa responded, “I don’t understand the reasoning behind it either, but I suspect that many recent events are not normal . After Nie Zun told me to secretly investigate this, I started to pay more attention to these things . ”

Nie Zun told him? I turned to glance at him . Of course, he had the same lazy expression as always . And then he even yawned .

Looks like I’m the only one who doesn’t concern themselves with all these things, I couldn’t help deride myself .

Ding!, the elevator suddenly sounded . Must be Muscle Man . I glanced back to the elevator to catch the doors opening . But when I turned back around, I found that Jeppa had already disappeared .

What agility! I guess Jeppa was staying hidden from the Eastsiders .

I looked back to the elevator . “Ms Li Zhen, our commander is not currently in . I’m not just saying that, but she’s really not in the building right now . I didn’t know earlier, as she doesn’t usually leave the residence at this time, but she’s not one to report her activities to me . So, I must apologize, but I’m afraid that you’ll have to leave now . ”

I thought back to what Jeppa told us earlier . If what he said was true, it wouldn’t be wise to rush in and interrogate Sly S right now . So, I just laughed . “Alright . Sorry for the troubles . We’ll head off then . ”

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“There are still 29 hours before day returns . Why don’t I arrange a place for you and Mr Nie Zun to stay?”

“There’s no need . When travelers pass through another district, they can stay in the school dorms . At the least, I’m aware of such a rule . There’s no need for you to inconvenience yourself . You can go . Nie Zun and I will head to the school building . ”

Muscle Man nodded . “Be careful on your way . ” As if not wanting to speak with me for an extended time, he pressed the button to close the elevator doors .

Seeing the elevator doors close, it appeared that the man had no intention of seeing Nie Zun and myself out . My lips twitched .

“Where’s Jeppa?” I asked Nie Zun .

“On the rooftop, probably . ” Nie Zun yawned again .

I really couldn’t be bothered to retort to such a response . Rather than wait for the elevator, I slipped out the 26th floor window and used my mental force to take me to the 30th floor .

Nie Zun followed behind and jumped up as well .

As Nie Zun had said, Jeppa was indeed standing on the roof, waiting for us .

Spotting my arrival, Jeppa immediately proposed, “Commander, I think that it’s better if we return to the district forest . Neither you nor Nie Zun are familiar with the way things work here, so I suggest that we wait in the forest . We’ll be able to return to Westside right away when day breaks . ”

“You’re really quick, you know . ” I commended Jeppa’s abilities, not opposing his suggestion .

Nie Zun suddenly spoke up . “Jeppa, you should return to the forest and wait for us there . Li Zhen and I are going to take a look at the other district border . Before the sky lights up, we’ll meet back up with you . If we don’t return, you can head back to Westside first . You don’t have to wait for is . The same as before . ”

After listening, Jeppa nodded . Then he turned away and seemed to vanish .

“Wow, he actually listens to you,” I couldn’t help sighing .

After listening, Jeppa nodded . Then he turned away and seemed to vanish .

“Wow, he actually listens to you,” I couldn’t help sighing .

“Who told you to ignore all your duties?” Nie Zun smiled slightly .

“But why are we going to the other district border?” I asked with confusion .

“I suspect that we’ll be able to meet Sly S there . ”

“Why?”

Nie Zun turned his head to the dark, night sky . It was rare for a district commander not to be in the district residence during the night . A situation like that meant that it was likely that she wasn’t in Eastside now .

“If she had gone to Westside, it’s not possible that neither Jeppa or You Ji noticed . So, my guess is that she went to Southside . In that case, why not wait for her at the border?”

“But if Laurel’s not dead, I don’t need to find her . ”

“No . Whether or not Laurel is dead, you still have to meet with her,” Nie Zun said .

“Why?” I asked, a bit confused .

“There haven’t just been one or two strange occurrences in Westside . You just remain blind to them . The bugs that covered the body that fell from the roof earlier carried a certain scent . And I just smelled that scent on the bandaged man we met, which means that Sly S must have had some involvement in the strange things happening in Westside . Even if you don’t plan on interrogating her, you should at least meet with her, to see what kind of reaction she has . You must know yourself and your enemy to be

victorious in every battle . She's a legendary figure, and yet, after you became the Westside commander, you never once met with her . Do you think that's right?"

"I've never met Si Luo either . " I didn't sound at all confident in my retort . Nie Zun's senses were stronger than most people's . If he smelled something, then I wasn't going to doubt him .

"Si Luo's an exception . He doesn't like outsiders . " Nie Zun suddenly laughed . "What, are you scared of Sly S?"

"Who's scared? Fine, let's go!" I clenched my teeth . You're a funny guy, huh . Who's scared?!

Chapter 9

DESIRES IN DARKNESS

Tit For Tat

We were currently on one side of Eastside, so it would take about 15 hours to make it to the opposite border . But Nie Zun's words made a lot of sense, so I ran alongside him to Eastside's other borderline .

No matter which district, the rooftops were the best place for traveling . There wasn't a single other person in sight .

When we arrived at the boundary forest, there were still ten hours before day .

I jumped up onto a tree and rested against a branch, planning on sleeping for a bit .

Not hearing anything from Nie Zun, I couldn't help glancing down at the ground .

And when I looked, I nearly peed my pants from laughing .

Nie Zun was currently at a tree across from me, exhaustingly trying to climb up a tree .

While his tall, black-clothed body didn't appear clumsy while climbing, he did sort of look like a silly monkey all the same .

“Monkey Nie, are you finding enough bananas?”

Nie Zun continued to climb diligently, his voice sounding lazily . “This is to conserve my mental force, okay?”

“Oh please . When the light of day hits tomorrow, our mental force will be replenished . ”

“This is Eastside . Who knows if someone might try a sneak attack? It’s never a bad idea to be cautious . ”

I laughed at his going to such efforts . Then I put my arms behind my head and looked up at the night sky .

It was always just an expanse of darkness, no stars or lights . There was nothing to illuminate the night here, unless you counted fluorescent lamps . We’re still able to see things because even in the night, we have a visual radius .

In this forest, my visual radius was roughly ten meters around me, and I found it sufficient . If it were pitch black in the real world, forget ten meters, I wouldn’t even be able to see my five fingers .

Despite us having more abilities in this world compared to humans in the real world, I still greatly missed living the life of an ordinary person .

People were always like this, looking forward to being different and setting themselves apart . But when we really find ourselves in a different situation, the loneliness we encounter when others cannot accept us makes it feel like asking for normalcy is an extravagant demand .

It’s a feeling of sadness, and I’ve always preferred to avoid this sadness . So, I decided to distract myself by starting a conversation with Nie Zun .

“So, what kind of personality disorder did you have?” I asked quietly .

While Nie Zun was alive, he’d suffered from schizoid personality disorder (SPD), which is said to be a pretty rare disorder . It’s because of his unusual illness that he became involved with my second identity . After my second

identity was superimposed with him, he had to remain within 500 meters of me .

I'll always remember what Mr Blond told me back then .

“His name is Nie Zun . He and you just happen to be complements . It's rare for someone with multiple identities to arrive in Split Zone No . 13 . Because they have two conscious existences, it's less likely that both of those will be caught and brought here . But you just happened to be that lucky one in ten thousand . Because your second identity resonated with Nie Zun at some point, your personality overlapped and filled in Nie Zun's missing part . In other words, someone with too much dropped a piece, and that piece was picked up by someone with too little, and then two complete persons were brought here . Since there was a time difference between your existences, one of you arrived an hour earlier, and one later . But an hour in the Split Zone is hardly considered any time at all . ”

And I remember the scene when Mr Blond told me those words .

I remember that I grew very anxious . I pointed at Nie Zun as I asked Mr Blond, “What you're saying is that my second identity lives within him now?”

“That's not entirely correct, but you can think of it that way . Nie Zun is still Nie Zun, not your second identity . However, because the two of you arrived here as complements of a whole, you two cannot be separated . ”

For a long time after that, I detested Nie Zun . Even now, I still hated him, because I suspected that the one who killed the person I loved was now a part of him .

It's because of this unusual relationship that the two of us must always remain within 500 meters of the other . Once the distance between us reached 500 meters, neither of us would be able to move if the other didn't follow and cooperate .

But this tethering bond between us didn't make me like him any more . I still hated him, even though I knew that I didn't have any other reasons to .

In the end, the person who killed my beloved wasn't him, but me .

Maybe it was just my selfishness . I couldn't hate myself, or rather, the hate I had for myself could never surpass the guilt and pain I felt . So, I could only hate him .

Nie Zun's quiet voice cut into my thoughts . "You're that interested in my past? You should at least wait until we live past tonight to ask . "

Nie Zun's quiet voice cut into my thoughts . "You're that interested in my past? You should at least wait until we live past tonight to ask . "

Hearing him say that, I suddenly became alert . I quickly sat up on the branch and reached the bow on my left shoulder .

When I finally took a look around, I suddenly felt a prickling on my face, like something was sweeping past it . I turned my head up .

"Ahhh—!!!" Seeing the scene above me, I couldn't help screaming out . But my body remained still, only swaying ever so slightly .

I saw a woman's face above my head, and her hair was sweeping across my face .

Screaming was a subconscious reactional habit that I retained from being alive . But after my scream, I calmed down and looked at the face before me .

I took in the scene . There was a woman sitting on a higher branch, and hers was a face that I recognized .

Of course I couldn't not recognize her . That pale, white face with a pair of large, dark, and empty eyes . Unless you had amnesia, you wouldn't forget that face after you saw it once .

I stabilized myself, and then leaned back against the branch, until I returned to my original position . My left hand was holding my bow, as my right hand steadied myself on the side . I put some distance between our faces, but she didn't seem to move, her face still expressionless .

With a charming laugh, I said, “Sly S, I am Li Zhen . ”

Hearing me speak, her soulless eyes suddenly quivered slightly, but just slightly .

“What are you doing in Eastside?” This was the first time I’d heard her speak . In the past, I’d only seen her from afar, never face to face . Her voice didn’t sound at all like I’d expected . It was strange and thick, a bit hoarse, but not unpleasant . And it seemed to have a womanly appeal to it .

I didn’t know how to respond, so I said, “I came to hang out with you . Exchange our feelings and the like . ”

Just as I spoke, I heard Nie Zun’s mocking laugh . I couldn’t help but turn to glare at him, sitting on another tree .

But after I looked that way, I saw three white-clothed people floating in the air behind him .

Each of them had on a conical hat that blocked their faces, as they floated there in white robes . (t/n: Wiki on Asian conical hats)

According to Nie Zun, floating in the air required 30 MF . In that case, these people must have had at least 40 MF, though, likely more than that .

I started to panic a bit, and I couldn’t help turning to Nie Zun . But he wasn’t looking at me . Instead, his gaze was fixed on the female above my head .

I started to panic a bit, and I couldn’t help turning to Nie Zun . But he wasn’t looking at me . Instead, his gaze was fixed on the female above my head .

I vigorously tried winking at him, to signal the danger behind him .

No matter the effort I put in though, Nie Zun was still staring at the demoness above me . I turned my head up, and after seeing that Sly S was still looking at me intently, I turned back to Nie Zun and continued winking .

I'd rather keep winking than look at this frightful woman!

Nie Zun didn't look to me, but he did respond in his lazy tone, "Your eyes are going to start flying . Stop blinking . I'm aware of the three dear friends behind me . "

After Nie Zun said that, I suddenly became embarrassed .

Sly S's rough voice sounded again . "Without my instruction, they won't make a move . Don't be scared . "

Who's scared?! I couldn't help rolling my eyes in my head . Of course I knew that those three people were the so-called protectors that were never far from Sly S . No one had ever seen their real faces, because they were always wearing those hats . Legend has it that they all look exactly the same because they're triplets . But who knew if that was true .

I wasn't sure how strong the three of them were either . In the stories I'd heard, when Sly S was in great danger, her three A-rank guards were also present, so these three guys hadn't needed to make a move .

But from the current situation, it seemed that they weren't weak .

My mind suddenly started to calculate the odds of my escaping if a fight were to really start up . (Passerby A: Shouldn't you be calculating your odds of victory? Me: Quit playing . How could I possibly be victorious in this kind of situation .)

But soon, my mind moved to another question . What was she doing out in the middle of the night? And didn't this mean that she hadn't gone to Southside as Nie Zun had predicted?

Just as I was considering the different possibilities, Sly S jumped off the tree . Seeing her jump down, I also quickly leapt down from the tree .

And following that, Nie Zun also leapt down . And then, of course, the three shadows behind him also floated down, though they still circled Nie Zun .

Black lines appeared on my forehead . Didn't the fact that they were circling Nie Zun mean that they felt his threat to Sly S was greater than mine? Were they looking down on me? (Passerby B: Of course he's a bigger threat . His MF is more than 10 levels higher than yours! Me: slaps Passerby B)

I stood across from Sly S, and she looked as if she wanted to say something . But suddenly two gusts of wind appeared and two people appeared before Sly S .

Muscle Man and the mummy .

My heart wailed in anguish . 6 v 2, no way we could win .

Muscle Man and the mummy .

My heart wailed in anguish . 6 v 2, no way we could win .

But after glancing at me, neither Muscle Man nor the mummy seemed at all concerned with me . Instead, they hastily reported to Sly S, "Commander, four of the seven B-rank officers have been assassinated . They're dead inside of their rooms . "

This news was greatly alarming . Four of seven B-rank officers were killed? From what I knew, B-rank officers in S Clan had MFs around 35-40 . Who could kill off four of them? And since Muscle Man and the mummy were making this report, they must have been at least B-rank officers as well .

"What about the other three?" Sly S didn't sound panicked, and in fact, didn't have much of a reaction at all . She remained emotionless .

"The other three B-rank officers went to Southside and have yet to return . But we were able to call them, and they're safe for now . "

Okay . So Muscle Man and the mummy must be two of the A-rank officers .

Suddenly, the mummy's eyes swept over me . "Commander, the Westside commander came to see you today, so I'm afraid that she can't be cleared from suspicion . "

I immediately retorted, “Don’t make blind allegations . You’re suspecting that I’m related to those deaths?”

“Your visitation today was the only thing out of the ordinary . Who else would be able to kill four B-rank officers?” The mummy glared at me with hostility .

“Let’s not make such hasty conclusions,” Sly S said .

And then, she slowly turned her head towards the three white-clothed persons behind Nie Zun . “Find out who did this . And whoever it was, make sure they disappear from the Split Zone . ”

With her words, my hairs all stood on end .

After hearing her order, the three white-robed figures vanished from my sight with a whoosh .

Even though Sly S didn’t seem to express any reaction to the death of four high-ranking officers, she must have felt angry and hurt . While I may not understand her, I did know something, and that was that she’d never before ordered the white robes to leave her side .

Suddenly, a strange feeling slipped into my heart . I felt a sense of sadness from out of nowhere, and so I lifted my head to look at Sly S .

She was looking back at me .

Chapter 10

10

Gao Qin Jiu Ye

“A district commander with only 52 MF . Mr Blond must have seen something in you, but what was it...?” Sly S’s voice flit through the air, and then she suddenly appeared right next to me .

At some point during all this, she suddenly drew out a sword with her left hand .

With an easy wave, a sword sliced down at me .

I quickly sidestepped and dodged, grabbing my bow with my left hand . I pulled out an arrow and aimed at Sly S’s left eye .

Without the slightest hesitation, I fired .

Sly S didn’t move to avoid it, so it pierced directly into her left eye .

I was taken aback . My arrows were coated with an extra pain stimulating chemical, causing their targets to feel 100 times more pain than they otherwise would . Moreover, the arrow had struck her eye .

But Sly S didn’t appear to feel any pain at all . An arrow was sticking out of her left eye, as fresh blood flowed down, but she didn’t make any move and her other eye was just opened wide, staring at me .

Then, the sword in her hand arced down at me again!

Once more, I sidestepped, and then I glanced over at Nie Zun .

Nie Zun was standing still in his original spot . He wasn't looking at me, but rather, his gaze was locked on Sly S . At some point, Muscle Man and the mummy had moved to either side of Nie Zun, seemingly waiting for their next order .

Slightly distracted, Sly S had already pulled the arrow I shot into her eye . I could see her lens being pulled out as well, but almost immediately after, her eye seemed to have completely healed over . During the whole process, there was no hint of hesitation . Her motions had been executed very smoothly .

I frowned . Grabbing a second arrow, I aimed at her left eye once more .

As I aimed at her, she raised her sword in preparation to attack again . Suddenly, a light chuckle sounded from nearby .

“That's all your skill amounts to, and you want me to work for you?”

Everyone on the scene turned towards the source of the words .

This person had likely been hiding in the forest the entire time, somewhere outside of our field of vision . Now, this person slowly walked out from a dark crevice .

As I watched him walk into our line of sight, my grip on my bow turned unsteady .

Sly S seemed to be even more startled than me . Her already wide eyes somehow grew even wider .

He was a man around the same age as Nie Zun and myself . His hair was dark brown and medium length, and he wore a white shirt and black jeans along with a pair of clashing bright yellow sneakers . His eyes were nearly the same color as his hair, and he looked completely ordinary, just like someone from the real world . Perhaps the only thing out of place was the flexible sword at his waist .

I'd seen such flexible weapons before, and they were even harder to wield than a whip . Very few people used it .

Seeing his face and those brown eyes, my body couldn't help trembling .

But he wasn't looking at me . He was looking at Sly S .

The mummy had already moved to this man's side as he said, "Gao Qin Jiu Ye, our commander sent three B-rank officers to Southside to recruit you, but how did you end up here?"

"Oh, so you sent those three stalkers . Sorry, I got rid of them..." A strange smile appeared on Gao Qin Jiu Yue's lips, his dark brown eyes shimmering .

I felt a bit unstable and I staggered backwards .

My unusual behaviour must have attracted his attention because he was suddenly looking right at me .

As his brown eyes looked at me, I couldn't help dropping my bow to the ground . I grabbed my head with both hands and violently shook my head . No, no, no... How could he be here?

Seeing my panic, a flash of surprise crossed his eyes . "Have we met before?"

I stepped back, and then I felt Nie Zun appear behind me . He supported me up with his right hand and grabbed the bow I'd dropped in his left hand .

I stepped back, and then I felt Nie Zun appear behind me . He supported me up with his right hand and grabbed the bow I'd dropped in his left hand .

I didn't turn back to look at Nie Zun . I just borrowed his strength and leaned against him .

"G-Gao Qi... How could you be here?" Tears were nearly flowing out of my eyes .

“Gao Qi? Haha, I’m sorry . While my surname is indeed Gao, my name isn’t Gao Qi . I’m... Gao Qin Jiu Ye . ” He smiled at me, his eyes ever resplendent .

I couldn’t understand what I was seeing . The person standing in front of me now, the one who called himself Gao Qin Jiu Ye, was the person I’d had a crush on, the person I’d unintentionally killed—Senior Gao Qi!

I couldn’t be mistaken . His hair and his eyes were a natural but unordinary kind of brown . His pupils were slightly larger than other people’s, and they emitted an enchanting kind of light . Moreover, he always wore a white shirt with black jeans and a pair of yellow sneakers! I remember always teasing him about the odd pairing . A grown man wearing bright yellow shoes, and with a white shirt and black jeans at that!

Sly S’s voice suddenly sounded, “No matter who you’ve mistaken him for, you’re wrong . He’s been in the Split Zone for more than twice the time you’ve been here . ”

“Since you know that I’ve been here even longer than you, Sly S, why do you act so impudently towards me? Aren’t you looking down on Southside too much?” Gao Qin Jiu Ye laughed tenderly . His words to Sly S were very gentle, as if he were speaking words of endearment . But even a fool could sense the callous, even murderous intent in his speech .

“You’re an antique, yes, but so what? I appreciate your ability, and so I invited you into my clan . You call that impudence?” Sly S suddenly smiled as well .

This was my first time seeing her smile . Her pale smile sat on her face, under two lifeless eyes, looking extremely ghastly .

“Well, whether or not I’d want to serve you depends on your ability . ” As he spoke, Gao Qin Jiu Ye suddenly formed a whirlwind of air . From the vortex, a streak of wind slashed at Sly S!

Seemingly at the same time, the air around Sly S started to vibrate, and frozen ice pellets seemed to appear . I could hear a hissing, like something

was about to crack .

When he felt the air around us changing, Nie Zun grabbed me by the collar and pulled me back .

Behind Gao Qin Jiu Ye, Muscle Man and the mummy also took several steps back .

A dense thicket of air needles flew out from Gao Qin Jiu Ye's whirlwind towards Sly S, and my eyes could barely keep up .

Sly S didn't try to dodge his attack . Instead, she seemed to have condensed the air needles headed for her . Almost like a pool of water shattering, the condensed air popped apart and disappeared .

My heart started trembling . The two of them were so strong that they could even control the way air flowed?

My heart started trembling . The two of them were so strong that they could even control the way air flowed?

Gao Qin Jiu Ye remained still . When he saw that Sly S had neutralized his attack without having to move a step, he suddenly laughed deviously and pulled out the dark sword at his waist .

At the same time, Sly S's expression tensed . She turned to Muscle Man and commanded, "Tao Lie, get him!"

The muscular man called Tao Lie immediately made a move . He extended his arms and grabbed Gao Qin Jiu Ye .

Gao Qin Jiu Ye didn't turn back and simply said, "Stop . "

Muscle Man suddenly stopped, frozen in place like a rock .

Meanwhile, Gao Qin Jiu Ye moved to draw out his long sword .

Sly S glowered, and then the air around her started to contract . I could even feel my skin start to tighten .

The scene was tense, in preparation for an attack that would happen at any moment, when suddenly the sound of a phone ringing came from Gao Qin Jiu Ye .

“Lala, I’m a little duckie~ Lala, I want to swim across the river~” The unexpected sound of an incoming call suddenly drifted from Gao Qin Jiu Ye’s jeans’ pocket .

Everyone at the scene was stunned, and I felt like countless crows were flying past us .

This ringtone...

My lips twitched . Gao Qin Jiu Ye simply let go of his sword and shrugged . He pulled out the cellphone from his pocket .

“Hello? Si Luo, what is it?”

A strange expression crossed Sly S’s face when she heard Si Luo’s name .

I don’t know what the person on the other end of the phone said, but Gao Qin Jiuye responded, “Okay, then I’ll head back . ”

After he put away his phone, his expression turned cold . Then he told Sly S, “We’ll meet again, beautiful . ”

Without waiting for our reactions, he dashed off to the border .

After he put away his phone, his expression turned cold . Then he told Sly S, “We’ll meet again, beautiful . ”

Without waiting for our reactions, he dashed off to the border .

But it wasn’t yet light, so as he approached, the borderline between the districts lit up brightly, showing the boundary barrier . However, Gao Qin Jiuye didn’t slow down .

I tried to open my eyes wider to see what would happen, but the boundary was just like a vast sheet of whiteness .

In just one second, he'd already disappeared from before my eyes . After the borderline flashed with light, it immediately returned to its ordinary dark appearance, like nothing had happened at all .

“N-no way . No one can cross the borders at night...” I stammered .

Sly S also seemed to be frowning . She continued to stare in the direction that Gao Qin Jiu Ye disappeared in .

Nie Zun suddenly whispered into my ear . “Shh . From this point on, don't say anything . ”

The feeling of Nie Zun's wet lips near my ear left me a bit uncomfortable . I shook off his hand that was still on my shoulder .

Nie Zun's lazy voice suddenly sounded, with no hurry . “Sly S, the sky will light soon . Why don't we all return to our own bases . As for your dead clan members, if you're interested in investigating, you're welcome to Westside anytime . Westside hasn't been entirely calm recently either, and there have been a number of bizarre deaths . I hope that we can keep in touch, as I suspect our goals are the same . ”

Sly S turned to Nie Zun . After a moment, she said to the muscular man, Tao Lie, and the mummy, “Tao Lie, Mu Li, let's return . ”

So the mummy was called Mu Li . What a strange name .

Then, Sly S and her men moved . As they passed by me, she turned to look at me . Her eyes still looked just as lifeless as before .

I felt a chill .

After Sly S left, I finally let out a breath . I tidied up my hair, and then pat my frightened heart .

“You know Gao Qin Jiu Ye?” Nie Zun asked me .

I paused . After a moment, I turned my head and looked in the other direction . Then I started running, returning to Westside .

“No, I don’t know him,” I finally said as I ran .

Chapter 11

11

Brief Tranquility

“Do you know someone named Gao Qin Jiu Ye?” I took a sip of milk and asked You Ji, who was sitting on my bed .

You could eat and drink as much as you wanted here, and it wouldn’t affect your body at all . That, at least, was still a good thing .

“Gao Qin Jiu Ye? Who’s that? I’ve never heard of him . ” You Ji was currently combing through her green hair .

With an annoyed look, I complained, “Go outside to comb . Don’t leave a pile of green hair on my bed . ”

You Ji completely ignored me and continued combing . “Did something interesting happen while you were in Eastside?”

“It’s best not to talk about it . But there is something I need you to check out . ”

“What is it?”

“It seems that Laurel didn’t die . Jie Pa said that someone had been disguised as her . ”

A flash of surprise crossed You Ji’s eyes . “Jie Pa? The one from the market?”

“Which other one is there?” I asked .

“I’ll go talk to him . If Laurel really didn’t die, I’ll find her as fast as I can .
” After You Ji finished speaking, she got up to leave .

“Okay . But if you’re heading downstairs, pass by the first floor and tell Old Man Fan to make a trip up here . ”

“Got it . ” You Ji nodded .

When Fan knocked on the door, I called out, “Old Man, grow your head back and then come in!”

Seeing Fan looking like an ordinary, friendly old man, I happily smiled .

Fan raised a trembling hand, as if he were about to touch me . Tears welled up in his eyes .

“What are you doing?” I asked with a face of disgust .

“Ah Zhen, I was very worried about you . They didn’t hurt you in Eastside, did they?” Old Man Fan sounded like he wanted to cry .

“Aiya, who would have hurt me? I’m still a district commander,” I responded . “Grandpa, I want to ask you something . Do you know of someone named Gao Qin Jiu Ye?”

Fan started at the mention of this name . Then he staggered over to a chair and sat down .

“Southside’s Gao Qin Jiu Ye?” Fan asked seriously, his usually tearful demeanor now gone .

Grandpa Fan was rarely this serious, so I also grew solemn .

“Mmh, that’s right . Him . He seems pretty strong . We met him in Eastside today . ”

“Although I’ve been in the Split Zone for a very long time, I don’t know much about him . I have heard though, that his activities are rather unusual . And he only obeys the commands of Southside’s Si Luo . He doesn’t even

listen to Mr Blond . No one seems to know what his mental force amounts to . He's someone without a record, and he works in strange ways . Sometimes he's good, sometimes bad . If you provoke him, he'll torture you with extreme cruelty . ”

I nodded, as I thought this over .

“How did he appear in Eastside? They say that he never leaves Southside . ”

“It seemed like Sly S was trying to recruit him . ” I took another sip of milk . Wah, delicious, I sighed .

Old Man Fan looked at me with concern . “Ah Zhen, I'll be frank with you . You should properly train . Running away blindly has no purpose . Since all these people are stuck here, they should at least be comfortable and safe . You have the responsibility to protect all the residents of this district, so you can't continue on this way . ”

I tilted my head slightly and touched the glass in my hand . “Grandpa, what I don't get is why I have to protect them . What does their life or death have to do with me?”

Old Man Fan rationalized, “You either protect them or they become your transgression . That is the way of the real world, and this place is no different . Also, consider why Mr Blond chose you as a district commander . It's because he knew that you wouldn't leave everyone to die . There are many people here who don't care about living, but you're not one of them . ”

“Why is living so tough everywhere? What's the point of it all?” I lifted my head and looked towards the window .

“Why is living so tough everywhere? What's the point of it all?” I lifted my head and looked towards the window .

Fan suddenly asked, “Have you ever thought about why there exist soul splitters, why they brought us here?”

I shook my head . “I never understood it . ”

“Perhaps these soul splitters exist for the purpose of telling us to cherish our lives . No one here had a meticulously clean record while they lived,” Fan started profoundly . “Then, have you ever thought about why it’s so difficult to find our soul splitters? If you were to find the reason for living, do you think our soul splitter would just be brought to us, by some work of fate?”

I was a bit distracted as I considered what Old Man Fan was saying .

After some unknown time, I suddenly raised my head and smiled warmly at the old man . “I understand, Grandpa . Don’t worry, I’ll protect all of you . I won’t let what happened to Laurel happen in Westside again . ”

Grandpa Fan nodded .

Nie Zun was lying on top of the residential building, his hands tucked behind his head, as he stared up at the sky .

I rolled my eyes as I looked at his carefree attitude .

“Miss me?” Nie Zun asked .

“What I’d like is for you to die . ” I scoffed and walked over to him . Then I laid down and rested my head on my arms as well . (t/n: the word for “to miss” is the same as “to want/like for something”)

“The sky here really is pitch black . ” He yawned .

“Nie Zun, Gao Qin Jiu Ye looks just like the senior that I killed . ” Instead of looking at the pitch black sky he mentioned, I closed my eyes .

Beside me, there was just silence .

After some time, Nie Zun’s lazy tone sounded again .

“This place has always been strange . Anything that happens can be considered normal . But you know, right . No matter what, everything here is all fake . ”

I kept my eyes closed . “If you think everything is fake, then why don’t you wake up?”

I heard a soft laugh . “I said it’s all fake, not that I was dreaming . I don’t know why we ended up in this place . What I do know is that we can go back . So, there’s no need to be overly concerned about anything here . ”

I heard a soft laugh . “I said it’s all fake, not that I was dreaming . I don’t know why we ended up in this place . What I do know is that we can go back . So, there’s no need to be overly concerned about anything here . ”

In the darkness, I finally opened my eyes . “You’re so accepting of this situation, but I really don’t get it . What is it about you that resembles my second identity? I have a hard time believing that someone as optimistic as you would somehow resonate with a demonic killer . ”

He smiled . “Don’t put it like that . That demonic killer is a part of you . Moreover, someone like me is probably good at convincing others . ”

“I often think that it might just be better if the two of us just die . ” I turned my head and looked at the side of Nie Zun’s face .

Even from the side, you could still see that calm, indifferent smile .

“Then let’s die together . But tonight isn’t the night for it . Don’t go talking about eternity, dying as you lived, loving without bounds... That kind of stuff, okay?” His voice was very clear .

I couldn’t help laughing . Then I closed my eyes and didn’t say any more .

An evening breeze blew past, and it felt very pleasant against my skin .

A voice suddenly sounded behind us . “The two of you sure are in a good mood . ”

I opened my eyes and sat up . Turning back, I saw Song Lu and Yu Liang .

Even if I didn’t have a large fangroup like S Clan to protect me, as Westside Commander, I did have several friends, at least .

Song Lu and Yu Liang probably counted as my friends .

They were a famous pair of lovers in Westside . It's said that Song Lu developed schizophrenia after being raped in the real world . After arriving here, she kept to herself and was uncommunicative for a long time . It was Yu Liang who finally pulled her out from the darkness .

I really envied her relationship with Yu Liang, and I always thought of her as an older sister . A few days ago, the two had gone to Northside in search of Mr Blond, to allow them a glimpse of themselves in real life . They finally returned today .

“Song Lu jie!” I rushed over with excitement and hugged Song Lu . (t/n: jie or jiejie means “older sister,” but is also an affectionate term for an older female)

Song Lu had a super hot body and a gorgeous head of curly hair that fell to her shoulders . I rubbed my face against hers .

“You perverted girl, release my wife!” Yu Liang called out exasperatedly .

“Hmph . ” I ignored him .

“You perverted girl, release my wife!” Yu Liang called out exasperatedly .

“Hmph . ” I ignored him .

Song Lu lovely pat my head . “I heard a lot happened while I was gone . Is everything okay?”

“Yeah . Now that you two are back, there's nothing I'm scared of anymore . ” I let go of Song Lu . Then I spread my arms out, tilted, and pretended to fly around the rooftop like a plane .

Song Lu sighed . “I heard from Old Man Fan, and I decided that I'm going to start training you tomorrow . While it's difficult to raise your mental force, it's not entirely impossible . You'll just have to work really hard . I can't let you get away with loafing around anymore . ” Song Lu smiled at me .

“That’s right . People in Eastside can manipulate the air, but she can fall off a building while she’s running . What’s up with that difference, right?” Nie Zun bantered .

I rolled my eyes at him .

“Yeah . It just so happens that our trip to Northside was quite insightful . After talking to Mr Blond, we returned with some new methods to control mental force . It’ll be helpful for training Ah Zhen . Want to give it a try?” Yu Liang pointed at me as he spoke to Nie Zun .

I couldn’t help jumping in . “Hey, hey, you’re treating me like a test subject now? I’m still a district commander, okay, Yu Liang? Just because your wife likes me more than you, you can’t get revenge like this . ”

Yu Liang smiled innocently . “Don’t try to escape . We’re not going to let you get out of this training . ”

I curled my lips and put on an expression like I wanted to cry . Then I wrapped my arms around Song Lu . “Song Lu jiejie, they’re bullying me . ”

“I agree with Yu Liang this time . ” Song Lu covered her mouth and laughed .

“Oh no, I’m done for...” I wailed .

So, for the next week, I spent every day being trained by Song Lu and Yu Liang . As for Nie Zun, he mostly laid around at the side, looking like a boneless coward .

After a week of nonstop training, day and night, I was finally able to increase my mental force to 53 . And now, I also didn’t have to use any MF for ordinary jumping, combat, or running . That counted as a success, surely . Well, I was very satisfied .

However, Song Lu and Yu Liang’s opinion boiled down to: This child is too dumb to teach .

I hadn't learned any cool moves during the week of training . And while it's true that not everyone could increase their MF in a week, but considering that my mental force was much weaker than the other two district commanders to start with, this extra one level of mental force was just enough to allow me to expend some on my sexy appearance . The two of them helplessly shook their heads at me .

And while I was training like my life was on the line, I often saw a scene of the lazy Nie Zun, sleeping at the side like a dead pig .

Chapter 12

12

The Return of Slaughtering

Jie Pa could often be found in a store at the center of the first floor of the market building . He ran a small liquor shop where he was often mixing up cocktails . His gentlemanly appearance always attracted a lot of passing eyes .

Split Zone was a place that its inhabitants had grown accustomed to . Even though people enjoyed morphing into all sorts of creatures at the start, they would eventually grow tired of that pastime . Then, they would return to their ordinary, human appearances and live ordinary lives .

And where there lived humans, there existed love .

The Split Zone is no exception .

A lot of people found true love here . People were free to cohabit as they pleased, but it wasn't possible to have children . Of course, that was a wish that many in the real world chased after—being able to live a happy life with the one you loved, without having to worry about caring for children .

I was currently sitting inside Jie Pa's wine shop, waiting for him to deliver a new cocktail concoction he'd created .

“Test out my new drink, Foul Dismemberment . ” Jie Pa placed a glass of something red in front of me, and then he gave Nie Zun the same .

My mouth twitched . “Jie Pa, can I just give a suggestion? Can't you choose a name that's more normal, more moderate? Otherwise, who would want to

drink this?”

“No, I think the name’s very fitting . ” Nie Zun had already taken several sips .

Of course, they were a pair of weirdos .

“If it’s not to your liking, I’ll make you something else,” Jie Pa responded respectfully . (t/n: uses polite form of you/your)

“My good sir, please, let’s not be so formal with each other . Just call me Ah Zhen . ” I waved my hand that there was no need to change the drink .

“Alright, Ms Ah Zhen . ”

.....

“Oh yeah, has Mr Blond supplied any new and interesting items recently?”

“One of the weapons shops recieved something new, and I thought it would be quite fitting for you, Ms Ah Zhen . Why don’t I take you for a look?”

I shook my head . I didn’t want to change my weapon .

Then Nie Zun suddenly said, “You should learn how to use a second weapon . A bow and arrow aren’t very good for short range combat . Let’s go take a look . ”

After considering it, I decided that Nie Zun was right . So, I got up and followed Jie Pa .

Jie Pa led Nie Zun and me to the elevator and pressed the button for the 7th floor .

As the elevator ascended, Jie Pa suddenly turned to Nie Zun and said, “The weapons shop also received something that I think you’ll like a lot . ”

“Oh? That I’ll like? We’ll have to take a look then . ” A flash of intrigue crossed Nie Zun’s eyes .

We got off the elevator on the 7th floor and then walked for roughly three hours before arriving at Shop Number 77777 .

A middle-aged married couple, who I vaguely recognized, ran the weapons shop . I'd received my bow from a different weapons shop, but this place was much loved in Westside .

When he saw us enter the shop, the husband called to his wife, "Ah Wen, bring out the two weapons that Mr Jie instructed us to prepare . The Commander and Nie Zun have arrived . "

"I'll be right out . " Shortly after her response, a gentle looking woman appeared .

The woman called Ah Wen was carrying two boxes . She handed one to me and the other to Nie Zun .

I opened the box, and my eyes couldn't help sparkle at what they saw .

A purple whip . The craftsmanship was exquisite, and its length was very fitting . While I was alive, I'd learned ribbon dancing for a period of time, so with a bit of practice, I ought to be able to use this whip with ease .

The whip was made from some material that I couldn't quite identify, but it was very tough . Its tail also seemed to be covered with extremely fine spines .

"Commander, be careful . This whip is called The Piercer . It's a very unique weapon, and we had to leap through numerous hoops to get our hands on it . The spines on the tail of the whip have been infused with a special substance . If you strike an opponent, their ensuing wounds will not be able to heal for an hour, and the pain they feel will be increased one hundred fold . The body of the whip is formed with a special material that cannot be broken with ordinary strength or severed by knives and swords . "

"Wow, that's amazing . " This weapon was delightfully surprising .

"Wow, that's amazing . " This weapon was delightfully surprising .

I turned my head to watch as Nie Zun opened his box, which contained a pair of gloves .

They were black and looked just like the ones on his hands inside his pockets .

I'd always scoffed at his odd hobby of covering up every inch of his body, so I naturally didn't think much of the gloves . But when Nie Zun saw the gloves, his eyes seemed to light up in surprise .

He was so pleased with these new gloves that he quickly shed his old ones and exchanged them for this new pair .

Nie Zun rarely took off his gloves, and when he did, they would be replaced very quickly . But his hands were very pretty, with slender and pale fingers . On the little finger of his left hand, he wore a ring with a skeleton pattern .

The ring hadn't left too much of an impression on me, but I did remember that it looked very delicate .

After thanking the couple, Nie Zun, Jie Pa, and I headed out to return to Jie Pa's wine shop .

After exiting the shop, a loud noise suddenly sounded behind us . Everyone fell forward to the ground .

On the floor, I turned my head back and realized that the walls inside the shop were covered in blood .

The shopkeeper looked at his wife blankly .

It seemed that a small bomb-like object had been placed on her . Her body had broken up into pieces and landed on the ground . Her head and body had been separated as well .

She's likely swallowed the explosive device, which wasn't actually all that powerful . She was the only one to be blown up, while everyone else had remained unharmed .

One of her arms had landed outside the shop, writhing on the ground .

People started poking their heads out of the surrounding shops, curious about what was happening .

We got up from the ground and pat the dust off our clothes . Seeing that Ah Wen's hand was still moving, I knew things would be okay . She would recover quickly enough, and then they could investigate the incident .

But then, a young boy suddenly appeared beside my leg . He looked to be about 5 or 6 years old, and I'd never seen him before . He ran over to where Ah Wen's blown-off hand was, and then he turned back to look at me .

I saw something dark and sinister in his eyes, a look that a child wouldn't have . As my suspicions started to grow, the boy suddenly bent over and grabbed the splitting key hanging around his neck .

I saw something dark and sinister in his eyes, a look that a child wouldn't have . As my suspicions started to grow, the boy suddenly bent over and grabbed the splitting key hanging around his neck .

I could feel that something wasn't right, so I leapt at him .

But it was too late . When I arrived at his side, I heard a click, like a key turning inside a lock . The key had already been shoved into the split symbol on Ah Wen's bloody hand .

Ah Wen's body parts had been crawling back together, about to rejoin, but then they suddenly stopped .

Boom! Boom! Boom!

Blood splattered in all directions and bits of flesh flew into the air .

Right in front of my eyes, that little boy received his punishment for killing another, exploding into a shower of rain .

In accordance with the rules of this world, after committing the crime of murder, the offender was blown to bits, with no form or shape remaining .

After getting covered in blood, I simply stood frozen in place .

I could feel the fresh blood slipping down my face . A slimy bone and blood mixture dripped from my face onto my neck and collarbone, quickly covering my whole body .

Screams sounded from the crowd . Even as the smell of blood and flesh struck my nose, I seemed to be numb .

The shopkeeper suddenly ran out and knelt on the floor . He held his wife's now motionless hand, as he sat still as a statue .

I suddenly wanted to extend a hand to comfort him, but when I saw my arm, I realized that my entire body was covered in the little boy's fresh, sticky blood . My arm looked like it had reached out from the bloody river of hell, carrying malice and evil . I froze, staring but still not quite comprehending my arm's appearance .

The shopkeeper seemed to sense something . He raised his head and looked at me with fearful eyes, looking like he wanted to hide .

Seeing the shopkeeper's terrified expression, I couldn't help feel a sudden pain in my heart, but I couldn't move .

And then, something seemed to grab me from behind .

Nie Zun grabbed my hand without the slightest hesitation and pulled me to his side .

I looked down at Nie Zun's tight clasp on my hand, the brand new gloves that he wore were now dirtied with blood . He stared coldly at the pool of blood on the ground .

Jie Pa quickly stepped forward and calmly crouched down . He gave the shopkeeper a pat on the back . "We'll be sure to find out what happened . Someone will be coming to take her to the corpse grave . You should follow along to see her leave . "

I looked down at Nie Zun's tight clasp on my hand, the brand new gloves that he wore were now dirtied with blood . He stared coldly at the pool of blood on the ground .

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Sympathetic eyes appeared in the crowd, but no one made a move or said anything . Perhaps death was all too common in the Split Zone . But then, I realized that a lot of people were looking at me suspiciously .

And then I was hit by another realization . There were a lot of people in Westside that I didn't recognize .

While there were tens of thousands of residents in a district and unfamiliar faces weren't unusual, I suddenly felt that after half a year of being a district commander, I was completely unqualified .

Nie Zun was still holding tightly onto my hand . He took another look at the pool of blood, and then dragged me backwards .

Nie Zun ordered me, "Go back to your room and clean up . We'll discuss this afterwards . "

I didn't retort or even respond, simply letting him drag me out .

With a nod towards Jie Pa, Nie Zun added, "I'll leave this to you, Jie Pa . "

Nie Zun pulled me along, running across the rooftop at his fastest pace, and it seemed that no one really noticed that I was covered in blood .

But when I got to the 13th floor, a lot of residents turned to look me over, like they were staring at an assassin who'd just made a kill .

Those expressions turned the air around me chilly . The scene didn't bring up flashbacks of my killing Senior Gao Qi, but perhaps because of the

blood, I did recall the truth that I was in fact a murderer . My body couldn't help trembling .

Seeming to have felt my shaking, Nie Zun added force to his grip on my hand, as if he wanted to comfort me somehow .

After entering my room, You Ji, who'd been inside cleaning up my arrow bag, saw me covered in blood and cried out, "What happened?!"

"Let her get cleaned up . I'll give you the details . " Nie Zun dragged me over to the bathroom, opened the door, and gave me a gentle shove inside . Before closing the door, he looked at me and said, "Don't think about it too much . Get cleaned up, and then we'll talk about it . "

After the door closed, I moved stiffly, like a wooden doll . I turned on the water and stepped into the bathtub .

The water streamed over my head, diluting the bloodstains across my body .

I trembled as I crouched down and hugged my legs .

Chapter 13

Volume 1

13 Suffocating Nightmare

As I curled up in the bathtub, several broken memories flashed through my mind.

“Hey, why are you helping her? Haven’t you heard? She has a mental illness!”

“Ah? That can’t be, right? Look how pitiful she is. She fell over, but no one’s even going to help her...”

“Aiya, let’s go. Just mind your own business. I’m telling you, she has problems up there...”

I must have turned on the cold water, because I felt the piercing, chilly water fall from my head to my legs. I scoffed. In a shitty place like this, where you’re neither dead or alive, you could still feel cold?

When I exited the bathroom, You Ji looked at me uneasily. I smiled at her, letting her know that I was okay.

Instead of her usual snake look, You Ji was dressed in casual garb. She walked over to me and grabbed my hand. “I’ll find out what happened. Don’t put too much pressure on yourself.”

“I’m fine. By the way, did you find out what happened with Laurel?”

You Ji swallowed. “There’s been a bit of progress, but...”

“Just tell me.” I looked at her, a bit suspicious.

She sighed and then said, “Per Jie Pa’s suggestion, we found someone with a keen sense of smell to investigate, but the trail cut at the Northern District border. So, I suspect that Laurel is currently in the Northern District.”

I frowned. The Northern District is a different story from the Southern District. The layout of the Northern District is different from the other three districts, and those who resided there were people recognized by Mr Blond. Ordinarily, unless we’re summoned, outsiders can’t just casually enter the Northern District. And when we do travel there, it’s only to the hall in the district center. The Northern District is a place beyond our understanding.

“Should we ask to meet with Mr Blond about this?” You Ji asked, looking to me.

I shook my head. “He hasn’t been very happy with me lately. If this really involves someone from the Northern District, I can’t make an accusation so lightly. Let me think about it a bit.”

You Ji smiled. “Alright, then I’m going to see Jie Pa about what happened today. You and Nie Zun can discuss some more.” She squeezed my hand, and then she headed to the door.

Just before she left, she turned back and said, “Laurel once told me that the moment she saw you, she took you as her older sister because she really liked you. Don’t worry. We’ll definitely find her and bring her back.”

As You Ji walked out the door, I lied down in my bed and looked up at the ceiling. Nie Zun was calmer than one would expect. He remained silent as he leaned against the wall by the door. After staring at the ceiling awhile, I finally said, “Nie Zun, I couldn’t even save someone who was right in front of me.”

Since he didn’t respond even after several minutes, I lifted my head to look at him. He was looking at me, but since his bangs covered his face, I could only see one eye. It looked bright, and yet dark.

I shot him a smile. “Since you resonated with that cruel version of me, tell me, do you think it was her who gave me this uncaring attitude to not save someone in danger?”

“Not saving someone and being unable to save them aren’t the same thing,” he responded softly.

I stopped looking at him and lied back down. “Only someone incompetent would be so useless. Even if one had the desire to help, without any power to do so, they wouldn’t be any different to a person who ignored a plea for help.” As I listened to my own reasoning, I felt quite empty inside.

“You really are so fragile that you fall over from one hit. I can’t imagine a killer living within you.” Nie Zun gave his devilish smile.

I looked at him coldly. “Yeah. I don’t understand how a demon like that could live inside of me either.”

“Since that demon has already joined together with me now, just do a good job being a good person. Leave the sinister stuff for your other self and me.” For some reason, Nie Zun’s words gave me a very warm feeling. But still, I wasn’t going to respond gratefully to him.

Nie Zun suddenly changed the topic. “The Split Zone is very strange, and the blond man is very strange too. Haven’t you ever suspected him? Or has he just always seemed above suspicion to you?”

“It’s not that I’ve never thought to suspect him, I just don’t have the ability to suspect him.” I closed my eyes, and an overwhelming exhaustion overcame me. I knew that everything about the Split Zone was weird and nothing about it made sense. But I was just really tired, and I didn’t want to keep thinking about it.

After I rested for a bit, I opened my eyes and turned to Nie Zun. “Let’s make a trip to the Northern District. Secretly. Without letting Mr Blond know.”

“That doesn’t sound easy.”

“It’s fine. I know that it’s impossible for Mr Blond to monitor us constantly. He simply has a lot of informants. We just need to come up with a plan,” I insisted.

“Whatever you want. If you’re going, it’s not like I can stop from following.” Nie Zun’s demeanor was fully unconcerned, even now. After speaking, he raised his hand and pushed aside the bangs covering one of his eyes. When I saw the glove on his hand still covered with blood, I lowered my eyes.

Noticing my attention on his gloves, he said, “It’s fine. I can wash them.”

“Who’s concerned? Are you so eager for me to ruin your new pair of gloves?” I rolled my eyes at him.

He tilted his head and laughed. “(For them) To be ruined by you would have been my pleasure.” I really couldn’t get used to his oddly charming and ambiguous demeanor. I didn’t bother responding, and instead turned so that my back faced him.

Nie Zun’s voice drifted over to me. “It’s been tough on you these few days. Close your eyes and sleep a bit. When you wake up, we’ll have a meeting with Song Lu and the others about the Northern District.”

I closed my eyes. And then I had a dream.

The Split Zone is a strange space where our consciousness lives. When our consciousness dreams, it’s almost like dreaming within a dream. Dreams here are different. When we dream here, we’re aware that we’re dreaming, but before the dream ends, we’re unable to wake ourselves up. During the dream, it feels as if we’re watching a scene unfold from the sideline. We can only watch but not intervene.

I rarely dreamt, and when I did, I rarely dreamt of myself. My dreams were always of endless, boundless deserts, with no one to trouble me, with no worries. But this night, I dreamt of myself.

In my dream, I wore a high school uniform. I sat at a desk, reading a comic book. The place looked like the classroom from my last year of high school.

Suddenly, several girls scurried past me. And then a girl looked at my comic book. After a glance, she suddenly cried out, “Ah Shen! Why are you reading this kind of gory comic again?! Gosh, it’s so scary. Seriously, you have such particular tastes!” Although the girl seemed startled, she simply said a few sentences before leaving it alone. Then, I lifted my head and smiled at her. She walked to her seat behind me.

As she walked, she spoke to the person beside her. “Li Shen’s a girl, so why does she like reading those cruel and bloody comics?”

The girl beside her responded, “Aiya. A lot of people nowadays like comics like that. I also heard that some adults can only get ‘into it’ when they read strange things.”

“Aiya, stop talking about such disgusting things.”

As those girls chattered, I saw another pretty girl with curly hair walking towards me. She was suddenly at my side, and she snatched away my book. With a laugh, she said, “Ah Shen, you’re reading these comic books again? Why don’t you listen?”

When I saw the pretty, curly haired girl, I shot her a bright smile. “Pomelo, you’re making fun of me again.”

And then, the scene before me changed. The classroom I had just been sitting in disappeared. Now, Pomelo and I were sitting in a corner of the playground. Both of us were holding a bar of ice cream.

I turned to Pomelo and said, “Pomelo, I’ll tell you a secret, but you can’t tell anyone.”

“Okay.” Pomelo smiled and nodded.

“Actually... Something’s wrong with me here.” I pointed to my head.

Pomelo’s eyes shimmered like a pair of shining stars. “Oh? What’s wrong?”

After taking the last bite of the ice cream in my hand, I tossed the wrapper into the garbage can and pat my hands clean. “When I was little, I would often talk to myself and I had some signs of ADHD. After a few years, a strange illness befell me, so my parents took me in for a checkup. The doctor said that I was showing some signs of a mental illness.”

“Oh? But you look the same as everyone else.” Pomelo also finished her ice cream.

I smiled to her. “Well, I am pretty much like everyone else, because the illness is very mild. Even if I were to hurt someone, it would be myself and not others. Hey, I’ll show you the diagnostic report.”

I pulled out a sheet of paper and handed it to the girl called Pomelo. I really wanted to stop myself, to open my mouth and warn me, but I couldn’t say a single word. Like someone who’d been poisoned, I tried to cry out, but I was rendered powerless.

When I recalled that I was dreaming, that I was watching a scene from high school unfolding, I gave up trying to shout and dejectedly closed my eyes. Just as the dream scene cut off, I suddenly heard Nie Zun’s voice. “Li Shen, wake up!”

I quickly woke up and saw Nie Zun looking down at me from beside the bed. His expression was complicated. I looked around me and realized that it was dark outside the window.

“It’s already night?”

“You slept for a long time.” When Nie Zun saw me sit up, he straightened his back and stuffed his hands back inside his coat pockets.

“Were you here the whole time?”

“Mmh.” Nie Zun nodded and then asked, “What did you dream about? You kept saying ‘Don’t, don’t.’”

I flinched as I recalled the conversation I had with Pomelo in my dream. I lowered my head and said, “It’s nothing. I just dreamt of my time in high school.”

Nie Zun looked at me thoughtfully. Then, he said, “I notified Song Lu and Yu Liang already, so we can discuss with them about the Northern District.”

“Okay.” I nodded.

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Chapter 14

14

Three Bows

When Song Lu and Yu Liang arrived, I'd calmed down a bit .

“We heard about what happened yesterday . And it's true that there's been trouble in Westside recently . We approve of a secret trip to Northside . ” Song Lu and Yu Liang were both dressed in black, and I couldn't help taking a second glance at Song Lu's sexy figure .

“Right . I think it's time for me to take a look at the world . ” I chuckled . “But, how are we going to get into Northside without Mr Blond finding out?”

In the past, we only ever traveled to Northside at Mr Blond's summons, where we would be transported to the hall at the center of the district . This meant that we weren't at all familiar with Northside's layout outside of the hall . The place wasn't used for housing residents, but it was very large, and in fact, I'd never stepped out the door before .

“Since we were always curious, when we went to the Great Hall this time, I had Yu Liang use his ability to search around . What we discovered was rather unexpected . ” Song Lu then motioned to Yu Liang to speak .

Yu Liang, who'd remained calm through the conversation, nodded . “You know about my ability . While Song Lu was taking her visitation, to see her real body, I used my doppelganger to quickly run outside of the hall . But the scene that we see from inside, through the glass doors, was completely different from what really existed outside the hall . ”

I was a bit surprised . The scene through the glass doors of the Great Hall looked much like what existed in Eastside and Westside . There was a large residential building, boundary markings, a forest, just as was expected from the Split Zone .

“When my body double went outside the doors, it was met with a dense fog that limited my sight to a 5 meter radius . And after I walked out of the hall, the hall seemed to disappear behind me, leaving behind only more fog . In front of me, there was something I’d never seen before . Three doors . They were each about four meters tall, labeled Heaven, Ghost, and Exit . ” Yu Liang said .

It was really unfathomable, but Yu Liang had never lied before . When he first arrived in the Split Zone, he was nicknamed the God of MF . His MF was only 39, but he was able to manipulate his mental force to accomplish things that were beyond the scope of most people’s abilities . He didn’t have to train extremely hard for it either; it just seemed to come easily to him .

In the Split Zone, our consciousness existed, not our physical body . And yet, Yu Liang was able to separate his consciousness once more still . To put it plainly, he could manipulate his mental force to have a controlled out of body experience, and this new soul wasn’t something that the rest of us could see . The only condition for it was that it had to remain within 100 meters from his “body . ”

“Mr Blond didn’t find out about what you did?” I asked Yu Liang .

“From our observations, Mr Blond doesn’t seem to be some all-powerful being . In fact, after much investigation, we suspect that he is just like us, an ordinary body formed from a consciousness . He probably has a split symbol as well . It’s just that his MF is leagues above ours . Of course, these are just suspicions, not facts . But, what we can be sure of is that he does not control everything . ”

“So how does he find out about what happens in all of the districts so quickly?” I remembered that when I’d gone to see him several days prior, he’d already known exactly why I was there .

Yu Liang's eyes glistened . “He has informants all across the districts . Ah Zhen, how much of these things are you ignorant to? What have you done for the past half year?”

I laughed awkwardly .

Song Lu frowned at Yu Liang . “Don't blame Ah Zhen . It's not like you don't know . Half a year ago, she...”

I quickly cut off Song Lu . I looked over to Nie Zun, and of course, his expression was serene, like someone who was about to return to the heavens .

Yu Liang sighed . “In any case, we've always been suspicious of the Split Zone, Mr Blond included . Although he treats us well and allows us to live peacefully and happily here, Ah Zhen, you also know that our families are waiting for us to return . Running away from that isn't a solution . We have to find a way home . And if Mr Blond is being controlled by the soul splitters, we have to figure that out too . According to the scent investigators, Laurel's trace disappeared at the North-South border . ”

I nodded my head slowly . “But without being summoned by Mr Blond, how will we get into Northside? The Northside border is at the other end of Southside, and the borderline there is red . We can't travel across it . ”

“During the time that you were uninterested in all of this, we heard a lot of things . You Ji thinks that Si Luo from Southside must have a way to travel across the boundaries . So, I'm afraid that we'll have to make a stop over to Southside first . At least, we'll have to go inquire about some things . ”

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“I've never been to Southside . ” I pouted .

Nie Zun suddenly commented, “Not just Southside . If not for the recent unrest, you probably would have never left Westside, right?”

I didn’t hesitate to roll my eyes at him .

“We’ve never been there either . Southside is different from both Westside and Eastside, and outsiders rarely visit . But still, I believe we need to make a trip there,” Song Lu said firmly .

“Fine . I’ll support your decision . Let’s go together . ”

After a moment, I spoke up again, “But how many people are going?”

“This trip will be different to ones in the past . Since we are now taking on the challenge of uncovering the secrets of the Split Zone, we cannot be shorthanded . With me and Yu Liang, and you and Nie Zun, we should also at least bring along Jie Pa,” Song Lu said to me .

I considered this for a moment . Old Man Fan lived on the first floor . Aside from the floors You Ji and I lived on, and the one that Jie Pa lived on, 13 and 30 respectively, every other floor also had its own floor manager . With twenty seven floor managers, plus Old Man Fan and also You Ji’s Seven Demons (You Ji’s seven capable subordinates), even if I were to leave Westside for a time, no major problems should occur .

In all honesty, even when I was present, I didn’t contribute much towards Westside .

“Okay . Then, the five of us will go . Make your preparations . Additionally, we have to give the shop owner peace . Have Jie Pa tell him that when I return, I will have an explanation for him . Right now, I’ll contact Old Man Fan . ”

“Okay . ” Song Lu nodded . Then, she and Yu Liang left my room .

“Okay . ” Song Lu nodded . Then, she and Yu Liang left my room .

I pulled out my cellphone and called Old Man Fan . “Fan, bring the other 27 floor managers up to section A of the rooftop to meet with me . ”

The sky was still dark when I met with 27 not unfamiliar faces and Old Man Fan .

Everyone looked around at each other, curious why the idle district commander, who only met with them for the monthly building meetings, suddenly sought them all out .

I looked at them solemnly, and then I bent over for a bow .

“Commander, what are you...” Twenty something voices started up .

I looked around . “I know that you are all capable people in Westside . Most of you served the previous district commander before Westside was entrusted to me . I’ve always known that you have been unsatisfied with some things, but you have all followed Li Qing’s orders to remain loyal to me, to continue protecting Westside . ”

The atmosphere grew heavy at my mention of the previous district commander, Li Qing .

“For the past half year, I have idled away . If not for Li Qing’s firm guidance and all of you already being familiar with the rules she set down, with the way I’ve acted, Westside would have collapsed by now . Fortunately, Li Qing’s rules remained in effect, and with You Ji’s supervision, Westside has remained fairly safe and stable . ”

I paused . Then, I continued, “However, with the recent happenings in Westside, a lot of people have grown uneasy . Of this, I am aware . Up until now, I’ve let everyone down . I cannot face all the residents of Westside, so I would like to ask all of you to help me apologize for this . And I promise that when I return to Westside after this trip, I will step up to lead Westside and its residents in rebuilding our home . ”

I made another bow .

Some people’s eyes were growing moist .

The floor manager of the third floor, a person named Ta Lai, said to me, “After Master Li Qing left us, we lost our way . While we tried our best to maintain order among the residents, we were also afraid . The brutal forces of Eastside were expanding, but we had no protector like Si Luo . Since no one had been able to find their soul splitter, everyone had fallen to despair .”

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I nodded . “That’s why I’ve said that I let you all down . I know that, even if no one had found a way to return to life in the real world, at least Li Qing gave you a place to live happily . Since I was the one to bring fear and helplessness to this place, I will go to Northside to investigate . And I will do all I can to return with a way to save us, a way to leave this place .”

Several people began to whisper . “Can you really do it? Even the great Li Qing had no answers...”

I raised my head and looked at them with a steady gaze . “I cannot guarantee that I will be able to find a way out of this place, but I promise that even if we can never leave this place, I will at least remain here forever with you, to keep you safe and at peace .”

In the real world, a promise like “forever” was hard to keep, but in the Split Zone, it felt like a very attainable thing . In the Split Zone, the feeling of being forever alone was something we lived with .

“Please, trust me .” I bowed for the third time .

Ta Lai was the first to speak up . “Commander, go . We will wait for your return . Master Li Qing asked us to follow you . As we trusted her, we will

trust you!”

The image of Li Qing suddenly appeared in my head—the woman who carried a bit of the tough, overbearing nature of a man . And then, a hint of pain slivered across my heart .

But this wasn't the time to lament over her death . I raised my head and looked at everyone . In a firm and resolute voice, I said, “While I am away, I entrust Westside to you . I hope that you can relay my message to all the residents of Westside, to wait for my return . ”

“Yes, ma'am!” Twenty something voices sounded in unison .

I turned to look at Nie Zun standing behind me . There was a light smile on his face, and he looked at me with a pair of eyes that seemed to shine even in the dark of night .

Chapter 15

15

Bad Fate With Murder

Dressed in black, the five of them arrived at the west-east border . The sky was still lit .

A line of people easily passed across the border and entered the Eastside Forest .

I was feeling so delighted that I couldn't help humming a song .

“Quit singing . Who are you trying to scare to death?” Nie Zun mocked .

I ignored him and continued humming my song .

We were walking through the forest when I suddenly noticed a figure standing up ahead .

I carefully adjusted my eyes as I tried to identify the person .

She was a very pretty young lady, bright eyes and curved brows .

The peculiar thing was that her hair was white . It fell down to her ankles, nearly 1 . 5 meters long .

Her skin was clear as jade . Her dancing figure, dressed in a white robe, easily made a person lose themselves in reverie . She was standing not too far from us, as if inspecting one of the trees in the forest .

When she felt that someone was approaching, she quickly raised her head to look at us .

I was a bit dazed by her pretty features . “What a pretty girl!” I mumbled to myself .

After hearing my words, the girl’s long brows knit together . “Who are you calling a girl?”

I was stuck in place, as if I’d been struck by lightening .

This... Her voice was that of a man’s!

Ha...ha... What kind of hobbies did people have nowadays...

“Ah, so you were actually a handsome man,” I said, a bit bitterly .

The strange man who looked as beautiful as a woman, with a head of white hair that extended to his ankles, raised his brow at me . “Are you Westside bugs?”

Bugs??? Who are you looking down on?!

I scowled at him indignantly .

Dressed in a long gown, he simply walked over to us calmly, with no urgency .

Yu Liang took the lead and stepped forward . “Hello, sir . We are indeed from Westside . We have a few friends in Eastside, so we came today to pay them a visit . ”

The white robed man suddenly dusted off his hands at us . “There’s no need to tell me those things . I have no interest in understanding ugly things . ”

...Ugly things?

I turned to my side and looked at the hot and sexy Song Lu dressed in black . Then I looked over the well-built and stoic Yu Liang, and then over to the

gentlemanly Jie Pa . And me—I-I wasn't that bad! Who was he calling ugly things?!

The white robed man scanned over our group, and then his eyes stopped on Nie Zun .

A smidgen of appreciation flit across his eyes .

Before I could react, he suddenly disappeared from before me .

I was stunned, and in front of me, Yu Liang and Song Lu exchanged confused expressions . All of us turned back at the same, only to realize that this man was already standing behind us, facing Nie Zun!

Seeing his back, I immediately grew alert and grabbed my bow with my left hand .

This man moved extremely fast! I hadn't seen him move at all, not even a trace of a shadow!

Facing his back, I retreated several steps until I stood beside Yu Liang and Song Lu, about a meter away from the stranger . Standing in front of him, Nie Zun had his hands stuffed in his pockets, a slight smile and a lazy expression on his face .

“You're beautiful, a true work of art . Won't you come with me?” The white robed man actually extended his hand to caress Nie Zun's face .

The hair on my body stood on end, and I felt my body on the verge of collapsing . What was this guy playing at?

But before the stranger's hand could touch Nie Zun's face, Nie Zun pulled his black gloved hand out of his left pocket and grabbed onto the pale hand, though it seemed he didn't exert much force .

But before the stranger's hand could touch Nie Zun's face, Nie Zun pulled his black gloved hand out of his left pocket and grabbed onto the pale hand, though it seemed he didn't exert much force .

“My also beautiful friend, I also like your appearance very much . But I’m sorry, I have business to attend to, so I cannot go with you,” Nie Zun said with a smile .

After hearing his words, I couldn’t help feel that something was strange . Also beautiful friend? Wow . He really never forgot to praise himself .

Just then, the white robed man did something that caused both myself and Song Lu to grab onto each other, feeling the urge to vomit .

He bent over slightly, and from the corner of my eye, I saw some kind of infatuation glimmer in his eyes . Then he lowered his head and stuck out his tongue to lick Nie Zun’s hand!

I gagged as I grabbed onto Song Lu, who was standing stiffly .

But then I raised my head, enduring the disgust, curious about Nie Zun’s reaction .

His expression made me regret my curiosity .

He looked the same as always, an indifferent smile on his face, as if he hadn’t cared at all that a man had just kissed his hand . No, licked his hand . No, that’s not right either . That a man had licked his glove .

I grew a bit suspicious . Considering how much Nie Zun cherished his gloves, how could he have no reaction to them being licked by this wretched man?

But Nie Zun hadn’t made a move to resist . He’d simply tugged his hand out of the man’s hold .

Seeing this, the white robed man took a step towards Nie Zun and thrust his face at Nie Zun . “Then, how about you come find me again after you finish your business?”

I shivered . They were so close together that Nie Zun could probably have felt the moisture of the man’s breath .

“Okay,” Nie Zun responded, his eyes curving with his smile .

The white robed man nodded with satisfaction at Nie Zun’s response . Then, he turned and slowly walked away, never looking at me once .

After the man walked a bit further, he suddenly vanished from sight . I shook my shoulders in an attempt to get rid of my remaining goosebumps .

Yu Liang looked in the direction that he disappeared, thoughtful . “His ability to transport is the fastest I’ve ever seen . He’s certainly not an ordinary person . ”

I quietly shook my head . Did this place have ordinary people?

Song Lu nodded . “We should be very careful since we don’t know what his motive is . ”

Jie Pa pushed up his glasses . “Nie Zun, he was right up next to you . He didn’t try any tricks, did he?”

Jie Pa pushed up his glasses . “Nie Zun, he was right up next to you . He didn’t try any tricks, did he?”

Nie Zun’s gaze was still focused on where the white robed man had disappeared . His eyes dimmed, leaving others unclear on his thoughts . He finally said, “No . ”

I clicked my tongue . “What? Are you that disappointed that he left? Were we all about to see some kind of shocking love affair unfold?”

Nie Zun turned to me, a flirtatious look in his eyes . “How could that be . If I got involved with him, what would happen to you?”

My leg flew at him . “If you did, the rest of my days would be wonderful!”

After another three hours of banter, we finally made our way through the forest and stepped into Eastside .

When we arrived at the Eastside Residence, we saw a crowd of people surrounding one of the entrances . Of course, there was no lack of strange looking characters among them .

We were squished between the crowd, and since there were so many people, we couldn't see what was happening clearly . I signaled to Yu Liang, who nodded and then closed his eyes . When he opened his eyes again, I knew that he'd already sent his soul out of his body .

After a moment, he suddenly pulled Nie Zun and Song Lu toward himself . When we all made our way back together within the crowd, he lowered his head and quietly spoke . “There's a corpse in the center . Looked like a murder, an ugly one . The body was in more than a hundred pieces, shaped into the word ‘death . ’ There were too many pieces to be able to tell where the split symbol originally was . ”

I frowned . After killing someone, they even played around with his corpse . Eastside was indeed a scary place .

I motioned for the group not to push forward anymore . We wouldn't be missing out by skipping that kind of scene . And so, we backed out from the crowd .

No one had arrived to take care of the body yet . I told everyone to split before we ended up stirring up some trouble in Eastside . We quickly moved on our way, but after traveling about 100 meters, a voice suddenly called out to me .

“Ms Li Zhen, I trust you've been well since our last meeting . ”

I halted in my steps and turned around . Less than 20 meters away stood the muscular man, Tao Lie, and the bandaged man, Mu Li . I couldn't help growing apprehensive . Why did the A-rank officers have so much fate with me?

Song Lu and Yu Liang didn't know who the two men were, so I winked to Song Lu and mouthed the letter “A . ” Song Lu quickly understood my meaning .

The man called Mu Li suddenly stepped forward . His whole body was covered in bandages, but for his eyes . And it was with those eyes that he was currently giving me a murderous look .

That's right . His eyes were filled with a murderous intent . It was different from the last time we met though, his expression not at all subtle .

“It really is a coincidence . Every time one of our B-rank officers meets their death, we get to meet with Ms Li Zhen . Shouldn't you give us an explanation, Ms Li Zhen?” Mu Li's eyes were locked on me .

I frowned . So what he was saying is that the corpse there, the one that was hacked to pieces and used to spell out the word 'death', had been one of the B-rank officers? If that were the case, it was no wonder that people would misunderstand . I must be some kind of jinx . When I came, it wasn't even ordinary people who died, but B-rank officers!

Oh my goodness . The person I most didn't want to start a feud with was Sly S . But from the look of things, this dispute was already set .

I frowned . So what he was saying is that the corpse there, the one that was hacked to pieces and used to spell out the word 'death', had been one of the B-rank officers? If that were the case, it was no wonder that people would misunderstand . I must be some kind of jinx . When I came, it wasn't even ordinary people who died, but B-rank officers!

Oh my goodness . The person I most didn't want to start a feud with was Sly S . But from the look of things, this dispute was already set .

“I find it regretful that these things always happen as I'm passing through, but I truly am just passing through . ” I spread my hands helplessly and smiled awkwardly, unsure if my words would be of any use at all .

Mu Li scoffed . “Whether or not you're just passing by, you'll still have to come with me for further questioning!”

His words had just hit the air when a bandage from his arm flew at me . Looks like he had no plans to discuss at all .

His strength was clearly different from last time . It didn't feel as if a bandage were coming at me, but rather like a golden cudgel was flying towards me .

I stood in place, still . Before the bandage hit me, Muscle Man Tao Lie suddenly stepped forward to block the attack . With a single hand, he easily grabbed the bandages heading toward me .

Tao Lie's voice sounded coldly, "Mu Li, why are you always so impatient? We've yet to find any evidence that Ms Li Zhen had anything to do with the previous days' events . And have you forgotten what the commander told us?"

Mu Li seemed to recall something . He continued to glare at me as he unhappily retracted his bandages .

Tao Lie walked up to me and nodded slightly . "Ms Li Zhen, our commander has instructed that if we were fortunate enough to run into you again, that we are to escort you to see her . "

Escort me to see her?

Are you sure we're not being brought in to get hacked apart?

While I was trying to figure out how to respond, Nie Zun suddenly stepped forward from behind me .

With a smile, Nie Zun said, "Okay, we'll go . Please lead the way . "

I immediately turned to him and made a face that said 'Are you crazy?!'

But he didn't seem to mind me at all .

"Alright, please follow me . " Tao Lie pointed to the right, at a different entrance to the residential building .

Nie Zun quickly followed behind Tao Lie and Mu Li . Song Lu and Yu Liang exchanged a glance and then signaled to me not to worry before

following along . Even the ever-cautious Jie Pa nodded to me, suggesting it was fine to follow .

I turned and glanced at the still-large crowd around the chopped up corpse, and I resignedly shook my head . Muscle Man and Bandages didn't mention taking care of the corpse of their comrade, but instead opted to take me to meet with Sly S first . I could already see my future—a burial in Eastside .

The others had already started walking into the residential building . With a silent wail, I hurried to catch up .

Chapter 16

16

Pretty Boy, Guan Nie

Considering Muscle Man's tall stature, as well as having seven people stuffed in the elevator, things felt rather crowded .

As the elevator stopped on its way up, most of the residents who saw Muscle Man and Bandages decided to wait for the next lift .

When the group reached the 27th floor, the elevator stopped .

Everyone exited .

“We'll have to move by foot above the 27th floor . The commander is on the 30th floor, so I'll have to trouble Ms Li Zhen and your companions to walk the rest of the way . ”

I quickly nodded my head . Taking the stairs was good . Delaying our meeting with that demon woman was good!

A line of people headed toward the 28th floor, and I took up the rear . I turned back and glanced at the 27th floor corridor . It looked just the same as a floor in Westside, an endless corridor with numbered rooms on either side of the hall . Only, there wasn't a single soul walking around .

“Does the 27th floor house S Clan's G to C-rank members?” I asked Tao Lie curiously .

An answer came, unexpectedly . “No, the 27th floor only houses C-rank members . ”

I developed a suspicion . According to that logic, the 28th floor would then be home to the B-rank members . While I didn't know how many C-rank members there were, the number wouldn't be that high . Additionally, there were only seven B-rank members—less even, since five had now died .

They used one floor to house seven people? What about the 29th floor then? Just for the three A-rank members?

Wasn't that too much of a waste of space? Each level of the residential building could house tens of thousands, but they were only using them for a handful of people? Was it simply to emphasize the importance of S Clan?

I was about to open my mouth to ask again, but after seeing Bandages' hateful glare, I could only resentfully shut my mouth .

We quickly arrived on the 29th floor, and then Tao Lie and Mu Li stopped before the stairs to the 30th floor .

I immediately grew wary .

Tao Lie said to me, “Apologies, Ms Li Zhen . There is an enchantment between the 29th and 30th floors, and I'm afraid that we cannot allow you to see the method for unlocking it . I hope you can understand . Please wait in the hallway, and we will continue shortly . ”

What? An enchantment? Was this some kind of online game? Why hadn't I ever heard of people in the Split Zone using enchantments? This wasn't a skill that humans ought to have, was it .

Of course, after living in the Split Zone for some time, my surprise for things never lasted more than three seconds .

After seeing those around me agree, we walked over into the hallway to wait .

We walked forward, more than ten meters, before we stopped .

“This floor seems to house just three people . Aside from Tao Lie and Mu Li, there would also be the third A-rank member . I wonder where their

rooms would be..." I spoke quietly as I looked around the empty corridor .

"My instincts tell me that there are more than three people living on this floor," Yu Liang responded quietly .

I trusted Yu Liang's instincts, so my guard quickly went up . If there were more than three people, then who else lived here? And why were the floors from the 27th up so quiet?

Could this be a trap...

Then, I suddenly thought of another possibility .

But Jie Pa shut off my train of thought . "Ms Ah Zhen, look at the protective measures for the Eastside commander . When we return, you should also set up some security for your room . "

"I don't know how to make enchantments . Which, by the way, why do enchantments exist in the Split Zone?"

Song Lu suddenly spoke up . "That is the purpose of our trip . It seems to us that there are certain people outside of Westside who appear to have harnessed abilities that were once only things of fantasy . We have to learn about these methods, otherwise, Westside will be at a disadvantage in the future . "

I nodded . "True . Many things that exist here have already undermined what we can imagine . Any and everything has the possibility of happening . If we can attain [these abilities], we'll be able to adapt and to search out the truth of our soul splitters . "

Clank...

As we were discussing, I suddenly heard the sound of a door opening behind us .

I turned around and saw a room door slowly open . And then, an enchanting and bewitching face appeared in front of me .

It was that white-haired man dressed in white robes .

The white robed man shot a charming smile towards my startled self . He placed a finger over his lips, as if saying to be quiet, and then a blast of wind blew past .

The white robed man shot a charming smile towards my startled self . He placed a finger over his lips, as if saying to be quiet, and then a blast of wind blew past .

Before any of us could react, our bodies had been carried away by a blast of wind . In an instant, the scene around us changed .

We looked around, and we were definitely no longer in a hallway in the Eastside residential building . Instead, we were in a forest filled with birds and flowers .

This forest was just like a forest in the real world, filled with lush trees, birds and insects flying . When you looked upward, you could see a blue sky and a bright sun . The warm sunlight scattered down onto our bodies .

A chuckle came from the side . We turned and saw the white robed man leaning against a tree, smiling over at us .

But for some reason, his smile made my hair stand on end .

Seeing his enchanting face against the natural backdrop, rays of light streaming onto his face, a girl's heart couldn't help beating faster .

Hands stuffed in his windbreaker, Nie Zun stepped forward and said to the white robed man,

“Hi . We meet again . ”

Seeing Nie Zun, the man's eyes lit up . “Hi, my pet . ”

Gag...

A familiar feeling of disgust rushed at me...

“Why did you bring us here? And where is this, anyway?” Nie Zun actually had a charming smile on his face .

The white robed man’s eyes remained on Nie Zun . “This is my room . When I opened my door and saw all of you there, I decided to bring you inside . ”

What? His room? Which meant, there was a hallway outside of this place? Why was this scene appearing inside of a room?

Jie Pa calmly extended a hand to adjust his glasses . “If we’re inside a room, it’s likely that what we’re seeing is just an illusion . ”

After hearing Jie Pa’s assessment, the white robed man happily clapped his hands . “Correct! Ey, this young man doesn’t look too bad either . I must have missed you this morning . ” Then, having taken note of Jie Pa’s gentlemanly appearance, he slowly approached us .

I subconsciously stepped back and warily looked at his approaching figure . “Why did you bring us in here? What do you want?”

The white robed man finally turned to me . “When I saw that those two guys were going to take you up to the 30th floor, I decided to wreak a bit of havoc . ”

“What we’re seeing now...is just an illusion?” Jie Pa stepped forward, as if humoring the man .

“What we’re seeing now...is just an illusion?” Jie Pa stepped forward, as if humoring the man .

“That’s right,” the white robed man said, standing a meter’s distance away .

“I don’t like all these questions,” he suddenly said, a smile on his face .

Nie Zun spoke up, as if coaxing a child . “We’re here to see your commander, so release us . I promise that we’ll come back to visit after our meeting with her . ”

And the white robed man actually cooperated . He pouted his lips and asked Nie Zun, “Are you really going to come back to see me?”

I inhaled a cold breath . Was this guy really a man? Wasn’t he acting too submissively?!

“Of course . But, if you tell me who you are and what you’re doing here, not only will I come visit, I’ll also play with you,” Nie Zun enticed .

The white robed man’s eyes wandered . “Ey, trying to learn my secrets . You’re so bad . ”

As he spoke, he extended a hand and tapped Nie Zun’s shoulder .

He blinked his eyes at Nie Zun and spoke mischievously . “Me? My name is Guan Nie . I’m here for the reason that I’ve always lived here . ”

Hearing a male voice come out of the mouth of such a pretty face, speaking so coquettishly, my mind felt like it was being ripped apart .

Suddenly, a loud knocking came down from the sky .

Several people turned their heads up . The sky was still blue, and the origin of the knocking was unclear .

The white robed man smiled . “Aiya, those two brutes are here . Alright, I’ll let you all go . Remember to come visit, my little pet . ”

I really couldn’t stand it anymore . I held my hands against my head, wanting to never again hear those two disgusting men’s flirting .

When I lifted my head, we were already standing in the middle of the hallway . Tao Lie and Mu Li were standing in front of me, and the door to that room was already closed .

Tao Lie’s expression revealed some surprise . He glanced at the room and then looked back at us .

“Ms Li Zhen, were all of you taken into Guan Nie’s room?”

I nodded .

I nodded .

Tao Lie and Mu Li exchanged glances .

Then Tao Lie said, “The enchantment has been unlocked, but the commander’s orders are that she will only meet with Ms Li Zhen, alone . ”

“No . ” Song Lu immediately stepped forward and blocked my path .

Yu Liang also stepped forward and pushed me behind him . “We’re sorry, but we cannot allow our commander to meet yours on her own . Forgive the inconvenience . ”

Tao Lie was silent a moment, and then he said, “At most, we can allow one other person to accompany Ms Li Zhen . We apologize, but the 30th floor is an important place in Eastside, so we cannot allow just anyone to enter . ”

Song Lu and Yu Liang turned to check my expression .

I glanced at Jie Pa, and he nodded to me . Then I turned to Nie Zun, who smiled and also gave a slight nod .

So, I said, “Okay . Then Nie Zun and I will go together . ”

Tao Lie looked long and hard at Nie Zun, and then he motioned for us to move along .

I turned back to Song Lu and said to everyone, “Wait for us downstairs, on the 1st floor . Don’t stay here . ”

I turned my chin over to the room we just exited, and Song Lu understood my meaning .

“Okay, we’ll wait downstairs . Don’t worry and go ahead without hesitation . ”

They walked over to the elevator . At ease, I walked with Nie Zun and Tao Lie over to the staircase to head to the 30th floor .

It was an ordinary staircase, but on the last step, I seemed to feel a very strong attractive power .

After arriving on the 30th floor, I took a look around . Indeed, it looked different to the floors below . Despite it being daytime, our visibility on the 30th floor was akin to what it would be during the nighttime . The hallway, though, did seem to be like other hallways . Only, with our decreased visibility, it looked like a black hole in front of us .

I cast a suspecting look .

A figure slowly walked out from the darkness . I struggled to increase my sight, and then I finally saw the figure clearly .

Sly S .

Chapter 17

17

Negotiations Between Districts

“Must you act so mysteriously and suspiciously?” I really disliked that someone would cause more worry in this kind of situation . I glared angrily at Sly S who was now standing in front of me .

“Sorry, this is a place that can’t be monitored, so everything is taken care of with caution . Your vision will only be as good as it is during the night . ” Sly S actually used her scratchy voice to apologize!

I looked at her with some confusion . This person was truly too difficult to understand!

She was dressed in a school uniform, cheeks rosy, eyes unquivering .

“Li Zhen, I want to know whether your group was the one who killed my subordinates . ” Sly S looked at me .

“No,” I responded without the slightest hesitation .

She slowly nodded her head . “I figured it wouldn’t have been you . You’re not yet equipped with that kind of ability . ”

Huh? Was that a compliment or...?

Her eyes moved ever so slightly . “As far as I know, there was a young girl who recently died in Westside, correct?”

I immediately recognized that she was speaking of Laurel and my expression grew grave . “Yes . ”

She nodded again . “Aside from the five B-rank officers who were assassinated in the past few days, Eastside also lost a young boy . However, from my investigations, that child’s body had been substituted with another’s . So, to be more precise, the boy has gone missing . ”

I quickly agreed . “It’s the same for us . It’s unlikely that she died, and instead, her body had been substituted . ”

“What clues have you discovered?”

Just as I opened my mouth, Nie Zun suddenly spoke up . “Why should we trust you and share this with you? We’ve yet to completely rule out that you had nothing to do with this matter . ”

I turned my head to look at him, but I didn’t say anything .

Sly S stretched her neck stiffly . Her actions always made others think they were looking at a lifeless doll for how unnaturally she moved .

Her eyes shifted slowly . “You don’t have to trust me, but not trusting me won’t get any of us closer to leaving the Split Zone . Since our goal is the same, why not work together?”

I stared at her as I said, “If you’re talking about working together, I have a question I’d like to ask first . ”

She turned to look at me . “Tell me . ”

“The Westside commander before me, Li Qing... Did you kill her?” My eyes were glued to her, not wanting to miss a single change of expression .

But even after hearing this question, she remained quite emotionless . “No . ”

“Then why didn’t you ever consider working with her while she was alive?”

“Because I didn’t understand the secrets of the Split Zone back then . ” Sly S suddenly gave an eerie smile .

“What secrets?” I quickly asked .

She took a long hard look at me . “If you’re willing to work with me to uncover the whereabouts of the two missing children, proving that we are of the same kind, then I will consider telling you about it . ”

“Seems that the child you’ve lost is very important to you . ” Nie Zun’s eyebrow raised slightly .

“Indeed . ” Sly S nodded without hesitating .

Nie Zun turned to me and nodded lightly .

So, I said, “Okay, we’ll work together with you . Then, what should we do now?”

Perhaps Sly S hadn’t expected my agreement to come so quickly . She took a moment to think .

“Your current plans are to travel to Northside?” She rotated her stiff neck once more .

“Yes . ”

Sly S’ next words were something I hadn’t expected to hear . “I’ll go along with you . ”

The bandaged man, Mu Li, suddenly spoke . “Commander, you cannot . You cannot leave Eastside on whim . Another B-rank officer was just killed, so there are many things waiting for you to take care of . Moreover, you cannot just trust their words that they weren’t involved in the members’ deaths . ”

“Are you suspecting my judgement now?” Sly S asked coldly .

Mu Li immediately lowered his head . “I wouldn’t dare . ”

Tao Lie also stepped forward . “Commander, what Mu Li said isn’t without reason . Even if you don’t suspect Ms Li Zhen, you cannot just leave Eastside . You cannot go to Northside . You—”

Tao Lie also stepped forward . “Commander, what Mu Li said isn’t without reason . Even if you don’t suspect Ms Li Zhen, you cannot just leave Eastside . You cannot go to Northside . You—”

“I’ve already made my decision,” Sly S cut him off .

Tao Lie was silent for a moment . Then he said, “If you must go to Northside, please take along the three masters . ”

The cogs in my head started turning . Three masters? He must be speaking of those three white-robed men . Of course she would bring them along . Wasn’t it the case that they never left her side?

Unexpectedly, Sly S shook her head . “I have something else I need them to do . I can’t bring them along this time . ”

An alarmed Tao Lie spoke up, “You want to travel to Northside on your own? We can’t allow that . ”

Sly S seemed a bit uncertain at first, but then it appeared that she’d made some kind of decision . With a determined expression, she responded, “I’ll bring Guan Nie along . ”

Tao Lie and Mu Li were both visibly surprised . They cried out at the same time, “That’s even worse!”

Sly S stiffly raised one arm and waved it, dismissing their concerns . Her expression remained unchanged .

My lip twitched . Guan Nie? If I wasn’t remembering wrong, that was the perverted and weakling man . He was going to travel with us? I was worried that I’d die from disgust before ever reaching Northside .

“Only with Guan Nie will we be able to remain undiscovered by Mr Blond . ” After saying this, Sly S appeared to think of something . She turned to me

and asked me, “Surely Mr Blond would be aware of your traveling to Eastside? Don’t you know he has informers in all the districts?”

I nodded . “I considered that . We let Jie Pa take care of it . The path we’re taking is clear of informants . If Jie Pa says that Mr Blond is unaware, then it’s likely he’s yet to find out . ”

“Jie Pa? The legendary gentleman with extreme skill in information acquisition?” For the first time, Sly S’ eyes seemed to glimmer with curiosity .

I was taken aback . Was there such a legend? Why hadn’t I ever heard of it?

Nie Zun helplessly shook his head . To Sly S, he said, “No need to ask her . All she knows is her own name . If you have any questions, it’s better to ask me . ”

I suddenly choked . But his words weren’t incorrect . Instead of asking me, it was better to ask him .

Sly S gave me a hard look . Then she told her two subordinates, “In any case, you both understand the reason why I’m traveling to Northside with them . I must bring Guan Nie along . ”

“Actually, Commander, before we arrived here, Mr Guan seems to have taken the Westside visitors into his room for a personal visit,” Tao Lie said .

“That’s right . But that wasn’t our only meeting . When we first arrived to your district, the beautiful Guan Nie was already waiting for us in the forest . ” Nie Zun suddenly gave a smile .

“Oh? That must have just been a coincidence . ” Sly S’ empty eyes didn’t seem as lifeless as before, as if she were considering something unfathomable .

“Oh? That must have just been a coincidence . ” Sly S’ empty eyes didn’t seem as lifeless as before, as if she were considering something unfathomable .

“He’s the third A-rank member in your clan?” Nie Zun suddenly asked .

That surprised me . That weakling was an A-rank officer? How did Nie Zun figure that out?

Sly S was also a bit surprised . “You could tell?”

Nie Zun gave a lazy smile . “It wasn’t anything in particular . He just resided on the 29th floor, so he must have been important . I just took a guess . ”

Sly S nodded slowly . “He is indeed an A-rank officer, along with Tao Lie and Mu Li . ”

She paused, and then suddenly smiled strangely . “But he’s the only subordinate I have whom I cannot control . There are even times when he doesn’t listen to me . So, if he were to cause you any trouble on the trip, I’m afraid I can’t take any responsibility for him . ”

Hearing her words, I was suddenly uneasy . Recalling the earlier events, I couldn’t help feeling a desire to turn down this collaboration opportunity .

How did Sly S learn of our intentions? And why did she suddenly want to work together with us? All these events seemed to be happening too abruptly .

I truly couldn’t understand it, so I turned to Nie Zun .

Nie Zun wasn’t looking at me . Instead, he nodded to Sly S . “Okay . You and Guan Nie will come along with us . But we must stay the night in your district . We’ll head out tomorrow . ”

Sly S nodded . “Okay . You guys can decide where you’d like to stay . I won’t arrange anything, as I expect you have your own plans . ”

I nodded . I don’t need you to arrange a place to stay . I want to actually have a good rest .

When Nie Zun and I returned to the first floor of the residential building, Song Lu and the rest of the group were anxiously awaiting us .

Song Lu saw me and quickly interrogated, “So, what happened?”

I hung my head dejectedly . “Nothing much . Just that Mr Nie Zun here invited Sly S, as well as that weakling man we met in the forest, to come along with us . ”

Jie Pa asked curiously, “Weakling? The one in the white robes? Why would we bring him along?”

“He’s the last A-rank officer in S clan . ”

Yu Liang nodded . “I’d already guessed that he wasn’t someone ordinary . ”

Well, yes . With such a peculiar appearance and odd behaviour, it would be strange if he were someone ordinary .

Nie Zun looked around us . “We agreed to set off tomorrow . Let’s head over to the school building to request for short-term living quarters . Remember to lay low . ”

Well, yes . With such a peculiar appearance and odd behaviour, it would be strange if he were someone ordinary .

Nie Zun looked around us . “We agreed to set off tomorrow . Let’s head over to the school building to request for short-term living quarters . Remember to lay low . ”

“They’re probably monitoring that place . ” I pressed my lips together .

Song Lu laughed and kneaded my head . “You have us . What are you afraid of?”

I could only nod . True . At least with them by my side, I could rest assured .

When we arrived at the school building, Nie Zun and Jie Pa took care of the formalities . We got two rooms in the dorm . Nie Zun, Jie Pa, and I would take one, and the other was for Song Lu and Yu Liang .

All the rooms in the school dorm were pretty much the same . One bunkbed per room .

“Nie Zun, you take the floor . Jie Pa and I will sleep on the bed . ” I motioned for Jie Pa to take the top bunk .

Jie Pa pushed his glasses up . “No need . Ms Ah Zhen and Nie Zun can take the bed . I’ll be fine on the floor . ”

“Hear that?” Nie Zun gave his lazy smile and then climbed onto the top bunk .

I glared after him, annoyed that he only moved with such speed in these kinds of situations .

Jie Pa slept on the floor in the corner .

Cold and heat didn’t greatly affect us in any case, so I closed my eyes to sleep .

Although it wasn’t yet dark out, resting a bit more is never bad . In the Split Zone, you could sleep as long as you wanted .

As I thought over the recent events, a sleepiness came over me .

In my drowsy state, I sensed that Nie Zun was tossing and turning in the bunk above me, but I didn’t bother opening my eyes to check .

With him and Jie Pa in the room, I didn’t have to worry about questions of safety .

After sleeping for some time, a knocking on the door woke me up .

Song Lu’s anxious cry sounded from outside, “Ah Zhen, open up! Something’s happened to Yu Liang!”

Chapter 18

Split Zone 13

18 Abrupt Assassination

When I heard the shouting, I immediately opened my eyes and sat up . Jie Pa had already opened the door and Nie Zun had gotten out of bed . I stood up and saw an anxious Song Lu before me .

“Yu Liang’s been poisoned . Come quickly . ”

We hurried to follow Song Lu next door . When she opened the door, I saw Yu Liang lying on the ground in the middle of the room . His whole body was emitting some kind of dark essence . It did look like he’d been poisoned .

Jie Pa quickly knelt down beside Yu Liang . He pulled out the handkerchief from his suit pocket and wrapped up his hand . Then, he checked the tongue and eyes of the already unconscious Yu Liang .

“I recognize this poison . It’s a neurotoxin that can also have an effect in the Split Zone,” Jie Pa said cautiously .

Song Lu’s eyes were filled with worry . “It’s been tiring recently, so after we lied down, we fell asleep . I thought I heard a sound, so I turned over and looked down . That’s when I saw him lying on the ground, with this black stuff coming off his body . ”

I was completely astonished . Song Lu was very sensitive, so who could have entered their room, without her noticing, to poison Yu Liang?

“Did you see anything else that was strange?” Jie Pa questioned .

“There seemed to be a dark shadow at the window, just briefly . They must have escaped out the window . ”

“This poison can be cured, but the antitoxin requires the juice of leaves from the border forest . We have to acquire that as fast as possible . Fortunately, the forest isn’t far from the School . Traveling to and back from the South-East Forest will probably take ten hours . The poison will have a dulling effect on his mind, so if he’s not cured in 13 hours, his mental force will likely suffer a major blow,” Jie Pa said .

Nie Zun immediately stepped forward . “We’ll go . Song Lu and Li Shen can stay here to protect Yu Liang . ”

Jie Pa calmly reasoned, “It’s best if someone tracks down Jiao S . You agreed to meet up and set out at daybreak, but that seems unlikely at this point . And since this happened in her territory, it’s best to ask her about it . ”

“Then, I’ll go,” Song Lu volunteered . “Ah Shen, your MF is higher, so you stay and watch over Yu Liang . ” I was too overwhelmed, so I simply nodded my head .

“Make sure not to touch his skin directly . ” After leaving him in my care, the others left out the window, one after another .

I looked at Yu Liang, his eyes closed, face dark, lying on the ground . Anxiety coursed through me . After an hour, I still remained motionless, sitting on the ground beside Yu Liang .

When the others left, they’d forgotten to close the window . It was pitch black outside, no hint of light to be seen . Despite the visual restrictions in the night, I could still feel the endless darkness .

“Finally, there’s just one remaining,” a low voice suddenly sounded from behind me .

I quickly turned around to see a masked figure inside the room . The masked figure was a head taller than me, and from his build, looked to be a

sturdy man . He was dressed in a grey hoodie, and his face was covered up, revealing only his eyes and mouth .

“Who are you? How did you get in here?” I frowned . The door hadn’t opened and the window was right in front of me . Though the window was opened, I hadn’t seen anyone enter through it . Moreover, he’d appeared from behind me .

“Haha . I’m the person who will kill you, and I came from below!” As he spoke, he suddenly raised a gun and aimed it at me .

I moved to dodge his attack and pulled out the new weapon secured to my calf . A whip, Piercer .

Although I’d only had a bit of simple training, I’m still someone who’s been to battle before . I’ve also learnt ribbon dance, so I easily flicked my whip at him . As he ducked out of the way, Piercer flashed with a violet light as it snapped against the wall behind him, leaving a hole in its wake .

While I inwardly marveled at how destructive the whip was, I flicked Piercer once more, attacking the approaching figure . Instead of moving to avoid the attack this time, he stood still and quietly recited what sounded like an incantation before he vanished right in front of my eyes!

My whip slashed through the air, and I staggered forward a bit from the force I’d exerted . I looked around me for a trace of the man after he disappeared, but the room was suddenly very still and calm, occupied by only Yu Liang and me . Alert, I searched the room again .

The room was silent . I tried to strengthen my senses, but all I found was still silence . I frowned and then glanced back over to Yu Liang on the ground . Suddenly, I felt a sharp stinging in my back! It was extremely painful, and then my body seemed to lose all of its strength . Piercer also fell to the ground as I fell forward .

I used all my strength to steady my steps as I inwardly panicked . I must have been pricked by something coated with a mental inhibitor . I felt the strength draining from my body as I collapsed on the ground .

The masked man appeared in front of me again . With a sneer, he said, “Didn’t expect powers of invisibility in the Split Zone, did you? Even if you’re the Western Commander, you can’t beat me, not when I can turn invisible!”

I tried my best to glare at him as I responded quietly, “Who sent you here? What do you want?”

Another sneer . “You don’t need to know that . All you need to know is that you’re not living past tonight!” He knelt down to pull off my left shoe, aiming for my split symbol . But when he touched my foot, a shadow appeared at his back .

In a second, a bullet coasted into his shoulder from behind . A bullet coated with the same mental inhibitor I’d been hit with . A surprised expression on his face, he fell backwards . That’s when I saw, standing behind him, there was Nie Zun with a charming smile .

Lying on the floor, I tried to move but found that I was still rendered unable . Then I saw Song Lu and Jie Pa come in through the window .

Lying on the floor, I tried to move but found that I was still rendered unable . Then I saw Song Lu and Jie Pa come in through the window .

“You still haven’t left?” I finally asked, now that the danger was gone .

Song Lu walked over and helped me up . “No . Yu Liang usually sends out his projection out before sleeping, just in case . The projection usually stays near the ceiling, to watch over us . Fortunately his projection was able to see a needle being inserted into his skin while we slept . He suspected that the opponent may have been using stealth techniques . In order to prevent the assassin from escaping, he arranged this performance . Since it was likely that the assassin came for you, we left you alone to lure him in . ”

Song Lu was helping to hold me up, but my body still felt very weak because of the mental inhibitor . I feebly leaned against her . “What about Yu Liang?”

Jie Pa walked over to Yu Liang . He pulled out a syringe from inside his suit jacket and injected its contents into Yu Liang's body . “He was really poisoned, but this type of neurotoxin is very common, and I had packed the antitoxin for it . When Yu Liang's projection came over to our room and told me and Nie Zun about this, I already prepared the medicine . ”

I helplessly shook my head . These people . Even though they hadn't disclosed this plan to me, I'd already known that something wasn't quite right . Though I didn't know about the poison, I did know that Nie Zun couldn't possibly travel to the border forest, as he and I had to remain 500 meters from each other . This was a secret only we two knew, so I didn't bother to stop him when he'd suggested the plan earlier . After such a long time with him, I knew that he had a reason for his words .

Still, now that my body had lost its strength, I couldn't help getting angry . “Why didn't anyone let me know about this? Even if I was bait, I didn't have to get stabbed by a needle! This mental inhibitor is going to take at least an hour to wear off . ”

Nie Zun laughed . “Yu Liang's projection did call to you, but you were sleeping like a dead pig . He called you several times but you didn't hear . It's not our fault . ” Leaning against Song Lu, I gave an embarrassed laugh .

Jie Pa helped a recovering Yu Liang stand up . As he got up, he extended his arm and unmasked the now fallen enemy . He was a middle-aged man with a very ordinary appearance .

“Who sent you? And why did you attempt to assassinate our commander?” Yu Liang asked .

The man laughed . “You saw through me, but that simply means I lacked the ability . You should give up the idea of gaining any information from me . If you can, use your life to kill me . ”

Nie Zun smiled as he looked down at the man with glimmering eyes . “No problem . We've already notified this district's commander and she'll be here soon . The Eastern District's death squad is the most famous in the Split Zone . If you were sent by them, they will naturally destroy you to

keep you from talking . And if you weren't sent by them, in order to rid themselves of suspicion, they will certainly force some information out of you . Do you think that you can resist the Eastern District's death squad?" The man's expression tensed at the mention of the death squad .

Nie Zun smiled as he looked down at the man with glimmering eyes . "No problem . We've already notified this district's commander and she'll be here soon . The Eastern District's death squad is the most famous in the Split Zone . If you were sent by them, they will naturally destroy you to keep you from talking . And if you weren't sent by them, in order to rid themselves of suspicion, they will certainly force some information out of you . Do you think that you can resist the Eastern District's death squad?" The man's expression tensed at the mention of the death squad .

Just then, the room door flew open . I was still too weak to turn my head, so I could only use my peripheral vision . Tao Lie and Mu Li followed Jiao S into the room . "After receiving Mr Nie's call, we hurried over . What's this situation, Ms Li Shen?" Tao Lie looked over with surprise while I leaned against Song Lu, motionless .

I gave a bitter laugh . "Nothing much . Someone just snuck in to cause some trouble . "

Jiao S' empty eyes stared down at the middle-aged man on the floor . "Who sent you to my district to act with such unruliness?" Her voice was rough, and hearing it in the night, I couldn't help shivering .

The man didn't answer . Then, I saw a sparkle in Jiao S' eyes . Her lips curved, revealing a ruthless smile . "Looks like he wants to experience our welcome . Tao Lie, let him know what it feels like . " Tao Li nodded . He charged forward, picked up the man, and headed toward the window .

Jie Pa quickly grabbed onto him . "I'm sorry, we cannot allow you to take him away . We've yet to determine whether or not he was sent by your side . " Tao Lie looked at Jie Pa coldly .

Jiao S gave a strange laugh . "Li Shen, if I were to kill you, would I really need to go through such measures? Moreover, since you've decided to work

together with me to travel to the Northern District, shouldn't you have some faith in me?"

I was silent a moment . Then I glanced over at Nie Zun, who nodded lightly in reply . So, I said, "Okay, take him away . I trust that you'll be able to provide me an explanation . "

Hearing my words, Jie Pa released Tao Lie's arm . Carrying the middle-aged man, he and Mu Li left the room . As they left, I caught a glimpse of the man . He was staring at me . Perhaps I was reading too much into things, but his eyes seemed to glow with satisfaction, like he'd accomplished his task .

Jiao S looked at me . "It's not just anyone who can act this way in the Eastern District . Of course I will proceed quickly to determine who tried to assassinate you, and at the same time, make an enemy out of me . "

I wanted to nod, but I didn't even have the strength for that . I could only say, "Okay . "

She turned to leave, but then she paused . Turning back to look at me, she said, "From the looks of it, you should be fine after an hour, and there are ten hours until daybreak . You should remain here, and I'll send some people to keep watch . After you recover, you should still be able to make it to the border forest in time . As we agreed, I'll be waiting at the district line when the sky lights . " After she spoke, she left the room .

Chapter 19

Split Zone 13

19 Difficult Punishment to Bear

We punctually arrived at the district line as the sky started to light . I immediately spotted Jiao S and the loathesome white robed Guan Nie . Guan Nie's eyes lit up when he saw Nie Zun and he quickly scuttled over . "I only agreed to join because I'd heard you'd be going . " Nie Zun fluttered his eyelashes and returned a bright smile . I rolled my eyes, a look of futility crossing my face .

Jiao S looked over at me . Not wanting to mince words, she said, "The Southern District is different from both your and my districts . I want to make some things clear before we cross over . " Everyone else remained silent as they listened intently .

She looked around first . Then she said, "Because the Southern District is filled with deficient people, the district commander, Si Luo, set up an impenetrable defense system . However, while we're heading into foreign territory, we needn't worry for our safety as assassins don't seem to appear in the Southern District . "

"What do you mean?" Jie Pa suddenly asked .

"From what I know, within the Southern Forest is hidden the Split Zone's top illusionist . Once you step across the district line, you will immediately enter a dream-like state that reflects what you hold deep in your heart . If you carry a murderous intent, the illusion will cause you to retreat out of the forest of your own volition . "

With a frown, I asked, “How have you all mastered such superhuman abilities?”

The white robed Guan Nie smirked . He looked at me with disdain as he responded, “Looks like the rumors were true . The Western Commander really is a good for nothing who hasn’t even been able to master anything beyond the basics . ” My face twitched . Hell .

Jiao S also looked at me with a twinge of surprise . “No one in your Western District has these abilities?”

Nie Zun laughed . “Even the commander doesn’t, so how could anyone else have them?” I broke out in a cold sweat . Th-this...

Song Lu and Yu Liang both lowered their heads, unable to refute . The white robed Guan Nie shook his head, a grudging expression on his face . “Since I’m worried you’ll slow my extraordinary self down, I’ll put up with having to teach you . ”

He took a few steps forward and turned around . Lifting his white hair from the ground, he exposed the sun symbol on the back of his neck . I suddenly felt my heart drop . I quickly looked over at Nie Zun . A moon, a sun... And in the exact same spot . Did that mean anything?

Nie Zun remained calm though . With a light smile, he looked at the back of Guan Nie’s neck . It was then that I realized that there was a key inserted into Guan Nie’s split symbol!

“What’s going on?” Jie Pa asked with great surprise .

“This is my own splitting key,” Guan Nie responded lazily . He turned back and shot a flirtatious look at Nie Zun . Gag... As he tenderly looked at Nie Zun, he started to give an explanation that seemed like it was directed solely at Nie Zun . “Our own splitting keys cannot kill us . If we insert them into our split symbol, we gain unrestricted control over our mental force . ”

Hearing this, Nie Zun’s eyes lit up . “To what extent?” he asked .

“It’s limitless in the sense that you can use any type of skills . Heh . But as mental force has its limits, most people will only be able to develop a single skill . ” So it was like that . Things like invisibility and creating illusions, and the like, could be explained this way .

“However, many people are unable to use this technique,” Jiao S supplemented .

“What do you mean?” I asked .

Jiao S stared at me . “After you insert the key, you will receive a punishment . As long as the key remains inside your split symbol, the punishment will continue . Each person’s punishment may be different . Some cannot bear the punishment, so they would rather not use this technique . I suppose this is the reason that Li Qing was unwilling to let anyone in the Western District use it . So, no one ever taught you guys . ” She looked over at Song Lu and the rest of the group .

A surprised expression appeared on Song Lu’s face . “Master Li Qing could use this technique?”

“Of course,” Jiao S said with a nod .

Guan Nie suddenly covered his mouth and laughed . “As an example, for the duration that my split key is inside my split symbol, my entire body will feel a constant pain that is 100 times more painful than an ordinary person could endure . ”

Nie Zun’s brow raised . “How do you endure it then?”

Guan Nie’s smile deepened . “It’s nothing much . At first, the pain was indeed difficult to bear, but I’ve grown used to it now . ”

A gust of wind blew by . I already felt the cold sweat pouring out of me . Being able to adapt to a constant pain that most couldn’t handle, living every day with such a pain—what did that feel like . I figure I would never feel that kind of pain .

Jiao S looked back at me . “This technique requires that your split symbol be unlocked . While using the technique, your strength will not decrease as you use your mental force . For example, if you want to use 30 MF to create an illusion, once the illusion ends, you will regain your 30 MF, but you won’t lose 1 MF for activating your mental force . However, this will take a toll on you once you remove your splitting key . When you return to your ordinary state, your mental force will decrease according to your usage . In this case, your mental force will drop 30 levels, and remain as such for a month before it’s recovered . ”

I became apprehensive . If that’s the case, then this technique costs a lot of mental force . Afterwards, you’d be left very weak, essentially living like a cripple for a month . And you would be in danger during that time .

“While our own splitting key is inserted in our split symbols, can others still kill us?” Jie Pa asked a key question, trying to analyze this information .

Jiao S explained, “Of course . Others can still kill you the same as before . Additionally, while your key is in use, you naturally cannot kill another . When you remove your key, your mental force will have decreased dramatically, so you’ll still unlikely be able to kill another . This technique can only be used for combat, and it does not allow for killing . ”

“Since the assassin who attacked me would have been using a stealth ability, meaning his splitting key was unavailable, why was he still trying to kill me?” I didn’t understand .

“I would guess that he wasn’t trying to kill you, but I don’t know what his motive could have been . ” Jiao S appeared to be deep in thought . I couldn’t help but furrow my brows also . Things were getting more and more complicated .

Jiao S suddenly gave a sinister laugh . “But no matter . Whatever his motive may have been, my death squad is sure to make him spit it out . ” I looked at her savage, smiling face and a chill ran down my spine .

Yu Liang stepped forward . “You’re telling all of this to us now because you want us to unlock this extraordinary power before we cross districts . You

think that we won't be able to pass through the illusion otherwise . ”

Jiao S savored Yu Liang's reaction and then looked at him with praise in her eyes . “That's right . Though we're not planning on killing anyone, and it's unlikely that any of us carry any kind of murderous desires, that illusion ability isn't something to think lightly of . Even if we don't plan on killing, our motives aren't entirely pure either . I'm worried that traveling through the forest will be time consuming and draining . I hope that you can all activate this technique so that we won't be slowed down . ”

Did this mean that she wanted us to insert our splitting keys now? But who would reveal their split symbol to others so easily? Not everyone possessed Guan Nie's confidence, so sure that no one could kill him .

Seeming to sense my apprehension, Guan Nie scoffed . “We won't look . Jiao S and I will cross first . As for the rest, you all can determine for yourselves what you'll do . Just know that the Southern District isn't the gentle place that you may think it is . ”

After he said that, he stepped across the district line without a hint of hesitation, not even giving us a moment to prepare . His body quickly disappeared into the forest on the other side . Then, I suddenly realized that he'd called Jiao S by name and not as Commander . Looks like this Guan Nie character really wasn't someone Jiao S could order around at will .

After he said that, he stepped across the district line without a hint of hesitation, not even giving us a moment to prepare . His body quickly disappeared into the forest on the other side . Then, I suddenly realized that he'd called Jiao S by name and not as Commander . Looks like this Guan Nie character really wasn't someone Jiao S could order around at will .

With a bit of concern still, Jiao S gave me a long hard look, before she turned and crossed the district line as well . These the Easterners were really very firm in their workings...

Nie Zun lazily scratched his head . “So, should we use it or not? Mmh?”

Jie Pa pushed his glasses on his nose . He stepped forward and said, “I’ll use it . ”

We all exchanged glances with each other, and then we nodded to Jie Pa, expressing our agreement . We all turned away as each person inserted their splitting keys . Maybe it was because I had my back to him, but time seemed to be crawling along at a snail’s pace .

After a long time, he finally said, “I’m done . ” His voice trembled ever so slightly .

When I turned to look at him, he was standing in the same spot and it didn’t seem that anything had changed . But then I noticed that Jie Pa’s ever calm and steady gaze carried a hint of fear and his body seemed to be trembling too .

Nie Zun was the first to notice that something didn’t seem quite right . He frowned and put a hand on Jie Pa’s shoulder . “What is it?”

Jie Pa’s expression slowly turned to one of pain . “I-it’s nothing . I’m fine . ”

Since Jie Pa didn’t seem to want to say any more, we didn’t probe him further, but Song Lu and Yu Liang exchanged a glance . Yu Liang comforted her, “I’ll go first . ” Song Lu looked at him uneasily .

Once again, we proceeded as before . When we turned back around, I saw that while Yu Liang didn’t appear to be in pain, he had a very helpless look about him .

He shook his head . “I’m afraid that the effect of this technique is that you must face the fears you’ve buried in the depths of your heart . ”

When I heard his words, a wave of worry rushed over me . I didn’t want to use this method . I felt quite certain of that . For some reason, when I felt afraid, my palms would turn cold . Subconsciously, in this time of worry, I turned to look at Nie Zun . He smiled at me and said steadily, “I’ll go next . ”

I wanted to reach out and stop him, but I ended up holding my hand out in the air a moment before lowering it .

I wanted to reach out and stop him, but I ended up holding my hand out in the air a moment before lowering it .

After some time, we turned around again . I almost couldn't even muster the courage to look at Nie Zun . I calculated the possibilities in my head, but I still didn't dare to look . I was afraid that there would be a never before seen fear in Nie Zun's eyes . But when I gathered my courage and raised my head to look at him, I didn't see any differences in his expression . His eyes still shone with that carefree attitude and his hands were tucked in his pockets as before .

He looked at me calmly and said, "It's enough that we've activated this technique . We can protect you, so you don't have to do it . " His tone sounded ordinary, but it carried a kind of irrefutable strength .

Those were his first words after entering this unlocked state that required its user to suffer an unbearable punishment . He said, 'I can protect you . You don't have to do it . ' My eyes drooped, and a sliver of warmth penetrated my heart . I nodded . For some reason, and especially after Nie Zun's words, I really didn't want to go through with this technique .

Last was Song Lu . She said evenly, "You don't have to turn around . My split symbol is on my collarbone . Ah Shen and Yu Liang both know this . " Yes .

She casually reached into her shirt collar and exposed her clean and pretty collarbone . With her other hand, she inserted her splitting key into her split symbol, and then, there was a flash of light . During the process, her eyes remained calm . But after the key was inserted, she suddenly stopped moving, as if she'd been turned to stone, frozen in place .

A gust of wind blew past, blowing at her soft curls, but her eyes were void of light, as if she were dead . I felt uneasy . I wanted to step forward and hold her, but at the same time, I didn't have the courage to . And so, I stood

fearfully still, my fingers rubbing against each other, as I waited to see the outcome .

“Ah!!!” Song Lu suddenly shrieked out . She didn’t move, but her eyes showed a kind of fear that I’d never seen before .

Seeing this, I immediately reached to grab her, but Yu Liang stopped me . He looked at Song Lu with pitiful eyes, but he didn’t move to hold her .

She continued to scream for some ten seconds, and then it seemed like she’d broken whatever spell was cast upon her . When she regained her ability to move, she gasped for breath and then pulled the key out from below her neck . She shook her head violently, her pupils darting around and trembling . “I-I-I can’t use it . ”

A gleam passed across Yu Liang’s eyes . Then he sighed and reached out to steady the shaking Song Lu . “Don’t . Don’t use it . I’ll protect you . ”

I suddenly recalled Song Lu’s story, from her time in the real world . Her psychosis had been triggered by a rape . Is that what she saw? If that were the case, it really would have been too horrific . I had even less desire to use this technique now .

I pushed the inky darkness down and down into the recesses of my heart, keeping it from seeping out, that unerasable fear . I opened my mouth and said, “Okay, let’s go . ”

All together, we crossed the East-South district line . As we stepped across, I touched my chest . A strange feeling seemed to be cross over my flesh .

Chapter 20

Split Zone 13

20 Unbounded Darkness and No One to Lean On

The moment I stepped across the district line, the people beside me suddenly disappeared . When I looked around, I realized that I was no longer in a forest, but rather, I stood on a wide open sports field . I suspected that I must still be in the Southern Forest, and that this was just an illusion . So this was the so-called dream state .

I calmly walked forward on the field as I recalled Jiao S' and Guan Nie's words . If this is really an illusion to determine what kind of person I am, what will appear here? I couldn't imagine it . Just as I couldn't understand why I would have hurt my beloved Senior Gao Qi back then, I don't know what it is that lives inside my heart now, after all these years .

Ever since I arrived in the Split Zone and my second identity joined with Nie Zun, I haven't exhibited any abnormal behaviors . In a way, my existence here is incomplete . Then, in this illusion, would I truly be able to experience what lives within my heart? I laughed to myself bitterly . I really want to see what's hidden inside of me .

“Ah Shen . ” A familiar voice sounded behind me . My eyes widened . Could it be...? I turned around slowly .

The white shirt, the black jeans, and the pair of bright yellow sneakers from my memories . With that ever unfathomable smile, that seemed both warm and yet wicked, he looked at me . “Ah Shen, it's been a long time . Just like before, you understand me, right?”

I looked at the person in front of me, my eyes slowly growing wider still . In that single, brief moment, I forgot about everything that's been happening . I was certain that this person in front of me was Senior Gao Qi —not Gao Qin Jiu Ye who I'd seen in the Split Zone a few days ago—and that this wasn't some kind of illusion . He was my Senior Gao Qi . Only my Senior Gao Qi would look at me with such warm eyes . Only he understands me .

Tears started to leak from my eyes . “Senior...”

He walked towards me slowly and reached out a hand to wipe away my tears . “What are you crying about? Didn't I already say that I'd wait for you at the end?”

I finally couldn't stop myself from wailing . “But I... To you, I...”

A smile appeared on his lips . “I didn't die . I've been here with you, but you just couldn't find me . ”

I looked at him, at his smiling lips . Just as I was about to say something, another voice pierced my ears . “Ah Shen, he's lying . Everything here is fake . I'm the only thing that's real!” As I heard the anxious cry, I turned my head to see a faroff Pomelo running to me . Alarm crossed my face as I watched her run towards me . She wore one of the matching Pikachu dresses that we'd bought together .

“N-no, no! Stay away from me!” I stepped back, frightened, and then I grabbed onto Gao Qi's arm . This was something I couldn't do easily before .

Pomelo stopped before she reached me, a hurt expression on her face, a pitiful look in her eyes . “Ah Shen, they're all fake . I'm the only one who's real . ”

“That's enough! I became this way because of you!” I cried out, still fearfully hiding behind Senior Gao Qi .

Pomelo took another step forward . “Ah Shen, listen to me . Everything here is tricking you . You must keep going . Aside from me, you can’t trust anyone else!”

I violently shook my head, pulling heavily on Gao Qi’s shirt . Using him as a shield, I shouted to Pomelo, “I’ll never trust you again! It’s because I trusted you that you betrayed me!”

Pomelo shook her head . “I didn’t betray you, Ah Shen . Think about it carefully . You’re the one who didn’t accept me . ”

I cried uncontrollably . No . I don’t want to think about it . I don’t want to ever recall that dark high school past that I’d buried away . It was a darkness that shrouded me all day long . It made me feel like a child who was drowning, yet unable to die . Every day hurt so much that I’d have rather been dead . I was being choked at the throat, with no way to escape, and no one to come rescue me .

The world has no Savior, and I hadn’t the power to save myself . Solitary, lonely, I was a child who couldn’t see the light .

Pomelo was once my best friend . We liked the same snacks, the same comics, the same celebrities . She was the person who understood me the most, the one who was always by my side .

I knew that I’d always been a strange child . I’d always liked horror movies, films like Saw and Seven . As I grew older, my attraction to those types of movies, comics, and novels increased . Though they appeared bloody and violent, they were stories that revealed the way of human nature .

Many kids around me would avoid me because of those interests . But I knew that there was nothing wrong with me . I was a good child . Even when my pet rabbit died, I cried for three days . I just had different interests... Why did I have to be ostracized just because I was different... I really wasn’t a bad kid . I just liked reading and watching those things . What was so wrong with that...

Still, my interests remained . My parents didn't have any oppositions to it, but reading and watching those dark things left me without any friends . Nevertheless, I remained cheerful . Even if others didn't understand me, I hadn't really been ostracized .

When I started high school, I still couldn't refrain from reading some violent comics . The pretty girls around me would fearfully grumble that I wasn't much like a girl . By then, I'd already grown accustomed to that type of thing, so I just smiled and didn't let it affect me .

Then, Pomelo showed up .

I'll always remember the day that Pomelo transferred to our school . At the time, I was reading a criminal psychology novel . I happened to look up at her and our eyes met . I believed in love at first sight, and I believed that the same could be said of friendship . From her eyes, I could see another me .

I'm not sure if others will be able to understand this feeling—when you meet a friend who makes you feel that they're the only person who truly understands you . That kind of feeling, that was the grace given to me that day .

After class that day, she walked up to me and said, "I like that book too . I like it a lot . " And so, every day after that, we'd be together, sharing the things we liked, never ever suspecting the other .

When I let her see the diagnosis report for my mental disorder, she hadn't seemed to mind in the slightest . I'd naively believed that she wouldn't turn her back on me, that she understood me, that we'd remain the best of friends forever .

But the next day, I saw the diagnosis report posted on the school bulletin board in such a careless manner . From then on, she brought an exhausting and cold high school life to me, just as easily as she'd posted that diagnosis report .

But the next day, I saw the diagnosis report posted on the school bulletin board in such a careless manner . From then on, she brought an exhausting

and cold high school life to me, just as easily as she'd posted that diagnosis report .

I can't recall clearly how I managed to get through that time, just as there are many things I can't fully remember . Even the word 'helpless' cannot sufficiently convey that period of time for me . It's a period of time that I've buried deep inside the recesses of my heart .

The one thing that supported me through the ordeal was waiting for graduation . I'd believed that once I was out of high school, I would be set free . But when I went to register for college, I ran into Pomelo, who'd enrolled at the same school . I don't think I'll ever forget that day either . She walked over to me, carrying what was, in my memory, the warmest smile on her face .

Her body seemed surrounded in light, whereas around me, there was just darkness . She walked up to me and whispered in my ear, "You can't leave me, because I'm the only one who understands you . Ah Shen, don't worry about others not understanding . Having me is enough..."

Unable to continue living in the past, I coldly glared at the dejected Pomelo in front of me . "You're the devil . I never want to see you again!"

Pomelo gave me a hard, long look . Then, faintly, she said, "What will it take for you to believe that I'm the only one who's real..."

Suddenly, Senior Gao Qi's laugh rang in the air . "You're not the only one who understands her . I've always been by her side too . Didn't you know?" Hearing Gao Qi's words, I felt like someone who'd been lost for a long while, finally finding my way . My grip on his shirt tightened .

Pomelo gave Gao Qi a look . "You've been lying to her all this time, turning her into this kind of person . " Then, she turned back to me . "Ah Shen, he's tricking you . Don't believe him . He'll hurt you again and again and again!"

I shook my head, not wanting to hear another word from her . Gao Qi gently turned to look at me . In a magnetic voice, he said to me, "Don't be

afraid . Leave your sins to me . I'll protect you . ”

I trembled . Not because the senior whom I'd loved for many years had spoken such heartwarming words to me . It was because his words made me suddenly think of a different person . Nie Zun . I thought of that lazy and carefree expression that always hung on Nie Zun's face . Then I looked up at Gao Qi, and then over to Pomelo . No, something wasn't right . This was Split Zone No . 13 . They were just illusions... But Senior Gao Qi... I raised my head and looked up at Gao Qi again .

Gao Qi seemed to notice something strange about me . His eyes started to wander . “Ah Shen, what are you thinking about? I'm Gao Qi . I died, but I'm living inside your heart . I'm here to take you away from the Split Zone . ”

Gao Qi seemed to notice something strange about me . His eyes started to wander . “Ah Shen, what are you thinking about? I'm Gao Qi . I died, but I'm living inside your heart . I'm here to take you away from the Split Zone . ”

My eyes immediately widened . “Take me away... from the Split Zone?”

His smile came like a breath of fresh air . “Yes . After I died, I became the strength inside of you . As long as you have the courage, you can use this power to leave this place . Don't try to resist me . I'm the only one who will never hurt you . ”

Suddenly, standing in front of me, Pomelo anxiously shouted, “Don't listen to him! He's lying to you! Wake up! I'm the only one who's real!”

No . Senior Gao Qi wouldn't lie to me . He's the only one who's never lied to me . Even if I killed him, he'd never hurt me until the day he died! I looked at Gao Qi's warm expression, and I nodded firmly to him . I extended my arms to embrace him .

“No! He's fake! Ah Shen, look at me! I'm the one who's real! Come to me!” Pomelo anxiously reached out, but she didn't move forward .

I frowned at her . “I never want to see you again . ”

Senior Gao Qi extended his hand and grabbed on to mine . “Don’t resist, just accept me . I’m the only one who can take you away . I’m the only one who won’t hurt you . I’m the power within your heart . Use me . Let me become your strength, and I can take you away . ”

I looked into his deep gaze and firmly held onto his hand . Senior said he could take me away, so he would definitely be able to do so . A warm light started to surround him . Perhaps I’d been resisting what was inside of me all this time, resisting Senior Gao Qi whom I killed . If I’d been able to accept it earlier, perhaps I’d have left the Split Zone by now .

As I thought of this, I felt a warmth . It wasn’t too late now . I was on my way to leave the Split Zone, wasn’t I? I took in the warm light . Suddenly another thought entered my mind, causing the darkness to envelop me all over again .

Chapter 21

Split Zone 13

21 Didn't You Say You'd Never Leave Me?

As I was about to leave with Senior Gao Qi, I felt my heart tremble . Because I suddenly thought of Nie Zun . Our fates were tied together because my second identity resided with him . If I were to leave now, what would happen to him?

Then, another thought popped into my head . Wouldn't that be better? That demonic identity killed my senior . Wasn't leaving her forever in this place with Nie Zun a good option? Nie Zun resonated with her, so Nie Zun was naturally not a good person . Just let them live here together .

But... No... Nie Zun...

My thoughts started to tangle together like an uncontrollable chaos . The more I struggled against it, the more chaotic my thoughts became .

Gao Qi was right beside me, holding my hand, telling me he would take me away . But if I left, wouldn't Nie Zun be in danger here? Then again, why was I worrying about him? He was just a resident of the Split Zone who had personality deficiencies . Who knew, he might even have simply been an illusion of my mind .

I looked up at Senior Gao Qi again .

An illusion... Could I be certain that Gao Qi was real?

I looked at him with a complicated expression, and then I quickly shook my head . How could I suspect Gao Qi? He was the one person who always

supported me, who always understood me!

My head felt like it would split apart, and for some reason, tears started welling up in my eyes .

“What’s the matter? You can’t be suspecting me... Ah Shen . ” Gao Qi’s warm voice sounded in my ears .

But, why weren’t my tears stopping... Why... Nie Zun...

“Shen’er . ” A familiar and yet strange voice suddenly echoed .

My eyes widened in surprise . This was Nie Zun’s voice . But why was he calling me Shen’er? He’d never called me that before . Even when everyone else called me Ah Shen, he hadn’t . (t/n: Adding ‘Ah’ before a name or ‘er’ at the end of a name are endearing ways to call someone .)

I looked around frantically, searching for the source of his voice . At some point, I let go of Gao Qi’s hand . His eyebrows furrowed into a frown . But even as he frowned, his expression was gentle .

Seeing the blaming look in Gao Qi’s eyes, I shook my head . I suddenly wanted to grab his hand again . But then he suddenly started to slip back, in the direction to where Pomelo stood at .

“No!” I wanted to grab onto him, but my body wouldn’t move . No... No... I don’t want to lose you again... I wanted to scream out loud, but my voice seemed to be stuck in my throat and I couldn’t make a sound .

And in my ears, that charming voice continued to echo, “Shen’er . ”

Gao Qi didn’t say anything more, as if unable to see how hard I was trying to speak . He just stood there, still, eyes filled with criticism, as his body moved further and further away from me .

At the same time, Pomelo also started to back away . Her face showed that unchanged dejection, as she spoke to me softly . “Ah Shen, they’re all lying to you . I’m the one that’s real . Hurry and wake up... You must hurry and wake up... We’re all waiting for you to wake up...”

“Ah—!!!” My arms flew up and wrapped around my head as I cried out a piercing scream .

Don’t leave me behind again... Didn’t you both say that you’d never leave my side... You guys said that... You said you’d always be there for me...

“Shen’er, you need to wake up . Don’t cry . ” Nie Zun’s voice became very clear, though I still didn’t see a trace of him . The only thing I could do was continue crying .

“Shen’er, you need to wake up . Don’t cry . ” Nie Zun’s voice became very clear, though I still didn’t see a trace of him . The only thing I could do was continue crying .

Suddenly, everything went dark before my eyes . As I closed my eyes, Pomelo and Gao Qi both disappeared .

“Li Shen, you need to wake up . ” These words were exceptionally clear . The charming voice that called ‘Shen’er’ was gone, and both Gao Qi and Pomelo were gone . I opened my eyes .

In front of me, there were several figures, kneeling around me, looking down with worried faces . Nie Zun looked at me, with that ever charming yet incomprehensible smile . Everything before my eyes slowly grew clear . I struggled to pull myself up and look around .

A forest .

“This is... the border forest?” I asked murkily .

Standing nearby, Jiao S responded coldly, “Yes, this is the Southern Forest . Everyone had been thrown into an illusion . I had Guan Nie break the spell, allowing everyone to wake up . You’re the only one who wouldn’t wake up . ”

As she explained, I regained my senses . With Song Lu’s help, I slowly got up . I looked around us . “The illusionist... Where is he?”

“Couldn’t find him . He comes without a shadow and leaves without a trail . But on the subject of illusions, ugly girl Li Shen, I already broke the spell, so why didn’t you wake up?” Guan Nie joked as he looked at me .

“Couldn’t find him . He comes without a shadow and leaves without a trail . But on the subject of illusions, ugly girl Li Shen, I already broke the spell, so why didn’t you wake up?” Guan Nie joked as he looked at me .

As my strength came back to me, I rolled my eyes at him . “Ugly girl? And haven’t I woken up now?”

Guan Nie sneered, “Woke up? It was Nie Zun—”

Nie Zun suddenly cut off Guan Nie and spoke up, “Alright, we should get moving . This place isn’t suitable for an extended stay . ” Guan Nie looked at him with a complicated expression .

I looked over at Song Lu and Yu Liang skeptically . Song Lu returned my gaze, confirming that I’d woken up on my own . She didn’t understand Guan Nie’s words either .

Jiao S suddenly stepped forward . “Let’s move . I only had Guan Nie break the illusion because the enchantment here is stronger than I’d expected . That kind of thing invites danger . The Southern Forest is different to other forests, and the path ahead is long . There are still 99 border guardians waiting for us . We have to be careful . ” At her command, we started to move .

But then it suddenly clicked to me that she’d said that the Southern Forest is different from the Eastern one . How did she know? Had the three B-rank officers she sent before reported that to her? If her subordinates could handle coming to such a place, why was she so worried?

Despite my heavy suspicions, I didn’t want to ask any questions, so I just followed along with the rest of the group as we continued forward .

Chapter 22

22 Unexpected Guest

As we put more distance between us and the border, I started to calm down .

Several times, I snuck glances at Nie Zun . His demeanor was carefree and unhurried as ever, and his eyes glistened like they were filled with diamonds . A casual turn of the eye, and starlight seemed to shoot out from them .

I looked down at myself, dressed in black robes with long, dark hair, and I couldn't help pouting unhappily . With a flick of MF, my long, blood-red dress returned . I looked at the shadow on the ground with satisfaction . A tall figure with a head of curly hair . I twisted left and right, my red dress swaying to and fro . Then I grabbed a lock of bright red, curly hair and took a sniff .

Song Lu suddenly turned back and caught me in my moment of vanity . With a loving smile, she reached out and pat my head . “You really like being dressed in red . Like a burning inferno . ” Her eyes swept over my ankle, revealed under my dress . “But this dress reveals your split symbol . ”

I looked down once more . She was right . But I didn't like wearing black . And I didn't like having long, black, straight hair . What was there to be done?

When she saw my frown, Song Lu smiled and bent down . From her black robes, she pulled out a piece of red silk . “I asked Jie Pa to get this for me previously . ” As she spoke, she wrapped the red silk around my left ankle, covering my split symbol . She also tightly wrapped up my purple thorned

whip . Not only was my split symbol now covered, I could also easily draw my weapon .

I giggled . “I knew you were the best, my awesome jiejie . ”

Once Song Lu was done, I grabbed her hand and hurried to catch up with the rest of our group who had walked ahead .

Several hours later, we finally made it out of the the Southern Forest . We’d met no strange characters on the remainder journey, and we didn’t come across the 99 border guardians of legend . The endless marketplace in the Southern District greeted us as we stepped out of the forest .

“Ah, the marketplace is here?” I asked with curiosity .

In front of the the marketplace, there were numerous colorful trees, creating the image of an old building that had suddenly appeared in the depths of a jungle, carrying a certain faroff beauty .

Covered with a layer of pale yellow paint, the building was different from the Western and Eastern District ones . From its appearance, it seemed that the the Southern District residents had worked together to cover the building . It must have been quite a bit of work . But the result was pretty good . It evoked a sense of compliance and obedience .

We walked into the building from the closest entrance to us, and the various stores gave my eyes and ears a pleasant surprise . There were all forms of stores in every direction . Perhaps because the residents here all had low MFs, there weren’t any strange looking creatures to be seen . Everyone looked like common, ordinary humans .

As Jie Pa looked around, he admired, “From everyone’s expressions, you can tell that they live peacefully and happily . ” I couldn’t help but nod in agreement .

Jie Pa pointed at a tea shop to our right . “Let’s sit awhile and observe the people here . It’s been a long journey after all . ”

Guan Nie had no objections . In fact, he led the group into the shop . We followed behind, one after another .

A young man, likely the receptionist, quickly moved to welcome us . He wore a white sweatshirt, black pants, and had a coat tied around his waist . His sleeves were rolled up, revealing a healthy pair of wheat-colored forearms . He also had high cheekbones and somewhat sharp, yet welcoming, eyebrows . Overall, he gave off a healthy and energetic aura .

He chuckled at us, revealing a mouth of white teeth . “From the looks of you all, you must be visitors . Since you were able to make your way here, you must be good people . Have a seat . I’ll bring you some specialty Southern tea . I guarantee that you’ll enjoy it . ”

He chuckled at us, revealing a mouth of white teeth . “From the looks of you all, you must be visitors . Since you were able to make your way here, you must be good people . Have a seat . I’ll bring you some specialty Southern tea . I guarantee that you’ll enjoy it . ”

Hands stuffed in his pockets, Nie Zun smiled at the man . “Thank you . But I wonder, if we sit here awhile, is there anything we can pay with?”

The lively young man led us to a table in the corner of the shop . With a bright smile, he replied to Nie Zun, “No, no . We don’t have anything like that here . Sit and rest easy, and when you’d like to leave, feel free to just get up and go . We don’t need anything . ”

“What’s your name?” I asked the young man . It had been a long time since I’d met someone as bright and optimistic as him .

“I’m called Ku Fei . Fei, like flying . ” As he introduced himself, he made a flying motion with his arm . The sight of his manly arm waving through the air made me laugh .

Our group sat down with easy hearts as Ku Fei walked over to the counter to brew tea .

Jiao S sat across from me, her face expressionless, stiff as a doll's . But I'd rather look at Jiao S' face than have to look at the face of that vile Guan Nie, whose own eyes were locked on Nie Zun . Still, it couldn't be denied that Guan Nie was beautiful, with picturesque features, and skin pale as snow .

While I inwardly grumbled about Guan Nie, two figures walked through the entrance . I turned and saw that there was a man and a girl . The man was dressed in a white suit . With light brown hair and a pair of amber eyes on a fair and delicate face, he was tall and slender, and looked like a hero out of storybooks . I couldn't help thinking that he looked very handsome .

The girl beside him was an entire head shorter, and she seemed rather young, 17 or 18 at most . She must have been around the same age as Ku Fei . She had elfish ears, likely conjured with mental force . Her skin was also very fair, with two apple red spots brightening up her cheeks . Like the man, her hair was maroon brown . Together with her delicate, elfish ears and a pink lady-like dress, she was the splitting image of a cute elf .

I quickly regretted calling her "cute . " As soon as she walked in, she glared at Ku Fei, who was at the counter . In a shrill voice, she called out, "Ku Fei!" At her call, Ku Fei stopped brewing the tea and looked over to the door .

I quickly regretted calling her "cute . " As soon as she walked in, she glared at Ku Fei, who was at the counter . In a shrill voice, she called out, "Ku Fei!" At her call, Ku Fei stopped brewing the tea and looked over to the door .

After seeing the two people who'd just entered, Ku Fei's once energetic eyes darkened . He put down the tools he held and pat off his hands . Then he walked out from behind the counter . He walked up to the fair and delicate young girl and bowed . "Lady Mi Fu . "

At his bow, the girl's brows tensed and she pouted . From her waist, she pulled out a whip . It was shorter than Piercer and pink in color . She quickly and fiercely attacked Ku Fei's partially exposed back . As my eyes followed the scene in front of me, I silently drew in a breath . A gash

immediately appeared on Ku Fei's back . His skin appeared to have been split off from the force of the attack . His white sweatshirt had also been torn, turning red as it seeped up his blood .

More importantly, the wound didn't appear to heal immediately . Had her whip been coated with inhibitors?

Ku Fei stood up . Once he straightened his body, the large height difference between him and the girl named named Mi Fu grew prominent . When I saw the pain in Ku Fei's eyes, I confirmed that the girl's pink whip had indeed been covered with something . I frowned .

Ku Fei suppressed the pain in his eyes and smiled at the two persons . “If Lord Huan Qing and Lady Mi Fu had called ahead about your visit, we would have prepared Lady Mi Fu's favorite tea and snacks . ”

My frown deepened . Lord Huan Qing? If someone in the Split Zone was being called Lord, they must surely have a lofty position .

As I thought about this, the young girl, Mi Fu, suddenly smiled naughtily . She fluttered her eyes at Ku Fei, and I let out a breath . But then, a second later, I saw her hand turn, lifting her whip, aiming for Ku Fei's face .

Ku Fei didn't seem like he would dodge her attack, and Lord Huan Qing didn't look like he had any intention of stopping the girl at his side . Anxious, I saw the whip move towards Ku Fei's face . An hour and a half before it would be able to heal . A naturally unbearable pain . From the girl's previous display of power, his eyes were also likely to be injured .

But at the time, I hadn't thought about it too deeply . Subconsciously, my hand reached for the purple Piercer at my leg . Because I'd been sitting, it had been very easy to reach . In an instant, my whip flew at the girl . No more than two centimeters in front of Ku Fei, my accurately aimed Piercer wrapped around young Mi Fu's pink whip . I pulled aggressively .

At that moment, she looked at me with bright, round eyes . After looking me over, she pulled on her whip . But her strength was no match for mine .

After a few tugs, she whined to me, “Who are you? Where did a crazy woman like you come from?”

But at the time, I hadn’t thought about it too deeply . Subconsciously, my hand reached for the purple Piercer at my leg . Because I’d been sitting, it had been very easy to reach . In an instant, my whip flew at the girl . No more than two centimeters in front of Ku Fei, my accurately aimed Piercer wrapped around young Mi Fu’s pink whip . I pulled aggressively .

At that moment, she looked at me with bright, round eyes . After looking me over, she pulled on her whip . But her strength was no match for mine . After a few tugs, she whined to me, “Who are you? Where did a crazy woman like you come from?”

Crazy woman??

A surge of fire rose inside me . A little girl like her was attacking someone for no reason at all, and she was calling me a crazy woman?

I stood up in my high heels and pulled on my whip . Standing up, with a tight grip on Piercer, I flicked the whip, and the girl fell backwards . The handsome Huan Qing, dressed in a white suit, rushed forward to catch her .

Huan Qing looked at me coldly, giving me a fright . In that moment, a burst of light suddenly spilled out from his eyes . Even his endlessly deep pupils started releasing a dizzying light . My eyes were drawn to it . In fact, my entire person seemed as if it were being pulled in by this primordial light . It felt like I was being pulled into a warm whirlpool, falling in, deeper and deeper .

Suddenly, I heard Nie Zun’s voice in my ears, “Li Shen . ” This time, his voice sounded different . It reminded me of the warm voice I’d heard in the forest that morning . The voice was warm and gentle, like water . It seemed to have the power to heal all wounds . That voice called to me, “Shen’er . ”

My mind was in a trace, but with Nie Zun’s call, my thoughts suddenly cleared . Before I realized it, Nie Zun had walked over to me . He leaned in and whispered with moist lips into my ear . “Don’t look into his eyes . ”

I dropped my eyes and pulled back Piercer . Without realizing it, my feet had retreated and I ended up behind Nie Zun .

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Chapter 23

Split Zone 13

23 Battle of Illusionists

When he saw Nie Zun stand, Guan Nie immediately got up as well . First, Nie Zun took a step, and then Guan Nie's white robe followed after .

“A delicate little girl like yourself shouldn't be so violent . ” Guan Nie covered his mouth and his white hair billowed behind him, the splitting image of a female celestial . In a flash, he suddenly appeared before Mi Fu . But Guan Nie's beauty didn't seem to attract Mi Fu's attentions, as she was still glaring scornfully at me .

Guan Nie brows shot up and he waved his hand in front of Mi Fu's face .
“Hey, kiddo, I'm talking to you . How can you ignore a beauty like myself and look only upon that ugly thing in red?”

Guan Nie, you're genuinely trying to help me right now... Right?

The white-suited Huan Qing reached out and grabbed Guan Nie's waving arm .

I couldn't refrain from looking over at this peculiar man, Huan Qing . His amber eyes were deep and incomprehensible as before, but they weren't emitting the same dizzying white light as they had earlier . With a hold on Guan Nie's hand, he spoke very clearly . “She's still young . Using your illusions on her is excessive, is it not?”

What? So, did that mean that when Guan Nie was waving his hand in front of her, he'd been creating an illusion?

I glanced over at Guan Nie . His smile gradually faded and his expression darkened . Huan Qing didn't release Guan Nie's hand . Two figures dressed in white . One gave off a gentlemanly demeanor, short hair, dressed in a suit . The other was as beautiful as an immortal, long hair, dressed in white robes . Our surroundings seemed to brighten with their white presence .

“And it wasn't excessive of you to use your sorcery on our group?” Guan Nie asked faintly .

Huan Qing glanced at us, an indiscernable expression on his face . “You are outsiders . Why have you come to our Southern District?”

Without waiting for Guan Nie to respond, a cracking sound suddenly came from Jiao S . I turned and saw her stiffly turn her neck a few times . She wore a school uniform and her long hair fell behind her . Her eyes looked lifeless as she stepped forward, like a doll .

Jiao S' stiff appearance must have frightened the young girl named Mi Fu, for her eyes suddenly trembled as they shifted over to Jiao S . Then she subconsciously moved to hide behind Huan Qing .

Jiao S' unusual neck crackling caught everyone's attentions, and everyone suddenly quieted and stopped their actions . Step by step, she walked up to Huan Qing . She extended her hand and pulled back Guan Nie's . With two large, black eyes, she looked at Huan Qing . “You were the illusionist who meet us in he Southern Forest, correct?”

Without waiting for Huan Qing's response, she gave a strange laugh . The scratchy voice continued from her stiff neck . “You have one chance . Tell me, what did you see in the illusion you set on me?”

My brain immediately started turning . The meaning behind Jiao S' words was that her illusion had contained a scene which she did not want outsiders to know about? What about my illusion then? Had this Huan Qing also seen that?

As the thoughts went through my head, my eyes swept over the lively youth, Ku Fei, who had been standing quietly at the side . Ku Fei's sharp,

black eyebrows furrowed deeply . His well-built body seemed to tremble slightly, and his rolled up shirt sleeves revealed somewhat visible beads of sweat on his wheat-colored skin . It looked like he was enduring some type of pain .

I guessed that the substance that coated Mi Fu's pink whip was unordinary . I quickly signaled to Jie Pa with my eyes . Jie Pa nodded to me . Then he adjusted his glasses and rushed over to Ku Fei's side .

"Let me see your wound," Jie Pa said to Ku Fei as he moved to check his back injury .

Unexpectedly, Mi Fu raised her hand and brandished her whip again . "Don't touch him!" Mi Fu shouted out loud . Jie Pa stopped in his steps, and I used Piercer to grab her pink whip .

All actions are followed by a reaction . After Piercer caught onto Mi Fu's pink whip, Huan Qing raised a hand and snapped his fingers . At the sound, I suddenly felt my body grow rigid, and the air around Jiao S started to hiss in a familiar way .

The air started to flow around Jiao S, and Guan Nie's smile disappeared . He also raised his hand and snapped his fingers . As if my acupuncture points had been closed and then re-opened, my stiff body returned to its lax state .

The air around Jiao S continued to hiss as the air started to spiral . Her eyes were wide, filled with a bright, exhilarated light . Her rough voice grew higher pitched . "You still haven't answered me . What did you see, Huan Qing?"

Huan Qing scoffed . He grabbed Mi Fu and retreated, wanting to put distance between them and Jiao S . Pulling back Piercer, I reached for the bow on my back with my right hand .

As Huan Qing retreated, the air on either side of Jiao S turned into rotating vortexes, a bit like two rivers flowing .

The air continued to spin, but the air needles I'd seen previously didn't appear . Huan Qing gradually retreated and Jiao S watched him, her expression provoked, callous . “Even if you are the greatest illusionist in the history of the Southern District, you cannot guarantee that you will win against all of us . So, come on then . Tell me what you saw . ”

As she spoke, I seemed to see a sliver of murderous intent in her expression . Perhaps I'd seen wrong, but it was a look that I'd never before seen on her face .

Huan Qing's eyes suddenly turned misty white, as if a storm were roaring inside them . And then he gave an indistinct laugh before coldly saying, “Do you really think I'm afraid of you? If anyone were to frighten me, it would be him...” Huan Qing glanced over in our direction, but it wasn't clear who he'd motioned at .

A sharp crack echoed . I turned to Jiao S in surprise, and saw the air condense around her, as if it were water, forming a smooth, mirror-like barrier . But at the same time that it condensed, it also started to fragment into pieces . Wind billowed and flowed out, surrounding Jiao S with countless vortexes .

The vortexes were gaining momentum, and her chilling voice sounded again, “I'm going to ask one last time . What did you see?!”

Suddenly, Guan Nie covered his mouth and laughed . He lifted his arm and gently tapped on Jiao S' shoulder . “Jiao S, forget it . Your Flowing Needles won't be able to affect him because this is only an illusion before us!”

Suddenly, Guan Nie covered his mouth and laughed . He lifted his arm and gently tapped on Jiao S' shoulder . “Jiao S, forget it . Your Flowing Needles won't be able to affect him because this is only an illusion before us!”

Jiao S started . Without questioning illusionist Guan Nie's words, she withdrew her whirlwinds and stepped back . The wind vortexes suddenly turned to mist before disappearing . And indeed, Huan Qing and Mi Fu's figures started to turn hazy .

Then I heard Huan Qing's cold laugh . "Jiao S, I've seen everything that you're afraid I've seen . What, you hadn't even expected this much when you decided to come to the Southern District?"

Jiao S' eyes widened, and in her eyes was an anger that I'd never seen . But, she didn't say a word . She simply stared into the space where Huan Qing and Mi Fu's bodies were disappearing into thin air . And until they completely vanished, she didn't move an inch .

Song Lu couldn't help asking quietly, "How could that have been an illusion? Illusions can injure people as well?" She pointed to the injured Ku Fei .

I quickly turned to him . Jie Pa had taken advantage of the confusion to hurry over and help the injured boy . Ku Fei was enduring the pain as Jie Pa applied medicine to his back .

Guan Nie laughed . "At first, it wasn't an illusion . But later, he used another form of sorcery to replace his body with an illusion . "

"When did we enter an illusion? Why didn't you stop it from happening?" Jiao S turned and glared at him .

Guan Nie's eyes flickered . "I only realized after the fact . It probably happened when I walked ahead to speak with them..."

I couldn't help admiring him . He'd discerned early on that something wasn't right, so he'd left an escape route?

"No . " Nie Zun's charming voice suddenly rang in my ears . With an enchanting laugh, he said, "It was before even then . "

"No . " Nie Zun's charming voice suddenly rang in my ears . With an enchanting laugh, he said, "It was before even then . "

"Oh? Then, when did it start?" Guan Nie's eyes burned even brighter . For some reason, it made me uneasy .

Nie Zun mischievously batted his lashes at Guan Nie . “I was just kidding . How would I possibly know when the illusion started . ”

A line of crows flew past my head...

Were you guys sent by god to deescalate this scene or just to add humor?

“This girl is truly vicious . ” Jie Pa suddenly frowned as he walked over from behind Ku Fei . “What animosity does this girl hold for you that she went to the extent of attacking you with a weapon coated in such a vicious poison?” Jie Pa asked, adjusting his glasses .

Ku Fei’s pain seemed to have decreased slightly . He did his best to smile brightly at us . “It’s nothing . Thank you, everyone . I am just an ordinary person, so I have nothing to give you in return . As you’ve come all the way to the Southern District, you must have your own business to attend to . I won’t waste anymore of your time . Please, come again, and I will present you with the best tea . ”

Come again? Was he kicking us out?

But Ku Fei didn’t look like the kind of person to forget those who have treated him kindly . I suspected that he may have had something he wanted to hide though . As I was about to ask, Nie Zun suddenly grabbed my hand .

He walked in front of me and pat Ku Fei’s shoulder . “Then, friend, take care of your injuries . Although I don’t know what medicine he applied, Jie Pa is very good with treating things and the like . I’m sure that you will not suffer greatly now that he’s applied that medicine . We’ll take our leave now . ”

Nie Zun motioned for us to exit the shop . Seeing Nie Zun this way, I turned to Jiao S and nodded . With her lifeless gaze, she looked over Ku Fei again, but she didn’t say a word . Then, in an orderly fashion, we left the shop .

Chapter 24

Split Zone 13

24 Surprise Appearance of a Soul Splitter?

When I walked outside the shop, there were already many people popping their heads out, watching us with surprised and suspicious eyes . This attention wasn't at all good . I furrowed my brows .

Jie Pa walked as he considered, "The injury on his back is the kind that not only increases one's pain, but also causes an addiction to the poison . This poison is extremely terrifying, and even the consciousness will become effected by it . Additionally, it's very difficult to treat . "

"It's probably not easy to get an antidote, right?" Yu Liang asked .

"Most shops wouldn't carry it . That girl must be of an unordinary background . "

I let out a sigh . "It's unfortunate that Ku Fei is unwilling to let us help him . "

Jiao S scoffed . "Si Luo has three extremely powerful people working under him: an illusionist, Huan Qing, a soul snatcher, Rong Jin, and a persuader, Gao Qin Jiu Ye . Against the three of them, even if we had Li Qing, we should be frightened . Let alone with you . "

I was a bit taken aback hearing Gao Qin Jiu Ye's name . I lowered my head and said, "Gao Qin Jiu Ye . Persuader..."

Jiao S didn't seem to notice my strange reaction and just nodded . "The person you saw before . He has an ability called persuasion . With just his

words, he can control people with MFs much lower than his . ”

So was this the reason that Tao Lie had followed his order to stop the other day? What kind of powerful ability was this?

Suddenly, a sliver of suspicion crossed Jiao S’ eyes . “But Li Shen, from your reaction that day, it seems that you’ve seen him before?”

I couldn’t speak, unsure of what to say . As I hesitated, Nie Zun suddenly spoke up . “Jiao S, what do you mean by ‘soul snatcher Rong Jin’?”

Jiao S gave me a long, hard look over, and then finally decided to answer Nie Zun . “The soul snatcher, Rong Jin, is the single person in all of the Split Zone who is able to contact those in the outside world . While he cannot control everything with his MF, he is still able to ‘connect’ to animals in the outside world, to pull their souls into the Split Zone to do his bidding . ”

A startled Yu Liang asked, “Contact the outside world? You mean that he can call animal spirits from the outside world and bring them here?”

Jiao S nodded . “Yes . It’s a very strange power, and I don’t quite understand it either . I’ve never seen him myself and have only heard about him from others . But we could still put up a fight against him and Huan Qing . Huan Qing’s MF is 50 and Rong Jin’s is 49 . Gao Qin Jiu Ye, on the other hand, he’s the abnormal one . No one knows what his MF is . ”

My heart shuddered with fear as I listened . Two people with MFs as high as my people, plus a person whose MF was unknown . Add on Si Luo, who had the highest known MF in all of the Split Zone, and it was no wonder that there was no crime in the Southern District...

“While we’re on the topic, how many of you have unlocked your split symbols?” Guan Nie turned to us as he asked curiously .

Ni Zun responded evenly, “Me, Yu Liang, and Jie Pa . ”

Guan Nie gave a serious cry, “Wow, none of the women have unlocked it . Men and women are truly not equals . ”

Song Lu and I glared at him .

He shrugged and then looked over to Yu Liang and Jie Pa with interest . “How did you feel afterwards? Did you find a skill that suits you?”

Jie Pa silently pushed his glasses up his nose . “This technique allows you to feel mental force flowing . As I’m not one to engage in combat, and my MF is only 40, I’ve decided to help heal others’ mental force with this . ”

Guan Nie praised, “A healer? I’ve never heard of anyone using their MF to treat others . A person’s mental force used to heal another’s vessel? Truly, a good idea . I can only wonder what kind of illness a normal person like yourself suffered to end up here . ”

My heart tensed and I turned to Jie Pa . While I’d assigned Jie Pa to the post of supervising the marketplace, I wasn’t clear on his past . When Li Qing was still here, he hadn’t yet become the supervisor . Only after I became the Western Commander did Nie Zun recommend him to me .

Jie Pa’s gaze deepened . “While I lived, I was a psychiatrist . I suppose I’d been affected by my patients, and I developed my own psychological disorder . ”

“In other words, you didn’t suffer a problem entirely of the mind, but also of the heart?” Guan Nie continued chattering on, but Nie Zun cut him off .

With a light smile, he said, “Yes . When we lived, he was my psychiatrist and psychologist . ”

I was caught off guard . Jie Pa had known Nie Zun when they were alive? They were doctor and patient? But Jie Pa seemingly arrived in the Split Zone before us . What happened? Two people who knew each other previously met again in the Split Zone?

Jiao S frowned . “You mean to say that we can meet people we once knew, here in the Split Zone?”

Jie Pa nodded . “Of course . ”

A helpless feeling suddenly overcame me . Then... What about Gao Qin Jiu Ye? No . Senior Gao Qi had already died . It’s not as if a dead person’s consciousness could also come here . Moreover, the only similarity between that mysterious and frightening Gao Qin Jiu Ye and my kind Senior Gao Qi were their appearances .

While I was deep in thought, Guan Nie moved to ask Yu Liang, “What about you?”

Yu Liang’s eyes swept over Song Lu and then over me . “I was already able to doubly project my consciousness, so this unlocked state simply allows me to more freely control that ability . To be precise, it’s become easier to create a projection and maintain its stealth in this world . ”

Guan Nie’s lips curved up . “Amazing . ”

“But...” His eyes turned . “I wonder if the punishments you were served were very cruel...”

Yu Liang exchanged glances with Jie Pa, but Jie Pa didn’t reply . Feeling the awkwardness in the air, I decided to speak up . “What should we do next? How do we find out about getting past the South-North border? From our current situation, it doesn’t appear that we’ll be welcomed by the residents here . ”

I looked around . The people around us had taken notice of our fight with Huan Qing in the tea shop, and so they were looking at us with suspicion in their eyes . As we stood there, unsure of how to proceed, an old granny with a humpback walked over to us .

The granny wore plain cotton clothes, and carrying her back, she hobbled over . “Are you visitors to our district?” she asked .

The granny wore plain cotton clothes, and carrying her back, she hobbled over . “Are you visitors to our district?” she asked .

I nodded, a friendly expression on my face .

Her eyes glistened . “The shop you just went to—my grandson Ku Fei is inside . Can I trouble you to help me with something?”

I exchanged glances with Nie Zun, who stepped forward uncertainly . He held onto the trembling woman’s body and said, “Tell us . ”

The old woman breathed roughly . “My grandson, Ku Fei—you just saw him—was a very good child when he was alive . It wasn’t until he started volunteering at the hospital that he became tangled up with that wicked girl . She would chase my grandson all around all day long, but my grandson already had a girlfriend . There were several years between them, but more than that, the girl was clearly mentally ill!”

I asked uncertainly, “Wicked girl?”

The old woman nodded . “The one called Mi Fu . She had been staying at the mental hospital, and then she somehow ended up setting her eyes on my grandson . She stuck around him all the time, but he didn’t like her, so then she traveled to the country to seek out a sorcerer so she could poison my grandson!”

When it came to love, women were truly frightening . Young girls too... I felt my heart tremble .

Tears leaked out from the old woman’s eyes . “I don’t know how, but then my grandson fell into a coma . I couldn’t handle it, and so I ended up with dementia . I would have never expected that I would follow him to this place . ”

As I looked at the old woman’s aged and tired face, worrying for her grandson, I couldn’t help thinking of my parents . Did their minds also grow weak from waiting day in and day out for me to wake up?

A deep pain hit me . I walked forward and held the old woman's hand .
“Granny, don't worry . If there is something we can do to help, we will do our best . ”

The old woman seemed to choke . “I... can feel that my time is coming to an end . After I came here, I've been watching my grandson, but he doesn't know that I'm here . I also saw that wicked girl, and I cannot help but worry . But there's nothing I can do . That girl is revered by all the residents in this district . They say that she is the girl of fate, so even when she is arrogant and tyrannical, everyone lets her have her way . I've been waiting and waiting for a traveler to come here and help me . But even after being here several months, I've not seen a single outsider . ”

Jiao S turned her head . In a rare move, she spoke warmly, “Tell us how we can help you . ”

The old woman continued to breathe roughly, as if living were very difficult for her . She struggled to lean in to me, motioning for me to lower my head . I quickly bent over and let her whisper into my ear, “An ill-fated relationship . That girl is my grandson's soul splitter, but my grandson seems to be remorseful toward her . You must find a way to allow my grandson to kill her, to return...”

The old woman continued to breathe roughly, as if living were very difficult for her . She struggled to lean in to me, motioning for me to lower my head . I quickly bent over and let her whisper into my ear, “An ill-fated relationship . That girl is my grandson's soul splitter, but my grandson seems to be remorseful toward her . You must find a way to allow my grandson to kill her, to return...”

Before she finished speaking, her body had started turning transparent . In a panic, I hurriedly clutched at her, but Nie Zun stopped me . “Her physical body in the real world has already run out of time,” he said .

And then, the old woman's body turned to a wisp of light and disappeared . She hadn't even finish speaking to me .

I tried to suppress my emotions . Everything had happened too quickly .

“What did she say to you?” Jiao S asked .

I suddenly recalled that yes, this was the point . I spoke quietly, “She said that Mi Fu is Ku Fei’s soul splitter, and she wants us to help him kill her . ”

Song Lu asked in surprise, “That can’t be . From what she told us, Mi Fu and Ku Fei were both brought here because they were ill . So how could she be a soul splitter?”

Jiao S’ eyes widened . “Wait . Haven’t any of you ever considered that perhaps soul splitters are just like us? That it’s only after we arrive here that we are deigned ‘ordinary’ people or soul splitters?”

It was a bold supposition, but not impossible . Still, I couldn’t help feeling surprised . “But if soul splitters are just like us, then why would they harm people? And what exactly are Mr Blond’s motivations? We’ve never seen soul splitters, but according to that theory, wouldn’t they be all around us?”

Stumped, Jiao S didn’t respond .

“In any case, whether or not the old woman’s words were true, we should still figure out what our next step is,” Nie Zun suddenly cut in .

Jiao S turned back to look at the shop we’d just visited . In a low, coarse voice, she said, “Let’s go talk with Ku Fei . If necessary, we can force him to speak . ”

Jie Pa suddenly spoke up, “That old woman was a bit suspicious . Although her words were reasonable, wanting to seek help from outsiders—everything is too much of a coincidence . ”

Jiao S nodded . “That’s why we must return and, doing whatever is necessary, we must make Ku Fei talk . ”

Chapter 25

25 Inner Demons

By the time we reached the shop, Ku Fei appeared to have recovered . His robust forearms were exposed as he wiped the counter with a cloth . He was visibly surprised by the return of our group, but still, he flashed his teeth in a smile at us . “You’re already missing my tea?”

I curled my lips . “We hadn’t even gotten the chance to try your tea . ”

In an awkward move, he rubbed his head . “Haha . Then I’ll bring some now . ”

Jiao S stiffly raised her arm and waved her hand . “We didn’t come for tea . We just met your (paternal) grandmother, and she passed away a moment ago . She asked us to help you . Are you still going to keep the truth from us?”

I exchanged a look with Jiao S . How could she reveal everything so quickly? I was afraid that Ku Fei would have a hard time taking it all in . But Jiao S paid me no heed .

More surprising though, was Ku Fei’s confused expression . He looked at us blankly and replied, “What are you saying? My grandmother? I don’t have a grandmother . ”

“Your grandmother, from the real world . She followed you to the Split Zone without letting you know . After you became a vegetable, she nearly went mad . ” I frowned . How could he have forgotten his own grandmother?

Ku Fei's expression grew more confused . "The real world? When I was alive? I didn't have a grandmother then either . I was an orphan . "

What?

I watched Ku Fei carefully, but I didn't see anything that suggested he'd lied . It seemed true that he didn't have a grandmother .

Then... Who had we just met with?

My whole body shivered .

I turned to Nie Zun . He gave his indifferent smile . Stepping forward, he said, "That's fine then . But can you tell us why, when Mi Fu arrived, she immediately set out to cause you trouble? If you're having any difficulties, we hope to be able to help . "

At the mention of Mi Fu, Ku Fei's expression stiffened . He rubbed his head, and then spoke with a bit of embarrassment . "It's nothing, really . I'm afraid it will sully her reputation if I speak of it . She means no ill-will . She's just trying to get my attention, though her means are a bit excessive . You needn't worry about me . " He gave another bright smile . "Thank you . It's been a long time since anyone has shown me such concern . Even more so, because you are outsiders . "

I grumbled inwardly . Her means were a bit excessive? She'd been ruthless, but you say it was just a bit excessive? She's clearly a madwoman .

"In your district, what kind of person is Mi Fu?" Song Lu asked warmly, speaking up when I didn't .

When the sexy Song Lu started to speak to him, Ku Fei's face reddened . "Lady Mi Fu is the goddess of the South . As for how, I'm not very sure myself . Lord Si Luo regards her importantly, so naturally, we all give our allegiance to her as well . Lord Huan Qing is always with her as a protector . "

Jiao S' brows knit together . "Si Luo thinks highly of her?"

Ku Fei nodded .

“Where can we find Si Luo?” Jiao S asked sternly .

I hadn’t anticipated for her to ask that so suddenly . I shivered . I really couldn’t stand this devil woman .

Ku Fei shook his head . “I don’t know either . No one knows where Lord Si Luo lives . He often comes and goes without a trace . ”

Ha . See, there’s a district commander less qualified than me . You can’t even find his shadow in his own district .

As if seeing through my thoughts, Ni Zun glanced over at me . With a light laugh, he said, “He and you are different . While he may remain mysterious, he governs his district well . ”

I shot him a fierce glare . Basically, you’re saying that I don’t govern the Western District well? Hmph .

“Might I ask why you’ve come to visit the Southern District?” Ku Fei asked with curiosity .

“We are...” I started to speak when Jiao S suddenly glared at me .

I quickly shut my mouth .

I quickly shut my mouth .

Jiao S spoke slowly, “We’re here in search of two kids . They went missing from our district, into yours . Have there been any strange occurrences in your district recently?”

“Right, right, two kids,” I hurried to say . “One is a 15 or 16 year old girl with blond hair . Her face is like a doll’s, with large, pretty eyes . The other is...” I suddenly realized that I didn’t know what the other kid looked like, so I turned to Jiao S .

Jiao S continued, “The other is also a girl, about 14 years old . She was dressed in a princess gown . She has a mole by her lip and dark hair . ”

Ku Fei thought for a moment . “I haven’t seen a girl with a mole, but I have seen a golden-haired, doll-faced girl . I’m not sure if she’s the one you’re looking for . ”

I quickly asked, “Where did you see her?”

Ku Fei scratched his head . “Lady Mi Fu’s new toy...”

My expression immediately hardened at his words . “What?”

Ku Fei looked to be in a difficult spot . “Promise that you won’t harm her . She’s really a good person . She’s just a bit headstrong...”

I scoffed, my appearance flipping 180 from the warm and welcoming demeanor I had at the start . I stared at Ku Fei and said coldly, “Tell me . What do you mean ‘Mi Fu’s toy’?”

Ku Fei sighed . He explained, “Mi Fu likes kids . She will often find a pretty and cute girl to become her playmate . She dresses the girl in new clothes and makeup . You’d call that a toy, right? But! But, she treats the girls very well!”

Treats them well? Laurel was still young, and she suddenly became someone’s plaything? Are you kidding me? His explanation caused anger to burst within me .

Song Lu was also visibly upset, but she was better at putting on a calm facade . She reached out and pat Ku Fei’s shoulder . “Kid, you do seem like a nice person . But that girl is still young, and she’d be upset at being separated from us, so we came here to find her . We only attacked earlier because Mi Fu had hurt you . We promise that, as long as we find the girl, we won’t bother your Lady Mi Fu . So, tell me, where is Lady Mi Fu?”

I shook my head at Song Lu’s patience and guidance . Ugh . I would never want to be a calm, water-like woman like that . Although, being stuck in

this damned Split Zone place, it'd be difficult to even be a woman .

Ku Fei awkwardly scratched his head . “I'd like to help you out, since you don't seem like bad people . But I really can't help you . Lady Mi Fu lives at the top of the Southern Residence . But even if you know that, it will be of no use to you . The top floor of the residence has 99 barrier masters guarding it all day long . You won't be able to get inside . ”

Ku Fei awkwardly scratched his head . “I'd like to help you out, since you don't seem like bad people . But I really can't help you . Lady Mi Fu lives at the top of the Southern Residence . But even if you know that, it will be of no use to you . The top floor of the residence has 99 barrier masters guarding it all day long . You won't be able to get inside . ”

So the barrier masters, who would ordinarily be in the border forests were hanging out at the residence to protect a girl . What kind of power did this girl have?

Nie Zun suddenly asked, “Where do you live? If we ever need some help, can we go find you?”

Ku Fei laughed . “I live on the first floor . Room 133113 . Come any time you'd like . ”

Nie Zun nodded . “Then we'll head to the academy and sign in to the dorm . Let us meet again . ” He signaled for us to go . All of us looked at each other a moment . Then we bid farewell to Ku Fei and then followed Nie Zun out of the shop .

“Why are we just leaving?” I asked, puzzled .

Nie Zun ignored me, but Jiao S spoke up . “Since we can't go to the top floor of the residence to find her, we'll just have to wait until she leaves . Nie Zun asked about where the young man lives, presumably because the girl will go to find him . Now, we wait . ”

Was that so .

Wait . That young man? Ha... Jiao S, how old are you to call Ku Fei in that way?

All around us were the suspicious eyes of the weak Southern residents . We decided to leave the marketplace from the first exit we came across . Once outside, we headed to the academy .

Jie Pa proposed, “We’ll go to the academy to apply for temporary housing now . Tomorrow, we’ll figure out how to approach Ku Fei’s room . ” The rest of us nodded in agreement .

Jiao S suddenly halted and stretched her neck with a loud cracking . Every time she turned her neck, I thought it was going to snap apart .

“You guys go first . Remember to reserve two rooms for me and Guan Nie . I want to take a look around . ” When Jiao S finished speaking, she disappeared without a trace .

Guan Nie covered his mouth with disdain . “One room . As if I would tag along with her . ”

I couldn’t help rolling my eyes . “How will we let her know which room she’s staying in? Does she have a phone?”

Guan Nie spoke without much care . “She never uses things like that . Don’t worry, she’ll find us . ”

I couldn’t help rolling my eyes . “How will we let her know which room she’s staying in? Does she have a phone?”

Guan Nie spoke without much care . “She never uses things like that . Don’t worry, she’ll find us . ”

I couldn’t be bothered to speak to this feminine man . I grabbed Song Lu’s arm and walked ahead, leaving the group of boys behind . After walking about ten meters, Song Lu suddenly spoke to me very respectfully, “Ah Shen, do you know what I saw in my illusion in the border forest?”

“What?” I asked curiously .

A sadness passed over Song Lu's eyes . "The penalty I received for using my splitting key was watching Yu Liang die in all kinds of ways, right before my eyes . One second, he was being stabbed by a knife . The next second, he was drowning . That's why I was unable to use the key . And then, in my illusion, I saw those bastards who defiled me while I was alive . I saw them killing Yu Liang..."

She was unable to continue, and her eyes were moist with tears .

I turned around to make sure the boys behind us hadn't heard, and I saw Yu Liang walking with his head hanging low .

I turned back to Song Lu and tugged her arm gently . "Don't worry . Nothing will happen . Didn't Jiao S say that using your splitting symbol would give you the punishment that you were most afraid of? And Huan Qing's illusions dig out the things buried at the bottom of your heart . All this means is that you really care for Yu Liang, that you're afraid he'll be hurt . It doesn't mean anything else . Don't worry . "

"But..." Her eyes were filled with worry . "I'm still afraid . The scene felt so real . Do you think maybe—"

I quickly raised my hand and stuffed a piece of food into her mouth . "Don't say baseless things . Nothing will happen . Trust me . I'll definitely find a way for us to go back . When you and Yu Liang return to the real world and find each other, you'll definitely be happy . Don't think about that kind of nonsense . "

Song Lu lowered her eyes and said quietly, "Well, even if we never go back, it's okay . As long as he and I can stay together forever..."

My mind drifted off as she spoke .

Forever...? Right... In the real world, forever was a rather laughable word . How long could forever be? But, here...

For some reason, I couldn't help turning back to look at Nie Zun . He seemed to be looking in my direction as well . Even though we were far

apart, I could see the sparkle in his eyes . If this devilish man and I could never go back, with our linked fates, would we be able to stay together forever?

What was I thinking about?

I shook my head . Turning back around, I held Song Lu's hand and gave her fingers a comforting rub as we continued ahead .

Chapter 26

Split Zone 13

26 Destiny

The same as last time, when we arrived at the academy, Nie Zun and Jie Pa went to reserve rooms . This time, we reserved four rooms, two sets across from each other .

“Why does Nie Zun always follow Ah Shen everywhere? He’s always close behind too .” Song Lu asked jokingly, unaware of the link between Nie Zun and me .

Nie Zun lifted his eyes and glanced over me . He revealed a small smile and said, “Because she can’t bear to leave me .”

My leg went flying across the air . “Who can’t bear to leave you? Go to hell .”

Song Lu looked at me with an ambiguous expression and smiled . I shook my head helplessly .

I couldn’t explain what Mr Blond had told me before, that the two of us had complementing personalities, and that’s why we always had to be within 500 meters of each other at all times . Since we were together every day though, it was natural that others would misunderstand . But surely, anyone who wasn’t blind could see that I hated him .

I hated that evil aura around him, hiding a demon within . The kind of guy who was frightening once he got serious . When I thought of how my second identity was trapped with him, I felt some resentment .

As I thought about these things, I snuck a glance at Nie Zun . He was the same as before—no, the same as always—looking like he could go to sleep at any moment .

“My pet, you’ll sleep with me tonight . Let that ugly girl stay with Jiao S . Jie Pa and you can come to my room . ” The white-haired devil looked at me with dislike as he invited Nie Zun and Jie Pa .

Barf .

Wanting to vomit, I responded, “The two of you should hurry over to him . Quickly, get away from me . ”

Jie Pa stood like a gentleman and adjusted his glasses . “Ms Ah Shen, I’m straight . ”

Guan Nie pouted and shot a flirtatious look at Jie Pa . “You’re so bad, rejecting me like this . ”

.....

I really couldn’t stand it . Could you possibly handle it if a pretty-faced demonic ‘man’ with white hair that flowed down to his feet, constantly said things like ‘I this and I that’ and ‘Oh, you’re so bad’ in a very masculine voice? (t/n: Feminine terminology)

Well, I can’t .

I quickly walked into my room and closed the door to get away from that monster . About ten minutes after I lied down in my bed, I sensed someone open the door and walk inside . Perhaps it was the culmination of all the long days spend together, but even without looking, I knew it was Nie Zun .

The school dorms had the same layouts in all the districts . I felt him jump onto the top bunk, and I closed my eyes . It would be just a bit longer before night hit .

I couldn’t fall asleep, so I lied there quietly . I don’t know how much time passed, and I’m not sure if the sky had yet darkened, but I didn’t want to

open my eyes .

“Li Shen . ” Nie Zun’s calm voice drifted down from the top bunk .

“Mmh?”

About three minutes passed before I received a reply . “Do you ever think that we may be stuck in this place forever?”

“Nothing lasts forever . It’s not like you haven’t seen them, the old people . If your body died in the real world, your consciousness would also disappear from here . ”

“Have you thought about the time conversion? If one day here is one minute in the outside world, what would you do?”

I was silent .

If... one day here was one day in the outside . Then, one year there would be 525,600 of our days . I would still be 22 in the real world . Forget one year here, even after ten or 20 years, someone in a vegetative state may still not have died in the real world . Then, time here would truly be unimaginably eternal .

Is this why people killed here, to conclude things?

But could I die?

As if seeing through my thoughts, Nie Zun replied, “You can’t die, because your life doesn’t belong to you alone . ”

Eyes closed, I gave a bitter laugh . “Even Li Qing could die . But not me?”

“Li Qing’s death was an anomaly . Everyone knows that she was no ordinary person . ”

That’s right . Li Qing was definitely not ordinary .

I remember when I first arrived in the Split Zone, after I was bestowed with my split symbol, and I always had to stay together with Nie Zun . I hated him so much back then . Even if we were inseparable, I hated him because I'd equated him to the murderer who killed Senior Gao Qi .

Nie Zun and I were both sent to the Western District . When I first met Li Qing, she'd been dressed in silver armor with a head of short, indigo hair . She was tall and always carried a broadsword that wasn't befitting of a woman . Her brows also had a masculine sharpness to them . When you saw her, you'd want to take a second look; it wasn't a gentle and delicate beauty, but rather a heroic and valiant kind of beauty .

Her eyes always had a certain edge, but the faint smile on her lips was as refreshing as a spring breeze . While she hadn't been the most beautiful woman I'd ever seen, she had been the woman who was hardest to forget .

The first thought I had upon seeing her was, 'Is this the same grace and elegance that surrounded Hua Mulan?'

Li Qing's actions had been swift and decisive, passing like thunder and moving like wind . She'd turned the Western District into something orderly and tidy . She had thirty capable and loyal subordinates under her, each in charge of managing one floor of the residence .

Among them was a group of triplets . Supposedly they all arrived in the Split Zone at the same time due to some genetic disorder; they were the only triplets in the history of the Split Zone . We addressed them as generals .

I'd heard from someone that the three of them, carrying the same formidable heroic auras, all loved Li Qing . Someone else said that after Li Qing died, they all went in search of death . But it wasn't possible for three people to seek death . And since they weren't the kind who would harm the innocent, I didn't believe those rumors .

No one knows where they disappeared to, but I never saw them again .

This left only 27 floor supervisors remaining .

Li Qing had become an esteemed, legendary figure in the Split Zone, not only for her governance of the Western District, but also because of the unique circumstances of her death . It may sound a bit strange to say that, but it's true . Li Qing had neither been perpetrator nor offender in a murder, and her consciousness hadn't left because her physical body died . No one knew how she'd died .

One day, she told her subordinates that she'd completed arrangements for the Western District . As if she'd known she were going to die . Even my assignment as the next commander, while technically appointed by Mr Blond, had to have been approved by her . Before leaving, she'd paved well the path for me, allowing the next six months to pass smoothly .

I was lazy and powerless... But it seemed I was fortunate, because a lot of people were helping to take care of me .

Whenever I think of Li Qing, I always feel a deep sadness . Though we hadn't been very close while she was alive, for some reason, her death had taken a great toll on me .

I opened my lips gently . “Nie Zun . ”

“Mmh?” Nie Zun replied, lightly .

“If Li Qing were still here, would there have been fewer incidents in the Western District? Was... Was she wrong in giving me the Western District?”

“If Li Qing were still here, would there have been fewer incidents in the Western District? Was... Was she wrong in giving me the Western District?”

Nie Zun's words came as a light breeze, “I can't answer that kind of question . ”

As expected, he always kept that carefree, cold demeanor . The occasional bouts of tenderness were fleeting, and ordinarily, he watched from afar, alone and keeping his distance .

“But,” his light voice sounded again, “is there something you’re doubtful or confused about? Whether it was right or wrong, she left the district to you . And whether or not you’ve governed it well up to now, what’s important is that we’re here to help you . ”

He turned in bed . “Li Shen . Haven’t Song Lu, Yu Liang, Jie Pa, You Ji, and the 27 floor supervisors been there for you? Even if you do something wrong, there will be others to help you carry the burden . Even if you’ve disappointed Li Qing, there will be others to carry that disappointment with you . So, what’s there to find difficult?”

I felt his eyes land on me, so I finally opened my own . The sky was dark . I saw his head hanging down from the top bunk, watching me . His eyes were filled with... something I didn’t understand . Was it indifference, calm, loneliness?

“Moreover,” he started again, his eyes carrying a warmth that hadn’t seemed to be there before, “you have me . ”

I was a bit startled .

His lips lifted up in an enchanting smile that somehow seemed to also carry an unclear agony . “Whether you like it or not, we’re inseparable . In this place, you’ll just have to let me stay with you forever . ”

Perhaps I’d already heard those words more times than I could bear, but I couldn’t understand the meaning behind his smile . It wasn’t a confession, and they were words filled with helplessness, but what was that agonized dejection on his smile?

Why would he be dejected?

No, don’t think about it . I never really think too much on things . By not thinking too much, I’m able to live fairly happily .

When I was alive, my parents said that my heart was so big that you could grab it right out . After dying, though I couldn’t pull it out, my heart was still very big .

No need to worry about too much . But...

Subconsciously, I glanced over at him again, wanting to determine where that dejection in his eyes came from . But when I looked over, I found that he'd already returned to lying on his bed .

I thought about it a moment, and then I suddenly turned over and got out of bed . “Nie Zun, I’m going for a walk . ” I walked over to the window .

“Your crazy nighttime running illness kicking up again?” he asked without much concern .

“Your crazy nighttime running illness kicking up again?” he asked without much concern .

Without turning back, I said, “You don’t have to come along . I’ll just run in circles . I want some fresh air, but I won’t travel more than 500 meters . ” And without waiting for his reply, I jumped out the window .

—

The Southern District really was very quiet . Once night arrived, it seemed no one went outside . These people must live strictly according to the rules .

The nighttime wind felt like it was making an attack .

I’ve never understood how the Split Zone could be likened to the real world . Everything here was so strange . There were no animals, and plants all had to be grown by the residents . There was no change in weather either .

But why was there wind? Why were we able to use cellphones?

I had no answers, nor did I want to try to figure it out . Perhaps I’ve grown too used to it here . In the end, it’s not all that different from living in the real world . If we were to talk about people’s cruelty, maybe people in the real world were crueler than those here .

With that thought, I tossed my hair and started running through the nearby forest .

In the Southern District, all the buildings were surrounded by forest . The greenery here didn't look bad . The people here must be very at peace, to sort something like that out .

To avoid traveling more than 500 meters from the school, I ran circles in the forest . As I increased my speed, I felt my red dress and hair blowing in the wind, like a burning flame . I didn't want to slow down . Running, running... After I arrived in the Split Zone, this is what I do most often .

After who know's how many hours, I finally slowed down and looked around the forest .

“Watching you run for three hours—even if you didn't get tired of it, I did .” A charming and attractive voice entered my ears .

I stopped in my steps . This was a voice I was much too familiar with .

Once, it had been a captivating voice, as if it had its own electromagnetic force . Every time I heard it, my soul felt like it was being captured . But now, though it was still enchanting, his voice lacked warmth and instead carried a sinister and chilling flavor .

I couldn't stop from turning towards the source of the voice . A face I couldn't be more familiar with suddenly entered my view .

Gao Qi . No, Gao Qin Jiu Ye .

Chapter 27

Split Zone 13

27 Evil or Cold?

Seeing that incomparably familiar, and yet endlessly unfamiliar face appear before my eyes, I couldn't help inhaling a deep breath .

Unbeknownst to me, Gao Qin Jiu Ye suddenly appeared in front of me . He sat on the branch of a nearby tree, arms crossed over his chest, ruthless and vicious eyes locked on me . He was dressed as before: a white hoodie, black jeans, and a pair of bright yellow sneakers on his feet .

I opened my mouth to speak, but I didn't know what to say .

Previously, I hadn't gotten a chance to look at him clearly, so this time, I quietly stood at a distance and examined him carefully . He hadn't changed at all . A sunny and cool appearance . A pleasant and attractive voice . The only difference was that his once gentle-as-water eyes now carried an indescribable and unspeakable malice . I've never seen eyes with such ruthlessness and unfeeling .

He wasn't Gao Qi .

When the thought landed in my mind, a trace of sadness passed in my eyes .

“Hey, do you keep staring at me because you've fallen for me?” That perplexing yet charming voice that left me bewitched every time I heard it, rang in my ears again . It echoed and lingered, cold and yet not unwarm .

I knew my face must have looked infatuated . I didn't want it to be so, but I couldn't control it . When I was alive, I'd been completely unable to resist

him . Now that I was dead, it seemed that my ghost was also more than willing to fall under his spell . The thing I liked more than anything was his voice .

I don't know how many times, after I'd grown exhausted from being bullied and excluded, his voice was able to soothe me . His voice had this power to penetrate through my skin, the power to carry warmth into my heart . Even though his voice now had an added wickedness, it still had its charm .

Evil . Darkness . They were things that have always been with me anyway .

“Come here,” Gao Qin Jiu Ye said, with a smile to me .

I couldn't stop myself . With light steps, I closed the distance between us .

“Shen'er . ”

I don't know why, but suddenly, Nie Zun's carefree voice sounded in my ears, the same way it had in that dream . His voice also had a bewitching quality, but it was different to Gao Qin Jiu Ye's . His voice was enchanting but not wicked . Charming, but not warm . And it always had that carefree, indifferent and unhurried calm to it . As if nothing in the world were important enough to provoke him .

Nie Zun's voice was always able to clear my thoughts . I don't know where the voice came from . I looked around, but Nie Zun was nowhere to be seen .

When I turned back to Gao Qin Jiu Ye, he looked at me with a curious expression . It seemed like he'd found a new toy to play with . His lips moved slightly, “Hah, how interesting . My persuasion don't seem to have effected on you . ”

I froze . Persuasion?

I suddenly recalled Jiao S saying that he was called a persuader .

The infatuation in my eyes slowly receded, replaced by a touch of coldness . “I'm still a district commander . Even if your mental force was high, it

wouldn't be so different from mine . Surely not enough to effect me . ”

Gao Qin Jiu Ye raised his brows . “Who said my persuasion relies on mental force to control others?”

I frowned . What was he saying? Before my thoughts got too far, he suddenly jumped down from the tree . Dressed in leisurely clothing, but emanating a kind of viciousness, he walked over to me casually . For some reason, I felt some kind of force pressing on me, and I subconsciously stepped back .

He stopped two meters in front of me . “What is your motive for coming to the Southern District? He looked at me, sharp malice in his eyes, without so much as a hint of warmth .

“To meet with Si Luo . ”

At the mention of Si Luo's name, Gao Qin Jiu Ye's eyes hardened . “Do you think you're all qualified to meet with him?”

I scoffed . “Are you his superfan or something? We're both district commanders, so what's wrong with meeting each other? What kind of act of superiority is he putting on?”

Gao Qin Jiu Ye's cold and malicious appearance left me melancholic . If he had Senior Gao Qi's appearance, he shouldn't be acting this way .

He sneered, “He's not the one acting superior . I am . If I refuse to let you meet him, then it's best to quit your wishful thinking . I don't care why you came here, just leave . Go back to where you came from . The Southern District is not involved in outside affairs . Whatever you're wanting to do, don't implicate Si Luo in it . ”

I took a hard long look at him . “Even if we cannot meet Si Luo, we must at least find our friends . In each of our districts, a young girl has gone missing . We suspect they are in your district . We can't not investigate this . ”

Gao Qin Jiu Ye raised his brows again . “Lost some kids? That’s just a sign of your incompetence . ”

What?

A wave of anger rolled over my chest . Disregarding his appearance, I glared fiercely at him . “Is it a hobby in the Southern District to kidnap kids? I’m incompetent? If you kidnap a child, does that make you competent? What? I didn’t expect that someone as young as yourself would be a pedophile . ” Anger clouded my judgement, and without much thought, I mocked him without a bit of hesitation .

Gao Qin Jiu Ye looked taken aback by my sudden attack . Then he laughed out loud and said, “And if I’m a pedophile, so what? As a pedophile, I wouldn’t like a strange woman like you . Next time you see me, try not to drool . ”

My temper flared . “Who drools when they see you?! Just because you look like my senior, did you think I would pay attention to you? My senior wore bright yellow sneakers because it was individualistic, but why are you copying him? Knock-off!”

He must have never been cursed at in his life, for his cold brows knit together . “What did you say? You madwoman, what did you call me? Who’s copying your senior? Who is your senior, even?”

I can endure anything, but I won’t let anyone speak ill of my Senior Gao Qi . In an instant, I grabbed the bow on my back with my left hand and an arrow with my right . I aimed it at Gao Qin Jiu Ye in front of me . “If you speak another insolent word, I will shoot your mouth . Do you believe me?”

Gao Qin Jiu Ye’s eyes suddenly lit up . As he stared at my bow, he said, “Nice bow . Won’t you give it to me?” Then he reached a hand out to me .

Without hesitating, I shot an arrow . He quickly sidestepped and easily dodged it . Before I could shoot another arrow, he grabbed onto my bow with his right hand .

Without hesitating, I shot an arrow . He quickly sidestepped and easily dodged it . Before I could shoot another arrow, he grabbed onto my bow with his right hand .

“This bow is really quite nice,” he admired the bow, completely disregarding me .

I glared at him . “Get your hands off . This belongs to me, so don’t even think about it!”

But he ignored me . With the tiniest bit of effort, he grabbed the bow out of my hand .

“You!” I stepped forward to take it back, but then, his eyes swept over me . I had a bad feeling .

Suddenly, the air around me started to condense together . Before I could react, the air between us started to form a vortex, similar to Jiao S’ ability .

As he looked over my bow in his hands, he said, “Don’t advance . I have no intention of going easy on you because you’re a woman . ”

I scoffed . Without hesitating, I stepped forward and extended an arm . With a push of mental force to add strength to my left arm, I moved to snatch back my bow . My feet and a shoulder got caught in his MF whirlwind and started to get sliced up . But I didn’t retreat in pain . I pushed forward and grabbed my bow with my left hand .

When I stepped back, my right shoulder had been shaved off, and my left foot was cut off . Fresh blood flowed out .

With another push of mental force, I leapt back . After putting a safe distance between us, I returned my bow to my back . I bent over, reaching for my ankle, and grabbed Piercer with my left hand . My foot and shoulder had healed by then as well .

Gao Qin Jiu Ye’s eyes trembled . Without stepping closer, he said, “No hesitation at all, huh . Looks like you’re not afraid of pain . Fitting of a

district commander . But I was just taking a look . Did you need to act so ruthlessly?”

I replied coldly, “I don’t like other people touching the things I like . ” As I spoke, I raised Piercer in front of me to deter his attacking .

Gao Qin Jiu Ye didn’t pay much attention to the action at first, but after a moment, he suddenly paused . An incredulous expression crossed his face as he looked at the weapon in my hand .

“What, do you enjoy longing for others’ weapons that much?” I sneered as I cracked Piercer . A violet light flashed .

“What, do you enjoy longing for others’ weapons that much?” I sneered as I cracked Piercer . A violet light flashed .

He furrowed his pretty brows, but his eyes were still locked on the whip in my hand . “Why do you have Piercer?”

“A shop in the marketplace gave it to me,” I replied casually .

Gao Qin Jiu Ye raised his head slightly . “The ones who gave you the weapon, were they a couple?”

Recalling Ah Wen’s cruel death, my heart ached . “Yes . And the wife died in front of my eyes . Many tragedies have been occurring in the Western District lately . That’s why we came to see your district commander . ”

A coldness flashed across Gao Qin Jiu Ye’s eyes . “Ah Wen died?”

“You know her?”

Gao Qin Jiu Ye didn’t respond . His eyes flit over to Piercer again, and then he finally said, “Piercer isn’t for you to use . It’d be best to return it to its owner . The weapon will bring catastrophe . If its user doesn’t die of their own accord, they will be killed by someone else . I told Ah Zhan and Ah Wen not to reveal it to anyone, so I don’t know why they gave it to you . I’ll investigate Ah Wen’s death; no need for you to bother . I don’t suppose you’d be able to help them anyway . ”

I hated being belittled . With a deep frown, I clenched Piercer and glared at him .

But then he gave a wicked laugh and waved a dismissive hand at me . “If you have the time to try proving yourself to me, why don’t you go back and check on your friends . For example, your Jiao S, who likes to roam about on her own . ”

After he spoke, he disappeared with a gust of wind .

My heart dropped . What happened to Jiao S?

Chapter 28

Split Zone 13

28 With Beauty Comes Poison

Though I've always been afraid of the strange Jiao S, at the moment, I couldn't help but feel worried for her .

I quickly returned to the school building . I'd arranged for Jiao S to have the room diagonally opposite mine and Nie Zun's room . A long while after I hastily knocked on her door, it finally opened, and my eyes were greeted with Guan Nie's alluring face . His eyelashes fluttered as if he hadn't quite woken yet .

Damn it! This guy was beautiful beyond words . The world was really too unfair .

When he saw me staring at his face, he raised his eyes slightly and said, "Ugly girl, what are you doing in the middle of the night?"

Recalling my original purpose, I immediately asked, "Where's Jiao S?"

Guan Nie rolled his eyes at me and turned, closing the door with him . He added faintly at the end, "Her room is next door!"

Had I recalled incorrectly?

I quickly moved to knock on the next door over . But even after a long time, there was no answer . A bad feeling flowed into my chest . I tried turning the door knob . With a creak, the door opened . I leaned forward into the pitch black room and walked inside .

The door closed behind me, taking with it the last sliver of light . Though the visibility radius allowed me to see, the room still felt very dark .

“Jiao S?” I looked over at the bunk bed . No one on the bottom . What about the top? I tiptoed to check . No one there either . Then I called out twice, but again, there was no reply .

I turned around, about to turn on the lights, when suddenly, I felt something grab my ankle . Because my split symbol was on my ankle, my feet were exceptionally sensitive . I immediately jumped into the air, which seemed to free me of their hold, and then I looked down .

It would’ve been better not to look . The scene caused me to jump back in fright . Jiao S looked to be sprawled on the floor behind the door . Lying there on the ground, in her school uniform, one of her hands kept trying to grasp onto me . Her uniform was soaked through with blood .

She lifted her head slightly, towards me . Her eyes were large and black, staring at me without even the slightest tremble . Her face was covered in blood, as was the rest of her body . A bloody path traced her crawl from the puddle of blood at the door over to my feet . She neither groaned nor gasped, just silently crawling over .

“You! You’re...” I cried out in alarm .

“Shh...” she commanded, signalling for me to stop shouting . But the action seemed to have been difficult for her . I immediately crouched down beside her .

“How did you get injured?” I looked at her body covered in blood, unsure where to hold her .

She lightly rested her head back on the floor, wanting to save some energy . “Help me up first . Over to the bed . ” I nodded and quickly helped her up .

I couldn’t see a wound on her body, and yet, for some reason, blood kept seeping out from her skin . It was as if there was a layer of blood coating her skin .

Without care to the blood dirtying my clothes, I helped her over to the bed and let her lie down . As she lied down, I saw her frown slightly . I understood that kind of endurance; it must have been very painful .

“What happened? Was it Gao Qin Jiu Ye?” I crouched down by her bed and looked at her skin, still leaking blood .

Jiao S eyes trembled, and she quietly sighed, “No . We did run into each other, but nothing happened then . ”

“Then, what’s going on here?”

For the first time, it seemed that a hint of distress crossed her eyes . “This scene must be very surprising for you . But for me, it’s already become commonplace . ” Though I was very curious about her words, for the moment, I decided to stay silent .

She lied on the bed before me, quiet and still . Her expression and complexion looked lifeless, her eyes looked empty . “Do you know how I ended up here?”

I lowered my head, silent .

“I killed someone . ” Her voice was faint, like a demon’s whisper, easily floating into my ears . I didn’t speak, but the slight tremble in my fingertips belied the change in my emotions .

“The pity is that she ended up living . I stabbed her so many times, but she still lived . ” Jiao S didn’t sound like she was talking about killing a person, but rather retelling a warm story . “Now... She must be sitting at my bedside, scraping at my skin with a small knife, one cut at a time, causing this to happen . ” She gently lifted a hand, watching the blood continue to flow out .

I frowned . “You’re saying that, this situation is happening, because someone is harming your physical body in the real world?”

She turned her head, and her neck cracked . “Yes . But these are small wounds, so she must be cutting me secretly . I can just imagine it—her back to my parents as she holds a small blade, gently marking my skin . Once, twice, three times...”

I couldn’t hold back any longer . I reached out and held her arm . “Don’t speak anymore . ”

She glanced at me, seemingly a bit surprised .

I looked back at her . “It must hurt . ”

A dim speck of light sparkled in her black eyes . “This small pain hardly feels like anything . ”

I felt my palm slowly wet with her blood . “That’s true . Compared to the pain you’ve inflicted onto others, your pain should hardly be considered painful . ”

I raised my head and made eye contact with her . “Jiao S, the first time I saw you was when you came to the Western District, when you tore apart that girl whom Li Qing greatly regarded . Do you remember her? Her name was Li Wen . ”

I felt my palm gradually turn cold .

I’ll remember that scene forever . Li Wen was Li Qing’s favorite disciple . Li Wen always called Li Qing ‘Master . ’ I’d heard that her name was bestowed onto her by Li Qing as well . Li Qing had said then, “I bestow this name to you, and so your life belongs to me . Before I command your death, you are not to die . ” But Li Wen still went missing .

I’ll remember that scene forever . Li Wen was Li Qing’s favorite disciple . Li Wen always called Li Qing ‘Master . ’ I’d heard that her name was bestowed onto her by Li Qing as well . Li Qing had said then, “I bestow this name to you, and so your life belongs to me . Before I command your death, you are not to die . ” But Li Wen still went missing .

Before Li Qing died, I saw with my own eyes, Jiao S leading a large group of her S Clan into the Western District . They'd surrounded the girl in the district center, allowing Jiao S to tear her to pieces in front of the crowd . Jiao S had stripped her naked and then dismembered her over and over again, silently shaming her .

After that incident, Li Wen disappeared . And Li Qing hadn't done anything to stop the attack .

I hated bloody scenes like that, scenes that seemed to put the darkness of human nature on display . That's why, from that point forward, Jiao S became a demon in my mind .

I'm tired of all these demons attaching themselves to people, be it Jiao S, Nie Zun, or myself .

Jiao S hadn't expected for me to bring up Li Wen so suddenly . The blood on her body seemed to have finally stopped spreading .

She nodded . "Li Wen, the woman whom Li Qing adored . "

I let go of her arm as my lips curved into a smirk . "So, of the pain you've suffered today, and the pain you had inflicted on her, which do you think is more painful?"

Jiao S' eyes turned and she looked over me, seriously . Finally, she looked me in the eyes and said, "Do you hate me?"

I returned her stare and shook my head . "I don't hate you . I simply don't understand your cruelty . "

Li Wen had been a sweet and gentle girl . To everyone, her first impression had been that of a sweet, kind, smiling girl . A fine and good girl who lived in the world . When you saw her, you may not exclaim at her beauty, nor would you find her overbearing, but you would think she was a good person .

Once you saw how wonderful a person she was, how could you bear to watch her body be broken into pieces, like slabs of meat?

Jiao S suddenly smiled . Her face had always been stiff as a board before, so seeing her smile felt rather odd . “Li Shen, do you know this? Beautiful things are always carry poison . The more beautiful they are, the more poison they carry . The beautiful things you see may not genuinely be that beautiful . All good things are adorned with evil . ”

Those were words that I could not dispute .

Those were words that I could not dispute .

She continued, “I took note of you then, watching from among the shuddering crowd . Like everyone else, you looked at me with frightened eyes, and your body trembled from fear . But I saw something more in your eyes, that others lacked . ”

“What?”

Her eyes wandered . “A goodness . A cruel goodness, the kind that belonged in the Split Zone . I’d seen that look in another person’s eyes once before, and he became someone I’ll never be able to forget . Fortunately, you were a girl, otherwise you’d have become entangled with me for all of time . ”

Her last line seemed to be a joke, and she had a childlike smile on her face . I was taken aback .

Jiao S suddenly sat up . “I’m going to wash this blood off of me . Don’t tell anyone about what happened today . ”

She took a few steps, and then abruptly turned back around, a playful radiance in her eyes . “If you tell anyone, who knows, you might be the next one I tear to pieces . ”

I wasn’t the slightest bit scared by her words . Rather, on the contrary, I found her a bit cute . I waved my hand, dismissing her and telling her to go wash . I won’t tell anyone .

Jiao S turned and looked at the bloodied floor . Her eyes swept the room, and then the air suddenly started hissing and cracking . The blood on the floor condensed together and then disappeared into the air .

After Jiao S walked into the bathroom, a knock suddenly came on the door . Since Jiao S didn't come out to ask about it, I walked over to open the door myself . The door opened slowly, and then a carefree and indifferent face greeted me .

Nie Zun leaned against the door frame, a light smile on his face . “Done chatting? If you're done, you should come back . ”

I cast a sidelong glance . “What, you already miss me?”

Nie Zun's lips opened gently, “It's not so much that I miss you as it is that Yu Liang and Song Lu are missing . ” He spoke as if he were telling a calm story, without emotion, without alarm . But I couldn't remain so unaffected . When I heard his words, my eyes widened and I clutched my hands together tightly .

Chapter 29

Split Zone 13

29 Falling Into a Trap

“What do you mean ‘Yu Liang and Song Lu are missing’?” I asked with a frown . Jiao S had just finished washing up, and after overhearing our conversation, she walked over .

Nie Zun’s eyes were slightly narrowed . “Come over and see . ” I followed him over to Yu Liang and Song Lu’s room across the hall .

When we arrived, the door was open, and Guan Nie and Jie Pa were already inside . Guan Nie’s red phoenix eyes (t/n: outer corners incline upwards) glanced over as he handed me a sheet of paper . On it was written: If you want to find them, come to the Northern District .

The furnishings in the room were undisturbed, and there was no sign of a struggle .

Jie Pa pushed his glasses up and said, “In the middle of the night, I suddenly had a question about medicine production that I wanted to discuss with Yu Liang . I knocked for a long time, but there was no response . When I walked into the room, nothing looked unusual, but for this piece of paper . ”

I frowned . “Wait . Let me go over the night’s events . So, tonight, we all returned to our rooms . Jiao S ran into Gao Qin Jiu Ye outside, and then she returned to her room . Then I went out and also ran into Gao Qin Jiu Ye . When I returned, Jie Pa discovered that Yu Liang and Song Lu were missing . Correct?”

Guan Nie raised his brow and glanced at Jiao S . “You ran into Gao Qin Jiu Ye?”

Jiao S nodded . “Mmh . We didn’t fight . He simply said he wouldn’t let us meet Si Luo . It seemed like he was in a rush to do something, so he didn’t speak to me long . ”

Guan Nie smirked . “Next time, don’t move on your own . If something were to happen to you, I’m afraid those three may kill me . ”

Jiao S didn’t respond .

Nie Xun’s arms were crossed over his chest, black gloves on his hands . “One after the next, unusual things have been occurring . Now we have clear instructions to head to the Northern District . If we don’t go, we won’t be able to uncover what’s going on, but if we do make the trip now, I’m afraid we can’t guarantee our safety . ”

Jiao S’ expression was determined . “I’m going . And I’ll be seeing Si Luo before I go . ”

Nie Zun’s lips curved into a slight smile . “You seem very resolute on meeting with Si Luo . ” Jiao S’ inner thoughts had been revealed . She tried to hide this fleeting, strange look in her eyes, but I’d seen it very clearly .

After a moment, she continued, “Aside from seeking out Si Luo, what other plans do you guys have?”

I lowered my head and thought for a moment . With a nod, I said, “I agree with Jiao S . The Southern Commander seems to be the only person who can give us a reasonable explanation . It seemed that Gao Qin Jiu Ye wasn’t acting with benevolence . After finding out about our arrival, he moved to block us from meeting Si Luo . There’s a problem somewhere in there . Now that Yu Liang and Song Lu have gone missing, it’s become very clear that our opponent is hiding in the shadows while we’re sitting in plain sight . We can’t act impulsively . All we can do now is to seek out Si Luo to clarify the situation . He’s a district commander, so he wouldn’t just block

us; he wouldn't want strange things happening in his district either .
Meeting with him is our best option . ”

Jie Pa also nodded . “Ms Ah Shen put it nicely . ”

Guan Nie glanced at me . “Ah, so the ugly girl has a brain after all . ”

I couldn't tolerate it any longer . My hand quickly passed by his head and grabbed a hold of his long white hair that nearly swept the floor . With a ferocious glare, I said, “Believe me when I say that I will chop Nie Zun up if you call me ugly one more time . ”

Guan Nie's beautiful face fell back as I grabbed at his hair, but his expression seemed to remain unchanged . In fact, his coquettish eyes swept over me . “Esteemed guest, don't be angry . Your (female) servant won't call you that way anymore~”

Gag... I couldn't help bending over to vomit, and naturally my grip on his hair loosened .

When he saw me let go, Guan Nie pulled his long hair away . “To sum it up, you want to find Si Luo . I heard he's a rarely-seen beautiful man . Looks like I'll be able to bear witness to his elegance . I will accompany you, reluctantly . But where exactly are we headed to find him?”

I turned to Jiao S . “Shall we find Ku Fei to lure out Mi Fu? Though, there's no guarantee that we're not walking into Huan Qing's trap . ”

Jiao S turned her neck, crack, crack . “You, Nie Zun, and Jie Pa should go to Ku Fei . Nie Guan and I will keep watch . ”

I looked at Jie Pa and Nie Zun, who both nodded .

—

The dark of night had yet to pass . When we arrived at the residence to find Ku Fei, there were still a few more hours before day came .

Knock, knock, knock .

The door opened and Ku Fei popped his head out, drowsiness in his eyes . It was clear that he'd just been woken from his slumber . When he saw the three of us standing there, he was taken aback . Along with his bright smile, he said, "You're here . Why did you come so late?"

I also smiled a bit . "We couldn't fall asleep, so we came to find you to chat . I hope you don't mind . "

Ku Fei smiled enthusiastically . "Of course not . Come in, come in . "

After we entered his room, Ku Fei closed the door behind us, and the three of us all subconsciously looked around the room . The light wasn't on, so we stood there in the darkness . When I heard the click of the door closing, for some reason, I felt ill at ease . Though Ku Fei had, up until then, appeared to be a bright youth, this night, I couldn't help turning back to look at him .

Coincidentally, I was met with Ku Fei's smiling face . He was indeed smiling, but it was unlike his familiar, bright smile . Instead, the smile was laced with a kind of cunning, a strangeness . Before I could even react, I suddenly felt the floor disappear beneath me, and I tumbled downwards .

When the floor suddenly falls out from under you, it's impossible to fall gracefully . That held true for us as well . As I fell, I screamed out, "Ahhh—!!" I saw that, at my side, Nie Zun and Jie Pa were tumbling down as well .

The fall seemed to continue on endlessly . The wind whistled in my ears . We'd fallen so far that I could no longer see Ku Fei . After some tens of seconds of falling, but before I could react, and especially before I was able to concern myself with my companions, we landed on the ground with a thud .

All the bones in my body felt like they'd broken to pieces . I lied on the ground in the darkness and rolled my eyes . It seriously f*cking hurt! After falling such a distance, I felt my body turn soft . I lied weak on the ground, and a pressure on my chest caused me to spit out blood .

I tried to get up and look at Nie Zun and Jie Pa, but because of my heavy injuries' slow healing time, I could hardly move . I was dizzy and my vision blurred; blood seemed to be all around me . My whole body felt miserable .

As I struggled and struggled more, I couldn't help vomiting more blood . When I finished, I caught a glimpse of Nie Zun from the corner of my eye . Nie Zun was lying on the floor nearby, his body still . I knew that his split symbol had been activated, so he wouldn't have had enough MF to stop himself from falling . If he'd removed his splitting key, he would have been too weak, so he surely wouldn't do that .

Dressed entirely in black, he lied there, a pool of blood around his body . I struggled to pull myself to the side, but was f*cking startled by what I saw . Jie Pa had been decapitated, and his body stood at the side in darkness . His glasses had fallen somewhere as well .

His bloodied face was looking right at me . Right at me... The image was too damned terrifying! A head lying on the floor, staring at me! A raging fire entered my chest, and I was vomitting blood again . Jie Pa's bloody face shot me his gentleman's smile, but at the moment, it looked anything but gentlemanly .

"How did you end up breaking your head off?" I asked weakly, doing the best to resist the pain surging through my body .

Seemingly unconcerned, Jie Pa's head said, "Don't worry . I bent my neck while falling, and I just happened to have a knife in my backpack . So it was accidentally chopped off . "

Pfft...

Lying there helplessly, I felt my bones and flesh gradually healing . After several minutes, I still wasn't strong enough to stand up, but Nie Zun looked to have already recovered completely . He got up slowly, and when he saw the pool of blood at his feet, he immediately jumped back, his face full of disgust .

What a germaphobe...

He looked at the blood on the ground and on his clothes, loathing muddying the carefree expression on his face . Though his black clothes were soaked with blood, it wasn't obviously visible . With his black-gloved hands, he lifted the corner of his coat to wring it out .

So, to summarize the scene before me: A somewhat bloodied yet decadent and handsome man, dressed in a black windbreaker and black gloves, was wringing the blood out of his clothes . Blood dripped from his clothes . A handsome man and fresh blood, inseparable, truly...

This sudden catastrophe must have affected my intelligence, causing my nonsensical thoughts .

After he finished dealing with his clothes, Nie Zun walked over towards me . One step, two steps... And he walked right past me, without a single glance my way . He helped Jie Pa put his head back on his body, to allow him to heal faster . Jie Pa told him, "Help find my glasses first . "

Just great... The scene and the dialogue between three people who'd broken up into pieces really made you feel stuffy inside .

But why didn't he help me up?!

I glared at Nie Zun's back . Feeling that my body had healed halfway, I tried to sit up . "Ah..." I moaned from the pain . I kneaded my exhausted body and looked down at my originally red dress, now soaked in blood . I felt my back, checking for my bow, and then I checked for Piercer at my ankle . Good, they were still there .

As Nie Zun helped Jie Pa, I raised my head and looked up above and then around us . We were in a circular, basement-like place . I don't know how far we fell, for above us was just darkness . My night visibility allowed me to see ten meters ahead of me, but all I saw was what looked like a round tunnel . There was nothing else, just darkness beside us and above us .

I tried to recall . We had fallen down from Ku Fei's room, through a trap door in the floor . After the door opened, we fell down here .

But why did this kind of a place exist in the Split Zone? Though we've planted trees before, plants in the Split Zone are different from the real world . The seeds that Mr Blond gives to us don't require soil to grow . Beneath the Split Zone was not earth nor an empty void, but rather layer upon layer of stone . So, had this place been dug out?

The ground in the Split Zone was made from stone though, so how could it have been dug out? I've never seen Mr Blond provide any excavation tools to any of the shops in the marketplace .

—

mayy's comments

I sympathize with Li Shen on some things, but mmh . Her turn-ons are weird .

Chapter 30

Split Zone 13

30 Nie Zun Makes a Move

“Hey, hey . Have you guys ever heard of a place like this existing in the Split Zone?” My body had nearly finished healing, though some residual pain remained . I couldn’t stand up, so I sat on the ground and watched Nie Zun and Jie Pa .

Jie Pa head already healed quite a bit, and Nie Zun was currently gathering up all the bottles and jars that had fallen out of Jie Pa’s bag . Jie Pa tousled his hair and then tried to tidy his suit . “I’ve never heard of any such thing . Is this a trap? Why would Mr Ku Fei want to harm us?”

I couldn’t help rolling my eyes at Jie Pa, in his gentleman’s outfit, calling the lively and youthful Ku Fei ‘Mr Ku Fei . ’

Picking up the things on the ground, Nie Zun spoke lazily, “He didn’t seem quite right, like someone had put a spell on him . ” As he said that, a girlish laugh sounded from a dark corner .

Her laugh was clear and pleasant, like a silver bell ringing . But in this situation, while we were surrounded with puddles of blood, the laugh didn’t sound so cute anymore . From the dark corner, a young girl walked out . Dressed in a pink dress, she had elfish ears and rosy cheeks .

It was that unruly girl, Mi Fu .

I suddenly had a headache .

Mi Fu fluttered her eyes at me, a pink whip clutched in her hands . “Jiejie, you fell down so carelessly . I’ll have to punish you . ” She must have been waiting awhile, for she couldn’t seem to wait any longer . She laughed out loud and then flicked her pink whip at me .

Because I was still in pain, I wasn’t fast enough to avoid her attack . As I reached for Piercer, Mi Fu’s pink whip came flying right in front of my face . Crap, I thought to myself . Jie Pa had said that the substance on her whip caused a lot of pain . It wouldn’t be an attack that was easy to cope with, but since the attack was already here, I closed my eyes and waited for the pain to hit .

One second . Two seconds . But no pain came .

I opened my eyes, and there was nothing in front of me but darkness . I lifted my hands up and rubbed my eyes . Then I took another look .

Nie Zun stood in front of me . Since his back faced me, I’d seen the black of his coat . I quickly stepped to the side to see what had happened .

Nie Zun had grabbed onto the pink whip with his black-gloved right hand . His other hand was stuffed in his coat pocket . Mi Fu pulled back on her weapon, but she was unable to pull the whip out from Nie Zun’s hand .

I put my strength into my legs, and then I took a step forward . When I turned my head, I happened to catch a glimpse of Nie Zun’s eyes . They left me stunned . His eyes seemed to have lost their carefree quality . His pupils didn’t simply reflect the light; instead, they flickered with power . An indescribable kind of power, seeming to carry the ability to see through all things, emanated from his eyes .

A chill ran down my body . Nie Zun’s eyes were suddenly overflowing with force!

I saw Nie Zun’s yank his arm back . Mi Fu didn’t release her whip, so it, along with her, fell forward . Mi Fu staggered, and then her pink-clothed body fell toward us .

While I stood at the side, dumbfounded, Mi Fu had already been dragged right up to Nie Zun's face . Suddenly, he reached his hand out from his pocket and flung it toward me . His left glove floated over to me . I subconsciously grabbed for it with my hands, looking quite the fool, like someone scrambling to catch two buns that were tossed to them from afar .

Nie Zun's now-bare left hand was pale with slender fingers, no lively tinge of color to be seen . Aside from being too pale, his hand was the most beautiful one I'd ever seen .

Still in a bit of a trance, I saw the fingers of his bare hand wrap around Mi Fu's neck . A cold light, that I'd never seen before, colored Nie Zun's eyes . No, they weren't just cold; they lusted for blood, as if her blood were an offering to him .

Like a reaper who'd dropped from the sky, a deathly aura emanated from his entire body . His left hand appeared very clearly, rough but delicate . And at that moment, that perfect hand was firmly and brutally clutching at Mi Fu's neck . Mi Fu wasn't tall . Rather, she was petite and dainty . When Nie Zun lifted her up with just one hand, her expression started to change .

Her eyes widened and her pupils started to dilate . They were filled with horror and deep pain . Her cute, rosy red cheeks were replaced by the bright red color of someone out of breath, someone being choked . Her face twisted into an ugly picture as she shook with fear . She no longer looked like a pretty, young girl .

It seemed like she'd seen the most terrifying thing in the world . And because of that, she shook and shook and shook .

Nie Zun's eyes shined with a hair-raising demonic gleam . His actions, plus the faint smile hanging on his lips gave me the feeling that he enjoyed the act of killing . I'd never seen Nie Zun that way before . For some reason, a heavy anxiety and panic streamed into my chest . It was as if Nie Zun hadn't only attacked Mi Fu, but also me .

I extended my arm to stop Nie Zun, and that's when I realized that my arm was shaking .

I stood there, at a loss for what to do . Fortunately, Jie Pa seemed to have fully recovered, and he quickly appeared in front of me, grabbing hold of the arm Nie Zun was using to strangle Mi Fu .

Jie Pa remained entirely calm throughout . He looked at Nie Zun and added a small amount of force to his grip . “Nie Zun, enough . Let go of her . It’s not worth it . ”

My words were finally able to escape my throat . “Nie Zun... I’m fine . Let go of her . She’s still a kid . ”

As if finally having heard Jie Pa and me, Nie Zun’s demonic, murderous expression finally eased up . He gently placed Mi Fu back on the ground .

When he released her neck, Mi Fu fell to the ground . She wrapped her own hands around her neck, coughing . She was no longer a cute, little girl, but rather, she looked like a child who’d been abused . Lying on the ground, gasping for air, her body trembled weakly, and her panic-stricken eyes darted back and forth .

Nie Zun’s right hand naturally returned to his jacket pocket, and then he turned around and walked over to me . He looked at me, his eyes indifferent and carefree once again . Then he reached out his left hand to me .

Nie Zun’s right hand naturally returned to his jacket pocket, and then he turned around and walked over to me . He looked at me, his eyes indifferent and carefree once again . Then he reached out his left hand to me .

I lowered my head and looked at his hand, pale as a girl’s and yet sharp and angular . And then I noticed the ring on his little finger .

I looked down and lifted my arm up . I helped him put on the glove that I held in my hands .

Suddenly, something dropped down from above us . I’d just put Nie Zun’s glove on his hand, so I subconsciously grabbed his hand and pulled him over to the side to move out of the way . A sudden gust of wind passed by, and a white figure appeared .

A white suit, chestnut hair, and exquisite amber eyes . The illusionist, Huan Qing .

When he landed, he looked at the shivering Mi Fu sprawled on the ground . His eyes hardened and he quickly went to help her up . Mi Fu's eyes still quivered violently, and there seemed to be tears in her eyes . "Huan Qing gege . "

Huan Qing's brows knit together as he looked around at everyone . His eyes were cold as ice . "Mi Fu is still young . She was simply playing a joke on you, but you dared to respond with such a heavy hand . Aren't you looking down on the Southern District too much?"

When I heard those words, I couldn't remain calm any longer . I pushed aside Nie Zun's hand and walked forward . My blood-red hair was tossed behind me .

I looked at him coldly . "She set up a trap for us to all fall into this pit . And you're calling that a joke? Who's looking down on who right now? I came as a district commander, to meet with another district commander . But your commander has yet to reveal himself, and his subordinates have repeatedly attacked and humiliated us . I don't care who you are . If you don't give me an explanation today, the Eastern and Western Districts won't be able to exist peacefully with the Southern District!"

It must have been all these days of alarming and dubious events . Coupled with the anxiety from still being unable to find Laurel, my patience had truly reached its limit . And so, I blabbered out some irresponsible words .

"She's right . If you continue on bullying us so, I'm afraid that neither the Eastern nor Western Districts will take it lying down . " Jiao S' rough voice sounded from above . Then she and Guan Nie floated down .

"She's right . If you continue on bullying us so, I'm afraid that neither the Eastern nor Western Districts will take it lying down . " Jiao S' rough voice sounded from above . Then she and Guan Nie floated down .

Guan Nie's white hair swayed at his slender waist . He walked over to join us, a filthy smile on his face . "Aiyayaya, this pit is very deep . Even with mental force, one might nearly break his bones . You must have gotten very hurt, my poor, precious darlings . "

Ignoring him, I kept my eyes on Huan Qing .

After a quick look around, Huan Qing's eyes locked onto him . "Li Shen, I was unaware of tonight's events . I set a spell onto Ku Fei, such that, at night, he listens to Mi Fu's words . Today's incident must have come about when Mi Fu ordered Ku Fei to play a practical joke . I only found out about this when Jiao S came to me, and I rushed over . Mi Fu carries no ill-will, so I hope that you will not take tonight's ordeal to heart . "

I didn't respond, but Jiao S spoke up, "We can forget about what happened tonight, but please, take us to see your district commander . There have been some occurrences in our districts recently, and we must speak with him . "

Huan Qing's lips curved slightly into a contemptuous smile . "Jiao S, I can believe that Li Shen is here to see the commander for business, but you... Aren't you simply using that as an excuse?"

Jiao S' eyes hardened . "What kind of crap are you spewing out? Just tell us whether you'll take us to see him . "

Huan Qing looked at her a few more seconds, a profound look on his face, and then he looked down and said, "It's not that I'm refusing to help you . Jiao S, it's not the first time we're meeting, and you should know that I don't lie . I don't know where the commander currently is . It's been about three months since I've seen him . "

Jiao S frowned . "Even you don't know where he is? Could it really be that..."

Huan Qing looked at her and slowly nodded .

Chapter 31

Split Zone 13

31 Trail of Clues

Nie Zun suddenly spoke up . “I don’t care about all that other stuff . But that girl in your arms...” He paused and pointed at Mi Fu . “Her whip is coated with a powerful poison, and she never hesitates to attack with it . A vicious heart as hers... I won’t let her off easily if I meet her again . ”

He spoke with resolve, drawing the girl’s ire . She looked at him but kept her lips tightly sealed out of fear . She dared to be angry, but not to speak out .

Huan Qing’s eyes were cold . “Nie Zun, don’t speak too confidently . Lady Mi Fu is the goddess of our district . No one, including Lord Si Luo, would tolerate anyone harming her . I’m afraid that not even you would be able to escape unscathed if you were to attack . ”

Nie Zun smiled, almost as if he were possessed . He lazily turned towards his right shoulder and dropped his head, looking down at the crouched Huan Qing and Mi Fu . “Why don’t we give it a try then? If she tries to harm Li Shen once more, then let’s give it a try and see . ” His last words were especially graceful and caring, like a lover’s, “Let’s go watch the sunrise together . ” But it was that loving tone that made me subconsciously tremble .

A violent storm stirred in Huan Qing’s eyes as he stared at Nie Zun . From behind the misty clouds, a murderous intent appeared . Subconsciously, I reached for the bow at my back .

The scene seemed to have paused at that moment . Huan Qing didn't move, his eyes locked on Nie Zun, foggy, white mist swirling inside them .

I'd already grabbed hold of my bow, sliding it onto my shoulder, and then I reached for an arrow as well . Nie Zun maintained his slightly towering position and narrowed his eyes .

No one dared exhale . Jiao S stood at the side, her eyes empty and expressionless, like a marionette stuck in place . Jie Pa silently pushed his glasses up his nose . Guan Nie was also unusually quiet and still . Diagonally behind Nie Zun, his hair fell casually down . Paired with his phoenix eyes, he really looked like a beauty inside a painting .

My eyes wandered around us, and my hand remained behind my shoulder .

Mi Fu, for some reason, looked like she was suffering a great pain, though it had been obvious that Nie Zun hadn't left any type of wound . She kept gasping for breath, leaning and holding onto Huan Qing, her face twisted up unnaturally .

The storm continued to rage on inside of Huan Qing's eyes awhile before finally calming .

He raised a brow and said, "If you all insist on meeting with Lord Si Luo, go find the persuader, Gao Qin Jiu Ye . He's the only one who would know of Lord Si Luo's whereabouts . My responsibility is to watch over Lady Mi Fu . If you continue to encroach on us, I won't let you go . As for the rest of your business, I have no interest, nor will I be allowing Lady Mi Fu to participate . "

Mi Fu glared at me . In a hoarse voice, she said, "I just like him . Why can't all of you just mind your own business?"

Huan Qing motioned for her to say no more . Then he spoke up, "Lady Mi Fu is young and inexperienced; she doesn't know how to express love . And truly, she simply fell in love with that young man . He's in the Split Zone all by himself, with a stubborn temper, moreover . We've never done anything untoward to him, but he continues to refuse Lady Mi Fu . I only put a spell

on him so that he would spend some time with Lady Mi Fu . The illusions cannot control one's feelings, nor will it cause any great problems for anyone . You outsiders are just being too meddlesome . ”

I was about to dispute him, but then I caught Jiao S lightly shake her head in my direction . Then I glanced at Nie Zun, and he didn't say anything either .

So then, I simply nodded . “Alright, we'll leave Ku Fei alone . After all, he's a resident of your district, and his life has nothing to do with us . But, we'd best not see any of your poison or nonsense again . ” I stared at Mi Fu, clearly enunciating all my words as I spoke .

Mi Fu looked at me, her eyes looking more spiteful than ever before . But she didn't dare say a single word .

Huan Qing helped Mi Fu up, and then he gave a short nod in our direction .

Jiao S suddenly spoke up . “Wait . How did you create this pit?”

Huan Qing gave a smile, chilling but emotionless . “There's no pit . This is an illusion . In order to protect Lady Mi Fu, who often visits Ku Fei in the evenings, I prepared this in advance . ” Just as he spoke, his hand appeared from his white suit sleeve . With a wave, the dark pit returned to the image of Ku Fei's room .

The rest of us looked on, dumbfounded . I looked at Nie Zun, who was clearly a bit taken aback as well .

Huan Qing gave another smile, lacking warmth as always . “My illusion began the moment you stepped into the room . While it may have been an illusion, it was also able to inflict legitimate pain . In other words, when you fell down the pit in my illusion, you were injured as if it were a real fall . ”

When he was done speaking, he picked up Mi Fu in his arms . And like before, in the shop, the two of them faded into the air . As his image disappeared from the room, he left a few final words, “That's why I said it

would be best if we didn't intervene in each other's business . Otherwise, when your face really gets torn, there's no escaping unscathed anymore . ”

I looked around me and saw that Ku Fei was lying in his bed, as if in a coma .

“I hadn't expected that he was so skilled . No wonder he's the top in the Southern District,” Jie Pa said quietly .

“What do we do now?” I looked at the unconscious Ku Fei and then back at our group .

Jiao S remained silent . Guan Nie stood at the side, looking completely uninterested .

Nie Zun contemplated a moment . “Let's not worry about Ku Fei . Li Shen, stop sympathizing with everyone as well . No one in the Split Zone is entirely innocent and pure . Not even a nice guy like Ku Fei . So, I think we're done here . ” Nie Zun turned to look at me .

I looked at him in the eyes, and then I finally dropped my gaze . I looked back over at the unconscious Ku Fei and said, “You're right . We can't even save ourselves, so how can we get involved in other people's business?”

Jiao S spoke up in her rough voice, “In any case, we must find Si Luo . ”

Nie Zun looked at Jiao S, his expression filled with interest . Finally, he said lightly, “Though I don't know why you cling to him, it does appear that, right now, finding him is our only course of action . Especially since two of our team are now missing . ”

Guan Nie grabbed his hair and sniffed it . Speaking relaxed and unhurried, “To find Si Luo, we must first find Gao Qin Jiu Ye, though his actions don't follow any kind of pattern . But once we find Gao Qin Jiu Ye, we should be able to find Si Luo . After half a day, we're back where we started . ”

Then he dropped the hair in his hands . He turned around and looked to Jiao S . “If following you all is going to be this boring, I'm not sticking around .

”

Jiao S sneered . “Since when have you had to report to me about your actions, Guan Nie? You can leave whenever you please . Or is it that, now that we’re finally meeting him, you want to cower back?”

Guan Nie’s eyes darted around . The way his lips twitched looked like fresh flower petals closing together . “Jiao S, since we are of the same kind, must we ridicule each other? When the three of them aren’t around, you know that we needn’t feign closeness . Remember what you promised me . ”

Then he turned to shoot a coquettish glance at Nie Zun . “You can continue discussing . I’m heading back to my room . When you’ve set your plans, pet, come knock on my door . ” After that, with a turn of his white robe, he left .

Then he turned to shoot a coquettish glance at Nie Zun . “You can continue discussing . I’m heading back to my room . When you’ve set your plans, pet, come knock on my door . ” After that, with a turn of his white robe, he left .

Jiao S rolled her eyes . “I’m heading back as well . Gao Qin Jiu Ye won’t easily appear, and he might not appear at all . I trust that you and Nie Zun will come up with a plan . ” And then, she also hurriedly left Ku Fei’s room .

I frowned . “They’re really companions who only travel half-way with you . Entirely unreliable . The secrets those two keep probably are probably on par to the secrets of the Southern District . It’s just the three of us now . We still know nothing about the Northern District . The only ones with the slightest bit of information, Yu Liang and Song Lu, have now disappeared . What are we supposed to do?”

My heart suddenly ached as I thought about Yu Liang and Song Lu; I didn’t know if they were hurt or not . I was truly a mess of a district commander .

Jie Pa muttered irresolutely, “This trip was indeed too sudden . We didn’t plan enough . That’s why the situation turned out like this . ”

Nie Zun said quietly, “Let’s head back first . Ku Fei will wake up soon . We can discuss things slowly, back in our room . ”

The three of us left the Southern Residence to find that it was already day out . We headed into the forest around the building, and though there was no sun, the sounds of birds, the scent of flowers, and being able to see into the distance allowed me to sigh in relief .

I stopped in my steps and looked up at the ever-grey Split Zone sky . Then I glanced back at the residence . After a few minutes, I turned and ran to catch up with Nie Zun and Jie Pa, who’d continued walking ahead .

“Why don’t the three of us head to the South-North border forest to scout it out first? It’s day now, and Jiao S and Guan Nie just happen to not be present,” Jie Pa suggested .

I exchanged a glance with Nie Zun . “Good idea . Let’s go take a look . ”

The three of us started running, but the Southern District seemed to be very expansive and filled with forests . By the time we made it to the border forest, more than ten hours had already passed .

There were numerous types of trees in the South-North border forest .

Trees in the Split Zone were a bit unusual . Plants here were like dead things, growing quietly, without need for water or soil; they grew simply with mental force . Most of those plants were sold in the medicine shops . But the trees, they forever grew silently yet oddly lush in the forests .

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Planting trees simply required picking out a hole in the stone ground and dropping in a seed . And it would grow . There were many different types of trees in the Southern District . The border forest was densely packed with them, and there didn't seem to be a clearing in sight .

We stood outside of the forest . Once we passed through the crowded forest, we would be at the border to the Northern District . The legendary blood-red border line that was impossible to traverse across .

Jie Pa suddenly frowned and turned to me .

“What is it?” I'd never seen Jie Pa quite so serious and concerned before .

He muttered, “Ms Ah Shen, do you remember that I've told you about sending a thousand-mile scent chaser to the South-North border in search of Ms Laurel?”

“I do . ” I nodded .

He was suddenly quiet .

Then, as if having confirmed something, he said, “Though my sense of smell isn't nearly as strong as a scent chaser's, from my experience brewing alcohol and medicine, my sense of smell has grown rather sensitive . When we approached the border forest, I caught the scent of Ms Laurel . ”

My heart skipped a beat . “What you're saying is that Laurel hasn't been taken to the Northern District, but rather she is within this forest?”

“Yes . ” Jie Pa nodded gravely .

Chapter 32

Split Zone 13

32 Boundary Trees

The Southern Forest was densely packed with trees, making it a bit difficult for the three of us to travel through it . Following Jie Pa's lead, we moved through each layer of the forest . The further in we went, the harder the passage became . We were quite literally squeezing in between two trees at every move .

After walking for nearly three hours, we finally arrived at the last row of crowded trees . The trees were lined up horizontally, side by side, and we couldn't see what lied on the other side of the them . The trees grew so closely together that their branches had intertwined . They looked like they'd grown together into a single tree .

Since there was no path through the tree barricade, we had to cut one out . I was about to push up my sleeves and get to work, when I realized that the red dress I wore had no sleeves... So instead, I grabbed Piercer and motioned for Nie Zun and Jie Pa to step back .

I lifted my arm, flicked my whip back, readied my mental force, and then flicked forward with great force . Pow! Pow! Pow! As I attacked the trees with my whip, I was satisfied to see three slashes of violet light in the air . After the light faded, I inspected the trees carefully .

My god! I'd hit about five trees with my whip, but not a single one had moved a single inch . Hadn't... Moved... An inch... My face twitched . There were only light whip marks on the trees . But I'd added mental force in my attack!

From the side, I heard Nie Zun and Jie Pa trying to suppress their laughter . An embarrassed expression on my face, I stepped back resentfully .

Jie Pa put down his backpack and pulled out a half blade sword . The blade was wide and thick, reflecting a cold light . The engraving on the handle was fine and meticulous; it was obviously a very good weapon . The only pity was that the tip of the blade was missing, leaving only behind half a blade .

“Half swords...are usually only used by immortals . Even at a glance, this sword doesn't look ordinary . Did it previously belong to a hero of the Split Zone? And then it was broken in a fierce battle, later to be discovered by you? Am I right?” I eagerly asked Jie Pa, my imagination running wild .

Jie Pa pushed up his glasses, a humorous look in his eyes . “That's not it, Ms Ah Shen . The blade for this was originally not very long, and the tip broke off when we fell in Mr Ku Fei's room, when my head was chopped off . I figured there was no use for the tip, so I threw it away . ”

Broke off when we fell in Mr Ku Fei's room...

Suddenly, I felt thoroughly and completely embarrassed . “Why didn't my bow break then?”

Jie Pa smiled warmly . “Ms Ah Shen, your bow is special . The inlaid locking mechanism on the holster as well . They won't easily break because of a fall, even if it's a high fall . Your bow is also protected by mental force, to reinforce it even more . ”

Protected by mental force...

I suddenly recalled something that caused my chest to ache, and I fell silent .

Jie Pa also didn't say any more . He simply stepped forward and made a cut on the trees in front of us . Then he pulled out a bottle from his backpack and poured its liquid contents over the cuts .

The liquid ate away at the trees, and then the trees fell back with cracking sounds . With five trees fallen, we could finally see the world behind them . We all fell into a daze .

From the newly made gap, I saw that behind the trees was a large pit, several hundred meters in diameter . The trees had been planted nearly on the edge of this abyss; they'd been planted in a circle around it, creating a protective barrier .

Because of the pit, we couldn't walk any further . We looked down from behind a half-fallen tree . The pit probably wasn't as deep as the one in Ku Fei's room had been, maybe just a few hundred meters deep this time, but the bottom still couldn't be seen . We only saw flashing lights coming through from the darkness below .

Nie Zun frowned . “Do you hear something?”

I leaned forward over the pit a bit more, and then a sound slowly entered my ears . The sound came intermittently, like waves crashing . There were pained cries mixed with sharp shrieks, difficult to distinguish from each other .

“What's going on? I've never heard of such a place in the Split Zone before . Moreover,” I said, looking around, “if the trees encircle this pit, then where is the border line?”

Jie Pa's expression grew grave . “I've never heard of this kind of place either . The faint light at the bottom looks like a beast's eyes, but also like the light of a fire . And the cries mix together . ”

“Could it be that the border line is behind the row of trees at the opposite end?” After I arrived in the Split Zone, I'd only ever heard that the South-North border line was colored red . Whenever we traveled to the Northern District, we were always summoned by the blond man . And since the Southern District didn't like visitors, and I rarely left the Western District anyway, I've naturally never come to this place nor seen the border line .

Jie Pa frowned slightly . “Ms Ah Shen, there’s one thing, but I cannot be certain . The smells here are all mixed together, but from what I can tell, I’m afraid that Ms Laurel is down there...”

“What?” I immediately moved to step past these trees, but Nie Zun pulled me back . I tried to push him away . If Laurel was down there, then I had to go down and save her . Who knew what kind of strange things were in this deep and frightening pit?

As I struggled against Nie Zun, I felt something press against my abdomen . I was moving past the half-fallen trees, when something blocked my path . I subconsciously stepped back, surprised by the unexpected incident .

The tree that we’d just knocked over had suddenly started to grow back, as if it were flesh! Before any of us had time to react, the trees all grew back to their original height . Their branches grew out, reaching for each other like arms holding their brothers beside them, tangling together .

“Th-the trees that we cut off fell into the pit, didn’t they?” I asked, dumbfounded .

“Th-the trees that we cut off fell into the pit, didn’t they?” I asked, dumbfounded .

Jie Pa looked up at the tree, a new frown on his face . “I’ve never heard of a tree that grows back this quickly . ”

“What do we do now?” I asked, with no ideas .

A strange wind blew through the forest, my red hair waving beautifully .

Before Nie Zun or Jie Pa could answer, I suddenly heard another voice sound behind us . “What are you all doing here?” The bewitching voice made me immediately turn around .

I was met with Gao Qin Jiu Ye’s cold gaze, a frown on his face as he looked at us .

Without expending any effort, we'd somehow easily found him . As I thought of the frightening aura exuding from the deep pit, as I thought of Laurel, I was suddenly filled with a strong indignation .

I returned his cold gaze . “You need to ask? We’re obviously here to find our missing friend . You clearly told us that you didn’t kidnap our kids, and then you told us not to search for Si Luo or to implicate him . Let me ask you this now . What’s behind here?” I pointed at the row of trees behind us .

Gao Qin Jiu Ye followed the direction of my finger, towards the strange, tightly knit row of trees . He squinted and said, “These aren’t any ordinary trees . They’re boundary trees, acting as a seal here . Lately, I’ve sensed an unclean presence in the Southern Forest, which is why I came to investigate . I’ve never seen this row of trees in front of you before . They do not belong to our Southern District . ”

I sneered, “Do you think I’d believe you? When we cut down some trees, guess what we saw? A deep pit! And our missing child should be within it . You’re telling me that you know nothing of it? If that’s true, you’ve become even more laughable . Someone’s dug a giant pit in your border forest, doing who knows what kind of strange things, but you didn’t realize it?”

Gao Qin Jiu Ye slightly raised his head . He glanced over me, and then frowned as he looked at the row of trees behind me .

Gao Qin Jiu Ye slightly raised his head . He glanced over me, and then frowned as he looked at the row of trees behind me .

Suddenly, a wicked smile slipped onto his face . “You cut down the trees? These boundary trees cannot be invaded unless the person who put them down undoes the enchantment . Many people will put these trees up when they are training, to prevent outside attacks . And the row of trees in front of you spans for a several hundred meter diameter . For such a large barricade, the person who placed these trees must be extraordinary . So how did you cut through them so easily?”

Unconvinced, I said, “You look down too much on Jie Pa’s abilities!”

But suddenly, standing beside me, Jie Pa spoke up . “Ms Ah Shen, listening to him, it seems his words are right . I’ve heard of these boundary trees before, but I’ve never seen them . They didn’t even cross my mind earlier . If what he’s saying is true, then I also would have no way to cut them down . ”

Startled, I replied, “Then what happened earlier?”

Hands stuffed in his pockets, Nie Zun said lightly, “That means that whoever placed the trees undid their spell, to let us see what lied behind them . ”

As he spoke, Gao Qin Jiu Ye looked over at Nie Zun . A strange kind of light appeared in Gao Qin Jiu Ye’s eyes . “I’d heard of a capable person who arrived in the Split Zone one year ago . He had a mental force of 67 when he first arrived, and yet refused many invitations to join any organizations . He’s also never attacked anyone with his power . When I saw you last time, we were uable to speak because of that annoying woman . You must be Nie Zun?”

Nie Zun smiled lightly . “Yes, I am . ”

Another gust of wind blew through the dense Southern Forest .

Chapter 33

Volume 1

33 The Tunnel

I was baffled by Gaoqin Jiuye's words.

Was Nie Zun that famous? When we'd met previously, Gaoqin Jiuye clearly hadn't recognized me at all, even though I must have looked smitten. Still, I'm a district commander. He didn't recognize the Western Commander, but he recognized Nie Zun?

It pissed me off. I rolled my eyes at Nie Zun. Tsk, this devil whom I was constantly stuck with, was actually more famous than me?!

Gaoqin Jiuye looked around us. "The one who put up these trees must still be nearby. I'm not the best at locating people, but I don't want you to misunderstand Si Luo. Why don't I accompany you past the trees to search?"

I quickly glared at him. "Why should we believe you?!"

Gaoqin Jiuye shot a bewitching smile at me. That heart-moving smile had me captivated.

He smiled and said, "Do you have any other plans? If what you're saying is true, that the child you're looking for is down there, then it will be easier to save her with my help. I don't want anyone causing trouble in the Southern District—not whoever put up these trees, and not all of you."

I really couldn't stand his haughty and arrogant demeanor. I was about to retort when Nie Zun grabbed me. He shot a charming smile at Gaoqin

Jiuye, the brightness nearly blinding my eyes. “Okay, then let’s take a look together. But if you’re genuine about helping us find the truth, I hope that we can assist each other without harming one another.”

After Nie Zun gave such an answer, I closed my mouth and didn’t reject the offer.

Gaoqin Jiuye nodded. But he didn’t move, and instead continued to look at the trees behind us. His eyes hardened, and then a chilling sound suddenly came from the air. Crackling, snapping. I quickly turned my head and saw the trees snap apart from his condensing the air around them.

My mouth twitched. Shit. I don’t match with this Split Zone at all. With just a stare, others can knock down trees. But I’d slashed for ages with Piercer and only left a scratch, like I’d been tickling the tree.

Gaoqin Jiuye stepped forward with his bright yellow sneakers, walking toward me. Then he walked straight past us, up to the gap he’d made in the trees. He took a step with his right foot and then jumped. Like a nimble, young athlete, he leapt stright down into the pit. Just as he jumped off, he added, “Hurry, the trees will tangle together again.”

My chest felt stuffed up. We don’t even know what’s down in that pit, but he just jumped in like that? Even if he wanted to die, I sure didn’t.

I crouched down and untied Piercer from my ankle, making sure to re-tie the red ribbon tightly around my split symbol. I coiled the long whip around my waist like a purple belt, leaving the tip of the whip hanging down. After I dealt with the other end, I moved my bow from my back to my shoulder and made sure I had enough arrows.

After I finished my inspection, I looked up to realize that everyone had disappeared. And the trees that Gaoqin Jiuye had cut down were already growing back swiftly.

“Ay! Wait for me!!” I shouted as I quickly charged forward.

Because the trees were weaving back together, I ran very quickly. I didn't jump in with a perfect pose like Gaoqin Jiuye had. My calculation must have been thrown off by how fast the trees grew, because after I jumped into the air, I stumbled over a tree branch before falling down into the pit.

As I dropped down into the pit, I screamed out, "Ahhh!!!" falling head first into the giant hole.

Since my body had flipped upside down, as I fell, I felt the skirt of my dress flip over and cover my face. So, instead of using my mental force to save myself, the only thing on my mind was whether or not they would see my underpants when I fell down!

As the thought spiraled in my mind, I finally landed into a cold embrace. Whomever it was must have used some mental force, because instead of plopping into their arms, I gently landed in them. But this embrace was truly chilling, like a vampire's skin, without a single touch of warmth.

I subconsciously raised my head to see Gaoqin Jiuye's grim and wicked face. I started to struggle against him, my heart flying into a panic. Having the face that I'd so utterly adored, so close before my eyes, the air seemed to stop flowing in my chest. I felt like I was suffocating. I quickly stepped back, a frantic expression in my eyes as I stared at him.

Gaoqin Jiuye continued to look at me as before, expressionless.

As I retreated, I backed into another body. I quickly turned my head and locked eyes with Nie Zun. The light flickered in his eyes, and he helped to support me. I felt a bit uncomfortable, so after I gained my footing, I moved away from him. Then I finally looked around us.

Jie Pa, Nie Zun, and Gaoqin Jiuye stood at the side. And as I'd suspected, the pit wasn't very deep, just a few hundred meters down. When I looked up, I could still see the bright, grey sky above.

There were no beasts in the pit either. In fact, there was nothing there at all. Under our feet was the same stone ground that existed throughout the Split Zone. The pit had a radius of about 100 meters. There was nothing else to

be seen though. Even the walls were stone. This was clearly just a large well that had been dug out from the ground, and not some kind of pit hiding strange creatures.

“What’s going on? Why isn’t there anything here?” I asked in surprise.

Gaoqin Jiuye motioned for me to turn around, and when I did, I saw a large tunnel-like structure on the wall; it looked like a doorway. “Let’s go and take a look.” After saying that, he headed directly towards the tunnel.

With Gaoqin Jiuye taking the lead, and Nie Zun and Jie Pa following, I joined behind them without any fear. When I arrived at the entrance to the tunnel, I discovered that it was the entrance to a path that headed down beneath this stone well. The path was also paved by stone, looking no different than normal, and it was wide enough to accomodate the four of us walking side by side.

It was dim inside the tunnel, and gradually, our visibility dropped to about ten meters. We couldn’t see what surprises lied ahead; in front of us was only darkness.

After walking for roughly ten minutess, we came to the end. I say ‘end’ because there was no more path to walk on. Instead, there was a closed stone door.

Jie Pa walked up ahead and pressed his ear to the door. He turned to us and said, “The door is very thick and blocks sounds, but I can still hear the mournful cries from beyond it. I’m afriad that what lies beyond this door is something unimaginable. And Ms Laurel’s scent is indeed present.”

I couldn’t help frowning. Who woud dig out this kind of giant well and tunnel to conceal something? And how was it that the people of the Southern District were unaware of it? Unless what we’d seen so far was just an illusion designed to lure us to this place?

“This isn’t an illusion, is it?” I finally asked timidly.

Gaoqin Jiuye sneered as he shook his head. “Even Huan Qing’s skills cannot affect me, so I really can’t think of anyone who could put me under a spell.”

My lips twitched.

Gaoqin Jiuye signaled for us to move back, so the three of us retreated a few meters. Then he walked up to the stone door and raised his arms. Startled, I belatedly realized that the air in the tunnel was condensing into rotating balls of air around his hands.

After about half a minute, he suddenly threw the spheres of air at the door. Though we were in the Split Zone, and he was manipulating his mental force to break apart a stone door, his movements still reminded me of Senior Gao Qi.

Senior Gao Qi’s back and his back were one and the same. At every school athletics competition, Senior Gao Qi had been the most eye-catching. He, who loved the color yellow, always wore yellow-green athletics clothes.

Every time I saw his warm and cozy smile, every time I heard his enchanting voice, I became intoxicated. For me, he was a perfect and yet distant temptation.

When I got to college, my condition hadn’t improve much. Because Pomelo continued to linger around me, my medical history also made rounds, but most of the students were indifferent and uncaring. At the peak of the heat wave, they much preferred gossiping about whose luxury car the school beauty rode that weekend.

Still, in many people’s minds, I was the ‘mentally ill girl.’ My illness wasn’t purely a mental disorder though, but also partly a behaviorial one. But well, mental disorder, psychosis, psychological perversion—to most people, they were one and the same.

To me at the time, Senior Gao Qi was genuinely like a male god in a girl’s comic book. Emphasis on ‘god.’ A god was perfect, faraway and sacred. I

never dared to make our relationship anymore than that of a god and his follower.

That is, until the end of the sports competition that year.

I was picking up the trash by myself, since the other people allocated by our class had already left. I'll never forget how I was crouched on the ground, grabbing at garbage, when a pair of bright yellow sneakers suddenly appeared before my eyes.

When I looked up to see Senior Gao Qi's smiling face, in that moment, the shoes on his feet, the dazzling expression on his face, the faint yellow-orange reflection of the setting sun converged into these things called 'hope' and 'happiness.' They flowed in through my eyes and then finally into my heart.

In his intoxicating and enchanting voice, he said, "You're the girl they talk about, right?"

My heart felt like a 500 kg rock had knocked into my heart. With drooping eyes, I nodded.

He crouched down beside me, one of his legs stretched slightly forward. As he neared, I could smell his unique scent mixed with sweat. He reached out his hand and gently pat my head. "I always see you in the library. I never thought that girls who liked *Les Misérables* or *Faust* would have any problems. You know, just like the rumors say, I always see you carrying books about psychological crimes or serial murders in to read at the library. Others say that you like those kinds of things because something's wrong in your head, but I really don't think that's true."

I raised my head and looked at him timidly.

The world's most gentle light radiated from his eyes and his lips curved up in a tender smile. "Because I like those things too. In the same way that beautiful things don't always conceal evil, (liking) sinful things doesn't always mean you wish for them. Like it says in *Faust*, if the world is a

bitter sea, then I believe that you are the only one who will understand me. Right?”

To me, the memory of that moment, that day, has doomed me beyond reprieve.

For some reason, it seemed that when Nie Zun looked into my eyes, my thoughts came back to the present. Nie Zun motioned for me to look ahead, so my eyes wandered over to Gaoqin Jiuye and then the stone door behind him. Gaoqin Jiuye hadn't shattered the door.

Chapter 34

Split Zone 13

34 As In Purgatory

There was no sound when the spheres of air hit the stone door, and neither did the door break apart . Instead, there looked to be two globs of liquid stuck on the door, slowly spreading out to cover the center of the door .

Gao Qin Jiu Ye said, “We don’t know what’s behind this door, so I used the air current to create a hole . On the opposite side, the air current will reflect the image of a stone door so whoever is on the other side remains unaware that we’ve broken through . Once we see what lies behind the door, we can decide if we will really break in . ”

I inwardly praised his thought process, but I was also surprised by his ability to control the flow of air . The air in the Split Zone was indeed different .

Just then, an area on the stone door turned transparent, as if part of it had been dug out .

“But don’t speak . Sounds and smells can still permeate through . ” Gao Qin Jiu Ye whispered to us as the transparent area on the door grew larger . And so, we all held our breaths as we looked into this window-like gap in the door .

As my field of vision widened, I saw a stone room, chiseled deep into the darkness . On the wall was an old-fashioned torch that looked like it could go out at any moment, casting a yellow glow on the walls . A silent, cutting cold crept out from inside the room, spreading over my skin .

From the hole, I could only see a flickering light . The light illuminated a wooden barrel in the center of the room . We could see about two meters around the barrel .

Curiosity overcame me, and I stepped forward, my breathing heavy . Even Nie Zun and Jie Pa couldn't help step forward . The three handsome men looked like a group of desperate chicken thieves, as they and I leaned in for a look .

After careful inspection, I saw that there was a woman whose body was half trapped underneath the barrel . The woman's dried up hair was matted together with red-brown blood . It was so stuck to her face that it looked like a single tug might pull her entire face off .

I widened my eyes, but perhaps because she'd been tortured for too long and her hair was covering her face, I was unable to ascertain if she was the person I searched for .

The clothes on her body had long ago been torn to shreds, now mixed together with dark blood . Her full chest was covered with dirt, and she lied on the ground like a corpse under the barrel .

Suddenly, two figures appeared; they were two women in brown robes . Their faces were exceptionally bewitching, with crimson eyes and lips so red they seemed covered in fresh blood . Had they been licking blood?!

Although I very much liked the color red—scarlet red—these two strange, red-lipped women left me feeling disgusted .

As I watched them, I saw the women each carrying a bronze basin, slowly closing in towards the wooden barrel . Their eyes were locked on the girl under the barrel, never once losing sight of her .

One of the women told the other, “Be careful, this isn't just an ordinary thing! This doesn't exist in the Split Zone . Putting aside how precious it is, you must remember how dangerous it is . Once it climbs onto your body, you will hope to live without being about to live, and pray to die without being able to die . Make sure you don't get it on your body . ”

I could see hesitation on the face of the woman who had spoken . It was clear that she was afraid of whatever was inside the bronze basin . When the woman slanted her hand, I saw that there was something dirty and filthy inside of it . The basin also seemed deeper than ordinary basins, but I couldn't clearly see what was inside it .

The other woman opened her red lips and smiled ever so alluringly . “I know, I know . There will be a good show soon . Shall we make a bet on how long she'll last today?”

The uncertain looking woman didn't reply . Instead, she cautiously poured the contents of her basin into the wooden barrel . With a splash, fresh blood splattered in all directions .

As she was pouring, I finally saw what was inside her basin . They were about ten centimeters long and three fingers wide . Squirming around, they looked like centipedes, only longer and thicker . They were headless and had soft, flexible, black and yellow bodies .

I used my mental force to heighten my visibility, but because of the dim lighting conditions in the stone room, I could only see a little more clearly .

On either side of those things, there were crab-like claws that extended another finger's length . As they fell into the barrel, they seemed to come to life . A lively sound echoed, like someone grinding their teeth . When they landed on the woman's body, they started to crawl around rapidly . They wandered onto her body and wantonly danced around, clamping onto and cutting her flesh until blood started flowing out .

The other woman went to pour her basin into the other side of the barrel, and those creatures covered up the fallen woman's back, chest, and the rest of her body under the barrel . The woman instantly woke up . In between all the matted hair, a mournful light burst out from her eyes . Just watching it, I couldn't help feeling frightened .

I quickly looked up and motioned to Nie Zun . The meaning being, ‘We're just going to keep watching and not do anything to save her?’ His eyes concealed a dark gloominess .

While I was hesitating, a strange sound pulled my attention back to the scene in the room .

The woman seemed to be trying to speak, but it sounded like she couldn't complete her words . A thick, piercing voice came from her mouth, reminiscent of the sound of nails on a chalkboard . Each cry grew louder than the last, and by the end, she was roaring .

Even standing on the other side of this stone door, all the hair on my body stood on end as I listened . Watching the scene, I even felt a stabbing pain across my skin, as if I were the one lying below the barrel! A retching feeling started to rise up from my abdomen . I tried to stifle it, but the pain made it a struggle .

Although I didn't want to keep looking, I forced myself to continue watching the girl being torn apart by those frightening poisonous bugs, while she looked like she'd prefer death over living .

I wanted to charge in, but Gao Qin Jiu Ye shot me a cold glare, as if having seen through my intentions .

I wanted to charge in, but Gao Qin Jiu Ye shot me a cold glare, as if having seen through my intentions .

Then I realized that there was more to the scene than I'd initially thought . Because our bodies will heal and regenerate in the Split Zone, as the girl's body was being torn apart and mutilated by those bugs, her skin and flesh were healing . But since her skin healed quickly, the bugs ended up trapped in her skin and flesh .

Watching the girl's skin envelope those horrifying bugs as it healed over, like a sponge soaking up water, while still having more of those bugs crawling on and eating her alive was really too much for me to bear . I quickly covered my mouth .

Then the woman who had mentioned having a bet lifted her arm and covered her red lips with her sleeve . A joyous laughter burst from her and she said, "Aiya, she's really suffering . If her torture ends quickly, and we

play with those three kids later, don't you think we'll sleep with smiles on our faces tonight?" As she spoke, she motioned to the other woman, looking towards the corner of the room .

The hole Gao Qin Jiu Ye formed in the door wasn't wide enough for us to see the corners of the room, just the center where the women were . But hearing the woman's words, I felt like I'd been hit by a large boulder . It seemed unimaginable to me that Laurel would be among the three kids that they tortured, and I subconsciously shook my head .

Gao Qin Jiu Ye seemed to have caught on to my thoughts again, for he gave me a look that said not to act rashly . But if Laurel was really one of the three kids, how could I just sit back and watch without doing anything?

As I tried to think up a plan, my eyes remained fixed on the door before us .

One of the two women slowly put down her empty basin, while the other woman enjoyed watching the girl being tortured, her skin fusing with the poisonous bugs, her tortured screams growing louder .

I couldn't bear it any longer .

With my right hand, I grabbed the bow on my back; it was small and compact, easy to get a hold of . With my left hand, I reached for four arrows . From the hole in the door, I aimed two arrows at each of the women, and then let them fly . With a whiz, the arrows soared out .

I've been practicing archery for more than just a few days, and my bow had a special setup, so without a hitch, the four arrows shot out nimbly, accurately hitting the two women's eyes!

I've been practicing archery for more than just a few days, and my bow had a special setup, so without a hitch, the four arrows shot out nimbly, accurately hitting the two women's eyes!

As the arrows hit their eyes, their heads arched back and they let out anguished cries . Not everyone had the same pain tolerance as Jiao S, so the

two women who'd been hit by the pain-stimulant coated arrow-tips dropped to the ground and wailed .

Gao Qin Jiu Ye turned and gave me a cold look, but there was also no uncertainty in his eyes . Instead, he raised his arms and once again, two vortexes formed . With a casual sweep of his arms, the stone door immediately cracked apart with a boom!

I stepped inside .

The two women were crouched on the ground, crying out in struggle as they tried to remove the arrows from their eyes . But because of the pain stimulant on the arrows, they were suffering too much to move . Blood sprayed out from their eyes, creating the effect of dark red eye shadow .

The woman beneath the barrel appeared to have melded in all the bugs . She was shaking and spasming, like someone who was being shocked by electricity . Her lips were dry and purpled, her hair matted onto her clothes and face .

I busily looked around the room, only to realize that the room was bigger than I'd thought; it was more than a hundred square meters . My eyes wandered until they finally landed on Laurel .

In a corner, Laurel and two other kids were strung up in the air . Laurel was in the middle . On the left was the girl with a mole by her lip—the missing child Jiao S mentioned, from the Eastern District . On the other side of Laurel was a bald boy whom I didn't recognize .

Laurel's body was covered in dried blood also . Her eyes were closed, her face dirty, and her soft, shining golden hair was stuck together with old, darkened blood .

Chapter 35

Split Zone 13

35 Crisis

I wanted to cover my mouth, but now wasn't the time to be weak . My eyes moistened and my heart suddenly throbbed with pain . I quickly stepped forward .

Jie Pa, Nie Zun, and Gao Qin Jiu Ye had already entered the room . Jie Pa rushed over to examine the woman under the barrel .

When I made my way over to Laurel, I tried to reach for her, but my hands trembled, as if unsure how to retrieve her . Tears streamed from my eyes and I heard myself croak, "Lau...rel..." At my call, Laurel's bloodied eyelashes twitched, and then she opened her eyes .

Before I could exchange a glance with her, I heard Jie Pa cry out, "A-Ah Shen! Th-th-this is Song Lu!"

My eyes widened and I turned my head slowly . My body was as stiff as a marionette's, and my lips started to tremble .

When I turned around, I saw Jie Pa carefully sliding aside the sticky hair covering the woman's face . Her lips opened as she gasped for air, and although her lips were already black, her eyes like two abandoned glass spheres, unmoving and sunken into her face, I still recognized her .

It was really Song Lu .

But how could it be Song Lu?! If it was Song Lu, then why hadn't I immediately charged in to save her? How could I have let Song Lu suffer

such brutal abuse, right in front of my eyes?

“Ah—!!!”

I was unable to deal with such a sudden blow . My hands wrapped around my head, my nails digging into my scalp, as I painfully cried out . A hoarse shriek came from throat, and my heart pounded furiously . My toes curled and my legs shuddered feebly . Finally, I dropped to the ground on my knees .

“Ahh!!! Ahh!!!” I howled as I burst into tears . “Song... Lu jiejie... How could it be you...” I cried like my heart and lungs were being ripped out . Gao Qin Jiu Ye also looked surprised .

The two monstrous women on the ground hadn’t been able to remove the arrows from their eyes yet, but they started to cackle with a strange laughter .

I tried my best not to cry; this wasn’t the time to cry . But trying to suppress my tears made my head start buzzing . My nose and my mouth were leaking as I gasped for breath .

Jie Pa glanced at me kneeling on the ground, grief in his eyes, but he quickly returned his attention to trying to remove Song Lu from beneath the barrel .

Nie Zun’s eyes sparked with an indescribable kind of greyness . His eyes locked onto me and he quickly walked over . My body shook uncontrollably as I tried to control the anguish inside of me . I extended my hand for Nie Zun to help me up . This wasn’t the time to grieve; I still had to save Laurel .

Yes, there was still Laurel!

Nie Zun had arrived behind me . Kneeling on the ground, I turned my head, which was at nearly the same level as Laurel’s head, her body still suspended in the air . Her eyes were already open, a strange expression on her face . Unlike her beaten, dirtied body, there was a look of triumph on

her face . It was strange, displaying a childish naughtiness but also a ruthlessness that only came with old age .

Before I could react, the upside down Laurel extended her arms and wrapped her hands around my neck . Her grip had an exceptional strength to them! My eyes instantly widened as my breathing became obstructed . As she strangled my neck with her unordinary strength, a tremoring force pushed its way into my head, and my entire body became immobile!

Hanging upside down, she strangled me mercilessly . Her dirty little face was grinning as it looked at me . Her once incomparably beautiful eyes were now filled with malice and viciousness .

Nie Zun immediately rushed over and grabbed Laurel's arms, pulling them off of me mercilessly . But Laurel's hands didn't move an inch; they were still clasped tightly to my neck!

Not only did it feel like I couldn't breathe, it also felt like a moist, 500 kg stone pressing down on my head . My mind grew fuzzy .

A look of surprise crossed Nie Zun's face . He clearly hadn't expected Laurel's grip to be so strong .

Gao Qin Jiu Ye seemed to have realized something wasn't right . He walked over to help, his air blades crackling in the air . But when he neared us, another of the hanging kids, the girl with the mole, looked like she'd just been resurrected . She swung over with great force, and latched onto Gao Qin Jiu Ye's back .

And then, I felt Nie Zun's eyes tremble . His hands slipped off of Laurel, and he stepped back . It seemed that the third, bald boy had grabbed onto his back . But my vision was already a bit blurred, so I wasn't quite sure what exactly happened .

My neck felt like it was on the verge of snapping off . And in that moment, the blond man's words suddenly echoed in my head . "Don't die in the Split Zone, Ah Shen . "

My neck felt like it was on the verge of snapping off . And in that moment, the blond man's words suddenly echoed in my head . "Don't die in the Split Zone, Ah Shen . "

Despite my body having gone stiff for some reason, I clutched onto the tail of Piercer, which had been wrapped around my waist, with all their strength . The spines dug into my palm, intensifying the dizzying pain in my head .

I wrapped the whip around Laurel's neck .

Jie Pa had previously made it very clear to me how much damage the spines on the end of Piercer could deal . Even a lightly made cut wouldn't heal for an hour's time . The spines were also coated with a pain intensifier that increased pain one hundred fold . Jie Pa warned me to be very careful when I used it .

I couldn't be bothered to worry about that now though . Blood dripped from my hands after they were stung by the spines, and I immediately felt the pain shoot through my arms and even spread towards my heart . My heart felt like it was being wrapped with thorns, and the pain quickly rose to an intolerable level . My lips trembled violently, the pain layering onto my purple, bruised neck like, acting like a fast-spreading venom, corroding my body .

The moment I wrapped Piercer around Laurel's neck, the sharp spines on the whip dug deep into her neck . A sinister look suddenly appeared in her large, bright eyes, and she screamed, finally releasing me .

When I saw her let go, I quickly pulled my right hand away . I wanted to grab the bow on my back, but because I'd held so tightly onto Piercer, I found that my palm had been mutilated! My entire right hand shook, the blood rolling off of it . I was able to grab an arrow from my back, and I forcefully stabbed it into Laurel's eye .

From the force I added, Laurel's hanging body swung back as she screamed . I hurried to get up, but my actions were hindered from holding Piercer in my left hand . I pulled the rest of the whip out and flung it .

My left hand was also dripping with blood, and both of my hands shook very violently . My right hand didn't even have the strength to hold onto Piercer . I stood up and stepped forward, Laurel's pained screams still echoing . To my left, the air around Gao Qin Jiu Ye crackled loudly . He tried to grab the girl on his back, and then multiple vortexes started spinning behind him, moving like gears . The girl's blood burst onto his back, but she didn't seem to be letting go . A dreadful light radiated from Gao Qin Jiu Ye's eyes .

On the other side, Nie Zun had been caught by the bald boy . The boy laughed as he covered Nie Zun's eyes with his hands . The boy had removed his legs from the shackles that held him in the air, and he had his legs wrapped around Nie Zun's neck, while he sat on his shoulders .

On the other side, Nie Zun had been caught by the bald boy . The boy laughed as he covered Nie Zun's eyes with his hands . The boy had removed his legs from the shackles that held him in the air, and he had his legs wrapped around Nie Zun's neck, while he sat on his shoulders .

Nie Zun's gloved hands weren't trying to remove the boy from his shoulders, but instead, he was flailing at me, as if wanting to grab hold of me .

My heart felt heavy .

Then I heard the evil laughter of those two women, and I immediately turned my head . They'd already removed the arrows from their eyes, which had now healed about halfway . They had a death grip on Jie Pa! One of the women had her arms wrapped around Jie Pa's leg, and the other around his waist . Jie Pa tried to walk to me, but he couldn't get rid of his captors .

I clenched my teeth and tried to raise Piercer with my right hand to attack, but the pain increased in my palm . My hands were already crippled at that point . An unbearable pain coarsed through them, and I dropped Piercer to the ground . My hands continued to shake as I tried to reach for Nie Zun .

He stopped swinging his arms and quickly removed his gloves . Then he grabbed onto the boy's legs that were wrapped around him . As if his hands

were covered in something, the once grinning boy now looked dumbfounded . Then a look of terror and suspicion crossed the boy's eyes . He looked broken, the same way Mi Fu had looked the other day .

With a loud wailing cry, the boy removed his hands from Nie Zun and tried to grab the hands on his legs .

Now that his eyes were uncovered, Nie Zun quickly looked around for me . His eyes finally landed on my body .

Laurel shrieked in pain as I reached out with trembling, bloody hands toward Nie Zun .

The wounds on my palms weren't healing, but were, in fact, festering . Dark blood bubbled out from the wounds, and the pain continued to spread from my palms to my heart . I couldn't stand firmly, so as I swayed there, I reached out two crippled hands, trying to reach Nie Zun .

Chapter 36

Split Zone 13

36 Unexplained Death

Nie Zun saw my hands, and his pupils seemed to sink briefly . For some reason, there was an ambiguous smile on his face . After he took off his gloves, his elegant, pale hands were exposed, and he looked very at ease in that moment . He pulled the legs of the boy off of his body .

Nie Zun's actions were entirely relaxed, and the moment he saw my hands, the depressed look in his eyes turned into a strange kind of enjoyment .

As he pushed away the boy, the boy's body ended up split in half! I nearly screamed out of fear . That bald boy had been ripped apart by Nie Zun! Right above his own head! Blood splattered onto my face and spilled onto Nie Zun's hair . But his expression still had that ambiguous smile, a kind of enjoyment on his face .

He tossed aside the boy he just ripped apart, and then he walked directly over to my side . He wasn't looking at me though . Instead, he walked up to Laurel, who'd just removed the arrow from her eye but was still screaming .

With his hands that were white as fresh snow atop a mountain, he grabbed Laurel's hanging legs and forcefully pulled down . He pulled her down from the rope that tied her to the stone ceiling with the ease of a person grabbing a small animal . Grabbing her by the legs, Nie Zun tossed Laurel over onto the boy he'd ripped apart .

On the other side of the room, Gao Qin Jiu Ye's eyes tightened, and the air inside the stone walls started to shake violently . My balance was already

unsteady, but now with the added surge of air, I fell over towards Nie Zun, my body still trembling and my hands still bleeding .

The weird expression in Nie Zun's eyes suddenly turned to panic when he saw me falling . Instead of reaching out to catch me, he quickly moved to dodge me . So then, I fell to the ground . Nie Zun bent over and picked up his gloves, quickly readorning them on his hands .

After replacing his gloves on his hands, Nie Zun helped me up . The air in the stone room continued to shake violently . Gao Qin Jiu Ye was surrounded in a stormy white fog, his eyes revealing something sinister and merciless . The rushing air had long ago extinguished the torch on the wall . In the darkness, Gao Qin Jiu Ye's eyes glowed like a beast's; it wasn't the kind of fiendish, amused expression that Nie Zun had worn, but rather a different kind of demonic glow .

The girl behind him was being shredded to bits by the white flurry surrounding her . It wrapped around her, like gentle clouds with blades cutting in clockwork-like intervals . And then the girl disappeared without leaving a drop of blood!

Gao Qin Jiu Ye clasped his hands together, and then the air thundered explosively .

As the fog spread, the entire room grew hazy . The increasingly tormenting pain inside of me was about to knock me unconscious . Before I passed out, I saw Laurel where she'd landed after Nie Zun tossed her . Blood still streamed from her eye . And then I heard her anguished scream turn into a strange laughter .

—

I had another dream .

Though I knew it was a dream, I couldn't wake up . I wanted to wake up, to see what had happened in the stone room, but I couldn't help it . I could only watch from above as the dream unfolded .

This dream took place in the Split Zone . I wanted to laugh at the irony, but I couldn't do anything but watch on .

Before my eyes, I sat atop the Western Residence rooftop, my legs hanging over the edge of the building . A gust of wind tousled my hair and my dress also billowed .

Li Qing was there, dressed in my favorite set of her silver armor . She walked over to me and took a seat beside me . She sat with one leg bent and one hanging down, looking just like a firm, unyielding man . The outline of her handsome, heroic face was rugged like a mountain, perfecting displaying a valiant silhouette .

She smiled confidently at me . “If I have to leave one day, take my place as commander, won't you?”

I turned to look at her, a bright, pretty smile on my face . “No . You can't leave, Li Qing . If you leave, what will happen to us?”

Li Qing's short, indigo hair fluttered in the wind . She gave a refreshing laugh . “Nothing is impossible . Li Shen, if I leave one day, I will put the Western District in your hands . You must protect it well . ”

I pouted . “Li Qing, don't scare me . Do you think I'm cut out for that kind of thing? Moreover, there's still Li Wen jiejie, and if she doesn't want to be the commander, You Ji is also very good at taking care of business . I'm not capable enough though, and my mental force is very low . ”

A strange light appeared in Li Qing's eyes . “A good commander doesn't simply need a high mental force . They need a strong heart that allows them protect their people . ”

I mocked myself with a laugh, “Even more reason I'm unfit . You know very well that I'm a weak person . ”

Li Qing narrowed her eyes, an honorable trustworthiness in her expression . “No, you can do it,” she said . “But if there were a condition for being the

district commander, there is something that feels a bit wrong, that I don't identify with but I must follow . ”

Li Qing narrowed her eyes, an honorable trustworthiness in her expression . “No, you can do it,” she said . “But if there were a condition for being the district commander, there is something that feels a bit wrong, that I don't identify with but I must follow . ”

I tilted my head and asked her, “What is it?”

Li Qing gave a slightly helpless expression . “Though few who arrive in the Split Zone ever return home, some do . But because the district commander cannot be changed too often or on a whim, those who are chosen as district commanders must lack the desire to leave . ”

I pursed my lips and thought for a moment . Then, with a slight smile, I replied, “If that's the case, then I guess I fit the requirement . Desire to leave... Haha, I really don't have much of that . ”

Li Qing's face, which displayed feminine grace and masculine determination at the same time, grew more distinct before me . She looked at me with the crystal clear eyes of an angel who would never lie . And then she said, “I'm sure that I've chosen the right person . ”

It stands to reason that when you dream, you don't feel emotions, because you're just watching a memory of the past unfolding before your eyes . Dreams in the Split Zone are, in the end, just a kind of memory . But in this moment, watching from above, I felt my heart ache .

Li Qing, are you sure you didn't choose the wrong person?

My eyes gradually opened, and I finally woke up .

I didn't immediately sit up, and instead quietly thought about my dream .

How long has it been since I've seen Li Qing? Even in a dream?

A rollercoaster of sadness swirled through my heart . I refused to feel that way, so I shook my head to stop the thoughts .

I sat up and realized that we had already returned to the dorm we were staying at in the Southern District . Nie Zun was standing beside the bed, quietly staring out the window, his hands stuffed in his pockets as usual . He'd changed into a clean, black windbreaker .

I wanted to open my mouth . I had a lot of things I wanted to ask about .

I wanted to open my mouth . I had a lot of things I wanted to ask about .

Is everyone okay? Did they get out of that place? Was Song Lu saved? What happened with Laurel?

But no matter how I opened my mouth, the questions wouldn't come out .

Nie Zun seemed to have realized I'd woken up, so he turned around . With a carefree and indifferent expression, he asked, "You're awake?"

"Mmh . "

He walked over and sat down beside me . Our eyes met .

Nie Zun spoke quietly, "We saved Song Lu but we couldn't do anything about the three kids . And while we weren't paying attention, the two women committed suicide with their splitting keys . "

With eyes wide, I asked, "What do you mean you couldn't do anything about the kids?"

Nie Zun looked at me . "Laurel escaped when I went to help you . And the other two kids didn't end up healing . "

Incredulous, I asked, "What does that mean, they didn't heal?"

"Exactly what I said . They didn't heal . The boy I split in half, and the girl that Gao Qin Jiu Ye shred to pieces didn't end up healing . They died . " Nie Zun spoke of death easily .

I frowned with disbelief at what I heard . Without using a splitting key, one couldn't die in the Split Zone .

Wait . Unless...?

“Is it because their physical bodies in the real world are already dead?” I asked .

Wait . Unless...?

“Is it because their physical bodies in the real world are already dead?” I asked .

Suddenly, Jie Pa walked in with a medicine box . Having heard my words, he replied, “Yes, they didn’t heal because their physical bodies have died . ”

Even more surprised, I asked, “How could there be such a coincidence? We attacked people whose physical bodies were already dead?”

Jie Pa walked over to me and placed a medicine box down on the table . Then he started undoing the gauze wrapping on my hands . It was only then that I realized that my hands had indeed been bandaged up .

As he worked, Jie Pa said, “No . For some reason, Nie Zun and Gao Qin Jiu Ye’s attacks directly caused their hearts to stop beating . ”

After he unwrapped my hands, I saw that they’d already healed, but Jie Pa still applied medicine to them . “Of course, this is just my conjecture,” he said . “As for the strange creatures on Song Lu’s body, they’re called demon leeches . They’ve only appeared in the Split Zone once before . Though creatures like them originally didn’t exist in the Split Zone, there’s a rumor that they may have been created by chemically refining insects brought here by a soul snatcher . I’ve never heard about their use or how much harm they can cause though . ”

I grabbed onto Jie Pa’s arm with my hands, and the medicine on my palms smeared to his arm . “What about Song Lu? I-is she okay?”

Jie Pa removed my hands from his arm and continued applying medicine . “Ms Song Lu is currently fine . When I pulled her out from the barrel, she had indeed been terribly wounded . But after her wounds healed, there was

no sign of the leeches . For now, I can't tell . She's still unconscious though, so we'll have to wait for her to wake up before we can ask her anything . ”

There was no way to force someone to wake from a coma in the Split Zone . Our physical bodies are originally already in a comatose state, so if our conscious is also in such a state... No amount of stimulation will wake someone, so it just depends on their willpower .

My lips trembled . “Song Lu's ended up in this state . Yu Liang's whereabouts are unknown . Laurel seems to have turned into some strange creature and has now gone missing...” I couldn't speak anymore, so I closed my eyes, as if that would take me away from this world . But I knew that would just be deceiving myself .

“Ms Ah Shen, don't worry too much . ” After Jie Pa applied the medicine, he wrapped my hands back up . “Piercer's sting is worse than I originally thought; it even spread to the rest of your body . Please rest . Though your hands may have healed, you'll need to apply a cleansing medicine for awhile . ”

As Jie Pa packed away his medicine, he told me, “Additionally, we've already relayed the events to Ms Jiao S . She and Gao Qin Jiu Ye are currently waiting next door for you to wake up and discuss the situation . ”

Chapter 37

Split Zone 13

37 Most Beautiful Exchange

When the three of us arrived next door, we discovered Jiao S and Gao Qin Jiu Ye silently facing each other . Dressed in a school uniform, Jiao S looked like a stiff SD doll . Gao Qin Jiu Ye stood on the other side of the room, similarly cold and still .

I walked in, and seeing them standing there, upright and motionless, like mannequins, I didn't quite know how to start the conversation . So, I turned to Jiao S and asked, "Where's Guan Nie?"

At the mention of Guan Nie, Gao Qin Jiu Ye's eyes trembled, and he turned to look at me . His long, narrow eyes carried a strange expression .

I didn't want to look him in the eyes, so I continued to watch Jiao S .

Jiao S turned her neck a bit . "He went off to who knows where, and disappeared before you guys returned; he never reports his plans to me . But Li Shen, what were you thinking, going into the border forest, just the three of you on your own? Even I've only passed by, and never traveled too deep inside . "

Gao Qin Jiu Ye sneered . "So you know then, that our Southern District doesn't welcome you . "

Jiao S seemed unfazed by his hostility though . Lightly, she replied, "You killed one of the kids from my district, but you're still using such pointed language?"

Her words seemed to have had an affect, as Gao Qin Jiu Ye's expression changed slightly and he didn't make a retort .

After she finished speaking, Jiao S' eyes shifted to Jie Pa . "Everyone's here now . Can you explain what you've deduced now?"

Jie Pa pushed up his glasses and began calmly . "It's like this . If I may be so daring, I believe that someone is plotting a scheme to kill others, without paying with their own life . What we know so far of the Split Zone is that as long as people protect their split symbol, no matter the harm that comes to them, they will not die . But if your physical body in the real world dies, then you will also end up dying here . My current suspicion is that someone is refining a poison that can directly bypass our consciousness and attack our physical bodies . With that, we lose our ability to heal in the Split Zone, and thusly, we'll die . "

I didn't quite understand . "You mean to say that those who fused with the demon leeches will lose their ability to heal? But Song Lu has already healed, hasn't she?"

Jie Pa shook his head . "The poison may not come from the leeches, or perhaps there are many types of poison and the leeches were just used for one such experiment . As you saw, the girl with the mole and the bald boy were both unable to heal after they were attacked; they directly died . From that, we can deduce that they had another kind of poison in their bodies . "

I frowned . "You mean that they were used for a different experiment?"

Jie Pa nodded . "Yes . Ms Laurel was able to heal after Ms Ah Shen's arrow struck her, so she was likely subject to a different type of poison . By the way, Ms Ah Shen, during your exchange with Ms Laurel, did you notice anything strange?"

I tried my best to recall the memory that I didn't want to remember . After a moment, I suddenly thought of something . "When Laurel was strangling me, her strength was no joke . Nie Zun couldn't pull her off of me either . And it wasn't just pure physical strength; when she attacked me, it felt like something was pressing down on my mind as well . "

Nie Zun spoke up . “Indeed, she was very strange at the time . My strength didn’t seem to affect her at all, and when I grabbed her arms, I also felt a pressure on my mind . ”

Jiao S suddenly spoke coldly, “Whatever experiments there may be, the only thing we know is that these poisonous creatures don’t originally exist in the Split Zone . There’s probably only one person who could create the things you’re talking about . ”

With an unfriendly expression, she looked at Gao Qin Jiu Ye . “If I’m not recalling incorrectly, The Southern District’s soul snatcher, Rong Jin, has the very ability to bring animal and insect souls to the Split Zone . Gao Qin Jiu Ye, with all this evidence pointing to you guys, are you sure you don’t want to let Si Luo show himself?”

At Jiao S’ mention of Si Luo, Gao Qin Jiu Ye’s expression turned chilly . “It’s just speculation, but you’re already insisting that Rong Jin is to blame? Is this how you two district commanders operate?”

I responded just as coldly, “At the least, we can be certain that the Southern District can’t be cleared of all blame regarding the events these past days . ”

Gao Qin Jiu Ye glared at me, and without cowering down, I returned his stare .

Just then, several knocks came on the door . The knocks came successively and quickly, signalling the urgency of the person waiting outside . After about five or six knocks, the person outside simply pushed open the door and walked inside .

“Aiyayaya, Jiao S, I only went out for half a day, and when I returned to find my pets, none of them are here . What’s going on...?” Like a young woman complaining about their lover’s later arrival to a date, Guan Nie fiddled with his long hair as he bounced in through the door .

When he walked in, he looked up . He was a bit taken aback by the full room, and then his pampered smile returned . But then, when his eyes landed on Gao Qin Jiu Ye, he paused again . The hair he’d been fiddling

with finally dropped from his hands . Guan Nie stood gracefully, and the strands of hair floated down to meet the rest of his hair behind him . Guan Nie's long phoenix eyes narrowed slightly, and his red lips curved into a subtle smile .

At the same time, Gao Qin Jiu Ye also narrowed his eyes . The two of them looked at each other for awhile, as if no one else was present . The flow of air in the room even seemed to slow . Or maybe I was just imagining it . Subconsciously, I ended up holding my breath, my eyes flitting back and forth between the two strange men .

Their attractive force was truly something . One had the cold yet radiant appearance of a reaper whom you couldn't keep your eyes off of . The other had a head of flowing white hair, dressed in a snow-white robe, with beautiful, sparkling eyes, looking like an immortal figure .

The room was silent .

And then, as if admitting defeat, Gao Qin Jiu Ye lifted his hand and casually ruffled his hair, avoiding Guan Nie's gaze . “Long time, Guan Nie .”

Guan Nie tilted his head, and his white hair streamed down from his right shoulder, like a flowing waterfall . His eyes narrowed more, the outline of his face beautiful and touching . His lips, tender and lovely as a flower, gently opened . “Yes, it's been a long time, Gao Qin Jiu Ye .”

I shamefully swallowed my saliva, unable to take my eyes off of Guan Nie's bewitching face . I sighed inwardly, the rotten pervert was seriously beautiful!

Guan Nie's head remained slightly tilted . His figure, hidden beneath his white robes, was fair and graceful . Although those weren't words meant for describing a man... But he was seriously way too beautiful!

Jiao S' eyes suddenly turned, a somewhat sinister feel to them . “Guan Nie, you'd better not bother me about not letting you know in advance . I didn't know they were going to bring him back .”

A light, as a burning flame, suddenly appeared in Guan Nie's eyes . He looked like a lecher who'd laid eyes upon a beautiful woman, or perhaps a starving ghost who saw a platter of sumptuous food . A slightly glistening tongue slipped out from his mouth and licked his lips . With an enchanting smile, he replied, "Don't worry . It's my pleasure to be able to see the person whom I spend all day and night wishing to tear their muscles and peel off their skin..."

A light, as a burning flame, suddenly appeared in Guan Nie's eyes . He looked like a lecher who'd laid eyes upon a beautiful woman, or perhaps a starving ghost who saw a platter of sumptuous food . A slightly glistening tongue slipped out from his mouth and licked his lips . With an enchanting smile, he replied, "Don't worry . It's my pleasure to be able to see the person whom I spend all day and night wishing to tear their muscles and peel off their skin..."

His raging eyes locked onto Gao Qin Jiu Ye's face, as if they had the power to entangle together with Gao Qin Jiu Ye's person .

My appreciation of Guan Nie's expression suddenly changed directions . His words really made my heart thump .

Tearing muscles and peeling skin...

This touching and ethereal voice uttering such words actually didn't sound frightening, but more like an unrivaled beauty fluttering her eyes that could charm a person in an instant, as she told you, "Give your life to me . " Instead of being scared, you want to nod your head, "Yes, yes, take it!"

However, as I am a woman, through and through, I was unaffected by his spell . Instead, I started to ponder the relationship between these two .

Was this a love and hate relationship? I started to imagine their story in my head .

When I thought of how Gao Qin Jiu Ye always seemed to become unhinged at the mention of Si Luo, I brazenly supposed: Had Guan Nie yearned for the legendary beauty of Si Luo, and so in the dark of night, snuck into the

Southern District to force himself onto Si Luo, causing Gao Qin Jiu Ye to erupt with anger and wage a grand battle against Guan Nie?

Or perhaps the fair and graceful pretty boy heard that Si Luo was the most beautiful man in the Split Zone, and out of jealousy and resentment, he traveled to the Southern District to murder Si Luo . But then he was righteously beat up by the protector, Gao Qin Jiu Ye .

Or maybe Guan Nie was attracted by the cold Gao Qin Jiu Ye, and persisted in chasing after him to eat him up .

My thoughts wantonly flew around inside my head, every possible link they might have popping into my mind...

Suddenly a chuckle broke my thoughts .

Suddenly a chuckle broke my thoughts .

A bit indignant, I looked over at the guy with black gloves, covering his mouth like a naughty child . With a smile and a teasing expression, Nie Zun, who didn't lose out to the others in looks, with his gloomy radiance, told me, "Li Shen, wipe the drool off your face . "

I felt my face instantly turn red . But that must have just been in my head, for my face never got red .

I quickly wiped my mouth .

Wipe, wipe . But I quickly realized that there was nothing there .

"Pfft..." Even Jie Pa, who'd been quiet the entire time, couldn't help scoffing . Jiao S also glanced over at me . And then I finally realized that I'd bitten Nie Zun's bait! I glared at him, but quickly my eyes returned to Gao Qin Jiu Ye and Guan Nie, not wanting to miss a single second of their show .

They continued to stare at each other, completely ignoring everyone else .

Super Dollfie dolls on Wiki

Chapter 38

Split Zone 13

38 The Culprit Was Nie Zun?

Jiao S cut off their exchange, “Guan Nie, why don’t you two settle your accounts later? Let’s first deal with the shocking matter that Li Shen and her pals brought back after rushing into the South-North border forest . ”

Guan Nie’s phoenix eyes slanted upwards . “I’m not curious, nor do I care about any of that . Don’t you know?”

Jiao S crafty eyes turned . “If I told you that someone was trying to develop a method of killing in the Split Zone without the use of a split symbol and splitting key, would you be interested then?”

Then a light seemed to flood forth from her eyes . Locked on Guan Nie, she said, “If there were such a method, then you wouldn’t need to sacrifice yourself to kill Gao Qin Jiu Ye . ”

I inhaled a breath of air . This... Do you need to be so direct when Gao Qin Jiu Ye is right in front of us?!

But it was clear that her words had an effect, because a spark of curiosity flashed across Guan Nie’s eyes .

Before Guan Nie could respond though, Gao Qin Jiu Ye spoke to Jiao S, “Don’t tease . His only motive is to get rid of me; as for his own well-being, he’s never been concerned with that . But these experiments won’t help him with anything . The problem now isn’t whether he’ll have to pay with his life after killing me, it’s the fact that he’s unable to kill me in the first place .

” As if putting on his haughty and ruthless outer coat, Gao Qin Jiu Ye raised his head slightly, somewhat by habit .

Instead of retorting, Guan Nie simply glanced over at him . Then he walked over to sit down at the desk, his long robes swaying along the way . He crossed his legs, and his soft, silk robes covered his inelegant action . He pulled his hair forward from behind his head, letting it fall to his legs . After pouring himself a cup of water, he drank it leisurely, as if he had nothing to say .

The situation between the two of them was becoming more and more unclear to me .

Jiao S saw that Guan Nie wasn’t speaking to Gao Qin Jiu Ye, and that the latter was also simply staring at the former . So, Jiao S spoke up, “What should we do now, then?”

Jie Pa suddenly jumped in, “I’ll check to see if Ms Song Lu has woken up . Perhaps she’ll be able to offer us some clues . ”

At the thought of Song Lu, my chest tightened . The weak coward that I was, I didn’t dare to check if she’d woken .

I couldn’t help closing my eyes when I recalled the hair-raising scene inside that stone room . The smell of blood an massacre seemed to linger at my nose, and I didn’t dare to breathe too deeply .

Jie Pa, who had just stepped out to check on Song Lu in the other room, suddenly backstepped into the room . It seemed as if he’d seen something when he walked out . He pushed his glasses up on his nose as he backed into the room, one step at a time .

We all turned to him .

Without us realizing, Song Lu had already woken up, and she was standing in front of the door . She held a sword up to Jie Pa as he slowly retreated . Wrapped in her sexy, black attire, she approached; Jie Pa must have had someone change her clothes in the ensuing time . Her large curls of hair

casually rested on her shoulders . Her breasts were beautifully outlined by her tight-fitting black clothes .

She looked as sultry and beautiful as before, only her eyes seemed a bit sunken, her face a bit fatigued . Her spirit hadn't entirely been recovered .

Her eyes were filled with a hateful, murderous intent, as well as a deep fear, mixed in with some pain . With her sword pointed at Jie Pa, she approached .

I quickly stepped forward and held up my hands, trying to placate her .
“Song Lu jiejie .” But Song Lu only glanced at me before looking around at the rest of the room .

When her loathing eyes landed on Nie Zun, she exploded . With her sword raised, she flew past me over to Nie Zun . “Nie Zun, you're going to pay!”

Everything came so unexpectedly that I could only stare blankly at the scene before me . Song Lu flew at Nie Zun with her sword, but he swiftly stepped out of the way, causing her to run into empty space . She flipped her hair and pressed her lips together, and then turned to attack again .

I grabbed Piercer and caught Song Lu's sword . My hand wasn't as nimble because it was still bandaged, but I was still able to stop Song Lu .

She clenched her teeth and pulled back on her sword . She pulled with more and more force as she glared resentfully at me . “Li Shen, you had better stay out of this . Otherwise, even if it's you, I won't show any mercy!”

“What exactly happened?!” I couldn't help shouting out loud .

Tears suddenly appeared in Song Lu's eyes . “Nie Zun... Nie Zun, he's the person who planned all of this! He killed Yu Liang!”

What?

Taken aback, my grip on Piercer loosened .

While my guard was down, Song Lu immediately pulled back her sword and lunged at Nie Zun . “Nie Zun! I will kill you here today to avenge Yu Liang!”

Nie Zun easily dodged her attack, his expression seemingly unaffected by the sudden events . With his same carefree tone, he said, “I don’t know what you’re talking about . ”

Jie Pa moved to stop Song Lu . “Ms Song Lu, please calm down . Tell us the entire situation . Perhaps there’s a misunderstanding somewhere . ”

“Yes, Song Lu jiejie, what exactly happened?” I quickly asked .

When Jie Pa reached out to block her, Song Lu paused, but her sword remained aimed at Nie Zun . The tears welling up in her eyes suddenly started to flow down . “Ah Shen, that day, Nie Zun came to our room to seek out Yu Liang . You know about Yu Liang’s ability; it’s not something that just anyone can fight against . Moreover, his split symbol was activated then . But Nie Zun isn’t just an ordinary person . Yu Liang hadn’t suspected Nie Zun at all, and he didn’t use his projection ability . But then Nie Zun ambushed us!

“He poured some type of inhibitor on us so that we couldn’t use our mental force, and then we were brought to the pit . Then those two women kept torturing me with strange poisons . Some kind of poisonous bugs ate at me until they were absorbed into my body . But Yu Liang’s body rejected them . In the end, to prove the viability of the experiment, Nie Zun stabbed Yu Liang with a sword covered in my blood . ”

Song Lu grew more distressed, and continuous streams of tears flowed down her face .

I gave a slight smile . “That can’t be . Nie Zun wouldn’t do that kind of thing . ”

Song Lu looked at me with tears in her eyes . “Would I lie to you?”

I shook my head . “You wouldn’t lie to me either . So, there must be something strange going on here . ”

I shook my head . “You wouldn’t lie to me either . So, there must be something strange going on here . ”

Jie Pa nodded . “Perhaps someone changed their appearance to look like Nie Zun?”

Song Lu shook her head, and a stream of tears slipped down her face .
“That can’t be . To disguise yourself as someone else, you must have a very high mental force . To imitate Nie Zun isn’t an easy feat, and they would have to understand Nie Zun’s habits as well . It had to be him!”

Jie Pa took a step forward . “Ms Song Lu, calm down . Where is Mr Yu Liang right now? Maybe we can still save him?”

At his words, Song Lu’s expression tensed in anguish . “He can’t be saved! I don’t know what kind of poison they put into me, but now whoever is harmed with my blood, they cannot heal! I saw Nie Zun stab Yu Liang in the heart with a sword covered in my blood!”

Her tears fell angrily, and she raised her sword to Nie Zun again .

Jie Pa nodded profoundly . “My suspicions were correct then . Someone is really trying to develop a method to directly kill others in the Split Zone . ”

Jiao S suddenly stood up . “Things are getting more and more complicated . Nie Zun, what do you have to say for yourself?”

Then, Guan Nie stepped forward . With a playful laugh, he said, “Although I don’t quite understand all that you’re saying, there’s no need to suspect my pet yet . ” Gao Qin Jiu Ye’s brows raised slightly, but he didn’t intend to speak up .

Nie Zun replied lightly, “There’s nothing in particular I have to say, but it wasn’t me . ”

Song Lu bit her lip, and a trickle of blood dripped down . Then she raised her sword with one arm and slit her other arm . A strange, pungent and irritating scent seemed to exude from the dark black blood flowing from her arm .

Then she slashed the blood contaminated sword at Nie Zun again .

“You’re going to insist on evading your wrongdoing! Don’t blame me for disregarding our year’s worth of friendship!” Song Lu shouted loudly .

An apprehensive feeling washed over me . Without hesitation or any questions, I raised my hand to stop Song Lu’s sword . Because of my close proximity to Song Lu, I saw my bandaged hand get chopped off by her sword .

An apprehensive feeling washed over me . Without hesitation or any questions, I raised my hand to stop Song Lu’s sword . Because of my close proximity to Song Lu, I saw my bandaged hand get chopped off by her sword .

Suddenly, the booming sound of an explosion sounded . Jiao S’ eyes tightened . Gao Qin Jiu Ye raised his left hand, and the two of them started to control the airflow . Blocked by their air blades, Song Lu was pushed back .

Nie Zun had already made his way over to my side .

Song Lu landed on the ground . She looked up, warm tears rolling down her face . “Ah Shen, are you really not going to help avenge Yu Liang?”

My chest tightened . With a frown, I replied, “Song Lu jiejie, I understand what you’re feeling, but you need to calm down right now . Nie Zun was not the perpetrator . I will vouch for it with my own life!”

Down on the ground, Song Lu’s pained tears streamed down her cheeks . “How could I possibly want your life... But... Who will compensate for Yu Liang’s...?”

I finally couldn't stand it any longer . Pushing aside Nie Zun, who was blocking me, I knelt down beside Song Lu and hugged her . “Song Lu jiejie, trust me . I can't explain the specifics of it, but Nie Zun definitely didn't do that . ”

Suddenly, Jiao S, who had just helped me, spoke up, “Li Shen, if you're hiding something, it's best that you tell us all now . Everyone is here now . Though I don't know how it was for you before, but right now, it's not only people from your district who have died . A child from our district has also died! Even if it's Nie Zun, if there's any suspicion, I won't turn a blind eye to it!”

Gao Qin Jiu Ye must have some enmity for Jiao S, for after she spoke, he was quick to mock, “You speak as though you're so righteous . Are you truly concerned for the kid, or are you just concerned that Si Luo may be involved?”

Jiao S fumed .

Guan Nie yawned and his bewitching eyes jumped . “Must you mock Jiao S? After all, are you truly standing here right now out of concern for the Southern District? Aren't you also doing this for that Si Luo or whoever?”

Gao Qin Jiu Ye's eyes turned cold .

I finally couldn't stand it anymore . I turned and shouted, “Enough!”

Chapter 39

Split Zone 13

39 Points of Doubt

As I held onto Song Lu, I turned my head . I felt an indescribable anger, and my eyes were cold as ice as I looked over all their faces . I sneered, “What are you all pretending to be noble and virtuous for? If we’re talking about motives, which of us here isn’t acting for their own selfish reasons? Attacking each other like this... Will you only know your place once we’ve all been sliced up and served to the enemy on a platter? You all may want to die, but I, Li Shen, do not want to join you!”

I rarely get angry, and I’ve never spoken such biting words . Everyone was silent from shock .

I turned back to Song Lu and made my voice as gentle as I could . “Song Lu, others don’t know this, but Nie Zun and I are linked together . When I arrived in the Split Zone, the blond man told me that Nie Zun had joined with my second identity, so Nie Zun and I must always remain within 500 meters of each other . That’s why it always seems like you see Nie Zun when you see me . That’s also why Nie Zun couldn’t have gone to the pit to attack you, without me . If he were to try traveling more than 500 meters from me, he wouldn’t be able to move . ”

When I saw Song Lu’s disbelieving eyes, I added, “It’s true . If you don’t believe me, we can show you . We must always remain within 500 meters of the other . So, he couldn’t have been the murderer . If it had been him, then that means he would have had to plot together with me . You may not believe him, but do you not believe me either?”

Song Lu looked at me, and then she looked at Nie Zun .

I lowered my head, silent for a moment . Then I turned around again, looking over everyone's faces, to see what they were thinking after my speech . “This is Nie Zun's secret, as well as mine . I had to tell you about it to prove his innocence, but I hope that no one will use this information to harm Nie Zun in the future . If you dare to divulge this information to anyone else, or if you try to use it to threaten us, whether you're a district commander or a high and lofty person, I swear that you will make an eternal enemy out of me!”

When Nie Zun saw my imposing manner, a sliver of warmth crossed his eyes . But still, he spoke in a cynical tone, as if things were completely unrelated to him . “Oh no, the secret's out . But no worries . Come find me anytime you'd like . ” He playfully glanced at Jiao S and Gao Qin Jiu Ye .

A devilish smile appeared on Gao Qin Jiu Ye's face . “Does this count as a weakness? Isn't it more like, if someone wants to attack one of you, they now have to face two people?”

“However,” he said, “if one of you were to suddenly decide to play guardian angel, then I'm afraid that this would truly be quite the weakness .”

My heart sunk .

Gao Qin Jiu Ye suddenly pointed a finger at me and looked over at Nie Zun with interest . “Nie Zun, this is the reason that you don't attack others and have never joined any groups, isn't it? You'd rather live this lazy life, because you're worried that this woman, who can't leave your side, will get hurt?”

I immediately raised my head and glared at Gao Qin Jiu Ye .

Gao Qin Jiu Ye looked a bit taken aback by my cold look . He gave a slight shrug of his shoulders .

Nie Zun slipped one hand into his pocket, while he used the other to flip up his coat collar . In his casual way, he said, “How could that be? I’m the one afraid of getting hurt, and I expect that she will protect me . ” Then he mischievously fluttered his eyes at me .

I tried to maintain my cold, uncaring demeanor, but I quickly lost out and rolled my eyes .

Gao Qin Jiu Ye narrowed his eyes, but didn’t speak .

Jiao S looked around and said, “I have no interest in spreading this information . ”

Guan Nie also complied, “Of couse I wouldn’t say anything detrimental about my pet . ”

After everyone made clear their thoughts, I turned my attention back to Song Lu, lying in my arms . She’d already stopped crying . After looking at me a long while, she finally sighed and said, “I beleive you, Ah Shen . ”

And then, as if all her exhaustion had finally caught up to her, her eyes drooped and she quietly mumbled, “Even if I can’t trust anyone else, I have to at least trust you . Ah Shen, I’ve always thought of you as my little sister, you know...”

I bit my lip, raising my hand to gently pet Song Lu’s hair .

Song Lu finally dropped the sword in her hand . Her eyelashes fluttered ever so slightly, and then she collapsed in my arms . With a loud, tearful cry, she wailed, “Ah Shen! Yu Liang... It was my blood! It was my blood that hurt him! The illusion I saw came true, and he really left me! Ah Shen! Is this really not a dream?! Split Zone... This damned place! Why does the Split Zone exist?! Ahh! Ah Shen, tell me!”

Her sobs felt like a thousand knives stabbing into my heart . It hurt, but I couldn’t escape it .

Jie Pa hurried over and crouched down . “Ms Song Lu, you said that you saw someone who looked like Nie Zun stab a blood-covered sword into Yu Liang’s heart . What happened after that?”

Song Lu sniffled, not quite sure what Jie Pa meant . “And then... And then, he stopped moving . Ever since I absorbed those bugs into my body, anyone who is harmed with my blood is unable to heal . He stopped moving, and then he was dragged off . ”

Jie Pa pushed his glasses up . “That means that we can’t be certain that Yu Liang is dead . You didn’t see his body fade away, right?”

Song Lu seemed a bit skeptical, but she shook her head .

Jie Pa thought for a moment, and then picked up the blood-covered sword that Song Lu had dropped to the ground . He made a small cut on his palm .

Jie Pa thought for a moment, and then picked up the blood-covered sword that Song Lu had dropped to the ground . He made a small cut on his palm .

Blood flowed out as Song Lu shouted, “Ahh!”

At once, I grew apprehensive . Though I didn’t shout out, my eyes were glued to Jie Pa’s hand . His expression was solemn as he watched his bleeding palm that didn’t immediately heal .

After awhile, he suddenly said, “As expected . Look . The wound doesn’t heal immediately, but the wound doesn’t continue bleeding either . That is, the body of my consciousness has become like a physical body . After being infected by Song Lu’s blood, my body seems unable to heal, but this inability to heal is more like a slowing in ability to heal, as if my body were made of the flesh and blood of the real world . That is to say, that if you want to use a blood-smeared weapon to kill someone, you must still deal a killing blow that would take out a real human body . Only then will that person die . ”

It was clear that his explanation left me a bit confused, as the neurons fired off in my brain, trying to follow Jie Pa’s thought process .

But then, suddenly, I recalled the day I found Jiao S lying on the ground, bleeding out . Jiao S' physical body had been harmed so her conscious body had similarly suffered . Ordinarily, when we're harmed in the Split Zone, our physical bodies don't end up injured, unless of course, we die from an attack on our split symbols .

So, Jie Pa was basically saying that Song Lu's blood can now break this barrier, allowing injuries on the conscious body to be transferred to the physical body? So, would Jie Pa's hand in the real world also be injured like this?

Song Lu was still leaning in my arms . Her eyelashes quivered again . "Perhaps that's the case . But Yu Liang was attacked at his heart! The sword went directly into his chest . If our physical bodies were injured like that, would there even be a chance of survival?"

Jie Pa pushed up his glasses . "But you didn't see Yu Liang's body disappear? From what we know, if your body in the real world dies, your body here will disappear . This is the only method of verifying a death . Though it seems the person behind everything wanted to use this sorcery to refine a method for harming the physical body, there appears to be a limit to its abilities . If Mr Yu Liang didn't disappear, then there are two possibilities . One is that his body hadn't been killed immediately . The other is that he may have been used in a different experiment, and his body has already been altered . "

A glimmer of hope slipped onto Song Lu's eyes . "Yes, the bugs they used on his body were different than mine!"

But, I couldn't help frowning . "They must have another laboratory space then . If they dragged Yu Liang away, they must have somewhere to take him to . And it wouldn't be too far away, which means it should be in the Southern District still . "

But, I couldn't help frowning . "They must have another laboratory space then . If they dragged Yu Liang away, they must have somewhere to take him to . And it wouldn't be too far away, which means it should be in the Southern District still . "

Suddenly, my eyes flew over to Gao Qin Jiu Ye . He seemed to have come to the same conclusion, and he also frowned slightly .

Jie Pa agreed . “The faster we uncover the truth, the better . Our opponent remains hidden . If we are unable to discover their true motive, our three districts will not be safe . ”

Guan Nie suddenly laughed . “Goodness, with such a big ordeal happening, are you sure you don’t want to contact the blond?”

Guan Nie spoke my thoughts out loud . I couldn’t help thinking about the fact that, if we hadn’t decided to travel to the Northern District to uncover the truth of the Split Zone, we might not have discovered these secret operations, and we would have certainly been in more danger .

Gao Qin Jiu Ye suddenly spoke up . “It’s no use . The blond’s gone missing . No one can contact him . Si Luo tried to call him out before, but he didn’t appear . If you don’t believe me, you can try calling for him . ”

What?

Although the method for contacting him was very dumb, as long as one of the district commanders called for him, he would certainly appear . If he didn’t... Could he truly have gone missing?

I still didn’t dare to believe it . I helped Song Lu up, and then I walked over to the window . I opened it and shouted outside, “The most handsome, invincible, cutest, strongest, and greatest leader, I’m your fan! Please meet with me!!!”

In the past, shouting this out had been embarrassing, but today, when Mr Blond didn’t appear from the sky, I finally seemed to feel the graveness of the situation .

Chapter 40

Split Zone 13

40 He's Not Gao Qi

I tried shouting again . And again, there was no response . I'd never come across a situation like this before .

Turning to Gao Qin Jiu Ye, I asked, "How long ago did Si Luo discover he couldn't make contact?"

"Last month . "

Suddenly, a fear came over me . It wasn't because I was a coward, but all the events that had occurred seemed to hint at an imminent disaster . This disaster wouldn't just be a setback or a difficulty . This disaster would be an inevitable, unescapable punishment from the heavens that we would all be forced to bear .

My intuition has always been accurate . Though I may not know what these bad omens mean precisely, I do know that I'm very frightened of what's to come .

One day, many years later, I would recall this day, and I would regret it . I should have avoided the disaster when faced with it . Like I always had before, I should have avoided it, instead of charging forward bravely .

But in that moment, I couldn't predict what lied ahead in the future . Instead, I said, "So what should we do now? It seems our only option is to turn over all of the Southern District to find any other experiment sites . But before Si Luo appears, it probably wouldn't be good for us to act

unscrupulously, right? Gao Qin Jiu Ye, are you truly planning to continue hiding Si Luo from us?”

A dejected expression appeared on his face . “I cannot—No matter what else happens, I cannot bring you to Si Luo . ”

“That’s enough, Gao Qin Jiu Ye!” Jiao S suddenly shouted out, enraged . “Without Si Luo, can we resolve this situation? Even if you can, do you think that by hiding him away like this, Si Luo will be safe?”

Gao Qin Jiu Ye shot her a cold look . And suddenly, a deathly aura permeated the air . He shouted, “Jiao S, don’t act like you’re infallible! No matter how much you may know about Si Luo’s situation, remember that it has nothing to do with you! I will protect Si Luo! You don’t need to get involved!”

A ruthlessness showed in his eyes . “Moreover, how can I be sure that all of this isn’t part of one of your plots? Who knows if you’re the one who planned all of this, just to draw out Si Luo . But I’m afraid you’ve wasted your efforts . Jiao S, listen clearly . No matter what you do, Si Luo will never be attracted to you! It’s impossible between the two of you!”

I couldn’t help feeling shocked at his cold, resolute words .

“It’s impossible between the two of you!”

“Li Shen, it’s impossible between the two of you!”

The words once spoken to me echoed in my ears again . I looked at the person before me, who looked exactly like Senior Gao Qi . Seeing the gentlest and warmest person I’d known suddenly speak so firmly, my body subconsciously stepped forward .

I walked up to Gao Qin Jiu Ye . The audience around me looked somewhat startled, as if watching a person who’d been possessed . But Gao Qin Jiu Ye, instead of looking surprised at my strange behaviour, continued to look at me with his chilly expression .

When I finally stood in in front of him, I raised my head and looked at his face, imagining that it wasn't stiff and cold . I imagined that there wasn't cruelty and ruthlessness in his eyes . I imagined that his lips, that spoke with the world's most enchanting voice, hadn't just sharply attacked another .

I felt my eyes grow moist .

“Li Shen, you and he will never be together . ”

The voice echoed in my head . Like a child praying to heaven, tears streaming down my face, I looked up at Gao Qin Jiu Ye .

He finally looked a bit shaken . Confusion and suspicion crossed his eyes . But there was also a kind of helplessness...and sympathy? Was I mistaken?

I continued to stare into his eyes, motionless .

This was how charming he was . I couldn't look away; I wanted him to be completely mine .

Mine? Why should you have him? You didn't have him enough yet?

You killed him!

No, no . He didn't die . Isn't he here, right in front of my eyes?

There seemed to be another voice inside my head .

“Heh . Gao Qin Jiu Ye, do you really enjoy tempting people this much? You must, don't you?” While I'd been distracted, Guan Nie had walked over to me, his gown swaying with each step . His beautiful eyes were locked on Gao Qin Jiu Ye as he spoke .

Suddenly, I felt my thoughts clearing up .

God, what was I just doing? How could I have been so entranced that I stared at Gao Qin Jiu Ye like that? He's not Gao Qi!

Feeling a bit embarrassed, I quickly moved away from Gao Qin Jiu Ye . As I hurried away, I glanced at Nie Zun . There was a strange gloominess in his eyes that I couldn't understand . It felt like I was never able to understand his expressions .

Gao Qin Jiu Ye turned to the side slightly, as if unwilling to face Guan Nie straight on . Instead of answering Guan Nie's nonsensical question, he turned to Jiao S . "I will, to my utmost ability, uncover the truth . However, I won't be allowing you to meet with Si Luo . I still hold my suspicions about you . But I will make things clear . "

His remarks seemed to be a move to wrap up this talk . He essentially agreed that that situation was suspicious, and he offered to help us investigate .

Jiao S had remained motionless since his jeering remarks earlier . Now, the crackling of her turning neck sounded . "Since you refuse to allow me to meet Si Luo, we should start investigating these things . But you'll have to bring out the soul snatcher, Rong Jin . You can do that, at least, can't you?"

Seeing Jiao S compromise, I let out a relieved sigh . For some reason, I didn't like watching everyone make Gao Qin Jiu Ye out to be the enemy . Even though we're not from the same group, in our situation, fighting amongst ourselves wouldn't help us at all .

Gao Qin Jiu Ye suddenly laughed without restraint . "I rarely interact with that illusionist and soul snatcher, so naturally, I don't know there whereabouts either . I'm starting at the same point as all of you, so let's just search together . "

Jiao S was unexpectedly compliant . "Okay . With how arrogant you are, it would be true that you don't end up interacting with many people . Then, for now, we'll remain in the Southern District, and you'd best stay with us while we investigate . "

Jiao S was unexpectedly compliant . "Okay . With how arrogant you are, it would be true that you don't end up interacting with many people . Then,

for now, we'll remain in the Southern District, and you'd best stay with us while we investigate . ”

I suddenly thought of something, and I probed, “Speaking of... Gao Qin Jiu Ye, do you know how to travel across the South-North border?”

Everyone was quiet, and everyone seemed surprised that I would ask such a question .

Gao Qin Jiu Ye scoffed . “Traveling across the border? I don't know about that, but you shouldn't spend so much time worrying about impossible things as that . I don't care about the blond's disappearance . I am only responsible for the Southern District . ”

Then he walked towards the window . “You should stay here . I'll check the news going around . Before I return, I hope you won't make any moves . Since we've agreed to cooperate, we should discuss our plans together . ” It wasn't a request as much as a warning .

After he finished speaking, he jumped out the window .

Guan Nie's eyes lit up . As he watched Gao Qin Jiu Ye's disappearing figure, he said, “You all discuss . Same as before, when you've decided what you're doing, have my pet let me know . ”

Seeing Guan Nie about to start tailing Gao Qin Jiu Ye, Jiao S grabbed him . “Don't do anything to him . Got it?”

Guan Nie gave a sidelong glance . “Yeah, got it . ”

Jiao S stared at Guan Nie's face, before finally releasing him . And then Guan Nie's white robe floated out the window .

“Ms Ah Shen, you should rest . Your hand hasn't healed completely yet, so you should be resting more these few days . It won't be easy to uncover the truth here, and rushing will do us no good . We need to make sure that we're strong first,” Jie Pa urged .

Jie Pa was right . I nodded in agreement . “Don’t worry, I’ll be sure to rest .”

Jie Pa walked over to Song Lu . “Ms Song Lu, I’ll have to inconvenience you to stay with me for a few days . I can’t be certain if your body will have any reactions, so I’ll need to test your blood again . ”

Song Lu nodded . I signaled to Song Lu, and after her eyes met mine, she left with Jie Pa to their room .

Song Lu nodded . I signaled to Song Lu, and after her eyes met mine, she left with Jie Pa to their room .

As Jiao S left, she walked past me and glanced over . Her expression was unreadable as she said, “Gao Qin Jiu Ye is most definitely not a nice guy . You’d do well not to get involved with him . ”

Her coarse voice was usually emotionless, but for some reason, I thought I heard some concern in her voice . So I responded with a slight smile .

The room was empty but for Nie Zun and me . He leaned lazily against the wall, with his hands in his pockets . His eyes swept around the room, not looking at anything in particular .

I felt a bit tired, so I returned to the bed and quietly lied down . Nie Zun remained leaning on the wall . After everyone left, he hadn’t spoken a word .

I glanced at him, and finally asked, “What’s... What’s going on under your gloves? You can’t touch anything?”

I recalled the times that Mi Fu and the bald boy touched his hands; their faces had been filled with terror . And then I recalled that when I fell down while we were in the stone room, he hadn’t helped me with his bare hands .

Nie Zun’s hair blocked his eyes from my view . Quiet and unhurried, he said, “If that’s the case, what of it?”

Nie Zun felt a bit different today . I sat up and looked at him . “What’s wrong?”

I turned around to the window for a look, startled to see that the sky outside was already dark . Had I been in a trance for that long during the day?

Nie Zun’s clear voice came from behind me . “Li Shen, he’s Gao Qin Jiu Ye, not the Gao Qi you killed . ”

My back was facing him . In the darkness, I bit my lip .

Chapter 41

Split Zone 13

41 Two Men

After a long moment, I finally released my gashed lip and admitted, “I know . I know that Gao Qi is already dead, that I killed him . ” I turned to Nie Zun .

He was still leaning against the wall, having straightened his body a bit .
“Then why do you always look at him like that?”

I didn’t reply .

After a moment, he turned around, his resolute back facing me . “Go ahead and rest . I’m going to look around outside . ”

After Nie Zun left through the door, I remained sitting in bed . My hands were still wrapped up with white gauze .

Right, Li Shen . He’s not Gao Qi . You already killed Gao Qi with your two hands . But why did he feel so much like Gao Qi?

Well, aside from his appearance, he isn’t at all like Gao Qi . Gao Qi’s warmth was like the feeling of being bathed in a spring breeze . All the places he passed would appear to light up, although that may have just been in my eyes .

Gao Qin Jiu Ye was different . Gao Qin Jiu Ye was always cold and arrogant . His eyes carried a heartless aura, like he never wanted to get involved in others’ affairs, like a reaper who would impartially punish everyone for their sins .

I did my best to highlight the differences between the two for them . I tried to pinpoint all their differences, as a reminder, to prevent myself from falling into another spell . I thought about it, and with my unconstrained imagination, for some reason, I suddenly thought of Nie Zun .

I asked myself what Nie Zun meant to me .

He was the devil . Because my second identity lived within him, he was the devil .

But, what else?

Nie Zun and Gao Qi were indeed very different . Nie Zun was mostly cold, though it was a different coldness from Gao Qin Jiu Ye's . His coldness was like his apathy, a shadow that others didn't see . Because he was carefree and unrestrained, his coldness was concealed .

Nie Zun was also a solitary person . I'd never seen loneliness in his eyes, but I could feel that he was solitary . His was a solitude that didn't require others' understanding, that didn't need others' sympathy . It was an undefeatable, honorable kind of solitude .

What am I thinking about right now?

I shook my head, unsure what exactly I was analyzing right now .

“Hey, Li Shen, you really are crazy,” I muttered to myself as I sat in the darkness .

“Haha, do you really enjoy talking to yourself this much?” An arrogant and teasing voice came from the window .

I quickly turned my head . Gao Qin Jiu Ye had already returned and was currently sitting on the windowsill, watching me with his demonic eyes .

“Where's Guan Nie? It seemed he couldn't bear to be away from you . ” I raised my eyebrows .

Gao Qin Jiu Ye shrugged . “I lost him ages ago . If I want to get away, no one can keep up with me . ”

I couldn't help rolling my eyes . Truly arrogant .

He seemed to have seen my eye roll, and then he jumped in from the window and walked up to me . Since I was sitting with my legs crossed on my bed, he stood much taller than me . His arms were behind his back as he bent down and stuck his head into the semi-enclosed space between the top and bottom bunks . His face stretched towards mine, until he was less than 10 cm from my face .

I grew a bit tense at his sudden action . My heart also trembled as this face, that had once enticed me so, moved into such close proximity .

I tried to breathe lightly, reminding myself that I'd already made it clear to myself that he and Gao Qi were two different people . He isn't Gao Qi . Li Shen, calm down .

He looked at me with his piercing eyes, and an oppressive force seemed to overcome me . I suppressed my breathing; with his face so close to mine, I worried that my breath would land on his face . The room was fearfully quiet . I started blinking so rapidly that the flapping of my lashes seemed audible in the silence .

A wicked and entrancing smile appeared on his face . “Li Shen, does this Gao Qi person look like me?”

With his charming voice sounding so close to my ears, I should have nearly fainted, but when I heard the name ‘Gao Qi’ in his voice, I suddenly felt a chill .

I looked down, trying to avoid his gaze . “Yes . ”

“Did you love him?” Gao Qin Jiu Ye teased .

With my eyes still lowered, I replied, “Yes . ”

Gao Qin Jiu Ye's laugh grew frostier . "So, the reason you're risking your life to get to the Northern District, to find a way to leave the Split Zone, is because you want to return to your world and meet him again? To meet with that person who looks like me?"

He held my chin in his hand, and pulled me closer to him . My eyes widened, and his eyes shined . "Now that you've seen someone who looks just like him in the Split Zone, do you feel that you can't bear to leave?"

Suddenly, I found it a bit laughable . I felt his strong grip on my chin as a smile appeared on my face . I looked at him, despair and hopelessness in my eyes . "Sorry, I've never once thought of returning . What's the point anyway? I don't feel any desire to return and meet with him, because even if I return, I won't be able to meet him . "

Suddenly, I found it a bit laughable . I felt his strong grip on my chin as a smile appeared on my face . I looked at him, despair and hopelessness in my eyes . "Sorry, I've never once thought of returning . What's the point anyway? I don't feel any desire to return and meet with him, because even if I return, I won't be able to meet him . "

Gao Qin Jiu Ye hadn't expected my response . After a moment, he asked, "Is he dead?"

He still held my chin in his hand . I nodded and then smiled . "Yes . And I was the one who killed him . "

Surprise and astonishment appeared on his face . It was the first time I'd seen Gao Qin Jiu Ye so startled . In fact, it was the first time I'd ever seen him show any emotion . Surprise was an emotion after all .

After a moment, he stood up straight and had a great big laugh, as if he'd heard the world's funniest joke . When he smiled, his eyes shined like no other . It even looked like tears were about to flow out .

My chin was still in his hand .

His laughter was exaggerated . “Hahaha! How interesting! Too interesting! Li Shen, you’re really very interesting!”

I stubbornly stared at him as he laughed, refusing to look away .

Suddenly, the door opened, and the light from the hallway streamed in . There was Nie Zun’s tall figure . When he walked in, Gao Qin Jiu Ye still held my chin as he laughed . Nie Zun must have been taken aback, but as his back was against the light and we were a distance away, I couldn’t see his expression clearly .

Gao Qin Jiu Ye finally released me . The same cold smile was on his face, but there seemed to be an added curiosity in his eyes now . He said to me, “If that’s the case, Li Shen, why not just continue living like this in the Split Zone? You can only have fun when you’re alive, right?”

Like a reaper who’d just taken a life, expressing his enjoyment, he smiled cruelly, and then he left through the window . After he left, I could only stare at the still-opened window, motionless .

Nie Zun had walked in quietly, his hands stuffed in his pockets . He walked over to the bed, and without a glance in my direction, he jumped onto the top bunk and lied down .

I felt a bit agitated, so I got out of bed and headed over to the desk on the opposite side of the room . I poured myself a cup of water, and leaning against the wall, I looked up at Nie Zun lying on the top bunk . I lifted my cup, about to take a sip .

I felt a bit agitated, so I got out of bed and headed over to the desk on the opposite side of the room . I poured myself a cup of water, and leaning against the wall, I looked up at Nie Zun lying on the top bunk . I lifted my cup, about to take a sip .

But the moment the cup touched my lips, a gust of wind blasted my way . In an instant, Nie Zun flipped out of bed and landed on the ground in front of me .

I froze, my lips having just gotten wet . From beneath his dark bangs, he glared at me, the dark billowing waves rolling in his eyes .

He raised his hand and grabbed the glass of water from my hand, throwing it to the ground . He pressed his other gloved hand against the wall behind me, putting me between him and the wall .

His face approached my face .

Though Nie Zun and I were always together, this seemed to be the first time we'd ever been so close . I looked into his eyes, and I saw his grey, seemingly hurt and lonely eyes . I could feel his breathing on my skin .

He turned his head and his hair seemed to sweep over my forehead . His hot breath and dark, burning eyes made mine feel like they were melting . For some reason, my heart was pounding in my chest . It wasn't like my exchange with Gao Qin Jiu Ye . I wasn't holding my breath, but my heart kept beating faster and faster . If this continued, my heart would jump straight out of my chest and dance about in the air .

Nie Zun remained like that, his dark, burning eyes locked on me . But he didn't say a word .

I didn't dare speak either . Instead, I frowned, as I couldn't handle the rapid beating of my heart . I raised a hand and pressed my palm against my own chest . My heart truly felt like it would leap out of my chest at any moment .

When he saw me frown, anger flashed across Nie Zun's eyes . His devilish voice sounded in my ears, "You happily let him hold your chin, but when I get near to you, you frown?"

His voice was neither loud nor quiet, neither cold nor warm . Like that, his voice boomed in my ears .

Chapter 42

Split Zone 13

42 Another Incident

He leaned in closer to my face . His lips stopped at the corner of my mouth, his cheek rubbing against mine . He was too close for me to see his eyes; I could only feel his lips looming near my own . The bead of water on them seemed to be able to touch his lips .

A dizziness overcame me, and my heart beat wildly in my chest . I cursed silently, but I didn't dare consider what this situation was .

Nie Zun's arm wrapped around me, holding me between him and the wall . He slanted his lips slightly and they touched the drop of water on my lips . Like a cloth absorbing water, his lips wicked off the water bead in an instant .

My eyes widened, and finally, I lifted my arm . I held my hand to my chest, in the space between us, trying to calm my beating heart . My lips started to tremble, but he didn't seem to care . He continued to stare at me with his shining eyes, a warmth passing over them .

I opened my mouth slightly to speak, and in that moment, his eyes dropped and his lips brushed past mine . They only brushed past ever so lightly, but a strong shock seemed to ripple out from my lips all the way down to my chest .

I couldn't bear it any longer, and so I pushed him away with both hands and I fell to the ground .

At my push, Nie Zun took a few steps back, looking startled . And then he laughed bitterly, before slowly stuffing his hands back into the pockets of his black windbreaker .

I ignored his laugh, still caught up by my beating heart that felt like it'd been struck by lightning .

I frowned, holding my chest with my hands, as if I'd finally found my breath . I inhaled, trying to wash away the aching, itchy feeling on my heart .

As I panted, I looked at the smiling Nie Zun . “You! Hurry over and help me up! M-my heart feels like it’s about to burst! Hurry and call Jie Pa! Is this an aftereffect of my injury?!”

Nie Zun froze and stared at me, my words taking him by surprise .

I frowned and looked over at him like a fool . And then, finally, as if understanding, a look of delight crossed his eyes, wiping away the dim, helplessness that had been there previously . His lips curved up seductively .

I couldn’t help rolling my eyes . With another frown, I said, “Have you gone insane?! I said my heart’s nearly bursting out of my chest! Hurry and help me up!”

Nie Zun sneered, the dark storm in his eyes calming . He walked over and helped me up . His scent floated into my nose again . I felt his arm around me and his gaze on me, and I quickly pushed away, stepping back .

A bit embarrassed, I raised a hand and kneaded my red hair . Nie Zun’s eyes darted around and he coughed into his gloved fist .

“So, why do you think someone would attack Yu Liang while disguised as you?” I tried asking .

The question seemed to suit Nie Zun, and his darting eyes calmed . “I wonder if, perhaps, someone is trying to incite discord between us . They

want us to suspect each other . ”

I frowned . “Who could be behind a plan like that? What’s his motive?”

Nie Zun stuffed his hands back into his pockets as he replied, “Perhaps these evildoings go deeper than we’re thinking . ”

I nodded, my heart heavy, as I pondered the recent events .

Bang, bang, bang!

A strange banging sound suddenly came from outside the window . Nie Zun and I exchanged a glance . And suddenly, a shadow flashed past the window .

I’d been nervous, but when we made it outside, I was stunned .

Nie Zun and I were already on the first floor of the school building . We ran out from an exit, and as we stepped out the doors, a person fell from above us . I quickly tried to dodge the falling body, which then landed right beside me!

Blood splattered all around, and the person died .

When Nie Zun and I looked up, we discovered that all the windows on the 11th floor of the building were shattered . Moreover, in the hundreds of broken windows were hundreds of corpses being tossed out . One after the next, bodies fell down, some nearby, some far away . One body looked to be healing as it fell .

Could it be?

A bad feeling came over me, but I couldn’t be bothered with that right now . With a bit of mental force, I jumped up to a broken window on the 11th floor . Nie Zun followed close behind .

I ended up in some kind of classroom . Most of the rooms in the building were classrooms; only the first ten floors were used for temporary-stay dorms .

The room was empty and very tidy . I ran out the door into the corridor, which was crowded with people, running out of their rooms, screaming . Because the weak Southern residents had never been faced with such a situation, some simply fell to the ground in despair .

The building was divided into sections, separated by large doors every 100 meters or so . The bodies were being thrown out from windows in this section of the building, so I ran through the crowd, searching for the person who could be behind the ordeal .

The frightened crowd made it difficult to get through the corridor, but I didn't dare use any mental force, lest I scare the residents even more . Nie Zun and I checked room after room, until we arrived at the elevator at the end of the building section . Then I saw some people running past the elevator . Jie Pa and Song Lu .

When I saw Song Lu, I felt my heart drop with a thud . All I could think was that as long as Song Lu wasn't behind this, that's all that mattered . Her face carried an exhaustion, but when she saw me, she seemed to sigh a sigh of relief, a heartbroken look in her eyes .

I also noticed that my expression wasn't good . I quickly turned to Jie Pa and asked, "What's going on here?"

I also noticed that my expression wasn't good . I quickly turned to Jie Pa and asked, "What's going on here?"

Jie Pa responded just as quickly, "Ms Song Lu and I were on the 12th floor, trying to analyze a blood sample . When we heard the cries from the 11th floor, we quickly ran down, but we don't know what's going on yet . "

Huh, what are you talking about? I pushed past them and ran towards the next section of the building . Past the elevator was another corridor, which was beginning to fill up with people leaving their rooms as well . I was trying to make my way through the increasing crowd when a figure passed by in the distance .

Though there was some light, visibility was nevertheless reduced in the night . But when the figure passed by, I turned and happened to glimpse something . And then I froze .

Standing frozen in spot, Nie Zun caught up to me and shook me . “Li Shen, what are you doing?!”

I watched the figure disappear into the distance, and I finally snapped out of it . I ran forward . The figure disappeared into a room, and so I followed behind into the room . It was another classroom . The windows weren’t shattered, but they were open .

I ran over to the window and looked down . It didn’t look like anyone had been dropped out from the window . When I looked around some more, I finally spotted an all too familiar, graceful figure by the woods surrounding the school .

My mouth dropped open in surprise as Nie Zun rushed over . The figure below turned and slightly raised their head and smiled at me, promptly disappearing into the woods afterwards .

Without too much thought, I jumped out the window . When I landed, I ran into Gao Qin Jiu Ye and Jiao S on the ground .

Even Jiao S looked astonished . “What’s going on here? Did you catch the culprit?”

I raised my head and looked over towards the woods where the figure disappeared . Knowing that I wouldn’t be able to find him under the current visibility conditions, I could only shake my head .

Gao Qin Jiu Ye asked with extreme gravity, “On our way over, there were more than a hundred people who fell out from the building without healing .”

Jie Pa and Song Lu had also jumped out from the window and caught up to us .

Jie Pa and Song Lu had also jumped out from the window and caught up to us .

Jie Pa quickly added, “Then their blood must have been mixed with blood of a constitution like Song Lu’s . My conjecture earlier wasn’t right . I was testing Song Lu’s blood earlier, and the reason that Song Lu’s blood causes others to die, is because when her blood mixes with another’s, it causes that person’s conscious body to become a physical body . That means it can be wounded, and those wounds naturally transfer to their physical bodies in the real world . ”

Alarmed, I reminded him, “You cut your hand with a knife covered in her blood!”

He returned a bitter laugh . “Yes . My wound cannot heal as quickly as we would expect here . It can only heal like a physical body ordinarily would, slowly . ”

I covered my mouth with my hand . That basically made you a cripple in the Split Zone!

A deeply pained expression was on Song Lu’s face .

Jiao S asked, “Can you still use your mental force?”

Jie Pa nodded . “Yes . Everything is as usual, but I shouldn’t get injured . This blood makeup is truly unparalleled . Song Lu’s blood causes others to lose their ability to heal quickly, while conversely, her own ability to heal has increased in speed . ”

Gao Qin Jiu Ye asked ruthlessly, “Who would do such a thing?!”

Jie Pa replied helplessly, “If I’m not wrong, the culprit was simply testing things today . Since the test was successful, I’m afraid that the residents of the Split Zone will be in much danger now . ”

Gao Qin Jiu Ye suddenly shot a cold look at Song Lu . “But she’s right here . From what you’ve told us, each of their experiments was different . How

can they be utilizing her blood then?”

With a downcast expression, Jie Pa replied, “I’m afraid they must have a second successful experiment . However, the chances of integrating the demon leeches with a human body is very low . It’s likely that Song Lu may have been their only complete success . I’m not sure who’s blood they’re using now, but it may not be as perfect as Song Lu’s . In fact, it’s possible that they’re creating such a large disturbance now in order to reclaim Song Lu . ”

Chapter 43

Volume 1

43 What You See May Not Be the Truth

I trusted in Jie Pa's reasoning skills. He'd always been logical and collected.

I decided to speak up, "Since the culprit remains hidden, we should first stay calm. Since those who have died may have been infected with blood like Song Lu's, let's have Jie Pa collect their blood to examine it. If you're bothered by it, Gaoqin Jiuye, you can go along with him. And since the deaths are your Southern District's residents, and Si Luo won't make an appearance, you ought to calm the residents' wary hearts. Nie Zun, Jiao S, and I will go search around the area where the supposed culprit disappeared."

Gaoqin Jiuye glanced at me, and then agreed with my suggestion.

I motioned for Jiao S to follow me. With a jolt of mental force for speed, I started running for the woods around the school building, Jiao S and Nie Zun on my heels.

After getting into the woods a bit, looking back, the school was no longer visible. All I could see was layer upon layer of trees under the darkened night sky. I stopped walking.

Jiao S looked a bit cautious. With large, flitting eyes, she looked at me. Nie Zun also stopped, a distance away, unsure of what I intended.

I turned back and looked at Jiao S. "Now that there's only you, me, and Nie Zun, I have something I want to say to you."

Standing still, Jiao S fixed her gaze onto me and said, “Go ahead.”

Standing just as still, I returned her gaze. “Guess who I saw when we were chasing the perpetrator.”

Jiao S rolled her eyes. “Don’t keep me hanging.”

Making sure to enunciate each word, I said, “I saw Li Wen.”

Surprised, she asked, “Li Wen?”

I scoffed, “Yes, the very one whom you injured and shamed in front of the Western residents, Li Qing’s beloved disciple, Li Wen.”

Jiao S shook her head. “That can’t be. She disappeared before Li Qing died. And for the past year, I haven’t heard of anyone spotting her in the Split Zone. I figured that she must have disappeared from the Split Zone, the same as Li Qing.”

At her words, I couldn’t help thinking of Li Qing’s death.

Li Qing’s death had been very different to everyone else’s. She seemed to have known her death was coming, long before it arrived, even making arrangements for it. That day, on the roof of the Western residence, after entrusting everything to me, she suddenly closed her eyes and fell over.

After Jie Pa examined her, we found that Li Qing had indeed died. Her consciousness was gone, but her body hadn’t turned to ash and smoke, and her split symbol was fully intact. We temporarily kept her seemingly comatose, unbreathing body. That is, until one day, when her corpse just vanished.

We had a very strict watch on her, which meant that it was impossible for someone to have snuck her body out, and so, Jie Pa and a few other medical persons suspected that her physical body may have finally died. Instead of turning to ashes and disappearing as smoke, she had instead slowly evaporated. But no one had seen the event unfold, and so no one truly knew what happened.

The blond man hadn't mentioned a single word about the incident. He simply promoted me to Western Commander, and never spoke of the situation again.

I'd been devastated at the time, but Li Qing had in fact told me about her leaving ahead of time. She said that she would die, and that everyone in the Split Zone would eventually die too. When she'd first brought it up, I hadn't really understood what she was talking about, but in the end, I had to accept that she was gone.

But it was Li Wen's death that came strangely. One day, she just suddenly disappeared from the Split Zone, without a trace. I had suspected Jiao S, but the blond man had a lot of informers spread about the place. He told me that Jiao S wasn't involved and to stop investigating it.

I have to admit that, at the time, I was quite the wretch. What, with Li Qing's death and Li Wen's disappearance, as well as the dejection I'd been feeling since my arrival in the Split Zone, I grew very accustomed to letting things happen without getting involved. I didn't think too much about anything, and just lied around all day, eating and drinking.

But I couldn't act that way anymore. Laurel's treatment at such a young age, turning into some strange monster. Song Lu, who always protected me, always thought of me first, the person I thought of as my real sister, she'd turned into something strange. Song Lu and Yu Liang, who had always been happy together, were now split apart. One's whereabouts were unknown, and the other had become some kind of science experiment. I couldn't act the same anymore.

When I thought of all that, my glare intensified. "Jiao S, tell me. Why did you do that to Li Wen, back then?"

Jiao S was quiet a moment. "Do you really want to know?"

I nodded.

Jiao S exhaled, a trace of helplessness slipping over her eyes for the first time. "I did it for Li Qing."

I was shocked, but I didn't cut in.

And she continued, "You know, Li Qing was always an unwavering and capable woman. Though her mental force wasn't extremely high, she always trained. In order to protect the Western residents, she really sacrificed a lot. Not long after I became the Eastern Commander, she visited me, wanting to befriend me. At first, I simply thought that she wanted to maintain peaceful relations between the districts, but later, I realized that she was really a very charismatic and charming woman.

"I've never agreed with others' governing practices. You may all see the Eastern District as a violent and riotous place, but that's just a consequence of the weak being prey to the strong. In the East, everyone is forced to become strong enough to protect themselves. Sometimes, having an easy life isn't really a good thing. I've always hoped that my residents would become cruel demons; they just need to protect themselves."

My heart quivered. Were these her thoughts? Although they were scary, could I say her method was wrong? In a place like the Split Zone, if you didn't eat others, you'd be the one eaten.

Jiao S paused and then continued, "While I didn't agree with Li Qing's governance, the Western District was indeed very comfortable and peaceful. The residents of the West weren't nearly as perverse or cruel as us, but neither were they as vulnerable as those in the South. Maybe it was Li Qing who was amazing, creating, in some sense, a genuine harmony."

I felt pained once more. That's right, Li Qing's success... I'd nearly destroyed it all in one blow.

Jiao S' still looked upset, as if recalling a past she didn't want to remember. "But Li Qing told me that all of that wasn't what she wanted. What she wanted was to go home. She once asked me why, when everyone came to this place, their panic would slowly turn to suspicion, before finally becoming acceptance. She couldn't understand it. It was always on her mind that someone was waiting for her to wake up, and she could never rest easy for a single day while she was here. She didn't know why everyone

seemed to give up after they couldn't find their soul splitters, why they could just accept things and keep living here."

I bit my lip. "I'm just the kind of person she spoke of. When she handed the commander position to me, she even said that, because I didn't want to leave, I would make a good commander."

Jiao S nodded. "That was Li Qing's conflict. She couldn't stay and protect everyone's safety if she wanted to leave at every moment. She didn't know what the right choice was."

I laughed bitterly. "What right and wrong is there here in this place? Everything's topsy turvy here. Lots of people don't want to return to the real world because life there will never be as good as it is here for them. At least here, there are no pressures. And if you live in a stable district, you'll be able to live all the more easily. You can enjoy life and do anything you want."

Jiao S was quiet a moment before she spoke up, "This was the selfish human nature that Li Qing spoke of. Perhaps life here may be better than reality, but isn't that just an excuse to escape reality? Also, think of the pain you're inflicting on your family, although some here may not have families in the real world. But the truth is that death is inevitable. Are you going to stay here and deceive yourself forever?"

My eyes dropped. "That does sound like something Li Qing would say."

Jiao S' eyes also fell. "Yes. Though I admired and understood her, and I knew what she said was reasonable, I could never bring myself to be so enlightened. The Split Zone is like a cage, and I'm afraid that I'm like a prisoner who's very much willing to spend eternity in it."

Suddenly, her eyes widened and her rough voice came sharply, "But this admirable woman gave up her chance to leave because of that girl!"

I frowned, not understanding.

A murderous aura filled her eyes. "I guess you never considered it. Li Wen was no ordinary person. She was Li Qing's soul splitter."

My eyes widened in surprise. Soul splitter? That word that always lingered around us and yet, was ever so distant from us... How could it be used on such a warm and lovely girl?

Jiao S closed her eyes, as if it was difficult to continue. "When I found out, I was also very surprised, but it's true. When you saw me tearing her apart, I was verifying this matter. I saw it on her lower back, the same exact peach blossom that Li Qing had, in the same exact spot! When I saw it, I was engulfed with anger. Li Qing couldn't bear to hurt Li Wen. She would rather give up her only chance to return to the real world than hurt Li Wen!"

Jiao S' eyes widened again. "So, I decided to be the bad guy. I forced Li Wen to go to Li Qing and kill herself instead. But she refused! Li Shen, you know how well Li Qing treated her! But she was the culprit who brought Li Qing to this damned place! She had no appreciation at all!"

I never thought I'd be hearing about Li Qing and Li Wen like this. My body felt like it had turned to ice, cold, frozen.

Jiao S' eyes were full of hostility. "She refused, so I tortured her. She refused to speak about the soul splitters. She refused to speak, and she refused to die. When Li Qing died, she disappeared. I spent a year searching for her, to no avail. But no one can stop me. When I find her, I'm going to let her know what eternal pain feels like!"

The evening wind flit through Jiao S' uniform skirt. She looked like a student, but the look in her eyes was cruel, as if she were possessed by a demon. And yet, she didn't look scary to me at all.

She had only thought of Li Qing as a friend, and for her, she hated someone else to this extent.

Suddenly, I felt such admiration for the Jiao S in front of my eyes.

Chapter 44

Volume 1

44 Nie Zun's Analysis

Nie Zun cut in suddenly, "But why would Li Wen appear here today?"

Jiao S gave me a suspicious look. "Are you sure you saw her?"

I nodded. "I'm positive. It was Li Wen. You know how Li Wen has this different aura. The way she carries herself—I couldn't have been mistaken."

Jiao S clenched her teeth, a dark force filling her eyes. "I didn't expect that she would show up. Looks like all of this isn't just a coincidence."

I couldn't help but wonder what awaited us. The events that had happened so far didn't exactly look to be related, and yet there also seemed to be some kind of underlying link between them. Could all of this have been a warning for a catastrophe to come?

Nie Zun suddenly asked, "By the way, where did Guan Nie disappear to?"

Jiao S shook her head. "Don't bother asking me. His movements are unpredictable. Don't worry about him. Although I can't guarantee he'll be of any help to us, I am certain that he's not a bad guy. When the time's right, I suppose he'll make his appearance all on his own."

I nodded.

The night wind suddenly attacked, the chilling cold seeping into my skin. For some reason, whenever a cold wind came like this in the dark,

nighttime forest, I would subconsciously look around me.

My probing gaze must have caught Jiao S' attention, for she also turned her neck slightly. The three of us were quiet. When I didn't notice any movement in the grass or air, I relaxed a bit.

"Li Shen, since we've spoken to this point, do you remember that I said I'd share a secret with you if we ended up working together?" Jiao S asked seriously.

Startled, I thought back to the Jiao S' words when I first headed to the Eastern District. I nodded.

"I think it's time to tell you now. The secret—" Before Jiao S could finish speaking, behind her, a dark shadow fled.

When I looked closer, I realized that the shadow belonged to Laurel! Laurel had undergone great changes. She was on all four limbs. Her gaze was murderous, like a cheetah waiting to pounce on its prey.

"Be careful!" I blurted out. Jiao S' gaze tightened, and then the air behind her crackled, turning to blades, flying backwards.

Laurel easily dodged the attack, her chopped up blond hair catching the light's reflection. On all fours, she leapt at Jiao S, trying to grab her back, as if her hands had claws.

Jiao S felt an incoming pressure, so she turned to the right and avoided Laurel. After dodging her attack, she turned again, when suddenly, she stared ahead.

As she moved, the air to her right fiercely vibrated and turned into a large vortex. The wind blew her hair high up, exposing her dark eyes. She stuck her arm into the vortex and pulled out the same sword she once attacked me with.

Jiao S quickly turned back and raised her sword. With a thunderous airflow, she aimed at Laurel's head, without any hesitation.

I quickly grabbed my bow and shot an arrow. *Whoosh!* The arrow struck Laurel's shoulder, pushing her to the side slightly, avoiding Jiao S' sword. Laurel fell to the ground in pain. I took a step forward, and before Jiao S could make another move, I pulled out Piercer and grabbed hold of her.

I tightened my grip slightly. "Don't move. Surely, you still remember what kind of pain Piercer brings!"

Seeing how set I was on not taking her life, Jiao S simply looked me over, without a word.

Laurel wanted to fight, but she also knew how powerful Piercer was, so she stopped. Her large eyes looked around, as if trying to find an escape route.

"Laurel, don't you recognize me? I'm Ah Shen *jiejie*. How did you become this way?" I still held my weapon tightly, but my heart softened.

Laurel stared at me. In a clear voice, she said, "Ah Shen *jiejie*, I haven't forgotten you, but what I'm doing right now is right. You've been wrong all this time. This is the life I want now."

Suddenly, she laughed tenderly. "And anyway, why are you getting angry at me, Ah Shen *jiejie*? Nie Zun *gege*'s the one who told me to do this. Didn't he tell you?"

As she glanced over at Nie Zun, Laurel's once innocent face suddenly looked so cunning.

I shook my head. "That can't be. Nie Zun would never do something like that." Though I said that, I could already feel that Jiao S had turned her suspicious gaze to the indifferent Nie Zun at our side. Her grip tightened on her sword.

I frowned.

Laurel fluttered her pretty lashes. "Ah Shen *jiejie*, you should give You Ji *jiejie* a call. Then you'll understand everything."

Nie Zun suddenly spoke up, "No. You cannot speak with You Ji right now."

Suspicion filled my face. Why would Nie Zun say that?

Laurel chuckled, and her laughter was crisp and melodious, as it had always been. “Nie Zun *gege*, you shouldn’t keep it a secret from Ah Shen *jiejie*. A big incident happened in the Western District, but you still want to pretend to be a good person?”

My eyes immediately widened, and I turned to Nie Zun. His expression was dark.

Taking advantage of my lowered guard, Laurel escaped from my whip and tried to get away. With swift eyes and arms, Jiao S raised her sword again.

But then, Nie Zun’s eyes tightened, and a ray of light shot forth from his eyes! Jiao S’ sword had yet to strike Laurel, when Nie Zun’s light ray grabbed hold of it. Laurel took this opportunity to slip away, and she disappeared into the dark night.

Jiao S turned to Nie Zun, pointing her sword at him. “What are you trying to do?”

Nie Zun’s reply came evenly. “I don’t mean anything, but I can only prove my innocence with her gone.”

“I left a chemical marker on her. Jie Pa made it, and he’ll be able to track her wherever she is.”

“But how exactly are you going to explain her accusations towards you?” Jiao S asked aggressively.

I didn’t say anything, but I was silently worrying about what could have happened in the Western District.

Nie Zun smiled glibly. “We’ve had this talk (about our problems) many times before. If we’re going to suspect each other, neither of us are any better than the other. Jiao S, you’re aware that a man previously died in the Western District after jumping off a building. We found that strange insects had eaten away his back, and the scent of those insects were found on your

A-rank official, Mu Li. Moreover, when we were staying in the Eastern dorms, you took away an assassin who targeted us, but have yet to give us any explanation. Don't you think we have out to have suspicions about you?"

Jiao S suddenly recalled something. "Since you mentioned that, I'm remembering that, when I leave my district, my S Clan will have someone report to me. Though I don't like cellphones, at the least, I can always be reached. But recently, no one has come to find me... But, there are definitely no problems with Mu Li. None of my A-rank officials are bad people. As for what happened, I'll be sure to find out as fast as I can."

I frowned. "That's probably because they can't get into the Southern District, isn't it?"

Jiao S shook her head. "No. The two B-rank officials were able to enter. Moreover..."

As if thinking up another problem, Jiao S quickly turned to Nie Zun. "Just now, that girl said that something's happened in the Western District. Nie Zun, what's happened?"

At that, I also cast a doubtful look at Nie Zun.

Nie Zun eyes turned, and finally, he let out a sigh. He said to me, "Earlier, when you were passed out, You Ji gave me a call. She said that there have been some attacks on the resident floor managers. Seven of the 27 have died. It's just like what we encountered here. They didn't die via their split symbol, but instead, because their physical constitutions were altered."

"Why are you only telling me about this now?!" I shouted at him.

"Your injury hasn't fully healed yet. And telling you would have been futile anyway, since you can't go back right now. It's clear that the enemy is spread all over the districts. Jie Pa also said that, aside from Song Lu, there was another with a similar constitution. If that was truly Li Wen that you saw earlier, then I'm afraid she can't be rid of suspicion. Since she's in the Southern District right now, that means the Western District should

currently be safe for the time being. And You Ji is there. Telling you would just cause you needless worry.”

While I had to admit that Nie Zun’s words were true, I couldn’t help feeling worried and distressed.

But even if I had known ahead of time, what of it? With my current abilities, would I have been able to protect everyone? I can’t even protect myself.

For the first time, Nie Zun had a lot of things to say, and he didn’t have his signature carefree expression. Seriously, he turned to face Jiao S and said, “I admit that I never really trusted you before. But it looks like, now, there’s something I can trust. Although the perpetrator is unknown, the things that have happened the past few days are connected. Since today, there’s only you, me, and Li Shen, how about you let me share my observations.”

Jiao S looked at Nie Zun, and then finally nodded. “Okay. I’ll trust you for now. Li Shen said that the two of you must remain 500 meters from each other. I trust Li Shen, so let’s try not to suspect each other.”

Jiao S’ words made me feel very honored.

Nie Zun lifted a hand and adjusted his jacket collar. The evening wind blew at his short, black hair, exposing his shining eyes.

His lips slowly opened. “To sum things up, before we came here, there were four strange deaths in the Western District. Among them were Laurel’s substitute, the female owner of a weapon shop, Ah Wen, and the boy who killed her. Additionally, there was the man who fell from the school building. Ordinarily, because the man and the substitute had died via their split symbols, there should be an additional two dead. Of course, no one saw these two people, so we can’t confirm whether or not they were Western residents.”

After a pause, he continued, “Among the four people, the boy was once a friendly kid in the Western District. But when he attacked Ah Wen, he’d acted like Laurel did today. His mannerisms and actions were unusual. I

suspect that he must have gone through some kind of experiment to change his temperament. As for the man covered in bugs, I'd originally thought that someone had killed him for their own personal gains and fun. But after these recent events, I had a discussion with Jie Pa. We think the man may have been an experiment as well, but because the experiment failed, he was disposed of."

An apprehensive feeling overcame me. When had he investigated all these things so thoroughly with Jie Pa? Why hadn't anyone asked me about it?

Chapter 45

Split Zone 13

45 Target of Criticisms

Nie Zun seemed to have gleaned my inner thoughts, but he simply glanced over me . He continued with his analysis, “I know that Jie Pa has been carrying on his own investigation . Jiao S, you should know that Jie Pa’s intel has always reached far and is trustworthy . At the time, we didn’t know there were such experiments going on, or that the insects on the dead man’s body were a failed experiment . That’s why Jie Pa’s investigation hadn’t yielded any results, that is, until we came to the Southern District, where everything seems to have become clear . Now I have a question for you . How exactly did the five B-rank members of your clan die?”

A deep pain flashed across Jiao S’ eyes . It disappeared quickly, but I know I saw it .

“The first four died at the same time that you first came to see me . And the fifth, you were witness to his death yourselves . The deaths of the first four were all the same . Their bodies were chopped to pieces and arranged into the word ‘death’ . ”

When I recalled that someone had died just upon my arrival to the Eastern District, I felt my mouth twitch . Since she suddenly brought that up, Jiao S didn’t mean to point her sword at me and ask for recompense now, right?

Nie Zun nodded . “If I’m not recalling wrong, you’d sent three people to find Gao Qin Jiu Ye, but they were unsuccessful . Then, one of them died the day we checked into the Eastern dorms . Correct?”

Jiao S nodded solemnly .

Nie Zun narrowed his eyes a bit . “On that subject, I have to bring up a few things . I hope that, in the future, both of you commanders will listen well .”

After seeing Nie Zun’s expression, I exchanged a glance with Jiao S . Then both of us waited for his next words .

His carefree nature seemed to have made a partial return . “Among the people we’ve met so far, there are a few we must be vigilant towards . You cannot forget this .”

A radiance suddenly flashed in his eyes . “First, there’s Gao Qin Jiu Ye . Jiao S, although the two of you seem to use a very similar, if not the same, air control technique, I don’t plan on investigating that further . That said, I’m sure you know that Gao Qin Jiu Ye isn’t someone benevolent . The black sword at his waist is a weapon I’ve never seen before in the Split Zone . And though I’ve never seen him use it, I would wager it’s not to be treated as a plaything . The way Gao Qin Jiu Ye manipulates his mental force, in addition to his persuasion ability, means that he won’t have any troubles in any situation or battle . A person like that is someone we cannot not fear .”

Jiao S looked around .

Nie Zun’s lips curved into a smile . “Then, there’s the illusionist, Huan Qing . He clearly gets along with the people of the Southern District . From what you’ve said, he guards the border forest between the Southern and Eastern Districts . But for that girl, Mi Fu, he left the forest . Why would that be? And if his illusions were truly perfect, how could there be so many strange creatures in the Southern District now? He holds secrets that we don’t know about . As for the girl, Mi Fu, I’ve never heard that the Southern District had a goddess or anything like that .”

I found myself getting a bit lost . I’ve never known Nie Zun to take anything seriously, let alone analyze anything so seriously . He passed his days in the Split Zone by chasing after me as I ran, lazing about in the day, and occasionally having a drink with Jie Pa . I’d never seen him take anything to heart or mind like this before . So, I listened intently .

Nie Zun suddenly yawned . “Actually, a lot of things seem to be pointing towards the as of yet unseen spirit snatcher, Rong Jin . But instead of suspecting someone I’ve never seen, I prefer to look at those around me .

“Last, there’s Guan Nie, whom you brought along . When you had us meet on the 30th floor to talk, you weren’t guarding against the blond man, but rather Guan Nie, right? From what I’ve seen, Guan Nie’s sorcery wouldn’t lose out to Huan Qing’s . But the question is, why would you fear him? You said that Guan Nie is trustworthy, aside from his dispute with Gao Qin Jiu Ye . And I believe that . But have you considered, if the two settle their differences, then the problem lies with Gao Qin Jiu Ye . How will you deal with that? You keep Guan Nie under your service because of his animosity with Gao Qin Jiu Ye . From what I’ve seen, his hate for Gao Qin Jiu Ye stems from past feelings . If they resolve their problems, what will you do?”

I felt my heart chill . Although I’ve long noticed the messy relationships between everone, I’ve never analyzed them or laid out their pros and cons . Nie Zun... I couldn’t help lifting my head and looking over at his easygoing expression .

Nie Zun, have I been mistaken in thinking I understood you?

Then I turned back to Jiao S . She rarely had such an uncertain expression . The light flickered in her eyes as she looked at Nie Zun and asked, “Why are you saying all these things to me?”

Nie Zun gave an honorable smile, like an immortal who was above eating mortals’ food . “It’s nothing, just a certain feeling I had . You’re rather quite dependable, compared to the two of them .

“I’m bringing this up today because I want to make sure you’re thinking over things carefully . You have to be careful with these people . The reason you kept those three protectors, who pledged themselves to you, was because you didn’t trust others, wasn’t it? I hope that you’ll think this over clearly . Li Shen and you are in the same positions now, and only if you two work together, without any suspicions for each other, will we be able to change the tide . And you know about the people in the Southern District .

You can't trust even the best of them . Just like your feelings for Si Luo—if you cannot restrain them, you're very likely to fall into a trap . ”

Jiao S was quiet awhile . Suddenly, she sighed and said, “You're indeed Nie Zun . ”

Her eyes went back and forth between me and Nie Zun . Finally, she looked into my eyes and said, “Li Shen, you're truly very fortunate . There are always so many people around you, willing to protect you . ”

I glanced over at Nie Zun, and then I lowered my eyes .

A lot of people were willing to protect me? I laughed bitterly inside . Was that the reason I didn't want to leave the Split Zone? Because I was afraid of returning to the real world, where there would be no one to watch over me?

Nie Zun looked at me, and a gentleness seemed to pass over his eyes . Or maybe I was seeing things .

Then, he stuffed his hands back into his pockets and said, “In any case, I hope you two will trust each other wholly . There have been incidents in both the Western and Eastern Districts now, but feeling anxious won't solve any of our problems . Let's first investigate here more . It's night, so we'll rest first . I trust that Gao Qin Jiu Ye and Jie Pa will resolve things on their end well . When morning comes, we can go after Laurel . ”

Jiao S nodded . There was a sparkle in her eyes, and then vortexes appeared beside her again . She raised her arm and returned her sword inside .

She waved to me and then turned to go . “Let's get some rest then . I'm sure they're already forming suspicions since we've talked for so long . ”

After Jiao S walked away, I looked over at Nie Zun .

“Nie Zun, how many secrets have you hidden from me?

Nie Zun laughed . “Regardless of how many secrets I have, haven't I always protected you? What are you afraid of?”

I was a bit taken aback . I'd never heard such words from him before .

He turned, about to return in the same direction of Jiao S . But before he walked away, he turned back to me . In the darkness, a strange, unfathomable warmth enveloped his face . “Let's head back . ”

He turned, about to return in the same direction of Jiao S . But before he walked away, he turned back to me . In the darkness, a strange, unfathomable warmth enveloped his face . “Let's head back . ”

I bit my lower lip, and then hurried to catch up .

—

When Nie Zun and I returned to the school, I saw Gao Qin Jiu Ye confronting Huan Qing .

“This is how you've protected the Southern District?” Gao Qin Jiu Ye asked Huan Qing, pointing to the broken glass shards and the blood stains that remained after their clean-up .

Huan Qing's threatening face didn't seem to carry any excessive emotions . “My job is simply to protect Mi Fu and guard the South-East border forest . ”

“Mi Fu? Ha, then you'd best protect her well . I won't argue with you about all the garbage that's made its way into the Southern District . But Huan Qing, if anything happens to her, even as the number one illusionist, your road will have reached its end . ” Gao Qin Jiu Ye was as arrogant and callous as ever .

Huan Qing's amber eyes sparked with a cold light . “Gao Qin Jiu Ye, don't be so arrogant . There's really no reason for you to treat me in such a hostile manner . I'm not Rong Jin, after all . I have no desire to fight over the commander's position with you . ”

Huh? What and what now? Gao Qin Jiu Ye, your enemy really isn't an ordinary person . I savored the moment . But quickly, my face darkened,

because after seeing us, this pair didn't seem to acknowledge my or Nie Zun's presence at all .

I stepped forward . Only when I was nearly at his side did Gao Qin Jiu Ye spare me a glance . As for Huan Qing, he didn't look at me, but he was glaring at Nie Zun .

Nie Zun's lips curved . “We meet again . ”

“I trust you've been well and have had good fortune since we last met . Lady Mi Fu still doesn't dare to walk around freely . ” A dark ruthlessness crossed his eyes .

“A lot of people will be happy with her off the streets, unable to harm anyone else . ” Nie Zun squinted as he smiled . Then he raised an arm to cover his yawn . “And besides, she's your goddess, not mine . ”

“I trust you've been well and have had good fortune since we last met . Lady Mi Fu still doesn't dare to walk around freely . ” A dark ruthlessness crossed his eyes .

“A lot of people will be happy with her off the streets, unable to harm anyone else . ” Nie Zun squinted as he smiled . Then he raised an arm to cover his yawn . “And besides, she's your goddess, not mine . ”

After yawning, he suddenly grabbed onto my shoulders, his actions fast as lightning . I flinched . I turned to look at him, but he seemed to be looking at Huan Qing and Gao Qin Jiu Ye .

An unignorable smile appeared on his face . “My goddess is right here . ”

For some reason, my face started to burn a bit . Nie Zun was an apathetic person, though occasionally seemed rather wanton ;it was something I'd long grown used to . He had a double sided personality, like me . But I'd never seen him so nefarious as today .

Gao Qin Jiu Ye's eyes darted between Nie Zun and me, an inscrutable expression on his face .

I lightly shoved Nie Zun off .

A carefreeness filled his eyes . “Top illusionist of the Southern District, I trust that you’ll be able to take care of the aftermath here . How about you let us borrow Gao Qin Jiu Ye for a few days? We have some things to look into . ”

The meaning behind his words was: You, Huan Qing, should do well and protect your goddess and the Southern District, and stay out of our affairs .

Huan Qing stood tall, looking like a storybook hero . With a cold expression, he said, “Don’t worry . Since we’ve already agreed not to interfere with each other, I won’t go back on my word . Investigate as you please . So long as you stay away from Lady Mi Fu, I will ask no questions of you . ”

“Well, you ought to ask some questions . At the least, with something like what happened today, we both have a tad bit of responsibility . ” Gao Qin Jiu Ye really didn’t seem to be friends with anyone .

Huan Qing glanced at him and replied, “Not an easy feat, the word responsibility coming out of your mouth . Investigate your matters as you’d like . I’ll finish taking care of things here . ”

Then he laughed . “We can’t compete after all . Si Luo’s favorite has always been you . ”

Chapter 46

Split Zone 13

46 A Different Poisonous Insect

After Huan Qing left, I asked Gao Qin Jiu Ye to join us to the laboratory to find Jie Pa and Song Lu . When we entered the lab, Jiao S was also present .

“I placed the chemical agent that you gave me on Laurel . So, can you locate her now?” Nie Zun asked as he walked in .

Jiao Pa’s expression was stiff . He said, “We’ll get to that later . I’ve discovered something else . ”

“What is it?”

Jia Pa exhaled and replied, “I’ve examined all the corpses, and as I suspected, the perpetrator today was likely a failed experiment . But I also discovered that Song Lu’s blood carries another kind of poison . ”

“What does it do?” I asked curiously .

With a grave expression, Jia Pa said, “The flow of her blood seems to be able to stimulate her split symbol, which is how she heals so quickly . Although her abilities aren’t as strong as someone who’s physically inserted their splitting key into their symbol, like Nie Zun or myself, they’re certainly not weak . As you’re all aware, using your split symbol may stabilize your mental force, but it comes at a cost . So with this type of blood inside her, there must be some kind of side effect . I just have no way of discerning what that side effect may be . ”

He paused and then continued, “I also suspect that Ms Song Lu isn’t a finished product . If she’s also a failed experiment, then there must be a corresponding price to pay . I’m not certain of it, but I’m very worried . ”

I felt my chest immediately tighten . Jie Pa was very rational and cautious . If he said he was very worried, then I could only imagine the worst .

Song Lu stepped forward . She looked exhausted . Her eyes were sunken, and her expression looked distant . She grabbed my hand and said, “It’s fine . There aren’t any major problems right now, so don’t worry . ”

Her gaze dimmed . “I don’t know whether Yu Liang is dead or alive . If he’s still alive, I don’t know what kind of pain he must be suffering . Aside from him, there’s nothing that could worry me . ”

For as long as I knew her, although Song Lu simply appeared like a sexy, warm woman, I knew that she was very strong . A lot of the women in the Western District were very strong . Whether it was Li Qing, You Ji, or Song Lu, they were all stronger than me .

I felt disgusted with myself . But looking at how haggard Song Lu was now, I knew that being upset or sad was pointless .

Living in a place like this, it was best not to get too emotional . Because what were emotions and good feelings worth in the end? What we had to consider, first and foremost, constantly, was how to continue living on .

So I grabbed her hands in mine . “Don’t worry . Jie Pa’s already found some clues . We’ll be able to find Laurel soon, and we’ll definitely find Yu Liang and bring him back to you . ”

I knew that I wasn’t exactly a competent commander, but I will work hard . I will work hard to protect the people of the Western District who have always been by my side .

I looked at Song Lu firmly, and I saw a glimmer of hope start to appear in her eyes . I wanted to embrace her, to try to get closer and comfort her . She

reached out, to reciprocate, but just as she was about to hug me, she suddenly frowned .

“What is it?” I asked anxiously . I watched her face twist with confusion, as if she were feeling uncomfortable .

She shook her head, to show that she was okay, but then she suddenly covered her mouth with her hand, as if she had to vomit . She bent over, her long curly hair falling, both hands now covering her mouth to suppress her nausea . I reached out to pat her back, but seeing her hair covering her face, I decided to move it out of the way .

Jie Pa asked with concern from the side, “Are you having any adverse reactions?”

Song Lu was still bent over, two hands covering her mouth . Her body trembled, but she didn’t speak . I gently moved her hair to her back, holding it with one hand, about to help her up with my other hand .

I looked at her face .

She bent over more, falling to the ground, her hands tightly held to her face . I sensed something was amiss . While I held her hair with one hand, I motioned for Jie Pa with the other, asking him to come help . He hurried over, wanting to help Song Lu up . But she didn’t want to stand up, bending over even more .

Finally, I saw her back trembling greatly as she pressed her hands to her mouth . I grabbed a hair band from my right wrist and tied her hair, and then I crouched down to look at her . I looked up at her face, and Jie Pa stood at her side, patting her back .

But when I saw her face, I froze . Song Lu’s face had turned completely red and her eyes were opened wide . Her hands were pressed tightly to her mouth, almost like she were trying to stop a demon from pushing its way out . Her hands had turned white and her eyes were bloodshot .

“Y-you... Song Lu jie, what’s wrong?” I asked .

Song Lu didn't look at me . With wide eyes, she stared down at the floor . The knuckles on her fingers creaked from the pressure she exerted .

Hearing my words, Jie Pa immediately crouched down on the other side of Song Lu . He looked carefully at Song Lu's face . Suddenly, he stared at her fingers, as if he'd seen something between them .

“What's wrong with her?” I looked at Jie Pa anxiously .

Jie Pa's eyes were still on Song Lu, but I saw his lips tremble slightly . He opened his mouth, and then he finally said, “M-Ms Ah Shen, everyone needs to step back!” As he said that, he'd already leapt back a distance .

I was still mulling over his words when Nie Zun grabbed my dress from the neck . He pulled us back and away from Song Lu .

On the other side, Jiao S and Gao Qin Jiu Ye didn't quite understand why, but seeing all of us move away, they followed suit and distanced themselves from Song Lu .

As Nie Zun pulled me back, my eyes remained on Song Lu . I started to shake my head, unable to believe what I was seeing .

Song Lu's hands loosened around her mouth, like she'd already used up her strength . She was still bent over, but I couldn't see her face clearly at this distance . All I could see was her hanging hair .

Song Lu's hands loosened around her mouth, like she'd already used up her strength . She was still bent over, but I couldn't see her face clearly at this distance . All I could see was her hanging hair .

And then, something started spilling from her mouth to the floor .

Pitter-patter . Pitter-patter .

One after another, creatures as hard as beetles gushed forth from her mouth, falling to the floor, wave after wave . These weren't the same as the black, poisonous bugs with pincers that had previously fused with her body . They were something else entirely, something else I've never seen before .

They were about the size of a fist, red-violet in color, and shimmering with light . They were shaped like a semi-circle with feet underneath, slowly rising from the ground .

Song Lu grabbed her stomach with both hands, looking in pain, as these large creatures climbed out from her . Her once gentle, beautiful, and sexy eyes now looked sinister . She whimpered .

At first, I was stunned by what I was seeing, but I quickly recovered and tried to get away from Nie Zun's hold, to help Song Lu .

“No! Let go of me!” When I tried to pull away, Nie Zun suddenly wrapped both his arms around me, holding me still . He slipped his two arms under my own and held me at the waist, his gloved hands clasped together, unwilling to let me move forward .

Anxiously and angrily, I turned back, yelling, “Let go of me! Song Lu...! She...! Just let go of me!”

Nie Zun was silent .

Jie Pa stared at the red-violet beetles on the ground, crawling slowly, and he raised a hand to signal us to stop . “Calm down . I don't know what kind of pain you'll feel if these bugs get onto your bodies . Please keep a distance from Ms Song Lu!”

“You must be kidding me! Jie Pa! How can I just watch idly by as Song Lu's in such pain?!” I shouted out, and I felt Nie Zun's hold on me tighten .

Jie Pa's initial fright from the bugs seemed to have resided, replaced by his ever-calm demeanor . He spoke solemnly, “Ms Ah Shen, don't act rashly . I'll do my best to help Ms Song Lu . Don't worry . ”

Jie Pa's initial fright from the bugs seemed to have resided, replaced by his ever-calm demeanor . He spoke solemnly, “Ms Ah Shen, don't act rashly . I'll do my best to help Ms Song Lu . Don't worry . ”

Then he turned to Jiao S and Gao Qin Jiu Ye . “Can you two freeze things with your control of air?”

Gao Qin Jiu Ye also seemed a bit taken aback by the turn of events, but he nodded . “Yes, but when I freeze things, they will shatter . ”

Jiao S looked at Gao Qin Jiu Ye with a complicated expression . Then she said, “Mine as well . ”

Jie Pa considered things for a moment, and then he said, “Then, destroy those bugs now . Just leave one behind . ”

Although Jie Pa was currently commanding two people who weren’t exactly known for their benevolence, Jiao S and Gao Qin Jiu Ye weren’t the type to fuss over such a small matter . So, the two of them activated their mental force .

Crackle, crackle...

The red-violet beetles were whipped up into their vortexes, frozen, and shattered . Soon, they disappeared from sight .

Jie Pa quickly captured the last beetle escaping Song Lu’s mouth into a glass jar he’d taken from the laboratory . Then he tied a strange knot and said, “Trap!” The jar closed and tightened, until finally the struggling beetle inside slowly stopped moving .

Song Lu had stopped vomitting . I undid Nie Zun’s arms around me and ran over to her .

Song Lu looked like she’d aged several years . Her expression was haggard and depressed, and then she passed out . There were dark, greenish marks around her eyes . I clenched my teeth, trying to hold back my tears .

I held her, and with a touch of mental force, I picked her up . “I’ll send her back to rest . ”

Chapter 47

Split Zone 13

47 If She's a Demon

With Jie Pa's permission, I carried Song Lu back to her room and laid her on the bed .

Jiao S had followed along, and she said, "Her face gained such rough wrinkles . I'm afraid those things must have taken a great toll on her . "

I remained silent, as grief rushed through me, submerging me in sorrow and guilt .

Once you arrive in the Split Zone, your appearance doesn't change unless you use your mental force to change it . Or unless your spirit has suffered great distress, which could possibly cause your form in the Split Zone to become unstable and appear to age .

"Right now, we can't bring Song Lu along to find Laurel . We don't know what kind of other changes may occur, so Jie Pa has to stay with her . But Jie Pa's body has also become as vulnerable as a physical human body, so he shouldn't be in danger's path . That means that one of us has to remain behind to guard them . " I looked at Gao Qin Jiu Ye, Jiao S, and then Nie Zun .

"Even if we can find Laurel, without Jie Pa, we may not be able to deal with her entirely," Jiao S said .

"But there's too much risk in bringing him along . I can't do it," I said, my eyes drooping .

“It’s okay . After Jie Pa activated his split symbol and studied enchantments, even if he hasn’t perfected his skills, it should be sufficient to protect himself . But the best option would be if Guan Nie stayed behind to protect them . As for Laurel, the four of us should go,” Nie Zun proposed .

I sighed . “But even Jiao S doesn’t know where Guan Nie’s gone off to . How will we find him?”

Gao Qin Jiu Ye’s eyes sparkled . “I can find him . Tell me when we’re going, and I’ll have him back before then . ”

Jiao S scoffed, “Indeed, you are Gao Qin Jiu Ye . After so long, you’re still that confident about Guan Nie?”

He didn’t reply .

—

He was able to accomplish what he promised though . We rested for a few hours in the night, and after we greeted Jie Pa in the morning, Guan Nie returned .

He still carried that feminine aura, and hung around as he liked . When he returned, he didn’t say a word to Gao Qin Jiu Ye . Instead, he simply stood at the side and played with his floor-length white hair .

Jie Pa touched some kind of medicine under my nose . “After applying this, your sense of smell will be heightened for the day . This will allow you to easily smell the scent I had Nie Zun leave on Laurel’s body . Take a smell . ”

I took a whiff, but I didn’t smell anything .

“Turn to another direction and smell again,” Jie Pa said .

So, I turned and took another whiff . Still nothing . Then I turned to the window and took a whiff . Ah, suddenly, a light fragrance drifted into my nose .

“I smell it . Smells nice . This way . ” I pointed out the window .

Jie Pa nodded . “So, you can just follow Ms Ah Shen’s nose . You’ll have to be directly facing Laurel to smell the scent, but you should be able to find her this way . ”

Huh? So, you mean to say that I’m going to be like a dog this whole trip, sniffing every which way?

My face twitched . Why did I have to let Jie Pa apply the medicine on my nose?

“Ah Nie, I’ll leave Jie Pa and Song Lu in your care . ” Nie Zun smiled saliciously at Guan Nie . It seemed that way to me anyway .

Guan Nie’s eyes shined, like a lamb who’d seen a wolf—ah, no, a wolf who’d seen a lamb . “How could I not put all my effort into it when my pet asks me to . ” And then he glanced at Gao Qin Jiu Ye ambiguously .

“Ms Ah Shen, don’t worry about us . I don’t know if you’re headed to another testing site, but I won’t need to worry either, with all four of you going together . I’ll stay here with Ms Song Lu so that I can examine her when she wakes up . And I can also analyze the insect that came out from her . If you make any discoveries, Nie Zun can call me at any time,” Jie Pa said calmly and clearly .

“Ms Ah Shen, don’t worry about us . I don’t know if you’re headed to another testing site, but I won’t need to worry either, with all four of you going together . I’ll stay here with Ms Song Lu so that I can examine her when she wakes up . And I can also analyze the insect that came out from her . If you make any discoveries, Nie Zun can call me at any time,” Jie Pa said calmly and clearly .

I nodded . “Okay, then we’ll head off . ”

Before we left though, I couldn’t help turning back . “Jie Pa, will Song Lu...” I bit my lip .

Jie Pa's calm eyes looked around . He said to me, "Ms Ah Shen, don't worry . I'll protect her . "

After the four of us left the school, the other three were clearly waiting for me to sniff out and point us in the right direction . A bit embarrassed, I turned around and started sniffing .

Jiao S' eyes wandered, and it was obvious she was trying to keep from laughing . And even with his cold exterior, a teasing smirk sat on Gao Qin Jiu Ye's lips .

Well, fine . I finally got a trace on the scent, but why was it coming from the direction of the South-East border forest?

I showed the way, and then all of us headed to the forest as quickly as we could .

As I ran, my red hair danced in the wind . I turned to the side and looked at Gao Qin Jiu Ye . His cold and arrogant expression paired with his bright sports outfit made him look both sunny and icy, creating a sort of contradicting beauty .

Jiao S' dark bangs paired with her schoolgirl uniform made her look like a student in a race, minus her lifeless expression .

When I thought of races, my mind drifted back to the year I first met Gao Qi . My eyes grew heavy and I glanced at Gao Qi Jiu Ye again .

He seemed to notice my eyes on him, as a sneer appeared on his lips and he cast a mysterious look my way . I felt my heart jump, and I subconsciously looked away .

And then my eyes happened to meet Nie Zun's .

With his black, high-collared windbreaker, his ink-black medium-length hair, and those dark eyes that no one could ever understand, even in the middle of the day, he looked like a silent reaper come for you in the dark of night .

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Nie Zun was often quiet . Although he occasionally seemed indifferent or dissolute, he was mostly just quiet .

Just like when I first met him when we arrived in the Split Zone . Back then, he hadn't spoken a word . He'd seemed like a person alone and abandoned by the world, but his eyes never looked like they were praying or asking for anything .

At the time, I always felt like Nie Zun was someone just living in his own world . But when I thought of it later, I found the thought a bit laughable . After all, wasn't I also someone just living in my own world?

I've always remembered the Nie Zun from back then .

When we first met, he wore a high-collared black shirt, and he didn't speak a word . And at the time, I'd hated him . I detested him .

Even when the blond man brought us to meet Li Qing, Nie Zun hadn't said a single thing .

I asked him back then, "Since that demonic identity of mine lives within you, if I told you I wanted her dead, would you help me?"

Nie Zun had simply looked at me, his dark as ink eyes roaming around .

The first time Nie Zun spoke was at the end of that first month . He and I had to remain together every day, and when I wasn't not looking at him, I only gave cold stares .

Until that one day, that is . I still remembered the incomparably dark night sky . For some reason, the light reflecting from his eyes made them look like stars . With his shining eyes, he said to me, "Li Shen, I really hope that your demonic identity stays with me forever . "

I looked over and scoffed . “Demons are truly demons . It’s not unusual that you’d like her, since you’re both the same . Devils without a heart . ”

Nie Zun hadn’t seemed affected by my pointed words though . He just replied, “If there’s someone who’ll stay with me forever, even if she’s a demon, that’d be okay . You say she’s a demon, but she’s also a part of you . If she remains with me, you’ll also remain with me forever . ”

I swear, I’ll never forget that day . I’ll never forget the words Nie Zun said then . His eyes were so deep, you’d find yourself unable to get away, and yet there was a loneliness that you were completely willing to give yourself to .

I admit, from that day forward, my hate for him disappeared . Despite the fact that he’d resonated and merged with the horrifying part of me that had killed Gao Qi, I still found myself unable to hate him from the bottom of my heart .

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“What are you thinking about?” Nie Zun asked, looking over at me . His voice carried that carefree tone that was like a slow poison, gradually making its way to my heart .

“Oh, n-nothing . ” I shook my head and looked forward, focusing on finding the scent on Laurel .

As we approached the South-East border forest, for some reason, the air started to feel strange . It was different from the first time we passed through it . Though we’d been sent into an illusion at the time, there had

also been a sense of safety at arriving in the Southern District . But this time, as the forest came into view, my apprehension increased .

While Jiao S ran, she asked, “Do you guys feel like something’s wrong?”

Gao Qin Jiu Ye frowned . “Ordinarily speaking, aside from Huan Qing and his grand illusions to protect the forest, there are also 13 hunters . So why have there been so many strange occurrences and outsiders recently?”

“Hunters? I’ve never heard of them,” Jiao S inquired curiously .

Gao Qin Jiu Ye shot her a chilly glance, but in an unexpectedly good temper, he explained, “Aside from the grand illusion you all entered, there are also 13 hunters that Si Luo arranged for . If anyone comes into the forest with ill intent towards the Southern District, then these 13 can handle them as they see fit . As for where someone gets taken, I don’t know, but no one’s ever reappeared . That’s why they’re called hunters . ”

Jiao S’ interest was piqued . “Oh? There’s actually something in the Southern District that Gao Qin Jiu Ye doesn’t know about? I thought Si Luo didn’t keep any secrets from you . ”

Gao Qin Jiu Ye smiled . “It’s true he doesn’t hide things from me, but that’s not information I care to know about . ”

Jiao S’ excited face suddenly stiffened .

The air between the two always seemed tense, so I interrupted, “The forest is just up ahead . ” Then I looked at Gao Qin Jiu Ye . “Gao Qin Jiu Ye, what are the stipulations for these hunters you mentioned? If the recent strange events were caused by outsiders, then why haven’t these hunters made a move?”

Gao Qin Jiu Ye’s eyes darkened, as if he’d thought of something . He was silent a moment, and then quietly, he replied, “I don’t know . ”

Before I could ask him any more, I realized that we’d arrived .

Chapter 48

Split Zone 13

48 Final Defense

When we walked into the border forest, it felt like the ground was turning beneath me . I looked up to discover that my three companions had disappeared .

“Shit, is this another illusion?” I muttered as I put my hands on my waist . The bow on my right shoulder swayed slightly with the motion .

Then, I heard Gao Qin Jiu Ye’s chilly voice fall from the sky .

“This is a space shifting illusion that Huan Qing set up as a final defense . It makes you feel like you’re walking on a puzzle piece that’s constantly being moved, but it’s just an illusion . However, it was meant as a final defense, which means something happened to Huan Qing . We can’t escape from the current situation, so each of us should search for traces of Huan Qing where we are .

“Hey, hey, that’s all you have to say? We came to find Laurel, not that illusionist in a white suit!” I shouted angrily towards the sky .

Was he kidding? Find him? Shifting puzzle pieces? Nie Zun always leads the way because I already get lost on land that doesn’t move!

After my shouting, I waited a bit, but no reply ever came .

Huh . I was left speechless as I cursed inwardly .

And then suddenly, I felt my body being dragged to the right . My body wasn't actually moving . It just felt like there was some kind of large magnet pulling me to the side .

As my body shifted involuntarily, I stood still . Then I quickly realized that this meant that Nie Zun was 500 meters away to my right! His body was moving to the right, and because we had to remain 500 meters from each other, I was being forcefully pulled along!

I felt like a crab being picked by some kind of shapeless hand, flying through the air, unable to move my limbs . I really wanted to just turn and run after Nie Zun instead . But then another thought came to mind . Why bother using up my mental force when I could just sleep here and get pulled along?

If you were there, you'd have seen a faceless woman in a red dress flying past you . Faceless, because my hair had been blown over my face by the fast speed .

I rolled my eyes as I was dragged along . Nie Zun seemed to be running, for some reason . I couldn't see anything but trees as I was pulled . I didn't see an end, and of course, I didn't see Nie Zun .

I felt myself moving faster and faster, and then I couldn't help turning and running along, lest I end up running straight into a tree!

“Nie Zun, where the hell are you running to?!” As I was muttering my grievances, I suddenly realized that the scene around me didn't feel quite right .

It looked like two portions of forest were overlapping . The images in front of me were distant, fuzzy, like a mirage . Slowly, my eyes widened .

The forest seemed to be turning! The scene spun, like a bagua trigram array . . . As the forest spun clockwise, everything blurred, and I was pulled forward .

“Is Nie Zun not the one running?! What the hell is happening?!” I shouted as I watched myself being pulled towards the spinning forest that couldn’t possibly be real, while I remained completely unable to stop myself .

“I’m dizzy!” I cried out helplessly, trying to adjust to the situation .

With a face full of misery and grief, I headed into the spinning forest . Then, suddenly, the magnetic-like pull disappeared . My head was filled with conjectures and complaints, so I forgot to pull the brakes with my mental force . Without the force pulling at me, I fell forward to the ground in my red dress .

With a crash, I felt my chin smash into the rock-hard ground of the Split Zone .

I think I broke it .

Lying on the ground, I reached to touch my teeth . It hurt a bit, but this kind of pain was more like an itch than anything else . I waited for my teeth and face to heal . My limbs were a bit sore from the fall, and since I couldn’t be bothered to move, I just lied there, sprawled out .

As my skin was healing, I heard that familiar carefree drawl float down from above, “What are you getting at, kissing the ground in such an ecstatic posture?”

I lifted my head slightly, to see an amused expression on Nie Zun’s face as he looked down at me . I immediately jumped up, somewhat embarrassed .

“Were you running just now?” I asked as I pat the dust of my body .

Nie Zun nodded . “I heard Gao Qin Jiu Ye’s announcement, and I figured that this final defense illusion must be breakable . Ordinarily, each person will be placed into their own illusory space, and these spaces can’t be intruded . Those without a strong will won’t be able to escape them either . So, I decided to make use of the bond between us instead . I kept running in one direction, forcing you to break through your illusory space into mine . ”

I exclaimed, “What if you failed?! What if the two illusions met and then I ended up twisted to shreds?”

Nie Zun pouted and smiled like a little boy . “Well, then you’d be in pieces now . ”

“Wow, wow, wow, you’re truly a demon, Nie Zun,” I remarked casually, no heart to mock him further .

But his expression darkened briefly . Just as I was about to fall for it, his eyes lit up again as he said, “But if I have to become a demon to protect you, I’d gladly do so . ”

Hearing those words in such a magnetic voice, I felt myself stagger .

With an unruly expression and a wanton smile, he said, “I was just kidding . Did you think I was being serious?”

I immediately rolled my eyes in annoyance . “But how was Gao Qin Jiu Ye’s voice coming down from the sky?” I asked .

“It must have something to do with his persuasion ability,” Nie Zun replied casually .

I looked around us . We were still in the border forest, the same place I was at previously . “So, he wanted us to find Huan Qing, but Huan Qing might not be in this illusory space, right?”

Nie Zun also took a look around . “This isn’t exactly an illusory space . Reality’s just been warped somewhat . He must be somewhere . We can’t escape, but if he’s here, we just need to find him . ”

Nie Zun also took a look around . “This isn’t exactly an illusory space . Reality’s just been warped somewhat . He must be somewhere . We can’t escape, but if he’s here, we just need to find him . ”

I frowned . “Where do we look for him?”

Nie Zun considered it for a moment . “See if you can smell which direction Laurel is . ”

I turned and sniffed around us . “Yes, that way . ” I pointed .

“Let’s check that way then and see if we can find another distorted space,” Nie Zun suggested .

After the two of us walked a bit, I discovered a figure lying beneath a nearby tree . “Nie Zun, look . Is there someone lying there?” I pointed towards the tree .

Nie Zun squinted . “Let’s check it out . ”

And so, we quickly walked over to the person at the tree . As we approached, I looked at the person lying on the ground . A bit startled, I asked, “Isn’t that Huan Qing? What happened to him?”

The person lying on the ground was indeed Huan Qing . But his spotless, white suit was now stained and bloodied . His handsome face was covered in scars, and although he looked to be healing, it was happening very slowly . His maroon hair was plastered down with blood, his eyes were tightly closed, and his lips were pressed flat .

Without a word, Nie Zun crouched down to inspect him .

Then, he said, “Turn around . I’ll have to remove his clothes to find his split symbol and verify my suspicions . ”

With a disgruntled expression, I replied, “Do you think he’s worried about that now? He’s passed out . Just do it . ”

But the look in my eyes and the drool at my mouth gave away my true intentions: Hurry and take the clothes off this handsome man!

Nie Zun helplessly rolled his eyes, and then he started searching for Huan Qing’s split symbol . Unexpectedly, he quickly found Huan Qing’s split symbol on his forearm, in what appeared to be a fox tail shape .

Nie Zun helplessly rolled his eyes, and then he started searching for Huan Qing's split symbol . Unexpectedly, he quickly found Huan Qing's split symbol on his forearm, in what appeared to be a fox tail shape .

Nie Zun placed his hand over the split symbol to try to get a read on Huan Qing's mental force .

“What is it?” I asked curiously, but I couldn't help muttering inwardly that of all places, his split symbol was in such an easily discoverable spot .

Nie Zun seemed wary . Then he checked the splitting key that still hung around Huan Qing's neck .

Our splitting keys are hung around our necks with our mental force . Each person's key is only useful to themselves . To others, it's simply a useless piece of metal . Moreover, a person can't take someone else's splitting key, for it's linked to the owner's split symbol; the key will simply return to their owner . We can remove our splitting keys without worry of losing them, for they always reappear around our necks .

After a long examination, Nie Zun finally said, “As I expected . His body no longer holds any mental force . ”

“What? None at all? How can that be?” I asked with surprise .

Nie Zun nodded . “Did you forget? Jiao S mentioned it before . After unlocking your split symbol with your own key, your mental force will disappear for an entire month . In order to create an illusion that can cover the entire border forest, he presumably unlocked his split symbol . At some point though, he must have been attacked and had his key removed . ”

I flinched . “Who could it be? If it's someone from Laurel's side, at least, we can be sure that Li Wen's not there . If she were, then he wouldn't even be alive now . If it's not Li Wen, then maybe they took away his ability to use his mental force because they were unable to take his life another way . ”

A dim light passed over Nie Zun's eyes . “That's not the important part . What's important is that, as far as we know, Huan Qing and the soul snatcher Rong Jin, and also Gao Qin Jiu Ye, are the most powerful people in the Southern District . With Huan Qing, though he may not have a high attack power, his defensive abilities are surely enough to allow him to escape .

“This distorted space is his final defense . That means that, even if he's lost consciousness, his illusion will not be easily undone . It will continue to conceal him . ”

My heart sunk as I took in his meaning .

Nie Zun finished by saying, “So, the most important question is, who in the Split Zone would be able to injure him to this extent, that he would put up his final defense . ”

Chapter 49

Split Zone 13

49 Mysterious Offender

An uneasiness crept over me as Nie Zun spoke .

“Give me one of your arrows,” he told me .

Although I wasn’t sure what he planned to do, I grabbed an arrow from my back and handed it to him . He took the arrow with his gloved left hand, and then he stabbed it into Huan Qing’s arm .

“What are you doing?!” I shouted in alarm . My arrows were coated with a pain amplifier . Most people wouldn’t be able to stand the pain, and Huan Qing was already injured!

Nie Zun didn’t reply, but Huan Qing suddenly woke up in a bout of pain . Nie Zun pulled out the arrow, leaving the blood to start spilling from Huan Qing’s arm . Huan Qing opened his eyes, his amber irises filled with pain .

After tossing aside the arrow, Nie Zun said, “Sorry, I had to get you to wake up, since there are some things I just can’t understand . You were unconscious, but fortunately, the lack of mental force in your body meant that you’d feel this pain . ”

Huan Qing’s eyelashes trembled, likely a side effect of the pain amplifier . I nearly couldn’t bear it as I recalled his once spotless appearance and his proud, honorable demeanor .

Trembling, he glanced over at Nie Zun . His chapped lips opened to say, “It’s fine, fortunate in fact . You have to go get Lady Mi Fu back . You can’t

let them take her away . ”

Nie Zun asked, “Who are they?”

Huan Qing’s eyes shook . “The soul snatcher Rong Jin and a... A very scary woman . ”

A bit incredulous, I asked, “How scary is very scary?”

Huan Qing gasped in pain, and Nie Zun quickly pulled out a small vial of what looked to be hemostatic powder . He poured it over Huan Qing’s arrow wound .

Huan Qing gasped again, and then slowly said, “I’ve never seen her before . She had purple hair, and she wore... She wore a fox fur coat . And she only had one arm . ”

A severed arm? I turned to Huan Qing in surprise . Most wouldn’t choose to only give themselves with one arm . Unless perhaps, she’d only had one arm while she was alive?

“Where did they come from?” Nie Zun asked .

Huan Qing shook his head . “I don’t know, but they came through from the Eastern District . They must be in the Southern District by now . I don’t know why Rong Jin was with her, or why he was in the Eastern District to begin with . ”

“Has Rong Jin made a move yet?” Nie Zun continued his questioning .

Huan Qing laughed . “You two don’t know, do you? No one has ever seen Rong Jin . Anytime he appears before Si Luo, there’s just a shadow on the ground and his voice in the air . But no actual person to be seen . Earlier, it was that same familiar shadow as well . He likely hasn’t made a move . ”

I grew more apprehensive . Shadows?

We didn’t have shadows in the Split Zone . Sometimes a dark haze would appear when the light was weak, but that was because our visual field made

things unclear . Within our sphere of vision though, there wouldn't be shadows at our feet . Because there's no sun in the Split Zone, and the sky is always greyed, and moreover, our bodies are formed by our conscious... Of course there wouldn't be shadows . How could someone have a shadow here?

I looked down at Huan Qing, who still looked to be in great pain, and I could only swallow my doubts .

Huan Qing spoke up, "Logically speaking, Rong Jin wouldn't betray Si Luo, so I don't understand why he would be with that strange woman .

"In any case, please, you must contact Gao Qin Jiu Ye . You can leave me here, but you must tell him that Mi Fu's been taken . Please, you must do that . "

It was the first time I'd seen such a look in the cold and arrogant man's eyes . A kind of desperation . I nodded, agreeing to help .

"Sure, we can do that . Gao Qin Jiu Ye is here now . You just have to undo your final defense . Right now, we can't escape this distorted space, and we don't know which area Gao Qin Jiu Ye is in . " Nie Zun said .

Huan Qing panted, "No . They must be outside this place right now . The final defense is keeping them from entering here . I came in after I was injured . They seem to be searching for something in this border forest . If I undo it now, everyone will be in danger . "

Then he looked at me . "Trust me . You won't be able to beat her . "

He was speaking of the one-armed woman . But his words piqued my curiosity . What kind of woman was she that Huan Qing was so sure that we wouldn't be able to beat her? And what would they be searching for in the forest?

It can't be... Nie Zun and I exchanged glances, both of us suddenly thinking of the same thing . "Laurel!"

They were searching for Laurel! That meant that they hadn't found Laurel after the stone room incident . Laurel was an experiment who'd fled, so she was now being hunted down .

But why had Laurel said that night, that this was what she wanted? If she truly wanted it, why was she running away?

I looked at Huan Qing and respectfully said, "Huan Qing, they seem to be searching for the missing girl from our district . Her name is Laurel . Trust me when I say that I want to save her just as much, if not more, as you want to save Mi Fu . So help us figure out a way to get out of this final defense and find Gao Qin Jiu Ye . It's true that Nie Zun and I aren't enough to fight them, but if we can't find Gao Qin Jiu Ye and Jiao S, then we an even smaller chance for success . "

Huan Qing sighed . His voice was a bit hoarse as he said, "Okay . But I don't have a single ounce of mental force in me right now . I can't use my abilities to help you find them . I can undo the defense system, but once it's undone, there will be nothing protecting this forest anymore . You promise me . If you meet those two first, you must get away and find Gao Qin Jiu Ye . "

Huan Qing sighed . His voice was a bit hoarse as he said, "Okay . But I don't have a single ounce of mental force in me right now . I can't use my abilities to help you find them . I can undo the defense system, but once it's undone, there will be nothing protecting this forest anymore . You promise me . If you meet those two first, you must get away and find Gao Qin Jiu Ye . "

"Okay," I promised .

Then, he closed his eyes and recited a string of words that I didn't understand . As he spoke, a sudden wind flew by . Huan Qing's words grew softer, and then, he fainted again .

Nie Zun examined him and then said to me, "His injuries are very serious . And without any mental force, it's unsafe for him to stay here . From the looks of it, he's undone the final defense . But the border forest is enormous

. If we don't have a way of finding Gao Qin Jiu Ye quickly, then we can't bring him along . ”

Impatiently, I told him, “But we can't just toss him away either . And we can't just sit here and wait to die . We have to find Laurel before they do . ”

Nie Zun lowered his head as he hesitated . It was clear that he didn't have a plan either .

“What are you two doing here? Was the protection lifted?” Jiao S' rough voice suddenly sounded behind me .

It was the feeling of finding a piece of straw that, although couldn't save your life, was still a pleasant surprise . I immediately turned around . But there was only Jiao S .

I hurriedly walked over to her . “Have you seen Gao Qin Jiu Ye?”

“No . ” Jiao S shook her head . Then she looked down at Huan Qing lying on the ground . Her already large eyes widened even more . “What's wrong with him?”

I shook my head . “I'm not even sure how to explain it . But from what he said before he passed out, a one-armed woman crossed the East-South border together with Rong Jin . Huan Qing also said that the woman's abilities are far greater than we can go up against . We suspect that they're here to find their missing experiment, Laurel . They also took away Mi Fu and did this to him . ”

Jiao S' eyes widened still . It was a bit frightening to see actually . “What? They took away Mi Fu?”

Jiao S' eyes widened still . It was a bit frightening to see actually . “What? They took away Mi Fu?”

I was a bit surprised that she was most concerned about that issue, but I simply nodded .

“Where are they? We must stop them!”

Because we were in a precarious situation, I didn't want to overstep and ask too much . As long as we were united in our goals, I didn't care what her motive was . I said, "Huan Qing said it would be best to first find Gao Qin Jiu Ye . Perhaps we'll have a chance of succeeding if all four of us are together . " I paused . "Right now, Huan Qing's mental force has been depleted, but we can't leave him by himself here either . Do you have any ideas?"

Jiao S immediately raised her right hand and a large whirlwind appeared . "We'll put him in here . But this space is currently sealed up by my airflow . If my mental force is depleted, I won't be able to maintain it . If the enemy truly is that strong, we'll have to pray that I'm not beaten . "

Then, with her other arm, she swept Huan Qing inside the whirlwind with a blast of air . Before she closed the vortex, she pulled out her sword .

"They're looking for Laurel . We can't find Gao Qin Jiu Ye right now anyway, so why not search for Laurel? We'll take it one step at a time . If we run into them first, well, what can you do about it," I said .

Jiao S nodded . So, I mobilized my nose and sniffed around for Laurel .

To the right . Sniff . Nothing . To the left . Sniff . Nothing . What was going on?

I frowned . Putting aside the fact that I'd look like a dog, I turned in a circle and started sniffing . But after turning around and around, I felt my heart drop . I looked at Jiao S and Nie Zun with a confused expression . "I can't smell it . "

Nie Zun's pretty brows quickly knit together . "How can that be? I'll call Jie Pa to ask him . " Nie Zun pulled out his phone, but before he could dial, a figure ran over towards us .

It was a very familiar figure . She ran towards us, crying out loud, "Ah Shen, be careful! Don't trust any of them!"

Chapter 50

Split Zone 13

50 An Expected Betrayal

My eyes opened wide, unable to believe who I was seeing before me . It wasn't just anyone who'd come, no . There was that head of green hair and swiftly sweeping serpent's tail .

“Y-You Ji, what are you doing here?” I asked with a fright . I couldn't understand why she would be here right now .

You Ji arrived at my side, looking flustered and panicked . She grabbed me and her green hair swished in the air . An aroma wafted up to my nose .

“Ah Shen, I just got here . Something's happened back in the Western District . Seven of the 27 floor managers are dead!” You Ji was very anxious .

“I know . ” I nodded, unsurprised .

You Ji turned and glared at Nie Zun . Then she turned back to me and said, “It was Nie Zun!”

I immediately shook my head . “That's impossible . You Ji, a lot of things have happened in the Southern District these past few days . I can't explain all of them to you, but trust me, Nie Zun has been with me the whole time . He couldn't have gone back to harm you guys . Someone must have disguised themselves as him . ”

“N-No . Ah Shen, listen to me,” You Ji immediately denied . She pulled me away, putting a distance between us and Nie Zun . “Ah Shen, although I

don't know what's happened to you guys here, I have to ask you this first . Where are Yu Liang and Song Lu?"

Recalling the missing Yu Liang and Song Lu, I replied dejectedly, "Yu Liang is missing . And Song Lu..." With a sigh, I said, "She's probably still unconscious . "

An expression appeared on You Ji's face that seemed to say, "Then I'm right!" She glared at Nie Zun again and then told me, "Ah Shen, you might not know this, but from the investigations that my 7 subordinates have been conducting, it seems that Nie Zun's hands have a special ability . He can shroud another's mental force for a time . That is to say, he can temporarily seize another person's mental force, as long as the abilities that they wielded!"

I was perplexed . I looked over at Nie Zun, who was calmly listening as You Ji spoke, seemingly having no intention of refuting her claims .

You Ji quickly added, "If Yu Liang's gone missing, maybe Nie Zun shrouded his mental force . You know how what he can do . He can project another instance of himself . Though I don't know how Nie Zun was able to turn Yu Liang's invisible projection into something that could be seen, I'm sure he can do it . In other words, we didn't see someone pretending to be Nie Zun, but rather, Nie Zun split himself in two!"

My eyes widened . Though I couldn't really believe it, the image did appear in my head . When Nie Zun took off his gloves and grabbed onto Mi Fu and that other kid, they'd looked incredulous . And just now, if that were the case, could Nie Zun have taken Huan Qing's mental force when he was examining him? Could he have also used Huan Qing's ability to create the illusion of our conversation?

I was frightened by these sudden thoughts . I quickly turned to Nie Zun .

Jiao S was also frowning . Though she hadn't quite understood, with so many people suspecting Nie Zun, she couldn't help but also turn to Nie Zun with suspecting eyes .

Seeing our suspicious looks, Nie Zun suddenly smiled . His smile was somehow even more beautiful than Guan Nie's . With a dim, grey light in his eyes, he said, "You Ji, you came all this way from the Western District just to say that?"

You Ji immediately stepped forward . Eyes locked on Nie Zun, she said, "Stop pretending! Old Fan has gone missing . Four members of my team have suddenly died for no good reason, and the other three have left me . Your projection is in the Western District right now, lying to the floor managers, trying to recruit them, saying that I killed Ah Shen!"

I frowned . "He said that you killed me?"

You Ji nodded . She grabbed my hand, a sad look in her eyes . "Since he dared to say such a thing, I suspected that he might really try to take the opportunity to kill you over here . Although I don't know how he can kill you and still keep his own life, I was still really scared . I quickly hurried over here, but their people pursued me .

"Jie Pa's working together with him . Those people used some kind of medicine on me so that I was unable to fight back . In the end, my last three members disappeared before I got here . I came to tell you that you can't let him succeed . You have to return with me right now, otherwise all those floor managers will be swayed by him!"

My thoughts were flying all over the place . Of course I trusted You Ji . She'd always been my friend, even back when Li Qing was the commander . But Nie Zun... How could it be him?

I turned to Nie Zun when I heard Jiao S laugh . "It's all clear now! Nie Zun knew that if he had you killed by sacrificing another's life, the blond man wouldn't let him off the hook! So he came up with a plan to come find the soul splitter . They would start an experiment to try to kill you, so he could become the Western Commander!"

I listened to her words, but I was watching Nie Zun . He still had that smile on his face . His expression was one of indifference, and he wasn't speaking up for himself at all .

“Ah Shen, I know that it’s hard to believe . But please forgive me for investigating you—I know that you and Nie Zun must always remain 500 meters from each other . It’s because he’s trapped to you that he’s trying to kill you now, so he can escape! Although I don’t know what’s happened here, I’m certain that he’s the one who plotted it all!” You Ji looked at me, an incomparable worry on her face .

I felt my insides chill .

Nie Zun had a light smile on his face and his eyes sparkled . “Well said . ”

I walked up to Nie Zun . Standing in front of him, I looked into his eyes that could suddenly light up on any random day . I sighed inwardly .

Nie Zun, I’m really very upset right now, you know? You must understand me .

You must know how much I hate betrayals and how much I hate exposing lies . But what can I do? In this numbing and inhumane Split Zone, what can I do? Sometimes I would rather not know anything . I would rather be lied to, or feign ignorance, so long as I didn’t have to make a choice . But can I continue this way, so weakly? Even if I don’t face the betrayal, does that mean the betrayer is no longer there beside me?

No, I can’t... No, it doesn’t .

No, I can’t... No, it doesn’t .

I raised my head and looked into Nie Zun’s eyes . They were bright as stars, and I felt my heart sinking into an ocean of sorrow and pain .

Then, mustering up all of my mental force, I quickly grabbed Piercer and slashed at You Ji’s eyes . You Ji hadn’t expected my attack at all, otherwise she would have certainly been able to avoid it . She was known for her speed after all .

Her eyes widened in surprise . That’s why she was hurt even more when Piercer landed its attack . The spines on Piercer’s tail pricked her eyes . She

cried out in agony as blood gushed forth from them .

Ignoring the wide-eyed, startled Jiao S at the side, I turned to Nie Zun . In a cold voice, I said, “Hurry, trap her!”

As if having understood me, simply from the tone of my voice, Nie Zun grabbed a piece of paper from his pocket and stuck it onto You Ji’s face . On the paper was a single word: Sealed .

The paper blocked her face, so I couldn’t see her eyes . But the blood gushing from them had already dripped down to her chin . Bright red, conspicuous, clearly seen . Her body had frozen the moment the paper was pressed to her face, and her tail had also stopped slithering .

I scoffed as I looked at her . “You Ji, you must be wondering right now, what’s going on . ”

I slowly put away Piercer, stroking the soft purple leather at my hands . I smiled enchantingly, my eyes shining like a victorious queen . I looked at the motionless and silent You Ji before me . “The day that Nie Zun told me something happened in the Western District, we contacted Old Fan . Did you think you could confuse everybody? Jie Pa has long suspected you, otherwise he wouldn’t have followed us to the Eastern District to tell us about Laurel!”

Jiao S looked utterly confused, her eyes flitting back and forth between You Ji and me .

I glanced over at her and signaled for her not to be confused . Just listen .

I glanced over at her and signaled for her not to be confused . Just listen .

I smiled . With a final touch, I finally put away my whip . My gaze landed on the statue-like figure in front of me, at the red lines streaming down You Ji’s delicate, pale neck .

There was a coldness and a mercilessness in my eyes . “You Ji, I never suspected you . I trusted you all along . I even left the Western District in

your hands . Despite Jie Pa and Nie Zun's suspicions towards you after Laurel's disappearance, I told them it wasn't the case . None of this could be related to You Ji .

“In order to find the truth and to prove your innocence, we came to the Southern District . Our original goal was, of course, finding a way out of the Split Zone, but we were also testing you . To see if you would impatiently give yourself away . ”

I gave a deep sigh . I didn't want to continue, but I had to finish speaking . “You must be feeling very anxious right now . But I'm not going to give you the chance to speak . Before we came here, Jie Pa coated my whip with Song Lu's blood . Your injured eyes may never heal . I don't know what your end goal was, nor do I know if you truly wanted to kill me, but I do know that you're still worried about Mr Blond . You won't kill me, because everyone knows what kind of punishment one gets for killing a district commander . ”

Jiao S suddenly cut in, “Li Shen, you...” She looked at me, her expression on guard .

I shot her a harmless smile . But I was confirming You Ji's betrayal right now, so the sadness I felt made the smile somewhat unnatural . “Listen to me first,” I told her .

Her expression was complicated, but she didn't try to continue .

I turned to You Ji and continued, “You knew that I suspected you . You knew that Nie Zun and Jie Pa's brains would have found a way to stop you . And because you fear Mr Blond, you won't immediately kill me . But you had the confidence to come to me and give all these arguments, to make me suspect Nie Zun . That way, I would reveal to you, how he told me to protect myself, right?”

My expression hardened as I spoke . “You spoke so well, and your method was good . If I were someone else who had known you so long, I might have hesitated between you and Nie Zun . And that hesitation may have

been the death of me . It's too bad though, that I'm not someone else . I know a secret that you don't know . ”

I gave an incomparably emotional smile . A gentle, yet vicious light circled in my eyes .

Chapter 51

51 Who's the Main Character Here?

Speaking briskly, I told her, “Here’s my secret . Not only is it true that Nie Zun and I must remain within 500 meters from each other, because he houses my second identity, our lives in the Split Zone are tied together . ”

A sudden breeze blew past . Jiao S had been startled numerous times this day already . Her widened eyes no longer seemed very frightening to me .

Thanks to the paper talisman that Jie Pa prepared for us, You Ji now stood frozen in front of me . I looked at her and gave a heavy sigh .

I suddenly felt exhausted . But I wasn’t done with my speech yet . “Because his life and mine are tied together, if he lives, I live . If he dies, I die . And vice versa . If either of us wants to leave the Split Zone, not only do we have to kill our own soul splitter, we must kill the other’s as well . Only then can we both return to the real world . Finding a single soul splitter is hard enough, let alone finding two . That’s why we’re searching for other methods!

“So, it’s very interesting that you’d suggest that he wants to kill me to get rid of me . If I die, he dies . So why bother?!”

In that moment, I didn’t want to say any more . To be honest, Nie Zun and Jie Pa had both warned me that You Ji may betray me . I simply didn’t want to believe them at the time . When Li Qing was still here, I loved hanging out with You Ji the most .

Because I liked snakes when I was alive, and You Ji also adored them . She liked to make herself look like a snake, and she liked having green hair . The Split Zone may be a place full of strange-looking creatures, but still,

there weren't many with green hair . She insisted on keeping her own style though .

You Ji wasn't like Song Lu . She wasn't gentle and kind . She was wise, rational, methodical, and thorough in all things she did . I always envied her, and I relied on her a lot .

That's why, after I became the district commander, knowing that I would be unable to protect the Western District, I left all matters and concerns to You Ji to take care of . She never expressed any interest in becoming the commander . If all that she's done up until now has simply been for that position, then I'd be even more upset .

Because You Ji, if you'd just told me... If you'd told me, despite Li Qing's wishes, I'd have resolutely let go of it all and given you the position .

Why did you have to betray me?

My heart ached . And ached and ached .

Though life in the Split Zone was comfortable, I'd long ago become accustomed to the fact that people in the Split Zone were much more cruel and merciless than those in the real world . I've been betrayed many times before, and yet, my heart still ached now .

You Ji, you tried to use the bond between Nie Zun and me to incite animosity between us . But you never once suspected that Nie Zun and my lives were bound together...

At that thought, I glanced over at Nie Zun . The entire time, he'd stood at the side, silent, watching as I revealed this great betrayal . And the entire time, his expression had remained unchanged and unaffected .

Haha . This demon-like man . This unpredictable man .

Although I wasn't certain about any of this, although I didn't understand any of this, although it seemed I'd never know quite what Nie Zun was, I'll always remember those words that the blond man told me .

Whenever he spoke to me, his eyes were always teasing and yet incomparably serious . That day, after explaining all the unchanging things about the Split Zone, he said to me, “Ah Shen, you can be wary of everyone else, but you have to trust Nie Zun . No matter how much you hate him, you have to trust him . Because the one you hate, the one who lives within him, is part of yourself . He and you, you and he, can never part . No matter how unwilling you may be, after coming to the Split Zone, your life and his are bound together . That’s something that no one can change, not even you . ”

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As I thought of the blond man’s words, and of all the things that I’d once thought were impossible and yet, had now occurred, I felt an unbearable pain in my chest .

Brows furrowed, I looked up and over at You Ji .

Another strange breeze blew by . It gently lifted her green hair, rustling as it brushed past the paper stuck to her face .

Her lips curved up strangely, and then her hand moved . Her entire body loosened up, as if it were coming back to life .

I recoiled slightly .

She lifted her arm and ripped the paper off her face . There were still blood stains trailing from her eyes in two red streams . Against her pale skin and green hair, it made her look like a witch .

Seeing her suddenly start moving, Nie Zun quickly stepped forward . He stood silently beside me, ready to attack .

Then I noticed that her eyes had completely healed . An enchanting light reflected from her eyes . Her red lips opened to say, “But you’re not smart enough . ” She laughed and added, “Betray? You? You’re not even on my level . ”

The look in her eyes turned vicious . “In all aspects, I am not inferior to you . I really don’t understand what Blond and Li Qing both saw in you . What is it about you that’s worth waiting for? You hardly even have the desire to leave this place, so what kind of protection could you possibly provide?” She scoffed . “You were right . I’ve been involved in it all . I didn’t know about your bond to Nie Zun . But so what? Did you really think that my end goal was you?”

The look in her eyes turned vicious . “In all aspects, I am not inferior to you . I really don’t understand what Blond and Li Qing both saw in you . What is it about you that’s worth waiting for? You hardly even have the desire to leave this place, so what kind of protection could you possibly provide?” She scoffed . “You were right . I’ve been involved in it all . I didn’t know about your bond to Nie Zun . But so what? Did you really think that my end goal was you?”

She laughed . “Who do you think you are that I would wage a war for you?”

She lifted her hand and wiped at the blood stains on her face . The somewhat dried blood smeared across her pale skin . She didn’t seem to care though, and she continued wiping and wiping, smearing and smearing .

Nie Zun hadn’t yet made a move, and Jiao S and I watched You Ji vigilantly .

As far as we knew, with Jie Pa’s talisman and Song Lu’s blood, she shouldn’t be standing before us thus . Even if she were involved in the experiments, even if she had the antidote to counter the effects of Song Lu’s blood, what of Jie Pa’s talisman? She couldn’t have undone it so easily with just her mental force . Because we didn’t understand the situation fully, neither I nor Nie Zun dared act hastily .

You Ji sighed lightly . “Li Shen, you’re always so confident like this . A shame really . What if I told you that I was simply a small participant in this experiment? That I’m not the one running it . What would you do then?”

Without waiting for my response, she simply continued, “Now, the Western District is in my hands . Did you really think that 27 floor heads would devote themselves to you with just a few words? Ah, well, 7 of them were indeed devoted to you . Of course, I’ve gotten rid of them now . ”

“Also—” She pointed at the paper seal she’d pulled off, now on the ground . “Don’t pull out trinkets like that . It’s beneath me . And the others, they’re even less interested in playing those games with you . ” She narrowed her eyes . “The Western District is mine now . ”

Then she turned to Nie Zun . “Nie Zun, did you think that those few people you and Jie Pa left behind were enough to hold the district until you returned? Now, you have nowhere to go . You’ll just have to stay with Jiao S in the Southern District, running from the big plan . It’s really a shame . None of you here are main characters in this game . Really, you’re all nothing...”

You Ji laughed coyly . She turned away, her back to us, and walked away with her tail swishing back and forth behind her . “You guys just stay here and slowly take in your complete lack of relevance as creatures not even worth being playthings . ”

Then, she suddenly seemed to have another thought . She stopped and turned back to us . She said to me, “Oh, I nearly forgot... Though I don’t know the details of your connection with Nie Zun, when I tried inciting some discord between you two, I hadn’t really expected it to work . I just wanted to know what was going on with you two . ”

You Ji laughed coyly . She turned away, her back to us, and walked away with her tail swishing back and forth behind her . “You guys just stay here and slowly take in your complete lack of relevance as creatures not even worth being playthings . ”

Then, she suddenly seemed to have another thought . She stopped and turned back to us . She said to me, “Oh, I nearly forgot... Though I don’t know the details of your connection with Nie Zun, when I tried inciting some discord between you two, I hadn’t really expected it to work . I just wanted to know what was going on with you two . ”

And then, she laughed . Her eyes glistened . “Who’d have thought that my silly comments would reveal such amazing information . ”

It was the first time I felt my heart drop so far .

As if seeing through my worries, her smile grew wider . “Don’t worry . This isn’t your weakness . Rather, it makes you two interesting . You’ll likely live longer than her . ” She pointed at Jiao S .

Jiao S sneered, her own malice flashing across her eyes . “I most abhor women like you . Look at you, putting on such airs, like that bitch Li Wen . Do you really think that if things go according to your plan, that you’ll become the master of the Split Zone?”

At that point, Jiao S raised her sword and pointed it at You Ji . She continued, “Though I have no interest in you or your grievances with Li Shen, your opinion that you’re infallible... You’re rather looking down on us too much, aren’t you?”

A ray of light suddenly burst forth from the tip of her sword, headed straight for You Ji .

You Ji’s laughter was enchanting, bewitching . As the light of the sword flew at her, the air around her started to vibrate and crackle .

Just like Jiao S and Gao Qin Jiu Ye’s abilities .

Jiao S cried out in surprise, “Th-that can’t be! How can you use this ability?!”

Chapter 52

Volume 1

52 Forest Showdown

The air around You Ji started to condense to shards, and the light from Jiao S' sword was shattered before it reached its target.

You Ji covered her mouth and laughed. "You mean to say that this move was taught to you and Gaoqin Jiuye by Si Luo, and that no one but you three should know it, right?"

At the mention of Si Luo, Jiao S' expression completely changed. A storm raged in her eyes.

And then the air around her started to tremble! Just like when Gaoqin Jiuye used this ability that day in the stone room, I lost my footing. I grabbed onto Nie Zun with one hand, and with the other, I blocked my red dress flying up in front of me, lest I miss this scene!

You Ji's green hair danced around her head as the air shook. Her face was covered with smeared blood. She smiled evilly, looking like Medusa of Greek lore. "Don't get anxious. I don't plan on fighting with you, and I don't plan on answering any of our questions. So, just step aside, and let me find that Laurel girl."

My eyes widened now. I released my hold on Nie Zun and quickly grabbed my bow and arrow, aiming straight for You Ji. "You'd better not touch a single finger on Laurel."

And then You Ji just laughed. "Me, touch her? That girl's no ordinary girl. If she continues running wild out there, I'm afraid that I won't even be able

to touch her anymore. You guys should stop letting your feelings lead you. Do you really think she's the same Laurel that you once knew?

"I really don't have time to play with you anymore." You Ji's smile slowly disappeared. The air around her started to shake again, and then it condensed into a thick gaseous wall, with us on one side and her on the other. She turned to go.

The storm continued to rage in Jiao S' eyes; her hair started to fly wildly. She raised her longsword, her rough voice rippling through the wind, "Twisting death, thousand blades!" The blinding sphere of light around the sword suddenly glowed much brighter. She jumped up and struck with her sword.

The blade sounded, and the sky filled with dust.

You Ji must not have expected her perfect barrier to get hacked up so easily. She turned and glared angrily at Jiao S. Her green hair was lifted into the air, curling, and her serpent's tail slithered on the ground. It grew longer and thicker, winding up on the ground like a python.

Not good.

I quickly rose into the air and immediately shot ten arrows. *Whoosh!* All ten arrows landed in You Ji's tail. Her face stiffened, and she was clearly in pain. But still, her serpent's tail slowly slithered over to Jiao S.

"Jiao S, be careful of her tail! Don't let her wrap it around you!" I shouted loudly.

Upon hearing that, Jiao S leapt into the air. And then, You Ji's tail chased after her, into the air like a pillar rising from the ground. Her tail grew longer, but it didn't slow down. In fact, it sped up, and Jiao S was quickly captured.

"Nie Zun!" I shouted as my dress flew.

Nie Zun immediately flew over to Jiao S' side. He moved so swiftly, he just looked like a flash of black. He stomped down on You Ji's chasing serpent's tail.

There was a flame at his foot as he stepped down.

I'd always known that Nie Zun was very strong. Though he always looked idle and carefree, he was very demanding of his body. He may not engage in much combat, but he trained enough to be able to utilize his mental force in attacks.

When he stomped down on You Ji's tail with his fiery foot, the flames spread to her. You Ji clenched her teeth and glared at Nie Zun. "You're just as vexing as before!"

I pulled out Piercer to attack her. With the twisting winds formed by You Ji and Jiao S on either side, I ran forward like a speeding bullet.

Piercer was very long, so before I got too close to You Ji, I raised my arm and flicked the whip at her. It glowed in a violet light, and with my added mental force, it straightened like a sword. I swung at You Ji's face.

You Ji looked back, a vortex of air forming. She wanted to block me! As if Jiao S would give her that chance. Her eyes also widened as she conjured a flurry of air to knock out You Ji's vortex.

I took this opportunity to strike You Ji with my violet sword.

Though it looked like we were ahead, I didn't let my guard down yet. I grabbed ten arrows from my back and aimed.

Armed with years of combat experience, Jiao S didn't give You Ji the chance to resist either. Even as she was forming her vortex, Jiao S held up her sword. On the tail of my violet sword, she charged.

You Ji's lips suddenly curled up in an eerie smile. I looked at her strange smile and aimed for her face.

Suddenly, a howling sound echoed. Three large wolves descended from above.

You Ji was caught between two blades when the wolves appeared before her. The wolves roared, furious, as a dark aura escaped from their mouths onto the swords. When the dark stream touched the light of the swords, explosive popping sounded and the blades shattered to smoke.

With my vision now clouded, I couldn't easily aim my arrows. The alarmed Jiao S and Nie Zun quickly returned to my side. When Jiao S landed on the ground, she started raising a storm, immediately dispersing the darkness.

As the smoke disappeared, the three large wolves stood proudly beside You Ji's tail. Their eyes were fierce, and together with You Ji, they stared at us.

You Ji looked around and laughed. "Goodness, looks like my reinforcement's here. Even these wolves are here; won't you show yourself, Rong Jin?"

My brows furrowed at her words. A wave of worry rushed over me as I recalled what Huan Qing had said. If the soul snatcher Rong Jin was here now, did that mean the one-armed woman who defeated Huan Qing was also here?!

But even after You Ji spoke, no one appeared. Then a voice suddenly floated over from behind her, "I didn't help you so that you'd sit around here wasting time. Or are you wanting to see what it's like to be dog food?"

I shivered. The voice sounded like a ghost. It felt like a male evilness, calling from the depths of hell. It made one feel entirely uneasy.

You Ji's expression remained unchanged as she heard this voice though. She didn't even turn. But her voice carried some restraint as she said, "I was on my way. Just help me take care of them."

Again, like an evil breeze, the demonic voice came again from behind her, "Go."

As if she'd just been given amnesty, You Ji sighed in relief and glanced at us with a smile. She collected her tail, which returned to its original size, and then she turned and fled into the forest behind her.

Jiao S and I wanted to chase after her, but the three large wolves, creatures I'd never before seen in the Split Zone, watched us like hunters waiting to catch their prey. As the dark aura escaped their mouths, we both stopped in fear.

Nie Zun also motioned to us to act cautiously.

By then, You Ji's serpent tail had already disappeared into the forest, and I could no longer pursue. I clenched my teeth. Laurel, wait for me. I'll definitely save you.

You Ji may have disappeared, but the wolves still stood in front of us, darkness at their mouths, like they'd been poisoned.

"Whatever demon hides there, show yourself if you can! Why simply leave these animals here to act savagely?" I brushed away my skirt as I angrily shouted towards the forest behind the wolves.

It's enough that you caused my dearest friend to betray me, but you even kidnapped a girl from our district and did some strange things to Yu Liang and Song Lu! There were just too many things going on here!

I glared at the darkness ahead as I fumed with anger inside. The smoke dispersed and a clear wind blew, carrying the evil, ghostly voice. "Who's this foolish girl who's so unaware of the rules?"

Goosebumps covered my body as that strange voice uttered the words "foolish girl."

Suddenly, a shadow appeared beneath the paws of the three wolves. I nearly jumped back in fright. A large and tall, ordinary-shaped man's shadow extended on the ground. It appeared here, in the forest, under the gloomy, ashen sky.

I exchanged glances with Jiao S and Nie Zun. We all looked at the mysterious shadow on the ground.

I stared at the shadow and said, “This foolish girl is the Western Commander, Li Shen! Soul snatcher Rong Jin, are you betraying the Southern District by engaging in these dubious affairs with my district’s You Ji?”

The shadow on the ground shook, as if he were laughing. The ghostly voice came again, “I don’t know of any Western Commander. And I’m entirely uninterested in the ‘dubious affairs’ you speak of. Whatever I do, it is for my own enjoyment. Hahaha!”

The goosebumps on my body returned as his frightful laugh echoed.

Just as we were about to make a move, another chilly voice came from behind us. “Is Si Luo aware of all the fun you’re having too?”

The three of us turned to see Gaoqin Jiuye, arms crossed over his chest. He walked over to us, his bright yellow sneakers stepping on the ground, a wicked smile on his lips.

Chapter 53

53 Sudden Change in the Situation

It was a bit of a pleasant surprise, but I still frowned as I said, “Where have you been? If you’d have come earlier, at the least, You Ji wouldn’t have been able to slip away . ”

Gao Qin Jiu Ye raised a brow . “You Ji? That snake woman from your district?”

“Mmh . She betrayed us and is colluding with that soul snatcher of yours, plotting these experiments . And it was like you guessed; Huan Qing’s mental force was completely depleted by them,” I explained as clearly and succinctly as I could .

Unaffected by most of the information, Gao Qin Jiu Ye simply turned to the ghostly shadow . “Having fun? Were you the one who injured Huan Qing?”

His voice came, “No . I couldn’t injure a disciple of the same master, so I didn’t do anything . ”

I added, “Supposedly it was him and a one-armed woman . They even took Mi Fu!”

Gao Qin Jiu Ye’s eyes narrowed at the mention of a one-armed woman .

I flinched .

Gao Qin Jiu Ye stared at the shadow . But instead of asking about Mi Fu, he said, “You didn’t mention that she was here . ”

Suddenly, I was thrown into a flurry of confusion . What's going on? Was Gao Qin Jiu Ye one of them? What the hell?

Nie Zun shook his head at me, signaling for me not to say anything yet . His bright eyes put me into a bit of a daze momentarily .

After seeing Gao Qin Jiu Ye, Jiao S once again stood still as a statue, only her wide eyes jumping back and forth .

The ghostly voice came again, faintly, "She didn't come here with the intent of going after Si Luo, so what would I need to say?"

Gao Qin Jiu Ye's gaze was cold . "Why did you two take Mi Fu? Where is she now?"

The shadow laughed . "She's taken Mi Fu to see Si Luo . Since she's here, she might as well visit and reminisce about old times a bit . "

His laughter would have made my hair stand on end, if it wasn't already .

Without even a second thought, Gao Qin Jiu Ye glared and then the entire forest started shaking .

I couldn't help thinking to myself: Are you serious? Again? This border forest sure is resilient, what with this group of air manipulators shaking things up like there were earthquakes every day .

Gao Qin Jiu Ye's eyes were still fixed on the shadow on the ground . And as everything shook, so did the shadow . I heard the crackling of the air, but noticed that those three wolves stood firmly, their eyes ferocious .

I couldn't help silently appreciating: Ah, I'd really like to grab one for a pet . (Passerby A: Long time no see! So you want a wolf as a pet? What tyranny do you want to send upon the Split Zone? / I unhesitatingly kick away Passerby A .)

The laughing shadow on the ground flickered with the shaking air . The longer you listened, the creepier it felt; it was like a tape that got stuck .

“Gao Qin Jiu Ye, your tricks aren’t at all fun . Why don’t you just take me to see Si Luo? And meet with her too, while you’re at it . ”

Gao Qin Jiu Ye suddenly froze . His expression darkened, but then he withdrew his mental force and the air around us returned to normal .

“Let’s go,” Gao Qin Jiu Ye finally cast two words .

Who knew he’d be so compliant? I was about to step forward, but Jiao S beat me to it . She took a great big stride and said, “I want to see Si Luo as well . ”

Gao Qin Jiu Ye immediately turned and glared at her . Hardly scared, Jiao S returned his glare .

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The ghostly voice floated over, “Jiao S, Si Luo’s already told you before . He never wants to see you again . Don’t turn this into something difficult . ”

Finally, I stood up and said, “Gao Qin Jiu Ye, don’t forget about our goal . You Ji has already taken Laurel . If you’re going to follow that damned shadow, you ought to at least take us along . ”

Without hearing Gao Qin Jiu Ye’s reply, the demonic voice laughed sharply . “Silly girl, who are you calling a damned shadow? Hahaha, how entertaining! Truly, what fun!”

His laugh nearly pierced through my ears . I rolled my eyes at him .

Gao Qin Jiu Ye gave a chilly laugh, his expression blank . “Jiao S, I cannot possibly take you to see Si Luo . As for Li Shen...”

He paused a moment and then turned to me, a cold yet mysterious look in his eyes . “I will step out from your matters now . Things have changed . Moreover, I was never interested in the lives of those from your districts . Whether you continue investigating or not, I can’t be bothered now . But

I'll leave you with some final words . Make sure to watch out for your own life . ”

I always knew that he he was cold and unfeeling, but I hadn't expected that he'd change colors this fast .

I scoffed and glanced at him . “Gao Qin Jiu Ye, looks like it's true that you don't care for anything but Si Luo . ”

I glanced at the shadow, and then I said, “Do as you wish . As for Si Luo, whether or not you take us along, Jiao S and I will still find him . I wasn't certain at the start, but it seems now that Si Luo can't be rid of suspicions . If you must act this way, then don't blame the Eastern and Western Districts for lacking manners!”

Jiao S appeared surprised that I was so firm . She smiled and gave me a praising look . Her stiff smile wasn't all that attractive, but still, I accepted it .

Gao Qin Jiu Ye said, “Do as you'd like . I suppose that you hid away the cripple Huan Qing, Jiao S? You both should just protect the people here and let things run their course . ” Turning to me, he said, “And you're right, Li Shen . The only thing I care about is Si Luo, and nothing else . ” He pointed at my face and smiled . “Yourself included . ”

I glared at him, looking at the face that had me so infatuated and yet brought about such a great change in me .

Suddenly, Nie Zun walked forward leisurely . His eyes were tranquil as water . He raised a hand and pressed down Gao Qin Jiu Ye's pointing finger . “Some things are better left unsaid . When spoken, some will wonder if perhaps you're being ironic . ”

Suddenly, Nie Zun walked forward leisurely . His eyes were tranquil as water . He raised a hand and pressed down Gao Qin Jiu Ye's pointing finger . “Some things are better left unsaid . When spoken, some will wonder if perhaps you're being ironic . ”

Nie Zun was calm and unhurried . Gao Qin Jiu Ye glanced at him and then at me . He raised his head slightly and narrowed his eyes . After a moment of silence, he laughed . He turned away, walking towards the three wolves .

“Goodbye, everyone . ”

Without looking back, he followed the wolves and the ghostly shadow, disappearing into the distance .

I stood still, my teeth clenched . I glanced at Nie Zun and Jiao S . They were also still and silent, and after a moment, I could only sigh . I knew that it would be pointless to chase after them . The three of us didn't have a great chance at defeating the two of them .

When Gao Qin Jiu Ye's figure disappeared entirely, Jiao S finally spoke .
“Li Shen, you can't smell Laurel anymore, can you . ”

It seemed to be more of a statement than a question, but I still nodded in reply . “When this situation started, I lost her scent . I'm almost positive that they've already found her . What do we do now?”

Nie Zun, who'd been quiet awhile, finally said, “As it stands, there are three opponents we're up against . You Ji, the soul snatcher Rong Jin, and the one-armed woman we've yet to meet . If Laurel was captured, then You Ji and Laurel will be together . The one-armed woman took Mi Fu to go find Si Luo; they probably won't go searching for Laurel . They seem to have a vested interest in her, but she's clearly not the end goal . ”

“The question is, where is Si Luo?” I frowned . Suddenly, I had a thought .
“Could he possibly be at the 30th floor of the residence?”

Jiao S shook her head . “He wouldn't be somewhere that easily found . ”

I looked at her a bit doubtfully, then asked, “Speaking of, Jiao S, why are you trying to find Si Luo?”

I didn't expect her to give an answer, but she actually replied without hesitating, “Because I like him and want to pursue him . ”

Pfft! I choked on a puff of air .

I stared at the woman before me .

Pfft! I choked on a puff of air .

I stared at the woman before me .

Dressed in a school uniform, a pair of large eyes, long, black hair with bangs, and a face with a heavy, deathly aura .

This strange woman with a domineering attitude in battle, who's never displayed an ounce of tenderness, who had great interest in bloody deaths and no interest in anything else, was telling me right now that the reason she's been chasing after Si Luo is because she likes him?

My lips twitched . The Split Zone was indeed, no ordinary place .

Jiao S seemed rather unaffected . “Didn't you ask me? So I answered you . What's so surprising? Weren't you two curious why they always brought up Si Luo in my conversations? This is why . Three years ago, Si Luo visited the Eastern District . I fell in love at first sight . He made me promise that I wouldn't step foot in the Southern District for three years . So I respected his wish, until this year, when I came here with you . ”

Jiao S' spoke the same way she always had . Her face was calm . But for some inexplicable reason, I seemed to feel a kind of pain from her .

Three years . In the Split Zone .

I knew that she'd been in the Split Zone for less than four years . Not long after her arrival, she was made a district commander by the blond man . In three years, she'd acted swiftly and resolutely to make the laws of the Eastern District known far and wide . She never hesitated to turn away anyone she deemed weak, keeping only those who were strong . Her actions were cruel and firm, and the impression she gave had always been one of an unfeeling woman .

But, in this moment, hearing her so calmly divulge that she liked Si Luo, I truly believed that she loved him to her core .

In that moment, somehow, I understood her love .

Although I don't know the story between them, considering how Si Luo had made her keep her distance, and how she then turned the Eastern District into something completely different to the Southern District, I suddenly just understood her . I understood her .

So, I asked no more . I simply said, “Then let's go find him first . ”

Chapter 54

54 The Heart in Chaos

“Cut it out, Li Shen,” Nie Zun interjected, “There’s no way we’ll be able to find them . Besides, I’m worried about Jie Pa and Song Lu . We should go back . We can’t just keep Huan Qing out of sight, out of mind either—we’ll need to get him out of the airflow . ”

What Nie Zun said was true, but I was still reluctant to leave matters as they were . Stuck in a dilemma, I looked towards Jiao S .

“Nie Zun is right . ” Jiao S conceded, unexpectedly calm . “We should head back first . Under such circumstances, not only should we return to Jie Pa, we’ll also need to get back to our respective districts soon . We can’t even be sure if our districts are in jeopardy as it is, rushing in blindly will only get us killed . ”

Retreat back to the Western District? That’s right . I wonder how Old Man Fan and the others are doing... but what about Laurel? And Yu Liang...?

I clenched my teeth . Just imagining the countless sorts of peril the Western District could be in had me nodding my head in agreement . Retreat was the only option .

They weren’t under any sort of attack during the time we were gone . Everything was as per normal when we got to the academy’s lab, with the obvious exception of Song Lu’s state of unconsciousness . Hence, I had no other choice but to convey everything that happened to Jie Pa and Guan Nie .

Guan Nie was the first to speak up and for the first time, I noticed a glint of harshness in his almond-shaped eyes . “So you’re saying that Gao Qin Jiu Ye returned to Si Luo’s side just like that?”

I nodded .

Guan Nie burst out laughing with a hand over his mouth, as if I’d just told the funniest joke of all time but the mirth did not reach his eyes . “Gao Qin Jiu Ye... Hahahaha, truly splendid! You really would do anything for Si Luo .”

“Ms Ah Shen,” Jie Pa spoke up, pushing up his glasses . “If the situation is as you described, then I suggest we leave Southern District for now . Since the last time Old Man Fan had reported to me on his suspicions about Ms You Ji, Nie Zun and I have not been able to get in contact with him .

“Moreover, we don’t know what is going on there . In my opinion, returning to our own districts should be the main priority . I’m worried about Song Lu’s condition too . We don’t have much MF left for combat; it certainly would not be enough to fight against those people you just mentioned .”

I pursed my lips tightly together, repressing the reluctance in my heart .

Jiao S exhaled a long sigh . “I know the idea of turning back after coming this far is hard to swallow, but we may lose our lives if we don’t . Most importantly, even Mr Blond is unreachable now . Who knows what kind of conspiracy lurks behind all these incidents?”

Before she could go on, Nie Zun turned to her and interrupted, “Regardless, it’s as I’ve said before . You and Li Shen should at least trust and cooperate with each other .”

I exchanged eye contact with Jiao S . Somehow, the demon I had once feared and hated was now my only trustworthy ally .

“Let’s start planning the journey back to our districts then,” I directed my words at Jiao S . “We’ll settle matters at our own districts and decide who to

bring along the next time we return . We'll get to the bottom of this . ”

Jiao S rolled her eyes, but eventually gave a nod . She handed me something that looked akin to amber, its core wrapped around what seemed to be a drop of blood .

“This Scarlet Compass was made from my own blood,” Jiao S explained in her usual hoarse voice, “I don't have a phone or anything like that, but I'll be able to sense it if you break the compass during the most critical moment . Through my subordinate's Scarlet Compass Formation, I can get to you within ten minutes .

“However, these things are difficult to craft—there are only three in existence as of now . Use it only when absolutely necessary; otherwise, it would be best if you can come find me personally or have Nie Zun contact Tao Lie . ”

Sharply dipping my head in acknowledgement, I took the amber from her and placed it securely behind the waistband of my red skirt .

“In that case,” Nie Zun started, “let's head towards the border before dark . ”

With those words, Song Lu instantly came to mind . I turned to Jie Pa .
“Will you be able to estimate when she'll wake?”

Jie Pa shook his head . “Song Lu is badly injured . We can't wake her up by force—all we can do is wait . For now, I can't do anything about the insect either; I'll need to return to the Western District and enquire about them with those who possessed the necessary competency . ”

A wave of helplessness crashed in my heart but I still managed a nod .

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Without warning, Jiao S widened her eyes . “There's someone we've forgotten—Huan Qing!”

“You’re right! Quick, let him out . ” My hand smacked against my forehead .

Following the motion of her left hand, the whirlwind began to appear beside Jiao S . With a whoosh, she dragged Huan Qing out the airstream and flung him to the ground .

She just... flung him... to the ground .

I was speechless . Huan Qing had already been reduced to such sorry state, yet it seems that Jiao S still didn’t spare the slightest bit of sympathy .

Jie Pa looked down at Huan Qing’s motionless and haggard body . “Is this what happens when you’ve completely exhausted your MF?”

I nodded .

Jie Pa crouched beside Huan Qing, wrapping a white handkerchief around his hand before checking up on the unconscious man .

“Jie Pa, you seemed to have a slight obsession with cleanliness as well, just like that perverted Nie Zun . ” I asked with interest .

Jie Pa adjusted his glasses and flashed a small smile . “Indeed, just a little . ”

“How is he?” I pointed at Huan Qing who was still on the floor .

Jie Pa kept his handkerchief . “It’s nothing serious . Seeing as he had sealed his symbol before, his MF is temporarily depleted . Going by what you’ve mentioned, he maintained a last illusion in this condition, which must mean that he exhausted every last bit of his MF in order to do that . It seems like he will remain in a catatonic state, just like Song Lu . It will probably be a while before he regains consciousness . ”

“It’s less than ten hours until nightfall and we’re still in the academy,” Jiao S noted, “Furthermore, we haven’t had much rest over these past few days —at this rate, our MF will be compromised .

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“To make matters worse, we now have two comatose casualties on our hands as well as another who absolutely cannot get injured . Venturing out at night in this state isn’t a good idea . I suggest we stay another night before heading out for the boundary lines in the morning . ”

I thought over it carefully . She was right, we haven’t slept in days—on top of the extraordinary amount of strength exhausted today, our MF had suffered as a result . Besides, I have not activated unrestricted control over my MF . Under these conditions, an attempt to make it to the border at night would undoubtedly be a terrible idea . With that in mind, I nodded in consent . Noting my agreement, Jie Pa and Nie Zun didn’t voice any objections either .

“Let’s return to our respective rooms and rest for the night then . Jie Pa, I’m afraid we’ll have to trouble you again in taking care of Song Lu and Huan Qing . ” I said wearily .

Jie Pa nodded .

Nie Zun turned to Guan Nie . “Since Jie Pa can’t be in harm’s way, and both Song Lu and Huan Qing are in coma, can you stay with them for now and protect them with your illusion?”

As the words tumbled out of Nie Zun’s lips, his eyes gleamed with tenderness . Guan Nie caught his gaze and gave a coquettish grin . “Whatever my pet says, goes . This is a piece of cake, leave it to me . ”

Surprisingly, Jiao S was the first to twitch at the scene in front of us . “I’ve never seen you this submissive even towards me, your own district commander . ”

Guan Nie pouted and whined . “Ahhh, but this pet is my lover . ”

... Someone just kill me now .

Even in the presence of two unconscious bodies and an extremely vulnerable gentleman—piled haphazardly above the mess we recently found ourselves in—my exhaustion triumphed my concerns . I felt the accumulated fatigue from past sleepless nights flood through me at the thought of finally being able to rest .

I took lead in leaving the lab, but not before informing Jie Pa and his companions about taking the room opposite ours, and to notify me immediately should any situation arise . Nie Zun followed quickly after me, as did Jiao S .

“Let’s sleep in the same room tonight . ” I turned and posed the suggestion to Jiao S .

Jiao S must not have expected those words to come from me out of the blue; her usual wide, hollow eyes had a fleeting glimmer of something different but it was gone just as soon . She didn’t refuse the offer so the three of us returned to our room on the first level .

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“The room is big but every dorm in the split zone is limited to a single bunk bed . One of us will have to make the supreme sacrifice in this case . ” With a hand thumping against my chest and an expression of awe-inspiring righteousness, I continued, “Since I’m such a kind-hearted person, I’ll take the lower bunk . Nie Zun, you’ll sleep on the floor . ”

I ignored them thereafter and went straight for my bed before shutting my eyes . I could hear the sound of movement once my eyes were closed; perhaps it was the sound of Jiao S clambering up to the top bunk, or maybe it was Nie Zun getting a cup of water . Regardless, I kept my eyes shut . I was too exhausted to care about anything else .

Except... I couldn't fall asleep .

After all the events from the past few days, my mind was in chaos . It was when I could finally stop the gears in my body from turning, that I finally had the time to digest the imprints left upon them . Even though I'm neither human nor ghost here, but I'm still alive in a sense—and as long as one is alive, they end up pondering . No matter how terrible the situation was, I still needed to calm down and think through everything properly .

The first person who came to mind was Gao Qin Jiu Ye .

I have no idea why he was the first person I thought of but I did know that there was no stopping this train of thought . In the darkness, I pressed my eyes tightly together, as though I could hide from my own tremors this way . I could still remember his abrupt appearance by my window not that many nights ago, the way he walked straight towards me .

Gao Qin Jiu Ye, no matter how many times I reminded myself not to expect anything of you, I still can't help but wonder... Are you really a cruel and ruthless grim reaper? Do you really not care about anyone else besides Si Luo?

And Si Luo... This is the first time I've felt such insatiable curiosity towards a person . What kind of person must he be to have people like Gao Qin Jiu Ye and Jiao S throw all caution to the wind just to chase after him?

Still, Si Luo did not linger long in my cluttered mind . In the end, my thoughts went right back to Gao Qin Jiu Ye .

Actually... It's not like we have known each other for a long time either . Why is it that meeting you made me think of Gao Qi less than before? Hadn't it been your striking resemblance to him and that same charming voice that swayed my emotions each time? With all these similarities between the two of you, exactly why do I find myself forgetting him because of you?

Gao Qin Jiu Ye, you really do look like him—no, you're exactly alike, like two peas in a pod .

I have always been aware of my feelings; I have never denied my love for Gao Qi nor my yearning and longing for him . I'm not the kind of girl who would conceal her feelings . I knew clearly throughout my college life that I loved him . Even after arriving at this treacherous place, Gao Qi, there is not a shadow of doubt that I still miss you, that I still love you .

Chapter 55

55 The Return Journey

I know I'm not fickle-minded but, Gao Qi, neither have I ever forgotten that I was the murderer who killed you . Even if I have no recollection of that moment, I could still remember the wave of panic and helplessness when I first saw Gao Qin Jiu Ye . I can't define it exactly... Just like how I feel towards you, Gao Qi .

Those numerous meetings atop our school roof when you—the popular you, who captured everybody's attention—would willingly give me the time of day just to listen quietly as I recited Faust . I was barely audible even to myself .

“The demon Mephisto said, ‘this world is an abyss of misery and it will never change . ’”

Gao Qi, if you're still here... Would you remember that day? You tilted your head and all the warmth of the sky melted in your eyes . You smiled at me, then said, “Ah Shen, if this world's really just an abyss of misery, what do you think is the most miserable of all?”

I don't blush, not even when you looked at me with that smile of yours but I would drop my gaze timidly, as though direct eye contact with you was enough to swallow my sight . It was why I had the tendency of lowering my eyes and the habit of talking to you in whispers .

That time wasn't any different either, when all I could manage was a soft mumble . “I guess... it'll be loneliness . ”

And as always, you said, “That's a great answer . ”

I used to get tired about the definition of time and love in romance novels, but I believed in them nonetheless . Throughout countless meetings with you by my side on that roof, I had always hoped for time to freeze into eternity . Instead, I ended your eternity and in that, I've ended my own .

Now, I'm faced with another you .

Actually, Gao Qi, what do I have to complain about? Wouldn't I be able to share my forever with you if we're both here?

Even if Gao Qin Jiu Ye isn't really you, I could tell myself that it was fine . Murdering you isn't something I could convince myself that it's fine, but what if the split zone was really giving me the opportunity to start over? Whatever four districts of this world, there will still be no one better than you in my heart .

Except... Is there really no one else?

Loneliness...

If loneliness is truly the most tragic in this abyss of misery, then who is the loneliest out of us? Is it me—the ostracized, mentally-ill loner—or you, the popular senior who felt like no one understood despite being surrounded by thousands of others?

Or perhaps it is...

Somehow, during the serene darkness of tonight and the rare chance I had to reminisce about Gao Qi, the moment was inadvertently interrupted by another .

Perhaps it is... Nie Zun .

As expected, you are the loneliest, right?

Unable to understand my true feelings, unable to comprehend the bond I have with Nie Zun, I slowly opened my eyes . As it turns out, Nie Zun wasn't sleeping at all . His lean but strong body was slouched against his

favorite wall with both hands tucked into the pockets of his windbreaker, and his gaze was cast towards the ground .

I wondered what was on his mind .

In the dark, I scrutinized the silhouette of Nie Zun from head to toe .

His fine bangs drooped over his forehead, covering the idle, indifferent eyes of his that seemed to coat with loneliness . His head was lowered and the collar to his windbreaker was pulled up high, hiding his sharp chin within its confines .

I couldn't put my finger on it, but the longer I looked at him, the more foreign he felt to me . It was like watching a stranger I've never met . An surreal sense of solitude surrounded him, blurring into my vision .

Nie Zun... if the world is an abyss of misery, would you need to be saved? Why do you always act as though you don't need saving? Why does that other identity of mine resonate with you? No matter how much I've searched for an answer, we still have nothing in common apart from our loneliness . Could it be that you were once ostracized too?

Nie Zun... if the world is an abyss of misery, would you need to be saved? Why do you always act as though you don't need saving? Why does that other identity of mine resonate with you? No matter how much I've searched for an answer, we still have nothing in common apart from our loneliness . Could it be that you were once ostracized too?

Even so, you're so much stronger than me and I'm truly envious of you . I'm jealous of the way you don't seem to care about anything .

I really want to know if you have something you care about too .

As I stared at Nie Zun in the dark, that question rippled in my heart . While I couldn't explain the reason behind this sudden curiosity, it felt strangely logical at the same time . At that moment, as if he had heard the words spoken in my heart, Nie Zun lifted his head suddenly .

His bright and indifferent eyes swept over to me casually yet seemingly deliberate . He met my eyes which had widened in shock by his abrupt movement . It was as if everything went without saying, like he understood all of it . Looking at me, a corner of his lips lifted slightly; an indecipherable smile spilled, flowing into my sight .

What are you thinking about? His eyes seemed to question .

Then... I averted my gaze . What about you? What are you thinking about?

“What are the two of you doing, exchanging affectionate looks instead of sleeping?” The hoarse and deep voice of Jiao S sounded from above me .

Startled by the intrusion, I was yanked back into reality . I tilted my head up to see Jiao S hanging down from the edge of the top bunk, her straight hair cascading down from the side of the bed, a pair of hollow eyes flitting from me to Nie Zun .

“Can you not scare others like that?” I rolled my eyes and straightened my back, trying to get into a more comfortable position .

Jiao S actually smiled for a moment; that rigid face of hers was still strange, but she seemed to be smiling a lot more these days and I’ve begun to grow accustomed to them .

“Seriously though, the two of you better get some rest . We don’t know what awaits us tomorrow . Eastern District may be faring better; after all, I still have the S Clan . Western District has already fallen into the hands of the enemy, and you are still awake? Hurry up and rest so you can head back to regroup . ” Looking towards Nie Zun, she continued, “You too, Nie Zun, get some rest soon . ”

Nie Zun was surprisingly compliant . Nodding his head, he laid on the floor with a simple, “Alright . ”

Nie Zun was surprisingly compliant . Nodding his head, he laid on the floor with a simple, “Alright . ”

I was taken aback . My gaze drifted from Nie Zun, who was already lying on his back with his eyes closed, to Jiao S who still had the slightest hint of a smile on her face . It has been a long time since I felt a rush of affection and for some reason, the sight warmed my heart tonight .

I smiled back . “Alright, I’m going to sleep now . ”

I managed to have a peaceful night of sleep without dreams and had just woken up when Jie Pa knocked on our door . Jiao S and Nie Zun were both awake .

“There are still three hours till daybreak, should we hurry on to the boundary lines?” Jie Pa asked while he made his way in . “What should we do about Mr Huan Qing though, do we bring him along?”

“Is Guan Nie watching over them now? Neither of them woke up?” I asked, rubbing the sleep from my eyes .

Jie Pa nodded . “They are still unconscious and from what I can tell, they probably will be for a long while . Mr Yu Liang is still missing, so it may be better that Ms Song Lu doesn’t wake . She will be devastated if she finds out that we are retreating without searching for him . ”

Sitting on the bed, I couldn’t help the slight jerk of my fingers when I processed Jie Pa’s words . It will definitely be a difficult task heading back to the district; Nie Zun and I will have to protect Jie Pa, along with the unconscious Song Lu and Huan Qing . Once Jiao S and Guan Nie part with us at the Eastern District, the two of us will have the sole responsibility of keeping the three of them safe . I’m afraid that our ability may fall short of our ambitions, but if we don’t try then I will never know what is going on in the Western District .

Besides, Old Man Fan is missing too .

Jiao S lowered her head in deep contemplation before speaking up . “How about this, Li Shen . Seeing as the current situation has made both retreat or advance difficult, why don’t we adopt a tactic of neither?”

“While I’m sure my Eastern District must have lost quite a few lives as the situation stands, I can still trust in S Clan’s loyalty towards me . Since we are allies in this, I won’t just sit idly by you and your companions’ plight . So, how about this: come back to the Eastern District with me, I will gather the right people and we will decide what to do from there . ”

Noting my silence, she continued, “I know you’re worried about the Western District and all that you hold dear, but your district may be suffering persecution by now . All around us are pitfalls waiting to drag us down; we really have no other option . We’ll be worried if you returned to the Western District too .

“Li Shen, you know what kind of place the split zone is, you don’t have time to take care of everyone . This is not the world we came from . Here, you have to learn to abandon them when you must because even if you don’t, they won’t survive in the long run if they don’t learn to protect themselves . You don’t even have time to protect yourself, much less their forever . ”

Nie Zun looked at me, his eyes flowing with an ink-black radiance . “She’s right . I know you’re worried about Old Man Fan, but you can’t even save yourself now . ”

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Nie Zun looked at me, his eyes flowing with an ink-black radiance . “She’s right . I know you’re worried about Old Man Fan, but you can’t even save yourself now . ”

In a baffling way, I felt dispirited by their words . It wasn’t like I had thought that much about it, but could it be that I had made my concerns this apparent? Burying my face in my hands, I conceded . “Fine, fine, fine . I’ll listen; I’ll do whatever you think I should do . ”

Jie Pa cut in, “Ms Jiao S, will you be able to use your whirlwind to transport both Mr Huang Qing and Ms Song Lu at the same time?”

Jiao S didn’t answer his question immediately . Instead, she asked, “Why do you address everyone so formally?”

My lips curled upwards at once, my eyes held a teasing glint . “No no no, Nie Zun’s the only exception to that . ”

Jie Pa straightened up, lifting his hand to adjust his glasses then spoke in his usual, respectful manner . “That’s because I’m a gentleman . ”

Pffft!

Though Jie Pa was indeed a gentleman, but I couldn’t help doing a spit-take as I watched such a composed person sing their own praises .

Jiao S smiled rigidly but I have learnt by now that these smiles came from the bottom of her heart . She waved a hand, “I’ll go ahead and place those two unconscious people in my whirlwind, but this means that I’ll need your protection on this journey back . After all, I’ll have to spend a lot of MF to support them . ”

Tch, tch... Jiao S’ coquettish behaviour was honestly unsettling .

Eventually, our discussion concluded and we left the academy in preparation to depart for Eastern District . Before we left, Jie Pa carefully stored a bottle with the huge beetle in his bag .

Walking along the Southern District in broad daylight, it was only natural that we would attract quite a bit of attention . After all, we have a ‘beauty’ like Guan Nie, Nie Zun in all his Dark Lord glory, along with Jiao S’ Sadako cosplay .

Of course, if one must attest that I am equally attention-grabbing, then it must be due to my beauty and not those bright red hair or skirt of mine . (Passerby A flew backwards from the impact of my kick before he could get a word in .)

Chapter 56

56 Long Time No See

We saw the silhouette of a man hurrying towards us from a short distance, not long after leaving the academy . Upon closer inspection, I recognized the person as Ku Fei, the young guy we met at Southern District's tea shop when we first arrived .

The cuffs of Ku Fei's sleeves were rolled up high, revealing his muscular arms . His thick and sharp brows were tightly knitted together like he was perturbed .

His eyes shone when they met mine and he rushed towards me immediately . “You—I heard from the others that you're the Western District commander, Li Shen . Do you remember me?” He waved both arms at me, his speech seemed a little slurred .

Noting his nervous disposition, I smiled and attempted to calm him down . “That's right, I'm Li Shen . Of course, I remember you . What's wrong? Why are you so anxious?”

Ku Fei blushed faintly, raising a hand to tousle his own hair, “Th—the last time... I heard from the neighbors that you came to look for me one of those nights, but I have no recollection of what happened then . ”

Recalling the night I was torn to pieces after falling down that pit, my lips twitched slightly . Heh, it's a good thing he doesn't remember . A good thing indeed .

He continued hastily, his eyes seemed to reflect his apprehension once more . “Actually, I figured you and your companions must have been pranked by Ms Mi Fu that night . And I... I know you hate her but she really is a good

person, she didn't mean anything by it . I asked around about the child you were looking for—she wasn't the new toy that Ms Mi Fu had acquired, s-so can you... can you please not hurt her...?" His last sentence was spoken with even more caution than before .

I frowned . "Hurt her? Why would we hurt her?"

Nie Zun was the first to unravel the situation at hand . Emerging from the group, he flashed Ku Fei a smile as well . "Are you worried because Ms Mi Fu hasn't been seeking you out these days?"

Ku Fei nodded his head fervently . "She hasn't come by in a long time, and I heard... I heard that no one has seen her or her illusionist on the streets of Southern District either . I'm a little worried that she might be in some kind of danger..." He stole a glance towards me as he trailed off .

I choked back on my boiling anger . Do I really look like someone who would hold grudges over petty matters like this, to the extent of kidnapping a little girl?! (Passerby B interjected, "You do!") I rolled my eyes but witnessing at how ill at ease Ku Fei was, I replied patiently . "We didn't hurt her . "

"Th, th-then..." Ku Fei grew even more anxious upon hearing that . "Then do you know where she and that illusionist went?"

We exchanged a look, at a loss for a suitable response . Eventually, it was Nie Zun who spoke up . "Ku Fei, calm down . Mi Fu shouldn't be in much danger, you should head back and tend to your tea shop . Perhaps she will return soon . "

Disappointment filled his eyes . "Do you really not know where she is...?"

I couldn't bear to tell him the truth but Jiao S replied before I could, "We don't . In fact, we are returning to our respective districts now . You should head back as well . "

Jiao S' voice had always been cold and hoarse, with her face clear of any emotions, but I knew she had Ku Fei's best interests at heart . After all,

seeing how worried he is, there was no way we could delve into the stranger things that has been happening in the split zone .

“Alright then . Do come back if you have the chance, and be sure to drop by my shop for some tea . ” His smile was strained yet his words were filled with sincerity . Perhaps it was because of his overwhelming concern for Mi Fu that he looked glum even with a smile .

“Of course . ” Nie Zun gave him a pat on the shoulder before gesturing for us to leave with a shift of his eyes .

As I walked by Ku Fei, I couldn't help but glance sideways towards his young and energetic face, now filled with such a dispirited expression . I told myself to stop looking and just like that I walked right past him .

It was a short distance before Ku Fei called out to us again . He caught up to us, swiping his gaze over the group . “Uh... B-before, you... you mentioned about wanting to look for the commander? Did you manage to meet him?”

I shook my head .

Ku Fei furrowed his brows tighter . “Have you tried?”

I nodded . “We tried, but we couldn't find him . ”

I nodded . “We tried, but we couldn't find him . ”

If at all possible, his frown seemed to deepen even further . “If that's the case, that means it's really—”

Without waiting for him to finish, Jiao S waved her hand impatiently . “That's your district's problem; whether it's your commander or that alleged goddess . Whatever the case, you should stop meddling with it . It's not something that is within your power anyway . ”

Once she was done, Jiao S reached for my hand and pulled, indicating that we should leave . There was nothing I could do about it . Following the others, we continued moving towards the boundary lines . From time to

time, I would look back to the sight of Ku Fei standing at that same spot with his downcast eyes, and I would feel the urge to let out a long sigh . He had been such a young and energetic boy . What a pity, why did he insist on being so kind towards that stubborn and vicious Mi Fu?

At that thought, I recalled the old lady who claimed to be Ku Fei's grandmother, and nudged Nie Zun hurriedly . "Do you all remember Ku Fei's grandmother? She said that Mi Fu was a soul splitter . Do you reckon that's the reason Rong Jin and the others took her?"

Nie Zun did not say a word, but the expression in his eyes told me he was considering the possibility .

Jiao S answered instead . "But didn't Ku Fei say he didn't have a grandmother? I wonder if she was one of Huan Qing's illusions . "

"Why would he feel the need to show us that?"

Jiao S shrugged . "We'll only get the answer to that question once he wakes . "

I sighed inwardly but nodded .

The group returned to the boundary forest between Southern and Western District . Walking into the forest, the betrayal of You Ji was still vivid in my mind . I took a deep breath but didn't think the air within Southern District felt all that fresh . As we walked on, Jiao S came to an abrupt stop .

"What's wrong?" Perplexed by her actions, I looked over at her .

Her eyes grew gradually wider . "I feel a familiar aura but I can't put a finger on it . Somehow, I have a feeling we've left out something . "

Her eyes grew gradually wider . "I feel a familiar aura but I can't put a finger on it . Somehow, I have a feeling we've left out something . "

My heart jolted at her words . Indeed... Something feels amiss . But... What was it exactly?

“It’s getting nearer...” All of a sudden, Jiao S’ eyes snapped open .

Meanwhile I could feel a headache coming on—must something always go wrong whenever we enter the boundary forest? Seriously, did the boundary forest exist with the sole purpose of being our battleground?!

I secretly shook my head .

Jiao S stretched an arm out and gave me a light push . “Don’t let your guard down . I really did sense an aura... a sort of familiarity I haven’t felt in a long while . ”

Nie Zun piped up, “She must have a keen sense of intuition . Nevertheless, if there really is someone in close proximity, then who could it be...? Who could conceal their whereabouts when we’ve already sensed their presence?”

I observed my surroundings and did not find anything unusual, at least within the circumference of visibility I had in this boundary forest . With such dense forest all around us though, it was hard to tell .

Guan Nie yawned, bearing an air of indifference . “What’s there to be afraid of? From what you’ve mentioned, those weirdos should be gathered at Si Luo’s by now . Unless Si Luo is hiding in here, which I highly doubt . If those people aren’t here, then there’s nothing to be worried about with our numbers . ”

Is this... the theory of strength in numbers?

For some reason, I couldn’t sense anyone approaching us but I did feel like we had forgotten something . This uncomfortable feeling of not knowing was akin to feeling a pea under those eighteen layers of mattress .

When Guan Nie brought up Si Luo, he looked towards Jiao S vaguely but she did not react . Her eyes was staring wide, frowning while she turned her stiff neck around to sweep the area around us .

“Perhaps you’re too sensitive? Just as Guan Nie said, there’s no reason for any of them to be here . ” I tried to adopt Nie Zun’s method of comfort and moved to give her a pat on the shoulder .

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“Perhaps you’re too sensitive? Just as Guan Nie said, there’s no reason for any of them to be here . ” I tried to adopt Nie Zun’s method of comfort and moved to give her a pat on the shoulder .

However, just as I lifted my hand, my heart sank sharply . I remembered what we had forgotten . My eyes widened in gradual realization . At the same time, Jiao S seemed to have made a connection about the owner of that unnerving aura . She turned swiftly with a creak in her neck and looked at me .

When our eyes met, I knew... We were thinking of the same person .

She appeared before either of us had the chance to speak . She hadn’t been hiding . Rather, she had always approached things from afar and in an unhurried manner . She drifted in from mid-air, at a slightly higher altitude above where we stood .

She always loved floating around like this since a long time ago . I could still remember her beautiful smile when she said to me, “Ah Shen, the split zone is actually pretty nice! Look, you can float like this, just like a flower . ”

She really did look like a flower .

Not the stereotypical, cheesy type of flower . More like a fusion of beauty and pureness from all the flowers in this world, like the queen of flowers . And at this moment, that was exactly what she looked like . Smiling that beautiful smile of hers, whirling around and floating like the wind, slowly drifting towards us .

Her black hair was coiled gorgeously into a bun at the top and flowing down her chest on the lower half, strands of it framing her face, lightly fluttering with the breeze . There were also those limpid eyes of hers . Where Guan Nie's beauty was coquettish, hers was soft and gentle . Just as I've said before, she was someone who could make others feel good simply with her presence .

She had always taken a liking to dressing herself in ancient costumes and she suited them well, looking much like the beauties in those tales of old . If she could travel back in time, she would have looked even more beautiful than she did in modern clothes . Right now, she wore an ancient garb and a yellow yarn dress . I recognized her—of course I did—but before I could call her name, Jiao S was already ahead of me .

Her eyes were slowly flooding with a complex loathing, her raspy and heavy voice sounded . “Li Wen . So it's true that you are still alive . ”

Li Wen smiled gently, then glided to a spot not far away from us, landing light on her feet . A pair of plain, white cloth shoes softly touched the ground .

“Ah Shen, Jiao S, long time no see,” she chimed, her voice drifting towards us along with her moving gaze .

Chapter 57

57 I'm a Soul Splitter

I suppose I must have looked rather bewildered at that moment .

I wasn't able to gather myself on such short notice, nor could I put on an appropriate expression to face situation before me . What was even more awkward, was that even Jiao S had fallen silent . At the sight of that smile tugging along the corners of Li Wen's lips, the few of us stood under the grey, overcast sky in stillness .

I swear, this was the exact type of scenario I loathed the most . With a turn of my head, I attempted to seek Nie Zun's help but came to a halt at the unexpected sight of Jie Pa . With a push against his glasses, he made his way to Li Wen and extended a friendly handshake towards the gentle but stern woman .

“Long time no see, Li Wen . You've been missing for so long—where did you go? You didn't even pay us a visit . ”

Jie Pa spoke naturally, as though there was nothing abnormal with this interaction but what he said was indeed true . In Western District, Li Qing once thought very highly of Li Wen . I don't know how close Jie Pa and her had been, but to me... she and I were close enough to be sisters . Still, I didn't know what to say . Not when so much time had passed . Not when Jiao S had told me about Li Wen being Li Qing's soul splitter . Not when—above all of this—there was the lingering speculation that she might have been related to yesterday evening's incident .

Li Wen's lips moved slightly, her voice still soft . “Jie Pa, we've known each other for a long time now . If the intention behind your handshake is to

sense my body constitution and compare them to that of Song Lu, then don't trouble yourself . That's precisely the reason I'm here today . ”

Jie Pa grew a little embarrassed but he calmly retracted his hand, nodding with a smile of his own .

Li Wen stroked the hair along her cheeks elegantly, her limpid eyes directing their gaze towards me . “Ah Shen, you must have a lot of questions, right?”

My lips moved as it attempted to search for all the right words to say, but it was futile; I didn't breathe a word .

Jiao S' hoarse voice resounded instead . “If you have something to say, then spill it! What's with the suspense?!”

Li Wen's gaze swept across to Jiao S . It was as though she had no memory of being stripped bare and humiliated in front of everyone by Jiao S; there was not a single trace of hatred or disgust in her eyes . In fact, she didn't even appear to pay Jiao S any mind at all . She merely swiped her gaze over to her leisurely, as one would to a bird up in a tree .

I turned my head to look at Jiao S . Her big eyes were staring once more and I could feel her dismal mood rising slowly .

“Ah Shen, I was the person you saw that day . I'm also the one who flung all those innocent people out of their windows and to their deaths . ” Li Wen's voice was smooth as water, and her tone light and casual as if this was just a casual heart-to-heart talk between girls .

Except this wasn't whispers spoken in confidence between teenage girls but an admission to her heinous crime . I finally found my voice . “How could you talk about them like they were nothing, Li Wen?”

Li Wen lowered her eyes gently then lifted them again with a smile . “Sometimes, there's nothing wrong with sacrificing the redundant in exchange for what's necessary . The purpose of my visit today is to warn

you to stay out of it and stop meddling in this affair . I know about You Ji's betrayal; Western District is now in her control . ”

She stepped forward as she spoke, moving that slight bit closer to me . “Ah Shen, how could you be so careless? You gave You Ji so much time to prepare for her betrayal . All three of us survived under Li Qing's care and guidance, and after all that time together even I could see her for who she truly is . Why is it that you just can't seem to do that?”

There was no a hint of hesitation in my response this time . I parted my lips and looked at her without fear . “After all this time, neither have I seen you for who you really are, isn't that right?”

There was a flicker in Li Wen's eyes .

Jiao S scoffed . “What right do you have to mention Li Qing? If it wasn't for you, she would have been able to return to the real world a long time ago!”

It was as though Jiao S' words had gone unheard; Li Wen's gaze remained fixated on me . “Ah Shen, Li Qing left the Western District in your care . If that's your attitude, then perhaps You Ji should continue running the district . ”

It was as though Jiao S' words had gone unheard; Li Wen's gaze remained fixated on me . “Ah Shen, Li Qing left the Western District in your care . If that's your attitude, then perhaps You Ji should continue running the district . ”

“So you're on You Ji's side now?” I smiled, my eyes never leaving hers .

She reciprocated the smile . “How could I be? I'm just telling you that it's time you snap out of it . ”

“You used more than a hundred innocent lives, just to tell me that?” I was still smiling, yet there was an increasing hostility with every sentence .

Li Wen's soft eyes flickered once more . “When did you get this critical?”

With a slight lift of my head, I narrowed my eyes, my sardonic smile deepening . “Li Wen, I have always been like this . After such a long time, haven’t you seen me for who I am?”

That’s right, I have always been like this, Li Wen . Li Qing knows, as does Nie Zun, and even You Ji should too . But, do you?

In reality, I’m a weirdo with mind-splitting disorder . I’m that kid who couldn’t gain the acceptance of others . Did you think I would be soft-tempered and beautiful like you? I’m afraid I will never be that .

Li Wen... I guess you never knew how envious I was of you . I was so envious of you and still, I liked you so much . Even through my jealousy I adored you; you were such a perfect person . I used to watch as you stood alongside Li Qing with that gentleness of yours against Li Qing’s valiance . I imagined it countless times; if I could be just like you with that untainted disposition, could I then be worthy of Gao Qi?

But I can never be like you . Not even in my wildest dreams .

I am a strange woman filled with darkness and cracks . Before the split zone, there was practically no one who liked me apart from my parents . I admit that I’m trash, one who would envy the happiness of others . I had once been jealous of you too, yet somehow, when I saw Jiao S torturing you that day, there was a gnawing pain in my heart . It was so painful that it rendered me useless; all I could do was clutch my chest and kneel on the ground . That part of me... that is someone you would never understand no matter how long it took, right?

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So, why do we even bother playing the blame game?

“Ah Shen, you’ve changed . ” Li Wen whispered . Her voice was as gentle as before but her smile was beginning to fade . Her eyes were smeared with an indiscernible sorrow . See, this is how easily you are able to touch a person’s heart, even if your only weapons were those subtle gaze and gesture .

“It’s too boring to talk about that now . ” My smile mirrored hers, fading gradually and I let my eyes relax . “Let’s talk about what’s going on with the recent incidents instead . ”

Li Wen sighed . “Alright . Let me tell you about it then . ”

Then, she grew more grim . “All the incidents you’ve encountered recently were led by a broken-armed woman named Du Yue . Du Yue is from Northern District and none of you have ever met her because you don’t know the secret to that district . However, I can’t tell you much about that either . The only thing I can tell you, is that Du Yue came to Southern District for a massive experiment . If she succeeds, then many lives would be compromised . ”

Jiao S and I were unusually in sync, both without any questions . Li Wen continued with a sigh . “Now, her main subordinates executing this are You Ji and Rong Jin . They are planning to have two perfect body constitution to be used as the most powerful weapon for murder . One of them is the type of blood within Song Lu . Without exception, any damage caused by the blood-stained weapon could be fatal, even if it was the body of our consciousness in the split zone . ”

I frowned . “But it lost effectiveness when I attacked You Ji with the blood-stained Piercer . ”

Li Wen’s lips parted again . “That because Song Lu wasn’t the perfect specimen for experiment, just like me . Once her blood has left her body for more than ten minutes, it will no longer have the same effect . I’m the same—we are both failed experiments . ”

Jie Pa seemed to have reached an epiphany . “Which means to say, while your blood may be used to kill someone, it has a time-restriction?”

Li Wen nodded . “That’s exactly right . I’ve been observing all of you in the dark . That is the reason for Song Lu’s regurgitation of those poisonous insects . Those bugs with the same fuchsia color as the beetle—they are the offsprings of those leeches that fused with us . ”

Ugh... A sense of nausea rushed towards my chest . Offspring? Those beetles were the offspring of that long, oversized and repulsive centipede-like creature with the two pincers? Did it have to be this disgusting? And they were reproduced within Song Lu’s stomach .

Li Wen nodded . “That’s exactly right . I’ve been observing all of you in the dark . That is the reason for Song Lu’s regurgitation of those poisonous insects . Those bugs with the same fuchsia color as the beetle—they are the offsprings of those leeches that fused with us . ”

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Li Wen seemed to notice my repulsion . “That’s right, those things originated from the soul snatcher . Rong Jin snatched the souls of centipedes, leeches and crabs, and forcibly brought them into Split Zone No . 13 . Through methods that even I have no understanding of, they refined them . Still, the abilities of a soul snatcher have limitations; they were unable to force the souls of organisms into this world unrestrictedly, which is why they thought of using the female body to conceive them .

“Of course, the body in the split zone cannot conceive but they are trying to devise a way . After all, only bodies projected by consciousness exist in this world—and they are the most realistic form of a body—so there’s always a way to make the people here a subject to their experiment . Song Lu and I are among those people but I was the first to fail . Not only does my blood lose its effect within ten minutes of leaving my body, I was also unable to conceive those creatures . ”

Jiao S looked at her firmly . “Why?”

Li Wen returned her stare . “You should know . It’s because I’m a soul splitter . ”

Even though Jiao S had already told me this, even though I’ve believed her all along, hearing Li Wen acknowledge the fact was still enough to startle me . There was an actual soul splitter standing right in front of me . Even those at the sidelines—Nie Zun, who had been casually leaning around, and Guan Nie who was fiddling with his hair—froze . Without moving, they glanced up at Li Wen .

Li Wen’s lips arched into a smile again, her beauty enough to cause the fall of a city . “Yes, you heard that right . I’m a soul splitter... I’m Li Qing’s soul splitter . ”

Following that, she turned around slowly, lifting up her yellow dress as she revealed the back of her snow-skinned waist . Her slender waist was displayed so casually but what captured my attention was the split symbol on it .

The back of her waist was imprinted with Li Qing’s peach blossom-shaped symbol .

Chapter 58

58 Don't Even Think About Taking Song Lu

After revealing her symbol, Li Wen rearranged her clothes unhurriedly before turning back around . “This is the truth . I am a soul splitter and so is that broken-armed woman . I don’t know with whom her symbol corresponds, only that you won’t be able to defeat her . ”

“The soul splitters we’ve been pursuing for so long have never made an appearance in the split zone and now, out of nowhere, there are two?” Jiao S scoffed . “How do you expect us to believe it?”

Li Wen smiled . “It doesn’t matter either way . This is the truth . Every single person here has been to the hall of Northern District . Do you recall that there isn’t a ceiling over it?”

At her words, the image came back to me at once . That’s right . The hall had been almost a thousand square metres in size, surrounded by four slabs of snow-white porcelain walls . With the exception of the screen which could show real-time snippets of the real world, there was nothing else there . Looking ahead, the only thing you could see was a flood of blinding white light .

However, if you did look up, you would realise that there was no ceiling over it . The top of the hall was nothing but an infinite black hole . I had once pondered over it too but did not pay it much mind . Since the sky in the split zone is grey, I didn’t bother dwelling on any other strange phenomenon that happens here . Back then, I had only lifted my head slightly; the hall looked as though it had been built at the bottom of a pitch-black pit, seemingly running endlessly deep . Even if you did lift your head

to its full extent, you would not be able to spot the end of that tunnel . All you would be able to see... is total darkness .

“That black hole you saw is the habitat of soul splitters . Mr Blond can’t reach it either . No one knows the secret to split zone’s soul splitters; it’s mere conjecture even on Mr Blond’s part . ” Li Wen’s gentle voice was strong and forceful at the same time, slapping us with these words of reality .

I deepened my frown . “If there is truly such a secret, then why are you telling us?”

With a faint smile, Li Wen replied . “I didn’t say anything and I never will . I’m a soul splitter after all . The only thing I can tell you is that, if Du Yue succeeds with her experiment then a bloodbath in the split zone will not be far away . ”

My eyes widened . “This... What exactly is this experiment about?”

“There are two segments . One of them is the body constitution that would allow reproduction of these diabolical leeches and seamlessly infuse them with the body at the same time . Their blood will carry an eternal ability to damage those who come in contact with it, and the offsprings of those leeches will be the perfect specimen to continue on to their next subject . This is where Song Lu and I failed .

“Then, there’s Laurel . Her experiment is on mental strength . Children have greater potential in honing their mental strength due to their young age, and they are easily manipulated and controlled . They want to create a child with high MF . Laurel was the first experimental subject who was near success, but the specific details aren’t known since she ran away . ”

I clenched my fist, my mind preoccupied by the words: Experimental subject... Experimental subject... how could they, Laurel is still so young!

“Why would they choose a soul splitter like you to conduct the experiment? Isn’t that claim too far-fetched?” Jiao S sneered .

Li Wen shook her head in resignation . “I’m just their sacrificial lamb . They wanted to find out if a soul splitter’s body was any different to a regular body of consciousness . In any case, I can’t say anything more than that . The reason I’m here, is to take Song Lu away . ”

At her words, I firmly and immediately shook my head . “Don’t even think about it! Li Wen, after all that you’ve spouted, your real motive had been to take her away?”

Li Wen stopped smiling, and looked me right in the eye . “Ah Shen, I know this is upsetting but you must hand Song Lu over to me . I’m still one of them which means two things . One, I have to bring her back to them and two, you will only end up getting her killed if she continues to stay by your side!

“Her body is imperfect . I suppose she only regurgitated those worms once? Did you think that will be the end of it? I trust you saw how she looked then, and it’s going to happen again for a second or third time but never more than that . After the third, there’s no doubt that she will be die . Even if it’s to continue the experiment, the only way we can save her is for me bring her back . ”

“No! Absolutely not! Don’t even think about it!” I was practically screaming those words . I can never forget about that day outside that stone wall; because of my hesitance and cowardice, I saw for myself the torture they put Song Lu through . Apart from Li Qing, Song Lu was the one person who was kindest to me, who treated me well . I will never condemn her to that hellhole again!

“No! Absolutely not! Don’t even think about it!” I was practically screaming those words . I can never forget about that day outside that stone wall; because of my hesitance and cowardice, I saw for myself the torture they put Song Lu through . Apart from Li Qing, Song Lu was the one person who was kindest to me, who treated me well . I will never condemn her to that hellhole again!

As I screamed, a wisp of red hair swept across my face and stuck itself to my quivering lips . Song Lu was still here, right by my side, yet for some

reason it felt as though I had just been robbed of my dearest treasure . The image of Song Lu covered in blood that day, her sunken eyes, her flesh relentlessly torn apart by those poisonous insects to such an extent where she was unable to even let out a proper cry . That image... For the past few days, I hadn't even the strength to recall them .

No... I will not allow that to happen again!

I bit down on my bottom lip harshly and the taste of blood spread across the tip of my tongue .

Li Wen looked as if she was caught between a rock and a hard place . “It doesn't matter if you believe what I've said or not . Regardless, you'll have to return to your own districts now . As far as I'm concerned, they're still lacking something and will not be able to complete the experiment immediately . Please stay united no matter what; only with the alliance of the Western and Eastern Districts will you have even a glimmer of hope at winning . ”

All of a sudden Guan Nie, who had thus far stayed silent, stopped toying with his hair and directed his words at Li Wen . “If everything is as you say, then I'd like to know more about that broken-armed woman, Du Yue . Why is she looking for Si Luo?”

The look in Li Wen's eyes shifted at the mention of Si Luo and I grew alert as well . Why is everyone connected to Si Luo in some way?

As I was stuck in my musings, Li Wen had already started her response . “I can't answer that . I can only tell you about the things you have to be on guard against . There's not much time left—please hand Song Lu over to me . ”

Without warning, Jiao S started laughing hysterically . “Li Wen, I see you're still as cunning as ever! When all is said and done, aren't you just afraid you'd get decapitated by the broken-armed woman if you don't return with Song Lu?”

Li Wen, who had always been gentle and pure, suddenly let out an alluring laugh . “Decapitated? I’m a soul splitter, Jiao S . Have you forgotten? Only Li Qing’s split key would be able to kill me, but Li Qing... As you know ___”

Li Wen, who had always been gentle and pure, suddenly let out an alluring laugh . “Decapitated? I’m a soul splitter, Jiao S . Have you forgotten? Only Li Qing’s split key would be able to kill me, but Li Qing... As you know ___”

Before she could even finish her sentence, Jiao S was already glaring . “I won’t allow you to sully her name!”

A sudden storm surged, the influx of air howled and columns of whirlwind charged towards Li Wen . I have grown so accustomed to the unpredictable attacks of those with control over airflow that by this time, no matter how much I swayed unsteadily against the storm, my expression remained relaxed . For some reason, I had a random thought: Gust and gale however they pleased—the boundary forest was sturdy enough anyway .

Perhaps I was trying to conceal my worries about our situation . Whether it was Li Wen trying to take Song Lu away, or the fact we may be forced to fight Li Wen at some point—neither was a scenario I was willing to confront . Somehow, since arriving at Split Zone No . 13, I’ve always been forced into this type of situation .

Just when I was feeling a little down, Jiao S pulled out her sword with lightning speed and sprung towards Li Wen .

“Don’t even think about taking any of us!” Jiao S’ shout was unusually loud, and with her hoarseness it sounded almost gruff .

I was taken aback for a moment—not because of the harsh tone of her voice, but that she had used the word ‘us’ .

Even in face of Jiao S’ attack, Li Wen was unperturbed . Her black hair fluttered loose in the wind and danced in the air, her cheeks tugged with the

hint of a smile . As Jiao S rushed at her with sword in hand, Li Wen's plain shoes tapped the ground below and, lithely, she leapt .

In mid-air, Li Wen's red lips parted and she spoke easily . "Since you chose to fight with a sword, then let me show you mine too!" Just as the words left her, she reached back with her right hand and pulled out a slender sword from thin air . Her expression was graceful and calm, as though what she's holding wasn't a sword sharp enough to wound but a peaceful dove .

We spent quite a bit of time together in the past but I have never seen her wielding a sword .

A feeling of unease filled my heart but I couldn't be bothered with worrying any longer . Holding up the bow that was slung on my back, I set my sight on Li Wen with the three arrows . "Li Wen, if you insist on fighting her, then don't blame me for this!"

We spent quite a bit of time together in the past but I have never seen her wielding a sword .

A feeling of unease filled my heart but I couldn't be bothered with worrying any longer . Holding up the bow that was slung on my back, I set my sight on Li Wen with the three arrows . "Li Wen, if you insist on fighting her, then don't blame me for this!"

Just as I was about to fire, Jiao S' sword had already struck . Li Wen ignored me; instead, her gentle lips were curved into a cold arc . With light movements, her slender sword sliced in both horizontal and vertical strokes, drawing the shape of a plus sign .

Following her strikes, something akin to a cross materialized in the air and like a shield, it blocked the razor light that came from Jiao S's attack . Jiao S reeled backwards as it deflected the attack back onto her faster than it had before . Jiao S arced her body backwards in haste, the light just grazing the tip of her nose .

From the impact of the contact, Jiao S fell back onto the ground . Stumbling a few steps back, I could see blood gradually flowing from her nose but the

arrows in my hand never left . I clenched my teeth, watching Li Wen who had floated way up high .

Li Wen was never able to fly this high in the past because that would exhaust a great amount of MF . Yet, seeing her now, I realized that even as a soul splitter, she must have been hiding her real potential all this while .

She didn't give me extra time to think either; with a smirk, she lifted the slender sword again and drew another three crosses in the air . Then, along with the first giant shield from before, those four shields fell from the sky without warning . Sensing the threat that rang in my subconscious mind, I immediately pulled out the Piercer with my left hand .

The first cruciform shield which attacked Jiao S had seemingly gained sight as it adjusted its direction like a homing missile and began charging towards me .

Crack! I waved the Piercer with immense strength and a flash of violet light shot forward .

Thump! Deflected by the shield, the violet light ricocheted towards me again . I jumped away from attack and the shield leapt along with me into mid-air . The other three giant shields seemed to come alive too, starting their attack towards Jiao S, Nie Zun and Guan Nie respectively .

No matter how I dodged, the cruciform shield followed closely at my heels without slowing down . I didn't know what would happen if I collided against it and any attack will only be deflected... All I could do is to keep evading .

Chapter 59

59 War at Sea

In the midst of dodging, Guan Nie leapt, his white hair flowing behind him . With a glance, he overflowed with grace . “I hate fighting and the like; they are not beautiful at all! You’re very beautiful yet you chose to do such unbeautiful things, so don’t blame my beautiful self for being discourteous!”

His words went right over my head; forget about that tongue-twister, did he really have to refer to himself as ‘my beautiful self’?!

Guan Nie squinted his almond eyes and shouted, “Sleep!”

What?? What is he playing at? Sleep... What sleep?! Sleep where, with who?

To hear such a ridiculous cry coming from him in the middle of this constant evasion, at such a time of confusion, it was a moment before I suddenly realized our surroundings had changed drastically . In an instant, the boundary forest disappeared and was instead replaced by the vast ocean . Countless rocks lined upon the sea and each of us stood upon a different piece .

I haven’t seen the ocean in such a long time, it was with uncontrollable awe that I stayed stupefied by the sight . Could it be... that this is an illusion? If it truly is an illusion, I suddenly wished to never wake up .

Swoosh!

A wave crashed against the rock underneath my feet .

The giant shields were gone . Just as the rest of us, Li Wen was standing atop a rock not far away from me, the slender sword in her hand had vanished . I looked around me: except for the absence of Guan Nie, everyone else was in the same position, each standing on a different rock . Above us the sky was still grey but the water beneath us was a sea of dark blue .

Li Wen stopped smiling, her eyes taking in the new surroundings with a cursory glance . “An illusion?”

It seemed Jiao S didn’t intend to dwell on that possibility nor had she planned to give Li Wen a breather . She narrowed her eyes and waves after waves of airstream surged from the surface of the sea .

Roar!

Caught between the drastic tumbling of airflow, I wobbled on my spot . From a distance away, I could see Jie Pa balancing unsteadily as well and grew worried . If it was true that you could get hurt even in an illusion, then in Jie Pa’s vulnerable state—with the body of a regular person from the real world—there was no way he could fight this battle at sea!

Before I was done fretting, Nie Zun had already begun jumping his way towards Jie Pa along the lined rocks . He grabbed onto Jie Pa with an outstretched arm and the latter immediately flashed a grateful smile . With Nie Zun by Jie Pa’s side, there was not much left to be anxious over .

Securing my Piercer back into the waistband of my dress, I took aim at Li Wen with my bow . Jiao S’ airstream had raised giant tides which were now charging towards Li Wen . Billows of water vapor hissed in the air—there was simply no way I could take aim!

Li Wen curled her lips . “Combining the power of illusion with your air manipulation? He lives up to his reputation indeed; I have long heard rumors that the skill of Eastern District’s Guan Nie is on an equal footing with Southern District’s top illusionist!”

Right after her high praises, she pulled both hands from her dress and made an intersection with her arms, into the shape of a cross . “Fall!” With her soft command, the sky began raining innumerable cruciform swords . Although they appeared smaller than the shields, all four points of the sword were extremely sharp .

With nowhere to hide from the attack, I held up the Piercer and braced myself in deflecting any falling swords . At the speed they were dropping, however, it seemed this would be a difficult task to follow through .

Jiao S yelled out suddenly, “Freeze!”

Hissss!

Bang, bang, bang!

At the sound of her shout, layers of water vapor solidified rapidly over our heads . Still, it was apparent that the intensity of the cruciform swords’ fall was powerful as layer after layer of frozen vapor shattered upon impact .

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A violent storm was whirling in Jiao S’ eyes . As her black hair whipped behind her, it was obvious that she was exhausting a extensive amount of MF just to protect us .

The frozen layers of vapor above Nie Zun were splintering as well . He retained an arm around Jie Pa as his lips pulled into a smirk, slowly bringing his free gloved hand to his slightly pale lips then pressed them around the tip of fabric around his middle finger . Before he was done with his delicate movement, the surface of the water around us suddenly swelled into huge waves .

Countless waves lashed themselves towards the sky, smashing the remaining barriers into smithereens along with the cruciform swords .

Relentlessly, the waves rushed and in a blink of an eye the swords were all thrust out of sight .

Li Wen bit her lips lightly at the scene before her, face tinted with restrained anger . “Guan Nie, it seems that I won’t be able win this battle without escaping your illusion first . ”

She shut her eyes abruptly, then exclaimed again, “Shatter!”

The myriad of cruciform swords appeared once again from all directions but instead of attacking us, they formed a ring and tore away at full speed towards the far corners of our surrounding .

“Let’s see how expansive an illusion you’re capable of constructing—I refuse to believe I won’t be able to destroy it!” Right as she finished speaking, the swords seemed to collide with the edge, emitting a continuous cacophony of banging .

All of a sudden, a devilish laughter rang out from the skies . “Actually, the rumor isn’t all that accurate; saying I’m on equal footing with the number one illusionist in Southern District isn’t all that true but—Ah, but what about it? Heh... Why don’t you witness it for yourself?”

In the distance, the tumbling sound of endless tsunamis seemed to roll in from the edge of the shattered illusion . I couldn’t see them clearly, and neither did I understand what was happening . In the midst of the air turbulence and waves, I was only focused on staying steady on this rock . On the other hand, Nie Zun’s gaze seemed hold a gleam of strange anticipation . He stopped clamping the glove between his lips and had instead grabbed the unstable Jie Pa with both hands .

Li Wen’s expression shifted upon hearing the distant roaring . “Are you able to manipulate elements of nature now? Without bounds? That’s not possible, my cruciform swords collided with the edge of your illusion earlier!

“But... ehehe... Even if I’m not powerful enough to attack an illusionist, aren’t you underestimating me a little too much, Guan Nie?” Li Wen

murmured under her breath, raising both arms up high at the same time . The action heralded the arrival of an endless number of giant cruciform swords from the bottom of the sea .

“But... ehehe... Even if I’m not powerful enough to attack an illusionist, aren’t you underestimating me a little too much, Guan Nie?” Li Wen murmured under her breath, raising both arms up high at the same time . The action heralded the arrival of an endless number of giant cruciform swords from the bottom of the sea .

Their emergence caused the surface to shake once more and I swayed along with the momentum . Just like before, we weren’t the target of those giant swords . Instead, they soared upwards towards the grey sky . In the midst of my swaying, I could see Nie Zun lifting a hand, still wearing his black glove . He was gazing intently at one of the swords not far behind me, shooting towards the sky like all the others . He reached a hand towards the sword with an open palm and suddenly curled his fingers into a tight grip .

I looked back in haste—the sword had changed direction with Nie Zun’s gesture and rushed towards him instead . Witnessing the scene, shock swept across Li Wen’s eyes . Attracted to Nie Zun’s unknown magnetism, the giant sword whistled as it whizzed past me .

Right before it reached Nie Zun, he jerked his hands in another direction and an even more inconceivable thing happened . It was as though his hand could stretch limitlessly to wield that giant sword as the weapon began altering its direction on his whim . This time it flew in a spiral, like the darts in movies and it rushed towards Li Wen .

“Such a minor trick!” Li Wen scoffed . Lifting her right hand, the slender sword appeared again . She drew a cross in front of her chest vigorously and her shield materialized once more . The cruciform sword charged decisively towards it .

My mind was filled with trivially irrelevant thoughts: Was this a contest between the strongest sword and the strongest shield? Which would win?

However, reality soon hit when the sword collided against the shield—it swiftly rebounded back at Nie Zun . Still, he looked as composed as ever; from the corner of my eyes, I caught a glint of wicked slyness flashing across his . With an effortless flick of his wrist he deflected the sword just as it was about to graze him .

It was then that I suddenly realized Jiao S had snuck up behind Li Wen without my knowledge .

She raised the sword high above her head and in that instant, it grew tenfold in size and into the image of a large sword . Jiao S hacked towards the back of Li Wen’s head with immense strength, seemingly without hesitation . By the time Li Wen tore her eyes from Nie Zun and reacted to Jiao S’ attack, the sword was already by the top of her head .

My face twitched . What was deal about bringing a gun loaded with those mental inhibitor bullets when we first arrived, then? These people... Once they have activated their split symbol, they gained the ability to manipulate the elements of nature . What use would a gun be towards them?

Just as Jiao S’ sword was about to strike Li Wen’s forehead, something hit me .

Li Wen’s a soul splitter—does that mean she possesses the same powers as us? Could she activate her split symbol? Did she have a splitting key? I didn’t see one when she revealed her symbol to us... Did that mean her powers were not activated? If that’s the case... then it means all her current strength was in spite of an unsplit symbol .

I shuddered, but there was no need to ponder any further—Jiao S’ sword had relentlessly split Li Wen into half .

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Puuu! Fresh blood splattered .

Jiao S did not hold back nor did she hesitate . From head to toe, she sliced Li Wen into clean halves and the once beautiful Li Wen was not even remotely as charming anymore . Her eyes were now in separate bodies while fresh blood spouted from each side . The seemingly endless sprays of blood stained the rocks and ocean, before the droplets were soon swallowed by the sea, gone without a trace .

That was a truly gruesome style of fighting, Jiao S... I felt sickened just thinking about it . That's definitely not the style for me .

Of course, Li Wen would definitely heal . Which was why, when both parts of her body collapsed against the rock, Jiao S called out, "Jie Pa!"

Jie Pa stood not too far away alongside Nie Zun, and he seemed to understand Jiao S' intention . He lifted both hands calmly and faced the slowly healing body of Li Wen with a gesture that signified stop . He whispered a soft, "Seal!"

Just like that, the two halves of Li Wen's body stopped moving mid-way through healing . My vision was suddenly overwhelmed by the gruesome sight of her body . Her lower body had completely healed and was covered in fresh blood, but anything above her waist had stopped its recovery and remained a huge crack . Li Wen's face was likewise split into two . With her torso teetering on her lower body, it made her exceptionally horrifying to look at .

Yet Li Wen's lips, which had not managed to reconnect, were still able to move . Her eyes seemed to move with them .

"You... You really are belittling me . "

I couldn't tell if the tugging at her lips was a smile; with her split into halves, there was simply no way of telling if she was smiling or crying .

Chapter 60

60 The Worst Battle

The split lip that was decorated with dried blood twitched began singing a sharp tune, “Yi~ Ah~ Ci~ Ah~ Yi~” The bizarre sound seemed to have a sort of melody to it but the unusually piercing tune became increasingly intense, spreading through the air .

I couldn’t help covering my ears at the sound . As I brought my hands to my ears, I saw Jie Pa growing unstable; judging by the change in expression, his enchantment doesn’t seem to be holding up either . A loud thump sounded . While it wasn’t clear exactly what had shattered, Li Wen’s body was beginning to heal again .

Li Wen, now fully healed, was still drenched in fresh blood . The ruthlessness of scarlet red bloodstains, stark against her tender and affectionate gaze, was contrasting but alluring in its own way, exuding an almost blinding charm . The smile she wore was a mix of both cruelty and warmth as she slowly got to her feet . Jiao S who had landed behind her, made haste to retreat back to her own piece of rock, clearly sensing the danger in our current situation .

Li Wen straightened up with a smile, then continued with the piercing tune . “Yi~ Ah~ Ci~ Ah~ Yi~” The strange melody seemed to be infused with MF, causing a stabbing pain to spread from my eardrum all the way to the heart .

Jie Pa was the first to cover his ears and crouch . The storm brewed in Jiao S’ eyes and her brows were knitted together . Nie Zun, on the other hand, was bent at his waist supporting Jie Pa but maintained his gaze on me .

“Yi~ Ah~”

“... Ci~ Ah~”

The horrifying tune was intensifying; my heart felt like there was a needle stabbing at it relentlessly . Between my eardrum and my heart, it was as though a piece of rope was tugging hard . Following the melody’s growing ferocity, the rope was likewise getting tighter, threatening to snap at any moment . I gritted my teeth; the tune was too much to bear and I was slowly reaching my limits . With both hands, I cupped them tightly around my ears .

Li Wen remained at the same spot, her smile still tender yet merciless when suddenly she widened her mouth and began singing even louder .

“Yi~ Ah~ Ci~ Ah~ Yi~!”

“Yi~ Ah~ Ci~ Ah~ Yi~!”

“Ah—!” I couldn’t help crying out at the profound shot through the heart, the gnawing pain made me hunch over . The last image engraved in my mind was of Nie Zun and Jiao S, both crouched over in agony, neither of whom was able to endure this strange melody .

“Yi~ Ah~ Ci~ Ah~ Yi~!”

“Yi~ Ah~ Ci~ Ah~ Yi~!”

I attempted a step forward but even the slightest movement seemed to tear my heart into shreds . Quickly realizing that covering my ears did nothing to stop the piercing tune’s effect, I let my hands fall from my ears and tried going for my bow again . The moment I shifted my hands, I felt the prickling, sharp pain in my ears .

Puu! Puu!

Both my inner ears seemed to have erupted in fresh blood . My head was buzzing and even my sight started to blur .

The sharp tune was still getting stronger and I finally reached my breaking point . Falling to my knees, a mouthful of fresh blood escaped my lips and I

struggled to look towards Nie Zun . He had both hands wrapped around Jie Pa's ears and seemed to be exhausting his MF in order to protect the other man from harm . Perhaps that was why, even when Jie Pa looked miserable, he wasn't bleeding from any of the seven openings in his head . It was a relief to see Jie Pa, who no longer could heal like us, almost unscathed .

(T/N: Seven openings include 2 for the eyes, 2 for the ears, 2 for the nostrils and 1 for the mouth)

Nie Zun wasn't as lucky; both his eyes and ears were spilling with blood but he was still unruffled, as though the liquid oozing out of his eyes wasn't actually blood but mere eye drops . He was looking at me and as my eyes were continued dripping with blood, it left my vision clouded in bright red . I was beginning to lose sight of his gaze .

Turning around, I looked towards Jiao S who mirrored my position on the ground . It seemed that the melody was prohibiting her from controlling the airflow—in a vicious repetition, her eyes would fog up with mist before it cleared again . Streams of blood slowly flowed from both her mouth and ears as well .

The excruciating pain worsened and spread itself all over my head and heart . After a few failed attempts at raising my hand with intention of wiping the blood from my eyes, I gave up and laid semi-paralyzed upon the rock .

Li Wen maintained her elegant smile, the corner of her lips covered in blood as she continued singing .

“Yi~ Ah~ Ci~ Ah~ Yi~!”

“Yi~ Ah~ Ci~ Ah~ Yi~!”

“Yi~ Ah~ Ci~ Ah~ Yi~!”

The sky of the illusion seemed to tremble with a rumbling start, and the roaring waves of the ocean seemed to gradually subside into tinier swells .

“Guan... Guan Nie...” Jiao S wanted to call out to him but she couldn’t contend with the destructive singing—a spurt of blood sprayed from her mouth instead .

Li Wen stopped her singing at that, smirking at Jiao S who was now lying prostrate on another rock . “This Demonic Tune can cut through an illusion and into Guan Nie’s ears . No matter where he’s hiding now, he would have issues taking care of himself . Are you still counting on him to save you?”

“Li—Li... ugh...” I pressed a hand to my chest and hurled another mouthful of blood . “Li... Li Wen, why are you...”

Li We turned her focus to me . “Li Shen, I’ve already told you this . You won’t be able to protect any of them . Give Song Lu to me . ”

Bang!

Distracted by her conversation with me, Nie Zun took advantage of the short period of pause; with his attention focused on the piece of rock beneath Li Wen’s feet, he winked his left eye lightly . Even as more blood dribbled from his eye from that small action, he remained quiet and calm .

Bang, bang!

Li Wen staggered as the rock under her feet promptly exploded into innumerable fragments . She was quick in stabilizing herself . With a touch of her plain shoes, she floated in the air once more and the fragments of rock sank slowly into the sea .

While she was caught up in her moment of shock, I lifted my bow and shot two arrows towards her eyes without hesitation . When she looked back, the set of double arrows flew from my bow and whizzed into her eyes .

Pu-tsst!

Blood squirted from them but she seem unfazed, the corner of her lips still sported that same smile . “Li Shen, you really haven’t changed that

preference for shooting other people's eyes . ” When she said this, she reached up to pluck out the arrows .

Laying on the ground, Jiao S whipped her head up and clenched her teeth . The storm in her eyes was back as she stared intently at Li Wen .

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Tsst, tsst!

The two columns of airstream appeared out of nowhere and pushed against the two arrows still in Li Wen's eyes, instantly plunging them through her head . Li Wen stumbled backwards in the air, her mouth grew rigid from the pain caused . The shattered sky and calm sea from before started shaking once more . This time from the wrath of Guan Nie .

Boom, boom, boom!

A colossal wave arose from behind Li Wen .

Li Wen tilted her head as though she sensed the changes to the surface of the sea . She bit her lip, angered . Without a care for the arrows in her eyes, she parted her lips and practically screamed out the tune . With her increased volume, I collapsed against the rock at the very first note of the Demonic Tune, unable to resist the damage it caused and began heaving huge mouthfuls of blood .

Rumble... Bang, bang bang!

Like the image of towns and markets of an oasis during an earthquake, the illusion began disintegrating with a crashing sound . It was as if we were in a stereoscopic mirror before . As our surroundings became fragmented and the sea gradually disappeared, the scenery of the boundary forest was revealed once again .

I continued expelling mouthful after mouthful of blood, glancing up from my position on the ground . Enshrouded among the bloodied rays of light, I

reaffirmed that we were back into the forest . Guan Nie was sitting atop a tree not far away, his cascading white hair stained with his own blood .

There was a trailing bloodstain by the corner of his lips, his eyes flashing a cold glint of viciousness . He had a hand to his chest and another supporting his weight against the tree trunk . The others were the same as me, spewing blood onto the ground in misery . Nie Zun's hands never left Jie Pa; even when Jie Pa was likewise puking mouthful of blood, his other features seemed unmarked .

Li Wen floated in the air, tossing the two arrows she had just yanked from her eyes onto the ground . She looked towards Guan Nie, "Your MF is strong enough indeed . Even my Demonic Tune couldn't make you fall?"

Guan Nie let out a sardonic laugh . The bloodstain along his lips seemed to be dripping with fresh blood again . "MF? No one here has a weak MF but none of us could have prepared against something we've never seen before . Did you really think you're all that capable?"

Sprawled on the ground, I grinded my teeth . Why isn't my MF sufficient enough to turn myself invisible? Is it because my split symbol hasn't been activated?

Li Wen raised the sleeve to her yellow dress and wiped her mouth gently . "Come on, Guan Nie . I'm not capable? I have yet to activate my split symbol and yet, the Demonic Tune was already enough to reduce all of you to this state . Do you still think I won't be able to handle the few of you on my own?"

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Li Wen raised the sleeve to her yellow dress and wiped her mouth gently . "Come on, Guan Nie . I'm not capable? I have yet to activate my split symbol and yet, the Demonic Tune was already enough to reduce all of you to this state . Do you still think I won't be able to handle the few of you on my own?"

Guan Nie's stiffened at her words .

Jiao S scoffed from her position on the ground . “If I hadn't promised Si Luo about not using that particular skill, do you really think you could still be standing this obnoxiously in front of us?”

Li Wen smiled . “Jiao S, you still wouldn't be able to deal any real damage to me . Ah, all of you . ”

At that, she whirled around towards Nie Zun who still had his hands around Jie Pa's ears as a precaution . “Nie Zun, that ability just now... was that a form of force, a skill controlled by the pupils?”

There was still a track of blood from when it flowed from his eyes earlier, as with the corner of his lips . When Li Wen called his name, his indifferent eyes swept a fleeting glance at her but he did not answer . Seeing as Nie Zun bore no intention of responding to her, Li Wen laughed scornfully but did not attempt to force a reply .

Instead, she turned gracefully around and the slender sword appeared in her hand again, casting it towards Jiao S . The action came so unexpectedly that even Jiao S had no time to react before she let out a hiss . Just like that, the slender sword was thrust into Jiao S' back .

Jiao S spewed a gush of blood, furrowed her brows and glared . Just as she seemed to move towards tugging the sword from her back, shock filled her eyes .

“Stop using your MF . Do you really think you won't exhaust your MF once you've activated your split symbol? The layers of protective barriers you cast over them in the illusion used up an extensive amount of natural elements, and now you won't be able to regain your MF for a period of time . You'll need time... but this Parting Sword of mine will absorb your MF and restrict such behavior!”

Following her words, as though the stealth enchantment had lost effectiveness, two other people appeared from thin air and fell to the ground; they were the still unconscious Song Lu and Huan Qing!

Li Wen spared a glance at the two who lay motionless on the ground, then smiled . “See, your MF isn’t even enough to support that airflow dimension of yours anymore . ”

Jiao S clenched her teeth tightly, a deep hatred evident in her eyes .

Chapter 61

61 A Difficult Choice

My own head and heart were beginning to heal while Jiao S was trapped on the ground . Just as I started to get up, the silhouette of a man dashed out from the jungle—out of nowhere, Ku Fei emerged . His eyes were washed with anger when he stared at me . “Li Shen, you lied to me?!”

He glanced over at Huan Qing then rushed to his side, supporting the unconscious man on himself and glowered at me once more . “You did have something to do with Lord Huan Qing and Ms Mi Fu’s disappearance! It was a good thing I followed all of you in secret . I even took a long time searching for you when you disappeared out of the blue!”

I was just about to speak when Li Wen got there before me, her brows creased . “You’ve been following them all this while? That means to say, you’ve been there all along until we disappeared? So you heard everything we spoke about earlier?”

Ku Fei was stunned at the fact that the beautiful Li Wen was speaking to him, but he quickly gathered himself and responded immediately . “Yeah, but what was the deal about all of that? I can’t be bothered about anything else, I just want to know the whereabouts of Ms Mi Fu . Where have you people taken her?”

Li Wen’s eyes flashed with an indecipherable delight . My heart sank .

Sure enough, Li Wen worked MF suddenly, “Fall!”

In that instant, a cruciform sword fell from the sky and drove towards Ku Fei . At the same time, Li Wen lifted a hand and dug her nails into the pulse

of her other wrist . Blood sprayed from the punctured wrist and as the sword flew past her in mid-air, she coated it with her blood .

No... That's not good . She's planning to send him to his doom! Her fresh blood was enough to let Ku Fei lose his healing abilities . I reacted at once, stumbling to my feet with full intention of rushing forward but there wasn't enough time . The sword was going to plunge itself into Ku Fei and Huan Qing any second now .

All of a sudden, there was a flash of movement and they... they actually disappeared! With a thump, the sword stabbed straight into the ground instead .

I hadn't caught Ku Fei's movement at all . In the midst of my shock, I saw Ku Fei carrying Huan Qing in his arms, having dodged to the other side of the attack . Ku Fei's eyes were filled with rage, but both his arms held onto Huan Qing steadily .

Li Wen was obviously bewildered, "How did you—Your speed could actually surpass my cruciform sword? Who are you?"

Ku Fei was fuming with anger . "What do you mean who am I?! What's so difficult about dodging that giant sword of yours? I've never met anyone who could run faster than me! And while we're talking about that—are you crazy, woman?! I heard the talk about you being a soul splitter, which means you're not associated with Li Shen and the rest, so why in the world did you attack me?!"

Li Wen stared wide-eyed at the mention of her being a soul splitter .
"Because you've heard things you shouldn't!"

Ku Fei leapt further away from Li Wen with Huan Qing in his arms . "Who cares about all that? I just want to know where Ms Mi Fu is!"

I replied hastily, "Ku Fei, listen to me . We weren't the ones who hurt Huan Qing, we brought him along to save him! You didn't see it when we disappeared but we were the ones who concealed his presence so we could

prevent this woman from hurting him! Mi Fu was also taken by them!” I declared loudly, pointing to Li Wen .

Yet Ku Fei only shook his head furiously . “Stop lying to me! I’m not going to believe any of you—I’m taking Lord Huan Qing away!”

He had probably realized there was no way he could go up against us all by himself, and so with his words he fled in haste into the deeper end of the forest . Li Wen swung her sleeves with full intention of chasing after him, but with a wave of his hand Guan Nie obstructed her sight with a puff of fog .

Li Wen glared at Guan Nie and halted in her steps, lifted a hand and waved it downwards again . With that movement, the sword she had stuck into Jiao S let out a violent, raucous wail .

I twisted my head towards Jiao S and saw the sword in her back glowing in a blinding light . All at once Jiao S’ eyes widened, as though she was enduring some form of torment .

Just as I was about to rush over, Li Wen spoke up coldly, “Li Shen, one more step and I will leave her in such an overwhelming agony, she’d rather die . My Parting Sword can absorb MF and forcefully drag it out of her . She’s already regaining MF at a slower pace too . With the combination of the two, I suppose, I can completely damage her mental strength at any time . If you dare take another step forward, I will leave her forever wrecked in paralysis!”

Just as I was about to rush over, Li Wen spoke up coldly, “Li Shen, one more step and I will leave her in such an overwhelming agony, she’d rather die . My Parting Sword can absorb MF and forcefully drag it out of her . She’s already regaining MF at a slower pace too . With the combination of the two, I suppose, I can completely damage her mental strength at any time . If you dare take another step forward, I will leave her forever wrecked in paralysis!”

I bit my lips, my enlarged eyes turned to glower at Li Wen, an arrow already locked and aimed at her .

Li Wen merely smiled at the bow in my hands . “Li Shen, recklessness won’t do you any good . Look at your situation now—none of you can resist my Demonic Tune in this state . Even if you were able to, with just a shift of my hand, Jiao S’ mental strength will be completely exhausted by my Parting Sword . I presume you didn’t know about this before but her split symbol is also on her back... and my Parting Sword is now jabbed right into it, able to completely destroy her MF at my whim! Even if it’s not stained with my blood and I’m unable to kill her, she will still remain paralyzed for the rest of time .

“And you... Are you confident that you’ll be able to kill me in the split second before I drop my arm?”

My lips had already been injured from my biting and was slowly beginning to mend, but I didn’t give it the chance . I continued chewing till it split open once more . I honestly had no idea what else I could do to vent this misery in my heart .

There was a dull aching along the rim of my eyes, I suppose the damage caused by her Demonic Tune had yet to be fully recovered, but I couldn’t bother with such insignificant pain and attempted to widen my eyes even more to glare at Li Wen .

Li Wen had already lifted her arm slightly, a gentle smile on her face .
“Look at the people around you . ”

Following her words, I looked towards Nie Zun who remained by Jie Pa’s side, both hands protecting him and prepared to shield the man from any attack that might threaten him . On the other side, Guan Nie sat atop the tree, the blood along his lips had yet dried and with his almond eyes, he stared intently at Li Wen’s back .

“None of you here are confident that you’ll be able to subdue me before I drop my arm, right?” Li Wen chuckled .

Jiao S gasped, obviously using all her might to keep from crying out in pain . The split symbol is the most important part of our body in the split zone; it is where our mental strength converged . To have your split symbol pinned

down by such a MF weapon... I can't imagine the kind of pain she must be going through .

I could hear wheezing from Jiao S who was still lying on the ground, her hoarse voice travelled from behind me, “No, no, no . Don't bother about me .”

I could hear wheezing from Jiao S who was still lying on the ground, her hoarse voice travelled from behind me, “No, no, no . Don't bother about me .”

I clenched my teeth .

Li Wen's smile became even gentler . “Li Shen, there's really no need for us to be like this . I never had the intention of injuring any of you, so why are you even doing this? All I wanted was to take Song Lu away . I promise, as long as you allow me to take Song Lu away without a hitch, I will not hurt Jiao S .”

I took a look at the unconscious Song Lu . Her wavy hair had slightly covered her pale face and her eyes were still a little sunken . She was lying quietly on the ground, unaffected by the unrest and bloodbath around her .

Song Lu, if you are dreaming... Then, is the world within that dreamland more peaceful than it is here?

Tears streamed from my eyes .

“Ah—!” With the slight lowering of Li Wen's arm, Jiao S was finally unable to restrain herself as a strangled cry escaped, her voice was hoarse and shrill . How I wished I could just rush towards Li Wen and tear her into shreds, yet, for Jiao S' sake, I mustn't move a single step .

I spoke through gritted teeth, “Li Wen, it seems the time we spent together was too short . If I had known that you were such a character, I would have cheered and applauded back when Jiao S was tearing you apart in front of everyone!”

There was a fleeting look of dejection in Li Wen's eyes, but it was gone soon enough and she fitted her smile again . "Think whatever you want . If you can't bear to let Song Lu return as an experiment subject, then you'll have to pay the price . If you can't bear to hurt Jiao S, then you'll lose Song Lu . Li Shen, this is the split zone—what right do you have to be a commander if you can't grasp this simple logic? Seeing you like this, don't you think Li Qing would be bitterly disappointed?"

Jiao S who had been panting behind me shouted in her gruff voice, "Don't you dare bring up Li Qing!" But what followed after was a horrible shriek of pain .

Li Wen's smile turned cold, "I don't have much time to talk through it all with you . If you continue on like this, then the choice you make today will be nothing but a mere drop in the ocean; one day, you're going to lose everyone you care about!

"Li Shen, make a choice; allow me to take Song Lu away or let me disable Jiao S . " Li Wen seemed to have run out of patience, presenting me with an ultimatum .

Li Wen's smile turned cold, "I don't have much time to talk through it all with you . If you continue on like this, then the choice you make today will be nothing but a mere drop in the ocean; one day, you're going to lose everyone you care about!

"Li Shen, make a choice; allow me to take Song Lu away or let me disable Jiao S . " Li Wen seemed to have run out of patience, presenting me with an ultimatum .

All of a sudden, from afar, Guan Nie's voice rang out, "Li Shen, Jiao S is still my district commander . If you allow for her to be paralyzed, then don't blame me, Guan Nie, for disregarding all the rapport we've built up over the past few days!"

Nie Zun spoke coolly before I could breathe a word . "Guan Nie, trust her .
,,

Listening to Nie Zun, Guan Nie swept his gaze coldly over me but said no more . My lips have already been ruined by my chewing and even my gums were beginning to bleed . I knew it was impossible for us to stop Li Wen before the drop of her arm, so I could only make a choice between the two .

Raging tears streamed from my eyes; I truly am sick of myself for being such a crybaby, but when I looked to Song Lu in her sleep, my heart felt like it was being pulled and wrung .

I could still hear the ceaseless pants of Jiao S . Even though she could hardly talk anymore, she still managed to force a speech in a low voice . “Guan... Guan Nie, I want y-you to help Li Shen kill her . Don’t bother about me!”

On the tree opposite us, Guan Nie squeezed his eyes shut, unable to bear hearing those words from her .

Li Wen moved her hand slightly but Jiao S didn’t scream this time round . It was as though she could no longer muster any cries, although I could hear her increasing labored breathing . I didn’t dare to turn back, didn’t dare to take a look at her . My falling tears merged with the blood on my face .

The streaks of tears on my face seemed to dry instantly with the gust of a chilly wind, taking with it the last trace of warmth .

“Song Lu...” I shut both my eyes, refusing to let the tears that had welled up escape once more . “Just take her . ”

Chapter 62

62 We'll Get Her Back

Li Wen smiled tenderly, her bloodied face was shaking a little with laughter, her eyes curved into a coquettish arc . “You made the right choice, Li Shen .”

She stretched her arms out and directed a cross towards Song Lu . Following the simple action, a shield appeared on the ground above her body . Li Wen waved her hand, using MF to place Song Lu’s body on the shield and with another eccentric gesture, the cross began glowing . In the midst of the glow, Song Lu’s sleeping form slowly faded away with the shield, right in front of my eyes .

I didn’t cry . I just watched in silence at the spot where Song Lu had vanished .

When Song Lu wakes up to find that we are no longer by her side, when she realizes she’s back in that horrifying place... How terrified and helpless would she feel? Would she cry? Would she think that I have abandoned her?

Song Lu, please promise that you’ll hate me, else I won’t be able to forgive myself .

Only solemn silence filled me, watching helplessly as she disappeared until the sound of Li Wen’s voice rang in my ears, “You should go back to Western District . Trouble might not have found you so quickly if you hadn’t come to the Southern District . You really should never have been here, Ah Shen . ”

My eyes were still frozen on the spot where Song Lu had vanished . After a long pause, my lips curved into a callous smile and I finally lifted my eyes

towards Li Wen . “Thank you for your warning . I will definitely be returning to the Western District, but I will also be coming back here . ”

I turned and walked to Jiao S, reached out my hand and pulled the Parting Sword from her spine; it wasn't the handle that I held on to, but the blade .

Li Wen didn't stop me .

A sharp pain shot through the palm of my hand but I didn't care . Clenching the blade tightly, I yanked and Jiao S gasped . With the removal of the Parting Sword, it wasn't long till she recovered her mobility, then tried getting up . I threw the Parting Sword back to Li Wen with my bloodied hand . The sword vanished with a mere shift of her eyes .

With an outstretched arm I helped Jiao S up . Her body still had a slight tremor to it but the hole in her back was already beginning to mend . As I supported her weight, I spoke in a soft voice to Li Wen, “Li Wen, you should go . It doesn't matter if what you said was true, or if you did this for ‘our own good’... the sisterhood between you and I ends today . ”

The words were spoken softly, without a hint of force . I helped Jiao S into a sitting position so she could lean on me while waiting for her injuries to fully heal . She had exhausted too much MF, and so her rate of recovery was compromised . I had not once spared Li Wen a glance when I spoke, and neither had she responded .

Jiao S looked over at me, her face stained with blood . Her spiritless, wide eyes were observing me quietly and she was still panting a little . Only after I had settled her in a comfortable position did I look towards Li Wen .

Li Wen was still floating in the same spot, but her eyes held a hint of sorrow as she watched me .

I smiled at her, and my eyes swept over her yellow and now blood-stained, dress . “Li Wen, you've always been so perfect . Those bloodstains don't suit you at all, just as I'm not suitable to be your friend . Perhaps that was why you left us, or why you left Li Qing . ”

A glimmer of sorrow fled across Li Wen's eyes .

I kept smiling, continuing in a soft voice, "Stop gazing at me with such despondent eyes . My heart used to ache for you whenever you looked like that... But now, seeing them just makes me nauseous . "

Another gust of wind blew and the hem of her dress swept up with it .

My voice was calm but detached, no longer agitated like it was before .
"Just go . From this day on, I will regard you as an adversary when we meet . "

Unexpectedly, Li Wen laughed with tears welling up in her eyes . The sight made me feel as though she had laughed to the point of tears . "Ah Shen... Is this about Song Lu? I know you feel miserable about this but you'll understand one day . You'll truly lose her if you insist on keeping her by your side . One has to go through pain at some point . Her tribulation is her fate, you can't blame yourself for it . "

I laughed weakly . "From the moment You Ji showed up right up to today when you appeared in such a manner, I finally understood something . You both truly are my sisters—both of you had taken pity on me, knew that I was a monster, so you were willing to turn yourselves into one to accompany me . How could Song Lu be the reason I'm treating you this way?"

There was a pause, before I continued, "I'm only retaliating because this was how you chose to treat me . As you said, this is the split zone . Because, this is... the split zone . "

Maybe words spoken in that soft voice was to emphasize this fact, or maybe it was because I have given up all hope . In any case, I no longer wished to speak any further . "Just go, Li Wen . Let's hope we never meet again . "

Li Wen finally stopped responding, her eyes shone with indecipherable forlorn . With a turn, she floated away . I lowered my head and helped Jiao S to her feet once she was gone . "Can you stand?"

Jiao S' uniform was drenched with blood but she stood up successfully . Her wide eyes turned to me slightly . "Li Shen, thank you . "

Jiao S' uniform was drenched with blood but she stood up successfully . Her wide eyes turned to me slightly . "Li Shen, thank you . "

I didn't breathe a word, nor did I respond .

Guan Nie descended from the tree as Nie Zun helped Jie Pa up . Jie Pa let out a few coughs before heading towards us . "Are you both hurt?"

"I'm fine . Are you alright? It'll be difficult to manage you getting injured . "

Calmly, Jie Pa laughed . "I'm alright . Nie Zun was protecting me with his MF all this while . I'm basically unscathed . "

At this admission, his usually composed gaze was laced with guilt . "I'm sorry, Ms Ah Shen . I wasn't able to protect Ms Song Lu..."

I brought up a hand immediately, gesturing for him to stop going on about it . "You should go check on Jiao S, see if her injury is serious . " Seeing the state I was in, he kept quiet and headed towards Jiao S .

I lifted my head towards Nie Zun who was standing in front of me . The fine bangs that curtained his forehead fluttered in the wind . Even under the grey sky you could still clearly see his starry eyes; quiet, indifferent and calm .

I can't explain it, but seeing his calm demeanor even after such a bitter defeat brought about an uncontrollable stream of tears flowing down my cheeks . I smiled and reached out to caress his cheek, but halted when my bloodied hand was a mere centimeter away from his face .

I parted my lips slowly . "If my other self is just like you... If she's able to treat everything with such composure... Can you return her to me? Just let her come back to me . I really wish I could be just like the two of you..."

To my surprise, Nie Zun's eyes betrayed an obscured hint of grief .

I doubted what I saw—what I thought I saw—but I grinned anyway and allowed the tears to flow to the corner of my mouth, bitterness and slight saltiness spreading across the tip of my tongue .

I finally cupped my hand against his cheek, “I—”

I had wanted to hurt him further with my words, wanted to mock his indifference; I was jealous of him . I was jealous of the fact that he could remain this unconcerned regardless of the situation . I am evil, I am hurting now, and because of that I wanted him to be as heartbroken as I am .

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But I wasn't able to say another word, for he had wrapped both arms around me and engulfed me in a hug, resting my head against his shoulder .

There wasn't much warmth to the hug . Instead, it carried an air of desolation . His shoulders didn't seem too dependable either; he was strong, but the body under that black shirt was still slender .

He didn't use much strength, just held me gently against him and said in my ears, “She's right here . You... Can you feel it?”

I was taken aback by his sudden action and those words, to the point where my tears stopped abruptly . I was stumped by the change in tone, and for a split second I forgot the heavy blow of Song Lu's newfound captivity, the bitterness of reality .

I didn't know how much time had passed before Jie Pa cleared his throat from beside us . “Uh... Ms Ah Shen . Jiao S isn't badly injured and her MF has recovered . Her body's recuperation rate is pretty strong, even I'm surprised . ”

I fell back to reality with a crash . Regaining my composure, I frantically loosened myself from Nie Zun's grip . His eyes seemed to glint with glee .

For some reason, my face felt a little warm and I immediately turned my back towards Nie Zun . Scratching a part of my head that didn't even itch, I answered Jie Pa with an awkward laugh . “A-ah, is that right? That's good to hear, good to hear indeed . ”

Jiao S sported a small smile . “My regeneration has always been strong, even before this life . ” Then, she looked down at her own body, seemingly lost in a daze of her own thoughts .

I thought back to the day when she was bleeding out in that room, thought of her mentioning someone hurting her true body back in the real world and my brows furrowed . I walked over to her, seeking answers to countless questions but was met with a soft tilt of Jiao S' head, silently assuring me that all was fine . And so, eventually, I stayed silent and kept my questions to myself .

Guan Nie shook his white hair and came to my side, the corners of his lips still stained scarlet red . His almond eyes were coy . “Aiya-ya-ya, Li Shen . You better not have a dalliance with my pet . He's mine . ”

Had he stopped there it would have been fine, but oh no—on ‘mine’, he turned and shot Nie Zun an alluring look .

... I can't even be bothered with him .

Nie Zun chuckled . “It'll be turning dark soon . Best cross the forest before it does and head back to the Eastern District . ”

... I can't even be bothered with him .

Nie Zun chuckled . “It'll be turning dark soon . Best cross the forest before it does and head back to the Eastern District . ”

Jiao S nodded . “Let's go . ”

The group of us continued stalwartly towards the boundary lines . I know I don't have the luxury of time to be hurting, but I couldn't help myself

turning back once more before we left, my eyes fixated at the place where we just battled upon .

When we arrived in this district, I would never have believed any of this could have happened . We failed to save Laurel, we have no idea whether Yu Liang is still alive, and now Song Lu has been taken away to be an experiment subject . Adding insult to injury, Jie Pa lost his ability to heal and even the Western District has fallen into the hands of the enemy .

And me... I just keep losing .

From losing Gao Qi, my motivation, then finally losing my sanity and arriving at Split Zone No . 13... I keep losing .

I began to wonder... if Gao Qin Jiu Ye looked identical to Gao Qi, then was fate toying with me on purpose? He pointed to me and said, “I don’t care about anything or anyone, including you . ”

A mirthless smile tugged at my lips .

I am truly useless . I can’t protect anyone around me, just as Li Wen said; I can’t even protect myself . I came to the split zone, have lived here since, but... for what purpose?

Jiao S seemed to notice I was deep in thought, and came back to my side . “Li Shen, let’s go,” her hoarse voice brought me back to the present . “We’ll return again, and when we do we will take back everything we’ve lost . ”

I twisted my head to look at her . It was a long while before I could muster up a smile . “Yeah,” I finally said . “We will take back everything . ”

With that, the two of us hastily caught up with the three people ahead of us, and continued towards the boundary lines .

Chapter 63

63 How Cute Are the Spider-Men?

The battle within Guan Nie's illusion had raged for an unexpectedly long time; by the time we crossed the endless boundary forest of the Southern District and into the Eastern District, the skies had grown dark .

Even though it wasn't the Western District we had returned to, I still felt a sense of ease wash over me the moment we crossed the border .

Lifting her fingers to her lips, Jiao S blew a resounding whistle . All of a sudden, we were surrounded by ten silhouettes of people who leapt down from the trees .

But the ten of them...

Pfft...

There was no telling each individual's gender, for they were all wearing matching Spider-Man outfits, complete with the mask . Seeing the ten of them in front of us, I felt a strong urge to say something teasing . However, as my grief had yet to dwindle, I chose to repress that urge .

“Commander, you're back . Lord Tao Lie instructed us to lead the entire Rank E troop and stand guard in the boundary forest around the clock, awaiting your return . ” The Spider-Man at the forefront of the group said .

(T/N: The honorific variation of 'you' was used throughout their address to Jiao S .)

One Spider-Man...

Two, three, four Spider-Men...

My mind was still fixated on their choice of costume . Whoever said the people in the Eastern District were vicious and horrifying?

Look at how adorable they are...

Look at how cute the Spider-Men are...

Jiao S gave a slight wave, her voice back to its usual hoarse and deep tone .
“What happened while I was gone?”

The same Spider-Man answered immediately, “After you left, there was an incident where more than a hundred residents died, without rhyme or reason; it wasn’t the doing of a splitting key either . With you still absent from our district, our entire team of Rank C members was very concerned .

“We suggested that Lord Mu Li lead us and strike our way into the Southern District, but the three Lords had instead commanded Lord Tao Lie and Lord Mu Li to protect the Eastern Residence—from Level 27 and above—from harm . They also commanded the ten of us in Rank C to lead Rank E into the boundary forest and take turns guarding the boundary lines . Half of the Rank F team were also sent to stand guard at the Western District’s boundary lines . ”

Jiao S nodded . “How did the other residents react to the massacre?”

“You weren’t back, so the other residents didn’t probe much either . Everyone trusted that you would give them a proper explanation . They have simply been waiting for your return . ”

Jiao S contemplated for a moment before she spoke . “Get Tao Lie and Mu Li to meet me . We’ll be heading to the Dorms at the Academy first to clean up; it’s too far away to rush from here to the Residence block . And tell them to hurry up; make use of the time we’ll need to pass through the Marketplace before the Academy, and appear before me by the time we’re done washing up . ”

Spider-Man nodded . “Yes, Commander!” He turned towards the other nine Spider-Men and made a gesture . At this, one of them stepped out and received their leader’s instruction . “Go look for a phone and contact Lord Tao Lie . The rest of you will continue guarding the boundary forest with me!”

Whoosh, whoosh!

The nine silhouettes promptly returned to their position atop the trees, with the other running at full speed ahead . When I lifted my head, the view still within my range of visibility but despite this, I was surprised to note that I could not spot even a single one of them in concealment .

I was secretly impressed by Jiao S’ methodical way of governing . I didn’t have long to dwell on it, however, before she turned to us and said, “The Marketplace is right around the corner; we’ll still need to work a little more and strive to reach the Academy in ten hours . I’ll arrange accommodation there so you can rest . ”

The group of us nodded, with the exception of Guan Nie who stepped away from us . He yawned lazily . “Since we’re back at Eastern District, then I’m relieved of my duty to protect you . Send someone to the 29th Floor if you need me—I still have matters I need to attend to . ”

After dropping that on her, he turned to Nie Zun with a coquettish smile and his coy eyes, “My pet, I hope we’ll meet again . ”

With that, he swung the sleeve to his long garment and disappeared right before our eyes without a hint of sentimentality .

“This Rank A personnel of yours seemed to do as he pleases...” I told Jiao S .

Jiao S’ rigid face donned a small smile . “He has always been this way, nobody knows what he’s thinking . Besides, his condition for coming over to the Eastern District was that we leave him be unless absolutely necessary . Even when we do need him to handle matters, we can’t restrict his freedom once it’s done . ”

“Where was he from? The Southern District?” Since the Western District didn’t have Guan Nie in their organization during Li Qing’s time, I grew curious .

Jiao S’ eyes shone of something indecipherable . “He didn’t belong to any district before us; one of the exceptions permitted by Mr Blond . When I heard about his extraordinary skills, I specifically sent someone to search for him—they eventually located him in the Southern District . In convincing him to come over to Eastern District and render his services to me, we made an agreement .

“Come on, let’s walk and talk . We have to get to the Academy as soon as possible—we can even clean ourselves up there . ” Jiao S gestured for us to make haste with a wave of her hand . Rightly so, otherwise it would take us more than ten hours to get through the Marketplace to the Academy .

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We made a mad dash the whole way, and I began to feel exhaustion creep up on me . While I do love running about wildly in the dead of night, the stimulation to both my body and mind over the past few days had pushed me to my limits . Furthermore, my split symbol is still unsealed, and hence blocked from my full potential . Every time I exert my MF, I lose some of them in the process . While they do get replenished overnight, somehow it seemed as though my mental strength wasn’t able to withstand it for much longer .

In order to distract myself from my own fatigue, I started up a conversation with Jiao S . Looking at her now, she’s no longer as terrifying as I once thought her to be . “Hey, Jiao S . If Guan Nie is as you described—that is, a freeman who has never followed anybody’s orders—then what kind of deal did you strike to convince him to help you?”

Jiao S was quiet for a moment before she eventually decided to answer my question . “I agreed to make Si Luo leave Gao Qin Jiu Ye . ”

... Wait, what?

What did she mean by “make Si Luo leave Gao Qin Jiu Ye”?

Guan Nie had always been submissive, and I’ve always thought there was something strange about the way he treated Gao Qin Jiu Ye, yet at the same time, it also seemed as though he was jealous of Gao Qin Jiu Ye’s loyalty to Si Luo . Then, how do you make sense of Jiao S’ words?

Unless... Could it be...? Could it be that Gao Qin Jiu Ye is gay too?! Is Si Luo his partner? Was Guan Nie jealous?!

In the split zone, my very own Senior Gao Qi is actually gay???

I played the entire theatrics of their possible love triangle over in my head .

Jiao S looked sideways at me, perplexed . “What’s with that weird look on your face?”

A little awkwardly, I hastily replied, “Oh, no, it’s nothing . I just didn’t understand . Si Luo and Gao Qin Jiu Ye, are they... that?”

Watching my wild gestures as I spoke, Jiao S frowned . “What do you mean by ‘that’?”

“Ai-ya, you know... Gay! The Si Luo you adore is gay?”

Jiao S looked at me incredulously . “It’s no wonder you got diagnosed with mind-splitting disorder . ”

I choked at that .

Hey, now just wait a minute—who in the split zone wasn’t diagnosed with some sort of mental disorder, huh? Why are you discriminating against my mind-splitting disorder!

Hey, now just wait a minute—who in the split zone wasn’t diagnosed with some sort of mental disorder, huh? Why are you discriminating against my mind-splitting disorder!

In resignation, she continued . “They’re not in that sort of relationship, but I don’t know how Guan Nie feels towards Gao Qin Jiu Ye . In any case, it doesn’t matter . I promised him . ”

I suddenly remembered another matter and swiftly changed subject . “Oh yeah, I meant to say—what’s the secret to the split zone you wanted to tell me?”

Jiao S’ eyes darkened . “Have you ever seen a legitimate soul splitter?”

I shook my head . “No, I’ve only heard about them . Didn’t they say Mi Fu’s a soul splitter, though? And then there’s Li Wen, she said she’s one too . ”

Jiao S sighed, “Sure, but we only have their word for it . We’ve never actually seen it with our own eyes; we’ve never seen someone return to the real world by inserting their splitting key into their soul splitter . I’ve seen a soul splitter once... but they looked identical to their counterpart . ”

“Huh? What does this mean?”

Jiao S shrugged and shook her head . “I don’t understand it either . Regardless, I have seen someone who inserted their key into their soul splitter’s symbol and the two of them looked exactly alike . I suspect the split zone has been concealing soul splitters, and that they are our doppelgängers . Still, Li Qing and Li Wen have the same symbols but they look different... though it’s possible one of them has been using their MF to disguise themselves . ”

I furrowed my brows . “Why do you think so? Just because you’ve seen it once doesn’t mean that it’s true of everyone . ”

Jiao S let out another sigh . “I don’t know why either . Still, I have a strong feeling I’m right . Besides, wasn’t there another Nie Zun who was causing trouble?”

Jie Pa chimed in at this point . “That might have been part of You Ji’s conspiracy . Nie Zun told me about the night You Ji came to sow discord,

spoke about the powers in Nie Zun's hands . We suspect that was You Ji's ability; maybe she was the one who masqueraded as Nie Zun in front of Yu Liang and Song Lu . ”

Surprised, I sought clarification . “Do you mean You Ji has the ability to replicate other people's skills? But that doesn't necessarily mean she can pretend to be another person convincingly . ”

Although... was that why she could manipulate the airflow too?

It wouldn't be that difficult a feat for her to masquerade as Nie Zun either; after all, she had known both Song Lu and Yu Liang for a long time now .

Jie Pa nodded . “That's our theory . ”

Jiao S had an epiphany then . “Even if that's the case, how was she able to replicate their abilities? Did she activate her split symbol too?”

I shook my head, uncertain . “I have no idea where her split symbol is hidden . I reckon it's on the lower half of her body; she always had a serpent tail for that part, so I couldn't see anything . ”

Jiao S had an epiphany then . “Even if that's the case, how was she able to replicate their abilities? Did she activate her split symbol too?”

I shook my head, uncertain . “I have no idea where her split symbol is hidden . I reckon it's on the lower half of her body; she always had a serpent tail for that part, so I couldn't see anything . ”

Jie Pa turned to Jiao S and asked, “Ms Jiao S, who is the person you saw with their corresponding soul splitter?”

In her eyes there was a flicker of heaviness, a shield concealing her own emotions . “I really can't tell you that . ”

Jie Pa pushed up his glasses in a gesture of silent understanding .

“Is this the secret about the split zone?” I continued probing .

With another exhale, she breathed out the words, “I’m afraid many speculations I had in the past were proven wrong . Our situation evolved too much, too quickly . It was too unexpected, and we can’t even get in contact with Mr Blond right now . ”

“Actually, haven’t you been in the split zone for almost four years now? Did you never research about the soul splitters?”

There was a quick flash of embarrassment to Jiao S at that . “I... Well, for the past three years, I’ve always been researching about Si Luo . It was only when these stranger things began happening that I considered leaving the split zone...”

My mouth twitched . How unexpected it was that this bizarre woman was actually a hopeless romantic, that she had never once thought of leaving the split zone—instead, she was enchanted by the most gorgeous man in the entire split zone, as labeled by rumors .

Still, I wonder what happened between them . Why did she agree not to step foot inside the Southern District for three years?

As I sped on, I twisted my head to look at Jiao S . She looked as though she was deep in thought as well, her eyes glazed over . Her gaze was locked straight ahead, yet at the same time seemed to see nothing at all .

I wondered, but ultimately chose not to ask about it .

Nie Zun, who had been quiet all this while, spoke up . “Don’t forget to ask Mu Li about the scent of those poisonous insects . The man from our district had a similar scent—the very person who collapsed with his entire back gnawed by those insects . ”

Jiao S hummed an acknowledgment . “Mm-hmm, I’ll handle it . Are those bugs the same as the ones we saw in the Southern District?”

Nie Zun shook his head . “No, they’re different . Still, the split zone isn’t supposed to have creatures like that . I suspect they’re related . ”

Jiao S conceded with a dip of her head .

Chapter 64

64 To Return is Another Form of Beginning

By the time Nie Zun and I were done washing up at the Academy Dorms arranged by Jiao S, it was already ten hours into the night . As per Jiao S' instruction, we made our way to the stone table near the entrance to the Academy . When Nie Zun, Jie Pa and I arrived, Tao Lie the Muscle Man and Mu Li the Bandage Man were already there, reporting back to Jiao S .

“Long time no see, Bandage Man . ” I've always had the inkling Bandage Man did not have a particularly favorable impression of me, but it didn't stop me from noting how intriguing he looked all wrapped up in bandages . I stepped forward and casually pulled at one of the loose strips of bandage around his head .

Bandage Man glared at me but didn't say a word—his indignant expression amused me .

Jiao S glanced towards Mu Li and said, “I asked about it . The reason why you smelled the bugs on Mu Li was because he had been bitten by them . ”

“What?”

Mu Li seemed a little embarrassed at that, but seeing the gesture of Jiao S' eyes he slowly started to unravel the bandages on his arm . As he unwound, I was taken aback . His left arm was densely packed with a sort of white and squirming entity—the same silkworm pupa-esque bugs that gnawed on the back of the man who had fallen from the building! However, there was a key difference: the bugs were not feeding on Mu Li's flesh . Rather, they seemed to be settled in him, compactly mounted within his flesh without

moving . His entire arm looked fake, as though paved with white cobblestones .

For someone with trypophobia like me, the image was simply too disturbing to look at .

“Ugh...!!” I turned to support myself against Nie Zun, spewing out mouthful after mouthful of stomach acid .

“S—sorry about that, Little Bandage . ” Panting while still holding on to Nie Zun, I looked apologetically towards Mu Li . “I didn’t mean to offend you, but my trypophobia is pretty serious . ”

The usually hot-tempered Mu Li was actually calm, “It’s alright . Even I’m disgusted by the sight . I don’t blame you . ”

In that moment, I was flooded with compassion, “What happened?”

Mu Li’s eyes were downcast for a moment . “It was a long time ago... and part of the reason I’ve always wrapped myself in bandages . Half a year ago, I took a trip down to the Western District . In the boundary forest, I met a masked man who attacked me out of the blue . I didn’t feel much at that time, but the part of my arm where he took a swipe at started growing these... things once I got back . While it was obviously disgusting, they didn’t seem to be causing me any harm, nor did they seem alive... so I’ve always just ignored it . ”

Jie Pa pushed up his glasses . “If you don’t mind, Mr Mu Li, may I extract one of those worms and conduct a study on them?”

Jiao S spoke up, “Mu Li, Jie Pa’s a well-known doctor and informant, you can trust him with this; let him handle it . Also, Ah Shen; I have faith in Mu Li’s loyalty . ”

Since Jiao S’ declared her stance on the matter, I motioned for Jie Pa to proceed . Jie Pa took out a pocket knife and a glass bottle from his bag .

Even as Jie Pa carved against his skin, Mu Li was unfazed; he didn't even furrow his brows, but kept his eyes on me instead . "I apologize for the misunderstanding from before, but I hope you can understand I will never risk anything that may harm the Eastern District; I am loyal to our Commander beyond a shadow of a doubt!"

He was fired up as he spoke those words, his eyes staring wild and wide, as if there was a large glass ball bound within that wrapped up mummy .

I nodded fervently, "I know, I know . Calm down . "

Tao Lie the Muscle Man, with his immense stature, emerged with his sunglasses on, "Ms Li Shen, our Commander had more or less briefed us on what happened . During the period you were all away, our people had been guarding by the boundary forest... and we have an unfortunate news to share .

"According to my subordinate's report, the Western District suffered more than a hundred casualties not that long ago as well . Among them, there were seven in the ranks of floor manager . The serpent woman who had once served under you seemed to be spreading the rumor that you abandoned the district residents and caused a revolt . Mr Blond had not made his appearance during this time either, so the Western District residents are resentful . The situation has been hostile . "

To be honest, I had long prepared myself for numerous possible scenarios in the Western District, but hearing the actual situation I was in shock

Tao Lie continued, "Since you and our Commander left for the Southern District, which isn't accessible to just anyone, you may not be aware of the events that occurred . There had been casualties in our district as well, but the S Clan was distinct in its rank hierarchy and so everything remained orderly . We've been able to suppress the incident with these freak deaths, and awaited our Commander's return .

"Your district wasn't as lucky, however . They're without a Commander now, and though you've always trusted the serpent woman, she turned

against you as well . As a result, the Western District has been very chaotic . I hope you're mentally prepared to face this before heading back . ”

“Your district wasn't as lucky, however . They're without a Commander now, and though you've always trusted the serpent woman, she turned against you as well . As a result, the Western District has been very chaotic . I hope you're mentally prepared to face this before heading back . ”

While I knew he hadn't said them with malice, his words fuelled my fears of incompetence at holding the title of Commander this whole time . There was seemingly no protection for the district, apart from the old system created by Li Qing and You Ji .

The guilt and remorse I felt was immense and surged through my heart . Even though I had never expressed much concern in the past over other people's lives, or deaths, it was impossible to assert that this didn't affect me, to pretend I didn't care .

Jiao S seemed to detect my sentiments and indicated for Tao Lie to stop talking . In turn, she attempted to console me . “It'll be fine . Although I've only just received a brief update about the situation with the Western District, and admittedly it didn't sound too optimistic, there's still a silver lining—I have been amassing strength over the years, and we will definitely lend a helping hand as and when you require assistance . Don't worry too much about it . The residents in Western District are just lost without an opinion of their own . Once you're back, I'm sure the matters will be resolved eventually . ”

I nodded dejectedly .

All of a sudden, Jie Pa exclaimed . “This thing—!”

We followed his voice and took a look . Jie Pa had extracted the soft, white bug and placed it into the bottle . Observing it up close, the bug had two holes that looked just like eyes . Strangely, apart from the hollowness from losing that weird worm, Mu Li's arm didn't have a drip of blood—instead, there was a white, sticky fluid . It seemed to flow white within the blood vessels of his arm, taking the place of blood .

Jie Pa looked grim . “Mr Mu Li, I hope we can maintain contact via the phone . With regard each new change to your arm, I hope you’ll be able to tell me in detail . I have a strong sense of foreboding, and if it is as you said, then it’s not reproducing too quickly . Perhaps once in several days . However, it had already covered your entire arm . Even if you haven’t yet felt much of its effects, I suspect the damage it can cause will be unprecedented . ”

“I understand,” Mu Li nodded . “I will keep in touch . It seems I’ll have to keep bothering you with this . ”

Jie Pa smiled warmly, “It’s not a big deal . ”

“Oh, that’s right . About the deaths of those hundred or so people in your district, how did they die?”

Jiao S sighed, “They’ve all had their hearts dug out . I speculate that it must have been contaminated with the blood that caused them to stop healing; there’s no other reason they would die and their hearts vanished . ”

Nie Zun frowned . “According to what happened during this period of time, only Song Lu and Li Wen had such a blood composition . Could it be Li Wen’s doing?”

Nie Zun frowned . “According to what happened during this period of time, only Song Lu and Li Wen had such a blood composition . Could it be Li Wen’s doing?”

Jiao S shook her head . “I can’t be sure . Even though I abhor her, and the blood of those in Southern District had indeed been in her hands, but I can’t say with certainty that this is committed by her . From what she had mentioned, I think the death within our districts might have been a warning from the conspirators to Li Shen and I . They wanted us to leave Southern District . ”

I conceded, “That’s right . This was just a warning . Otherwise, with them being much stronger than us and in hiding, it wouldn’t have ended this simply if they truly had the intention of attacking us . ”

Jiao S tilted her neck and fixed her gaze on me . “And so, before they find success in their scheme, we must be fully prepared for the dawn of doom and find out about the details of it . I’ll send my people with you for your return to Western District this time round . You and I have to form an alliance . Otherwise, we’ll just be pawns in their game . ”

I lifted my eyes towards the direction of Western District, but with the distance in between, I could see nothing of it .

“I’ll need to restructure my S Clan . You should go back and settle things in Western District, and then we’ll head back to Southern District together . ”
Jiao S continued .

Jie Pa echoed her sentiments, “And upon my return this time, I can give Ms Ah Shen some of the strength I’ve accumulated . ”

I turned back, and observed those gazes who held nothing but utter confidence in me .

Jiao S, you’ve said it yourself that you had no idea why Li Qing and Mr Blond would choose me as Western District’s commander . Yet... You’re being so supportive of me now . Is it because you’ve figured out the reason?

If you did, could you let me know? Because I’m still in the dark about it; why had they chosen me, why had they placed so much trust in me...

You’ve seen it with your own eyes, how I’m... good for nothing . How I just can’t do anything right .

Jiao S seemed to have understood . Her hollow eyes watched me quietly, but her rigid face held a small smile to them . During this night, it didn’t look all that strange anymore .

She said, “Jie Pa, you won’t have to keep in contact with Mu Li . I’m going to be sending both Mu Li and Tao Lie to Western District with you . Don’t underestimate them, they’ll be able to protect all of you . ”

Jiao S seemed to have understood . Her hollow eyes watched me quietly, but her rigid face held a small smile to them . During this night, it didn't look all that strange anymore .

She said, "Jie Pa, you won't have to keep in contact with Mu Li . I'm going to be sending both Mu Li and Tao Lie to Western District with you . Don't underestimate them, they'll be able to protect all of you . "

Tao Lie seemed to remain compliant to Jiao S' instruction regardless the instruction . Even if he had a huge stature, always seemed dependable with a hint of sternness, but in front of Jiao S, he's always as loyal as a servant, and would never overstep his boundaries .

Mu Li, on the other hand, seemed to be caught in a dilemma, "But the Eastern District..."

Jiao S waved her hand, gesturing that it would be fine, "I'll have Feng, Huo, Lei with me . They'll never leave my side even for a split second . You don't have to worry about me . "

(T/N: Feng, Huo, Lei are directly translated as Wind, Fire and Lightning respectively . Since they are names in this case, I left them as it is to avoid confusion .)

Tao Lie was also unperturbed when he looked towards Mu Li, "That's right, the three Lords will be able to protect the Commander . There's nothing for us to worry about . Besides, Guan Nie is back too . "

The three Lords? Feng, Huo, Lei? Are those the three with those big bamboo hats, who had once followed ever closely by Jiao S' side?

What commanding names they have...

Nie Zun chuckled, "In any case, thank you for everything . "

Jiao S smiled, "It's an honor in itself to have Nie Zun thank me personally . You should rest here for the night, and leave only when daybreaks tomorrow . "

I looked up at the pitch-dark sky and couldn't help the mixture of feelings in my heart . Western District, I'm back . It has only been less than a month, but can I still live as comfortably as I used to, in the Western District that I had always perceived as peaceful and calm?

Chapter 65

Jiao S' POV

My name is Li Jiao . I am eighteen years old, but I still have no idea how to brush my own hair . Why? Because she takes care of everything for me .

Who is she?

My sister, Li Qing . She's as beautiful as her name .

And her heart?

Her heart's even more beautiful .

Still, there's always poison in beautiful things; the more beautiful they are, the more poisonous they get .

She's five years older than me and had always been regarded as a gifted child . At the age of three she understood the basic mathematical concepts of addition, subtraction, multiplication and division, then attended primary school when she was five . She skipped three grades after that, and graduated when she was just seven .

My sister was extremely gifted and my parents couldn't be more proud .

Being my parents' pride and joy, her condition for repayment was that she get whatever she wanted, and my parents did not hesitate in doing so . Anything could become a toy in her hands . Including me .

I didn't know before that my existence on this earth was such a huge threat to my sister . In the eyes of our parents and relatives, she was a unique and

talented girl . As such, the preferential treatment that once belonged to her, and her alone, was threatened when I came along .

Being the intelligent girl that she was, despite her young age, she knew very clearly that the presence of a younger sister was a mistake, one that should have never existed .

Even to this day, years down the road, I suppose I can understand how she must have felt when I think back on it . How terrified she must have been .

When relatives congratulated my family they claimed that having a daughter was a blessing, but it was supremely fortunate to have two of them . The family was abuzz with anticipation as to whether their second daughter would be as clever as the first, or perhaps even exceed her talented older sister .

How flustered and helpless must she have felt? After all, she was only five . My sheer existence was like to someone took away her favorite candy . And when I turned five myself, it seemed to her like the candy had finally been eaten by another .

I was never the genius others had expected me to be, and our family never had another talented girl . I was your average child with a slightly weaker constitution, occasionally showing a little more wit than my peers, but those events were short-lived and spontaneous .

Unexpectedly, my parents doted on me as much as they did my sister . For the sake of filial piety, I shouldn't criticise my parents . In reality, though, if we're being honest, my parents treated me better than her .

Isn't there a saying like that? When parents have more than one child, they tend to coddle the youngest most of all? Or in relative terms, the weakest . That child might not be smart, or sensible, or even obedient . Yet it was exactly this weakness of theirs that gained the favor of their parents .

I seemed to be like that .

My parents cared for me in every way possible, even to the extent of neglecting my gifted sister at times . My parents were gentle and mild-tempered people, so it hadn't been to the extent of abuse . On the contrary, they still pampered my sister and treated her well .

Even so, she was adamant in her belief that they would have treated her even better without my existence . If it wasn't for me, they would have praised her intelligence more, and whatever she wanted, she would have received them with less effort .

Yeah, even if the family background is decent, if the desires of their children doubled with the numbers, then it'll obviously be more difficult to get whatever you wanted .

For someone as smart as my sister, how could she not have figured this out? It was precisely because she was smart that she hadn't thrown a tantrum over her stolen candy like the other kids would have . Even though that was the epitome of normalcy for a kid to behave .

My sister wasn't a kid though, she never was . She possessed intelligence beyond her age, and hence, she chose to use her own method in dealing with the disaster which had descended from skies—me .

From the moment I turned three, she started buying dolls for me . By the time I was five, I already owned a great number of them and began developing memories . When I was ten, she was fifteen .

From the moment I turned three, she started buying dolls for me . By the time I was five, I already owned a great number of them and began developing memories . When I was ten, she was fifteen .

As with many child geniuses, the period when their intelligence drastically surpassed their peers was when they were young . At fifteen, my sister was no longer as much smarter than them as when she was five .

The skipping of grades when she was younger had led to a weaker foundation in the subjects she had studied, and as a result, while she was outstanding in high school, she was far from being gifted .

Still, her love for me was unwavering, and she continued buying those dolls for me . Being that young, I felt nothing else besides delight in receiving them, to be pampered with those dolls .

More frequently than not, she loved grooming me into a doll . As a kid, she could dress me up cutely, like a puppet, and no one would pay any mind . My parents were overjoyed that my sister loved me so much and treated me with so much kindness .

I had thought so too .

Many memories from my childhood had already faded, but my sister's soft yet bewitching voice was deeply engraved in my mind .

“Jiao'er has to be doll . She has to be jiejie's favorite doll, right? Look at how lovely dolls are . If you are willing to be a doll, jiejie will buy you a lot of pretty clothes too, and I'll brush your beautiful hair, do you want that?”

At that time, I didn't know better . I jumped for joy and answered, “Yeah, yeah! I want to be a doll, jiejie, I want to be the prettiest doll!”

And she answered with an incomparably gentle voice, “Alright, then Jiao'er will be jiejie's doll forever . Forever, ok?”

I didn't know at that time, how this promise of being her doll forever was but a seed that would eventually grow into a demon .

I could still remember that year, when she helped me into a puffy skirt which she bought . She looked at me, and with her slender, fair hands, she stroked my face . It was as though she was touching her favorite toy when she said to me, “Jiao'er, do you know what's a SD doll?”

I giggled, “I do! They are those pretty dolls with big eyes . ”

I giggled, “I do! They are those pretty dolls with big eyes . ”

“You're the most beautiful SD doll in jiejie's heart . Do you want to be a SD doll from now on? Jiejie will name you Jiao S, how does that sound?”

There wasn't a hint of hesitation when I agreed . All I thought of at that time was how lovely SD dolls looked, but I've forgotten about everything else that others have mentioned, about how their eyes were always lifeless and strange despite their cute appearance .

Which was why, up until I turned eighteen, when it was supposed to be the most beautiful moment in a teenage girl's life, I was instead molded into the perfect doll by my sister .

Like a doll that had spent years in the making, the result wasn't the attention of others when it was done, but a completion of a meticulously plotted scheme . She had started brainwashing me since I was young, and I eventually became the doll she created .

I didn't smile much, because every time I do, she would tell me that SD dolls don't smile . I was used to being expressionless, because she had told me that dolls didn't need expressions .

The greed towards dolls started since I was around ten; the continuous plea for my sister to get me a new one, coupled with her brainwashing had caused my family to distant themselves . For a daughter, I was simply too unusual .

The distancing continued till I was eighteen . Occasionally, however, from the worried glances in my parents' eyes, I could tell that they loved me and they still cared for me . Except, I was only a crafted doll by my sister, one who did not understand the concept of gratitude or any other emotions .

In fact, even until today when I had been cruelly oppressed by the doll complex caused by her, I couldn't claim that it was entirely her fault because I had been willing . Even when she willfully educated me into abnormalcy due to her own selfish desires, my life was still shaped by my own choices .

If I hadn't been attracted by the beautiful dolls, then I would not have been developed such greed for them and none of this would have happened .

Accustomed to being expressionless, I had no friends and even our relatives said that I looked numb . My eyes were spiritless, it didn't have a glimmer of gratitude or emotions .

Everyone had thought it a pity; a pity that I didn't look like my sister, that I wasn't that sensible, gentle, intelligent girl that everyone loved . Everyone felt regretful for me, just because I wasn't like my sister .

Yet, nobody has ever asked the question that was buried deep in my heart—I am my own person, why did I have to be just like my sister?

My sister finally divulged her scheme to me one day . She said that her plan had been to shape me into an eccentric and reclusive monster that nobody loves . While she didn't achieve the result that she anticipated, she still did it . I really did become a monster .

Yet, nobody has ever asked the question that was buried deep in my heart—I am my own person, why did I have to be just like my sister?

My sister finally divulged her scheme to me one day . She said that her plan had been to shape me into an eccentric and reclusive monster that nobody loves . While she didn't achieve the result that she anticipated, she still did it . I really did become a monster .

The numerous times I had been criticized and warned against having an expression—because dolls did not have them—had in turn made me into a truly expressionless person as time went by .

There was nothing scarier than someone without an expression, and all of things, that was who I have become .

On the contrary, my sister grew to love me even more, because I was the end product of her effort . As a finished product, any treatment I could enjoy would only be given from her, my owner . I had no expression, no relationships, no friends . I only have jiejie .

As for my sister, after succeeding in more than a decade of defense, she remained as my parents' favourite daughter . No one could take away any

share of glory or love from her .

She's the only one .

Until that day, when she finally revealed her devil-like mindset to me, did I finally realize... She didn't want to provide me with whatever she could, instead, all she had wanted was to take away everything I have .

Just like she said, it was only a matter of time before dolls get abandoned .
Whoever told you to become a doll?

As a doll, the moment when she had taken away everything and decided to abandon me, was the first time I felt the behavioral reflex of a human . That is, revenge .

The knife in my hands plunged into her body so many times, until finally, it was the single piece of medical certificate that sent me into a mental institute .

Li Jiao, delusional patient with deep paranoia, always thought of herself as an immaculate SD doll which will forever be loved by her owner .

The mental illness brought me a new place . It was not a prison, but as for what it truly was, I have no idea .

Chapter 66

66 The 13 Giants

Nie Zun waved his hand at me, smirking while he did, “I know I’m good-looking, but there’s no need for you to drool over me like this . ”

Heat rushed to my cheeks with his words . Not wanting to bother with him, I turned my attention towards the scenery beyond our window .

“On a serious note though...”

Hearing the earnest tone to his words, I flicked my gaze back to him .

His starry eyes held its constant radiance, “Song Lu will be fine . The people within split zone have to learn to protect themselves . You have to believe in her, and you have to believe in yourself . From now, as long as you face everything with courage, there’s still hope . We still have time . ”

Never in my life had I ever expected to hear these words from the indifferent and egocentric Nie Zun .

After a pregnant pause, I broke into a smile, “Alright, let us head back to Western District then! We still have time . ”

Nie Zun’s lips curled upwards ever so slightly, “Let’s rest for a while . We’ll head back first thing tomorrow . ”

...

“This is where I leave you; you’ll reach Western District once you get through this boundary forest . You should bring Tao Lie and Mu Li along with you . ” Jiao S said to me .

I glanced back at Muscle Man and Bandage Man, both of whom were standing respectfully to the side, then nodded, “Thanks, Jiao S . ”

Brightening her usually stiff face was a smile which held a trace of exuberance, “It’s nothing . I hope you’ll be able to resolve the issues in your district soon . I’ll inform Tao Lie once the investigation on my end is concluded, and if everything goes on smoothly on your side, we can regroup again and discuss our next step . ”

I nodded in agreement, then with a gesture, I indicated for Jie Pa, Nie Zun, along with Tao Lie and Mu Li to proceed towards the Eastern-Western District boundary line .

“Oh, it seems like every district has their own protective measures set up within the boundary forest . Tao Lie, does Eastern District have them in place too?” Still watching my surroundings, I asked .

“Under normal circumstances, the G-ranking offices in S Clan will conceal themselves within the boundary forest on either end of the district . With the increase of these unexplained incidents, we’ve also sent some of our higher ranking members to guard them . ” Nodding in response, Tao Lie explained .

For a moment, my mind worked itself to its extremes, attempting to recall if the Western District had placed similar efforts in protecting our own . “We... Do we have people guarding our boundary forest?” Unable to contain myself any further, I turned towards Nie Zun .

Yet, Nie Zun, who only spared a fleeting glimpse my way, didn’t seemed to be in the mood to entertain my query, “Aren’t you the District Commander? Why are you asking us that?”

With my heart on my sleeve, the embarrassment I felt at his statement was apparent to everyone in our company .

Jie Pa smiled, “Ms Ah Shen, we do have them at Western District . Ms You Ji was the one who organized them in the past; this time, though, I’m afraid those preventive measures would be targeted at us . ”

Sigh, am I really going to meet my own district's residents with force?

“According to our recent reports, Western District's boundary forest has been deathly still, to the extent that it's starting to feel peculiar . It'll be wise to stay cautious when we enter later . ” Tao Lie did a similar action of pushing up his glasses, just like Jie Pa, only that his was a pair of sunglasses .

Sigh, I can't believe I have to be cautious even when I'm going back to my own district .

As we're going through the boundary forest, I inhaled a deep breath . This was the scent of Western District's boundary forest that I know so well . Subconsciously, taking heed to Tao Lie's advice I took a quick look around us but failed to detect anything out of the ordinary .

“Do you feel anything out of place?” I directed the question at Nie Zun . He didn't speak, but calmly swept his gaze around .

I frowned, “This doesn't feel good; it's as though I've committed a crime in my own home . I'm returning to my own damn district, what's there to guard against!”

And so, I stomped my foot, placed both hands on my hips, inhaled a deep breath that traveled all the way to my diaphragm, then bellowed, “Whoever is hiding out there, show yourselves! I've already seen you!”

The group fell into silence...

The group fell into silence...

It was Jie Pa who made the first comment, “Ms Ah Shen, we still have Mr Tao Lie and Mr Mu Li in our company . Please take more care in managing your reputation as a District Commander . ”

I was immediately overwhelmed by a feeling of indignation—did I not have the image of a District Commander?! But I'm great!

“Li Shen, I hope you're well . ” A familiar voice sounded .

... What? Did they really show themselves after I told them to?

Lifting my head I could see 13—No, wait—15 of them .

There were two standing in the forefront of the group; in his late 20s, the man on the left wore a dark blue jacket with a head of neat, inch-long hair . His left hand was continuously in preoccupation with twisting the jade stone ring that he had worn on his right .

I recognized him; he was one of the 27 floor managers under me . Ta Lai, manager of the third floor .

I didn't know the name of the other man beside him, but I have seen him around as well . Middle-aged man with a pale and gaunt face, short hair .

He was the shopkeeper of the Weapon shop back in Western District's Marketplace, the one who gifted the Piercer to me . It was his wife's body that exploded right in front of my eyes—Ah Wen .

He was the one who spoke up earlier, “Li Shen, I hope you're well . ”

There were 13 other men with them, or more specifically, 13 giants . These 13 men were all around 5 meters tall, their body covered in muscles and wore only a pair of pants . The vicious look on their faces reminded me of an anime I've watched when I was still alive—those titans in Attack on Titan .

I'm not sure how you interpreted the words, “I hope you're well . ” In my opinion, if anyone says that to me, then in contrary, they definitely did not wish for me to be “well” .

Be it the giants in their company, or the eyes which were filled with pure hatred in Ah Wen's husband eyes... Either way, I could tell that I'm not welcomed here .

Yet, I still thought it strange . How did we not hear the sound of movements if there were this many giants approaching us?

Yet, I still thought it strange . How did we not hear the sound of movements if there were this many giants approaching us?

Noting the lack of response, Ah Wen's husband continued, "It seems that a person of our District Commander's status is apt to forget indeed . I'm Zou An, Ah Wen's husband, the one who gave you your Piercer . " His honorific form of "you" was accompanied by a sardonic laugh .

I shook my head, "I didn't forget about you, and I've remained grateful for the Piercer you and Ah Wen gifted . " I pulled out the Piercer that was tied around my calf and held it in my left hand .

Zou An didn't spare a glance at the Piercer . Instead, he continued regarding me with his cold gaze, "It's too bad . My wife and I didn't want your gratitude when we gave it to you, what we wanted... was your life!"

A malicious glint flashed across his eyes when the words left him, and his haggard face was instantly lit by his intent to kill .

With a wave of his hand, the 13 giants behind Ta Lai and him scurried to their feet and leapt into the air .

From that simple action, I unraveled the mystery behind their quiet footsteps when they approached us moments ago . The movements of those 13 giants were nimble, even more so than a regular person like us despite our comparatively petite stature . Observing their swift but light movements, I speculate that the huge size of their body did not have much effect on their mobility .

Since the trip to Southern District, there was no longer an ounce of fear left in me towards battling . I have already encountered all sorts of situation since arriving into the split zone . Did they really expect to restrain me by the mere use of these giants?

Dream on!

Pushing the tip of my foot against the ground, I jumped as well, drawing back the Piercer with my left hand then whipping it forcefully at the

incoming giants .

I realized it when I poured my MF into the Piercer the previous time—the combat weapon in my hand didn't feel ordinary . It almost seemed alive with the way it unleashes a destructive streak of violet light once it has its fill of my MF . If I coordinated this attack with just the right amount of strength, then the damage it could produce would be elevated to an extreme .

While I did not have a perfect grasp in terms of my control, but I did have almost a year and half worth of experience in Split Zone No . 13 . Besides, meticulous control over MF has always been Song Lu's forte, and I have never forgotten about her coaching .

Which was why, when I flicked my wrist sharply and channeled my MF into the Piercer, it roared into life . Like the crackling of lightning, an elongated flash of Violet Blade blazed its way to its target, whizzing decisively towards the 13 giants!

“Zou An, was it really necessary to get violent? No matter what, I'm still Western District's Commander!” Unable to maintain my hover in mid-air, I descended gradually while keeping my eyes fixated on the the Violet Blade as it traveled towards the giants behind Zou An .

Zou An's murderous intent was undisguised and clear from the look in his eyes, “Li Shen, were you ever deserving of that title?”

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Zou An's murderous intent was undisguised and clear from the look in his eyes, “Li Shen, were you ever deserving of that title?”

Following his words, my eyes followed in surprise as all 13 giants increased their speed . Some were bent at their waist, others leapt in mid-air for a

second time and in an instant, each one of them had managed to dodge my Piercer's Violet Blade attack without missing a beat .

Was it possible? Even a person of normal stature would not have guaranteed success in surpassing the speed of my Piercer's attack, yet... these 13 giants who measured at 5 meters tall are able to dodge them with such agility?!

Missing their swift evasion, the Violet Blade whirled past them and into the deep forest .

Snaaap! Craaack!

An entire cluster of trees was cut down by the horizontal strike of Violet Blade!

While I was inwardly impressed by the increased damage potential as a result of my own collaboration with the Piercer, I was startled as well—when did these 13 monsters appear in the Western District?

One after another, as though crushing us with their weight had been their intention, the 13 giants appeared over our heads and plummeted . Pushing his glasses, Jie Pa took an abrupt step forward and crouched . On his right hand, he crossed his index and middle finger, seemingly forming a knot with his hand prints, then drew a circle around him while muttering an incantation, “Shield!”

From where his fingers were, a stream of bright light appeared at his word, and an arched barrier of white light was formed from the ground .

At incredible speed, the barrier drew a semicircle from one end of us and curved forward into the ground of the other, forming a hemispherical layer of protection .

Thump, thump, thump!

A series of thuds sounded when the weight of those 13 giants made contact with the shield at the end of their fall . The soles of their feet glowed white for a split second, before the enormous body of theirs rebounded .

With a loud crash, the giants were thrown into mid-air once more and plunged back to their initial position behind Zou An and Tai La . Their eyes were bloodshot with rage as they viciously glared at us .

Chapter 67

67 Did You Think I Would Be Oppressed?

With a swing of my long dress, I took a huge step forward and glared at Zou An . A sneer upon my face, I started, “Zou An, you truly are bad at differentiating between the good and evil . As far as I’m concerned, the incident regarding Ah Wen was not my doing . On the contrary, the history behind these experiments has everything to do with You Ji and yet, you are all willing to work for her?

“I admit that I have not contributed much as a District Commander since I was given this position . Still, I hope that despite this, you’ll remember that Li Qing’s appointed commander is me, Li Shen!”

A strong gust of wind whipped at my hair, but my gaze remained stubbornly upon the group of men in front of us .

I will not retreat, nor will I show any signs of weakness . Even if I hadn’t done my best in the past, I can start over now . I have Song Lu and Yu Liang waiting for my rescue, and there’s Laurel too . There was no way I would surrender my district to those people!

A peculiar expression formed on Zou An’s gaunt face, and he looked at me as though he was watching a monster . After a long pause, he smiled, “Who said I was working for You Ji? I’m afraid she wouldn’t be able to make me even if she tried . Ah Wen and I had always concealed our identities in order to live a peaceful life within your district’s Marketplace, and I have never held any expectation towards an incompetent commander like you to protect us . At the very least, though, you could have left us out of your battles .

“But you—if we were to talk about Li Qing’s appointed commander, then I did have a question for you . Have you acted worthily of Li Qing? Did you think you are the only one who’s qualified to bring her up?”

I frowned . Not because he had called me incompetent, but because of the obvious hidden meaning behind his words .

What did he mean by concealing their identities?

While there were many questions answered, I didn’t take the liberty to ask them . Instead, I glanced towards Jie Pa and Nie Zun . With their quick-thinking, I was confident that they could make the most correct analysis of any situation .

As expected and in perfect sync, they looked over at me and gestured with a slight shake of their head .

Alright, they were indicating that I should not act rashly .

“Concealing your identity? What did you mean by that?” I asked in an attempt to drag it out .

There was darkness in Zou An’s eyes, “If Ah Wen hadn’t been unwell in the past year, then we would have never fallen into the trap of that demon, You Ji . Nonetheless, you’re to blame for everything . ”

I honestly did not want to tolerate this any further . With a nod of my head and a smile that didn’t reach my eyes, I was almost gritting when my teeth when I asked, “Zou An, can you speak in a way that I’ll be able to understand? From what I’m hearing, you seemed to know that You Ji is behind all this, so why are you directing your hatred at me?”

“You Ji did all this to bring light to your incompetence; she couldn’t stand the fact that a person like you was able to receive recognition from both Li Qing and Mr Blond before her . When you became District Commander, her motive was never to kill you . Instead, she wanted to throw Western District into chaos in order to reflect your inadequacy, to prove a point that not choosing her was their mistake .

“Even so, we shouldn’t have been the sacrificial lambs in your battle! Not Ah Wen, not that little boy, not even the people You Ji sent to kill you . This is all because of you . ”

It was only when he mentioned Ah Wen’s name that Zou An’s voice trembled .

“So you’re saying that, you knew this was all You Ji’s doing?” I could feel an unrestrained coldness filling my heart at the news .

Fleetingly, a look of exasperated anguish swept across Zou An’s eyes . He was just about to speak again when he was interrupted by Tao Lie, the man who had been quietly turning the ring on his finger all this while .

Ta Lai was tall with equally long legs, completed with a perfectly sculpted torso . In combination with the blue jacket and his well-kept short hair, he exuded an air of wild abandon with a hint of gracefulness .

Despite the time I have spent in Western District, I have never noticed such a good-looking guy within my group of Floor Managers . I scrutinized his figure from head to toe, and couldn’t help those indecent thoughts that crept up to me .

Up till a moment ago, his left hand was rotating the jade stone ring on the middle finger of his right . He lifted his hand, elegantly gesturing for Zou An to cease our conversation .

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It was with keen observation of his movement that I realized my previous speculation had missed its mark—the person in control of those 13 giants was not Zou An, but Ta Lai . As the floor manager took a step forward, the 13 giants followed closely behind .

He spoke unhurriedly as he kept his eyes on me, “Let me ask you a question, Li Shen . ”

I stayed silent, and his left hand went back to give his ring a single rotation .

His voice was calm when he continued, “What’s on your mind now that you’ve returned from Southern District, and faced with this?”

I was caught off guard by his words . I recalled the moment when I vowed to protect Western District in front of those 27 Floor Managers, he had been the first to speak at that time . Taking the current situation into account, no matter how I thought about it, he didn’t seem to be on my side . So why was he asking me such a question?

Noticing the 13 giants behind him with the murderous look in their eyes, each one of them ready to attack at any time, I know I didn’t have the luxury of time to ponder .

I was rapidly weighing out the current position I’m forced into . With Tao Lie and Mu Li’s support, I had been nothing but confident with my return to Western District . After all, they were Rank A members of the S Clan; even if they weren’t a match in ability as compared to Guan Nie, they wouldn’t be too shabby either .

However, the unexpected entrants of those agile giants changed the circumstances . Without knowing what other abilities they possessed, there was no way of telling whether we would win in a fight against them . Even if we might not necessarily be the weaker link, but their numbers against us was a worthy consideration to deliberate over; I wasn’t confident that Jie Pa would be able to escape unscathed, and the current condition of his body didn’t allow for a lapse in judgement . A reckless decision on my part would be enough for me to lose him .

I answered coolly, “I didn’t think about anything . Not only was I unable to find Laurel during this trip to the Southern District, I didn’t figure out the method to leaving the Split Zone either . On top of that, I lost Song Lu and Yu Liang . Through all of it, there was nothing left for me to dwell on . What I do know, is that there is no way I will leave Li Qing’s Western District in ruins, and I will definitely find a way to get my friends back!”

My gaze was fixated on Ta Lai when I was done . In the past, I had remained idle through my days in Western District, not putting much effort in understanding these Floor Managers . There were some who were capable of great achievements when Li Qing was around, but I had never heard of Ta Li among them . As he stood so composedly in front of me today, it was my gut instincts that warned me against belittling his capability .

My intuition had always been accurate . Furthermore, if Nie Zun and Jie Pa hadn't stepped in by now, then it further fuels the belief that they don't think we should be hasty . Tao Lie and Mu Li, on the other hand, were outsiders to this district and it seemed like they wouldn't recklessly intervene with our affairs .

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In this scenario, everyone has taken a cautious approach, even more so than when we were exchanging direct assaults within the illusion at Southern District . None of us knew the extent of strength when it comes to the other party, and in such situation, the odds of winning may not necessarily lie with the person who strikes first .

Even with my gaze on him, I couldn't find any trace of effect to his emotions at my words, and in that, I didn't find any flaws on him .

My wariness towards him increased once more .

He remained composed when he dipped his head, and in his usual steady voice, he asked again, "And if you managed to save your friends, how do you plan to protect Western District in the future?"

I inhaled a deep breath . This was a question that I had been avidly avoiding, but that didn't mean that I have never thought about it .

The ordeal that we have been put through during this period of time had forced me to contemplate this . People within the split zone may behave indifferently, each minding their own business, but I came to a realization that where there's humanity, there would be concern .

Concern was the fundamental emotion between human, it exists even at a place like this, even at a place without compassion .

Which means to say, no matter how much I'd like to avoid the responsibility, I have to acknowledge that my decisions and choices play a direct role in other people's lives . It was precisely because I accepted the Li Qing's appointment that I lost my right to do as I pleased in the split zone .

Because I'm Western District's Commander .

“I won't be able to protect Western District; everyone in the split zone is only capable enough to protecting themselves—this is a fact that I can't escape, even as a District Commander . What I can do, is to lead the residents of Western District towards the right direction in leaving the split zone . As long as you are willing, I'll accompany all of you to the very end .”

Those words were spoken with vigor, but I didn't feel the same confidence in the depths of my heart . I knew that it was a feat easier said than done .

Everyone knew that there was a secret to the split zone, that soul splitters were a rare breed, and that acceptance was seemingly the only option you have once you've arrived into the split zone . Yet, as the person who appeared to have difficulty even accepting her situation, I was now suggesting to lead everyone in revolt .

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appeared to have difficulty even accepting her situation, I was now suggesting to lead everyone in revolt .

As rebels, we win if it succeeds, but it'll be our lives on the line if we lost .

It wouldn't matter if I was the only one to perish, but it's a group of people that I'm leading to their deaths, and yet, I'm eagerly attempting to gain their trust .

Even I had doubts about myself on this .

Nevertheless, it was all I could do to match Tao Lie's calm stare with one of my own .

He didn't speak after that . All he did was turn his ring around once, then again, and again .

“Why are we wasting our breath? I hadn't realized she had such silver tongue till now . ” Zou An interrupted .

He looked straight back at me, his eyes were filled with hostility . “Li Shen, I understand you might think that you're innocent, but there's no other choice . Since the incidents started because of you, then it's only reasonable to demand a form of justification from you . You can only fault your own destiny for this—I must kill you!”

His words were so ridiculous to me that I couldn't help the sneer from tugging at my lips . Observing my strange smile, Zou An's grew even more agitated .

Still, I couldn't do anything else but laugh .

Blame it on my destiny? I, Li Shen, has never led a fortunate life but when have I ever offended anyone?

Just because I have horrible luck in my own fate, just because you wanted my life, did that mean I would obediently serve it to you on a silver platter?

Chapter 68

68 Two Arms and A Net

“Zou An, it seems like your prejudice against me won’t be resolved by words alone . If that’s the case, why don’t you just get to the point? What’s your motive? Are you after my life?” My words were without emotions as I posed the questions to the older man, no longer wishing to be entangled in this dispute . If a fight was what they wanted, then a fight they’ll get .

Zou An glanced towards my Piercer, “Even if i don’t kill you, any owner of that Piercer will not survive long either . Li Shen, I have just one question for you . ”

“Shoot . ”

There was a trace of hesitance in Zou An, but he spoke up eventually, “During your trip to Southern District, have you ever met a person named Gao Qin Jiu Ye?”

Gao Qin Jiu Ye...

Ha, he had to ask about the one person I was most unwilling to think about .

Somehow, every so often, I would inadvertently recall the scene of Gao Qin Jiu Ye’s departure, when he pointed at me and said that he didn’t care about anyone . It would always leave me out of breath, as though my heart was stuffed with clouds and clouds of cotton wadding .

What right did I have to favor you? After all, you’re not Gao Qi, nor had we known each other for long .

Still, what was I secretly expecting out of him?

My chest tightened at the recollection of his ruthless yet enchanting face, “I did, and just like you, he told me that the Piercer brings misfortune upon its owner, and wanted me to return the weapon to where it was last found . ”

Zou An was in clear disbelief, “He actually allowed you to return?”

I frowned, “Yes . What’s your point, exactly? Do you know each other?”

Zou An’s eyes shifted darkly and squinted . Upon his gaunt face, there was the similar hint of darkness, “It’s nothing . Even if sacrifices are needed, it seems like there’s no way I’m going to let you get out of here alive today!”

With that, he raised both his scrawny arms above his head and shouted a single word, “Gather!”

There was not an ounce of exaggeration when I say that the action prompted a heap of weapons to emerge from the forest behind him and charged in the direction of his finger, whizzing towards us . The number of weapons were innumerable; ranging from knives to swords, daggers to guns and arrows .

“My barrier won’t be able to block those weapons . ” Jie Pa voiced out immediately at the sight before loosening his hand gesture, dispelling the shield to recover his MF .

With the fall of Jie Pa’s shield, the calm and composed Ta Lai jerked his fingers as well . The slight movement gave those 13 giants the green light to charge forward without hesitation; their hands fell onto the ground in front of them . On all fours, they pushed towards us with even more speed than before .

It was when they opened their mouth that I had a clear look of their rows of sharp teeth, which resembled a meat grinder . Those ruthless fangs were coated with a sticky venom-like substance as they roared towards us .

Ugh, how repulsive .

Gritting my teeth, my Piercer was raised in preparation to counter the 13 giants while my mind fell in a frenzy; weighing out the number of weapons that was charging at us at the same time, it searched for a way to dodge them all .

How much MF does Zou An have, in order to control this many weapons at the same time? Also, even if his family owns the weapon shop, was there really a need to waste their resources like this?!

“Argh!” Witnessing the amount of razor-sharp weapons rushing towards us, Bandage Man sprinted forward and took position in the forefront of the group . With the sounding of his sonorous growl, another bang resounded from his back before an enormous net blasted from it . It bore a resemblance to that of a spider web .

It was the first time I’ve seen such a technique and in that moment, I was stunned . I didn’t manage to gather myself enough to produce a proper reaction, all I did was to stare fixedly at Bandage Guy, Mu Li’s back .

Mu Li’s body was fully wrapped in bandage and at the moment of his growl, a protruding lump formed in the center of his back; that was the core of the web . From there, a huge structure made out of densely packed and intertwined bandages was formed . With the web behind him, he looked like a spider spreading its web .

All around the web, there were innumerable bandages which resembled tens of thousands of pedipalp . Some of which were more flexible than the others and seemed to have sight of its own, binding itself around weapons flying through the air without difficulty .

With that, the hundreds of weapons found themselves entangled in Mu Li’s net, as insignificant as insects caught on a spider web . The web in front of me stretched relentlessly on all ends, almost encasing the entire clearing of forest .

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me stretched relentlessly on all ends, almost encasing the entire clearing of forest .

Woah... That's incredible . I could hardly keep my jaw from dropping at the sight .

But that wasn't the most amazing display .

During the time when I was caught in a daze, the 13 giants gathered . Like a squad, they bolted towards us on their hands and feet with bared teeth .

While Mu Li was preoccupied with his own defense, Muscle Man Tao Lie burst into action as well . Just like Mu Li, he rushed and took his place in front of the group and all I could see was his back . Still wearing his sunglasses, his toned muscles were hidden under the grey sleeveless shirt .

A series of crunching noise emitted from his back when those 13 giants rushed forward, and I was even more dumbstruck than before by the spectacle!

From the gap of his sleeveless shirt, I was able to catch a glimpse of the muscle across his back which had started beating rapidly like a blood vessel . As it pumped further, his shoulder began inflating in size, and as if he had evolved into a beast in that instant, they grew tenfold in size!

Bang, bang!

Crunch!

At such speed of growth, the cacophony of his muscles breaking through its constraints as well as the twisting of his bones reverberated . Soon, they had grown at an unimaginable speed into two gigantic arms .

Despite my hanging jaw, I was still unable to find the words to describe it .

It was about a meter in diameter, and extending to not less than five meters in length . Yet, the combination of appearance was peculiar...

Even though Tao Lie was tall, measuring at almost 1 . 9 meters in height, he still had the regular build of a person . Right now, however, his arms seemed to be heavily infused with steroids but his body remained in its regular state . Comically, with those huge arms, his body looked like that of an ant's .

Even so, his comparatively tiny body held steady, as if it contained an unfathomable strength, and began swinging his arms swiftly .

Even so, his comparatively tiny body held steady, as if it contained an unfathomable strength, and began swinging his arms swiftly .

Boom!

With the swinging of those giant arms and the wall of bandage web, Nie Zun, Jie Pa and I stepped back immediately in order to vacate the premise for them .

With our hasty retreat, I turned back in full speed and swung my Piercer with immense force . Numerous Violate Blades whizzed forward at the stroke, cutting down a vast area of trees behind us .

I apologized inwardly, “Sorry trees, the battle calls for it!”

I could hear Nie Zun's teasing laughter from beside me, “Can't help practicing on those trees the moment you gained a slightly more combative skill?”

Despite wanting to roll my eyes at him, it was true that I'm proud of the new application to my Piercer . At least he was complimenting the new technique I've developed .

As expected, the tactics of fighting are found through actual combat, unable to attain through private practice alone .

When I drew back by almost ten meters, I could see the enormous arms swinging away at the giants, knocking back three of them in succession .

My face twitched at the brutality of his fighting style . It's no wonder he's one of Jiao S's most capable underling...

The turn of events had obviously left the 13 giants flabbergasted; they hadn't expected the appearance of such enormous arms, and much less the fact that they could be picked up as easily as chicks and flung back with overwhelming force .

Be that as it may, there were still limitations to Tao Lie's arms . Between the intervals of his swings, several of those nimble giants scurried through the gaps and headed towards us .

At high-speed, Bandage Man Mu Li's web, with its limitless extensions, bound tightly around the variety of weapons that were whirring over from the other side of the forest .

Pulling back when we did, three giants emerged ahead of Jie Pa from the gaps of Tao Lie's attack .

Just as he was about to step forward and seal us in his force field, I glanced over at Nie Zun . Nie Zun's eyes met mine swiftly and understood my intention immediately .

I spoke up in haste, "Jie Pa! Hide behind us! Your defensive skills will be able to protect yourself while it assists us . Stop showing off, protecting you is our first priority!"

Just as he was about to step forward and seal us in his force field, I glanced over at Nie Zun . Nie Zun's eyes met mine swiftly and understood my intention immediately .

I spoke up in haste, "Jie Pa! Hide behind us! Your defensive skills will be able to protect yourself while it assists us . Stop showing off, protecting you is our first priority!"

Wielding the Piercer, I rushed forward with Nie Zun hard on my heels . Nie Zun's dark silhouette appeared beside me in a flash, staying close to me .

I tossed the Piercer to him just as our eyes met .

With his lack of participation in battles, I was never sure of Nie Zun's combative skills, but I knew that he didn't use any form of weapons and thus, was unsuitable for long distance combat .

He caught my Piercer promptly . In the meantime, with my tip of my feet against the ground, I leapt in mid-air and readied my bow, my hands drew out six arrows at once .

Arrows on bow, it struck forward at full speed!

My six arrows shot through their ferocious eyes of all three fast-approaching giants with precision . I infused my MF into them for the first time, and the effect it achieved left me pleasantly surprised .

As if it held the radiance of a blaze, the arrow sunk fully into the giant's eyes!

The strength brought upon by the tip of the arrow was enough to make the giants stop in their steps as well .

“Ahoooo!”

The three giants inclined their head towards the sky, parted their lips, and wailed .

At the same time, Nie Zun's held up my Piercer unwavering with his right hand, a faint smile decorating his features . Just like me, his gloved hand swung it laterally with force, flicking a stream of Violet Blade forward .

What frustrated me though, was the fact that his Violet Blade was far more powerful than mine!

The Violet Blade in front of my eyes seemed to be ignited by a violet glow and expanded in size as it traveled forward . Like a laser, the giant blade that whizzed past was dazzling .

Chapter 69

69 You Will Beg Me

The Violet Blade seemed to carry an electrical current, winding up a strong gust with it . As the three giants clutched their eyes from my arrows, it struck them against the chest .

Boom! There was an explosion of violet light and blood sprayed the surroundings!

Pu-tsst!

As if it was alive, the Violet Blade continued ruthlessly forward even after it collided with the giants, until it had completely sliced through them into halves .

Rumble!

Severed into six segments, the giants clashed loudly to the ground .

When I descended back down, I twisted my head towards Nie Zun .

He donned a peaceful smile, his starry eyes were surging with a shred of radiance, and his jet-black fringe fell in front of his eyes, covering that fair forehead of his . When he noticed my gaze on him, he smirked, reaching out to return the Piercer .

I glanced sideways at him, “It seems like you’re more suited for this weapon . ”

There was a faint smile on him when he shook his head lightly, “I have no use for something so violent . I’m a very gentle person . ” He winked .

In reciprocation, I rolled my eyes again .

When I returned my attention, the situation ahead of us had already changed .

Five of the giants flew back from the impact of Tao Lie's bellow and another three were torn apart by his arms . This was even worse than being sliced by my Piercer .

The remaining two were just about to charge forward when Ta Lai jerked his finger again . Keeping their ferocious expression, they obediently returned to Ta Lai .

On the other end, Mu Li's giant net had flung all the weapons back to where they came from . With a piercingly cold gust of wind, the countless number of sharp weapons deflected back towards Zou An .

Zou An's pale face did not express any changes; he merely lifted a hand calmly, and dropped it again decisively .

Rattle!

As though it had lost its anti-gravitational force, the weapons that were cutting through the air fell to the ground in a rattle, littering the ground in front of him .

Just as I was about the step forward, there was a glaring light emitting from the giants which we had sliced apart, as well as those that Tao Lie ripped into shreds . With a blink of an eye, they shrunk into mini version of those giants like a wooden figurine .

I was taken aback by the transformation . Were these... Were these figurines brought to life by Tao Lie, then transfigured into giants and placed under his control? Did he infuse his MF in order to do that? Was that possible? I had infused MF in my Piercer as well, but I couldn't convert it into an element of control over the weapon . The only thing I could manage was to become one with the Piercer and unleash an attack that was immensely more damaging .

These people, Mu Li and Tao Lie included, had mastered the trick to controlling their MF with precision, including those that were expended .

Among those I've met, Song Lu had been the best at her precision of MF control; even though she didn't have a high level of MF, with a tiny stream of water, she would be able to fatally pierce through her enemies .

These people, on the other hand, had clearly honed their skills in MF control to perfection .

I frowned . As it turns out, my time here was still too short, right?

It appears that MF could be used in two ways . The first would be precision control to fulfill its attack on the enemy, while the second was the sensing of MF, using it to construct a unique ability of your own . Just like Guan Nie with his illusions, Jie Pa with his shield, and Yu Liang with his soul projection .

It was apparent that I couldn't incorporate either methods deftly... Or perhaps, I just hadn't ever figured out how to do so since the very start .

At a time like this, I truly wish I could ask Li Qing and Mr Blond for the reason behind my appointment . What had they seen in me that made me worthy of being a District Commander? Could it be that it was my double identity disorder which convinced them? Would my second identity emerge again and transform me into a deadly female warrior?

I really don't understand it... Among these people... I'm practically useless...

Sigh...

It was obvious that our enemies on the other end couldn't comprehend the knit in my brows or the dip of my head, much less the reason for my gloominess .

Ta Lai watched me with great interest before finally speak up, "Are you surprised by this puppetry technique?"

Preoccupied by my self-hatred, I didn't respond .

“Li Shen, it seems like you have brought reinforcements upon your return from Eastern District . However, I'm afraid you have been oversimplifying the situation at hand . ”

Still stuck in my dejection, I couldn't gather enough anger for a retort . Instead, I raised a brow at him coldly and stared, “What do you mean?”

Still stuck in my dejection, I couldn't gather enough anger for a retort . Instead, I raised a brow at him coldly and stared, “What do you mean?”

Zou An smiled but didn't answer .

I seriously can't stand people who speak in such baffling manner...

Graceful and calm, Ta Lai shot me a smile, as though our successful counter to their attack was not at all surprising to him .

He turned and took a step, then, with his long and slender legs, he leapt onto one of the remaining two giants, taking a seat upon their shoulder .

He faced us, and crossed his legs with incomparable elegance, a hand stroking the jade stone ring on his other, “Li Shen, I'm not interested in taking your life . I want something else . ”

“What?” I raised my brow .

“I want you and you alone, to tag along with me somewhere, and stay there for a month . ” Ta Lai smiled gracefully .

... I don't understand this at all .

These two lunatics must have snuck out when You Ji wasn't looking...

“I know you don't understand it now, but you will one day . In fact, you will be begging me when the day comes . ” Ta Lai turned the ring on his right hand twice, and spoke with a firm but calm voice .

A sardonic laugh escaped me, “Oh? How are you so sure that I will beg you? Haven’t you heard that I, Li Shen, has never begged anyone?”

Ta Lai tilted his head, supporting it with the palm of his hand as he leaned against the giant’s head, his composed smile was beginning to get on my nerves, “Of course you wouldn’t beg anyone for yourself, but what if it’s for him?”

Unhurriedly, he lifted his left hand and pointed to the spot beside me, right at Nie Zun .

I was stupefied . I turned and took a glimpse at Nie Zun . What... did he mean by that?

Before I could respond, Nie Zun chuckled and brought his gaze slowly towards Ta Lai, “I will never allow her to beg anyone on my behalf . ”

There was an indecipherable stabbing in my heart .

It was as if Nie Zun words had intrigued him; his usually unperturbed eyes was suddenly flooded with strong interest as he watched Nie Zun .

It was as if Nie Zun words had intrigued him; his usually unperturbed eyes was suddenly flooded with strong interest as he watched Nie Zun .

For some reason, I hated the way he was looking at Nie Zun; the way he watched Nie Zun like he was something he could attain with extreme ease, something he must have .

“Whatever you are thinking about, whatever you want to say or do, just spill it . I’m not interested in prolonging this meaningless conversation . Do you want to continue the fight, or did you want something else? Just say the word and get this over with . ”

I raised my voice, fearlessly looking at the people opposite me .

Ta Lai was not in the least affected by my loud declaration . His eyes remained fixated on Nie Zun even as his words were directed at Zou An, “Let’s go . There’s no way you’ll be able to kill her today . ”

A self-deprecating smile crept across Zou An's face for a split second before it was wiped away completely . He turned towards Ta Lai, "Don't forget about your promise . "

Ta Lai's smile was as composed as ever when he nodded in response . Then, to Zou An, he added, "Let's go . "

Meanwhile, I was startled .

"Hey, hey! Aren't you taking us too lightly? You charged at us out of nowhere and initiated a battle, and now you are just leaving as you please?!"

I have had enough with this ridiculous situation . With a swing of my Piercer, I clamored .

However, the giant had already turned its body and began walking into the depths of the forest . Zou An, on the other hand, regarded me coldly before jumping onto the other giant's shoulder, then followed after Ta Lai .

"We're just going to let them come and go as they please?" Frustrated, I turned towards Nie Zun .

His eyes were unexpectedly solemn, and the words tumbled out, "We won't pursue . "

Fine . Even though I was still raging, but since Nie Zun had made the decision, then I've lost all interest in it as well . And so, I merely gritted my teeth while I watched their retreating backs before spinning back towards Tao Lie and Mu Li .

I had initially wanted to admire their tactics in detail, but by the time I turned my gaze towards them, they were already back to their usual form . Tao Lie still had his sunglasses on, standing respectfully to the side, while Mu Li's sparkling green eyes were no longer as terrifying as it had been .

Jie Pa stepped out from behind us, and pushed against his glasses before calmly making his way to one of the abandoned wooden figurines .

Crouching down, he took out a white handkerchief and wrapped it around the figurine before placing it into a glass bottle that he had prepared . Once again, he stuffed the bottle into his backpack .

“Tch, tch . Jie Pa, that backpack of yours is basically Doraemon’s magical 4D pocket! Despite all the bottles that you keep in there on a daily basis, it still fits . ”

Jie Pa smiled warmly at me, “Ms Ah Shen, what’s a Doraemon?”

...

Jie Pa smiled warmly at me, “Ms Ah Shen, what’s a Doraemon?”

...

“Jie Pa, were you a doctor in your previous life?”

Jie Pa nodded, “Yes, a psychiatrist . ”

Ah, it’s no wonder...

Awkwardly, I scratched my head and laughed .

“Ms Li Shen, I’ve never seen the guy in blue before today . Who is he?” All of a sudden, Tao Lie asked .

“He’s one of my floor managers . He wasn’t that active in the past and I don’t know much about him either . I only know of his existence . ”

With his sunglasses on, I couldn’t read his expression .

“Ms Li Shen, I hope you will practice even more caution when you meet him again . ” Eventually, Tao Lie said .

I frowned, “Why? Did you notice something?”

Mu Li continued on behalf, “It’s like this... The man had claimed that it was a form of puppetry technique he used earlier to control the giants .

Typically, we might assume that it's a mere manipulation of the MF . However, to Tao Lie and my understanding, puppetry techniques are capable of much more than that . ”

“Basically, even if it was the puppetry technique, there was practically no one in the split zone who had achieved perfection in its execution . ”

Adding on to Mu Li's answer, Tao Lie pushed against his sunglasses . “With the exception of Southern District's soul snatcher, Rong Jin, we haven't met anyone who would exhaust this much MF to practice this sort of puppet manipulation skills .

“But that's not the most important part . What's most crucial is the fact that such a person with puppetry skills had gone under Mu Li and my radar all these years . They might have chosen to keep it low profile, or maybe they have something to hide . Either way, it puts us ill at ease . ”

Jie Pa nodded in agreement, “Yes, that's the most critical . My informants had never reported this to me either . A floor manager with such ability... Even Nie Zun and I have never heard about him before today . ”

...

I'm no longer surprised . There were many people with astounding abilities in the split zone and they were always more mysterious than the next . After such a turbulent month, there was nothing much that could shock me anymore, including our new discovery .

Chapter 70

70 Empty City

“What should we do now, then? We still have no clue about the situation in Western District . ” I turned towards Nie Zun and asked .

Nie Zun was looking ahead, but the expression in his eyes seemed to have drifted even further .

“Does any of you feel like our surroundings have changed?” Nie Zun muttered suddenly .

I looked around but... All around us was still the same boundary forest of Western District . Apart from the battle earlier, there was nothing different about it that I could pinpoint .

Nie Zun exhaled a soft sigh, “Let’s carry on forward then . ”

His tone seemed to suggest that we had arrived at an unfamiliar place, as opposed to the Western District where we resided in . I complained inwardly . Sigh... The atmosphere had grown so tense, and those two weirdos from before did nothing to help it .

After a little more than an hour, the group of us finally got through the boundary forest .

The thought of Western District being on the other side of those line of trees in front of us left me worrying about the look of fear or contempt I may face in my resident’s eyes . Even so, it was still difficult to conceal my excitement at the idea of returning to a familiar site .

Such mixture of emotions was completely vanquished by the scene that unfolded in front of me .

While Western District's boundary forest may not be as dense as that of Southern District's, it was still planted by our own residents seed after seed . I didn't catch the faintest whiff of decay as I walked through the exuberant forest, so why... Why was I greeted by such a dilapidated sight the moment our district came into view?

When we finally got through the boundary forest, whether it was me who had always appeared jovial, or Jie Pa who remained calm and composed through everything, or even the indifferent Nie Zun, all of us were rooted to our spot from shock .

At this moment, there was only a sort of indescribable emotion mashed out of glazed stares, fear, incomprehension, helplessness, so on and so forth .

The Marketplace which was supposed to stand proudly by the boundary forest was no longer there . Right in front of our eyes was a scene that shouldn't have existed, nor should it ever have been able to exist .

“This... Am I seeing this right?” Almost hollering out the question, Mu Li asked .

Even Tao Lie's bulky stature seemed to have shivered a little, “Li—Ms Li Shen, the people we have sent to survey your district have never crossed over the boundary forest . We didn't know about this... this... Wh—what exactly is going on here?”

I could feel the trembling of my legs, but it wasn't out of fear . It was out of concern; an excessive and overwhelming worry .

Such apprehension wasn't the same as when others warned you about the arrival of doomsday . Such apprehension... was as if you had witnessed the end of the world with your own eyes .

I couldn't divert my gaze, and so I allowed my attention to be stubbornly fixated upon the wasteland in front of us .

That's right . A wasteland .

It was not the Western District that we knew which appeared in front of us, but a wasteland .

Like an ancient castle which had caved in, the sight that welcomed us out of the forest wasn't the Marketplace... No, perhaps it might have been, but you could no longer identify it in its current state .

The spot where the Marketplace used to be was now replaced by a collapsed building .

A boundless odor of decay filled the air all around the debris, with brown pieces of rocks and jet-black rubble resting upon it . The sky was filled with drifting dust and dirt .

At a glance, there was only an overcast of smoke and dust . At a glance, there was not a single soul in sight .

I wanted to step towards the ruins, yet, when my right foot moved forward, it was as though a withered hand had materialized from the ground, coiling an iron grip over my ankle . My leg faltered in pain and was giving way; I felt an overwhelming urge to fall on my knees where I stood .

It was Nie Zun who held me up .

“Nie... Nie Zun... What's going on? Where... Where's Western District?” I could feel an unexplainable grief filling my eyes and I clutched tightly onto Nie Zun's hand in return . Staring into his eyes, I asked with trepidation .

“Calm down . Let's continue forward and check the situation ahead . ” Even though his voice remained in its apathetic tone, but I saw the fleeting gaze in his eyes . It was as though he couldn't bear it either .

I sucked in a deep breath and repeated Nie Zun's words, reminding myself to hold myself together . With that, we began moving along, going increasingly faster with every step, never stopping .

As we went deeper into the district, there was nothing new that caught our eyes . On each flank, the view that surrounded us was nothing more than barren land and ruins .

It was like walking through a vast desert which had buried an abandoned, ancient castle . The corners of countless collapsed buildings were buried within the unique stone ground of the split zone, bringing forth an aura of doom .

It was like walking through a vast desert which had buried an abandoned, ancient castle . The corners of countless collapsed buildings were buried within the unique stone ground of the split zone, bringing forth an aura of doom .

We ran even faster .

Ruins, ruins, and even more ruins .

I didn't know how long we had been running through this area, but wherever we looked, all we could see were ruins .

There wasn't a single building that was left intact, not a single tree, not even the plaza square that would typically be outside the buildings . There was only an empty land of stone grounds, void of everything else but ruins .

There was not a single person .

“What the hell is going on?!” Unable to bear the heinous scene anymore, I stopped in my tracks and screamed out without care .

“Is this still the Western District? Did we get trapped in an illusion?” Even Jie Pa, who always stayed cool-headed, began asking as he swept his gaze around .

“Where's everyone?” Tao Lie and Mu Li asked at the same time .

But, did I look like I have the answers?

We stayed glued to the ground and glanced at one another . Eventually, no one was able to explain the scene that we were faced with .

There was not a single soul or thing, in the entire Western District .

Apart from the normalcy we found in the boundary forest, everything else in the Western District seemed to have been struck by calamity, leaving the remnants of graves with no bodies .

There was no response to my yelling, not even an echo . The vast area in front of us seemed surreal, but at the same time, it was beyond the shadow of doubt, real .

Nie Zun continued running, and while I could distinctly feel the wobbling of my legs, I ran along .

It seems like there was nothing I could do, besides running .

We didn't know how long we had ran before we finally spotted something different from those relics .

We didn't know how long we had ran before we finally spotted something different from those relics .

No... Not something .

It was a person .

“Ah—!” Erupting from my throat, I let out a high-pitched scream that reverberated throughout the abandoned and desolate land .

In this infinite stillness, we finally found a familiar face .

According to the blueprint that had been so deeply engraved in our minds through the years, we should be near the center of Western District, in front of the Academy .

But... could we have sprinted too far ahead? All that littered the place were fragments of building tiles .

The only difference was the man in the middle .

Specifically, it was an old man who had been turned to stone . His feet were buried deep in the rubble, with both hands placed clasped in prayer in front of his chest . His eyes were shut tight, and his entire person was covered in stone .

His head... was lacking its crown .

During this state of petrification, the scarlet red of blood no longer seeped through . Instead, within his bare skull sat his brain in jet-black .

It was Old Man Fan .

“Grandpa!” I screamed out when I rushed to his side, my outstretched arm attempted to touch him .

But... I didn’t know where to start .

Old Man Fan had both his eyes closed, his entire body was besmirched by soil, and even his limbs and organs seemed to have been turned to stone, albeit not completely . As though he hadn’t completed his fusion, he became half human and stone, abandoned in the midst of this chaos without a hint of breath .

Jie Pa rushed forward and pulled me back, advising against laying my finger on Old Man Fan .

“What happened to him? Huh? Jie Pa!” I was almost shouting at this point .

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“What happened to him? Huh? Jie Pa!” I was almost shouting at this point .

“Ms Ah Shen, don’t panic . Let me take a look . ” As Jie Pa attempted to calm me down, I could see the slight quiver to his hand when he held out his handkerchief . Despite how much he tried to conceal under the calm facade, it was obvious that he was unnerved too .

Surprisingly, it was when I noticed his distress in my peripheral vision than I quietened down . I mustered all my faith in the single gaze that I shot him .

Jie Pa nodded at me, and began his investigation with the handkerchief between his right hand and the stone statue .

He tried moving Old Man Fan's hand to no avail .

“He has been turned to stone?” Tao Lie asked, as aghast at the sight as we were .

Jie Pa nodded solemnly . “It seems so . Still, looking at the brain that's been exposed through the top, it appears that there are still flesh and blood underneath the surface . ”

Taking the time when Jie Pa was studying Old Man Fan's body, I surveyed our surroundings . Similarly, Nie Zun circled the circumference at full speed .

“There seems to be nothing else here in Western District, except this . ”
Finally coming to a conclusion, Nie Zun pointed to the battered stone figure —Old Man Fan .

“What do you mean there's nothing else? How can there be nothing else?” I was in disbelief at the news .

Nie Zun sighed, his eyes held a gleam of perplexing worry .

“Ms Ah Shen, this should be Old Man Fan's body . As for how he had been transformed into this state, I honestly have no way of knowing and neither have I encountered such a situation before . The flesh and blood beneath this stone surface have been completely frozen over as well; I don't know if he's still alive, or if he still has MF . ” Jie Pa exhaled, then added, “I really... have never seen something like this before . ”

“Tao Lie, Mu Li...” I was about to speak when Tao Lie moved to remove his sunglasses, revealing those eyes that were brimming with vigor . He

seemed to have guessed my next words before I even spoke . As though revealing his eyes was a form of affirmation of his answer, he replied before I even had to ask, “Ms Li Shen, such an occurrence is unheard of, much less witnessed by us . ”

“That’s right . Those officials we had concealed in our boundary forest mentioned that there were always throngs of people scuttling around on this side of the forest, as if someone was instigating an uprising . As such, we speculated that Western District had fallen into chaos . Now that we’re here, however, there’s not a single person in sight and the entire district seemed abandoned . We’ve never imagined it to be reduced into such desolation!”

My heart was overwhelmed with the cold sense of dread .

Chapter 71

71 District Commander, I'll Await Your Return

“What should we do now?” I tried my best to soothe my nerves .

Jie Pa looked solemn . “I had a group of residents who acted as my informants . While they might not be able to help every single time, I still had faith in their loyalty . During the time while we were gone, I had been worried that You Ji might have figured them out and inflicted harm on them as a result, but now it seems that the issue isn't restricted to just a few people . ”

Nie Zun swept his gaze around before eventually speaking up . “Right now, we can be almost certain that this isn't an illusion, nor was it possible to send a large group of people away just like that . After all, Western District is the dead end to the split zone, and Eastern District bordered the other side . I don't suppose there's an ability in existence that could allow undetected transportation of a few thousands of people all at once?

“Which means to say, we can be sure that the cause of this must be something we are clueless about, something that's beyond even our wildest imagination . ”

Listening to Nie Zun's conclusion, a thought sprung to mind . “Does this have to do with Ta Lai and Zou An? Didn't we meet them in the boundary forest earlier? They left in the direction of Western District, so where are they now?”

The answered was revealed right as I asked .

As though they were returning to match our speed, Ta Lai and Zou An approached, still perched atop the two giants' shoulders .

“Ta Lai, is this your doing?” Without waiting for them to reach us, I shouted towards them with a finger pointing at the barren land .

On top of the slowly approaching giant, Ta Lai’s face was unexpectedly grim, and his voice held a hint of dejection, “We were only a step ahead of you, and had similarly just returned to the Western District . We have already surveyed the entire district; this is all that we could see . ”

A retort was at the tip of my tongue when Nie Zun gestured for me to keep my cool, before stepping up himself . “You mean, you haven’t been camping out in the boundary forest in waiting of our return?”

Ta Lai leapt from the giant’s shoulder, “That’s right . When you departed from Western District, Zou An sought me out and we left together . We’ve never returned here all this while and had only been a step quicker than you today . We were just more well informed than you were; we knew about You Ji’s intention a long time ago but had never expected Western District to be reduced to such state . ”

“Why should I believe you? You claimed that you left after we did, but You Ji brought up the deaths of 7 floor managers and the betrayal of 20 . Why didn’t she mention anything about a missing manager?” I asked coldly .

Ta Lai rotated the ring on his hand calmly, “It’s up to you whether you want to believe it or not . After you left, the floor managers did betray you, but your understanding of You Ji was practically at zero . Once her split symbol is activated, she will have the ability of duplication; within a small period of time, she can replicate the ability of another person, as long as it didn’t exceed her MF . Did you ever know about this?”

I was speechless .

My understanding... of You Ji?

Was that why she was able to use Jiao S’s air manipulation? Did that mean to say, when she had purposefully framed Nie Zun, the ability that she claimed he had was actually her own? In that case, what was she trying to tell me?

“Regardless of You Ji’s ability, her decisiveness or viciousness in executing her plans, it was true that she was a thousand times stronger than you were . When you left, there were many who didn’t wish to betray you, but within the split zone, who wouldn’t prioritize their own survival when the situation has taken a turn for the worse? Li Shen, District Commanders aren’t Kings in the split zone . What’s the purpose of a District Commander, why did Mr Blond appoint them—Have you ever truly pondered over this?”

As before, I remained speechless .

Ta Lai’s voice remained calm throughout, speaking without a change in dynamics of his speech, “I reckon that perhaps too much time had gone by since Li Qing’s departure, perhaps during this time you had forgotten about everything you ever promised her . You were never able to trust in yourself, never able to comprehend the reason behind Mr Blond and Li Qing’s appointment . Even so, there were ways to attempt understanding even when you can’t comprehend, but you didn’t . All you did was evade, you chose to remain oblivious . It was only natural that You Ji would hate you . And Zou An? Zou An’s hatred towards you was just as it should be . ”

His forlorn eyes were locked onto me, not granting any opportunity to escape, “If one failed the people who had unwaveringly committed their faith in them, then, that in itself is a sin . ”

“It’s true that I’m not qualified to be the Western District Commander . ” I said, dejected .

“If you don’t have faith in yourself despite the trust others have placed in you, then that’s even more unforgivable . ” Ta Lai’s words were like needles, drawing blood with every prick .

Despite this, I knew that the words he was speaking—someone whom I used to be complete strangers with before this day—was nothing less than fitting for me .

This is exactly who I am .

“That is why, what I think you really need is someone to lend you a helping hand . Someone to remind you why you were made the Western District’s Commander, and what that title really meant!”

“That is why, what I think you really need is someone to lend you a helping hand . Someone to remind you why you were made the Western District’s Commander, and what that title really meant!”

His last sentence was forceful, and his gaze on me was penetrating and sharp .

Zou An, who had hopped from his giant’s shoulder, turned quiet at his words .

I didn’t breathe a word, and the same applied to everyone around me .

In the end, it was Zou An who spoke up . As though he was unwilling to even spare me a glance, he turned to Ta Lai, “You’re going to bring her there right now?”

Ta Lai nodded gracefully, his slender fingers turned the ring on his hand twice, “Yes . As you can see, the circumstances have changed . ”

Zou An’s face was wiped of emotions, and he stayed quiet for a few moments before walking back towards the Western-Eastern boundary forest . “I know there’s no way you would agree to it if I asked for her life at this moment . I just hope that you won’t forget about your promise . Anything else is up to you . I’ll be heading back . Let’s meet again when you’re done . ”

With a nonchalant lift of his right hand and a little wave, the giant followed after Zou An, “Why don’t you let him follow you?”

Zou An didn’t respond but neither did he reject the offer . He leapt onto the giant’s shoulder again and walk past us . Not once had he looked my way .

“Li Shen, leave with me . ” Ta Lai flashed a small, elegant smile .

Logically speaking, if a baffling and mysterious character such as Ta Lai asked this of me, I should have rejected without hesitation . However, for some unknown reason, there was something about his speech that made my subconscious tug at me to accept .

But... Can I really believe him?

How should I respond? Where was he planning on taking me?

Noticing my lack of response, the finger that was resting upon his ring jerked, “Allow me to analyze the current situation for you .

Noticing my lack of response, the finger that was resting upon his ring jerked, “Allow me to analyze the current situation for you .

“There are two items on your agenda right now . One, to get your friends back, and two, to protect Western District . Observing your current level of strength, you wouldn’t be able to accomplish either . The plight that Western District has found itself in had far exceeded my expectation as well, but you don’t have the right to reject . I must make you remember, exactly why you were appointed commander . ”

His words were arrogant, yet, like a deflated ball I had no will left in me to fight back .

“The existence of a choice is for those who are competent, and the incompetent had likewise forfeited their right to choose . You can only go with me . ”

Tao Lie seemed to have sensed my desolation when he stepped forward, “Ms Li Shen, do you want us to contact our commander and search for a solution together?”

At the thought of Jiao S, I immediately declined with a wave of my hand . Jiao S still has the burden of Eastern District on her shoulders, how could I continue being this reliant on her?

When we travelled to Southern District, I had relied on her and Gao Qin Jiu Ye, and the result?

I still couldn't figure out the true meaning of my existence .

This... Could this be why Gao Qin Jiu Ye abandoned me?

Even if I knew that he did it for Si Luo, even though I knew that we had only known each other for a short while, but why can't I let go?

I want to be like Jiao S, to be that strong and brave in pursuing the person I like...

"Thank you for your good intentions, Tao Lie and Mu Li . " I took a deep breath, turning towards them .

"Not only am I helpless about the plight of Western District, I was in the dark all this while . I'm afraid I've let both of you witness myself as an incompetent, joke of a commander . " I laughed bitterly .

Mu Li responded in haste, "That's not it, Ms Li Shen . I might have developed some prejudice against you before, but we have utmost faith in our commander . If our commander trusts in you, if she's willing to help you, then that means you have your own set of strengths . "

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My eyes wavered . To have people who trusted this much in her, I was suddenly so envious of Jiao S .

Nie Zun's eyes fled swiftly to mine, like he was asking, "Don't you have them too?"

That's right, don't I have them too?

I glanced at Jie Pa, who stood to the side, still as calm and composed as ever . I thought of Song Lu and Yu Liang .

It was true, I did have them .

But I...

As if I had made a major decision, I returned my attention to Mu Li and Tao Lie, "I've decided to go with him . I know it's possible that you may not comprehend the rationale behind my conclusion, but this is something I must do, and I'll need to ask for your help . "

Mu Li had every intention of stopping me but was blocked by Tao Lie's muscular arms . His spirited eyes shone with a form of trust, and in his usual respectful manner, he said, "Please do tell . "

Pointing at Jie Pa, I inhaled a deep breath, "Please take Jie Pa back to the Eastern District with you and do your best to protect him . "

Jie Pa didn't seemed surprised at my words . He met Nie Zun's eyes, then, with his calm gaze, he said to me, "Since Ms Ah Shen has decided, then I'll return to the Eastern District with Mr Mu Li and Mr Tao Lie . I'll be able to conduct experiments on the items I've collected over the past few days while I'm at it as well . "

Then, with his familiar habit of pushing up his glasses, he flashed a faint smile, "Commander, go on ahead . I'll await your return . "

In an instant, my eyes reddened .

Chapter 72

72 A Hand in the Dark

Tao Lie nodded . “Ms Li Shen, please be rest assured that we’ll protect Mr Jie Pa to the best of our abilities . We swear it on our reputation as Rank A officials of the S Clan . ”

I nodded fervently, then swept my gaze towards Nie Zun . He was looking back at me with his usual indifferent and calm gaze but I understood the meaning behind them .

I turned towards Ta Lai once more . “Alright, since you’re adamant about bringing me with you then I might as well follow along . I’d like to know if I’m truly the Western District Commander too!”

I was firm with my declaration .

There was a trace of appreciation in Ta Lai’s eyes . “All things considered, there are still aspects to you that I can look forward to . Don’t worry, I don’t want to kill you . Through this journey with me, you’ll definitely achieve something unexpected . ”

I shook my head . “I’m not worried about whether you plan on harming or helping me and neither am I curious about where you’re taking me . I just really want to know what I’ve forgotten!”

Ta Lai smiled but didn’t answer .

“But wherever I go, I’ll have to bring him along . ” I pointed towards Nie Zun .

It was only then that Ta Lai shifted his attention to Nie Zun . At the moment he looked over, Ta Lai's eyes glistened .

“You can control with your pupils?” He asked with a tug of a smile .

“Yes . ” Nie Zun responded with a faint smile of his own .

“Alright . ” The word seemed to be directed at Nie Zun even though he was nodding his head at me . Either way, he appeared to have agreed to the proposal of Nie Zun accompanying me .

I dipped my head in ponder for a moment before taking in a deep breath again, flashing a radiant smile at Tao Lie and Mu Li . “Alright then, you should go . Bring Jie Pa along with you and return to the Eastern District . Inform Jiao S about everything that has happened here but tell her not to worry about me; I'll definitely visit her again . ”

Worried, Mu Li shot a skeptical glances at Ta Lai who remained at his spot opposite us .

Tao Lie nodded . “Don't worry, Ms Li Shen . We will convey this to our commander without missing a single word . ” As though in warning, he looked towards Ta Lai when he spoke . His eyes seemed to be expressing a hidden message, conveying that Jiao S would send someone for me if he dared to harm me in any way .

Ta Lai maintained his elegant and casual smile without responding .

I waved my hand . “Let's go on our separate ways then . You should hurry up and get through the boundary forest before night fall . Don't stay here overnight; staying in this wasteland seems pretty frightening too . ”

Tao Lie and Mu Li shot one last unease glance at Ta Lai, but nodded their head eventually .

Jie Pa remained unperturbed through it all . Adjusting his glasses, he held out a small black bottle from his bag and passed it to Nie Zun .

Likewise, Nie Zun received it casually, placing it safely in the pocket of his windbreaker .

Jie Pa gave a nod towards Nie Zun who dipped his head in return .

There's a mutual understanding that I didn't understand . Nonetheless, I could sense the immeasurable trust between them .

“It's settled then . Ms Ah Shen, go on and head off with Nie Zun . We'll be leaving Western District before dark as well . ”

I nodded .

Thereafter, the three of them sprinted towards the boundary forest after one last glance towards me .

“Alright, let's talk about this . Where are you bringing me? Apart from the three established districts, it doesn't seem like there's anywhere else to go in the split zone . ” I said to Ta Lai .

Ta Lai flashed his usual smile . “That's not true . There's a lot of other places within the split zone . Where I'm bring you now is just one of them . ”

Lifting his slender finger, he pointed towards the opposite of Eastern-Western boundary forest .

“But this is the end of Western District and in that, the end of the split zone . ”

Before the setting of the sun, we followed Ta Lai to the edge of Western District where the Western Residence was .

There were no boundary lines on this side of Western District, for there isn't a district beyond here . The area was occupied by vast area of boundary forest which was only lined with dense trees on the outer rim . Within the forest, there were more empty voids and was a spot where many would come to practice their MF .

At the end of the forest, there were clouds of black fog that were impossible to cut across .

This... is the end of the split zone .

As we stepped into the core of the boundary forest, Ta Lai took position on a vacant stone ground . All of a sudden, he lifted his hand and grasped at the void .

With his movement, a gust of wind surged from the ground beneath his feet! Nie Zun and I were standing in the midst of it all, and the strong burst of wind whipped my hair and red dress around haphazardly .

With his movement, a gust of wind surged from the ground beneath his feet! Nie Zun and I were standing in the midst of it all, and the strong burst of wind whipped my hair and red dress around haphazardly .

Freaking hell, I'm about to expose myself!

Just as I was about to weigh my dress down with a hand, the piece of ground beneath us seemed to come to life!

By the time I reacted to the situation, I was already falling .

The three of us, along with the ground that had just breached open in a square, plunged at full speed as though we were taking an elevator!

“Ahhhhhhh!!” I screamed as the grey ray of light slowly disappeared from above our head and all around us was covered in stone walls . With the speed of my fall, the wind that was rushing from below blew my hair in the opposite direction, making it stand atop my head .

During the entire process, the two graceful and calm men watched me as if they were looking at a monster!

Although I could understand that the image must have been horrifying—a screaming woman with her long, red hair standing upright atop her head, pressing down on her equally red dress with both hands in vain . Even so,

the feeling of weightlessness was seriously uncomfortable! I could care less about how I must have looked, I just screamed on .

After falling for several metres, the right hand where Ta Lai donned the ring twitched again and the stone ground that carried us floated in mid-air!

Yet, the only thing on all four ends were stone walls, as though we've sunk into a well . I still haven't recovered from the terror but my thoughts had already began to wander .

Why is this scene so familiar?

A deep tunnel? Could it be that the boundary forest here has a tunnel of its own?

Could it be that Ta Lai wants to turn Nie Zun and I into experiment subjects as well and stuff us into a big bucket...

The thought of those hideous leeches made my lips quiver and I shot my glance towards Ta Lai but he didn't return my gaze . Instead, he lifted a finger on his right hand and pointed to one of the stone wall .

It was when I followed the direction of his finger, that I realised there was a stone door fixed upon it .

Stone door...

Is there a stone room behind that door too...

I feel faint just wondering about this!

Still, despite my reluctance, the situation is no longer within my control . Ta Lai walked over to the door and with a turn of his ring, the door began to open gradually but all I could see within it was darkness . There wasn't even a shred of light .

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open gradually but all I could see within it was darkness . There wasn't even a shred of light .

Nie Zun and I caught each other's eyes, and just as Ta Lai was about to step in, the two of us caught up to him in haste .

The moment our feet stepped through the door, the stone piece that transported us here rumbled to life and rose towards the ground above again, just like an elevator .

While I was looking back in horror as the stone floor disappeared into view, the stone door closed with a swoosh!

When I turned back, I realized... I realized that I couldn't see anything!

My vision was pitch-black, and everywhere I looked was filled with darkness . I couldn't even make out the silhouette of my own fingers!

Even if it had turned dark outside, being bodies of consciousness in the split zone, we still had our circumference of visibility . So how was it that I could see nothing in here?!

I swiftly directed MF towards my eyes, enhancing my vision but there was still nothing at all, only a vast area of pitch-black darkness!

"Nie Zun? Ta Lai?" I cried out .

In the midst of the darkness, I could hear Nie Zun's reply, "I'm here . "

But Ta Lai said nothing .

Like a blind person, I stretched both my arms forward and began feeling my surrounding aimlessly . If I remember correctly, Nie Zun shouldn't be too far ahead of me .

"Nie Zun, you didn't move, right? Don't move around . " I tried to calm myself down but the usual panic that one would face in darkness was slowly creeping up to me .

“I didn’t move . ” Nie Zun’s voice was still composed like always and that put me more at ease .

Guided by my subconsciousness, my outstretched arms continued searching as I moved forward .

On my left... Nothing .

On my right? ... Still nothing .

My feet took a careful step forward, followed by a light movement of my hands, exploring the area ahead .

I couldn’t feel anything, and it made me feel a wave of helplessness .

This feeling of helplessness seems familiar...

I couldn’t feel anything, and it made me feel a wave of helplessness .

This feeling of helplessness seems familiar...

“Nie Zun?!” I was getting scared . Ever since I’ve arrived into the split zone, I was able to see even in the night . I’ve never been faced with such darkness .

“I’m here . ” Nie Zun replied calmly .

I could hear Nie Zun’s voice from somewhere not far away from me, but why can’t I reach him?

Gritting my teeth, I took a huge step forward . With the long stride, my heart sank with it as well .

It was a good thing that my feet was still in contact with the ground . It seems like there wasn’t an abyss or anything strange like that here .

I really don’t want to imagine myself falling into any strange pits .

With a small sigh of relief, I took another huge stride forward then began feeling around my surrounding again .

Finally, I seemed to have reached his arm .

I felt a burst of glee and was just about to speak up when the arm I felt began moving vigorously!

I haven't had time to respond before the hand in the dark grabbed onto my own right hand and yanked forcefully!

“Ah—Ahhh!”

A chill ran down my arms, then with a sound of splatter, my entire right arm was pulled apart by the hand I felt .

I could feel the deluge of blood spraying from my right shoulder, the sharp pain began to spread from there to my entire being .

With my scream, I staggered three steps back and at the same time, placed pressure on my right shoulder with my left hand, heaving for air .

“Li Shen, what happened?!” Nie Zun's anxious voice sounded once again from ahead of me .

Despite this blindness in the peculiar darkness, my eyes were still staring wide open, sweeping around me in the dark .

As for the hand that pulled my arm off, it seemed to cease its breathing after that single action .

For now, three steps back seemed to be a safe range . I could feel my right arm beginning to heal .

Chapter 73

73 What She Taught You

If there was a way to retrieve the arm that had been yanked off, it would have taken no time at all for it to mend . Unfortunately, the chances of that was lost in the midst of this darkness and considering the fact that my body has to grow a full limb, the rate of recovery was slow; it will take at least ten minutes for it to be healed .

“What exactly happened to you? Li Shen?” Nie Zun’s voice sounded in the dark again .

I continued applying pressure to my injury and did my best to calm my breathing . Even when my tolerance for pain had multiplied after the time spent in the split zone, it had still been a long while since I’ve sustained injuries of this extent .

Keeping my voice as steady as I could manage, I replied, “Nie Zun, be careful . We’re not the only ones here . ”

“You’re hurt? Where are you? I can smell blood . ” The rustling sound of his movement told me that he must have started searching for me yet, for some odd reason, I couldn’t pinpoint his location . It was as though the place could distort your five senses, there was simply no way of locating him .

“I am, but it’s fine . You can feel it too, right? This place can make a person lose all their senses . Be careful . ” I warned in a soft voice .

“Mmh . ” With a hum, the stone room fell back into silence until all I could hear was my own suppressed panting .

Bearing the pain of my arm's regrowth, I began shifting forward with increased vigilance . Removing the Piercer from my calf, I gripped it tightly in my left hand .

“Ta Lai, what's the meaning of this?” I asked softly but there was no response .

I swung my Piercer lightly against the ground .

Crack!

“Nie Zun, can you determine the location of this sound?” I questioned . At the same time, staring at the spot where the Piercer should have been, I came to the realization that I was blind even to the violet glow it should be emitting .

“I can't . This place seemed to have messed up my senses . ” Nie Zun responded calmly .

“I guess all we can do is wait . ” I sighed .

“Are you alright?”

“I'm fine, don't worry . ” Once again, I raised my Piercer and struck it forcefully towards the front .

Crack!

I could hear the sound of the whip, but not the light that it should be giving off .

“Nie Zun, I'm going to use my MF . In a while, I'll whip a Violet Blade in all directions so there's a chance I may hit you, but you can use that to determine where I am . ” I explained .

“Alright . ”

At the moment when I lifted my Piercer, ready to initiate the Violet Blade, I felt a hand latching around my right feet!

It was a knee-jerk reaction when I struck the Piercer towards its direction .

Crack!

The hand loosened their grip when the Piercer made contact with my feet . However, with the strike came an agonizing pain that shot through my leg and I grew unsteady where I stood .

“I can’t feel your Violet Blade . ” Nie Zun spoke up .

“Tsst... That hurt like hell . ” I muttered under my breath as I endured the pain of my flesh being torn open by the whip .

“It’s futile, Li Shen . This stone room will distort your senses . ” Composed as always, Ta Lai’s voice rang from the depths of this darkness .

“What the hell are you doing?” Baring my teeth, I retorted . Never once did the grumbling in my heart stop—this hurts so damn much!

“Eheh, I’ve told you before, I’m going to help you remember everything Li Qing had taught . ” Ta Lai’s laughter was graceful and serene .

I froze at his words .

In that instant, a snippet of memory seemed to rush into mind .

It was like an incident that had happened in the past which you’ve never forgotten but, for some unknown reason, you’ve never thought about it either . Yet when the day comes, when it gets triggered again, it seems to drown your mind with vividness of the memory .

I was brought back to that very day, about a month into my arrival at the split zone .

I was brought back to that very day, about a month into my arrival at the split zone .

“Ah Shen, you’re slacking off again . If we are not done with planting these trees by the time Li Qing gets back, we’ll get punished again . ” Li Wen

flashed a smile at me while I was stuck in a daze, perched on a tree .

I stared blankly at the branches above me . “How did trees appear in the split zone?”

Pouring the growth agent into the pit she had just dug, she responded, “What’s the use of over thinking it? Now that we’re here, we should just get used to this lifestyle . Weren’t there also plants and greenery in our previous life? Just treat it as though we’re still in that world, then . ”

I was quiet for a moment .

“Hey, you guys aren’t done yet? I’ve already planted dozens of them . ” You Ji’s cheerful voice rang from afar . Lifting my gaze, her pale green hair upon that serpent body fluttered in the wind .

I couldn’t help the bitter smile from forming . “How do we pretend that this is still the previous world?”

Li Wen seemed to have sense my thoughts . Her gaze flitted from You Ji’s approaching body, then back to me . “Ah Shen, you’re always this pessimistic . ”

Am I pessimistic...? I just... really want to go back...

I’m really not used to this...

“What are you thinking about, Ah Shen? Come on down and help us! With the three of us, we might just be able to finish planting them before Li Qing returns . ” You Ji beckoned me over as she reached out to help Li Wen .

I responded with a soft and simple, “Coming . ”

“Do you need my help?”

A timid voice suddenly spoke up from behind me .

I turned back to see Nie Zun in his black turtleneck shirt, a pair of black jeans, with both hands tucked in his pocket . He shot a gaze that would have

been able to melt anyone else's heart and gain their sympathy, but I hate it . I hate it when he looks at me that way .

“No, just stay away from me . ” I replied callously .

Hopping down from the tree, I dusted my hands then asked Li Wen and You Ji begrudgingly . “Why do we have to plant trees?”

You Ji ignored my whining . Instead, her intrigued gaze was fixed at a spot behind the tree I had just leapt from . “Ah Shen, he's always following you around . Does he like you?”

You Ji ignored my whining . Instead, her intrigued gaze was fixed at a spot behind the tree I had just leapt from . “Ah Shen, he's always following you around . Does he like you?”

My brows knitted together . “Don't bring him up; I don't like him . ”

“Tch, tch, tch . ” Making a fuss about our relationship, You Ji curled her lips . It was with that look of hers that amused me into laughter and as a result, both Li Wen and You Ji guffawed along .

A sense of glee swelled in my chest and perhaps it was because of this contagious joy that a soft spot in my heart began to sink . I turned back subconsciously and watched the tree where Nie Zun was .

Nie Zun was sitting on top of it, he had a dazed, distant look to his eyes, and I have no idea what could be on his mind .

“How can a person like you resonate with her...” I couldn't help muttering to myself .

“What did you say?” You Ji nudged me .

“Oh—oh, it's nothing . ” I forced a smile in return .

“Was this all you have planted after one whole day?” Li Qing's hearty laughter reverberated from behind us .

I turned my head and regarded the woman quietly .

When I first met her, I called her “Li Qing jie”

She frowned, her face contorted while she waved her hand . “Don’t call me that! Call me Li Qing!”

I didn’t understand anything when I was assigned to the Western District . I didn’t even dare to speak as I pleased . Yet, as a district commander, she would always drag a newcomer like me with her . She loved wearing that silver armor of hers, and with a valiant flick of her short, indigo hair, she always looked so bright and full of life .

Li Qing was someone whom everyone in the split zone worshipped and looked up to .

“Was Ah Shen slacking again?” Li Qing opened her arms casually . Wearing her armor, she stopped beside me and wrapped an arm around my neck .

The refreshing scent of her seemed to drown me in an instant . Regardless whether we were in the split zone or the real world, I’ve never been this intimate with anyone, and it left me feeling uneasy .

I tried to twist my shoulders but Li Qing’s strength forbids me to .

Li Wen smiled . “Of course she was . I realized that being in a trance is her hobby . We should just call her ‘Trance Girl’, right, You Ji?”

You Ji beamed a charming smile, and shook her glossy green hair but did not breathe a word .

Li Wen smiled . “Of course she was . I realized that being in a trance is her hobby . We should just call her ‘Trance Girl’, right, You Ji?”

You Ji beamed a charming smile, and shook her glossy green hair but did not breathe a word .

My neck was still caught in Li Qing's tight grip . The texture of her hair was stiff and as the wind whipped them to my face, it prickled .

“The Eastern District has been chaotic recently . There's always some old man attempting on encroaching my Western District residents on the basis of their meager MF . I'm going to fight back one of these days, and put them in their place . ” Li Qing's voice was melodious and clear, with a hint of a man's arrogance .

“Those kind of violent acts aren't up my alley . ” Li Wen's eyes were soft, donning a sweet smile .

“Bring me along, then . I want to learn how to properly use my MF too . ” You Ji touched the green hair that cascaded down her chest .

Li Qing loosened her grip around my neck, her lips curved upwards into a smile . “Sure, I'll bring all of you along and teach you through actual combat while I'm at it! The split zone is different from your previous lives; there isn't a difference in strength between genders, but a difference in your MF . Anyway, being able to protect yourself is the main focus . All of you will follow me this time . ”

I lowered my head; my voice was neither loud nor soft when I spoke . “I don't want to go . ”

Li Qing rejected my declaration without hesitation, “No, you must go . ”

I turned my head, meeting her bright and limpid eyes . “Why must we fight?”

Li Qing's smile was cool as a breeze . “Because the split zone is too boring . The result of this boredom is either to bully others, or be bullied . ”

With that, she let go of my neck and stepped forward . Her head was tilted upwards, and the smile that tugged at her lips was even more striking than her eyes . “So, which do you want to be? The bully or the bullied?”

At that moment, I really wanted to open up my arms and say, “It doesn’t matter, I’ve always been the one to get bullied anyway . ”

But I remembered as quickly that that had been my previous life . In the split zone, I’m now a newcomer who possessed a MF of 52 .

And so I acquiesced .

Li Qing seemed to be overjoyed by my silence, and let out another ebullient laugh . After a few seconds, as though an abrupt idea had crept to her, or perhaps she knew it all along but had just now found an opportunity to say it, her eyes shifted sideways towards something to her back . Towards the spot not far away from us, his quiet presence on top of the tree felt as if he didn’t exist at all . “Nie Zun, you’re coming along too . ”

Chapter 74

Volume 2

74 The Basiliscampus

(T/N: Basiliscampus means Basilisk Sea Monster . Both Greek, ‘basilisk’ refers to the legendary reptile reputed to be King of serpents, and ‘campus’ has the direct meaning of ‘sea monster’, from the mythology ‘hippocampus’)

“Ah!”

The shriek came from You Ji just as we were traversing the boundary forest between two districts, moving towards the East .

You Ji had always been gutsy; there wasn’t much that could scare her, which was why I immediately whipped my head towards her at the scream .

The moment my eyes fell upon the culprit, I was flabbergasted .

For some reason, a creature was circling beneath a tree ahead . It had the appearance of a mermaid, yet at the same time, bore a striking resemblance to a serpent! Though it had a fish tail for its lower body, it wasn’t beautiful like a mermaid’s . Rather, it was filled with bumps and hollows of different sizes . Its upper body was human and from the peaks in its figure, you could faintly distinguish it as a woman .

However, the monster had no nose, her eyes were like black holes and when she parted her scarlet red lips I could see her green, serpent-like tongue . As for the tangled mess on her head, I could not tell if it was her hair or a bunch of sodden seaweed .

“Wh-wh-what is that?” My teeth chattered from fear . To be honest, even though I’ve been in the split zone for more than a month, I’m still not used to these strange creatures .

I looked at Li Qing frantically . At a time like this, only the armor-wearing, noble Li Qing could provide me with a sense of security .

Yet, in a twist of events, the expression on Li Qing’s face was even more peculiar than the monster . It was so strange that it surpassed my fear of the monster circling under the tree at the moment I saw it .

The expression on Li Qing face seemed... sympathetic, yet helpless at the same time .

It was simply too bizarre . I’ve only been in the split zone for a short time but as newcomers, Li Qing stayed with Nie Zun and I almost every day so she could look after us . That was when I knew that Li Qing was a resilient woman, almost beyond the point of comprehension .

Sometimes, I don’t even regard her as a woman anymore .

Her usual calm and unflustered self, unwavering before the monster, should have been the norm . Instead, it was as though she was a believer overflowing with compassion, on a mission to save the world, her face washed with empathy and resignation .

“Don’t do anything, just hide . ” Li Qing spoke up suddenly in a grave tone as she turned towards us .

“Didn’t you bring us here to practice real life combat?” Despite Li Wen’s gentle appearance, she was much more courageous than You Ji and I .

Li Qing squinted . “Perhaps another day . It’s still too early for any of you to handle this thing . ”

Without giving us a chance to question the monstrosity any further, she swung her arm and grabbed the broadsword from her back . Along with her

armor, she charged towards the creature like an awe-inspiring female warrior .

“You have the audacity to create havoc in my Western District? I’ll make sure you can’t get out of here alive!” Li Qing’s arrogant voice reverberated through the forest .

The monster was circling, staring at us with her black eyes . At the very moment Li Qing rushed forward, the creature opened her mouth wide and whipped out her green tongue, springing like an elastic band which could stretch and contract as it pleased . With a swoosh, the creature swiped with her tongue, coated in a dark green substance .

“How repulsive . ” You Ji’s eyes were filled with disgust, staring at the creature in front of us, her hand smoothing down her own green hair defensively . I glanced sideways at her glossy green hair and immediately felt sick to my stomach .

When I returned my attention to the battle, the broadsword which seemed far too large for a woman to wield was still in Li Qing’s firm grip .

With a swing, the blade sliced through the air and it was then the monster seemed to come alive . She rose from her spot, her tongue lashing about like a whip . The green toxin sprayed in all directions and a black fog formed wherever it landed; it seemed the substance on her tongue was acidic, capable of corroding anything in its way .

“Is this thing a serpent or mermaid?” I asked Li Wen in a soft whisper .

To which, she replied with a laugh . “Who knows?”

Tsst!

The swing of Li Qing’s blade severed the monster’s tongue!

“Ooh-oww!”

What the f– Even its cry was animalistic!

I was dumbstruck by the creature's mournful wail . In the next moment, her eyes were painted a scarlet red and her bloodied lips began spouting some form of black pus . The severed tongue was still twisting on the ground and her fishtail flapped vigorously .

Bang!

Bang!

Bang!

One by one, the trees were struck down by her tail!

“How truly disgusting, I simply can't bear to watch this anymore . ” You Ji wore an enchanting smile before she casually swept her captivating serpent tail .

Thump!

With the flick of her tail and an easy leap, You Ji moved dozens of metres ahead . Following her hasty advance, her hair danced in the air before it formed into two green whips at the back of her skull, seemingly infinite in length .

As she closed the distance between herself and that wailing monster, the end of her two whips made a sharp swerve backwards, forming the shape of a pointed arrow then plunged straight into the two black holes which made the creature's eyes .

Pu-tsst! Pu-tsst!

Two streams of gooey substance gushed from the monster's eyes and it let out a shrill cry!

The cry was exceptionally sharp and piercing to my ears . Without realizing, I grabbed onto Li Wen's hand and attempted to retreat a few steps back . It was then when I saw the hint of excitement that was spilled across her face .

Li Wen didn't sense my grip on her at all . I stared at her side profile, watching the excitement as it crept to her before eventually making the decision to loosen my hold .

And so, as an alternative, I shifted my focus towards looking for another shelter to hide . What can I say? Saving my dear life is an important matter!

When I advertently turned back, Nie Zun's eyes met mine . It seemed lonely yet clear at the same time and his chin was tucked into the collar of his turtleneck .

For some reason, my heart tightened at that and I stared coldly at him in return . In complete contrast to my indifference, my legs snuck a few steps back, moving closer to him .

“Ow!”

Another piercing wail sounded . I was only greeted with the complex expression on Li Qing's face when I shifted my attention back to them . Brandishing her broadsword, she lunged towards the monster again with a roar .

Despite being blinded by You Ji's attack, the monster didn't seem to be affected by its lack of sight . Instead, between its forceful movements of the tail, two withered arms grew from below the peaks of its body!

Tattered pieces of meat hung loosely upon it, looking as if the formation of those arms hadn't been completed . The arms crunched when it stretched forward, grabbing onto the two columns of You Ji's hair which had penetrated into its eyes!

You Ji was obviously alarmed by the abrupt change of the creature's body . Using her startled state to its advantage, the withered hands of the monster clutched tightly onto her hair like it could see even without eyes . It yanked her down by the hair before flinging her upwards again!

Along with her hair, You Ji's body was flung up by the blind monster and began swiveling in circles!

Swoosh! Swoosh! Swoosh!

I covered my mouth in disbelief; like a toy in the monster's hands, it swung You Ji by her hair, round after round with immense strength . A strong gust rushed towards wherever it passed, until a whirlwind began to form around its circumference!

A foul stench emitted from the whirlwind . Li Qing swung her sword but was forced backwards by the sheer strength of that foul wind . In retaliation, she swung her broadsword back and forth in succession, cutting through the air to keep herself hovering in mid-air!

A foul stench emitted from the whirlwind . Li Qing swung her sword but was forced backwards by the sheer strength of that foul wind . In retaliation, she swung her broadsword back and forth in succession, cutting through the air to keep herself hovering in mid-air!

You Ji had extended her hair too far out during her attack and now, as she was being swung this high up in the air and swivelling at such speed, we were momentarily stumped by the situation .

I can no longer get a clear look of You Ji!

Horror drowned my eyes as I watched everything in front of me and my hand found its way over my lips .

Li Wen glared and gritted her teeth before she, too, was floating in the air .

“Don't come near!” Li Qing hollered towards us, as if she had sensed Li Wen's movement .

Li Wen clenched her jaw, seemingly reluctant to stay out of the battle but neither did she dare to defy Li Qing's orders . Just like that, she remained afloat in front of me .

I've never witnessed such a brutal fight in the time that I've been in Western District . “Wh-what should we do?” Growing frantic, I couldn't help tugging at Nie Zun's sleeve .

Nie Zun's downcasted gaze swept calmly from the sleeve I was holding, to my face .

His voice was soft and gentle, "It'll be fine . "

Just like that, his voice seemed to hold an inexplicable ability of reassurance; those words alone calmed my mind in an instant .

I took a deep breath and watched Li Qing's continuous attempts at breaking through the whirlwind . After a second of ponder, I reached for the bow on my back .

The bow was gifted to me by Li Qing but I wasn't proficient at it . In all honesty, I haven't had much use for it since my arrival .

I held the bow in my hands and tried pulling back the bowstring .

... It didn't move .

I crunched my mind and contemplated Li Qing's words; feeling the infinite power surging from my split symbol, I tried manipulating some MF into my hands .

This time, I was able to pull the bowstring with ease . Attaching the arrows, I took my aim .

Should I shoot at the whirlwind? No, it'll get diverted the moment the arrow hits . What should I do then...?

... Ah, whatever . Let's just give it a shot .

... Ah, whatever . Let's just give it a shot .

Manipulating my MF, I pulled back, and secured my target in sight...

Swoosh!

A single arrow flew decisively ahead, charging towards the whirlwind!

Swoosh!

“Ah!”

Bang!

In a miraculous turn of events, the whirlwind broke apart at some point and we finally heard a cry from the swiveling You Ji . The monster’s hands were still holding onto the two bunches of splintered green hair!

Since her hair had been abruptly severed while she was spinning rapidly in mid-air, like a grenade, You Ji flew deep into the forest with a scream, gone without a trace .

Li Qing could care less for what happened, only that there was an exposed weakness on the monster right now . Leaping immediately, the luminescence from her broadsword shone!

She was furious now . The slice of her blade drew upon a shrill howl of wind .

Swoosh!

The glare from her blade was blinding, sliding across the monster’s flesh like it had been mud .

The monster’s body was split into half and its torso flew off with impact .

Floating back to the ground, Li Wen paid no attention to the savage end to the creature . Instead, she turned her focus to me, her features exhibited her shock . “What immaculate archery technique! You actually managed to take perfect aim at You Ji’s hair despite the speed! Even going through the effort of calculating the speed and movement of that whirlwind, in order to splinter You Ji’s hair!”

I was still in a trance .

Hearing Li Wen’s words, I watched her impressed expression as it lingered upon the bow in my hand and me .

Although it did feel nice to be complimented, I couldn't help wondering...
How did the arrow find its way along those rings of whirlwind, until it
eventually severed You Ji's hair?

I was clearly aiming for the creature's head...

Chapter 75

75 A Brutal Test

“I’ll go look for You Ji . ” The tip of her sole tapped lightly against the ground and Li Wen was once again floating through the air .

In the distance, after Li Qing’s initial cleave, she brought her broadsword down for a second, third, and fourth time .

Swoosh, swoosh, swoosh!

The luminescence of the blade was practically blinding my unworthy eyes!

Beneath the glare of her strikes that shone in all directions, the monster lay like a fish on a chopping board, sliced apart by a knife-wielding master . Still, the image of its blackened flesh splitting apart was an uncomfortable sight to behold .

For a split second, I thought Li Wen had escorted another mermaid-type monster when she returned with You Ji .

You Ji was covered in splatters of blood with only half the length of her hair left after my arrow struck through them . Her arm was bent at a weird angle and appeared to have been fractured .

Li Qing’s grumbling towards You Ji was relentless as she approached with her broadsword in hand, her . “I instructed all of you to stay put, yet you still took matters in your own hands . ” Despite this, it was apparent that she wasn’t truly annoyed by You Ji’s actions .

In spite of the masculine way Li Qing held herself—always with a hint of nonchalance and uncouthness—she had a great temperament, especially

towards the residents of her own district . In the Western District, she never viewed herself as a commander, and instead cared for us like a friend .

Nie Zun, who always had little to say, suddenly spoke up in an almost inaudible voice, “What exactly is she? Why isn’t she healing?”

His despondent eyes flitted ever so slightly towards the disintegrated corpse of the Basiliscampus .

There was a split-second flicker in Li Qing’s expression, but she gathered herself just as quick and took us into her outstretched arms . “Perhaps it’s because she was sliced to shreds by me . All of you should head back; I’ll take care of this . ”

“I’m covered in injuries, Li Qing . Make me something nice for dinner tonight . ” You Ji cried out .

Li Qing chuckled . “You should thank Ah Shen’s ‘arrow that missed its mark’ . ”

I drowned in embarrassment . “You could tell?”

Li Qing broke out in laughter . “That goes without saying! I’ve never seen you use the bow I gifted before today . Besides, even I might not have been able to get such an accurate shot . When something is that impossible, then it must have been by chance!”

“Ah, so that wasn’t a deliberate shot...” It dawned on Li Wen that she had been mistaken

I scratched my head bashfully .

While everyone was teasing me and everything began to return to the peaceful atmosphere that comes after victory, I noticed an abrupt shift in Li Qing’s eyes .

There was a murderous glint in them when she stared at me .

Baffled by the expression in her eyes, I froze .

While I stared blankly back at her, she had already lifted the broadsword in her hands and charged towards me at a much slower speed than she could have . With a swing, she slashed her blade down onto my arm .

“Ah!” The shrill cry that erupted from my throat was worse than the monster’s, reverberating through the boundary forest .

It hasn’t been long since I arrived at the split zone; hence I had zero experience of combat here . As a result, my tolerance for pain was about equivalent to a regular human being’s, and to the mere student I was in my previous life, the searing pain of a broken arm wasn’t something that could be easily suppressed .

Excruciating pain surged through me all at once, spreading across my entire head at the very moment my arm made contact with the earth beneath me . I convulsed, collapsing to the ground and onto my own pool of blood . Tears streamed ceaselessly as I whimpered, staring at my arm on the ground which was still bearing its warmth .

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“Li... Li Qing, you...” I could hear You Ji and Li Wen’s startled voices from beside me .

There was a prickling sensation stemming from where my left arm was severed, and the intolerable pain left me wailing uncontrollably . With the detachment of my arm, my train of thoughts had likewise detached itself from trying to come up with a logical explanation for this . After much struggle, I wanted to look up at them but was instead greeted by an encore of the familiar sound—the sound of a blade slicing through flesh twice .

“Ah!”

“Ah!”

Thump! Thump!

Another two arms fell by my side and before I could react, a shadow scurried in front of me .

The pain had not only muddled my sight, it had cancelled out all my other senses as well . It was only after Nie Zun had fallen back almost 20 meters that I realized he had picked me up and fled from the battlefield .

Without knowing when he had taken my fallen arm, he held it against the open wound when he sprinted, all the while holding me tightly in his arms . The moment the injury made contact with the detached arm, it began mending with rapid speed .

Despite the swift recovery, the fresh blood that was still gushing stained his black sweater .

He never stopped running, not until Li Qing and the others were out of sight; it was only then that he placed me on the ground .

Stricken with pain, I applied pressure to the arm that had just healed, not daring to move it around recklessly .

“Try moving your arm, it shouldn’t hurt too much anymore . ” Nie Zun’s voice was low, but light .

I glanced sideways at him . Even if I had always hated him, he still saved my life . As such, there was no reason for me to treat him with my usual harshness . I obediently moved my arm . There was a dull pain where it was severed, but it was more bearable now .

I glanced sideways at him . Even if I had always hated him, he still saved my life . As such, there was no reason for me to treat him with my usual harshness . I obediently moved my arm . There was a dull pain where it was severed, but it was more bearable now .

My heart palpitated from the mere recollection of the agonizing pain, the moment when the blade penetrated my flesh . Now that the pain had

subsided, however, my mind began pacing once more .

Why did Li Qing do that?

Could it be a toxin in the monster infected her mind?

Without giving me much time to contemplate the matter, Li Qing was already hot on our heels . Behind her, baring their teeth from the pain and holding their broken arms against their own wounds, were You Ji and Li Wen .

An overwhelming fear brewed in my subconscious when I saw Li Qing rushing towards us . My hand held onto my left arm defensively and I took a few steps back .

In response to my retreat, Li Qing's usually dignified expression was replaced with a gentler alternative . She stopped while there was still a distance between us and swept her gaze towards Nie Zun, who had moved to shield me from her .

“Do you know why I attacked you?” Li Qing glanced around the few of us, standing in a haphazard circle .

I was silent . You Ji frowned, biting back her pain as she responded with a simple, “No . ”

Eventually, Li Qing rested her gaze on me . “Ah Shen, I looked at you with murderous intent clearly written in my expression before I sliced your arm . The amount of time I gave you to counter was enough even for a newcomer with no combat skills . If you had reacted at the moment you sensed danger then, based on my lowered speed, you would have easily been able to dodge my attack . Why didn't you?”

I hadn't expected those words to tumble from her lips, leaving me frozen in shock once more .

She didn't dwell on my lack of response and shifted her focus onto You Ji and Li Wen . “Between the time I severed her arm and your startled cries, I

had given you both more than enough time to set up your defense . Why didn't you evade it? You allowed me to slice your arms too without breaking a sweat . ”

Li Wen narrowed her eyes but didn't speak . You Ji was stunned for a moment, then gritted her teeth in frustration .

Finally, Li Qing kept her broadsword and returned to her usual, carefree expression . “The only one who passed the test today is Nie Zun . He was able to react appropriately at the most critical moment . ”

Li Wen narrowed her eyes but didn't speak . You Ji was stunned for a moment, then gritted her teeth in frustration .

Finally, Li Qing kept her broadsword and returned to her usual, carefree expression . “The only one who passed the test today is Nie Zun . He was able to react appropriately at the most critical moment . ”

Following that, she lifted a finger towards me . “Ah Shen, though it's only natural that you couldn't dodge my attack when you have never expected me to hurt you, that is exactly why I wanted to teach all of you this lesson: you have to take stay on your guard against everyone and everything in the split zone . As long as you cannot guarantee they will never ever betray you, you'll need to take precautions . Even if I never had any intention of hurting you, you have to remain cautious . I had already made my malicious intent so evident, how could you still stand there and not counter?”

She pointed to You Ji and Li Wen next . “You two were worse . I had already severed her arm—I had obviously demonstrated my intentions . At least in that very moment, you must have developed doubts about me, so why didn't you defend yourself? Just because I'm a commander you get along with?”

You Ji had a retort at the tip of her tongue . “But...” She trailed off, never finishing her sentence .

Li Wen took her lip between her teeth, before letting it go again . “You're right . We should have been wary . ”

At Li Wen's words, Li Qing seemed to let go of the breath she was holding, but she sighed once more . "I know it's cruel of me to do this today, especially for Ah Shen . Ah Shen, you haven't been here long and as such, you've yet to endure many injuries . I know a broken arm must seem overboard but I really hope this excruciating pain will help you remember what I've taught you today .

"Only when you're wary enough and protective enough of your own consciousness can you survive in a place like the split zone . " Li Qing's eyes wavered for a moment then added, "Because I won't always be here to protect you . "

I was quiet through it all . While my eyes glistened with tears, I couldn't tell if it was from the pain or the complicated emotions I'm feeling .

Li Qing broke out into lively smile again, patting each of our shoulders . "Alright alright, I know you must have a lot on your mind right now, and you may even hold it against me . That's fine—I have faith in all of you that you'd understand my intentions . "

She clapped Nie Zun's shoulders, the last person in line, though I sensed some hesitation . She let a small smile decorate her features . "Oh, but Nie Zun, how were you able to react so promptly earlier, choosing to flee the scene and even taking Ah Shen with you? Not bad at all, being able to think on your feet at times of unprecedented crisis .

"You have a decent sense of danger and place importance on your bond as partners, knowing better than to flee without them . You even took the opportunity to pick up her arm as you went so she could heal faster . There aren't many who were swift enough to escape from under my nose like that, and with an arm and another person in tow? This further demonstrates your impressive mobility . "

Li Qing was filled with praises for him, her eyes revealing her appreciation and satisfaction towards Nie Zun's performance .

His eyes, however, were as indifferent as always, his sharp chin tucked in the collar of his black top .

Chapter 76

76 To Protect You

All this reflecting on our past ceased abruptly when I pictured that melancholic face Nie Zun used to wear .

My mind returned to the darkness in front of us .

In the darkness, I was still panting slightly . Blindly grasping at my arm, I could feel that it had grown by almost half the length . I'm no longer the newcomer who would lose her responsiveness simply from the pain of losing an arm .

I manipulated MF into my eyes, nose and ears once more, increasing sensitivity to my surrounding in this pitch-black darkness, seeking out the slightest hint of light . Even the ability to locate Nie Zun would be a satisfactory option at this point

Still, why did Ta Lai do this?

According to him, he wanted me to recall everything Li Qing taught—did he yank my arm off just to provoke that memory? Was he trying to warn me against trusting others?

No... I don't think that's the case . It can't be that .

Or rather... it can't be just that .

Besides, how would he know about my past?

The calculations in my mind shifted at a rapid speed, going through all the possible scenarios . Eventually, testing the waters, I spoke up, "Nie Zun, my

arm was pulled off by a mysterious hand in the dark . ”

In the blindness, I was greeted by Nie Zun’s silence . He spoke up after a minute . “And you thought back to when Li Qing sliced your arm off?”

I nodded before realizing he couldn’t see me . Even so, I knew he would have guessed that I was nodding despite not being able to witness it for himself .

With all Li Qing had taught me before, I couldn’t be sure if that memory was what Ta Lai wanted me to remember . Even if it was, I was still at a loss as to what he was trying to convey—did he want me to maintain my wariness towards others?

What I did gather from the memory though, was that I had indeed forgotten a good chunk of what Li Qing taught me . It was in that moment when I realized that I had grown into the person I am today because of Li Qing’s care and guidance . Even though it wasn’t enough to be a qualified commander, I wasn’t the Li Shen I had been before .

I was always evading, wallowing in self-deprecation and lived idly . Yet, I’ve never been so conscious about the fact Li Qing had already taught me how to face these trials and tribulations, the dangers of which I didn’t know before .

It wasn’t because I’ve never been taught, nor was it because I have yet to master them but because of the simple fact that I allowed myself to erase these from memory . Not because I’ve forgotten; but because I’ve allowed myself to forget .

That was why, no matter Ta Lai’s intention, no matter if he was good or evil, I was still grateful . Even though I haven’t yet found the path I’m supposed to take, at least I know that I should start moving forward—I can’t stay rooted to the ground forever, much less retreat .

On top of them all, I recalled just another tiny detail .

Nie Zun .

Contrary to the sight of pure darkness ahead of me, a glimmer of light flickered in my heart .

I had always ostracized and detested him because of my alternate personality, to the extent where I wanted nothing more than to abandon or kill him... Right? But Li Shen, he has never done a single thing to hurt you . In fact, hasn't he always been focused on helping you?

In a manner much like telepathy, his melodious and apathetic voice sounded at the very moment my thoughts turned to him, like a shining light in the midst of darkness .

“Actually, Li Qing was wrong about that time . ”

“Hm?” I was taken aback and couldn't comprehend the meaning behind his words .

Though it was impossible to see him in the depths of darkness, Nie Zun's voice was clear as day . “She said my reflexes were quick enough and that I had a decent sense of danger . In fact, I didn't rely on those at all when I escaped with you in my arms as quickly as I did . ”

I couldn't fathom what he wanted to say next, but my heart began pounding nonetheless . It was as though I had predicted them deep down in my heart . Yet, at the same time, it felt like an unknown premonition bubbling up to the surface .

“My subconscious had urged me into a series of reflexes and action when I saw you hurt . That didn't have anything to my sensitivity to danger and neither was it because of my composure during that moment of crisis . All of that happened merely because I saw you hurt . All those things I did based on my subconsciousness was because I wanted to protect you, to take you away . ”

Those words of his were like a heavy bomb to my heart . It shattered into smithereens and I knew there was no way of mending it back even if I'm in the split zone .

A shot of pain surged through my heart .

“What a sentimental conversation . ” Without giving me more time for my whirling thoughts, Ta Lai’s voice rang out once more .

“While I’m not interested in your history, I am intrigued by this: in a place where you can’t even get to her, can you still protect her? Can you still take her away?”

It was then that I realized he was directing the question at Nie Zun .

It was true; darkness had the ability of distorting your senses and all capacity of judgement . This might be why humans had an innate fear for darkness .

“I can . ” Nie Zun was unconstrained; his simple words succinctly expressed his thoughts .

“I can . ” Nie Zun was unconstrained; his simple words succinctly expressed his thoughts .

“Ehehe, then can you protect yourself?”

With that, I heard two sets of swooshing sound and Nie Zun’s faint, short wheezing .

I panicked . “Nie Zun? Are you alright?”

“I’m fine . ” He sounded calm, but I could hear the slight tremor to his voice .

“Ta Lai, if you want to fight someone then come at me!” I shouted towards the dark . Reaching to my back, I plucked my bow and arrows .

Ten arrows, ten different directions . In the dark, I steadily pulled my bow .

“Nie Zun, ten arrows . ” I hinted before letting go of the bowstring .

Swoosh, swoosh, swoosh!

“I can’t determine the location . ” Nie Zun replied .

I gritted my teeth . Just as I was about to send another arrow flying, I felt a sudden sensation of approaching danger .

“Quick, run...” In a mystifying turn of events, another voice whispered in my heart .

But it was because of that voice that I swiftly wore my bow on my back again and wrapped my Piercer around my waist, before taking an experimental step forward .

“The more you fear the dark, the harder it’ll be for you to defeat it . ” Ta Lai’s elegant voice chimed from all directions .

Should I dash forward? Should I charge blindly in the dark? This overwhelming unease—who would have the guts to do so?

Even so, as the sense of danger got more potent, like an intense air pressure pressing down from all 360 degrees, it left me almost breathless .

“To hell with it!” I muttered under my breath . In that instant the tip of my right foot made contact with the ground and I lunged forward at full speed .

If I were to collide with a wall, I’m sure I would pass out from the impact alone . Still, if I could estimate the area of this darkness in this manner, even the possible location of Nie Zun, then it’s all worth it!

If I were to collide with a wall, I’m sure I would pass out from the impact alone . Still, if I could estimate the area of this darkness in this manner, even the possible location of Nie Zun, then it’s all worth it!

At least, that was what I thought, anyway .

If you were the one who had to recklessly sprint through this pitch-black darkness without being able to see even your own fingers, you would be weak in the knees too .

That was why, my wild sprint was just a manner of moving forward step by step .

“Ehehe, in the face of such situation, is this your way of resolving it?” Ta Lai’s voice rang again in the dark .

I have finally reached my limit of tolerance .

“Hey, what exactly do you want, huh? Whether it is to kill or dismember us, can you hurry the hell up? What’s the whole deal about this hide and seek game?!” I yelled in annoyance with both hands on my hips .

“What’s the hurry? Ladies shouldn’t be so short-tempered . ”

... How dare he retain such a carefree mood in ridiculing me...

“No, seriously, Ta Lai . What are you playing at?”

“I’m teaching you how to fight . ”

“In the dark?”

“This will teach you how to fight without any sense of sight, hearing and smell . ”

It was still useful for a woman to lose her temper after all—Ta Lai was finally giving me an explanation on his intentions .

“What has this got to do with what Li Qing taught me?” I was baffled .

“That depends on how much you can recall during this process . ” His voice bounced back .

“In any case, in this space of absolute darkness, your sense of sight, hearing and smell will be distorted . You shouldn’t waste any mind trying to locate Nie Zun too . It’s impossible for either of you to reach the other .

“Whatever happened before was just a small greeting . I’ll be releasing my children next . It’s up to your own competency on defeating them in this

space that's void of sensory . ” Right after he was done, a set of three handclaps followed .

“Hey, hey! What do you mean, ‘your children’?! Don’t tell me it’s those puppet giants—are you wishing for my demise?! You little—”

“Whatever happened before was just a small greeting . I’ll be releasing my children next . It’s up to your own competency on defeating them in this space that’s void of sensory . ” Right after he was done, a set of three handclaps followed .

“Hey, hey! What do you mean, ‘your children’?! Don’t tell me it’s those puppet giants—are you wishing for my demise?! You little—”

This time, there was no response .

Out of a sudden, there was a chill on my back and I felt a blade slice down my back!

I turned back at once, my left hand unwound the Piercer and gave it a whip!

Crack! The sound of the Piercer echoed in this darkness as my eyes darted blindly in all directions .

Swoosh!

Another cut dragged down my back!

When the sharp warmth of pain surged through my back, the wound that was torn apart by the blade began mending just as soon .

At the same time, the fragmented sound of brandishing blades sounded from the other side .

Speculating that Nie Zun was likely facing the same crisis, I couldn’t spare any mind in worrying for him either . On one hand, I was dodging aimlessly, on another, I was brainstorming a way out of here .

The blade that sliced me seemed to be a fine knife; it appeared to have retracted the moment it drew a line down my skin . The location of those slices didn't seem to have any logic to them either .

I was basically a mouse in the dark, fleeing in all directions but never able to dodge that fine knife which was cutting down my back, chest, leg, arm and more .

“Bloody hell!” Another blade snipped at my back . Without caring about the pain, I turned back and held the knife in the palm of my hand and lashed my Piercer towards them with my other hand .

The hand gripping onto the blade was sticky and thickly coated with fresh blood but the Piercer seemed to have hooked itself onto something . The mysterious creature wailed out .

Biting back my pain, my right hand pulled the knife towards myself and my left hand hooked the Piercer back again before ruthlessly whipping it forward!

Just as I was about to tear the monster ahead of me, another chill sliced down my back .

Pu-tsst!

The knife inflicted a large gaping wound down my back and I felt blood as it gushed to my back in an instant, splattering outwards through the injury .

Chapter 77

77 Straighten Out Your Thoughts

Innumerable blades from all directions began making their marks against my skin!

Tsst!

Fresh blood spurted, but my skin began to mend just as soon .

Tsst!

Another blade tore open yet another gaping wound into my skin!

I heaved, recklessly brandishing my Piercer in the dark—at times, the whip in my hand would hook onto something, only for me to promptly yank it away . Most of the time, however, my effort was futile . Unable to injure anyone, I was nothing but a prey, a pig waiting for slaughter—No... I was basically a pig getting slaughtered right now...

“Can you both use your brains a little?” Ta Lai spoke casually .

Use my brains...

Hang on—in this abyss of darkness, the senses of smell, sight and hearing are distorted... but what about touch?

Just as I reached that epiphany, Nie Zun broke his silence, “Li Shen, your sense of touch . ”

Exactly! Our touch!

“That’s right!” I concurred immediately, before adjusting my mind and body .

Retracting the MF I had deposited in my ears, nose and eyes, I redirected them towards my skin and speed . I won’t look if I’m blind, won’t listen if I’m deaf and won’t smell if I can’t!

Shutting down all my other senses, I awaited my enemy’s next move .

As the tip of another knife grazed the surface of my skin, I pushed all the MF I could muster in that instant and dodged .

The effect was akin to teleportation; seizing the opening from my maneuver, I sidestepped in the opposite direction before whipping my Piercer at the assailant .

In a smooth movement—swoosh!

I could feel the Piercer as it sliced into the offender .

Just as I was about to gloat on my success, however, another chill of blade neared my skin once again .

I dodged .

Swoosh!

And the Piercer tore at them successfully .

As I prepared to channel all my MF into defense, a stinging pain stabbed at my eyes . In a subconscious reflex, I shut them immediately . It was then, when I gradually reopened them, that I realized I had completely regained my sight .

With the return of my sight, I instantly cast my eyes about my surroundings .

I found myself standing in a stone-walled room, similar to one we’ve been in back at the Southern District . The only difference was the torches lining

the walls, and the area was spacious and bright .

Lowering my gaze to my body, I saw blood drenched through my clothes and wounds that had yet to heal . However, apart from my blood which stained the ground beneath, there was nothing else to be seen .

That was when I realized that I was completely alone .

“Nie Zun!” I yelled frantically .

Hastily, I ran across to one of the walls and gave a few knocks, a few pushes . It certainly felt like a stone wall .

Sprinting to the next three slabs of wall, I knocked against each one in a panic, but they were the exact same .

I’m trapped in a sealed-off stone room!

The huge door behind me from which I entered was gone . All that was left was this cavernous stone room, with torches ominously lining the walls . Apart from me, it was void of anything else .

“Nie Zun! Nie Zun!” I called out again but there was no response .

“Nie Zun! Nie Zun!” I called out again but there was no response .

“Ta Lai?” I tried crying out for the other instead .

What... is this situation? There’s no response at all... What the hell is going on?!

I checked through the orphaned room again and reaffirmed my suspicions once more—there was no one here but me .

Eventually, I slid weakly against the wall and onto the ground .

I glanced at my injuries again; they seemed to have healed . My bow was still on my back, and the Piercer was still in the tight grip of my left hand .

Lifting my gaze, I observed this tranquil stone room with its twinkling flames .

Alright, if there are no enemies around, then perhaps it wouldn't be too bad to stay here in this stillness for a while .

I have been too tired recently . I am really... exhausted...

“Ta Lai... Nie Zun...” I tried again to no avail and so, I rested my head against the wall behind me and closed my eyes .

I needed to think; needed to work through all the stuff that had happened—I can't allow myself to be taken in by anyone's tricks and schemes any more . Ever since I've arrived at the Split Zone, there was always someone by my side . Even if they had all left one after another, I still had Nie Zun—I always did . It was his reassuring, dependable presence that I had forgone my own ability of analysis .

I did have the capacity to protect myself .

Just let me quiet down for a moment, let me think it through a bit more . I just need some time .

This all started with Laurel's fake death, followed by the man who fell from the building—a failed experimental subject . Thereafter, there was the little boy who assassinated Ah Wen . Following these three incidents, I headed off to the Eastern District to gather any information I could but was met with another assassination, and then became acquainted with Jiao S and her comrades .

However, it was during this period that Song Lu and Yu Liang went missing, and suspicions about the Southern District rose accordingly . Charging into the Southern District, we met Ku Fei . We offended Huan Qing and Mi Fu in order to protect Ku Fei, and eventually found Laurel and Song Lu who had both been turned into experimental subjects themselves .

Lastly, I found out about You Ji's betrayal in the Southern District, as well as the perpetrators of these experiments—Du Yue, the broken-armed

woman, and Rong Jin, the soul snatcher . You Ji was in on it too .

Li Wen, who had vanished for such a long time, resurfaced once more, dragged into the experiment before stealing away Song Lu after we had gone to such lengths to save her .

There were too many of these incidents to be a coincidence, and I had only just realized that I've never thought them through properly until this very moment .

There were too many of these incidents to be a coincidence, and I had only just realized that I've never thought them through properly until this very moment .

Tilting my head, I glanced around the quiet stone room—there was nothing suspicious to it; seems like a good opportunity to straighten these thoughts out to me .

Firstly, based on what we know so far, the assassination of Ah Wen and the subsequent assassination plot against me, are part of You Ji's ploy to highlight my incompetence as a district commander . The man who fell from the roof was a failed experiment subject, and was likely part of the underground experiments that were being conducted by You Ji and that broken-armed woman .

Still, there were certain things that just couldn't be explained . Did You Ji really betray the Western District because she was jealous of me?

No, I don't think that's reason enough .

Then that begged the question—what exactly enticed You Ji into cooperating with the broken-armed woman?

Thinking through it carefully, a light bulb flickered to life in my mind—

... I got it! It's the experiment!

If what Li Wen said was true, then they didn't have the perfect body constitution at their disposal right now . This means they won't be able to

complete the experiment all that easily . Perhaps they had been working on this for some time now but the news of it only began to surface recently .

That would be plausible . Maybe we haven't yet discovered the true motive behind these experiments—maybe we don't know the true abilities a successful experiment subject would possess .

Yet one thing was evident through it all—they were looking for children .

All of it started with Laurel and ended with her disappearance .

We still have no idea if they managed to find Laurel, but there had been two other kids in that stone-walled room . It was undeniable that those children were a crucial part of the experiment .

Was this why they targeted Mi Fu?

Though, if we were to talk about Mi Fu, then there was another man who had to be brought into this fog of confusion .

Si Luo .

At the mention of Si Luo, I recalled the last time we parted with Gaoqin Jiuye, that apathetic expression on his face .

A bitter smile tugged at the corner of my lips . Regardless of where we are in this world, it seems as though the two of us are destined to be in such a distant relationship—unable to be near you, unable to touch you .

While Gaoqin Jiuye wasn't a saint, I was still stubborn . Maybe it was the remnants of feelings I still held for Gao Qi, but I still believe that he must have his own reasons . Even so, no matter what those reasons were, I can only conclude that whatever was happening had something to do with Si Luo—that fabled, most gorgeous man in the split zone .

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With that, my mind drifted to Jiao S .

Through the series of events, it was evident that those who remained wary, those who appeared as though they were a cruel villain, might not be as they seemed . Likewise, those who always greeted you with a welcoming smile may not be your friend either .

Even with the hint of ruthlessness, I was sure Jiao S could be trusted .

At the very least, she was one who had principles and an opinion, and she would never do anything that would defy her morals . In the split zone, those were values that were difficult to retain .

Perhaps that was why, as much as Li Qing had never grown to accept the savageness of Eastern District and the freaks they had there, she tolerated Jiao S . In fact, from what Jiao S had told me, they might have been confidants .

However, for a person with such principles to devote herself in pursuing the truth, I had believed that she must be doing it for her subordinates of Eastern District who had died and the children . Even so, my mind wandered further—if saving a small group of people meant that countless others would be sacrificed, I don't suppose Jiao S would do it either .

If that's the case, then there's only one logical explanation—she was doing this for herself and that personal agenda, is Si Luo .

I had once noticed the way she spoke with others . Even those meaning between the lines had hinted that Si Luo might have been hiding something, or keeping a secret . This experiment might be directly related to Si Luo or maybe they were targeting him .

But... Why would they be targeting him?

Where was this broken-armed woman from? If she was from the Northern District, does that mean that something has gone wrong there?

We had lost all contact with Mr Blond . Perhaps all of it was an omen? Perhaps the unspeakable secret of Northern District was slowly making itself known? What about the three ‘Heaven’, ‘Ghost’, and ‘Exit’ doors that Yu Liang and Song Lu spoke of? What was behind them?

Just as many aspects of this were resolved through my analysis, more questions piled on, drowning me deeper in the confusion .

It was obvious that all the happenings were the fruit of someone’s malicious planning but not only do I not know who they are, I might not have ever met them before either .

Through this conspiracy—of which we couldn’t even be sure about its scale—it gave birth to those cruel experiments and I had yet again, lost another friend .

In the end, when I returned to Western District with full anticipation of witnessing You Ji running the Western District with her most trusted Seven Demons—to separate herself from me and make me lose my authority—what I saw was Western District in ruins instead . Everything was reduced to a wasteland and I grew even more baffled than I was before .

It did make me realize one crucial detail: this mysterious conspiracy that lurks in the shadows had finally opened the curtains to its prelude .

Chapter 78

78 The Loophole

If it is necessary to question the purpose of my existence in this split zone, then I suppose I'm still as clueless I was in the past . But I do understand a little more now—I want to save everyone who has ever been by my side in this alternate dimension .

Because... I've always been alone . Now that I finally have people I could call friends; how can I simply stay a spectator to their persecution?

“Do you have any desire to leave the split zone?” For some reason, a question Li Qing had once posed surfaced in my mind .

Do I want to leave...

I'm sure my parents are waiting for me, right...?

But what would happen once I leave this place...?

I'll still be that mentally ill girl everyone ostracized and detested . I'll still have no friends and if... If I do return, I'd have to face the reality of murdering my most beloved Senior Gao Qi...

I'm nothing but a criminal . What right do I have to possess the desire for return?

To be honest, I don't mind wherever as long as I'm not alone . I'll be fine as long as I'm not lonely anymore...

Speaking of loneliness, I wonder if the other 'her' within me might have been lonely too...

I hated you for so long . You distanced me from society, you made me kill the one person I loved, and you practically ruined my entire life . Even so, you were also the only one who stayed by my side through everything . You were the only one who did...

But... Where are you now? Have you really fused with Nie Zun? Were you the reason he remained by my side through days and nights?

You... Could you give me an answer...?

Did Nie Zun really resonate with you?

Nie Zun...

At the thought of Nie Zun, I leapt to my feet . With the Piercer in my hand and the bow on my back, I circled the stone room again .

Knock, knock, knock!

I thumped against the walls .

Despite the space looking just like a normal stone room that had been dug from the ground, I was sure that there were mechanisms in place; how else could I have ended up here?

Winding the Piercer around my waist, I manipulated and focused my MF towards both my hands and attempted to push against each of the four walls .

My effort was futile .

I rested against the wall again . It seemed I'd have to take some time to reflect about Ta Lai, properly and in detail .

From the depths of my memory, Ta Lai was low profile and his existence wasn't something that many would notice . Why, then, did he decide to appear at such a time? He was helping me... But why?

And why did he have the habit of rotating his ring, the one embellished with a jade stone?

Li Qing had never mentioned anyone like him while she was around, so how was it that he seemed to know so much about the lessons she taught me? What was his motive for bringing me here?

After contemplating extensively, not knowing how much time had passed, I stood up and swept my gaze around my current confinement again .

“Ta Lai, what’s your motive? Why have you locked me up?!” I roared . Anyone would grow irritable from being trapped in a confined space for an elongated period of time—I was no exception .

Despite this, there was no answer apart from my own voice; there wasn’t a slightest bit of noise here .

Could it be that he wanted to test my ability to escape this room? But it didn’t look like there’s any sort of threat in here...

Lifting the Piercer, I utilized my MF and lashed it with great force towards the wall opposite me .

Crack!

A dull sound emitted from the collision of my whip against its target but there wasn’t even the slightest hint of a scar on that stone wall .

All of a sudden, I realized just how peculiar this room was .

After infusing my MF into the Piercer, the damage inflicted by its Violet Blade should have been massive; if this was a regular, underground stone room, the whip would have been more than enough to break it apart .

“What exactly... is this place?” I muttered under my breath . While my eyes darted around, I was trying to find a loophole . My mind flashed back to the moment we stepped into the darkness before I was mysteriously transported into this soulless stone room .

An illusion...? No, that can't be it . If it was indeed an illusion, then Nie Zun should be in the same plight as me right now and would have been able to see through the gimmick and found me by now . Even though I have never seen it in action, nor had any idea how his eye technique worked, I had once overheard Jie Pa talking about it—Nie Zun had the ability to see through illusions .

Of course! Was this why he could get along so well with Guan Nie? Was it because Guan Nie knew from the get-go that his illusions would have no effect on Nie Zun, yet didn't do him any harm? If that's the case, then was it Nie Zun who broke the Huan Qing's illusion back in the Southern District's boundary forest? When I thought of Pomelo and Gao Qi?

In that split second, the particular memory rushed to mind .

In that split second, the particular memory rushed to mind .

“Couldn't find him . He comes without a shadow and leaves without a trail . But on the subject of illusions, ugly girl Li Shen, I already broke the spell, so why didn't you wake up?” Guan Nie joked as he looked at me .

As my strength came back to me, I rolled my eyes at him . “Ugly girl? And haven't I woken up now?”

Guan Nie sneered . “Woke up? It was Nie Zun—”

Did Nie Zun use his powers to enter the illusion and forcefully yank me back to reality?

Then... Then the person who called out “Shen'er”... was him?

From that point on, was he also the one who called out “Shen'er” numerous times since, saving me from falling into enchantment and captivation of others?

Could that be true... Is he that gentle...?

With those thoughts swarming my mind, I was caught in a mixture of emotions . Being trapped within these four walls without a single other soul

did not help my irritancy either .

I'm exhausted... I guess I'll take a nap .

.....

When I woke up, there was still no one around .

“F—What the hell is going on?!” Combing my fingers through my hair, I scrunched them up and hopped in fury on my spot .

“Are you holding me captive in here? For the love of God, you could have at least warned me before imprisoning me! Instead, you trapped me in here without the tiniest bit of explanation, are you for real?!”

I cried into the air, but no one responded .

I am absolutely furious by now . I could feel a sense of replenishment in my MF that hinted the passing of an entire day—I have been trapped in this confined space for an entire day .

Like I'd gone berserk from being stuck here, I exerted every single bit of my MF and smashed the walls relentlessly with punches and kicks . I even pulled the bow from my back and began knocking countless arrows towards the wall .

Yet, this horrifying wall seemed to be made out of an indestructible diamond, without a way of penetrating through—there wasn't a single crack despite my attacks!

“You call this training? Aren't you just toying with me?!” I exclaimed as I glared at the wall, then to the ceiling above and the ground below .

In spite of it, no matter how much I entertained myself or how much I wallowed in self-pity, no matter how much I yelled in rage... there was no one who cared to hear it . In here, I was on my own... There was no one else but me .

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“I honestly can’t stand this anymore . Ahhh—!!” Tugging at my hair, I cried out wildly . Time was going by way too slowly . A niggling feeling of something in my mind told me I would go crazy if I stayed here any longer .

(Passerby A spoke up, “Aren’t you already crazy?”)

“Ahhh—! Ahhhhhh—! I beg you! Please let me go!” I screamed, no longer about to tolerate the distress of being stuck here alone .

What is going on?!

“Sigh... He’s looking for me...”

A voice chimed in my mind out of the blue .

This voice...

Isn’t this my own voice??

Without a clue of what just happened or what I had just heard, I knelt to the ground in disbelief . My spiritless eyes stared straight ahead at the blank wall in front of me .

Who... was the person... I heard earlier?

“Sigh... He’s looking for me...” Such vivid words... Who could be speaking them?

As if I had snapped, I leapt to my feet and shouted out aimlessly into the air . “Who? Who’s here?! Come out!”

“Sigh... He’s looking for me...”

It sounded like a faint voice of sleep-talk or a murmur into the mirror . That sound was clear, and I knew it in my mind that it was my own voice . It was a fact that I am unable to ignore .

“Have I... Have I gone insane from being trapped here?” I thought aloud, frantically looking at my surrounding .

“Come out now!” I shouted exasperatedly .

Not knowing when it started, my tears began sliding down my cheeks and splattered onto the lifeless stone floor below, disappearing without a trace .

I could feel the tightening of my head, as though it was about to combust . My mind began rattling vigorously and with the confusion in my consciousness, I could feel the MF from my split symbol growing unstable .

“Is it you? Could it really be you? ... I know it’s you!” I screamed .

Yet, as soon as the words left my lips, I found myself asking: Li Shen, what’s there to be afraid of? So what if it’s really her?

“Is it you? Could it really be you? ... I know it’s you!” I screamed .

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Hadn’t it been because of your confinement that you’ve started acting this bizarrely? What are you so afraid of? Are you afraid that she’d take over your body once more?

It’ll be fine . Didn’t Mr Blond explain that? Since our arrival into the split zone, she had resonated with Nie Zun and vanished; all that’s left now is Nie Zun... She will never appear again . She will never take over your body to kill your loved ones .

She will never take over your body again, so why are you still so afraid, Li Shen?!

... But it’s a fact that I’m still really, really scared...

Hugging my knees against my chest, I slid against the stone wall, allowing my tears to fall freely .

“Shen’er . ”

Another voice sounded from beside me!

This time, it was Nie Zun’s voice...

I may not know what’s going on with me now, or why I’m being trapped here but his familiar voice brought a wave of serenity over me . Just like the way he called out to me in the illusion, his simple “Shen’er” was enough to calm me down .

Breathe, Li Shen, you must calm down .

Calm down, Li Shen, and think through this carefully . It’s impossible for her to appear and she will never make her appearance in the split zone, much less take over your body . All of this is the work of the stone room .

That’s right . Upon careful contemplation, it was clear that Ta Lai had his reasons for doing this .

Didn’t he ask about Nie Zun’s eye techniques at the very beginning...?

... That’s right, he did ask about it!

It was how he figured out that if we were within a room where all five senses were working, Nie Zun would be able to save me no matter the circumstances . As such, he must have wanted me to be immersed in a space like this, that was why he triggered a room that could distort our senses! He wanted to distract Nie Zun and I into defending those attacks before slipping me into this isolated void during his window of opportunity!

His intention had been to tap into my consciousness!

Yes, that’s right! If that’s the case, then I can safely assume that the ability he possessed after sealing his split symbol was the manipulation of space—he can create a space and manipulate everything within it to his desire!

Chapter 79

79 Into the Dreamscape

I decided not to struggle once I've thought it through .

Perhaps a good state of mind would be able to overcome all the dreaded unknown which awaits me .

With that, I found a comfortable corner to settle down in ease and shut my eyes, planning to catch a wink... but my rest didn't come as peacefully as it did before; I fell into a dream .

It was the most peculiar; the way I seemed to fuse with the 'me' in my dream .

I was hyperconscious of the fact that I'm dreaming—unlike all previous occurrences when I've always watched myself from a third-party point of view, I appeared to have quite literally fallen into the dreamscape . It was as though I've intruded into another dimension . I observed my surrounding, astounded by the sensation .

In that instant, the words Li Qing had once said to me flitted to mind .

“In the split zone, the only time we have any interaction with our memories is when we dream . Like a pair of eyes, you will overlook your past experiences in that dreamscape . Seeing as only those who suffers from mental disorders or trauma would arrive into the split zone, the existence of dreams can sometimes help us recover lost memories or distorted feelings .

“Which means to say, you may be able to find those memories that you've forgotten, or perhaps even situations which you've misinterpreted that had formed your current memory . ”

“Does that mean we’ll have to watch ourselves suffer through painful memories without being able to interfere?” I asked .

“That’s right . This is because the split zone didn’t exist with the intention of helping you change the past, but to accept . Even so, you’re an exception because you were diagnosed with double identity disorder . In the history of the split zone, there was only one other person apart from you with this syndrome .

“Since having double identities would mean that you have two bodies of consciousness, the dream that you witness might likewise be different than the rest of us . I can’t be sure if the assumption is true, but I do know that the person who was the same as you had the ability to participate in his own dreams . I’m not in the position to determine if that’s a gift or a curse . ”

At this very moment, it was clear to me that I’m in my own dream . I entered this dream when I dozed off in that stone room, and I’m still blown away by it .

I continued watching this vivid dreamscape of mine .

It was when Li Qing’s words echoed in my mind that I realized I’ve only remembered how important Li Qing was to me, and how much I had depended and missed her . Yet, in an ironic twist, I’ve forgotten much about what she had told me, and what she passed on to me .

Li Qing had so clearly conveyed it before, that I’m different from the others because of my double identity disorder .

As much as the double identity disorder had been a sin in my previous life, it was what made me unique in this alternate dimension .

I wonder if it would be able to tell me which path to take one day?

“Honk, honk, honk—!”

I snapped from my train of thoughts at the sound of the car’s honking .

Seized with terror, I darted my eyes towards my surrounding .

That's right, I am currently in a dreamscape, and I wasn't looking on as a spectator . I was in it as a participant, immersed in the dream as my own body of consciousness .

Could it be... that perhaps this dream would be able to help me recall the moment I killed Senior Gao Qi?

It wasn't like I wanted to recall that particular memory, but what if it could explain the real reason I arrived into the split zone? Should I seek the truth if that's the case?"

I took it all in, absorbing the dreamscape into sight—this is the world of my previous life .

Right now, I'm opposite the main gate of my school, along the road not far away .

I tilted my head upwards, towards those blue skies and sun rays that I haven't seen in a long time .

Just like, my tears streamed down without control .

I didn't want to cry but no one would understand just how much I missed this sunshine .

Before the split zone, I had always thought the sun was too piercing when it hung high upon the sky, and loved staying cooped up in my house . I've never been too concerned with the rumors of doomsday, or those discussion about the combustion of the sun either .

Yet, now that I've been sent to the split zone, when I lost all contact with this world, I understood just how much I've relied on it .

The familiar warmth of the sun and that clear blue sky—all these things that I haven't seen in a long time was nothing more than a wishful thinking for me now .

“Bloody hell . Sir, even if you're planning to commit fraud by deliberately crashing into cars, do you really have to use such low-quality commodities?

At the very least, shouldn't you use an entire bottle of ketchup? How could you smear th—th—this Lao Gan Ma's Black Bean Sauce on your head like that? Can we be a little more professional here?"

"Y-y-you! How did you know that's black bean sauce?! Did you steal a taste from my head? You impudent rascal! You're not conscientious at all!"

"Old man! You're the one who faked a crash by running in front of my car! You have the audacity to say I'm the one who's not conscientious?!?"

The banter from the street ahead made its way to me, and I couldn't help the surge of perspiration .

I know that I was a kind girl in my previous life, who had a tendency of lending a helping hand at the sight of unjust . Still, for this outlandish event which highlighted the reality of society to be my first recollection, even to the extent of tampering with a section of their dialogue... It didn't seem cynical but felt more like a silly dream instead .

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Black bean sauce...

I'm drunk in my own imagination...

It was said that dreams stemmed from your heart's desires...

I watched as more and more people rushed towards the street ahead .

That's how this world worked . People scuttled at the sign of disaster but gathered like moth to flame at such stirring of trivial matters .

I've never liked crowds, or places which were bustling with noise and excitement . I turned my attention towards the school instead .

Ah, so it was my university that I'm dreaming about...

It's fortunate that it's the university that appeared in my dreams .

Even though I have been ostracized in university too, it was still an immense improvement from the dark days of high school . Besides, I suppose I would be able to see his warm and gentle smile again if I'm here...

I lifted my hand to rid the tracks of tears from my face at that thought and gave myself a pep talk .

You can do this, Li Shen . You've been in the split zone for a long while now; you've grown stronger . Go face him . Even if it's only within this dreamscape, go face him one more time and ask for his forgiveness!

The thoughts circled my mind and with long strides, I moved towards the school .

“Ah Shen, where have you been? I've been searching for you for so long .”

A familiar voice sounded from behind me .

A shiver ran down my spine . After a moment of contemplation, I calmed myself down and turned towards the origin .

Running towards me merrily, was Pomelo in a long-sleeved, Pikachu-printed top .

I dropped my gaze to my own apparels . As expected, it was the same Pikachu-printed top—a set of twin outfits .

A bitter smile twitched at the corner of my lips . Li Shen, oh Li Shen, did you really bear such deep hatred for her that even in your dreams, you thought of her first and not Senior Gao Qi whom you had missed so dearly?

A bitter smile twitched at the corner of my lips . Li Shen, oh Li Shen, did you really bear such deep hatred for her that even in your dreams, you thought of her first and not Senior Gao Qi whom you had missed so dearly?

Why was hatred so much harder to forget in comparison to love?

Since I'm in a dream, since this is a replay of my memories, then let's just integrate myself into it and handle this the way I used to .

I lifted my head and forced a smile . In a soft voice, I replied, "I'm just about to head back to school . "

"Let's go together then!" Pomelo approached with a hop in her steps and linked her arm with mine naturally .

Her eyes are bright and crystal clear . "You can't leave me, Ah Shen . You know that, right?"

I could hear the soft exhale of breath from the depths of my heart .

Sigh... Just reject her...

Eventually, I beamed a bright smile that didn't reach my eyes . "I know . "

With her satisfaction, Pomelo's arm tightened around mine . "Let's go to the cafeteria! Are you hungry?"

I nodded without a word .

Following in her steps, allowing her to tug and pull me as she pleased, we headed towards the cafeteria building .

The building where the cafeteria resided was behind Block 3 of the male dormitory, and we would have to pass through the latter to get to our destination . The scale of a university was different from that of a high school; just a trip to the cafeteria would take us more than ten minutes .

I could feel the distinct palpitations of my heart as we traversed across Block 3 . And when I heard the words, "I love you, Senior Gao Qi!" I was startled .

There were dozens of people ahead when I lifted my gaze . Amidst the crowd, there was a beautiful young lady with both hands cupped around her

mouth, amplifying her voice as she shouted towards the balcony on the second level of Block 3 .

She yelled, “I love you, Senior Gao Qi . ”

“Wow—!” The spectators cheered on .

These scenes were not a daily occurrence in university, but it was a common sight .

Under the dormitory, she laid out the candles to accompany her confession and cheers erupted all around .

It seems that it’s still an easier feat for ladies to confess .

Under the dormitory, she laid out the candles to accompany her confession and cheers erupted all around .

It seems that it’s still an easier feat for ladies to confess .

“Hey, look, look! It’s Gao Qi from Senior year! He came out, he came out!”

“It’s really him! I’ve always heard that he’s popular . Not only that, he’s already in his Senior year, just a step before graduation, yet there are still such young juniors confessing to him like this . ”

“What’s the use of it though? Rumor has it that Gao Qi has never had a girlfriend in his four years of university . Some even suspect that he may be gay...”

“Aye, what nonsense . How can such a handsome and affable man like him be gay?”

“It’s always a possibility . The more outstanding they are, the more they don’t think any woman could be compatible with them . That’s how they develop a unique taste; that’s how they start looking for those of the same gender for some thrill . ”

“Since we’re on the topic of unique tastes—I heard that the only person Gao Qi has ever initiated a conversation with, is that girl with mental illness?”

Without realizing, we had already reached the spectating crowd and their discussion flooded my ears .

I dropped my head .

“Ah Shen, isn’t that the senior you adore? Don’t you want to take a look at him?” Pomelo’s voice prompted from beside me .

I met her glistening eyes then, without a trace of hesitation, I tilted my head towards Gao Qi on the second level balcony .

Perhaps she had not expected such courage in me to look over; I felt the hand that was clutching my own grow rigid .

My lips curled upwards ever so slightly, undetected by anyone around .

Squinting my eyes, I watched the figure who had been lured out by the commotion on the ground—the one and only Senior Gao Qi who flashed a faint smile at the sight of me .

Heh, I’m not longer the Li Shen of the past . I am Li Shen, Commander of Split Zone 13’s Western District, and this is just a dream of mine . In my dream, Pomelo, did you think you’d witness a weak and helpless me? Did you still expect me to turn to you for help eventually?

Dream on .

“There, there! That’s her! That’s who I’m talking about . Quick, look behind you . ”

The murmuring from in front of us bustled on but that’s alright . I remained with my head held high, watching the balcony opposite us and at the man with a smile as warm as spring breeze .

Chapter 80

80 Fragments of Memory

“Senior Gao Qi, I’ve liked you for a long time now . Will you give me a chance?” The young lady lifted her head and called out at Gao Qi’s appearance .

It was only then that he retracted his gaze from me and looked over the balcony ledge, shifting his attention to the lady down below .

Instantly, he broke into a warm smile . “Thank you . ”

The smile on my face widened; anyone with common sense could decipher it—sometimes, ‘thank you’ is equivalent to ‘I’m sorry’ .

In some context, gratitude is a form of rejection .

As expected, the lady was relentless, giving her best fight for the opportunity . “Does this mean you’ve agreed to be my boyfriend?”

“I will have to get back to you on that . ” Deep down, that was the answer I expected from him . Senior Gao Qi’s gentle and kind personality was a known fact, and he had always taken extra care even in rejecting his admirers; he always did so in private, leaving those who confessed in front of an audience with their pride intact .

Gao Qi’s eyes curved into a perfect arc . “I’m sorry, I can’t agree to that . I already have feelings for another . ”

My eyes snapped wide open at that, looking up in disbelief at Gao Qi, who remained by the edge of the balcony .

He actually rejected her? And claimed that there was someone else he fancied?

H—how is this possible? Is this because I’m in a dream?

No... that can’t be it . Li Qing once told me that dreams in the split zone are just memories of the past; unlike our previous life, these dreams cannot be formed by imagination alone . Although there may be slight alterations, the basis of the dream is based on unchangeable facts .

Dreams in the split zone are really just a trip down memory lane, so then... does that mean this really happened? This scene is a memory?

“Oh my God . Did you hear that? Gao Qi rejected her in front of an audience!”

“Yeah, yeah! How did this happen?”

The crowd erupted into a roar of gossip .

In the center of them all, the lady slipped her lips between her teeth . There was a glint of malicious grudge behind her eyes . “And who exactly is that? I am thoroughly interested in knowing who’s capable of making you, Gao Qi, confess your feelings in this manner!

“... You know who I am, right? Even if you say her name now, I dare say she wouldn’t have the guts to accept!”

Those words... sound so familiar...

Swiftly, I carefully sized up the girl who confessed . She donned a pink skirt .

... Wait . She’s the daughter of the principal, Duff!

I understood the underlying meaning behind her words; Gao Qi had never shown an interest in anyone and likewise rejected many confessions . If there was someone whom he had taken an interest in—regardless of who they are, they’ll definitely be the common nemesis of all ladies .

Even if we're in university now, the jealousy and discrimination of women were still terrifying, much worse when the threat came from the daughter of the principal .

Actually, forget about the principal's daughter; within the university, we have to be fearful of people with even the most minor roles . Moreover, Duff didn't rely on her family background alone; her own interpersonal skill was nothing to be scoffed at . She was appointed Chairman of the Student Union after just a year in school . It was also said that she had personally led the outreach department into clinching a sponsorship deal with the most affluent company in the city . With both her abilities and family to back her up, her position in this school is unwavering—who would dare compete with her for a boyfriend?

“Li Shen, I like you . Do you dare accept it?” Gao Qi's enchanting voice felt like a heavyweight bombshell at this moment, combusting into smithereens as it fell from the balcony above .

What a familiar feeling...

Did this really happen...? Could it be that he had truly confessed to me before, but I've forgotten all about them?

Motionlessly, I fixed my stare upon the calm and composed him on the second floor with a slight smile on his face .

Pomelo took a few steps closer to me, to point where I was sure I could almost feel her moist lips on my ear . Leaning on my shoulder, she started, “Are you happy, Li Shen? Your crush just confessed to you...”

I didn't breathe a word, nor did I spare her a glance .

And so, she chuckled . “What should I do? I'm not happy about this at all; another person has emerged, threatening to rob you away from me...”

I felt a chill run down my spine .

“Her?! Gao Qi?” Incredulous, Duff turned and lifted a trembling finger towards me . “Gao Qi, you’re in love with a lunatic?” Her eyes enlarged, seemingly near hysteria .

Gao Qi, you’re in love with a lunatic?

Gao Qi, you’re in love with a lunatic?

Gao Qi, you’re in love with a lunatic?

No... Don’t taint him . Don’t taint him because of me . I’m already someone who’s down in the pits of darkness, how could I drag him down with me?

No... Don’t taint him . Don’t taint him because of me . I’m already someone who’s down in the pits of darkness, how could I drag him down with me?

The thought was all too familiar; as it surged into my heart, it was as if I had already gone through this process before .

I told myself to calm down . I put up a desperate fight with this turmoil, reminding myself that this is a dream . It was just a memory that I’ve forgotten .

Don’t be manipulated by your memories, Li Shen . Calm down and watch what exactly went down during that time .

“Ah—!”

Just as I was doing my best to keep my composure in check, a series of screams rang from the crowd . I was greeted with the sight of Gao Qi leaping from his balcony when I looked up .

Even if the height of two storeys wouldn’t be enough to inflict any critical damage, it was still dangerous!

Right after that familiar, striking yellow sport shoes made its landing, Gao Qi began strutting towards me . Accompanied by an innumerable number of

glares which were tinged with animosity, he walked towards me step after step .

For some reason, as my eyes lingered upon this man with his radiant smile and gentle gaze, another name came to mind .

Gaoqin Jiuye .

Gaoqin Jiuye...

My gaze fled towards the man in front of me again . Gao Qi...

Is Gao Qi really as gentle and kind as I thought him out to be? The abrupt question that bubbled in my heart startled me .

He reached my side by then and like a bottomless pool, his eyes seemed to pull my gaze to him .

“Ah Shen, do you like me?”

“So it’s a lunatic that you like?!” Without waiting for my reply, Duff’s humorless laugh filled the air from behind him .

Gao Qi’s eyes narrowed a little . Perhaps it was my time in the split zone that had polished my senses; in the instant, I felt a hint of danger emitting from him .

Duff was already strolling over, and a crowd slowly gathered around . Scoffing when she neared, she lifted a hand towards me . Gao Qi attempted to stop her, but with a nimble twist of her hand, her arm was already on my hair .

“What are you so worried about? I just wanted to touch her hair . ” With a raised brow, she continued, “Such jet black hair . Ehehe, I’ve heard that your favorite color is red; you’re always dressed in blood scarlet . Why don’t you dye your hair red as well?”

I dropped my gaze for a second before lifting them up to meet hers again .

I dropped my gaze for a second before lifting them up to meet hers again .

With an indecipherable smile decorating my features, I raised my left hand and coiled my fingers around Duff's which were still resting atop my head .

I plucked her hand slowly from its spot, the words leaving my lips, "Thanks for the reminder . What a coincidence, I was just thinking of dyeing my hair . "

A flicker of viciousness flashed across her eyes . "I heard there's something wrong with your brain . Do you think you're good enough for him?" Duff yanked her hand back from mine in disgust; her eyes darted sideways at Gao Qi .

Pomelo stood up without warning and with a giggle, she stretched out both her arms and shoved Duff .

"Ah!" Screams erupted once again from the crowd .

Staring down at astonished Duff who had fallen to the ground, Pomelo spoke up, "I'm the only one who's allowed to bully her . "

By accident, Duff's hair was caught under the sole of a spectator, making her attempt to get back on her feet an embarrassing struggle . Swatting the dust off herself, she glared at us venomously . "You are all lunatics! Karma will find you one day!"

With that, she fled, possibly because she had no desire of staying out in the open for long with her pathetic state .

Following Duff's departure and our peculiar silence as the three of us stood rooted to the spot, the crowd finally got the message and began to disperse .

Pomelo returned to my side, donning a forced smile on her face when she regarded Gao Qi . "You are willing to sacrifice your God-like reputation just to snatch her away from me? What a pity, I'm afraid you're not that capable yet . "

Gao Qi's pupils contracted slightly at that but his smile remained . "I'll have to try to find out . "

As the two engaged in a stare down, I kept quiet at the side .

Eventually, Pomelo shrugged . "Have a chat . Ah Shen, I'll be waiting for you up ahead . "

She moved to leave the scene, only to stop abruptly in her step once more and turned back at me . She blinked . "Ah Shen, you know this, right? You'll never be able to leave me . "

It was only when she's out of range that I tilted my head towards Gao Qi .

It was gorgeous; the way Gao Qi's alluring eyes were arched like the moon . I swept my eyes across his features in nostalgia .

I know that this is a dream; their conversation and its ending... all of it would unfold according to my memories . Even so, let me drink in the details of him once more since I'm already in this dreamscape .

"Ah Shen, you haven't given me an answer . Do you like me?"

I know that this is a dream; their conversation and its ending... all of it would unfold according to my memories . Even so, let me drink in the details of him once more since I'm already in this dreamscape .

"Ah Shen, you haven't given me an answer . Do you like me?"

"I do . " In a soft voice, I replied .

Gao Qi broke out in a satisfied laughter . "Then, are you willing to be by my side forever, regardless of the circumstances?"

My brows began to furrow .

Did Gao Qi speak these words to me before? Why do I not have an inkling of recollection about them?

Gao Qi, why are you speaking to me in such a manner?

“Even if I’m not as I seemed, even if I’m not the person you thought I was, will you still be able to stay with me?” In a seemingly doting gesture, he brought up a hand and coiled around a column of my hair .

Without recollection of this scene, I didn’t know and hence, wasn’t able to react as I had when it happened . I could only opt for silence .

“They called you a weirdo but I know you’re the only one who understands me, right?” I couldn’t put a finger to it but in that moment, the smile on Gao Qi’s face seemed to hold a hint of ruthlessness .

Why... why does this demeanor of his remind me so much of Gaoqin Jiuye?

Layer after layer of suspicions began to bubble to the surface, like I had caught on to something . As though he wasn’t satisfied with the shallow pampering, he took two steps towards me, further closing our distance .

I didn’t evade it .

His warm lips leaned towards my ear . “Ah Shen, how in love with me are you? Are you willing to die for me?” The deep, bewitching voice of his was coated with a layer of coldness that I recognized . It was like a summon from the grim reaper, ringing out with a bang beside my ears .

This scene... is far too foreign, yet so familiar at the same time .

Speaking my next words slowly, it was as if I’m about to clear the fog on the mystery . “You... who exactly are you?”

“Shen’er, it’s time to wake up . ”

Before Gao Qi could reply me, Nie Zun’s hollow and indifferent voice rang from the sky overhead .

Stunned by the sudden intrusion, I shot my head upwards and watched as the blue sky began to crack .

The entire world began to shatter .

Chapter 81

81 A Lesson in Combat

Just like that, I woke up .

In the trance of my waking, I could barely make out the pale, sharp chin of Nie Zun . In a flash of movement, I pulled myself up and stared wide-eyed at him before panning to our surrounding .

We are still in the same stone room .

Clutching at his hand, the words rushed out, “Where did you go? I’ve been held captive in here for several days without a single soul around . ”

Nie Zun let out a mischievous laugh before pointing overhead .

“Oh?” Following the movement of his finger, I glanced up towards the ceiling .

In that instant, I reached an epiphany!

Damn it! Even if the four walls couldn’t be shifted, there was still the ceiling! How did I not think of that?!

“We entered this space from the room above . There’s a mechanism in place that sent you straight down . ” Unhurriedly, he explained .

“Why the hell did he have to throw me in here?” I raged .

“This is to train you . ” Ta Lai’s voice travelled from the space behind me, leaning elegantly against the corner of the room when I snapped my head back .

“Y–y–you...” Stuttering from shock was a reflexive tendency of mine—when did he get down here?!

Ta Lai rotated the jade ring on his finger . “In this underground space, I have the ability of manipulating all senses; it’s only normal that you couldn’t feel yourself falling from the level above . I know you have a lot of questions right now, so I’m going to explain them to you . ”

Before that though, he scratched his head bashfully and flashed a cheeky smile . “Actually, there’s really nothing to explain; they should all be pretty clear, but Nie Zun told me that you have low intelligence to the point where it’s almost worrying . Which is why, after consideration, I decided it’ll be better if I explained it . ”

I have low intelligence?!?

Huffing in anger, I glared at Nie Zun who held his palms up with a look of faux innocence .

“First, let me declare my identity . ” Ta Lai slowly pushed himself off the wall . His tall and slender stature looked even more dashing right now .

“I’m a soul splitter, Ta Lai . ”

...

...

There were many possibilities that ran through my mind before—in fact, I had even once wondered if he was a spy who was sent here by Mr Blond . Never in my wildest dreams had I thought that that would be his true identity!

I met Nie Zun’s eyes but both of us chose to keep mum .

On the other hand, Ta Lai was calm . “I understand that you don’t have much exposure to soul splitters, and have next to zero knowledge about the split zone . This is why I’m here today—to shed some light on the affairs of split zone . ”

Even though I can't place my full trust in the person in front of us, I could still sense the gravity of the information he was about to give . I could feel myself holding my breath in anticipation .

Ta Lai's eyes glistened in an elegant radiance . "The secret to the split zone is that... anyone who attempts to unveil it, is bound to face death sooner or later . "

...

What a redundant statement .

I rolled my eyes before I could stop myself .

Ta Lai paid no mind to it . "Li Shen, you've always kept a look of nonchalance but I am most aware of such a character like yourself; if you ever decide to pursue this earnestly, you'd undoubtedly give us a run for our money . I have no desire to make an enemy out of you, nor do I deem that necessary .

"All I can say is, I'll be able to assist you, whether it's to save your friends or to protect Western District . However, if unravelling the secret to split zone is your goal, if you plan on instigating an uprising and make a mass escape, I suggest you give up on those ideas now . "

I scoffed . "Why? Just because you're a soul splitter, you're worried that we'd uncover the identities of all soul splitters eventually? Our consciousness are stuck here and we'd like to return to our previous lives—what's so wrong about that?"

I scoffed . "Why? Just because you're a soul splitter, you're worried that we'd uncover the identities of all soul splitters eventually? Our consciousness are stuck here and we'd like to return to our previous lives—what's so wrong about that?"

"Are you sure you want to return?" Ta Lai shot a faint smile .

"I..." I was rendered speechless by that question .

“I suppose you had a similar discussion over this with Li Qing, right? Why did she entrust the role of Western District’s Commander to you?”

Was he referring to what Li Qing brought up before? When she said, “To choose the next commander, we have to first consider those who have the least desire to leave the split zone . ”

Could it be that a majority of the reason why Li Qing trusted me enough to be a district commander, was because of my lack of desire to leave?

“I can tell you’re confused . How about this, face up to yourself and answer my question honestly .

“Li Shen, do you wish to leave the split zone, and return to your previous life?” The same smile was still hanging on Ta Lai’s face .

It was a question that everyone seemed to have asked me at some point in private, but had never surfaced in this manner . I turned my head towards Nie Zun and saw the look of anticipation in his eyes while he watched me .

“I believe Li Qing chose you because she was sure that you’d stay . ” Ta Lai continued, “Therefore, if you stuck to your original intentions, if you choose to stay in the split zone and spend these endless days here, I can help you achieve whatever you wanted . Regardless of whether it’s to save your friends, or to reclaim Western District .

“However,” Ta Lai’s smile faded ever so slightly, “if you choose to unravel the secrets to the split zone and return to your previous lives with anyone whom you deem worthy, then I’m afraid I will not be of much help . On the contrary, I might even be the reason for your demise . So, what do you choose?”

Do I have to make a decision? The split zone has never given me a choice...

Leave the split zone? I guess I’ve never really thought that possibility through properly . While I acknowledge that escaping in this manner isn’t filial of me, would the reality of my previous life be any better? I was a

murderer who killed my own crush, a demon with a killer lurking inside me . I was alone, useless and pathetic .

Did I really want to return to that life?

Even so, just because I don't, it didn't mean that others wouldn't want it either...

Still, despite our desire to return, there's no one who could truly comprehend the existence of soul splitters, and there isn't a way to be near them . What do we have to rely on then, if we wanted to return?

"I promise that I'll not hold any desire to return . I want you to help me in saving my friends, and take back my Western District . " I declared somberly, as if I finally came to a decision .

"I promise that I'll not hold any desire to return . I want you to help me in saving my friends, and take back my Western District . " I declared somberly, as if I finally came to a decision .

At the moment the words escaped, I could feel Nie Zun's clear eyes on me; his gaze held an element of loneliness that seemed impossible to dissolve . They searched mine wordlessly, as though asking, "Do you really... have no desire to return?"

Do I really...?

In spite of the flaws that world had, no matter how cruel it was to me, did I really have nothing I held on to? Do I really have no desire to return...?

"Alright . Remember what you've promised and listen well to what I have to say next . They are all critical details that will help in saving your friends . " Ta Lai nodded in satisfaction .

The choice to doubt my own decision was gone, all I can do now is nod in acceptance .

"For a start, from what I've gathered, your friends, Song Lu, Yu Liang and Laurel should have been turned into some form of experimental subjects by

now . If you wish to save them, you'll have to go against the mastermind of these experiments—Du Yue .

“Given that you're still alive, I believe you've heard of her but had yet met her . ”

What a chilling statement...

My existence right now is proof enough that I've not met her? How terrifying must that woman be...

“Like me, Du Yue is a soul splitter . Evidently, just as none of you know who your split symbol corresponds with in this dimension, neither do we; we do not have the information and with the amount of people in split zone, we don't have much interest in seeking out who could pose as a threat to us either .

“In any case, I won't divulge any information about soul splitters or the secret to split zone, so don't even bother asking about them . ”

“I didn't plan to . ” I sneered .

“Anyway, as soul splitters, both Du Yue and I have an immense amount of MF . However, the objective of the experiments wasn't as you've deduced—soul splitters have no desire in killing any of you . If we did, we could have just used a splitting key .

“We have no interest in eliminating any of you because your insertion of splitting key into our split symbol doesn't equate to our perishment; it just means you've managed to return . ”

“What? You won't die from an insertion of splitting key?”

“Well, actually, that's not all that accurate either . We will still disappear in that moment but...” As though he had realized his own oversharing, Ta Lai swiftly returned back to the topic . “Anyway, that's not the point . All you need to know, is that she isn't doing these experiments to target the average

resident like you, who had arrived from your previous life and are trapped here . ”

“What’s her motive then?” I frowned .

“Well, actually, that’s not all that accurate either . We will still disappear in that moment but...” As though he had realized his own oversharing, Ta Lai swiftly returned back to the topic . “Anyway, that’s not the point . All you need to know, is that she isn’t doing these experiments to target the average resident like you, who had arrived from your previous life and are trapped here . ”

“What’s her motive then?” I frowned .

Ta Lai stopped speaking, his gaze seemed distant as it flickered . Just as soon, he broke into a radiant smile . “I suppose she’s doing it to get rid of soul splitters like me . ”

I froze .

Ta Lai had always been elegant and calm, but why did his smile look so sorrowful now? Are my eyes playing tricks on me?

Du Yue...

When Du Yue’s name came up previously, didn’t Gaoqin Jiuye wear the same melancholic expression?

What kind of woman was she? The question bubbled curiously in my heart .

“All that aside, there’s no way the experiment will be completed that soon . From what I know, there hasn’t been a case of success with their experiments thus far, and what you need to do before then is to master the control over your MF .

“Whatever comes next, be it saving your friends or reclaiming Western District, will naturally be possible once you’ve grown capable . That’s what I’m going to do now: to give you a lesson in combat . ”

A lesson in combat?

“I’m aware about the 500 meters restriction between you and Nie Zun, as well as the fact that your split symbol is unsealed . Which is why, I’m going to be teaching you how to fight with an unsealed symbol . ” Ta Lai smiled .

How... did he know about that?

“This stone room is where I train . I have the ability of manipulating senses within a restricted area of enclosed space—this includes the four of them: your hearing, sight, smell and taste .

“The darkness you witnessed when you arrived was the effect of my distortion . I am unable to affect your sense of touch which is coincidentally the aspect I planned to train you both . In an actual combat, losing all of those four senses will be a common occurrence; I will first teach you how to continue fighting when the senses you had relied on a daily basis disappears . ”

From the sound of that, it seems like this training would be pretty tough...

Chapter 82

82 Devil's Hand

“I conducted a fundamental test on your combat abilities after you entered this space of mine . There were two scenarios: the first was the dark room that you were both in . I distorted your four senses and Li Shen, using your sense of touch, you went with the strategy of evading at full speed, increasing the rapidity of your movement by at least double the moment your enemies made contact and dodged them successfully—that’s a good tactic indeed . ”

Ta Lai broke into a smile . “But Nie Zun’s way of countering was even better—while you made use of your sense of touch to evade, he used them to accept . He sacrificed his own body to accept those attacks and, in that process, evaluated the enemy’s condition before eliminating all my puppets in the dark . Even I couldn’t resist the gasp of admiration at that . ”

Looking sideward at Nie Zun, he looked as calm as ever, as though Ta Lai’s high praises weren’t directed at him .

“Oh, but I am curious, Nie Zun . You used your bare hands when you attacked my puppets—what powers do your hands have? From what I understand, anyone who has sealed their split symbol will gain an ability of sorts, yet I’ve never seen anyone who retained their bare hands as a weapon after . ” A fleeting glint flashed swept across Ta Lai’s eyes .

Nie Zun flashed a faint smile . “It’s nothing special, really, only that my ability lies in these hands of mine . After sealing the split symbol, it allowed them to converge better . ”

“Do you mind sharing how you achieved it?”

Nie Zun's gaze turned dark for a split second, then spoke up softly . “The best doctor in our district invented various chemicals that could affect the consciousness in split zone—I'm sure you're aware of this . After all, three of our district's residents had used it for good and bad . I'm no different; I'm just a user of these chemicals . ”

“What did you do with them?” Unease filled my instincts as I posed the question at him .

Nie Zun smiled weakly . “Nothing much . I merely soak my hands in various types of mental inhibiting chemicals on a daily basis . ”

What... does that mean?

Ta Lai retracted his smile; a steely gaze decorated his features . “You mean, the reason behind those powers of manipulation and destruction in your hands lies in the fact that you've been using the mental inhibiting chemicals on yourself? How reckless! To soak in those chemicals, you've basically been using your own hands as an experiment subject! Any sort of mental inhibiting chemicals could have caused damage to us and yet, you combined them?! How did you endure it??”

Ta Lai wasn't the only who's taken aback by the news; even I was startled .

Frozen in shock, I couldn't gather myself enough to have any sort of reaction, but I gradually recalled a snippet of memory .

“Why do you always have a pair of gloves on?”

“Because these are the devil's hands . ”

“How pretentious . ”

It couldn't be helped if I had never asked, but I did . I did ask Nie Zun about those gloves of his and he did reply my question earnestly, but I've never taken them to heart .

Devil's hands...?

This wasn't the devil's hands, this was him turning his own pair of hands into a devil . Within the split zone, while I have no idea what makes up their compound, mental inhibitors are the only things that could hurt us . I do know, though, that an arrow stained with the chemical would be enough to torment its target for a long time .

Yet... he used a mixture of them to soak his bare hands?

Why did he have to treat himself in this manner...?

“You...” I opened my mouth, but the words trailed off the moment I spoke, and I couldn't finish my sentence .

Nie Zun beamed a carefree smile . “It's nothing . I merely fused my MF into my hands, then used a variety of chemicals to soak them . It is why there's a certain level of toxicity in my hands now . Ever since I've sealed my split symbol, my MF was able stabilize itself upon my hands; pre-existing toxin turned into something more demonic, and I'm consequently able to inflict a certain amount of damage on the mental strength of my target . ”

My heart began to quiver as I processed his words .

My heart began to quiver as I processed his words .

How could he reiterate them with such ease? Did he lure out such abilities from his hands to protect himself? I reckon that the agony and price for it wouldn't be something that anyone could tolerate, right?

And me... I am stuck with him through days and nights, how did I not know anything about this?

Have I ever truly attempted to understand him...

Watching that ever-present desolation in Nie Zun's eyes hanging upon that striking face of his, a squeeze of sourness surged through my heart .

Ta Lai sighed . “I've always knew that you have extraordinary endurance, Nie Zun, but never have I expected that you were so prepared . Were this all

for your own protection?”

Nie Zun’s eyes blinked lightly . I watched his eyelashes fan several times, looking as though it would be drenched at any moment . “That’s not important . ”

I clenched my hands in secret .

“From the look of your control over the eye techniques, it’s really not necessary...” Ta Lai trailed off when Nie Zun swept a cursory glance at him, seeming to have received the message .

Just like that, they three of us remained in silence .

I didn’t have a clue about the thoughts that were running through their minds, but I snuck a peek at Nie Zun .

Lit by the torches on the wall, the silhouette of the Nie Zun’s side profile flickered in the stone room but the light in his retinal was unfathomable .

After a long while, Ta Lai exhaled another breath before speaking up again .
“In any case, with the absence certain sense of perception, your subconscious would begin to harbour fear towards your surroundings . The duration of this fear will have a direct impact on the outcome of your battle .

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“In any case, with the absence certain sense of perception, your subconscious would begin to harbour fear towards your surroundings . The duration of this fear will have a direct impact on the outcome of your battle .

“Despite losing your senses, both of you found a way to deal with it in a short period of time; this is incredible and worthy of a mention . ”

At that point, Ta Lai looked towards me . “In the instant you discovered your sense of touch, I placed the two of you on separate levels . In your

layer, Li Shen, I kept it void of any mechanisms . The reason for this second training was to exercise your patience .

“The elements of unknown—to be stuck within an enclosed space without the freedom of choice between life and death—could easily break a person; this was what I wanted to observe . As the rumored, sole double identity disorder person in split zone, what sort of darkness would this enclosed space stir from your heart?”

“What do you mean by ‘the rumored, sole double identity disorder person in split zone’?”

“You don’t know about this yet, right? Those who arrived in the split zone were brought here after their consciousness has been captured . Logically, those with double identity disorders will have two sets of consciousness tied to them, and it’ll be almost impossible to capture them at the same time . This is why, through the many years in split zone, there hasn’t been such a case until now . ”

I frowned . “Li Qing did tell me that I was different from the rest, but she also mentioned someone else in the history of split zone who had the same disorder . ”

Ta Lai’s gaze suddenly grew heavy with profound pain, as though he was recalling a memory that he could not bear to revisit . As if I had uncovered the only weakness that could shatter all his reason, it carried a lingering trace of sorrow .

Without conscious awareness, his voice gave away his despondency .
“Indeed, there was but they were different from you; they had multiple identity disorder . Double identity disorder merely split your personality into two, and the burden would still be manageable . However, for a person with multiple identity disorder—with the shattering of their personality and arrival into the split zone—none of them was complete . ”

“Then... how are they now?” I may be oblivious to the identity of this person, but I could clearly see the inexplicable pain in Ta Lai’s eyes when he talked about them . Hence, my tone of enquiry softened .

Ta Lai squeezed his eyes together but didn't answer, and awkwardness began to pour itself into me .

When he reopened them, his gaze seemed to return to its usual elegance, reason and calm . “Regardless, Li Shen, you still passed my second round of test . However, there was an interesting portion during the test—at one point, your emotions were visibly swayed, and you kept yelling ‘Come out!’ around the empty stone room . Who were you talking to? Your second personality?”

Like my heart, my eyes turned cold . “You don't have to worry about that .”

Ta Lai watched me thoughtfully and said, “Since you don't wish to talk about it then I won't force it out of you either . I just want to make it clear that only when you can tap into your true, subconscious mind, will you be able to use your MF freely . In the split zone, it's not a given that every soul splitter will be more powerful than your average body of consciousness . Level of might depends entirely on your inner strength . ”

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Lifting a slender finger, Ta Lai pointed to his own mind gracefully . “Inner strength refers to your mental strength; the strength you have up here . ”

“Only when you have control over the full potential of your strength, could you gain the capability in changing your circumstances . I'm going to ask you one question: are you sure you're not willing to unleash the power of your split symbol?”

Should I... unleash the power of my split symbol...

For some reason, there was an irrational fear in my heart from the moment I heard about this from Jiao S . Without waiting for my response, Nie Zun replied, “No . I’ll not allow her to seal her split symbol . ”

Ta Lai donned a peculiar smile . “Oh? Why’s that? Aren’t you even the slightest bit curious about the punishment such a unique person would suffer from, upon the sealing of her symbol?”

Nie Zun’s eyes began to turn cold . “She shouldn’t have to suffer through them, no matter the punishment . ”

“You can endure through those devil’s hands but couldn’t bear for her to go through even a little agony? How interesting...”

I don’t know why but a self-deprecating smile surfaced on Ta Lai’s face . “How like me you are...”

In that moment, I realized the silhouette of another in his gaze .

When a person is deeply in love with another, there will be a defect in their gaze . It will carry the shadow of the one they love, and it is within this that revealed all the emotions a person ought to have, all the emotions they had previously concealed in their desolate gaze .

Chapter 83

83 You're Not to Blame

Did Ta Lai have someone he loved deeply too...?

“I’m curious about your symbols . Will soul splitters suffer from punishment upon the sealing of it as well?” Nie Zun asked .

“We do, just as you would . This is something that was set in stone from the very start . A split symbol is a form of contract—this was the price to pay for capturing your souls . This contract had likewise given us abilities . It’s only a matter of perspective if you see the ability as a gift or the punishment as a curse . ”

“Why did you people capture us?” I asked furiously .

“There are some things that are beyond our control . Despite bringing you here, we still can’t recognize the soul we captured among the sea of people . ” Ta Lai replied .

“Resignation happens to any living person; soul splitters are no different . ” He laughed self-deprecatingly . “Soul splitters aren’t divine beings, just resigned humans . ”

I followed with a cold reply, “How great you are at concocting excuses . There are many things in the world that are aggravating, but to harm and ruin another’s life is a sin no matter how you try to explain it . ”

Ta Lai reciprocated with a calm smile . “Alright, alright . I’m not here to discuss the right or wrong, the sin or redemption . I’m here to teach you a lesson on combat, so let’s stop here with the discussion about life . For now, let’s teach you proper combat . ”

My eyes stared fixated on him . “I won’t be grateful . ”

He met my gaze, “I know . Let’s just treat this as a trade-off . This way, no one will be stuck in a difficult position . You’ll only have to remember what you promised . ”

“Aren’t you afraid I would regret it?”

His smile widened . “You won’t and even if you did, I’d have a way of making sure you can’t . ”

The words put me at great unease but I didn’t have any other option either . I am keenly aware of my own abilities; forget Du Yue, I am a far cry from even Jiao S .

“Fine, come on then . I’ll grant you an opportunity to be a teacher . ” I waved my hand, donning a facade of resolution as though I’m ready to risk everything .

“Even though you’ve both leveraged on your sense of touch to combat earlier, the method of usage could still be improved on . I hope you’ll be able to create the perfect combat tactic by combining both your techniques . I have to take a trip into Western District today; the obscured reason behind its decapitated state baffled me too . I hope you’ll be prepared by the time I get back; I’ll distort your senses once more and release my children again . ”

Laughing gleefully, he continued, “The children I’m unleashing will no longer be a child’s play, which is why I’m giving you time to think through your strategy .

“Oh, and you can use this time to talk things out as well; I’m sure there are a lot of things on your mind after our earlier conversation . ”

Once he was done, he rotated the jade ring in his finger in the direction of the ceiling . It opened with a swoosh from that small gesture .

I looked up to witness infinite darkness

The tip of his feet lightly touched the ground and he dived into the darkness . With his departure, the ceiling began to close up once more .

Nie Zun and I were the only ones left in the enclosed stone room .

I tilted my head towards him; with both hands stuck into his pocket, he headed straight for the corner of the room, returning to his favorite posture—leaning against the wall with a slight slouch .

The torch near him flickered quietly, lighting up just half of his face .

I opened my mouth to ask the innumerable questions echoing in my head, but couldn't find the words to start . Through the torch, I watched him in silence .

Slowly, his indifferent gaze met mine without a word . In depths of his eyes, the flame danced and rippled . Just like this, the two of watched each other in stillness .

Eventually, I was the one to break the silence, “You... Can you tell me the cause of your arrival into the split zone?”

A slight smile graced his features; so faint that one would miss it without careful observation . “I thought you'd ask about this hand of mine first . ” At that, he raised his left hand .

I pursed my lips into a tight smile but didn't reply .

I pursed my lips into a tight smile but didn't reply .

Unhurriedly, Nie Zun pulled out his right hand and tugged at the glove on his left . His slender, pale hand stretched towards me . As though attracted by an enchantment, his hand lured me a step closer, and then another .

I met his eyes for a split second when I arrived before him, before dropping it towards his outstretched hand . The palm of his hand which had been facing the ground turned upwards lightly .

There was no palm prints on them .

Through the days and nights I had spent with him, even though I rarely saw him without his gloves but it wasn't the first time witnessing it either . Still, I've never taken particular note about them until today . When he flipped his hand over, revealing his palm without reservations, I could clearly see his loneliness .

With the amount of supernatural books I've read, I didn't need any explanation from him . I knew... that anyone without palms prints was said to have a cursed life . Likewise, without need his illustration of his back-story, I could already imagine the difficulties and agony he had been through in his previous life .

It wasn't the 'cursed life' that had made him suffered, but the rumors . Spirits and ghosts were never the scariest entities in this world; beyond those, there were humans who were immensely more vicious .

For him to be the owner of this cursed palm, I'm sure he must have suffered great discrimination growing up, especially if unfortunate events had coincidentally occurred in his family .

The animated discussion from an innumerable crowd of people sounded in my mind once more .

“She's a freak!”

“Stay away from her!”

My heart felt like it was drowning from a sudden surge of tide, and my eyes welled up . Before I could even stop myself, I reached out my own hand, laying it above his palm .

I watched the flicker in Nie Zun's eyes for a moment . In that second, he looked like a helpless, frightened, child . With my palm against his own, my hand atop of Nie Zun's, the chill of his hand pulsed into mine .

His body had always been this cold .

A prickling sensation of pain began to extend through our contact; though he hadn't fused his MF into his palm, after those days of soaking them in chemicals, they were no longer soft to touch .

A prickling sensation of pain began to extend through our contact; though he hadn't fused his MF into his palm, after those days of soaking them in chemicals, they were no longer soft to touch .

I didn't mind, though . Just like that, I met his eyes with my palm on his . Still, there was a nagging feeling that I've missed something .

What was it...?

Oh!

That's right, the ring!

I lowered my head in haste, removing my hand and flipping his hand over once more . My eyes dropped towards the skull ring on his pinky finger .

I've seen it before, but hadn't felt the same peculiar sensation I did today .

As I stared at the lacquered black, exquisitely carved skull ring, I couldn't help muttering under my breath, "This ring... Why does it look so familiar? Why... can't I remember?"

I felt a sudden squeeze on my left shoulder; clasp ing his glove on his right hand, Nie Zun held it against my shoulder .

Lifting my head, I met his gaze again in unintentional intimate distance . My mind was once again captured by the waves behind his eyes .

A glint of glee flickered across his eyes, the corners of his lips arched upwards . "Tsk, tsk . You can't cast your greedy eyes upon other people's gem . "

Hearing his teasing tone, I grew furious from embarrassment and took a step back immediately, letting go of his hand in the process . "Who would even care about it . "

Despite those words, only I knew that my action came from the desire to distance myself from him; perhaps it was the powers behind his eyes, but I found myself being pulled into his gaze every time our eyes meet, and I'm unable to turn away .

... Ah, it's probably because of the powers in his eyes!

As expected, he was just like a demon; his entire being was the epitome of mystifying danger!

Nie Zun was laughing to his heart's content . "Aren't you going to ask about my printless palm?"

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Nie Zun was laughing to his heart's content . "Aren't you going to ask about my printless palm?"

I swept a glance at him . "So what if you have no palm prints? According to speculations, didn't that just mean you have a cursed life? Did you really expect me to believe in those?"

The smile was still hanging on his lips, but a glint of misery flickered momentarily in the depths of his eyes . "I didn't believe it before either, but... what if I said I have begun to? I really do feel like I have a cursed life; I've always brought misfortune upon the people around me..."

Nie Zun looked over at me with a self-deprecating smile . "Who knows, maybe you were cursed by me too . Haven't you always condemned the fusion between your second personality and I? Who knows, maybe it was this cursed palm at work . "

He lifted said hand and gave it a short wave .

I stared straight back at him . "I'll admit, Nie Zun, that I am still brooding over the fact that my second personality had resonated with you . I knew none of this was your fault but I was still stubborn in growing my hatred

towards you . That has nothing to do with you, you haven't done anything wrong . The reason behind all that was only because I didn't think I could persevere if I didn't at least hate you a little .

“Perhaps I wouldn't be able to stop this hatred despite all the days we had spent together, with you protecting me by my side . Even so, I knew very clearly that you're not at fault . Whatever cursed life you think you have, I'll neither sympathize with you nor blame you for it . I'm here because of the karma I've incurred from killing another; you don't have to carry this sin for me . ”

His eyes softened drastically; maybe it was the flicker of lit torches that was playing tricks on my eyes . “If this cursed life of mine has the right of carrying your sin on your behalf, I'll be more than willing . ”

I raised a brow . “When did you get so kind?”

Nie Zun laughed and his pale left hand touched his nose . “It's a cursed life anyway; there isn't much use for it . Since it's cursed, I'm sure it could at least deflect against minor mishaps . ”

I fixed my gaze right into his . “It's not a cursed life . You might have face unfortunate events in your life—perhaps those were the work of fate or mere coincidences—but they were definitely not your fault . ”

“I can't even be sure that they were not my fault, how can you be this decisive about it?” His voice reverberated clearly in this stone room .

I tilted my head with a slight smile . “Because I'm Li Shen . ”

The flame hanging along the stone wall quivered abruptly, as did the glow reflected against Nie Zun's face .

Chapter 84

84 His Past

“Oh right . There was something else I wanted to ask . ” I fixed my gaze on him .

“Hm?”

“When I was caught in an illusion at Southern District, it was a voice that summoned me back with a simple ‘Shen’er’ . From then on, this voice would pull me back whenever my consciousness dipped in chaos . Like a mechanism that was set, I managed to regain my consciousness when I hear it .

“That voice... sounded a lot like you . Was it you, Nie Zun?”

“It’s me . ” Nie Zun lowered his head and tugged his gloves back on .

“I used my sight to plant an enchantment into the depths of your eyes . This enchantment will activate when your consciousness begins to grow unstable . When your consciousness is affected and you become irrational, your eyes will likewise turn spiritless; that’s when the enchantment begin its work . The voice was also a mechanism I’ve placed . There is no other use for it besides bringing you back to your senses . ”

I froze . I had never expected to hear such a thing .

“Why?”

“Jie Pa had hypnotized you once . Your mental state wasn’t stable enough, even Mr Blond had informed me about this before . Although double identity disorder consisted of two independent consciousness, they both

arrived here in your case but your present state of identity isn't complete . There wasn't an exception like yourself in the split zone before—you're aware of that as well . All the forms which you maintained here, including your life, was only allowed to happen because your consciousness exists in this dimension . ”

He paused for moment, then continued . “And your situation is special . Just like how water vapor and droplets are essentially the same thing, but the composition of water vapor isn't as stable as droplets . Mr Blond and Jie Pa were worried about the remnant of your identity after the split between your two consciousness . They were worried that fluctuations in this dimension would cause instability, yet, they were unable to predict the consequences of that . Therefore, some preventive measures were established . ”

Regardless of how you put it, didn't all that just mean that they were trying to protect me...?

Li Shen, what did you have to grumble about...? Had you ever been worthy of their concern...? Almost everyone had been by your side, taking you into consideration on their own about the innumerable possibilities that might happen to you...

Watching the creasing of my brows, he spoke again . “To be honest, due to your unique situation, your condition hadn't been that well from the get-go . It was precisely because of that that Mr Blond made sure to emphasize this to Li Qing and I, to remind us that we have to pay special attention to your emotions in case you run into any trouble .

“You know this too—Even if Mr Blond couldn't give us an answer to the countless secrets to the split zone, nor was he able to help us find our soul splitters, but he had always hoped that our bodies of consciousness could reside here in peace . ”

Indeed, Mr Blond was strict but kind . I can't deny that as a guide, he was able to calm the emotions of every new person who had just arrived into the split zone, and let them live here in peace . Mr Blond once said to me that he couldn't promise our return to the previous life, but he could promise a new beginning here in this dimension .

For someone with a smirch in both their life and mental state, the words “a new beginning” was enough to bring tears to their eyes .

I suppose that was also why the common folks in these districts didn’t possess a particularly strong desire to search for their soul splitters; maybe they just wanted to live here in peace forevermore .

Those who arrived here with a vulnerable mental condition and were likewise weaker, would be assigned to Southern District by Mr Blond . That promised land was an easier option to accept in comparison to the cruel world of their previous life .

Those with a distorted state of mind, who weren’t sound or who held a hint of malicious intent were assigned to the Eastern District, where they could they unleash their malice .

This dimension could satisfy certain desires that we hold, and it was how it could continue in stable existence . Yet, there were people who are attempting this disrupt this serenity now .

“When did you plant the enchantment into my eyes?”

Nie Zun met my gaze . “It was during that time, half a year after our arrival...”

I interjected, “Got it . ”

Reading my reluctance to be reminded of the incident, Nie Zun didn’t insist either .

Reading my reluctance to be reminded of the incident, Nie Zun didn’t insist either .

“Oh, that’s right . Why do you have such a close relationship with Jie Pa?” Are you two...” I hesitated, unsure of whether I should pose the question .

Nie Zun laughed weakly . “Just as I’ve told you before, he was my doctor from my previous life . ”

He shrugged with both palms facing up . “I don’t know if it’s due to my cursed life but both my parents passed away . Growing up, my sister and I always depended on each other . Jie Pa has had a crush on my sister for years, while my sister had sent me to treatment with him out of fear that I’d be psychologically affected by all the incidents that occurred . ”

Ah... So Nie Zun has a sister...

Nie Zun let out a bitter laugh . “Eventually, my sister got into an accident too . I thought that perhaps I cursed her to death too . My mental state must had been severely affected by the accident which caused my arrival into split zone . For some reason, Jie Pa appeared after me as well and I never knew why . He always joked that a doctor like him was driven crazy by a patient like me, but I don’t think that’s the case . ”

“And your sister...”

“I saw her when I watched the snippet of reality from the lounge . They managed to save her . I suppose she’s doing well now . ” I couldn’t read the profound expression in his eyes .

I bit my lip . “Then... I’m sure you must really want to go back to accompany her... And Jie Pa too...”

“I don’t know either . Who knows if I’ll bring her more misfortune by going back . Maybe my presence here will be a good cause for anyone . ”

A good cause for anyone...

Must you always take others into consideration...?

How can such a person be branded with that horrible label of a cursed life... This world truly isn’t fair...

How can such a person be branded with that horrible label of a cursed life... This world truly isn’t fair...

If we’re going into this topic, then aren’t I the one bringing misfortune to people instead? He had been unlucky enough to be fused with my second

personality; as long as I don't find my soul splitter, he won't be able to return either . To be bound in this way is still a form of harm no matter how you try to spin it; by taking him away from his sister was a form of harm inflicted on him .

No longer willing to watch as he drowned in his sorrow, I waved my hand in front of his eyes . “Alright, let's not dwell on the past since we're already here . We should find a solution to our current predicament . ”

Nie Zun nodded . “I always thought that the incidents weren't as easy as it seemed . The disappearance of Mr Blond had almost never happened within the split zone . Now that I think about it, there was also a problem when Li Qing sliced your arm off . ”

I asked dumbly, “What problem?”

“Do you remember that I had once asked her about the basiliscampus? About why it didn't heal after it was diced by Li Qing? She avoided my question then . In retrospect, the basiliscampus should have been a human like us, or at least a human with a disguised form . If so, why didn't it heal? Unless it's not a human? But it isn't, then how did such a monster get into the split zone?”

As it dawned on me, I exclaimed, “Do you mean to say that regardless of those strange monsters which were concocted from souls brought in by the soul snatcher, or composition from the experiments, they had long appeared on the day Li Qing sliced me?”

Nie Zun nodded . “I'm afraid Li Qing had been concealing information from us . ”

“In that case, was there something wrong with Li Qing's death as well? Just like how Li Wen reappeared after such a long time, could Li Qing still be alive too?” If we could establish such a possibility, then the conspiracy that was lurking behind the scenes just became scarier . Even so, the probability of Li Qing's survival still filled me with excitement .

“We can’t bear such an optimistic view . Whatever the case, our current situation doesn’t look good . Western District has been reduced into ruins, Old Man Fan was transformed into a statue, Song Lu and Yu Liang have both fallen into enemy’s hands, and we still don’t know where Laurel is .

“I don’t mean to infuriate you but you must face the reality of this—the reality that didn’t allow any trace of optimism . ” Nie Zun watched me .

I nodded . He was right . Avoidance and fear wouldn’t solve anything; right now, only danger and the unknown await us .

“So, as Ta Lai mentioned, we’re doing an equal trade off . If that’s the case, then why don’t we believe in him for the time being . If he can increase both our abilities and help us bring back Song Lu and the others, then maybe the truth will slowly float to the surface through this process . ” I said to Nie Zun .

“That’s right . Since this is so, we should accept it . It just so happens that your fighting ability isn’t something I can bear to witness . ” Nie Zun blinked at me, returning back to that annoying demeanor of his .

“So, as Ta Lai mentioned, we’re doing an equal trade off . If that’s the case, then why don’t we believe in him for the time being . If he can increase both our abilities and help us bring back Song Lu and the others, then maybe the truth will slowly float to the surface through this process . ” I said to Nie Zun .

“That’s right . Since this is so, we should accept it . It just so happens that your fighting ability isn’t something I can bear to witness . ” Nie Zun blinked at me, returning back to that annoying demeanor of his .

I rolled my eyes at him . “I’m brilliant, okay? Didn’t you hear Ta Lai’s compliment? About how great my tactic was in using my sense of touch to swiftly avoid the attack!”

With his pretence at being serious, Nie Zun nodded . “Yes, yes . You did great! It was indeed great to have an arm yanked off, and speak to yourself in this empty stone room for several days... It’s great indeed . ”

I really want to aim a good kick at him...

“Oh, Ta Lai said you made use of your sense of touch too, but instead of evading, you attacked . What did he mean by that?” With my mind drifting back to the topic at hand, I asked in haste .

“It means that I made use of my touch to sense the moment of attack, but I didn’t move to dodge it . Instead, at the moment of contact, I used it to determine the perpetrator’s condition by analyzing their location and strength of attack . From there, I retaliated .

“In summary, you’re passive and I’m aggressive . The time he gave us to communicate is also for us to concoct the best strategy that could combine our attack and defence tactics . ”

At the mention of that, a glimmer of appreciation flickered across Nie Zun’s eyes . “Ta Lai’s highly intelligent . He didn’t see the 500 meters restriction between us as a weakness but an opportunity to use it to our advantage . Since we can’t be separated, then we should collaborate our efforts; the perfect combination is the key to being successful on the battleground . ”

I regarded him from the corner of my eyes . “How exceptional; you have so much to say at the topic of combat . A demon indeed, to be this interested in fighting and bloodshed . ”

He merely blinked at me again . “Aren’t I doing all this to protect you?”

Even though I still held disdain over his unruly behavior, but his words still caused a surge of warmth to spread through my heart .

Chapter 85

85 Let the Training Begin

Nie Zun and I had decided on our combat strategy by the time Ta Lai returned .

“How’s the situation?” I asked in haste the moment his stature came into view .

He responded with a shake of his head . “It remains in ruins . I never realized how powerful Old Man Fan was; the state of Western District is a likely a consequence of his doing, but I can’t decipher the technique that was used . The fact that everyone in Western District has disappeared is just as baffling to me . ”

“Old Man Fan? Wasn’t he turned to stone?”

“That’s right, and it’s precisely because of that that I suspect he had used a form of space-time manipulation or cementation technique to transport all of Western District . Even I have no idea where he could possibly relocate these people to . ”

“But... Why would Old Man Fan do that?” I frowned .

“For you, perhaps . Before your return, You Ji and the Seven Demons called for a change of district commander . It was rumored that their Penetration of Seven was one of the strongest enchantments to exist . I assume they must have been waiting in ambush for your return and Old Man Fan did what he could to protect you . ”

His words rendered me speechless .

“Regardless of whether the state of Western District was Old Man Fan’s doing, the crux of our problem lies in the fact that this has never happened in the history of split zone . With such a peculiar affair, it will naturally attract the attention of others who would come forth to have a look . I can’t know if Du Yue would return, but You Ji would surely make her way back soon . What you need to do now, is to increase your combat skills before it happens . ”

I gritted my teeth . “What great timing if she comes back; I have a bone to pick with her . ”

Once again, Ta Lai shook his head . “Don’t oversimplify the matter; You Ji is joined with Du Yue on her side . The only reason they allowed you to live is because they have their sights set on Southern District’s Si Luo right now . You Ji’s objective differed from Du Yue’s; You Ji wanted the prestige of commanding Western District . This is why she’d definitely return if Western District falls into peril .

“Jiao S might be able to hold her back for some time . Even so, we don’t know the state of Southern District nor the result of Du Yue and Si Luo’s negotiation . It will be wise to practice caution . ”

“Negotiations? Why is it that all of these are related to Si Luo?” My frown deepened .

Ta Lai sighed . “After all, Si Luo has the highest MF in split zone . Even if the MF of soul splitters aren’t high but with our experience, we’re still much stronger in battle . However, Si Luo is an exception; he’s someone whom even we don’t dare to offend .

“That said, there has always been a rumor floating that he isn’t well, that he’s about to perish . Regarding the disappearance of a district commander, I’m sure you understand the issues it attracts . ”

I met Nie Zun’s eyes, our eyes flooded with undisguised shock .

Si Luo’s about to wither away? How could that be possible?

But... In retrospect, when Jiao S asked Huan Ying if a certain something was true, he nodded his head . Could it be that she was asking about this? If Si Luo was on the edge of disappearance, that must mean he's in dire condition in the real world .

For a body of consciousness, as our flesh body in the real world withers, our body in this dimension would also begin to exhibit various illness . They were an omen signifying that our end was nearing . Despite that, the strength of our MF was still controlled by our minds, and so it wouldn't necessarily be affected by the status of our flesh body . Just like Jiao S' incident previously; our bodies of flesh and consciousness are in sync .

I don't know how long Si Luo has been in the split zone but it was rare for anyone in the split zone to be faced with perishment . The difference of time between the split zone and real world is far too great for it to occur .

If the rumor is true, however, then we can only expect chaos to ensue . The death of Southern District's commander would imply that a successor has to be chosen soon but... the next generation of commander is decided between the current commander and Mr Blond . Mr Blond is missing, and there's practically no one in the split zone who could live up to Si Luo's might . If Si Luo does pass away, who would protect the countless number of vulnerable residents in Southern District?

“Th—that’s terrifying, it’s unbelievable . But, what has this got to do with soul splitters like you?” Confused, I posed the question to Ta Lai .

“Th—that’s terrifying, it’s unbelievable . But, what has this got to do with soul splitters like you?” Confused, I posed the question to Ta Lai .

Ta Lai's gaze flickered . “As much as I am unwilling to reveal the soul splitter's secrets, there is something that I can assure you—soul splitters can't do as they willed . Even if we're more mysterious than you, we have our own set of rules and regulations . Apart from Northern District, the balance of the other three districts has to be maintained; we have no interests in subjecting you to our persecution .

“You must have developed some misunderstanding towards soul splitters after all this time . Although you can return to reality with the combination of your splitting key and corresponding soul splitters, this didn’t mean that soul splitters are your nemesis . To us, you’re not our enemies . ”

I laughed bitterly . “Who knows if that’s true? It’ll only be conceivable if soul splitters truly won’t die from the insertion of a splitting key, but how can we know if you were being honest about that?”

Ta Lai flashed a graceful smile . “That’s up to you to believe . In any case, the residents in these three districts aren’t our target . However, peace can only find you if there is balance in the relationship among the districts . Soul splitters have their own set of regulations, and you have your wars—that’s what makes the split zone . ”

Nie Zun spoke up abruptly after a long period of silence, “Soul splitters have engaged in current affairs despite us not being your enemies and on top of it, there’s the issue of experiments conducted by Du Yue . It seems as if there’s discord among soul splitters as well?”

Eh? What did Nie Zun mean by that?

Nie Zun turned to me, obvious that his simplified explanation was done for my sake, “Which means to say, just like our three districts—Southern, Western and Eastern—perhaps there are different clans among the ranks of soul splitters as well . Maybe Du Yue’s target wasn’t us, but the clan of soul splitters that opposed her . ”

Ah?

A faint smile tugged at the corner of Ta Lai’s lips . “You live up to your reputation indeed; rumor had it that you have exceptional intelligence with incredible reflex .

“You’re right . I’ve told you before too; Du Yue is targeting me but I can’t divulge the details of that . All you have to know is that the common folks of your districts aren’t her objective . Soul splitters have our own rules;

apart from Northern District, we would've broken the rules just by setting foot in any of the other three districts . ”

Does that mean they had been living in Northern District all this while? Wouldn't it mean that Mr Blond had been concealing the truth from us then? They had been in Northern District yet we weren't allowed there; how else could we have found our soul splitters and return to reality?

Does that mean they had been living in Northern District all this while? Wouldn't it mean that Mr Blond had been concealing the truth from us then? They had been in Northern District yet we weren't allowed there; how else could we have found our soul splitters and return to reality?

“Li Shen, I know you have a lot of questions in your mind . Mr Blond didn't lie; it is true that we have to visit the three districts in set intervals, it's a routine .

“In other words, fate would have allowed you to find your corresponding soul splitter if you really wanted to . Whether you would be able to identify each other, that's your own problem . The secret to the split zone, is that everything has its predestined fate; this has been decided since the start and no one—not even soul splitters—can escape from it . ”

I'm getting even more confused by the second...

“I'm Du Yue's target but she still has no idea that I'm here . To put it plainly, the purpose of her negotiations with Si Luo is to verify the rumors surrounding his condition . If it is true, then she'd help the soul snatcher, Rong Jin, in becoming the next district commander . This way, she'll be able to establish her experiment sites as she wished in Southern District .

“You Ji's ambitions aligned well too; if You Ji took over Western District, it would be equivalent to it landing in the grasp of Du Yue . ”

A surge of rage gushed into my chest . “Did she think that anyone and everyone of us could be her experiment subjects? She was willing to overlook all the innocent lives just for the sake of her conflict with you? The soul splitter's regulations allowed her to do as she pleased too?”

Ta Lai sighed . “Some things can’t be changed; her actions will naturally incur relative repercussions, that’s why I’m here . Dwelling on her cruelty is a useless feat; what you need to do now is to stop her, to stop Rong Jin from being the next commander of Southern District, and stop You Ji from taking over Western District .

“But you’re still too weak . ”

I grew embarrassed at that . It was true; regardless of their ultimate objective, there was no use feeling enraged when I didn’t possess the ability to stop anyone now .

Did Jiao S know about this though? Could it be that she had known about them from the start? Was protecting Si Luo the reason why she was so determined to visit Southern District?

But how could she remain so calm and composed while fighting alongside me, if she had known about Si Luo’s deteriorating condition? If I had known about my lover’s approaching demise, I’m afraid I would be even more maniacal than her in wanting to see them .

“There’s no benefit in speaking anymore . Let’s start training the both of you . ” Ta Lai smiled . A hand slid elegantly behind his back while the other snapped his fingers .

But how could she remain so calm and composed while fighting alongside me, if she had known about Si Luo’s deteriorating condition? If I had known about my lover’s approaching demise, I’m afraid I would be even more maniacal than her in wanting to see them .

“There’s no benefit in speaking anymore . Let’s start training the both of you . ” Ta Lai smiled . A hand slid elegantly behind his back while the other snapped his fingers .

Before I could react, the snap of fingers plunged us into darkness once more .

In the darkness, Ta Lai's voice resounded . "I've placed both of you into this space that's obscured from your four senses again . I'll release 99 puppet giants—they're same as the 13 giants you've met before . Of course, they don't have much thought nor a splitting key, so they're not enough to kill you . They'll only attack you continuously .

"I'll let you out the moment you defeat all 99 giants . "

What the fu—?!

99 of those enormous giants??

Forget our four senses! Even with them, I'm afraid Nie Zun and I would need several days and nights before we could defeat all 99 of those playthings .

Now he wants us to eliminate them while we're stuck in this space with distorted senses? Wouldn't Nie Zun and I be torn to shreds before we could even kill them?

With such skewed senses, I'm sure we won't be able to leave this place in just a few days, right?

What's his problem, huh?!

Chapter 86: 99 vs 2.

Volume 2

86 99 vs 2

“Don’t forget about our arrangement!” Right after Ta Lai’s words, Nie Zun’s voice rang out in the dark .

“Hm!” With a hum of acknowledgement, my left leg reached backwards while I clasped my hand around the Piercer and held it in front of me .

As expected, with two steps back, my back flushed against Nie Zun’s .

This was the arrangement we had concluded from before; we will counter our enemies in this back-to-back position . Regardless of the direction our enemies attack from, we’ll turn clockwise, staying back-to-back till the end .

Pressing against his back, I squeezed my eyes shut, focusing all my MF onto my skin and increased my sense of touch . This way, I will be able to feel the atmospheric changes caused by the movements of those giants .

Incoming!

Bang!

The Piercer struck forth horizontally just as my left foot stepped to the right before retreating back to its original position . In perfect coordination, Nie Zun mirrored the same movement . However, just as my right feet took an experimental step forward, it seemed to have landed on a thick, bear-like paw!

“Ahooo!” A roar reverberated from above my head . Since I wasn’t able to discern the location of the sound in this space, I could only feel the trembling from the top of my skull .

Without a hint of hesitation, I shifted my MF and focused it on my right hand . I kept what seemed to be the giant’s foot captive under my sole . The fingers of my right hand lined tightly together as though in preparation for karate and I pierced them towards the right!

Pu-tsst!

In that instant, I could feel my hand plunging into the body of the giant, penetrating right through its flesh!

“Ahooo!” Accompanied by an animalistic wail, I sensed impending danger from above!

As if I had summoned everything I could muster, I plucked the set of bow and arrow from my back at swiftest speed and aimed it overhead .

Pu-tsst!

Ahooo!

In an apparent effort to swallow my head whole, the arrow I released struck through the throat of the giant above me . At the same time, I felt Nie Zun pushing against me from behind!

I understood his intentions at once; pulling back the foot that was stepping on the giant’s, I stepped back in time . With my retreat, Nie Zun moved three steps back as well . Just like that, the both of us moved backwards with my back against his .

I let go of my left hand . Distancing three steps from the giant from before, my left hand found the Piercer once more and struck another whip forward .

Swoosh! A powerful ray of Violet Blade was unleashed from the gesture .

In the split moment before it vanished, I could feel the Violet Blade slicing through dozens of giants ahead despite my lack of sight .

Thump, thump, thump!

The attack sliced across their torso and the giants fell one after another in a loud crash . It's truly fortunate that these puppets couldn't heal . Just as I exhaled a sigh of relief, a hand penetrated my body through my back!

One of the giants in front of Nie Zun had pierced its hand through Nie Zun's stomach and in consequence of our position, stabbed me through my back as well .

"Ah!" While I let out a brief yelp from impact, Nie Zun didn't even make a sound! I furrowed my brows and caught that giant's hand with my right .

There wasn't a slightest trace of concern for Nie Zun; I have complete faith in him that he'd be able to eliminate this giant which had a death wish . It was with that thought that I kept a death grip on the hand which penetrated through my stomach, not giving it a chance to escape!

Simultaneously, I shifted my MF into my left hand and held up my Piercer . "Lower your head, Nie Zun!" I bellowed, then swung the whip in a full circle above our heads!

It was the first time I've expended this much MF, to the extent of retracting those I've placed upon my skin . Similarly, it was the first time I've circled the Piercer above our heads like a halo .

Even with the pitch-black darkness, I could still vaguely make out the sheen of violet light, exploding in the room like special effects in television dramas . Surrounding Nie Zun and I, the Piercer whistled as its attack spread in all directions!

Thump, thump, thump, thump, thump!

The giants surrounding us seemed to have tumbled to the ground!

I inhaled a deep breath . Since my split symbol was still unsealed, I could distinctly feel the amount I had expended upon retraction of my MF . After all, with every usage, a portion of MF wouldn't be recoverable until the next day . In addition, under such combat circumstances, there's a rise in frequency of MF usage .

“Done!” Nie Zun muttered and I understood the meaning behind his words . Between my breaths, I kept my right hand clasped onto the giant's hand and with a gritting of my teeth, I yanked it out from my stomach .

I swung my right hand forward with a little MF, throwing the broken giant's arm in a random direction .

Thump! Ah, I have no idea which unlucky giant got hit by it .

My MF had reduced by so much that I was beginning to feel exhaustion creeping to me .

“Turn me into a Piercer!” Nie Zun spoke up from behind me .

Huh?? What did he mean by that?!

Without waiting for my reaction, I felt Nie Zun's hand snatching at my Piercer while another clenched against my left hand . Thereafter, Nie Zun scurried to my side, as though he had begun leaping!

I felt a force pressing down on my left hand and finally understood his intentions . Swiftly recovering my right hand, I held onto his tightly and swung his entire body up!

I clenched my jaw . “You're so heavy!”

Nie Zun's voice, on the other hand, was relaxed and carefree . “You can only blame your MF for dropping . ”

If this room had been brightly lit, I'm sure our current scene must not have looked unglamorous, but also hilarious .

I held onto him tight and swiveled him around in the air and just like a dancer twirling on a pole, Nie Zun brandished my Piercer as he whirled; no living giants could infiltrate this circular formation of ours .

As much as we couldn't see it, our imagination would suffice; within this perfectly guarded ring, any giants who approached would be sliced into halves!

Fighting against 99 giant in this space where our four other senses were compromised, creating a protective barrier in this manner was our best bet . With the circumference of safety from our enemies, we were able to attack at a distance . Otherwise, as soon as a group of giants managed to make their way near us, the both of us would surely be reduced to mush by their attacks!

Just as I was celebrating in glee at our achievement, Nie Zun yelled out a word of warning, "Careful!"

An enormous pressure pushed down towards us from overhead!

An enormous pressure pushed down towards us from overhead!

Like a metal structure free falling from the sky towards your skull, the sort of pressure was something that could be detected even with the loss of senses .

It was as though one of the giants had realized the futile efforts to get near us . From the feel of it, it must have leapt towards us from afar, striking downwards in the direction above the crown of my head!

I took a hasty step back . What should I do?!

My mind is drawing a blank!

Ah, there's no time to over think it; it wasn't like I could predict where it would land either . Increasing MF in my left hand, I maintained my vice-like grip on the traversing Nie Zun . Freeing my right hand, I held it over my head in preparation to block the incoming fall at any moment!

Even though it was impossible to stop a free falling giant with just an arm...

Thump!

The abrupt shift of my right feet seemed to have escaped the fallen giant by sheer chance! It collapsed onto the ground beside me but just by the distorted sense of hearing, I couldn't accurately discern its position .

Not giving me any chance to ponder further, Nie Zun seemed to have collided into something in mid-air .

Ah, it must be the giant!

I let Nie Zun go, knowing for sure that he would be able to defeat the giant .

There was an inexplicable understanding between Nie Zun and I; at the very moment I flung Nie Zun out, he had already whipped the Piercer towards me . The moment it touched my skin, I wound it around with the back of my hand but the Piercer didn't feel light .

I pulled, immediately understanding the reason he threw the Piercer towards me; he had already wound it around his own ankle with the other end when he did . This way, as he engaged in combat with the giant he collided into, it would prevent us from being completely separated . It would have been difficult to find each other again in this space that's obscured from our four senses .

I speedily calculated the length of my Piercer in my head and stepped back accordingly . Not only would I prevent myself from holding Nie Zun back by his ankle, I could even lend him support in this manner .

"Done!" At the sound of his voice, I immediately pulled him back .

Nie Zun returned to my side with an arm wrapped around my waist . His other hand took my Piercer from me and circled it above us with more damage than I had mustered before!

In the darkness, I blushed at the feeling of his arm firmly wrapped around my waist .

In the darkness, I blushed at the feeling of his arm firmly wrapped around my waist .

Bang, bang, bang, bang, bang!

Ahoo, ahoo, ahoo, ahoo, ahoo!

Innumerable wailing and cracking echoed from all around us .

“That should be all . ” Nie Zun’s voice was calm and composed as always; even his breathing remained steady .

I tried to pull myself away from his grip . However, not knowing if I had stepped on a pool of giant’s blood with my step back, I slipped with my attempt and fell backwards at once . My immense exhaustion of MF had also delayed my reflexes during the process!

Considering his tight grip on my waist and the Piercer in his other hand, Nie Zun didn’t seemed to have realized the impending fall either . Just like that, I pulled him down with me . With a flip of his body, his arm was trapped under my waist and I latched onto him subconsciously .

Thump!

I felt a splattering of something as I crashed onto the ground .

I must have landed in a pool of blood!

“Ahh!” I screamed, feeling Nie Zun’s presence as he fell on top of me; our skulls collided with each other and imaginary stars filled my eyes .

Are you serious? After such a long battle with those giants, I would end up getting a concussion because of Nie Zun?!?

After the collision, I turned my head to my left instinctively and his lips made contact with my right cheek . One of his arms was still trapped

underneath my body and his other seemed to have wanted to push his weight up . With the amount of blood on the floor though, all we heard was the slid of his arm .

Right as the lips that had collided against my cheek lifted, it came crashing down again from his slip . It was a coincidence when I turned back right at that moment, and our lips met .

In the darkness, the clash of our lips brought upon a surge of pain . His lips were pressed brutally against my own .

“Hm...” I screwed my eyes shut in pain . In the chaos of trying to push him off with my right arm, I had laced my fingers with the back of his head by accident .

Ah, what was supposed to be rejection turned into an invitation!

Chapter 87

87 Ta Lai's Nightmare

His lingering warmth spread across my lips and my eyes trembled in the dark . Loosening my grip on his head, I pushed him off before sitting up—like a panicked hare, the series of my action happened in mere seconds .

After getting up from my position, I stared at the darkness ahead without being able to see him .

In that same darkness, I could hear his panting breaths .

“Ah... . Accident, it was an accident . ” Lifting an arm, I scratched the back of my head awkwardly .

Before Nie Zun could even respond, I felt a tremor beneath my feet and light filled my eyes once more .

Rubbing my eyes from the sudden intrusion, I could make out the clean and lit stone room when my sight cleared . Nie Zun got up slowly from opposite me and I followed suit . Behind us, Ta Lai's voice bounced off the walls .

“Well done . You did better than I expected; I had thought you would at least get torn to shreds before making it out of there . ”

.....

As expected, you were planning to torment us!

“Since time is scarce, let's continue onto our next segment . The previous exercise displayed your perfect understanding and coordination with each other . By logic, the two of you aren't able to separate from the other, but

what if you did? I hope you'll be able to figure out what to do if you had been in that same situation on your own . ”

I met Nie Zun's eyes but neither of us spoke . For some reason, gazing into his eyes reminded me of his lips . My mind was stuck in a trance and I shook my head vigorously in attempt to return to reality .

“You'll be training alone for the next segment . ” Ta Lai began strolling around the stone room leisurely while rotating his jade ring . “Li Shen, since you have no desire to seal your split symbol, I wouldn't force it either . However, this means that you'll have to go through an even tougher training; you'll need to reach a level where unleashing normal physical attacks wouldn't require MF .

“As for Nie Zun, I don't know how far ahead you've mastered your vision techniques and it doesn't look like you plan on revealing to me too . Either way, you'll need a weapon, so I'll choose one for you . ”

Nie Zun smiled drily . “Thank you for your good intentions, but I don't fancy using weapons . ”

Ta Lai reciprocated with a smile of his own . “Trust me; you'll be satisfied with my choice . ”

Nie Zun spoke no more .

“Hey, hey, hey . Shouldn't you let us rest before the next training? I'm exhausted . You don't seriously expect us to train without pause, do you?” I yawned .

Ta Lai smiled . “You're right . After all, the both of you haven't had a peaceful rest since your arrival . Alright, let's take a break then . Don't worry; no enemies will be able to intrude this space . ”

Aren't you the enemy? What other enemies do we need intruding if you're already here? The thought filled my head before I could stop myself .

When I lifted my gaze, Ta Lai was already lying on the floor... asleep .

What the hell?

I rubbed my eyes and widened them again—is he for real? He really did fall asleep??

With his back against the ground, Ta Lai laid down with his eyes shut . His blue jacket was neatly arranged and both his hands were interlaced atop his stomach .

How... casual of him...

“Look at him, falling asleep just like this . Is he for real? There’s not a single bed in this stone room so he decided to just doze off on the ground like that?” Circling my gaze around the spacious stone room, I turned back to Nie Zun only to notice he was gone .

Eh?

I was about to speak again when my lowered gaze spotted Nie Zun by my feet . He was already lying down! In my figment of imagination, a bunch of crows yakked its way across the top of my head...

I was about to speak again when my lowered gaze spotted Nie Zun by my feet . He was already lying down! In my figment of imagination, a bunch of crows yakked its way across the top of my head...

These two...

I was frozen to the spot for a long while, watching as the two men slept as soundly as a corpse on the floor without any intention of waking . Growing bored, I rearranged my scarlet dress and began lying down as well .

I’m so exhausted...

With a yawn, I was ready to take a rest too . Despite my fatigue, however, I couldn’t fall asleep . Tilting my head towards Nie Zun, my eyes followed the soft movements of his chest as he breathed, then drifted to the strands of black hair which fluttered down the side of his face, taking in the stark contrast against his pale skin .

Without conscious awareness, the corner of my lips lifted into a slight arc . I have no idea when it started, but I seemed to have grown accustomed to his presence by my side . Now that I think about it, he had been quiet and reclusive during our first month in the split zone . Even now, I seemed to be one of the few he held a conversation with; he really didn't seem to care about anyone else .

But... Did he care about me? Am I being too narcissistic?

“Bian Ying...” In the midst of my wandering thoughts, I heard a name slipped from Ta Lai's lips .

I frowned slightly and sat up immediately . Following my movement, Nie Zun—whom I had thought was deep in slumber—shot up as well .

Supporting my weight with both palms against the ground, I shifted in the direction of Ta Lai with my perky butt . (Passerby B spoke up, “Perky butt... You're really too much...”)

As I neared Ta Lai, Nie Zun stood up and settled in a squatting position on the other side of him . His eyes seemed to be measuring up Ta Lai's sleeping form .

Ta Lai's brows were tightly knitted together, in a manner which looked as though he was having issues unknotting the troubles in his heart . His thin lips were pursed into an equally tight line; his eyes seemed to be trembling behind closed lids . Between his lips, a continuous call for “Bian Ying” poured .

“Is he dreaming?” I asked Nie Zun .

Nie Zun's gaze was stubbornly fixed on Ta Lai . “Not just any dream . I'm afraid he's dreaming about something that has been haunting him . You understand it too; our dreams in the split zone are mere memories of the past, and nightmares are obstacles that he couldn't get through . Just like that, it traps him within them .

Nie Zun's gaze was stubbornly fixed on Ta Lai . "Not just any dream . I'm afraid he's dreaming about something that has been haunting him . You understand it too; our dreams in the split zone are mere memories of the past, and nightmares are obstacles that he couldn't get through . Just like that, it traps him within them .

"Those who were more severe in these encounters might never wake up from it . "

I couldn't help pursing my lips into a tight line at the sight of Ta Lai's agonized expression . Of course I knew about the dreams in split zone—I was once trapped within the same nightmare for a whole month . If I hadn't diffused it at that time, I might have become one of those comatose bodies of consciousness atop the Academy roof .

When a body of consciousness enters the dreamscape or a coma, waking them up by force isn't an option . Similarly, if their willpower is too weak to wake on their own then they'd fall into an irreversible coma, just like their flesh bodies in real life . That was also known as the Secondary Coma; it was akin to death of their spirit .

It was why we couldn't wake Song Lu up by force when she fell into unconsciousness, and neither would we be able to if we tried . Besides, forcing it would only stir chaos in their memories . On top of the separation between our flesh body and consciousness, if the memories of our consciousness fell into chaos and our MF dipped accordingly, the consequences would be unpredictable .

"Bian Ying... Don't leave me..." Those words were spoken louder than before . I lifted my gaze and witnessed the track of tear as it cascaded from the corner of Ta Lai's eye .

I was momentarily stunned by the scene, before giving Ta Lai a careful once over .

No... I was right, my eyes weren't playing tricks on me; the man lying in front of me was indeed Ta Lai . The graceful, rational, composed Ta Lai . Yet, at this very moment, his hands were tightly interlocked together . For

the first time, his left hand wasn't rotating the jade ring on his right, and his elegant face revealed a hint of uncharacteristic sorrow and helplessness .

“Who's Bian Ying? Have you heard of them?” I asked Nie Zun .

Nie Zun shook his head . “Never . From the looks of it, however, I suppose they were his lover . ”

Lover...?

As though sensitive to the word, Gao Qi's face surfaced from the depths of my mind at once and when he did, so did another .

Gaoqin Jiuye .

... What am I thinking about?

In my trance, I lifted my head subconsciously and met Nie Zun's eyes . He didn't blink; his gaze remained fixated on mine . I grew flustered by his stare, and retracted both my arms which had been supporting my weight without knowing where else to place them .

... What am I thinking about?

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“Why are you staring at me?” Eventually, I settled on smoothing my hair .

Nie Zun responded casually as always, “What are you thinking about?”

“N-nothing . ” I dropped my gaze then extended a hand towards Ta Lai's forehead despite how naive the action was—illnesses like fever or a cold didn't exist in the world of split zone .

“Gaoqin Jiuye isn't Gao Qi . ” All of a sudden, Nie Zun spoke up coldly . His gaze left me and began darting around the stone room without focus .

I didn't understand why he brought that up with me or why he thought it necessary . I frowned once more .

In the end, his attention fell back to me . A tinge of frustration flickered in his eyes when he stretched his arm in my direction and squeezed my shoulder . I stared as his lips moved without a sound, waiting for unexpected words to escape them in the heat of the moment .

During the split second when our eyes met, he chose not to say anything at all . Instead, he released his grip on me, his eyes turned vacant . My eyes drooped, finding myself at a sudden loss of what to say .

“Bian Ying!” Ta Lai screamed out abruptly and like his eyes, his hands were beginning to tremble as well .

I reached out my hands and pressed against his shoulders in haste . “What should we do? Will something happen to him with such severe emotional exposure?”

Emotional exposure refers to the moment when troubles we have kept bottled up escape during a dream . They can happen in manners like screaming and shouting, or even sleepwalking .

Nie Zun shook his head . “I can't guarantee that nothing will happen to him, but it is indeed dangerous for him to continue this way . ”

“Exactly . With such strong emotional exposure, it must mean that he's been tied down by his nightmare . If this dream of his is recurring back-to-back, then it could cause him direct harm . As a soul splitter, could he not escape the manifestation of dreams either? Does that mean no one can escape it in the split zone?”

Nie Zun's eyes gleamed suddenly at that thought . “That's right . Perhaps dreamscape is just another dimension . If that hypothesis holds true, then could the dreamscape in this split zone coincide with that of our flesh body's, providing us with a way to escape from here?”

Chapter 88

88 Full Spectrum of Training

I didn't quite understand the meaning behind Nie Zun's words but this was no time to ponder; at the sight of Ta Lai's agonized expression, I waved a hand at Nie Zun in hurry . "That's not important right now . Ta Lai is our main concern . We can't possibly leave him like this; we can forget about getting out of here if he doesn't wake . "

"Let me try . " Nie Zun shifted over and removed the black glove on his left hand unhurriedly . Lifting Ta Lai's right hand, he weaved their fingers together .

"Wh—what are you doing?"

Nie Zun's reply was calm, "With the combination of my hand and MF, it will provoke a reaction from his body of consciousness . I'll try to see if it could affect the consciousness in his dream . "

I stared at Nie Zun's hand and fell deep in ponder .

To be honest, I've always been curious about that hand of his . I had no idea he had drowned it into chemicals and turned it into the devil's hand during this time . All I had ever known, was that he didn't remove his gloves often, and neither had he ever touched me with his bare hands .

Now that I found out about the secret of his printless palms and the ability it had after he soaked them, I grew even more curious .

There was a vague prickling sensation when we touched, as though it could assault my heart through the point of our contact—at least, that was what I felt at the moment we touched, but I knew he hadn't manipulated any MF .

What about those people who had come into contact with his hands when they were infused with MF then? How did they feel?

I could take a guess on how terrible it must feel just from the expression on Mi Fu's face when he clasped his hand around her neck, and from the kid back in that stone room of experiments—maybe it really is the devil's hand .

Even if that is so, I was still like a moth fluttering towards the flame; I still wanted to touch those hands of his . As if I've been entranced by the sight, I reached out my hand slowly towards his .

Just as I was about to touch him, Ta Lai bellowed out of the blue, "Return Bian Ying to me!"

Taken aback by the unexpected outburst, I retracted my hand subconsciously . When I snuck a glimpse at Nie Zun, nothing seemed to indicate that he realized my movement from before . His eyes were focused on Ta Lai .

"He's in bad shape . " Nie Zun frowned ever so slightly .

I turned to Ta Lai at once; his face was scrunched tightly with beads of sweat glistening across his forehead . His lips were pale and quivering .

I gave his body a light push . "Ta Lai... Ta Lai, can you hear me?"

Nie Zun shook his head . "It's no use; even my hand wasn't able to affect him . I'm afraid he has sunken into deep coma . We'll need to find a way to wake him immediately, although I don't know if it'll work . "

"If he had always been this way in his sleep, then there must be a way to wake him . Maybe we should trust in his willpower . "

It was at that moment when Nie Zun's eyes darted swiftly to the jade ring on Ta Lai's finger, as though he reached an epiphany .

Letting go of the hand he was holding on to, Nie Zun's slender fingers turned the ring which Ta Lai donned . Like a mechanism set in place, the

shaking form of Ta Lai calmed down in an instant and his frown began smoothing out as well . His breathing returned to its stable pace .

I breathed a sigh of relief . “What kind of mystical power does that jade ring have?”

“I don’t know either but he always had a tendency of turning it, so I thought to give it a try . ”

Witnessing his breathing stabilizing to normal, I shook his shoulders gently . “Ta Lai?”

No response .

“I’m sure he’s fine . He will wake up once the tension in him dissipates . Don’t worry . ”

I nodded .

It wasn’t long before Ta Lai roused from his slumber . The graceful and calm expression returned to Ta Lai as he sat up, wide awake after his rest as though nothing happened . As if he was oblivious to what happened just moments prior . “Have you both had enough rest?”

Please, we didn’t catch a single wink of sleep in order to take care of you...

Still, watching his oblivion towards the nightmare, I didn’t bring it up .

Still, watching his oblivion towards the nightmare, I didn’t bring it up .

“Li Shen, the training we’re going to embark on next will be targeted at your physical fitness . The objective of this is to ensure you don’t expend any MF when using your physical force . I’ll send out another ten of those giants which had immense strength and speed .

“However, I have my own limitations to MF usage as well and it takes a lot of time to craft those puppet giants; most of them had been destroyed by both of you . Hence, I’m going to send out only ten this time and your mission is to defeat them without using any MF . ”

Huh? Defeat ten giants without using any MF? You might as well tell those giants to beat me to pulp .

Without giving me the chance to object, Ta Lai turned to Nie Zun . “I’ve changed my mind about your training . From the strength you’ve transmitted earlier, I thought of something more suitable for you . Please follow me in a while . ”

Astonished by his words, my question spilled, “You knew about what happened earlier?”

Ta Lai flashed an easy smile . “My nightmares are a common occurrence, but the severity of it had been beyond my expectation . I felt the prickling sensation on my hand in the depths of my subconscious earlier .

“Logically speaking, I should be invincible in my own dreams, that’s how I derived to the conclusion that the pain must have been caused by factors beyond my dream . It was because of this realization that I grew lucid in the nightmare, allowing myself to escape it without much time spent . The only one who could make that happen must be Nie Zun . With your current control of MF, you won’t be able to achieve that yet . ”

I grew evidently indignant . Who are you belittling, huh?

However, changing my line of thought, didn’t what he said meant that he was able to rid himself of the nightmare in shorter time because of Nie Zun’s help? So... even without Nie Zun’s help, he would still have been able to wake on his own?

Then what the hell were the two of us so worried about?!

Ta Lai had already stood back up in the midst of my annoyance . “Nie Zun, take a stroll with me . Don’t worry, we won’t be more than 500 metres away from her . Li Shen, why don’t you stay here and play with the giants?”

He didn’t even give me time to gather myself . With a wave of his hand, ten of those giants lined up at the corner of the stone room! I swallowed the lump in my throat . It was fortunate that the stone room was huge, equipped

with a high ceiling . Otherwise, these ten giants would be enough to congest this space!

“Hey, hey!”

Ignoring my calls, Ta Lai leapt towards the darkness above with Nie Zun in tow and disappeared .

Ignoring my calls, Ta Lai leapt towards the darkness above with Nie Zun in tow and disappeared .

How... very spontaneous...

Speechless, I turned towards the giants who were preying on me while baring their teeth . I berated, “Who do you think you’re looking at, huh? You—Yes, you! What are you drooling about? I’m not your food, or are you greedying over my beauty? Even so, you’re not allowed to drool!”

In the face of those giants, I was basically speaking to myself with wild gestures—none of them were even listening to me! Instead, they charged at me without hesitance!

“Hey, hey, hey! Aren’t you going to give me some time to prepare? Hey!”

.....

By the time Ta Lai and Nie Zun had returned, they were greeted by the sight of me on the ground—completely drained of energy—and a pile of broken corpses which littered all around .

Ta Lai lifted his perfectly straight legs in an elegant posture and walked towards me without avoiding the blood on the ground . As the splattering sound of blood against sole echoed, a trail of bloody footprints made its way to me .

“Not bad at all . You felt the increase in your strength, right?” Ta Lai pointed at the floor of ‘giants’ around us . “I’ve already programmed them earlier; this training must have been really beneficial to you . ”

I rolled my eyes, unable to muster any strength for a response .

“Alright . The next crucial aspect is to train your control of MF; we’ll conduct the new training back in Western District . ”

As he spoke, Ta Lai clapped his hands . The broken pieces on the ground vanished and the giants returned to its shrunken, wooden form, leaving a pool of fresh blood behind .

“Let’s go, I’ll bring you there . ”

With that, Ta Lai turned the jade ring on his finger and a previously non-existent door appeared on the stone wall .

I no longer had the energy to be surprised by these things . With a slump of my head, I broke my silence as I regarded Nie Zun’s gleaming eyes—they looked as though he was ready to crack a joke about me anytime . “Can’t you read the situation better? Hurry and help me up . ”

Nie Zun smiled . As he approached, he withdrew a hand from the pocket of his windbreaker and extended it towards me .

I no longer had the energy to be surprised by these things . With a slump of my head, I broke my silence as I regarded Nie Zun’s gleaming eyes—they looked as though he was ready to crack a joke about me anytime . “Can’t you read the situation better? Hurry and help me up . ”

Nie Zun smiled . As he approached, he withdrew a hand from the pocket of his windbreaker and extended it towards me .

I inhaled a deep breath when we returned to the boundary forest of Western District .

“Phew, the past few days had been suffocating underground! Speaking of, why is the boundary forest the only area that’s not affected by the ruins? Ta Lai, hurry up and spit it out—how long have you been secretly building those two stone rooms?

Stretching my limbs, I turned my head upwards to the grey, overcast sky . It had coincidentally been day time when we came up; after such a long time underground, I've lost track of time .

“If you have time to wonder about this, then why don't you ponder about how to manipulate your MF instead?” Ta Lai smiled .

“I can manipulate MF into my moves now though! Witness it for yourself if you don't believe me . ” I pulled out my Piercer and poured MF into it . With a horizontal flick of my whip, a powerful Violet Blade struck forth, rushing towards the trees ahead!

Crack, crack, crack!

The trees were easily snapped into half by my tackle!

Yet, Ta Lai merely shook his head . “This isn't manipulating your MF . You struck with your MF, and so your MF will only return to you at the conclusion of the move . The time taken for it to return is too long, and you'll need to protect yourself during combat as well . Hence, you wouldn't be able to manipulate too much MF at one go . This isn't the best way to fight . ”

I tilted my head . “What do you think I should do then?”

Ta Lai smiled . “Humans fight with their bodies; their flesh body and consciousness can't be separated . This is the reason why your consciousness in the split zone takes the shape of your flesh body even though it had been forcefully separated . You display combat moves through the functions of your body, and so, you should be able to increase your strength just by the use of MF . ”

Seeing my look of bewilderment, Ta Lai raised a hand . “For example, you can increase the strength of your wrist with MF . Focus 80% of your MF on your wrist and the muscle fibre on your hand at the instant you whip your Piercer . Try it; increase the strength and speed of your wrist before using your Piercer . ”

Even though I was still unsure, I followed his instructions . Lifting my hand, I attempted to manipulate my MF before striking my Piercer again!

Chapter 89

89 The Living Weapon

Crack! Rumble!

Three whole rows of trees collapsed!

“Wow! What great strength indeed!” I exclaimed in surprise as I rolled my left wrist around .

On the contrary, Ta Lai shook his head with a smile . “It’s still too weak; it’s evident that your precision at MF isn’t too strong . Song Lu was still better in this aspect . ”

At the thought of Song Lu, my head drooped in silence . Song Lu’s precision and control of MF was well known in Western District . She had once taught it to me too, but I was always too distracted to learn .

“Your body in the split form is a translation of your consciousness . In other words, one’s precision can reach a point where you would be able to sense and change every single cell in your body; that’s a form of superpower in itself . Hence, such degree of precision for the function of your body and MF can have a direct impact on the strength of attack you unleash . Just like creating a form of technique with MF, it uses your liking for the type of technique to invent it .

“Take the enchanted shield for example; such thing didn’t exist in the real world, but it was possible to craft it in the split zone through the meticulous control over MF . It requires you to understand the principles of its physics, and use it with the manipulation of its molecules .

“Of course, you must first have enough capacity of imagination to craft it; the core of MF is your mental strength and in layman terms, the techniques within split zone are basically imagination—whatever your brain can invent will be possible in the split zone . It goes without saying that imagination would require precise control over MF . ”

I rolled my wrist again and felt the flow of MF as my blood fused itself with it .

“Precision, that’s what you have to take note of . Other than that, as you’re working on converging your MF, you can inject a portion of it into your Piercer as well . The Piercer is different from just any other weapon; if you are able to wield it right, it can achieve great damage potential . ”

“Oh?” I tried to shift my MF and raised the Piercer again . Ta Lai gestured for me to hold .

“Do you not know about the Piercer?”

“What about it? Are you talking about it being a murder weapon, or that it brings misfortune upon its owner?” I brandished the Piercer .

“No . ” Ta Lai shook his head . “I guess you have no idea . In that case, let me explain it briefly .

“There are two categories to the weapons in split zone: the Living and the Dead . Most of those you see are dead weapons; they’re the most common . Similarly, there are only a handful of weapons that are called living weapons . ”

“Living weapons?” I asked in curiosity . I’ve never heard of such a phrase . Nie Zun’s eyes shone as well, indicating that this was the first for him too .

Ta Lai nodded . “Living weapons are just as it sounds; they’re weapons which are “alive” . They are made from a part of the consciousness . ”

I was baffled . “What do you mean? It’s made from a part of the consciousness?”

“That means, if a body of consciousness used a part of themselves and infused their MF to create a weapon before they died, then the weapon becomes “alive” due to the inclusion of consciousness . However, these weapons are difficult to craft and it’s difficult to maintain the performance of consciousness after their death in the split zone . Hence, most people transfer a portion of their MF into the weapon before they get murdered . In simpler terms, they sealed a part of their soul into the weapon . ”

This means... I’m carrying someone’s soul in this Piercer?

As if he read my mind, Ta Lai nodded his head slightly . “The reason for the horrifying rumor behind your Piercer is because it was made from the skin and fresh blood of a person!”

What?!

What?!

I lifted the Piercer and ran my fingers along the Pierce’s handle, no longer feeling the same excitement I had once upon time . Instead, a feeling of fear drowned me .

“I don’t know much about the Piercer . In any case, putting aside the curse of this Piercer and the potential of it backfiring on its user due to the remnants of consciousness, it is still a great weapon in combat . Even so, the prerequisite is that you’ll have to be good enough to wield it . In the split zone, there are only three other weapons that had a name—‘Leopard’s Claw’, ‘Shen Qi’ and ‘Seal’ . ”

“Where are the other three?” Nie Zun interjected .

Ta Lai rotated the jade ring, his eyes flickering . “I don’t know where ‘Seal’ and ‘Leopard’s Claw’ are, but ‘Shen Qi’ is the personal weapon of Southern District’s Gaoqin Jiuye . ”

My eyes snapped towards him at once . “Gaoqin Jiuye’s personal weapon? That black, long and flexible sword?”

Ta Lai flashed a mystifying smile . “You know him?”

My lips twitched . “You’ve already found out so much about me, are you really trying to imply that you have no idea I’ve met him?”

“I know you did . From what I heard from Zou An, it seems as though the relationship between you and Gaoqin Jiuye isn’t as simple as we thought . I’m really curious; you’ve never seen him before, so how did you two get tangled together without reason? I’m not the only one who’s puzzled; there are others who didn’t understand either . That’s the reason why I’m asking you in person . ”

I continued staring at him . “There’s nothing between us, no secrets nor any entanglement; you’ve all been thinking too much about it . ”

Ta Lai smiled knowingly . “I guess you aren’t willing to explain it to me . That’s fine, I don’t know much about what happened between you two . All I know are the reason and motives behind the major incidents of the three districts, and it wasn’t as mysterious as you thought . Since you don’t wish to talk about it, then I won’t ask anymore either . That said, I must remind you that Gaoqin Jiuye isn’t as simple as you imagined him to be; it’ll be better for you to stay cautious when it comes to him . ”

Not as simple as I imagined him to be...?

Not as simple as I imagined him to be...?

Ehehe, I’ve never thought him as simple . Ta Lai wasn’t the first person who advised me about staying careful about him, right? And him? His behaviour and attitude had always been worthy of being cautious against, right? Whether it was the coldness and maliciousness that lurked behind his expressions, or the way he operated without hesitation . Still, he looked exactly like Gao Qi and now, even his personal weapon was named ‘Shen Qi’—am I supposed to just ignore that?

No, I can’t . Since I don’t know the secret to split zone, anything is possible . I’ll never believe that his resemblance to Gao Qi is a mere coincidence! But, as much as I know he’s a dangerous figure, if he had even the slightest

inkling of relationship with Gao Qi, then I would still have to face him at some point .

Regardless of the excuses or reasons, Gao Qi was someone I've loved and admired . Even if I realized I had known nothing about him through my recollection of memories, I am still adamant about finding out what happened between us before I stabbed him!

My instincts told me that only split zone would be able to return that memory to me; only Gaoqin Jiuye would be able to give me that!

"I understand . " I nodded .

"The fact that you're agreeing to it this calmly makes me even more worried . Li Shen, you're not someone who's capable of being calm and logical . " Ta Lai spoke unhurriedly .

I sneered . "How did you know so much about me anyway? Enough to know that I'm not someone who's calm or logical? Ta Lai, maybe all of you had read too much into me!"

Ehehe, no matter how superior you are in the split zone, have you ever murdered someone in your previous lives? Have any of you murdered the person you loved? I'm a demon with double identity disorder, that's a fact . What was there for my illogical and frantiness tendencies to change?"

"Alright . Whatever it is, remember what I told you: be careful of him . Now, then, let's return back to the topic at hand . Your Piercer and his Shen Qi are both well-known living weapons . Still, your knowledge and control of the Piercer is of no match to Gaoqin Jiuye . I hope that you'll be able to interact with your MF even without having the use for it; don't treat it as a weapon but a person . Perhaps you will be able to conquer it in the end .

"The ability of the Piercer is far beyond what you see now . If you can conquer it and the rumored backlash, then you'll be able to eliminate opponents on You Ji's level even without sealing your split symbol . " Ta Lai added .

I nodded . “About the precise manipulation of MF, I’ve tried to sense it again earlier . Even if I couldn’t interact with the Piercer immediately, I believe with practice and your guidance, I can at least reach a breakthrough on its usage . ”

“Alright, let’s practice more than . Before we start, there’s another thing I must clarify . ”

I nodded . “About the precise manipulation of MF, I’ve tried to sense it again earlier . Even if I couldn’t interact with the Piercer immediately, I believe with practice and your guidance, I can at least reach a breakthrough on its usage . ”

“Alright, let’s practice more than . Before we start, there’s another thing I must clarify . ”

I looked at him and exhibited that I’m all ears .

“Even though you’ve not sealed your split symbol and so controlling a technique would be tough, but I hope you’ll be able to breakthrough your limits and adopt one that’s suitable for you . Using the technique you created, it can increase your precision with MF manipulation . ”

Technique?

If it’s as Ta Lai mentioned, the ‘technique’ in this split zone is a combination of imagination and abilities . That means to say, ‘technique’ in itself had no limitations, whether it was You Ji’s duplication, Jie Pa’ enchanted shield, or Nie Zun’s sight . Those were all combinations of imagination and abilities but from the looks of it, it isn’t as easy as it seems . It must be a difficult feat to convert imagination into reality through MF .

“There are a lot of techniques; my distortion and illusions are a form of space manipulation technique . The illusions within split zone aren’t similar to those you read in books; there’s a limitation of range here when you use MF to change in that space . My distortion technique works the same way, creating or changing certain range of space . The enchanted boundary shield

and sight are different as well . There are many variations to it, depending on what suits you . ”

What suits me...?

Why are ‘money-making’ and ‘turn me into a beauty’ techniques the first that came to mind?

Alright, alright . I’m just kidding...

But... what kind of technique would suit me?

“There’s no rush; everything still depends on your ability to control MF . After all, imagination is just a part of the creation process . Let’s focus on practicing your control of MF and the use of Piercer for now . ” Ta Lai concluded .

Chapter 90

90 Meeting You Ji Again

Boom!

I watched with satisfaction as a plot of trees collapsed with just a single-handed stroke of Violet Blade .

“Such meagre improvement after this many days of practice; you’re practically a pig . ” Nie Zun’s lazy voice sounded from behind me .

Turning back, I rolled my eyes towards Nie Zun who had just returned from his solo training with Ta Lai .

Ta Lai was right behind him, an arm behind his back . His smile was calm . “It’s good news as long as there’s an inkling of improvement . It means that your hard work wasn’t for nothing; you’ve finally learned to control your MF . ”

“Oh, that’s right, Ta Lai . I remembered something . I’ve seen Jiao S and Gaoqin Jiuye manipulating airflow; is that the same as this precise usage of MF?”

Ta Lai shook his head . “No, that’s not the case . To use abilities involving natural elements, you have to have an even more meticulous control over MF and on top of that, have extrasensory about these elements . For someone who hadn’t sealed their split symbol, this would be a difficult feat .

“What you need to do now is to strengthen your control over MF, then combine that with the Piercer in your hand . That would be enough . Piercer

is a living weapon; if you view and treat him as you would to a person, as a helper, you'd eventually understand its abilities . ”

I nodded .

“Ehehe... Ah, I was just wondering what happened to Western District . So it seems that you've found someone to help you, Li Shen . ” A familiar voice trailed from behind us .

Before I could even turn back to have a look, my eyes had already turned cold .

Turning back slowly, the Piercer in my hand swayed lightly with my movements . In the face of this unexpected intruder, I sneered . “You're pretty quick, You Ji . Were you done being another's lapdog this early, enough to be able to check up on the condition of this little place you have robbed?”

You Ji who had slithered into the forest without our knowledge, squinted her eyes at me . “Ah, how can you put it that way? I'm here to check if you're still alive . Aren't I just concerned about your well-being? After all, I've placed the Seven Demons here to welcome you, haven't I?”

There was an aching in my heart at her words . You Ji, did you hate me this much? To the extent where you would place your most elite subordinates to kill me?

You Ji's eyes swept from me to Nie Zun, before landing on Ta Lai who remained behind .

You Ji flashed a malicious smile . “Ta Lai... Li Shen, are you really relying on this insignificant Floor Manager to back you? Is he the reason you are able to speak this savagely?”

Ta Lai smiled gracefully and snapped his fingers with the hand behind his back .

Bang!

A roar reverberated from all around us; a huge, five-metres tall giant appeared right by You Ji, charging towards her as it snarled!

There was a shift in You Ji's expression and a glint in her eyes . "It seems I've underestimated you all this while, Ta Lai .

"But are you really trying to scare me with a party trick like this? Aren't you belittling me?!" The moment her words sounded, she snickered . Following the twist of her waist, the serpent-like tail of hers grew several-fold thicker without warning! The tip of it spiralled as she flung it towards the bellowing giant!

Despite the gigantic size of her tail, her movement was swift . Without much time, it coiled itself around the giant . As her gaze steeled, she crushed the giant into smithereens with just another twist .

"How dirty . " Lifting a jade hand, she swiped it across her bloodied face, emotionless .

Ta Lai maintained his smile, reaching out his other hand as it rotated the jade ring on his pinky . "You Ji, you've been allowed to run wild with your impertinence for far too long . I truly don't understand why you'd entangle yourself with a soul splitter . "

Ta Lai maintained his smile, reaching out his other hand as it rotated the jade ring on his pinky . "You Ji, you've been allowed to run wild with your impertinence for far too long . I truly don't understand why you'd entangle yourself with a soul splitter . "

You Ji rolled her eyes . "Oh? What are you talking about? I don't understand? Who are you talking about?"

Ta Lai's gaze wandered . "You're doing this for Mr Blond?"

You Ji's eyes widened abruptly . "Nonsense!"

I furrowed my brows ever so slightly . Why did You Ji react this strongly at the mention of Mr Blond?

You Ji shot a vicious glare at me . “I’m not doing this for anyone . I’m doing it simply because I think she’s unworthy!”

“Worthy or not, I’m afraid you’re not one to judge!” I gritted my teeth but a hint of sorrow swept across my heart . We had been sisters for a long time after all; the difference in her attitude towards me was too drastic . I really couldn’t bring myself to accept it .

You Ji sneered . “Li Shen, you’re ridiculous indeed . How did you treat the people who were nothing but nice to you since your arrival to split zone? You’re holding a grudge against me just because I wasn’t willing to be part of those who protected you foolishly? But do you even have a right to? What right do you have to expect that we’d always protect you? Who have you even regarded important in your eyes?”

“You claimed that there were many who protected me, but haven’t there been others who stayed by your side too?” I countered .

A scornful smile tugged at the corner of You Ji’s lips . “Many favored you despite how strongly you’ve always came across . Li Qing had been blind to have favored such a useless person like you . ”

“No matter how useless she is, at least she wouldn’t conspire with an outsider to plunge Western District into the state it is today . ” Night Zun sounded indifferent when he interjected .

You Ji scoffed again . “Nie Zun, clarify yourself; who are you trying to imply as the cause of Western District’s plight? The reason I’m back here was precisely because I’ve lost contact with Seven Demons . Never had I ever thought that I would return to the sight of this horrifying ruins . Did you think I was the culprit? It’s true that I hate Li Shen, but did that mean that I didn’t wish for a good life for the residents of Western District?

“In fact, this was something I had wanted to ask . How is it that Western District was reduced to this state the moment you returned?” You Ji pointed a finger towards the district which laid behind her . “Old Man Fan was turned into a statue, the entire district is now in ruins . Li Shen, how long more are you going to curse this place?”

“In fact, this was something I had wanted to ask . How is it that Western District was reduced to this state the moment you returned?” You Ji pointed a finger towards the district which laid behind her . “Old Man Fan was turned into a statue, the entire district is now in ruins . Li Shen, how long more are you going to curse this place?”

“This wasn’t my doing, so how am I the one who cursed it? I heard you had planted various forms of ambush in waiting of my return and yet Western District was reduced to this . How do I know if you’re not behind this in order to frame me?”

“Li Shen, I’m not someone who would deny my own doings . I was the one who plotted for someone to replace Laurel in order for you to believe in her death . The death of those B ranking officers in Eastern District was also executed by my Seven Demons . I’m also the one who sent someone to kill Ah Wen, in order for Zou An to bear a grudge against you . I was the one who sent someone to assassinate you while you were in the dormitory at Eastern District too . I admit I have done all those things but this—the state of Western District—is not on me . ”

My frown deepened . “You did all of that just because of your hatred towards me?”

You Ji flashed a cruel smile . “That’s right . I wanted to sow discord between you and Jiao S, wanted everyone to leave you . Li Qing is no longer here to witness your incompetence so I should at least make Mr Blond understand that you, Li Shen, do not have the right to be a district commander! Even so, I had not once expected you to collude with someone like Jiao S! Yet, I guess it’s true that birds of the same feather flock together!”

I sneered . “Birds of the same feather? You are able to collude and conduct experiments with soul splitters, take Song Lu and Yu Liang away from us, and hurt everyone who used to be your friend in Western District—and you dare regard yourself as a good person?”

You Ji brows furrowed in that second . “Take Song Lu away? There was a little accident when Song Lu and Yu Liang were chosen; I had wanted to

teach you a lesson, and demonstrate the consequences of your negligence over those who protected you . But, didn't you take Song Lu away? She's a failed experiment, yet you had forcefully taken her away . Now, you're blaming it on me the moment she's showing signs of trouble? How truly expected from you!"

Furious, I took a long stride forward . "What are you talking about? Taken away by me? You had that soul splitter Du Yue on your side, and eventually sent Li Wen to snatch Song Lu away from us! Both you and Li Wen had been my best friends but both of you betrayed me; do you have a conscience then? Li Wen had been Li Qing's soul splitter, and there's a possibility that Li Qing disappeared because of her—did you know about that? If you had colluded with her despite knowing that, then have you done right by Li Qing?"

A flicker of surprise flashed across You Ji's eyes . "When did Du Yue send Li Wen after Song Lu? After soul snatcher, Rong Jin, and I separated from you, we went to look for Laurel, and Du Yue took Mi Fu to see Si Luo . How would she send Li Wen after you? Besides, wasn't Li Wen missing? I've never seen her since her disappearance!"

Just as I froze at her words, Ta Lai frowned and posed his own question to me . "You've met Li Wen?"

I nodded my head blankly . "I met her in Southern District and she took Song Lu away . Her blood composition was distorted in the same way as Song Lu, with the ability to harm the body of consciousness . She said she was forced to follow the orders of Du Yue whom you spoke of . "

A sharp glint flickered in Ta Lai's eyes . "Her blood?"

You Ji seemed to have exclaimed at the exact same time . "Her blood?"

Dazed, I took turns to look at both of them . "Why are you both so shocked?"

You Ji seemed to have exclaimed at the exact same time . "Her blood?"

Dazed, I took turns to look at both of them . “Why are you both so shocked?”

You Ji frowned . “Do you really need me to repeat myself? I’ve never seen Li Wen, and it’s impossible that she was sent by Du Yue!”

Ta Lai lowered his head in deep ponder before speaking to me once more . “There’s something fishy about this . Li Wen wouldn’t form an alliance with Du Yue . ”

My frown deepened . “She claimed that she was taken away by Du Yue to become an experiment subject; Du Yue had wanted to see the effects of these experiments on a soul splitter . As a soul splitter, didn’t you know about Li Wen?”

You Ji exclaimed in shock once more, “Ta Lai, you’re a soul splitter?”

My hand flew up to cover my mouth . Crap, I had forgotten that You Ji wasn’t aware of this .

Ta Lai waved his hand at me, indicating that all was well . “That’s right . I’m a soul splitter . But... How did I not know that Li Wen was a soul splitter too?”

I stilled from shock at his words .

You Ji continued after him, “And didn’t you just say that Li Wen was Li Qing’s soul splitter? How could that be? Wasn’t Li Qing murdered by Jiao S?”

I furrowed my brows at her . “Jiao S murdered Li Qing? You would believe such a statement?”

“At the very least, Jiao S must have had a part to play about Li Qing’s deteriorating health and eventual disappearance . Li Wen had gone missing during at that time . How could you be so sure that Jiao S had nothing to do with it?”

Nie Zun, who remained quiet thus far, chuckled lightly . “Even if all of it had something to do with her, do you even care? You Ji, do you even care about the life or death of Li Qing and Li Wen?”

Chapter 91

91 Too Much of a Bully?!

You Ji locked her cold gaze on Nie Zun . “I hate this about the both of you, always thinking that you are kind and good, while everyone else is heartless and evil . I care about Li Qing and Li Wen no less than Li Shen does!”

“What’s important is that Li Wen definitely has no connection with Du Yue, I’m very certain of this,” Ta Lai said .

“What makes you so sure? Just because you are a soul splitter?” You Ji raised her brows .

Ta Lai smiled . “Not only am I a soul splitter, I know Du Yue’s intention, and I also know your intention . ”

Seeing You Ji’s icy stare, Ta Lai’s gaze shifted towards me . “I’m not sure about Li Wen’s situation and the specifics, but I am certain that Du Yue’s experiment should not involve Li Wen . ”

My heart sank . Does this mean that Li Wen was acting solely on her own?

Then, why would she be suitable as an experimental subject? Why must she take Song Lu away?

Song Lu...

I looked toward Nie Zun in a panic . Nie Zun gave me a slight nod, trying to tell me not to worry .

He then addressed Ta Lai, “Seems like Li Wen is acting alone, she took Song Lu away . ”

You Ji sneered, “Didn’t think there would be such an unexpected reward . Right, Rong Jin?”

I snapped alert, looking around me immediately .

Ta Lai narrowed his gaze .

A gust of wind suddenly whipped up around us . I had already cut down many of the trees in this forest, and the few left standing in the distance were rustling in the wind .

“Kekekekekeke, that’s right, didn’t think we’d hear about Li Wen here . ”

An eerie laughter rang out from the distant forest, and a familiar, ghostly voice floated towards us .

I shivered . I remember this extremely disturbing voice . It belonged to the Southern District’s Soul Snatcher, Rong Jin .

You Ji’s gaze seemed much calmer now . She looked mildly perturbed when facing the three of us alone, but she seemed to have recovered her charm and grace . Stroking her head of green hair, she asked, “Since you’re here, why not show yourself? Aren’t you curious how the Western District turned into a pile of rubble?”

The ghostly voice said leisurely, “To know the secret behind the ruins, one would have to go back into the ruins . Hahahahaha...”

A series of ‘hahas’ that did not sound like genuine laughter sounded from a distance and entered my ears, before floating further away like an echo, making me extremely uncomfortable .

You Ji’s cold gaze lingered on me for a second, before turning back suddenly . “Let’s have a look then . ”

Moving her serpentine tail, she looked back and smiled wickedly at me . “How about you, Li Shen, do you want to have a look? Because of whom did the Western District become like this?”

After saying that, she slid towards the direction of the Western District .

I looked back to meet Ta Lai and Nie Zun's eyes, and the three of us quickly followed .

When we arrived back at Old Man Fan's statue, there was a shadow on the ground, right at the bottom of the statue .

I stared at the shadow . "Rong Jin?"

The shadow quivered slightly, and there was a creepy laughter . "It's me, crazy girl . "

All the hairs on my body stood on ends . Could you stop making it sound like we are close? If I remember right, you and I are enemies, right?

All the hairs on my body stood on ends . Could you stop making it sound like we are close? If I remember right, you and I are enemies, right?

A ghostly voice sounded above the ghostly shadow, "Crazy girl, was the Western District already in this shape when you first arrived back here?"

I furrowed my brows . "Why should I have to answer you?"

"Heeheehee, crazy girl is crazy . Not very obedient either . "

Following the creepy 'heeheehee', there was a flurry of icy wind above the vast expanse of rubble .

Finding it a little odd, I looked up in confusion .

I quickly realised why it felt odd . As I lifted my head, I saw a crack suddenly appearing in the sky!

"Ahwoo! Ahwoo! Ahwoo!"

Three ferocious wolves with shiny bright green eyes swiftly jumped out from that crack in the sky!

Slightly alarmed, I quickly backed away while keeping my eyes trained on the three wolves .

You Ji looked over and moved to be behind those three wolves, sliding over with her serpentine tail .

“Crazy girl, come on, be good . Tell me, why did the Western District become like this?” The ghostly voice rang out again .

I stared at the three wolves opposite . Together with these wolves were a snake woman and a dark shadow – it was a really weird combination .

“I already said, I don’t know what happened in the Western District . I’m even more curious about this than all of you . ”

The ghostly voice laughed . “I travelled so far to be here, because I heard that a phenomenon never before seen in the Split Zone happened in the Western District . During this time, only the few of you were here . Do you think I would believe you when you say this has nothing to do with you?”

The ghostly voice laughed . “I travelled so far to be here, because I heard that a phenomenon never before seen in the Split Zone happened in the Western District . During this time, only the few of you were here . Do you think I would believe you when you say this has nothing to do with you?”

I smiled mirthlessly . “Why are outsiders like you so interested in the Western District? As a subordinate of the Southern District’s Si Luo, aren’t you reaching too far into others’ affairs! After betraying your commander, are you trying to make an enemy out of me too?”

The ghostly voice boomed with laughter . “Crazy girl, don’t be petulant . Who said I betrayed Si Luo?”

“If you didn’t betray Si Luo, why are you in cahoots with Du Yue working on some shady experiment? Even if you did not betray Si Luo, you are always hiding and dodging people . I’m pretty sure you are not a good person either,” I said callously .

“Crazy girl, seeing that it hasn’t even been two years since you assumed the position of District Commander, you really haven’t seen enough of the world . Hahahahahahaha . ”

This ghostly sound continued grating on my ears to the point that I wanted to cover them with my hands .

Contemptuously, I said, “It doesn’t matter how long I’ve been District Commander . As long as someone infringes upon my territory, I will not let them get away easily!”

You Ji smirked and pointed to the ground . “Don’t speak too soon . We didn’t infringe upon your territory, it was you who couldn’t keep it safe, and it even got destroyed . ”

“This is none of your business . Are you here because you are worried about Western District matters?”

As Rong Jin’s dark shadow wobbled, a chuckle came out from the ground . “Crazy girl, I’m not interested in your Western District territory . I’m here to get three items from you . ”

I laughed . “Would I have any items that can drive you, the soul snatcher, to travel this far to obtain?”

The ghostly voice scoffed, “Yes, you have them . I want that woman named Song Lu, the little girl called Laurel, and also this old man from your district . ”

The shadow moved to Old Man Fan’s statue at the mention of ‘old man’ .

I burst out laughing so hard that my eyes were about to tear . “Are you kidding me? You guys took Song Lu and Laurel away in front of my very eyes, and now you are asking for them? It might also be because of you that Old Man Fan is like this, and you even want his corpse now?? Do you really think that I, Li Shen, am an easy target to bully?!”

I stared angrily . As I concentrated all my MF into my meridian channels and blood vessels, my red hair started to fly up and blow madly in the wind .

The ghostly voice floated past, “I did hear your previous conversation, you said Song Lu was taken by Li Wen . If that is true, then there might be one more troublesome matter for me on this trip . I hate troublesome matters . Furthermore, I totally didn’t expect to see Ta Lai here . Even if Song Lu is not with you, you still cannot prove that Laurel did not seek you out after she ran away . As for this old man, the phenomenon in the Western District definitely has something to do with him . It just so happens that I love strange phenomena, so I’m going to bring him back with me today, to study this in-depth . You can’t stop me, crazy girl . ”

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“How audacious! You are merely a subordinate of the Southern District Commander . Even if you have some skills, you have no right to act like this in the Western District, and you have the gall to ask for my people? Dream on!” I gritted my teeth, unable to put up with these people who continually want to take away my close friends .

I was boiling with rage . The pain of losing Laurel, Song Lu and Yu Liang had not yet dissipated, how am I able to tolerate these people going around intimidating others and doing whatever they please, just because of someone who claims to be a soul splitter?

“Hahaha, crazy girl, you really don’t know fear . Do you have any skills apart from plain talking?”

Ta Lai spoke up in his refined voice, “She can rely on me . What, you think I’m not worthy enough for her to depend upon when up against you, a mere soul snatcher?”

I deadpanned . Although I am a lot more at ease with you around, it is not as if I am completely depending on you . This makes it sound like I am totally useless . (Passerby B: Are you sure you are not useless...)

The dark shadow on the ground started wobbling as soul snatcher Rong Jin laughed loudly . “Ta Lai, never would I have thought you’d actually come here to help this crazy girl . Even if you want to help her and stop this experiment, you shouldn’t have come here so openly . Aren’t you afraid that Du Yue would want to kill her immediately after finding out you are here?”

I gave a derisive laugh . “Are you belittling me? Even if you unscrupulously betray Si Luo and collude with the soul splitter, Du Yue, do you really think that whoever you are getting orders from can really kill me that easily? You really think that I’m a tiny ant in the palm of your hand? I’ll tell you, an ant will bite when cornered, and you don’t even know if that ant is a poisonous one!”

Ta Lai continued with a smile, “So what, I’m willing to help this girl, pretty good right?”

The ghostly voice chuckled . “You definitely have a temper, but we don’t know if your skills are greater than your temper!”

With a swish, I held Piercer in my left palm . “Whether my skills are greater than my temper, you’ll know once you get a taste of it!”

Before today, I might not have picked fights so rashly, but only until now did I realise, if I was weak, I might lose my friends and the people I care about, and my dignity would be trampled upon by others!

I have endured long enough, until today . I am not going to put up with this anymore!

Chapter 92

92 Going into Battle!

Rong Jin's ghostly voice rang out in the empty Western District, "I guess a fight is inevitable . I really don't want to fight you Ta Lai, but since you are not willing to tell the truth, this is the only path we can take . "

I lifted Piercer and scorned, "Why do you need so many excuses to start a fight? Since you've travelled so far to reach my Western District to act like a barbarian, you should be prepared for a fight . Don't regret!"

I did not want to remain passive anymore . Without further hesitation, I swung Piercer towards the three wolves in front of You Ji .

Crack!

The violet blade whistled as I sent it out . It no longer looked stark and crude, it now looked bedazzling!

The shadow on the ground suddenly started to extend towards us, there was even a shrill laughter accompanying it!

Both Nie Zun and I moved back, away from the shadow, and Ta Lai lightly tapped his feet on the ground, before nimbly leaping into the air with that slender pair of legs!

After Nie Zun and I backed away, the three wolves had already dodged the violet blade and were charging towards us with a thunderous roar!

I smirked and flicked my left wrist!

The violet blade, now behind those wolves, turned back to attack them!

Pu-sst!

Blood sprayed everywhere!

Like a spinning razor, the violet ray slashed into the backs of the three wolves, tearing their flesh apart . The wolves were slashed into halves and their bodies dropped to the ground .

However, just as the wolves' bodies touched the ground, two shafts of green light raced towards Nie Zun and I!

Swish swish!

You Ji, who was hiding behind the wolves all this while, whipped her head fiercely, and her green hair started to twist into two sections, resembling drills, coming straight for Nie Zun and I at lightning speed!

I swung Piercer, and caught one of the sections!

I pulled hard with my left wrist, but I could not yank that hair!

You Ji's gaze was icy . Gritting her teeth, she tilted her head, and tendrils started growing rapidly from that section I just caught . The tendrils extended along Piercer and were coming toward my arm!

The other section of hair was still racing towards Nie Zun!

Concerned, I subconsciously looked at Nie Zun, only to see Nie Zun calm and composed as usual . When the section of hair was about to touch his face, a spark lit up in his eyes!

Crack!

As if it was electrocuted, that vine of twisted hair was reflected and thrown backwards right before Nie Zun's eyes!

You Ji widened her eyes in shock, and I am not about to give her an opportunity to retreat . Piercer was now entangled in her green hair, and after the tendrils extended all the way to my arms, I concentrated a large

amount of MF into my left arm . As I pulled my arm back, You Ji was also violently yanked by her hair towards us!

There was a sudden burning sensation on my left arm which was still tangled with You Ji's green hair . Gritting my teeth, I pulled out an arrow from behind with my right arm . Without a bow, I used my MF to send the arrow in the direction of You Ji's head!

You Ji could not dodge the arrow in time as I held on to her hair, and the arrow lodged itself into her skull!

You Ji's skull cracked as the arrow found its target, and her head was thrown back by its force!

My left arm suddenly felt like it was being stung by many tiny needles, and as I loosened my grip on her hair, her serpentine tail grew to several times its original size . Like a gigantic python, her body was lifted up by her huge tail!

The arrow was still stuck in her skull, and she retracted her hair in that moment when I slackened my grip .

I shook my arm in an attempt to get rid of the numbing pain and retreated backwards!

Nie Zun, who was originally beside me, turned around to face the back .

An massive shadow was spreading on the ground behind me as I turned around to look, and it was coming out of the ground, extending into the air, like a two-dimensional picture transforming into a three-dimensional object!

The shadow looked like a colossal demon and two demonic claws were coming right at us!

Although I was rather alarmed, I chose to trust Nie Zun, and quickly turned back to focus on the fight with You Ji and her enormous tail!

I was about to leap into the air as You Ji's serpentine tail whipped towards me, but the sky grew dark in an instant!

I was a little stunned . Was it dark already? But there should still be about an hour or so before night!

After a moment, I realised what was happening . Because right now, I could not see anything at all!

It was Ta Lai!

Ta Lai made use of the opening during the fight to create this enclosed space where he can control the four senses!

This means that right now, we are all trapped in his space!

This means that right now, we are all trapped in his space!

What the hell, Ta Lai, why did you trap both me and Nie Zun here too!

It was pitch-black and I could not even see my fingers in front of me . As I started to focus on using my MF and to recall how it felt to fight within such a space, a massive object smashed onto the top of my head!

That was probably You Ji's gigantic tail, a lucky strike that it hit me in this chaos and darkness!

It felt like there was a 1000-pound cauldron on my head, and that gigantic tail had pummeled me to the ground!

My head felt dizzy after being smashed into the ground, but I tried to focus my MF on both my hands to push away that huge tail holding me down .

I quickly rolled towards the side to get away from that object which smashed onto me, and felt a little faint .

I ended up lying face up on the floor after rolling some distance away .

“Hey, what are you trying to pull, Ta Lai!” I shouted upwards .

Only my voice rang out in the darkness, there were no other sounds .

I immediately opened my eyes . It was totally dark and there was zero visibility . I started to be more alert .

Out of nowhere, I heard a crackling sound!

This sounded so familiar!

I tried hard to remember .

It's the sound of air vortexes!

Jiao S is here?? Or... is it Gaoqin Jiuye?

Crackle crackle crackle crackle!

There was more crackling, and I could feel the tremors in the surrounding air!

“All five senses don't seem to work here in this space, heh heh, a technique of space distortion? But I've just messed up the air currents in this space, so you probably won't be able to attack me right?!” You Ji's voice rang out of nowhere from the darkness .

So she was the one behind these vortexes?! Right, her skill is duplication! But can she do it without any limitations? I am sure she cannot, there had to be some weakness!

“Hahahahaha, Ta Lai, space distortion . Do you think that someone like me who's used to living in the shadows will be scared of this?”

“Hahahahaha, Ta Lai, space distortion . Do you think that someone like me who's used to living in the shadows will be scared of this?”

Rong Jin's ghostly voice rang out in the darkness .

The ghostly voice said, “Kids, come out and play with them!”

I stood up instantly, gripping Piercer tightly in my left hand, I focused my MF onto my skin to sense the surrounding changes!

I concentrated on avoiding any incoming attacks but those air vortexes made it more chaotic, affecting my sense of touch . Before I could dodge, my right shoulder seemed to have been slashed by an animal's sharp claw!

I pivoted to avoid it, swinging my left hand at the same time!

A violet light appeared!

Pu-sst!

Something in front of me seems to have been cut!

My right shoulder was in pain, but there was no time to be concerned about that now as there were two sharp claws digging into my back!

In the dark, I sprang forward before turning around and cracking the whip in my left hand!

Crack!

“Ahwoo!”

It sounded like I hit a beastly animal as a monstrous roar sounded!

There was a feeling of impending crisis all around me!

I tried to react quickly, and heard Nie Zun's voice at the same time!

“Ta Lai, too many animals are in this space, the enclosed space will only aid them in attacking us!”

I heard Ta Lai's composed voice from above . “Understood . ”

In an instant, just as I was about to focus my MF for battle, our surroundings lit up again!

I was left slightly dazed as we were abruptly thrown back into normality from that confounding space .

Surrounding us were 20 ferocious beasts which kind of looked like wolves and tigers . They were staring at us and baring their teeth!

Rong Jin's shadow was nearby, and it seemed to have been seized by two giant marionettes from behind in an unsuccessful attempt to escape back to the ground . The marionettes looked like they were clutching a piece of dark cloth, and held on tightly to both arms of that colossal shadow .

Surrounding us were 20 ferocious beasts which kind of looked like wolves and tigers . They were staring at us and baring their teeth!

Rong Jin's shadow was nearby, and it seemed to have been seized by two giant marionettes from behind in an unsuccessful attempt to escape back to the ground . The marionettes looked like they were clutching a piece of dark cloth, and held on tightly to both arms of that colossal shadow .

“Kill them!” Rong Jin's shrill voice rang out from the shadow, and the 20 beasts originally surrounding us promptly charged towards the two giants beside the shadow .

I was rather startled when these 20 monsters passed by me so closely!

At this point, the enemy seemed to have collected themselves, and You Ji's gigantic tail came straight for me at the same moment when the beasts went towards the shadow!

In her desire to kill me, You Ji is truly not letting any opportunity slip away!

I was infuriated . I put my MF into my left wrist, and lifted Piercer up high!

I brought it down with great force!

Wham!

Piercer produced a bright strip of violet light, crashing into the gigantic tail opposite!

A shadow then appeared above me!

It was Nie Zun!

I looked up swiftly, and saw red fog surging in his eyes!

As his eyes surged with the fog, streaks of blood red rays shot out from his eyes . They looked like blood red lasers as he leapt up and chased those beasts!

Bam!

The violet strip of light crashed into You Ji's gigantic python's tail .

Whoosh!

“Ah!”

As You Ji cried out, the violet strip of light scattered into many tiny violet blades, stabbing her in the tail!

She retreated hastily as she screamed!

Many tiny violet blades were already wedged into her tail!

She howled unbearably as red and green blood mixed with the tiny blades!

Chapter 93

93 A Hostile Visitor

Pu-sst! Pu-sst! Pu-sst!

Ahwoo! Ahwoo!

Ahwo—!

Ahwoo—!

Nie Zun leapt up and stopped in mid-air, as the red fog in his eyes surged, red laser streaks impaled the wolf- and tiger-like beasts .

The carcasses of these beasts slumped onto the ground amidst painful howls!

Nie Zun looked like the god of death levitating in the air, with the red fog in his eyes, a pair of black gloved hands and a black jacket flying in the wind!

The giant marionettes were about to chomp on the dark shadow they were holding on to, when the shadow seemed to become enraged!

The shadow put up a violent struggle, and the two marionettes were thrown back as if they had been shot by bullets!

Bam! The giant marionettes were thrown with such force that they flew into the air before dropping onto the ground!

The dark shadow looked as if it had devoured countless other shadows, and became a gargantuan shadow which covered almost half the sky!

Stabbed in her tail by the many tiny violet blades of mine, You Ji's green hair started to fly up . She still had an arrow stuck in her head, and the sight of her hair blowing in the wind like this looked horrifying!

She ignored the arrow as she seemed to feel nothing even when that arrow had been coated with a pain-inducing agent .

Crackle crackle crackle!

I could see air vortexes appearing in the air in the part of the sky not yet covered up by the massive shadow!

You Ji stared at me angrily!

Between the swirling air vortexes, countless air needles were shot in my direction!

Before I could react, the air around me seemed to condense .

It was the same crackling sound, but this was not from You Ji's side . There was a frenzy of sound all around me!

Thud! Thud! Thud! Thud!

A few transparent sheets resembling glass doors materialised above me, before descending into the ground, blocking the many air needles coming toward me!

As I collected myself, the massive shadow which seemed to cover half the sky had suddenly stopped moving!

Ta Lai was in mid-air like Nie Zun, and both of them were stock-still!

They were all looking at something behind me!

You Ji's gaze was also directed at something behind me! She wanted to attack me with the air needles but it was neutralised by those sheets that appeared!

Sensing something amiss, I slowly turned my head to look back .

Following my movement, a menacing voice floated by .

“Addicted to copying my skills? Can’t you switch it around, learn some other tricks?”

Our visitor carried his usual indifferent expression on that charming face, with hands in both pockets, white sportswear from head to toe, and that same pair of bright yellow sneakers . He walked with light steps, and the air crackled around him as he walked .

Our visitor carried his usual indifferent expression on that charming face, with hands in both pockets, white sportswear from head to toe, and that same pair of bright yellow sneakers . He walked with light steps, and the air crackled around him as he walked .

With a menacing smirk, a pair of dazzling eyes fixated on my own .

You Ji said from behind me, “Gaoqin Jiuye, I don’t think we have any enmity between us . Why are you being so nosy?!”

“I don’t like it that you’re copying me, so I wanted to intervene . What of it?”

Although his steps were light, his eyes revealed otherwise . He shifted his eyes and locked his menacing gaze on You Ji .

Crackle!

Whoosh!

Air needles sharper and more powerful than You Ji’s buzzed past my ear, flying towards her!

When I turned to look back at You Ji, she already put up a giant defensive air sheet, but it was not nearly enough for those needles which were already crushing the sheet!

The air needles dropped on the ground, and You Ji retreated several steps!

A long trail of blood was left on the ground as she slid away with her injured tail!

You Ji looked at Gaoqin Jiuye, incensed . Her blood-stained lips quivered as she breathed heavily, but she did not dare to make any sound!

Shadow Rong Jin who was extending across the sky stopped what he was doing, and asked with a string of laughter, “Gaoqin Jiuye, what brings you here?”

Raising his eyebrows coldly, Gaoqin Jiuye said, “Isn’t it because of you the soul snatcher, Rong Jin?”

“Oh? When did you care so much about me?”

Gaoqin Jiuye looked up at that shadow covering half the sky . “Si Luo wants me to bring you back, and prohibits you from participating further in Du Yue’s absurd acts . You won’t even listen to Si Luo anymore?”

Gaoqin Jiuye looked up at that shadow covering half the sky . “Si Luo wants me to bring you back, and prohibits you from participating further in Du Yue’s absurd acts . You won’t even listen to Si Luo anymore?”

The ghostly shadow burst out laughing . “Gaoqin Jiuye, when have I ever listened to Si Luo? Even if I don’t listen to him, he still treats me as well as he treats you . Gaoqin Jiuye, you think you’ll be able to become his most capable assistant just by following him around like a lapdog? You are merely a selfish jerk . ”

I widened my eyes in surprise, and my jaw was about to drop to the ground . Someone actually dared to speak to Gaoqin Jiuye in such a manner?

I looked around with shifty eyes, this is pretty weird . Not far from me, You Ji was also observing the situation, while Nie Zun and Ta Lai seemed to have been petrified into stone statues in mid-air . They were so still and quiet that I could not figure out what they thought of this . Rong Jin’s

shadow seemed alive . It was covering half the sky in front of me, and seemed to lock its gaze on Gaoqin Jiuye .

What surprised me was that Gaoqin Jiuye did not seem the least bit angered, and his gaze remained cold and menacing as he spoke, “I can’t help him . You think these reckless acts of yours and Du Yue’s can actually help him?”

“Hehe, are you worried about Du Yue or Si Luo?”

A brief moment of sorrow flashed past Gaoqin Jiuye’s eyes after Rong Jin finished speaking .

I was quite puzzled . Every time that woman with a broken arm, Du Yue, is mentioned, Gaoqin Jiuye’s expression seemed slightly unusual .

“No matter what, Si Luo wants me to take you back . Du Yue already went to see him, and since you haven’t been around for a while now, he is rather worried about you too . Look, he even sent me to look for you . When would you stop being so reckless?” Gaoqin Jiuye said impassively .

“Don’t make it sound like we have such a warm, brotherly relationship . If I go back, wouldn’t you have to start worrying about who Si Luo passes his role to? Won’t you have another contender once I’m back? In this case, when I’m gone, the role will be given to you, what’s so bad about it?”

Gaoqin Jiuye scorned, “You’re not nearly enough to become a threat to me! What I do know is that I will do whatever Si Luo tells me to!”

“Hahaha, a lapdog will remain a lapdog . Now that Huan Qing’s MF is down to zero, you weren’t able to take good care of Mi Fu, and I am involved in Du Yue’s experiment, are you that confident that Si Luo will give you the role? But Gaoqin Jiuye, I’ve seen through you . I know you are ambitious and I know your motive . I won’t allow you to succeed . Si Luo will not die, I will not let him die, and don’t even think about taking anything that belongs to him!”

Gaoqin Jiuye's gaze was frigid, and I was left rather confused as I listened in to this conversation .

Are these two contesting for the position of Southern District Commander? What does it mean by Si Luo will not die? Is he dying soon? Seems like the situation was what I predicted it to be – that the experiment and everything that happened had a direct connection to Si Luo?

Is the aim of this experiment to find a way to save Si Luo? But why is he dying? Is the condition of his body in the real world deteriorating?

Was it because Jiao S knew some of the reasons behind this situation, that she wanted to look for Si Luo so badly?

Is the aim of this experiment to find a way to save Si Luo? But why is he dying? Is the condition of his body in the real world deteriorating?

Was it because Jiao S knew some of the reasons behind this situation, that she wanted to look for Si Luo so badly?

“Stop bullshitting . Are you going back with me or not?” Gaoqin Jiuye no longer wanted to continue his conversation with Rong Jin .

“I'm definitely not going back before I can further investigate this matter . I hate seeing a burden like you hanging around him anyway . Don't you worry, Gaoqin Jiuye, I'll show Si Luo the real you, and prove to him you are a greedy wolf! As for Du Yue, it doesn't matter how much power you claim to have, she will not go back to you!”

Gaoqin Jiuye's eyes seemed to fill with pain and sorrow for a fleeting moment .

The ghostly voice refused to quit, and continued saying, “Being so focused on looking for me, have you realised that this person is actually here? What do you think Du Yue would do if she knew he was here? Hmm? Gaoqin Jiuye?”

A hand materialised from the shadow in the sky, pointing at Ta Lai .

Ta Lai was smiling gently as usual, not moving an inch, and looked like he was completely uninterested in the conversation between the shadow and Gaoqin Jiuye .

Gaoqin Jiuye did not look at Ta Lai, but his eyes darkened . “I saw him . I also know that before I arrived, he was definitely not an easy opponent!”

The ghostly shadow chuckled . “How is it? Being able to see two people who are thorns in your side, do you feel good? Ahahahaha, I feel really good when I see you upset!”

What a lowly attitude...

This Gaoqin Jiuye does not seem to be very popular... If I remember right, Huan Qing did not like him very much either... His relationship between the soul snatcher, Rong Jin, seemed to be filled with tension, and from this conversation, does it mean there was some sort of conflict between Ta Lai and him?

Gaoqin Jiuye finally lifted his head to look at Ta Lai, who was floating in mid-air . “I’m sure you don’t wish for Du Yue’s absurd acts to succeed . If you still care about her, let me take Rong Jin with me today . ”

I was baffled . I have never heard Gaoqin Jiuye speak to anyone in this way, as if he was requesting for permission .

Ta Lai smiled, his arm was placed behind him, and he landed on the ground with a quick movement of his feet . Nie Zun quietly followed and landed behind me, standing where he usually stood, by my left shoulder .

Ta Lai’s feet had not yet firmly reached the ground and Rong Jin’s shrill laughter rang out once again . “You will take me with you just because he allows it? Gaoqin Jiuye, when will you ever stop being so conceited?”

Chapter 94

94 A Large-scale Negotiation

Ta Lai smiled as he interrupted Rong Jin's antagonism towards Gaoqin Jiuye .

“It's pointless to keep bickering or fighting . How about everyone be forthright about their goals, and we try to reach a solution after hearing what everyone has to say?”

Everybody quietened at once, probably since no one expected Ta Lai to say something like this .

I looked around and pondered for a moment before I spoke, “No matter what the dispute is between you guys, my goal is very clear . You Ji, get out of my Western District with your people, and I will not acknowledge you as someone from the Western District in future either . Apart from that, soul snatcher Rong Jin, I don't know what you and Du Yue are plotting and aiming for with this experiment, but know that as long as you hurt my people in the Western District, I will not let you get away . Please return Yu Liang to me as well, and I'll not give up in my search for Laurel and Song Lu either . ”

You Ji smirked . “You really thought I was interested in your position of Western District Commander? Your friends are people, how about mine? The Seven Demons are nowhere to be found in this pile of rubble, and you think I would leave things like this without finding out where they went?”

Rong Jin continued, “Crazy girl, I can begrudgingly accept that Song Lu is not with you . But you have to explain what happened here in the Western District . As for Yu Liang, I regret to inform you that I'm not aware of the

situation nor am I interested in it . I only focus on things I am interested in, and like Ta Lai said, since we're trying to reach a mutual understanding here, I shall not make things too difficult for you . I just want to take that stone statue with me . ”

Dream on! Ha, I sneered inwardly and raised my brows, not bothering to give a reply .

You Ji promptly added, “Just taking Old Man Fan is not enough . Li Shen, you best come clean with me . What sorcery did you use and where did you take my Seven Demons?!”

My heart sank . I too want to know what exactly happened in the Western District!

Tired of squabbling, I just looked at Ta Lai .

Ta Lai nodded at me, and addressed the rest, “Everyone’s goal is clear now . After Gaoqin Jiuye arrived, he didn’t ask how the Western District turned into a pile of rubble . This means that Gaoqin Jiuye’s goal is simply to take Rong Jin with him, is that right?”

Gaoqin Jiuye sniggered menacingly . “That’s right, I don’t care about what happened here, nor whatever you want to investigate . I am only here on Si Luo’s orders to bring Rong Jin with me . ”

His gaze seemed to briefly sweep past me when he spoke .

My heart hurt slightly . When Gao Qi was alive, he was proud, free and unbridled . But you, Gaoqin Jiuye, Si Luo is your only reason for existence . Apart from your looks, seems like you are nothing like Gao Qi!

Seeing some sort of resentment from my gaze, Gaoqin Jiuye seemed bemused .

Ta Lai nodded . “Gaoqin Jiuye wants to take Rong Jin with him, and Rong Jin, you want to take the stone sculpture with you, while You Ji wants to

find out what exactly happened in the Western District . Let me tell all of you clearly now, we truly do not know what happened here . ”

You Ji gritted her teeth and looked at me with vengeful eyes, before asking, “Ta Lai, as a soul splitter, why are you helping Li Shen?”

I shot a cold look at her . You Ji, do you just hate it that people are on my side?

Ta Lai smiled . “Not only am I helping her, I’ll tell all of you plainly that this experiment of yours will definitely fail . I will stop Du Yue, and it doesn’t matter what you and Rong Jin’s goal is . My advice is not to get involved with Du Yue, and if you insist on participating in her absurd acts, I am not going to sit back and ignore it . ”

“Also,” Ta Lai swiftly turned to Gaoqin Jiuye . “Gaoqin Jiuye, would you tell me what’s happening with Si Luo?”

Gaoqin Jiuye’s expression changed .

The dark shadow also stopped moving suddenly .

Ta Lai continued with a smile, “Is there a need to keep it from me? Du Yue has already gone to look for him on her own, and he hasn’t appeared for a while . If I were to guess, something must have happened to him . How about sharing this information, on what actually happened to Si Luo, and we can work together to think of a solution . ”

The dark shadow remained still .

Gaoqin Jiuye’s eyes darkened . “Si Luo’s condition seems to be worsening . We’re not sure why, but it could be because of his body in the real world . ”

The dark shadow shuddered . “You...”

Gaoqin Jiuye shot a dispassionate look at Rong Jin . “He will find out sooner or later . ”

Gaoqin Jiuye shot a dispassionate look at Rong Jin . “He will find out sooner or later . ”

Ta Lai’s eyes brightened . “You’re saying that, Si Luo is now showing symptoms we’ve previously only ever heard about?”

“That’s right,” Gaoqin Jiuye nodded . “Before we find out the reason to this and a solution, I will not allow anyone to try and hurt him or jeopardise the Southern District!”

After speaking, his eyes swept past Rong Jin momentarily .

Rong Jin burst out laughing . “I think you are the one hankering for the Southern District and trying to hurt him!”

Gaoqin Jiuye did not speak .

Ta Lai’s eyes were shining brightly as he said, “So it’s like this, I understand now . Du Yue sought him out as she probably wanted to get some information from him . This sounds like what she’ll do . But if this were the case, what I don’t get is why you, Rong Jin, joined forces with Du Yue when you’ve always been loyal to Si Luo?”

I turned to look back at Nie Zun . It was obvious I could not do much in this situation, and Nie Zun seemed to be concentrating while looking into the distance . I am sure he was listening intently to the conversation .

The ghostly shadow did not reply .

“I know why he is doing this . ”

Hearing the familiar, hoarse voice, I looked up in surprise!

As expected, Jiao S was walking towards us unhurriedly . Jie Pa and the three masked men in white wearing bamboo hats followed behind her .

As she slowly walked towards us, a black layer seemed to cover the grey sky, and it became dark in an instant .

It was night .

Visibility shrunk to 10 square meters, and the dark shadow was nowhere to be seen as it blended into the night .

Visibility shrunk to 10 square meters, and the dark shadow was nowhere to be seen as it blended into the night .

Jiao S walked into my vision field, and her sudden appearance crowded out my vision slightly .

Walking with a steady pace, she finally stopped beside me, with Jie Pa and the bamboo hat trio .

She flashed a stiff smile at me, and I was put at ease immediately . She is telling me that she has some results .

Rong Jin's shrill ghostly voice rang out in the darkness, "Jiao S, you linger around even more so than Gaoqin Jiuye . Why aren't you chasing after Si Luo?"

Jiao S gave a rigid and savage smile . "No need for you to fret . "

I hastily asked, "What did you mean by that?"

Jiao S spoke steadily, "Ta Lai, you might not be familiar with me, but I know some things about you . On behalf of the Soul Snatcher, I can answer your question for him . The soul snatcher, Rong Jin, simple-mindedly thought Du Yue's experiment could provide a way to save Si Luo, so he thought he was helping Si Luo . However, in reality, he was merely used by Du Yue . "

I frowned . "You saw Du Yue?"

"No," Jiao S said, shaking her head . "I just thoroughly investigated all that happened, and the clues led me to this . I haven't seen Ta Lai before either . "

The ghostly voice sounded again, “You mean to get involved in this complex situation while solely relying on these guesses and your deduction? Jiao S, you are still as annoying as before!”

Ta Lai cut Rong Jin off, smiling, “Jiao S, I know you, the Eastern District Commander . I too know some things about you . Please continue, I’d like to hear what you have to say . ”

It was apparent that Ta Lai was not civil with Rong Jin as he said this, and although the shadow cannot be seen, Rong Jin did not speak further . He seemed to start dreading Ta Lai .

Jiao S nodded stiffly . “Firstly, since Si Luo’s situation is no longer a secret, I would not need to hide it further . Yes, I did receive news that Si Luo’s body had started to deteriorate, something never before seen in the Split Zone . Normally, this will not happen to people in the Split Zone, and his body in the real world is still fine . This then became a mystery . For now, I want to ask, who are all of you people and what are your identities? Shouldn’t all of you be frank and come clean?”

At this point, Jiao S seemed to be rather amused, and her keen gaze brushed past Gaoqin Jiuye and Ta Lai .

Jiao S nodded stiffly . “Firstly, since Si Luo’s situation is no longer a secret, I would not need to hide it further . Yes, I did receive news that Si Luo’s body had started to deteriorate, something never before seen in the Split Zone . Normally, this will not happen to people in the Split Zone, and his body in the real world is still fine . This then became a mystery . For now, I want to ask, who are all of you people and what are your identities? Shouldn’t all of you be frank and come clean?”

At this point, Jiao S seemed to be rather amused, and her keen gaze brushed past Gaoqin Jiuye and Ta Lai .

Ta Lai smiled as he said, “I’m a soul splitter, you should know that . ”

Jiao S had a sinister smile on her face . “From that black hole above the Northern District’s Great Hall?”

Ta Lai remained smiling while he asked, “Who told you that?”

Jiao S’s expression changed . It looked like she did not want to speak about this, but I knew who it was . This was what Li Wen told the few of us back then, when she said the black hole above the Northern District’s Great Hall was the world of the soul splitters .

“Li Wen,” Jiao S begrudgingly said the words in the end .

Ta Lai remained indifferent . “Her again . Seems like she’s hiding many things...”

Ta Lai looked down briefly, as if in deep thought, and lifted his head again to speak, “I know what you’re trying to get at . Yes, just as you had no significant reason to keep Si Luo’s situation a secret, I don’t have any significant reason to hide it either . Gaoqin Jiuye and Rong Jin, both of you don’t mind that I reveal Si Luo’s secret, right?”

Rong Jin’s voice did not sound in the darkness, but a gust of wind blew past me, lifting a little corner of my dress .

There seemed to be something different in Gaoqin Jiuye’s eyes, and he tilted his head to look at me . I looked back in confusion, not able to understand what he was trying to say .

“That’s right, Si Luo is just like me, we are soul splitters,” Ta Lai said .

As if satisfied that what she predicted had now come true, Jiao S breathed a sigh of relief .

But I was dumbstruck . This was something I could not wrap my head around . Si Luo is a soul splitter too?

Chapter 95

95 Disappearance of the Western District

I turned back to look at Nie Zun, who was also looking towards me . His eyes gleamed, but he did not look surprised .

Jiao S sighed . “I knew it . I’ve been suspecting this for a while, but I still don’t get it . If it was simply like this, everything can be unravelled . I don’t know what Du Yue’s experiment is about, I know nothing about her, and much less about you soul splitters . There’s only one thing I can be sure of, Si Luo’s deteriorating condition is extremely unusual, and I will find a way to save him . ”

Rong Jin’s languid voice sounded in the darkness, “Heh heh heh, since it’s already known, let’s reveal everything . I can tell you what Du Yue wants to achieve through the experiment . Her goal is to find a method to kill soul splitters, and she’s not targeting normal people like you . Heh heh heh, and we have Ta Lai to thank for all this . ”

Ta Lai pursed his lips .

I looked at Ta Lai in surprise, never have I seen such an expression on his face . At the same time, I noticed that Gaoqin Jiuye had the same kind of expression!

The ghostly voice continued lazily, “You know that right, Ta Lai? Because of you, Du Yue is trying all ways and means to look for a method that can kill soul splitters who never die, and then kill the one you love – Bian Ying!”

Bian Ying... The name Ta Lai called out to in his nightmare?!

A rivalry of love? Meaning Bian Ying is a soul splitter too, they are all soul splitters, and since soul splitters almost never die here in the Split Zone, Du Yue wants to find a way to kill Bian Ying with such a cruel experiment?

During his nightmare, Ta Lai seemed full of anguish . Where is Bian Ying now?

The people of our district were taken away to be experimental subjects just because of this trivial rivalry?!

I was incensed, and terrible images of Song Lu throwing up poison leech spawn flashed through my brain once again!

Ta Lai sighed . “Rong Jin, is this your goal? Working with Du Yue to find a way to save Si Luo? Aren’t you too naive... even if such a method exists, do you think that Du Yue will let you have it easily? You will forever be controlled by her once you work for her...”

Gaoqin Jiuye was slightly agitated . “Du Yue is not like what you think, she...”

He frowned, not completing his sentence, almost as if there was something he could not say .

My gaze lingered on his sharp facial features, unable to move my eyes away from his perpetual downcast face .

“Hahahahahahahaha, Gaoqin Jiuye, someone as pompous as you would defend a woman like her?”

Gaoqin Jiuye’s face crinkled . “Rong Jin, didn’t you also choose to work together with her? Ta Lai is right, aren’t you too naive? Why would she have a way to save Si Luo?”

The ghostly voice chuckled . “How about Mi Fu? Mi Fu’s older brother was a special case in the Split Zone, and the only case before Si Luo where one’s body had symptoms of deteriorating, and at the time, Si Luo was desperate to uncover the truth behind it . But he died in an incident while

protecting Huan Qing, becoming the first and only soul splitter in the Split Zone to die an unnatural death . Funny thing is, Mi Fu does not have the body constitution of a soul splitter! How would you know that the secret to saving Si Luo lies with Mi Fu then?”

Gaoqin Jiuye gave a humourless smile . “If she knew a method, would her brother have died?”

“That’s not because she does not have a method, she is the method herself! Anyway, I’m not going to give up in unravelling this mystery, and in finding out why the Western District became like this . I suspect it’s due to some sort of technique that can contort space . No matter what, as long as it can save Si Luo, I’m willing to give it a try! Even if I’m being used by that Du Yue woman!”

I was deeply shaken by such remarks, even when spoken in Rong Jin’s shrill and piercing voice .

He did all this for Si Luo...

Gaoqin Jiuye also had a bleak expression... He did not usually look like this...

Gaoqin Jiuye also had a bleak expression... He did not usually look like this...

Si Luo... These people are willing to risk everything for you . What kind of person are you exactly?

Nie Zun spoke up beside me, “You’re saying that Mi Fu is not a soul splitter? But an old woman once told us that she is one . ”

Gaoqin Jiuye interrupted, “That might have been an illusion created by Huan Qing to protect Mi Fu . Huan Qing had always felt guilty about the death of Mi Fu’s older brother, since it was to protect him . Because of this, he tries his best to protect Mi Fu, and probably thought that she’ll not be harmed if you thought she was a soul splitter . ”

Jiao S abruptly said, “Since everyone seems to be on the same page on the matter of saving Si Luo, let’s all work together in finding a solution . When Jie Pa and Tao Lie returned to the Eastern District, they informed me of the situation in the Western District . During the past few days, Jie Pa and I were able to sense some remnants of MF in the ruins . Together with other remaining traces and clues, I have a daring conjecture to make . ”

“What is it?” Rong Jin asked in a sharp voice, as if he could not wait any longer .

Jiao S cracked her neck . “Just as you said, Jie Pa and I both suspect that this is some sort of spacial contortion technique, probably some kind of transference technique . ”

I looked at Jie Pa, puzzled .

Jie Pa adjusted his glasses and nodded at me . “Miss Ah Shen, I suspect this is Old Man Fan’s doing . Something major might have happened in the Western District, and Old Man Fan might have used all his MF to try and change that using a transference technique . As you all know, we use our MF in the Split Zone, derived from the mental strength of our comatose bodies in the real world, to maintain our existence and appearance . The power of our subconscious is infinite, it is only limited by how we use it . ”

Jiao S nodded, adding, “Put simply, Old Man Fan has great mental strength, and whatever happened in the Western District caused him to activate all of his MF for this transference technique . Of course, all this was at the cost of depleting his mental strength . Although his mental strength has been depleted completely, he is still alive in the real world, and thus he will not die in the Split Zone . However, since all his MF has been used up, unlike Huan Qing’s case, he might not be able to recover from it, and this caused him to become just like a petrified statue . ”

I cried, “What? What happened? Why did it become like this!”

I moved forward and grabbed Jiao S’s arms tightly, looking at her in disbelief . I asked, “You mean Old Man Fan completely depleted his MF to use this technique? What kind of technique is this? Why would he do that?”

I heard You Ji's voice close by . "What else? Probably to protect you, Li Shen! That old man is pretty loyal to you, he refused to betray you no matter what I said . Why did that old geezer drag my Seven Demons to hell with him using this technique?"

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Bam!

I activated my MF and flicked my wrist, producing a blinding ray of violet light which streaked towards You Ji's face!

As I triggered my MF, I looked like I was engulfed in angry flames as my red hair flew up!

I stared at You Ji, outraged . It looked like she could not dodge in time, and the violet ray was about to slice her head off!

"Ow!"

A gigantic lion then appeared out of nowhere in the black night!

Boom!

The violet ray sliced into the lion in front of You Ji, cutting it into two halves!

Blood sprayed everywhere!

With a blood-splattered face, You Ji said in a dazed manner, "Thank you, Rong Jin . "

My gaze was chilly as I flicked my long hair, saying, "You Ji, if I ever find out that Old Man Fan became like this because he confronted your Seven Demons in order to defend me, I, Li Shen, swear that I won't let you live!"

Anger rising in my throat, I kept my gaze steely and enunciated each word clearly!

My gaze was chilly as I flicked my long hair, saying, “You Ji, if I ever find out that Old Man Fan became like this because he confronted your Seven Demons in order to defend me, I, Li Shen, swear that I won’t let you live!”

Anger rising in my throat, I kept my gaze steely and enunciated each word clearly!

You Ji gave a bitter smile, but it was difficult to hide how astonished she was at my attack . “You care about Old Man Fan, I care about my Seven Demons too!”

She then turned and stared at Jie Pa . “What kind of technique is this?”

Jie Pa looked at her impassively . “We are not sure how such a transference technique works, but what we can be sure that since Old Man Fan used all his MF to freeze and move everyone in the Western District . It’s possible that there is a Western District still intact somewhere, except that it’s stuck in another space!”

I pressed, “What does this mean? The Western District still exists somewhere? Just that we don’t know where it is?”

Stiffly, Jiao S reached out to gently pat me on the arm . “That’s right . Everyone in the Western District should have been frozen at the same moment, and moved to some unknown space, except we don’t know where it is . Apart from the real world and the Split Zone, we’re not sure if a third dimension exists here in this world . ”

Rong Jin’s sharp voice sounded leisurely, “So it’s like this, not disappointing at all, very spectacular . Seems like more secrets of the Split Zone will be unveiled once we find out why the Western District disappeared, and we might even find a way to save Si Luo!”

I looked over at Gaoqin Jiuye, who remained quiet, and looked over at Ta Lai, who was silent all this while and had a perpetual smile on his face .

I suddenly felt like I could not trust either of them .

There are too many secrets in the Split Zone, and all of these people have separate goals . No matter what their goals are, be it to save Si Luo, to save Bian Ying, or something else, I am sure that their goals do not align with mine!

I am only here to save my friends and to protect them!

Chapter 96

96 Destruction?

I smiled nonchalantly . “After all that discussion, we ended up in a stalemate? Nobody knows where the Western District is, and for all of you, protecting Si Luo is the main goal . I’m not involved in Si Luo’s matters and I’m not interested in protecting him either, I just want to save my friends and destroy this experiment of yours!”

I pointed at You Ji, and at the shadow which appeared behind her .

Ta Lai spoke up, “My goal is simple, Rong Jin, I want to stop Du Yue’s experiment . There has to be a base for this experiment of hers, so why not tell me where her base is?”

Rong Jin’s shadow quivered . “Kekeke, finally being forthright about your goal? What a pity, one of the larger bases used for Du Yue’s experiment was within the Western District’s Academy building . Now that the Western District’s gone, what are you going to do?”

I stared at You Ji in outrage!

You Ji met my eyes with a frosty gaze, and from that look, I was almost certain that she had always been in cahoots with Du Yue, exploiting those in the Western District and using their lives for this experiment! That man who fell from the roof of the Academy could just be another failed experimental subject!

How many more have been harmed that I know nothing of...

I looked at You Ji with gritted teeth . “Why must you do this? You can bear to kill so many innocent Western District residents?”

You Ji's face looked like that of a crazed savage . “Just like you, I too have people I care about . I can do anything for him, even if it means taking others' lives!”

Jiao S suddenly said, “All of you have gone mad . For your individual goals, you are willing to help such a witch in her experiment . Du Yue's ultimate aim is to kill soul splitters, but in her quest to do so, how many innocent residents will she kill? Rong Jin, even if you say you are doing it for Si Luo, I'm sure Si Luo would rather die than see you indirectly cause the death of so many people!”

Rong Jin produced a creepy laughter, but before he could speak, Gaoqin Jiuye said coldly, “Jiao S, you think you know Si Luo very well?”

Jiao S gave a chilly smile . “Would I not know what kind of person you are, Gaoqin Jiuye? You don't care about anything, much less the residents here . You don't care even if the Split Zone gets destroyed . But I'm different from you, I have other friends, and an entire district of residents who need my protection! You think you're keeping Si Luo from harm, but do you know what Si Luo wants the most? He wants the Split Zone to be peaceful!”

With a crazed, bloodthirsty gaze, Gaoqin Jiuye asked, “What do all of you know about peace in the Split Zone? There will never be peace here!”

He pointed at all of us .

My heart hurt a little when I looked at his cold-blooded and ruthless gaze .

As I stole a glance at Jiao S, I sensed sorrow and helplessness .

Jiao S, you must be in quite a dilemma...

I know that feeling, I understand it . You want to save Si Luo, but there are other things you have to consider, and you also have a kind heart .

Although I have never seen Si Luo, from all the effort he has put in to protect the Southern District's residents, I truly believe that he will stand on

your side .

Do not be afraid, Jiao S, and do not lose your way . Gaoqin Jiuye is wrong!

Jiao S felt my gaze on her, and she looked at me with tired eyes .

I smiled at her, before turning to look at Gaoqin Jiuye .

It is not my wish to go against you, but if Jiao S can make such a sacrifice, how can I be selfish and only think about my own feelings? There are still many awaiting my rescue!

I then laughed wickedly . “Gaoqin Jiuye, no need to put yourself on a pedestal . The fact that Si Luo is in such a dangerous situation right now is proof that you’re not able to protect him!”

There seemed to be a fleeting pain that passed through Gaoqin Jiuye’s eyes as I articulated every word .

Are you in pain? You deserve it . How could you be so cold-blooded and ruthless when you look exactly like him?

Rong Jin laughed . “Seems like nobody understands us, Gaoqin Jiuye . Although I hate you, let’s make today an exception . How about we work together to snatch that stone statue, and we’ll definitely find some clues behind the disappearance of the Western District . I’m sure you know that I, Rong Jin, won’t do anything I’m uncertain of, but I am confident that through Du Yue, we can find a way to save Si Luo!”

Gaoqin Jiuye looked downcast, and his icy gaze swept past all of us .

With an elegant smile, Ta Lai moved the ring on his finger, saying, “Gaoqin Jiuye, are you sure you want to be taken advantage of by Du Yue in her scheme again? I thought you learnt your lesson . I’m pretty sure you know this – that no one knows Du Yue as well as I do . She will not be able to save Si Luo . ”

With an elegant smile, Ta Lai moved the ring on his finger, saying, “Gaoqin Jiuye, are you sure you want to be taken advantage of by Du Yue in her

scheme again? I thought you learnt your lesson . I'm pretty sure you know this – that no one knows Du Yue as well as I do . She will not be able to save Si Luo . ”

The words ‘Du Yue’ seemed like poison to Gaoqin Jiuye, and he looked like he was in agony every time these words were mentioned .

In the end, Gaoqin Jiuye compromised . “Rong Jin, I'm not interested in your experiment, but I'll help you take the stone statue back today . However, I want you to go back with me and see Si Luo, this is his request . I'm not going to participate in your affairs . ”

Rong Jin unexpectedly agreed . “Fine, you help me take the stone statue, I'll go with you to see Si Luo . You know what to do next right, You Ji?”

You Ji gave a ravishing smile . “Of course, go with him . I'll bring this stone statue back to Du Yue, don't worry about it . ”

I instantly snapped alert . Looks like Rong Jin is a stubborn old fool who is not letting go of that statue . Our negotiation was useless .

That annoying shadow, siding so quickly with Gaoqin Jiuye after seeing Jiao S arrive and the increase in our firepower!

I am all up for a fight . We definitely have more firepower on our side, and Jiao S even brought the bamboo hat trio . I am not scared!

In his bright yellow sneakers, Gaoqin Jiuye walked over to be beside the shadow and You Ji .

Two persons and a ghostly shadow were standing directly opposite the row of us .

With a wave of her hand, Jiao S's bamboo hat trio moved to be in front of us .

Jiao S pulled me with her as we retreated backwards .

As for Jie Pa, he cleverly moved right to the back . He is not a coward, but his current condition is peculiar . If we were to fight, he had to be at the back, or we might have to expend more energy to protect him .

Nie Zun and I looked at each other, and I felt at ease right away as I looked at those starry eyes . He nodded at me and retreated to be beside Jie Pa . He wanted to keep Jie Pa safe .

A team battle formation was more or less formed . The bamboo hat trio in white were right in front, Jiao S, Ta Lai and I were in the middle, and Nie Zun and Jie Pa were at the back .

Rong Jin's shrill and evil laughter rang out from opposite us, "Seems like we are a little weaker here ahahahahahahaha!"

Rong Jin's shrill and evil laughter rang out from opposite us, "Seems like we are a little weaker here ahahahahahahaha!"

Gaoqin Jiuye gave an unfriendly smile . "Not necessarily . Have you forgotten the last time we worked together? Do you think that a team made up of the Southern District's Soul Snatcher and Persuader, Gaoqin Jiuye, would be beaten?"

Bloody hell, how preposterous!

Gaoqin Jiuye was practically begging to be thrashed with that face, and I suddenly really wanted to beat him up, pin him down, and ask him, just who are you?!

Jiao S looked like she could no longer stand to look at Gaoqin Jiuye's ridiculous face, and her black hair started to fly up!

Whoosh!

Strong winds started to rage all around us, almost as if a tornado was approaching!

My red hair was flying in the wind, and my eyes were painfully whipped by the strong winds . The wind was so strong that it was louder than all other

surrounding sounds!

Rong Jin's ghostly voice floated past amidst the powerful winds, "On such a dark night, you won't win no matter what you do! Kakakakaka!"

Countless shadows shaped like humans came out of the ground right after that weird and creepy laughter ended .

These shadows moved like zombies, standing up awkwardly after lifting themselves off the flat ground with their black hands!

"Feng, Huo, Lei!" Jiao S shouted . The bamboo hat trio were originally as still as corpses, but they suddenly leapt into the air like quick hares!

Fire, the sound of thunder and gusts of wind surrounded them as they moved!

I was stunned at these natural phenomena that appeared, as I have not seen these in these in the Split Zone for a long time!

Ta Lai had also leapt into the air to be behind the bamboo hat trio, and smiled as he moved the jade stone ring on his finger!

There were more shadows coming out from the ground in front of us, and they were all coming toward us with their jet black, outstretched hands!

Ta Lai had also leapt into the air to be behind the bamboo hat trio, and smiled as he moved the jade stone ring on his finger!

There were more shadows coming out from the ground in front of us, and they were all coming toward us with their jet black, outstretched hands!

Without hesitation, I drew 10 arrows, activated my MF and let them fly!

Those arrows flew through the air like comets, and 10 of the shadows were shot!

Sizzle!

As if loaded with electricity, the arrows burst into flames while still embedded in the shadows!

I smiled mischievously . This was a new attack of mine, where I coated the tails of the arrows with a flammable substance . Combined with the sparks caused by fusing my MF into the arrow, this fire cannot be extinguished easily!

Crackle! Sizzle!

Those 10 shadows were twisting and struggling, and it was a horrifying sight as the fire was blazing around their bodies!

However, the 10 arrows did not have much of an effect . Many more shadows continued to come out of the ground!

The wind roared around us . Jiao S looked enraged, and at the same time, Gaoqin Jiuye, who was opposite us, started to manipulate the air currents around him, ready to go against Jiao S!

As if to announce the start of the battle, the bamboo hat trio produced fire and thunder!

Just as I was about to brace myself for a big fight, the ground below started buzzing and quaking!

A blinding ray of light then came out from Old Man Fan's statue, shooting up into the night sky!

Boom!

All of us looked overwhelmed by the massive tremor, as it was obviously not the work of any of us . There was an impending sense of doom!

Chapter 97

97 Back to Reality

Above the entire Western District, pillars of light came raining down from the night sky, surrounding all of us . The howling wind was deafening, and I almost fell off my feet as cracks started appearing in the ground!

I turned back quickly to look at Nie Zun, who met my eyes . He held Jie Pa tightly as he tried to move towards me!

“Protect Jie Pa!” I shouted .

Damn it, my dress is flying up! (Passerby A: That’s because you love to wear dresses during fights...)

Boom!

A blinding white light engulfed everything in front of my eyes, and a white fog enveloped my brain .

It felt as if I was being sucked into another dimension, and I started to lose my grasp on reality .

In the chaos, I heard Nie Zun’s voice . “Shen’er . ”

But it was different this time, that voice was not able to bring me back . Just like this, I passed out in the ocean of fog .

“Beep beep beep—!”

“I heard that an online personality committed suicide yesterday . ”

“Are you for real?”

“Hey, I’m ending the call, I’m going to be late . Hello, can you hear me?”

“Bloody hell, do you even know how to drive?!”

I heard people’s voices, and while still in a daze, I tried my best to wake myself up .

What met my eyes was the sight of a bustling street and a busy crowd, it was a boisterous scene .

My eyes and jaw widened slowly .

The sun was already above the high tower in the distance, and I am currently on a sidewalk .

“What, what’s all this...” I murmured, looking at everything around me in disbelief .

Buildings, roads, vehicles, pedestrians, the sky, the clouds, the sun!

This was the world before I died, this is reality!

“Surprised?”

I heard a grim but familiar voice from behind .

I turned and saw Gaoqin Jiuye frowning, he was looking at our surroundings and was as surprised as I was .

“You, you, you, how did you, this, this, just what exactly is happening?”

I wanted to use my hands to close my mouth to stop it from dropping any further .

Gaoqin Jiuye shot me an icy look . “How should I know . I just woke up here . Then you dropped beside me in a pillar of light . ”

I looked around me again in shock . “This, this isn’t the Split Zone, this is the real world?”

Gaoqin Jiuye nodded . “Yes, I’ve ascertained that it’s not an illusion . ”

Every time I am stunned, I stutter . “We, we, we, we are back in the real world?”

Gaoqin Jiuye smirked . “Yes, we are back in the form of spirits . ”

I widened my eyes again . “In the form of spirits??”

Gaoqin Jiuye walked over to a woman on the sidewalk who was making a call, and said coldly, “Hey . ”

Together with ‘hey’, he reached out to slap the woman .

But what shocked me more was that his hand passed through the woman’s face! No matter what he said to her, she never once looked at him!

“They, they, they, they can’t see us?” I continued stuttering .

Gaoqin Jiuye’s unfeeling brows crinkled to formed graceful arcs . “That’s right . ”

“Just what is happening...” I almost collapsed to the ground .

“How would I know, you already asked this so many times . ” Gaoqin Jiuye then casually stuck his hands into the pockets of his white track pants, not wanting to engage in further conversation with me .

“M, MF? Can we use MF here?” I hurriedly checked my weapons, both Piercer and my bow were still on me .

Gaoqin Jiuye tilted his head and smiled at me . His smile carried a tiny hint of savagery .

Gaoqin Jiuye tilted his head and smiled at me . His smile carried a tiny hint of savagery .

Before I could react, his gaze became as cold as steel!

Crackle!

The air currents beside him turned into two vortexes, and from those vortexes, air needles were hurtling towards me!

I could not dodge in time, and a few of those air needles pierced right through my shoulder!

A wave of pain started spreading from my shoulder, but he signalled for me to look behind before I could react further .

The air needles were not damaging, before my shoulder could bleed, it was already healing . I looked back in the direction indicated, and I heard the sound of air needles whooshing past my ear!

These air needles pierced through the eyes of a pedestrian!

I almost screamed, but I realised that these air needles were not able to harm the pedestrian . They simply continued on their trajectory!

This meant that we can still use our abilities, and it affects only us, while it has absolutely no effect on anyone in the real world!

“Seems like we are back here with our identities from the Split Zone . We don’t belong here in this world at all . ”

I am not sure if I heard wrong, but when Gaoqin Jiuye spoke, it felt as if he was miserably laughing at himself .

“Is there any way to go back...” I murmured .

Gaoqin Jiuye shook his head calmly . “I don’t know, there probably is . ”

“What should we do now? Have you seen any others?”

Gaoqin Jiuye suddenly smiled at me wickedly . “Haven’t seen them, and I don’t know what to do either . No one here can see us, and only we can see

each other . Since it's just you and me, how about we have a fight to pass time?"

What a lunatic!

I was left speechless .

I squatted and rested my face on my palms, looking around me dully .

This world, it is familiar yet foreign at the same time...

My eyes started to sting, and tears were about to fall . I wiped my eyes after a moment, and continued to look at the crowd and sights around me .

"Hey, stop being so gloomy . Since we're already here, let's not keep standing in the same place . Do you know this place?" Gaoqin Jiuye walked up to be beside me, and kicked me in the leg .

"Hey, stop being so gloomy . Since we're already here, let's not keep standing in the same place . Do you know this place?" Gaoqin Jiuye walked up to be beside me, and kicked me in the leg .

I looked up and rolled my eyes at him .

But, hey, it is true that this place is pretty familiar!

This seems like the street behind my university!

A sudden thought struck me, and I rushed to the magazine stand at the front of the sidewalk!

I wanted to pick up a newspaper, but my hand just passed through it! I quickly bent down to look at the date!

I was dumbstruck when I saw the date .

I started counting quickly in my head, while Gaoqin Jiuye ran over and asked, "What are you looking at?"

I slowly turned my head at him, saying, “It has only been 18 days since I arrived in the Split Zone...”

Gaoqin Jiuye frowned . “What does that mean?”

I held his gaze, as if confirming both our suspicions . “This means only 18 days had passed in the real world after I became comatose, while I have been in the Split Zone for a year and eight months now . ”

Something flashed past Gaoqin Jiuye’s clear eyes and he pondered for a moment, before asking, “That means, a day in the Split Zone is equivalent to a minute here?”

Nodding, I said, “It converts like this, close to what I expected it to be . It’s not a coincidence that there are 60 hours each day in the Split Zone . There are 60 seconds per minute in the real world, so one second in the real world is equivalent to an hour in the Split Zone! And, an hour in the real world is equivalent to a day in the Split Zone!”

Gaoqin Jiuye’s eyes turned dark, but he did not speak .

I frowned slightly, unsure of the reason behind his silence .

“How long have you been in the Split Zone?” I asked carefully .

Something flashed past Gaoqin Jiuye’s eyes, something complex that I could not comprehend .

His gave a mysterious smile . “Very, very long . ”

I was, unexpectedly, rather surprised by his answer .

“Since we’re here, let’s not waste time loitering aimlessly . How about you bring me to take a look at where you lived before?” Gaoqin Jiuye suddenly said in a casual tone .

Where I lived before...

I looked up and scanned the area carefully, making sure that it was the street behind my university . Has it been 18 days... 18 days after Gao Qi died...

Where I lived before...

I looked up and scanned the area carefully, making sure that it was the street behind my university . Has it been 18 days... 18 days after Gao Qi died...

My eyes started to well up with tears .

Where can we go? To the hospital to look at my unconscious self? To look at my parents' sorrowful faces? Or to the university to look at my fellow students who bullied and ostracized me before I died?

Gaoqin Jiuye waved a hand in front of me . “Why, no place to go?”

His voice seemed enchanting, and it made me think of Gao Qi once again .

I then smiled at him . “There is, my university . It’s just nearby . I’ll bring you there?”

Gaoqin Jiuye shrugged . “Your call . ”

With me in the lead, we walked along the big street like two homeless spirits .

“That’s the sun?” Gaoqin Jiuye pointed at the sky .

I frowned slightly . “Even if you have been in the Split Zone for a long time, you can’t forget the sun . Are you that retarded?”

Gaoqin Jiuye tilted his head, giving me an evil grin . “Retarded? That’s the first time someone called me that . ”

I looked at him smiling with that mesmerizing face, and got slightly tongue-tied .

That face still makes me melt into a puddle of goo...

No!

I stopped walking as I suddenly thought of someone else .

“What’s the matter?” Gaoqin Jiuye asked curiously .

I looked at him, asking, “How about Nie Zun? If Nie Zun cannot be more than 500 meters away from me, he should be nearby right?”

Gaoqin Jiuye shrugged . “No, he’s not here . When I arrived, I manipulated the air currents to have a sense of the environment . There is no one from the Split Zone within a 500-meter radius here . ”

I thought as much, that there would be no one else here . If he was really within 500 meters of me, he would probably have already found me .

But, where did he go? Nothing changed since we arrived here, but has the fact that he cannot be more than 500 meters away from me changed?

Chapter 98

98 I am The Devil

“No use thinking about it too much now, let’s just see how it goes . We’ll be back when it’s time . ” Gaoqin Jiuye’s eyes were bright and clear .

I sighed inwardly as I looked at the only person I can communicate with in this world . He was my enemy just a while ago .

Gao Qi, our relationship really is complicated...

“Let’s go, I’ll show you around,” I said as I brushed my hair .

We finally arrived at my university after crossing the street .

Gaoqin Jiuye’s eyes brightened as if he saw something novel . That vibrant expression of his brought a smile to my face . It was rare that he had such a lively demeanor .

As we walked into the university, Gaoqin Jiuye stopped to look at almost everything .

“I didn’t go to class and the lecturer had to take attendance today . What luck,” a girl was complaining to another female student as she passed .

I felt a moment of despair .

Going to class... that phrase seems so distant now . I did not know how to cherish being alive before I died, and ended up in the Split Zone . Even if you are not happy being alive, you should still press on .

To be alive is to be blessed, it is something to be so grateful for that one should be crying tears of joy . But I took away the right to live from the person I love .

As I thought of this, I quietly looked over at Gaoqin Jiuye, who was curiously looking at the flowers in the school grounds .

“What’s this?” Gaoqin Jiuye asked while pointing at a tulip .

“That’s a tulip,” my gaze lingered on him as I casually answered .

His eyes seemed to shine . “Tu...lip? She has a name? It sounds nice . ”

My thoughts were filled with Gao Qi, and I did not wonder too much about why he did not know what are tulips, and why he was so curious about a single flower .

Many years later I kept asking myself, if I had felt something was wrong today, would things have been different?

What a pity that we cannot turn back time, nor can we foresee the future .

“I know I’m good-looking, but you don’t have to keep looking at me with such a starved expression,” Gaoqin Jiuye said while waving a hand in front of my face .

Narcissist... As I wanted to roll my eyes, I coincidentally caught sight of someone walking not far behind Gaoqin Jiuye .

Almost as if struck by lightning, I was rooted to the ground in shock . My heart instantly felt like it was being branded and scorched, while I remained stunned and motionless .

He was in the warm sunlight, and he walked unhurriedly . His back did not look as sturdy as before, his face was slightly pale, and I could not decipher his thoughts behind those dark, hazel eyes .

A warm and gentle smile was on his lips, but his gaze was frosty .

He was still in the same sportswear, and he was wearing a pair of bright yellow sneakers .

Gaoqin Jiuye's clear voice sounded beside me, as if overlapping with the person I just saw .

“What are you looking at?”

My eyes finally moved back to Gaoqin Jiuye's face .

They were exactly the same, but Gaoqin Jiuye's was comparatively more vibrant and menacing, while his expression was rather cold .

Tears started to well up in my eyes, and Gaoqin Jiuye followed my gaze, looking back .

“This...” Gaoqin Jiuye sounded surprised, but he did not seem that shocked .

At that point, my tears were already falling and I rushed towards Gao Qi hysterically, no longer caring about Gaoqin Jiuye .

“Gao, Gao Qi! You're not dead! You're not dead right?!” I cried and whimpered as I tried to hold him, but I realised once again that I could not touch him at all .

“Gao, Gao Qi! You're not dead! You're not dead right?!” I cried and whimpered as I tried to hold him, but I realised once again that I could not touch him at all .

“A dream? Is this a dream? Can you see me? Are you really alive?” My entire face was wet with tears .

However, he could not see me at all .

He continued walking forward, slowly and unhurriedly .

His beautiful brows furrowed slightly, it was not relaxed like before, and he looked as if he was enduring some sort of pain . His pale lips were also

pursed into a straight line .

“This is the lover you killed before you died, the one who looked like me?”
Gaoqin Jiuye ran beside me, looking at Gao Qi with interest .

Both of us activated our MF as we backed away while Gao Qi walked towards us .

“It is exactly the same . ”

My tears were still falling . “Gao Qi, you’re alright now, right? Were you saved?”

Gaoqin Jiuye grabbed me, and looked at me with slight blame in his eyes .
“It’s obvious that he isn’t dead, what are you still crying for?”

I flung his hand away and did not bother to look at him, solely focusing on Gao Qi’s face . “Why do you look so pale...”

Gao Qi did not look at me, and Gaoqin Jiuye grabbed my hand again, lifting my arm, staring intensely at me . “You are already dead in this world, he won’t hear anything you say!”

I stubbornly looked at him, allowing my tears to flow . “I still want to speak to him . It’s none of your business . ”

Gaoqin Jiuye’s eyes dimmed . “Don’t you feel that I’m him now?”

I stared at him, and looked at Gao Qi’s face .

I laughed bitterly . “Even if I wanted to deceive myself, fact is you are not him no matter how much you look alike!”

Gaoqin Jiuye laughed icily, and with a sharp gaze, he tightened his grip on my arm . “It’s that no matter how much he looks like me, he is still not me! Don’t get that order wrong!”

Gaoqin Jiuye laughed icily, and with a sharp gaze, he tightened his grip on my arm . “It’s that no matter how much he looks like me, he is still not me!

Don't get that order wrong!"

I scoffed, "That's what you think . I've never gotten the order wrong!"

Gaoqin Jiuye looked outraged, and forcibly dragged me towards Gao Qi, who had now moved a distance away . He pointed at Gao Qi with one hand as he dragged me with the other . "Look clearly now, he can't even sense your presence! You are already dead in this world!"

I bit my lips and remained silent .

Gao Qi stopped in his tracks abruptly, as if sensing something .

Both Gaoqin Jiuye and I stopped moving . I looked at Gao Qi's face, not daring to breathe .

Gao Qi turned back slightly, and his gaze swept past me without stopping .

Finally, his gaze landed on my face .

I was breathless .

Gaoqin Jiuye's hand, which was holding onto my arm, also seemed to be frozen .

Gao Qi's pale lips slowly widened into a smile, his eyes were warm and gentle . "Haven't met in a while . "

I was speechless . He, he, he, he can see me now?

As I was still in shock and waiting for an answer, I saw Gaoqin Jiuye's gaze focus on something behind me .

Before I could turn back, a hand came out of my chest! That hand seemed to pass through my torso from the back with great force, and it was lifted high in front of my face!

Smack!

The hand that came out of my chest slapped Gao Qi!

I moved aside in surprise, and finally turned to look .

It was Pomelo!

I moved aside in surprise, and finally turned to look .

It was Pomelo!

Pomelo was not in our couple wear, and she was wearing a high-necked sweater . She was a lot thinner, and her eyes looked distant and tired .

“No!” I wanted to grab her hand, but I could only watch as she gave Gao Qi a slap .

Gao Qi’s pale face did not turn red even after being slapped, instead, he looked more pale and sickly .

Gao Qi’s smile remained, and he kept his eyes on Pomelo .

“Why are you not dead yet . If you don’t die, how can you still face her?” Pomelo’s voice was frigid .

Gao Qi’s gave a bitter smile . “I wish I was the one lying there instead . ”

Hatred flashed past Pomelo’s eyes . “Don’t pretend to be kind! Didn’t think that you would survive . That heart of yours is rather tenacious!”

Gao Qi looked to be in agony . He looked different from before, when he looked mysterious but gentle . He put a hand over his heart . “It was able to heal after being stabbed, but, why do I feel as if I’m never going to heal . ”

This was heart-wrenching . I watched him miserably with tearful eyes .

Nevertheless, he could not see me . His unfocused gaze was still on Pomelo .

Pomelo burst out laughing suddenly . “Gao Qi, why are you pretending to be nice? You have always been a sacred being to her, but I know what kind of person you really are . I know people like you well, and those who get involved with you will end up addicted, unable to tear themselves away from you . I tried all ways and means to get her away from you, but I wasn’t able to stop you from destroying her!”

I started screaming at Pomelo, “Go away! Who are you to say these things to him?! Stop acting! What are you talking about?!”

I could no longer keep my emotions in check, and nothing made sense to me here . Just what is the truth? Are we back in reality? Why is he alive, and why is she saying such things to him when he is still alive? I had no idea what is happening!

But I didn’t want to understand it either! I could still see Gao Qi... What should I be unhappy about?!

Even if I see him alive, can this make up for all the harm I have caused him?!

I, Li Shen, am still a devil who will kill the one I love when crazed!

Chapter 99

99 Sudden Appearance of The Seven Demons

As I was staring at both Gao Qi and Pomelo, Gaoqin Jiuye suddenly dragged me forcefully away from them .

“What are you doing?” I wanted to fling his hand away, but his expression was serious and grim .

“What’s wrong with you?” I frowned, glancing at him .

Gaoqin Jiuye tilted his head slightly, as if observing something . “Shh, don’t talk . There seems to be someone like us nearby . ”

There was a nagging feeling that these people were not on our side, and I snapped alert, looking around to see if there was any danger .

Gaoqin Jiuye had dragged me about 20 meters away from Gao Qi, and though my MF was activated, it did not seem to work on Pomelo and him . I could not hear their conversation at that distance .

I could only look at those unfathomable eyes of his, which currently looked dull and lifeless .

I wanted to move closer again, but I felt a killing intent!

I met Gaoqin Jiuye’s eyes, and his gaze confirmed my suspicions! Just who is near?

Whoosh! Whoosh! Whoosh!

Seven masked individuals in navy blue wraps appeared, holding seven blades!

“Are they acting in a drama? They look like assassins from Japan,” I smirked, recognising them as You Ji’s Seven Demons!

Gaoqin Jiuye seemed to also recognise them . “Seven Demons?”

The leader of the seven spoke in a deep and hoarse voice, “Didn’t expect we would be that famous . We’ve finally found you, Li Shen . If you don’t tell us how to return to the Split Zone today, don’t blame us for not being civil!”

I was dismayed . Tell them how to return to the Split Zone? Who would tell me the method then??

“How did you arrive in this world?” Gaoqin Jiuye asked swiftly .

The third person among the seven – Number 3 for the moment, I shall identify them in this order for now .

Number 3 scoffed, “I don’t know what ability Old Man Fan used, but he moved the entire Western District into a crack in space that exists within this world, trapping all of us here, even separating us! The real world is huge, do you have any idea how long we took to find one another?”

What and what? This is Old Man Fan’s doing?

“Give a clearer explanation,” I said icily .

Number 7 spoke, “Li Shen, why are you pretending? This is a crack in space between the Split Zone and the real world . Old Man Fan moved everyone from the Western District here, to different places all around the world . But we are not able to return to the real world nor the Split Zone . It’s all thanks to him that we are living here like spirits!”

This means that everyone from the Western District is now within this crack in space? Old Man Fan’s technique resulted in this? Why did he do it?

“How about the Western District Residence?” I asked .

“How would we know . We arrived here individually, and we are looking for a way to go back to the Split Zone . ”

Gaoqin Jiuye suddenly gave me an evil smile . “You Western District people do have some skills . Such a technique is almost like passing judgement, making everyone end up in different places in the real world, but still they remain in a different dimension, being able to only live like a spirit . This is a type of technique where space can be controlled, but not everyone can easily find the crack in space between the Split Zone and the real world . Does this mean that he has unlocked the secret of the Split Zone?”

My thoughts were in a flurry .

No matter how clear my head was, I was still unable to understand the current situation . I saw Gao Qi walking further away, almost entering a building in the university, and Pomelo was walking towards the entrance .

It was agonizing looking at Gao Qi’s figure, but this was not the time to chase after him .

Tilting my head, I saw Gaoqin Jiuye staring at me coldly, as if he was about to burst with outrage .

“You’re the Southern District’s Gaoqin Jiuye?” The leader of the Seven Demons asked out of nowhere .

“You’re the Southern District’s Gaoqin Jiuye?” The leader of the Seven Demons asked out of nowhere .

Gaoqin Jiuye then moved his gaze away from me to look at them . “Only recognize me now? And you call yourselves the Seven Demons? More like the Seven Demented . ”

I deadpanned . You think you are the emperor, and everyone had to recognize you? I did not even hear about you before this .

Now was not the right time to bruise his pride though . After all, I might not be a match for the Seven Demons alone .

“Hehe, Li Shen, colluding with the Southern District’s dog when you don’t know how to be a district commander?” Number 7 asked .

I sucked in a breath, not wanting to look at Gaoqin Jiuye’s expression . Shaking my head inwardly, I prayed for these children who speak without learning enough about the world . I hope you don’t die too terribly . I should be taking it up with you when you think I am not a good district commander, but since you have offended a scarier BOSS, I shall let it slide .

As I expected, after that juvenile spoke, reeling air currents immediately appeared around all seven of them!

Like a sudden hurricane, the seven vortexes surrounded them tightly!

There was a whooshing sound, and countless pillars of air rose up around me!

I couldn’t help but snatch a look at Gaoqin Jiuye . He did not look angry anymore, but he had an ominous expression as he moved his lips . “Fix!”

Fix? Persuader?

This is the second time I have seen him use his ability of persuasion, and I quickly looked at the seven individuals, trying to determine how powerful of an ability it was!

What surprised me was, these individuals holding onto their blades all looked dumbstruck, and they were rooted to the ground!

Since they were motionless, those pillars of air around me and Gaoqin Jiuye started flying towards them, and pierced them all, turning them into bloody dice!

Looking at the bloody bodies leaking from their wounds, I almost shouted, “People really listen to you, Persuader . Just like this, they stay put?”

I dashed up to the seven individuals in disbelief and gave Number 7 a slap . Number 7 looked at me, incensed, but stayed motionless!

I dashed up to the seven individuals in disbelief and gave Number 7 a slap . Number 7 looked at me, incensed, but stayed motionless!

That great?!

Then why did he still engage us in fights previously? When he could just make us stay put?

Gaoqin Jiuye playfully said, “My powers of persuasion only work on those with a lower MF than me, and the bigger the difference in our MF, the longer it lasts . ”

What? Lasts longer? There is a time limit to this? Phew, I was relieved . This should be the case, or else it would become a god-like power .

But the Seven Demons are You Ji’s trusted aides, so their MF should not be too low . Even if it was not as high as Gaoqin Jiuye’s, there should not be much of a difference right?

“How long will they stay motionless?” I pointed at Number 7 .

Gaoqin Jiuye shrugged . “I don’t know . With your MF, it would probably be effective on you for a second or two . Their MF should be lower than yours, so about a minute?”

Why didn’t you tell me this sooner?!

I retreated in haste, but I was not quick enough . Number 7, who had already regained mobility, was looking at me with a raised blade!

I drew an arrow from behind, and stuck it right in his face . I then activated my MF and teleported back to Gaoqin Jiuye’s side!

“Why didn’t you tell me sooner? Make them stay put again!” I shouted angrily at Gaoqin Jiuye while pointing at the row of people coming towards us with their blades .

Gaoqin Jiuye casually shrugged . “I can’t use it today anymore . I can only use this ability of persuasion once a day . ”

Bloody hell!

No time to argue with this airhead, I used Piercer to produce a violet blade!

The seven individuals hurriedly retreated as I sent out my violet blade, and rapidly, they formed a human wall with three in the bottom layer, and two each in the middle and top layers, like a gymnastic formation!

At the same time, they put their blades right in front of their faces, and made a weird posture!

The seven individuals hurriedly retreated as I sent out my violet blade, and rapidly, they formed a human wall with three in the bottom layer, and two each in the middle and top layers, like a gymnastic formation!

At the same time, they put their blades right in front of their faces, and made a weird posture!

Like a perfect formation, countless blades of light flew towards us as they chanted!

My violet blade was dissolved by some of the blades of light after colliding into them!

There were still some blades flying towards us!

Gaoqin Jiuye focused his gaze, and a white fog appeared with a boom!

A pillar of air rose up from the ground, crushing all the blades of light!

“Can you kill this Southern District’s dog?” Gaoqin Jiuye asked leisurely .

I looked at the seven individuals to my side who looked like they were going into a new formation, shouting, “Don’t you want to go back to the Split Zone? We arrived here knowing nothing either . There’s nothing to gain by fighting, how about we look for a solution together?”

I suggested this as I know that these seven are good with their formations, and although Gaoqin Jiuye has skills, if we were to fight, it would be a long one, and we would not even be able to kill them .

Apart from that, I wanted to find out if they had a way to kill Gaoqin Jiuye and I . To put it simply, to find out whether the experiment was successful and whether they have found a drug that could effectively kill the consciousness .

As expected, the leader scorned, “You think the seven of us are afraid to die? We can sacrifice ourselves whenever needed!”

Alright, this meant they did not have a way to kill Gaoqin Jiuye and I, and they can only kill us through the split symbols . In this case, I am not afraid .

“That’s what I’m saying, what for? If any of you dies, your formation will be broken . Even if you want to make an enemy out of me, we can always return to the Split Zone to continue the fight!”

The leader of the seven smiled menacingly . “Who said that our formation will be broken if one of us is gone?”

Suddenly, all of them landed back on the ground and slid their blades into the ground, producing seven arrays of light!

Chapter 100

100 Human Skin Violet Whip

Individual formations? Are these people are just itching for a fight?

“It’s obvious these are excuses . They just want a fight . ” Gaoqin Jiuye raised his hands, smirking .

Huh, fight? Shall we fight then?

I took Piercer in my right hand, flicked my hair, and moved two steps backwards .

Starting with a good posture is a must before a fight! This is to look imposing!

Gaoqin Jiuye did not underestimate the abilities of these seven individuals, and with his right hand, he was already reaching for the long and black flexible sword he carried with him at the waist!

If I remember right, Ta Lai mentioned that this long black sword was one of the four living weapons – Shen Qi!

Gaoqin Jiuye held onto Shen Qi’s conical hilt, and slowly drew it out, revealing the cold, gleaming black sword . The weapon attracted my gaze, and all of my focus was on that sword .

When worn on his waist, the sword looked like high quality black silk, but as he pulled it out, it sprang into the world’s thinnest and sharpest blade .

Ping!

He swished the sword upwards, and a jet black ray flashed past me!

This is the most beautiful moment I have witnessed in the real world! Rays of sunlight scattered onto the jet black sword, and its cruel killing intent was made stronger by this contrast of warm sunlight blending with the chilly sword!

The seven individuals opposite were also staring at Shen Qi like fools!

Gaoqin Jiuye wielded Shen Qi gracefully, which was two meters long!

The long and thin blade was extremely steady and it did not even waver when high in the air!

“Wrath of the gods, the prayers of ten thousand, the sorrows of the living and the dead, Shen Qi is indeed one of the four living weapons!”

The seven opposite started to sing praises of the weapon!

I was a little resentful, Piercer is also one of the four living weapons, a beautiful weapon with a length of more than two meters, why did it feel like it was not as great as this Shen Qi?

Gaoqin Jiuye smirked . “Is this the time to praise your enemy?”

Immediately after, he lightly flicked his right wrist .

“Ping!” The swish of the sword produced a bright and clear sound, generating dark rays!

A pencil-thin ray of black and red light flew into the air, just like the northern lights!

The seven opposite us were mesmerized! Although they looked dumb and idiotic, I had the same expression at this moment! Those slender rays were just too beautiful! A slim arc of jet black with a little bit of blood red formed in the air, just like an arc of water, it was blooming in the air!

Slash!

A more beautiful sight was that of those seven heads flying into the air .

Fresh blood splattered everywhere in the sunlight, prettier than watercolor!

It is indeed true that the more beautiful it is, the deadlier it will be...

I shook my head at those seven heads in the air, surprised expressions still on their faces . I know their abilities, and if they had seen Shen Qi before, they would not have been so enthralled and this careless . Not only was the light produced by Shen Qi ravishing, its speed was comparable to that of lightning!

Before I could blow raspberries to boo at these people, Gaoqin Jiuye used his other hand to bring out several charms!

As he chanted, the seven charms stuck themselves onto those seven heads, and they instantly dropped to the ground!

As he chanted, the seven charms stuck themselves onto those seven heads, and they instantly dropped to the ground!

This scene was too beautiful for me to continue watching... So I chose to look at Shen Qi instead .

Shen Qi was back at Gaoqin Jiuye's waist, looking like a black belt!

"This Shen Qi of yours..." I pointed at his waist, wanting to speak, but at a loss for words .

Gaoqin Jiuye looked at me playfully, and excitement flashed in his hazel eyes . "I know he is pretty . Actually, Piercer can be like this too . Piercer is cursed, so she'd be much more ravishing . "

I held my head high proudly . "Of course my Piercer would be beautiful . "

Gaoqin Jiuye mocked, "I'm saying when she comes alive . Your Piercer right now is in a dormant state, how could it be beautiful . "

"Dormant?" I was stunned .

Gaoqin Jiuye nodded . “What? Since you already know we have living weapons, don’t you know these weapons can be in two states – dormant or resurrected?”

I shook my head, Ta Lai did not mention this before .

“Living weapons are named so because they have been created with a part of a living person, and because Piercer was created with an entirely intact piece of human skin, it has a malicious aura . ”

Human skin... My face twitched as I looked at the soft whip glowing with a faint violet light .

“I cannot say too much about Piercer, but it might not be a bad thing that she is dormant now . I suggest not trying to tame Piercer, it is different from Shen Qi . Though the soul in Shen Qi is not a kind one either, at least he obeys me . I’ve never seen the soul in Piercer submit to anyone, she’s merely a bloodthirsty and rebellious soul . My advice is to return it to where you got it from as soon as possible . ”

I listened to Gaoqin Jiuye’s words carefully, but my eyes were on those seven severed heads on the ground . They were motionless and their eyes were staring into the air, with those charms still stuck on their faces . Their bodies remained stiffly in their original position .

“What happened to them?” I pointed at the seven, asking Gaoqin Jiuye .

Gaoqin Jiuye put his hands back into his pockets . “I’m temporarily restricting their movement with these charms, since they won’t seem to listen to either of us . Being in such a beautiful place, I’m not in the mood for a fight either . So, I’m letting them be good for a while . ”

Gaoqin Jiuye put his hands back into his pockets . “I’m temporarily restricting their movement with these charms, since they won’t seem to listen to either of us . Being in such a beautiful place, I’m not in the mood for a fight either . So, I’m letting them be good for a while . ”

I thought of something and frowned . “If I remember right, the charms just need to be attached to a part of the body, why did you decapitate them?”

Gaoqin Jiuye tilted his head, his dark brown hair was rather long and covered half of his eye . There was a glint in his dark hazel eyes, and his lips formed an arc in a slight smile . “Because, I like it . ”

...

I was speechless .

I thought it was because the opponent was too strong that he had to use Shen Qi . In the end, it was because he wanted to show it off to distract the enemy, and take advantage of the opportunity to use the charms!

Are all men in the Split Zone horrid like this...

“What should we do next?” I asked while looking at those severed heads and the seven standing corpses .

Gaoqin Jiuye shrugged . “Bring me around to continue exploring . Let’s leave them here . ”

Cold sweat formed on my forehead . “You’re not planning to go back to the Split Zone?”

“Didn’t they say that this was Old Man Fan’s doing? Since Old Man Fan did it for you, he would have provided you a way to return . Don’t be so anxious, the method will find you eventually . Moreover, as long as they were in the Western District, they would have arrived in this crack in space . This means that the others will be able to find us, and our teammates will be here sooner or later . Everything will be alright, so let’s continue exploring the area . ”

Gaoqin Jiuye looked excited and curious, and continued to look around the area, as if he had never seen anything in the real world before .

What positive thinking...

It's just an excuse to continue having fun here...

Alright, since the situation is as it is, why not do as he says . Considering Jiao S and Jie Pa's intelligence, they'd be able to find me very quickly . As for Nie Zun, just where did he go, why would he be separated from me...

“Let's go, stop blanking out . Those few would be immobilized for at least 60 hours, but I don't know how time works in this crack in space . Let's go .”

I looked at the figure of Gaoqin Jiuye from the back, and hurriedly caught up .

“Let's go, stop blanking out . Those few would be immobilized for at least 60 hours, but I don't know how time works in this crack in space . Let's go .”

I looked at the figure of Gaoqin Jiuye from the back, and hurriedly caught up .

“You're not going to look for your first love?” Gaoqin Jiuye suddenly asked .

My heart hurt as soon as I reminded myself of Gao Qi's pallid face . “No, knowing he is still alive is already enough for me . He can't see me anyway .”

“Hehe, now that you know he's alive, are you more intent in finding your soul splitter so that you can return here to be in love with him?” Gaoqin Jiuye's voice sounded slightly off .

I took a deep breath . “No . No matter what, it is a fact that I almost killed him . To this world, I'm merely a sinner who shouldn't exist . Why come back here .”

Gaoqin Jiuye turned back quickly, holding me by the shoulders, he had a cold gleam in his eyes . “You just love to take responsibility for everything? That's a bad habit .”

I looked up at him . “Who would be used to this? But the fact is, it is my fault . Some things just cannot be resolved . ”

“So running away can solve the issue?” Gaoqin Jiuye continued .

I was silent for a moment, then I spoke, “Gaoqin Jiuye, have you never thought of running away?”

His gaze seemed to waver, but it was only for a moment . “I had to pay a high price for running away, so I don’t wish for you to go on the same path . ”

I scoffed, “So this is for my own good? Didn’t know you had it in you to be kind to me...”

It might be because I’ve always been ruthless when chiding him, or it was my tired expression that made him more affectionate in that moment . Unexpectedly, he lifted his hand to stroke my hair .

I could almost hear the sound of my hair moving as his fingers swept through my red hair .

“Indeed I am curious . Just why do I feel like I want to be kind to you?”

This voice close to my ear was eerily similar to that of Gao Qi’s enchanting voice .

Chapter 101

Volume 2

101 Gan Jiang Mo Ye

(T/n: Gan Jiang and Mo Ye refer to a swordsmith couple in Chinese legend.)

Such intimacy was familiar yet foreign, and I backed away slightly in my uneasiness.

Gaoqin Jiuye's expression darkened.

I thought for a moment, and decided to change the topic. "Oh yes, I wanted to ask you some things about Piercer."

"Go ahead," Gaoqin Jiuye said as he slotted a hand back into his pocket.

"The person who gave me Piercer is named Zou An. He's the owner of a weapon shop in the Western District. His wife, Ah Wen, died in the course of this experiment. She was harmed by You Ji."

Gaoqin Jiuye's gaze momentarily turned cold. "Yes, I'm aware of that. I investigated it."

"Ah Wen and you seemed to be old friends. Why didn't you avenge her when you saw You Ji?"

Gaoqin Jiuye looked at me squarely. "Avenge? Dead people can't be revived. Furthermore, there are many other complicated issues entangled within. It's not as simple as you think it is."

“So what if it’s complicated. You probably won’t care no matter how complicated it is, since you do everything solely for Si Luo.”

Gaoqin Jiuye smirked. “You were hoping I could put myself in your position to consider things?”

“You’re reading too much into this,” I said while rolling my eyes at him.

“Also,” I turned serious. “I saw Zou An after Ah Wen’s death, and he’s putting the blame on me for what happened. Could you tell me a little about him, since he seemed to have known you as well? I don’t wish for that misunderstanding of his to continue.”

Gaoqin Jiuye’s gaze dimmed. “He might perhaps be aware that you were not at fault, but in order for him to continue having the will to live, he needs to direct his hatred at something.”

“Hatred? Then why is he hating me and not You Ji? Although I might not have been a responsible district commander, Ah Wen’s death wasn’t something I wished for either. Why is everyone blaming me?” I suddenly felt so wronged, and this might be due to the fact that he did not defend me on the matter.

Gaoqin Jiuye sighed. “What I meant was, I hope you can understand him. Zou An is a pitiful person. Though I always find it a bother to tell stories, I’ll just tell you more about him.”

Cut the bullshit and be quick about it...

“Zou An and Ah Wen were a loving couple who had lived in the Split Zone for many years, and they opened a weapon shop in the Southern District because they both had a passion for the research and development of weapons. Days in the Split Zone might have gotten a little lonely, as Ah Wen suddenly had a grand wish.”

“What was her wish?” I asked while crinkling my brows.

“She wanted a child.”

“What? A child? How can the consciousness in the Split Zone produce a child!” I was shocked. This was not only an extravagant wish, it was something that can never be realized!

Gaoqin Jiuye glanced at me coldly as he continued, “You really don’t know the real purpose of the Split Zone. That place is where we depend on MF to live, and MF comes from our subconsciousness, that is, our mental strength within us. Technically, as long as our mental strength is strong enough, there is nothing we can’t do.”

“Nothing we can’t do? Even so, having a child should be impossible, wouldn’t it? Even if one had the willpower, a child can’t possibly appear out of nowhere. If the child was created with MF, then it wouldn’t be a real child either.”

“That’s the reason why there is a high price to pay to realize such wishes. The more difficult it is to get what you want, the greater the sacrifice you’d have to make. It was initially a mere thought, but over time, Ah Wen wished for it more and more. I can understand why she had such a wish, but you might not be able to empathize with her. You haven’t tasted the loneliness in the Split Zone, since you’ve only been there for less than two years. But this is especially so for lovers, when they see each other every day and there’s nothing else to do. Even love cannot ease such loneliness.”

I admit that what he said made sense. *But, Gaoqin Jiuye, how can you be so sure that I am not able to empathize? I lie on my bed every single day, practicing my skills with the bow and arrow, and you think I’m not lonely? But Split Zone 13 is a place with no escape. Should we then all start hoping for something that we definitely won’t be able to obtain?*

I no longer want to go through the experience of hankering for something that did not belong to me, and end up paying some unknown price for it.

Seeing that I was silent, Gaoqin Jiuye continued, “Ah Wen and Zou An’s desire for a child grew day after day. Finally, someone named Cang Ming found them, and told them that he could fulfil their wish, as long as they forged a living weapon for him.”

“Who’s Cang Ming?”

Gaoqin Jiuye’s gaze looked unfocused for a moment. “He’s also a soul splitter, from the Northern District’s Ghost Gate.”

Ghost Gate??

Did this Ghost Gate refer to one of the three huge doors labeled ‘Heaven’, ‘Ghost’ and ‘Exit’ Song Lu and Yu Liang saw in the Northern District?

“What’s... Ghost Gate? Why would there be soul splitters there?”

Gaoqin Jiuye seemed briefly shocked at my ignorance, but he regained his composure quickly. “It’s nothing much. I can’t explain in too much detail to you about Northern District matters. I can only tell you that Cang Ming is a notorious soul splitter in Split Zone 13, known as ‘Satan’s Soul’.”

“Satan’s Soul... What a cool nickname...”

Gaoqin Jiuye seemed amused by my awed expression, and his eyes shone for a fleeting moment. “He’s a devilish character who appears relatively often, and many want him dead. However, he’s still living freely with ‘Satan’ as his moniker. He’ll sometimes appear in the Eastern, Western and Southern Districts. What I’ve heard is that there will be bloodshed and mourning wherever he goes.”

Another devil...

“Being so mysterious, nobody really knows Cang Ming’s whereabouts. There are many legends about him, and I’m drunk on the fact that as a district commander, you actually know nothing of this character.” (T/n: ‘Being drunk’ is Chinese slang used when faced with a situation that one finds absurd or ridiculous, and is usually used as a scornful remark. The phrase describes a state where one doesn’t even bother to give any reaction or reply because he or she is too drunk to do so.)

Do you need to use slang when chiding me? That’s intelligent...

“So he had a method for Ah Wen and Zou An?” I asked.

“That’s right. I hear that there’s nothing he can’t do, and he’s an evil maniac just like Satan. He can fulfil your desires, but he can also bring you ultimate pain.”

Ultimate pain... Isn't 'ultimate' usually used to describe something positive...? How horrid would ultimate pain be then...

“Anyway, there used to be only three living weapons in the Split Zone – ‘Sealer’, ‘Leopard Slasher’, and my ‘Shen Qi’. Cang Ming wanted a living weapon of his own, one filled with absolute malice. So, he looked for the couple who were good at forging weapons, and requested for a living weapon. In exchange for that, he promised to give them a child of their own.”

“This deal sounds pretty good. But like you said, since Cang Ming was just like Satan, the price for it would probably be high...” I muttered.

Gaoqin Jiuye nodded in agreement. “Yes, it’s not a simple task to create living weapons. A voluntary soul, that is, somebody’s consciousness, would have to be willing to be sacrificed. I don’t know how Ah Wen and Zou An created Piercer, but I know that it was made by them, and it is powerful.”

“What else?” I unconsciously reached out to touch the violet whip hanging at my waist, and suddenly felt like I wanted to know more about its past.

“After Piercer was finished, the couple passed it to Cang Ming’s maidservant, Bian Ying, since he was nowhere to be found. Bian Ying gave the couple a pill in return, telling Ah Wen that she’ll have a child within seven days of swallowing the pill. Bian Ying took Piercer, and Ah Wen took the pill.”

“Wait,” I interrupted Gaoqin Jiuye as I heard the familiar name. “Bian Ying? Who is she?”

“She’s Cang Ming’s maidservant. You might have heard Ta Lai mention it, as she used to be his lover. I don’t know what happened between them, but I know that she’s serving Cang Ming now. She’s the only one who can reach Satan Cang Ming and also the only one who knows everything about him.

Word has it that she fell in love with Cang Ming at first sight, and could even abandon Ta Lai for him. But I'm not too sure about the details, since these are just stories about the soul splitters."

I grew silent. Ta Lai always seemed calm and composed, and if I did not witness him having a nightmare, there is no way I would believe he could be that loyal to any woman. It seemed to be a memory filled with heartache, or Ta Lai would not be trapped by that recurring nightmare of his.

"Ah Wen did give birth to a child after seven days, and the process of labour and delivery was exactly like what would happen in the real world, but with a much shorter duration. Zou An and Ah Wen were elated at having a child, and did not have further worries. What's weird is that the child grew and cried like normal children in the real world did. The child grew very quickly, and not long after, the child already looked like a one-year-old."

I shivered as I listened. That was way too weird.

"However, something shocking happened. Living weapons can either be dormant or resurrected, and resurrected living weapons are like another soul, becoming partners to their owners during fights. Piercer resurrected on its own before Bian Ying could hand it over to Cang Ming, and it devoured Bian Ying's consciousness."

"What?" I was stunned. Piercer can devour consciousness?

"Yes. I don't know how it happened either. From this, we already can see that Piercer is different from the other three living weapons."

"Bian Ying, she..."

Gaoqin Jiuye's eyes darkened. "If it was somebody else, it would be equivalent to death. Luckily for her, Bian Ying is an outlier. Apart from you, she's the only one with double identity disorder in the Split Zone."

Chapter 102

102 I want to go back!

“What? She’s the one Li Qing was referring to? The only other person with double identity disorder who appeared in the Split Zone?”

Gaoqin Jiuye nodded . “That’s right . Double identity disorder is already unusual in itself, and having the two separate personalities captured and brought to the Split Zone at the same time is something almost impossible, unless other unique factors were at play – just like how Nie Zun’s personality and that of yours coincided . In Bian Ying’s case, it was something else . I’m not sure what it was but what I know is that Piercer devoured one of her personalities, causing her to become someone with an incomplete consciousness . ”

Incomplete consciousness...

“Satan Cang Ming was furious when he found out about this, and tortured the couple for more than 10 days . Nobody knew what happened in that time, but in the end, he wanted to take the child away, and he also wanted Ah Wen’s life . I know the couple because I was the one who rescued them . ”

“How did you save them?” I cautiously asked, sensing that it was not as simple as it sounded .

Gaoqin Jiuye glanced at me . “Curiosity killed the cat . ”

I shrugged . “But I’m not a cat . ”

“Anyway, the couple moved out of the Southern District after that, and I didn’t ask where they were going either . Zou An is pitiful, and now that his

wife and child have left him, I just hope you can understand him . ”

Understand him...

I don't blame him actually... It's because he loved Ah Wen too deeply that he hates me so . Any kind of hatred, no matter how misplaced or illogical it is, would probably be worthy of redemption if it was for love .

“There's nothing much I resent . They've gone through so much, and as a district commander, I wasn't able to provide them with the peace and serenity they hoped for when they chose to live anonymously in the Western District . That's my fault, of course,” I said with a rueful smile .

Gaoqin Jiuye probably did not expect it, as he seemed rather surprised to hear me say something like this .

What I'm more concerned about is how you managed to save the couple . Since you mentioned that Cang Ming is just like Satan, how could it be possible that he didn't pursue the matter further? How did you save them? Gaoqin Jiuye, just what secrets are you hiding?

The more important question is, why would you actually do something for this poor couple? You're cruel and ruthless . Apart from Si Luo, you don't seem to care about anything or anyone else . Does this mean that all this time, you're not the kind of person whom everyone thought you were?

My thoughts raced as I looked at his eyes .

“I haven't talked so much in a long time . It's rather tiring . Let's go, bring me around . ” There was a fleeting moment of warmth which swept past those eyes of his .

When I thought I was mistaken, he suddenly grabbed my hand and started walking .

I was utterly stunned .

Lowering my head, I looked at his hand that was holding mine . This action of his was done so smoothly and felt so natural .

Gaoqin Jiuye... What kind of person are you?

As I looked up at his cold and handsome features, I felt that he indeed shared some similarities with Gao Qi . All of a sudden, a thought flashed by me . What if it wasn't a coincidence that he looked so much like Gao Qi?

Could there be a correlation here...

“Oh, bring me to see you,” Gaoqin Jiuye interrupted my train of thought .

“Hm? See, see... me?” I was slightly surprised .

“Yeah, to see ‘you’ . ”

To see me... The me who is now lying in a psychiatric hospital?

“Let's go, stop running away,” that firm and enchanting voice sounded in my ear .

Before long, we were in the hospital .

“Since not much time has passed here, it should still be the same room . Right here . ” For some reason, even though I could not smell the odor of disinfectant used in this familiar hospital, I still felt a chilly aura in the surroundings .

“Since not much time has passed here, it should still be the same room . Right here . ” For some reason, even though I could not smell the odor of disinfectant used in this familiar hospital, I still felt a chilly aura in the surroundings .

Feeling a little exhausted, I leaned against the corridor, looking at the familiar room in front of me .

“Not going in? I'm going in . ” Gaoqin Jiuye actually smiled at me while saying this .

In my moment of hesitation, he pulled me by the hand into the room before I could protest further .

Just like spirits which could pass through walls, we passed through the door and went into the ward .

Nothing has changed here . There was one single bed, a small drawer by the side, and on the windowsill still stood the cactus plant I like .

There was no one in the room but a pallid girl on a respirator lying on the bed .

I twitched my lip . “It’s weird looking at myself like this . It felt like I was watching a movie back then in the Great Hall, but this right now, it’s quite an experience . ”

Gaoqin Jiuye did not seem to pay attention to my muttering and kept his gleaming eyes on the ‘me’ who lay on the bed .

He turned back and looked into my eyes . For the first time, his voice was gentle and warm, and it did not carry the slightest hint of chill, “Maybe you really should think about how to go back . ”

I was stunned by his words .

I looked at him in surprise, and his eyes contained an emotion I could not comprehend .

This... is it heartache, or is it... something apologetic? Why would he be apologetic??

Why did he have such an expression on his face...

I furrowed my brows as I was not used to seeing such eyes, and I did not want to see these previously suppressed emotions .

But I knew it was useless, as it was always difficult to warm people’s hearts .

But I knew it was useless, as it was always difficult to warm people’s hearts .

“Go back? Heh, back to this body, looking at the cactus every day in this tiny room, telling myself I’m mad?” I mockingly asked as I pointed to that pale face on the bed .

“But look, she’s not happy sleeping there . ” Gaoqin Jiuye walked over to ‘my’ side and reached out his graceful hand . It looked like he was about to touch ‘my’ face, but his fingers eventually sank through the pale skin .

Looking at his fingers, I saw that the skin under ‘my’ eyes seemed dark and tired .

Are you not at peace... Is it because of how I’m living in the Split Zone...

But do you know that no matter how difficult life gets in the Split Zone, it’s still easier there compared to being in this world .

Although the Split Zone is a place of bloodshed, murder and competition, it doesn’t ostracize or mock me, and there’s no isolation or loneliness there .

There are many people with me in Split Zone 13...

Creak—

I looked back as the door opened .

Her face was thin and gaunt, and her eyes were sunken . There were some strands of white in her hair, and it was tousled around her ears .

My mother walked in, looking worn out .

However, her eyes glimmered when she looked at the ‘me’ who lay on the bed, as if she was instantly refreshed . She smiled brightly and quickly walked towards ‘me’ .

“Child, ma is here to see you . Did you dream of anything today? Did you dream of mum? The weather is warmer now . Wake up soon after you’ve slept enough, I’ll bring you out to see the sun . ”

“Child, don’t be afraid, no one will mock you when you wake up . With Dr . Jin’s help, you’ll be well in no time . As long as you wake up, I’ll be by your side to protect you . ”

“Child, here, let me help you clean up, I know you love to be clean...”

“Child, don’t be afraid, no one will mock you when you wake up . With Dr . Jin’s help, you’ll be well in no time . As long as you wake up, I’ll be by your side to protect you . ”

“Child, here, let me help you clean up, I know you love to be clean...”

My tears were already falling, flowing onto my neck and down my chest .

“Ma—!” I screamed .

Her small and frail back seemed to pause for an instant, and her eyes seemed to look around the room as she turned her head back, before she gave a bitter smile and continued to help clean ‘my’ motionless body .

“Ma!” I rushed over as I cried . All my suppressed emotions erupted in an outburst, and I could not think of anything else .

I tried to hug her, but no matter how many times I tried, I felt nothing but cold air .

“Ma—! I’m here! Ma, look at me! Ma!” My vision was blurred and my heart started beating furiously . I was overwhelmed by sorrow .

“She can’t hear you . Don’t cry anymore . ” Gaoqin Jiuye could stand it no longer and walked up behind me . He grabbed me by the shoulders and attempted to stop my arms, which were still flailing and trying to get a hold of my mother .

“She can’t see me! She can’t see me! She can’t see me! Ahhh! Waahhh!” Messy strands of hair stuck to my tear-stained face as I turned around . Grabbing Gaoqin Jiuye by the shoulders, I activated my MF . My sharp nails, together with my fingers, pierced through his shirt into his arms .

Gaoqin Jiuye looked sympathetic, and he looked like he could not bear to do so, but he held me down firmly, saying, “You . You calm down, Li Shen .”

My vision fogged up with tears once again, and Gaoqin Jiuye’s face became distorted .

Calm down... I can’t calm down!

I thought I didn’t care, that I didn’t want to return, I thought living in the Split Zone was good . I thought I could live like that forever, punishing myself for what I did to Gao Qi, not needing any redemption!

I only discovered today that I had wanted to return so badly, that the only thing left for me to do was to run away from my wishes and not carry any hopes from the moment I realized I wasn’t alive!

Although I knew there was no hope, I still wanted to go back...

Chapter 103

Volume 2

103 The Rebirthing Technique

“Ma!” I was crying in agony again. Gaoqin Jiuye grabbed me and activated his MF, bringing me out of the hospital.

“Let go of me!” My throat was hoarse from all that screaming.

“Li Shen!” Gaoqin Jiuye shook me as he stared at my tear-stricken face.
“She cannot see you! If you don’t want her to be sad, go back to the Split Zone, find your soul splitter, and find a way to return! Crying won’t solve anything!”

Crying won't solve anything...

But I still feel like crying!

I know that crying doesn't solve anything, but I still want to cry!

I was crumbling, and my tears seemed to be stained with something red.

The world seemed to be going topsy-turvy, and I could hear nothing but Gaoqin Jiuye’s anxious shouting in my ear.

“Shen’er...”

It's Nie Zun's voice... Where are you, Nie Zun...

Nie Zun, I want to cry...

The world is spinning, why is it spinning...

Why do the tears in my eyes look red...

I'm so dizzy...

I can't hear Gaoqin Jiuye's voice anymore...

So dizzy...

“Ah Shen, Ah Shen.”

A voice which sounded aged but steady appeared in my mind. It reverberated through my ear, travelling to my heart, and eventually sounded in my brain.

All I could see was a swirling, blood-red world.

So dizzy... The world is distorting, whirling, red, everything is red.

“Ah Shen, I'm Old Man Fan.”

Is it Grandpa Fan... Grandpa Fan...

Grandpa Fan you're still alive, right...

Why is the world still spinning? Why is it getting redder? Is this blood? Did I kill somebody again?

“Ah Shen, listen to me.”

It really is Grandpa Fan's voice... I want to ask him if he's well, but why can't I speak?

“Ah Shen, whatever you've seen here is a reflection of what you yearn for. This might or might not be the same as what is happening in the real world. Either way, I used this technique to show you what you really want at the bottom of your heart. Ah Shen, I could turn a blind eye to your previous

apathy, but I can't now. Split Zone No. 13 is about to be finished, and I'm really worried about you. I want you to escape from here."

Split Zone is about to be finished... The only place where I can stay will be gone too...

"Ah Shen, amidst all the truth and lies, what is it that you really want? When would you be able to understand?"

What do I need to understand...? What's the point of understanding...? Can I save Gao Qi's life if I understand...?

Once I understand, will there be a place for me, and will there be no more solitude...?

"Ah Shen, this technique of mine is not a spacial transference technique, it's a sealing technique. I sealed the Western District not to get rid of the Seven Demons, but to help you find yourself, and to accept her."

"Ah Shen, double identity disorder is not something to be afraid of. Moreover, she's not with you now. You can't keep running away, you have to accept yourself. How can someone who can't even come to terms with themselves protect others?"

Protect others...

"Anyway, Ah Shen, go back, back to the Split Zone. Don't think too much about what's happening here, this all belongs to you as it's just a reflection of your heart's desires. Because you have a second personality, you have powers that others don't have. Don't ostracize her. You're in solitude because you shun her. Try accepting her, try to accept her."

Try and accept her... The one who killed Gao Qi?

"Ah Shen, this is a dream. Everyone is dreaming. They might not want to wake up, but you have to wake up. Once you hear the sound of the flute, you'll go back, and the Western District will be back to normal. I'll seal the Seven Demons here forever. Don't try and save me, I've already lived long

enough. The Seven Demons are also not as simple as you think they are, without them, it is equivalent to You Ji having lost both her arms.”

No, what do you mean by you’ve already lived long enough? Don’t leave me!

But, why can’t I open my mouth to speak?!

“This is the rebirthing technique. As its name suggests, I hope it can provide you with a second chance at life. Go back, Ah Shen. Go save your friends, go to the Northern District, and find a way to leave the Split Zone. Stay brave and strong no matter what happens.”

What about you? Old Man Fan, what about you? What method can I use to save you?!

“Ah Shen, remember not to trust anyone too easily. Depend only on yourself, and accept your second personality. Accept her and find your way home.”

“Ah Shen, go back now.”

The blood red color slowly faded, and my heart dropped as I recovered from the dizziness. The sight in front of me started to regain its usual brightness.

It was day.

The Western District was back to normal. Opposite me stood You Ji and Gaoqin Jiuye. Jiao S, Ta Lai, Jie Pa and Nie Zun were near me.

We looked at one another.

There were now pedestrians to be seen and it was obvious that the Western District was restored.

“Thank you, District Commander! It’s all because of you that we could see our families, thank you for this great technique!”

“Yes, District Commander. Although they weren’t able to see me, I haven’t been this close to my family for years! It’s all thanks to you. We’ll definitely remain loyal to you, and we believe that you’ll be able to find a way to leave this place!”

A few of the residents saw me and started surrounding me.

I was confused.

What is happening??

Nie Zun stepped out, and explained to the residents with a friendly smile, “This is the District Commander’s technique. She felt sorry for not being very involved in Western District matters, and did this to make it up to everyone. We hope all of you can spread the news, and work together in finding a way to leave this place.”

“Alright, we’ll get going now.”

“What’s the situation now?” You Ji suddenly shouted.

“Get out of the Western District, traitor!” A resident passing by shouted and stared at her.

You Ji looked startled, and my expression was not pleasant either.

After a long moment, Jie Pa adjusted his glasses and sighed. “Seems like this is Old Man Fan’s technique. The spacial transference brought everyone to the crack in space, and Old Man Fan probably brought them to the places they wanted to go, allowing them to meet with their family and friends. Although the residents can see their family members once a year, after spending a long time here, they start to lose hope and also lose their will to return. Old Man Fan used this to rekindle a tiny flame of hope in everyone, and gave all the credit to you.”

“Are you kidding? Why didn’t I see my family?” You Ji shouted angrily.

Jie Pa looked at her coldly. “How should I know.”

No, that's not right. Although what Jie Pa said made sense and can explain everything that's happening now, I did hear Old Man Fan's voice when I was still in a daze!

Old Man Fan said this isn't spacial transference, it's a sealing technique!

'They might not wake up, but you have to wake up.'

I was reminded of Old Man Fan's words.

Was everything a dream?

The Western District didn't disappear?

But why would Rong Jin and Gaoqin Jiuye appear here? Everyone had been bewitched?

“Kakakaka, what an interesting technique.” As it was daytime, Rong Jin's shadow appeared clearly on the ground.

“Old Man Fan's body is still here,” said Jie Pa as he pointed at the stone statue.

I decided not to ponder too much about this. Since Grandpa Fan has already prepared all this for me, I shall not let him down!

I took Piercer in my right hand, feeling its chill through my MF.

Piercer, if you really have a soul, if you are a living weapon, open your eyes and take a look. Look at this woman who killed the one that created you! I thought to myself as I activated my MF, staring squarely at You Ji opposite.

You Ji might have sensed something amiss because of my gaze, and she looked at me oddly, as I held Piercer up high.

“You Ji, since the Western District has been restored, how about you tell me the location of Du Yue's experimental grounds?” I gave her an unfeeling smile.

You Ji tossed her green hair. “What if I don’t tell you?”

I smirked, “Then you won’t be able to leave!”

Gaoqin Jiuye abruptly asked, “You Ji, was it you who sent someone to kill Ah Wen?”

You Ji paused for a moment before she replied, “I don’t know what you’re talking about.”

Gaoqin Jiuye’s eyes narrowed, while You Ji turned to Ta Lai, asking, “I know you’ve been looking for Bian Ying. Du Yue is also looking for her. You know what would happen if Du Yue finds her before you do, right? How about we make a deal.”

Ta Lai’s elegant and refined smile remained this time as Bian Ying’s name was mentioned. Moving the jade stone ring on his finger, he said, “You Ji, I know you well even if others don’t. Work with you? I’m not that dumb.”

“Lala, I’m a little duckie~”

...

Gaoqin Jiuye’s expression turned grim as he took the call.

“Rong Jin, go back with me now,” Gaoqin Jiuye said coldly after hanging up.

I have never seen Gaoqin Jiuye with such an absolute, cold and piercing gaze.

The dark shadow quivered slightly as it produced a ghostly voice, “Seems like there’s a situation. Alright, hahahahahaha I’ll go with you. But Gaoqin Jiuye, don’t even think about playing tricks.”

Before the ghostly voice could finish, Gaoqin Jiuye was already hundreds of meters away from us.

The ghostly shadow wobbled, and Rong Jin disappeared from You Ji’s side.

Jiao S tightened her gaze. “There must be something happening at Si Luo’s side, or else those two wouldn’t have left so quickly.”

“Do you want to go and have a look?” I asked, concerned.

Jiao S shook her head stiffly. “They won’t let me follow. I’ll think of another way.”

I then realized You Ji made use of the opportunity in the slight chaos to back away from us.

Chapter 104

104 Du Yue, the Soul Splitter

Without hesitation, I swung Piercer with my right hand!

Electric violet light flew towards You Ji!

“You Ji, don’t even think about leaving if you don’t tell us where Du Yue’s experimental grounds are!” I stared at her angrily .

Sizzle!

The violet ray dazzled like lightning, and in her astonishment, it looked as if she could not dodge the attack in time!

“Roar!” Right above the violet electricity, a ball of fire appeared in mid-air!

Boom!

We shielded our eyes and backed away . The sheer force of the collision pushed all of us back . Jiao S’s black hair flew wildly in the wind as she focused her MF to stifle the impact from the resulting explosion!

Although the powerful impact was countered, our feet left marks in the ground as the impact forcefully pushed us back!

Jiao S glanced at me . “What power!”

I remained silent and frowned as I felt a chill from where I held Piercer in my right hand .

This chill was not the kind of chill felt when touching something cold . It felt like a twisted, disgusting and terrible kind of chill that was gnawing at my heart .

My right hand shivered, but I forcefully suppressed the feeling .

I kept my eyes on Piercer . Was this its power? So it's like this . Such great power can be harnessed as long as the MF is well-controlled .

Then again, where did that ball of fire come from?

After the smoke and dust settled, a handsome figure appeared opposite .

I thought the tall figure belonged to a man, but I did not expect to see such a delicate face!

The visitor was in a deep purple tight-fitting top, and her jacket that looked like it was made of fox fur ended at her waist . She was in a high-waisted pair of dark green pants and dark green high-cut boots . Her mulberry-colored hair was worn in a high ponytail, and she exuded both beauty and aloofness in her exquisite features, making it difficult to determine her character .

She was an extraordinarily tall woman, among one of the tallest I have ever seen . Those slender legs tightly wrapped in dark green could easily lead others into fantasies .

Her beautiful eyes seemed to be warm but cold at the same time, and her gaze was firm and clear . She stood diagonally in front of You Ji and behind her was a qilin which produced sparks from its mouth continuously! (T/n: The qilin is a four-legged mythical creature in Chinese legend .)

It was not accurate to call it a qilin, since it did not look quite like one either . It was a creature likely created by combining two different animals together . It had blood-red eyes and there was incessant firelight in its mouth!

The most eye-catching thing about this woman, however, was not her dressing or the monster behind her . It was her left arm!

Her left arm was empty, she had no arm, and there was no sleeve!

Not only did she not look weird without an arm, this look matched her aura perfectly . There was nothing unsightly about it!

“You are... Du Yue?” I asked, horrified .

This one-armed woman said in a crisp voice, “That’s right . ”

I felt spooked . Although Huan Qing already told me about how frightening she was, I felt a different kind of fear when faced with her right now!

This fear of mine did not come from being afraid of her, nor was it because of her ferocious looks . This fear was a feeling of terror from a unique kind of aura that one instinctively knew did not belong in this world . The fear when one witnesses something never before seen!

Ta Lai stepped forward, positioning himself in front of us . I could not see his face, only his upright figure from the back .

“You found your way here . ” Ta Lai sounded calm .

I was creeped out by the peculiar expression which formed on Du Yue’s delicate face . She looked as if she was high on drugs in that very moment!

Du Yue continued speaking with that expression, “How can I not be here when you’ve appeared . I hear you’re here to help a little girl who’s a newcomer to the Split Zone? Come on, let me meet her . You know I’ll make her life hell as long as it’s a woman who has a close relationship with you . ”

She said this naturally and calmly, as if she was talking about the weather .

But I felt heat rising up within me, almost as if I just came out of the sauna .

You Ji, who was standing behind her, suddenly pinned her eyes on me, and formed a bizarre smile with her lips .

You Ji, who was standing behind her, suddenly pinned her eyes on me, and formed a bizarre smile with her lips .

This smile angered me . Forgetting about the disturbing aura from that one-armed woman, I stepped forward .

“That little newcomer you’re talking about is me . Let me see how exactly you can make my life hell today!” I said frostily, without a second thought .

Du Yue looked at me for a brief moment, before shifting her gaze to Piercer, which was in my hand .

Her eyes shone brightly . “You really deserve to die!”

“Roar!” The fiery qilin charged towards me as soon as she said that .

I kept my gaze icy as I swung Piercer!

Pu-sst!

“Stop!”

Ta Lai said loudly in a cold and solemn voice!

Du Yue stared with her beautiful eyes as she raised her only arm in the air!

With her raised arm, the fiery qilin promptly turned back and returned to her side!

The fireball which came out of its mouth collided with Piercer’s violet light once again!

“Du Yue, Gaoqin Jiuye left only moments before you arrived . If I remember right, it’s been a while since you last met, don’t you want to see him?” Ta Lai’s voice lost its usual serenity, and carried a hint of gloominess .

Du Yue's frown deepened as she heard the words 'Gaoqin Jiuye' .

"Du Yue, just what do you want?" Ta Lai sounded exasperated .

"I want Bian Ying dead," Du Yue said calmly, without hesitation .

"I don't care what you want, return Song Lu and Yu Liang to me!" I shouted at her, annoyed at how conceited she looked!

"Song Lu isn't with me, and Yu Liang is currently in an experimental barrel in the Southern District . Do you want to visit him?" Du Yue remained composed as she spoke .

"Song Lu isn't with me, and Yu Liang is currently in an experimental barrel in the Southern District . Do you want to visit him?" Du Yue remained composed as she spoke .

"You?!" I wanted to charge at her, but Jiao S held me back .

Jiao S's looked at me with large, listless eyes, signalling that I should not act rashly .

I took a deep breath and tried to calm myself down .

"You sacrificed so many lives in the Split Zone for all those experiments of yours, just to find a way to kill Bian Ying?" Ta Lai sounded pained .

Du Yue's gaze was steady and composed . "That's right . I just want her dead at all costs . If she doesn't die, your heart will be with her forever . You will only look at me if she dies . "

No matter what she says, her tone remained the same . It was neither urgent nor anxious, and there was no change in pitch .

What a unique woman .

No wonder Gaoqin Jiuye favors her . Such a woman will always be able to attract the attention of others no matter where she is . Before her, I have only sensed such aura from Li Qing .

But Li Qing was different . She had an unrestrained, debonair feel .

“What is your goal now that you’ve arrived here?” Nie Zun, who was quiet all this while, abruptly spoke, a slight smile on his face .

Du Yue’s eyes fell on Nie Zun and for a fleeting moment, she looked surprised . But she regained her usual expression in an instant . “I’m here to see Ta Lai of course, and also, to bring You Ji back . ”

You Ji spoke softly, “Du Yue, you’ve heard about what happened in the Western District from the little snakes I sent, right? The spacial transference is now undone, and what’s left is that stone statue . ”

She pointed in the direction of Old Man Fan .

I widened my eyes, “Don’t even think about touching Old Man Fan!”

You Ji smiled mockingly . “I’ll have to defer to Du Yue on this . ”

I shifted my gaze to Du Yue .

Du Yue looked at me and spoke calmly, “No need to stare at me . I have no interest in your Western District nor your friends . You’re not even worthy of my interest . The experimental ground in the Western District is on the 27th floor of the Residence, and I’m no longer using it . The screams of the Western District residents sound horrible, and I don’t like this place anymore . Your friends – the couple – seem slightly more interesting . I heard that you lost the girl, but no need to look for her, I’ll just find her and continue my experiment . As for that little girl, you can give up searching for her, I want her for sure . ”

“Huh, what a maniac, are all soul splitters this haughty? No wonder Ta Lai doesn’t like you, if I were a man, I wouldn’t like you either!” I gave her a smug smile as I spoke, criticizing her with every word .

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Don't think that I, Li Shen, can be bullied!

As expected, a ruthless glare escaped her eyes after I spoke .

“You really want to die . ”

Ta Lai spoke up abruptly, “Enough . If you take her life, don't you even wish to see me again!”

Du Yue suddenly laughed, and her soft, red lips curved into a pretty angle . “Do you think you can threaten me? The more you want to protect her, the more I'd want to destroy her . But don't you worry, I don't have the time to play with a little girl now . I should concentrate my effort in killing your lover, Bian Ying, am I right?”

Her eyes were looking at Ta Lai with passionate emotion as she asked ‘Am I right?’ .

This is a woman who went crazy for love...

I felt a sense of helplessness .

Why does this craziness make me discriminate it so, yet it felt so familiar?

Was I like this too, to Gao Qi...

How frightening was I...

My heart skipped a beat .

Nie Zun's hand was on my shoulder, and I saw his starry eyes as I looked up .

I have not seen these eyes in a long time, and I felt a sense of nostalgia . I miss them even though they are so close .

“How about this, I'll go back to the Northern District with you, and you promise that you'll give up your experimental grounds in the Western District, and don't let You Ji step one foot into the Western District in future . ” What Ta Lai said sounded like a compromise .

Is he not confident to face off against Du Yue?

Chapter 105

105 Different Means to the Same End

Du Yue paused for a while before she finally nodded . “Alright, I’ll promise you . Return to the Northern District with me, and I will not step foot into the Western District ever again . ”

You Ji hastily added, “But my Seven Demons are still nowhere to be found, and we’re just going to leave the Western District experimental grounds like this...”

“Don’t forget your promise to me, You Ji . The Seven Demons have extraordinary abilities, but there are still others more powerful than them . I’ll provide you with stronger subordinates,” said Du Yue firmly .

You Ji shot a sharp look at me, her eyes filled with hatred . I stared back at her .

“Where’re the Seven Demons? Why don’t I sense their presence even after the Western District is restored?” You Ji asked me angrily .

“Old Man Fan sealed the Seven Demons, and I don’t know how to release them either,” I decided to tell her honestly .

Although I blame You Ji for betraying me, I know she cares for her subordinates as much as I care for Song Lu and the others . Since we were once as close as sisters, I do not hate her as much even though she let me down .

Agony flashed past You Ji’s eyes, however, she had no choice but to obey Du Yue .

“Alright, bring me back with you too,” You Ji said to Du Yue .

Du Yue nodded, then turned to address Ta Lai, “Let’s go . ”

“Hold on . ” Ta Lai raised his hand as he smiled elegantly .

The world became pitch black in an instant .

It’s that technique to distort the four senses!

I snapped alert, looking at the blackness around me .

“Li Shen, although Du Yue is a cruel character, she keeps her promises . Once I leave with her, she’ll stop her reckless acts in the Western District . Although I can’t see through Old Man Fan’s technique, everything still ended positively . I hope you’ll rebuild the Western District after I’m gone, and I’ll help you gather information about the friend who’s in Du Yue’s hands . If you still trust me, please don’t go searching for her in the meantime . You are still not strong enough to go against her . ”

“Also, don’t forget my training . I hope you’ll be able to perfect your use of Piercer through everything I’ve taught you in the past few days . ”

“One last thing, don’t ever desire to return to the real world . I can help you in all matters, be it rebuilding the Western District or saving your friends, as long as you keep the promise that you won’t return to the real world . Although I don’t know what you witnessed through Old Man Fan’s spacial transference, you can be sure that I’ll be taking your life if you go back on your word . ”

Before I could ask further questions, the world was restored to brightness .

“Where is he?” I looked around . Ta Lai, Du Yue and You Ji were gone, and only the row of us was left .

“What was that?” Jiao S asked, frowning .

“That’s the ability of the man in the navy jacket, Ta Lai . It’s a space that distorts the senses,” I explained patiently after a sudden realisation that all

this was unknown to Jiao S .

“I heard Jie Pa say he is a soul splitter?”

“That’s right, both he and Du Yue are soul splitters . Du Yue is the mastermind behind these experiments, and she’s also the one who injured Huan Qing . Her goal is to develop a method that can kill soul splitters, and for now, it seems like this is all to go against a woman named ‘Bian Ying’ and to compete with her to obtain Ta Lai’s love . ”

Jiao S’s listless eyes gleamed as they widened . “Bian Ying? That unique case in the history of the Split Zone?”

“Seems like you already know about it . Gaoqin Jiuye told me as much, he said her case is identical to mine, someone who arrived in the Split Zone with double identity disorder . But, how is she a soul splitter too?”

“From all we’ve heard so far, the world of soul splitters should be in the Northern District,” said Jie Pa .

“Oh, where did Old Man Fan bring all of you to? Did you meet your families?” I asked curiously .

Pain flashed past Jiao S’s eyes, slightly startling me .

Pain flashed past Jiao S’s eyes, slightly startling me .

Jie Pa met Nie Zun’s eyes, but they did not say a word .

What’s this all about...

But as I thought of my mother, I quietened . Perhaps everyone was in low spirits just like me...

“We’re able to at least get a temporary reprieve now that they’ve all gone . I’ve settled the matters of those who died, and also inspected every single one of my Eastern District residents, so there isn’t much of an issue on my side . You should go to the experimental grounds and settle the issues in the

Western District as soon as you can,” Jiao S told me, turning her neck stiffly .

“Do you need to go over to Si Luo’s side to get a sense of the situation?” I asked cautiously .

Jiao S suddenly looked up at the sky and was silent for a moment . She smiled as she turned back to look at me, her usual pale and stiff face looking a little more lively .

“I’ll go over to take a look now . You’re okay here, right?”

I smiled as I said, “I’m okay . I still have Nie Zun and Jie Pa with me . Seems like the Western District needs new protectors . ”

Jie Pa stepped forward to address me, “Miss Ah Shen, rest assured . My intelligence network is back now that everyone from the Western District has returned . Nie Zun and I have been working for the past year to pick those able to help you protect the Western District . We’ll be able to get to the bottom of this matter . We’ll also think of a way to release Old Man Fan from that sealing technique . ”

I nodded . “Look, Jiao S, I have these two awesome, handsome guys – Jie Pa and Nie Zun with me . I’ll be fine, so you go ahead . I’m not sure what the situation at Si Luo’s side is, but I probably can’t help much before I finish settling the matters here . After I’ve gotten things more or less sorted out, I’ll go with you to investigate what’s happening in the Split Zone and Si Luo’s matters . ”

Jiao S smiled and nodded . “Although we have to part after we’ve just met, and I’m a little reluctant to do so, now is not the time to sit around and chat either . I’ll send someone to investigate in the Southern District, and I’ll help you look into Laurel’s whereabouts . Just like what that person said earlier, your priority should be the matters in the Western District, everything else can be done later . You still have me, and everything can surely be solved, even if our opponents are soul splitters . ”

From the day I got to know her, I have never heard Jiao S say such things to me with such a friendly expression . All I could do was nod .

Jiao S, I will no longer be cowardly . Trust me, I will fight alongside you .

Jiao S also said something else before she left .

Jiao S also said something else before she left .

“Li Shen, although that world is not a nice place, I still want to return . I’m sick of everything in the Split Zone, and even though I’ve found a reason for existence here, I still want to bring Si Luo back . I know you have the same thoughts deep down in your heart, even if you’re not aware of it now .”

I did not answer .

Just like how I did not answer Ta Lai or Li Qing when they asked .

Even now, I am still not certain of my answer . Old Man Fan is right, I should look for what I really want . Gaoqin Jiuye is also right, running away cannot solve anything .

I believe that I will be able to find the answer as long as I continue on this path . What I should believe in, what I should grab hold of, how I should live, where I should live – the answers to these questions will one day be known . I am firm in my belief .

“They’ve all left . It’s just the three of us now .” I arranged my hair and flashed a brilliant smile at Nie Zun and Jie Pa .

“The bamboo hat trio following Miss Jiao S looks really familiar,” Jie Pa suddenly said .

I shrugged . “Haven’t seen their faces, and haven’t witnessed much of their skills either .”

Jie Pa adjusted his glasses . “Miss Ah Shen, I’m going to look for my intelligence network to analyze the current situation in the Western District

and find individuals who will be able to assist you . ”

“What about the experimental grounds?” I asked .

Nie Zun spoke, “Let Jie Pa go first, I want to speak to you . After Jie Pa is done assembling the people, we’ll go to the experimental grounds located in the Residence . ”

“Alright . ” I nodded .

“Both of you go ahead to the Residence first, we’re in front of the Marketplace and you’ll need 10 hours to go back from here . I’ll look for the both of you once I’m done assembling the people . ”

After speaking, Jie Pa walked into the Marketplace building .

I looked at Jie Pa’s figure slowly disappearing into the building in front of me, and looked at the statue of Old Man Fan on the stone ground in front of the building .

After speaking, Jie Pa walked into the Marketplace building .

I looked at Jie Pa’s figure slowly disappearing into the building in front of me, and looked at the statue of Old Man Fan on the stone ground in front of the building .

“Nie Zun, where did you go when we were in the real world? Why were we separated?” I turned back to ask Nie Zun .

Nie Zun gave a slight smile, but for some reason, it did not seem genuine .

“Didn’t you always wish to be separated from me . Now that it’s happened, why’re you asking so much . ” His voice was icy .

My heart knotted slightly . Something was not right about him, and it felt as if he was angry .

But, what was he mad about? What an odd guy! I didn’t provoke you!

I rolled my eyes at him angrily . “That’s right, I can’t wait to be separated from you and I wanted to stay in that crack in space forever so that I wouldn’t have to come back and look at this icy face of yours . You, you, you, what’re you doing?”

Before I could finish, Nie Zun took a big step towards me . His usually indifferent gaze seemed to fill with intense emotion and a burning anger .

He took my head in his gloved hands, and pulled my face towards his . Leaning forward, his gaze locked on mine .

“You, you, what are you doing...” I slowly lost the will to speak . The closer I was to his eyes, the more intense his fiery gaze felt .

“You’re angry...? But what are you, you, you mad at...”

His fingers bent slightly and I felt his grip tighten on the back of my head, as if afraid that I would run away . His voice was no longer idle and indifferent; it was alluring, steeped in layers of emotion . “You really want to just be with him in that crack in space?”

I was a little astounded . What?

“Have you fell in love with him again?” His voice trembled slightly, and I wondered if I had heard wrong .

Chapter 106

106 What the Heart Really Wants

“I fell in love with who again?” I was rather taken aback .

Nie Zun looked at me with sparks in his eyes . “Have you mistaken Gaoqin Jiuye for Gao Qi? Developed feelings for him again?”

My mind was a blank .

Why... why say that?

Seeing me silent, he looked incandescent . He pulled my face closer to his!

I stared with wide, open eyes as I made contact with those icy lips .

His eyes were such a fiery contrast to the grey, sunless sky .

No, what am I thinking?! What’s he doing?!

I hurriedly pushed him away as he was about to pry open my lips with the tip of his tongue .

“You, you, you, what do you think you’re doing . ” I looked at him, not knowing what to do . His hair hung over his forehead, obstructing the firelight in his eyes .

“Answer me . Did you fall in love with Gaoqin Jiuye?” He voice was deep and hoarse, and he stopped closing the distance between us .

I felt angry all of a sudden . “Why would I fall in love with him?!”

“Because he looks exactly like the person you were holding a torch for when you were alive?”

I was once again reminded of Gao Qi's pale face, becoming momentarily speechless .

Old Man Fan, how does that sealing technique of yours work? Was what I saw just a hallucination, or was it reality?

Gao Qi... Is he really alive?

“Now that I think about it, what did you see when you were there? Do you think that's really the real world?” I asked Nie Zun hastily, moving closer to him .

Nie Zun replied in his deep voice, “Answer me first . Did you fall in love with him?”

I gave him a hard shove . “I might misunderstand that you have feelings for me if you continue being this ridiculous . Why would I fall in love with that ruthless character? I did love Gao Qi, but he isn't Gao Qi . ”

“How would I know if you didn't confuse him with Gao Qi . ” Nie Zun sounded stifled .

He looked absurd in this moment, but I stopped myself from laughing .

“Alright, how about you tell me what you saw? Whatever happened in that crack in space, was it a reflection of the real world?”

“I wasn't paying attention . I only saw you and Gaoqin Jiuye sticking together . ” Nie Zun put his hands back into the pockets of his windbreaker, and his voice regained that lackadaisical tone as he spoke .

Shocked at what I heard, I asked, “What? You could see the both of us? Why couldn't I see you? Where were you?”

Nie Zun looked at me lazily . “I was inside you . ”

Pfft... This sounded way too hilarious...

“Why do you look like you just ingested feces?” Nie Zun looked at me in confusion .

I did not reply .

Yeah, right! As if I’d admit I thought of something dirty .

Nie Zun’s eyes suddenly shone, looking enlightened . “You’re that filthy, Li Shen?”

I rolled my eyes .

“What I meant was that my consciousness was inside your body . ”

“Why would your consciousness be inside my body?” I asked with a muffled voice .

“Why would your consciousness be inside my body?” I asked with a muffled voice .

“Because... I don’t actually know either . ”

“...”

“Maybe your second personality didn’t have a place to go because the crack in space is a different dimension from the Split Zone, and my consciousness just so happened to be dragged along with her when she merged with you .
” Nie Zun came up with an analysis .

“You know my second personality so well,” I answered with sarcasm .

Sensing the mordacity in my voice, he locked his eyes on me . “Why are you so prejudiced against her?”

I scoffed, “Why then are you so concerned that I’m prejudiced against her? You think you know her well? Would you know her better than me? Or are

you predisposed to defending her because of your link with her? Do you want me to return this body to her, so that she can be alive again?"

For some reason, I was agitated, and it has been a long time since I said so much .

Nie Zun's eyes gleamed . "I just wanted to let you know that she is you, and you are her . The split identities are caused by your prejudice against this part of yourself . The tragedy when you were alive – it also happened because of this split . You're in pain because you do not accept yourself, and I don't want to see you in pain . "

Although those words were spoken with concern, it was merely an annoying sound in my ears .

I said frostily, "I'd not be in pain if not for her . She's the cause of all my pain . Thanks for reminding me that she's in you now, or I would probably have forgot!"

"She loves you more than anybody else, because she is you . Only you can truly protect yourself . " Nie Zun kept his gaze on me .

My heart started hurting .

"She's not me!" I shouted at Nie Zun . "She's a devil! She's a murderer! She's a psychotic! If not for her, my life would not be like this! I wouldn't have lost Gao Qi, and I wouldn't have ended up here in the Split Zone!"

Nie Zun looked like he was in agony . "I know that . But you can't change the fact that she is you . "

I felt like crying, but I took a deep breath and forced myself to hold the tears back .

"Don't be like this, Nie Zun . I might start hating you," I said, sniffing .

After what felt like centuries, he finally let out a sigh, and did not speak further .

After what felt like centuries, he finally let out a sigh, and did not speak further .

The atmosphere felt empty and it became a little awkward, but I did not want to speak first . Nie Zun, I understand all these . But I'm a sinner, I'm different from everyone else .

Even though there are many who care for me in the Split Zone, even though I told myself not to be cowardly anymore, I still can't do it . I couldn't forgive myself . I was too used to being ostracized and too used to the solitude to forgive myself .

I could not forgive her because I could not forgive myself .

“Nie Zun, since your consciousness was with me, you saw my mum too, right?” I ended up speaking first .

We kept our gazes on each other .

“Yes, I saw her . ”

“Have you ever thought of leaving this place? Going back?”

I thought Nie Zun would hesitate and remain silent, but he answered swiftly, “Yes, I want to go back . My sister is waiting for me . ”

I was rather stunned . This was the first time I heard Nie Zun say he ‘wanted’ anything, something that he actually wished for .

Nie Zun always gave the impression that he did not have a care in the world, and that he wanted nothing and needed nothing . Was it because of this that I neglected his feelings?

Whether I chose to leave or stay, I did not think of Nie Zun at all before this .

Our lives are tied together and my decision will definitely affect him! Only if we manage to find our soul splitters can we go back together .

And I did not, even for a second, think of what he wanted?

I was shocked at the abrupt realization of how selfish I had been .

As if able to read my mind, he spoke softly, “I just decided today that I want to go back . There’s no reason for you to blame yourself about this . ”

“Why did you decide to go back?”

“Because you want to go back,” Nie Zun casually said as he smiled .

“Why did you decide to go back?”

“Because you want to go back,” Nie Zun casually said as he smiled .

“Pft . ” Looking at that unconcerned expression of his, I could not tell if his words were genuine .

My relationship with Nie Zun has always been like this . There are times when I suddenly hate him, and there are times when I rely heavily on him . In the Split Zone, Nie Zun is the only person I can trust whole-heartedly .

It might be because she’s with him, or that deep inside, I knew that she and I were actually the same person . The fact that she is with him makes it feel like I am always together with Nie Zun as well .

“You want to go back, for real?” Nie Zun looked at me squarely .

My smile faded, and looking at him intently, I said, “To be honest, I really don’t know . I promised Li Qing and Ta Lai that I won’t ever think about going back . ”

“Are you regretting now that you’ve seen your family?”

I shook my head . “I have no idea . It might not be regret, but it seems selfish of me to keep hiding here in the Split Zone . It feels as if I were an invertebrate only focused on protecting myself, that I wasn’t able to put myself in the shoes of others who might be sad after I was gone . Nie Zun, I

always thought it didn't matter if I lived or died . But I only realized recently that as long as one is still alive, everything still matters . ”

“It's impossible to be fearless as long as there are things you still care about . ” Nie Zun arranged his fringe casually .

“It's because you hate yourself that you didn't want to return, you didn't want to take on the role of district commander, and you were running away from everything . You hate yourself for killing the one you love, and it isn't the Split Zone that you can't let go off, it's that self-loathing . ”

Nie Zun sounded gentle, “We all need to learn how to give ourselves a chance . ”

I was silent . I did not know what to say .

“Alright, let's not talk about this anymore,” he said, walking towards me with a smile .

“From the looks of it, we might actually stand to gain some things from Du Yue's experiment . A number of soul splitters are involved, and the experiment is connected to things we previously didn't know about . We might be able to uncover some clues that could help us find our soul splitters and leave this place . ”

“Hmm, that's right . Let's first look at the experimental grounds – 27th floor of the Residence, right? Now that I think about it, I seldom visit other levels apart from where I live on level 13,” I said .

With a nod, Nie Zun and I started walking in the direction of the Residence .

Chapter 107

107 Bloody Experimental Grounds

We were at the rooftop of the Residence .

There were two groups of people standing behind Jie Pa . I recognised one group – the various floor managers . According to Jie Pa’s investigation, they were already unhappy with how You Ji was running things . Furthermore, she was always keeping secrets from them . However, as a rather useless district commander, they could not put their trust in me either .

This time, they chose to pledge their loyalty to me because of Old Man Fan’s technique, and also because I played a part in chasing You Ji away .

The other group was Jie Pa’s intelligence network . I heard that they were all outstanding individuals – there were computer experts and people involved in scientific research . (Me: Maybe people with a high IQ are more susceptible to psychological problems, since there are so many geniuses here in the Split Zone . Passerby A: You’re definitely not one of them .)

I was not aware of the existence of this intelligence network previously, since I did not bother about such things . It was under the leadership of Jie Pa, and Nie Zun had been using this network, while I was in the dark .

There were about 30 individuals in the group, and everyone looked dapper and gentlemanly in their suits . The leader of this group was named Chou Yu .

“Miss Ah Shen, I’ve already briefed them on everything that happened . Is there anything else you’d like to add?” Jie Pa asked as he adjusted his glasses .

I looked at the two groups in front of me . Some of them were looking at me suspiciously, some looked worried, while some of them just looked at me like I was a total stranger .

I sighed inwardly .

“First, go with me to the experimental grounds . I’ll tell you what I want to say there . I know all of you might not trust in my abilities right now, but please, trust me this once,” I said in a committed voice .

They looked at one another, and nodded eventually .

One of the floor managers spoke, “District Commander, You Ji’s experimental grounds had always been on the 27th floor . She connected a number of rooms on the 27th floor, turning it into a top-secret area which was always guarded by her Seven Demons . Anyone who tells after hearing about it would turn up dead the next day . We’ve always been afraid but we weren’t able to tell anyone about this . ”

In that instant, I felt so apologetic . As District Commander, how could I have not been aware of what was happening to the residents?

“Bring me to have a look . ” Now was not the time to feel sorry . I had to change things!

“It’s right here . ”

All of us walked up to the 27th floor with poise, and there were some curious glances directed at us from residents who happened to pass by .

The Residence is usually divided into different zones . There was a lift in between each zone and one zone usually contained 10 or so rooms .

“All the rooms in this particular zone had their walls removed and have been connected, forming a continuous path . The zone is sealed at both entrances, and the lifts are not in service either . We have no idea what’s happening inside . ”

“Both Jie Pa and you were unaware of this too?” I asked Nie Zun .

Nie Zun shrugged . “No . You Ji probably got an illusionist to hide this place, so I didn’t know such a place actually existed . ”

Suspicion grew in me as I looked at Nie Zun’s eyes .

Was he really not aware? Or did he just not bother to find out more...

Nie Zun, you don’t care about anything usually... Am I right to assume that you’re actually doing all this, for my sake...

I had no luxury of time, and I walked to the door of this sealed-up zone .

I had no luxury of time, and I walked to the door of this sealed-up zone .

There was a seal on the double doors, looking like the crime scene tape from television dramas .

“You Ji said no one lives here and it was used for storage, then she sent the Seven Demons to seal it . ”

“How should we open this?” I looked towards Jie Pa .

Jie Pa thought for a moment before saying, “Since we don’t know what’s inside, I’d suggest using a long-range attack . ”

I nodded and signaled for everyone to retreat .

I backed away and as I swung Piercer with my left hand, I felt a chill which went from my palm into my heart . It was this chill that made me accurately feel the MF merging with Piercer .

Swoosh!

As the violet blade swung out, I heard low exclamations from behind . They were acknowledging my ability .

I started to feel smug . The door opened easily, though it was now horribly destroyed . Before we could see what was behind those broken doors, we were assailed by the strong smell of blood . I gagged at the odor .

As the doors crumbled to the ground, the inscriptions on the seals glided off .

I felt like choking and throwing up as the smell of blood, together with something rotten, spread into my nose and mouth . The inscriptions might have kept the smell and the noise in previously, but now that the seal has been destroyed, we could only stare at what was before us .

As we stepped through, we were faced with a long and continuous path . Lighting was sparse as all the windows were sealed . There was nothing but our footsteps .

As we stepped through, we were faced with a long and continuous path . Lighting was sparse as all the windows were sealed . There was nothing but our footsteps .

Splat, splat, splat . Each step resounded, leaving a bloody print behind . Everyone quietened, and only footsteps on the wet ground could be heard .

My breathing became heavy as the strong odor engulfed my senses, prickling my eyes and assaulting my nose . I kept telling myself to stay calm as I looked around . Don't cry, don't get angry, I have to remain composed .

My heart started racing as I took in the sights around me . There was a row of rusty iron cages against the wall on the left . Each of these were a little over a meter in height, and every cage contained something that looked part-human and part-animal, all huddled up in their dead forms .

We could not tell if these things were humans or not . Some of them had the head of a cat and the tail of a snake, while others had wooden stakes driven all over their bodies . Animal and human parts were merged together, and two bloody holes replaced the eyeballs in all of them .

I heard Jie Pa's voice in the darkness . "There are no signs of life, they're all dead . "

There was a label with a number on each of the iron cages, and ‘Experiment No . 2’ was written in dark red .

All the rooms in this area were connected, resulting in a very long path . As we ventured deeper, we could hear the sound of gears grinding slowly . Clack, clack, clack .

The further we walked, the darker it got . It smelt so rotten that I just wanted to close my eyes so I would no longer have to look at all the blood on the floor . How can anyone be so cruel and do something like this?

I lifted Piercer with my right hand, and as I felt its chill spread through my entire arm, I swung it several times, shattering the sealed windows . The gloomy skylight was finally able to come in, but the smell of blood did not dissipate .

I widened my eyes at the sight as we neared the end of the path .

There was a sealed wall at the end, and there was a gigantic device hanging from the ceiling . It looked similar to a torture device in medieval legend – the iron maiden . The human-shaped casket was open, and there was a body impaled within . There were no signs of life in the body, and the chains below the device led to a wooden pail on the floor . The blood which flowed onto the chains was already dry .

There were gears on the ceiling still rotating slowly, and the body was gradually crushed into smithereens by a circular device on the other end .

It was unusually quiet behind me, but I did not have the guts to turn around and look at their faces .

There were gears on the ceiling still rotating slowly, and the body was gradually crushed into smithereens by a circular device on the other end .

It was unusually quiet behind me, but I did not have the guts to turn around and look at their faces .

I took a deep breath, welcoming the smell of rotten blood, as I walked up to the row of wooden pails . Looking into one, there was nothing in it apart from pieces of solid, dried blood .

Picking up a piece with a handkerchief, Jie Pa sniffed at it . “They used human blood to feed the leeches . But whatever was in here should have been an imperfect form of leech spawn . It might not be sustainable for Rong Jin to continue capturing souls from the real world to create the leeches, so they might be thinking of using human blood and human bodies to create a suitable environment for breeding leeches . ”

Jie Pa calmly gave his analysis, but I could not remain calm after hearing that . My heart knotted painfully, as if it was continually being squeezed by a powerful hand, causing me to be a little unsteady on my feet .

I tried my best to keep my emotions in check . After what I witnessed in that stone room, I am now no longer that fearful of such a cruel and bloody sight .

“That Du Yue woman is practically insane . Sacrificing so many lives just to kill her rival in love? These bodies have all been bitten by the leeches, and they can no longer heal, right?” I asked, pointing at the pile of bodies in front of me .

Jie Pa nodded . “Yes . ”

I frowned . “No wonder Rong Jin was so interested in Old Man Fan’s statue . He wanted to find out more about Old Man Fan’s technique, because once he is able to break that barrier between the two dimensions, he’d be able to capture as many animal souls to create the leeches!”

Nie Zun added, “That’s highly possible . That man is a mystery . There’s nothing known about him, and apart from that shadow, no one has ever seen his face . We know nothing about that man, except for the fact that he’ll not turn against Si Luo . ”

I gritted my teeth as I thought of how I could have actually felt some sympathy for him . No matter what, I cannot forgive him for taking so many

innocent lives!

But, how is Gaoqin Jiuye related to him? Why did he bring Rong Jin back to see Si Luo?

Who can I actually trust?

Chapter 108

108 Rising Up in Rebirth!

“All of you have witnessed it . These are the experimental grounds of Du Yue, the soul splitter . She’s working together with You Ji, that traitor, and the Southern District’s soul snatcher, Rong Jin,” I addressed the group behind me as I pointed at the gigantic device .

Remaining silent, they looked at one another, awaiting further instructions .

I looked around me, before finally meeting Nie Zun’s eyes .

I kept my eyes on him for a few seconds, and he looked at me with confusion .

Nie Zun, I need to face this .

Facing the group, I slowly bent my knees and knelt on the floor .

The blood on the floor seeped into my red dress, blooming into dark red patches . I looked up at the shocked expressions in front of me before I spoke .

“I know your hearts are still with Li Qing, even though she’s gone . After she left, the Western District became a lifeless place . I don’t leave my room at all, and I left everything to You Ji . You Ji was like a lunatic, and all of you didn’t dare to speak even though you were unhappy with how she was handling things . As District Commander, I wasn’t aware of anything .

“I know I let Li Qing down . I’m kneeling in front of everyone today to apologize . I’m not putting on a show here, nor do I wish for forgiveness . Just like how I bowed to the floor managers previously, I know this cannot

make up for all the lost lives . But there are some things from the bottom of my heart that I wish to let everyone know . ”

The smell of blood was dissipating, and the group facing me remained silent, intently listening to what I had to say .

“Firstly, there are three things all of you should know . The first is about me . Everyone here might not understand or know me well, but I’m sure all of you are aware that I was rather favored by Li Qing when she was alive . I’ve heard people who say they think the one Li Qing favored is a useless idiot, but I didn’t give it much thought . I think I played the character of a useless idiot well, not being involved in any Western District matters . But it eventually led to today, You Ji’s betrayal, and the death of so many residents .

“I’m not a responsible district commander, and to be honest, I didn’t want to take on the role . May I ask everyone what you’d do if you were me? For those who end up in the Split Zone, who wasn’t abandoned in the real world? It’s already difficult to live in peace here, what more to protect others? I’m an ordinary person, just like everyone else .

“But now, I’ve already taken on the role of District Commander, and I promised Li Qing that I’ll protect this place . I really deserve to die for all this tragedy here today . I’ve disappointed every one of you . ”

I started choking on my words, while the group continued remaining silent .

“I know saying sorry doesn’t fix things . What I can do now is to help everyone reclaim the peace . This brings me to my second point, your hearts . May I ask everyone here, where your hearts are? Do you wish to peacefully live in the Split Zone, or do you wish to return to the real world? Please give this Li Shen a truthful answer . ”

There was total silence .

My knees were starting to feel stiff, and finally, Chou Yu, head of the intelligence network, spoke up .

“District Commander, I’m addressing you this way because I’m confident that you can lead us . As you said, if we were in your position, we might not care about the lives of others, since it was already difficult staying alive on our own . I don’t blame you for that . According to our investigations, if this experiment succeeds, the peace in the Split Zone will be broken, and this will lead to mass hysteria .

“I don’t know how you’ll choose to face it, and I’m glad you asked since we’re not able to force you into doing things either . I don’t know about the others, but I, Chou Yu, wish to go back . Even if life in the Split Zone is good, this is still Split Zone 13, not the real world . I want to go back, to be alive and to live like an ordinary person . ”

Chou Yu spoke steadily, but I could hear a slight tremor in his voice, as if he was talking about an impossible dream .

“How about the rest?” I asked, looking at the others .

“I... I want to go back too . ”

“I... I want to go back too . ”

“Me too . ”

“Although I didn’t have money or skills, and my life wasn’t great before, I thought I was already abandoned by the world . But it was only when I arrived here did I realize that I wasn’t really abandoned . It’s being here that is equivalent to being abandoned . So, I... I... I want to go back!”

“I want to go back too... In that crack in space, I saw my wife and children waiting by my side . ”

Everyone spoke, and I could hear a flurry of different voices .

“That’s right, everyone wants to go back . This is the last thing I would like to tell all of you – change . ”

The dried blood on the floor stuck to the ends of my dress, and I heard a tearing sound as I stood up .

I looked at everyone . “I know every District Commander before me was able to provide you with peace, but I’ve failed . I’ve brought you disaster instead .

“I’ve decided to use another method to make up for this .

“Everyone in the Split Zone has given up hope to return, because we weren’t able to find our soul splitters . Furthermore, suspicion and distrust led to the propagation of violence, and this is the reason why there are three different districts where the rules are different and where people behave differently .

“Today, I hope to use a different method to lead the residents . Just like you said, once the experiment succeeds, there will be no more peace in Split Zone 13 .

“So, I hope to lead all of you in leaving this place . ”

“So, I hope to lead all of you in leaving this place . ”

I said this with commitment . Everyone looked at me with mixed expressions of surprise, suspicion and worry .

“I know this sounds impossible to achieve . Nie Zun said we might be able to gain some things from this experiment, as we were able to find out a lot more about soul splitters . I’ll tell all of you now that Mr Blond is missing, and I’ve been unable to contact him . This means that Split Zone 13 no longer has a leader .

“Why don’t we take charge of our own fates? We’ve always followed the rules and abided by the standards without opposition or suspicion . Put nicely, we’re enjoying this eternal life that the Split Zone gives us, but in fact, we’re just wasting our time here . Old Man Fan’s sacrifice made us realize that our families are still out there waiting for us . What should we do to repay Old Man Fan for his sacrifice?”

I continued without waiting for an answer, “In following the rules, we end up being trapped in this eternal prison where there is pain everywhere .

Split Zone 13 is nothing but a jailhouse!”

I pointed at the floor as I articulated every word, “I once promised Li Qing I’d never abandon this place . Now that she’s gone, I’ll break my promise today . I, Li Shen, am tired of this place . I want to unlock the secret of the Split Zone, and lead all of you in escaping this place . ”

I believe there had never been someone who acted like me today in the history of Split Zone 13 . Everyone who ends up here, whether cruel or cowardly, would eventually be assimilated into this environment – quietly accepting their fate for all eternity .

They might possibly die here, or get plundered .

For me, I am not about to be robbed of anything, nor do I wish to surrender to this fate .

My wish is not to dominate the Western District or the Split Zone, nor do I wish to be the leader of a group . What I want is to be an ordinary person living an ordinary life .

This is why I need them to sober up, and I am going to bring them out of here .

One of the floor managers was tearing up . Choking on her words, she said, “I’ve never dared to say nor ask this, but I’ve always wondered why there was never any revolt in the Split Zone? Why did everyone give up hope once they realized they couldn’t find any soul splitters? There’s now finally someone who put into words what I had only thought of . District Commander, get us out of this place!”

“Yes, get us out of here!”

One of the floor managers was tearing up . Choking on her words, she said, “I’ve never dared to say nor ask this, but I’ve always wondered why there was never any revolt in the Split Zone? Why did everyone give up hope once they realized they couldn’t find any soul splitters? There’s now finally

someone who put into words what I had only thought of . District Commander, get us out of this place!”

“Yes, get us out of here!”

“We believe in you!”

They looked at me with utmost sincerity, their words wrought with emotion .

I felt an immense pressure, but there is no turning back now that I have said all this . Even if this road ahead is paved with spikes, I, Li Shen, will not regret my decision .

I have made too many mistakes both when I was alive and when I was here . It must be because of my cowardice that I was ostracized and left in solitude .

From today onwards, I will no longer be cowardly, I am going to be strong and I will be reborn .

“I’ll need to trouble the floor managers to spread the word to the residents . If everyone agrees, please allow this useless district commander to request for your loyalty . Everyone, I hope that you’ll be able to follow in my leadership, destroy this experiment, uncover the mysteries of the Northern District, find the soul splitters and leave the Split Zone!”

I concluded .

I felt warmth in my heart as I looked at the hundreds of faces, resolutely pledging their loyalty .

“Miss Ah Shen, please take a rest . Leave it to us here . I’ll look into the experimental grounds, and we’ll discuss the next steps after the floor managers finish informing the residents of your decision,” Jie Pa spoke with composure .

I nodded .

Chapter 109

109 Inescapable Shackles

I could finally take a rest after heading back to my familiar room on the 13th floor .

I lay on my bed after taking a hot shower .

Nie Zun was leaning against the wall, looking sleepy and idle as usual .

I yawned, turned to my side, and tried to fall asleep .

Nie Zun's voice sounded beside me, "I have a question . "

"Go ahead," I said in a tired, nasal voice, keeping my weary eyes closed .

"You managed to persuade all of them to rebel and leave Split Zone 13 . How about you? Have you decided to return?"

Nie Zun's voice sounded alluring, and when I opened my eyes, the sky instantly turned dark . It was night again .

I should have been able to answer him right away, but why did I hesitate? I wanted to go back, and I hoped for everyone here to sober up and be able to return as well . But would I really choose to go back if that day arrives?

"You're not thinking of sacrificing yourself are you, Li Shen?" Nie Zun looked at me as he sat beside me on the bed .

I was speechless . Sacrificing myself... how?

“Never mind that . No matter what you think, we’re still unable to part, and I’ll always know . ” Nie Zun’s gaze was gentle, and I kept my eyes on him .

“Why’re you like this today...” I spoke hesitantly .

“There’s something I never told you,” Nie Zun said suddenly .

I was confused . “What?”

“I’ve seen you, before arriving in the Split Zone . ” Nie Zun’s voice sounded in my ear .

I opened my eyes wide . “When was that? Where?”

He blinked in slight confusion at my intense expression . “At a salon, you were getting your hair dyed red . ”

I frowned . Salon? Dyeing it red?

Oh yes, I did dye my hair red before, during that time...

I could not bear to revisit those memories... But why couldn’t I remember seeing Nie Zun?

“And also, your senior Gao Qi, in the hospital,” Nie Zun added .

I lifted my head at him, not expecting him to say that .

“You...” I said softly .

Nie Zun continued with his gleaming eyes, “There were many people with him at the hospital, and you were following behind . ”

I sat up immediately, grabbing his elbow . He looked at my hand, where the knuckles were already turning white, surprised at my reaction .

I kept my gaze on him . “You saw me? When I was still conscious? I can’t remember what happened when I killed Gao Qi, what exactly happened?

When I woke up, I was already in the hospital, and after a doctor gave me a shot, I ended up here in the Split Zone!”

I kept my gaze on him . “You saw me? When I was still conscious? I can’t remember what happened when I killed Gao Qi, what exactly happened? When I woke up, I was already in the hospital, and after a doctor gave me a shot, I ended up here in the Split Zone!”

Nie Zun moved my hand away gently . Holding my arm, he said, “Calm down, I’ll tell you everything . ”

I stared at him, waiting for an answer .

“I think it wasn’t you I saw . Or rather, not the you I’m seeing now,” Nie Zun smiled as he said this .

Cold sweat started forming on my palms, and I felt anxious and insecure, as if I was about to learn of a terrifying secret .

“You mean... You saw, her?” I tried to hide my anxiety with a raised eyebrow .

Nie Zun’s eyes shone . “Yes, that should be her . At that time, you weren’t like this . There was a totally different aura . Maybe it was your second personality . ”

“What did she say?! What did she do?!” I became agitated .

Nie Zun answered calmly, “She didn’t do anything . She just followed behind Gao Qi, with blood all over her . ”

Smack!

I slapped his hand away, staring at him . “It’s her! She killed him! Why didn’t you stop her? Why didn’t you stop me if you knew who I was?!”

Nie Zun did not expect me to have such an explosive reaction, and his brows were tightly knitted . “How do I stop you? I didn’t know you . When you arrived there, he was already stabbed . ”

My shoulders dropped . I realized he was right . How could I blame him when it was not his fault .

“Did she say anything to you,” I asked with trembling lips .

Although I was not aware of what happened, I knew I was the one who killed him . Even though I knew that, I was not able to revisit those painful memories since I could not remember it .

Although I was not aware of what happened, I knew I was the one who killed him . Even though I knew that, I was not able to revisit those painful memories since I could not remember it .

Until today, when someone told me he’s seen me covered in blood at the hospital .

After a long silence, Nie Zun spoke, “No . ”

I collapsed on the bed face up, lying down . Looking at the bunk bed above me, I asked, “Why tell me this now . ”

Nie Zun turned, with his back facing me . “No particular reason . Just that, when I saw her, she’s different from how you expected her to be . She doesn’t look like a ruthless devil . You might just be prejudiced against her...”

“Enough!” I sat up again, feeling a little dizzy from the sudden movement .

“Nie Zun, enough! You said you saw her covered in blood! She sent him to the hospital covered in blood?! How can she not be a devil? How can I not be a devil? That’s somebody’s life! Even if you want to console me, there’s no need to say things that betray your conscience . ” My voice trembled, and I was gripping the bed sheets tightly .

Nie Zun continued speaking with his back to me, “I did see her covered in blood, but I didn’t see her kill anyone . That horrific past that you’re unable to recall – you can’t remember a thing, and I didn’t see it either . ”

I bit my lip . “What’re you trying to say?”

“You still don’t understand? Whatever you thought had happened might not be the truth . You saw it too through Old Man Fan’s technique, Gao Qi is still alive . What if everything was just an accident?”

I laughed bitterly . “That’s my fault . I should’ve told you this . Old Man Fan’s last words were that it wasn’t spacial transference, it was a sealing technique . What I saw might not be the real world, and it might just be what I was wishing for in my heart . ”

“Like he said, it might be, so there’s a chance it’s real, right? I heard what Old Man Fan said to you, did you forget my consciousness was in your body at that time? It’s hard to get what he meant, but it’s possible that whatever you wished for is exactly what is happening in the real world, since so many were able to meet their families again through that technique . ”

“How about you? Did you see your sister?” Instead of answering, I asked him another question .

Nie Zun stiffened . “My consciousness was in your consciousness, so I wasn’t able to see her . ”

Hearing that, my heart hurt a little . Sighing, I said, “Nie Zun, how is your fate linked to her... So much so that you’re so closely tied to me like this... Just what’s the point of all this...”

Nie Zun stiffened . “My consciousness was in your consciousness, so I wasn’t able to see her . ”

Hearing that, my heart hurt a little . Sighing, I said, “Nie Zun, how is your fate linked to her... So much so that you’re so closely tied to me like this... Just what’s the point of all this...”

“Heh, fate? Finally think that she and I aren’t similar?” He turned back, laughing .

His smile looked bitter .

I looked down . “I don’t know if you’re similar to her . Nie Zun, sometimes I feel like I don’t know you at all . ”

It was silent for a while, and I tried to steal a glance at him . Nie Zun was looking towards the window . His gaze was unfathomable as usual, and it carried a hint of solitude . I took a breath, and asked, “Nie Zun, you think that the me you saw wouldn’t kill?”

Nodding slightly, Nie Zun continued staring into the distance with that faraway look .

I frowned . “But I know that I killed someone . Although I can’t remember a thing, my body, my brain, my fingers, everything is telling me that I, for sure, have killed someone, and it was someone I loved . You won’t understand that feeling if you haven’t sinned . This is why I’ve never wished for redemption . ”

After a pause, I continued, “Or it might be as you said, whatever Old Man Fan showed me, is both a reflection of my heart’s desires and what’s happening in the real world, and maybe Gao Qi isn’t dead . But, so what? It doesn’t change the fact that I attempted to murder him .

“I’m a child who was abandoned in that world, and I’ve become a murderer . Will I be worthy of redemption? You keep asking me if I want to go back . So what if I go back? Even if I want to, I’d still need face my sins, right?”

“So you’re going to stay here and keep running away?” He turned back, staring at me .

I stared back at him . “No, I’ve decided not to run away anymore, and to search for the method to bring everyone back . But I’ll admit, I don’t know if I’m able to go back . ”

There was agony in my eyes . “You’ll never understand . I know my parents are waiting for me, and I don’t wish to be in such sorrow either . But I’ve dealt with this pain for too long, I just can’t let go . ”

Sorrow flashed past his eyes, and he gave a bitter smile . He showed me his left hand, before pulling the black glove away .

“I don’t understand? Can your solitude match this?” With slender fingers, he pointed at his left hand, which was devoid of palm prints .

Chapter 110

110 Forgetting Him, Forgetting Myself?

My heart hurt .

“Li Shen, when were you diagnosed with your psychological disorder?” Nie Zun asked suddenly .

I broke out in a layer of cold sweat...

Bro, that’s not a mental illness...

Fine... It’s actually considered one...

I rolled my eyes inwardly . “In high school, probably during my sophomore year . ”

He smiled . “I’ve been called a freak since I was little . Actually, no, since I was born . Everyone around me kept dying, and people said I caused it . ”

It felt as if there was something stuck in my throat, and I could not speak .

“Li Shen, you think you killed the man you loved the most?

“But I feel like I’ve caused the death of everyone I loved, and those who loved me most...” Nie Zun’s voice was soft, his eyes an ocean of solitude .

My heart ached like never before . This was a different type of pain from what I usually felt .

“You think there’s no place for you in that world and you can’t be redeemed? I don’t even dare think about the word ‘redemption’... I just

hope that I'd stop bringing harm to others... I've never asked to be forgiven...

“At least you're stuck in a dilemma between going back, and wondering if you should be going back . I don't even know what I should do . You can blame your other personality and pour your hatred on her, Li Shen . But who should I hate?”

Nie Zun looked at me with what seemed like the most tender gaze in the world, hiding the anguish deep within .

I cannot describe what I felt, but I knew what I wanted to do, and what I had to do .

I reached out and hugged him . His back was cold, and I turned to lean my cheek near his heart, hearing his heartbeat .

“Why is it so difficult to warm someone's heart...” I murmured .

“Promise me, try to recall those lost memories, try to remember what she was like, before making a decision...” Nie Zun said .

My heart tightened, and I nodded .

A wave of tiredness hit me . After so many days without rest, I could finally sleep .

I was dreaming again .

I sighed lightly as I entered the dreamscape . Again, I was not a spectator, but a participant in this . I was myself in the dream .

It had been hectic and a long time since I last slept, and I started dreaming once I fell asleep . I knew the reason I was able to participate in the dream was because I did not remember this, and every dream was an opportunity to recall the pieces of broken memories .

I laughed at my ability to calmly analyze this situation . Should I be happy about this? I would rather be a lazy and dumb girl, not thinking of anything

every day .

I suddenly thought of what Li Qing mentioned previously . Ta Lai's lover, Bian Ying – the only other person who was just like me, was able to personally participate in her dreams too . I remember Li Qing saying that over time, Bian Ying could even control what happened in her dreams .

But if what we saw were just fragments of lost memory, how was she able to manipulate that? Or could that have been her subconscious forcing her to do certain things?

In between my thoughts, I found myself on that rooftop again . It was a familiar place where I used to wait for Gao Qi and spend time with him

He was always reading alone on the rooftop; it could be Goethe's Faust or Hugo's Les Misérables . I used the excuse of reading to stay together with him, but in fact, I just wanted to steal glances at him .

I knew I liked him a lot . Liking someone like this is just like being an avid, crazy fan of an idol, or being so unwilling to let go of a belonging of yours . I liked him so much, to the point that I could not pull myself out of it .

I remembered in the previous dream, he asked me how much I liked him, and if I would be willing to die for him .

I know I would not die for anyone, because life is precious . This is also why I cannot forgive myself for taking somebody else's life .

I was confused before, on why Gao Qi would ask that of me .

“Even if I'm not as I seemed, even if I'm not the person you thought I was, will you still be able to stay with me?”

“Even if I'm not as I seemed, even if I'm not the person you thought I was, will you still be able to stay with me?”

“They called you a weirdo but I know you're the only one who understands me, right?”

“Ah Shen, how in love with me are you?” “Are you willing to die for me?”

The memory of that previous dream was still fresh, and if that was really a fragment of my memory, then it might not be a simple coincidence that I am dreaming again . The previous dream ended when Gao Qi asked me those questions, and I wonder if I would be able to find the answers this time?

In my previous dream, Gao Qi professed his love for me . Did I agree?

Was I together with him when I was alive? Could that have been possible? That dream was a reality? If so, how could I have forgotten such a thing?

Now that I think of it this way, I should dream more often . Since I thought it would be painful to recall, never did I expect that there might be some important bits in these lost memories of mine . Even if it was tiring, this was an opportunity for me to pick up the lost pieces of memory .

Maybe Nie Zun was right, I should give my second personality a chance, a chance to return the truth to me .

No matter who you are, I’m now ready to face the truth . Tell me, what exactly happened .

“Ah Shen, you’re here . ”

I heard Gao Qi’s voice behind me . Keeping my composure, I flashed a brilliant smile at him as I turned .

He looked exactly the same as how I remembered him to be, that gentle face and smile, holding a book in his hand .

“Want to take a look at the new book I brought today?” He walked over and handed me a book which was moderately thick .

Not sure how this dream would develop, I chose to take the book . It was heavier than I imagined it would be, and my hands sunk slightly under the weight .

I looked at the name of the book in shock .

‘The 1003rd Type of Shattered Corpses’

What... kind of book is this?

The cover was khaki in color and looked old and dirty . Though it did not look thick, it felt rather heavy in my hands .

The cover was khaki in color and looked old and dirty . Though it did not look thick, it felt rather heavy in my hands .

“This is...?” I looked up at Gao Qi .

Gao Qi smiled . “This is a book on dissection . ”

My hairs stood on end . Why did I not know Gao Qi liked reading these books? Why did I not have any impression of this? I knew he had unique interests, but I thought he was just into western literature like me, maybe some novels that explored the dark side of humanity . But he actually liked to read about dissection?

“What’s wrong? Why do you look so shocked, Ah Shen? Forgot that I’m in Forensic Medicine?” Gao Qi’s voice was melodic and alluring .

Forensic Medicine... Gao Qi studied Forensic Medicine?!

Yes he majors in Forensic Medicine... Why didn’t I think of this earlier?

I remembered this as soon as I got reminded of it . That’s right, Gao Qi majors in Forensic Medicine .

“Anyway, if I wasn’t doing Forensic Medicine, you’d find me weird if I read such books, right?

“You think I’m a weirdo too, just like the others?” Slight pain flashed past Gao Qi’s eyes, but his voice did not carry the slightest hint of blame .

My heart tightened, and I reached for his face .

He held onto my outstretched hand, and the chill from his fingers reminded me of Nie Zun .

Nie Zun was always this cold .

“Ah Shen, since we’re already together, don’t leave me, please,” Gao Qi said, embracing me in a hug .

Leaning against his shoulder, I shivered slightly in his arms .

We were... together? We got together after what happened in that previous dream? Like lovers?

“We... How long have we been together?” I asked hesitantly .

Gao Qi sounded gentle, “Almost a month . You forgot again, dumbo . ”

“We... How long have we been together?” I asked hesitantly .

Gao Qi sounded gentle, “Almost a month . You forgot again, dumbo . ”

I pushed him away gently, looking into his eyes . I did not know what to say . This face which drew me like a moth to a flame is right in front of me now, telling me that he and I are lovers, and that we have already been together for almost a month now .

However, I did not seem happy about this . I could not remember a thing, and I do not recall anything about this particular piece of memory which seemed like it was a real fragment from the past .

What exactly happened then?

Did she really have her reasons?

No, I cannot create excuses for her, I cannot forgive her . She took over my body and hurt my lover .

But... I looked at the face in front of me .

How much did I forget...

“Ah Shen, I’ll bring you to the lab, okay?” Gao Qi pulled me by the hand, his gaze gentle . I nodded, as if possessed .

Gao Qi walked down from the rooftop unhurriedly .

There were some glances as we passed through the school grounds . These gazes were chilly, full of jealousy and incredulity .

Still like this even when we’ve been together for a month?

“Gao Qi, why are you together with me?” I asked as we walked .

Gao Qi answered without turning back, “Because I like you, don’t you know that?”

He looked back after speaking . His smile looked mischievous and his gaze seemed to contain a slight malice .

I was rather stunned . This gaze, why did it resemble Gaoqin Jiuye so much?

Chapter 111

111 The Delusion of Dominance?

I kept looking around as we made our way to the laboratory . I was pretty sure I have never been here, or I might have forgotten all the times which I had been here . This place was absolutely foreign to me, and I did not have the slightest inkling of it . I did not even know there was such a laboratory in our school .

The hallway was rather eerie . All hallways that lead to medical laboratories or morgues always seem this eerie .

There was a tiny window in each laboratory door . I saw a myriad of sights through the windows as Gao Qi led me past those doors .

There was a stone head contained in one of those spaces, and sometimes specimens of various colors could be seen in the tall, white cabinets within . I also saw a diagram of the human body hanging on one of the walls .

Without pausing, Gao Qi kept walking past these tiny windows, leading me forward . I looked down at the back of his ankles; his pace was firm and steady . We were walking in tandem, and I was about to put a foot forward every time he stepped out . We kept going forward with this pace until we arrived at the end of the hallway .

“It’s here . ” Gao Qi let go of my hand, pointing at the door in front . The door was painted red, and it looked like the color of dried blood .

I frowned slightly . Through the glass, nothing could be seen from the outside, and it looked as if the windows had been covered with newspaper on the inside .

I started to feel a little uneasy . I have always liked strange, mysterious, and dark places, even if I was a little afraid of them .

Creak—

“Come on in . ” Like a gentleman, Gao Qi welcomed me in as he stood at the door . Looking at that smile of his, I walked in slowly .

It was almost evening now, and daylight was sparse in the room . There were a few desks placed horizontally across the room, and at the far corners on both sides were life-sized human figures . One of those figures had half of its brain exposed, and I felt slightly uncomfortable as I could see the entire structure of the brain hanging there .

I felt Gao Qi’s breath as he moved closer .

“Ah Shen, want to take a look at my experimental subject?” I shivered as I heard that spellbinding voice .

Without waiting for my reply, he walked over to the first desk and took out a glass jar . I held my breath as he walked towards me with the jar .

“Look, this is the end point in life . ” Following his keen gaze, I saw the head of a cat, completely submerged in formalin, its eyes open . The cat did not look like it suffered much . The cut on its neck was clean and even, and each one of its whiskers could still be clearly seen .

“This...” I felt waves of stinging pain at the bottom of my throat, as if something was stuck in it .

“There’s nothing to be afraid of . I know this might look frightening to some, but it was a sick cat . To this cat, death was equivalent to freedom .

“I didn’t want to see its life end just like that, so I kept its final appearance in here . ” Gao Qi looked at the cat’s head with warmth in his eyes, caressing the glass jar with his fingers .

“Gao Qi, you...” I was rooted to the ground, dumbstruck .

This was unbelievable . How could Gao Qi, such a warm and gentle individual, have such a hobby?

“Do you think I am dark?” He asked, smiling at me .

Subconsciously, I backed away from him .

The specimen of a cat’s head should not have frightened me, considering the bloodshed and horror I have witnessed in the Split Zone . But I could not stay composed in this situation . This person was someone I loved, someone who would never do such a thing .

Gao Qi noticed me backing away . He put the glass jar back onto the desk and started making his way towards me .

“Ah Shen, I thought you were different from the rest . You understand me . This isn’t cruelty, it’s art . Ah Shen, are you frightened too? Are you going to leave me?” Sadness flashed past Gao Qi’s gentle eyes .

I felt sympathetic to such solitude and sorrow, and quickly said, “No, that wasn’t what I meant . ”

I felt sympathetic to such solitude and sorrow, and quickly said, “No, that wasn’t what I meant . ”

“Ah Shen, are you willing to stay with me until I uncover the true meaning of life?” The sky turned dark outside as Gao Qi came closer .

I felt his breath closing in . My breath was heavy and my heart started beating quickly .

Just when I was at a loss of what to do, a knocking sound was heard at the door .

“Oh...” I backed away in slight surprise, furthering the distance between Gao Qi and me .

Gao Qi looked rather angry as he heard the knock, as if someone had trespassed into his territory .

The door opened shortly after he asked, “Who is it?”

My jaw dropped as I turned my head towards our visitor .

It was Pomelo .

Why did she come here? She... Should I say she’s like a spirit that’s haunting me?

Pomelo’s expression was cold and dark . It was different from that usual smiling demeanor of hers . She stared at Gao Qi, and her glance swept past the specimen of the cat’s head within the glass jar on the desk .

“Ah Shen, what’re you doing in such a scary place? Go back with me . It’ll be dark soon, don’t loiter outside . Have you forgotten about your illness? It might be triggered under certain circumstances . ”

Pomelo walked towards me quickly, pulling me behind her .

I felt a surge of anger . Pomelo was always like this, directing and controlling everything . She wanted to be in control of my life, whether I liked it or not .

I felt a surge of anger . Pomelo was always like this, directing and controlling everything . She wanted to be in control of my life, whether I liked it or not .

She kept bringing up my illness, pretending to care about me while she actually hurt me .

She might have known that she was hurting me, but she would rather keep me by her side in this way so she would not need to share me with anybody else . I was just like a toy that she could trample on in any way, something belonging solely to her that nobody else could touch .

I wanted to say something in protest, but I realised I was not able to speak at all .

Was this because I had a different mindset now? Or was it because this represented what happened in the past, and it could not deviate from what happened originally?

I am now much braver than I was . I did not know how to resist previously, nor did I think that there would be any good in resisting – this was the reason why I was overwhelmed by Pomelo before .

“She’s my girlfriend . What now, you want to be involved even in matters of the heart?” Gao Qi’s voice sounded icy, and his lips turned into a creepy smile as he held Pomelo’s stare .

I stared with wide eyes . This, this expression, this gaze, it was too much like Gaoqin Jiuye!

But that cannot be possible! I rubbed my eyes in a bid to see clearly . This is different from Gao Qi’s gentle gaze, this gaze belonged only to Gaoqin Jiuye!

Why would Gaoqin Jiuye’s expression appear on Gao Qi’s face?!

What is happening?!

“Huh,” Pomelo scoffed, “you’ll need to be alive to be in love right? Gao Qi, do you think you can fool me after duping so many other girls? Don’t even think about influencing Li Shen! The condition of her illness is worsening nowadays, you better stay away from her, or else, you can count on me telling others about your secrets!”

What did Pomelo mean by all this? Does this mean that Gao Qi was hiding something that? It did not seem like it was something decent either . Before I knew it, I already reacted in anger .

I swung Pomelo’s arm away . “Pomelo, that’s enough . Stop trying to meddle with everything . Can’t you just leave me alone with Gao Qi? I’m begging you, I’m already being controlled by you in every way, what else do you want?”

I felt rather edgy . I did not intend to say this! Was this a fragment from my memory?!

I swung Pomelo's arm away . "Pomelo, that's enough . Stop trying to meddle with everything . Can't you just leave me alone with Gao Qi? I'm begging you, I'm already being controlled by you in every way, what else do you want?"

I felt rather edgy . I did not intend to say this! Was this a fragment from my memory?!

The Li Shen of the past might have said something like this, but now, I would not .

Was it because I no longer liked Gao Qi as much as I did before...

There was no time to think about this, as I saw Pomelo's eyes fill with hurt and sorrow .

"Li Shen, you can't be together with him . He'll destroy you . " Pomelo looked at me, while pointing at Gao Qi .

I tried to calmly analyze the situation before me, but Gao Qi started laughing .

"Can you have her forever?"

Pomelo argued, "I can't, and I won't let you do that either!"

I frowned . They were talking about me like an object!

Hmph, and in the end it was me who turned into a vegetable?

I no longer wanted to remain silent . Trying hard to free my voice, I spoke my mind, "I don't belong to either of you . Why compete over this?"

Both Gao Qi and Pomelo looked at me in surprise .

Pomelo previously grabbed my hand when she walked into the room, and I could feel her palms starting to sweat .

“She’s about to be triggered...,” she muttered, staring at me .

Chapter 112

112 Bone-chilling Cold!

I jerked awake, sitting up on the bed!

“Damn it!” I felt beads of sweat on my forehead, and as I looked around me, I knew I already awoke from my dream .

Nie Zun fell asleep standing, leaning against the bunk bed . He seemed to be looking down and resting his eyes . Seeing me awake, he lifted his head and looked at me with those starry eyes .

“What’s wrong?” He asked softly, noticing the perspiration on my forehead .

I sighed . “Nothing, I just had a dream . This is the second time . It seems as if I’d be able to see pieces of that lost memory every time I dream . It was just like my last dream, and this dream was a continuation of that previous one . I woke up at a crucial moment, and I wasn’t able to get a clear sense of the situation . ”

He smiled gently . “This is destiny . Since you’re supposed to recall it, those memories will come to you . You just have to wait patiently for it . ”

I twitched my lips . “You really have no desires, leaving it all to fate . ”

He shook his head, eyes shining . “No, those who leave it to fate value life . As for me, it doesn’t matter if I live or die...”

He gave a charming laugh, waving a gloved hand in front of his own face .

What he said made my heart ache .

This is why you have an indifferent, heedless and cold demeanor, because you gave up on yourself...

You need to be protected far more than I do...

These thoughts sprouted out of nowhere .

“But these dreams might actually help you solve some of the problems you faced when you were alive . It might even help you accept her . ”

Nie Zun seemed as if he was looking at a lover . His gentle gaze was directed at me, but at the same time, it did not seem like he was looking at me .

I felt a weird, tangled emotion .

A thought flashed past . Could it be because of my second personality that he was so patient with me all this time? He... did he do this all for her...

“Ah...” I called out as I felt a sudden chill in my palms .

“What’s wrong?” Nie Zun looked alert .

I lifted my hands, looking at my palms . There was nothing different about them, they looked the same, and they didn’t look affected by any sort of poison .

But right now, my palms felt like they were riddled with holes, as if there was a cold wind blowing through these holes . A bone-chilling cold spread swiftly from my palms to my heart . As if rapidly submerged in water, I shivered as the chill spread through my body .

“What’s happening to you?” Nie Zun asked again, a concerned hand on my shoulder .

I felt my lips starting to tremble, and I realized it was getting hard to speak .

“Your lips are turning purple . ” Nie Zun looked anxious as he noticed my lips .

The chill continued emanating from my palms, and I spoke with quivering lips, “Quick, get Jie Pa here . ”

Nie Zun called Jie Pa on his mobile phone immediately . Without his hand on my shoulder, I felt colder . I collapsed onto the bed, clutching at the sheets, not able to bear the chill .

Usually, we would not be able to feel any temperature fluctuations in the Split Zone, unless it was caused by MF . So if someone was having a fever, it was simply a symptom caused by damage to their MF .

I tried to quickly interpret this situation .

Was it caused by something poisonous in the experimental grounds? Was I infected by it? No, it can't be, I believe in Jie Pa's deduction and he'd have known if there was something wrong with the experimental grounds .

Was it caused by my dream? That shouldn't be the case either . I activated the MF around my split symbol .

This isn't right, my MF is normal . So the problem doesn't lie with me .

An ambush? Not possible, Nie Zun was always by my side, how could I have gotten hurt .

An ambush? Not possible, Nie Zun was always by my side, how could I have gotten hurt .

The chill hindered me from focusing on my thoughts, and I could no longer think of any other possible reasons for this .

“He needs a few hours at the very least . Are you okay? He asked if this could be caused by poison, and he wants you to activate your MF around your split symbol, see if there's anything wrong . ” Nie Zun held my hand, trying to keep my emotions stable .

“No... no problem . Tell... tell him, I... I've thought of all... possible situations, this... should... should be something... out of the... ordinary... get him here... quick . ”

“You’re feeling really cold?” Nie Zun frowned, and I was distracted by his dreamy eyes .

But I was about to become an icicle, and I could not expand any more of my energy to ogle at the pretty boy . I was so cold my teeth were chattering .

I felt a sudden pressure on my wrist, and Nie Zun lifted me up in an embrace!

My head hit his shoulder, and I felt the warmth of his chest . My lips lifted in a bitter smile . Nie Zun always felt chilly, but this time, I was colder than him, and it was the first time I felt warm in his embrace .

“Huu...” I let out a breath of cold air . It felt as though my skin was already frozen . I looked at my hands and they looked completely fine, as if the chill was spreading outwards from my heart .

“Nie... Zun, are you trying to take advantage of me...” With trembling lips, I chided him to counter the chill .

He spoke calmly in my ear, “Do you have anything to take advantage of?”

...

Can’t you say something nice?!

I rolled my eyes . Every inch of my skin felt icy, and I was quite afraid that my eyeball would remain frozen right under my eyelid .

“Ssss... .” I muttered, “Nie, Nie Zun... it’s too... too cold...”

I felt his arms tighten, holding me closer to him .

“Do you want me to follow what they do in the dramas, provide you warmth by stripping?” Although I could not see his eyes, I could hear the mischievous tone in his voice .

“Do you want me to follow what they do in the dramas, provide you warmth by stripping?” Although I could not see his eyes, I could hear the mischievous tone in his voice .

“You, you... you are... you are... not much warmer...” I was so cold that I did not want to move any part of my body, and I rolled my eyes inwardly .

I heard his laughter by my ear, but I scrunched up further in the chill .

“Just what’s happening?” Nie Zun was hugging me so tightly that I almost could not breathe .

This chill invaded me, but I remained conscious, and my five senses seemed to have been enhanced . I did not feel faint at all, but it felt as if the insides of my body had been bored through by an icicle .

“D... Don’t know . ” I continued shivering in his arms .

“Ah—!”

I screamed as I felt a violent, icy stab in my brain!

Nie Zun held me tighter, cradling my head!

“Ah—!” This stabbing feeling was not like how a mortal wound would feel, it was directed at the nerves!

It felt like being forcefully possessed by a ferocious and resentful spirit that was horrific and full of malice . My soul felt like it was being torn apart, and my pupils started to dilate!

Sensing something was wrong, Nie Zun let go of me . He looked at me anxiously, grabbing me tightly by the shoulders . I tried hard to keep my eyes wide open, but I was not able to stop that cold, dark chill that was eating at my brain .

“Nie, Nie Zun, Nie Zun... get... get Piercer off me... get it off!”

I screamed those last three words with all my might!

Nie Zun swiftly took Piercer from my waist and threw it to the side!
Though I was unsure of the reason, I just felt that Piercer had something to do with this chill!

However, there was no reprieve . All the nerves in my brain were fired up, and I bit my lip tightly in pain . My hands were turning white from gripping the sheets, and my fingers were sinking into the mattress .

The only warmth I felt was on my shoulders, where Nie Zun's hands were .

Looking like he could no longer bear to see me in such pain, Nie Zun lifted one of my legs .

The only warmth I felt was on my shoulders, where Nie Zun's hands were .

Looking like he could no longer bear to see me in such pain, Nie Zun lifted one of my legs .

My lips felt frozen, and I could not ask what he planned to do .

He quickly undid the red silk tied around my left ankle, until the glowing symbol of a scorpion was revealed . He grabbed my ankle and pressed down on my split symbol .

Stunned, I felt vibrations emanating from the split symbol .

He's using MF to attack my split symbol!

But why?!

Split symbols are where MF is concentrated at . Apart from a splitting key, there is almost no other way to damage a split symbol! Any attack directed at a split symbol will be reflected rapidly, and it will cause greater damage to the attacker!

“You... what are you doing?!” It felt like I had to use all my energy just to ask this .

Nie Zun looked at me with dark and unfathomable eyes . “Using my MF to help stabilize the raging flow of yours . ”

Although my MF is going all over the place and in chaos right now, it was caused by the chill invading me, not because of my split symbol . If this goes on, my consciousness might just crumble!

But, how could he use his MF to forcefully control mine?! Even if his MF was much higher than mine, this was too dangerous a method! If my consciousness crumbled, he’d definitely be affected!

“No, you... you let go of me...” I looked at Nie Zun who was holding on to my ankle tightly . Just looking into his eyes, I knew he was suppressing pain .

He did not listen to me, and I felt the force from his MF continuously on my split symbol .

Blood seeped out from the corner of his lips .

Tears welled up in my eyes, and I tried my best to speak, “You, you, quick... let go... I...”

Chapter 113

113 Piercer's Poison

After bursting through the door, the usually calm and collected Jie Pa called out as he took in the scene before him .

“What are you doing?!” He rushed in and quickly pushed Nie Zun away . Following that, Nie Zun spit out a mouthful of blood! A few drops landed on my face, but I did not have any energy to wipe it off as I collapsed on the bed!

“Jie, take a look at her,” Nie Zun struggled to say .

Jie Pa's eyes were full of worry . “You really don't fear death huh!”

Letting go of Nie Zun, he walked over and touched my split symbol to feel the MF . His gaze was inscrutable .

He let go of me and used his fingers to form a seal . Turning around, he aimed it at Piercer on the floor!

As Piercer was hit by the seal, it glowed with a bright violet light!

“Ah—!” Not able to withstand the stabbing pain in my brain, I called out in agony .

“Huh... another one trying to subdue me... do you have a death wish?”

A voice appeared in my head!

I opened my eyes wide .

“I’ll be back for you . ”

I heard that woman’s voice in the back of my head again .

I sat up screaming, covering both ears with my hands!

At the same time, the bright light emanating from Piercer instantly vanished! The stabbing chill was also gone in an instant!

“Okay now?” Jie Pa turned to look at me . I panted heavily, and put down my hands only when I was sure the pain in my head was entirely gone .

I looked at Jie Pa weakly . “Jie Pa, what... what’s this?”

I was unsure of how to broach the subject .

Jie Pa looked guilty . “It’s my fault . I didn’t suspect Zou An and his wife at the time, and I thought a living weapon would be able to help you in some way . I didn’t expect things to turn out this way . Nie Zun told me about what happened, and it seems that there is another body of consciousness attached to Piercer that is full of resentment . It should be her who was trying to devour your consciousness, and I’ve used a sealing technique to temporarily suppress her . ”

“What does it mean by temporarily . ” Nie Zun looked pretty much alright now, and he stood up as he wiped the corner of his mouth .

Jie Pa’s eyes darkened . “I’m not able to seal her forever, because it’s a living weapon . When living weapons are created, the soul within it is forever incarcerated, but it is also free . ”

“Why did you still give it to her if you knew about this . ” It was the first time Nie Zun spoke to Jie Pa with such reproach .

Jie Pa lowered his head slightly . “I knew that living weapons have souls in them, but I didn’t know that the body of consciousness in Piercer was different from the other living weapons . It’s my fault, I harmed Miss Ah Shen . ”

I lifted myself on the bed . “Don’t say that . You’re not at fault . Who’d expect such a thing? Zou An and Ah Wen are not bad people either, and there’s no way they could’ve anticipated that the user wasn’t able to control the living weapon . ”

Nie Zun sighed . “Is there any way to solve this . ”

Jie Pa looked serious as he adjusted his glasses . “There are only four living weapons in the entire Split Zone, and Piercer is a peculiar one . To be honest, I didn’t hear of any curse related to Piercer, but if both Gaoqin Jiuye and Zou An say so, it might probably be true . At this moment, we know too little about Piercer, and I’m afraid I don’t have a solution for this . The best option for us might be to find the previous owner of Piercer . ”

Jie Pa looked serious as he adjusted his glasses . “There are only four living weapons in the entire Split Zone, and Piercer is a peculiar one . To be honest, I didn’t hear of any curse related to Piercer, but if both Gaoqin Jiuye and Zou An say so, it might probably be true . At this moment, we know too little about Piercer, and I’m afraid I don’t have a solution for this . The best option for us might be to find the previous owner of Piercer . ”

“As far as I know, Ta Lai’s lover, Bian Ying, might know a thing or two about it . According to Gaoqin Jiuye, Piercer was commissioned by the legendary Satan Cang Ming, who wanted Zou An and Ah Wen to create a weapon for him . But before Piercer could reach him, it brought misfortune to Bian Ying . So, could Bian Ying have wielded Piercer?” I deduced .

Jie Pa nodded . “I’ve heard of Cang Ming, and I know he got Zou An and Ah Wen to create Piercer for him . I knew Piercer was a powerful weapon, but I haven’t heard of anything regarding Bian Ying . Where can we find Bian Ying though?”

I met Nie Zun’s eyes . “Seems like this calls for a trip to the Northern District so we can unravel everything . These questions can only be solved by finding the soul splitters . ”

“Have you decided then, Miss Ah Shen?”

I shook my head . “No, I haven’t settled matters in the Western District yet . And with my current abilities, before I can find any soul splitters, I’ll probably be dead once I step foot into the Northern District . We need to get to the bottom of this experiment and defeat Du Yue first . ”

“What about Piercer? You can no longer wield it easily with MF . ” Jie Pa picked up Piercer and handed it to me . I took Piercer in my hands, touching the body of the whip .

“Apart from Bian Ying, there should be someone else who knows more about Piercer . ”

Jie Pa’s eyes brightened . “You’re referring to Zou An?”

I nodded . “That’s right . Zou An parted with Ta Lai previously, and Ta Lai went back to the Northern District with Du Yue . Zou An is still an ordinary resident, so he should be in one of the other three districts . Jie Pa, get your intelligence network to find out where Zou An is . ”

Jie Pa nodded quickly . “Understood . Also, Miss Ah Shen, I have some things to report . ”

“Mm, go ahead . ”

Pushing up his glasses, Jie Pa continued, “We’ve looked into the experimental grounds, and there’s nothing else to find except for the abandoned corpses . However, from the look of the bodies, I’m quite sure they haven’t succeeded in their experiment, or at least, not yet in the Western District . ”

I frowned . “Is there any way to find out what the goal of their experiment is?”

I frowned . “Is there any way to find out what the goal of their experiment is?”

“I’ve looked into that, and it’s likely they are trying to find a body . ”

As if interested in this, Nie Zun interrupted, “Body?”

Nodding, Jie Pa explained, “That’s right . They’re looking for a body, or rather, a body of consciousness . They might be looking for someone who’s perfectly suitable as a breeding vessel for those leeches . ”

“Perfectly suitable?”

“I’ll explain it this way . The leeches are created by merging the souls of animals and insects captured from the real world by soul snatcher Rong Jin, together with a type of drug only found in the Split Zone . Blood taken from bodies of consciousness devoured by the leeches would be able to affect the regeneration abilities of another body of consciousness, to the point that it can cause permanent damage . However, the leeches don’t survive for long since they are essentially a mixture of insect souls and drugs, and they cannot reproduce .

“It’s also difficult to create these leeches . This is why they are looking for a perfectly suitable body that can merge with the leeches, and reproduce them thereafter . ”

“What’re the criteria for such a body of consciousness?” I asked hastily .

Jie Pa shook his head . “That’s what I’m still unsure of, since the information we have isn’t much . From what has been happening thus far, we can deduce that they’re looking for the consciousness of a child . ”

“Laurel?” I asked in shock .

Jie Pa nodded grimly . “We can assume so, but they might not be sure of this either . Younger bodies of consciousness are rare finds in the Split Zone . They might be attempting to merge these bodies with the leeches since it’s easier to manipulate and alter the MF of younger persons . If Li Wen was one of the subjects, they might have tested it on soul splitters too, since the eventual aim of the experiment is targeted at soul splitters .

“This might also be the reason why Huan Qing tried to make others think Mi Fu was a soul splitter . He might have sensed some danger, but without knowing what the target was, he tried to blindly protect Mi Fu in such a way . ”

“Looking at things, they should have already taken many children for this?”
I asked with knitted brows .

“That might be the case, and they might be looking for Miss Laurel and Miss Mi Fu right now . Miss Mi Fu has always been under the protection of the Southern District, but we have no way of knowing how negotiations between Si Luo and Du Yue went . What we can be sure of though, is that it’s likely they haven’t been able to find Miss Laurel . ”

“Just where did Laurel go...” I felt immense guilt as I thought about Laurel, since I could not protect her well .

“That might be the case, and they might be looking for Miss Laurel and Miss Mi Fu right now . Miss Mi Fu has always been under the protection of the Southern District, but we have no way of knowing how negotiations between Si Luo and Du Yue went . What we can be sure of though, is that it’s likely they haven’t been able to find Miss Laurel . ”

“Just where did Laurel go...” I felt immense guilt as I thought about Laurel, since I could not protect her well .

“There’s no need to worry, Miss Ah Shen . I trust my intelligence network back here in the Western District . The leader, Chou Yu, has a great team, and I’m sure they’d be able to find Laurel . Du Yue might have also been making use of an opportunity to look for Laurel by making a trip to the Western District . ”

I nodded . “Oh, Jie Pa, do you know of any method that can kill soul splitters?”

Jie Pa laughed bitterly . “Miss Ah Shen, I haven’t seen a soul splitter before this either, and I wouldn’t be aware of what you don’t know . But, it should be safe for us to hazard a guess that soul splitters cannot be killed by inserting splitting keys into their split symbols, and such an act can only bring us back to the real world . Because of this, Du Yue is sparing no effort to find a way to cause direct damage to soul splitters . ”

I said angrily, “Who is she to make use of ordinary residents’ lives for this experiment just to kill her rival in love?”

“This is definitely cruel . But regarding the bodies of consciousness in the Split Zone and why this place exists, there are definitely secrets unbeknownst to us, and this is where we can start unraveling it . ”

Nie Zun added, “I agree with Jie Pa . The mystery of the Split Zone is definitely linked to these recent events, and we might be able to uncover some secrets . ”

“Oh, also, how did everyone react to my decision?” I asked, looking at Jie Pa uneasily .

Jie Pa smiled . “You have nothing to worry about, Miss Ah Shen . They’ve spread the word to the residents of the Western District, and everyone is supportive . They hope you’d be able to help them find a method to return to the real world . ”

Nie Zun nodded . “No matter how good it is here, it’s still weird and foreign to humans . Humans depend on the warmth of our family, friends, and lovers, so most of them would choose to go back; it’s just that they might have been too cowardly to admit this before . ”

The warmth from family and friends...

I stole a glance at Nie Zun’s distant eyes .

Chapter 114

114 Pre-emptive Strike

“No matter what happens, I’ll try my best to make up for being such an irresponsible district commander in the past . ” I adjusted my dress, hung Piercer back onto my waist, and got up from the bed .

“We’ll need to split into three different teams from here . You lead a team to continue with the investigation on the experiment, and try to find Laurel as soon as possible . The second team should look for a method to save Old Man Fan and also find Zou An in order to get to the bottom of Piercer’s mystery . Thirdly, I’ll meet with Jiao S to discuss the next steps and design a plan before we head for the Northern District to uncover the secret behind the Split Zone . ”

Jie Pa nodded in agreement .

“I’ll get started then . Don’t worry about the residents, Miss Ah Shen . The floor managers have passed your message to the residents . However, if you’re planning to go to the Northern District, I think you should bring some capable individuals along with you . The intelligence network put together by Nie Zun and I is great at collecting information, but they’re not that good at other things . ”

I pondered for a moment . “You’re right . Old Man Fan is not around now, and You Ji turned her back on us . Even Song Lu and Yu Liang are not here... If I were to go to the Northern District, I’ll definitely need more help . Would you happen to have any ideas?”

I scratched my head in slight embarrassment . “Well, you know that I’m not very familiar with the people of the Western District...”

Jie Pa laughed . “It’s alright . I can give you a suggestion . Miss Ah Shen, Miss Jiao S has her S Clan and the Southern District’s Mr Si Luo has three capable subordinates . You need people like that too, but looking at the situation in the Western District now, there isn’t many who’re capable enough . Even if we could find such individuals, they might not be loyal to you at all because of your previous indifference towards district matters . Though you’ve made your stance clear now – that you’ll work to get everyone out of the Split Zone, you haven’t yet done anything which can let these people fully put their trust in you, right?”

I nodded with guilt .

Jie Pa continued, “I can recommend two individuals, and I’d suggest that together with Jiao S, you bring them with you to the Southern District . I don’t think Du Yue will turn back on her word yet, so we can attack with a pre-emptive strike in the Southern District to retrieve Yu Liang, and also to get a clear picture of the Southern District Commander, Si Luo’s stance towards all this, before we decide on further steps . Whatever happens in the Southern District will directly affect our plans in the Northern District . If we’re able to get Si Luo’s support, Rong Jin will naturally align with him, and Du Yue’s chances of a victory will thus be lowered . ”

“But looking at Rong Jin’s actions thus far, it seems as if he’d stubbornly go ahead with this experiment even if Si Luo objected to it,” I said with a frown .

“That’s true . However, it isn’t beneficial to us if we aren’t sure of Si Luo’s stance on this, and furthermore, we haven’t even seen him before . Though we need to settle the matters of the Western District and take time to recuperate, we don’t want to end up a sitting duck either . ”

Nie Zun poured himself a glass of water, and I was momentarily distracted by the sound .

I looked towards Nie Zun, seeing him calmly pick up the glass .

“We kept talking and I forgot about you . You, you’re alright...?” I asked with slight guilt as I thought about what he did for me, looking at the traces

of smeared blood at the corner of his lips .

Nie Zun laughed, saying, “What could possibly happen to someone with an MF of 67?”

...

Getting cocky again...

I knew I shouldn't have asked...

“That reminds me . ” Nie Zun took a sip of water, before placing the glass back onto the desk .

“All these plans are good, but I have a question . Jie, I'm afraid the trip to the Southern District would turn out much deadlier now that she can't use Piercer so freely . Furthermore, you'll definitely have to stay here . I just can't be at ease knowing that you'll be alone, and if something happens with Piercer when we're in the Eastern or Southern District, who should we turn to?”

Jie Pa adjusted his glass and addressed Nie Zun's concerns gravely, “Nie Zun, even if I'm right beside Miss Ah Shen, I can't help much with Piercer . This type of seal wouldn't work a second time, and what I can do now is to locate Zou An as soon as I can . There's no need to worry about me either . You know Chou Yu too, and I'm sure I'll be safe with him in the Western District . When the both of you meet Miss Jiao S in the Eastern District, make sure to form a strong working partnership as well . This is so she'll send some people to protect the Western District . ”

I nodded in agreement . “Apart from ourselves, Jiao S is the only other person I trust the most right now . ”

It seems so ironic that I used to treat her with so much suspicion, but she turned out to be the only one I can trust .

“I agree with Jie Pa's suggestion, no use being a sitting duck . Since everyone is aware of my decision, the Western District residents would be

able to protect themselves, and I might not be of much help here either .
What I can do now is to go to the Northern District, unravel the mystery
behind soul splitters, and bring everyone home . ”

“I agree with Jie Pa’s suggestion, no use being a sitting duck . Since
everyone is aware of my decision, the Western District residents would be
able to protect themselves, and I might not be of much help here either .
What I can do now is to go to the Northern District, unravel the mystery
behind soul splitters, and bring everyone home . ”

Nie Zun looked at me . “Okay, your call . ”

“Jie Pa, as for the two individuals you mentioned, I’ll still want to meet
them first . I’m not planning to bring them to the Southern District with me
though, because I hope they can stay here to protect you,” I addressed Jie
Pa, speaking with conviction .

Looking at how resolute I was on this, Jie Pa sighed lightly . “Alright, since
Miss Ah Shen has decided, I’ll bring the two of them to meet you . ”

“It’s the two floor managers?” Nie Zun asked .

Jie Pa nodded . “That’s right . From what I know, these floor managers keep
a low profile, but they were important figures to Li Qing previously . ”

I was quite surprised . “You’re referring to the Yuan siblings – Yuan Shen
and Yuan Qian?”

“That’s right, it’s them . ”

I sighed inwardly .

I heard about Yuan Shen and Yuan Qian . They are two individuals who
decided to become siblings after meeting in the Split Zone and who
christened themselves with their current names . It takes the pronunciation
of the Chinese characters for ‘fate that is deep and shallow’, as if they were
trying to bid their pasts goodbye and start new lives here in the Split Zone .

(T/n: The Chinese character for ‘fate’ is pronounced yuan, while that of ‘deep’ and ‘shallow’ are pronounced shen and qian respectively .)

Li Qing mentioned that the siblings are strong, just that they might have rather weird personalities . They were both personally selected by Li Qing to be floor managers, and after Li Qing left, I was not involved in the matters of selecting floor managers, leaving it all to You Ji . Some of them did not want to remain as floor managers, while some simply continued in the roles, like Ta Lai and the Yuan siblings, and I just let them decide freely .

The siblings have a unique ability – they are experts in poison .

Although the poisons used in the Split Zone are essentially derived from mental inhibitors, the siblings have continued to develop many new poisons . These poisons cannot be used to kill anyone here, but they are known to cause great pain .

Although the poisons used in the Split Zone are essentially derived from mental inhibitors, the siblings have continued to develop many new poisons . These poisons cannot be used to kill anyone here, but they are known to cause great pain .

The siblings do not usually attack others with their poisons, nor will they let others use the poisons . They are weird in that they merely continue developing these poisons without using them or allowing others to use them .

Since they abhorred violence, I seldom call for their help even if things do happen in the Western District . I do not ask for more as long as they are able to take care of the floors they are in charge of .

“Miss Ah Shen, the siblings had requested to meet you after seeing you kneel that day . They are well-versed in the use of poisons, no less than I am in fact, but they might not be willing to get involved in this matter . If you are able to convince them to join our fight, I’m sure they will be a great help . ” Jie Pa adjusted his glasses .

“Alright, I’ll go meet them then . Where’re they now?”

“I’ll get them to come over . They manage the 10th and 11th floors actually, so it’s not far from here . I’ll be meeting up with Chou Yu to brief him on our plans then . ”

“Sure . ”

Jie Pa started to leave .

I called out in haste, “Jie Pa . ”

Jie Pa turned back, waiting for me to continue with an earnest gaze .

I beamed at him . “Nothing, I just wanted to say thank you . I wasn’t close to you before, but you’re sparing no effort to help . I’m just really grateful . ”

Jie Pa smiled gently . “Miss Ah Shen, although you aren’t close to many people, you didn’t even hesitate when Nie Zun recommended that I take care of the Marketplace . I have reason to believe that you trust me instinctively, and this is also a form of trust towards Nie Zun . Since you trust him, and you trust me, there’s really no need to thank me for this . ”

My heart was flooded with warmth .

“Miss Ah Shen, Nie Zun will never betray you . If Nie Zun doesn’t turn his back on you, I won’t either . ”

My heart was flooded with warmth .

“Miss Ah Shen, Nie Zun will never betray you . If Nie Zun doesn’t turn his back on you, I won’t either . ”

Jie Pa left after saying all these .

I glanced at Nie Zun . “You two are really close . ”

Nie Zun laughed . “He’s a good guy, and he loved my sister so . It’s just tough luck that he met me . To save me, he even ended up here, away from my sister . I owe him a lot . ”

He looked at me, blinking . “He really wasted a lot of time on this patient cum ‘little brother’ of his . ”

I smiled . “That’s nice . So why did you come here? Even if you are cursed, you’re still surrounded by people who love you and care about you . ”

I pointed at his left hand .

He looked calm and relaxed as he said, “Everything happens for a reason . ”

I shrugged . “Stop trying to look brooding, I can’t stand it . ”

“But then again, why did Jie Pa come here together with you?”

Nie Zun’s eyes looked unfocused . “Like me, he probably thought my sister died . Or maybe he was sent here to be my savior like a gift from heaven . ”

Nie Zun smiled, but his eyes looked lonely .

My heart ached at this .

Chapter 115

115 Poison-making Siblings

I observed Yuan Shen and Yuan Qian as the both of them arrived in my room .

They were both in similar plaited shirts, and the older brother, Yuan Shen was a head taller than Yuan Qian, who wore her hair in a simple ponytail . Apart from their indifferent expressions – they look like they do not really care about anything, they looked just like any other pair of siblings in the real world .

“District Commander,” the siblings addressed me in a calm and composed manner .

I became rather curious about this pair of siblings .

“Sit,” I said as I looked at them .

They looked at each other, almost as if they did not expect me to say such a thing . Seeing that they did not move from their current positions, I simply shrugged, not minding it .

“I heard the both of you are experts at using poison?” Copying Nie Zun, I poured myself a glass of water to drink, trying to look natural and also make myself look a little friendlier .

“We just know a little bit,” older brother Yuan Shen answered .

I took a sip of water, and leaned casually against the wall with the glass in my hand, hitting it lightly with my fingers .

“How about you show me some skills?” I smiled at them .

Smiling faintly, younger sister Yuan Qian stepped forward . “You’ve already been poisoned, District Commander . ”

“Oh?” I pretended to be surprised as I shook the glass in my hand . “Is it the water?”

Immediately after, I saw the hand holding the glass slowly turn gray, and it started to hurt a little .

“No, it was on the glass . ” Yuan Qian pointed at my hand .

“Oh, what does it do?” I calmly placed the glass back onto the desk .

“District Commander, what would you do if I tell you that this poison will spread through your arm, and it will cause damage to your MF upon reaching your heart?” Yuan Qian asked without smiling . She looked at me seriously, as if talking about something important .

I smiled, shrugging . “Then I’ll do this . ”

I swiftly took the under-utilized fruit knife from the desk, activated my MF in my right hand, and cleanly cut off my left arm .

Without blinking an eye, I looked at the broken arm on the floor and thought to myself, Poor arm of mine, you’ve been broken so many times recently . Sorry about that .

“Very decisive, District Commander . Why were you so indifferent before?” Yuan Shen spoke .

I looked at them squarely . “Firstly, I admit that I let the Western District residents down by how I acted before . I’ve apologized for that, and since the both of you have accepted my apology, I believe as Western District residents, you’ll still be loyal to me . Secondly, I know the both of you were very close to Li Qing, and I know you guys don’t like me . However, I hope to remind you that the current District Commander is me, whether you like

it or not . Li Qing placed the Western District in my hands, and if the both of you are truly faithful to her, you should be loyal to me as well . ”

I spoke with authority and made sure to keep my expression steadfast . Although this was not really how I wanted to present myself in front of others, I knew I had to have an air of dominance of a District Commander in order for me to continue on this path I chose .

The siblings looked surprised . They looked at each other for a long time before looking back at me .

A new arm had already started to grow, but I did not give it much heed, even though it was rather harrowing .

I smiled at them again . “What do you think, would you like to lend me your strength?”

Yuan Shen met Yuan Qian’s eyes, seemingly coming to a mutual decision through the exchange of gazes .

Yuan Qian spoke first, “We await your instructions, District Commander . ”

After saying that, Yuan Qian finally broke into a smile for the first time after entering the room . She looked rather pure and innocent .

“Phew, why didn’t we come to an agreement earlier . I even had to cut my arm off . Stop being so formal, and quickly give me the antidote for my arm . ” I heaved a sigh of relief, and went back to how I usually acted .

Yuan Shen looked a little stunned seeing the abrupt change in me, while Yuan Qian smiled, revealing her dimples, as she said, “The poison’s gone, I’ll help you reattach the arm . ”

Yuan Shen looked a little stunned seeing the abrupt change in me, while Yuan Qian smiled, revealing her dimples, as she said, “The poison’s gone, I’ll help you reattach the arm . ”

She picked up my arm on the floor and attached it back to where it belonged . Moving her nifty fingers, I felt a tingling of warmth as she put

the parts together, and there was actually no pain when they fused .

“You’re really good at this,” I praised her as I nodded in slight awe .

“It’s not much, but we should be able to help fight against small fry . ”

Yuan Qian seems rather lively, and it looks like she has a good sense of humor too . I guess she didn’t talk to me much because she really didn’t like me before this...

“What do you need us to do, District Commander?” Yuan Shen spoke steadily .

“Oh, it’s nothing much actually . I just need the both of you to stay here in the Western District to protect Jie Pa, that’s all . I trust you guys . Don’t call me District Commander please, just call me Ah Shen . ” I waved my hand, signaling that they do not have to be that formal with me .

“Help Jie Pa?” Yuan Shen asked with raised brows .

“Yup, that’s right . I’ll be heading for the Southern District in a few days to find out more about that experiment . I’m sure you’ve heard the details from Jie Pa and you’ve also witnessed the scene . I need to get to the bottom of this . When I’m gone, I’ll be leaving everything in the Western District to Jie Pa, so I hope you’ll be able to stay by his side and protect him . Would the both of you be agreeable to this?”

Looking at how serious and sincere I sounded, Yuan Shen and Yuan Qian nodded without hesitation .

“As long as you’re willing to lead the Western District residents like Li Qing did, even if you’re not able to find a way to go back, we’ll still be willing to lend you our strength . ” Yuan Qian smiled gently .

I sighed inwardly . The residents might not have asked for much, and they might have just wanted to lead simple and peaceful lives, but I was not able to provide them with the security they yearned for .

Why did I agree to take on the role of Western District Commander in the first place if I've failed in all this?

Either way, since I'm already the District Commander, it's now my job to protect them .

"I promise to bring you peace . I hope you'll be able to help me . " I humbly lowered my head .

"Sure . " Yuan Qian put a hand on my shoulder, signaling her willingness to help .

"Sure . " Yuan Qian put a hand on my shoulder, signaling her willingness to help .

I gave her a grateful smile .

Nie Zun's mobile phone rang at this moment .

"You have visitors . News from Jie Pa's informant at the district border," said Nie Zun as he kept his phone .

I asked with curiosity, "Oh, guests? Who'd be visiting now considering the recent spate of events?"

Nie Zun smiled lazily . "I'm sure you wouldn't be able to guess who these three are . "

"Stop it . " I rolled my eyes at him impatiently .

He yawned . "Huan Qing, Mi Fu and Ku Fei . "

...

I did not expect that .

"Why'd they be here? Has Huan Qing recovered? Oh right, it's already been more than a month from that time . We really lost track of time during our training with Ta Lai . I guess his MF is recovered now . "

“It’s you who lost track of time . I knew exactly how many days had passed . ” Nie Zun glanced at me .

I rolled my eyes inwardly . I shall not argue with you over this since the Yuan siblings are still here!

“Where’re they?”

“They said they wanted to look for you about something . Jie Pa directed them to the Residence, so they’d probably need a few hours . ”

“Since they’re guests, we shouldn’t make them wait either . Let’s go meet them, it’ll save time . ”

I looked back at the Yuan siblings . “I’ll leave the matters of the Residence to the both of you for now . Jie Pa might already be too overwhelmed looking after both the Marketplace and the Academy . I’ll need the both of you to look for more capable individuals to look after the Residence . Help me reassign the floor managers too . For those that seem unsuitable, it’s okay to replace them . I’ll be going ahead to meet our visitors . After I’m back, could I get the revised name list of the new Residence management?”

“Since they’re guests, we shouldn’t make them wait either . Let’s go meet them, it’ll save time . ”

I looked back at the Yuan siblings . “I’ll leave the matters of the Residence to the both of you for now . Jie Pa might already be too overwhelmed looking after both the Marketplace and the Academy . I’ll need the both of you to look for more capable individuals to look after the Residence . Help me reassign the floor managers too . For those that seem unsuitable, it’s okay to replace them . I’ll be going ahead to meet our visitors . After I’m back, could I get the revised name list of the new Residence management?”

Yuan Qian looked shocked . “All, all this, you’re just leaving it to my brother and I?”

I smiled . “That’s right . I trust the both of you . I’ll be leaving all matters of the Residence to you guys . ”

Yuan Qian looked at Yuan Shen for a moment, and then the both of them met my gaze with thankful eyes .

“Okay, stop looking at me like this . I’ll totally replace you guys if you don’t do a good job . ” I blinked at them cheekily, and waved Nie Zun over .
“Let’s go meet our three important visitors . ”

Following which, I jumped out of the window . As soon as we hit the ground, Nie Zun asked with those starry eyes, “You trust those two that much?”

“I trust Jie Pa’s recommendation, and I have an accurate instinct about these things . I trust them . ” I looked back up in the direction of the window we leapt out of .

“You have an accurate instinct? Why don’t I agree with that? Didn’t you always think I was a devil? How can that be accurate?” Nie Zun looked at me mischievously .

Glancing at him, I asked ostentatiously, “How is that inaccurate?”

Nie Zun smirked, and there were ripples in his eyes . “Seems like you’re back to your usual self now . That’s good . ”

“Stop it . That contented expression looks as if you’re seeing someone of the next generation change for the better . I’m going to puke . ” I waved my hands at him as I said this .

“Next generation? Yup, that’s right, dear daughter . ” Nie Zun’s eyes creased with laughter .

I was momentarily speechless . Fine, I dug my own grave for this .

“Let’s go . We’ll talk while on the move . Isn’t running around in the Western District your favorite thing to do? Although it’s day now, it’s still nice to be able to run around . ” He was gone with a light tap of his feet .

Chapter 116

116 The Secret behind Split Symbols

We finally saw Huan Qing and party as we arrived in front of the Academy .

Mi Fu was dressed in her usual pink, and following closely behind her were the sunny athlete, Ku Fei, and handsome Huan Qing .

“Look at you, you’ve recovered well,” I spoke as we were within earshot of the three .

For the first time, I saw some emotion pass in Huan Qing’s amber eyes, and he smiled . “I’ll have to thank you for saving me the last time . ”

“No need to be so polite . I didn’t really do anything, much less save you . ” I laughed .

Ku Fei reddened . “That, on that, Ah Shen, I misunderstood you previously . Lord Huan Qing told me everything after he regained consciousness, and I, I’ve been feeling really guilty about it . I even abandoned all of you...”

“No biggie, it’s understandable that you’d misunderstand in that kind of situation,” Nie Zun said . He seemed to like Ku Fei a lot .

I glanced at Mi Fu, and our eyes met coincidentally as she was also trying to steal a glance at me . Seeing me look at her, she quickly averted her gaze .

This little girl, she’s quite stubborn, but her nature... Thinking about what she did previously though, she seemed to be rather wicked .

“Weren’t you kidnapped?” I teased her . Mi Fu blushed in embarrassment, and her rosy cheeks showed that she was indignant .

Seeing Mi Fu angry, Ku Fei quickly continued, “Ah Shen, Du Yue did take her away . But it was to bring her to meet Lord Si Luo . That horrible woman Du Yue has already left . ”

I thought to myself, Does this mean Mi Fu isn’t a perfectly suitable body of consciousness for their experiment?

“I’ll be frank with you . We’re here today to seek help from you . ” Huan Qing spoke, looking slightly worn out .

“Go ahead . ” Though I looked calm on the surface, I had my suspicions about this . I just could not wrap my head around why they would be here in the Western District at this time . Furthermore, the usually haughty Huan Qing is asking me for help .

Things are getting rather complicated these days...

“It’s like this . ” Huan Qing looked around him to ensure there was no one else around before he continued .

“What I’m about to tell you is the Southern District’s greatest secret . ” Huan Qing had an extremely serious expression .

Be quick about it... Doesn’t it mean you trust me if you came here looking for me... Why the long story...

“Li Shen, our District Commander, Si Luo is weakening . ” Huan Qing looked pained as he said this, almost as if he could not bear to reveal the truth .

I said calmly, “I know that . ”

Huan Qing was slightly surprised . “You know?”

I nodded . “Rong Jin already told us . ”

“Rong Jin was here in the Western District, and he already went back with Gaoqin Jiuye,” I explained to Huan Qing .

Huan Qing sighed after thinking for a while . “I don’t know how Rong Jin said it, but let me just explain it again in detail . Right now, Si Luo’s life force is slowly weakening . We don’t know what’s causing it and we can’t find a way to save him either . I’m in as much agony as Gaoqin Jiuye and Rong Jin over this, it’s just that the two of them are way too inflexible about this . ”

Huan Qing sighed after thinking for a while . “I don’t know how Rong Jin said it, but let me just explain it again in detail . Right now, Si Luo’s life force is slowly weakening . We don’t know what’s causing it and we can’t find a way to save him either . I’m in as much agony as Gaoqin Jiuye and Rong Jin over this, it’s just that the two of them are way too inflexible about this . ”

I felt a little grieved . This aloof gentleman who always seemed to be so proud and distant now looked so forlorn because of this . Everyone seemed to have been dragged into this conspiracy, and it looks like there is no escape .

“What are his symptoms?” Nie Zun asked an important question .

“It’s not his MF that’s weakening, it’s his body . Just like a real body, he actually started to fall ill and weaken . ”

I pondered for a moment . Addressing Huan Qing, I asked, “Since you initially didn’t know Rong Jin told me about it, why did you come all the way here to say this?”

Huan Qing looked at me . “Like I said, I need your help on something . This is something you need to know before I can seek your help . ”

Before I could speak, Mi Fu rudely interrupted, “No need to waste so much time talking to her . I don’t need anyone’s protection . Huan Qing, don’t beg her!”

I smirked, “Little girl, just be quiet for a moment . I can tell that whatever request Huan Qing has, it definitely has something to do with you . Since he came all the way here just for you, do you need any further explanation? Whatever Huan Qing does, it’s all for you . Are you still going to continue being such a spoilt brat?”

Mi Fu’s rosy cheeks turned redder in embarrassment, but she bit her lip and did not continue . Sensing that I might get angry, Ku Fei quickly said, “Ah Shen, please don’t fault Mi Fu for this . She’s not a bad person, though she can be a little stubborn...”

I rolled my eyes . Fine, she’s not a bad person!

Huan Qing spoke abruptly, “Is it okay if we speak in private?”

I looked at Nie Zun to get his agreement, and nodded at Huan Qing .

“Actually, it’s not Nie Zun I wanted to avoid . It’s Mi Fu and Ku Fei . ”
Huan Qing’s gaze was on Mi Fu, who was now more than a hundred meters away from us .

“Apart from Si Luo’s condition, I also heard about you and Mi Fu . I heard her brother saved your life once . ”

“Apart from Si Luo’s condition, I also heard about you and Mi Fu . I heard her brother saved your life once . ”

Huan Qing looked stunned . “Rong Jin told you about me too?”

I met his eyes squarely . “No, he didn’t go into detail on that . Huan Qing, don’t mind me asking this question, but I hope I can get an answer .
According to Rong Jin, Mi Fu’s older brother was a soul splitter . So how did he die while saving you? This means soul splitters can die too right?”

Huan Qing looked pained . “Usually, soul splitters don’t die, unless they want to . ”

I frowned in confusion . “I don’t get it . ”

Huan Qing sighed, as if he was powerless about this . “I just don’t know where to start explaining these things . ”

“You’re referring to the fact that Si Luo is a soul splitter?”

“Just what did Rong Jin say?” Huan Qing looked like he was about to flip out .

I shrugged . “He didn’t say anything else, just that Si Luo is a soul splitter, and Mi Fu’s older brother was a soul splitter who died while saving you . ”

Huan Qing’s fists clenched as I spoke .

“Alright . ” As if compromising suddenly, Huan Qing sighed again . “Since you know this too, it’s not difficult for me to talk about my request . As you know, Si Luo is a soul splitter . All soul splitters have a matching split symbol with someone else . The one who has a matching split symbol with Si Luo is Mi Fu . ”

What?? Mi Fu’s soul splitter is Si Luo, Si Luo is Mi Fu’s soul splitter??

“So, Si Luo’s weakening life force will affect Mi Fu?” I asked in confusion .

Huan Qing shook his head gravely . “No . It’s because of Mi Fu that Si Luo has symptoms of a weakening life force . ”

“So, Si Luo’s weakening life force will affect Mi Fu?” I asked in confusion .

Huan Qing shook his head gravely . “No . It’s because of Mi Fu that Si Luo has symptoms of a weakening life force . ”

“Could you explain this more plainly...” I muttered .

“Do you remember when you first arrived in the Split Zone? New arrivals don’t have split symbols on them, and they’ll even glow, identifying them as somebody different from those who are already here . The split symbol needs some time to form, and only after that will the glow fade . Split

symbols do not appear on their own either . They are actually carved by the soul splitters who brought you here . ”

These words were like bombs, exploding loudly in my ears .

Does this mean that we’re all here because of soul splitters? These split symbols and splitting keys were all created by them? No, if the split symbols were carved by them, why would they leave a splitting key? Wouldn’t this be like digging themselves into a hole?

“I know you definitely have your questions, and I can’t say much either . What I can tell you is that, split symbols are carved onto us by the soul splitters, and once a split symbol forms, it is equivalent to a contract with the Split Zone . This contract encompasses you, your soul splitter, and the Split Zone . The contract is a simple one . The Split Zone provides you and the soul splitter with split symbols, which contain MF and power . At the same time, the Split Zone gifts you with a splitting key, and that’s to give you a chance to return . ”

This time, I heard it clearly, and I realized what such a contract might really mean . I felt dispirited, but I still had to ask my questions . I had to know if my suspicions were right .

“So, when the soul splitters give us our split symbols, a split symbol will also appear on them . Once the split symbol appears, there would be MF . Does this mean that they captured us because they want the power from the split symbols?” I tried my best to keep my voice from trembling .

Huan Qing looked pained . “That’s exactly right . ”

I took a deep breath to steady myself, but I felt like I was already losing focus on Huan Qing’s voice .

“To the soul splitters, MF is equivalent to having a super power in the real world . The only way to obtain this power is to get a split symbol . In the Split Zone, the split symbol is an ancient curse . Those who obtain it are able to obtain great power . However, all split symbols come in pairs, and they can restrict each other . Soul splitters have found a perfect way to

obtain such power without the restriction, that is, to capture souls from the real world and apply the curse on themselves and the soul who was brought to the Split Zone . This way, both of them obtain the power .

“As the split symbol is a curse in itself, that power doesn’t come for free . Since you are not originally from the Split Zone, when the split symbol forms, a splitting key will form at the same time . Put simply, the splitting key is a way for you to go back to reality by inserting it into the matching split symbol to end the curse . ”

Chapter 117

Volume 2

117 Contract via Split Symbol

I felt suffocated by what I just heard. “This means that soul splitters are the cause of all this? They brought us here, away from our world, our families and loved ones, just to fulfil their selfish desires?”

“Just, merely to fulfil... that desire for power?” I repeated what I said, slowly.

Huan Qing nodded grimly.

“Haha.” I felt like laughing for some reason.

Although it is common knowledge that soul splitters are the ones who captured our consciousness and brought us here, the reason behind this has been unknown to us. Because we do not know the secrets of the Split Zone, I kept thinking that the soul splitters might be doing such a thing because they were somehow forced to, and that they might have been forced to do so in order to survive here.

I tried to understand and believe that they had certain reasons to do so, thinking that this was simply how it worked in the Split Zone, that they had no other options. What I hear now is that, they simply wanted the power the split symbols can provide.

“How different is this from murder?” I looked at Huan Qing, thirsty for an answer that could lighten the weight in my heart.

I did not get any.

He took a deep breath. “I don’t know. I’m not a soul splitter, and I don’t know why they do this.”

“Then why are you working for the soul splitters?” I almost screamed the question.

Aware that there was still a group of people nearby looking at us, I tried to keep a lid on my emotions.

“Because I owe my life to one.”

Trying hard to remain calm, I told myself to be patient and listen to his story.

Huan Qing looked into the distance. “Mi Fu’s older brother was the soul splitter who captured me. Soul splitters have no pity for humans, so I didn’t carry any hopes of being able to return. However, there were people I still care about in that world, and for her, I had to go back. This is why I did something which I thought was the most embarrassing thing ever at the time – I knelt in front of Mi Fu’s older brother to beg him.

“I didn’t have high hopes at first. Since they captured us to gain power, why would they let go of their catch easily? What I didn’t expect was that he agreed to my request, and did not engrave a split symbol on me. For those in the Split Zone, as long as they don’t have a split symbol, there’s still a possibility for them to go back. Once they have a split symbol on them, the only way they can leave the Split Zone is to use their splitting key to undo the curse.

“Since he did not engrave a split symbol on me, that led to his life force depleting.”

I opened my eyes wide. “Does this mean that by capturing us, it not only gives them power, but it prolongs their life as well?”

Huan Qing fidgeted slightly and looked at me. “I’ll try to explain this as plainly as possible.

“Soul splitters are naturally stronger than us, but if they want greater strength, establishing a contract via split symbol would be the only way. They’d have to engrave the split symbol on the human soul they captured, and the contract forms once they succeed. Though the contract provides power to both the soul splitter and the human, it also has a restriction. Once the contract is established via the split symbol, it provides the soul splitter with greater strength, but at the same time, the human will receive a splitting key that can undo it. If the human finds the soul splitter and succeeds in using their splitting key to undo the contract, their split symbol will disappear and they can return. However, the split symbol on the soul splitter will still remain.

“Half of the split symbol will remain on their bodies, and they’d then have to find a new soul within a certain amount of time in order to re-engrave the other half of the split symbol onto somebody new. If they don’t, they die.”

“So this means, he had initially established a contract with a human via split symbol, but that human undid it and returned to the real world. Therefore, in order to survive, he captured you. However, because you begged him to, he decided to give up engraving the split symbol onto your body, and this eventually caused his death?” I asked in disbelief.

How could this be? If Mi Fu’s older brother captured Huan Qing in order to save himself, why would he let Huan Qing go so easily?

Huan Qing nodded in response. “Yes. He did not engrave a split symbol onto me, and he eventually weakened after a period of time. His last request to me was to take care of Mi Fu.”

“Mi Fu is human, so why is she his little sister?”

“I don’t know about that either. I heard he used to have a real younger sister who was a soul splitter too, and Mi Fu just looks very similar to her. Soul splitters are able to see the real world from here, and when Mi Fu was captured by Si Luo, he begged Si Luo not to engrave a split symbol on her. Si Luo agreed, and instead of engraving a split symbol on Mi Fu, he captured another human. Coincidentally, I was captured at about the same time. Although Mi Fu doesn’t have a split symbol engraved on her, she fell

in love with Ku Fei here and refused to return to the real world. We can't force the consciousness of others to do things they don't wish to, and so Mi Fu's older brother let me go, with one condition. He wanted me to persuade Mi Fu to go back to the real world before I leave this place, and to go back together with her."

"What about him? He didn't capture any new souls after that?"

"Finding a suitable body of consciousness and capturing it is no easy feat, and there is a condition to do so. I don't know what that condition is, but this is the fate of a soul splitter. When Mi Fu's older brother let me go, he wasn't able to capture another human soul in time, causing his life force to weaken."

"Why didn't he just engrave the split symbol on you first, and let you undo it via the splitting key only after Mi Fu decides to go back? Couldn't he have continued looking for another body of consciousness after you bring Mi Fu back?" I asked, finding it rather odd.

Huan Qing sighed. "Even if he had engraved a split symbol on me, I wouldn't have been able to go back immediately anyway. There's something about the split symbols you don't know. Without activating your split symbol, your splitting key is basically trash, it can do nothing. This means that if you haven't activated your split symbol with your splitting key, you won't be able to go back even if you inserted the splitting key into your soul splitter's split symbol. Once you activate your split symbol, you also activate the curse and obtain the power. The curse of the split symbol dictates that you have to experience this before you are able to leave. Furthermore, it's not that easy for newbies to activate their split symbol so quickly since they're still not familiar with how they can control and manipulate their MF. He did it all for me, since I wanted to return so badly."

I felt a wrench in my heart. *This means that even if I've found my soul splitter, I can't go back? Since I haven't had a taste of the split symbol's curse?*

No, wait, that's not right.

Whatever he said sounded like it made perfect sense, but there's still a problem.

Why did Mi Fu's older brother let Huan Qing go at the risk of possibly losing his life?

Even if Huan Qing stayed here because of Mi Fu, why does he have such great MF? He even became the top illusionist in the Southern District after activating his split symbol?

“I know what you're wondering.” Huan Qing looked at me.

“I had to protect Mi Fu after her older brother died, and without any power, I wouldn't be able to fulfil my promise. Because of that, I decided to let another soul splitter, who just so happened to have lost their human soul counterpart, to engrave a split symbol on me.”

What??

Without speaking, I looked at him in a daze.

Why do such a thing?

Because he was grateful to Mi Fu's older brother for letting him go, and in order to protect Mi Fu, he gave up on the opportunity to return?

There was actually such kindness between soul splitters and humans in the Split Zone???

Huan Qing gave a wry smile. “Don't worry, I'm not stupid. I have a similar agreement with the soul splitter who engraved the split symbol on me, and once Mi Fu decides to leave, I'll undo the contract.”

Is it all because of Ku Fei that Mi Fu refuses to leave?

Subconsciously, my eyes landed on Mi Fu and Ku Fei, who were not far from us.

She's definitely stubborn, even in love. She's very possessive of Ku Fei, but is it because she can't pull herself out of it?

So, in not accepting her feelings, is Ku Fei doing this for her? Hoping she would leave?

This was an information overload, all these things relating to the soul splitters. I need time to think it through and also discuss it with Nie Zun. But everything seemed rather unrelated to me, so why did Huan Qing look for me for help? What did he need me to do?

Huan Qing continued, "I've told you the secret of the soul splitters, and I'm about to request something from you."

"Go ahead."

"As I said, Mi Fu is currently the only human in the Split Zone without a split symbol. I've used illusions to protect her and make her look just like another ordinary human here. To keep her from being discovered by other soul splitters, I've even tried to lead others into thinking that she is a soul splitter herself. Mi Fu's constitution makes her a suitable soul for Si Luo, and Si Luo had captured another human after agreeing to Mi Fu's older brother's request of letting her go. That human already undid the curse and left the Split Zone. Without a suitable human soul, Si Luo's life force thus started to weaken."

Listening to Huan Qing, I began to understand what he wanted my help with.

Chapter 118

118 Huan Qing's Request

“Without a human soul as a counterpart to his split symbol, it is now eating away at Si Luo's life force . His symptoms are identical to that of Mi Fu's older brother at that time, and without an opportunity to find a new body of consciousness, the best and quickest way to save his life is to let him engrave a split symbol onto Mi Fu . Gaoqin Jiuye and Rong Jin are aware of this, and they're both looking for Mi Fu now . ”

My brows furrowed . “You don't want them to find Mi Fu and let Si Luo engrave a split symbol onto her? But if Si Luo does so, Mi Fu will not die, this just means that she'll have to leave later . If Si Luo doesn't do it, then he might die . You're willing to take such a risk?”

Huan Qing looked pained . “No, it's not like that . Mi Fu's older brother made me swear to protect Mi Fu before he died, because she cannot be engraved with a split symbol . Once that happens, she'll die . He didn't tell me why, but by his expression and tone when he said it, I know it definitely wasn't a lie . ”

“Mi Fu will die if she gets engraved with a split symbol? So what you're doing now is simply to protect her and prevent that from happening, until she decides to leave the Split Zone of her own accord?”

I could not believe this .

Mi Fu, why are you so stubborn? This man protected you all this time because of a single promise, giving up on going back to the real world to see his loved ones just for you . But you just refuse to leave the Split Zone because of love?

Love is selfish . But if so many people end up being sacrificial lambs for such a love, can you still choose love?

“Don’t blame Mi Fu for this, she doesn’t have any idea . She doesn’t even know there was a soul splitter who treated her like a younger sister . All she knows is that she loves Ku Fei, and we can’t do anything about it if she doesn’t want to leave the Split Zone . These things aren’t important now . What’s important is that Rong Jin and Gaoqin Jiuye now know the secret and they are trying all ways and means to get to Mi Fu . ”

“Is this under Si Luo’s orders?”

“No, Si Luo doesn’t want to sacrifice Mi Fu . He’d rather die . But Gaoqin Jiuye and Rong Jin are adamant on this, and they want me to hand Mi Fu over . ”

I felt a rush of sympathy for this handsome man, who now just looked like he was exhausted .

Agony flashed across Huan Qing’s eyes . “Li Shen, I care about Si Luo as much as Gaoqin Jiuye and Rong Jin . But sacrificing Mi Fu isn’t what Si Luo wants . I know he will not use someone else’s life to save his own, and also, there’s no way I would go back on my promise to Mi Fu’s older brother . This is why I’m going to look for a new body of consciousness . Although the chances of finding one that’s suitable for Si Luo is low, I still have to try . Gaoqin Jiuye and Rong Jin can’t wait any longer – they’ll definitely be looking for Mi Fu, so I need someone reliable to help me take care of her . ”

So this was it . He thought I was the reliable person .

Although I should be pleased that I was being trusted, there was now a heavy burden in my heart .

“Li Shen, I don’t know why I looked for you either . I knew from the first time I saw you that you were different from the others in the Split Zone . I’m not saying this because I want your help, it’s the truth . I can’t pinpoint the exact difference, but I just thought of you, and so I came looking for

you . If Jiao S knew the reason behind Si Luo's weakening life force, I'm not sure if she'd go after Mi Fu too . Would you be able to help protect Mi Fu before I return?"

I remained silent .

I cannot agree to this so easily . This was not a question of being cold-hearted, but this to me, was an extremely difficult task .

I cannot agree to this so easily . This was not a question of being cold-hearted, but this to me, was an extremely difficult task .

I already have so many things on my plate, how do I protect somebody else? Furthermore, Gaoqin Jiuye and Rong Jin already had their eyes on her . But, can I really turn my back on this?

"I know this request is a little too much, but I have no other choice . If you can protect Mi Fu until I return, I can promise you one thing . "

Although I do not wish to take advantage of others in such situations, I definitely need to hear what he had to say .

"What's that?"

Huan Qing's eyes shone . "Although I don't know what you're thinking and what you plan to do, whether it's to save your friends or to go against the soul splitters, I know you want to unravel this mystery, and you'll need to go to the Northern District . Remember that you couldn't find the blood-red border when you were in the Southern District previously? That's because I hid that border with an illusion . Even if you found it, you'll not be able to go through it anyway . I'm no saint, but I won't go back on my word . If you agree to my request, I promise to take you to the Northern District . Without my help, you'll never be able to step foot into the Northern District . I'm not lying about that . "

This was attractive, but there were other factors to consider .

If I agreed, I will be fighting against Gaoqin Jiuye and Rong Jin .

To fight against Gaoqin Jiuye...

I felt ashamed at myself for such thoughts, but we are all human... My first thought was that I did not want to be on opposing sides with him...

I felt ashamed at myself for such thoughts, but we are all human... My first thought was that I did not want to be on opposing sides with him...

Why did it feel like I understood Mi Fu a little more now...

Even without my feelings, looking at this purely from the angle of my abilities, it might not be something I can do . How am I able to go against Gaoqin Jiuye and Rong Jin? Furthermore, right now, I can't even wield Piercer well .

As I was in the middle of my thoughts, Huan Qing grabbed my hand .

Never have I seen such a humble and sincere expression from this classy man . "Si Luo will be in agony if Mi Fu was forced to die for him . Trust me, I will spare no effort in finding a way to save Si Luo . Gaoqin Jiuye and Rong Jin don't know I've brought Mi Fu to you, and I've applied an extremely complex illusion, and they'll not be able to undo it that quickly . But it's only a matter of time before it's undone, and they'll start looking for Mi Fu once they escape the illusion . Without your help, I can't be at ease if I leave Mi Fu and Ku Fei alone . "

Huan Qing, you're not confident in being able to find a way to save Si Luo, right? Since Gaoqin Jiuye and Rong Jin are so adamant in looking for Mi Fu, this means the method of looking for another body of consciousness doesn't work . You want me to believe something that even the two of them don't think can be done?

In all honesty, it might not be a wise decision to trust you . But this doesn't affect my decision to help you . If everything you said was true, then you'd be the one in the most pain right now .

The eyes won't lie, and I can see that deep anguish in you . You're worried that Si Luo can't be saved, but you can't sacrifice Mi Fu for this either .

There're also people waiting for you back in the real world, right?

Hah, such a place like the Split Zone should never have existed . Soul splitters, even if you feel sympathetic towards others sometimes, how could you capture us and dictate our lives?

I haven't seen Mi Fu's older brother, but I'm not Huan Qing, and I don't believe that you let Huan Qing go simply because you sympathized with him . You even sacrificed your life in exchange for Huan Qing's promise and loyalty . What exactly is your goal?

Hah, such a place like the Split Zone should never have existed . Soul splitters, even if you feel sympathetic towards others sometimes, how could you capture us and dictate our lives?

I haven't seen Mi Fu's older brother, but I'm not Huan Qing, and I don't believe that you let Huan Qing go simply because you sympathized with him . You even sacrificed your life in exchange for Huan Qing's promise and loyalty . What exactly is your goal?

I, Li Shen, will definitely uncover these secrets!

I then smiled at Huan Qing . "I'll help you . I'll protect Mi Fu before you return . "

Huan Qing's eyes sparkled . "You're serious?"

I nodded . "There's something else . Although this seems like it has to be kept a secret, I'll still have to check in with Jiao S on this . You said Jiao S might go after Mi Fu for Si Luo, but I disagree . When Mi Fu disappeared, Jiao S looked as worried about her as you did . I suspect she already knew this, and it's hard to believe that there's anything she doesn't already know when it comes to Si Luo . If she wanted Mi Fu to be sacrificed, I think she might already have went ahead to confront the lot of you . "

I continued after a short pause, "I don't really know what she thinks, but I believe she's different from Gaoqin Jiuye and the rest . Even if she loves Si Luo, she isn't somebody who would selfishly take away the lives of others .

I want to know her choice, and I hope you can trust her this time, just like how you trust me . With her on my side, it'll be a great help . You know that it'll be difficult if I go against Gaoqin Jiuye and Rong Jin alone . ”

It was obvious Huan Qing was now in a dilemma . “I found it weird too . Jiao S should've known all this even before Gaoqin Jiuye did, but she didn't look for Mi Fu, which I expected her to . But I'm not able to trust her fully even if she didn't do so, since she loves Si Luo deeply . It's hard to believe that she would not sacrifice Mi Fu for Si Luo . ”

Yes, it seems love reigns over all logic .

I smiled . “You mentioned Si Luo doesn't wish to sacrifice Mi Fu either . Maybe Jiao S isn't on Gaoqin Jiuye's side because she doesn't want to do the things that Si Luo doesn't wish for? Or, because of her love for Si Luo, she wants to fulfil his wishes instead of saving his life in such a manner?”

Chapter 119

Volume 2

119 Splitting Up

“You know me really well huh...”

A voice floated past our heads!

I snapped my head up in surprise, only to see Jiao S hanging upside down from a tree branch near us, looking at me with her glassy, friendly eyes.

Huan Qing’s brows knitted slightly. “I placed an illusion around us to prevent passers-by from listening in. Jiao S, even if your MF is high, you shouldn’t have been able to break it if you didn’t know any illusion techniques. But you’ve actually managed to approach us without me noticing. How did you do it?”

Jiao S cracked her neck, and her black hair fell across her face as she moved, this looked...

“I don’t know about illusions, but that doesn’t mean others don’t know about them too.”

After Jiao S’s explanation, I knew immediately what I would be seeing.

As expected, a white figure flew past me. It moved towards Nie Zun, who was looking in our direction.

“My pet, I’ve missed you so much!”

Guan Nie’s whiny voice floated past my ear.

My lips started twitching. I felt like throwing up as I watched that figure in white launch itself into Nie Zun's arms.

Huan Qing did not seem to care about this, and looked at Guan Nie's figure. "Seems like the title of top illusionist would no longer be mine if I were in the Eastern District."

Jiao S jumped down, walking towards me. She actually started consoling Huan Qing, "Your technique isn't bad, and you are definitely worthy of being called the top illusionist. It's just that even I don't know how powerful Guan Nie is."

Huan Qing asked with raised brows, "Since you're here, you've probably heard everything. What's your aim?"

Jiao S looked at me with her pitch-black eyes. "My aim is simply to go with you to find a way to save Si Luo."

Huan Qing was dumbstruck.

A slight smile formed on my lips, and I met her eyes with a knowing gaze. Jiao S said in her hoarse voice, "Huan Qing, I know that you, Gaoqin Jiuye and Rong Jin don't like me, and you guys don't like it when I approach Si Luo. But there's something you all know, that I love Si Luo, and I'll never hurt him."

Huan Qing kept his eyes on her. "That's exactly right. It's because you're always like this that Si Luo has to hide from you, and this is why we hate you so."

Jiao S shook her head stiffly. "No, this isn't why you guys hate me. Deep in your hearts, Si Luo is a god-like figure who is just and composed, his emotions always remain stable and there's nothing that can affect that nobility of his. The only time you've seen him do something out of the ordinary, that was all because of me. You guys are jealous, and you can't let go of it because you guys don't understand it."

Huan Qing's gaze changed. "Yes. Jiao S, Si Luo will always be noble. How could you stain him and interfere with his life like that?"

Jiao S gave a cruel smile. "He needs to be alive before I can even interfere in that! You're always protecting him, ostracizing me, getting him to leave me, but isn't he still going to die? You, Gaoqin Jiuye, Rong Jin – the three of you are the ones who shouldn't be beside him, and not me, Jiao S!"

Huan Qing was stunned, and his eyes darkened.

For some reason I could not really bear to see Huan Qing like this, so I shot a look at Jiao S.

Jiao S caught my gaze, and although she probably had other things to say, she did not continue.

"You're truly willing to work with me in finding a new body of consciousness to save Si Luo?" Huan Qing asked with slight hesitation.

Jiao S looked at Mi Fu, and looked at me, before saying, "Si Luo will never sacrifice Mi Fu. Gaoqin Jiuye and Rong Jin are just plain stupid. Even if they took Mi Fu, they're too naïve to think that they can force Si Luo in engraving a split symbol onto Mi Fu. Si Luo will never do anything he doesn't want to, when has that ever changed. I'll go with you to find a new body of consciousness, but I don't know what Si Luo is thinking. I wasn't able to see him, but I suspect he might not even accept any new bodies of consciousness."

Huan Qing sighed. "I don't know what he's thinking these days. Sometimes, I don't even know where he is."

"How long can your illusion against Gaoqin Jiuye and Rong Jin last?" Jiao S suddenly asked.

Huan Qing pondered for a moment. "With that complex illusion, they should be trapped for about twenty days. But I don't know about Gaoqin Jiuye's abilities, so a conservative guess would be fifteen days. Fifteen days will include the time they'll need to break the illusion and to find out that

I've brought Mi Fu to the Western District. To be on the safer side, we should assume they'll be able to reach the Western District in fifteen days."

Jiao S's eyes shone. "How much more time does Si Luo have?"

Huan Qing said glumly, "Three months, at most."

Jiao S bit her lip. "Although I'm not that familiar with Gaoqin Jiuye, I know very well that in the Split Zone, Si Luo is the only one who can stop him. I don't like him, and both of us don't know the depth of his abilities nor the value of his MF. He's definitely not an easy opponent."

Huan Qing nodded slowly. "This is what I'm worried about. To be frank, he definitely has skills. It's not just anyone who can wield and control 'Shen Qi', and there's not many of those in the Split Zone. Furthermore, in all the years that Gaoqin Jiuye has been here, even I haven't seen him activate his split symbol."

What? Gaoqin Jiuye hasn't activated his split symbol for those abilities??

Just by looking at his ability to manipulate air currents, he's probably more powerful than Jiao S, right? Was this the reason behind Jiao S's initial friendliness and eventual antagonism towards him?

I've always known that he was mysterious and powerful, but I didn't expect for Jiao S and Huan Qing to have such an assessment of him.

How about Rong Jin... From what I know, there's only one such person who can capture souls like that... Huan Qing and Jiao S have never seen him in the flesh either...

Did I confidently agree to help Huan Qing earlier... I agreed to go against these two monsters just to protect that stubborn little girl...

How I wish for amnesia to hit me now!

As if sensing that my thoughts were flying all over the place, Jiao S smiled at me.

“It’s okay, I’ll come up with a perfect plan for this.”

This was not to put Huan Qing at ease, it was to put me at ease.

“So,” Jiao S continued, “if there was anyone who could stop Gaoqin Jiuye, that would be Si Luo. Huan Qing, you really don’t know where Si Luo is now?”

Huan Qing met Jiao S’s eyes squarely. “I really don’t know.”

Jiao S frowned slightly. “It seems like he’s avoiding us on purpose. I might be right, that he doesn’t wish to sacrifice Mi Fu, and he probably doesn’t even want to accept new bodies of consciousness. He’s prepared to die.”

Jiao S bit her lips hard, and there was a hopelessness in those empty eyes of hers. “Si Luo, why didn’t you tell me and bring me with you to meet death? Tough luck, don’t even think about dying without my permission!”

I felt beads of cold sweat forming above my brows.

I almost forgot her swagger after not seeing this little devil for a while. I liked her more and more by the second, even though she always had this weird, stiff look.

But talking about weird, which one of us isn’t weird here?

“Then that’s decided,” Jiao S said resolutely. “Ah Shen, you go look for Si Luo, hopefully before Gaoqin Jiuye and Rong Jin escape. Think of a way to get him to convince Gaoqin Jiuye and Rong Jin to give up on looking for Mi Fu. Huan Qing and I will look for a way to save Si Luo.”

I hastily asked, “Where would the both of you find it? You guys aren’t soul splitters either, so how’d you help him capture new bodies of consciousness?”

Huan Qing answered, “I can’t capture them, but I know someone in the Northern District who can. I’m going to look for my soul splitter.”

“Can’t you take me with you to the Northern District?” I asked.

Huan Qing's eyes shone. "Li Shen, since I've promised you, I'll definitely take you there. The Northern District is not a place that ordinary people can go to. If I didn't have an agreement with my soul splitter, I'd be no exception. If I succeed in bringing Jiao S to the Northern District this time, it'll also be proof of my ability to do so, right?"

Jiao S continued, "That's right, Li Shen. Go look for Si Luo. Though I haven't been able to find him, you might be able to. I'll share with you what I know, and you can go with Nie Zun to look for him. For the time being, I'll send my people to protect the Western District as well. Huan Qing, you can leave Mi Fu here in the Western District, so that Li Shen and my people can protect her."

Huan Qing nodded after a few seconds of hesitation.

I thought for a moment, and said to Huan Qing, "Since I've already agreed to help you, please trust me, and trust Jiao S too. Though time is tight, this is no simple task. I'd suggest all of you rest up in the Western District for tonight, and also discuss the details of your plan before setting off tomorrow."

Jiao S nodded in agreement. "Huan Qing, you and Mi Fu traveled all the way here without resting. Mi Fu doesn't have a split symbol, and even if you had helped, she'd be tired as well. You guys rest for today, and if you trust us, just leave the rest to Li Shen and I."

Huan Qing looked at Jiao S, then at me, and back at Jiao S again. Finally, he said, "Since I've chosen to work with the both of you, I trust you. I owe you one for this, and I'll definitely return the favor in time."

He glanced at the group who were still waiting. "I'll take Mi Fu and rest up. The both of you can work out a plan, and we'll split up tomorrow."

I nodded. "Go ahead. I'll get someone to prepare your accommodation and to stand guard."

Chapter 120

120 Keeping Company, that's Love?

After Huan Qing, Mi Fu and Ku Fei left, Jiao S and I did not immediately go over to Nie Zun and Guan Nie, who were now in a conversation .

“Why bring him here?” I tilted my chin in the direction where Guan Nie stood .

“He wanted to come . I can’t force him to do anything that he doesn’t wish to . ” Jiao S glanced .

I sighed . “Though I don’t know how he’s connected to Gaoqin Jiuye, I guess he’s probably wishing for Si Luo not to survive . ”

Jiao S nodded . “There’s a selfish side to any kind of relationship . Guan Nie tried all ways and means to pry Gaoqin Jiuye away from Si Luo, and I know that even though he doesn’t look kindly upon those who wish for Si Luo’s death, he probably wishes that they don’t succeed in finding a way to save Si Luo either, since this matter creates some sort of rift between Si Luo and Gaoqin Jiuye . I totally empathize with him on this . ”

“You’re really understanding . ” I smiled at her teasingly .

There was a sparkle in Jiao S’s eyes . “That’s rare . Didn’t you always think I was cruel, ruthless and unfeeling?”

I pretended to be shocked . “You actually knew that?”

Jiao S laughed .

Seeing her laughter, I took a deep breath and put a hand on her shoulder .

She glanced at me .

I looked at her . “You, are really alright with all this? I know it’s hard for you, since you know Mi Fu’s life can save Si Luo . Isn’t it difficult for you not to go to Gaoqin Jiuye’s side for this?”

Jiao S smiled gently . “Ah Shen, even if I find it difficult, this is something I have to do . Si Luo doesn’t wish to sacrifice Mi Fu, and the best thing I can do right now is to assist him in finishing what he wishes to complete, without harming innocent lives in the process . ”

I felt a little melancholy . She really loves him .

Jiao S gazed into the distance . “I didn’t know Si Luo was a soul splitter initially, and even though I did suspect it, before I could confirm this, I simply wanted to uncover the truth of the Split Zone and take him away with me . After I learnt he was a soul splitter, others thought I should give up . So, I decided to change my goal . Since he’s a soul splitter, I’m going to find out the reason behind the existence of soul splitters, and I’ll think of a way to bring him, a soul splitter, back to my world . ”

Jiao S looked at me again . “Our world might not be that great, but it’s still worth living in . I want to bring him back . ”

There was a dim fire in her eyes, and I felt uncharacteristically sympathetic for her .

“You will definitely succeed in this . We all will,” I said resolutely . “We’ll unravel all the mysteries and leave this place together . ”

For some reason, I glanced at Nie Zun as I said this .

I thought about what he said, Do you really wish to go back?

“I left to investigate Si Luo’s matters earlier, and my subordinates informed me that Huan Qing passed through the heavily-guarded Eastern District to reach your place, so I guessed that he was probably bringing Mi Fu to you . I then contacted Guan Nie and arrived here with him . I’ll be heading for

the Northern District with Huan Qing tomorrow, and while we're looking for a way to save Si Luo, I can snoop around for news there . You just try to locate Si Luo as soon as possible . ”

“Wouldn't Si Luo definitely know that Gaoqin Jiuye and Rong Jin are trying to capture Mi Fu? Since he's not interfering, would it be of any help if I were to look for him on this?” I frowned .

“It's not that he doesn't want to interfere, it's that he can't . Si Luo knows Gaoqin Jiuye well, and he won't interfere in whatever that Gaoqin Jiuye wants to do for him . Si Luo is like this, he respects how others choose to live their lives . In fact, I've wanted you to meet Si Luo, not only for you to persuade him in convincing Gaoqin Jiuye, but also to see what he has to say about how you chose to live your life . ”

I looked at Jiao S, confused . “I don't get it . ”

I looked at Jiao S, confused . “I don't get it . ”

Jiao S met my eyes . “Ah Shen, I don't know if you know this, but you're different from the rest . I can't place it, but you're just different . You'll understand why I want you to meet him once you see Si Luo . I'm also curious to see what he'll do upon seeing you, whether he'll change or remain as he was . ”

I did not fully understand Jiao S, but I just nodded .

“To be honest, I don't know where Si Luo is either . However, my instinct tells me that since Li Qing chose you to be the next District Commander, even though he's dying, Si Luo would definitely meet you on account of his friendship with Li Qing . You don't actually have to look for him . He'll probably come looking for you once we leave . ”

I looked at Jiao S's steadfast gaze . “You're sure about that?”

Jiao S replied, “I'm not sure . I still don't fully understand him even after so many years, but we can always try . ”

“I really envy you . Those guts and that passion of yours, you’re not afraid of anything,” I said, smiling at Jiao S .

Jiao S answered in surprise, “I actually envy you . ”

I raised my brows, asking, “Oh? Why?”

Jiao S’s huge eyes moved to where Nie Zun was standing, saying, “Don’t you think he likes you a lot?”

My heart skipped a beat . Why did I react this way?

I was a little befuddled . “He, he, he likes me?”

Jiao S gaze carried a hint of envy . “I’m always chasing after Si Luo, but Nie Zun is always beside you . No matter what ties the both of you together, such a fate is rare . Ah Shen, how do you feel about him?”

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I was speechless at this .

Jiao S continued without waiting for my response, “How do you feel about Gaoqin Jiuye? Though I don’t know why, but I can tell you look at Gaoqin Jiuye differently . ”

I was pretty stunned . Jiao S, you’ve been taking notice of me all this time?

I was moved by this . At least there’s someone here who cares about me .

I glanced at Nie Zun, who just so happened to look over at us . I addressed Jiao S while looking at Nie Zun, “I ended up here because I killed someone, and that person was someone I loved . He looked exactly identical to Gaoqin Jiuye . ”

I looked back at Jiao S, and as expected, she was shocked when she heard this .

Her look of surprise faded quickly . “So it’s like this . Though we still don’t know what kind of place this is, do you remember what I told you previously? I suspected that soul splitters were just another form of ourselves . Although this conclusion can almost be invalidated, there has got to be some sort of correlation between these two worlds . Maybe what you hope for isn’t to leave this place, but to find out what this correlation is . If that’s your goal, then it’s understandable that you keep thinking about Gaoqin Jiuye . ”

“But Ah Shen, you have to be clear that he is Gaoqin Jiuye, not your lover . ”

I remained silent .

Jiao S continued, “Gaoqin Jiuye is quite the legendary figure in the Split Zone . He can pass through any border at any time he pleases, nothing can stop him and nobody knows his whereabouts .

“The only legendary fearsome soul splitter that had often appeared in the Split Zone’s history, Satan Cang Ming, was someone nobody dared to oppose . From what I heard, Gaoqin Jiuye saved the lives of this couple from Cang Ming, all on his own . Nobody knows what happened on that day . I don’t know why Gaoqin Jiuye would do that, but I know that Gaoqin Jiuye is probably the only person who can stand up to Cang Ming .

“Gaoqin Jiuye is naturally suited to live in this place . Nobody would be able to oppose such a mysterious and godly figure, and he’s not your lover . But I’m willing to help you unravel all this, to find out if there really is any correlation between them . ”

Jiao S looked like she was going to continue, but I interrupted her with a smile . “I know all that . I know very well that he is not him . But just like how you persevere, to me, I’m already contented to be able to see someone like him, as if he received a chance to live after his life was taken away by me . ”

“Gaoqin Jiuye is naturally suited to live in this place . Nobody would be able to oppose such a mysterious and godly figure, and he’s not your lover .

But I'm willing to help you unravel all this, to find out if there really is any correlation between them . ”

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“Jiao S, Gaoqin Jiuye isn't my lover . I'll definitely let it go some day . ”

I kept smiling as I said this .

Jiao S gazed at me like she was looking at a poor and defenseless creature .

“As for Nie Zun,” as I spoke, I subconsciously looked over at him . “You say he likes me . I guess there's some sort of like there, since we're always together . We're no longer little girls, so there's no need to avoid such things . But what I can't tell is that if he loves me, or he merely thinks that we're both lonely people and make good company for each other . ”

“Keeping company, that's love...” Jiao S said in her rough voice .

I was stunned by her words .

I looked at Nie Zun, who looked like he was looking at me as well .

Nie Zun, are you keeping me company because of love?

“Love is like the truth, it'll definitely be revealed some day,” Jiao S said quietly .

“I've brought some people from the S Clan to help you protect the Western District . Let's draw up a perfect plan to protect Mi Fu tomorrow before we split up . ”

Jiao S then signaled for Guan Nie and Nie Zun to come over .

A smile hung on Nie Zun's lips as he walked towards me .

Chapter 121

121 The Stunning Beauty, Si Luo

I patiently explained our plan to Nie Zun .

With two gloved hands, Nie Zun pointed at his ears, smiling . “Have you forgotten that my five senses are more sensitive than ordinary people? I heard everything you said . ”

...

Why did I spend so much time explaining this to you then? Why didn't you just say so earlier?

Wait . This means that he also heard my discussion with Jiao S on whether he liked me or not??

OMG!

I looked at Jiao S in embarrassment, while Jiao S went back to her usual indifferent expression .

Guan Nie looked at me with his squinty eyes . “Ugly girl, aren't you touched that I traveled all the way here to help you . ”

Are you sure you're here to help me, you weakling???

I laughed in response .

“I've placed some people from the S Clan along the Eastern and Western district border, and before we met, I've actually discussed some things with your strategist, Jie Pa . Together with his intelligence network, we've placed

informants all over the Western District . I'll head for the Northern District with Huan Qing tomorrow morning, and I'll leave Guan Nie with you since he's good at illusions . The best way to hide somebody is to use illusion techniques, and I've asked him to stay by Mi Fu's side .

“If you could prepare some empty rooms for them please, and Jie Pa will be using his barrier technique for extra security . After that's done, you can head for the Southern District with Nie Zun . It'd be best if you guys happen to meet Si Luo on the way, and when you arrive at the Southern District, Gaoqin Jiuye and Rong Jin might already have undone the illusion and escaped . If so, please try to stall them for as long as possible . ”

Jiao S told me about the plan and I nodded . “I'll go with Nie Zun to pick some rooms that won't be easily identified . ”

Guan Nie glanced at me . “Ugly girl, are you touched that I'm here to help you?”

My face twitched . I really wanted to hit him .

After hiding Mi Fu, Ku Fei and Guan Nie, Jiao S left with Huan Qing . Jie Pa has been slogging his guts out settling matters in the Western District for me, and I sounded like a broken record as I kept reminding the Yuan siblings and Chou Yu to keep him safe .

“When do we leave for the Southern District?” As I was looking out of the window, Nie Zun walked over to my side . From the 13th floor window, people on the ground looked just like tiny ants .

“I'm wondering if I should go look for Zou An first . I don't want to be so hasty now that I'm not able to use Piercer . ”

Nie Zun smiled . “I'll protect you . ”

I turned to look at him, meeting his profound gaze .

“Are you scared of what's going to happen next?” Nie Zun kept his eyes on me .

Am I scared? Why do you ask this?

“You’ve seen it too, many of them wish to leave . Since I’ve made my promise, I’ll not be afraid,” I said softly .

Nie Zun’s gaze was unreadable . “I’m not talking about this .

“I’m talking about what if Jiao S doesn’t come back in time, and if Gaoqin Jiuye and Rong Jin catch up . Are you afraid that you might have to go against Gaoqin Jiuye, and possibly fight him?”

He asked this with a serious tone .

I frowned . “Why do you care so much about me and Gaoqin Jiuye?”

“You’re the one who cares too much . ”

“I don’t really care about that . I know very well that he isn’t Gao Qi . ”

I thought Nie Zun would say something in response, but he did not . He went back to his usual, impassive self . I felt irritated with him, and shot him a fierce look .

I thought Nie Zun would say something in response, but he did not . He went back to his usual, impassive self . I felt irritated with him, and shot him a fierce look .

“Let’s go to the Marketplace to find another weapon . I’ll need something to use in close-range combat now that I can’t use Piercer . ”

With a smile, Nie Zun followed me out .

I was instantly drawn to Jie Pa’s bar when we arrived at the Marketplace . Jie Pa is way too busy to be here, and I had to make do with someone else mixing my cocktail . I really miss this . It’s been so long since I had a drink here .

I dragged Nie Zun with me into the bar, and we waited for our drinks as we sat in a corner .

“Are you trying to take advantage of me by dragging me into this remote corner, or are you trying to hide so that others won’t find out that their mighty District Commander is actually slacking off and drinking here?” Nie Zun teased mischievously .

Nothing good comes out of your mouth!

Not paying him any heed, I rested on the armchair and pointed at him, getting him to sit opposite me .

There were many of these armchairs placed facing each other in Jie Pa’s bar . We were right in a corner, and there was another seat behind me . We were in the most remote corner of the bar, and light was sparse . Seldom would there be people here, though there are times when couples in the Split Zone might get a little intimate .

I saw the bartender holding a glass of blood-red liquid .

“Oh, I don’t remember having seen this in Jie Pa’s bar?” I asked Nie Zun while pointing at the bartender who was walking towards us .

Nie Zun turned to look . “Neither have I . I think there’s such a drink, but I haven’t had it . ”

Holding the wineglass, the bartender passed by me to reach the seat behind . Following the bartender’s movement, I turned back to look . The back of the seat was so high that I could not see who sat there .

“There’s actually somebody there? Who’d be drinking alone at the corner on a bright day like this,” I muttered to myself .

Nie Zun laughed . “What’s there to be curious about . There’re many kinds of people in the Split Zone . ”

I looked back at Nie Zun, wanting to argue with him . But before I could do so, he shook his head and shot me a look .

I looked back at Nie Zun, wanting to argue with him . But before I could do so, he shook his head and shot me a look .

I understood immediately . Nie Zun is very sensitive to MF, and that look probably meant that the individual in the corner was no ordinary passerby .

“No need to hide . I’ve come here to meet the both of you . How about we have a drink together?”

Nie Zun and I exchanged looks as we heard a voice coming from that corner . It sounded like it belonged to a man . It was a very crisp and clear voice .

Could it be Si Luo?

I signaled to Nie Zun and with drink in hand, we went over to the seat behind . I flipped the switch on the wall to turn the decorative light on as I passed the armchair, trying to get a clearer look at who it was .

I took a good look at the man as I stood opposite him .

A man in a white silk robe was leaning across the armchair lazily, holding a wineglass filled with blood-red liquid . His exquisite features were perfectly sculpted, and his long and shiny silver hair fell across his shoulders . There was a blood-red crescent moon between his brows, and he looked absolutely stunning .

His eyes were a silvery-white, a color that was almost two shades lighter than that of his hair . It was just like the heavy white fog atop a deep, quiet lake . It looked as if he was glowing through melting snow as he looked at me .

What was more amazing was that, even under the artificial lighting, he looked like he was shrouded in clouds with his white robes . It was like he was bathing in soft moonlight as he floated amidst the clouds .

I was sure the man was Si Luo . Nobody would be able to top such an aura and such beauty .

“Si Luo,” I said carefully .

Ripples of white fog formed in his eyes, and his pale lips turned upward in a beautiful angle, forming a stunning smile . “That’s me . ”

I was dazed as I heard that crisp voice .

As I was still awestruck, Si Luo coughed twice, covering his face with the robe on his arm .

Although he looked like he was ill as he coughed, he still remained stunningly beautiful, reminding me of the Chinese idiom *dong shi xiao pin* . (T/n: The idiom describes how someone tried to be as beautiful as Xi Shi, one of the renowned four beauties in ancient China, by imitating her actions . One day, Xi Shi went around with knitted brows as she did not feel well . However, she still looked beautiful even when ill . In wanting to be as beautiful as her, someone imitated her sickly expression, but of course it was a failure .)

“You’re really the most beautiful person in the Split Zone . ” Nie Zun actually praised him when he rarely even spoke to strangers .

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“You’re really the most beautiful person in the Split Zone . ” Nie Zun actually praised him when he rarely even spoke to strangers .

Si Luo just smiled, and he did not say things like ‘you flatter me’ or ‘thanks’ .

“Please sit . ” It sounded like an invitation, but it also had an air of authority that made it difficult to go against, and his voice had such a quality that you would not want to go against .

Nie Zun and I sat opposite him . He looked at the both of us .

“Connected hearts and minds are fated to last . ”

I was not quite able to understand what he meant, but Nie Zun responded .
“Oh?”

Si Luo’s lips looked pale as he spoke, “Li Qing had foresight . ”

I understood it now . It was to praise me . I smiled at him . “I hope you don’t mind that I haven’t visited the Southern District . ”

Si Luo placed his wineglass onto the table and laid back into his seat, the blood-red crescent moon on his forehead flickering under the decorative light . “That’s great . I don’t like outsiders . ”

His voice was clear and calm, and he had the autocratic aura of a solitary nobleman .

I kept marveling at him . For a man to be described as beautiful, he probably had to have some feminine qualities . Like Guan Nie, who was a pretty man, not womanly, but he had a sort of feminine quality to him .

Si Luo, on the other hand, was different . It was difficult to imagine a man so beautiful who seemed to not have any feminine qualities . Exceptional beauty and that kingly, domineering aura were both present in this man . It was dazzling .

I suddenly understood why that dashing man, Huan Qing and the sinister, conceited Gaoqin Jiuye were loyal to him . His aura was overwhelming, as if he was some kind of god .

There were no words to describe him . Si Luo simply cannot be described .

Chapter 122

122 Your Deepest Fear

“I’ve waited a long time for the both of you . ” Si Luo gestured to the armchair he was on .

I raised my brows . “Oh? How did you know we’d definitely come here? I just decided to come in here for a quick drink . ”

Si Luo eyes creased in a smile . “A coincidence is also fate . ”

He coughed again .

Cough cough cough

Though those white-robed sleeves of his concealed part of his face as he lifted a hand while coughing, it could not hide his pallor .

I started to pity this man in front of me . He was so beautiful, and this was not a look created through MF either . There was probably nobody else like him in the Split Zone . Why make him go through such pain?

Although I did not like soul splitters, I felt that Si Luo did not deserve to die, much less go through this experience of his life being slowly drained out .

“Is this a symptom of death that’s nearing?” Nie Zun smiled, sipping the drink in his wineglass .

Cold sweat formed on my forehead . Do you have to be so direct?

In my surprise, Si Luo smiled in response, and answered casually, “Yes . ”

“A girl is currently being hunted in order to save you . Though I don’t like that girl very much, I still want to hear what you think about this . ” Nie Zun placed his wineglass onto the coffee table .

I was secretly delighted that he was making so much conversation with a stranger, because I was at a loss for words right now .

Si Luo’s eyes sparkled like diamonds . “This problem would resolve itself if I die earlier . ”

He did not sound sarcastic, and he said this with an extremely serious tone . He is saying that he should die, but he did not sound grieved .

I suddenly felt that he and Jiao S would be a great match .

There might be nothing in this world worthy of being his match, except for that unique aura that Jiao S had . It felt identical to Si Luo .

I could not place it, but no matter what it was, it was something that felt unique and dynamic .

I gave him a brilliant smile . “Si Luo, please stop Gaoqin Jiuye and Rong Jin, though I know they have your interests at heart . But both your life and Mi Fu’s are equally precious, no?”

Si Luo lifted his wineglass and took a sip of the blood-red liquid with his snow-white lips .

“You’re in love with Gaoqin Jiuye?” His voice remained cool and crisp, like the clear waters of a spring .

I almost lost my grip on the wineglass . Why did he say such a thing?

Without knowing it, I turned to look at Nie Zun, and I was met with those starry eyes of his .

Yes, wasn’t this pair of eyes the most beautiful ones in the Split Zone?

Si Luo stepped over the coffee table between us, and put his face right in front of mine . As he moved, his long, silvery-white hair fell across the coffee table, it was a beautiful sight .

He stared at me with those bright eyes . “Why then do your eyes look like they’re crying when his name is mentioned?”

I was stunned .

All of a sudden, a black hand appeared in front of me .

Nie Zun looked at Si Luo calmly . “There was another Gaoqin Jiuye she missed when she was alive . This is just her being stubborn, it’s not love . ”

Si Luo laughed . It was dazzling .

He looked at Nie Zun with curiosity . “You think you’re the one she loves?”

For some reason, I really wanted to know the answer to this question . I stared at Nie Zun, waiting for a response .

Nie Zun’s eyes darkened, and his eyes filled with solitude, making my heart ache for him .

I was suddenly afraid of hearing what he had to say, so I stood up abruptly and said to Si Luo, “No matter what, please stop Gaoqin Jiuye, and trust that Jiao S and Huan Qing will definitely be able to find another way to save your life . ”

There seemed to be a slight change in Si Luo’s crystalline eyes when I mentioned Jiao S . He was silent for a moment, before he finally looked up .

There seemed to be a slight change in Si Luo’s crystalline eyes when I mentioned Jiao S . He was silent for a moment, before he finally looked up .

“What I want is not for her to find a way to save my life . I want her to leave me, I want her to stop doing things for me, and to stop thinking about anything that has to do with me . ”

I smirked . “This isn’t the best method even if you can’t accept her feelings . What good would avoidance do you? Since you could see my eyes crying, why can’t you see that your eyes were wavering when you heard Jiao S being mentioned?”

Out of nowhere, I had the courage to speak to this extraordinary person in such a way .

Si Luo’s gaze was bedazzling as he looked straight into my eyes .

“If you’re that confident of being able to manage the situation, show me your tenacity . ” Si Luo’s enchanting voice sounded in my ear, and I felt light-headed as I looked into his eyes .

Si Luo leaned back into his armchair, taking another sip of that blood-red liquid .

A sudden cough shook him, and that blood-red liquid dripped from the corner of his lips, down his pale neck, blooming into red flowers as it flowed onto his white robes . He did not seem to mind any of this .

“Come with me . Show me just how determined you are, and I’ll stop Gaoqin Jiuye . ” He smiled casually .

“Where are we going?”

Without answering me, Si Luo looked towards Nie Zun . “May I borrow her for a few days?”

Nie Zun’s gaze was inscrutable . “Will you return her?”

Si Luo smiled . “Definitely . ”

Nie Zun looked at me . “Go ahead . ”

I was about to lose myself in his brilliant gaze .

But right now, I couldn’t be bothered about how pretty his eyes were or how beautiful Si Luo was! What did these people take me for?! Hey there,

don't treat me as if I don't exist!

They were not about to give me any explanation even upon seeing how discontented I was . Si Luo simply finished his drink and stood up .

His white robes flared out with his movements, and I felt a little faint as that silver hair of his brushed past my eyes .

How can there exist such an enchanting individual?!

How can there exist such an enchanting individual?!

“Let's go, Li Shen . Show me your determination . ”

I looked at Si Luo, and a white fog surged in his eyes .

“Go, I'll wait for you here . ” Nie Zun was already standing, and he was gently pushing me towards Si Luo .

I looked at him in disbelief, finding him a little odd . He held my gaze, and something flashed through his eyes .

He planted a kiss above my left eye .

“Go ahead, Shen'er . There're some things you have to make clear . I want to know what's in your heart too . ”

Nie Zun's magnetic voice came from above my forehead . My left eye felt warm, as if it was crying for Nie Zun's gentleness .

I suddenly felt like crying, and my left eye started to tear .

Only heaven knows how lonely I was .

A hand on my shoulder, he said, “Since you've chosen this path, don't look back . You want to save all these lives in the Split Zone and free them, but I just want you to stay alive .

“Li Shen, even if you hate me for this, I still have to say it . The person who killed your lover is not your second personality . She is you, and you are her . Even if you turned into a devil, I will still protect you . ”

Tears rolled down my cheeks . I was choking on my words as I looked up at him . “Why’re you saying all this...”

His eyes shone . “Because I’d be scared too if it was me . ”

As he let go of the hand on my shoulder, Si Luo’s silver hair appeared between us .

Blood dripped from the blood-red crescent moon in between his brows, and I was once again taken in by those stunning eyes of his .

“Cage, open the seal—”

I heard Si Luo’s crisp voice .

I was forced to close my eyes as I suddenly felt unsteady . Pain shot through my heart, and it was as if my chest was impaled by a hand .

I heard Si Luo’s crisp voice .

I was forced to close my eyes as I suddenly felt unsteady . Pain shot through my heart, and it was as if my chest was impaled by a hand .

“Open your eyes, let me see what’s in your heart . ”

I heard Si Luo’s enchanting voice in my head, as if he had now become a part of me . At this, I was forced to open my eyes .

I was blinded by a bright light, and I tried to shield my eyes from it .

As I adapted to the light, Si Luo’s voice continued . “Open your eyes . ”

I finally opened my eyes fully, and what I saw made me shiver .

Someone was lying on the ground in front of me . His tightly-shut eyes and lips seemed to be describing the agony he was going through . He was in a pool of blood, and there was a knife in his chest .

I looked down, and I saw a blood red color on both my hands .

My hands turned icy, and I felt my knees weaken .

Snap!

I fell onto my knees . I tried to reach out to that person in front me, but I did not dare look at my bloody hands .

There was nobody around except for layers of white fog surrounding the two of us . I looked around me in a panic . There was nothing .

The bottom of my feet felt wet, and I realized the blood had already reached me .

“Ah—!”

I screamed, but it felt as if I had no more voice .

I tasted blood in my throat, and the tip of my tongue started to hurt, but I did not pay attention to any of that . I simply stared at the person lying in front of me .

He was Gao Qi .

Chapter 123

123 This Is All You Can See

“Gao... Gao Qi...” My trembling hand was outstretched, trying to reach out to him.

A ghostly hand landed on my shoulder, and I felt a chilly air near my right ear. I tilted my head and saw someone looking over my shoulder.

I met a pair of eyes that seemed to shine with pale moonlight. Si Luo smiled at me. “This is what you’re afraid of?”

As if somebody had a tight grip on my throat, I could not speak. Tears welled up in my eyes, and I tried my best to summon my voice. “Si, Si Luo, save, save... save him...”

A strand of Si Luo’s silver hair landed on my neck. “No one can save him if he’s already dead in your heart...”

The corners of my eyes were now wet with hot tears.

Si Luo came closer to speak in my ear. “Relax, don’t push me away. Let me take a look at what else you have hidden in your heart...”

Haven’t you already seen it...

I felt helpless.

“No... That’s not enough...”

“Ah—!” As I tried to move closer to Gao Qi’s prone figure, I felt another stabbing pain in my heart. It felt as if the invisible hand which impaled me

was putting more pressure on my heart. Blood started to drip from the corner of my lips. I could no longer move my heavy knees. They seemed to be weighed down with a thousand pounds.

“Don’t push me away...”

Strands of silvery-white hair started to wrap itself around my neck, and I could not escape Si Luo as his face was right beside me on my shoulder. I cried helplessly, staring at Gao Qi in front.

Gao Qi’s lips started moving.

I held my breath, and Si Luo’s hair stopped wrapping itself around my neck.

Gao Qi, who originally looked like he was in pain, opened his eyes slowly, and a smile appeared on his lips.

The stabbing pain in my heart stopped, but I could not breathe properly as I looked at Gao Qi while the blood from my hands dripped onto the floor.

Gao Qi sat up, looking at me. There was malice in his gentle eyes.

I widened my eyes slowly, keeping my eyes on him, not shifting my gaze.

Gao Qi attempted to wipe the blood from his face, but instead of being wiped off, the blood spread across his pale face, leaving dark red streaks behind.

The knife was still in his chest, and blood was still spilling from his wound.

His blood-stained lips then turned upwards.

My heart felt as if it had instantly turned into ice.

Such eyes, this gaze, it was wild and full of evil mischief. That smile on the corner of his lips was like a malicious chill.

My fingers twitched involuntarily as I did not know what to do.

This... isn't Gao Qi...

Isn't this... Gaoqin Jiuye?!

They were too similar, but too different at the same time!

My throat was suddenly free, and I spoke, “Gao... Gaoqin Jiuye...”

Gaoqin Jiuye was silent, but that frigid smile of his remained. His face looked almost like a graffiti wall painted with wild streaks of blood. After he finished wiping his face, he stood up slowly.

Pitter-patter.

Stepping into blood, he walked towards me. His evil grin stretched from ear to ear, and as he walked, he plucked that knife out of his chest!

Splat!

Fresh blood started pouring out from his chest.

I shut my eyes involuntarily as the blood splattered onto my face.

When I opened my eyes, he was on one knee, about a meter away from me.

He lifted the knife high above him.

I stared with wide eyes, as if I knew what was about to happen, but I remained motionless.

I started tearing again as the knife went straight for my heart. These tears seemed to be stained with blood, fogging up my vision with a sea of red.

It did not feel as painful as I expected it to be.

There was no pain because Nie Zun appeared out of nowhere, and his dark figure was kneeling in front of me now.

My face was almost flushed against Nie Zun's back, and I was pushed back as he leaned back slightly.

All I could see was black. I then heard a sound as I lifted my head!

Nie Zun seemed to flinch.

I felt uneasy, and I tried my best to crawl over to Nie Zun's side.

Nie Zun and Gaoqin Jiuye were both on one knee, facing each other. The knife which Gaoqin Jiuye attempted to stab me with was now embedded in Nie Zun's chest.

Both of them turned to look at me. Gaoqin Jiuye's evil grin was replaced with a face full of sorrow. Nie Zun smiled at me as if he was relieved, his eyes gentle and warm. Blood was pouring from his chest.

"No, no no no..." On all fours, I crawled over, trying to reach him.

The silver hairs around my neck caught it in a tight noose! Si Luo stopped me, appearing in front of my face. I was lost again in those unfathomable eyes of his.

"This isn't enough..." He muttered, as the blood-red crescent on his forehead shone with a dazzling light. He slowly reached out a hand towards me in those white robes.

I wanted to avoid him, but my body just did not listen. I could only look on as his pale hand slowly reached into my heart. My heart was like soft tofu, he could do anything to it.

Pain shot through my heart again, and he looked gentle and sympathetic. His fingers have finally found my beating heart.

Badum, Badum!

Badum, Badum!

"I might just take your life if you don't come out..."

He smiled gently at me.

The red in my eyes started spreading, fogging up my entire vision. Everything was coated in red, and Si Luo suddenly looked surprised.

I started to lose my grip on my senses. It was an unusual feeling. I was conscious, yet not fully aware. It was as if another soul was in me, trying to take control of my body, and I was being relegated to a quiet corner while she did that.

Everything looked blood-red.

The white fog was gone, and everything in this world was stained red. Involuntarily, I lifted a hand that was still stained with blood.

I grabbed Si Luo's neck with it.

What is happening...

I saw a mix of emotions in Si Luo's eyes. There was surprise, suspicion, and a strange look of expectation.

My lips moved on their own, and a lazy, empty voice came out.

“Are you... looking for me?”

Si Luo's lips turned up into a smile.

“So it's like this... It's really like this...” He looked me up and down.

As if possessed, I lifted my other hand and started to strangle Si Luo with both hands. His silvery hair was still tight around my neck, and my bloody hands gripped his neck with force.

We were like this for a while, our eyes on each other.

The blood-red in my eyes then started floating into the air, becoming blood-red droplets which were moving towards him.

He smiled. “You’re too mischievous. It’s no wonder she’s having a hard time.”

I did not understand what he was talking about, and this feeling of not being in control of my body was horrible. I wanted to let go of his neck.

“But, you met me...” Si Luo flashed me a smile, lifting his hand to draw a circle on my forehead.

A strong, white light appeared, and I felt a burning sensation on my forehead.

My red hair grew long, and it started flying up into the air. By now, my fingernails had already embedded themselves into Si Luo’s icy skin.

“Hehe...” I actually laughed.

“You guys are really intransigent here... Always trying to peek at things not meant for you...” I heard a voice which kind of sounded like me.

As I tried to escape the invisible restraints, I was again dazed by a pain shooting through my heart.

A bright light engulfed us as countless pillars of light appeared and surrounded us!

The ever-confident Si Luo had a sudden look of disbelief.

My hair was flying in the air, looking like blood red air currents. A sea of red covered my vision.

My hands were no longer on Si Luo’s neck, they were simply hanging on my sides. My eyes fixed themselves on Si Luo’s moonlit eyes. He abruptly let go of the hand that was in my heart!

A bright light flashed through his stunning eyes! He wanted to bring his hand back, but I grabbed his arm before he could do so!

Five blood-red streaks appeared on his arm.

I kept my eyes on his.

He then went from looking surprised to being composed. He laughed softly, with a hint of bitterness. “That’s really a personality that cannot be controlled... It is unmatched...”

I did not get a single word he was saying. In my daze, I could see blood spilling from his mouth.

“I’ve failed...” Si Luo smiled beautifully.

Chapter 124

Volume 2

124 The Death of Si Luo?

The scene changed in front of me after Si Luo spoke.

There was no longer an invisible restraint as I became fully aware. I stood up carefully.

Si Luo was gone. Gaoqin Jiuye and Nie Zun were gone too. I looked around me. What was this place?

Swish—

I turned as I heard the sound of running water behind me.

This was a beautiful place. There were pretty flowers and a clear spring!

I looked up to see the bright blue sky. Though there was no sun, the sky was an extraordinary clear blue. There were trees and grass, and a small river was flowing some distance away. My feet were in a tiny stream which branched out from that river.

Such a place existed in the Split Zone? Was I dreaming?

Awestruck, I walked towards the river.

Beside the river, a man was seated on a huge boulder.

The man was dressed in white, and he looked like he was faintly glowing under the bright blue sky. His head was lifted towards the sky, and I saw a

pair of silvery-white eyes on a smooth, flawless face. He was gazing at the sky, looking content. His silver hair spread out onto the boulder like countless silver threads.

This man was Si Luo, but he seemed younger than Si Luo by a few years.

“Si Luo?” I asked.

He did not seem to be able to hear me, and he did not answer.

“You look so good. Are you from around here?” I heard a timid voice coming from behind Si Luo, and I followed Si Luo’s gaze as he looked back.

A young boy, who looked to be about seventeen or eighteen, was standing there.

This teenager...

He was also dressed in white, and his timid eyes carried a hint of doubt.

Si Luo smiled mysteriously. “Yes. Are you?”

The teenager looked down. “Yes.”

“Why such a look?” With a wave of his hand, Si Luo seemed to have summoned the teenager. In an instant, he was sitting beside Si Luo on that boulder.

The teenager looked shocked at first, but he started to calm down as he looked into Si Luo’s beautiful eyes.

I found the teenager rather familiar, but I just could not place him.

“I’m Si Luo.” Si Luo’s voice was melodic.

The teenager looked a little dazed and confused, as if intensely attracted by Si Luo’s aura.

“My... My name is... Gaoqin Jiuye,” the teenager replied timidly.

I was stunned. *Gao... Gaoqin Jiuye???*

“Oh...? That’s a really nice name...” Si Luo’s clear voice spread through the forest.

Pain flashed past the teenager’s eyes. “Nice name... Huh... But, why do people hide from me when they hear my name...”

As if seized by a wave of emotion, a malicious glint appeared in his eyes. Following which, great rolling waves started appearing in the gentle river below them!

Crash!

Swish! Crash!

The water rose and fell!

Si Luo’s face was splashed with water, but his expression remained calm.

The river started roaring, as if it was an embodiment of the teenager’s emotions! I found myself in the middle of the river, but the water passed right through my body!

Si Luo lifted a hand. As if it was a magician’s wand, a streak of white light appeared with a wave of his hand, calming the roaring currents.

He smiled gently. “If they don’t like you, how about you stay with me from now on?”

The teenager looked up in surprise, startled by this.

“You, you... You’re not afraid of me?” He asked.

Si Luo laughed. “Why should I be afraid of you...?”

The teenager stared, and tears started to roll down his cheeks. He murmured, "But... why are they... all afraid of me..."

Si Luo smiled as he gently touched the teenager's head. "That's because you're extraordinary... They're jealous."

The teenager's eyes shone brightly, and darkened again. "No, I know. It's because I'm different from them. I'm a monster..."

I'm a monster...

I'm a monster...

I felt a twinge of pain in my heart!

Si Luo raised a small wave with a quick movement of his hand. "What a coincidence, I'm a monster too... From now on, you can stay with me..."

The scene before me crumbled just as I wanted to say something! As if electrocuted, I opened my eyes in a startle!

I was still in the bar in the Western District, Nie Zun was beside me, and Si Luo was opposite, looking at me with incredulous eyes. He was bleeding from the corner of his lips!

"This..." I was at a loss for words.

Si Luo gave a wry smile. "I guess there's no need to borrow her for a few days."

Nie Zun simply smiled in response.

"Just what happened here?" I asked in a daze.

Si Luo panted lightly, before settling weakly back into the armchair. He looked extremely sickly. "I wanted to look at what was in your heart, but I didn't expect that I wasn't able to take control of your other personality. You looked into my heart instead."

My heart?? The other personality in my heart?

A rush of fear overcame me, and I looked at Nie Zun in confusion. “She, isn’t she, with you?”

Nie Zun gave a bitter smile. “She is you, so why would she be with me? We just resonated with each other, that’s all...”

“What, what do you mean?” I looked at him in disbelief.

No matter how desolate this place was, I thought I had escaped her in the Split Zone.

Nie Zun, no matter how much I might have hated you before, I was still grateful that you were able to take her away from me. Now you’re telling me that she’s in my heart?

I pressed down on my heart. “You guys are saying that she’s in here?”

Si Luo continued panting lightly, and it looked like it took great effort for him to speak. “Your heart is like a heavily-guarded dungeon. There’re too many things bottled up within. How would I be able to unlock it if you can’t even do it yourself...”

“Whatever you saw was a reflection of your worries, your fears, and what is at the back of your mind. These are the reasons you’ve locked yourself up,” Si Luo continued with substantial effort.

What does it mean that I saw my worries and fears? I’m afraid that Gaoqin Jiuye will kill Nie Zun? Huh, how can that be?

Or did what I see mean something else?

“You’ll remain a caged animal if you don’t let go. Li Shen, it gets harder the longer you lock yourself up. Like being in quicksand, it just gets more difficult the more you struggle...” Si Luo fixed his eyes on me.

I’ve locked myself up for too long? It’s the Split Zone which trapped me!

“You said I looked into your heart...” I tried to change the subject.

Si Luo’s eyes darkened.

Si Luo’s heart...

I guess he’s the most worried about Gaoqin Jiuye...

Cough cough cough cough cough

Si Luo started coughing violently.

“What... what’s wrong?” I could only look on in shock as he spat mouthfuls of blood, dyeing the coffee table a dark blood red. Nie Zun walked over immediately, trying to ease this sudden outbreak.

Si Luo’s eyes shone on his pale face, looking like he suddenly thought of something. “The both of you should go. Gaoqin Jiuye can sense it once I’m at my limit. I’m afraid he’s already on his way here...”

Si Luo panted, struggling as he said this.

I shook my head. “Where should we go, we aren’t fugitives either. Anyway, Huan Qing said he needs at least a few days to arrive here.”

Si Luo shook his head in disagreement. “He doesn’t know Gaoqin Jiuye. If I, If I...”

Before he could complete his sentence, he was racked with another violent spate of coughing, and he kept spitting out mouthfuls of blood!

I frowned, looking at Nie Zun. “Take him to Jie Pa, quick!”

Before Nie Zun could help him up, Si Luo shut his eyes and stopped moving.

“What’s happening?” I asked in shock.

Nie Zun frowned, looking grim. Si Luo was leaning against Nie Zun. They were in black and white, and the contrast was apparent.

The blood on Si Luo's white robes bloomed into red flowers. There was still blood on the corner of his lips, but his beautiful face looked like it was just peacefully resting.

It was a kind of morbid beauty which pained my heart.

"He's no longer breathing. This was exactly what happened to Li Qing," Nie Zun said slowly.

Li Qing...

If Li Qing didn't wake up, what about Si Luo?

Why did this happen...

My trembling hands reached towards Si Luo.

"He... he's dead?"

Nie Zun was silent for a moment. He then said, "I don't think so. It doesn't feel like it. My gut tells me that if Si Luo dies, there'll definitely be great upheaval in the Split Zone. Because of this, he won't die that easily, nor would he allow himself to die so easily."

This sounded confusing.

What am I supposed to do now?

I did not know what to say.

"Let's just take him to Jie Pa first," said Nie Zun as he carried Si Luo.

"Okay."

Under the curious glances of some residents, we rushed out of the bar with Si Luo in Nie Zun's arms.

We were met with a sudden rush of air as we stepped out of the Marketplace building.

We could see a lone figure running towards us under the gray sky. The figure seemed to be shrouded in an evil, gray mist, and its gaze was sharp and full of anger. It was coming straight for Nie Zun and I.

I could not believe my eyes.

It was Gaoqin Jiuye.

A kind of dark aura encased him, and with amazing speed, he snatched Si Luo from Nie Zun before backing some distance away.

Strong winds whipped around the Marketplace, making me slightly unsteady on my feet.

A dark fire was raging in his eyes. “What did you guys do to him?”

His voice was hoarse, and though it sounded angry, I could hear a slight tremble in his voice, and a hint of... helplessness.

Chapter 125

125 Kill Her, Shen Qi!

I have never seen such an incensed and alarmed look on Gaoqin Jiuye .

“We didn’t do anything to him . I don’t know what’s happening either...” I muttered, stunned by Gaoqin Jiuye’s expression .

A storm was raging in Gaoqin Jiuye’s eyes, and shortly after, a dark shadow rushed out from behind him!

“Awrr—!” Seeing Si Luo’s prone, bloody form, Rong Jin called out in a woeful scream, and that dark shadow grew into a gigantic one!

“Li Shen, hand Mi Fu over now . We need to save Si Luo by engraving a split symbol on her!” Gaoqin Jiuye shouted in anger .

I panicked . I did not want Si Luo to die either! But there’s no way I can hand Mi Fu over!

Nie Zun answered, “No, we can’t hand Mi Fu over . ”

Gaoqin Jiuye smirked . “You think you have a choice?”

Strong winds howled .

Gaoqin Jiuye flew some distance away and leaned Si Luo against a tree . Shen Qi was already in his hand when he turned back to face us!

Pointing the pitch-black Shen Qi towards the sky, he made his way towards me . He looked like a grim reaper drenched in the icy waters of death!

Rong Jin remained silent, but a hand stretched out from that dark shadow . With a quick wave, countless beasts appeared in the sky! There were lions, tigers, and various other abnormal animals like a cat-headed snake and an elephant with the head of a wolf! Their eyes were all blood-red, and their jaws were wide open!

This is bad! We were right in front of the Marketplace, and there were still many Western District residents around! Many residents who were out and about ran away screaming in fear as they saw the beasts appearing in the air!

Gaoqin Jiuye seemed to have sensed my worry, and with a menacing smile, he raised Shen Qi and slashed a graceful arc to his left!

Woosh!

A dark ray of light appeared . It was jet black but blinding!

“Ah!” “Ah!” “Ah!”

A few innocent bystanders were cut down some distance away by that dark ray!

He spoke in a frigid voice, “Those injured by Shen Qi might lose their consciousness for a few days . If it was serious, their MF might even be damaged . Though you can’t die here in the Split Zone, won’t it be a living hell for them if their MF is greatly damaged? Li Shen, do you want to hand Mi Fu over, or do you want me to kill every single one of your residents?”

Boom!

I was incensed as I saw more and more residents falling onto the ground in pain . My red hair flew up into the air, flying amidst the rolling air currents!

“Gaoqin Jiuye, if you dare, you’ll have to fight me!” I drew my bow with gritted teeth, sending out 20 arrows!

Gaoqin Jiuye dodged them easily, keeping his steely eyes on me . “Let’s just see if I dare do it?!”

As Gaoqin Jiuye held Shen Qi, a deathly aura started to surround it! I instinctively knew that I had to stop him!

Without any further thoughts, I took Piercer in one hand, activated my MF on my feet and I pounced onto Gaoqin Jiuye in a second!

At the same moment, the beasts started going around tearing apart innocent residents!

There was a loud crack in the sky and a bright light appeared from the heavens above!

I was only inches from Gaoqin Jiuye's face, and I could see the dark fog surging in his eyes . I raised Piercer high, and whipped it towards him!

"Piercer, stop him!" I shouted angrily!

Piercer's violet light appeared! In that instant, I felt pain shoot through my palm all the way to my heart!

"Li Shen, put Piercer down now!" Nie Zun's worried voice sounded from behind me!

I endured the pain and focused 20 MF onto my wrists, whipping Piercer with a speed that even Gaoqin Jiuye cannot dodge!

Gaoqin Jiuye's eyes darkened . He could not dodge this, but he was not planning to! He drew something in the air with Shen Qi in his left hand, and countless explosions started sounding somewhere to his left!

He met Piercer's attack with his right hand!

He met Piercer's attack with his right hand!

Smack!

Piercer's tremendous power slammed into his palm, together with a great force of MF!

“Pff!” Gaoqin Jiuye spat out a mouthful of blood as he met the attack!

He looked at me with hostility, and that flexible sword Shen Qi was now wrapped around my neck with a quick movement of his left hand!

Swish!

That icy, razor-sharp sword cut into my neck, and blood started to gush out!

We were facing each other . His arm was broken by Piercer but he held it tightly, even though his arm was still in the process of healing!

Shen Qi was still around my neck . I activated my MF to protect my neck, preventing him from using Shen Qi to cut my head off!

Both of us spat out mouthfuls of blood! I stared at him with wide, open eyes while he held my gaze with an angry stare!

“Li Shen, I really hate you!” Gaoqin Jiuye released my neck, and used Shen Qi to attack something behind me!

There was a loud crash after he said, “Exterminate!”

I turned back, only to see one entire block of the Marketplace being demolished with countless air currents and a dazzling brightness from the sword!

As the block crumbled, countless bodies dropped out, as if they were mere puppets!

“No!” I screamed, only to see a blinding light reflected from that bright screen which previously landed in front of the Marketplace! Jie Pa was holding a long scroll, and as he said the sealing incantations, countless bright screens started to form a wall in front of the Marketplace!

Gaoqin Jiuye took me in a chokehold from behind!

I then saw dark fog surge in Nie Zun’s eyes . It felt more terrifying than the glint in Gaoqin Jiuye’s eyes! Nie Zun shot us a look which seemed to

become a pressure that targeted the consciousness!

“Ah!” Gaoqin Jiuye shut his eyes as he called out!

“Ah!” Gaoqin Jiuye shut his eyes as he called out!

I held my head in my hands!

Rong Jin’s shadow flitted towards Nie Zun . Nie Zun no longer had his gloves on, and he grabbed Rong Jin’s shadow forcefully, dragging him across the ground! Hellfire was burning in his eyes, and he was much more horrifying than Gaoqin Jiuye as he seemed to be engulfed in a dark light!

Gaoqin Jiuye forced his eyes open, and blood flowed from both his eyes as it was damaged by Nie Zun’s ability!

He let go of me suddenly, tearing off the splitting key hanging from his neck! This is bad!

Before I could stop him, he bent down and stuck the key into his left ankle, while I could only stare with wide eyes!

I heard the fabric over his ankle tear, and what I saw was the exact same scorpion symbol that was on my left ankle!

I shook my head in disbelief, and met Gaoqin Jiuye’s cold and menacing gaze!

He stared at me, saying, “Shatter— Unlock the seal!”

Crash!

As his split symbol produced a bright light, the air currents between us turned into tiny air needles which zipped through my body!

“Ah—!” I screamed in pain . I stared at Gaoqin Jiuye through bleeding eyes . Instead of escaping, I enunciated every word clearly, “You are, my... soul splitter?”

“That’s right! I was the one who captured you!” As he looked at me, there seemed to be agony in his eyes, as if he was talking about something anguishing!

But I know better, why would he be pained over this! He brought me nothing but pain!

“Why did you do that?!” Tears and blood flowed from my eyes . I held Piercer tightly, allowing that painful, icy chill to invade my heart!

“You even killed him, so why can’t I do that?” Gaoqin Jiuye’s eyes were misty, and he looked as if he was drowned in sorrow!

Him?

Who's that?

You mean Gao Qi?

Who's that?

You mean Gao Qi?

How are you related to Gao Qi?!

“Awwr—!” I heard Rong Jin call out!

“You, you, you, you! You’re really the devil! A deviiiiiiiiiiiilllllllll!!!!!!”
Rong Jin’s screams continued behind me!

I turned back abruptly, only to see Nie Zun drenched in dark blood, a devilish glow surrounding him. There was an insatiable killing intent in his eyes, and he seized the neck of Rong Jin's shadow tightly! He seemed to be merely holding onto a shadow, but that shadow was screaming in agony at this moment!

The beasts were no longer attacking the residents, they were charging towards him now! Giant claws started to materialize from the ground, closing in on him, as if about to tear him into pieces!

“Do you have the time to worry about others?” I heard Gaoqin Jiuye’s cold voice behind me before a giant wave and countless jet black air currents started flying in my direction!

“Hand Mi Fu over . If not, I’ll cripple you and you’ll not be able to use your MF ever again!” Though Gaoqin Jiuye said this without wavering, I saw a hint of sorrow and sympathy in his eyes!

Huh, I must be seeing things . I, Li Shen, must have been seeing things! Why would Gaoqin Jiuye feel sympathy for me!

“Kill me if you can!” I choked on a mouthful of blood .

He threw Shen Qi on the ground, scoffing . “Shen Qi, kill her!”

Shen Qi transformed into another Gaoqin Jiuye as it hit the ground! His entire body was jet black, and his eyes were a blood red!

This was the soul in the sword?!

No, it’s the devil in the sword!

Shen Qi placed both hands on the floor, and the ground started quaking violently!

Shen Qi’s bloody eyes were fixed on mine, and I felt pain shooting through my heart . Together with the icy pressure from Piercer, I began to feel like my consciousness was crumbling!

“Ah!” I screamed!

Chapter 126

126 Nie Zun's Killing Intent

“Ah—!” I heard Rong Jin's cries as I screamed!

Nie Zun tore Rong Jin's shadow into two! He ran towards me, and as he was shielding me with an arm, black clouds started billowing from his other hand! Those black clouds had a macabre aura which felt deadly, and it encased that figure which Shen Qi transformed into!

Shen Qi started to shiver!

Gaoqin Jiuye looked surprise . “These are the devil's hands themselves!”

Nie Zun's hand pressed down on my shoulder, and he sounded merciless .
“I've always been the devil!”

His pupils started moving like it was an eight trigram symbol!

The sky directly above me turned into a pitch black . It looked like a giant paint palette, and it started rotating with the movement of his pupils!

I spat out a mouthful of blood! The twisted, deathly and cruel darkness spread into my eyes, making me tremble . I felt like throwing up under that immense pressure which seemed to press onto our consciousness!

“Urgh—!” Gaoqin Jiuye and I both threw up mouthfuls of blood!

A horrific killing intent engulfed Nie Zun, sucking every one of us into this black hole that he created!

I felt pain on my shoulder where his hand was!

“Nie, Nie Zun...” I cried out, recalling the incident which happened half a year after my arrival here . It was something I always refused to bring up, and something which Nie Zun does not even remember being involved in .

Nie Zun was a person of few words, and I hated that he always followed me around .

Until that day...

“Ah Shen, let’s go have fun in the border forest,” Li Wen said with a cone in her hand . She sat down beside me as I was enjoying the scenery from the rooftop .

Even though there was no scenery to speak of in the Split Zone...

“Didn’t Li Qing say there has been a recent spate of deaths due to newcomers not being able to deal with the stress of living here? Let’s just stay here,” I said .

“Don’t be lazy . I know you best . Quick, let’s go, you’re about to turn moldy at this rate . ” Li Qing hooked her arm onto mine as she finished the last of her cone .

I smiled weakly, but I did not reject her either . I happened to turn back as I left the rooftop, and I saw that dark figure behind me again .

I felt angry all of a sudden, but there is nothing to be done about this since he could not be more than 500 meters away from me .

Li Wen chattered non-stop as we walked . She was always this bubbly and bright, as if she had no worries at all . She learnt to manipulate her MF rather quickly, and she was like a carefree, brilliant young girl .

I saw many unfilled pits in the ground as we arrived at the border forest . I laughed . “I knew it . You wanted my help in planting trees . ”

Li Wen stuck her tongue out at me cheekily . “I’m doing this for you . You just daydream on the rooftop all day and run all over the Western District at night . I’m afraid you might sink into depression if you continue like this . ”

I smiled bitterly . Depression? I'm not afraid of this puny illness, I have an identity disorder .

Li Wen grabbed my arm suddenly . “Ah Shen, look at that person squatting beside the pit . Doesn't he look a little weird?”

I looked towards the direction she was pointing, and I was startled!

There was a man squatting in the forest . He was in a weird position, with both hands around his head, and he was staring at Li Wen and I . The man had scars of various sizes on his face, and he looked terrifying .

Excitement shone in Li Wen's eyes . She did not seem to be scared of anything . “Ah Shen, this guy's weird, right?”

Excitement shone in Li Wen's eyes . She did not seem to be scared of anything . “Ah Shen, this guy's weird, right?”

I nodded . “He is weird . Look at that cold face . Let's not go any closer . Didn't Li Qing say there was some upheaval recently? We better be careful...”

Li Wen waved an unconcerned hand . “Our MF is high, why should we be scared of him?”

She hopped over and reached out a hand, waving to scarface . “Hey, did you just arrive in the Western District? What're you doing here?”

I followed in haste, as I felt there was something odd about that man .

As he saw Li Wen going over, his face twisted, and he slapped the ground with both hands! The ground then shook violently!

Li Wen and I almost fell off our feet! As I raised my head, I saw the man running towards us with splitting key in hand!

Damn it, he wants to die and drag one of us with him!

Though my MF was high, I did not yet know how to use it properly in battle!

Li Wen smiled, and with a slight wave, a ray of light from her arm flew towards the man! The man looked sturdy and well-built, but he was extremely agile . He dodged Li Wen's attack easily and charged straight at me!

I was simply rooted to the ground! As the man was about to reach me, a dark figure appeared beside me!

It was Nie Zun!

A black fire crackled around Nie Zun as he stared at the man angrily . That fire surrounded both the man and Nie Zun!

I was dumbstruck . I had never seen fire in the Split Zone before this!

Great waves of killing intent surged in Nie Zun's eyes . It was as if such killing intent materialized into that black fire, scorching that man!

Great waves of killing intent surged in Nie Zun's eyes . It was as if such killing intent materialized into that black fire, scorching that man!

This memory pained me . Nie Zun went berserk with killing intent that time, and when he woke up, he could not remember what happened . After that, he seemed to become more audacious and less inhibited, though there are times when he was quiet like before .

I remember Li Qing telling me not to talk about the incident to Nie Zun, because he would struggle with knowing it . I used to think that it was because of my other personality that made him this way, so I never brought it up . Because I did not want to fight others, afraid that I might go crazy and become just like Nie Zun one day, I was reluctant to take on the mantle of District Commander!

I had to admit that I viewed Nie Zun as a devil at the time . He was like a ticking time bomb, usually quiet and harmless, but all hell breaks loose

once it explodes . I was scared of him, just like how I was scared of my other personality .

Maybe Nie Zun was right, maybe she broke away from me because I had not accepted her!

Although I initially wanted to hate Nie Zun for being such a devil, my impression of him changed as we spent the days together . Even though I knew that Nie Zun was a devil, that the explosive anger and coldness of his surpasses even that of Gaoqin Jiuye, I started to accept him subconsciously!

Sometimes I wonder if I had any right to not accept him? Am I not a devil, am I not a monster myself? I hated myself, I hated her, and because of this, I hated him!

These memories still pained me as I recalled them .

Now that I think of it, Li Wen could have stopped scarface with her abilities at the time, but why didn't she do so?

Yes, I remember it now . She just stood there, doing nothing!

Why...

Li Wen...

You Ji...

Why?

My trip down memory lane was stopped short as I felt Nie Zun's malicious killing intent invading our consciousness!

Already unsteady on his feet, Gaoqin Jiuye stared at Nie Zun . "Pupil technique! The realm of the eye?! You can actually use the same ability as soul splitters!"

My trip down memory lane was stopped short as I felt Nie Zun's malicious killing intent invading our consciousness!

Already unsteady on his feet, Gaoqin Jiuye stared at Nie Zun . “Pupil technique! The realm of the eye?! You can actually use the same ability as soul splitters!”

This black hole seemed to be what Gaoqin Jiuye referred to as the realm of the eye . This space was created through Nie Zun’s pupils, and everything he sees will be sucked into this space!

More importantly, this space invades the consciousness, and it felt twisted, cold and cruel . It was as if a horrifying scene was being created in your head, and there was no way you can escape it . You could only throw up!

If you happened to meet Nie Zun’s gaze, those rotating pupils of his would make you feel like your five senses were crumbling!

Though Rong Jin’s shadow already healed, it seemed to be immobilized by this mental pressure, and the shadow could only attempt to creep slowly away from Nie Zun!

Gaoqin Jiuye looked like he was suffering as well, and that dark figure which Shen Qi transformed into was also struggling! Since I was in this space, I too was in misery!

His left hand, the one with the skull ring, held my hand tightly . I did not feel any chill from the hand of the devil which was supposed to bring misery to others . Instead, I felt a calming strength!

Although the pressure in this space increased, smudging our consciousness, I felt warmth coming from his hand . This warmth was like liquid air, forming a layer around me, as if it was protecting me!

I could not bear the bloody taste in my throat, and even though I felt like my consciousness was about to crumble, I still looked Nie Zun in the eye .

I saw pain in his eyes! The pain he feels when he hurts others!

But Nie Zun, can people like us really be redeemed? Are we worthy of sympathy? Whether we like it or not, both of us carry evil killing aura in

our hearts, we have devilish hearts!

I looked at him with teary eyes, and he met my gaze with a look of deep sorrow .

Nie Zun, don't turn into a monster... Even if it's for me... Even though I already knew it was all for me that time...

Please don't . I'll hate you more like this, because you are adding to my sin!
I already killed Gao Qi, I can't continue sinning!

Chapter 127

127 Guan Nie's Injury

I looked up at Nie Zun's sad and lonely eyes, shaking my head . My heart throbbed with pain, and a chill was invading my consciousness, but I kept thinking, No, Nie Zun, don't turn into a monster again because of me...

The agony in Gaoqin Jiuye's eyes slowly turned into anger, and he pulled me away from Nie Zun!

As I met his cold gaze, I saw a determined hatred in him . The corner of his lips was stained with blood, and his eyes were filled with a chilly menace .
“Li Shen, didn't you only have eyes for him? That man who looks exactly like me, Gao Qi . Your heart, your eyes, your soul, wouldn't they all stay with him forever?”

“You refused to leave even when he did those horrid things to you, and now you're changing for Nie Zun?”

“Just because you killed him?”

Gaoqin Jiuye fired these questions at me, befuddling me .

What... What did it mean by doing horrid things to me?

“You, how do you know all this...” I answered without realizing .

I saw Gaoqin Jiuye pursing his lips for the first time, and at this moment, the dark sky began to crumble . It felt like the apocalypse!

Nie Zun flitted to my side, grabbing my other hand!

Gaoqin Jiuye shot him a cold look! Following which, he seemed to be sucked into the black hole of Nie Zun's eyes!

Gaoqin Jiuye looked like he was in anguish, and he tightened the grip on the hand that was grabbing me!

I kept my eyes on him . “Tell me, didn't you say you didn't know who Gao Qi was? Why did you bring me to the Split Zone? If you didn't know him, how do you know what happened between us?”

Gaoqin Jiuye laughed out loud, to the point that he started to tear . “Li Shen, even if I didn't bring you here, didn't you still stab him?”

I was quite floored, but I smirked at him . “What has that got to do with you no matter how many times I stab him? Do you soul splitters all have doppelgangers in our world? A body double? Are you in a drama? Or, did this mean that you witnessed me stabbing him, but being in another world, there was nothing you can do?!”

I did not know why I said this . It was cruel, ruthless and it made no sense . I felt like there was something in me which was previously in a deep sleep, but it was beginning to gain awareness, and it was about to be revived .

Such revival was not a saving grace, it was not a rebirth . It was destruction .

“That's right, I couldn't stop him, and I couldn't stop you!” Gaoqin Jiuye had a poignant smile . Though the word ‘poignant’ did not seem to suit him, it described him well at this moment .

He still looked pompous with that chiseled jaw, but his wounds coupled with that look of sorrow in his eyes made the picture heart-breaking . I subconsciously looked down at his bright yellow sneakers, which were now stained with blood . An indescribable emotion welled up in me .

I felt someone pulling on my arm painfully, and looking up, I saw Gaoqin Jiuye's despondent gaze . “Didn't you only love him?”

Before I could react, I felt something pulling on my other arm . It felt hesitant, as if it was afraid of hurting me . I looked up in that direction, and met Nie Zun's quiet, lonely eyes . Those quiet eyes looked like they were trying to tell me so many things . Starlight shone in his eyes, and he held my arm in a tight grip .

“Tell me, didn't you only love him?!” Gaoqin Jiuye pulled me back, forcing me to look right at him!

“Gaoqin Jiuye, what are you doing? Si Luo is still waiting for us!”

I heard Rong Jin's helpless cries for Gaoqin Jiuye from behind . He dared not come any closer because of the realm of the eye . It was a realm of darkness, and as a shadow, he would only be swallowed into it!

As if suddenly woken from a dream, panic, surprise, pain and anxiety flashed past Gaoqin Jiuye's eyes . It looked as if he was surprised that he would actually forget about Si Luo while talking to me . He looked like he was in a deep anguish, except I did not know what it is .

He then became enraged . He shouted, “Shen Qi!”

I was impaled by the jet black Shen Qi in an instant, and I could feel it trying to invade my consciousness!

“Ah!” I cried out in pain as I felt my soul being torn apart!

“Shen'er!” It was the first time I heard Nie Zun call out like this . It sounded like that voice within the illusion .

Crash!

As Nie Zun felt my consciousness starting to crumble, the realm of the eye started collapsing! The sky collapsed, and there was only infinite darkness .

There was no escape .

There was no escape .

As I started losing grip on my awareness, I could see Nie Zun grabbing me by a hand, and that ring on his pinky finger in the other hand produced a streak of bright light . That light felt like a devil out to devour, and it was aimed right at Gaoqin Jiuye's heart!

A feeling of uneasiness swept over me!

“No!”

I screamed this in my heart, but why did I hear a similar cry coming from somewhere far away?

A white figure rushed into this space . The figure had a head of long hair that swept the ground, and a look of worry and fear was etched in those upturned eyes!

It was Guan Nie!

He rushed in front of Gaoqin Jiuye to shield him!

Stab!

He was stabbed through the chest with a blood-red streak! The light from Nie Zun's pinky ring skewered Guan Nie right through his heart!

Gaoqin Jiuye's eyes opened wide as Guan Nie collapsed onto the ground gracefully! He lifted his fingers as he collapsed, and moving his lips, he applied an illusion!

Great waves appeared on the jet black ground! The force of these waves was tremendous! Nie Zun and I were swept into the waves, and we were sucked into the waters .

Although this was an illusion, I shivered as I was being immersed in the water . The only warmth came from Nie Zun's hand, holding me tightly .

“Ugh...” I choked on the rolling waves and started to feel faint .

It felt like I kept sinking with Nie Zun, and the water pressure made it feel like I was already a few hundred meters under the sea . I tried to open my eyes, but there was nothing but a flashing light, and there was nothing I could hold on to .

Nie Zun's hand suddenly let go, and I tried to move, searching around for him .

This water is really icy .

This water is really icy .

But it's good that it can wash all the blood off me .

In my daze, I felt as if I have landed on the sea floor, as the waves seemed calmer now .

But that bone-chilling cold and pressure seemed to remain .

I wanted to look for Nie Zun and I tried hard to open my eyes, just a little .

Why did I feel so tired .

“Shen'er...”

I heard a voice from the bottom of the sea . Whose is this?

It sounds like the voice of a siren singing a beautiful song...

It did not belong to Nie Zun .

Whatever was restraining me seemed to let go now, and I paddled with my hands, trying to swim towards that call .

“Shen'er...”

“Shen'er!”

I heard Nie Zun's voice out of nowhere . It was like a splash of cold water, waking me from my dream .

The instant I woke up, I became aware of the immense water pressure from all sides .

I saw Nie Zun's hair floating in the water like dark seaweed . His eyes shone with a dazzling light, and he was swimming towards me . I wanted to reach out to him for an embrace .

His icy lips touched mine, as if he was giving me CPR .

Can souls actually suffocate?

His icy lips touched mine, as if he was giving me CPR .

Can souls actually suffocate?

A breath of cold air entered my body, and I desperately held on to this lifeline .

It was getting difficult to open my eyes in the water, but as I opened them, I met his starry eyes .

Brilliant fireworks went off in his eyes .

Crash!

The waves disappeared, and the darkness receded from my brain . It felt like we were about to go back to where we were .

We were back in front of the Western District Marketplace, and the black hole was gone . Guan Nie's last minute illusion and the black hole seemed to have canceled out each other's effects .

In front of the Marketplace, countless individuals were groaning on the ground . Jie Pa was standing behind the many bright screens which shielded the building and him .

I was met with a scene where the ground seemed to be littered with bodies .
Though I knew they weren't dead, I could see the misery on their faces .

Such destruction was brought about by Gaoqin Jiuye, by Nie Zun, and by me .

As I wanted to question Gaoqin Jiuye on this scene, I saw him carry the bloody Guan Nie, looking at Nie Zun and I with crazed eyes .

Nie Zun looked unusually pale . Did he damage his MF when he forcefully escaped the illusion with me?

Guan Nie was a picture of tragic beauty, like a beautiful lady who was injured, he remained elegant through the pain . Though he cannot be compared with Si Luo, he was still graceful .

His beautiful upturned eyes contained a kind of turbulent sorrow, and his lips were stained with blood . Looking at Nie Zun, he said, "My... pet... You... for her... you broke through my illusion... Do you know the damage..."

As if he thought of something else, those dewy eyes looked towards Gaoqin Jiuye .

Chapter 128

128 The Second Personality

Guan Nie's pained eyes lingered on Gaoqin Jiuye .

I glanced sideways at Nie Zun .

Something was not right . He was very pale, and from his eyes, I could tell he was suppressing some sort of pain . He suppressed it very well, and I almost could not tell .

“What's... wrong?” I wanted to reach out to him, but he backed away, as if he was avoiding me .

Guan Nie started coughing, just like Si Luo .

Cough cough cough

He then spat out a mouthful of blood!

Gaoqin Jiuye looked slightly anxious, and tried his best to keep his voice from panicking as he held the beautiful Guan Nie in his arms . “Are you okay?”

Guan Nie gave an exhausted smile . “You worry about me too...”

Gaoqin Jiuye had a complicated expression .

I could no longer be bothered with the two of them . I just found Nie Zun's gaze becoming more and more unfocused .

“Guan Nie, what did you do to Nie Zun?”

I stared at Guan Nie . Ridden with anxiety, I did not realize that Guan Nie looked to be in more agony than Nie Zun was at this moment .

Guan Nie smiled elegantly . “It’s not me, it’s you . Who else can break my illusion? With my pet’s ability, others might not be able to hurt him in the least . But with you by his side, he can’t help but get hurt while protecting you .

“As long as he cares about you and he wants to protect you, he will not be able to protect himself . ”

“How about you, what did you do for him?” Nie Zun interrupted Guan Nie, pointing at Gaoqin Jiuye .

Gaoqin Jiuye was stunned .

Guan Nie smiled, a longing in his eyes . He looked at Gaoqin Jiuye and said softly, “I can never compare to him... no matter how much I do for you...”

Gaoqin Jiuye pursed his lips .

A dark red line of blood seeped out from the corner of Guan Nie’s lips, and he looked like he was in anguish . “Why such an expression? Aren’t I right? Gaoqin, what’s so good about him? Is it because he’s more beautiful than me?”

Though this was a sorrowful scene, I felt warmed .

Guan Nie might be the most innocent among us all . He was infatuated with Gaoqin Jiuye, and thought that Gaoqin Jiuye cared about Si Luo more because Si Luo was more beautiful than him .

A gentle warmth spread across Gaoqin Jiuye’s features as he looked at Guan Nie, though he did not speak .

Guan Nie suddenly turned brutal, and he took Gaoqin Jiuye’s face in his bloody hands .

“Say it, just why?”

“Even after spending all those lonely years with you, Gaoqin, I wasn’t able to move you, I wasn’t able to earn a place in your heart . Why did you leave with him with just a single word? You didn’t hesitate? There was nothing you missed? Why was he able to achieve something that I wasn’t able to when we’ve spent such a long time together?”

Guan Nie teared up, and I was filled with pity at this . This looked like a scene where an injured but beautiful lady was crying to her lover, asking him why she was not able to move him .

But what moved me was not the scene in front of me, but Guan Nie’s words .

Why was he able to achieve something that I wasn’t able to when we’ve spent such a long time together?

How many of us would have had similar thoughts?

“Gaoqin Jiuye!” Guan Nie cried out suddenly!

His eyes were filled with tears . “Gaoqin Jiuye! You’re a monster! I’m one too! I’m the only one who understands you!”

With a breath, his hands fell to the ground . I only realized at this point that his wound did not heal! Gaoqin Jiuye noticed it too, and he looked like he was in a panic .

I gave myself a bitter smile . Gaoqin Jiuye, there’re things that you’re afraid of too?

Are you afraid that he’ll die?

What if I want him dead?

As if shocked by the darkness in my heart, I opened my eyes wide and shook my head subconsciously .

As if shocked by the darkness in my heart, I opened my eyes wide and shook my head subconsciously .

What was I thinking?

Did I have to be controlled by this devil within me whenever it comes to Gaoqin Jiuye?!

“Only me... why was Si Luo able to earn a place in your heart...” Tears flowed down Guan Nie’s cheeks . It was heart-breaking .

“You were ostracized and left alone... but I loved that lonely look of yours... I really liked you at that time... doesn’t matter if you were just standing or sitting, it seemed as if no one could come near...”

Guan Nie’s voice started trembling, “How I wished for you to be lonely forever... I wished no one else would walk into your heart... If I can’t do that, nobody else can do it either...”

“How I wish there would be no one by your side for all eternity... I wish for everyone to turn their back on you, leaving only me by your side...”

Guan Nie’s voice became softer .

My heart felt like it was shredded into a million pieces .

Such a selfish and possessive love, wasn’t I like this before?

I was ostracized and called a monster . They were right . No matter how I justified my actions, I had to admit that I acted like this towards Gao Qi .

Wishing that no one else remained by your side, so that there’ll only be me left .

“Ka—!”

A shrill and eerie laughter broke my train of thought, and as I turned back, I saw Rong Jin’s dark shadow pierce through Nie Zun’s heart!

His dark shadow was long and thin, looking like a shadowy blade . As no one was paying attention to him, he took the opportunity to injure Nie Zun!

“No!” I screamed, lifting my arm to strike with Piercer . Piercer produced a bright light, and my hand was actually restrained by this light!

The pain shot up my arm and straight into my heart!

Nie Zun looked calm, but his eyes were holding back pain . The light in his starry eyes seemed to darken .

I could not move my arm!

“Urgh—!” Guan Nie continued coughing mouthfuls of blood!

“Urgh—!” Guan Nie continued coughing mouthfuls of blood!

Upon seeing Guan Nie’s condition, Gaoqin Jiuye seemed to go back to being enraged . He lifted his hand, and Shen Qi turned back into that long, thin sword in his hand!

There was a horrific aura surrounding Shen Qi now, and one’s defenses naturally guarded against it . Once that hits you, your MF will be greatly damaged!

Shen Qi was heading for the temporarily immobilized Nie Zun, who was impaled by that dark shadow!

“Don’t—!” I screamed as my arm was not able to move even an inch . I looked at Gaoqin Jiuye, begging him with my eyes!

I wondered if I was seeing things, but I thought that Gaoqin Jiuye slowed down for a second because of my cries! However, the cold glint that flashed past his eyes made me sure that he would not stop the attack!

It was just a second away from peril!

What should I do?! What do I do! I can’t move, I can’t move, my arm can’t move Piercer!

“Shen’er...”

A voice which did not belong to Nie Zun, but sounded like him, appeared in my head!

Nie Zun's eyes darkened, as if he had given up on dodging the attack . I reached toward my own neck with my other hand!

I focused all my MF on that hand, and with lightning speed, I plucked out my splitting key, knelt down, and jammed it into my left ankle!

Into that same scorpion symbol which Gaoqin Jiuye, no, which he and I shared!

Clack .

I heard a clear clicking sound .

“Hai . ”

Something which sounded like a light sigh floated past my ear .

It sounded familiar, yet helpless .

It sounded sorrowful and lonely .

Everything seemed to stop for a second . In this second, I was able to see Gaoqin Jiuye's hand about to slash into Nie Zun, and Nie Zun's eyes seemed to shine with a dazzling brightness!

It sounded sorrowful and lonely .

Everything seemed to stop for a second . In this second, I was able to see Gaoqin Jiuye's hand about to slash into Nie Zun, and Nie Zun's eyes seemed to shine with a dazzling brightness!

An uneasy feeling overwhelmed me from head to toe . This feeling... It was stronger than all the other times when I felt uneasy!

It felt as if something deep within my soul was trying to break free, and even though I knew I was heading for an abyss, I dove in without hesitation

.

I could not tell if my soul was being torn apart or if my heart was being shattered . The monster within me could finally break free and roar, and I released it to destroy this world .

I threw Piercer onto the ground, and Shen Qi stopped in the second before it touched Nie Zun . Rong Jin's shadow stopped moving and Guan Nie looked at me with bated breath .

All their eyes were on me .

I cried out in what was possibly the most painful, sorrowful cry that anyone has ever heard in the Split Zone . Almost half of my MF was used up in this cry . It had a force that pierced through souls, making everyone quieten down .

Even me .

Because of that darkness which clawed its way through, I saw things clearly now .

It was as if we were apart for a century, but you came back to me eventually .

After I focused a high amount of MF on my throat, it felt hoarse after I let out that bloodcurdling scream . I fixed my eyes on someone in front of me .

As I activated my split symbol, my body produced a streak of red light . This red was eerie but dazzling . It was bright, it was shiny, it was blinding .

Not far from me, the red light materialized into someone . She had a gentle but ruthless smile on her, as if she could easily destroy the world in a second .

Leaving no one alive .

At this moment, she had a stunning smile . It was empty and cruel, and she was staring at me .

She was dressed in red and she had red hair, looking exactly like me .

She looked like she just returned from a bloody battle, and smiled at me with empty eyes .

“Shen’er . ”

This was the voice of the siren in the sea .

Chapter 129

129 The Curse of the Split Symbol

“What’re you thinking about?”

I have been daydreaming on the rooftop of the Residence building for a while now, and my thoughts were interrupted by Huan Qing, who walked over to be beside me .

I looked up at him in a daze, shaking my head .

He sat on the floor beside me, not afraid of dirtying his white suit at all .

“Li Shen, thank you . If you didn’t try your best in stopping Gaoqin Jiuye, who knows if it’s still possible for Mi Fu to live this happily here in the Split Zone . ” It was rare to hear Huan Qing thank someone .

I gazed into the distance . “Is she happy now?”

Huan Qing was silent .

I let out a sigh . “Huan Qing, there’s no need to thank me . Everything she has now is all thanks to you . Even if she doesn’t like it, even if she isn’t happy, you won’t be able to change that . She’ll be able to live well as long as she is wherever her heart wants her to be . As for you, you’ll have to think about whether you want her to merely be alive, or to live a happy life . ”

Huan Qing gave a wry smile . “When life gets difficult, wanting a happy life will merely be an unreachable dream . ”

“You and Jiao S really weren’t able to find any way to save Si Luo?” I looked at him .

He didn’t meet my eyes, but simply looked into space as he replied, “No . ”

“Oh, how’s your... situation? Everything alright?” He asked suddenly .

I wanted to say ‘Not bad’, ‘Pretty good’ or ‘Nothing much’ .

But why couldn’t I say so?

A whole week had already passed since the day Gaoqin Jiuye and Rong Jin attacked the Western District in their attempt to take Mi Fu . However, that moment when I activated my split symbol still lingered in my mind .

As one activates their split symbol, they’d be placed under a curse .

I believed that, and I did not activate it because I did not want to experience that curse either .

Until that day, when I saw Gaoqin Jiuye charging towards Nie Zun with Shen Qi in hand and a killing intent that seemed inextinguishable, I had no other choice but to do it .

After activating my split symbol, I received power, and also a curse .

That curse was able to destroy me .

How long has it been since I’ve seen her?

No, I should be saying, have I seen her before?

People around me used to mock me .

“What a weirdo!”

“Stay away from her . ”

“I heard she’s a loony . ”

Where were you in all those lonely years?

Through all these days and nights, I opened my eyes and closed them, again and again .

My head was filled with thoughts of her .

She turned into a devil, and she was stepping through blood .

She called out to me gently, “Shen’er . ”

Everyone stopped in their tracks when I let out the scream that day, but nobody could see her .

She was something only I could see .

She was the curse, the curse I received after activating my split symbol .

I’ve previously thought of many possibilities of how the curse would manifest itself, but I never would have expected that she would materialize and appear right in front of my eyes .

She was the curse placed upon me by my split symbol .

It was actually her .

I always knew that even though she was a devil, she was a devil which belonged only to me .

On the day of that battle, she stopped Gaoqin Jiuye’s attack on Nie Zun . It was a beautiful scene where blood splattered dazzlingly . It might even be the most beautiful battle the Split Zone had witnessed, an attack that not even Shen Qi could parry . But I couldn’t remember a single thing .

I simply fell apart when I saw her .

I didn’t know that bodies of consciousness could fall apart in the Split Zone .

I only knew the results from the battle .

She stopped Gaoqin Jiuye's attack on Nie Zun, following which, Si Luo miraculously woke up .

Since Si Luo was awake, taking our lives were no longer Gaoqin Jiuye and Rong Jin's priority .

Since Si Luo was awake, taking our lives were no longer Gaoqin Jiuye and Rong Jin's priority .

With their unwavering loyalty, they once again went back to Si Luo's side .

Loyalty is just like shackles that cannot be broken .

Guan Nie was abandoned .

Gaoqin Jiuye might have been aware that Guan Nie's injuries were not fatal, but I could tell that his choice made Guan Nie hate him once again .

The depth of hatred can only commensurate with the intensity of love .

To the others, I might have been the one who stopped Gaoqin Jiuye, since they could not see her .

To the others, I was the one who went berserk and turned into a monster .

It was like I went insane .

But, she isn't me . That is something only I know .

Though she helped finish what I started, I cannot accept her just because of this .

She brought me years of loneliness when I was alive .

I will never forget that pain she brought me by taking my love away .

I'm already dead, with my consciousness stuck in this godforsaken place .
Why can't she just let me off already?

You, why don't you just let me off?

Don't even dream of me being able to accept you merely because of this bit of power you're able to provide .

On that day, I passed out shortly after activating my split symbol .

The circumstances were amusing when I awoke .

Si Luo's condition miraculously improved, and he finally ordered Gaoqin Jiuye and Rong Jin to stop attacking Mi Fu and I . Mi Fu and Ku Fei were then finally able to come out of hiding .

Instead of leaving immediately, Si Luo, with his two cruel subordinates, stayed in the Western District . Together with Mi Fu and Ku Fei, they waited for me to regain consciousness .

He even used a special technique to summon Huan Qing and Jiao S, who were at that point still searching for a method to save him .

As Huan Qing and Jiao S did not succeed, they were initially in disbelief when they saw Si Luo's much improved condition .

I thought I was dreaming when I didn't see her as I woke up .

I thought I was dreaming when I didn't see her as I woke up .

When she reappeared, she was squatting on the floor, drawing circles .

Her profile looked beautiful . Her red dress was identical to mine, and it flared out onto the floor, hiding those pretty ankles of hers .

Her bright red hair was also identical to mine . It was long and fell over her shoulders naturally . She was a beauty .

As I walked towards her, she looked up slowly, giving me a charming smile .

I was being stared at by myself .

Her smile was gentle and warm, and her profound eyes made it look like I was looking into a deep lake .

She asked, “How are you?”

How should I answer?

Mm, I’m good .

Without you, I’m good .

From then on, I didn’t know how I should answer such a question . I didn’t know how to answer Huan Qing, who asked the exact same question as she did .

Eventually, I decided to answer, “I’m great . ”

Huan Qing did not seem to read too much into this reply of mine .

He simply said, “They said you activated your split symbol during that battle, and that you were a little weird after that . ”

I shrugged . “I’ve always been weird, you just need to get used to it . ”

Though I answered this way, I thought to myself, I was weird?

Hah, seems like as long as she’s around, I’d be labeled ‘weird’?

“No . ” Huan Qing looked me in the eye with a serious expression . “You know what I mean . Do you want to consider telling me about the punishment you received after activating your split symbol?”

I laughed . “Huan Qing, curiosity killed the cat . ”

Huan Qing did not lighten up even after I laughed . He continued looking serious .

He sighed . “Anyway, as someone who hopes to use that power in battle from activating my split symbol, I know very well that the punishment is not an easy one to bear . Even though I didn’t witness the fight that day, or your reaction after activating it, I can fully understand .

“Li Shen, no matter what the punishment is, it’s definitely something unimaginably painful . ”

Huan Qing reached a conclusion regarding the effect of the activated split symbol .

“Li Shen, no matter what the punishment is, it’s definitely something unimaginably painful . ”

Huan Qing reached a conclusion regarding the effect of the activated split symbol .

My dear Huan Qing, that isn’t unimaginably painful .

Pain can be felt . But what she brought me was destruction, of me losing all feelings towards this world .

How could I let her out?

How could I, how could I, how could I let her out in this place where I could escape and finally be independent?

I then smiled at Huan Qing . “I’m not in pain . She’s the one in pain . I’ll let her regret ever coming to this place which belongs only to me .

“Also, Huan Qing, how could you understand my pain? Who are you to understand it?”

My lips twisted into a cruel smile .

Through his gaze, Huan Qing was trying to tell me that he understood, so that I wouldn't be so helpless . However, he looked surprised upon hearing what I said .

“Who... who is she?” Huan Qing asked carefully .

I smiled gently . “A devil, a monster . ”

Huan Qing frowned slightly, as if he did not know what to say .

“Huan Qing . ” I looked down, a smile still on my lips .

“The punishment you received upon activating your split symbol might not be an unbearable one .

“But when I activated it, I didn't receive a punishment . I received destruction...”

I looked up gently at him .

On that day of battle, Guan Nie was worried for Gaoqin Jiuye . After settling Mi Fu and Ku Fei, he rushed to the scene .

Because of his choice, he had to once again witness Gaoqin Jiuye choose Si Luo over him .

Jie Pa got even busier after that day repairing the damage to the area because of the battle .

After Jiao S and Huan Qing returned, Jiao S also stayed in the Western District, waiting for me to regain my consciousness . She might have been worried about me, or maybe it was because she could finally see Si Luo .

It was as if everything came to a temporary stop, as if everyone was temporarily saved .

Except for me .

Not only did I summon a monster, I also destroyed what tied Nie Zun and I together .

Chapter 130

130 Jiao S's Heart

Nie Zun was gone .

After I woke up, when everything came to a temporary stop, he was gone .

More accurately, he was gone from the moment I activated my split symbol and saw her in battle .

Not only was he gone, I could not find him anywhere . After I activated my split symbol, that restriction where we could not be more than 500 meters apart was also undone .

I used to hate it, since I could never be more than 500 meters away from him from the first day I arrived in the Split Zone . It was a restriction that had no apparent reason, and it was gone so suddenly .

Did I try to look for him?

I didn't .

Maybe I just couldn't believe that he'd just go missing and leave me like this .

You couldn't wait to leave me once that restriction was lifted, Nie Zun?

Nie Zun .

“As for Nie Zun's disappearance...” Huan Qing seemed to hesitate .

You seem to be able to read my mind .

I looked at him, encouraging him to continue .

Huan Qing looked worried . “After you passed out, we looked at Guan Nie’s injuries . They were more serious than we thought, and it caused some permanent damage to his MF . I don’t know what Nie Zun did to cause such damage . Though I might not be able to accurately estimate Guan Nie’s abilities, as a fellow illusionist, I know he isn’t an ordinary one . One can escape from that physical illusion he created with MF, and it can also be undone, but it cannot be forcefully broken . However, Nie Zun was able to do just that . ”

His eyes darkened . “I don’t know what you saw in the physical illusion, since it’s meant to bring out the darkness in your hearts . No matter what you saw, Nie Zun probably broke the illusion by force because he was trying to prevent that darkness from devouring you . He accomplished something which isn’t usually possible . Because of that, I have reason to believe that he is gravely injured . ”

I opened my eyes wide .

“Li Shen, bodies of consciousness in the Split Zone don’t die easily, but we can still get hurt . I’m not talking about those injuries which can heal themselves, I’m referring to the permanent damage that can affect MF . To us, MF represents our ability and it forms the foundation of life here . It’s difficult to go on if our MF is damaged . If you really care about him, it’s best to look for him as soon as possible .

“I’m leaving now . You’ve been daydreaming here on the rooftop almost every day since you woke up . What I’m trying to tell you is that, some things cannot be solved by simply daydreaming . ”

Huan Qing left after that .

I remained silent when he spoke .

I’m just daydreaming, not avoiding things .

Jiao S and Si Luo are still here in the Western District . All of you are still here .

Why are the lot of you here, why are you still here, what are your aims – all of this isn't important right now, and I couldn't care less about it . I didn't want to think about anything, and I didn't want to do anything .

I'm not running away .

For some reason, I had no energy to do anything . It was as if half of my soul was lost .

Why did he leave when all of you are still here?

I heard footsteps behind me .

I knew immediately who it was . Nobody walks as stiffly as she does .

“Are you guys taking turns? Why, you're afraid that I'd jump off from here? Don't worry, I won't die from it even if I do . ” Although I didn't want to do anything and my emotions were in a mess, I regained a lively nature in front of Jiao S .

Jiao S sat beside me . “You've been sitting here without sleeping or resting for two days . ”

I shook my head . “I did rest . ”

I shook my head . “I did rest . ”

“You're waiting for him?” Jiao S asked in her hoarse voice .

I remained silent, shaking my head .

Jiao S and I both looked into the distance .

“I was finally able to see him in this Western District of yours, after that huge battle, after you passed out from activating your split symbol,” Jiao S said .

I nodded . “How do you feel when you could finally see him? You’ve admired him for a long time . ”

Jiao S continued, “How do you feel about Nie Zun’s disappearance? He has always been by your side . ”

My head shot up . She did not look angry, but why did she have to say something like this to break my heart?

She stared into my eyes . “Others don’t know you, but I know you . You’ll never come clean if I don’t force you to . Ah Shen, tell me, you’re really totally fine with Nie Zun disappearing?”

I held her gaze . “No, I’m not fine at all .

“This is why I’m here . ” I gave her a wry smile as I pointed at the rooftop I was sitting on .

For a long moment, Jiao S looked at me with those empty eyes . She then did something unexpected .

Slowly, she leaned her head close, and rested it against my shoulder .

This was so familiar . There was only one other person who did this to me when I was alive .

She used to be my best friend, and she was also the one who betrayed me .

My heart hurt as I thought of Pomelo .

I could not get used to Jiao S’s breath on my shoulder .

I could not get used to Jiao S’s breath on my shoulder .

I haven’t been in such close proximity to anyone for a long time . Just like a contagious patient, I kept my distance from everyone .

Though I was not used to this, it felt nice .

A slight smile formed on my lips, and there was fatigue in her voice .

“What good does it do for me to ask you these . I’m also an idiot when it comes to love . ”

I suddenly thought that I should ask her about what she said to Si Luo, and what happened after seeing him after such a long time .

But, could I really ask something like this?

“I saw him, and he was just as gentle to me . A gentleness that had this distance to it, a distance which can never be overcome . ” She spoke even before I could formulate my question .

I was silent .

“Ah Shen, I’ve always known that he had countless admirers and loyal followers . He has this angelic aura, and he is always so wise . How could I be worthy of standing beside him, even if I was just a subordinate? I’m someone peculiar, and I know I’m known as the queen of annihilation here in the Split Zone, a cruel, ruthless, emotionless person . I’ll just be spoiling the picture if a person like me were to stay beside him .

“But, why did I still want to be by his side? I knew it was impossible, I knew I wasn’t worthy . Why chase such a faraway dream?

“Though I wasn’t worthy, there were many other things I wasn’t worthy for, there were far too many things that I lacked . So can’t I just dream about it?” She heaved a sigh, but I could hear her helplessness .

I did not dare move, and I let her continue leaning against me . I was afraid to move because I was afraid to see the tears in her eyes . I did not want to see her cry . She was always so strong, as if nothing could beat her .

“They all loved him and they would protect him, but why did it feel like it was me who understood him best? They were all thinking of how to save him when he was dying, but it was only me who wanted to help him

accomplish what he wished for . Even though I didn't even know what his wish was .

“I simply wanted to help him achieve what he wished for . There were so many who loved him, but none could provide him with the life he wanted . Ah Shen, I still don't know what he wants . But I know that it is not something easy, and it is definitely non-violent . I know he wants peace, so how could he accept sacrificing Mi Fu's life to save his own? I would never do anything he doesn't wish for . Instead of dying in peace, they all want him to stay alive, when all I want is just for him to have a happy life . I don't want him to die, and I know he won't die . I want him to be the happiest person in this world . ”

I want him to be the happiest person in this world .

Such promises were usually made by one male to another female .

I want him to be the happiest person in this world .

Such promises were usually made by one male to another female .

But you carry such wishes for Si Luo?

How are you not worthy of being by his side?

Tell me, apart from you, Jiao S, who else is worthy of being by Si Luo's side?

The loyal but naïve Gaoqin Jiuye and Rong Jin?

Or somebody else?

“Ah Shen, he was just as distant as ever when I saw him again . I know I should give up, but I just can't change my heart . Ah Shen, I'm acting just like a teenage girl . I can't even bear to leave him even for just a while . Haha, how can someone like this lead the Eastern District?

“Ah Shen, I wasn't well-liked nor accepted by others when I was alive, and I'm not about to hope for something nice here in this world . Maybe this

was the reason why I lost my will to live and ended up here in the Split Zone . I didn't expect that I would meet him here . I know being this emotional isn't like my usual self at all, but Ah Shen, do you know that when I met him, I finally learnt that there was still something in this world that made me gravitate towards it . I realized I could be like an ordinary person, someone who wanted things, and not be a monster . ”

Silent tears rolled down my cheeks . I started crying even before she did .

The listener was the one who cried .

Jiao S, would there be anyone apart from me who knows exactly how you feel?

For someone who had grappled with years of identity disorder, who was always treated like a terrorist and shunned by others, Gao Qi was that dream of mine, the only thing that was good in this world .

Si Luo pushed you away, Si Luo rejected you, Si Luo left you .

Don't be afraid, don't cry . At least you didn't dirty your hands killing him...

Droplets of tears hung on my chin, before dripping onto my palm .

Jiao S was also crying silent tears, and her tears met mine as they landed on my palm .

Chapter 131

131 How Can You Bear to See Me Upset?

Jiao S and I were drowned in a sea of sorrow . Leaning against each other, we were feeding off each other's precious warmth .

My vision cleared as I stopped crying .

I saw her figure appear slowly in front of me .

After I activated my split symbol, I could never tell when she would appear . She appeared at irregular intervals, without rhyme or reason .

She was just floating in mid-air, like a female ghost dressed in red . She floated towards me with a gentle smile on her face .

My shoulders stiffened . I did not want to move, but my breathing turned heavy as I saw her approaching .

“What's... wrong?” Jiao S, who was leaning against my shoulder, straightened up and asked carefully . She was perceptive, and she could definitely see something was different with me .

I kept my eyes on the figure in front of me . Once Jiao S lifted her head from my shoulders, I started dragging myself backwards with my hands and legs, trying to back away .

“Go away . ” I looked at her coldly .

She gave me a brilliant smile .

She glanced at Jiao S with those bright eyes, as if to say, ‘Aren’t you afraid that she’d find you weird if you talk to yourself like this?’

I smirked . Weird? I’ve always been weird .

Jiao S was not surprised at my actions, and she simply asked with slightly knitted brows, “I wanted to ask, what exactly is your curse? It seems like everyone is worried about that after you activated your split symbol . ”

“Who, do you see?” Jiao S followed my gaze, looking in her direction .

But she couldn’t see her .

She stopped in front of me . That hateful smile remained on her face . Apart from asking me ‘How are you’ on the first day, she did not say anything else .

“Nothing, let’s go . If I don’t return, I’m afraid Si Luo and the rest might just stay here in the Western District forever . ” I shot her one last icy look, and stood up .

Jiao S followed closely behind, leaving the rooftop with me .

“I feel that you’re different after you activated your split symbol,” Jiao S said in her coarse voice .

Instead of responding to her question, I changed the subject . “Where are they staying?”

Jiao S looked at me meaningfully, and continued, “Guan Nie is seriously injured, and I got my guys to take him back to the Eastern District after you woke up . Rong Jin returned to the Southern District upon Si Luo’s orders . Only Si Luo and Gaoqin Jiuye are staying in the Academy . Ku Fei and Mi Fu are staying directly opposite Jie Pa in the Residence, probably because he’s afraid that Gaoqin Jiuye’s killing intent might be reignited if they stayed too close to Si Luo . ”

“Guan Nie returned to the Eastern District on his own? Isn’t Gaoqin Jiuye still here? And Si Luo is here too,” I asked calmly .

Jiao S looked at me again, and as if sighing, she said, “He’s also human, and he has a heart . With Si Luo around, Gaoqin Jiuye will never look at anyone else . He bore witness to this fact once again, so he’s probably extremely heartbroken . His injuries were already serious, and when he left, frankly even I’ve never seen him with such a forlorn expression in all these years . ”

I looked into the distance as we arrived at the ground floor .

“After you activated your split symbol, do you still remember all that happened on that day during the fight?” Jiao S asked suddenly .

Now that I was reminded of it, do I really remember everything from that fight which she helped me end?

I looked back . She did not follow after Jiao S and I as we left the rooftop . She just disappeared .

“Even I was surprised that day . You wielded Piercer so well . From what I know, Piercer has always produced violet light and violet blades, but on that day, Piercer had a bright red glow, as if it was a complement to your dress . It was a beautiful battle, everything was bathed in red . ”

I scoffed, “That was a fight . How could you describe such a violent incident as if it was a beauty pageant . ”

“You left a really deep impression on that day . ” On the topic of fights and bloodshed, Jiao S sounded so excited, as if she was inherently wicked .

“How deep?” I asked with raised brows .

Though I asked, I did not really want to know . I did not want to know how horrid I would have looked while I was being controlled by her .

“To the point that even someone like Gaoqin Jiuye looked subdued . ”

My heart skipped a beat .

My heart skipped a beat .

Jiao S shook her head . “I’ve never liked Gaoqin Jiuye, but that might be because I didn’t like the fact that he was always hanging around Si Luo . Looking at it objectively, I am impressed by Gaoqin Jiuye, and he definitely has the right to be as conceited as he is . ”

She looked at me . “Apart from Si Luo, I’ve never seen Gaoqin Jiuye being so tender with anyone else, not Guan Nie, not you . However, he made an exception for you . Though he didn’t openly express it like he does with Si Luo, I could tell it was different .

“You looked like an elegant goddess who was drenched in blood on that day when you struck at him with Piercer’s red ray, and I saw that there was this bloodthirsty cruelty and extreme passion in his eyes . It was as if he finally found his match, and he was willing to be ensnared by you . ”

“Goosebumps are appearing all over me . ” I laughed coldly .

Willing to be ensnared by me? By me or by her?

I had always thought that Nie Zun protected and cared for me because we were together every single day in the Split Zone . I did not expect for him to tell me he had actually seen me before, and that it was not exactly me, but the me who was being controlled by her .

Does this mean that she was the one he cared for, not me?

If he didn’t, would Gao Qi’s fate be any different?

How about Gaoqin Jiuye?

Though I’ve seen that cold, ruthless and bloodthirsty expression of his countless times, something felt different about him when we were in that crack in space .

Now you’re telling me that his passionate look was because he found his match, her?

Her?

Why is it always her?

Why did she have to destroy everything I had?

My heart seemed to be enshrouded in a heavy mist that just could not clear up, and I seemed to be viewing everyone as an enemy .

They all say that she is me, that she is my other personality . No matter how much I hate her, she's still me .

But I couldn't accept this .

But I couldn't accept this .

Even if she is me, she isn't who I want to be .

Maybe it's because she always gets the attention of others, and this just makes my cowardice and weakness all the more apparent .

How can someone who had always been unloved and ostracized suddenly turn into a strong person?

I've been trying my best to change, but why did she always have to interfere? I can never surpass her, I can never wield Piercer as well as she can .

You're so outstanding, while I'm just useless . Why can't you leave me alone?

"You look like you've given up all hope . Ah Shen, I'm not blind . I can see that layer of dust over your eyes and your heart . "

Jiao S kept her eyes on me . "I know you've changed because of Nie Zun . "

I sucked in a breath . Could you not say this name?

I have already waited three days for him . Three whole days without eating or sleeping .

How could you bear to see me upset?

Do you like her too? Didn't you always like her? Why did you have to leave then?

Isn't she out now?! Won't you take a look at her?

I tried to regulate my breathing in an attempt to calm my surging emotions .

A monster started to crawl out of my heart . Slowly, it was going to break out .

I'll always protect you .

I split my dry lips as I smiled . Tiny cracks appeared as I haven't had any water for a few days .

Forget that, Li Shen .

I turned to look at Jiao S . "Bring me to see Mi Fu, I want to persuade her to leave the Split Zone . "

Forget that, Li Shen .

I turned to look at Jiao S . "Bring me to see Mi Fu, I want to persuade her to leave the Split Zone . "

Jiao S nodded stiffly .

"Have you ever thought that I might stand on Gaoqin Jiuye's side and go against you?" Jiao S asked suddenly .

I was reminded of my conversation with Huan Qing . I told him that instead of having Si Luo stay alive through such a method, she might just want to accomplish what Si Luo wishes to complete .

Though I should have answered her like this, I tried to suppress my emotions and responded as coldly as I can . "It doesn't matter where you

stand . Even if all of you go against me, I'll still use every ounce of strength to stop Gaoqin Jiuye . ”

Jiao S did not look surprised at this . She simply looked at me calmly .

I was a little guilty as I met her gaze, and I pried my eyes away .

“Let's go, I'll bring you to her . ” Jiao S finally spoke .

I heaved an inward sigh of relief, and we continued walking to the next zone in the Residence .

“You guys are probably looking for me . ”

As we passed one block, a tiny figure ran out from behind a door .

I frowned as I looked at Mi Fu .

She was still in pink, and she had that arrogant look with a pair of rosy ears and sparkly eyes .

I smirked . “The little princess ran out on her own? Not afraid that Gaoqin Jiuye might kill you?”

“You!” Her cheeks puffed up in anger, as if she had a comeback . But before she could say anything, it seemed like she thought of something else, and decided to swallow her retort .

Looking at her, I crossed my arms . “What? You want my help with something?”

If she is looking for me on her own, it must be to get help . Her face immediately reddened as I hit the nail on the head .

Chapter 132

132 I'm No Saint

“I have something to tell her, could you let us speak in private for a moment?” Mi Fu turned to Jiao S, giving her a cold look .

Jiao S did not budge even an inch .

“No,” she said hoarsely . Mi Fu’s face turned even redder at this .

“What’s up with you guys . I know you hate me for being stubborn and arrogant, but I hate you guys too!” Mi Fu pointed an angry finger at me and Jiao S .

“I know I’m stubborn, but so what! Once I like someone, I’ll keep liking that one person forever! Can you do it? Hey, Li Shen, where’s your Nie Zun? Why isn’t he by your side? I’m stubborn but I’m not afraid of loving someone! It’s obvious that you like Nie Zun, but you just don’t dare admit it . He used those monstrous hands of his to strangle me that time, all for you!”

Mi Fu even used her hands to reenact the scene, as if to recall that horrible memory .

“Are you going to abandon Nie Zun who could turn into someone so scary all because he wanted to protect you?” She said angrily, as if she could not stand seeing anyone give up on love .

Mi Fu, must I be like you who can charge forward bravely and not give up on your love? You don’t carry any burden because others are carrying that burden for you!

But why was I speechless when faced with these accusations of hers?

Jiao S scoffed, “You’re really brave huh . Do you even know the price Huan Qing paid to protect this love of yours?”

I looked at Jiao S, signaling for her to stop .

Although I did not look kindly upon Mi Fu, I remember Huan Qing telling me that she was not aware of what he did, and he did not want me revealing anything to her . Even though I did not like Mi Fu, I respected Huan Qing’s wishes .

Mi Fu’s arrogant expression turned slightly gloomy as Huan Qing was mentioned .

I looked at her, wondering to myself if this little girl suspected anything .

“This is why I’m looking for you guys,” Mi Fu said in a lowered pitch . It was not as grating on the ears as before .

“Although I don’t understand all that’s happening, I know Gaoqin Jiuye was trying to take my life, but I don’t know why he wanted to do such a thing . Huan Qing Gege and Ku Fei Gege don’t tell me anything, they simply tell me not to be scared and not to worry, but I’m not an idiot . There has to be something going on here . ” Mi Fu’s expression darkened .

I sighed inwardly . Though she had always been under the protection of others and kept in the dark about this, what did she do wrong? She’s just a victim who didn’t even know the truth .

“Although I don’t know the truth of the matter, I know that these things likely happened because of me . I hope you can tell me the truth . ” Mi Fu looked up at me .

Before I could speak, Jiao S replied, “You’re only asking now? Don’t you think that’s too pretentious of you?”

Mi Fu gritted her teeth, but she did not argue . “You guys will never understand how I feel . To you, I might just be a scaredy-cat who knows

only to hide and be protected . Do you think I'm happy about this?
Everyone is keeping things from me, and I can only pretend to be happy
because I don't want them to worry . Do you think I'm happy when I don't
know the truth and I can't do anything to help?"

I was silent . What she said made sense .

It was as if the world was always on the side of the protectors, and if those
being protected were not grateful, they would simply be abandoned .

I like bananas, but you gave me an apple, and I don't actually want it .

But you continue giving them to me .

But you continue giving them to me .

To the point that others can no longer stand it, and start saying that I am
ungrateful .

But I simply like bananas .

Sometimes, the ones being protected might not be having an easy time
either .

There are just too many rules in this world . You have yours and I have
mine . It is difficult to reach a consensus and to be truly fair .

"I agree with you on this, but have you ever thought that even if you're not
having an easy time, this is life? You have a right to pursue love, just like
what you said to Li Shen, you feel that she doesn't love Nie Zun enough
and cannot be like you, but have you ever thought of things from her angle?
You're definitely steadfast in your pursuit of love, but have you ever
wondered if your perseverance had hurt others?" Jiao S sounded like she
was preaching .

I was more and more impressed by Jiao S . I had never expected that this
woman, whom I initially thought was a crazed murderer, would actually be
my soulmate in the Split Zone, someone who knows my thoughts and
understands me .

Even the unreasonable Mi Fu was at a loss for words .

Jiao S cracked her neck, and her gaze was unfathomable . “I used to be like you . I thought love was to chase after something, to have it for myself . But in reality, there’s a price to pay for the wrong kind of love . ”

A moment of hesitation flashed past Mi Fu’s eyes, but she regained her steadfast look very quickly . “Even if you’re right, I’m not going to give up on Ku Fei Gege . Up until now, the happiest moments of my life have all been spent with him . I have a feeling that if I miss him this time, there would be nobody else who can give me such happiness . Sometimes, there’s only one person in the entire world who can give you such happiness, and you won’t even want take a second look at others . No matter what price I have to pay, I will not leave Ku Fei Gege . ”

“Why are you so cruel to him then?” I recalled the first time I saw her, when she was torturing Ku Fei without hesitation .

She tilted her chin arrogantly as she looked up, and there was a hint of pain in her eyes . “I want him to remember me, I want to be involved in every moment of his life . He might just run away if I’m not careful . ”

I nodded . “Since you like him so much and have decided to follow him, why have you come to us asking about this? You have to make a choice . Your fate might change if you learn about certain things, but you might also lose that steadfast attitude towards your love . How would you choose if they were in conflict?”

I nodded . “Since you like him so much and have decided to follow him, why have you come to us asking about this? You have to make a choice . Your fate might change if you learn about certain things, but you might also lose that steadfast attitude towards your love . How would you choose if they were in conflict?”

Mi Fu looked slightly distressed . “I’ve thought about this for a long time . If they’ve put so much effort in keeping this from me, they must have had sacrificed some things . ”

“What if Ku Fei isn’t affected by this?” I asked abruptly .

Mi Fu’s eyes sparkled . “Really? Whatever they’re keeping from me won’t hurt Ku Fei Gege, right? Ku Fei Gege won’t get hurt because of me, right?”

“Yes . ” I nodded, keeping my eyes on her, observing her expressions .

She looked worried at first, but relaxed once she heard that this would not hurt Ku Fei . However, as she thought of how it could possibly hurt another person, she had that worried look again, as if she was in a dilemma .

In a dilemma .

She was in a dilemma, she was hesitating .

I looked at her without blinking, not wanting to miss any of her expressions . I was curious how such a pampered little girl would make her decision .

“Do you still want to know the truth?” I asked .

Mi Fu wrung her hands in front of her pink dress, looking distressed .

Since she was kept in the dark even if it did not hurt Ku Fei, this meant that it would hurt Huan Qing, but she did not know how much Huan Qing did for her .

She wants to know the truth, but at the same time, she is afraid that her feelings for Ku Fei might be shaken after hearing it .

Logically, I should have tried to lead her towards considering Huan Qing’s position if I wanted Huan Qing to take her away, for her to leave the Split Zone .

She wants to know the truth, but at the same time, she is afraid that her feelings for Ku Fei might be shaken after hearing it .

Logically, I should have tried to lead her towards considering Huan Qing’s position if I wanted Huan Qing to take her away, for her to leave the Split Zone .

For some reason, I did not do that . Instead, I could see how determined she was in her love towards Ku Fei .

Was this because I hoped for someone else to accomplish what I was never able to do?

Even if I wanted her to leave, there were still other methods available . I could respect her decision on this .

As expected, after thinking for a long time, she looked at me resolutely . “It’s fine, I don’t need to know the truth anymore . I don’t think you guys were prepared to reveal anything anyway . Sorry for the trouble . Just do what you guys want . I’ll trust in Huan Qing Gege and Ku Fei Gege . ”

On the surface, she is acting as if she is unwilling to listen to us and does not trust us, but in fact, she understood what I meant, and she feels guilty for it . She was consoling herself by telling herself that everything is fine as long as it does not harm Ku Fei .

She looked at Jiao S and I once more with complex emotions in her eyes, before running away .

“Is it good for you to do this? Didn’t you want her to leave the Split Zone? Now, she’s even more committed in her decision,” Jiao S asked .

I smiled, and looked in the direction of where Mi Fu went .

After a while, my smile faded . “Even if I told her the truth, I’m afraid that she might not choose to leave Ku Fei for Huan Qing’s sake . She looked like she was in a dilemma, and this proves that she might waver after knowing the truth . However, if I tried to steer her in the direction of selfishly choosing love, she’d have to face Huan Qing with a guilty conscience . Infatuation will fade, but love can grow over time . While she’s feeling guilty, I’ll be looking for a suitable juncture to reveal the truth . At that point, she’ll definitely choose to leave with Huan Qing . ”

Jiao S looked rather surprised at this . “Seems like the serious Li Shen is definitely no saint...”

I gave her a wry smile .

Saint? There's no word that describes me as inaccurately as this . I'm a devil .

Chapter 133

133 Hitting the Nail on the Head

Jiao S and I made our way to the Academy after Mi Fu left .

Si Luo and Gaoqin Jiuye have been staying in the same room in this period of time . It's no wonder Guan Nie left . I could almost imagine that heartbroken expression on his pretty face .

But there is nothing to be done about it . This was Gaoqin Jiuye's choice .

Just like how I was infatuated with Gao Qi, it was something uncontrollable that could not be altered .

Jiao S seemed to look slightly nervous as we were about to knock on the door . I guess she was like this as we were going to see Si Luo . It looked like she had not met Si Luo on her own while I was still on the rooftop . If she did, it would not have been often . I wonder if she felt better with my company .

I pushed the door open after I heard Si Luo's clear voice, "Come in . "

As the rooms in the Split Zone were all designed in the same way, I naturally looked towards the bunk beds beside the window . Si Luo was seated on the bottom bunk . And Gaoqin Jiuye...

I looked around and finally saw him near the wall, opposite Si Luo .

He was leaning casually against the wall . That arrogance of his probably prevented him from asking Jie Pa for some clean clothes, because his bright yellow sneakers were still stained with dirt and blood .

He looked distant, shifting his gaze from Si Luo to me . I immediately thought of Nie Zun as I looked at that lonely figure against the wall .

Has Nie Zun always been like this, standing in front of me like a protector and keeping me company in the Split Zone?

Why did I not notice it all this while? My heart hurt at this thought .

Why did you have to leave if you had kept me company for such a long time? Was it because I always ignored you and you finally couldn't stand it? Or was it like they said, you got injured, but did you have to leave because of that? Don't you trust me?

“Does the Western District Commander love daydreaming so much that you can do it anywhere regardless of time and place?” Gaoqin Jiuye raised his brows, looking at me sharply .

My brows furrowed slightly . Is he still holding a grudge against me?

But why did he have to hate me? Firstly, Si Luo isn't dead, and secondly, I'm sure Jie Pa would have treated them well as guests here . The ones who hurt my Western District residents and Nie Zun were them, so what did he have to hold a grudge against?

Moreover, he's the soul splitter who captured me . Now that he's revealed himself, I should be the one holding a grudge against him . Why is he getting angry first?

“I'm afraid no one would be in the mood for anything once they meet a party-pooper like you,” I said sarcastically . Gaoqin Jiuye did not respond .

I looked at Si Luo, not bothering to continue the conversation .

Si Luo's silvery-white eyes were glowing faintly, and he looked like he was being enshrouded in soft, white light in his white robes .

“Seems like you've recovered well . ” I smiled at him, seeing how he looked much better than before .

He nodded . “Yes, I didn’t expect it either . I wonder if it’s the air here in the Western District, I’ve been recovering really well these few days . ”

He nodded . “Yes, I didn’t expect it either . I wonder if it’s the air here in the Western District, I’ve been recovering really well these few days . ”

“Does this mean there’s no longer any need for Mr Gaoqin Jiuye here to chase after me and make an attempt on Mi Fu’s life?” Gaoqin Jiuye’s pompous look was at the back of my mind, and I had to take a stab at him whenever I said something .

Si Luo smiled elegantly . “If I’m healthy, then that wouldn’t be needed . Even if my condition worsens, I’ll guarantee you they’ll stop troubling you, how’s that?”

Si Luo was actually willing to compromise on this .

Gaoqin Jiuye was not as understanding as Si Luo on this, and he spoke, “Don’t even think about that . If your condition worsens, whether it’s that little girl’s life or her life, I’ll personally take them!”

He shot a cold look at me as he said ‘her life’ . Anger welled up in me . Did I offend you?!

Looking at this, although Gaoqin Jiuye is loyal to Si Luo, he might not listen to everything Si Luo says . As long as he thinks something is beneficial to Si Luo, it looks like even Si Luo cannot stop him from doing what he wants to .

Si Luo turned serious, but that beautiful face of his made every kind of expression look good .

“Gaoqin, I’ll tell you seriously . You know I’ve promised Mi Fu’s older brother to take care of Mi Fu and keep her safe . This is the reason why I’ve made her the Southern District’s goddess, so that everyone has to respect and protect her . Have you forgotten?”

Si Luo and Guan Nie both seem to address Gaoqin Jiuye as Gaoqin .

Gaoqin Jiuye's eyes turned gentle as he looked at Si Luo . "I know, and I've also made a promise to you . But you know me, how could I simply look on and do nothing when your life is on tenterhooks? If Huan Qing isn't able to find a new body of consciousness, I'll definitely be taking that girl . "

Si Luo sighed softly, his silvery-white eyes shining .

Si Luo sighed softly, his silvery-white eyes shining .

"Huan Qing and I will definitely find a new body of consciousness . " Jiao S spoke her first words since entering the room .

I was sure that those two, like me, could hear constrain and nervousness in her voice, which was a rare thing .

Her voice was already hoarse and low-pitched . Now that she is trying to sound calm, she was trying to keep her pitch steady throughout, and this made it sound even stiffer than it usually was .

I glanced at her . She was still, not moving an inch, but her trembling gaze revealed her nervousness .

I sighed inwardly . There was always something that could beat you in this world . I never expected Jiao S to be this nervous .

"Huh, why should I believe you? Just because you're never going to give up on your love for Si Luo?" Gaoqin Jiuye smirked .

This hurt, and Jiao S eyes wavered . Si Luo's eyes shone with a dim light, as if it was a shallow lake, but mysterious at the same time .

I could not stand Gaoqin Jiuye's conceited attitude . If you can stay beside Si Luo like this, why can't we persevere in our own beliefs?

I scoffed . "Aren't you also sticking to Si Luo all the time? At least Jiao S would never do anything that Si Luo doesn't wish for . You, on the other hand, want to go against his wishes and take the life of Mi Fu, putting him in a position where people would look down upon . Do you think that's very noble of you?"

Gaoqin Jiuye shot me a cold look . “So what? Looked down upon by others? Li Shen, you think you’re still living in your world? This is Split Zone 13 where the strong survive . May I ask who would dare to look down upon Si Luo? Who can look down on him?”

My lips twitched in a smirk . “Oh yes, I almost forgot you guys are soul splitters and different from us . You’ve always seen these dirty sins and dealings as noble acts, or why else would you guys capture us?”

Instead of arguing, Gaoqin Jiuye remained silent, and pain flashed through his eyes .

My lips twitched in a smirk . “Oh yes, I almost forgot you guys are soul splitters and different from us . You’ve always seen these dirty sins and dealings as noble acts, or why else would you guys capture us?”

Instead of arguing, Gaoqin Jiuye remained silent, and pain flashed through his eyes .

Si Luo smiled widely . “Seems like you have a deep misunderstanding of soul splitters, but that’s understandable . From what I know, it’s also survival of the fittest in your world, and it’s common for people to backstab others . In the Split Zone however, these deeds are brought above the table . Do you prefer a world that is steeped in fake kindness, or this city that is openly full of sin?”

He changed the subject from what Jiao S said about finding a way to save him as he spoke, effectively turning it into a conversation with me . But I noticed the quick look he gave Jiao S .

Pale moonlight shone from those silvery-white eyes of his, and I was able to witness that quick glance he gave Jiao S . I wonder what Jiao S is to him . It was probably not easy to walk into the heart of this perfect person .

Just like how I felt Gao Qi was perfect when I was alive .

Thinking about it that way, I could understand much of how Jiao S was feeling .

“It doesn’t matter if I like it or not . I’m not courting death, so I’ll be trying my best to stay alive . You naturally can’t choose your plane of existence when you’re alive, so it doesn’t matter if I like it or not . Just like how we were forcefully captured here, you guys have never asked for our opinions when you did all that, so what’s the point of asking now?” I raised my brows in sarcasm .

Si Luo’s gaze was inscrutable . “You seem different after activating your split symbol . You seem fiercer, more hostile . Though this should be a good thing, but it’s a little too much, and you look like you won’t care even if you got hurt in the process . If I’m right, I’m guessing this has something to do with that monster in your heart . Just what triggered that monster to break away from its restraints? Was it Nie Zun?”

He hit the nail on the head, and it was a clean stab to my heart with every single word he said . Are you saying this because you looked into my heart? Or could you see that monster which would sometimes appear beside me?

If you can’t, don’t talk about it like you know how I feel . We’re both lonely people, just like you and Gaoqin Jiuye, Jiao S and Nie Zun . Since everyone is the same, why do we doubt one another like that?

We always put up our defences when someone tries to pry .

I gave him an icy look . “There’s no need for the Southern District Commander to worry about such issues . You should instead be thinking about how to save your own life . ”

Chapter 134

134 You Love Him That Deeply?

“What’s there to think about? You hand Mi Fu over, I let Si Luo engrave a split symbol on her, and the problem’s solved,” Gaoqin Jiuye said with a sharp glance .

Si Luo waved an elegant hand . “Li Shen, do you think that Jiao S and Huan Qing will be able to find new bodies of consciousness, or do you think you’re able to find another way to save me?”

This question was unusual .

How would I know other methods to save you? I don’t even know what’s going on with you soul splitters here in the Split Zone .

I smiled casually . “Si Luo, I think the issue lies with whether you want to be saved by us, and not whether we can find a way to save you . If you wish for death, how can I save you? It’s just like what you said to me when you peeked into my heart, ‘No one can save him if he’s already dead in your heart’ . There’s nothing we can do if you want death, but your loyal Gaoqin would end up pinning the blame on me . Wouldn’t I be so wronged then?”

What I said seemed to cause both Jiao S and Gaoqin Jiuye to look towards Si Luo for an answer . Gaoqin Jiuye’s eyes seemed to burn with a dim fire, as if he wanted Si Luo to deny it .

Si Luo was silent for a moment, before breaking into a warm smile . “Li Qing really had good foresight . ”

“You’ve already said this,” I spoke calmly .

“How about this . Let me speak with you in private, and you can make a decision after that . ” Jiao S spoke abruptly, as if she finally found the courage to voice her opinion .

“Don’t even think of coming close to him . ” Gaoqin Jiuye stepped forward, showing clearly that he will intervene if we even dare take half a step forward .

Si Luo looked at him gently . “Gaoqin, let me speak with her . ”

“Si Luo, you...” Gaoqin Jiuye looked at Si Luo with a complex emotion in his eyes, and after a quick pause, he slowly retreated to where he was before .

Haha, in this world, Si Luo was probably the only one who could get Gaoqin Jiuye to come to a compromise .

Si Luo, who was originally lazing against the bed, suddenly flew towards Jiao S . His movement was so quick that I could only see a flurry of white go pass .

I was stunned . Was this the ability of the person with the highest MF in the Split Zone? Seems like he has recovered really well...

His floating robes enshrouded him like a piece of painting, and his silver hair fell across his neck as he looked down, right in front of Jiao S . As he was only inches away from her, his long hair seemed to entangle with Jiao S’s black hair when he moved .

It was obvious Jiao S did not expect him to do this, and I did not expect it either .

Jiao S looked dumbfounded, and also a little surprised .

Her emotionless face seemed to light up in an instant, as if she was suddenly alive . It was like a sleeping princess being awoken by a kiss from her prince .

I kept looking at the both of them .

Si Luo was really beautiful . No mortal could compare to such beauty, which also carried with it a hint of nobility .

Although the dubious and emotionless Jiao S was not usually described as someone beautiful, she always had a unique aura about her . Her black hair framed those huge, black eyes of hers, and though she looked like a young girl, she had that domineering air when leading the S Clan, a kind of queenly aura .

Right now, there was slight surprise and bashfulness on her emotionless face . This was an eye-opener for me . Yes, that was the word, eye-opener!

The contrast between the two was great . Their auras were totally different, but this scene made it difficult for me to tear my eyes away from the both of them .

I happened to catch a glimpse of Gaoqin Jiuye, and he had this dark, worried expression as he looked at the two of them .

Si Luo kept his noble and gentle gaze on Jiao S, saying in his melodic voice, “You’re still the same as last time . ”

Si Luo kept his noble and gentle gaze on Jiao S, saying in his melodic voice, “You’re still the same as last time . ”

...

That’s weird having to hear him say this to her!

Joy blossomed in me . This proves that Si Luo had been thinking of her .

My heart softened . I believe that Jiao S would feel happy at this, after having suppressed that loneliness for so long . I was really happy for her .

To prevent anyone else from being the gooseberry, I walked over to Gaoqin Jiuye and grabbed his hand . “Let’s go . Since your District Commander has spoken, why not we give them some time to themselves? You don’t actually think that Jiao S would actually hurt him, do you?”

Gaoqin Jiuye was visibly shocked at my sudden actions, and he seemed to be momentarily frozen . I made use of this instant to pull him out of the room .

“We’ll wait in the room beside . ” After speaking, I dragged Gaoqin Jiuye out, and closed the door after me as we entered the adjacent room .

Behind me, I heard Gaoqin Jiuye scoff . “So much effort to spend alone time with me? What, are you going to mistake me for Gao Qi again?”

I turned back and stared at him . “Gaoqin Jiuye, I don’t understand what’s up with your current attitude towards me . If I remember right, you pretended not to know me the very first time we met . Fine, that I understand if you might not want me to go any closer and realize you were a soul splitter . But why weren’t you cold all the time? I’m not blind, so don’t pretend . There was a time when you treated me like a friend, so why are you so against that?”

“Huh, friend? I never have friends . ” It was as if he just heard a joke, his eyes full of self-mockery .

I kept my eyes on him . “Si Luo used a technique on me, I don’t know what, but it backfired on him and I was able to witness the scene where the both of you met . ”

I saw Gaoqin Jiuye’s eyes tremble . “What did you say?”

I held his gaze . “It’s true . It was probably this that caused his condition to worsen at the time, and you appeared after he passed out . In his dream, I seemed to have seen the younger you beside a small river, and it looked like your first meeting with him...”

I held his gaze . “It’s true . It was probably this that caused his condition to worsen at the time, and you appeared after he passed out . In his dream, I seemed to have seen the younger you beside a small river, and it looked like your first meeting with him...”

Before I could finish, Gaoqin Jiuye pushed me back against the door with his hands!

Boom! He was not gentle about it!

His eyes were on fire and it felt dangerous . He pressed on my shoulders with greater force as he asked, “What else did you see, huh? Li Shen?”

I was perturbed by this sudden outburst, but I regained my composure quickly . After calming myself down, I looked at him squarely, “What you afraid of me seeing? That you were originally also a lonely person who was ostracized? That you were cowardly and full of self-loathing when you were younger?”

Gaoqin Jiuye did not get angry like I thought he would . Instead, he simply let out a sigh . “So you only saw me at that age . ”

I don’t understand . Apart from those memories from your younger days, what else were you afraid of me seeing?

I tried to pry . “There was actually another person around...”

Gaoqin Jiuye turned anxious again . “Was it a he or a she?”

What?

The suspicion in me grew . Just who was he talking about? Seems like I knew these people as well? Wait, a girl... Yes, wasn’t he always a little weird with that Du Yue?

I looked away as I answered as surely as I could, “Du Yue . ”

Gaoqin Jiuye was stunned at first, but said, “That’s not possible . ”

He looked pained . “How could you have seen her in Si Luo’s heart . Are you trying to test me? Li Shen, I suggest you tell the truth . ”

As he said this, his head moved closer to my face . He still looked cold, but in the moment when he approached me, I thought I saw a hint of gentleness

there .

He looked pained . “How could you have seen her in Si Luo’s heart . Are you trying to test me? Li Shen, I suggest you tell the truth . ”

As he said this, his head moved closer to my face . He still looked cold, but in the moment when he approached me, I thought I saw a hint of gentleness there .

Upon a second look, he still looked cold . When has Gaoqin Jiuye ever been warm .

I have never seen any warmth in his expressions, there was only complex emotions, pain and sadness even when others talk about Du Yue, who seemed to have a great influence on him, or about Guan Nie, who gave so much for him .

It was only when he faced Si Luo would there be any trace of warmth .

For some reason I was rather irritated, and I looked at him coldly . “Why should I tell you? What are you afraid of? You don’t have to worry, I’m not interested in your life at all . Your past, who you’ve met, I don’t care . ”

Gaoqin Jiuye looked rather stunned, and his eyes seemed lit with firelight . “You really don’t care about my past, who I’ve met, and everything else about me? Even if I might have some connection to the lover you killed?”

His hands were still on my shoulders, and his face was about to touch mine .

My heart ached immediately .

“What did you say?” I stared at him with wide eyes .

His lips were right in front of my nose, as if it could come into contact with my nose anytime . He smiled sarcastically . “What, finally interested in me now? Because of him? You love him so much that you’ll continue loving him even after you’ve killed him? You still love him after you killed him? You still love him even after he’s dead?”

He asked all this at one go . I was not seeing things this time, I was sure there was some wildness and passion in his voice and in his gaze .

For some reason, I did not really dare to answer ‘Yes, I just love him’ . I thus avoided his eyes and his questions .

He grabbed my chin with a hand, forcing me to look at him .

“Say it, Li Shen . You love him that deeply? Why is that so?”

Chapter 135

135 A Slap and A Call

The air was heavy with our breaths, and his eyes were like a strong fire ready to burn me to ashes at a moment's notice .

My emotions felt like it was a wild beast breaking out from my chest .

“You love him this deeply...” Gaoqin Jiuye repeated in a lower voice, and I felt his lips trembling slightly .

I did not know how I should answer, and I started avoiding his gaze, afraid to look directly at him .

“Li Shen, I’ll help you out . ” Gaoqin Jiuye grabbed my hand, and moved it towards my chest!

“What’re you doing!” I asked angrily .

An evil smile appeared on his face . “Where do you wish to go . ”

I then realized he forced me to hold my splitting key in my hand!

He moved even closer, keeping his wild eyes on me . “I’m giving you a chance now . Quick, put it into my split symbol and you can leave this place!”

I did not expect him to say this, and I was dumbstruck .

“Why? Don’t you always have something to say? You’re going to back away this time?” There was a wild mischief in Gaoqin Jiuye’s eyes, and his smile looked like a challenge .

For a moment I was stunned, but I calmed myself down and smiled back at him . “Gaoqin Jiuye, I do want to go back, but not now . I have a friend to save, and I have to uncover the secrets of you soul splitters . How can I leave when I haven’t done any of these?”

“Li Shen, you’ll die if you keep being this naïve . The Split Zone didn’t exist for a mere day or two now, and it’s not as simple as you think it is . Just by your own ability, it might be possible to save your friend, but I’d suggest you give up in accomplishing anything else, like going against the soul splitters . ”

I smirked . “What, you’re trying to convince me now? You want me to leave this place? Aren’t you afraid of dying? Since you were the one who captured me, why are you pretending to be the nice guy now?”

Gaoqin Jiuye’s expression stiffened .

“That’s right . Just this once, I’m not afraid of dying as long as you leave the Split Zone, right now . ” It looked as if he made a certain decision in that moment, and he said it in a low and serious tone .

I did not like it that I always seemed to be in a daze in front of him, but I was stunned once again .

We looked at each other for a long time .

“Gaoqin Jiuye... You’re really stubborn... What do you mean by this? Just what do you want me to do?” There was a slight trembling in my voice .

“Gaoqin Jiuye, I was captured here by you, not by anyone else, but you! After capturing me, you even pretended not to know me when you saw me here . Wasn’t that because you didn’t want me to find you, so that I wouldn’t be able to go back? Didn’t you only care about Si Luo? What are you trying to do now, trying to get me to go back, releasing me even though you might suffer the same fate as Si Luo if you don’t manage to find another body of consciousness? I might not think much of it if it was anybody else, but you’re Gaoqin Jiuye, when have you ever had sympathy for me?”

I felt a little bitter, and this was not what I wanted to say originally .

“Do you actually have some compassion?” I asked softly .

A flash of helplessness passed in Gaoqin Jiuye’s eyes . “Yes, that’s right . I was the one who brought you here . Compared to how you were living in that world, isn’t it better here?”

My heart was about to burst .

What do you mean by how I was living in that world?

“You... you’ve been...” I looked at him in a daze .

“Yes, I know everything about you . ” Something colorful flashed in Gaoqin Jiuye’s eyes, making me feel faint .

“What do you mean!” I was getting agitated . People in the Split Zone seem to have so many secrets and always talk in circles! From the moment Li Qing was gone, to the disappearance of Mr Blond, to the appearance of soul splitters and the experiment which took my friends away, all of it were just too torturous!

I wriggled out from his hands and stared at him .

“I can’t explain it in any clearer way . The truth is I’m very aware of your life in that world, and because I knew how painful it was for you, I brought you here after you killed him . Li Shen, I saved you!” Gaoqin Jiuye smiled cruelly .

My eyes widened slowly .

“You, you actually!” My eyes grew wet with tears, and I grabbed hold of his collar .

“You, you actually!” My eyes grew wet with tears, and I grabbed hold of his collar .

“Since you could see everything, why did you still let me kill him? Why didn’t you stop me before I killed him!” I asked with gritted teeth as I looked at him through tearful eyes .

Gaoqin Jiuye gave a ruthless smile . “Why should I do that? What has it got to do with me if he lives or dies? At least you could be of some use to me after I engrave a split symbol on you, but what use did Gao Qi have?”

Smack!

I gave him a hard slap!

Gaoqin Jiuye’s face tilted from my slap, his dark brown hair moving .

My hand was trembling slightly, but it was my heart that was shivering .

Nothing but our heartbeats could be heard in the quiet room .

I still had not gotten the hang of manipulating my MF after my split symbol was activated, and I was not able to control my strength well . Blood appeared on the corner of his lips .

My heart ached, and my slightly quivering lips revealed how much I regretted it .

But I could not forgive anyone who spoke badly of Gao Qi . I might seem idiotic to others, but what is true love if it isn’t ugly and stupid?

I admit that my infatuation for Gao Qi had blinded me, but love just cannot be controlled .

Right now, it wasn’t only what he said that pained me, it hurt to know that he was putting himself down like that . Why did he want to let everyone think that he was such a cruel person?

“You... You’re not someone like that... I know that...” My tears flowed out .

He was initially angry when I slapped him, but he looked frozen after hearing me say that .

He turned back at me, a red stain still on the corner of his lips . He looked at me with unfathomable eyes .

Since I've already said it, I'll finish it .

Since I've already said it, I'll finish it .

“I know it... You're not such a person...” Tears continued falling from my eyes .

I could not decipher Gaoqin Jiuye's expression . After a while, he spoke .

“Li Shen, don't regret this . I've given you a chance to leave and you didn't take it . From now on, don't even think about being able to leave the Split Zone . You can stay here and continue your fight forever . ” Gaoqin Jiuye's eyes were like whirlpools, making me feel lost in them .

Why did this sound like ‘You can stay here and continue being with me forever’?

No, what was I thinking?!

Shaking my head, I pushed him away, increasing the distance between us .

I felt a little dizzy as I pushed him away .

In my daze, I seem to catch a glimpse of a black shadow passing by the window .

My heart dropped!

Was it him! Is it him?!

I rushed to the window and pulled open the curtains, looking out .

It was the third floor, and there was no one familiar around .

I felt a little sad, did my eyes fool me?

“Hehe, he ran away . Is it because he saw you acting so close with Gaoqin Jiuye? Even if he wanted to come back to you, he might have decided to leave in the end...”

I heard a familiar voice, and I felt wet lips on my ear!

Shivering, my hairs stood on ends, and I immediately jumped away!

As I moved away, I saw her floating in mid-air . It was her lips which were on my ear!

Shivering, my hairs stood on ends, and I immediately jumped away!

As I moved away, I saw her floating in mid-air . It was her lips which were on my ear!

This was the first time she spoke after the ‘How are you’ since I woke up!

She was in an unusual position in the air, looking at me with those lazy eyes and an expression which looked like a half-smile .

“Ah—!” I did not know why I screamed either . It was as if only by screaming can I find some relief in the helplessness I felt whenever I see her!

“What’re you doing, Li Shen?!” Gaoqin Jiuye was obviously confused by me suddenly running to the window and screaming . He rushed over and hugged me from behind .

I stiffened, and the body behind me did the same .

He probably did not expect he would hug me either . He let go, and my emotions calmed down because of his sudden movement .

But she did not let me go . She covered her smile with a hand . “Hehe, Li Shen, you fell in love with someone like him again? Do you need my help again...”

“Ah—! Shut up!” I shouted, covering my ears .

Her red dress was flying, and she floated out from the window . She gave me another mocking smile as she left .

“Devil... Devil...” I pressed my trembling hands against my ears . I never wanted to see her again!

Gaoqin Jiuye had let go of me, but he grabbed me again, though not as tightly as before .

“What’s happening to you?” He frowned, a rare look of worry in his eyes .

However, I did not feel any warmth from this . It just made me miss those eyes even more .

The most beautiful pair of eyes in this world .

“Nie... Nie Zun...” I kept mumbling with quivering lips .

Chapter 136

136 Reopening Old Wounds?

With hands on ears, I squatted slowly as I continued mumbling . Gaoqin Jiuye stepped in front of me, pulling me up in a huff!

“Come on, Li Shen, if you have the guts to slap me, you shouldn’t be crying here now! Slap me again if you dare . In the Split Zone, apart from you, I swear there won’t be anyone else who dared hit my face!” He pulled me up, forcing me not to cover my ears .

Looking at his frenzied face, I slowly calmed down .

Suppressing the pain in my heart, I told myself, Li Shen, you have to be strong . You were living well even without Nie Zun in a previous life . It has just been a year of sticking together . Even if this suddenly disappeared, you’ll get used to it . You have to be strong .

Li Shen, you can’t cry . She’s back now, are you going to continue being that cowardly? You can’t let her have opportunities to take control of your body and do whatever she wanted to anymore .

Li Shen, didn’t you decide to be strong and not let her get her way? You’re not letting the soul splitters get their way and you’re not letting the Split Zone get its way!

I forcefully suppressed my emotions . I took a deep breath and slowly looked up, trying my best to look at Gaoqin Jiuye with steady eyes . “Do you want to return the slap? If you don’t do it now, there won’t be any more chances in future!”

Gaoqin Jiuye looked visibly relaxed as I said this . It was as if he would be willing to look at this icy face of mine as long as I was not that weak, cowardly cry-baby .

He smirked . “I’m really generous . I’ll treat this slap as a gift for you . ”

I brushed my red hair back, and my gaze turned cold . “Since you’re not returning the slap, let’s talk about something serious . ”

Gaoqin Jiuye straightened up and looked at me with a cold smile . “That’s really some identity disorder there, changing in just a second . ”

I raised my brows . “Thank you for the compliment . ”

Though my heart was hurting, who else would save me if I don’t save myself?

“What did you want to discuss?” Gaoqin Jiuye shrugged .

I stared at him . “Two things . First, if I remember correctly, you know Zou An . Jie Pa’s men couldn’t find him, and I want you to help me find him . Second, I want to save my friends . If there are things you know about Du Yue, I hope you can share them with me . Since you can’t stop me from doing these things, why not just help me out . ”

Gaoqin Jiuye’s eyes darkened . “Oh? Why should I help you?”

I smiled casually . “Of course, there would be conditions . Though I’ve been daydreaming a lot the past few days, and I don’t quite remember what happened after the fight that day, I do remember some things .

“If I’m right, even you guys don’t know why Si Luo’s condition miraculously improved after I activated my split symbol, and you’ve witnessed it too, that he’s been recovering well these few days he’s here . Though none of us know why, I’m sure you’re also suspecting that this has something to do with the Western District .

“I might not be able to promise that I can find a way to save Si Luo, but I can at least promise to keep him safe . As for you, you don’t have to do

anything but tell me a little more about Du Yue and Zou An, and also don't interfere in what I do . ”

“Si Luo's condition has improved, but how would I know if his condition will not deteriorate? Unless you can promise me that you'll hand Mi Fu over right away if there're any changes to his condition!” Gaoqin Jiuye's eyes shone .

I could never agree to this, but I had to at this moment .

I could never agree to this, but I had to at this moment .

To Gaoqin Jiuye, I might not be someone who goes back on my word, but it's just too bad that women are like villains, we're unpredictable .

I pretended to nod in a serious fashion . “Okay, I trust Jiao S and Huan Qing, and I trust in my own abilities . If anything goes wrong, I'll not stop you from looking for Mi Fu . That okay with you?”

Suspicion hung in Gaoqin Jiuye's eyes, but after seeming to consider that Si Luo was fine these few days, he probably thought this was not a bad deal .

He then asked, “You're looking for Zou An because of Piercer?”

I took Piercer in my hand to let him have a look . “Have you noticed that the original purple skin is slowly turning red, as if it absorbs the blood from every battle? I can't wield Piercer very well now since I couldn't control it, but it's difficult for me to save my friends if I didn't have a living weapon with me . I need to find him to look for a way to solve this issue . ”

Gaoqin Jiuye looked at Piercer . “So it's really because of Piercer . I've told you before, that this isn't a weapon you can use . I asked you to return it to Zou An, but you just didn't listen . ”

“Yes, I should've suspected you when you told me about Piercer's story when we were in that crack in space . You seemed to be familiar with soul splitters and Cang Ming, and you could even rival him . I should've guessed that you were a soul splitter then . ”

I smirked . “But there’s no use saying all this now . Since I’ve used it, I’m not giving up . It’s difficult for the owner if the weapon doesn’t listen . I must find a way to subdue it . ”

“It might not be as easy as you think it is . ” Gaoqin Jiuye looked at me .

“I know that, that’s why I’m looking for you . Since you could save Zou An and his wife from Cang Ming, if there’s anybody in the Split Zone who knows his whereabouts, it would be you . Also, from what you said about the living weapons, you seem to know some things about Piercer too . You can either tell me how to solve this problem, or tell me how to find Zou An . ”

Gaoqin Jiuye shook his head . “I don’t understand Piercer that well, I just know that it was created with the full skin of a soul belonging to a female . I happened to witness the scene when Piercer had an outburst, so I know how much damage it can cause . Apart from that, I don’t know how to solve this problem of yours .

Gaoqin Jiuye shook his head . “I don’t understand Piercer that well, I just know that it was created with the full skin of a soul belonging to a female . I happened to witness the scene when Piercer had an outburst, so I know how much damage it can cause . Apart from that, I don’t know how to solve this problem of yours .

“As for Zou An, I can definitely find him . But you need to be sure about this, since both of you aren’t on friendly terms . He thinks that you caused Ah Wen’s death even though I’ve looked into it and explained it to him, and he still hates you . Do you think you’ll be able to find an answer even if you look for him?”

“This is the question that’s been bugging me . ” I shrugged .

Gaoqin Jiuye looked like he suddenly thought of something, and he said, “Oh right, weren’t you able to control Piercer very well on that day when you activated your split symbol? To be honest, I haven’t seen anyone who’s able to forcefully suppress Piercer and make her cause such great damage .

“Though Piercer was still dormant on that day, it was the most powerful it could be in a dormant stage . I’ll have to admit you were a strong rival on that day, so I thought that you had a talent in manipulating MF after you activated your split symbol, and that you had subdued Piercer . Why are you still troubled by this?

“Also, you were rather unusual after you activated your split symbol . It was you, but it wasn’t like you at the same time . Why was it so?”

I recalled what Jiao S said to me on the rooftop, so I just smiled at Gaoqin Jiuye . “I heard that after I activated my split symbol on that day, you acted like you were wildly impressed by me?”

Surprisingly, the usually conceited Gaoqin Jiuye did not argue, but simply shrugged and nodded . “Yes, you looked extraordinary that day, like a war goddess . Even I couldn’t help but admire you . ”

My heart ached, and my gaze turned sharp . “No need for you to worry about these things, and there’s no need for you to wonder about the reasons behind my wanting to look for Zou An . Since you’ve already agreed, you just need to get him here . ”

My tone changed because I felt distressed .

Extraordinary, war goddess?

This wasn’t a description of me, because I know she took control of my body on that day!

Extraordinary, war goddess?

This wasn’t a description of me, because I know she took control of my body on that day!

So, the person who impressed Gaoqin Jiuye was her, not me, Li Shen!

“Your mood swings are crazy . Or is this an after-effect of activating your split symbol?”

“Many others have asked this, and I’m not interested in answering any of you . If you’ve agreed in helping me look for Zou An, I’ll move on to my second point . ”

Gaoqin Jiuye smirked . “Go ahead . ”

I gave him a half-hearted smile . “I want to talk about your old lover, Du Yue . Are you sure you can tell me about her?”

Gaoqin Jiuye’s gaze tightened . “Who said she was an old lover?”

I waved a hand . “Save it, Gaoqin Jiuye . Are you soul splitters trying to act all innocent? You look different every time someone mentions Du Yue . I’m not stupid, and any woman who could move you in such a way would definitely have some sort of connection to you . It’s not that I’m trying to pry into your affairs, but two of my friends are held hostage by her, and they might currently be treated cruelly as experimental subjects . Laurel also disappeared because of her experiment, so I naturally would be looking for someone like you, who has some sort of relation to her, to try and learn more . I hope you understand . ”

I even blinked at him as I said, “I know, love is something that’s difficult to look back on . But since you’ve already agreed, just endure for a while and reopen those wounds, please?”

Gaoqin Jiuye’s dark eyes turned bright all of a sudden . “It’s really not like what you think . But I’ve never liked to explain things . Let me just tell you more about Du Yue, to prove that you think too highly of yourself if you really thought you can see through others . ”

Chapter 137

137 An Attack on Yuan Shen

“Du Yue, she...” Before Gaoqin Jiuye could finish, there was an urgent knocking at the door .

“Miss Ah Shen, are you inside?”

I waved a hand at Gaoqin Jiuye after hearing Jie Pa’s voice, and walked over quickly to open the door .

Jie Pa adjusted his glasses and looked like he was about to say something, but stopped as he saw Gaoqin Jiuye walking towards me . Jie Pa’s gaze changed a little .

Gaoqin Jiuye gave a self-mocking laugh . “No issue, both of you can speak outside, I won’t eavesdrop . ”

...

Why do we have to leave, can’t you wait outside instead... This is the Western District bro!

I heard a cracking sound while I was rolling my eyes in contempt of a certain someone’s excessive self-confidence .

The door to the adjacent room opened, and Jiao S walked out with a funny expression on her face .

“Great timing . You come over, I go back . ” Gaoqin Jiuye signaled to change places with Jiao S . Without waiting for any response, he moved

over and opened the door Jiao S just closed, closing the door behind as he went in .

“You sure he’s not in love with Si Luo?” I pointed at that door as I asked Jiao S .

Jiao S just smiled .

“Oh yes, Jie Pa, what did you want to speak about?”

Jie Pa nodded and said, “Let’s speak inside . ”

The three of us went back into the room .

“Miss Ah Shen, do you still remember the Yuan siblings?”

I nodded . “Of course I remember them . Didn’t I get them to stay by your side to protect you?”

Jie Pa nodded in response . “Yes, but since I think Chou Yu is more experienced in battle, I got them to help look for Laurel . The two of them were assaulted at the East-West district border, and because of protecting Yuan Qian, Yuan Shen is now gravely injured and unconscious . From what I’ve heard, it seemed like Yu Liang was the one who attacked them . ”

I opened my eyes wide . “Yu Liang? Didn’t Du Yue go back to the world of soul splitters with Ta Lai? Or did they leave Yu Liang in their Southern District experimental grounds?”

Jie Pa looked grim . “This is also the reason I’m looking for you . I think we should work with Mr Si Luo to thoroughly look into the Southern District’s matters . If there’s still an experimental ground, it would probably be in the Southern District . ”

Jiao S said, “Yes, I’ve looked into it . There’s not much of an issue in that Eastern District of mine, maybe because the MF of the average person is rather high there so they didn’t do much in the Eastern District . If like what you said, the experimental grounds in the Western District have been

destroyed, then it's highly possible that there's something still hidden in the Southern District . ”

I frowned . That horrible experiment, I really did not want to see that again .

“Apart from that, Miss Ah Shen, I didn't ask because your emotions were a little unstable before, but I'll have to ask now . Nie Zun had never once looked for you after he disappeared?” Jie Pa was visibly worried .

I took a deep breath . “No . ”

The scene of that black shadow flashing by the window when I was still in the room with Gaoqin Jiuye replayed itself in my head .

The scene of that black shadow flashing by the window when I was still in the room with Gaoqin Jiuye replayed itself in my head .

Could it be him?

Jie Pa said in an exhausted manner, “Nie Zun, always making others worry . ”

It was only now did I realize that the gentlemanly Jie Pa, who was always in clean clothes, looked tired and a little dismal . His suit was not as tidy as before, and there were specks of dust and blood stains on his shoes .

The ever-polite Jie Pa would probably only say things like that when he was talking about Nie Zun, as if he was chastising his own child .

I felt a little gloomy . After my friends left me one after another, he was the one who had been helping me out all this while, and I have just been piling these things upon him .

Li Shen, even more than Nie Zun, you are the one who makes others worry about you .

However, I was fully aware that it was in a large part because of Nie Zun that Jie Pa was treating me well .

But now, Nie Zun is gone .

Jie Pa might have noticed the glum look on my face, and he smiled at me, regaining his usual composure . “Don’t you worry, Miss Ah Shen . I’ll definitely find Nie Zun, and I’m sure he won’t leave you for real . ”

For some reason, my face reddened at this .

Jie Pa’s eyes looked distant as he continued, “The feelings he has for you are definitely not as simple as any other relationship between a boy and a girl . He’s not good at expressing himself, and he never talks about the things that bother him . He won’t even say it if he’s hurt, and he’ll just hole himself up somewhere . No matter what happens, I’ll help him undo the knot in his heart and bring him back . Miss Ah Shen, I hope you can go back with him as well . Though the invisible leash tying the both of you together is now broken, we still can’t be sure if the both of you will need to undo the split symbol curse at the same time to go back . I hope you don’t give up . ”

So bringing Nie Zun back and undoing that knot in his heart were the real reasons Jie Pa remained in the Split Zone .

I’m impressed, and also a little envious that Jie Pa could come to the Split Zone just for you, Nie Zun . There’s someone with you, you shouldn’t let your eyes be lonely anymore .

I’m impressed, and also a little envious that Jie Pa could come to the Split Zone just for you, Nie Zun . There’s someone with you, you shouldn’t let your eyes be lonely anymore .

“I won’t give up . ” This was the only thing I could say .

Jiao S then interrupted, “Si Luo has made his intentions clear . He’ll be staying in the Western District for some time, together with Gaoqin Jiuye . As for me, I’ll be going with Huan Qing to look for another suitable body of consciousness . ”

“Jiao S, does Si Luo really wish to continue staying alive? Though I know I shouldn’t be asking this, but I have this nagging feeling that it might not be that difficult to find another new body of consciousness . I just feel that he seems to be tired of such a life,” I said with knitted brows .

There was a resoluteness in Jiao S’s emotionless eyes . “That’s right, he’s exactly like this . I know that he’s pushing me away, he doesn’t want to live, and that he’s tired of the Split Zone . But I’m not going to give up . He can give up, but I won’t . Ah Shen, I’m begging you, no matter what, help me change his mind on this . This isn’t something I can do, but I have a feeling that only you can . ”

I was stunned .

She continued, “You’re unique, just like Si Luo is . I’ve never been able to tell what he was thinking after all these years, though I know that he’s getting tired of all the drama here . Probably because he’s also a rare breed here, whatever is hidden in his heart, be it loneliness or solitude, I can’t see it . Maybe you can help him understand it . ”

Do I really have such an ability... I hate this world too...

But, why do we hate this world? This world is beautiful too...

Even though it’s full of killing and bloodshed, aren’t we all still alive...

“Go ahead . I’ll help you look after him, I won’t let him die . ” I flashed her a brilliant smile . Though my heart was feeling bitter, I know she needed my encouragement . I am not going to let Jiao S become the next person hurt by me . I will do whatever she needs me to .

“Thank you . ” Jiao S’s eyes shone .

I looked back at Jie Pa . “Where are the Yuan siblings now?”

Jie Pa adjusted his glasses . “They’re at the accommodation in the Residence, in another block, probably about ten minutes or so away from here, if we use MF . There’s no need for you to go over, I’ll take care of

Yuan Shen . It's just that we don't know when he'll wake up . What I hope you can do now is to discuss matters with Si Luo, and it's best if he can go with you to the Southern District to investigate matters . Our chances against Du Yue will be better if we cooperate with them . ”

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“What do you think?” I asked Jiao S for her opinion .

“Si Luo is a soul splitter too, but he didn't reveal any secrets about them during my conversation with him . I'm thinking that he might have some difficulties, or someone like Si Luo would definitely not allow them to continue their absurd acts in the Southern District . ”

I thought about it before, that as a soul splitter, Si Luo had been staying in the Southern District for years, protecting the ordinary and weak residents . I have also witnessed the Southern District residents living happy lives . He might just be different from the other soul splitters, but I cannot give up on trying to pry some information out of him just because he seems to be a neutral party . He is the only clue we have now .

“Oh yes, I forgot to tell you guys . Huan Qing told me some things about the split symbols previously . ”

I suddenly recalled what Huan Qing said, that soul splitters captured souls and engraved split symbols on them, forming a three-way contract between the human, the soul splitter and the split symbol . I explained this to Jiao S and Jie Pa in detail .

“So it's like this...” Jie Pa looked shocked .

“You thought of something?” I asked hastily .

Jie Pa said, “I was a psychologist, so I naturally didn’t buy into the supernatural . I thought that the existence of the Split Zone could be some sort of separation from our consciousness . What we can confirm is that we still don’t know enough about the Split Zone, so all the contradictions and all our suspicions hinge on this secret . As long as we uncover it, we’ll be able to link everything together .

“Right now, you have to look into the experimental grounds . I have my own deductions based on what we saw, but they’ve destroyed most of it, and we don’t have much to work with . Miss Ah Shen, it’s best if you could find Yu Liang, or bring back an experimental subject from the experimental grounds in the Southern District . I’ll be able to find out more then . ”

“Yu Liang escaped after attacking the Yuan siblings?”

I thought of something else, and added quickly, “Jie Pa, no matter what that experiment did to Yu Liang, you have to remember that he’s a rational person, just like you . His character will not change . So, why did he suddenly attack one of us? Was he trying to tell us something? Maybe, you might want to take a closer look at Yuan Shen’s injuries . ”

Jie Pa nodded in response . “You’re right, Miss Ah Shen . I might have neglected this fact, that he might have a reason for doing so . ”

Chapter 138

138 You Cannot Kill Him

“I’ll go convince Si Luo and Gaoqin Jiuye, and get them to go to the Southern District with me . ”

“If we discover that Yu Liang is in the Eastern District, I’ll send someone to you immediately . But are you okay on your own, now that Nie Zun isn’t with you? Do you need me to get Tao Lie or Mu Li to go with you?” Jiao S asked .

I shook my head . “There’s no need for that . I know you’ve sent many people from the S Clan to defend the East-West border, if not there’s no way that Jie Pa would learn about the attack on the Yuan siblings so quickly given how busy he is now . Your people have already helped me out so much, and the defences on your side might weaken if you send more . I can’t trouble two more of your B-rank officers . ”

Jie Pa nodded . “Miss Ah Shen is right . Miss Jiao S, I haven’t been able to thank you properly . Your people from the S Clan have been a great help to us . ”

Jiao S moved her neck stiffly . “No problem at all . What’s important is that we all work together in uncovering the secret of the Split Zone . After going through so much, I’m sure that this isn’t the place for people to live forever . We have to go back someday . ”

That’s right, we’re going back someday . At least, you guys are going back .

I looked around involuntarily, and I did not see her .

Hah, a bitterness welled up in my heart .

Can I still escape from here?

“Right, Ah Shen, if I remember correctly, you haven’t slept in about a week . Though people in the Split Zone can go without food and water, our consciousness still needs rest . If you don’t sleep, it’s more difficult for you to manipulate your MF . You should rest up before you go,” Jiao S said .

I shook my head, saying, “I don’t want to sleep . ”

Jiao S and Jie Pa looked at each other, and then back at me with worried gazes .

I did not want to sleep, and I could not fall asleep either .

It had been almost two years, one day and sixty hours . All this time, Nie Zun was always by my side as I fell asleep .

In that time, he was always lying quietly on the top bunk, being still most of the time .

Many nights ago, he followed behind me as I ran around in the Split Zone . As I came back, he returned as well, and we always went to sleep at about the same time .

It became such a habit that I forgot he was always beside me, keeping me company .

Now that such a person has left, how do I break this habit?

How do I fall asleep without him around...

I forced myself to smile . “It’s fine . I can manage, trust me on this . Furthermore, if Si Luo and Gaoqin Jiuye go with me, what do I have to be scared of with the both of them around?”

“Gaoqin Jiuye might not let you leave the Western District with Si Luo, unless you bring Mi Fu along,” Jiao S gave her analysis .

This was definitely a problem .

“Jie Pa, what do you need me to do? Find the experimental grounds and bring back an experimental subject, right?”

Jie Pa took a bottle from his jacket pocket . “The Yuan siblings are good at using poison . Though their combat ability might not be great, it’s not difficult for them to leave a trace on Yu Liang . This is something which can track him . Try your best to bring him back too, if you can . ”

I stiffened as I took the bottle in my hand, because I thought of that bottle we used the last time we were tracking Laurel .

“This... has to be dabbed on the nose again?” I asked awkwardly .

Jie Pa nodded without hesitation . “Miss Ah Shen, there’re no animals here in the Split Zone, so we can’t use animals like dogs for tracking . I’ll need to trouble you for this . ”

The way you say it...

The emotional quotient of a doctor is really high, very good at socializing...

...

...

Jiao S laughed . “Your subordinate can come up with some really good things, I’m quite envious . ”

You use it then!

I took the bottle with an unwilling face .

There wasn’t even any place for me to keep it with this dress of mine! I guess I’ll just have to put it on my nose later .

“I’m guessing Gaoqin Jiuye will never let you leave with Si Luo if you don’t bring Mi Fu along . ”

I nodded . “But if I bring Mi Fu along, Gaoqin Jiuye will definitely take her life if Si Luo’s condition worsens when we’re on the road . What do I do if both you and Huan Qing will be away looking for other bodies of consciousness? Oh, I also forgot to ask, did you go to the Northern District with Huan Qing?”

Jiao S said, “We didn’t enter the Northern District, but Huan Qing did bring me to that blood-red border . He didn’t expect Gaoqin Jiuye to find you guys so quickly, so we turned back . I don’t know the way to that blood-red border line either, since Huan Qing used an illusion when he took me there . I don’t know what relationship he has with Si Luo, but we returned when Si Luo directly summoned him, and we weren’t yet able to enter the Northern District . ”

“How about this, Ah Shen . Since Huan Qing and I are going to the Northern District again, he’ll also be more at ease if we bring Mi Fu along . How about we go to the Southern District with you to find the experimental grounds, and after that, Huan Qing and I can head for the Northern District,” Jiao S continued .

This was a pretty good idea .

“This is definitely a good idea, Miss Ah Shen . I’m a little worried if Miss Jiao S isn’t with you too . Both of you can go together, and the priority is to bring Yu Liang or another experimental subject back . Don’t head for the Northern District impulsively,” Jie Pa said .

“Okay, you go ahead to take a look at the Yuan siblings . I’m throwing everything here to you again . I’ll try to be back as soon as I can . ” I felt a little guilty as I looked at Jie Pa’s tired face .

“You need some rest too, Jie Pa . Don’t be too hard on yourself . ”

Jie Pa smiled . “Don’t worry about me, Miss Ah Shen . ”

Jie Pa was about to leave, but turned back as he seemed to think of something . “Miss Ah Shen, if you happen to find Nie Zun while you’re on

the road, you have to bring him back . I'm afraid that he might be hurt from that fight . ”

My heart hurt once again . I nodded slowly .

My heart hurt once again . I nodded slowly .

Initially, I wanted to discuss matters regarding the trip to the Southern District together with Si Luo, Huan Qing and the rest . But as we were all gathered, Si Luo requested to first speak with me in private .

Recently, it seemed to be private negotiation time . I wonder why people in the Split Zone have so many secrets .

I felt like heaving a sigh . Humans are really simple!

“Heh...” Si Luo laughed softly . “Seems like I'm not the prettiest man in the Split Zone . ”

Not expecting him to say something like that, I asked, “How could that be? Who else can be prettier than you?”

His silver eyes shone with a dim light . “Then why do you look distracted? Others won't be distracted if they were looking at the prettiest person . ”

Did he get infected with Gaoqin Jiuye's narcissism...

But I have to plead guilty for this . As someone with an identity disorder, I was always distracted and daydreaming . Though I have suppressed my other personality for years, my thoughts are sometimes going in different directions . This is also why I always have an inattentive and distracted look . Those who know me have gotten used to this as well .

So it's not you, it's my mental illness . But I couldn't say something like this, it sounded too weird .

I tried to change the subject . “What did you want to discuss in private?”

Si Luo's eyes creased a little . “To agree upon some conditions . ”

Huh... these people are either trying to have a heart-to-heart or trying to agree upon conditions . What's wrong with this world .

“Li Shen, I know what's your curse after you activated your split symbol . ”
Si Luo smiled casually .

My face stiffened . He, he knew?

“There's a monster hidden in your heart . ” Raising his pale fingers, he pointed towards my chest .

“This is the reason why you are different in the Split Zone, and it's also the reason why my condition is improving . ”

“There's a monster hidden in your heart . ” Raising his pale fingers, he pointed towards my chest .

“This is the reason why you are different in the Split Zone, and it's also the reason why my condition is improving . ”

What? What has your condition got to do with me?

Dazzling light shone through Si Luo's eyes . “Li Shen, I want to ask three things from you . If you're able to complete them, I'll give you whatever you want . ”

This was an attractive condition, but can you give me whatever I wanted?

My instincts tell me that Si Luo was different from the ordinary person . I should not underestimate this man who is able to take people like Gaoqin Jiuye and Rong Jin under his wing .

The feeling Si Luo gave me was different from most . How he looked into my heart, how it backfired on him, how Li Qing respected him when she was alive, and now that I know he is a soul splitter, I had a feeling that he is the key to uncovering the secrets of the Split Zone .

There had to be a particular reason that he could stay with the ordinary residents and protect them for so long .

Thus, I said meekly, “Go ahead . ”

“Firstly, you can’t kill Gaoqin, ever . ” Si Luo smiled, and a gentle warmth filled the corner of his eyes .

My heart skipped a beat .

Why did he say that?

But taking a step back to think, he does have his reasons .

Since I saw Gaoqin Jiuye in his heart, I could tell that Gaoqin Jiuye was very important to this Southern District Commander . He was probably afraid that I would insert my splitting key into Gaoqin Jiuye’s corresponding split symbol one day, and Gaoqin Jiuye would then be forced to find another body of consciousness to survive .

But he did not say this .

“I know Gaoqin very well, and I’m afraid that he’ll do something extreme someday . If ever I’m no longer in the Split Zone, I hope you can stay by his side . If you want to leave, you can insert your splitting key into his split symbol, but he needs to be agreeable to it . I’m not asking you to stay here forever, because I believe that once I’m dead, he’ll willingly let you insert your key into his split symbol to undo it . All I want from you is that, at that point in time, just do what he wishes for . ”

I was confused . How is this not killing him? Isn’t this killing him?

Chapter 139

139 A Complex and Intricate Matter

“You’re asking me to kill him, so how’s that not killing him, ever?”

Si Luo smiled elegantly, a complex look in his eyes . “How do you define killing someone? Is plunging a knife into your lover’s chest killing him? Li Shen, the reason you can’t run away from the Split Zone is not because it has entrapped you, but because it’s you who’s trapping yourself . ”

Why did Si Luo know everything?

Si Luo tilted his head, and his silvery hair brushed over his shoulders in a dazzling arc . “Everyone knows how to talk about life’s philosophies, but not many can practice what they preach, and that’s the reason behind their unhappiness . Gaoqin is different, and I want him to be like me, to break free from these restraints and live life as he pleases .

“Undoing the split symbol on Gaoqin isn’t killing him, but you’ll truly be killing him if you refuse to do so . You need to keep him company on the road he wants to take, and not on the road that he should take . ”

Though I still could not understand the real meaning behind Si Luo’s words, another emotion welled up in me . I began to believe that Si Luo was an extraordinary person . It’s no wonder so many people liked him .

“And, the second condition?” I did not understand the first one, so I’ll just go on to the second one .

“Secondly, you need to get Jiao S to leave the Split Zone . You cannot leave before her . Either you send her away first, or both of you leave together . ”

As Si Luo's pale lips moved, there was a desolate kind of beauty in his eyes .

I could agree to this, because he was not asking me to leave . He simply wanted me to help Jiao S find her soul splitter and send her away . As long as I did not have to make a decision to leave the Split Zone at this moment, I could agree to this .

On this, I have also promised Ta Lai, that I would never leave this place .

“Okay . ” I nodded .

“The third one?”

“Thirdly...” Si Luo looked out into the distance through the window, solitude flashing in those silvery-white pupils of his .

For what seemed like a long while, I stared at his beautiful profile . He then turned back and faced me with a bleak but beautiful smile . “Thirdly, I want you to kill me . ”

My brain felt like it just crashed .

First, don't kill him .

Second, take her away .

Third, I want you to kill me .

As expected of Si Luo . If I did not personally hear these with my own ears, I would never have thought of it .

“How can I kill you? Moreover, how do I even kill you?” I frowned deeply .

He smiled casually . “This isn't important, and I'm not telling you to do it now . I just want you to promise me that if the time comes, and if you have the ability to kill me, don't hesitate if I ask you to . ”

This... how can it even be possible? Firstly, I can't kill him with MF alone, and it's even more impossible to do it through split symbol since he's a soul splitter, and he isn't even my soul splitter . There's no effect on him if I stabbed him with my splitting key, so how do I even kill him?

Or, did this mean he knew how to kill soul splitters?

That can't be . Aren't soul splitters immortal? Isn't there only one way to die – if they don't manage to find another new body of consciousness after the previous one leaves?

Right, Du Yue!

Du Yue is looking for a way to kill soul splitters, so does it mean...

“There's no need for you to think too much into this . I won't get you to sacrifice yourself, and you won't be hurt if that opportunity presents itself . You'll only benefit from killing me, and the only negative effects from killing me personally is that Gaoqin Jiuye and Jiao S would then probably doubt you . ”

I don't think it'd just merely be doubt...

I don't think it'd just merely be doubt...

“I don't care anymore . Li Shen, I've lived for too long, and the only person who can kill me is you . So you have to agree to this . When I ask for it sometime in the future, you'll have to kill me . ”

Si Luo's pupils seemed to dilate, and they were staring at me with a dim, white fog .

“No... don't ask that of me...” I waved my hand unconsciously . I could not agree to this, how could I kill him when I think he is a good person, a soul splitter who was different from the rest .

“You can't refuse this, Li Shen . In the Split Zone, I'm the only one who can help you reach the Northern District, I'm the only one who can help you find Nie Zun, and I'm the only one who can help you defeat the one

you want to beat . ” Si Luo laughed maniacally, but there was steadfastness in it .

I opened my eyes wide . Apart from that one line, I could not hear anything else .

“You... you can help me find Nie Zun?”

Si Luo smiled . “Only I can . ”

It felt like we were looking at each other for a long time, and I finally could ensure that he was not bluffing, that what he said was the truth .

If Si Luo said this, I have to reason to believe in it . If I agree, I’ll need to kill him when he asks me to . If it’s like this, was it worth it for me to agree? Can I really kill him when that day arrives?

I’m afraid I might not be able to . Though I’m a monster, I’m no grim reaper who takes the lives of others without even blinking an eye .

“Don’t reject it so quickly . Take some time to think about it, but you’ll have to give me an answer eventually .

“Oh right, I’ll be going to the Southern District together with Gaoqin Jiuye and the rest . I know about the experimental grounds you guys were talking about, so I can bring you lot there, and also to look for your friends . ” Si Luo was still smiling, but it just did not feel genuine .

I kept my eyes on him . “You knew about that already? Why didn’t you stop it then? Though you haven’t been well, you’ve been the Southern District Commander for so long and protected those weak residents even as a soul splitter . Judging from your personality, I don’t believe that you’ll allow somebody like Du Yue to conduct her cruel experiments and hurt others in your territory . ”

“I wasn’t aware of it initially, but after I learnt about it, it wouldn’t make much of a difference whether I interfered or not . Furthermore, I can’t act on impulse when it comes to Du Yue . ”

“I wasn’t aware of it initially, but after I learnt about it, it wouldn’t make much of a difference whether I interfered or not . Furthermore, I can’t act on impulse when it comes to Du Yue . ”

“Why?”

“You can look at it like it’s for Gaoqin, but this isn’t important . What’s important is that, are you still going to waste more time here now that I’m willing to take you to look for your friends?” Si Luo’s smile remained, but his pale eyes had a sort of icy glint to it .

He looked like a noble immortal with a cold cruelty . The blood-red crescent moon on his forehead was a bright contrast to his pale, white eyes . It made him look like he was the world’s most noble and classy individual, and it made others voluntarily bow down to him .

Seems like there is no use in continuing the discussion . I might have already gotten the best answer I could get .

“Let’s go, back to your Southern District . ”

As the deal was sealed, I opened the door, wanting to involve the rest in the conversation .

But when I opened the door, I saw Gaoqin Jiuye, Jie Pa and Jiao S simply standing there with shocked expressions .

“What’s wrong with all of you?” I asked, confused . Gaoqin Jiuye’s complicated gaze brushed past me and he looked towards Si Luo, who was just behind me .

Si Luo seemed a little surprised by their expressions as well, and looked towards Gaoqin Jiuye for an explanation .

Jiao S was the first to speak . “Huan Qing and the rest... with Ku Fei and that girl, Mi Fu, they’re gone . ”

What does it mean they’re gone??? Weren’t they just standing outside?

Si Luo was obviously much calmer than I was . Though there was still surprise in his eyes, he went back to his usual self quickly . “Explain it in detail . ”

Gaoqin Jiuye had a complex gaze . “In the same instant when you opened the door, a bright light appeared around the three of them, and before they could react to it, they disappeared right in front of our eyes . ”

I was shocked . “Light? Could it be Mr Blond?”

Jie Pa looked grim . “Yes, it was the same kind of light that Mr Blond uses when he takes us to the Northern District, but its speed was a hundred times faster . ”

I was shocked . “Light? Could it be Mr Blond?”

Jie Pa looked grim . “Yes, it was the same kind of light that Mr Blond uses when he takes us to the Northern District, but its speed was a hundred times faster . ”

Gaoqin Jiuye kept his eyes on Si Luo, looking even more worried . Si Luo’s eyes darkened, and said to Gaoqin Jiuye, “Could it be?”

A storm seemed to rage in Gaoqin Jiuye’s eyes, and he did not answer Si Luo’s question .

“What’re the both of you hiding from us? You’d be familiar with the Northern District since you are both soul splitters . What happened to Mr Blond, where is he now, and why did he do that?” I asked a flurry of questions .

Si Luo looked at me . “This isn’t the best time to explain all this . We should make our way to the Southern District to look for the experimental grounds . Li Shen, if you don’t move fast, there might be even more unexpected incidents that will never have an explanation . ”

My heart sank .

Jie Pa stepped forward . “Miss Ah Shen, since it’s like this, go ahead with Miss Jiao S . Make it a quick trip, bring back Yu Liang, and let’s not think about anything else for the moment . ”

I glanced at Jiao S and saw her gaze on Si Luo . She seemed confused, as if she was feeling glum that she could never understand Si Luo .

“Right, I’ll have to leave the Western District in your hands again . ” I nodded at Jie Pa .

“Jiao S, if you could send Tao Lie and Mu Li to help protect Jie Pa, please . Now that the Yuan siblings are hurt, there’s only Chou Yu and his intelligence network, I just can’t put myself at ease . ”

I was too worried about Jie Pa getting hurt as his body is now just like that of a normal human being, and I had no choice but to borrow manpower from Jiao S .

“I’m fine,” Jie Pa hastily said .

I did not bother about him, while Jiao S nodded quickly . “Not an issue . I’ll contact them before I go . Don’t worry, I still have Feng, Huo and Lei, and they’ll help me take care of Guan Nie and safeguard the Eastern District . I’ll send both Tao Lie and Mu Li to help protect your intel . ”

I nodded . “Thank you . ”

I caught a glimpse of the slight change in Gaoqin Jiuye’s face . It was probably because Jiao S mentioned Guan Nie .

Chapter 140

140 The Walls Have Eyes

I only left the Western District with Si Luo and Jiao S after Tao Lie and Mu Li arrived and finished discussing matters with Jie Pa .

We ran at moderate speed, since Si Luo did not seem to like rushing .

The silence throughout our journey made me a little gloomy, and I felt that the combination of our team was rather weird . Jiao S and Si Luo, Si Luo and Gaoqin Jiuye, Gaoqin Jiuye and I .

No matter how we are grouped, it seems quite shocking as long as the four of us were together .

Gaoqin Jiuye had a cold expression throughout, probably because he always had a hostile attitude towards Jiao S, or maybe because Mi Fu's sudden disappearance made him worry about Si Luo's condition .

Someone in the group finally spoke after we passed the Western District and reached the border forest in Jiao S's Eastern District . It was Si Luo who spoke .

Si Luo's long, silver hair formed a perfect, dazzling silver line as he ran, and I could not pull my gaze away from how he looked as his hair fell across his shoulders as he stopped .

He turned back, smiling at Jiao S . "The Eastern District is always so orderly under your command . "

Something flashed past Jiao S's eyes, but she did not respond . Right after Si Luo spoke, five spidermen lowered themselves from the tree in front of

us .

Yes, these five are among those ten cute spidermen...

This scene was too much for me, and I rested my forehead in my palm to prevent myself from taking in the scene .

“District Commander, you’re back!”

There were five voices, and there were only eyes and mouths to be seen under those masks .

Jiao S moved her neck stiffly, nodding . “Where’s Feng, Huo and Lei?”

“District Commander, Lord Feng led the other five to the border on the other side, and Lord Lei is settling Eastern District matters on level 30 of the Residence where you live . Lord Huo is currently gathering the rest from the S Clan, possibly for training . ” The leader of the spidermen spoke .

“Right, no need to bother them about this, I’m just passing by this time . Tao Lie and Mu Li are both in the Western District now . Same rules apply, protect the East-West border and the South-East border, and once Tao Lie summons you guys to help out in the Western District, go immediately . ”

“Yes, District Commander!”

All of them answered at once without any hesitation, as if they received training in the army .

Just that, these were a bunch of well-trained spidermen...

Jiao S addressed the rest of us, “How about resting for the night in the Eastern District’s Academy? We won’t make it in time if we were to head for the Southern District now anyway, it’s going to be dark soon . ”

I suddenly thought of something, and abruptly asked Gaoqin Jiuye, “Right, Gaoqin Jiuye, why were you able to cross the border at night the first time I saw you?”

Jiao S's pupils seemed to grow big, as if I reminded her of her suspicions, and she looked toward Gaoqin Jiuye for an answer .

Gaoqin Jiuye's gaze remained cold as he looked at me, smiling with malice . "Because I'm a soul splitter . "

Jiao S and I looked at each other, then we both looked at Si Luo .

Si Luo laughed in his elegant manner . "That's right, soul splitters are not restricted by the borders . "

As if we had telepathy, Jiao S and I looked at each other again . Though Jiao S could not pull herself out of her love for Si Luo, I know she is a very rational person, and her love would be rational as well .

A rational love is true love . Because of this, I believe that her suspicions were the same as mine at this very moment .

However, we could not voice our suspicions now as we were faced with two soul splitters whose abilities were far above us, and one of them was even my soul splitter .

What I suspected was that, if soul splitters had such power, did it mean that everything in the Split Zone was an elaborate set controlled by them?

Si Luo suddenly looked at me with those white, misty eyes . "Still remember our agreement right . Don't worry, your questions will be answered when it's time . "

Si Luo suddenly looked at me with those white, misty eyes . "Still remember our agreement right . Don't worry, your questions will be answered when it's time . "

Jiao S gave me a questioning look . It was obvious she wanted to know what my agreement with Si Luo was .

I sighed inwardly . There was no way I could tell her that your lover's agreement with me was for me to kill him when he wanted to die someday .

Therefore, I gave her a look that said, Don't worry, I'll tell you when I get the chance .

Sometimes, consolation is also a form of deception .

When the victim finally realizes they have been deceived, they seldom look upon it as a kind lie, but rather, just a lie .

“Though the two of us are not restricted by the borders, the both of you would be . It's not too late if we rest for a night in the Eastern District and set off tomorrow morning either . ” Si Luo was the one who made the final decision, and the rest of us agreed in silence .

Jiao S roomed with me and Si Luo roomed with Gaoqin Jiuye in the Eastern District Academy building . Even though we were two pairs of males and female, two males stayed in a room, and two females stayed in a room .

The four of us were a perfect description of the phrase ‘true love can only be found with someone of the same sex’ . (T/n: A modern phrase in Chinese, it is sometimes used sardonically . It says that couples got together just to produce offspring and that real, true love can only be found with someone of the same sex .)

What is weirder is that Jiao S disguised herself under a bamboo hat, as if she did not want to be recognized by her residents . She told me that many of them recognized her, and many still think that her absence was because she was still investigating the death of her B-rank officer . She did not want to let her residents know that she is trying to uncover the secret of the Split Zone, so that everyone can leave .

The people in the Eastern District were quite different from those in the Western and Southern District . Most of them were always up for fights and they were relatively more ambitious . Because of this, they might not want to return that badly . Even though Jiao S might have gotten tired of the killing and the fights in the Split Zone, it did not mean that the Eastern District residents felt the same, since they have also been living here for a while . Before she gets to the bottom of that experiment, it might be a better decision to keep this a secret .

I thought it still looked awkward with that bamboo hat of hers . It seemed like not many recognized Si Luo and Gaoqin Jiuye, and probably not that many recognized me either . The four of us – a stunningly beautiful man was rooming with a malicious, cold man, while a bright, fiery red girl was rooming with a lady in a bamboo hat .

Even in such a place like the Split Zone, a weird combination like this would probably set some tongues wagging .

The glum me had no choice but to awkwardly enter the same room with Jiao S under the curious gazes of the peculiar-looking Eastern District residents .

“You need to sleep . You haven’t been sleeping for days, it just won’t do . You think I can go against both Si Luo and Gaoqin Jiuye at the same time?” Jiao S finally took off her bamboo hat in the room .

I laughed bitterly . “It’s not that I don’t want to sleep, I can’t fall asleep . ”

I laughed bitterly . “It’s not that I don’t want to sleep, I can’t fall asleep . ”

Jiao S put her bamboo hat on the table, looking at me with her huge eyes . “Because of Nie Zun?”

She knows me really well .

I nodded helplessly .

“Well...” A tiny, feminine smile appeared on Jiao S’s usually emotionless face . “I’ve always wanted to ask you this . Do you love Nie Zun?”

I choked a little on the water in the glass which I poured for myself .

My lips froze for a second .

Love...?

“Why do you ask this?” I looked down, placing the glass back onto the table .

“You’re different from me in this sense . I dare to love and hate with passion, how about you? Even in the Split Zone, there won’t be that much of a difference in a relationship between a man and a woman . I won’t believe it if you say your relationship with Nie Zun is purely platonic,” Jiao S said confidently .

But what’s the point of saying all this now? So what if I answered that it’s love, how would that change anything? He has already left, and no one knows where he is .

What right do I have to love someone? I hoped that there would be a nice beginning and ending to my love . The previous person I loved, who was the only person I loved, had his life cut short personally by me . I ended that love .

For someone who couldn’t even solve her own mental problems, how do I even begin to think about who I love just like other normal women?

My love for Gao Qi isn’t dead either, so where do I even begin talking about falling in love with somebody else?

“Could you treat this question seriously?” Jiao S looked me in the eye .

I smiled . “This suggestion isn’t great, you might as well suggest for me to force myself to fall asleep . ”

Jiao S looked me up and down a few times before finally smiling . “Maybe your suggestion is better . ”

I smiled . “This suggestion isn’t great, you might as well suggest for me to force myself to fall asleep . ”

Jiao S looked me up and down a few times before finally smiling . “Maybe your suggestion is better . ”

I might have wanted to avoid the question, so I walked over to the bottom bunk and lay down .

My heart skipped a beat when Jiao S went up to the top bunk . It reminded me of how Nie Zun went up to the top bunk, something which I have never put too much attention on .

My eyes started to tear . I hated myself like this . I turned and faced the wall .

I thought I would be able to sleep for the first time after being separated from Nie Zun after a long time of staring at that white wall, but that did not happen .

After a few moments of stunned silence, I cried out, still facing the wall .

“Ah—!”

I got down from the bed and stood up, keeping my eyes on that particular spot in the wall I was previously looking at .

“What’s wrong?” Jiao S jumped down from the top bunk and walked over to me .

I pulled on her sleeve . “Is your Academy building haunted?”

She waved a palm in front of my face . “What’re you talking about, Li Shen . This is the Split Zone, where do you find ghosts here?”

I pointed at the wall in a daze . “That, that wall . It’s there, look . ”

Jiao S bent down to have a clearer look at that particular spot I was pointing at .

I pointed at this tiny hole, which for some reason, existed in the wall . When I lay down and faced that wall, I saw an eye in there .

Chapter 141

141 An Octopus

Jiao S's hair touched the floor as she bent down, and I almost stepped on that long, black hair of hers as she bent down to look .

She stared with her dark pupils as she straightened up!

Crackle!

An air current formed into a slender air needle, stabbing the eye in that tiny hole!

Pu-tch!

The eyeball burst as the air needle passed through it, and a small stream of blood flowed out from that hole, dripping down the white wall and staining it red .

I shivered . This witch was really decisive in her actions! What else do I have to be scared of with her around? I bet demons and monsters did not even dare come close!

Jiao S cracked her neck, saying to me, "Let's go and check out the situation beside . "

Si Luo and Gaoqin Jiuye were in the room on the other side . I took another look at that wall, and I swear if there was a hole in their room, I will be sticking my eyeball in to check if they were gay .

With a loud crash, Jiao S kicked open the door, causing many to stick their heads out to see what was happening . Jiao S already went in, and I was left

standing outside awkwardly while everyone else thought I was the one who kicked the door .

Gaoqin Jiuye then opened the door and looked at me coldly . “What’re you doing when it’s already dark?”

I shot him a look, trying to signal that there was someone weird in this room .

Gaoqin Jiuye did not get me at all, and he banged the door close after giving me an irritated look!

Anger welled up in me, and I could hear Jiao S’s voice as I trembled with anger . “What monster dares trespass into my Eastern District?”

I went into the room quickly to take a look .

I was startled by the sight .

A giant octopus was on the window! Oh, no, it was an octopus man!

It was not exactly an octopus, but it had tentacles like one . The person had a twisted body, and he stuck to the window in an S-shape . He looked very spooky against the backdrop of the black night outside .

There were four tentacle-like limbs which stretched out from the two ends of his twisted body . They looked like arms and legs, and they were more than three meters long, stretching all the way to the walls on both ends . The ends of the tentacles looked like conical drills, and they were embedded into the walls . There was only one tentacle not in the wall . There was a bloody hole in the wall, and that was the exact hole we saw in our room .

That particular tentacle had something like a broken eyeball on its end, and the other tentacles were still drilling their way into the walls, as if they would go through anytime .

I shivered . An eyeball on a tentacle and it could still drill through walls? Just how strong was that eyeball? Probably nothing but Jiao S’s air needles could break it .

This scary thing, which was probably a man, had a kind of twisted expression on his soulless face, and he had this very long tongue with spikes all over it .

“What the heck is this?” Gaoqin Jiuye’s icy voice sounded behind me .

“You scared me!” I turned back and stared at him .

He raised his brows . “When were you ever afraid of these things, Li Shen . You’re so close to Jiao S, isn’t she and her S Clan even more frightening when they transform?”

That was quite the sarcastic remark on Jiao S...

Jiao S ignored Gaoqin Jiuye completely and kept her eyes on that octopus man on the window .

Jiao S ignored Gaoqin Jiuye completely and kept her eyes on that octopus man on the window .

“Spit it out . Who are you?”

A creepy smile appeared on octopus man, wrinkling his already creased face into a ball . He did not respond after that creepy smile, but he went straight for Jiao S as he raised that tentacle with the eyeball previously broken by her .

A sharp gaze appeared on Jiao S’s eyes, and the air started crackling and freezing!

Numerous air needles formed behind her in that sheet of air she formed, and it flew towards that tentacled monster!

That tentacle which was going for Jiao S was extremely agile, dodging many of the air needles by twisting and turning . Not caring about the other air needles which stabbed into his body, he continued reaching forward with that tentacle towards Jiao S’s breasts .

Yes, her breasts!

“Ka—!”

At this point, there was a perverted, dirty smile on his face, and he produced a creepy laughter . A huge blob of saliva dripped from that twisted mouth of his, and it was dripping onto the floor!

Disgusting...

I shivered involuntarily .

That tentacle was about to touch Jiao S’s breasts, and she was enraged . The air currents on her right instantly became a whirlpool, and she drew a sword from that whirlpool and hacked at that tentacle which was already in front of her face!

Jiao S’s sword was very sharp, and that tentacle was cut off as she swung her sword!

The cut-off tentacle was still going forward, and it was now coming for my head!

I backed away as I looked at that slimy thing, and pushed Gaoqin Jiuye in front of me!

I backed away as I looked at that slimy thing, and pushed Gaoqin Jiuye in front of me!

Gaoqin Jiuye was stunned by my actions, but he could only stare at me with anger as he pushed that tentacle to a corner with a frozen air current!

I shrugged at him, indicating that there was no choice for me to do so, since I could not use Piercer at will, and I will not take it out if there were other options . Arrows cannot stop this thing either, so I could only use him as a human shield .

“Ka—!” it did not seem painful for the creature to have one of his tentacles cut off . As he produced more creepy laughter, he removed the other seven tentacles from the walls!

There were eyes on each and every one of these tentacles!

Damn! This is too disgusting!

Although people in the Split Zone, especially those from the Eastern District, liked to style themselves in pretty peculiar ways, it was still rare to see someone make themselves look this creepy!

More importantly, my gut was telling me this was not a look created through MF, it was how his body of consciousness originally looked like!

There was no time for me to think about all this as all the tentacles were going straight for the three of us!

As they reached out towards us, the eyes on their ends became a few times larger, and there were even more tiny tentacles which starting coming out of their pupils!

It was just like an eye of a devil which could endlessly produce tentacles, those tiny tentacles could reach out in all directions like a jellyfish, and they were coming towards us!

There is no way I will allow these horrid things to touch me!

Of course, I did not want Piercer to be in contact with these things either . It was not a matter of whether I dared to use Piercer or not, it was that I just did not want these things to be in contact with any part of me!

Thus, I grabbed Gaoqin Jiuye's belt from behind!

Gaoqin Jiuye was in a pair of black pants, and his belt was that long, flexible sword, Shen Qi! I was so disgusted with that thing that I forgot his belt was Shen Qi, simply grabbing it at one go!

Thus, I grabbed Gaoqin Jiuye's belt from behind!

Gaoqin Jiuye was in a pair of black pants, and his belt was that long, flexible sword, Shen Qi! I was so disgusted with that thing that I forgot his belt was Shen Qi, simply grabbing it at one go!

Gaoqin Jiuye did not expect that I would once again treat him like a shield, and that I would even grab his belt!

But he could not turn to stare at me this time, because there were three tentacles going straight for him!

I hid behind him and bent down, looking at those three tentacles like a timid rat, holding onto Shen Qi behind his waist . I was surprised that the sword did not cut into my hands . It was as if Shen Qi was sealed when not in use . There was no time for me to bother about such things now, and I kept muttering, “What’re you doing? Quick! Cut this disgusting thing down quickly!”

Gaoqin Jiuye let out an angry roar, and all that coldness turned into a rage . “How do I cut it when you’re holding onto Shen Qi!”

“Oh, sorry about that . ” I let go of his ‘belt’ with an apologetic look .

It was too late, the tentacle already reached the top of his head .

I squatted as I tried to avoid it .

Gaoqin Jiuye was still turned towards me, and it made him even angrier as he saw me squat down without any intention of helping him . That anger made the air currents around him freeze at a much stronger and faster rate!

This room seemed to be a storage filled with huge blocks of ice right now . Jiao S and Gaoqin Jiuye activated their MF to freeze the air currents in the room, surrounding those tentacles with pieces of frozen air currents that looked like ice .

Jiao S backed away a couple of steps, and raising the sword in her hand, she swung it multiple times at that frozen tentacle in front of her, smashing it into smithereens!

Gaoqin Jiuye also took Shen Qi in hand, and it produced a beautiful black ray which smashed the tentacles!

I was marveling to myself about how intelligent a living weapon Shen Qi is . It seemed to be dead when worn at his waist, as if it could do no harm, but once it was in his hand, even if it didn't come to life, it was instantly a killing machine!

Pieces of broken tentacles fell to the floor, but there seemed to be no agony on that octopus man's wretched face, who has now lost his tentacles . He still had that filthy and greedy look, and the saliva continued dripping from the corners of his mouth onto the floor .

Chapter 142

142 The Hatred in Yu Liang

“Tsk tsk, this thing is really gross . ” I looked at that saliva-dripping octopus man in disgust .

Gaoqin Jiuye stared at me, incensed . “And you use me as a shield for this gross thing?”

I feigned a smile, tapping on his shoulder . “We’re all so familiar, no need to take it to heart~ Furthermore, you had the opportunity to save a beauty and show your heroism . ”

Gaoqin Jiuye just deadpanned...

Jiao S did not seem to pay attention to our conversation, as she was still focused on that creepy thing on the window . “I’ll give you one last chance . Stop that shameless laughter of yours and tell me where you are from and what are you . If not, it’s not only those fine hairs that would be cut off!”

Jiao S’s hoarse voice was sharp, and she pointed at that octopus man with sword in hand .

The corners of my mouth twitched . My dear Jiao S, aren’t those things tentacles and not fine hairs?

Octopus man did not seem to understand what Jiao S was saying at all, and he continued that creepy laughter . The tentacles which were cut off did not show any signs of healing either .

Looking at this weird creature, I thought of something else .

I recalled the time when Li Qing and us attacked that basiliscampus a long time ago .

Yes, that basiliscampus was just like this creature in front of us, it was a weird combination of animal parts, and looked as if it did not have an awareness like humans did . It looked like it could not heal but it had this inherent ability to attack humans .

Would these creatures happen to have some sort of connection?

I was upset with the fact that this creature made me think of Li Qing, and my smile receded into a cold gaze as I stared at that octopus man who was still twisting and turning on the window .

Suddenly, a head popped up from the window behind the octopus man!

The head slowly snuck in through the windowpane, as if it melted the glass and went through it . After which, her neck, torso and two hands appeared!

Her hands grabbed the neck of octopus man softly, and she rested her chin on the top of his head! She had a dazzling smile on her, and she was looking at me gently .

She tightened her grip on the octopus man's neck while keeping her eyes on mine .

I knew her . It was my other personality .

Because of this, I drew Piercer out without hesitation and a violet light flashed as I activated my MF!

I was either too agitated, or I still did not get the hang of manipulating MF properly after activating my split symbol, causing a high amount of MF to concentrate in one location . When I swung Piercer, it produced a ball violet fire instead of a violet blade!

The violet fire flew towards her!

However, her face, her head and her entire person was already gone as the violet light appeared!

That violet fire then went straight for the octopus man, bursting open in his face!

Boom!

There was a loud explosion, and even Gaoqin Jiuye and Jiao S backed away!

In the smoke, I could see the octopus man and the window both smashed to pieces, and some of the broken pieces fell out of the window .

Gaoqin Jiuye shot me a look . “What’s with that sudden rage of yours?”

Instead of looking at him, I kept looking at the pile of rubble .

There is no use telling him this, he could not see her and he would never understand why I attacked so abruptly and mercilessly .

Jiao S looked at me with worry, but she did not say anything .

Jiao S looked at me with worry, but she did not say anything .

I did not feel anything when I used Piercer, but this time when it was in my hand, I felt an icy pressure stabbing into my palm . I frowned slightly, feeling beads of cold sweat forming on my forehead .

I then tried to tie Piercer around my waist as naturally as I could .

“Hah, Piercer’s power is definitely extraordinary . ”

I heard a familiar voice from the broken window .

Upon hearing this voice, I froze in the midst of adjusting Piercer on my waist .

This, this is...

I snapped my head up, and a somewhat familiar face appeared in the window .

He looked like he jumped up here . He was well-built, and both his hands were holding onto what was left of the windowsill . He popped his head in before hopping into the room .

“Yu Liang...” I mumbled .

He was in light gray . His facial features were sharp like before, and his eyes were calm and rational . It was definitely Yu Liang .

Apart from those eyes, nothing about him had changed .

His eyes were now a bright red .

He looked at me with a frigid gaze . “Been quite a while, my District Commander . ”

As expected, ‘Been quite a while’ is always an unfriendly greeting .

I stepped forward, not minding the clear animosity in his eyes . “Yu Liang, where did you go all this time? How are you doing?”

I stepped forward, not minding the clear animosity in his eyes . “Yu Liang, where did you go all this time? How are you doing?”

Though I was a little emotional at seeing Yu Liang after worrying about him for so long, I calmed down as I felt Jiao S reach out a hand to grab me .

That’s right, I had to be alert . Although I didn’t want to doubt old friends of mine, I had to stay alert right now .

Jie Pa wanted me to find Yu Liang on this trip, and he even said Yu Liang hurt the Yuan siblings . Yu Liang will not appear here without rhyme or reason .

I suddenly recalled something else, making my heart sink a little more .

I dabbed that drug on my nose before I left, but there was absolutely no whiff of Yu Liang, and Jiao S's subordinates reported that there was nothing out of the ordinary in the Eastern District either . I thought we would have to reach the Southern District before we could have some idea of where Yu Liang was, but why did I not sense it when he appeared?

I don't doubt the Yuan siblings' abilities in using poison, and usually, he wouldn't have realized if there was a tracking drug used on him . There wouldn't be any problems with Jie Pa's drug, so why did I not sense anything at all if Yu Liang is here?

Just what is happening .

“How am I doing? Do you think I'll be well without Song Lu?” A cruel smile appeared on Yu Liang's face, and there was undisguised hatred in his eyes .

Though there were many things I wanted to ask, I could not say anything at this moment .

The hatred in Yu Liang was very visible, and I could totally understand and accept this hate that was directed at me .

When he was taken away with Song Lu, according to Song Lu, he was assassinated right in front of her, and she thought him dead . However, based on Jie Pa's deductions, we thought he is very much alive .

But there is no use in knowing he was alive, because I did not do anything to rescue him . Though Jie Pa has been sending people to look for him, it was never successful .

More and more incidents occurred, and I kept losing the friends around me . Up until the point where Old Man Fan turned into stone, these things kept happening one after another, and I just did not have the time to clear my mind and think about things properly, much less do anything about these things .

Though these are excuses, this is still the Split Zone . We cannot even protect ourselves well, so how do we even begin to protect others?

My heart was bitter . I was really an unqualified District Commander . Not only did I not have the ability to protect them, I didn't have a calm and clear enough mind to analyze the situations they were facing .

All the pain Yu Liang experienced in this time was brought upon by me .

My heart was bitter . I was really an unqualified District Commander . Not only did I not have the ability to protect them, I didn't have a calm and clear enough mind to analyze the situations they were facing .

All the pain Yu Liang experienced in this time was brought upon by me .

When Du Yue said he was still in an experimental barrel in the Southern District, there was nothing I could do even when I was mad and in agony about it .

Even now, when I am looking for him, I didn't even realize it when he appeared in front of me .

If I look for him, I can't look for Song Lu . Even if I could save him, others like Song Lu, Old Man Fan, Laurel, and more, were still waiting to be rescued . And also, Huan Qing and the rest who just disappeared without a trace .

Not to forget Nie Zun, who is also missing .

I keep losing the people I care about as I lived here in the Split Zone, but my powers are limited . Before even looking for them, I might already be in danger myself .

What is the purpose of my existence then?

Why didn't I realize that I couldn't even find my friends when I made those mighty promises of uncovering the secrets of the Split Zone, taking them away by undoing the restraints of our split symbols, and overthrowing the rules in the Split Zone?

Even though things were in dire straits, even though it looked like it could only get worse, even though I might lose even more people, I cannot give up as long as there is still one person by my side, right?

I'll really not be able to get any of them back if I give up .

My thoughts were in a mess and my heart was in a dilemma, but I have finally sorted them out as I met Yu Liang again after such a long time .

That's right, I can't give up, no matter how bad the situation is .

I searched high and low, only to find Yu Liang where I least expected to .

I said calmly, "You've changed a lot in this time, but is this the reason you're treating me with such hostility? If you're referring to Song Lu, let me tell you, I'm also looking for her . The more time we waste here, the less we have to find her . Why not get to the point, why did you appear here out of nowhere?"

I had no choice but to use such a tone and attitude with such an old friend . He was just like a brother-in-law to me, and he was someone important, but in this world where only the fittest survive, people change easily .

No matter how my heart hurt, I had to endure it for the many others who were still waiting for me .

Chapter 143

143 A Deficit in MF

Yu Liang burst out laughing as he heard me mention Song Lu . “Li Shen, you have the cheek to say that Song Lu is waiting for your rescue? It doesn’t matter that you didn’t look for me, I wouldn’t hate you even if I died, but how could you let them take Song Lu? They are such a cruel bunch . Song Lu already went through so much hardship when she was alive, how could you bear to let her go through so much pain again?!”

I zoomed in on what he said . “A bunch? Who are they? It’s Du Yue, right?”

Yu Liang’s face darkened . He raised a hand and said, “There’s no use talking about this . I’m going to rip your heart out today, to see for myself if you even care about Song Lu at all!”

After saying that, the fingers on his left hand started melting, bone and flesh blending together . His hand was gone and it was now a circular stump .

Pu-sst!

A tentacle came out of that circular stump, and like a loach which was being electrocuted, it wriggled non-stop . The tentacle seemed retractable, and it extended and retracted with a wave of his arm!

I was stunned by this scene which could only be seen in science fiction movies when we were alive . With my mouth hanging open, I saw his other hand going through the same transformation .

Jiao S seemed to hate these tentacle-like things even more than I did . She did not wait for Yu Liang to be ready for the battle, she just raised her sword and slashed it towards his elbow without hesitation!

The tentacle from Yu Liang's arm sensed the danger from Jiao S's sword, and before her sword could reach him, it shot forward, wrapping itself around Jiao S's wrist with amazing speed!

I could see raging white fog surging in Jiao S's eyes as her wrist was trapped by that slimy tentacle, and the air condensed in the entire room!

Gaoqin Jiuye was not slacking either . With a fast movement, he swung Shen Qi, but Yu Liang was even faster . The tentacle from his other hand wrapped itself around Gaoqin Jiuye's wrist at lightning speed!

It seemed like I was the only one who just stood there in a daze...

The rage from Jiao S and Gaoqin Jiuye made the air in the room shake as white fog surged in their eyes!

But! There was a sudden calm before the great storm!

All the wild air currents in the room stopped in an instant!

It was as if everything went silent in the room, even the sound of breathing was absent!

I looked to my sides at Gaoqin Jiuye and Jiao S, and saw that they both had shocked expressions on their faces!

Yu Liang laughed coldly . "The slime on this tentacle can paralyze movement of the consciousness . No matter how great the value of your MF is, this is the price you have to pay for underestimating your opponent in battle . Sorry about this but I know the two of you have pretty strong abilities, so I had to attack and paralyze you guys first . It'll be an easy job after this!"

I smirked . "Easy job? You think that I'm still the old Li Shen?"

I was already holding Piercer tight in my hands at this point .

Gaoqin Jiuye gave a malicious laugh . "Even if you don't see her as much of an opponent, the person with the highest MF in the Spit Zone is now in

the adjacent room . Do you think you have any chances of winning this fight?”

Yu Liang’s icy smile remained . “You think I’ll appear without preparation to face the four of you? If I’m right, the one in the adjacent room only has half of a split symbol left, right? The person who had a corresponding split symbol undid it and returned to the real world, and he hasn’t been able to find another body of consciousness . Have you forgotten what a soul splitter who’s left with half a split symbol most afraid of?”

As if recalling the world’s most horrific incident, Gaoqin Jiuye’s eyes sunk into the abyss of hopelessness .

“You’ve been here for quite a while now, why didn’t he come over? You think he’s just lazy?”

Gaoqin Jiuye could no longer bear to hear anymore, and with a sharp gaze, he used his MF to cut off that tentacle wrapping around his wrist with a moderately powerful air current . After which, he staggered towards the door .

I swung Piercer at this moment! Yu Liang quickly grew a new tentacle after the last one was cut off, and it entangled itself with Piercer!

Gaoqin Jiuye’s gaze seemed a little unfocused, probably because of the powerful effect of that paralyzing slime!

I looked at him anxiously, but I could not stop him from using the last of his energy to exit the room and look for Si Luo in the other room!

Jiao S was now seated on the ground, paralyzed, and her sword dropped to the floor with a clang! Her eyes were also beginning to lose focus!

“What drug did you use on them!” I said coldly . At the same time, I tried to use MF to stimulate Piercer, so that it will come alive .

Yu Liang gave me a cold look . “The name of this slime on the tentacle is ‘Intoxicate’, and it takes effect in just a few seconds . Everyone who gets

into contact with it will lose their awareness and be unable to freely use their MF!”

I tightened my grip and used more than 20 MF on Piercer, trying to get it out of the restraint that was Yu Liang’s tentacle!

I felt a sudden chill in my palm!

I felt a sudden chill in my palm!

I had a bad feeling!

Piercer glowed with a violet light, and a bone-chilling cold invaded every inch of my body!

Piercer is trying to take control of me!

I heard a cold, evil-sounding female voice in the back of my head say, “You think you’re worthy?”

I had no time to think about what these words meant . Using my left hand, I drew an arrow and stabbed my right arm with it!

Pu-sst!

Blood sprayed out, and the pain-inducing agent that was on the arrow attacked my senses!

The immense pain countered Piercer’s horrible chill, and I could move my wrist again!

Violet light appeared in a thunderous strike! There was no stopping the attack, and Yu Liang’s tentacle was being burnt!

Yu Liang did not rest, and the tentacle from his other hand let go of Jiao S!

As the tentacle let go, Jiao S collapsed onto the floor, and that tentacle was charging straight for me!

It was as fast as lightning, I could not dodge it!

In an instant, a sudden bright light engulfed the entire room!

My vision turned hazy, and it was no longer the scene in the room!

Crash!

Boom!

It was an ocean with roaring currents!

It was an ocean with roaring currents!

I thought of who it was almost immediately, and a figure appeared in the air .

Guan Nie was pale, and he looked almost translucent, as if it was extremely difficult for him to maintain this illusion .

I was standing on a rock, and Yu Liang was standing on a similar rock not far from me!

Si Luo was lying on a rock to my left with his eyes closed, and beside him was Gaoqin Jiuye, on all fours due to paralysis, who kept trying to wake Si Luo!

Jiao S was lying at my feet with a lost look and wide open eyes!

The floating Guan Nie's sorrowful gaze landed on Gaoqin Jiuye's figure . "I sensed that you were in danger and I rushed over . Even when I'm trying my best to help you and using so much of my MF, you still only look at him..."

His voice was soft and light, and it almost could not be heard amidst the roaring currents in the ocean, but I could hear it!

Yes, Guan Nie was in the Eastern District . He returned to the Eastern District after being wounded in that battle!

He probably already discovered that Gaoqin Jiuye arrived in the Eastern District, but instead of showing up, he just observed Gaoqin Jiuye from afar!

Gaoqin Jiuye seemed to have also heard Guan Nie's voice, as he seemed to spend a great deal of effort to turn back and look at Guan Nie . There was immense guilt in his eyes, but his lips were arched in a way that did not show any regret!

This was his decision, and he would never regret this!

Guan Nie gave a beautiful and heart-breaking smile, endless sorrow reflected in his eyes .

Turbulent waves rocked the ocean!

Yu Liang's tentacles were healed now and they were charging towards me!

Piercer was thrown to the side, and I lifted both hands as I focused my MF on them!

Making use of the illusion, I focused MF on my two hands and as I raised my arms, and the water from either side of the rock I was standing on rose to form two pillars!

I put my hands together, and the pillars of water slammed together, creating a complete screen of water in front of me, blocking Yu Liang's tentacles which were coming toward me!

Making use of the illusion, I focused MF on my two hands and as I raised my arms, and the water from either side of the rock I was standing on rose to form two pillars!

I put my hands together, and the pillars of water slammed together, creating a complete screen of water in front of me, blocking Yu Liang's tentacles which were coming toward me!

I gritted my teeth and used 10 more MF on my hands, and clasped my hands as if in prayer!

The screen of water receded, turning into a giant pillar of water which charged towards Yu Liang, throwing him back some distance!

He flew as the pillar of water hit him!

The rage in my eyes could no longer be hidden, and I focused all my MF on my hands!

The floating Guan Nie was still translucent, and his sorrowful eyes were still on Gaoqin Jiuye's figure . He suddenly spat a mouthful of blood!

Crash!

As the blood sprayed onto the ocean, it started to shake!

Not good! The illusion was about to be broken!

The water beneath my feet was still roaring, and the pillar of water I was controlling with my MF tilted to the side!

Yu Liang wanted to avoid my attack, but the rock beneath him was smashed by a wave of Guan Nie's hand!

His other hand lifted towards the sky, as if he was attempting to join forces with me to defeat Yu Liang before the illusion broke!

Seawater rose up high as he raised his hand, and it crashed towards Yu Liang!

But Guan Nie's gaze looked unsteady, and he spat out another mouthful of blood!

It was obvious that his MF was greatly damaged in the previous battle, and he was forcefully using his MF to maintain this illusion . Such a method puts extra pressure on MF, and it will just cause more damage to the consciousness!

I gritted my teeth and tried to activate the MF I had left . Before this attack ends, I would not be able to regain all that MF!

But as I was trying to focus all my MF, darkness blanketed my eyes, and it felt as if I was going to fall backwards!

Chapter 144

144 Hanging On to Life

A feeling of extreme unease enveloped me, and in a second, I realized why it was so .

As a body of consciousness, my MF was already weakened since I did not sleep for days on end . Just like a tightly-strung bow, I was forcing myself to use my MF almost to its breaking point!

Using such a high amount of MF so suddenly pushed it further towards its breaking point, and while I forcefully used what was left of my MF, my consciousness started to crumble!

There was nothing but darkness around me, but I was still able to make out their shadows in this infinite blackness!

I felt Guan Nie's illusion falling apart, and with fresh blood staining his chin, I saw his translucent body looking like a shredded paper man, slowly floating down towards Gaoqin Jiuye .

Gaoqin Jiuye seemed to be trying to reach out to him, but no matter how hard he tried, he could only move a single finger .

Jiao S could not move an inch . She was totally immobilized and could only stare up into the air with her huge eyes as she lay on the rock .

Yu Liang did not give up on his attack even when the illusion was already falling apart . However, a dark shadow suddenly appeared behind him .

That shadow felt familiar, and I tried to remember where I had seen it before . I kept staring at it, but I just could not get a clear focus on it .

I felt a horrible pain at the back of my mind, and I knew at this moment that I had used up all of my energy .

I lost my consciousness at this point .

“This is called a butterfly kiss . ” I heard a familiar and enchanting voice .

My eyes snapped open .

I was dreaming .

I was not able to participate in this dream probably because too much of my MF had already been used up . I could only look on as an audience .

I was trying to tell myself to wake up from the dream . There was no spare time for me to be dreaming right now . The rest are not able to fight currently, and that dark shadow which appeared, could that have been him...

No...

Wake up...

This did not seem to work at all, and the scene in front of my eyes was clear as day .

This is...

The laboratory .

It was the laboratory at the end of the hallway that Gao Qi had previously brought me to .

The ‘me’ in the dream was facing Gao Qi, and we were both seated .

Gao Qi took both ‘my’ hands in his, and I could see that ‘I’ was about half a head shorter than him . Gao Qi leaned forward, towards ‘my’ face, with a smile .

‘I’ had a shy expression on my face, and ‘I’ looked down . ‘My’ lashes fluttered, and ‘my’ eyes finally closed . Gao Qi’s thin and cold lips then landed above ‘my’ right eye .

“This, is called the butterfly kiss,” Gao Qi said softly as he kissed ‘my’ right eye tenderly .

‘My’ lips trembled slightly as ‘I’ said, “Senior Gao... Qi...”

“No, don’t call me senior, just call me Qi...” His voice was enchanting, and his eyes were shining with an enticing light . Still on ‘my’ eye, his lips moved as he answered .

“Qi...” ‘I’ muttered .

Gao Qi finally moved back a little, putting a minor distance between ‘my’ eye and himself .

“I gave my favorite thing a very nice name . ”

“What’s it called?” ‘I’ opened my eyes slowly, and it looked like ‘I’ did not want the previous moment to end .

“Shen Qi...”

I felt a brutal chill from the bottom of my heart, and I tried again to wake myself up...

What kind of dream is this...

All dreams in the Split Zone are memories from when we were alive...

But why did I not remember a single thing...

But why did I not remember a single thing...

“I’ll show you ‘Shen Qi’ the next time you come over to the laboratory . ”
Gao Qi promised with a smile .

Wake up...

The scene then changed abruptly .

‘I’ went back to my room on my own, and I was met with huge red graffiti on my door .

‘Go to hell crazy person’

As I was still in shock, the door opened suddenly . The person who opened the door was obviously shocked by me standing there .

“Ah!”

“You scared me!”

She stared at ‘me’ angrily, and walked away while avoiding ‘me’, as if afraid ‘I’ would infect her, only to call out again as she was rudely surprised by the red graffiti on the door as she turned back .

She then walked back towards the door . Another girl came out as she heard all the noise .

“What’s happening?”

The girl who came out earlier pointed at the door .

It was now the other girl’s turn to be surprised by me .

The girl who came out earlier then pointed at ‘me’, telling the other girl, “We’d also be seen as lunatics if we keep rooming with this crazy person . ”

The other girl seemed to have a friendlier demeanor, and she nudged the girl slightly, signaling for her to not be so direct about it in front of ‘me’ .

The girl who was nudged then got angry . “What’re you afraid of? Do you know who she pissed off? Duff, the principal’s daughter! I heard that for our class, there’s only one vacancy for scholarship applications this year!

It's all because of her! We'd be embroiled in this matter sooner or later since we're roommates with her!"

"How could that be... And why would Duff hate her anyway..."

"It's because this crazy person got together with the most handsome senior in school, the one Duff attempted to pursue but failed . To let others know that Duff, the principal's daughter, isn't even comparable to a crazy person, how embarrassing would that be?"

"But isn't this too much..."

"But isn't this too much..."

"This isn't too much, look at the words on the door!"

"Ah! What, I didn't even realize it!"

"We should leave this place as soon as we can, to rid ourselves of this bad luck!"

A crowd was beginning to form along the corridor as students started poking their heads out to see what the commotion was all about .

'I' was still standing there expressionless, and 'I' did not say anything either .

Another girl then stepped out of the room suddenly .

'My' expression changed slightly .

It was Pomelo .

Pomelo stared at the two girls coldly . "Nobody is stopping you if you want to leave . She does have a mental illness, but she's still ten thousand times better than the both of you . Look at you two, one looking like a prostitute with that thick make up you put on every day, and the other a bitch who knows nothing about filial piety, ordering her parents around through the

phone all day long . What right do the two of you have to talk like this? She has mental issues, but you guys are just rotten to the core . ”

“What the eff are you saying?” One girl pointed at Pomelo angrily .

Pomelo scoffed . “I’m effing talking about you, prostitute . ”

The girl was incensed, and using both her hands, she shoved Pomelo back into the room . Though the other girl was not as fierce, it was obvious she was angry with Pomelo, and she walked into the room quickly, as if she wanted to argue with Pomelo .

‘I’ followed behind them silently, closing the door behind me as I entered the room .

I looked at ‘me’ . ‘My’ face was without any expression, and ‘my’ eyes were on the other three in the room . It looked like I was just a stranger to this situation, as if it was totally not because of me that these girls started arguing .

“Say that again if you dare . I’m telling you, Jiang You, I’ve had enough of you . You’re always together with this mad woman, I’m really effing down on my luck to be rooming with you two! Since we’re already at this point, don’t blame me for not taking our relationship as roommates into consideration!” (T/n: Jiang You is Pomelo’s full name . Li Shen usually refers to her with her nickname, You Zi, which means Pomelo .)

Huh, relationship as roommates .

The other girl chimed in, “That’s right, Jiang You . You didn’t have to say things like that . We weren’t going to do anything to her anyway . ”

Pomelo smirked . “Since you guys have had enough of me, how about I help you dig your dirty eyeballs out? No need to be in a rush to tell me what to do, I haven’t even ripped your faces out yet . ”

“Fuck you, this bitch is really in need of a beating!” One of the girls was enraged at this point, and she was ready to throw a chair at Pomelo .

Pomelo smirked . “Since you guys have had enough of me, how about I help you dig your dirty eyeballs out? No need to be in a rush to tell me what to do, I haven’t even ripped your faces out yet . ”

“Fuck you, this bitch is really in need of a beating!” One of the girls was enraged at this point, and she was ready to throw a chair at Pomelo .

Anger usually makes a person stronger . That chair was already light to begin with, and it made a whooshing sound as it was lifted up .

‘I’ stepped forward to be in front of the girl, shielding Pomelo behind me .

Pomelo looked shocked for a brief moment, but in an instant, cruelty appeared in her eyes .

The chair crashed onto ‘my’ back, and I let out a muffled cry while ‘my’ eyes remained cold and calm .

Pomelo pushed ‘me’ away, and grabbing a thin shirt hanging on the chair to her right, she started walking quickly towards that girl who threw the chair on me .

She pushed the girl onto the floor, and got on top of her in a flash .

The shirt was pulled into a long string, and she was starting to strangle the girl by the neck .

The other girl was so shocked at the scene that she did not even call out .

“Urgh...” The girl was now being strangled by Pomelo, but Pomelo simply looked on coldly, with an evil malice in her eyes .

Her hands were strong, and she continued pulling that shirt in opposite ends while she stepped on that girl’s hair, which was now spread on the floor .

After being pushed away, ‘I’ seemed to be off-kilter for a few moments, but after regaining ‘my’ balance, ‘I’ walked over quickly to be by Pomelo’s side .

‘I’ bent down in a half-squat to hold onto Pomelo’s arm, saying my first words in this dream, “Leave it . ”

Pomelo loosened her grip slightly and looked towards ‘me’ .

A light flashed in her eyes .

Cough cough *Cough cough cough* The girl had no strength to push Pomelo away, who was still sitting on her . She could only cough as she held onto her neck .

Pomelo looked at ‘me’ for a brief moment, before saying, “I’ll leave it since you said it . ”

“Aren’t you lucky to have hung on to your dear life because of this crazy person . ” She stood up, looking down on the girl who was still curled up on the floor, coughing non-stop .

Chapter 145

145 Yu Liang's Intelligence

As I opened my eyes, all I could see was a pile of rubble .

That dream felt long, but not much time seemed to have passed .

I looked up to see the room we were originally in, and Jiao S and I were now able to see Gaoqin Jiuye and Si Luo through a huge hole in the wall . Gaoqin Jiuye was beside Si Luo, who looked very peaceful with his eyes shut .

Jiao S was still lying on the floor, and Guan Nie was crouched near Gaoqin Jiuye, spitting out mouthfuls of blood .

I struggled to get up, and I saw Yu Liang leaning against the wall below the window . It looked as if he was also gravely injured .

If I remember right, the last attack Guan Nie and I used on him did not inflict so much damage, so why was he hurt so badly?

I staggered over, squatting in front of him .

He looked up at me with an unfathomable smile, blood stains still visible on the corners of his lips . “Li... Li Shen, in the end, you’ll still lose what you’re most afraid of losing . No, actually, you’re already losing it now...”

A light appeared around him after he spoke .

Following that light, something like a layer of ice appeared above him, slowly encasing him and finally freezing him entirely .

He was just like a human frozen and encapsulated in amber . I touched that ice, but instead of feeling chilly, it felt like something at room temperature .

His eyes were still open .

“This, this is the split freeze . This is when one focuses all the remaining MF into the split symbol, using that energy to freeze everything around one’s body . It’s a defensive method where one encapsulates oneself within a protective layer . ”

Guan Nie explained with difficulty .

There was a look of hopelessness in those upturned eyes of his .

I was rather worried about him, and I rushed over to his side, trying to support the wobbly Guan Nie . “Are you okay? You look seriously hurt . ”

Guan Nie leaned on my shoulder, like a sickly female, but I could see the burning passion in his eyes, which were looking in Gaoqin Jiuye’s direction .

But he only managed a look before he fainted in my arms .

“Hey, Guan Nie!” I called out .

Gaoqin Jiuye was crouched beside Si Luo, and hearing me cry out, he forced himself to turn and look back at Guan Nie .

“Ugh...” Jiao S suddenly made a sound, but it looked like she was still paralyzed .

I took another look at Guan Nie . He had lost all consciousness and I could not do much for him right now . I lay him on the floor and ran over to Jiao S to help her up .

Gaoqin Jiuye seemed to be regaining mobility as well .

“The split freeze huh... Seems like that MF he used to paralyze us has also been frozen . ” As he said this, Gaoqin Jiuye shot a cold look at Yu Liang,

who looked like he was fossilized in amber . He tried to support Si Luo up, but Si Luo still had that calm and peaceful expression on his face, like a toddler who was in deep sleep, he did not look like he was about to wake up anytime soon .

Jiao S moved her neck stiffly . It seems as if they are recovering their mobility very quickly .

Jiao S moved her neck stiffly . It seems as if they are recovering their mobility very quickly .

“Doesn’t that slime on the tentacle cause paralysis? How can you guys move so quickly?” I looked at Gaoqin Jiuye, while helping Jiao S to loosen her joints .

Gaoqin Jiuye gave me a sideways look . “Because that wasn’t caused by any drug, the slime was MF itself . You can look at it like it’s a kind of filthy MF, once that MF is sullied, it can become something that can directly inflict a huge amount of damage . But if the body of consciousness can no longer use that MF, just like how he is now, or if they die, then such MF will lose its effectiveness as well . ”

“What’s wrong with Si Luo?” These were Jiao S’s first words after regaining her mobility .

Gaoqin Jiuye’s eyes darkened . “Yu Liang’s splitting key was inserted into his split symbol . ”

Shocked, I asked, “Yu Liang’s splitting key? But Si Luo isn’t Yu Liang’s soul splitter, would that key have any effect on Si Luo?”

Gaoqin Jiuye nodded gravely . “That is usually the case, but it’s different with Si Luo’s current condition . Let me explain it like this . To soul splitters, all the souls captured by us are called ‘heirs’, and once we engrave a split symbol onto the heirs, we’ll be able to obtain the power granted to us by the split symbol, and at the same time receive the curse of the split symbol . If the heir is able to find us and insert their splitting key into our

split symbol, they're effectively ending that curse by locking the split symbol, and they can then leave the Split Zone .

“As for us, since we're only left with half a split symbol, we'll have to find a new heir . Now that Si Luo is without an heir and there's currently no new heir for him, any splitting key will be able to freeze his split symbol and his consciousness . He will also continue to be in this state until the splitting key is taken out by that particular heir who inserted it . ”

Jiao S stood up after cracking her neck . “But now that Yu Liang froze himself with that split freeze, how do we help Si Luo recover?”

I understood what Gaoqin Jiuye was trying to get at from what he said, and that was also why he had such a grave expression .

“This means, Yu Liang has to personally do it for Si Luo to recover right? But now that Yu Liang is like this, how do we solve it?”

Gaoqin Jiuye looked at me . “From what I know, the split freeze is the final line of defense of any body of consciousness . So if the consciousness itself is not willing to undo it, there's nothing we can do . ”

... Nothing we can do .

“If the consciousness is willing? You mean Yu Liang can hear our conversation even in such a state?” I frowned .

“If the consciousness is willing? You mean Yu Liang can hear our conversation even in such a state?” I frowned .

Gaoqin Jiuye shook his head, saying, “I don't know . But he might be willing to do it if we can find Song Lu . ”

Song Lu...

Song Lu was taken away by Li Wen, and Li Wen seemed to be in cahoots with Du Yue . Where do I begin looking for Li Wen when I cannot even seem to find any traces of Du Yue!

Seems like the first thing we should do is to make a trip to the Northern District!

To be honest, I was making a selfish decision here . I did not know Si Luo that well, so it will be a lie if I said I wanted to help him recover because we were friends . In reality, my goals would be easier to fulfill with Si Luo helping me . Now that he had already agreed to help me out, it would be a huge loss if he could not do so .

I looked at Gaoqin Jiuye squarely . “Gaoqin Jiuye, only you can bring us to the Northern District now . How about you lead the way? Song Lu is with Li Wen, so we as long as we know where Li Wen is, we can definitely find Song Lu . And since Li Wen is Li Qing’s soul splitter, she’s definitely in the Northern District now . ”

Jiao S interrupted me, “Don’t you remember what Jie Pa said? You have to bring Yu Liang back to Jie Pa . ”

Yes, this was too complicated .

“There’d be no use bringing Yu Liang back to Jie Pa in this state . Since Si Luo is also not awake now, he won’t be able to bring us to the experimental grounds either . You’re the only one left . How about you work with us, go with us to the Southern District to look for the experimental grounds and bring back an experimental subject, and we can head for the Northern District after that to look for Song Lu . ”

Gaoqin Jiuye smirked . “Li Shen, everything is how you wish for it to be right now . You’re using this opportunity to get my help in saving that friend of yours, and you’re also able to borrow Jiao S’s and my abilities to help break into the Southern District’s experimental grounds . ”

I smiled . “That’s right . I have to say things have turned for the better . However, since this is for someone you want to protect . ” I pointed at Si Luo as I continued, “Even if you’re being used by me, I guess you don’t really mind it?”

Gaoqin Jiuye then narrowed his eyes at me . “Have you ever thought about why this friend of yours would suddenly appear?”

He pointed at Yu Liang, now encased in amber, as he spoke .

Gaoqin Jiuye then narrowed his eyes at me . “Have you ever thought about why this friend of yours would suddenly appear?”

He pointed at Yu Liang, now encased in amber, as he spoke .

“Could it be...” Jiao S and I looked at each other .

That’s right, why did Yu Liang suddenly appear?

Logically, if we were setting out to look for Yu Liang with a team led by Si Luo, Yu Liang should have been avoiding us instead . Furthermore, out of Jiao S, Gaoqin Jiuye, Si Luo and I, three of us were District Commanders, and Gaoqin Jiuye’s abilities were not to be trifled with . An ordinary individual would likely not be able to do any great harm to us, and if Yu Liang was alone, it would be almost equivalent to using an egg to fight with someone who had rocks . So why did he do that?

However, from that previous battle, Yu Liang did seem to be gaining the upper hand before Guan Nie appeared .

I looked towards the blood-stained Guan Nie, who was lying beautifully on the floor .

Gaoqin Jiuye followed my gaze, and he looked pained . “He’s gravely injured . We’ll need to go to the Northern District to find a healing expert among the soul splitters to save him .

“The slime on the tentacles is only one part of Yu Liang’s sullied MF . If Jiao S and I forcefully focused our MF, there was no way he could have gained the upper hand . Guan Nie’s appearance just made it all the more chaotic . But that’s not the point, the point is, why did Yu Liang still appear even though he would know this was a battle he cannot win?”

Gaoqin Jiuye looked at me as if he already knew the answer, but he still wanted me to say the words .

I took a deep breath . “Seems like his aim was to force us to look for Song Lu . This situation was probably what he had already anticipated . He came into the lion’s den and froze himself . In this way, he wouldn’t reveal where the experimental grounds were, but at the same time, he’d be able to force us into a position where we had to look for Song Lu in order to save Si Luo . ”

I marveled at Yu Liang’s equanimity and intelligence . This was probably all planned beforehand .

“Even someone as intelligent as him couldn’t find his lover on his own and had to resort to such methods to force us to find her instead . This will not be an easy task,” Gaoqin Jiuye said calmly .

Chapter 146

146 Not Going to Look for Him?

Jiao S nodded slowly . “That’s right, this is no easy task . But since it has already come to this, I guess we don’t have any choice . Guan Nie is gravely injured . Gaoqin Jiuye, you really don’t care about him at all?”

Though Guan Nie and Jiao S are working together because of their own personal goals, I could understand Jiao S’s desire in wanting to protect Guan Nie after having worked with him for such a long time .

Gaoqin Jiuye shot her a cold look . “Does it matter if I care about him or not? He’s not a child anymore . Does he still want to continue these extreme acts to attract my attention? He already knows that there’s no one else but Si Luo in my eyes . ”

After speaking, Gaoqin Jiuye seemed to steal a quick glance at me, as if he was less sure of himself .

Jiao S pointed at Guan Nie, saying, “He tried his best to help you, you can’t leave him like this . Since you said there’re soul splitters who can save him in the Northern District, how about you bring us there .

“We’ll first go to the experimental grounds to look for clues, then we’ll head for the Northern District to look for Song Lu . If Song Lu can get Yu Liang to return to his normal state, then we’ll be able to get Yu Liang to take his splitting key out and help Si Luo recover . ”

Gaoqin Jiuye looked towards me . “All of your friends, they’re really great at using this huh,” he pointed at his own head while speaking, words laced with sarcasm .

I understood his frustration at this . Before, he listened to no one and only did what he wanted to do, what his heart told him to do . But now, because of Yu Liang's tactics, we had no choice but to help him look for Song Lu . Furthermore, Si Luo is being held hostage in such a situation, and this situation was something that was extremely hard to accept for Gaoqin Jiuye . It was understandable that he was not happy about it at all .

But how do I consider his feelings at this point?

Originally, Jie Pa was waiting for me to bring Yu Liang back in order to take a proper look at an experimental subject and look for a feasible solution before we head to the Northern District to confront Du Yue, and also to find Song Lu and Laurel . Yu Liang's sudden appearance threw a wrench in the works, and right now, we could only head for the Northern District first to solve the current situation . Now that Nie Zun is no longer with me, and Huan Qing and party had gone missing, only Gaoqin Jiuye, Jiao S and I were left . It would be extremely tough if Gaoqin Jiuye does not work with us, especially when I was still unable to use Piercer very well .

Right now, my best option is to calm Gaoqin Jiuye down . I thus tried to speak to him as calmly as I possibly could, "This is our original route as well, just that it seems to be forced upon us right now . Don't forget that you've promised to help me find Zou An . How about we work together to solve this, since Huan Qing and his party are also missing right now . I'm sure you know that light is how Mr Blond transports people . This means that Huan Qing, Mi Fu and Ku Fei should be in the Northern District for now, for whatever reason it might be .

"Now that Si Luo is in a state of deep sleep, and he doesn't have an heir yet, if we don't head for the Northern District and his condition worsens, there might really be no way of saving him, since Mi Fu is not around . From the current situation, you'll still have to go with us to the Northern District, whether you're willing to work with us or not . "

Something flashed past Gaoqin Jiuye's eyes . "I'll definitely go, but all this just fell into place too nicely, and I can't help but suspect you . "

I lifted my brows as I smirked . “Suspect me? You can’t be thinking that I was working with Yu Liang on this, would you? If I was working with Yu Liang on this, would I still need to plan it in such a way?”

“But...” Gaoqin Jiuye narrowed his eyes at me . “When you lost your consciousness momentarily, Jiao S had also lost her fighting ability, and I didn’t forcefully activate my MF either . At that point, it was difficult for Guan Nie to even support himself, to the point that his illusion started to fall apart . So who inflicted so much damage upon Yu Liang?”

I frowned as I began to understand what he was trying to get at .

“How would I know . You said it yourself, I lost my consciousness momentarily . ” I looked at him, but my heart was doubtful .

I lost my consciousness because I went too many days without proper rest . That dream felt long, but it felt like I woke up rather quickly . But if I had lost all awareness and was in such a deep state of unconsciousness, how did I manage to wake up so quickly?

Gaoqin Jiuye kept his eyes on me . “Li Shen, at the point, I only saw a dark shadow pass in front of the window, and when I tried to focus on it, Yu Liang already collapsed on the floor . Dark shadows are pretty common here in the Split Zone, but if I remember right, Nie Zun is someone who loves wearing black, right?”

My heart skipped a beat .

Gaoqin Jiuye’s gaze was frigid . “After that battle, was it really like what you said? That he went missing, but actually he’s still trying to protect you secretly, or was this all just a sham, something that you designed, something that you planned together with him so that Mi Fu can escape?”

I found his words ridiculous and felt incredulous .

I found his words ridiculous and felt incredulous .

I will do whatever I want to do .

I walked towards Gaoqin Jiuye, who was currently still crouched on the floor beside Si Luo . I bent down slightly, looked him in the eyes and gave him a brilliant smile . “Gaoqin Jiuye, if I can find Nie Zun now, as long as he can return to my side, I don’t even care about anything else that’s happening . Instead of working with him secretly, to me, it’s more painful not being able to see him . I’m already too used to seeing him in front of me every day .

“Even if you wish that I did work with him secretly to help Mi Fu, it’s something that I wouldn’t do . This Li Shen isn’t so noble to the point that she can endure so many days without Nie Zun, just for a little girl . ”

For some reason, there was a clear agony in Gaoqin Jiuye’s eyes after hearing me say these words .

I was rather surprised at such a reaction .

He kept his cold eyes on me, with a slightly furrowed brow .

“You, really admire him . ” He seemed to be referring to Nie Zun .

Why did it feel like he was a little jealous? And to even say such words in this situation?

Jiao S walked over and pulled me away, addressing Gaoqin Jiuye, “We should stop wasting time discussing other matters . Si Luo will be in greater danger with every minute we waste . How about you help Ah Shen find Zou An quickly, so that she can wield Piercer again, and then we’ll head for the Southern District to look for the experimental grounds and clues, before going to the Northern District to solve all our problems . ”

Gaoqin Jiuye shifted his suspicion to Jiao S . “What I’m more interested in is that, Jiao S, aren’t you in love with Si Luo? Why do you not seem to be putting him as the first priority? Li Shen has her reasons for doing so, because she wants to save her friend, but how about you? Just why are you doing this?”

Jiao S's expressionless face seemed to turn a little livelier, but her smile still seemed rather unnatural . "She's doing this to save her friend, I'm doing this to help a friend . "

Jiao S's expressionless face seemed to turn a little livelier, but her smile still seemed rather unnatural . "She's doing this to save her friend, I'm doing this to help a friend . "

She looked at me after saying that .

I felt a rush of warmth in my chest .

A light flashed past Gaoqin Jiuye's eyes as he looked at me . "Li Shen, you really have many protectors . "

I laughed . "I would say I'm quite a selfish character, so it's just nice that I'm playing the role of someone who's protected . I'm not as noble as you though, you've always played the role of the protector, to the point that you don't even care if you hurt others while protecting someone . "

My eyes swept past the prone Guan Nie very briefly .

I initially did not want to rile Gaoqin Jiuye up like this, but for some reason, when he starts taking an aggressive stance, I just wanted to fight back . We were like two hedgehogs about to freeze to death, and the only way to keep ourselves warm was to use all our spines to prick at each other .

Jiao S walked over to Guan Nie's side, looking at him with slight sadness in her eyes . "Poor thing, your persistence does not lose to mine . Seems like I didn't know you well enough..."

Gaoqin Jiuye's gaze wavered, and there seemed to be a split second where I could see exhaustion in his eyes .

I felt a bitterness in my heart . It was definitely not easy for this proud man . There was nobody he offended, but there was still no way to cure that loneliness, and the people around him even had to get hurt .

I gritted my teeth inwardly and told myself that I cannot feel any sympathy for Gaoqin Jiuye, because he is a soul splitter, and he was the one who captured me .

I looked at the quiet Yu Liang, Si Luo and Guan Nie, and that sympathy was overwhelmed by various other emotions .

What did Guan Nie do wrong? Why did he have to face this?

I looked at the quiet Yu Liang, Si Luo and Guan Nie, and that sympathy was overwhelmed by various other emotions .

What did Guan Nie do wrong? Why did he have to face this?

Si Luo is someone who seems to ask nothing of this world . Though he is a soul splitter, he probably wouldn't have been embroiled in this if he did not have other desires .

And Yu Liang .

He's just an innocent bystander . I know him, he treats me well and I know that he isn't a bad person .

Just like how my heart felt like it was stabbed a thousand times after losing Nie Zun, I could understand how desperate he must have felt when he lost Song Lu, his long-time lover .

I wouldn't be surprised if such a loss caused him to change greatly .

His love for her is so deep that he would sacrifice himself by going into the lion's den like this, just for the simple aim of trying to get us to look for Song Lu .

“Heh... He appeared again... Why don't you chase after him to ask why he's avoiding you...” A feminine face appeared in the night sky beside the window, looking at me lazily .

“How about it? You're really not going to look for him first? Uncovering the secret of the soul splitters, saving people, put these aside and go look for

him . I know that's what you want to do..."

That face, which looked exactly like mine, was looking at me with a smile .

Chapter 147

147 Disfigurement

My hands tightened into fists as I looked at this audacious, smiling face . I shot towards the window, pouncing at her .

Gaoqin Jiuye and Jiao S were visibly bewildered at my actions .

She was gone in a moment . My heart instantly felt heavy, and I started to pool my MF on the bottom of my feet .

I hopped onto the windowsill . My red hair billowed in the wind and my fiery red dress flew in all directions as I jumped out of the building .

It was still night .

I ran as fast as I could in the darkness, going towards where my instincts led me to, not caring about anything else .

As I ran, I took in the sights within the visibility field of 10 square meters, absolutely sure of where I was going, absolutely sure of my target .

I felt it .

She would not have appeared without any reason . I can feel it .

As I ran, the wind howled in my ear, and a few strands of hair were caught on my lips . I continued running forward, not paying it any heed .

Wherever it was, it was always dark at night, just an infinite blackness .

As that feeling started to dissipate, I cried out into the air .

“Nie Zun—!”

There was no answer .

It’s him, I know that it’s him! It must be him!

She’s right, I have to find him! How could I lose him!

The wind stung my eyes as I continued running .

“Ah!”

Anxious and desperate, I was not able to balance the MF properly under my feet, and I fell onto the ground .

“I’m really useless!” I sat on the ground with my hands balled into fists, and I started punching the stone ground!

Once, twice, three times .

The skin on my hands started to tear, but I had no intention of stopping even when blood started seeping out .

“You’re useless! You felt him!” I continued hitting the ground, frustrated at myself .

I did not stop even when the ground was stained with blood .

My arms were numb, and my fists could not heal in time as I simply kept on disintegrating them by smashing them into the ground .

“Ah—!”

I focused my MF into my right hand, and the ground cracked as I smashed my fist into it .

I cried out involuntarily, and as I looked down, I saw my right wrist twisted in a weird angle, the bone utterly smashed . As my hands were balled up, my fingers were also deformed . My pinky finger was the one closest to the

ground . Looking at it, I had only half a pinky finger left as it was already broken . I could feel my fingers crying out as they healed .

“That’s enough!”

A dark shadow then appeared out of nowhere, pulling me up abruptly!

I felt a little dizzy due to how fast I was pulled up!

I heard this warm and enchanting voice in my ear, “Why are you hurting yourself!”

I still felt dizzy, and all I could see was a blurry figure in the dark . I did not think any further and simply stretched out my bloody hands, taking the dark figure in an embrace, not willing to let go!

I’m never letting go!

That dark figure seemed to react to my embrace, trying to struggle out of it . I bit on his shoulder as hard as I could!

“Ah...” He let out a low-pitched cry .

A tear escaped from the corner of my eye .

I continued biting on his shoulder, not loosening my grip on him, afraid that he would run away again .

A gentle and warm voice said, “Why do you have to do this...”

I stopped biting on his shoulder and pushed him hard! I stared at him angrily . “Why? How could you leave me! How could you bear to leave me!”

I stopped biting on his shoulder and pushed him hard! I stared at him angrily . “Why? How could you leave me! How could you bear to leave me!”

My tears started falling . Behind that curtain of tears blurring my vision, I no longer saw that same pair of starry eyes .

His eyes... His face...

The Nie Zun in front of me now had a black pupil on the right, but his left eye was a menacing, bright red!

There was a darkness in that red, it was startling! That darkness seemed to be alive, as if someone put a black curse into that red eye!

He had different colored pupils!

And his face...

There were scars of various sizes on his face, and these hideous scars were savagely embedded into his flesh!

He still had those thin, wispy bangs . It hid part of that black pupil of his, and it also hid the vulnerability and avoidance in his eyes .

As he looked at my astonished face, there was this resoluteness that appeared in his eyes, and he turned to leave .

Without hesitation, I grabbed his hand!

He was still wearing that pair of black gloves on his hands!

I grabbed his hand, wanting to speak, but...

Why did this hand feel...

Astounded, I pulled away the glove on his left hand! He tried to pull away quickly, but I focused on my MF to grab him tight!

I pulled his left glove out, revealing that slim and white hand of his! But there were only two fingers on this hand!

His index, middle and ring finger were all gone! They all looked like they had been hacked away neatly! There was only a thumb, and that pinky finger with a skull ring on his left hand!

Shocked, I did not know how to react to this situation . I looked up at him, only to see pain and self-loathing in his eyes!

When did my Nie Zun have such a look? I had never seen such a look on him!

I felt worried and scared, and I grabbed his arm . Shaking my head, I said, “This, this... Just what happened...”

As if he felt my hands trembling, or as if he misunderstood the reason behind my trembling hands, a deep sorrow appeared in his eyes .

As if he felt my hands trembling, or as if he misunderstood the reason behind my trembling hands, a deep sorrow appeared in his eyes .

“No...” I felt a wave of unease and a feeling of impending danger . I kept shaking my head and tried to gain a tighter grip on him!

My hands were starting to hurt because of how tightly I held onto his arm, but I was not about to give him an opportunity to leave me again!

In this instant, that uncanny red left pupil of his started to rotate .

“No...” I was still shaking my head . For some reason, I felt extremely uneasy!

As I looked at that rotating red eye of his, my hands started to lose their strength .

“No!” I cried out as I finally realized what he was doing!

At this point, I focused all my MF onto my hands . My index finger was like a sharp blade, piercing through his black sleeves, embedding itself into the flesh of his arm!

My finger was already close to bone, but I held it steady like a pincer . I don't care if this was painful for him, I won't let go even if it was!

I, Li Shen, will never let go!

However, no matter how hard I tried, no matter how much MF I focused onto my hands, to the point that I heard my shoulder blades cracking under the pressure, I started to feel faint under that ability of his!

It felt as if I was about to lose something extremely important, and tears rolled down my cheeks as I felt like I was about to lose all awareness .

“No... Don't leave me...” I was almost begging him, choking on my words . He was biting on those pale lips of his . I felt devastated as I looked at his hopeless gaze, full of agony .

In the end, he was still able to use his ability to immobilize me, leaving me .

My head was still fuzzy, and I saw that he looked at me with a gaze that felt like it would be the last time I saw him .

Following which, he disappeared into the darkness . He was gone .

“No—!”

Still under the influence of his ability, I was not fully functional yet, and that cry felt like it tore my throat apart . I heard a whirring sound in my brain, as if there was something inside which suddenly stopped functioning, something that suddenly broke .

I collapsed onto my knees .

“Nie... Nie Zun!”

A figure appeared behind me in the darkness, grabbing me .

“Li Shen! Li Shen, what's wrong!”

A figure appeared behind me in the darkness, grabbing me .

“Li Shen! Li Shen, what’s wrong!”

Gaoqin Jiuye took me in a tight embrace from behind, trying to pull me up .
But my knees felt weighed down with a thousand pounds, and they
stubbornly stuck to the ground!

I tried hard to struggle out of his embrace! But he did not loosen his grip!

I tried my very best to get out!

I felt like I was at the edge of my sanity!

“Let go of me! I’m going to find him! I want to look for him!”

“AAHHHHHHH!”

I cried out as I did not manage to escape, and there was no other way for me
to express the pain I felt!

“Li Shen, calm down! Who’re you talking about!” Gaoqin Jiuye sounded
worried and anxious!

“Nie Zun! It’s Nie Zun! Let go of me! I want Nie Zun!”

I finally escaped from those clutches of his, but I just fell onto my face as I
attempted to run towards the direction Nie Zun went in! My MF was
previously all focused onto my hands, and I could not balance the MF under
my feet in time .

“Ah!” I smashed the ground with my fists!

I hate that I’m so useless!

Bam!

Crack!

The bones on both my wrists broke!

Jiao S had caught up now, and seeing me like this, she ran over immediately, trying to help me up!

But I struggled to escape from her!

I heard Gaoqin Jiuye's voice from behind . "Think of a way to stop her! She's gone too many days without rest and she's been forcefully using too much of her MF . If she can't control her emotions at this point, it will cause permanent damage to her MF!"

Jiao S's eyes turned sharp after she heard this, and with that gaze, the air around me started to freeze!

That frozen air began to encase me . The air currents felt chilly but warm at the same time, trying to get me to calm down!

Chapter 148

148 Can't Live Without Him

“Calm down, Li Shen!” Jiao S shouted at me!

My mind was caught in a flurry of emotions, and I could not deal with losing Nie Zun a second time . It felt like the only reprieve to such agony was to inflict pain on myself, so that it could replace the pain in my heart!

I had never expected that I actually relied on Nie Zun so much that I could not pull myself out of this!

I hated him initially . I blamed him for all my shortcomings, and piled all that pain upon him, as if that was the only way for me to lessen the agony I felt . Even as a mental patient who had already been ostracized for years, I knew the problem did not lie with me . I love my family and my friends, so what right did this world have to abandon me and treat me like a monster?

Even if she shared a body with me, and there were two different personalities in me, who did I let down in all these years?

It was the world that let me down, while I only let one person down, the one I loved .

Yes, I killed Gao Qi and I am paying the price for it now, right here in this place .

But Nie Zun was not at fault . It was only until today did I realize, Nie Zun did not do any wrong .

He felt even lonelier than me, but who did he blame for it?

Everyone avoided him when he was alive, and even here in the Split Zone .
He did not do any wrong!

Even if everyone around him ended up dying, this didn't mean that he caused those deaths! What did he do wrong that people had to treat him in such a way?!

What did he do wrong that I had to treat him like this even after he arrived here in the Split Zone?!

He was always behind me, looking at me silently .

Now that I think about it, when was I ever lonely after arriving in the Split Zone? Never .

Because he was always by my side, always behind me .

Did anything harm me after I arrived in the Split Zone? Nothing .

I have my MF, and I was always being protected by him . I was never hurt .

He and Li Qing had always protected me, even when I became District Commander and received the support of the Western District residents .
There was nothing I was particularly unhappy with nor was there anything that upset me .

What bothered me was what happened when I was alive, my past . When I started my new life here in the Split Zone, there was nothing which caused me pain .

But this was not the case for Nie Zun . It was because of me that he ended up with a chance of getting hurt .

Nie Zun did not like to speak initially, and he was always silently following behind me . At that time, I gave him the cold shoulder, and I hated that I could always see him every time I turned back .

I had to admit that even though I hated it at the time, being able to see him every time I turned gave me a sort of security .

I had never felt secure before this, and this was something that others might not be able to empathize with .

I simply felt insecure when I alive . Every single person I see would almost always roll their eyes at me or avoid me as best as they can .

But after arriving in the Split Zone, those beautiful, starry eyes of his had always been on me .

Just what was it that blinded me so much that I could ignore such a feeling of security it gave me?

Think about it, if there would always be somebody by your side protecting you no matter what you do, who would hate such a thing?

As I thought about this, I clutched at Jiao S, crying . “I was wrong . I was always wrong . I can’t live without him...”

I saw a tenderness in Jiao S’s big eyes, and she took my hand in hers .

Yes, I was wrong .

Nie Zun was beside me as we had our meals, even though it made no difference to us if we ate or not .

Nie Zun was beside me as we slept, even though I was not afraid of the dark, I was afraid of being alone in the dark .

Because of Nie Zun, I did not have to work so hard to learn how to use MF, as I always felt that since we could not be separated, he would have to protect me since he could not leave this place if I died either .

He also said to me, ‘I will always protect you’ .

He also said to me, ‘I will always protect you’ .

Even up till now, he was still protecting me .

But what did I bring him?

From his initial silence, to how he started smiling more, to how he started making fun of me and being goofy, when did I ever think about the reasons behind these changes?

What did he think about every day? Did he want to leave the Split Zone? Was the tie between us a restriction to him? Did I ever consider his position at all?

I never did .

I never did anything for him . And I don't even know the reason he turned out this way today .

I knew nothing about him, while he was always protecting me .

I would rather die than go through this .

Now that I was here, I did not carry much hope . The only thing that was not a source of pain was the fact that he was always by my side, albeit it was forced upon us .

But he was leaving me for some unknown reason, and no matter how hard I tried, I could not make him stay .

What was my purpose of being here?

I looked at Jiao S without moving . “He’s no longer here, what’s the point of me being here?”

Jiao S did not speak, and I felt Gaoqin Jiuye grabbing my other hand, pulling me up from the ground!

I struggled! I had no strength left to stand!

In the end, I sat down in a heap on the ground, but he still did not let go of my hand .

Jiao S crouched in front of me, her long hair sweeping the ground . I could see worry in those huge eyes of hers .

Gaoqin Jiuye bent down, looking at me with a cold gaze . “What purpose? Li Shen, have you forgotten why you’re here? I’m telling you now, I didn’t force you to come here, you came here voluntarily! Because you’re running away, you’re avoiding the fact that you killed Gao Qi! Now you’re asking me about your purpose of being here . Does this mean that you’re finally sick of this place and you want to leave?”

Gaoqin Jiuye bent down, looking at me with a cold gaze . “What purpose? Li Shen, have you forgotten why you’re here? I’m telling you now, I didn’t force you to come here, you came here voluntarily! Because you’re running away, you’re avoiding the fact that you killed Gao Qi! Now you’re asking me about your purpose of being here . Does this mean that you’re finally sick of this place and you want to leave?”

“Why did you choose to stay then? Back when I gave you a chance to leave? Since you’re sick of this place, why didn’t you leave?!”

Gaoqin Jiuye was extremely agitated .

My tears were already dry by now, and I looked at him, stunned .

“Yes, why did I stay...” I muttered .

“Why can’t you be more like me? I’d rather let everyone down, rather than have everyone let me down . ” Gaoqin Jiuye looked at me with pained eyes .

“Why were you never selfish when you were alive? Even after arriving here, you’re still not allowing yourself to be selfish?”

I was still stunned . “What’re you talking about?”

Gaoqin Jiuye looked me in the eye squarely . “What I’m saying is that, you’ve never thought for yourself when you were alive, even when everyone let you down, ostracized you and hated you . If I were you, I’d kill every single one of them! But you, I should be happy that you finally killed him, but you kept blaming yourself, and you’ve avoided the matter by

escaping here! It's hell here! There's nothing wrong in killing him! Why did you have to go to hell?! Why can't you just be a little more selfish?"

Jiao S looked at Gaoqin Jiuye calmly, before taking another look at me .

My emotions began to stabilize because of Gaoqin Jiuye's sudden outburst and his words .

What did it mean by... thinking for myself when I was alive?

I grabbed him . "Just who are you, why do you know everything about me?"

Gaoqin Jiuye paused at my question, and that emotion and the fire in his eyes seemed to have been largely smothered .

His expression then changed in a second, to one that looked like it belonged to someone who had seen too much of this world and was already tired of it .

"Li Shen, have you fell in love with Nie Zun?"

"Have you fell in love with someone else again?"

His eyes were full of despair .

My heart hurt . Why did it hurt so badly?

His eyes were full of despair .

My heart hurt . Why did it hurt so badly?

It felt like an emotion that was usually ignored, but it was appearing now . I did not understand this, and I could not tell what it felt like .

Have I fallen in love with Nie Zun?

I turned to look at Jiao S . "I can't live without him . Help me look for him," holding her hand as I said so .

Jiao S looked at me, nodding slowly .

I felt Gaoqin Jiuye's hand turn stiff, and he let go of my hand abruptly .

“You said you will only love Gao Qi . ” He looked at me willfully .

I looked at him stubbornly, saying, “You also said you only care about Si Luo . ”

It was clear what I was trying to get at . Since you only cared about Si Luo, why are you being so pretentious right now? Weren't you always heartless and cruel, even towards me? If you brought me here just to gain power, why did you have to sympathize with me now?

I just want Nie Zun to return .

“I let Gao Qi down by killing him, and I'll make up for it in here forever . But I can't live without Nie Zun, and I'll definitely get him back . He's gravely injured and disfigured, and I should be protecting him now, so how could I let him leave all alone . ”

As I calmed down, I spoke resolutely, looking at Gaoqin Jiuye .

“He's disfigured?” Jiao S asked with a frown .

It hurt but I nodded, answering her . “I just saw him, and something's off about him . He was disfigured, and three of his fingers are gone . One of his eyes also turned red . ”

“Bodies of consciousness in the Split Zone don't usually get injuries that can't heal . Disfigurement and losing his fingers? Did he already become an experimental subject, and like Jie Pa, he's not able to heal?” Jiao S voiced her thoughts .

Gaoqin Jiuye asked abruptly, “I'll ask you again . Do you really not wish to leave this place?”

I smiled at him . “I've already told you, I'm not leaving . ”

Even if I wanted to, I wouldn't be doing it now .

Chapter 149

149 Bamboo Hat People

I grabbed Gaoqin Jiuye's hand, smiling at him as I held onto his palm tightly . "Gaoqin, bring me to Zou An, now . "

Gaoqin Jiuye's gaze narrowed .

Jiao S tried to stop me . "Ah Shen, we left Guan Nie in the building to chase after you . I'll need to go back to make sure he's being well settled . You shouldn't be rushing now either, you need rest . "

I shook my head . "No, there'd be a higher chance of Nie Zun leaving me the longer I wait . I need to head for the Northern District as quickly as I can . "

"How can you be sure that he's also headed for the Northern District? You saw him here today, so he's definitely still here now!" Jiao S's voice was getting higher-pitched, and she sounded rather strict, as if she was upset that I did not want to rest .

Jiao S's words reminded me of something else .

"Jiao S, get people to guard the border between the Eastern and Southern Districts, don't give Nie Zun any chance of leaving!"

Jiao S took a deep breath . "I'll definitely do that . But, Ah Shen, you have to know that Nie Zun, Yu Liang, and that weird octopus monster were all able to enter the Eastern District without the knowledge of my subordinates . So I'm afraid such security will not have any effect on them . "

I tried to suppress the anxiety and frustration I felt, trying to think of the most efficient way I could find Nie Zun .

The more I thought about it, the more tired I got . I didn't think too much about the tie between us before this, and I took it for granted that we would always be less than 500 meters away from each other . It was only now that I felt useless . It was so difficult for me to find him and to even take one look at him .

But I knew I had to remain calm in such situations .

I hugged my legs, slowing sitting down onto the floor, staring at it blankly .

I didn't realize that I was doing something so similar to what she did that day when she was drawing circles on the floor .

I spoke softly after looking at the floor for a while . “Jiao S, go take a look at Guan Nie first, he's probably really badly injured this time . Give me some time to think about this, I'll go look for you after . ”

Jiao S looked at me with worry . “But...”

All of a sudden, three figures appeared behind Jiao S .

I looked up, squinting at our visitors . They were in bamboo hats . Jiao S's expression changed slightly as she felt their presence, but I could not see her face as she turned around to face them .

Her voice was hoarse and low-pitched . “Why're the lot of you here instead of protecting the Eastern District?”

The me now was no longer as lazy as I was before Nie Zun's disappearance, and I started to put more thought into things recently . Even though I did not meet these three individuals very often, I do not remember hearing any of them speak .

But these figures were uncannily familiar . I narrowed my eyes as I observed the three of them . The funny thing is, no one spoke even after Jiao S asked the question .

Something was odd, and I slowly stood up . Those three did not move an inch .

Jiao S seemed to turn back a little, as if she felt my movement . She spoke in a low tone, “It’s okay, just say what you have to . ”

The one in the middle of the bamboo hat trio then spoke up .

It belonged to a male, and his voice sounded steady and dependable . “Our mission is to protect you . You’ve been too willful recently . We can’t let that happen from now on . ”

I narrowed my eyes at them again . This voice was so familiar, but I just could not recall who it belonged to .

Jiao S waved a hand . “No . I’ll definitely make this trip to the Northern District . Tao Lie and Mu Li are both stationed in the Western District now, and Guan Nie is badly injured . If the three of you leave with me, wouldn’t the Eastern District be left unprotected?”

The one in the middle continued, “Tao Lie and Mu Li are your top subordinates . Since you’ve already moved the most powerful people away from the Eastern District to protect the Western District, why are you worried about the Eastern District being unprotected?”

Jiao S seemed to be slightly annoyed at this, and her tone turned a little colder as she answered, “Huo, you know I wouldn’t let anyone in the Western District get hurt . ”

Jiao S seemed to be slightly annoyed at this, and her tone turned a little colder as she answered, “Huo, you know I wouldn’t let anyone in the Western District get hurt . ”

Though I was touched by her words, something was weird about it . It seemed as if it was not because of me that she said it?

Since she called the middle one Huo, looking at it now, they should be Feng, Huo and Lei, from left to right .

Three elements huh?

“Guan Nie’s injury is not that simple . He was already gravely hurt when he returned from the Western District, and after forcefully using his MF, his consciousness has almost crumbled . For some reason, he has also lost the will to live . Looking at the situation now, it might lead to his MF dissipating, and his split symbol might also peel off, leading to his death . You didn’t even inform us that you were back in the Eastern District, and if it were not for Guan Nie who felt your presence, we might still be kept in the dark about this . ”

Peeling of the split symbol?

I heard about this before . In the Split Zone, it is usually only through split symbols that one can die . However, if one’s MF is greatly damaged to the point that even the body of consciousness itself gives up on life, then the split symbol will peel off, and this ends the tie between their body of consciousness and their body in the real world, causing death . I’ve heard that this process is called the peeling of the split symbol, but I have never witnessed it .

This is rare in the Split Zone, as there are many who wish to die here, but most of them would want to drag somebody else together with them, and use the method of inserting their splitting key into another to achieve death . It was rare that someone just wanted to die without affecting any others, so I have never witnessed anyone whose split symbol peeled .

For one’s split symbol to peel, one has to lose all heart and will to survive before that process can even start . Even if they did not care much for the world, it was still very rare for anyone to have that mindset of giving up everything they have .

Was Guan Nie at such a stage?

I glanced at Gaoqin Jiuye, and I saw an infinite darkness in his eyes . I couldn’t tell what he was thinking about at this moment .

“There’re already signs of his split symbol peeling?” Jiao S asked immediately . She knew this was something serious .

Huo said, “Yes, his split symbol has already started to float up, and his MF is simply swimming around him, without a regular pattern . Who did he go up against back in the Western District? Why is his consciousness being invaded by a kind of dark emotion?”

Dark emotion?

I thought of something immediately .

I thought of something immediately .

Guan Nie’s original injury was inflicted by Nie Zun . At that time, Nie Zun was going for Gaoqin Jiuye in order to protect me, but Guan Nie wanted to protect Gaoqin Jiuye so badly that he probably didn’t think about defending himself . And Nie Zun...

Nie Zun used that pinky ring in his attack! That black skull ring!

Yes, I found that ring familiar, but I don’t recall where I had seen it!

Nie Zun’s hands had the ability to invade the consciousness of others, and anyone in contact with his hands would feel a menacing pressure upon their consciousness . How about that ring? From what I remembered on that day, that ring produced a black and red ray which made everyone cringe in fear . Guan Nie was stabbed through the chest with that ray .

Was that darkness inflicted upon Guan Nie through the ring?

Though I always knew Nie Zun had monstrous power, I did not know how far he could go . From Guan Nie’s condition, it was definitely terrifying .

Because of this, I definitely had to look for him . I had to find out what exactly happened to him!

I spoke abruptly, “He’s injured by someone under me, and I’m willing to take responsibility for that . There’s someone good at healing in our district,

so how about bringing him to the Western District?”

The bamboo hat trio did not move, but the one on the left, who was most likely Feng, spoke . “Miss Li Shen is referring to Jie Pa?”

I was slightly stunned . Why did his voice sound exactly the same as that of Huo’s?

Suspicion began to grow in me .

Huo spoke, “If it’s Jie Pa that Miss Li Shen is referring to, there’s no need . Jie Pa will not be able to save Guan Nie . Right now, there’s only one person who can save Guan Nie, and that person is a soul splitter who is currently in the Northern District . ”

I remained silent, waiting for them to continue .

Jiao S interrupted Huo, “Though Guan Nie’s injuries are major, the most serious injury is psychological . If his heart is not well, what use would it be if we bring him to the Northern District?”

She looked at Gaoqin Jiuye clearly as she spoke, as if she was placing the blame on him .

Jiao S interrupted Huo, “Though Guan Nie’s injuries are major, the most serious injury is psychological . If his heart is not well, what use would it be if we bring him to the Northern District?”

She looked at Gaoqin Jiuye clearly as she spoke, as if she was placing the blame on him .

I could not make out Gaoqin Jiuye’s expression clearly in the dark, and he had been rather quiet after the bamboo hat trio made their appearance .

I looked at him standing there in the dark silently, and for some reason, I thought of Nie Zun again .

My heart hurt at such a thought, it was just too painful to bear .

Gaoqin Jiuye finally spoke after hearing the sarcasm in Jiao S's words, "How long does Guan Nie have?"

Huo answered, "Seven days at the maximum, unless we find that person in the Northern District . I'm sure no further explanation is needed from us as for who that person is . Mr Gaoqin Jiuye should know it very well . "

Oh? This is starting to get interesting . Why did it seem like I was the only one who did not have the slightest idea about the Northern District and the people there?

Jiao S might not know either, but seeing that these subordinates of hers are no ordinary individuals, she would've probably got all her intel from them .

Just who are these three individuals? Why did I find their voices so familiar?

"Then we'll go to the Northern District and find him to save Guan Nie in seven days . "

Gaoqin Jiuye sounded so sure when he spoke, as if there was nothing that could change this decision of his .

I did not have much to disagree with, since I wanted to go to the Northern District as quickly as possible .

"You guys can't come with us," Jiao S told the three suddenly .

Chapter 150

150 The Whirling Forest

“If we don’t follow, how are you going to protect the three of them?”

That’s right, Yu Liang, Si Luo and Guan Nie were not conscious . How do we bring these three individuals with us?

Jiao S looked towards Gaoqin Jiuye . “You know how to use air currents to take someone with you right? You can take Si Luo, and I’ll take Guan Nie .”

Gaoqin Jiuye looked at me .

I nodded . “You can take Si Luo . Jiao S, help me get someone to send Yu Liang back to Jie Pa in the Western District . ”

“If you’re sending Yu Liang back, why do I still need to bring Si Luo with me?”

I stared at him . “I’m not intending for you to bring Si Luo to the Northern District . Do you think the three of us should be bringing two deadweights along? What I intend to do is to leave Si Luo in the Southern District as we pass by, then we can head for the Northern District to look for Song Lu, before going back to save Yu Liang and Si Luo . ”

Huo suddenly spoke, “There’s no need to worry . If the person who can save Guan Nie can be found in the Northern District, you’ll be able to find someone who knows how to teleport . Even if you left these two individuals here, they can be transported over at that point . ”

I raised my brow, asking, “May I know how the three of you know so much about the Northern District?”

Unexpectedly, Jiao S had a similarly doubtful expression on her, and she looked at these three loyal subordinates of hers with suspicion .

I took a quick glance at Jiao S, wondering if she was simply acting .

No, that couldn’t be . It’s unlikely that she’s lying to me .

However, these are subordinates who’ve been with her for so long . Was she really unaware of who they were and what they knew?

Feng, who was standing on the left, spoke . “Miss Li Shen, it’s understandable that someone in your noble position will forget minor things . There’s no need for us to make too much introduction about ourselves . ”

I smirked . “What? Understandable that someone in my noble position will forget minor things? Aren’t you guys too unreasonable about this? You don’t even dare to show your face, and you blame it on me?”

Feng shook his head, bamboo hat wobbling as he did so . “If Miss Li Shen did not forget, then you would have been able to identify us when you heard our voices . ”

I was speechless . From this, I could tell I definitely would know who these people were .

There were three of them . Two of them had identical voices, and I should know them . Fine, I am the forgetful one . But I’m no noble, I’m just unlucky .

My mind worked quickly . Now that it is likely that Nie Zun was still in the Eastern District, and Gaoqin Jiuye and Jiao S both felt that the priority was in heading for the Northern District, should I be asking for assistance from these three?

I smiled sweetly at the three . “My mind seems to be rather slow these days . How about this, I lost a friend in the Eastern District, and I know all of

you have extraordinary abilities since you've followed Jiao S for so many years . Might I request for your assistance in locating this person?"

Feng answered speedily, "You're referring to Nie Zun?"

My face froze . It was hard for me to remain calm when I heard his name .

Huo continued, "Nie Zun should already be on his way out of the Eastern District, and he'll probably be at the Southern District's border line at daybreak . If Miss Li Shen were to go after him now, you might be able to meet him in the Southern District . "

This sounded rather sarcastic when he said it . I answered in a cold voice, "Since all of you knew, why didn't you stop him?"

Lei, the third individual in the bamboo hat finally spoke this time . "Miss Li Shen, our job is to protect Miss Jiao S . It is not to protect the Eastern District, nor to protect you . "

Jiao S's gaze shifted .

I shrugged and laughed . "That's true . Now it seems like I'm asking too much of you guys . "

"Miss Li Shen is used to taking things in her stride and doing things without too much ceremony . We believe that as long as Miss Li Shen puts her heart and mind to it, you definitely wouldn't need us to help look for Nie Zun . "

My smile slowly faded .

Jiao S waved her hand, interrupting our conversation . "Enough, let's stop discussing this . Since we're all basically going for the same goal, we should be heading for the Southern District now . You guys, go to that building we were in and get someone to send Yu Liang back to the Western District . Bring Si Luo and Guan Nie here . It's going to be daybreak soon, and we'll set off then . "

Jiao S waved her hand, interrupting our conversation . "Enough, let's stop discussing this . Since we're all basically going for the same goal, we

should be heading for the Southern District now . You guys, go to that building we were in and get someone to send Yu Liang back to the Western District . Bring Si Luo and Guan Nie here . It's going to be daybreak soon, and we'll set off then . ”

“Ah Shen, before day breaks, you should just take a quick wink . ” Jiao S pointed at the building near us .

Though I did not want to, I had to admit that I felt tired as I used my MF . There is only about three hours left to daylight, and even though that amount of time is not enough for me to recuperate and go back to my normal state, it was better than nothing . I knew that if I continued like this, I might not be able to use my MF eventually .

I thus agreed with Jiao S's suggestion .

As Gaoqin Jiuye and Jiao S settled Si Luo and Guan Nie in their air currents, I was already up and ready to go .

My head still felt a little fuzzy, and I tried to activate my MF . Ever since I activated my split symbol, I haven't really gotten the hang of how I should use this infinite amount of MF . Sometimes I would use too much of it, but sometimes it felt as if it was difficult to draw MF out . Furthermore, since I did not get much rest, it felt slightly tiring to use my MF .

But I had no time to think about this, because Nie Zun is still waiting for me .

He's waiting for me .

I calmed myself down and opened the window, jumping out of the building .

Gaoqin Jiuye and Jiao S were already waiting for me downstairs . I looked back at that window, and a bitter smile appeared at the corners of my mouth .

This was the first place where I fell asleep on my own, after Nie Zun left .

Though it was only for three hours .

Seems like I can only manage to sleep three hours without him .

“Let’s go,” I said to the two of them .

The bamboo hat trio did not appear again . I wonder what Jiao S said to them .

“We’ll need to increase our speed with MF, so that we can arrive in the Northern District and look for the individual who can save Guan Nie within a seven-day timeframe .” Gaoqin Jiuye was already on the go as he spoke .

“We’ll need to increase our speed with MF, so that we can arrive in the Northern District and look for the individual who can save Guan Nie within a seven-day timeframe .” Gaoqin Jiuye was already on the go as he spoke .

I caught up quickly . I still felt dizzy as I focused the MF under my feet .

We were able to move faster now that it was day and there was greater visibility, and the three of us moved at our top speeds, arriving at the border in just eight hours .

Before we stepped into the Southern District, Gaoqin Jiuye said to me, “Don’t forget that Rong Jin is still in the Southern District . He doesn’t have such a good impression of you .”

Hah, there are many people who don’t have a good impression of me . Didn’t I still survive till this day?

The three of us then stepped across the border and entered the Southern District . Gaoqin Jiuye was definitely familiar with everything here, and I started feeling a little emotional .

The last time I was here, it was Huan Qing’s illusion that welcomed me . I was trapped in it, and I even saw Gao Qi and Pomelo in that illusion . It was Nie Zun’s ‘Shen’er’ that pulled me out of it .

I started to tear . You haven't called me Shen'er in a while, how could you leave me like this .

As my mind was going in all directions, we found ourselves in the Southern District's border forest . As we stepped into it, the soil under our feet started to whirl!

“What's happening?” Jiao S looked at Gaoqin Jiuye .

Gaoqin Jiuye looked bewildered .

It was obvious he did not know what was happening either .

I squatted immediately, putting my hands on the ground and keeping my feet slightly apart, trying to steady myself .

Jiao S stayed still and did not move an inch . White fog surged in her eyes and she used her MF to steady herself with air currents .

Gaoqin Jiuye's hands were in his pockets, and he was leaning forward slightly, eyes darting around the place, trying to identify the cause .

However, the forest we were standing in was just like a giant carousel, it was just whirling around and we were like tiny pearls rolling around on it .

Not only did the forest start whirling, I heard cracking sounds as the trees around me started to snap . Broken bits of tree seemed to be flying towards me with a force!

However, the forest we were standing in was just like a giant carousel, it was just whirling around and we were like tiny pearls rolling around on it .

Not only did the forest start whirling, I heard cracking sounds as the trees around me started to snap . Broken bits of tree seemed to be flying towards me with a force!

Though I dodged the trees, the ground was whirling faster and faster, and I felt myself slowly losing my awareness . It could have been caused by the whirring or it could have been caused by a lack of rest .

“Try not to separate!” Jiao S shouted . She moved towards me as her black hair billowed in the wind . As she controlled the air currents, she was also dodging the trees that came at her . She grabbed my right hand as she reached my side .

Gaoqin Jiuye also reacted quickly . With a light tap of his feet, he was instantly by my side, grabbing my left hand .

At this point, Jiao S reached out for Gaoqin Jiuye!

Gaoqin Jiuye glanced at her and seemed to hesitate for a moment, but the whirling ground forced him to take her hand!

The three of us formed a circle, while both Jiao S and Gaoqin Jiuye tried to work together in encasing us within a giant air current which rotated in the opposite direction from the ground!

With that, we were able to achieve some form of stability, as it countered the force under our feet!

However, the ground was still whirring with amazing speed, and countless trees were coming at us from all directions at the same time . An unseen force was plucking these trees out of the ground and they were just flying straight at us!

Since we did not work together previously, there was a lack of common understanding between us . Furthermore, in such a situation, it was definitely not easy to maintain everyone’s balance through mere air currents .

As I was under their protection, I did not hesitate to turn .

Bam!

I tried to dodge a tree flying towards me, and in my attempt to not implicate Gaoqin Jiuye in my movement, I subconsciously let go of his hand .

The tree crashed into the ground beside me, and Gaoqin Jiuye’s momentum was broken by me suddenly letting go . He started to fall backwards, and it

felt like Jiao S and I were falling into an abyss together with him, but in reality, we were just falling towards the stone ground .

Chapter 151

151 A Dark Space

Unexpectedly, instead of hitting the ground, we entered a dark space .

Our surroundings changed in an instant, as if we were transported into another plane of existence .

“This...” I looked around me, frowning at this infinite blackness that met my eyes .

Why did this darkness feel so familiar?

“Gaoqin Jiuye?”

“Jiao S?”

I called out softly .

In this darkness, I couldn’t even see my fingers in front of me .

“I’m here . ”

“I’m here . ”

After hearing their answers, I was quite certain where we were .

“Where are you, Ah Shen? Why can’t I make out your position from your voice?” I heard Jiao S ask in the darkness .

“This is a space that distorts all senses, with the exception of the sense of touch . This means that right now, things like your hearing, your sense of

taste, they've all become useless, and you can only rely on touch to dodge attacks . ”

Without waiting for their reply, I continued, “Ta Lai, do you have to resort to violence as you meet an old friend?”

There was a ghostly silence .

“Ka—!”

A shrill and eerie laughter sounded . It felt terrifying, making all your hairs stand on end! This clearly belonged to Rong Jin, not Ta Lai!

“Rong Jin, what're you doing?” I heard Gaoqin Jiuye's cold voice in the dark .

The ghostly laughter stopped suddenly .

I snapped alert .

A deathly quiet surrounded us once more .

Pu-chh!

I then heard the sound of a knife stabbing through flesh somewhere!

“Who's hurt?” I shouted immediately .

“I'm okay,” Jiao S said hoarsely .

I did not hear Gaoqin Jiuye's voice .

I slowly drew Piercer with my right hand and activated my MF so I could feel the minute changes in the surroundings .

“Gaoqin Jiuye?” I tried calling out .

There was nothing but silence . I walked a step forward .

“There’s someone else here...” I heard Gaoqin Jiuye’s voice, which seemed to come from somewhere in front of me . He sounded like he was panting a little, as if he was injured .

No need for you to tell me that, I know there’s someone else here!

I lifted Piercer with my right hand, swinging it in front of me without hesitation! A violet light appeared momentarily, before being swallowed by the darkness .

“Ta Lai, can’t we talk in a brighter place? I’m tired of these games,” I said coldly as I faced the darkness .

“Kaka, this crazy girl never knows when to stop . ”

A spotlight suddenly appeared in the darkness after Rong Jin spoke!

Gaoqin Jiuye was under this bright spotlight that had a diameter of about a meter . He was kneeling in a pool of blood . Gaoqin Jiuye was on one knee, a hand pressing on his lower left abdomen . It looked like a wound that was gushing blood .

Gaoqin Jiuye was under this bright spotlight that had a diameter of about a meter . He was kneeling in a pool of blood . Gaoqin Jiuye was on one knee, a hand pressing on his lower left abdomen . It looked like a wound that was gushing blood .

He was looking down . His hair covered most of his features, but his lips were tightened in a straight line .

I wanted to rush over in a moment of worry, but rationality stopped me from doing so .

Even though I could see that spotlight, I was not able to estimate my distance from it . As long as we were in this darkness, we would probably not be able to use our sight effectively . He seemed to be right in front of me, but at the same time, it felt as if he was a thousand miles away .

There was no other sound apart from Gaoqin Jiuye's heavy breathing, and nothing seemed to be happening at Jiao S's side .

Right now, Jiao S might be able to see Gaoqin Jiuye just like me, but she is probably thinking of the next step . In such a situation where the odds are stacked against us, doing anything on the spur of the moment might cost us our lives .

Gaoqin Jiuye seemed to be in pain, and his hand seemed to press harder on his abdomen . “Careful, there's a hand in this darkness . From the looks of it, you won't be able to heal so quickly if you get stabbed by it . ”

No wonder his wound did not seem to be getting any smaller, and the blood was still flowing out .

But, a hand in this darkness? Could it be those giants? No, from Gaoqin Jiuye's wound, it did not look like that hand belonged to a giant . It should have belonged to an ordinary person .

“Kaka, Gaoqin, these girls are not going to save you . Are you still going to help them out by telling them this?”

Rong Jin's voice sounded from somewhere .

Gaoqin Jiuye looked up with gritted teeth .

“Rong Jin, why are you doing this?”

“Do you dare tell me where Si Luo is now?”

“Si Luo's with me . ”

“Kaka, yes, he's with you, and he's not conscious because he's hurt by someone from the Western District? Gaoqin Jiuye, you have the gall to come back here? Hand Si Luo over and don't step foot into the Southern District ever again!”

Gaoqin Jiuye laughed menacingly . “Rong Jin, how do you know all this? Your intel is pretty good these days huh? Or is it that you can't wait for Si

Luo to die, so that you can take over as the Southern District Commander?”

Rong Jin stopped his weird laughter as he turned angry . “Gaoqin Jiuye, you think everyone is heartless like you? Only I can save Si Luo, you lot will only harm him!”

“Is that so . ” Gaoqin Jiuye smirked . He then gave a cruel smile as he said, “Come out, Shen Qi!”

“Is that so . ” Gaoqin Jiuye smirked . He then gave a cruel smile as he said, “Come out, Shen Qi!”

From his waist, Shen Qi produced a black ray, and in a second, it transformed into another Gaoqin Jiuye beside him!

I knew that was another form of Shen Qi, and I held Piercer tight, ready to assist him in battle!

Rong Jin’s shadow suddenly appeared in that spotlight! It was reaching for Gaoqin Jiuye’s neck with an outstretched hand! Gaoqin Jiuye fell backwards to dodge it, and Shen Qi shielded him in front!

I realized that the spotlight followed Gaoqin Jiuye wherever he went! Without further ado, I moved as quickly as I can towards that light!

This isn’t right, why couldn’t I reach that light no matter how I moved?! Is it because we were still in this dark space?

My sense of direction was totally thrown off, and I just could not reach Gaoqin Jiuye no matter what I did! This was making a fool out of us! Letting Jiao S and I see Gaoqin Jiuye being attacked, but preventing us from reaching him?

“Jiao S, where are you?”

“I can’t go there . You probably can’t too . ” Jiao S’s low-pitched voice sounded calm .

The fight between Shen Qi and that ghostly shadow has commenced . A living weapon is definitely extraordinary, and all of Shen Qi's movements were so powerful, as if he was a blade on its own . Flashes of light surrounded Gaoqin Jiuye as Shen Qi moved with amazing speed .

Shen Qi was fast, while Gaoqin Jiuye did not seem to be healing . I could see beads of sweat on his forehead, and his blood continued flowing from that spotlight into the darkness!

This is bad, if it doesn't stop bleeding!

I was feeling anxious, and I had to admit I would still worry about him like this .

Why did it turn out this way? Rong Jin was someone who could be easily manipulated, so someone must be behind this if he knew Si Luo was attacked and not conscious now . Just who could it be?

This was obviously Ta Lai's ability, but why would Ta Lai help Rong Jin out? Or did Ta Lai already find out I went back on my promise with him and that I've decided to return to the real world?

"Ta Lai, no matter what you think, let's talk about it . " I could only remain where I was since I could not go near that spotlight .

Nobody answered me .

Gaoqin Jiuye looked pale now, and he looked like he would faint anytime . Blood was pooled on the ground below him . That wound was like a dam, and blood just kept flowing out .

Shen Qi's eyes were full of a reddish anger, and he grabbed Rong Jin's shadow in a death grip with his hands, which seemed to produce firelight!

Crack!

Shen Qi's eyes were full of a reddish anger, and he grabbed Rong Jin's shadow in a death grip with his hands, which seemed to produce firelight!

Crack!

It sounded like a light being switched off . We were met with an infinite darkness again! The light surrounding Gaoqin Jiuye was gone, and it was pitch black now!

Crack!

A weird sound again!

It was me this time! My surroundings lit up!

My expression was frigid . We were being targeted one by one?

Was there really no way to escape from this dark space of Ta Lai's? How can we simply let them attack us like this?

As I was thinking about these things, my sense of touch subconsciously reacted, and I moved to the right! The spotlight followed me as I moved! I would definitely not be able to dodge it if it were not for my previous training in this space!

I could almost feel the kind of damage I would receive if that hand were to stab through me!

“It's this hand!” I heard Gaoqin Jiuye in the darkness . He could see me now, just like how I could see him earlier!

I grabbed that hand with one of mine, and with my other hand, I swung Piercer at the individual, trapping the attacker! I pulled the individual towards me, and the attacker was right in front of me!

Hah, I smirked inwardly . I wonder who it is whose hands have such ability that it could even skewer Gaoqin Jiuye through the abdomen!

I was still smirking when I saw that face .

But I lost that smirk in a second .

I was stunned .

I was still grabbing tightly onto that hand which had attempted to stab me, and Piercer was still around his neck . We were face to face, looking at each other .

Our noses were almost touching, but I could not believe my eyes .

I moved my head back a little, and that face with scars of various sizes could be clearly seen now .

Chapter 152

152 A Living Puppet

“Nie... Nie Zun...” My eyes widened .

“Nie Zun!”

I heard both the voices of Gaoqin Jiuye and Jiao S at the same time .

That’s right, the attacker whom I had trapped with Piercer was none other than Nie Zun .

At this moment, his gaze looked so hopeless . There were many tiny black lines in that bright red left pupil of his, and they looked like a mark left behind from a curse . His other eye was still as starry as before, and it was looking at me with so much gentleness .

Scars of various sizes were all over his face .

Even with those scars, I was still able to recognize that he was Nie Zun .

He was still in that black, high-collared windbreaker, and his hair seemed to be a little messier now .

A funny feeling overcame me as we looked into each other’s eyes .

“Nie Zun...”

I called out to him, forgetting that we were still in the midst of a fierce battle just moments ago . I let go of his arm, and pulling his elbow towards me, I tried to get him to come closer, just in case he wanted to disappear on me again .

Right at this moment, a desolate look flashed in his normal eye, and before I could decipher what it meant, I felt something at my lower abdomen .

My eyes opened wide .

“Ah Shen!” “Li Shen!”

I heard Jiao S and Gaoqin Jiuye’s anxious voices .

A bittersweet smile appeared on my face .

Nie Zun’s right hand was currently embedded in my lower abdomen, and it jutted out of my back like a sharp blade .

The tip of Nie Zun’s nose was about to touch mine .

I let go of Piercer in my right hand, and it fell away from his neck, dropping onto the ground .

This was probably the first time that I had let go of Piercer .

My right hand slowly found its way to his left hand . As I held the hand that was now only left with two fingers, I saw a column of tears escaping that black eye of his .

I smiled at him, right hand holding on tightly to his left hand, while my left hand was at his waist as I held onto him . His left hand was in my palm, and his right hand was still embedded in my body .

“Li Shen you have to wake up! He might be a fake!”

I heard Gaoqin Jiuye’s shouts in the darkness .

No, Gaoqin Jiuye, you’re wrong . I’m sure this is him . This monstrous, disfigured man was my Nie Zun .

“Why did you have to do this?” I smiled as I moved my lips closer to his lips as I asked .

The tip of his nose brushed against mine as he attempted to move his head backwards . As he moved, I felt a sharp pain in my lower abdomen!

The pain caused me to fall forward a little, and my lips brushed against his cheek . My lips felt wet . I tasted his tears .

He remained silent even though endless tears were gushing out of his eye . An emotion flashed in his eyes, and that bright red left eye of his seemed to turn a bloodier red . It was so red that it looked like it could bleed anytime!

He drew his left hand out of my abdomen suddenly!

Pu-chh!

Blood sprayed out from the wound in my lower abdomen!

“Ugh...” I was starting to feel unsteady on my feet because of the pain!

But my right hand held on tight . I refused to let go of his left hand!

But my right hand held on tight . I refused to let go of his left hand!

I saw a look of consternation and despondency in his eyes, as if he wanted to turn and run away again!

“Don’t...” Though it was painful, I tried my best to speak . It felt as if my body was slowly crumbling to the ground .

“Uhh!” Nie Zun opened his mouth! But instead of speaking, he produced a series of weird, hoarse sounds! It sounded as if his vocal chords had been broken . It was a hoarse, low-pitched voice which made my heart break!

Freeing his left hand, he used both hands to grab onto my shoulders, staring at me with anxious eyes!

“What a resilient lady . ”

The darkness was gone in an instant with Ta Lai’s elegant voice!

We were in the Southern District's border forest again!

I looked towards the sound as soon as we were out of that darkness . A lanky individual in a blue jacket was just a short distance away behind Nie Zun . Ta Lai was walking towards me with an elegant and enchanting smile .

Gaoqin Jiuye and Jiao S rushed to my side, one pulling me away from Nie Zun, while the other held onto him! Jiao S dragged me a few steps away from Nie Zun!

“No!” I tried to escape Jiao S's clutches in an attempt to get closer to Nie Zun, but I ended up falling onto my knees due to the pain in my abdomen!

Though Gaoqin Jiuye held onto Nie Zun, he was still bleeding from his lower abdomen . He was very pale and it was obvious he could not use all his strength!

Nie Zun let him be, and his eyes seemed to have lost all control as he kept looking around, producing unintelligible sounds .

“What's wrong with him?!” I directed this at Ta Lai, who was getting closer to us .

Ta Lai smiled, using his left hand to turn that jade stone ring on his right finger .

“I planted a living puppet in his left eye, and he is now a living puppet that belongs to me . Just like a puppet on a string, he's being totally controlled by me right now . ”

A fire burned in my chest as anger rose up in me!

“No need to look at me like this, Li Shen . You went back on your word, and this is your punishment . ”

“No need to look at me like this, Li Shen . You went back on your word, and this is your punishment . ”

Ta Lai lost his smile as he moved that jade stone ring! With that, Nie Zun seemed to turn into a robot that was switched on . He used his bare hands to grab Gaoqin Jiuye, throwing him somewhere behind Jiao S and I!

As Gaoqin Jiuye was already injured, he was not able to react in time . He was simply thrown by Nie Zun!

“Those are definitely the hands of a devil . After my honing, his hands can harm bodies of consciousness directly, and the wound would not heal as quickly!” Ta Lai looked at the crazed Nie Zun in awe .

After he threw Gaoqin Jiuye, Nie Zun was coming for Jiao S and I!

Jiao S was supporting me with both hands, and she stared at Nie Zun!

Boom!

We were encased within powerful air currents, and Nie Zun slowed down! Jiao S signaled for me to steady myself, and after she let go of me, she took a giant sword in her right hand! She swung that giant sword at Nie Zun seemingly without any hesitation!

My heart skipped a beat . Though I was worried about them both, I knew that Nie Zun could dodge that attack easily!

But as he dodged it, he bent down to pick up Piercer which was on the ground!

“Careful!” I called out, trying to alert Jiao S!

As I called out, I saw an agony in Nie Zun’s eyes!

That pain shot right through my heart!

“Let him go, Ta Lai!” Pressing onto my abdomen, I shouted at Ta Lai!

Nie Zun’s every move was being controlled, as if he was attached to some invisible string and being forced to fight against us!

“Uhh!” Nie Zun produced a bizarre sound once more!

“Let him go!” Hearing that sound, I was on the verge of tears as I cried out! I was on my knees, and my hands were already wet and sticky around my waist with blood .

But all this could not compare to the pain I felt in my heart! The usually lazy and distant Nie Zun was now being tortured in such a cruel manner, just like a puppet that had been completely broken . He was being used to attack us!

As Jiao S swung at Nie Zun with her sword again, Nie Zun swung Piercer, and a striking violet ray was produced!

But all this could not compare to the pain I felt in my heart! The usually lazy and distant Nie Zun was now being tortured in such a cruel manner, just like a puppet that had been completely broken . He was being used to attack us!

As Jiao S swung at Nie Zun with her sword again, Nie Zun swung Piercer, and a striking violet ray was produced!

The violet ray was flying straight at Jiao S like lightning, and with white fog surging in her eyes, Jiao S retreated backwards quickly!

At this point, Shen Qi appeared again . He was standing beside Gaoqin Jiuye, who was currently crouched on the ground because of his injury . Shen Qi stared with angry eyes, and his stance was that of a protector!

Ta Lai was standing some distance away, an elegant smile still on him . He moved that jade stone ring gently, and smiled lightly at me as he said, “Seems like you miss him a lot . In this case, I’ll let him speak with you for a bit . ”

Nie Zun stared with wide eyes as the restriction on his voice was gone . He shouted at me as soon as Ta Lai freed his voice!

“Shen’er, don’t care about me!”

“Ugh...” I covered my mouth with my hands, crying .

Don't care about you? How can I not care about you?! How can you always say such things so easily!

Jiao S was forced to retreat some ten meters or so because of Piercer's violet blade, and she suddenly swung that giant sword towards where Ta Lai was standing!

Ta Lai laughed, and with a wave of his right hand, a giant dropped from the sky! It was a puppet!

This was Ta Lai's best ability, manipulation!

The giant roared as it blocked Jiao S's sword! At the same time, Ta Lai signaled at Nie Zun with a hand!

Nie Zun shouted at me, “Go away!”

He could not control what he did, and he already swung Piercer, violet blade flying in my direction! Looking at the strength he swung it with, there was no way I could have dodged that in my injured state!

Gaoqin Jiuye was also stopped by Shen Qi when he tried to protect me!

Shen Qi is a living weapon, and it was obvious that protecting Gaoqin Jiuye was of utmost priority to him right now! He wanted to ensure Gaoqin Jiuye's safety!

“Shen Qi, move!” As I heard Gaoqin Jiuye's chilly order, the violet blade was already right in front of my eyes!

A look of indescribable agony appeared in Nie Zun's bright red eye!

Chapter 153

Volume 3

153 The Light of the Scorpion Ray

In that same instant when the violet blade was about to reach me, I felt a warmth emanating from the skin on my back.

This reminded me of my bow immediately. *That's right, I still had my bow!*

Now that I think about it, after getting stronger, I seldom used my bow since Piercer was always used for close-range battles, and the bow was more suited for long-range fights.

This bow was given to me by Li Qing. On its own, the bow was not as beautiful a weapon as Piercer was, and it did not look very unique either. Only the device that kept it behind my back was exquisitely made. I liked the bow, but I did not think it was very much different from other bows out there.

Until today, the bow simply seemed like an ordinary bow. However, it seemed to change in the moment when I was about to be attacked by Piercer's violet blade.

A light appeared from behind my back, shielding me from Piercer's violet blade! It was bright like a comet, and it turned into a bow and arrow as it met the violet blade! Bright light flashed!

I was blinded by the white light, and I could feel my nerves trembling from the impact!

I automatically lifted my left arm to shield my eyes from the light. As I lifted it, I felt something hot on my wrist. I looked at my arm.

Something out of the ordinary happened. The white light transformed into a huge mouth, swallowing all the bits of Piercer's violet blade, turning it into white smoke. All the light then seemed to condense into that spot on my wrist.

As the white light dissipated, something resembling the tail of a scorpion appeared on my left wrist!

It was engraved deeply in the flesh, looking quite translucent. Looking at it, it slowly combined with the flesh, and formed a palm-sized pattern embedded deep within my skin.

I stared at my arm, dumbfounded at what just happened. I felt a chill on my back, and with my hands, I reached backwards.

The bow was gone. *Did the bow turn into this insignia on my arm?*

"The Scorpion Ray... You actually conquered the fifth living weapon!"

Ta Lai no longer looked as calm as before, he seemed rather serious now.

"The fifth living weapon? Weren't there only four living weapons here in the Split Zone?" I narrowed my eyes at him as I asked.

His usual expression returned with an elegant smile. "Well, this fifth living weapon is actually a failed product. How else do you think you'd be able to conquer it if you weren't able to resonate with its soul? It's a defective product, and it awakened at a crucial moment to protect you."

I frowned slightly. I did not care about this. Nie Zun is all I cared about right now. And I did not really understand all that he said anyway.

As I looked towards Nie Zun again, he seemed to have changed.

His hair seemed to be moving, though there was no wind currently. That black windbreaker of his was also flapping about on its own.

A dark shadow appeared in that bright red eye of his, as if it could swallow that blood red anytime. A dark and evil aura began to surge in his right pupil.

“How could I hurt you...” Nie Zun spoke, his voice full of misery and self-loathe. I knew something was wrong in an instant, but I just did not know what to do.

Ta Lai squinted as he said, “Stop struggling and just rip her heart out!”

The jade stone ring on his right hand moved on its own after he finished speaking! Nie Zun raised Piercer again, prepared to attack!

I kept my eyes on Nie Zun, telling myself to stay calm and look for an opening. *If Nie Zun could be controlled like this, there must be an opening somewhere!*

But as Nie Zun swung Piercer, it did not simply produce a single violet blade!

More than ten dark purple blades of light flew out, looking like beautiful auroras, full of killing intent. All of them were flying straight at me.

Something was weird about Nie Zun’s gaze. A dark shadow was moving around in both his pupils, as if all the darkness in the world was being absorbed by them. A deathly aura started to surround him.

Though that aura felt weak now, I was sensitive enough to be able to feel it.

My instincts told me that I had to stop this change in him. I activated my MF to protect that wound on my abdomen so that it would not bleed so much, and with gritted teeth, I lifted my left hand high and gave it a strong wave!

Initially, I wanted to try it out, to see if it worked. Turns out that with a wave, the scorpion symbol on my left wrist produced a silvery white light. Like a treasure box which was finally being opened, silvery-white light

engulfed my wrist and encircled my entire arm. As I moved my palm, bright white needles made of light flew towards Nie Zun!

My wrist continued producing that white light, which continued turning into needles of light. These needles separated into thin rays, one becoming two, then three. Before long, there were countless needle-like rays being produced!

No wonder this was called the Scorpion Ray. It was sharp just like a scorpion's tail, and the rays were dazzling!

Bright light was produced as the needle-like rays met the violet blades in the air. Like a needle pricking through water, it slowly absorbed the violet blade, and the violet blades just disappeared right in front of me!

The rays which did not meet the violet blades were flying towards Nie Zun, all of them glowing with a chilly silvery-white!

I never expected the bow to be this powerful when resurrected, and my heart tightened. I dropped my arm in a panic, and looking at Nie Zun, I shouted, "Careful!"

Before I finished the word, Ta Lai's expression darkened. He gave Nie Zun an order.

"Activate – dark insignia!"

After that, those black lines in Nie Zun's bright red pupil started to expand within his eyeball!

"Go!" Nie Zun was almost roaring at me!

Shen Qi, which had been behind me all this time, seemed to sense something. He turned around and transformed into a black shadow, encasing Gaoqin Jiuye within!

The pale Gaoqin Jiuye tried to stand up, but he was rendered immobile by Shen Qi's dark shadow!

On the other side, three giants were produced by Ta Lai. Jiao S had no problem fighting against them, but she had no time to spare for me or Nie Zun!

Squiggly black lines started to cover Nie Zun's bright red eye, and these lines extended from the corner of his eye onto his temple, starting to grow all over his face like tendrils!

As he bit his lip, I saw his other eye tremble, as if he was being put through the worst torture ever!

"No!" I shouted in a panic. I could almost feel his pain just by looking at his eye!

The scars on his face were slowly being covered by those black tendrils, and his bright red eye was flashing with a demonic scarlet light under those black lines which resembled spider webs!

My brain felt like it was being scalded as I looked at that scarlet light!

"Ah!" I cried out loudly. Something seemed to be controlling me from the back of my mind, and I started to feel a massive pain spread throughout my body!

My left hand started to throb with pain, and the scorpion insignia on my wrist produced countless rays of light which flew towards Nie Zun!

The left side of Nie Zun's face seemed to be covered entirely with the black tendrils now, and he suddenly moved at lightning speed! It was so fast that I almost could not follow his movements with my eye! All I could see was a black windbreaker flitting through the forest under the gray sky!

"Go." Ta Lai instructed Nie Zun as he looked at me coldly.

The side of Nie Zun's face which was covered with black tendrils was cold and devoid of any expression. On the other side of his face however, that starry eye of his still emanated warmth even though it looked like it was in agony.

Two different faces, two different expressions, two different individuals.

Just what did he do to Nie Zun? What had my Nie Zun become?!

Rage welled up in me, and my red hair and red dress started to fly around in my anger. I activated my MF on my right hand, and aiming it at Nie Zun, I made a grabbing motion in the air! A force of MF blasted Piercer, which was still in Nie Zun's hands!

"Come back, Piercer!" I said in a chilly tone as I felt rage surge through me!

Under the influence of MF, Piercer looked like it came alive as it flew back into my hands looking like a dark purple water snake!

With a light tap of my feet, I swung out with my right hand! I then used my left hand to beautifully draw a circle around me!

The bright aurora combined with Piercer's attack, and silvery-white light engulfed the violet blades as they flew towards Ta Lai!

Ta Lai unhurriedly moved that jade stone ring of his, controlling Nie Zun!

"Sss..." The black tendrils on Nie Zun's face seemed to come alive, producing a horrifying ripping sound as it combined with the skin on Nie Zun's face!

Nie Zun was now totally controlled like a puppet, and with that numb face devoid of expression, he moved over to Ta Lai, shielding him from my angry attack!

Subconsciously, I shook my head. I used a high amount of MF in that attack as I was just enraged. It would not be easy to take that attack head-on like this!

"Nie Zun!"

Chapter 154

154 Don't Turn Into a Devil

I focused all my MF on my feet, planning to block that combined attack from Piercer and the Scorpion Ray for Nie Zun with my body!

A smile then appeared on Ta Lai's face!

He lifted the hand with that jade stone ring and moved it while facing Nie Zun!

Nie Zun, who was originally about to move, was now rooted to the ground!

“Oh no!”

This was bad! Ta Lai was restricting Nie Zun's movements so that my attack will hit Nie Zun directly! He was trying to destroy Nie Zun! And I would be the one who destroyed him!

No! I will not let that happen!

Uneasiness overcame me, and it felt as if I returned to that forgotten memory which tormented me night after night!

In my memory, I killed my lover with my own two hands!

How could I let such a thing happen again!

Gritting my teeth, I reached out with both hands, using my MF as a shield . At the same time, I moved so fast that it almost seemed like I teleported right in front of Nie Zun!

Bam!

Everything happened in that moment .

In a second, the light from Scorpion Ray slammed into my back . Nie Zun caught me as I fell forward .

I could smell his familiar scent as I fell into that cold embrace . It was light and not overpowering, the scent that accompanied me every night .

His embrace did not feel warm, but like bathing in a cold river, I did not want to leave it .

I felt a burning sensation on my back, as if there was someone roasting me with a fiery torch .

Nie Zun was panting as he held me . My hands were against his chest, and I reached for his face .

It no longer felt smooth under my fingers, and I looked at him as I started to tear .

“You said you wouldn’t leave me, you said you’d protect me forever,” I said softly .

“I’m Shen’er...” I could hear my own voice trembling .

I left a streak of blood on that cold and expressionless face of his as I touched his face, trying to look at what changed in him as I looked into those eyes .

“Kill her,” Ta Lai said in his elegant manner .

Nie Zun’s gaze changed!

The burning sensation on my back was getting unbearable, and it felt as if I was just beside a raging fire!

Black lines started to appear once again in Nie Zun’s bright red eye!

“Careful, Ah Shen!” Jiao S rushed over to my side as she sensed something wrong, no longer caring about the giants .

But this was a mistake . The giant grabbed her from behind and threw her into its mouth!

As I saw a blood red tongue and canines, Jiao S was already gone!

I tried to forcefully use my MF to maintain my consciousness and mobility, but Nie Zun’s hands were already tight around my neck!

“Ugh...” Nie Zun’s hands were strong . With just seven fingers, he had my neck in a death grip and lifted me high up above the ground!

My feet left the ground slowly, and I felt this agonizing, painful pressure on my neck . I was choking as I tried to think of something to say to Nie Zun .

What should I say .

Don’t be afraid, I’m still here .

Don’t be in pain, don’t be sad, I won’t die .

Don’t be in pain, don’t be sad, I won’t die .

Don’t blame yourself, it’s not your fault .

Don’t cry, we’ll always be together .

I saw Nie Zun’s tears as I thought of that last phrase .

He looked like he had already given up all hope as those tears were flowing from both his eyes . His tears were dripping down his face, and they were dripping into my heart .

Those hands of the devil were on my neck, lifting my entire person up .

I knew this could not kill me, but I still felt like I was about to die in the next instant .

I was not scared, nor was I sad .

I was just worried about him .

“Admit it... You love him...” A lazy, feminine voice sounded in my ear . I felt a pair of hands move up my back, leaving a chilly feeling as it moved .

That pair of hands moved up from my back, then through my neck and through Nie Zun’s hands, and finally, they covered my eyes .

I felt wet lips near my ear, as she asked, “Need my help?”

“No! Not even when I die!” I shouted in my heart, but choking sounds were all that came out of my mouth .

Nie Zun’s expression changed as he heard me struggling while being strangled .

That black mist which surrounded him in a thin layer suddenly became a thick fog, as if trying to pull me with him into it .

A horrifying aura emanated from his eyes!

He let go of me suddenly, and I crashed onto the ground!

Cough cough cough

I held onto my neck as I coughed, tears in my eyes .

I held onto my neck as I coughed, tears in my eyes .

As I regained my vision, I saw this lonely, dark and twisted aura which surrounded Nie Zun . It looked like black fog and a viscous black liquid . Nie Zun’s eyes were now absolutely devoid of humanity .

Ta Lai’s eyes widened . Using his left hand, he moved that jade stone ring a few times .

There was no use . Nie Zun seemed to have lost all control, and that dark aura around him seemed to be getting stronger . A rage was emanating from that dark fog around him, and anyone who was at the scene would be overwhelmed by an impending sense of death .

Even I was quite surprised . The Nie Zun right now is the devilish Nie Zun .

This felt like that time when he protected me after having recently arrived in the Split Zone . But he was more like a devilish infant at that time .

Today's Nie Zun had one bright red eye shining in that dark fog, and his eyes looked like the most cruel and heartless pair of eyes in this world . The corner of his lips then started to turn up slowly in an evil, menacing smile .

I was on the floor, and my lower abdomen already felt numb . It healed so slowly that it seemed like it was not healing at all, and the burning sensation on my back seemed to be slowly swallowing me up .

I struggled to get up, hoping to stop Nie Zun from falling into that abysmal darkness .

I don't want him to turn into a devil, even if it was for me .

By now, Ta Lai had sensed something amiss, and it was the first time his smile faded from his face . With a stride, he started moving towards Nie Zun!

Nie Zun had an expression which looked like it was frozen in a half smile . He was enshrouded in darkness, and he clasped his hands together as he faced Ta Lai! With that action, two dark air currents condensed in between his palms, and it flew towards Ta Lai!

Being unprepared, Ta Lai seemed to be shocked as he was instantly surrounded by the dark air currents!

He muttered, "That can't be, how could you..."

He looked like a god of death that had absorbed all the sin and monstrosity in this world, and even I no longer recognized that face . It looked like it

belonged to a stranger, one that had a cruel smile . There was nothing but darkness that emanated from him, enshrouding him in the scent of death and a killing aura . It felt as if he was the only devil in this world which killed everyone he met, no matter who they were .

Just a moment ago he was a puppet being controlled . Right now, he was a devil that nobody could control . Everyone was being pulled into this dark domain with those murderous hands of his .

Ta Lai looked at all this as he was engulfed in that black fog, and an anger rose in his eyes .

That's right . It wasn't surprise or fear . It definitely wasn't a look of composure either . It was a rage that did not fit that elegant image of his at all .

Such rage did not come from someone getting angry at something . It was a rage that came about when one saw an arch-nemesis, where one still felt like destroying that enemy even after a long time of not having crossed paths .

That's right . It wasn't surprise or fear . It definitely wasn't a look of composure either . It was a rage that did not fit that elegant image of his at all .

Such rage did not come from someone getting angry at something . It was a rage that came about when one saw an arch-nemesis, where one still felt like destroying that enemy even after a long time of not having crossed paths .

But why did he look at Nie Zun in such a way?

“The soul of Satan huh? How are you related to Cang Ming?” Ta Lai enunciated each word clearly . He sounded like he was on the verge of doing something with explosive violence .

The soul of Satan...

Satan Cang Ming?

Does this mean that the aura surrounding Nie Zun right now was that same aura that Satan Cang Ming left behind wherever he passed, just like what is said in those legends?

This was highly possible . According to Gaoqin Jiuye, the reason Cang Ming had Satan as a nickname was because he left this dark aura behind wherever he went .

And right now, Nie Zun definitely had the power to make everyone fear him .

“You dare hurt her...” Nie Zun spoke in a cold, low-pitched voice which sounded extremely powerful .

His eyes remained heartless, but he looked lost . It was obvious that he did not even know who the ‘her’ referred to . That darkness and pain had eaten away at him, and all he remembered was the hatred towards whoever had hurt me, but he did not remember me .

A real devil would not remember kindness and love, because as long as he still had these things, he would not be able to turn into a real devil .

Nie Zun lifted his hand, and with that movement, the black fog surrounding Ta Lai seemed to surge as it turned into black vapour .

I could only make out Ta Lai’s head in that black fog . He still had that look of rage on him, and he locked his gaze squarely on Nie Zun .

“Nie Zun, don’t forget that you’re Nie Zun, my Nie Zun...” I was already out of strength . I lay on the ground, my face against the icy cold stone .

I was listening to the sounds, and listening to my own heartbeat .

I was crying, telling Nie Zun not to forget himself, and not to forget me .

Not to turn into a devil .

Chapter 155

155 The Demon that is Nie Zun

“Your consciousness could actually devour the curse I planted in your eye...” Ta Lai muttered as he could not believe what he was witnessing . The black fog started to burn pieces of his skin as it surrounded him .

Nie Zun’s other eye was starting to turn red as well . A bright scarlet layer enveloped his black pupil, and his pale hands continued to produce black fog . That fog surrounded his fingers, and white bones appeared from where he lost those three fingers!

The white from the bones were in sharp contrast with that black fog, and I could see the flesh melding around it and knitting together at amazing speed!

From the cold stone ground, I looked at Nie Zun’s hand . By now, it had already regenerated fully . In less than a minute, that hand already looked perfect, and there were no scars on it .

A demonic light shone in Nie Zun’s eyes as that black fog surrounded his hands . He looked like a jet black shadow enshrouded in a dark mist . That black fog created a shadowy layer, covering the gray sky and bringing with it a sense of impending doom .

Only Ta Lai’s head could be seen now as his entire body was already encased within the black fog . I could hear a crackling sound, as if he was being roasted . He looked like he wanted to cry out, but with a slight movement of Nie Zun’s left index finger, a monstrous face appeared in the black fog . Going around Ta Lai’s neck with a roar, it prevented Ta Lai from producing any sound .

Ta Lai's eyes were becoming wider and wider, as if his eyeballs were about to fall out anytime . I could hear the sound of bones being broken within that black fog, and it sounded like his bones were being smashed one by one .

“Nie Zun...” As the black fog spread around the forest, I began to feel a horrifying pressure . I could not manipulate my MF very well since I did not get proper rest, and now that I was injured, I simply could not move any closer to Nie Zun . No matter how hard I tried, all I could do was wriggle on the ground like a tiny worm .

The corners of my lips and eyes suddenly felt like they were being torn apart, and I attempted to prop myself up with my blood-stained hands, trying my best to reach Nie Zun .

The scorpion insignia on my left wrist was flashing brightly . Nie Zun's back was facing me, and I could only see his jet black shoes as I looked up .

A hand suddenly grabbed my red dress, and before I could tell it was Gaoqin Jiuye, I was lifted up by him . He grabbed me and put a distance between us and Nie Zun . As I turned to look at him, I realized he still looked unusually pale .

He was still pressing on his wound with one hand, and it seemed that his wound did not stop bleeding at all . His fingers were all stained with blood, and I could see that a lot of blood had already seeped through his trousers .

As he pulled me away from Nie Zun, I saw two jet black swords in Shen Qi's hands . He was charging towards Nie Zun!

“Let go of me!” I stared at Gaoqin Jiuye angrily, but there was no strength in my voice .

Gaoqin Jiuye looked at me coldly as he spoke in a low voice, “Ta Lai's curse was devoured by his consciousness . He won't recognize anyone in this demonic state, not even you . Are you tired of living?”

He was still unusually pale, and he looked rather weak right now .

There was blood on strands of his hazel hair, and it stained his forehead .
Under that blood-stained forehead were a pair of strong brows and a pair of
evil, menacing eyes, which could at times be filled with warmth .

“The more I can’t leave him like this,” I said softly, looking at him .

I caught what looked like sadness flashing past Gaoqin Jiuye’s eyes .

“Listen to me if you want to save him . ”

As he spoke, I saw Shen Qi’s swords wrap themselves around Nie Zun’s
monstrous hands .

Nie Zun turned back . Under those wispy bangs, I could see those bright red
eyes of his sweep past Shen Qi and us .

A scarlet light flashed in his eyes, and his lips turned up in a cruel smile .
Black fog started enshrouding Shen Qi!

Shen Qi’s eyes were also red . With a wave of his hands, the two swords
produced a clear sound!

Clang!

The swords slashed into Nie Zun’s hands, severing them cleanly from the
wrist!

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wrist!

“Ah!” I covered my mouth as I took in what just happened .

Though a living weapon could come alive, it was still a weapon . There was
no withholding in that cruel attack!

Nie Zun’s demonic hands were cut off just like this, but there was no
change in his expression . His smile did not fade, and it did not even look
like he felt an ounce of pain!

Even weirder was that two sets of bone started growing from his wrists!
Flesh was knitting together on these bones .

A new pair of hands appeared in just a few seconds!

As Nie Zun's black sleeves had been slashed apart, his arm was now partially exposed!

His hand regenerated at such godly speed! But the scars on his face still remained, and they did not look like they were going to heal anytime soon .

I heard Gaoqin Jiuye sigh in defeat . “Seems like we’re all going to die here today . ”

I looked at him in shock . Did you have to go and say something like this?

“Once he loses his humanity, it would be difficult for even soul splitters to go against him . ” There was strong emotion in Gaoqin Jiuye's exhausted eyes .

My expression of surprise turned cold . “Just what do you know . ”

Gaoqin Jiuye gave a menacing smile .

All of a sudden, he grabbed my chin with the hand that was originally pressing on his wound!

All of a sudden, he grabbed my chin with the hand that was originally pressing on his wound!

He wanted to press his blood-stained lips against mine!

Nie Zun, who was about to attack Shen Qi, witnessed every moment of what just happened!

I turned my head in the instant that I realized what Gaoqin Jiuye was trying to do! Because of this, Gaoqin Jiuye only met the corner of my lips!

From Nie Zun's perspective, it would look like we were locked in a passionate embrace as our faces were covered by that red hair of mine!

"Are you trying to call upon what little humanity he still has within him?" I spoke softly in Gaoqin Jiuye's ear .

In reality, I was a little tense . He looked foreign yet familiar, and that face which originally had a cruel smile on it had just brushed past my lips with a warmth that felt so conflicting!

I felt Gaoqin Jiuye's throat move, and he tried to use his hand to adjust my head, attempting once again to press his lips against mine! Momentarily, a feeling of anxiety overcame me .

As I tried to avoid it, Gaoqin Jiuye looked at me with a pair of forlorn eyes . I pursed my lips and avoided it as quickly as I could!

I felt sorry for this, and I wanted to meet his gaze to convey an apology . But at this moment, a chilly laugh from Nie Zun immediately froze all of us!

As I turned to look, Nie Zun had a deathly cold gaze, and a ghastly aura surrounded him! The smell of blood invaded my senses as the devil in Nie Zun had completely awoken!

Not only did Gaoqin Jiuye's method fail to bring out his humanity, it further triggered his rage!

He lifted a cruel hand in the air . With a grabbing motion, a hand materialized from that black fog, capturing Shen Qi!

Gaoqin Jiuye's eyes darkened . He charged towards Nie Zun with great speed! White fog surged in his eyes as air currents started roaring around him!

The air currents and black fog met each other in loud, thunderous clashes!

Gaoqin Jiuye's eyes darkened . He charged towards Nie Zun with great speed! White fog surged in his eyes as air currents started roaring around

him!

The air currents and black fog met each other in loud, thunderous clashes!

Behind Nie Zun, Ta Lai was still encapsulated in that black fog . He looked like he was in pain but unable to make any sound!

As Gaoqin Jiuye moved, Shen Qi had already turned back into that long, flexible sword in Gaoqin Jiuye's hands!

Gaoqin Jiuye was fast, and with his sword and those explosive air currents, he pushed back against Nie Zun's demonic aura!

The scarlet light in Nie Zun's eyes was still burning brightly . With a light tap of his feet, he flew up into the air, avoiding Gaoqin Jiuye's slashes!

I was quite perplexed at this . In the end, why did it become a fight between the two of them!

A fight between the two of them...

As I thought of this, a horrifying scene appeared in my mind!

It was the scene where Gaoqin Jiuye ruthlessly killed Nie Zun!

It was that scene which appeared when Si Luo was looking into my heart!

I looked on anxiously . Gaoqin Jiuye's previously pale face now looked full of color . It was not how a gravely injured person should look like . This look was a look of a victor . He raised his sword high, slashing it towards Nie Zun!

Nie Zun was a black figure with bright red eyes, and those pale hands of his made several complex signs . With those signs, the black fog started to quake and roar, encasing everything in its path!

My heart sank . Without hesitation, I focused all my MF to prop myself up, and with a flick of my wrist, Piercer was back in my right palm!

Chapter 156

156 Amitabha

I leapt towards the two of them in the instant I retrieved Piercer!

As I moved, I noticed a difference in Ta Lai's gaze as he made a last-ditch effort to escape from that black fog!

Boom!

Our surroundings turned pitch black once again! I stopped focusing my MF and tried to remain steady with both feet on the ground .

I contemplated this, realizing that there had to be a reason Ta Lai could not sustain this dark space for too long, since he ended it rather abruptly before . There had to be some weakness, or there should be something which could cancel its effect!

He might not be using his ability to attack us this time . It was likely that he was trying to escape!

As I realized his intentions, the surroundings lit up again!

“Gawrr—!” A fiery qilin appeared in the air! The jaws of the fiery qilin was producing fireballs, dissipating the black fog around Nie Zun!

There was no humanity in Nie Zun's eyes, only a bloodthirsty ruthlessness . Both he and Gaoqin Jiuye retreated quickly in my direction!

Riding that fiery qilin was a striking woman dressed in purple, with a high-waisted pair of trousers that showed off the silhouette of her long, slender legs!

It was Du Yue!

Du Yue had a cold and arrogant look about her . With one hand controlling the fiery qilin, she flicked her other wrist in a motion that pulled Ta Lai out of that black fog!

Ta Lai was charred . Everything was burnt from his neck down!

A look of suppressed pain appeared on Ta Lai's usually elegant face, but he looked more shocked at the appearance of Du Yue!

Du Yue looked around and stared at me . I felt an immense killing intent!

“Ta Lai, I've told you this before . You shouldn't have spared her life!” As she spoke, I was overcome with an impending sense of doom!

At that moment, I heard a voice of a middle-aged man behind me!

“Amitabha— Be good . ”

That draggy, low-pitched middle-aged voice seemed to come from somewhere around us . Du Yue's eyes widened in shock as she heard it!

I wanted to turn back to look, but a pillar of golden light appeared from the sky! The golden light was dazzling, and it shone directly onto Nie Zun, who was still surrounded by the black fog!

Nie Zun's eyes narrowed as he was encased in that golden light!

An incredulous look appeared on Gaoqin Jiuye's face!

The sense of doom I felt coming from Du Yue was also dissipated by this golden light!

As I looked back, I saw a middle-aged monk in a kasaya walking towards us slowly with prayer beads in hand! (T/n: A kasaya is a term that refers to the robes worn by Buddhist monks .)

Though his pace seemed slow, he was able to reach us in just a few steps!

He had a slightly chubby face which had a very calm expression, looking like he had seen everything and had had enough of this world . His prayer beads shone with a bright light as he moved!

The light shot in Du Yue's direction, and Du Yue waved a hand!

The fiery qilin roared . With the injured Ta Lai and Du Yue on its back, it turned and left in a haste!

All of this happened within a split second . As air currents continued to explode and collapse around us, Du Yue and the fiery qilin were already gone!

The monk looked like he was able to bring calm into any storm . He had a smile on his face that was gentle, but at the same time, it seemed to bear down on people with an unknown pressure!

“Amitabha . ” With that Buddhist greeting, the monk passed by slowly without looking at me, and he disappeared in front of my eyes!

What sorcery was this!

In another second, everything went back to normal . Ta Lai was gone, Du Yue was gone, and the monk was also gone!

Nie Zun was now lying unconscious on the ground, and Jiao S had re-appeared! She was also laying on the ground, unconscious .

Shen Qi was already back at Gaoqin Jiuye's waist . He was very pale, and he looked exhausted as he stood beside Nie Zun with a hand on his abdomen!

Shen Qi was already back at Gaoqin Jiuye's waist . He was very pale, and he looked exhausted as he stood beside Nie Zun with a hand on his abdomen!

Two figures suddenly dropped from air currents that appeared out of nowhere .

Like discarded toys, Si Luo and Guan Nie dropped onto the ground beside Gaoqin Jiuye and Jiao S .

Gaoqin Jiuye looked like he could no longer bear with his injury as he sat down on the stone ground .

The sudden calm made me slightly anxious, and I looked around, my gaze finally landing on the prone forms of Si Luo and Guan Nie .

One had long, silvery-white hair, while the other had white hair spread out messily across the blood-stained ground . They looked like a gift from heaven, two beautiful individuals sleeping peacefully in this quiet and spooky forest .

Exhaustion overcame me, and I fell backwards . All I could see was my red dress as I closed my eyes .

Two years ago .

“I heard Mr Blond say the value of your MF is 52?” Li Qing was beside me . I had been daydreaming on the rooftop for quite a while now .

“Yes,” I answered calmly as I continued looking into the distance .

“You don’t like the Western District?”

I looked at Li Qing who had a dashing smile on her face .

“Why do you say that?” I gave a slight smile .

“So this means you’re admitting that you like this place .” Li Qing gave me a charming smile .

“Since you like it here, you have to learn how to protect yourself so that you can continue living, and surviving here .” She put more emphasis on the last three words ‘and surviving here’ .

“We won’t die here anyway . ” I laughed casually, though I did not feel light-hearted about this at all .

“No . ” She looked me in the eye as she continued, “There’re many places to die here in the Split Zone . Don’t think that you won’t be able to die as long as you keep your split symbol well-protected . ”

“Is that so . So what...” I sighed and looked into the distance once again .

“Is that so . So what...” I sighed and looked into the distance once again .

Li Qing was someone who was sure of everything she did, and she looked especially charming in fights . She was just like a genius .

But there were also times when she was just like a child .

Just like now .

Under that silver armor, she lifted a sculpted arm to adjust her hair, and she had this slightly distressed expression .

“Mr Blond entrusted you to me, and it seems like I’m not able to take care of you well . I always see you daydreaming here . Well, the Western District is a nice place . Stay here and I’ll protect you . ”

As if she found the root of her problems and solved it on her own, she laughed loudly and draped a hand over my shoulder .

As I looked at the gray sky and the forest in the distance, the refreshing scent of Li Qing’s hair wafted into my nose as a wind blew past us .

“Hey . ” She used her chin to point in the direction behind me .

“Does it feel nice that he’s always with you?” Li Qing laughed .

I frowned a little, a look of irritation in my eyes . “No, it doesn’t . ”

Li Qing’s hand which was on my shoulder pinched it hard, and I looked at her in annoyance .

Her gaze was clear like spring water .

“No matter what world we’re in, company is always precious . It’s your luck that you have it now . No matter how unlucky you were when you were alive, whatever you have now will always be the best you can get . ”

Though I didn’t understand what she meant nor was I touched by what she said, I did not react very strongly to it .

I made a non-committal sound, trying to end this .

“You don’t know how to protect yourself, and you want to drive away the one who can protect you . What a façade . ”

She was criticizing me, but she sounded so full of love as she said it .

“I’ll be teaching you how to fight soon . But before that, you’ll need a weapon . ”

She was criticizing me, but she sounded so full of love as she said it .

“I’ll be teaching you how to fight soon . But before that, you’ll need a weapon . ”

Though I was uninterested in everything since arriving in the Split Zone, I still respected and relied on Li Qing greatly .

I was not very interested in getting into fights or having weapons, but because Li Qing said it, I tried to make myself look slightly more interested as I looked towards her .

Li Qing took a sideways look at me and it felt as if she already knew what I was thinking . She grabbed something from behind and threw it into my arms .

I looked at it as I picked it up .

It was a bow .

It was silvery-white, the same color as her armor . No wonder I did not realize she was carrying it when she walked over before .

The bow was not large either, it was small and portable .

There were not many designs on that silvery-white bow, and it did not seem to be exquisitely decorated either . Though it looked like an ordinary bow, nothing extremely beautiful, it felt right in my hands .

For some reason, I already fell in love with this ordinary bow as I lay eyes on it .

“This is a... bow?” I looked at Li Qing with a rare curiosity .

Li Qing’s hair was blowing in the wind, and she squinted in a smile .

“That’s right, it’s a bow . It’s for you . Use it to practice defensive moves next time . ”

“How about the arrows?” I asked casually as I played around with the tiny bow .

“I’ll get someone to create the arrows for you, they’ll be dipped in a suppressant . It’s lucky that this dress of yours is pretty thick and it isn’t too revealing either . I’ll attach the quiver on the dress, and you can bring them with you wherever you go . ”

“What’s the story behind this bow? I’m sure you wouldn’t be giving me any ordinary bow . ” I asked jokingly, not being too serious about it . It did not matter whether the bow was a good weapon or not, since what was important to me was that I liked it on first sight, and I would definitely want to use it in future .

“Sadly, this bow is really just an ordinary bow . There’s nothing special about it,” Li Qing answered with a smile .

Chapter 157

157 The Smartest Individual

“Shen’er...”

A pleasant, familiar and slightly husky voice was calling at me .

I opened my eyes unwillingly as I felt something cold beside my face . I was simply too exhausted .

Nie Zun’s scarred face met my eyes as I opened them fully . Though he had a face full of scars, it could not take my attention away from the gentle light that shone through those starry eyes of his .

Wait, his eyes...

I sat up, staring at him . “Your eyes have recovered?”

No, I shouldn’t be asking like this .

“You, you’ve recovered?”

Nie Zun’s eyes seemed to darken for a moment before he answered, “I think so, except for this ugly face . ”

A bittersweet smile appeared on his face .

I was heartbroken at how he seemed to hate himself .

Looking around, I realized we were already in a building in the Southern District . Nie Zun was sitting on the bed, and I was asleep in his arms previously .

I grabbed his arm . “You look better this way . At least your eyes and hands are fine . ”

Nie Zun laughed, and I saw the defeat disappear from his eyes . “You’re really bad at consoling others . Why would you tell someone they look better with a face full of scars?”

I asked, “But seriously, what happened?”

Something flashed in his eyes . “Nothing . ”

With a slight frown, I pulled his arm towards me in a sudden motion . He was caught unawares as I pulled him much closer to me .

It was the first time I saw an expression that looked like embarrassment on his face .

I stared at his face, still holding onto his arms tightly with my hands . I asked in a severe tone, “Tell me what happened . Why did you disappear after I activated my split symbol? What happened in this time? I’ll bite you if you don’t tell me . ”

I was trying to be a little bit more girlish, hoping that I could lift his spirits a little since he did not feel good about the disfigurement, and he was definitely blaming himself and regretting that he attacked me when being controlled .

Nie Zun’s gaze softened as he sighed .

“Nothing much, actually . I was badly injured that day, and for some reason there was this demonic energy leaking from my hands . You know that this pair of hands had already caused the deaths of so many around me when I was alive . I was afraid of it happening again . When I saw that demonic aura, I didn’t know what to do, so I decided to leave temporarily . But then I realized I could actually be more than 500 meters away from you, so I just left . ”

Furrowing my brows, I pouted . “You just left? What do you mean you just left? You left me merely because of this?”

It was only after I finished speaking that I realized I was acting like such a little girl by asking such a thing .

I was a little tense, and my face seemed to be a few degrees hotter .

I was a little tense, and my face seemed to be a few degrees hotter .

With Nie Zun’s disappearance, I was now very sure of his place in my heart .

Though I didn’t dare admit it, what I felt for him was what I felt for Gao Qi at that time, or rather, I should say that this was completely different . I couldn’t tell whether it was love .

But I knew that I couldn’t live without Nie Zun .

Subconsciously, I squeezed his arm as I felt a little upset .

Nie Zun’s eyes shone, as if he felt a slight change in me .

“I never thought of leaving you . I wanted to be on my own for just a little while, just to make sure that this pair of demonic hands wouldn’t hurt the people around me . I planned on returning after that because I’d never risk hurting you, never ever .

“Even if I had to leave, I’ll never let anything hurt you . ”

Nie Zun’s voice slowly regained that unique steadiness and confidence he had, and I began to find familiarity in him again .

“Never knew you were this good at sweet-talk . ” I just had to chide him . I rolled my eyes at him, but my hands were still holding onto him firmly, not letting go .

Nie Zun’s lips turned up in a slight smile . “Never knew you could be so adorable either . You were always ignoring me, and even though you were

such a weakling, you were so ill-tempered it was crazy . Weak, ill-tempered and egoistic . ”

My lips twitched . Haha, how could I have forgotten that Nie Zun was a devil that could never say anything good?

“What happened in the end then?” I changed the topic since I did not want to discuss how ‘not adorable’ I was in the past .

I could feel Nie Zun freeze a little, so I waited patiently for his answer .

I could feel Nie Zun freeze a little, so I waited patiently for his answer .

“In the chaos, I passed through the East-West border line and arrived in the Eastern District where I happened to meet Ta Lai . The demonic aura was spreading continuously from my hands, and I was badly injured . He told me that he’d be able to help, and since I knew him from before, I didn’t suspect anything and simply went with him . I lost my consciousness as I entered that dark space of his, and he already planted the curse in my left eye when I woke up . ”

I listened quietly, but my heart was hurting .

I knew Nie Zun too well . He had amazing endurance and an ability to not crack under pressure, possibly because he had always been living under a certain kind of pressure when he was alive . This could also be the reason why he looked at everything in such a cold and calm manner . However, to protect me, he lost his restraint in that battle with Gaoqin Jiuye, causing that demonic aura to be released from his hands . This might all be because of me, and I just might be the trigger .

Not only did Nie Zun have amazing endurance, he did things carefully and he was a rational person . When that demonic energy seeped out from his hands, the first thing he thought of was not of what will happen to him, but of whether he would hurt me with it . To protect me and to prevent himself from being a ticking time-bomb if he was by my side, he chose to leave, and he did not even think about going to Jie Pa to treat his wounds first .

As long as I was implicated in some way, he was no longer able to think through the next steps calmly . How else would he have run all the way to the Eastern District and get taken away by Ta Lai so easily?

He was always intelligent and cautious, calm and collected . If it were not for me, how else would Ta Lai be able to convince him with just a few words?

All this was because of me .

I started tearing up, and I tried to silently take a deep breath to control my emotions .

“I knew something was wrong after he planted that weird curse in my left eye, so I decided to go against him . At that time, my injuries had not healed, and I was tortured by him under the restraints of that curse . ”

Nie Zun used a light-hearted tone to say this, and he kept his eyes on me the whole time . I knew he was afraid I would be upset to hear this if he didn't use such a tone .

But what he didn't know was that I would still feel heartbroken no matter how he told the story .

I was already heartbroken when I saw him again with his face full of scars and a hand that was missing three fingers . I could not imagine these horrifying things happening to him, I could not imagine it could change him, my Nie Zun, in this way .

Nie Zun's eyes regained their calm gaze as he continued his story .

I was already heartbroken when I saw him again with his face full of scars and a hand that was missing three fingers . I could not imagine these horrifying things happening to him, I could not imagine it could change him, my Nie Zun, in this way .

Nie Zun's eyes regained their calm gaze as he continued his story .

“He has this knife he specially uses to carve those wooden puppets that become giants . These scars were left by that knife of his . That demonic energy was still seeping from my hands, and though I tried strangling him, I couldn’t beat that curse he placed, and he was able to cut three fingers off my hand . ”

“Why don’t these wounds heal then?” I looked at him in worry .

He shook his head . “I don’t know either . It could be because of that knife . I was shocked at the time, but I didn’t have much time to think about it . He kept controlling me through the curse . I tried to oppose him initially, but in the end, he used that knife to leave a mark on my face every time I tried to oppose him . ”

He laughed at himself . “Though I’m a man, I’d be lying if I said I didn’t care about my appearance at all . So as time passed, I began to be controlled by him entirely . ”

“Why did Ta Lai do such a thing?” My voice was trembling slightly, heartbroken at how he was tortured by Ta Lai .

Nie Zun shook his head again . “I don’t know . He said it was because of your betrayal, saying that you’re making plans to leave the Split Zone even though you promised not to leave . But I’m sure it’s not because of this . Ta Lai is an intelligent person who’s great at mind games, there’s no way he would do this to me just because of this . ”

“That’s right, he doesn’t look like someone like that either . There must be some other reason to it . ”

“Yes, and Ta Lai returned to the Northern District with Du Yue previously . So why did he appear in the Eastern District so quickly again? I suspect he has his own reasons for doing so, but I can’t tell if it was by mere chance that he met me . What I can be sure of though, is that there’s something else going on, something he didn’t reveal .

“Also, he seemed a little different when he first met me, when he used that knife to scratch my face . ” There was no longer pain and self-loathing in

Nie Zun's eyes . He now looked extremely collected as he recalled what happened, trying his best to look for clues .

I felt relieved as I looked at that expression . This is the real him, this is my Nie Zun .

Nie Zun is not someone who can be easily defeated .

If he was a devil, then he would be the most intelligent devil I've met .

Chapter 158

158 Who Changed These Clothes?

“What’s different about him?” I asked .

Nie Zun’s eyes were shining, as if he was speedily recalling everything that happened before .

“Something was off about him . Ta Lai has always been calm and composed, you know that too . But he looked different that day, as if there was this hatred in him, and he looked a little agitated . ”

Hatred? Agitated?

Ta Lai was like this too when that demonic form took over Nie Zun . He should have been shocked, but after just a split second of looking surprised, there seemed to be this immense hate and anger coming from him .

Yes, he was talking about Satan’s soul at that time too .

“Right, he was like that too when that demonic form took over in you . Could it be that you had some similarity with Cang Ming when in that form? I’m guessing that it might have triggered the hatred he had towards Cang Ming . ”

After a moment of pondering, Nie Zun answered, “That’s possible . According to legend, Bian Ying, his lover, had a sudden change of heart and she’s currently by Cang Ming’s side . There might be some resentment there, and since he saw me being similar to Cang Ming, he might have directed that hatred towards me . ”

“But,” Nie Zun continued with slightly furrowed brows . “It doesn’t seem right that this was all because of a grudge . Ta Lai doesn’t seem like the kind who’d do something so cruel because of a personal grudge . I think there’s definitely something more to this . ”

“Since he looked different, could he have been under some sort of restraint? Do you remember his nightmare? In his nightmare, he kept calling for Bian Ying . Do you think this might somehow be related to his nightmares?”

After a pause, I spoke more slowly, “No matter what, now you’re back and Du Yue has taken Ta Lai away . We’ll definitely get an answer in the Northern District . ”

I squeezed Nie Zun’s palm and starlight shone in his eyes .

I gently touched his face with a hand . “I should’ve brought Jie Pa with me . He’d definitely be able to help heal your face . ”

With a pale and slender hand, Nie Zun took my hand in his . “It’s no use . I’ve tried ways and means to destroy this face, but it heals every time . The only thing that doesn’t is these scars . It could be something to do with that knife of his . ”

I frowned . “Don’t worry about it . There’d surely be a way . ”

I was already tearing, and I felt even more emotional as I looked into those starry eyes .

“Right, since your eyes have recovered, does it mean that the curse has been removed after that demonic form took over? From what Ta Lai said, you devoured the curse . But there wouldn’t be any side effects from that right?” I looked at his left eye in worry .

Nie Zun smiled . “There shouldn’t be any . ”

“I’m still worried about it . Let me take a look . ” I leaned in closer to his face, focusing on his left eye as I tried to look for traces of that curse .

This action of mine closed the distance between us, but I did not notice it at all, or it might have turned a little awkward . At this point though, I saw a tiny red dot in the pupil of his left eye . I blinked and focused my MF onto my eyes . In a bid to get a clearer look, I leaned in further .

All of a sudden, Nie Zun's eyelashes fluttered as he took a deep breath . Our eyelashes brushed against each other .

I blushed as soon as I realized how close we were to each other .

This was rather awkward . What should I do now? If I back away, it would seem like I was trying to hide my feelings . I hated girls who did that, and I was not one to hide my feelings either .

But would it be too much if I went forward?

As these thoughts were racing through my mind, I suddenly found Nie Zun grabbing my hand!

I felt a cool air on my face as Nie Zun breathed out .

I felt a cool air on my face as Nie Zun breathed out .

I blinked .

Nie Zun looked up, and the starlight in his eyes made me momentarily forget that I was looking for traces of that curse .

I saw his lips turn up a little, and in the next second, he grabbed the back of my head!

I was wondering if I should resist as I felt the pressure on the back of my head, but I hesitated for just one second .

In that second, he pressed his lips against mine! Though this was not the first time our lips touched, it felt different this time!

Our eyes were still on each other, and there was a warmth from those cold lips as they hit me .

“Mm...” A murmur escaped me as I felt lost in that familiar scent of his, feeling a little giddy . I felt as if I was about to suffocate, and I tried to move away subconsciously .

As if able to tell I was about to move, fireworks seemed to appear in Nie Zun’s eyes! Those fiery eyes locked themselves on me, and I felt a greater pressure from his hand which was still on the back of my head!

I felt his dry lips as both our lips smashed into each other from what was originally a light peck! There was no longer any cold now, only a burning heat .

My lips felt like they were on fire, but it wasn’t a scorching heat; it was a heat that made me drunk on it . It was the first time I felt temptation like a moth drawn to an open flame .

I was initially a little unsure, but with newfound courage, I pressed forward and returned the kiss! My hands found his arms and moved to his back, taking him in an embrace .

For a moment, Nie Zun froze as he felt my acceptance! But very quickly, he took me in a tight embrace, like a sudden fire that was lit!

Gentle exploration turned into a forceful taking as he pried my lips open, his chill entangling with my warmth!

Gentle exploration turned into a forceful taking as he pried my lips open, his chill entangling with my warmth!

A poisonous temptation spread through my mouth, and my hands held onto him even more tightly as he grabbed me with both arms! Instead of his usual coolness, I felt like I was about to be roasted in Nie Zun’s fiery embrace!

I could see the fireworks in his eyes, and I leaned back as I felt a sudden urge to avoid him, afraid that this passion would be suddenly extinguished!

Nie Zun was not taking things slow anymore . His lips turned up in a haughty smile, and he took the opportunity to pin me down as I leaned backwards!

My hair was in a mess, and our lips parted for a short moment as we fell . My brows furrowed at the lingering emptiness as my lips left his . But before I knew it, I could already feel his soft tongue in my mouth . He was holding me tight, and his breathing was getting heavier!

Trembling, my eyes were open and I saw a devilish firelight in those starry eyes of his . We were pressing into each other's bodies as his strong arms kept me pinned down!

As we were locked in passionate embrace, there was a sudden knock on the door .

Shocked, I accidentally kicked Nie Zun in a fluster!

“Ow...” Nie Zun jumped out of the bed in pain . His hair was in a mess, and those starry eyes looked a little pitiful . Looking at him like this, I couldn't help but let out a tiny laugh .

Nie Zun stared at me, as if telling me that he would take his revenge someday, before saying ‘Come in’ .

Gaoqin Jiuye was the first to walk in .

For some reason, I froze for a second as I looked at him .

Gaoqin Jiuye swept his menacing gaze past Nie Zun and I, finally stopping on my rosy cheeks and slightly messy hair . He looked mysterious and dangerous with those narrowed eyes and both hands in his pockets .

After a moment, I heard Nie Zun laugh . He was back to his usual self as he said, “Come in and have a seat . ”

That sounded a little out of place, but...

After a moment, I heard Nie Zun laugh . He was back to his usual self as he said, “Come in and have a seat . ”

That sounded a little out of place, but...

It sounded as if we were newlyweds, while Gaoqin Jiuye and Jiao S, who was behind him, were our guests .

No, what newlyweds, what am I thinking about?

The petite Jiao S came forward quickly after hearing Nie Zun . She was by my side in a second .

“Are you okay now, Ah Shen?”

An intelligent and perceptive person like her seemed to have already noticed the difference in me and the awkward ambience in the room . There seemed to be some emotion in her blank eyes, and she kept looking at Nie Zun and I .

I felt a little awkward . Their observation skills were really something...

I stood up hastily, trying to put some distance between the bed and myself .
“I’m much better . Are the both of you okay too?”

Jiao S smiled . “We’re fine . When I was swallowed, I fainted from that horrible stench in the giant’s stomach . The rest of you were already on the floor when I woke up . ”

So you actually fainted and weren’t digested by the giant...

“Oh, is your stomach okay now? Though Gaoqin Jiuye’s wound healed really slowly, it still healed eventually . I think you should be fine too . ”

I was reminded of my injury only when Jiao S mentioned it . I was actually impaled through the stomach! I looked down and realized there were no more bloodstains on my dress, and there was no hole there either .

Almost immediately, I looked up at Nie Zun in a rage . Nie Zun had a face that seemed to say this had nothing to do with him .

I gritted my teeth in anger . Don't pretend like this has nothing to do with you . Who changed my clothes then?!

Chapter 159

159 A Fight Between the Snipe and the Clam

(T/n: A phrase in Chinese, yu bang xiang zheng, that describes a third party benefiting from a fight between two others .)

I addressed Jiao S while keeping my eyes on Nie Zun, who remained looking innocent .

“I should be fine... I guess . ”

There was a chill in Gaoqin Jiuye’s gaze as he asked, “Nie Zun, can you give us some sort of explanation?”

Nie Zun gave a casual laugh, and he quickly repeated what he previously told me about being taken away by Ta Lai . I then told him about what happened to us when he was missing .

After that, there was nothing but silence in the room .

Gaoqin Jiuye was the first to break the silence .

“You were rather merciless when you went against us previously, so why should we believe you now?” He directed this question at Nie Zun, as if snubbing him .

Nie Zun was his usual, calm self . “You can choose not to believe me . ”

Okay, a stalemate again .

I looked at the two of them and thought to myself, When did the two of them start hating each other like this?

But this might not be peculiar, since Gaoqin Jiuye wasn't a popular person, and he didn't care about others anyway . As for Nie Zun, he always had this demeanor as if he couldn't be bothered about anything else, and he was an even more unpopular individual .

I guess it's quite normal that such individuals would hate each other?

I was never good at dissipating such situations, but Jiao S was a natural at this . She said, "Good that you're back, we need to work together so that the soul splitters can't get the better of us . "

However, what Nie Zun said next seemed to carry some hostility . "Work together? Among us, you're the only soul splitter here, right?"

He looked at Gaoqin Jiuye with a smile, and even I trembled at that smile which was obviously far from genuine .

I always knew that Nie Zun only looked like a lazy bum on the outside, but in reality, he was someone you do not wish to ever offend . Even so, he cared so little about the things around him that it was rare to see the other side of him . From the current situation however, he could no longer sit back and watch while doing nothing at all .

Gaoqin Jiuye returned the smile, his cruel lips turning up at an angle . "That's right . When you guys say work together," as he said this, he pointed at the three of us one by one . "The three of you are on the same side, while I'm a soul splitter . So I'd suggest you don't put too much trust in me .

"I've also said this before, that I'm doing all this for Si Luo, including going with all of you to the Northern District . You could say it's partially for Guan Nie too . Once I've obtained what I set out for, there's no need for us to be working together anymore . "

Looking at how clearly he drew the line between us, I felt a little upset at it, weirdly .

Yes, why did I forget that Gaoqin Jiuye is different from us again?

Weren't we fighting against him in that battle which caused me to activate my split symbol?

He does everything for Si Luo .

Only for Si Luo .

But why did I have a feeling that he was creating this veneer to separate himself from others on purpose? Why did I want to believe that he wasn't such an individual?

No matter how many times others have told me to stay away from him, to be wary of him, and even when the things he did could harm me, why did I still want to believe in him?

“How badly is Guan Nie's split symbol peeling?” Nie Zun asked abruptly .

Seems like he cares quite a bit about Guan Nie too .

Before I could answer, Gaoqin Jiuye laughed . “No use worrying about him . If we don't go to the Northern District to find the individual who can save him, death will come knocking on his door . ”

“Furthermore, I'm pretty sure you know how bad his injuries are . That shadow which appeared in front of the window and beat Yu Liang – that was you, right?” Gaoqin Jiuye asked with narrowed eyes as he lifted his head, seemingly looking in Nie Zun's direction .

My heart skipped a beat . Right, how could I forget . According to Nie Zun, demonic energy was seeping from his hands after he got injured, and he left alone because of that . He met Ta Lai shortly after, and he'd been under Ta Lai's control since . If that's the case, why did he appear in the Eastern District on that day? He even helped us out, and let me find him?

I looked at Nie Zun doubtfully .

There was no change in Nie Zun's calm expression . “Ta Lai let me go on purpose that day, and it was a coincidence that we met . After I helped you guys out, Ta Lai took control of me again . ”

“You mean all that was planned by Ta Lai? Then we’re back to that same question . What’s Ta Lai’s objective?”

Nie Zun did not answer Gaoqin Jiuye this time .

I took a deep breath, saying to Gaoqin Jiuye, “I trust Nie Zun . If you’re coming with us, then I hope you’ll trust Nie Zun too . No matter what, I believe he wouldn’t hurt me . ”

I was met with Gaoqin Jiuye’s frigid gaze as I looked up .

“Huh, is that so . You believe that he wouldn’t hurt you no matter what? Is that why you refused to let go of him even when he created a bloody hole in your body?” Gaoqin Jiuye sounded harsh and angry as he said this .

I did not expect him to say such a thing, and I was rendered speechless at how direct he was .

Nie Zun’s gaze darkened, and I knew that he was upset at how Gaoqin Jiuye brought this up again, because it was an undeniable fact that he had hurt me .

This was probably unbearable for him .

This was probably unbearable for him .

Gaoqin Jiuye just had to mention it to rile up Nie Zun and I, and I spoke in the spur of the moment, “So what? He was being controlled at the time, but you actually went against me on your own accord . By this logic, should I be more wary of you instead?”

I said this without thinking it through, and I felt a tinge of regret after that as I saw a look of self-mockery on Gaoqin Jiuye .

I quickly suppressed that feeling . What I said was the truth, so why should I sympathize with him?

He was the one who brought me here to the Split Zone . He was the one who went against me before . And now he’s trying to put some sort of

blame on Nie Zun when we're trying to work together?

Gaoqin Jiuye, who are you to put the blame on others? Do you treat me that well? In fact, you should be my greatest enemy, my soul splitter .

Gaoqin Jiuye kept his eyes on me, and I returned his stare .

Sometimes, I'm curious why we would be able to meet here in the Split Zone, with this rather complicated relationship . Why did I meet you, someone who looks exactly like Gao Qi, here?

Fate loves to play games with us, don't you think?

"What's the use of bickering now? Our goals are one and the same . Gaoqin Jiuye, both you and I are doing this for Si Luo and Guan Nie, while Li Shen is doing this for her friend . Since our aim is to reach the Northern District, why're we fighting here?" Jiao S finally spoke .

"Furthermore, two days have already passed . There're still five more days to go before Guan Nie's split symbol completely peels off, and before his consciousness disappears in the Split Zone forever . He no longer has a will to live, and if we don't reach the Northern District in time to find the one who can save him, he'll definitely die .

"Gaoqin Jiuye, instead of arguing, why don't you use this time to think about how to save Guan Nie? Or are you happy to see him die because of you?" Jiao S looked at Gaoqin Jiuye with a frown .

Mentioning Guan Nie worked as Gaoqin Jiuye quietened .

"Moreover, we're now in the Southern District . Doesn't matter if it's Ta Lai or Du Yue, it's obvious that entering and leaving the Southern District is a piece of cake for them . Si Luo is in a deep sleep now, and as the person he trusts the most, and also as someone who's among the candidates for the next Southern District Commander, can you just sit back and watch as you let all this happen?"

Jiao S's eyes shone with a light that looked so full of justice . “Gaoqin Jiuye, I know you're not interested in being District Commander and whatnot, and you've never had a sense of responsibility for whatever you do . But even if you didn't bother about all this, can't you protect what Si Luo built?”

Jiao S's eyes shone with a light that looked so full of justice . “Gaoqin Jiuye, I know you're not interested in being District Commander and whatnot, and you've never had a sense of responsibility for whatever you do . But even if you didn't bother about all this, can't you protect what Si Luo built?”

Compared to Nie Zun and I, Jiao S was sharp and precise in her words, and it was difficult to argue with her since whatever she said was indeed true .

In the past, I never would have thought Jiao S could be such a reasonable individual who fought for justice .

Gaoqin Jiuye asked with narrowed eyes, “What're you planning to do?”

Jiao S looked at him . “Do you know where the Southern District's experimental grounds are?”

Gaoqin Jiuye laughed cruelly . “I really don't know . You have to ask Si Luo or Rong Jin . ”

His evil smile froze as he seemed to be reminded of something . All of us froze as well .

Rong Jin... Where's Rong Jin??

Rong Jin was the first to show up in Ta Lai's dark space, but after Ta Lai appeared and engaged us in battle, where did he go? Also, why would he be involved with Ta Lai?

“Why did Ta Lai side with Du Yue all of a sudden?” Jiao S voiced our doubts .

I caught Gaoqin Jiuye's gaze wavering as Du Yue was mentioned again . When Du Yue appeared that day, I had no spare time to pay attention to Gaoqin Jiuye's expression . I wonder what happened between them .

“You can't find the experimental grounds, but you can find Rong Jin, right?” Jiao S asked Gaoqin Jiuye again .

Gaoqin Jiuye replied, “I can't . You should know this too . Ever since he went under Si Luo's wing, he never showed his face . He always used those shadows of his . No one knows where he is or why he's suddenly working with Ta Lai instead of properly protecting the Southern District . ”

Jiao S tilted her head . “Alright, you don't know anything and you can't find anything . I'll ask you one last question . As a soul splitter, you should at least know how to go to the Northern District right?”

Chapter 160

160 A Cruel Disaster

Gaoqin Jiuye finally nodded . “Of course I know that, but let me make something clear . Even though I’m a soul splitter, Si Luo and I have been in the Southern District for a very long time . We’ve never left the Southern District in these years where Si Luo took care of the weaker ordinary residents here . So I wouldn’t know what the Northern District looks like now . I’m sure it’ll look different compared to how it was many years before . I can definitely bring you there, but I can’t guarantee what may happen . ”

So what if you can guarantee anything? I know you’re a soul splitter, and in principle, we shouldn’t be standing on the same side . What else can I ask of you?

“Right, there’s also one more thing . That octopus monster we saw in the Eastern District before Yu Liang appeared, it should be a failed experiment . According to reports from my S Clan, although Ta Lai and the rest can enter and leave any district as they please without others realizing, the security of the Eastern District is not so lax to the point that a mere octopus monster can enter whenever it wishes . I think that this likely means the monster might have entered the Eastern District in another form, possibly in human form . ”

“So you mean, he was initially just a normal body of consciousness, but turned into an octopus monster after entering the Eastern District?”

Jiao S nodded in response to my question . “Yes, we can look at it from the point before he turned . If he turned into that creature only after entering the Eastern District, then according to our border records, it’s highly likely he

entered from the Southern District together with Yu Liang . Just like what you deduced, Yu Liang already had a plan, and what he did was to force us to look for Song Lu . ”

I suddenly thought of something else . “It must be because of that experiment that caused Yu Liang’s hands to turn into those things . If that’s the case, then that octopus monster might just be a failed experiment . If Yu Liang did escape from the experimental grounds, what was he trying to tell us by bringing a failed experimental subject with him?”

Jiao S laughed . “That’s possible, but that octopus monster has already been hacked into a million pieces by you . Even if there were any clues on it, it’d be useless now . ”

I smiled awkwardly . I remembered the scene clearly . I saw my second personality, and in a moment of uncontrolled rage, I used Piercer to attack that octopus monster .

Wait, that octopus monster was originally human and a body of consciousness? And that experiment caused him to change?

Cold sweat appeared on my forehead .

“What’s wrong?” Jiao S sensed my discomfort .

I looked towards Nie Zun, who was also looking at me with questioning eyes .

“Nie Zun, do you remember that basiliscampus...” Cold sweat dripped down my brows .

Nie Zun seemed to remember it as I saw his lips move, as if about to say something, but he did not say anything eventually .

“Just what happened?” Jiao S and Gaoqin Jiuye were both looking at me .

I took a deep breath before speaking . “Nie Zun and I have both seen something similar to that octopus monster . At that time, the creature had parts of a fish and a snake . Now that I think about it, that might have also

been originally a human . We called it a basiliscampus at the time, and Li Qing attacked it and killed it shortly after . At that time, I never thought it might have been a human .

“According to what you just said, if the octopus monster was originally a human, then why did he lose his healing ability? The basiliscampus we saw couldn’t heal either . If they were all originally bodies of consciousness, then would they actually be considered successful experiments? Isn’t their aim to kill bodies of consciousness?”

Jiao S realized how serious this was . “But, if the experiment had already seen success, would it still be this peaceful in the Split Zone right now? Or could there still be some problem with the experiment? Furthermore, that monster is obviously different from the experimental subjects you’ve seen previously . So does this mean that there’s actually more than one experiment going on?”

I added quickly, “That’s highly likely . ‘Experiment number 2’ was written on what was left in the Western District’s experimental grounds . If that’s the case, then it’s likely there’s number one, number three, and so on . The objectives of these experiments might be different then?”

My palms started to turn cold, and I saw Jiao S’s gaze getting more and more anxious . “More importantly, it was quite some time ago when we saw that basiliscampus . That was when Li Qing was still around . At the time, Li Qing also had this weird look on her .

“Nie Zun and I weren’t aware of this previously, but now that we look at it, this conspiracy could’ve already been planned since then . What’s happening right now could just be a continuation of that plan . If that’s really the case, then Du Yue’s objective is definitely not as simple as just killing Bian Ying, her rival in love .

“There could be a greater conspiracy behind all this .

“There’s something else to take note of too . Li Qing might have known about this long ago . If that’s the case, can I assume that Li Qing and Mr Blond’s disappearance are all inter-related somehow?”

“There’s something else to take note of too . Li Qing might have known about this long ago . If that’s the case, can I assume that Li Qing and Mr Blond’s disappearance are all inter-related somehow?”

I enunciated every word as I looked at Jiao S . A quick flicker passed in Jiao S’s eyes, possibly because I mentioned Li Qing .

I turned to Gaoqin Jiuye, staring at him . “As a soul splitter, even if you’ve left the Northern District for so long, do you really know nothing about this plan that should’ve already been set in motion years ago?”

Gaoqin Jiuye’s eyes shimmered and darkened, and he suddenly smiled . That smile looked so unpredictable and nobody could tell what he was thinking .

Boom!

There was a sudden explosion outside!

All of us looked towards the window, trying to see what just happened . As I took a step forward, the floor below us started quaking!

The entire building shook violently, as if we were experiencing an earthquake! I activated the MF under my feet, and together with the three of them, we jumped out of the window!

The building collapsed behind us right after we jumped! It was disastrous, and dust was flying everywhere!

“No!”

“Save me!”

Cries of help could be heard everywhere! But what we saw outside the building shocked us!

From the North-South border district, a stampede of monsters was charging in the direction of the Southern District’s city center, which was exactly where we were!

From the North-South border district, a stampede of monsters was charging in the direction of the Southern District's city center, which was exactly where we were!

It was Resident Evil in the Split Zone!

The monsters all looked different; most of them were the size of a normal human being, and while some of them were half the height of the average human, some of them were as massive as those five-meter tall giants created by Ta Lai . All kinds of monsters could be seen . There was the basiliscampus, the octopus monster, tiger heads on the bodies of lions, pythons with the heads of wolves, and many others that looked like nothing I have ever seen!

With wide eyes, Jiao S spoke slowly, “When did the Southern District... become a zoo?”

What sarcasm .

But none of us were in the mood for jokes as we faced this horrid scene .

Many people were jumping out of the windows as the Academy started collapsing behind us . Since most of the residents here had MF of a low value, some of them were not able to land safely on the ground, and I saw many tear-ridden faces that were full of fear and helplessness .

The monsters were closing in, and they would just rip humans apart at first sight . Those with low MF would not be able to heal quickly if attacked .

Looking at the situation, though it was not as bad as witnessing an apocalypse, this was still extremely terrifying for the Southern District residents . Thousands of monsters were attacking the people, and the ground shook as buildings collapsed one by one .

“Gaoqin Jiuye, these are your residents!” I looked towards Gaoqin Jiuye .

Gaoqin Jiuye had a shocked look on his face . Even he was stunned by what was happening .

“Save me!”

“Who can save me?!”

“Save me!”

“Who can save me?!”

“Ahh save me!”

The ground started shaking, as if the stone ground we were standing on was a boat that had hit some island while floating on the ocean, causing it to quake violently . Even I couldn't keep steady!

Boom!

The buildings continued collapsing, and a huge boulder came flying in my direction! Activating my MF, I dodged it . Though the boulder did not hit me, it smashed into a young lady not far from me!

There was no time to think and no time to be afraid . I could only use my MF to dodge whatever came at me!

I haven't seen such a horrible disaster even when alive!

The sea of monsters started to spread out, leaving a trail of destroyed trees and human body parts wherever they passed . Blood was spraying everywhere amidst painful cries!

It was difficult to engage in battle in this situation . We were already lucky to not be smashed by any of the collapsing buildings on this violently quaking ground!

Many residents with a low MF value healed extremely slowly, and I saw some of their bodies being destroyed again as they were still healing and trying to find the other parts of their bodies!

This was a massacre of the Southern District . Though the residents here had no way to resist, they could not be killed like this either . They could

only experience the pain again and again as they endured the ruthless attacks of the monsters!

Chapter 161

161 Going All Out in Battle

Why was this happening? I gave myself a belated slap to make sure this was not a dream!

The painful cries that surrounded us made it clear that this was all too real . The Southern District was currently overrun by a sea of monsters which continuously attacked and tortured the residents!

“Just, what’s happening...” Jiao S said in a trembling voice .

Never have I thought I would be able to witness such a scene where the landscape was painted with blood and where there were countless bodies strewn all over the place .

Though we could see Gaoqin Jiuye trying his best to project his voice, it was miniscule compared to the crashes and explosions around us .

“It’s still possible to defeat these monsters . What’s destroying the place is the earthquake and collapsing buildings . We have to find the source of the earthquake and kill these monsters!”

The man who originally did not care about anything and anyone else but Si Luo was now in a fury . With raging eyes, he freed Shen Qi . Shen Qi leapt out beautifully in a bright arc! There’s nothing he cannot kill within fifty square kilometers!

Gaoqin Jiuye was right, it was the violent earthquake and collapsing buildings that posed the most danger . As we dodged the falling debris, Shen Qi was like a godly sword bathed in blood as it slashed the monsters into two!

A group of frightened Southern District residents ran out of the building in front of us, their tear-stricken faces looking around in a panic . In an instant, a few tiger-headed monsters charged towards them!

I couldn't bear to watch anymore, and before I whipped Piercer out, I remembered Scorpion Ray on my left hand!

Though I still didn't know how to use Scorpion Ray very well, there was no time for me to ponder . I jumped to be near them and raised my left hand towards those monsters that were now roaring at me!

“Kill them, Scorpion Ray!” I shouted without a hint of mercy .

Swish!

The Scorpion Ray on my wrist produced a bright light, forming countless silver needles that flew towards those monsters! The silver needles pierced through the monsters like horizontal streaks of rain, and they were instantly riddled with holes!

Seeing my ability, the terrified Southern District residents all tried to hide behind me! However, one of them slipped and fell, causing the rest to trip!

I actually caused a stampede!

I was anxious at this and I wanted to tell them to keep calm and try to protect themselves, but the ground shook so violently that everything became a blur and I fell on the ground!

Something that looked ugly and twisted was flying towards me . Nie Zun, who came from nowhere, pulled me up from the ground and stared at the monster!

With just a stare, that monster lost its combat ability! From some distance away, Gaoqin Jiuye shouted, “Stay!”

I cupped my ears as a high-energy soundwave ripped through the air around us! The smaller monsters hit by the soundwave were instantly rooted to the ground!

The ground was still shaking, and these monsters looked like frozen chess pieces glued to a chess board, shaking stiffly!

White fog was already surging in Jiao S's huge eyes, and I could hear the air buzzing amidst all the smoke and dust . She raised both her hands and put them down again, and as she concentrated her MF on her hands, air currents started wrapping around the monsters which were not hit by the 'Persuader' . As she balled her fists, I could hear the sound of bone cracking in those monsters!

“What’s happening!” I shouted . Why am I always in battle recently? And the usually peaceful Southern District met with such a disaster . My goal is the Northern District, am I going to die here in this sudden earthquake before I even reach the Northern District?!

“My guess is that the experimental subjects escaped from the experimental grounds!” Jiao S shouted back at me as her black hair flew in the wind .

“My guess is that the experimental subjects escaped from the experimental grounds!” Jiao S shouted back at me as her black hair flew in the wind .

“What! I hope Du Yue didn’t just up and go to escape back to the Northern District with Ta Lai while leaving the Southern District’s experimental grounds to ruin!”

Nie Zun grabbed my arm suddenly . “Don’t just focus on shouting, be careful!”

When faced with this disastrous scene, I couldn’t feel any warmth even from Nie Zun’s caring words!

My heart started hurting again as I saw the many helpless tear-stained faces around us! Though I was no saint, I still felt sorrow and despair as I looked at how the residents had to face such a catastrophe!

How would Si Luo feel if he was awake, if he saw these residents who were living peacefully under his protection having their houses destroyed and being ruthlessly attacked by unknown monsters?

And if today's disaster happened in the Western District instead of the Southern District, how would I have felt?!

No, Old Man Fan?! I suddenly thought of Old Man Fan! Did he really move the entire Western District just because of You Ji's Seven Demons?!

Could it be... could it be...

Did a similar disaster also befall the Western District? So Old Man Fan chose to sacrifice himself to save the Western District through that spacial transference technique?

But why did no one in the Western District remember what happened? My thoughts were all over the place, and I already had Piercer in my right hand

.

I was merciless in my attacks, and monsters were continuously destroyed by my whip! I concentrated my MF on my feet in order to dodge attacks quickly, and the Scorpion Ray on my left hand continued producing a silvery-white light, which turned into a long streak when I moved with speed .

Though disaster called suddenly, we were able to get into the rhythm of battle very quickly . It was pretty weird, as the four of us seemed to have formed this tacit understanding with one another in a mere ten minutes or so!

Though disaster called suddenly, we were able to get into the rhythm of battle very quickly . It was pretty weird, as the four of us seemed to have formed this tacit understanding with one another in a mere ten minutes or so!

When the stone ground started shaking violently, Gaoqin Jiuye would command Shen Qi to attack the monsters coming at us, and Jiao S would focus her MF on the air currents to create a gigantic screen above us, shielding us from the debris of the collapsing buildings .

I was standing behind them to the left, and Nie Zun was on the right .

For the monsters that escaped from Shen Qi's attack, I would pick them off with my Scorpion Ray! Black fog also surged in Nie Zun's eyes as he used his pupils, forming a defensive wall to our left and right!

We stood in a rectangular formation as we fought against the monsters that came at us!

Though there was no difficulty in fighting the monsters, we weren't able to protect the residents this way! There were too many monsters and just the four of us were not enough!

Many residents had taken notice of us, and they were all running towards us with all their might . We could not do anything else as we looked at their terrified faces!

We could not protect them, but we could not let them surround us either since that would hinder us in the fight! But in such a situation, how do we even get them to leave?!

The four of us looked at one another as we knew very well that this cannot continue for long . This was not a feasible solution to the main problem!

"Where's Rong Jin? If only his monsters were here?! Is there no one else apart from the three of you in the Southern District!" I shouted at Gaoqin Jiuye .

"Are the three of us not enough? Together with Si Luo, who else did you think there was?"

What the hell, then you guys had better protect your district well!

But out of these three powerful individuals from the Southern District, two were missing, and these two were good at large-scale attacks . Be it Huan Qing's illusions or Rong Jin's summoning techniques, both of them would be much more useful than Gaoqin Jiuye in this situation, but none of them was here!

And Si Luo was in a deep sleep now!

But out of these three powerful individuals from the Southern District, two were missing, and these two were good at large-scale attacks . Be it Huan Qing's illusions or Rong Jin's summoning techniques, both of them would be much more useful than Gaoqin Jiuye in this situation, but none of them was here!

And Si Luo was in a deep sleep now!

I started worrying about the Southern District . If this was indeed caused by the experimental subjects escaping from the experimental grounds, it would spread very quickly to the Eastern District, and even to the Western District if we could not put a stop to it here!

“We need to find the source of the earthquake . Just where did it come from?” Nie Zun spoke suddenly, looking at me calmly .

“Ah Shen, I'll clear a path for you . You charge into the sea of monsters and see if there's anything behind that's controlling them or if there're any clues!” Jiao S shouted .

“Right!” Without hesitation, I agreed . My red dress billowed as I leapt up, charging forward towards the sea of monsters with Piercer in hand!

Jiao S used air currents to encapsulate me, forming a solid dome of defense!

I looked back at Nie Zun, whose eyes darkened . I nodded at him, signaling that I was fine!

He then nodded in response . After which, he used his pupil ability to destroy the monsters around Jiao S!

It would be hard for Jiao S to protect herself if she was solely focusing on protecting me!

The ground was still shaking below us, and I whipped Piercer around without mercy as the blood and flesh sprayed all over me . I did not bother wiping them away since I was only focused on destroying these monsters and not letting any one of them get away!

Following closely behind me was Gaoqin Jiuye who fell into step quickly .
Shen Qi was behind him, killing everything that came our way!

Chapter 162

162 You'll Find Out If You Try

I saw a familiar face as I reached the center of the sea of monsters!

Among the monsters, there was this enormous python in the middle . It looked like an ordinary python, but it was humongous . A pair of bright green eyes was staring at both Gaoqin Jiuye and I .

Wrapped up in that enormous python was a tiny figure . She was sitting on the python and she giggled as she blinked at me . She even waved at me .

Soft, golden hair fell across her forehead, and she looked like an adorable doll even with a mischievous expression on her chubby face . Her looks did not match with that gigantic python at all!

I said, “Lau... Laurel!”

“Hehe, Ah Shen jiejie, come quick, come over here . ” Laurel kept waving at me, like a little child who was waiting for me to play with her .

Gaoqin Jiuye held me back . I turned and shook my head at him, reassuring him that I will not do anything impulsive .

But Gaoqin Jiuye did not let go .

I turned back, but I wasn't able to see Nie Zun clearly .

“Jiejie, come over quickly, don't you want to go to the Northern District? Now that the Southern District is about to be destroyed by me, the only way to the Northern District is through my baby's tummy . ”

Laurel giggled mischievously, pointing at that giant python below her .

I kept my eyes on her . There were tons of questions in my mind, and seeing her unlocked a flood of emotions in me .

Everything started because of Laurel . I still remembered how innocent and naïve she was when she first arrived in the Western District . She's like this now because I wasn't able to protect her .

It's all because of me .

“Ah Shen jiejie .” Laurel smiled at me warmly .

“Didn't you say that you'll always protect me?” She continued in a soft voice .

I bit my lips .

“Laurel, it's my fault for not being able to protect you . No matter what, no matter what you've been through, go back with jiejie . This time, I'll definitely protect you well,” I said resolutely as I looked at her .

She lifted a tiny hand to hide her lips . “Jiejie, haven't I told you this before? I've found what I want . I hope jiejie can come with me too . Aren't you always on my side, Ah Shen jiejie?”

“What do you want .” I started to calm down as I kept my eyes on her .

Laurel laughed . “What I want, you really cannot give, jiejie .”

“How'd you know if you don't say it .” I smiled .

Laurel's eyes flashed with a cunning flicker as she said, “I want to...

“Bathe the Split Zone in blood...

“I hate this pretentious look of you jiejie, kekekekeke...” Laurel laughed as she saw me frown in response to what she just said . There was a quick flicker in her eyes as those tiny hands continued to hide her laughter!

Then, that enormous python opened its wide, bloody jaws!

No, wide is not the right word . I could see nothing but blood red in front of me after it opened that mouth! I could see the flesh moving inside its blood red jaw, and there was a black hole right in the middle of it .

“Come over quickly . ”

The sky disappeared from above me, turning into a blood red, and all I could hear was Laurel’s voice .

“This is bad!” Gaoqin Jiuye seemed to have seen something, and he tried to pull me backwards!

But it was too late . That python seemed to have a black hole in its throat, and as it opened its mouth, a massive force pulled me and Gaoqin Jiuye towards it!

The both of us were hit by that force, and it felt as if there was no way to escape from that gravitational pull! It felt like there was an invisible hand in the darkness, forcefully pulling me and Gaoqin Jiuye towards the abyss!

“You think of something!” I shouted at Gaoqin Jiuye as we were slowly sucked into the python’s mouth as it heaved with its rotten breath .

“I can’t think of anything . You have any ideas?” Gaoqin Jiuye could actually smile at me in such a situation . I really felt like beating him up!

My heart sank a little . Then I shouted as loudly as I could, “Nie Zun! Jiao S!”

As the words ‘Nie Zun’ came out of my mouth, I saw Gaoqin Jiuye’s face instantly turn cold .

As the words ‘Nie Zun’ came out of my mouth, I saw Gaoqin Jiuye’s face instantly turn cold .

“Don’t look for me to save you if you end up in danger later,” he said coldly .

Hell, what is wrong with you?!

While complaining inwardly to myself about Gaoqin Jiuye's crazy mood swings, the both of us were already sucked into the python's throat .

As we were dropping into the stomach of the giant python, I shouted at Gaoqin Jiuye, "Do you think we'd still be able to heal if we were digested by the python's stomach acids?"

Gaoqin Jiuye answered me with silence .

With that, we continued dropping into the humid darkness .

Thud!

"Aiyo!" That was painful!

Why was this python's stomach hard like bricks? I almost snapped my neck!

Feeling my head in a weird position, I felt around my neck with my hands .

Crack!

I twisted my neck back to its original position!

Right, time to open my eyes!

In a daze, I opened my eyes .

There was nothing but white .

Where's this place?

I moved my arms and waited for my body to heal as I attached a broken leg back, propping myself up into a sitting position .

The white ceramic tiles on the floor felt cold . Looking up, it was also white .

The white ceramic tiles on the floor felt cold . Looking up, it was also white .

Bloody hell, where is this? This isn't the python's stomach!

Wait, something felt familiar...

As I touched the ceramic floor again, my vision started to clear up, and I finally recognized this place .

My heart sunk immediately . I looked around in a panic . There was no one around!

“Nie Zun?!”

I tried to stand, but the pain in my leg made me fall back onto the shiny floor .

“Gaoqin Jiuye?!”

As I was shouting, I felt a gust of strong wind from above . I looked up, only to see a white dot coming closer and closer .

“What's this?” I asked myself . Before I finally realized what was happening, the white dot crashed into me!

“Ah! F***!” I swore without caring about my image! I just couldn't control myself!

After reattaching my limbs from a high fall, I'm now hit by a person falling from the sky! The annoyance!

My nose was broken, and I felt like I was being weighed down by a thousand-pound boulder that almost turned me into minced meat!

“What're you shouting for, I'm in more pain than you are...” I could hear Gaoqin Jiuye's voice though I was still in quite a daze . My nose bridge was hurting, and I had no strength to argue with him!

I was like a cushion for you . How could you be in more pain when you literally fell onto this live meat cushion!

“Ow... It’s so painful!” I teared up as I touched my bloody nose, waiting for it to heal . I wanted to push Gaoqin Jiuye away, but my dislocated shoulder hurt when I tried to move! I squinted my eyes in pain .

Though this pain was nothing to me now, it was still painful! I opened my eyes in anger, looking straight at Gaoqin Jiuye .

He was sprawled onto me .

I started pinching him, and his body seemed soft, so he probably had eight to ten broken bones or so .

“What’re you pinching?” His beautiful eyes squinted in a frown .

I started pinching him, and his body seemed soft, so he probably had eight to ten broken bones or so .

“What’re you pinching?” His beautiful eyes squinted in a frown .

“Can’t I pinch you a little when you’ve already broken my nose?

“And also, when are you going to get off me?” I looked at him as I asked, without realizing that I sounded pretty much like a hooligan .

Gaoqin Jiuye actually blushed a little before he flipped over to the side .

I found it pretty funny . Gaoqin Jiuye was someone who blushed too?

I sat up as I suddenly thought of something interesting .

“Hey, Gaoqin Jiuye, there’s something I’d like to ask . What exactly are soul splitters? Have you guys always been living here in the Split Zone?”

Gaoqin Jiuye shot me a cold look .

“I know you won’t answer something like this . But actually what I really want to ask is...”

I blinked at him . “Do you soul splitters get married and have kids too? Do you guys mate?”

What I didn’t realize was that the word ‘mate’ was not exactly an accurate representation of what I wanted to ask!

“Ahem ahem, ahem!” Gaoqin Jiuye sucked in a mouthful of air as he heard my question, almost choking himself in the process!

I started laughing hysterically at this .

“But in all seriousness, for soul splitters, males and females still date and do that right?” Though I still didn’t know what soul splitters were exactly, they still looked human . So I guess they’d be like us . Since it was rare to see the haughty Gaoqin Jiuye flustered, I had to make use of this chance .

“Ahem ahem...” As Gaoqin Jiuye recovered from his coughing spate, a malicious smile appeared on him as he lifted his brows . He flipped back on top of me in a second!

Pinning me against the floor, a mischievous light shone in his eyes as he looked at me with a devious smile .

“How about you try and see if I do that or not?”

His enchanting voice sounded just like that charming voice in my memories, except that his had a rather devious quality to it .

Chapter 163

163 A Lone Man and Woman

“Get off me!” I kicked him . Rolling my eyes, I added, “You try it yourself!”

He fell onto the cold floor and simply lay there . He used his arms as a makeshift pillow for his head before he looked up and asked, “Seriously though, where’s this place?”

My heart sank a little . I almost forgot about this while trying to make fun of him! Should we have been wasting time like this?!

“You don’t know this place?” I responded coldly as I looked around me, my eyes eventually landing on his face .

Gaoqin Jiuye looked confused . “Would I have asked you if I knew? Should I know this place then?”

I stood up silently and slowly . Looking up, it was just pitch darkness .

Around us was a blanket of white, and only Gaoqin Jiuye and I were in the middle of this whitewashed hall . Turning around, I looked at the wall behind me . There was a huge screen on that wall, but nothing was playing right now .

“This is the Great Hall,” I said each word slowly .

Gaoqin Jiuye’s smile froze .

“You’re saying, this, is the Northern District?” He stood up .

I smirked as I glanced at him . “Why’re you pretending that you don’t recognize the Northern District? Aren’t you a soul splitter?”

He looked at me with a serious expression . “I’ll ask you again . Is this the Northern District?”

I frowned . “You mean to say as a soul splitter who originally came from the Northern District, you don’t even recognize the Great Hall?”

Putting his hands in his pockets, he looked around him . “I’ve told you this before, I’ve left the Northern District a long, long time ago . I’ve never been back here ever since I left for the Southern District . What do you think ‘a long, long time ago’ means?”

“You said that too when we were in that crack in space previously . You said the same thing when I asked how long you’ve been in the Split Zone . ”

I had no idea why I suddenly said that .

“How do we exit this Great Hall?” Looking up at that darkness, Gaoqin Jiuye changed the topic abruptly .

I laughed . “How would I know something that even the soul splitter doesn’t? Li Wen previously said that the darkness above is where soul splitters rest, but seems like that isn’t the case, since the both of us actually fell from there . ”

Following Gaoqin Jiuye’s gaze, I looked up at that mysterious black hole which seemed to be endless .

“Li Wen? She said soul splitters rest there?” Gaoqin Jiuye asked as he pointed above him .

“That’s right . ”

“Ha, as a soul splitter, I didn’t even know I actually rested there . ” Gaoqin Jiuye’s laugh was laced with sarcasm .

Looking at that darkness, I asked, “I remembered it correctly right, that we were both sucked into a python’s stomach? So why would we fall from that hole above?”

“How would I know . ”

“Don’t tell me?! This hole here has something to do with that python?!”

“How would I know . ”

“Good heavens, is that black hole the python’s stomach itself? Or does the python’s stomach lead to that black hole?”

“How would I know . ”

“God! If the python’s stomach leads to this black hole, then wouldn’t the black hole be its anus?! That would be so disgusting!”

“...”

Thousands of possibilities were floating in my head, and I felt disgusted at that thought .

“How do we get out of this Great Hall?” Gaoqin Jiuye could no longer be bothered to entertain me on this .

“How would I know,” I responded immediately with his previous answers .

“How would I know,” I responded immediately with his previous answers .

“...”

He decided to ignore me for real this time as he walked towards a large space in the direction of the window at the end of the hall .

Tsk tsk . I tutted disapprovingly as I followed behind him .

Before moving, I turned and looked at that screen again . It was gray with nothing on it . I gave myself a bitter smile . Why would I even hope to see

my family on that screen? Would I still dare to face them?

Suppressing the emotion in me, I caught up with Gaoqin Jiuye . We reached the end of the hall rather quickly . This was somewhere new to me . Opposite that wall with the screen, a huge window was on this wall in front of us .

There was only white fog outside the window, and nothing else could be seen outside of a three-meter radius . Looking out, we could not see anything else but that fog .

“There’s nothing here . ” I stuck my face to the glass in an attempt to see farther .

“Let’s go out and have a look,” Gaoqin Jiuye said .

“How do we go out? There doesn’t seem to be any doors here . ” I looked around . There was nothing in this empty Great Hall but this window .

“You mean we won’t be able to leave just because there’s no door?” Gaoqin Jiuye scoffed . With a quick gaze, the air around us started rumbling! The air currents turned into sharp air cones as they flew towards that glass window!

I took in a breath at how unceremonious that seemed . Sadly, only a loud sound was produced, and the glass did not even crack a little .

Gaoqin Jiuye obviously did not expect for this to happen, and he even let out a breath in surprise .

“I’m not seeing things right?”

I replied, “Nope . ”

With another chilly gaze, the air started roaring around us again! As the air currents cleared up, the glass still looked as good as new!

I let out a laugh, not minding Gaoqin Jiuye’s angry glance . I focused my MF onto my palms and placed them against the glass .

The MF felt like water in my palms, and controlling one's MF was just like controlling water inside one's body . Though it was rather difficult, I've gotten better at manipulating my MF especially after all the recent battles .

The MF felt like water in my palms, and controlling one's MF was just like controlling water inside one's body . Though it was rather difficult, I've gotten better at manipulating my MF especially after all the recent battles .

I froze as I finally received some feedback on my MF .

“This... this glass, I think it can absorb MF?”

Gaoqin Jiuye asked with a frown, “What?”

“Try it . Focus your MF on your palms and put some pressure on it to feel it .”

After trying it for himself, Gaoqin Jiuye said, “I think you're right . But instead of saying it absorbs MF, it's more accurate to say it cancels out the MF .”

“What's happening here? Yu Liang and Song Lu exited from this wall previously, and according to them, just behind that veil of fog are huge doors labeled ‘Heaven’, ‘Ghost’ and ‘Exit’ . Why aren't there any doors here and why can't we pass through even with the use of force?”

“Are we locked up in here?” Gaoqin Jiuye gave me a mysterious smile as he looked up at that black hole, and then back at me .

My hairs stood on ends as he said that .

“Don't hope for any role-play here . I'm a very proper person .” I looked Gaoqin Jiuye in the eye .

He regarded me with disdain before walking back towards the middle of the Great Hall .

“Hey, you're going to give up just like this? Not going to try again?”

He answered me lazily, “What else can we do? It’s obvious we can’t exit from that window . Instead of wasting energy on that, why not just lie down and take a rest . ”

He already lay down before finishing his sentence . I glanced at him, and he looked like he could fall asleep any second .

An endless white welcomed me as I looked around the empty space . Looking up, there was only that seemingly endless black hole .

Gaoqin Jiuye seemed extremely comfortable on the floor, looking like this has nothing to do with him and he was not going to care even if the world was in fact going to ruin .

I glanced at him again, before finally deciding to sit on a stone somewhere near him .

“When did you learn to ignore everything just like Nie Zun . Let me tell you, you’re already unpopular because you’re so cold . If you continue acting like a lazybum just like Nie Zun, you might never be able to find a girlfriend . ”

I glanced at him again, before finally deciding to sit on a stone somewhere near him .

“When did you learn to ignore everything just like Nie Zun . Let me tell you, you’re already unpopular because you’re so cold . If you continue acting like a lazybum just like Nie Zun, you might never be able to find a girlfriend . ”

I just wanted to ridicule him .

However, I did not expect silence .

My back was facing him initially, but I decided to turn around since the silence was rather unsettling .

I met Gaoqin Jiuye’s eyes as I turned . He was already up in a casual sitting position . He was looking at me, not moving an inch .

I subconsciously held my breath as he seemed a little weird like this .

A light flashed in his eyes as he asked, “Why am I being like Nie Zun? Why is it that, in your eyes, I’m always being like somebody else, acting like somebody else?”

“Li Shen, I’m Gaoqin Jiuye . I’m not Gao Qi, neither am I Nie Zun . ”

His lips then turned up in an arch .

“Li Shen, are you confused about who I am all this time, and how you should be acting towards me?”

I was momentarily stunned . “What do you mean?”

He leaned in, closing the distance between us .

“In your eyes, do you have any inkling or impression of what Gaoqin Jiuye is like as a person? Do you even recognize Gaoqin Jiuye as an individual?”

“You are asking such a funny question . No matter how mental I am, it’s not to the point where I can’t tell that you are you . ”

I responded coldly .

“Is that so?” He smirked . “If you weren’t confused from the get-go, judging by your personality, I’m afraid you might’ve chosen differently every time you fought against me . ”

Chapter 164

164 The Malice of Two

His words made me curious . Raising my brows, I asked, “Oh? You mean it was because I confused you with Gao Qi, and that led me to be lenient towards you so many times?”

Gaoqin Jiuye’s gaze darkened slightly . “Well, at least I can tell that you feel something for him, and I can tell you treat me a little differently because of that . ”

I smirked . “You’re overthinking . Firstly, since you think like this, it means you’re definitely aware that I’ve been lenient towards you more than once . Even after I found out that you were the soul splitter who captured me, I still chose to be lenient . Secondly, I hope you get this clear – that you and Gao Qi are totally different, and you guys have absolutely no similarities . This is why no matter what, there’s no way you could have triggered the feelings I had for him . ”

Gaoqin Jiuye laughed so hard to the point that he was almost tearing .

“Nothing’s made me happier than hearing I have absolutely no similarities with him . I, Gaoqin Jiuye, want nothing to do with that man whom you’re willing to love and protect with your entire life . ”

For some reason, I felt like there was an underlying meaning to what he just said, and it felt unsettling .

“You know him?” I didn’t know why I had to ask that, but I had this feeling that Gaoqin Jiuye did not look well upon Gao Qi . I felt like it might have been more than a simple feeling of dislike – that it might have been hate .

I was shocked by what went through my own mind . How could a soul splitter, Gaoqin Jiuye, hate Gao Qi if they should not even have met?

These weird thoughts must have appeared because I was too tired .

But, weren't I also unaware of what exactly a soul splitter was? If we uncover the secret behind the soul splitters one day, and they were indeed somehow related to each other, what should I do?

“Are you afraid that I'll know him . ”

I looked away as I met Gaoqin Jiuye's eyes .

“Gaoqin Jiuye, I don't care how you treat me . Just don't use him as a tool to beat me down and trigger my emotions . I admit that I'm not strong enough, especially when it comes to matters that has to do with him . I wouldn't be here in the Split Zone now if I was strong enough to withstand such things, if I had retorted and fought back in those situations . ”

I then looked up at him with a smile .

He looked rather stunned .

“You're really, something . ” He laughed suddenly, and lay back down .

He continued in a low voice, “Tell me how you feel about him . You can start wherever you want, or you can just start from how it began . ”

I had never expected a day like this . A day where I could have a peaceful conversation with Gaoqin Jiuye about the feelings I had for Gao Qi, the person with the exact same face and body as him .

It might be because I've never thought of this before, but I suddenly had an urge to complain .

I just didn't know where to start .

“If you don't know where to start, how about you answer my questions then?

“Promise to answer truthfully?”

I smiled as I answered, “I will . ”

Gaoqin Jiuye closed his eyes and said, “What do you love about him?”

I thought this was a simple question that I could answer immediately, but I was stunned by how my mind was a blank .

Yes, that’s right . All this time, what do I love about him? Though there was usually no reason needed to like or love someone, there still had to be some point where it starts . What was it about him that attracted me, why did I start noticing him, and what was it that turned initial curiosity into love?

Just what was the reason behind it?

“At the time, everyone around me knew that I was afflicted with a mental illness, and they ostracized me because of that . But Gao Qi...” I didn’t know how to continue after this .

“At the time, everyone around me knew that I was afflicted with a mental illness, and they ostracized me because of that . But Gao Qi...” I didn’t know how to continue after this .

Gaoqin Jiuye opened his eyes, as if he was looking at that black hole above us .

“But, you found something similar in Gao Qi?”

“No, that’s not it! Gao Qi is different from me . He’s nice and popular among the girls . He’s also known to be a really warm person in school, so how could such an excellent person be similar to me at all!” My emotions went a little out of control as I made a loud retort .

I felt a little breathless after finishing my sentence, probably because I used too much strength while saying it .

“He’s excellent, warm and nice, and others like him, so you like him too . Do you think this is the case?”

Gaoqin Jiuye's question was rather normal, but why did I feel as if he was trying to drive me into a corner?

At the beginning when Gao Qi suddenly showed an interest in me at the sports field, I did find him very warm . But, was it because he was a warm person that I fell in love with him?

“I lost many of my memories with Gao Qi after arriving here in the Split Zone, so, so I...”

As I was trying to explain myself, Gaoqin Jiuye interrupted me . “How could you forget the feeling of loving someone just because you lost your memory? Even if you've forgotten majority of your time together, you'd still remember that he was the person you loved, right? So how could you have forgotten why you love him?”

But I seem to have really forgotten .

Yes, why did I love him?

“Admit it, Li Shen . That senior Gao Qi whom you've always loved was never who you thought he was . More importantly, it's not because you aren't sure of who he really is, it's because you know exactly who he is that you love him . You're just afraid to believe that you've fallen in love with a monster . You're avoiding it, and that's why I had the chance to step in and take you here . ”

Gaoqin Jiuye yawned before continuing casually, “Nobody knows you better than I do . ”

I looked at him .

I looked at him .

“What did you say?”

“Nothing,” he answered with a smile .

Huh, nobody knows me better than you do? Are you kidding? How long have we known each other?

A terrifying emotion overwhelmed me .

“You, just how are you related to Gao Qi . ”

Gaoqin Jiuye closed his eyes and ignored me once again .

I crawled towards him on all fours as I was overcome with emotion .
Grabbing his collar, I pulled him up into a sitting position .

Gaoqin Jiuye looked irritated . “Li Shen, can you be a lady for once?”

“Just how are you related to him . Both of you look exactly the same, that’s no coincidence, right?”

My voice trembled as I finally voiced the question I had always been afraid to ask . But it seems that I had to clear this up now . There are too many secrets and mysteries here, and I’ll just go crazy like this . (Passerby A: You’re already crazy... It’s been medically proven... Me: *kicks Passerby A without hesitation*)

Gaoqin Jiuye suddenly looked at me with interest .

“What if we were really related in some way? What if I told you I was him, or we have some sort of inseparable relationship? What would you do, Li Shen? Would you love me like you love him?”

“Don’t be ridiculous, you’re not him . How could you be like him . ” I responded without much thought, but I saw Gaoqin Jiuye’s gaze instantly turn cold .

“That’s right, I’m not him . So please stop asking me how I am related to him, since you’ve also said so, that I’m different from him . And since you’ll never love me like you love him, then don’t ever ask me who I am!

“Since you’ve never cared anyway . ”

“That’s right, I’m not him . So please stop asking me how I am related to him, since you’ve also said so, that I’m different from him . And since you’ll never love me like you love him, then don’t ever ask me who I am!

“Since you’ve never cared anyway . ”

It felt like my heart was instantly wrapped in ice .

His voice carried a sort of cold, viscous sorrow that seemed like it would never be quelled .

I was rather confused as I looked at Gaoqin Jiuye’s eyes . I could not comprehend this . I didn’t understand why he was like this, why he had such a gaze, and why he would say such a thing .

Me and him, him and I, him and him, just how are we related to one another...

Gaoqin Jiuye seemed to get angrier as he saw the look of confusion on my face . He leaned closer suddenly, asking “Li Shen, why lie to yourself? It’s no fun . Others don’t know, but did you think that I, Gaoqin Jiuye, wouldn’t know too?”

The underlying meaning seemed to be: ‘How could I be unaware of what happened when you were alive if I was the one who brought you here?’

I looked at him anxiously . “You know what happened in my lost memories? Can, can you tell me...”

“Huh . ” He laughed, eyes shining . “What can I tell you? You’re asking because of him, right?

“Li Shen, you know very well what kind of individual Gao Qi is, and you also know how Nie Zun is . Even so, you still love them . The only thing you don’t know is what kind of person you are . The her that you ostracize, is the you that you don’t know . And you don’t know what kind of person I am either . ”

It sounded complicated, but my eyes were surprisingly wet with tears after hearing it .

“Li Shen, I’m not saving you . I can tell you’re feeling wretched, and you know this too, but why are you running away from it? Why are you being even more cowardly than when you were alive?”

A malicious, evil feeling overcame me, as if my soul was dyed black in a mere instant . I looked at him coldly . “Are you that much stronger than me then? If you were doing everything right, Si Luo wouldn’t end up like this today, Du Yue might not be like this now, and I might not end up like this either . ”

Chapter 165

165 Arriving in the Northern District

Though I felt the malice in what I said, I didn't actually know what exactly was it that made it feel so malicious . But what I didn't expect was for Gaoqin Jiuye to pounce on me .

He suddenly hugged me .

It felt foreign and unfamiliar . From that hug, I could tell he definitely was not Gao Qi .

“It's different right, me and him . ” I heard his enchanting voice in my ear .

“Yeah, different,” I answered softly .

Gaoqin Jiuye seemed to have wanted to say something else, but before he could do so, both of us felt this gust of wind above us .

A familiar feeling of unease overcame me, and I pushed Gaoqin Jiuye away . Something hit me as I looked up .

Thud!

“Why do I always have to get hit by falling objects in such an enormous Great Hall!” I lay on the floor complaining while the girl who fell on me was struggling to get up .

“You scared me . ” Jiao S extended a hand to help me up as she stood up .

“Lucky I used my MF . At least I didn't break you into pieces even though there was very little time for me to react . ”

My lips twitched as I responded, “I’ve already been broken into pieces earlier . ”

I realized Nie Zun had also fell from above as I stood up, but he didn’t crash like Jiao S did .

“This is... the Great Hall?” Jiao S looked around, surprise on her face .

Nie Zun did not take his eyes off me ever since arriving here .

“Yes, you guys were swallowed by that snake too?”

Nie Zun answered calmly, “We got swallowed on purpose, to look for the both of you . ”

“How’re things in the Southern District?” Gaoqin Jiuye asked .

Jiao S looked glum . “How should I put it . Nobody knew where those monsters came from, and Nie Zun and I definitely cannot turn the tide on our own . Since the both of you had already disappeared into the stomach of that snake, we decided to just follow . ”

“That was weird . Also, why would Laurel appear together with those monsters? Why does the stomach of the snake lead here to the Great Hall?” I felt like I was about to go insane .

We were all silent .

“Since we’re already here, let’s go out and have a look,” Jiao S said .

“The problem is that we aren’t able to leave . That glass seems to be able to cancel out MF, and Gaoqin Jiuye and I can’t think of anything else . ”

Jiao S walked over to the glass window and used a similar attack to what Gaoqin Jiuye did with the air currents!

Nothing changed . The glass window looked as good as new .

“Try it this way . You’ll see how the MF feels like it’s being absorbed . ” I pressed my palms against the window as I demonstrated it to Jiao S and Nie Zun .

Following my example, they pressed their palms against the window .

“You feel it right?” I smiled at Jiao S .

Her expression changed . “Wait, don’t take your hands away!”

I was a little stunned at her reaction, but I followed her instructions .

When I pressed my hands against the window again, a peculiar feeling entered my palms, spreading throughout my entire body .

“What’s this feeling...” I muttered .

“What’s this feeling...” I muttered .

Nie Zun’s eyes flashed . “This feels as if that the glass would melt into a liquid form when all three of us have our palms against it, as if it was about to suck us in . ”

What Nie Zun said reminded me of something, and I turned back quickly to Gaoqin Jiuye . “Gaoqin Jiuye, come over quickly . Try to press your palms against this . ”

Though Gaoqin Jiuye seemed doubtful about this, he still walked over and did what I asked .

A miracle happened when he put his hands against the glass .

It was as if the last key had opened the final lock . When Gaoqin Jiuye’s hands touched the glass, it turned into a transparent liquid form, and whirlpools appeared where our palms were, slowly sucking us into them .

“Shall we enter?” I asked the others, since we were still unsure of what would be on the other side .

The three of them met my eyes .

Once I was sure of their decision, we let the glass suck us in .

In just a minute or so, the four of us had passed through that glass in the Great Hall and arrived outside in the thick fog .

The Great Hall was already gone when we turned back to look .

“It’s exactly like Yu Liang said . I guess we’ll be able to see three huge doors soon if we continue walking ahead . ” I realized there was nothing but thick fog surrounding us as I looked around .

“Everything is so bizarre . We better be careful,” Jiao S added .

“Si Luo and Guan Nie are still with us, right?”

A transparent vortex appeared in the fog with a wave of Jiao S’s hand, and Guan Nie’s prone figure was partially hidden in that vortex .

“As long as our MF does not reach its lowest point at any time, they’ll be safe with us,” Jiao S explained .

I nodded in response, while Nie Zun said, “It has already been four days since Guan Nie got injured . If we aren’t able to find the person who can save him within three days, his life might be in danger . ”

I nodded in response, while Nie Zun said, “It has already been four days since Guan Nie got injured . If we aren’t able to find the person who can save him within three days, his life might be in danger . ”

Jiao S heaved a sigh . “That’s right . Moreover, we don’t even know where this person is . And now, we’ve ended up here in this godforsaken place . ”

Gaoqin Jiuye smirked . “There’s no need for you people to be so forlorn . I’ve already told you I can find the person who can save him in the Northern District . Jiao S, no need to care too much about Guan Nie when you still have Si Luo to think about . ”

Jiao S returned the smirk . “Who’s going to care about my subordinates if I don’t? Are you going to care about him? There’d probably be no need for me to think of how I can save this subordinate of mine if it were not because of you, who wasn’t even willing to look him in the eye properly . ”

“Alright, stop arguing the moment you see each other . The priority now is to look for the person who can save Guan Nie . Gaoqin Jiuye, lead the way since you know what to do . ”

I extended a hand toward Gaoqin Jiuye, signaling for him to walk ahead .

He walked towards the three of us with narrowed eyes, before turning and walking straight into the fog without looking back .

We were met with the three huge doors after just passing through one layer of fog .

I frowned slightly . All of these seemed to have been prepared specially for us, as if everything was waiting for our arrival .

“Why were we able to exit the Great Hall only when all four of us used MF on that glass? Yu Liang and Song Lu didn’t have to do that previously . Does this mean that all of these were specially prepared and designed for us?”

In response to Jiao S’s suspicions, I answered glumly, “It’s possible that this is all designed for the four of us . I’m sure it’s no coincidence that all four of us were able to arrive here at the same time either . ”

I looked up at the three huge doors in front of us .

These weren’t real doors .

The ‘door’ in the middle was a few meters tall, about 10 meters wide, and it was a simple structure where a horizontal pillar on top was held up by two vertical pillars on each side . It was more like a simple doorframe made up of three pillars . A sign on the horizontal pillar was partially obscured by the fog, and it said ‘Ghost’ in huge, fancy lettering .

The gate of 'Heaven' and 'Exit' were on its left and right respectively .

I glanced at Gaoqin Jiuye, smiling half-heartedly . “Which one to enter, my dear soul splitter?”

Gaoqin Jiuye could obviously sense the hostility in my tone, but he didn't seem to mind it . He simply pointed at the 'Ghost' gate .

“I'll make a disclaimer first . I've never passed through this 'Ghost' gate, and I don't know what's in there . What I know is that the person we're looking for lives inside . So whatever happens inside, there's no need to ask me about it, since I don't know either . ”

Gaoqin Jiuye could obviously sense the hostility in my tone, but he didn't seem to mind it . He simply pointed at the 'Ghost' gate .

“I'll make a disclaimer first . I've never passed through this 'Ghost' gate, and I don't know what's in there . What I know is that the person we're looking for lives inside . So whatever happens inside, there's no need to ask me about it, since I don't know either . ”

“If you don't know anything, how are we going to find that individual who could possibly save Guan Nie?” Jiao S asked with a frown .

Gaoqin Jiuye shrugged . “I'm very sure that if I were to pass through the 'Ghost' gate, the person we're looking for will come looking for me . As long as we can enter within three days, that individual will definitely find us in a matter of seconds . ”

I shot a look at him . “Seems like it's an enemy . Well, I guess you have many of those, since you're so unpopular . ”

Unexpectedly, Gaoqin Jiuye laughed . “Seems like you're fearless now that he's back by your side . You don't need anything else huh . ”

He slowly pointed at Nie Zun as he finished his sentence .

I looked towards Nie Zun, but the first thing I noticed were those messy scars on his face .

He was looking at me with his usual calm and composed gaze as our eyes met . For some reason, as I looked into his eyes – though it was neither fiery nor extremely gentle – all the fear, the doubt and those complex emotions seem to just dissipate .

Those eyes allowed me to feel at ease .

I always felt like crying every time I find such a sense of security .

That's right . I don't seem to be afraid of anything as long as you're by my side .

I felt a sharp glance in my direction, and as I turned back at Gaoqin Jiuye, I realized he was looking at me with this frigid expression which had replaced that cruel smile of his .

How did I offend him this time? What a weirdo .

Nie Zun walked over and took my hand, saying to Jiao S and Gaoqin Jiuye with a slight smile, "Let's go . "

I felt a little uncomfortable at this sudden change of events . I also realized that Nie Zun had both his black gloves back on .

Jiao S's huge eyes darted back and forth between Nie Zun and I .

"Let's move . Aren't we going? Why're you guys still not moving?" Gaoqin Jiuye said moodily .

Chapter 166

166 Meeting Bian Ying

We could see nothing but thick fog through that ‘Ghost’ gate .

“It kind of feels like we’re entering the gate to hell,” Jiao S joked .

“If this is the gate leading to hell, then I hope the grim reaper’s handsome,” I said as I tried to look further into the fog .

“There’s nothing but handsome guys on your mind . ” Gaoqin Jiuye scoffed .

“You’re definitely not on my mind . ” I rolled my eyes at him .

As we spoke, we heard a singing voice nearby .

“Seems like there’s somebody singing . ” I quickened my pace .

“Yes, it sounds like a woman . ”

We were met with a different scene after passing through all the layers of fog .

“This...” I looked up in surprise at the sky . It was something that should not belong here .

The sky was blue with white clouds and there was also a sun .

Apart from the blue sky which looked exactly like how it looked like in the real world, there was a dense green forest right in front of us . That forest

looked exactly like what we'd see in the real world, and it was not made up of those fake trees from growing agents used here in the Split Zone .

“What're these? Do these gates lead to the real world?” Jiao S sounded extremely surprised .

“No, take a closer look at the sky, it's different,” Nie Zun said calmly .

Upon closer observation, I realized there really was something different about this place .

The sun was shining peacefully in the azure sky, and there were bits and pieces of white cloud all around . Though nothing seemed special about this, there was an unnatural quality to it . It was way too serene .

The sky was blue and the clouds were white, but nothing moved .

The sky in the real world did not move either, but it was not like what we were witnessing here . The sky here was like a painting, as if the real sky above was covered with a huge painting of a blue sky . And although the sun was bright and round, it seemed to look like it was embedded there on purpose .

“This... Why does the sky seem man-made?” Jiao S took the words right out of my mouth .

That's right, this was what it felt like – man-made . Everything looked man-made and everything was eerily still .

We heard that singing voice again, and it seemed like it was coming from that dense forest right in front of us .

“Let's go over and have a look . ”

We found the source of the voice as we walked into the forest .

There was a ring-shaped river with water clear as crystal, but it did not seem to be flowing . There was a lady sitting on a huge rock beside the river . Hugging her knees, she had this thin white shirt on her . Her face looked

thin, and her eyes seemed adrift with a tinge of melancholy in them . The faint singing voice was coming from her, but her lips did not seem to be moving at all .

“What a unique lady...” I muttered .

This lady was not as dashing as Li Qing nor did she have that gentle beauty of Li Wen, but as I took a closer look, she had very refined features, except that she seemed a little too thin, and it made her look a little tired . Though ordinary women cannot surpass beauty the likes of Si Luo and Guan Nie, this lady had a very unique aura about her . There was a modest charm about her that made her seem tough but gentle, as if she was quite a willful individual .

But that willfulness seemed to feel more endearing than annoying .

The soft singing voice stopped as the lady turned towards us slowly, as if she could hear my thoughts .

Her gaze swept past me and she looked at every single one of us before her eyes finally landed on Gaoqin Jiuye .

She looked surprised at first, then she looked like she was about to burst into tears of joy, but these were all replaced by a look of suspicion very quickly .

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She floated over with a light tap of her feet .

What amazing speed, I thought to myself .

“Gaoqin, why are you here? You’re finally willing to come back...”

“It’s been a long time,” Gaoqin Jiuye interrupted her . She looked a little stunned, and she looked around at Jiao S, Nie Zun and I .

“They’re from the Gate of Heaven?”

Gaoqin Jiuye shook his head .

“Is this your soul splitter friend? Aren’t you going to introduce us?” I asked Gaoqin Jiuye with raised brows .

He laughed .

The lady then stretched a hand towards me . “Hello, I’m Bian Ying . ”

I was hit by surprise .

Bian Ying?? Ta Lai’s lover, Bian Ying?

“Ta Lai’s lover?” Jiao S spoke before I could say anything .

Bian Ying’s face instantly turned white, and her pale lips looked even paler . “You guys... You know Ta Lai?”

After a brief moment, she nodded to herself, as if everything began to make sense now . “Of course, you guys will know him...”

“We aren’t soul splitters, and we didn’t know Ta Lai originally . We met him along the way,” I explained .

“We aren’t soul splitters, and we didn’t know Ta Lai originally . We met him along the way,” I explained .

That look of melancholy in her eyes was instantly replaced with shock . “You, you guys aren’t soul splitters? You’re heirs? Why would heirs be here in the Northern District?”

Before anyone could say anything, she turned to Gaoqin Jiuye and continued, “Are you mad, Gaoqin? You brought heirs here to the Gate of Ghost?”

Gaoqin Jiuye shrugged . “I didn’t bring them here . If it was me, I wouldn’t have brought them to this ‘Ghost’ gate that even I haven’t been to myself .

This isn't even the original entrance of the Gate of Ghost anyway . ”

He pointed at the direction in which we came from .

“Then how did you enter? And why do you have heirs following you?”

“I don't know . I'm here because I got swallowed by a python . ”

“Python?” Bian Ying asked with knitted brows .

“From what I'm hearing, it seems that we aren't that welcome here in the Northern District if we don't originally belong here, calling us ‘heirs’ and all . ” Jiao S spoke suddenly .

Bian Ying glanced at Jiao S and I . It seemed as if she was very curious about me, as her gaze seemed to linger on me .

Although she addressed us as ‘heirs’, I could tell she was not hostile towards us, and that she wasn't a cruel soul splitter . Now that I think about it, all the soul splitters I know had unique personalities; there was Li Wen, who looked gentle but was in fact cruel, Gaoqin Jiuye who was just cold and evil, and Si Luo who was mysterious and secretive .

Bian Ying also had a unique aura, but compared to the other soul splitters I know, there was no hostility to it . She didn't appear weak, but she didn't look like she would attack us either .

However, once she caught sight of Piercer hanging on my waist, she had this look of disbelief and incredulity . She looked surprised, but at the same time, there was abhorrence in her eyes .

“Why do you have Piercer?” Nie Zun stepped forward to shield me as Bian Ying took one step closer towards me . I had to pull at his hand to indicate that it was fine before he turned slightly, so that I could face Bian Ying properly .

“It's actually a long story . Simply put, I accidentally offended the couple who created Piercer, so they...” Before I could finish, I realized that something wasn't quite right .

I didn't offend Zou An and his wife earlier, so why did they give me this cursed living weapon?

They could've been used by You Ji too, but now that I see Bian Ying, something just wasn't quite right about this . Though You Ji might've been jealous and hated me, I'd believe it if she decided to work with Du Yue, but I don't think she would stoop to doing such a thing .

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Was there another reason that didn't cross my mind?

“Forget it, I can't really explain it either . Anyway, Zou An and his wife gave me this Piercer, and Zou An's wife, Ah Wen, she's dead . ”

Bian Ying looked even more shocked at this . “Ah Wen... died? How did she die?”

Gaoqin Jiuye interrupted me, “It's a complicated story, and we have a more important mission right now, which is why we're here in the Northern District's Gate of Ghost . It's great that we met you, since it helps save me a load of time . Tell us, where's Cang Ming? We've brought with us someone who needs his help . ”

Jiao S and I looked at Gaoqin Jiuye in shock, doubt apparent in our gazes .

He was actually referring to Satan Cang Ming when he talked about that healing expert who could save Guan Nie? Why didn't he say so earlier?

More and more questions continued to pop into my head . Gaoqin Jiuye simply smiled mysteriously as he saw the looks on our faces . Is there some sort of conspiracy going on here?

I didn't want to suspect Gaoqin Jiuye, but his actions are always this unexpected, and it didn't help that there were always people around me who advised me to be wary of him .

“You're looking for Cang Ming...” Bian Ying had that melancholic look on her again, and her eyes looked lost .

“Yes . I'm not familiar with what's here in the Gate of Ghost, and if it weren't for you, I might not be able to find him in the limited time that we have . If that's the case, I might have to create some huge trouble to lure him over as quickly as possible . ” Gaoqin Jiuye looked at Bian Ying with an unfathomable expression .

Bian Ying smiled . “How could that be the fastest way to look for him . You should know how he is . Nobody knows where he's going and where he's gone . We don't even know how to begin to look for him, much less the fastest way to get to him . ”

Gaoqin Jiuye shook his head slowly . “No, I'm not sure about other methods, and I was obviously kidding about creating huge trouble here in the Gate of Ghost . But, there's one method that I'm sure is effective, and that's also the only method that we can use to find him . ”

Bian Ying's expression seemed to darken as she remained silent .

Gaoqin Jiuye smirked . “I think I got that right . Even when nobody else can find Cang Ming, you're the only one who can . If there was only one person in this world who can find him, that would definitely be you, and if there was only one method to find him, then that would be through you . ”

Chapter 167

167 A Robe Dyed Blood Red

“I don’t think it’s a good idea for you to see him . Furthermore, there’re so many others with you . ” Bian Ying looked at us with a stony expression, as if she did not welcome ‘heirs’ like us .

I wasn’t paying attention to their conversation since my head was filled with other questions at this point . Bian Ying was the only other person in the Split Zone with double identity disorder like me, but why is she a soul splitter? Nobody actually said that she was indeed a soul splitter, but if she wasn’t one, then why did she seem to be unwelcoming of heirs? And why is she living in the Northern District?

“There’s actually no need for you to go through all the trouble of bringing me to him . We both know what’s most efficient . ”

Gaoqin Jiuye sounded a little weird when he said this, and white fog whirled in his eyes as he spoke .

Bian Ying was extremely calm in the face of Gaoqin Jiuye’s combative stance .

“Seems like this particular individual is very important to you, else I’m sure that you, Gaoqin, wouldn’t engage me in battle this thoughtlessly . But I’m rather curious as to who exactly this person is whom you care about so much . ”

Though her voice was steady and her expression calm, there was a poignant quality to everything she did . It was neither a bitter desolation nor an agonizing sorrow; it was more of a dispirited bleakness .

White fog continued surging in Gaoqin Jiuye's eyes, and his lips arched in a cruel smile . "Even someone like Cang Ming has a weak point like you . This shouldn't be all that surprising since I, Gaoqin Jiuye, am just someone ordinary . " With a cold gaze from Gaoqin Jiuye, the air around us started vibrating . I then reached out a hand to stop him .

"Gaoqin Jiuye, you owe us an explanation for all this . You're not the only one who wishes to save Guan Nie . Who we're looking for, what we should do, how we should go about doing it – shouldn't you have told us earlier if we had decided to work together? The three of us seem to be out of the situation now, and that doesn't seem quite right, does it? I also have many other questions to ask Bian Ying here, what're you trying to do by getting into a fight now?"

Jiao S looked at Gaoqin Jiuye as she pushed my arm down . "Ah Shen's right . Gaoqin Jiuye, I know you're used to doing whatever you want by yourself, but this is a journey the four of us decided to go on together . Since we have the same goal, you can't just go deciding everything on your own .

"Well, you might think Ah Shen and I probably think we're queens and that we're at the top of the world, but we're still district commanders . It was a mess just coming here, and it's not your fault for that, but shouldn't you have discussed plans with us first?"

Bian Ying laughed . "Gaoqin, this is really interesting . Is this a show put up specially for me?"

Gaoqin Jiuye did not respond, and the white fog in his eyes began to subside .

Bian Ying turned towards me and asked, "What's your name?"

"Li Shen . "

"Have you awoken Piercer?"

"No . "

“You’re also here because you want to save the person Gaoqin Jiuye wishes to save?”

“It can be understood as such . ”

“Why’re you answering every one of my questions?” Curiosity flashed in Bian Ying’s eyes as if she thought I was such an interesting individual .

I smiled as I waved a hand . “I tried to stop Gaoqin Jiuye because I wanted to speak with you, so I’m definitely more than happy to answer your questions . ”

“Why do you want to speak with me?”

“Because Ta Lai said you’re the only other person in the Split Zone who has double identity disorder, just like me,” I answered honestly .

Bian Ying’s face turned white instantly!

With a look of disbelief, her voice trembled as she asked, “What, what did you say?”

Why is she so shocked? No, that’s not it, it’s fear .

Why did she have such a fearful look?

Why did she have such a fearful look?

I glanced at Gaoqin Jiuye with doubt in my eyes, but he simply looked elsewhere, and that smirk on his face seemed say, Don’t you have questions? Go on and ask her then .

“I said I also suffer from double identity disorder, and I arrived here in the Split Zone after being captured by this particular soul splitter, Gaoqin Jiuye, who seems to be your friend . I heard from Ta Lai that you also have double identity disorder, and one of your personalities had been devoured by Piercer . Since I happen to have Piercer, I’ve always wanted to meet you and ask you about this . We might be able to learn something from each other since there seems to be some similarities between us . ”

Gaoqin Jiuye grabbed me, seemingly in a fit of anger . He probably did not expect me to reveal everything like this, including the fact that he was my soul splitter .

Nie Zun, who was just standing quietly by the side, reacted with lightning speed as he slapped Gaoqin Jiuye's hand off my arm .

In this very moment, Bian Ying stretched out a long and slender arm to take that arm of mine in her hand .

Everything seemed to happen in the span of a second . Why is everyone trying to snatch my arm? It's not some kind of precious treasure, I thought inwardly to myself .

Shock was apparent in Bian Ying's eyes as she asked, "You were captured?"

I nodded . "Yes, by none other than Gaoqin Jiuye . "

This time, it was Jiao S who looked at me questioningly . They were definitely wondering why I would reveal these things to a total stranger .

But I knew what I was doing . I was simply tired of all this .

I was tired of all the questions and all the strangers here . The Split Zone was way too mysterious, and the feeling of not knowing the answer even to one single question was simply unsettling .

This is why I'd rather reveal everything in the hopes of being able to obtain all the answers I wish I had as quickly as possible, even when such a method might put me in danger . I'm not afraid of being in danger or being embroiled into conspiracies, but I hate that feeling of not knowing anything .

The unknown is what's scariest .

"How could you be captured here? If you had double identity disorder like me, how is it possible that you could be captured?" Bian Ying's voice was trembling .

“How could you be captured here? If you had double identity disorder like me, how is it possible that you could be captured?” Bian Ying’s voice was trembling .

I was a little stunned at this . Instead of getting answers, more questions appeared . What do you mean ‘how could I be captured’? What does she mean by saying that?

Gaoqin Jiuye’s gaze was icy cold . “I’ve told you this, I’m trying to save someone right now, and he doesn’t have much time . Stop asking all these questions and just find Cang Ming as soon as possible .

“Also, Li Shen, are these questions more important than Guan Nie’s life right now? All of you think that I’m deciding everything on my own without discussing anything with you guys, but aren’t we still wasting time now? There’re secrets everywhere here in the Split Zone . Even if you’ve successfully entered the Northern District, the answers cannot be found in a mere day or two . Can’t you talk about that after we save Guan Nie?”

Gaoqin Jiuye was right . But at that moment, I just felt frustrated and irritated, probably because double identity disorder had been mentioned, and this caused me to take a shot at him . “You weren’t this anxious when Guan Nie got injured for you . Isn’t it too late for you to shed crocodile tears now?”

I regretted what I said almost immediately, and my face wrinkled with a frown .

I realized I was never able to keep my calm when faced with Gaoqin Jiuye . He seemed to be able to trigger that ruthlessness in me, but at the same time, I seemed to be able to put my trust in him and forgive him surprisingly quickly .

Gaoqin Jiuye looked at me with a gaze that felt ice-cold .

Observing the situation, Bian Ying said, “Seems like you’re really anxious this time, Gaoqin . But it’s not that I don’t want to help, it’s just that I really don’t know where he is right now . ”

“That’s why there’s no need for all this talk in the first place . This is the best method!” Gaoqin Jiuye said all of this quickly before he suddenly attacked with lightning speed!

Shen Qi was already in Gaoqin Jiuye’s hand, and just as I could make out Shen Qi’s jet-black color, the sword had already made a cut on Bian Ying’s neck!

Pu-chh!

Blood sprayed from the wound in Bian Ying’s pale neck .

Bian Ying remained composed, as if she had anticipated Gaoqin Jiuye’s actions, and it did not look like she was about to fight back either .

Jiao S and I looked at each other with the same question on our minds . How could Gaoqin Jiuye be this fast?

Bian Ying remained composed, as if she had anticipated Gaoqin Jiuye’s actions, and it did not look like she was about to fight back either .

Jiao S and I looked at each other with the same question on our minds . How could Gaoqin Jiuye be this fast?

We all knew Gaoqin Jiuye had extremely high MF and that he was quick in his attacks . Together with Shen Qi’s sharp blade, it was effortless for him to injure Bian Ying . But I had never seen him move at such an amazing speed! Was he hiding his true abilities all this while?

For some reason, I felt uneasy as there were more and more questions popping into my head about Gaoqin Jiuye .

Probably because I was betrayed too often .

But shouldn’t I already be numb towards being betrayed since it has happened far too often? Why did I still care about this? Why am I feeling afraid?

Whoosh—!

I shielded my eyes from this sudden strong wind that blew past us . A blood red figure seemed to have flown past .

The blood red figure wrapped itself around the pale Bian Ying and it moved to increase the distance between us .

As I refocused my vision, I saw a man in red standing five to six meters away, looking at all of us . He was carrying Bian Ying .

My eyes were inexplicably drawn to this man .

He dressed in a way that was similar to me in those red robes, but there was a dark tint to it, as if it was stained with dried blood .

And that face, his face was demonic!

Though his skin and his features could still be considered as belonging to someone handsome, he had this demonic expression on him . That macabre face, though somewhat attractive, was frightful and horrid at the same time .

He had blood-red lips and long, thin eyes with a head of messy black hair that looked like it belonged to a deranged person .

Chapter 168

168 I'll Heal Your Face

“Cang Ming...?” The words just came out of my mouth .

The demonic man raised a brow, but he did not give any acknowledgement .

Seems like I guessed right .

The man in front of me looked exactly like how I imagined ‘Satan Cang Ming’ to be . In fact, he was even more demonic than I thought he would be . While Guan Nie was enchantingly beautiful, this man could be described as dark and demonic .

His eyebrows were partially covered with that messy hair, and he had an aquiline nose above those blood-red lips . There was a cold gleam in those reptilian eyes of his .

Bian Ying, wrapped entirely in white, was now in the arms of this blood-red figure, and they seemed to match each other in a rather strange way .

Though the two of them were not considered extremely attractive, nor did they look too shocking, there was this unique air surrounding them that made them have an undeniable presence .

The tall Cang Ming had skin the color of wheat and even with Bian Ying in his arms, I could tell he was rather toned under that blood-red robe . Based on that physique, one would expect to see an extremely masculine face, but his eyes and lips were slightly upturned, adding to that demonic allure he had . He practically looked like a god of war with that cruel gleam in his eyes .

Bian Ying seemed to be shocked at his sudden appearance, and her gaunt face looked even paler now . Her eyes, though, remained bright and clear .

“Seems like you’re looking for ways to die recently .” Cang Ming laughed cruelly as he looked at Gaoqin Jiuye impudently .

With raised hands, Gaoqin Jiuye clapped slowly . “This is why I’m here to look for you . To meet you, I’d have to put both her life and my life on the line .”

Still carrying Bian Ying, Cang Ming walked over to that huge rock Bian Ying was originally resting on and sat on it . As he sat, the blood-red robe spread across the rock, making it look as if he was sitting in a pool of blood .

He just sat there with Bian Ying still in his arms . Though Bian Ying looked like she wanted to struggle out of his embrace, Cang Ming was way too strong for her as he held her tightly against his chest . Bian Ying seemed to have turned even paler at this .

“You and Si Luo have both left the Gate of Heaven for so long, and the last time I saw the both of you was because of that weapon-smithing couple . Word is that Gaoqin Jiuye is a cruel and wild individual, just like a devil . But you seem to be living only for others, from what I’m seeing here . So, who is it that you’re here for this time?”

Gaoqin Jiuye narrowed his eyes . “Devil? I wouldn’t dare take that name with you around .”

Cang Ming also responded with a narrowing of his eyes .

Because it was inflicted by Shen Qi, the wound on Bian Ying’s neck healed extremely slowly, and it had only scabbed over . Cang Ming did not even take one look at that injury after he saved her from the attack .

Apart from Gaoqin Jiuye, he did not seem to have looked at anyone else either .

He pointed at us, with one hand still around Bian Ying . “Both of us shouldn’t dare to take that name when he’s around . ”

I looked towards the direction he was pointing at – he was pointing at Nie Zun .

Under the myriad of scars on his pale skin, Nie Zun’s face looked a little tired . But that starlight in his eyes can never be obscured no matter how many scars were on his face .

Nie Zun seemed indifferent to what Cang Ming said as a slight smile hung on his lips .

Cang Ming settled Bian Ying beside him on the rock . Though the rock was not small, they seemed to be squeezing in a small corner since Cang Ming had a sturdy, well-built physique and he took up quite a bit of space .

A forlorn expression appeared on Bian Ying’s gaunt face . She naturally held onto Cang Ming’s arm as her feet seemed to almost touch the water .

Cang Ming rested his hands on his knees as he smiled, looking dangerously attractive .

“How did you injure your face?” Cang Ming tilted his chin upwards, signaling for Nie Zun to answer .

“How did you injure your face?” Cang Ming tilted his chin upwards, signaling for Nie Zun to answer .

I did a huge eye-roll towards the sky . How could this man be haughtier than Gaoqin Jiuye?

Nie Zun smiled as he answered casually, “Ta Lai . ”

Bian Ying looked up with wide eyes as she heard Ta Lai’s name .

As Cang Ming felt her move, a hand shot out from under that blood-red robe to reach for her chin, pushing Bian Ying back down towards the rock!

The quiet waters of the river seemed to suddenly come alive as he moved, and in an instant, we felt ourselves wrapped in a fiery atmosphere!

In just a few moments, Bian Ying's pale face seemed to be trapped under Cang Ming's strong hand . He leaned towards her with fire in his eyes, pressing down on her face as he said, "I told you, you're not allowed to think of him, not even just a little . "

My lips twitched . This was the Bian Ying who left Ta Lai because she fell in love with Cang Ming at first sight? She was obviously being forced...

My heart filled with pity as I saw the willful obstinance in Bian Ying's clear eyes . Bian Ying's face was already turning red under the pressure of Cang Ming's palm, but she did not make a single sound no matter how much strength Cang Ming used .

Gaoqin Jiuye stepped forward with hands in his pockets, looking at this scene where a weak lady was being crushed by an overlord . He said, "Brother Satan, I know you're never one to be gentle . But isn't it too presumptuous to be crushing a little white rabbit in front of all of us?"

I gasped inwardly . Yes, it is presumptuous, but the both of you aren't that different either .

And, crushing a 'little white rabbit'? Hahaha, only you, Gaoqin Jiuye, would come up with such a phrase .

Seems like Gaoqin Jiuye's words worked even against the arrogant Cang Ming, as he freed Bian Ying with a wave of his arm . Bian Ying's jet-black hair fell across the rock as she crouched against it, gasping for air, a hint of resistance showing through those unnaturally rosy cheeks .

Cang Ming did not look at Bian Ying again . He leapt across the river to reach us .

Cang Ming did not look at Bian Ying again . He leapt across the river to reach us .

He glanced at Gaoqin Jiuye . “Enough with the small talk . What’s your purpose in coming here to the Gate of Ghost?”

Gaoqin Jiuye smirked . A vortex appeared with a quick wave of his left hand, revealing the sleeping Guan Nie .

“Help me save him . His split symbol is peeling . ”

Cang Ming laughed hysterically, as if he just heard a joke . His blood-red robes fluttered behind him as he did so .

“Help you? You, Gaoqin Jiuye, would actually say these words?”

Gaoqin Jiuye raised a brow, but he remained silent .

After observing him for a moment, Cang Ming shifted his gaze to Nie Zun who was beside me .

“I’m going to heal that face . ” He pointed a presumptuous finger at Nie Zun’s face .

I was overwhelmed with instant joy, and I asked in my excitement, “Really? Can you really heal his face?”

Cang Ming then looked at me for the first time .

Nie Zun reached out a hand towards me, shaking his head .

Seeing his reaction, I could only suppress the questions I had .

Nie Zun smiled as he nodded at Cang Ming . “Thank you, but there’s no need to . I’m fine just like this . ”

I didn’t know why Nie Zun rejected his help, but if this was his decision, I’ll respect it .

Nie Zun smiled as he nodded at Cang Ming . “Thank you, but there’s no need to . I’m fine just like this . ”

I didn't know why Nie Zun rejected his help, but if this was his decision, I'll respect it .

Gaoqin Jiuye said coldly, "And you said we have the same goal . If we have the same goal, please be reminded that we're here to save Guan Nie and not your lover!"

I was incensed upon hearing these words . What's wrong with this person? Has he gone mental? What did he have against Nie Zun and I?

"Hey, what're you trying to do, Gaoqin Jiuye? Have we offended you? Since your friend 'Satan' here has healing abilities, and it was him who offered to heal Nie Zun's face, why are you acting this way? It's not like we decided not to save Guan Nie now . Aren't these totally different?" I stared at Gaoqin Jiuye in anger .

Gaoqin Jiuye responded in the same cold voice, "I just thought it was interesting that you seem so anxious for him . Why be so anxious when he obviously doesn't want it healed? Or is it because you're not comfortable looking at Nie Zun's disfigured face, and you don't like it?"

"What did you say?" I asked, pointing an accusing finger at him . He really made me angry now .

"Shen'er . " Nie Zun stopped me once again .

Nie Zun has been calling me Shen'er ever since he returned, and no matter how agitated I felt, I would always calm down every time I heard it, just like how a ruffled little puppy would quieten every time its owner petted its head . (Passerby B: This analogy is a little...)

The atmosphere between the three of us seemed to have turned a little tense . Cang Ming then laughed loudly .

"When I say I'm going to heal your face, I wasn't asking for your opinion on it . I'm just telling you that . Nobody can stop me from doing whatever I want to do . " Cang Ming looked at Nie Zun impudently .

I realized why Nie Zun rejected him now . No amount of eye-rolls can accurately describe how presumptuous this fellow was .

Nie Zun simply smiled and kept quiet .

“As for the person you’ve brought with you, Gaoqin Jiuye . Haha . If my brain is working right and if I remember right, the peeling of the split symbol is caused by the individual . You want me, somebody who’s already so used to being a devil, to bring some hope to your friend and to heal issues of the heart? Gaoqin Jiuye, I think you’ve hung out with these low-grade creatures for way too long that you’ve forgotten how to think . ”

Low-grade creatures?? Are you referring to us heirs??

Chapter 169

169 The Third Kind of Existence

“Issues of the heart? Huh, you mean I’ll just have to tell him to wake up and his split symbol will stop peeling? Just tell me, are you going to heal him or not?” Gaoqin Jiuye questioned Cang Ming as he pointed at Guan Nie, who was lying on the ground now, no longer in that vortex .

These two were really insane . If he had asked me in that tone of voice, even I would have declined to help! I then started to think of other possible ways to save Guan Nie in case this opportunity was ruined by Gaoqin Jiuye .

I did not expect Cang Ming to actually nod and say, “Alright, I’ll heal him .”

I almost choked on the air . Why were these people always doing unexpected things?

I looked at Cang Ming with suspicion, and I noticed that Jiao S was being extremely quiet beside Nie Zun .

Jiao S had those bleak, empty eyes, as if she had been petrified by someone triggering an acupoint . She looked like she was thinking about something .

She had to be planning something . I’ve gotten quite used to her habits now, and she usually did not have that expressionless face on her . This was just her front when she’s in deep thought and there are other things on her mind .

There was this clean separation between her expressions and how she actually felt . She puts on that mask when in front of people she doesn’t

really care about, and even her gaze could be faked . Nobody would be able to tell what she was thinking and how she was really feeling inside from just looking at her face . She takes that mask off only when she's with us, when she meets us with liveliness and the utmost sincerity .

“You and you, you guys stay here first . ” Cang Ming suddenly pointed at me and Jiao S .

“You and you, follow me . ” He then pointed at Nie Zun and Gaoqin Jiuye .

I sulked inwardly . Does he think he's the emperor? Going around pointing at everyone like this . But who cares how audacious he is if he could really heal Nie Zun's face?

Cang Ming walked towards the forest on the opposite side of the river bank after he spoke .

Without taking another look at any of us, Gaoqin Jiuye carried Guan Nie and followed behind Cang Ming . Guan Nie looked like a sleeping beauty wrapped in white in Gaoqin Jiuye's embrace .

Before Nie Zun left, he said, “Wait for me to be back . ”

Cang Ming paused momentarily as he passed that huge rock by the river where Bian Ying was . She was still crouched on the rock and she did not move an inch .

“Stay here and don't think of him, or else I'll kill every single person here . ”

The three of them left for the forest behind the river after Cang Ming said that to Bian Ying .

A light wind blew past, making my eyes feel dry, but that made me feel as if I've really returned to the real world .

After Cang Ming left, Bian Ying struggled to get up . She continued hugging her knees as she resumed her sitting position . Jiao S and I looked at each other, wondering what we should do next .

It was Bian Ying who spoke first . “You’re Li Shen?”

I nodded .

She seemed to hesitate before asking her next question . With eyes that looked adrift, she glanced at the quiet water below the rock with melancholy, sighing as she did so . She then walked over to me and Jiao S .

“How did you get to know Ta Lai?” Her voice and her eyes were as clear as spring water .

Smiling, I told her about how I met Ta Lai and everything that happened in between, including how he disfigured Nie Zun . Jiao S glanced at me quite a few times with looks of worry, but I simply shook my head gently, signaling that it was fine .

Like what I’ve said before, I’ve had enough of these secrets . I don’t care if doing this is dangerous anymore or if I’m actually walking into a trap, because I’ve had enough of it .

Like what I’ve said before, I’ve had enough of these secrets . I don’t care if doing this is dangerous anymore or if I’m actually walking into a trap, because I’ve had enough of it .

As I spoke, I saw Bian Ying’s expression change several times, and I wasn’t sure what she thought of it after I finished my story .

But the one thing I can be sure of is that she definitely did not leave Ta Lai for someone else . I believe that there’s something else that we don’t know about her, Ta Lai, and that presumptuous Cang Ming .

I walked over to the river after I finished my story, squatting down as I ran my hands in the water .

“Anyway, I wouldn’t say I hate Ta Lai, but I don’t know why he changed so suddenly either, and why he was so cruel to Nie Zun . I know he approached me initially with personal reasons, but I want to believe that Ta

Lai is a good man,” I said as I played with the water . These words were meant for Bian Ying .

I chided myself inwardly as I thought, Oh, Li Shen, since when did you learn to lie?

It was true that I do not hate Ta Lai, and I knew he had his aims, but no matter what those aims were, he cannot be a good man if he had hurt Nie Zun . At least I wouldn’t think that way even if he really was one .

It was always difficult to separate the good and the bad . For me, whoever went against me were the bad ones .

The water felt cold and icy, and I felt a peculiar feeling spread through my palm as my hands were in the river . I looked at the river with curiosity, but I wasn’t able to see any reflection of myself because of the ripples I created in the water . With a faint smile, I continued observing my palm as I quietly waited for a response .

I heard a sigh from behind me after a short while . A victorious smile escaped from the corner of my lips as I stood up and turned to face Bian Ying .

Bian Ying looked at me with hesitation in her eyes . Even so, she did not avoid me as I took her hand in mine .

“Could you share your story with me? What happened between you and Ta Lai? Since you’re the only other person in the Split Zone with double identity disorder, I figured I could do with some suggestions from you . ”

Though Bian Ying looked woefully weak and pensive, I knew from that obstinate gleam in her eyes that she was not a woman easily persuaded .

“What’s your goal?” She asked .

“What’s your goal?” She asked .

I took a deep breath . “I want to save my friend . To be honest, I don’t look too kindly upon soul splitters, and there’s this particular one called Du Yue

who keeps hurting my friend . If it was possible, I'd rather not have to come to the Northern District ever so that there's no need for me to meet any soul splitters . But I know that I'll have to meet you guys in order to save my friend .

“Like what I told you earlier, I promised Ta Lai that I'd never leave the Split Zone ever, and that was why he agreed to help me . But he did that to Nie Zun since he thinks I have an intention to break that promise . In my eyes, you soul splitters are an unreasonable bunch – you guys are extremely cruel and have no humanity whatsoever . ”

As I spoke, my tone was increasingly uncongenial, and I realized afterwards that I was squeezing her hand rather tightly .

Her pupils dilated slowly and she finally said, “No, it's not like that . Ta Lai isn't like this . ”

That's right, say it . Continue talking . I want you to tell me the truth . Why did Ta Lai suddenly treat me and Nie Zun this way? As his lover, you'd definitely know why, right?

A faint smile appeared on Jiao S's lips as she understood what I was trying to do .

The passive Bian Ying suddenly grabbed my arm, clear agony reflected in her eyes . “Trust me, Ta Lai isn't a bad person . Everything he did, he did it for me . ”

I smirked . “For you? If I remember right, I've never seen you before today . Since we don't know each other, and I'm an heir while you're a soul splitter, how are we connected? If we're not related in any way, why did he have to hurt me and my friends for you?”

She then smiled dejectedly . “Who says that we aren't connected?”

The smile on my face froze . I was about to discover the truth, but why did I feel scared all of a sudden?

Indeed, the unknown is what's scariest . There's no way to resist especially when you know it's about to be revealed, and you can't help but be fearful when you have absolutely no idea what it is .

Bian Ying sighed again before slowly taking her hand away from mine .

“You're wrong, Li Shen . It's not that an heir like you and a soul splitter like me have no connection, it's that both of us are neither heirs nor soul splitters . ”

Bian Ying sighed again before slowly taking her hand away from mine .

“You're wrong, Li Shen . It's not that an heir like you and a soul splitter like me have no connection, it's that both of us are neither heirs nor soul splitters . ”

Bian Ying had a calm and steady gaze that was different from before, when it looked like she did not have a single care in the world . Right now, she was capable of instilling fear with that eerily calm gaze .

“There aren't only heirs and soul splitters here in the Split Zone . We are both examples of the third kind of existence here, different from heirs or soul splitters . ”

I tried to make myself look as calm and composed as I could . “What do you mean by a third kind of existence?”

Bian Ying glanced at me before walking over to the river . Her back was facing Jiao S and I as she sat by the river bank . “Come over and have a seat, I'll tell you all you want to know . ”

Jiao S and I looked at each other again, but this time, it was me who hesitated .

“Come over, don't you want to know the truth? Are you afraid now that you're about to discover it?”

I looked up at that gloomy sun .

It was Jiao S who answered, “The truth is definitely terrifying, but it is still the truth . Go ahead, we’re listening . ”

She then walked over and sat to Bian Ying’s left, dipping a leg into the cold river, while her other leg remained propped up against the river bank . That pose made her look so much like the dashing Li Qing when she used to accompany me on the roof .

I took a deep breath before walking over quickly and taking a seat on Bian Ying’s right .

I dipped both feet into the river and looked in front as I answered Bian Ying, “Tell us . I’ll make sure to listen very carefully . ”

Chapter 170

170 The Trio of Death and Sorrow

Bian Ying smiled in response . “The Split Zone is different from the real world that you know . Soul splitters are the living things here in the Split Zone, like how humans beings are in the real world . Soul splitters are bodies of consciousness that are able to make use of their mental abilities, and things like disagreements and fights occur among them too . Because of that, there are also different factions among the soul splitters .

“All of you have already seen how the factions are separated when you first arrived in the Northern District – by those three huge gates . There are three major factions among the soul splitters right now; Heaven splitters, Ghost splitters, and Exit splitters .

“These three groups do not get along with one another . They’ve found a way to obtain power, and that is to create a three-way split symbol contract . For soul splitters, they need to find an individual whose strength is on a different level from theirs, so they’ve found heirs from your world . They’re able to capture these heirs to the Split Zone under certain favorable circumstances . A splitting key will then be given to the heir as a means of undoing the contract once the split symbol is engraved on both the soul splitter and the heir .

“I’m sure the both of you are wondering why soul splitters can activate their split symbol . Actually, this isn’t something they’re able to control since they don’t have a splitting key . When a split symbol is engraved, both the heir and the soul splitter obtain power at the same time . When heirs activate their split symbol and gain access to greater power, the split symbols on their soul splitters will automatically be activated at the same time, providing their soul splitters with greater power .

“When heirs insert their splitting key into the split symbol of their soul splitter, they are effectively sealing it . Once they do that, they can then leave the Split Zone, and their soul splitter will lose the power gained . If a new heir can’t be found in a certain period of time after losing that power, the soul splitter will die .

“This is why there’s this class divide between heirs and soul splitters . But for us, Li Shen, we are neither soul splitters nor heirs . ”

Bian Ying smiled at me at this point .

My hands started curling up into fists .

“I say that because soul splitters capture the consciousness of their heirs . In your world, that would be called capturing your souls . To people with double identity disorder, we can look at it like we have two independent sets of consciousness . ”

It was hard to keep my emotions in check . “What did you just say?”

Bian Ying kept her eyes on me as she continued, “As individuals with double identity disorder, we have two independent sets of consciousness . Soul splitters cannot capture two bodies of consciousness at the same time, and the split symbol contract cannot be made with a fourth party . ”

I felt like there was a ticking time bomb placed in my heart that continuously went tic-tic-tic, and in the next few seconds when it goes off, I would have nowhere to run since I was already tightly bound to it .

“So it’s not accurate when you say Gaoqin Jiuye is your soul splitter, because it wasn’t him who forcefully captured you . ”

“Then why does he have the same split symbol in the same place as I do?” I asked with a trembling voice .

Bian Ying sighed . “Actually, I’m not very sure about what the situation is between you and Gaoqin Jiuye . I would be able to give an answer if it was

somebody else, but you're just like me and we're different from the other types of existence found here . Let me first tell you about myself .

“I don't know what happened that caused me to arrive here in the Split Zone, but as someone with double identity disorder, there was no way for me to survive if I had no power . Ta Lai tried engraving a split symbol on me to protect me, but since I had in me two sets of consciousness, and split symbol contracts cannot be made with a fourth party, he was unsuccessful . Because of that, he sought Cang Ming's help .

“I don't know what happened that caused me to arrive here in the Split Zone, but as someone with double identity disorder, there was no way for me to survive if I had no power . Ta Lai tried engraving a split symbol on me to protect me, but since I had in me two sets of consciousness, and split symbol contracts cannot be made with a fourth party, he was unsuccessful . Because of that, he sought Cang Ming's help .

“He looked for Cang Ming because Cang Ming was the only person in the Split Zone who had great MF even when he did not establish any split symbol contract . ”

“What?” Jiao S and I asked in shock .

Bian Ying answered us calmly, “Like what I said earlier, soul splitters are an ordinary type of existence here which depend on MF to survive . Everything is created with MF, and they capture heirs to obtain greater MF through split symbol contracts . If they do not establish any contract, they will never die . But once they establish a contract, they might face death if they aren't able to find another heir if the previous one successfully undid it . So they'd literally have to bet their life on it if they decide to establish a split symbol contract .

“As time passed, more and more soul splitters did this since more of them were gaining greater powers, and you'd be bullied if you were a weakling .

“Before long, almost all soul splitters in the Split Zone had established split symbol contracts, except Cang Ming . He's like what you'd call a prodigy

in the real world . Blessed with great MF from a young age, he didn't need to establish any split symbol contract . ”

My brows furrowed as I heard ‘from a young age’ . Soul splitters grow up like we do?

Thinking about it, that might be the case . Didn't I see the teenage Gaoqin Jiuye when I looked into Si Luo's heart?

But if they could grow older, why couldn't they die?

But if they could grow older, why couldn't they die?

“Ta Lai looked for him because he did not have any split symbol engraved . The Cang Ming of the past was bold and someone with no inhibitions . Though he was also presumptuous, he wasn't cruel or ruthless . Not only was he good friends with Ta Lai, because he was blessed with such great MF, he also used it to develop a lot of ways that could heal others when their MF received damage . He used his own MF to save others . At that time, he agreed to Ta Lai's request without a second thought .

“He discussed this in great depth with Ta Lai, and he finally found a solution; to ‘combine the consciousness’ . ”

At this point, Bian Ying gripped the edges of her white blouse tightly . It looked like what she was about to tell me was what caused her the most agony .

“Since the split symbol contract can only be made with three parties, Ta Lai chose to establish it with the main personality in my soul – that's the current me . As the split symbol was being engraved, they forcefully lured my other personality out and combined that consciousness with Cang Ming, engraving a split symbol on him . ”

“Why can't the split symbol be engraved on both your personalities at the same time, but it can be engraved on you and Cang Ming at the same time?” I asked .

“Because even though the personalities are independent of each other, they are still me . They are independent sets of consciousness which can combine whenever they want to, so the split symbol contract cannot be established on someone with double identity disorder . The only way to go about it is to lure the fourth party out .

“Ta Lai, Cang Ming and I ended up having the same set of split symbols . Since Cang Ming is a soul splitter, he should have an heir with a corresponding split symbol, who is actually supposed to be my other personality . But because of what we did, my other personality disappeared as she was absorbed by Cang Ming, and this caused a drastic change in him .

“From then on, Cang Ming became a totally different person . Sometimes he was nice, sometimes he wasn’t, but most of the time, he was cruel and violent . He was absolutely merciless wherever he went, always leaving a trail of blood behind him . After a while, he gained the nickname ‘Satan Cang Ming’ . As for me, I was then able to live together with Ta Lai in the Split Zone because of his help, and I’m usually by Cang Ming’s side because he’s less bloodthirsty whenever I’m with him .

“But the good times didn’t last . When Cang Ming wanted a living weapon, he got Zou An and his wife to create Piercer for him . The soul trapped in Piercer was still very demonic when it was newly-created, so it tried to devour me when I was delivering it to him . If it was Cang Ming, it would only have caused damage to his MF, but because the other half of my personality was gone, I wasn’t able to withstand the living weapon, and my consciousness was devoured by it .

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“To save me, Cang Ming tried to force my other personality out of him, but it wasn’t successful . He eventually dragged half of my personality out of Piercer, but half of it is still with Piercer . So, the current me doesn’t even have a proper consciousness . ”

I was a little confused at all of this . I interrupted her to ask, “You mean that you were surviving with your main personality after your other personality was combined with Cang Ming, but since it was devoured by Piercer and only half of it could be saved, does this mean that your consciousness is split into three now? One, that is you, one in Piercer, and one in Cang Ming?”

She laughed at how I described it . “That’s right, it’s exactly like this . Half of me is in Piercer, while the other personality of mine is in Cang Ming . An incomplete body of consciousness cannot survive here, but Cang Ming found a solution to it . As long as I’m within five hundred meters of him, this broken body of consciousness in me will be able to survive in the Split Zone since it can sense the presence of my other personality in Cang Ming . ”

Five hundred meters... My heart sank, wondering if this was all fated to be .

“But because I’m an incomplete body of consciousness, my presence caused a greater change in Cang Ming due to the side effects of my consciousness interacting with my other personality that’s in him . As time passed, he began to attempt to possess me like I was an item, and he wanted the love I had for Ta Lai . He became more and more overbearing, not allowing me to see Ta Lai, and eventually not allowing me to leave him at all, eventually turning into what he is today .

“As for Ta Lai, he had lost me and he had been trying ways and means to take me away and rekindle the love between us . But there’s nothing he can do about this . If he is adamant about wanting to see me, Cang Ming will leave me, and if Cang Ming leaves me, I’ll no longer be able to survive . Though the distance of five hundred meters is not a binding restriction, my body will start deteriorating if I’m more than five hundred meters away from him .

“Because of this, Cang Ming, originally a Heaven splitter, took me away from the Gate of Heaven and brought us here to the Gate of Ghost, while Ta Lai continued being a Heaven splitter . ”

Chapter 171

171 Always Regarded As A Freak

“Ta Lai... is a soul splitter from the Gate of Heaven?”

Bian Ying nodded . “Not only Ta Lai, Du Yue too . Even Si Luo and Gaoqin Jiuye, they were all soul splitters from the Gate of Heaven . ”

Recalling what Ta Lai said previously, I began to realize why he approached me in the first place .

Bian Ying moved her feet, creating ripples in the water . Jiao S continued to listen quietly with a poker face .

“You can probably guess what happened next . Ta Lai tried all ways and means to save me from Cang Ming, to no avail . He realized that the best way to make me complete again is to look for another individual with double identity disorder just like me . ”

I tried to suppress my shock at this . “But, my personality is still mine . So, how could it help to make you complete?”

Bian Ying sighed . “That’s right . This is why Ta Lai began to look for ways to extract the essence of the consciousness – he wants to extract the essence of your other personality . This means he wants to erase all memory from your other personality, and use it to make me complete again . He needs time to find a way to do so, and that’s why he requested for you not to leave the Split Zone .

“He probably hurt Nie Zun in an attempt to push you into a corner, since you’re like me, where your other personality will appear only under great

pressure . So that could've been his attempt at luring your other personality out .

“I don't know if he has found a way to extract the essence of the consciousness since I haven't seen him in a long while now . I don't know how far he has gone for me either . ”

I tried to calm myself down as I took this all in .

“If everything you say is true, then whatever he does, he did it all for you . So, why are you telling me all this?” I asked coldly .

Bian Ying's eyes widened as she looked into the distance with eyes that looked adrift . “Because I don't agree with whatever he's doing . Too many people have sacrificed themselves for me, the kind Cang Ming turned into someone bloodthirsty, so how can I let Ta Lai turn into a monster because of me?

“I can't do anything else but stay by Cang Ming's side . So I'm really happy that you guys are here now . ”

Though I did believe her, I still laughed at this . With a frigid smile on my face, I kept looking at her, forcing her to eventually shift her gaze and meet my eyes .

“Maybe, you have another reason for doing so . ”

“In the years that you've been by Cang Ming's side, you realized that you've already fell in love with him, and that you no longer feel the same for Ta Lai . You want to stop all this because you don't want to leave Cang Ming . ”

My voice echoed through the forest and Jiao S's eyes widened as she heard what I said .

Bian Ying's gaze wavered, her hands slowly balling up into fists .

After a while, she looked at me with sorrow . “That's right . I've fallen in love with Cang Ming, but I still love Ta Lai . I know you'd probably look

down on me for this, but it's the truth . I don't want to leave Cang Ming, but at the same time, I can't bear to see Ta Lai do all this for me . ”

I suddenly felt sorry for Bian Ying .

Even in the real world, it was not impossible to fall in love with more than one person at the same time . Though there are those who think that we would only love only one person at any one time, there would always be exceptions .

Bian Ying's feelings hurt both Cang Ming and Ta Lai, but she would be in the most pain .

How should she choose, who should she protect? How can someone with a broken consciousness, a broken personality choose?

I said softly, “Does Ta Lai know this...”

I said softly, “Does Ta Lai know this...”

Bian Ying's gaze darkened . “I'm sure he knows how I feel towards Cang Ming, but he stubbornly thinks that I had a change of heart because I have an incomplete consciousness . This is why he is trying his best to make my consciousness complete again . ”

“Is your consciousness never going to recover once it's devoured by Piercer? Can't Piercer return it to you?”

Bian Ying laughed sadly . “Piercer was created with the body belonging to a female soul, and she had a lot of hatred in her . She even cursed Zou An and his wife, so how could anyone be able to separate my consciousness from Piercer?”

“What do you mean by she even cursed Zou An and his wife?”

“You said Ah Wen died, and even though there probably are external factors at play, I think a large part of it has to do with Piercer . You said Zou An hates you now, but in reality, this is karma for them . I've entered the body of Piercer previously, and nobody will know it better than I do . She hates

Zou An and his wife, so Ah Wen's death definitely has something to do with her .

“As for why Piercer landed in your hands, I suggest you might want to look into this thoroughly, because no matter what, Piercer will not bring any luck to its bearer . Anyone who gives Piercer to you must have a deep hatred for you . ”

But Zou An and his wife were the ones who gave Piercer to me, and even that was under Jie Pa's recommendation . There's no way Jie Pa would hurt me . Zou An said he was forced to do so by You Ji, but did You Ji hate me so much? Was it just because she was jealous?

Jiao S suddenly spoke in that hoarse voice of hers, “Both of you have missed the most important point here .

“The point is that if both Ah Shen and you have double identity disorder, then it should be impossible for a split symbol to be engraved on Ah Shen as well . If that's the case, then why was Gaoqin Jiuye able to engrave a split symbol on Ah Shen?”

Her question seemed to have created a sudden explosion in my heart, bringing me back to the current situation!

I looked at the two of them . Bian Ying looked calm, as if she had already anticipated such a question .

“This is why I'm telling you the truth .

“This is why I'm telling you the truth .

“There's not much use in sharing my story, since the most you can do is to be wary of Ta Lai from now on . But looking at the situation now, you might be experiencing the exact same thing I did years ago, and I just couldn't bear to see it . ”

A bitter feeling overcame me . “Why would you feel for a stranger like me?”

Bian Ying looked at me with glistening eyes . “Stranger? You seem to be the only one who understands how I feel . As someone with double identity disorder, we’ve always been considered freaks . Even in this world, we aren’t able to fit in . How can ordinary heirs or soul splitters understand such solitude?

“Don’t you understand, Li Shen? Even in the Split Zone, you and I are still freaks who don’t fit in . To survive here, both of us have to sacrifice others in order to find a place for ourselves . Who else would understand this better than you can?”

A tear rolled down Bian Ying’s cheek .

I felt as if I was about to be suffocated .

To survive here, both of us have to sacrifice others in order to find a place for ourselves .

Sacrifice others .

Sacrifice, others .

I closed my eyes, trying to stop thinking about this .

I heard Bian Ying’s voice continue, “You’re in a worse plight . At least I’m aware of all that had happened and who had actually sacrificed themselves for me to be able to live peacefully here . But based on what you’ve said earlier, you had no idea about this . You don’t know who sacrificed themselves for you in order for you to have this power, or even this life here now .

“Li Shen, I don’t know much about Gaoqin Jiuye as he was always mysterious and even more unpredictable than Cang Ming . Even in the Gate of Heaven, no one knows his true abilities . A long time ago, when Si Luo, one of the most powerful soul splitters in the Gate of Heaven, suddenly decided to leave the Northern District and the Gate of Heaven, Gaoqin Jiuye followed him without a second thought .

“The next time I saw Gaoqin Jiuye, it was in the Southern District . At that time, my consciousness had been devoured by Piercer as I was on my way back to the Northern District . Because of that, Cang Ming massacred the Southern District as he wanted to look for Zou An and his wife for revenge . It was Gaoqin Jiuye who saved the couple, and I’ve never seen him again after that .

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“He has never broken his oath of re-entering the Northern District . But now that he’s here, no matter who he did this for, I knew there was more to this when I saw you . ”

I interrupted Bian Ying, “You were saying that Gaoqin Jiuye had great MF since a long time ago?”

Bian Ying nodded . “Yes, Gaoqin wasn’t as strong as Cang Ming, but he’s also unique . I can’t say too much, but just know that Gaoqin Jiuye can still survive and live well even without engraving a split symbol .

“Since he had decided to follow Si Luo and not come back to the Northern District to participate in the territorial disputes among the soul splitters, why did he need to establish a split symbol contract? And even if he did want to do so, why did he have to choose someone like you with double identity disorder?

“I don’t know the reasons or the truth behind this, but I believe that Gaoqin would have his reasons . I look towards Gaoqin as a friend, and I can tell that he has a place in your heart as well . I believe you don’t wish for others to sacrifice themselves for you while you’re in the dark about it, right?

“You might want to look into this, Li Shen . ”

My fists were balled up so tightly that my nails were digging into my palms, and blood was already dripping down my hands .

Gaoqin Jiuye, what’s all this? I thought you didn’t know me? Aren’t you unrelated to Gao Qi?

I was terrified of this suddenly . If everything happening here can affect Gao Qi, even just a little, how could I still face myself?

Bian Ying’s words continued ringing in my head .

To survive here, both of us have to sacrifice others in order to find a place for ourselves .

Chapter 172

172 Underwater Stone Cave

Other than Gaoqin Jiuye, I also thought of somebody else .

Nie Zun .

If it was because of somebody's sacrifice that Bian Ying could live like this now, then it was clear that Cang Ming had given up much more than Ta Lai did . Though I was sympathetic to Ta Lai, it was heartbreaking to hear Cang Ming's story .

How about Nie Zun? If we couldn't be more than five hundred meters apart, and this was a binding restriction, what could that possibly mean?

But Nie Zun is different from Cang Ming, he isn't a soul splitter . So what exactly happened between Nie Zun, Gaoqin Jiuye and I?

On this, Bian Ying wasn't able to provide me with an answer . I stood up, looking at water disappearing slowly into the soil as it dripped from the ends of my red dress .

When was the last time I've looked at soil like this?

I said quietly, "After all this time, you still haven't told me what exactly are soul splitters, the truth behind them, and why the environment in the Northern District looks so much like the real world . "

Bian Ying looked up at me as she said, "I can't tell you any more than what I've said . You'll have to look for the answers on your own . My only suggestion for you is to find out how your split symbol came about, and to

give up on Piercer as soon as you can . Don't follow in my footsteps . Also, don't go against Du Yue . ”

“Don't go against Du Yue? Do you know how many of my friends had been hurt by her? I'm definitely going against her . ”

“Bian Ying, I've heard others say that Du Yue's eventual aim is to kill you in order to obtain Ta Lai's love . What do you make of this?” Jiao S asked an important question .

Bian Ying smiled bitterly . “Du Yue is definitely very much in love with Lai, and I don't know how deep her hatred is for me . But I know that she has always been headstrong, nobody can stop her in whatever she wants to do, and nobody would be able to escape if she wanted to kill them . ”

I smirked . “Ta Lai doesn't love her, so she's still sadly at the losing end . ”

Bian Ying shook her head . “In recent years, even I have no idea what Lai is thinking . He has almost gone insane in trying to save me . I've heard some things about what happened at your living quarters . Li Shen, whatever happened between Lai and Du Yue isn't that simple, since feelings are always complicated like this . Anyway, my advice is not to approach Lai anymore, because his goal is to take your second personality away . On that, he's rather similar to Du Yue as he wouldn't give up until he achieves his goal . ”

Ha, my second personality? To take my second personality away? I don't even mind giving it to him for free!

Looking down at Bian Ying, I said, “I'm sorry but I'm not able to take your advice on this . I'm different from you . I don't really like my second personality anyway, so if Ta Lai is doing all this for that other person in me, then I'm more than welcoming of him . I can't get rid of her no matter what I do, so I should be thanking Ta Lai if he really can take her away from me . ”

I saw Bian Ying frown for the first time, worry apparent in her eyes . “Li Shen, though you might not like your second personality, you have to know

that she is a part of you too . No matter what, she'll always be on your side . If you approach Lai because of this little pettiness, you're not the only one who'd get hurt . Nie Zun, your lover, might get hurt too . Even so, are you still not going to take my advice?"

I bent down to meet her eyes . "I'm grateful for whatever you've shared with me today, but I've learnt something in the Split Zone from all that had already happened . Whether you run away to protect yourself or simply in avoidance, you'll never be able to escape your fate . If I want to survive here, I should be fighting back instead of running away . "

Bian Ying's eyes shone for a second before dimming .

She sighed . "Things might not have turned out this way if only I had been as brave as you are . "

I laughed, reaching out to her with a hand . "It's never too late . There's nothing difficult about this, Bian Ying . You'd have to make a choice between Ta Lai and Cang Ming . I understand that you're in love with two people, but you have to know that no matter how many people you've fallen in love with, you have to make one final choice . It's better for you to make that choice sooner rather than later, because the longer you take, the worse it'll hurt for all three of you .

"Come on, let's go . Let's see how Cang Ming and the rest are doing . "

"Come on, let's go . Let's see how Cang Ming and the rest are doing . "

I grabbed Bian Ying as she stretched out a hesitant hand, pulling her out of the water . I looked at Jiao S, who was already up and ready to go . She was always this in sync with me .

Bian Ying's hand felt cold, just like mine . I wanted to say something as the three of us were standing on the riverbank, but a dark green tentacle suddenly rose up from the river!

I got a rude shock and I backed away a couple of steps, pulling Bian Ying with me .

Jiao S turned back to look at what was it that terrified me so, her black hair sweeping in a beautiful arc as she turned .

“What’s this?”

The three of us were now standing in a row as we looked towards the tentacle that appeared in the river . It was long and thick, with a dark green spotted surface resembling the skin of a toad . There were soft protrusions all over the tentacle, and there were five dark green claws at the end of it . It was coming for us right at this moment!

Bian Ying’s brows furrowed . “I don’t think this is something that belongs here in the Gate of Ghost . Why is such a thing here?”

That tentacle was approaching us fast, and without putting much thought into it, I felt around my waist with my right hand as I prepared to wield Piercer .

Bian Ying stopped me quickly . Shaking her head, she said, “Don’t use Piercer . From now on, try not to use it at all . ”

Jiao S had already leapt into the air with her large sword in hand! She roared as she swung her sword with her right hand, producing a ray of light which flew towards those claws!

The tentacle was slashed into two as those five claws were cut, splashing into the water as they dropped into the river .

The tentacle was slashed into two as those five claws were cut, splashing into the water as they dropped into the river .

We kept our eyes on the surface of the river as Jiao S retreated to my left . There seemed to be more coming our way since we defeated this monster rather easily .

As expected, the entire river started quaking after the tentacle was cut .

Why were there earthquakes everywhere I went? I wonder if it was someone causing this, or did the Split Zone just have a weak ground

foundation?

The earthquake did not last long, but the ground below us suddenly collapsed!

At the same time, there was a great force pulling us into the river . As we weren't able to steady ourselves on the collapsing ground, we were sucked into the river in mere seconds .

I tried to activate my MF once I was immersed in the cold river, but once we were in the water, I felt like my MF had been frozen solid .

I started sinking into the river .

As I opened my eyes in the water, I saw two blobs of black hair floating in the water, looking like two jellyfish .

Right, this looks like all three of us are sinking .

Everything looked so similar to the real world that I actually held my breath while in the water .

I tried swimming towards Jiao S and Bian Ying, but it wasn't as easy as I thought it would be . I wasn't able to use my MF properly, and I just kept sinking . There seemed to be no bottom in sight and it felt like we were in the middle of a huge ocean .

I finally decided to give up on using my MF and use my physical strength to swim towards them . However, something held onto my leg and pulled me down towards the bottom of the river!

I tried swimming towards Jiao S and Bian Ying, but it wasn't as easy as I thought it would be . I wasn't able to use my MF properly, and I just kept sinking . There seemed to be no bottom in sight and it felt like we were in the middle of a huge ocean .

I finally decided to give up on using my MF and use my physical strength to swim towards them . However, something held onto my leg and pulled me down towards the bottom of the river!

The force was so sudden that I spit out all the air I was holding and choked on a mouthful of water I just gulped . As I wasn't able to use MF, my vision blurred momentarily and I felt like my throat was on fire .

It felt horrible as I continued gulping down mouthfuls of water as I tried to fight against the water pressure .

As I was struggling in the water, that force which pulled me down suddenly disappeared .

I felt my feet touch the ground .

I tried moving around in the water as I steadied myself . We were probably at the bottom now .

The water pressure surrounding me was gone once both my feet were on the floor . The feeling of choking and suffocating was gone too .

I rubbed my eyes .

Jiao S and Bian Ying were opposite me, looking as bewildered as I was . Looking around, I realized we were in a sort of underwater palace . Well, it wasn't exactly a palace . It was more like an underwater cave .

This place looked to be about a hundred square meters wide, and I saw the transparent waters of the river above us . The water simply floated above us without any glass ceiling . Everything in this place was made of stone – stone desk, stone chair .

As I took in the sights, I saw a familiar figure in the middle of the cave sitting on a stone chair behind a stone table .

Chapter 173

173 Du Yue's Plan

The seated figure looked tall and slender in a tight purple top and a pair of dark green high-waisted trousers . With those exquisite features, she regarded us with a dispassionate gaze .

It was Du Yue!

Du Yue sat cross-legged, leaning against the stone table lazily as she rested her chin on a palm . She shot a cold look at Bian Ying .

“Why are you here in the Gate of Ghost?” Bian Ying did not sound friendly .

Though this was the first time I’ve heard Bian Ying use such a tone with anyone, I could understand why she did so . If Du Yue was the woman pursuing my lover, my attitude would probably be worse than Bian Ying’s!

Du Yue scoffed . “Why, are you afraid of me? If I’m here, it’s definitely because of you . ”

There was no need for me to be friendly with Du Yue . I grabbed Piercer in my hand, pointing it towards her . “Where’s Song Lu? What happened to Yu Liang? What is your experiment all about? How about you come clean with us right now?”

Du Yue glanced at me . “Who do you think you are, ordering me around like this? Or do you actually think you’re a respectable person in the Northern District now that Gaoqin Jiuye is helping you out?”

Before I could say anything, Bian Ying answered, “You’re quick to mention Gaoqin . This means you haven’t forgotten him, so why are you still bothering Lai? You people from the Gate of Heaven are never satisfied with what you have and love to take things belonging to others, don’t you!”

I wanted to applaud Bian Ying . I didn’t expect such a fierce retort from such a gentle lady .

Du Yue seemed to be angered by this as her face wrinkled in a frown .

“Bitch, you only dare talk like this because that person is king here, and poor Ta Lai is still enamored with you . Yes, I take the belongings of others, but that’s still better than you who refuse to give up what you have even after you’ve obtained other things!”

Du Yue slammed the table, standing up on the stone chair! The stone table cracked into four with that angry slam!

“Tch tch tch . Pretty great strength for a person with only one arm . ” I smirked .

I no longer bothered about being kind or gentle . Ever since I stepped into the Northern District, I learnt that you had to hold your own or else you’d just get trampled on! I can forget about saving my friends if I don’t have some ability or might of my own!

Du Yue sensed my sarcasm and shot me a piercing look . “Who are you? You’re just a puny little heir who’s lucky to survive until now . Do you think you’d still be alive if I didn’t spare you?”

I raised a brow . “Sorry for being such a pain, but it’s just too bad that I’m still alive . I’ve personally witnessed Ta Lai’s love for Bian Ying, and it’s the first time I’ve seen a soul splitter so enamored with someone . It’s no wonder you won’t give up in your pursuit . Sadly, you aren’t the one he loves!”

Du Yue was incensed by these harsh words of mine, and she looked like she was about to explode in anger .

I raised Piercer in my hand as a challenge to her .

Looking at what I just did, she laughed . “Seems like you’ll have to meet some of your old friends before you’re willing to stop this audacity . ”

She raised her right hand and snapped her fingers .

Somebody dropped from the water above us! A figure drenched in blood landed in front of us with a loud thud .

I took a closer look, trying to make out who it was...

It was a woman who landed on the ground . Though she was covered in blood, I could see that the top half of her body was still human . Her breasts were gone, replaced by two dark, bloody holes in her chest .

The bottom half of her body was the tail of a snake, but it had no skin . It was a dark red, blotched with numerous scars all over it .

Her hair was in a mess, and she gave off an odor that smelt like rotten flesh . I couldn’t make out who she was .

Du Yue smirked as she pointed at the woman on the ground . “Li Shen, this is your old friend, You Ji . I’m giving her to you . Not only did she betray you, she also caused the death of Zou An’s wife, Ah Wen . You can do whatever you want with her now . ”

What?! This is You Ji??

I trembled at the thought . I could not recognize her at all!

I trembled at the thought . I could not recognize her at all!

Her green hair was drenched in blood, and it looked just like a bunch of rotten seaweed on her head . I bent down to push her hair out of her face, taking a closer look . I was shocked at what I saw!

Her eyes, her eyes had been gouged out, leaving two bloody holes where they were supposed to be . Her nose was also cut off! Her mouth, it was

sewed tightly shut with what looked like a thick black line!

“No, this can’t be You Ji...” I shook my head .

Du Yue laughed cruelly . “If you don’t believe me, how about you feel her MF? Her split symbol is somewhere three inches from where her tail starts . You’re welcome to feel it to check if she really is You Ji!”

With shaking hands, I did as I was told .

I froze as I felt You Ji’s tail .

“Any body of consciousness turned into an experimental subject by me will never be able to heal from their injuries . Her abilities are not that great, and seeing that she even betrayed her friend, I found her to be a pain . So, I decided to gouge her eyes out, cut her nose off, sew her mouth shut, and also put some pain-inducing agent on these wounds that will never heal...”

“Enough!” I swung Piercer out with my right hand!

It was the first time I saw Piercer produce something that resembled a violet dragon, and it flew towards Du Yue!

“Don’t!” Raising both her arms, Bian Ying tried to stop me!

With a quick stare, Jiao S took control of the air currents in the cave! She used an air vortex to restrict Bian Ying’s movements!

“Don’t act rashly if you can’t fight!” Jiao S shouted at Bian Ying as she moved to fight alongside me!

Air vortexes and Piercer’s violet dragon flew towards Du Yue . Du Yue simply smirked as she waved her right hand! With that, we felt a strong gravitational force that seemed to aim straight for our hearts!

My heart felt like it was made of metal that had shattered into a thousand pieces, and it was being forcefully attracted to the ground which acted like an extremely powerful magnet . Both Jiao S and I fell face first into the ground as we were affected by this force!

This unknown force was in total control of my heart as my chest smashed against the ground! My chin was also broken by the fall!

This unknown force was in total control of my heart as my chest smashed against the ground! My chin was also broken by the fall!

Though my chin started healing, a pain begin to spread from my chest!

This unknown force was extremely powerful!

I struggled to look up at Du Yue, who was still smirking . Lifting my left hand with difficulty, I said with a mouthful of blood, “Scorpion Ray, kill her!”

I stared at Du Yue as I focused the MF onto my left hand!

Scorpion Ray produced countless silvery needles that shot towards her!

Du Yue shielded her eyes from the dazzling light of Scorpion Ray, backing away a little!

Jiao S and I were still struggling to get up!

Du Yue waved her right hand again!

Once again, Jiao S and I were affected by that unknown gravitational force!

Bam!

We fell onto the ground again!

“Stop it! This is territory in the Gate of Ghost, and I don’t think you’d dare do anything to me!” Seeing Jiao S and I in a bind, Bian Ying stood in front of us with outstretched arms, trying to shield us .

A sudden pain shot through my right arm and I spat out a mouthful of blood, letting go of Piercer involuntarily .

Du Yue was able to dodge most of the silver needles from Scorpion Ray, but she was still pierced by some of them . Her brows were knitted in a frown, and I could tell that those needles were giving her a ton of pain!

She was visibly enraged as she saw Bian Ying trying to protect us . “I don’t dare do anything to you? I’m actually here to torture you! Ha, don’t you underestimate me . Don’t even hope for Cang Ming to come and save you when I’ve trapped you here at the bottom of the river!”

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With an angry roar, Du Yue grabbed the air with her right hand, and a pillar of water flew towards Bian Ying!

At this moment, a figure dashed out from the water, shielding Bian Ying!

It was Gaoqin Jiuye!

Gaoqin Jiuye shattered the pillar of water with just a quick glance!

I took the opportunity to clean my face as I was splashed with all that water!

“Of course Cang Ming wouldn’t come here . That’s because he fell into your trap!” Gaoqin Jiuye’s voice was icy and his gaze was frigid . He was no longer looking at Du Yue with those sorrowful eyes like before .

Bian Ying grabbed Gaoqin Jiuye as soon as she heard this . “What do you mean by Cang Ming falling into a trap? What happened to him?”

Du Yue smirked . “That’s right . To save Guan Nie, I knew that you guys would look for Cang Ming, and if Cang Ming wanted to save him, he’d

have to go to that cave . I set up an illusion in that cave, and once he enters, you'll never be able to find him . As for whether he can escape, that would depend on his abilities!"

Bian Ying was almost screaming now . "Why did you do that?! Cang Ming did nothing to you!"

Jiao S and I took the chance to get up while they were talking .

Gaoqin Jiuye consoled Bian Ying as he said, "There's no need to worry . Cang Ming wouldn't be called Satan Cang Ming if he could be hurt by Du Yue this easily . Du Yue, where did this confidence of yours come from? Not only have you trespassed into the Gate of Ghost, you even set up a trap for Cang Ming . Is this all to pursue Ta Lai, or is there another conspiracy here?"

Du Yue smiled . "Who told you I'm here alone? Gaoqin Jiuye, you'd go against me just to save Guan Nie? Or is this because of her?"

Raising her only arm slowly, Du Yue pointed at me .

Chapter 174

Volume 3

174 You Ji's Death

Gaoqin Jiuye remained silent, keeping his eyes on Du Yue.

He then drew Shen Qi from his waist, pointing it at Du Yue. "Tell me, where's Cang Ming and the rest?"

His choice was crystal clear.

Wiping away blood from the corner of my lips, I bent down to pick Piercer up from the ground. A bitter cold shot through my palm all the way to my heart as I picked it up.

Facing Du Yue, I enunciated each word as I said, "Heal You Ji's injuries."

Du Yue glanced at You Ji who was crouched on the ground. "Li Shen, I'll be honest with you. She's dying. You should've felt it from her split symbol, her life force is diminishing. All experimental subjects will not be able to heal, and they can only endure whatever their bodies could withstand in the real world. Her injuries are serious, and since she has already been turned into an experimental subject, there's no way to save her."

I knew anger could solve nothing, so all I could do was point at her. I have never been more resolute as I spoke, "Right, don't save her then. I, Li Shen, swear that if You Ji dies today, I'm going to personally kill you. I'll find you wherever you are."

I bent down to help You Ji up after that, not taking another look at Du Yue. I could feel You Ji trembling while she leaned against me. It seemed like she was enduring immense pain.

She looked around, but she could not see me with those black holes that had replaced her eyes. I then slowly pulled apart the black lines which sewed her mouth shut. Her mouth was already full of blood as I took it out, but I knew I had to do this, I knew she had something to say.

Her voice was coarse and raspy. If I didn't look at her, I wouldn't have known it was her.

She said, "Is it... Ah Shen..."

She called me Ah Shen.

My eyes welled up with tears, but I tried not to let any of them fall.

I will never cry in front of Du Yue.

"It's me," I answered croakily.

You Ji's arms started flailing about, and I grabbed her hand.

She looked at me with those gaping holes where her eyes should have been, as if tears of blood could drip out anytime. "Ah Shen, I was jealous of you... Because I love Mr Blond... I did all this to look for him... I'm no longer able to achieve my goal... Can you promise me that you'll find him for me..."

I squeezed her hand tightly. "Alright, I promise. I'll definitely find him."

After I spoke, You Ji's arm slackened.

It wasn't like a television drama where we had some extra time with each other. She just died in my arms. Her body turned into light as it disappeared slowly.

I couldn't believe that this was the intelligent You Ji who had betrayed me the last time I saw her.

This time, I'll never be able to see her again.

"This is the first time you've witnessed the death of someone close to you, right? Sadly, there'll be more of this happening if you go against me. I know what kind of person you are, Li Shen. Do you really think a weakling like you can hold your ground against me?"

Du Yue seemed like an arrogant goddess, looking down upon me.

Jiao S walked over to my side, helping me up. Her eyes had a resolute gaze as she looked at me. It seemed like she was telling me that it's fine, that we'll avenge her.

Gaoqin Jiuye was still holding Shen Qi in his hand. "Du Yue, you've really changed. Is this all because of Ta Lai?"

Du Yue grabbed Shen Qi's blade with her bare hand. "I've always been like this. Gaoqin, you and I are the same. Have you forgotten why you fell in love with me? Because you know that we're the same! Stop running away from it. Cruel acts are merely child's play to you and I, and sympathy will only make you weak."

Bian Ying ran over to Jiao S and I, and she turned and shouted at Du Yue, "You're insane! You've gone crazy in loving Ta Lai! These people are innocent; take me as your target!"

"Take you as my target? Who do you think you are?!" Incensed at Bian Ying's words, Du Yue bent Shen Qi's tip towards Bian Ying!

Shen Qi was a flexible sword, and with Du Yue's movement, its tip was now facing Bian Ying!

Gaoqin Jiuye obviously did not anticipate that Du Yue would do something like this when his sword was already pointing at her face. In the time that

she used to bend the tip, Gaoqin Jiuye could have cut her hand off easily if he had raised his sword.

But it was clear that she knew Gaoqin Jiuye would never do that. However, that doesn't mean that I wouldn't do something Gaoqin Jiuye won't!

I leapt forward to grab Shen Qi's blade somewhere closer to the hilt. I didn't blink an eye even when I felt the piercing pain of its sharp blade cutting into my palm!

Du Yue's hand was already dripping with blood where the blade had cut into her palm. We looked at each other, neither of us having any intention of backing off!

Looking at the situation, Gaoqin Jiuye focused his MF on Shen Qi.

There were three sources of MF on Shen Qi now.

Du Yue glanced at Gaoqin Jiuye, then back at me, before a victorious smile appeared on her lips. She looked extremely sure that even though Gaoqin Jiuye will not help her, he would not wish for her death either.

But she seems to have overestimated me on this. I'm not about to go solo against her.

I called out loudly for Jiao S, "Jiao!"

Jiao S knew exactly what I wanted her to do as she leapt towards us with her huge sword, swinging it towards Du Yue!

With only one hand, Du Yue's strength was now focused on Shen Qi. She wanted to retract her MF upon seeing Jiao S's incoming attack, but I wouldn't give her this chance! I focused all my MF on my hand and Shen Qi as I tried to stall her. Gaoqin Jiuye's expression darkened as he hesitated. I knew he would not take Shen Qi back rashly in this moment, since both our hands were still on it, bloodied by its blade.

As Jiao S's sword was about to reach its target, a long and slender arm appeared to block it!

I was upset about this sudden turn of events. Looking at the jade stone ring on that hand, I knew who it was immediately!

Jiao S's head tilted, doubt apparent in those big eyes of hers.

I looked at Ta Lai, who was now in between Jiao S and I. "I don't understand what's happening now. You're stopping us when she's here to kill your lover, Bian Ying? What're you trying to do?"

Ta Lai had that composed smile on his face as he pushed Jiao S's sword down with his MF. "Because she isn't here to kill Bian Ying."

Not here to kill Bian Ying?

That's right, why didn't I think of this. Although Du Yue hates Bian Ying, why would she suddenly want to kill her if she didn't hurt her in all these years? Also, this territory in the Gate of Ghost doesn't belong to her either.

If so, then why did she come here to the Gate of Ghost?

As I was lost in my thoughts, Du Yue let go of Shen Qi. Without her grabbing the tip of the sword, Gaoqin Jiuye and I naturally stepped backwards. Jiao S retreated to my side as Ta Lai had also let go of her sword.

Bian Ying walked up, looking at Ta Lai with unfathomable eyes, not saying a word.

I thought there would be a change in Ta Lai when he saw Bian Ying, but he looked as calm and composed as ever. It seemed like he didn't even take one look at Bian Ying.

I was confused at this. Even if Du Yue wasn't here to kill Bian Ying, Ta Lai still shouldn't be on Du Yue's side. Or is this because he wants to take my other personality, and he'll work with whoever can help him do so?

Du Yue was fearless with Ta Lai around. "Gaoqin Jiuye, I'm sure you've also heard of that cave where Cang Ming was headed. Looking at how much time has passed, he's probably not gone too deep into it. It's also

likely he doesn't know what's happening yet. You just might be able to save him if you can find the cave and find him soon."

Her cunning eyes were full of malice. "You might not care about whether he lives or dies, and you might think that he and Nie Zun would think of a way to escape from that cave, but don't forget that Guan Nie and Si Luo are both with them now, and they're both not conscious. Even if Cang Ming can save Guan Nie, he won't be able to wake Si Luo. What do you think is the probability of those three escaping from that cave with another person who's as good as dead?"

Jiao S stared at Gaoqin Jiuye after she heard Du Yue. "Why did you bring Si Luo in? You know very well that only Yu Liang can save Si Luo now, so why did you still do that?"

Gaoqin Jiuye's eyes darkened. "It's not that I did it, it's just that the air currents near that cave were extremely uneven, and it's different from that in the Eastern, Southern and Western Districts. I wasn't able to control the air vortex that carried Si Luo well enough, and when I let Si Luo out, they just suddenly got sucked into that cave."

Du Yue smirked. "Of course you'd think that was sudden. It was all planned by me. You haven't forgotten that you were never able to win me, right?"

Gaoqin Jiuye did not respond.

I felt a little indignant at this. *When did Gaoqin Jiuye become like this?*

Where did that arrogance go? Why was he such a coward in front of Du Yue?!

I stared at Gaoqin Jiuye angrily, but he simply looked into the distance as if he was in deep thought. *Why is he daydreaming at such a moment!*

Du Yue gained confidence as she saw Gaoqin Jiuye's expression. "Well, you just might be able to save them if you go look for them now and stop them from going further into that cave."

Jiao S interrupted Du Yue. “If you’re talking so much even after planning all this perfectly, I’m guessing you probably didn’t expect for Gaoqin Jiuye to be able to escape and return here. You’re doing all this to divert his attention, right? You’re not here for Bian Ying, you’re here for Ah Shen.”

Chapter 175

175 Gaoqin Falls into a Trap

Du Yue raised her brows with interest . “Quite intelligent, but you didn’t get everything right . It’s not that I didn’t expect Gaoqin Jiuye to be able to escape from the trap, and I did anticipate that he’ll help you out, so everything is still going according to plan . ”

She looked at me with a smirk . “I did all this because I wanted you to see for yourself how Gaoqin Jiuye would make his decision . ”

Du Yue seemed to love doing things like this .

I knew what she was getting at .

Looking at the situation now, Du Yue definitely didn’t come here for Bian Ying . If her target wasn’t Bian Ying, then it was me . Though I don’t know why she’d be targeting me, since Ta Lai is now on her side, I have reason to believe that they’ve agreed on working together for now .

No matter what the truth was, if they wanted to capture me alive, they’d have to divert the attention of two others – Nie Zun and Gaoqin Jiuye .

With Nie Zun in that cave, only Jiao S and Gaoqin Jiuye were left by my side . Since Bian Ying wasn’t able to fight, their victory would depend on Gaoqin Jiuye’s decision .

She then used the trump card at this point – Si Luo .

Both Du Yue and I knew that Gaoqin Jiuye would not hesitate to choose Si Luo no matter what happens . Even though I wasn’t related to Gaoqin Jiuye

in any way, the reason Du Yue planned this was to let me have a taste of being abandoned . Anyone would feel a little down if they were not chosen .

That feeling of being let down would then put me at a disadvantage in the ensuing battle .

This woman was a cruel character . If Gaoqin Jiuye did love her once, his feelings for her would probably have dissipated by now . But I told myself that I should not be sympathizing with Gaoqin Jiuye .

“Gaoqin, the longer you wait, the higher the chance of Si Luo being in danger . Aren’t you going?” Du Yue looked at Gaoqin Jiuye smugly .

Even though I knew his answer, I didn’t want to hear him say it . Therefore, I spoke before he could say anything, “Go, Jiao S and I are here, it’ll be fine .”

Gaoqin Jiuye looked at me with troubled eyes before finally handing Shen Qi to me . “Take him, he’ll protect you .”

Du Yue’s eyes widened at this . Seems like Shen Qi had never once left Gaoqin Jiuye’s side .

But I was selfish about this, since he still chose Si Luo in the end . I smiled as I pushed his hand away . “I’m not so weak that I need others to protect me . Even if I did, I just need Nie Zun . Just go, help me get Nie Zun back .”

I didn’t know why I had to say something like this, why I had to mention Nie Zun . It was as if I knew this name could hurt him, and it definitely worked .

The hesitation in Gaoqin Jiuye’s eyes faded, and after looking at me for a few moments, he took Shen Qi and leapt up into the water above us .

I took a deep breath, feeling a little upset at this .

That’s right, this was my choice . We were fated to be on opposite sides from the beginning, everything was already decided from the moment you

decided to make use of me, so don't ever change in the future . You and I shall go on our separate paths . If you don't have mercy for any others, then don't have mercy towards me either . Apart from Nie Zun, there's nobody else I trust and rely on, not even you .

Let's be on opposing sides forever .

“Are you sad? Hah, have you fallen in love with Gaoqin?” Du Yue asked with interest .

I answered coldly, “Enough with the small talk, you can tell us your goal now . I never thought you were such a person, Ta Lai . Not only did you hurt Nie Zun, you're even working together with Du Yue now . Why are you doing this!”

Right at this moment, Ta Lai glanced at Bian Ying .

Du Yue seemed a little upset by it . “Obviously it's because he thinks that I'm the only one who can give him what he wants right now . Is a mere heir like you trying to meddle in the affairs of soul splitters now? What you should do right now is to pray that you'll come out of this alive!”

I smirked . “I really don't know just why Gaoqin Jiuye liked you . ”

I smirked . “I really don't know just why Gaoqin Jiuye liked you . ”

Ta Lai spoke suddenly, “Li Shen, I'm sure you know the reason I approached you . Are you willing to give your personality to Bian Ying?”

“Do you even need to ask?”

Ta Lai moved the jade stone ring on his finger . “As a mark of respect, I'll still have to ask . Since you're unwilling, I'll have to use force . ”

Bian Ying stepped forward . “I don't know if you're ignoring me, or if you don't have the guts to look me in the eye . Lai, even if I die, I'll never be able to accept this . How could you do something like this?”

Ta Lai finally looked at Bian Ying . His eyes were shining with a gentle light .

Everyone saw how he looked at her, and Du Yue saw it too . Her right fist slowly balled up into a fist .

I suddenly wanted to laugh at this .

These soul splitters treat human lives like they were nothing, and they're trying to look for love that exists between human beings?

Ta Lai said to Bian Ying, "There were many things that you wouldn't do and couldn't accept, but you still accepted them in the end . So why is it different when it comes to me?"

Bian Ying bit her lip .

I understood Ta Lai . He was jealous that Bian Ying could accept Cang Ming, that she could stay by his side and even fall in love with him . Ta Lai, upset at this, decided to give it his all . But he was met with Bian Ying's rejection even when he gave his all, so he'll definitely feel jealous .

Sadly, he didn't understand this .

I said to Jiao S, "Jiao, go help Gaoqin Jiuye and look for Si Luo and the others . I know you're worried about him too . "

I said to Jiao S, "Jiao, go help Gaoqin Jiuye and look for Si Luo and the others . I know you're worried about him too . "

Jiao S shook her head vehemently . "No, Si Luo won't die that easily . Since Gaoqin Jiuye is on his way, there's no reason for me to be there too . I'll stay with you here . "

I sighed inwardly as I saw her resolute gaze . I originally wanted to make her leave, but it was too impractical of me .

"Ta Lai . " I smiled at him . "You're right . It's true that Cang Ming has been forcing Bian Ying to do things that she doesn't want to, but Cang

Ming does all of it for Bian Ying . ”

Ta Lai stopped turning the jade stone ring on his finger as he answered, “And I’m not doing all this for her?”

I glanced at Du Yue . As expected, she was visibly more upset now .

“You’re doing everything for her too . But Cang Ming had only hurt himself, while you have only been hurting others . ” I said all this very directly .

Bian Ying interrupted me, “Li Shen, there’s no need to speak with him anymore . I’ll never let him take you away . ”

Du Yue smirked . “I’m afraid that’s not up to you to decide . ”

She snapped her fingers .

Ta Lai looked surprised at this, and he reached out to stop Du Yue . Du Yue stared at him . “Are you still going to waste more time? Don’t you want to save her?”

Ta Lai then paused .

The water floating above us suddenly fell, flooding the entire space .

I didn’t expect Du Yue to do this, and I was swimming around frantically in the next second . This water felt exactly like water in the real world, and I had to hold my breath and swim in it .

Visibly was low, but I seemed to feel Jiao S holding my hand . As I focused my MF and tried to swim upwards to the surface, the water around me started to close in .

I didn’t expect Du Yue to do this, and I was swimming around frantically in the next second . This water felt exactly like water in the real world, and I had to hold my breath and swim in it .

Visibly was low, but I seemed to feel Jiao S holding my hand . As I focused my MF and tried to swim upwards to the surface, the water around me started to close in .

A pain shot through the hand that Jiao S was holding . It was a hundred times more painful than getting my limbs cut off, and I retracted my hand quickly . I couldn't see anything around me anymore .

The water seemed to be pressing down on me . I felt like a submarine which had already reached its crush depth, as if I was about to be compressed by the great water pressure all around me .

I told myself to stay calm . I wasn't the old Li Shen anymore .

I held my breath and refocused my MF . But I wasn't able to control it . My MF was swimming all over the place within my body . I tried my best to forcefully focus it on the Scorpion Ray on my left hand .

My surroundings were finally lit up as Scorpion Ray produced a dazzling light in the water .

Du Yue was in the middle of all this water, right in front of me . She was floating in a weird position with her eyes closed .

I got it! She was using her MF to control the water!

The water was now an extension of her limbs, and she was using MF to fight us .

Under the immense water pressure, I turned to my left with great difficulty, only to see Ta Lai appear in front of Jiao S, who was on my left!

The hand with that jade stone ring was on Jiao S's neck!

Jiao S's black hair was floating in the water, like a bunch of seaweed . Her eyes were wide open, as if there was no other way she could fight back .

Looking to my right, Bian Ying seemed to have already passed out . She looked like she was lying down with her eyes closed as she sank .

I was in a dilemma . If I help Jiao S, Bian Ying would continue sinking . If I help Bian Ying, Jiao S might be in danger .

Chapter 176

176 Mr Blond Appears?

I was sure that Ta Lai would not let Bian Ying die, and with Jiao S's abilities, she should be able to hold her own against Ta Lai . But then again, it was still Du Yue who controlled all this water . How should I choose...

Holding my breath, I decided to swim towards Bian Ying . I believed in Jiao S . I will not let Du Yue get her way, and I'm confident of my plan .

Du Yue seemed to have sensed my movement as I swam towards Bian Ying . I smirked . She must have thought that I would choose Jiao S, but I wouldn't fall into her trap like Gaoqin Jiuye!

The water pressure suddenly increased as I was almost by Bian Ying's side! Gritting my teeth, I pulled Piercer out!

Surprisingly, there was no resistance this time when I focused my MF on Piercer! Piercer seemed to be built for use in the water, as it swung gracefully towards Bian Ying with a flick of my wrist!

Du Yue opened her eyes as she realized what I was trying to do!

I smirked . There's no way I'll let her get her way! The force broke through the water pressure and Piercer was almost about to reach Bian Ying when all of a sudden, Ta Lai let go of Jiao S and grabbed Piercer with an outstretched hand!

Du Yue spit out a mouthful of blood! The blood disappeared in the water just as quickly .

I heaved an inward sigh of relief at this . It worked!

Bian Ying's consciousness was absorbed by Piercer once, and no matter what, Ta Lai will never let Piercer come in contact with her a second time!

Since the water was controlled by Du Yue, she was able to use it to attack us and also help Ta Lai attack Jiao S . However, when I whipped Piercer towards Bian Ying, Ta Lai would break the balance in the water to stop Piercer . When that balance was broken; Du Yue would get hurt indirectly!

Ta Lai looked enraged as he held Piercer in a tight grip . Bian Ying stopped sinking and she was now just floating in the water looking like she was asleep .

Probably because she got hurt, Du Yue lost her control over the water for a few seconds! There was no way that Jiao S and I would let these precious few seconds go to waste!

I heard crackling sounds nearby and it sounded like water being instantly frozen into ice!

Yes! There was air in the water too, and wherever there's air, Jiao S could take control of it!

The water and air rapidly wrapped itself around Du Yue, and in mere seconds, Du Yue was encased in ice! She looked like an ice sculpture floating in the water with a peculiar pose!

I pulled Piercer back towards me at this moment . As Ta Lai was pulled in my direction, I put my left hand in his face!

The light of Scorpion Ray pierced into Ta Lai's eyes . He couldn't dodge it as the MF in Piercer held him tight!

Ta Lai shut his eyes at Scorpion Ray's attack, and he would probably not be able to open them anytime soon . I clapped my palms together and focused my MF as I thought inwardly to Scorpion Ray to trap him!

Though I wasn't confident that I would succeed, after going through some battles, I knew that MF was just the manifestation our mental ability, that is,

the power we have in our hearts . So theoretically, we could use whatever power we wanted to as long as we could think of it, and it would all depend on whether we were able to persevere through it!

As I was thinking about this, I saw Scorpion Ray produce a few rays of light . That light looked like soft tentacles as they wrapped themselves around Ta Lai!

Scorpion Ray continued producing rays of light that looked as fine as silk, wrapping Ta Lai up tightly . Before long, he looked like a giant silkworm with his face partially obscured!

Even I was surprised at this . I could use Scorpion Ray like this?! There's really no better way than engaging in real battle if I want to practice manipulating my MF well .

Focusing my MF, I cut off that silky light . Ta Lai was simply floating in the water now, all wrapped up .

At this moment, Du Yue, Ta Lai and Bian Ying were all floating in the water, none of them moving . As I was about to celebrate, I saw Jiao S's worried look .

What's she worried about?

As I asked myself this question, I heard a cracking sound from the frozen Du Yue .

As I asked myself this question, I heard a cracking sound from the frozen Du Yue .

Since the water was an extension of Du Yue's power, if there was still water around, this meant that her power had not been entirely frozen!

Jiao S's gaze tightened, and the water around her started swirling like a whirlpool!

She looked at me and pointed somewhere above her head! I understood her immediately, and I swam upwards as quickly as I could!

She wanted to freeze the entire body of water! Only then could she freeze Du Yue's power!

Focusing my MF on my limbs, I leapt out of the water like a lively fish!

"Pch...!" I spat out a mouthful of water as I broke through the surface . Looking around, it was still the same forest and river . I felt the water under my feet beginning to freeze . I whipped Piercer against the water below me, using its force to leap out of the water!

Water continued dripping down my dress as I reached the riverbank . The river was now entirely frozen, and its entire surface was ice .

There was nothing but silence .

I wiped the water off my face . What do I do now? Jiao S seemed to have frozen everyone, including herself under the water .

What should I do next?!

My mind was in a flurry, and I didn't even realize there was somebody behind me!

I felt pain as the needle was inserted into my shoulder, and before passing out, all I could see was a yellow figure as I turned around!

This felt different from fainting in the real world . In the Split Zone, the consciousness enters another space as we pass out, as if we were entering a dream . That space might be found deep within our souls, where it was possible to recall lost memories, or it might be a space controlled by somebody else, just like Old Man Fan's spatial transference technique . Or, it could also be an illusion technique that affects the consciousness, creating an imaginary space as a result .

Darkness slowly overcame me .

Darkness slowly overcame me .

It seemed as if I was falling into an endless abyss, and all I could hear was the wind blowing past my ears as I continued to drop . I could not move, and there was nothing I could do to resist . I tried to open my eyes, but I wasn't even in control of my body .

After what seemed like a long fall, I felt a sudden cold wind .

I shut my eyes almost immediately after I pried them open, blinded by a bright light . I had to open and shut my eyes several times before I could finally see the surroundings clearly .

I sat up, shocked at what I saw .

I took another look at my surroundings again . This is... the Great Hall! Why was I back here in the Great Hall?!

“Surprised? You're back here again . ”

A familiar voice sounded from behind me . I haven't heard this voice in a long time .

I was absolutely stunned .

The Great Hall was empty as usual, and its stone floor felt cold under my palms .

“Why don't you turn around if you can recognize my voice, Ah Shen . ”

Like a puppet moving at its master's command, I turned back slowly .

Looking up, I saw a face that could only belong to someone of mixed heritage . Those shining, blue-green eyes dazzled lazily like sapphire under sunlight, and that head of bright golden hair looked just like a golden nugget in the middle of this Great Hall .

The figure was dressed simply in white .

“Blo... Mr Blond...” I said with trembling lips . This was too shocking!

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“Blo... Mr Blond...” I said with trembling lips . This was too shocking!

Looking at how stumped I was, he laughed mischievously and bent down to meet my eyes . “This isn’t the first time you’ve seen me . Do you have to be this surprised?”

Of course I’m surprised! You’ve been missing for so long! Though I had many questions, I was at a loss for words!

Mr Blond smoothed my hair, as if he already anticipated such a reaction from me . “You’re not actually in the Great Hall now . Since you passed out, I had the opportunity to take your consciousness here while it was at its weakest . We don’t have much time, and forgive me for not being able to answer all of your questions right now . There’s something more important you have to know . ”

He grabbed my shoulders, turning me around entirely .

“Look . ” My back was against him now .

I saw the screen that was always in the Great Hall as I looked in the direction he indicated . The screen was originally empty and gray, but it lit up slowly as I looked at it, as if a movie was about to start .

A scene then started playing on screen, and it got clearer as it continued playing .

My eyes widened slowly as I watched . I felt Mr Blond’s lips close to my ear . “This is the current situation in the Eastern, Western and Southern Districts . These aren’t illusions . ”

Still against the stone floor, my hands started shivering .

“No, it can’t be . This is an illusion...” I muttered .

Mr Blond gripped my shoulders with more strength, and his voice seemed to waver as he said, “I’m not lying... Ah Shen, as the leader of the entire

Split Zone, would I play such a prank on you...”

“Impossible! How can this be!” I stared at the scene playing on screen, unable to tear my gaze away .

Mr Blond sighed . “I know . This is close to impossible . But, this is the truth...”

Chapter 177

177 You are the Key

There were three separate scenes playing on screen, showing the situation in the Eastern, Western and Southern District respectively .

The Southern District was a pile of rubble as monsters continued to prowl and look for ordinary residents to swallow or tear apart .

The entire S Clan in the Eastern District was battling a huge group of monsters, but it was obvious that they were grossly outnumbered .

As for the Western District..., Jie Pa and the floor managers were in the midst of battle . Chou Yu and the Yuan siblings never left Jie Pa's side, protecting him during the fight . Tao Lie and Mu Li were also in the Western District helping us out, but everyone looked exhausted . There was no way they could win if it was a long-drawn battle .

The last time I felt such fear and horror was when I saw the Western District turn into a pile of rubble . This time, I sat rooted to the ground as I took everything in .

I couldn't believe what I saw . A massacre was occurring in all three districts, and these places were supposed to be under the command of me, Jiao S and Si Luo . I wasn't able to do anything but watch as it went on .

“What's happening?!”

With everything that had happened thus far, I thought I would be able to stay calm no matter what happened . But this was too horrific to bear .

Mr Blond gripped my shoulders, preventing me from turning around . I heard him say, “This is the truth, neither of us can stop it now . Du Yue’s third experiment has succeeded in changing many heirs, and among those mutant heirs, some of them are able to cause permanent damage to the consciousness, and cause permanent wounds that will never heal...”

“Impossible!” I screamed . My nails scraped against the stone floor so hard that blood seeped out as they broke .

“There’s nothing that’s impossible... Du Yue is only helping that person destroy the Eastern, Western and Southern Districts... In order to save you, Laurel brought with her that spatial transference snake to swallow you up, bringing you to the Northern District – the only safe haven left now . All the others will die today...”

Mr Blond lifted a slender finger as he pointed at the people on screen .

“No!” I screamed till my voice was hoarse . Balling my hands up into fists, I stood up and turned to look at Mr Blond . “Tell me how to go back, I want to go back!”

Mr Blond was still crouched on the ground, and he looked at the floor as he said, “What’s the use of going back? Are you able to save them with your abilities? This plan has been in place for a long time, even before you arrived here in the Split Zone . Even I’m being held in this cave within the Gate of Ghost now . Li Shen, how are you able to save all of them alone?”

Trembling, I turned to meet his eyes . Touching his face with my bloodied fingers, I said, “What did you say... Who can trap you? Don’t lie to me, you’re the leader here...”

My voice was trembling, and my eyes were already wet with tears .

Sorrow flashed past Mr Blond’s sapphire eyes . “Ah Shen, what do you think a leader is? I’m just a puppet . Originally, there were only two areas in the Split Zone – the residential area and the area belonging to the soul splitters . I took more than a thousand years to create the Eastern, Western

and Southern Districts to let these heirs live in a more dignified manner . But all this will come to naught...”

“No, it wouldn’t! You’re lying!” I continued screaming .

“No, it wouldn’t! You’re lying!” I continued screaming .

Mr Blond’s gaze turned cold . “Ah Shen, don’t cry . You have no right to cry . Both Nie Zun and your good friend, Jiao S, will survive this, so what are you upset about? If you’re telling me that you’re crying for these innocent residents, then you’re wrong . Even in the real world, we don’t have time to worry about the life and death of others, so you should be more selfish here in the Split Zone!”

My face was drenched in tears now . Looking at Mr Blond, I said, “What? Mr Blond, don’t you love these residents? You said it yourself, that you were the one who created the Eastern, Western and Southern Districts to protect these powerless people . Why are you telling me to be selfish now?!”

Mr Blond shot a cold glance at me . “I’m doing it for you, Li Shen . Think, why are you here in the Split Zone?! Li Qing and I were wrong from the beginning . We let you become district commander not for you to protect these people, but for them to protect you! You think that Li Qing wasn’t selfish? She liked you, and she saw her past self in you . This is why she was always being considerate, and she even gave you that bow!”

I was momentarily stunned . I then started laughing . “Mr Blond, are you kidding? For me? Who do you think you guys are?! Why do you always say it’s all for me?! Like what you said, there’s no one who isn’t selfish here in the Split Zone, so why do all this for me? What right do I have to receive such honor?!”

Mr Blond took my chin in his hand, forcing me to look at those unsmiling eyes . “You have the right, because you’re the key to everything . I know this is all very sudden and it’s hard for you to take in everything at once, but Li Shen, this is the Split Zone, this is the truth . Even if it was someone I

was protecting for years, as long as they're lowly heirs, their lives can be taken anytime by soul splitters!"

"What... did you say?" I looked at him with teary eyes .

His eyes were gleaming . "Ah Shen, this isn't heaven, it's hell . Don't forget that fact because you've been here for too long . You chose to come here because you couldn't accept the person who was in you; you arrived here because you gave up on your own life, just like the others . Soul splitters will never have any opportunity if you didn't first give up on yourselves in the first place . Since all of you have chosen this place, you'll have to go through the punishment here, unless you have the ability to leave . "

He stood up slowly, looking down at me . "This wasn't what I wanted to tell you today, but if you're not able to be ruthless and remain impassive, you'll never be able to see what the real Split Zone is like, and you'll never be able to survive here . Li Shen, the Eastern, Western and Southern Districts are bound to be destroyed, and there might be the possibility that the only heirs left would be the ones who journeyed with you to the Northern District . Tell me, what will you do in such a situation?"

Kneeling on the floor like an abandoned puppet, I didn't know how to answer .

Kneeling on the floor like an abandoned puppet, I didn't know how to answer .

Mr Blond is right, what should I do...

"Think about it, Li Shen . Am I wrong? Why did you come to the Northern District? Do you still remember your initial goal? You wanted to save Laurel, then Yu Liang and Song Lu, and that brought you here . Though Laurel is being controlled now, her humanity is still intact and she brought all of you here to save you guys . Everyone you want to save is still alive, so what right do you have to cry? You guys are the lucky ones who were chosen to be alive . "

Huh, chosen to be alive? If someone had to decide my life and death, then what's the point of being alive at all?

“Enough . Just what are you trying to say?” I heard my impassive voice ring through the empty Great Hall . I looked up at Mr Blond with a wintry gaze .

A smile then slowly appeared on Mr Blond's face . “Du Yue is working under the orders of somebody else . The aim of her experiment is to find a way to destroy all heirs . Once all heirs are gone, the soul splitters will not have any corresponding heirs left . Even with a split symbol, there'd be no way to undo the split symbol contract . ”

“Don't soul splitters wish for that? They trap heirs in the Split Zone so that their split symbol contract will not be undone?”

Mr Blond nodded . “That's right, and because of that, it only further proves the importance of heirs . Without any one party, the split symbol contract doesn't work . If a large number of heirs die, this would mean that there would also be a large number of soul splitters with split symbol contracts that can never be undone .

“Soul splitters can look for new heirs if the old heir returned to the real world . But since these heirs died in the Split Zone of unnatural causes, their corresponding soul splitters will lose half of their split symbol, and they'll definitely die in a limited time . ”

Though I was still upset at what I just saw, I knew how serious this was . I stood up, waiting for him to continue .

Seeing me calm down, he continued, “When a large number of heirs die, there will be a time limit placed on all the lives of their soul splitters . Apart from those who planned this, of course, because they've already trapped their corresponding heirs in the Northern District . You'll then have a chance to destroy the Split Zone and leave this place when the soul splitters are no longer immortal . ”

Though I was still upset at what I just saw, I knew how serious this was . I stood up, waiting for him to continue .

Seeing me calm down, he continued, “When a large number of heirs die, there will be a time limit placed on all the lives of their soul splitters . Apart from those who planned this, of course, because they’ve already trapped their corresponding heirs in the Northern District . You’ll then have a chance to destroy the Split Zone and leave this place when the soul splitters are no longer immortal . ”

I looked him in the eye as I asked slowly, “Why do I feel that by telling me all this, you’re actually trying to destroy the Split Zone, including the soul splitters?”

Mr Blond seemed to smile . “That isn’t important . What’s important is that you protect those who’re left and take them away from this place . ”

“Do I even have the ability to do so?”

He smiled . “Not in the past . But now, soul splitters will no longer be immortal . So, what are you afraid of? Also, I haven’t told you the most important thing . ”

I was a little uneasy at this . If he wanted to tell me something important, then it must be related to me in some way .

Mr Blond continued speaking even though I remained silent, since it was what he wanted to tell me in the first place .

“The most important thing is that, although soul splitters without their heirs would no longer be immortal, the splitting keys of their heirs would also be gone . Apart from natural deaths caused by the peeling of the split symbol after a certain period of time without a heir, you are the only person who can kill them . ”

Chapter 178

178 Li Wen's Scheme

“What do you mean I’m the only person who can kill them...”

Before I could ask further questions, the Great Hall started quaking, as if there was a sudden earthquake .

Mr Blond looked around . “Seems like it’s time . Li Shen, you have two tasks after waking up . The first is to take control of Piercer . I know that it’s difficult, but you cannot let Piercer devour you . The second is to save Si Luo, he cannot die...”

The Great Hall started collapsing before Mr Blond could finish .

Don’t go, I haven’t finished with all my questions!

Where are you, how do I save you, who trapped you? Is Li Qing still alive? Where is she?

How do I go back to the Western District? What should I do? Why does it have to be me? Why am I the only one who can kill soul splitters? How do I kill them?

And also, why do I have to kill soul splitters... I don’t want to kill anyone...

“Wait!” I reached out a desperate hand in an attempt to grab hold of Mr Blond, who was now being buried deep within the collapsing Great Hall . With a gleam in his eyes, he pushed me backwards!

Once again, I fell into an endless abyss of darkness . There was nothing but the sound of the wind blowing past my ears .

“Ah—!” I woke up screaming .

“You’re awake . ”

I looked towards the source of this gentle voice .

There were traces of green moss all over the walls in this place . It seemed to be some sort of cave .

I was lying on a bed of grass .

The voice came from somewhere near the entrance of the cave . It was extremely bright outside, and I could not recognize the figure walking in .

Focusing my MF on my vision, I took a clearer look at the figure . She was in a pale yellow chiffon dress . Her hair framed her rosy cheeks, and her eyes were filled with emotion .

“Li Wen...” I muttered .

Hearing me call her name, she walked towards me with a beautiful smile .

“Ah Shen . ”

Her smile was gentle and her pace steady, as if we were still close friends who spent all day together .

Sadly, my head is clearer than ever now that I’ve woken up .

As I recalled what happened, I realized it was Li Wen who attacked me by that riverbank, and she brought me here while I was unconscious .

I turned cold . “Are you a soul splitter from the Gate of Ghost too? Why did you bring me here?”

I was already sitting up as Li Wen sat down beside me .

She was fiddling with the ends of that chiffon dress . “Me? I’m not someone from the Gate of Ghost . I come from the Gate of Exit . I’m sure you know that the Gate of Exit is just beside the Gate of Ghost, on its right .”

Gate of Exit?

I suddenly remembered – Heaven, Ghost . If Si Luo and Gaoqin Jiuye were from the Gate of Heaven previously, then are the soul splitters there kind? But, why did they leave the Gate of Heaven? Was it because of Du Yue and Ta Lai?

The Gate of Ghost obviously sounded like it was populated with villains .

The Gate of Exit...

Why did I not wonder about its name before? (T/n: The Chinese character used for ‘Exit’ here is li, the same character as the li in ‘Li Wen’ .)

Don’t tell me... I looked at her . “Are you the ruler of the soul splitters in the Gate of Exit?”

Li Wen laughed in response . “Ah Shen, you think too highly of me .”

Li Wen laughed in response . “Ah Shen, you think too highly of me .”

“I am...” She looked at the chiffon dress in her hand . “I’m just a loyal dog...”

Loyal dog?

I couldn’t believe this was something Li Wen would say, much less use to describe herself .

For whatever reason it was, I knew that I didn’t want her pouring her heart out to me right now, and I didn’t want to hear her talk about what happened .

I didn't want to pity her because of what she might tell me, nor was I in the mood to forgive anyone right now .

The Western District was destroyed right in front of my eyes . Why should I sympathize with these people who abandoned the Western District, these people who abandoned me?

I changed the subject abruptly, "Where's Song Lu?"

Li Wen stopped fiddling with her dress . "Seems like Song Lu is the only one you care about . Of course, since you were the closest to her when we still had fun together in the past . "

I smirked . "I was the closest to her? Li Wen, have you forgotten that it was actually you and You Ji who spent the most time with me? Among the two of you, you were the closest to me . But in the end? The both of you..."

My heart hurt at that thought . "Forget it . You Ji is already dead, I shouldn't be talking about her like that . "

Li Wen grabbed my hand suddenly .

"What did you say? You Ji is dead?"

I shot her a cold look . "Yes, dead . She was tortured to death, by Du Yue . Are you happy now? Li Wen, you guys are really cruel . Soul splitters are really cruel . "

I said that last phrase with gritted teeth .

Grieve flashed past Li Wen's eyes, but she regained her composure just as quickly .

The smile which momentarily disappeared had reappeared on her face . "This is the Split Zone, Ah Shen . Have you only realized it now, that I'm cruel and ruthless? I'd be dead if I wasn't cruel and ruthless!"

The smile which momentarily disappeared had reappeared on her face . "This is the Split Zone, Ah Shen . Have you only realized it now, that I'm

cruel and ruthless? I'd be dead if I wasn't cruel and ruthless!"

Her gentle smile turned into a resolute one .

I loosened my hand from her grip . "Seems like there really is no need for me to say anything more . Let's just cut to the chase, why did you bring me here?"

She smiled . "We're sisters, so of course I'll help you out . "

"Shut up!" I stared at her . "You're not my sister! I said it on that day when you took Song Lu away, that we'll no longer be related in any way from then on!"

Though my emotions were in a mess, I tried not to show any weakness . I can't lose . From now onwards, I cannot lose even once, I cannot afford to lose anymore .

Li Wen didn't seem to mind what I said as she continued calmly, "Ah Shen, you can't choose and decide on things alone . I've brought you here because I really want to help you . I'll tell you the truth . The Eastern, Western and Southern Districts have already been destroyed by Du Yue . "

I froze .

She looked at me . "I know you might not believe what I say, because I wouldn't either . But it's the truth . You have to believe me no matter what . You're lucky enough to come out alive in this massacre, and what you have to do next is of utmost importance . "

She probably thought I froze because I didn't believe a single word she said .

But in reality, Mr Blond had already told me everything . I was a little surprised at this, that I was the only one who was aware of what he had told me, including the fact that he was still alive . Though it made no sense, knowing this made me feel just a little bit safer .

If Li Wen knew everything, and everyone except me knew the truth, it would have been too terrifying .

Seeing me silent, Li Wen was a little edgy . “Ah Shen, I’m telling you the truth . Du Yue has succeeded in her third experiment . She brought with her mutant heirs to the Southern District, causing all the heirs outside of the Northern District to face total destruction . The path leading to the Northern District from the Southern District has also been destroyed, and there’s no way we can go back there ever again . You can’t go back to the Western District anymore . ”

I asked calmly, “Then, why am I here in the Northern District, and how do you know all this?”

She was visibly surprised, as if she did not expect me to be this calm .

She then smiled . “I don’t know the reasons behind it, but I always knew you were a special one . Since I met you here in the Gate of Ghost, I knew that you survived the catastrophe . As for all that destruction that’s happening, any soul splitter in the Northern District would know about it, so how could I not be aware?”

I looked at her with a piercing gaze . “According to what you’ve said, you didn’t know if I had escaped . If so, why did you come here to the Gate of Ghost instead of simply staying on in the Gate of Exit?”

Her eyes narrowed slightly . “I’m here to look for someone . ”

I looked at her with a piercing gaze . “According to what you’ve said, you didn’t know if I had escaped . If so, why did you come here to the Gate of Ghost instead of simply staying on in the Gate of Exit?”

Her eyes narrowed slightly . “I’m here to look for someone . ”

“Who?”

A mysterious smile appeared on her face . “Originally, I wanted to look for a soul splitter named Bian Ying . But little did I expect that you’d actually

be able to escape from that apocalypse and arrive in the Northern District . ”

She leaned in close . “But I’m just overjoyed to be able to see you, because it’s so much better that you’re alive . And this means I won’t have to look for that Bian Ying anymore...”

Alright, no matter how dumb I might be, I finally understood some things now .

If what Mr Blond said was true, then I had some sort of power that could kill soul splitters, and that ability might have something to do with the existence of my other personality . Because of this, Li Wen wanted to look for someone like me, that is, Bian Ying . But since she met me, there’s no need for her to look for Bian Ying anymore, because I can be her weapon .

Seems like the world of soul splitters would still be chaotic without the existence of heirs .

Are the three factions of soul splitters actually going to engage in war? But no matter what their goal is, I had no interest in being a pawn . Want to make use of me? Dream on .

I’ve made a decision . I’ll leave with Song Lu right after I save her . Thinking about this, I suddenly thought of something else . Yu Liang?!

Yu Liang is still in the Western District?! How do I save Si Luo like this??

No, I didn’t see Yu Liang on the screen previously!

Who took him away? I tried to calm myself down . I had some bargaining power now that I’m a weapon that soul splitters can make use of .

“What do you need me to do?” I asked finally .

Li Wen seemed pleased as she said cheerily, “I never get tired when I talk to you, Ah Shen . This is what I like about you . ”

I smirked and interrupted her, “There’ll come one day when you’ll feel an immense pressure just with me being around . ”

Chapter 179

179 Meditation and Cultivation

Li Wen did not argue in the face of my callous response .

Well, that joyous mood would hardly be dented even if her pet scratched her a little, since that pet would be able to win a battle for her .

“What I want you to do is simple . You’ll just need to stay here and I’ll help you with your training . ”

Training? I wanted to laugh at this . Why did everyone want to help me train? Before this, it was Ta Lai, now, it was Li Wen . Did I really possess some sort of hidden great power?

“And you’re not telling me the reason why you’re doing this? What’s your goal?” There was no need for me to take a roundabout approach, since we were already being so frank .

Li Wen smoothed her skirt . “You wouldn’t believe it even if I told you I didn’t have a goal . People are always like this . The wife would never believe it even if her husband was loyal, and she’d make a big fuss over it . But if her husband really had a mistress and admitted he was wrong, then she might just let it go . ”

“Enough with the bullshit . ”

“I’m being honest . I don’t have any goal . If you want me to just say something that can be considered a goal, then this might probably be a little hobby of mine . ”

Li Wen flashed an arrogant smile . “Me, I love to see things liven up . So I really hope to see the Gate of Ghost in a mess . Everyone in the Gate of Ghost would probably quake in fear if I can force that person out of you successfully . ”

My heart dropped .

As expected, she was the target all this time? It’s no wonder she said he was looking for her when I heard her the first time while training with Ta Lai .

Seems like no one else knows I can see her with my split symbol activated, and that she isn’t always by my side .

But even if she was by my side, I didn’t feel any different . My power and abilities were the same as before, so why are they all looking for her?

“You’re talking about my second personality?” I asked carefully, trying to get more information out of Li Wen .

“Yes, that personality you’re supposed to be closest to, but have forgotten about . ”

“Why are you guys looking for her?”

Li Wen looked at me with an impenetrable gaze . “It’s a secret, I can’t tell you that . ”

I was sure I didn’t look too happy at this .

I decided not to ask any further . Li Wen was a crafty one, and I’d never be able to get any information from her if it was something she wasn’t willing to share . I didn’t have the skills to force her to come clean nor did I have anything I could intimidate her with .

She reached out, taking my hand in hers gently . “Anyway, you have to believe me, Ah Shen . I’ll never hurt you as long as you do what I tell you to . You’ll obtain power others can only dream of having . I hope you’ll be able to defeat the ones who hurt you in the Gate of Ghost, and those who hurt your friends . I’ll also return Song Lu to you . ”

Hah, of course . Your eventual aim is to go against those in the Gate of Ghost .

I found this rather amusing . I was always that crazy, ostracized person when I was alive, and now that I'm braindead, I'm forced to become this useless district commander in this godforsaken place . Now, I've become a weapon that others want to make use of in their war .

My, my, Li Shen, are you considered down on your luck, or is this a blessing in disguise?

My hand was still in Li Wen's as she asked softly, "Are you agreeable to this?"

I remained silent .

As if out of patience, she leaned in closer . "Actually, you don't have a choice . You aren't familiar with this place, so do you think you can escape from me? Also, do you think Jiao S can really trap that female monster in that river? I added something in the river after I saved you, and only then could she really trap Du Yue there . But Du Yue is powerful, so even with my help, she'll only be trapped for a maximum of three days . If I don't see your second personality within three days, I'm sure you know what will happen to your friend..."

I whipped her hand away!

I whipped her hand away!

Staring at her, I said, "Let's stop talking and start then . "

Li Wen laughed . "This isn't difficult, actually . "

She pulled me up from the bed of grass .

"The aim of this training is for you to wake her up and obtain her power, that is, that power sleeping within you . We have to use a two-pronged approach to unlock that deep power within you . First, you'll have to remain still . "

I raised a brow . “Still?”

Li Wen nodded . “That’s right, just like Song Lu who can manipulate MF very accurately . It’s intricate to the point that the MF is evenly distributed across every single blood vessel . Only when you do that can you unlock your full potential . You need to learn how to manipulate MF like her, and the first step is to remain still so you can feel it . Feel that power coursing deep within your veins . ”

Hearing Song Lu being mentioned so suddenly made me a little upset, and I said impatiently, “Just tell me how to do it . ”

I wanted to know if there really was a way to force her out or a way to regulate her appearances so that I wouldn’t have to be alert all the time .

“Don’t do anything, just sit . ” Li Wen pointed at that pile of grass in the middle of the cave . I looked at her in suspicion, but I did what she said and sat cross-legged on the grass . Since we’re going to sit, why did you pull me up in the first place .

Li Wen looked down at me . “That’s right, sit straight like this . Close your eyes, but don’t fall asleep . Three days . You’ll just have to sit on the first day . There’re 60 hours in a day in the Northern District, and the sun is out only in the day . Just sit here for 60 hours, and within this time, no matter what I say, what you hear or what you see, you cannot do anything but open and close your eyes .

“You’ll fail if you move, and we’ll have to do it again tomorrow . There’re only two things we’re practicing, and we have three days . If you’re unable to return to the river before Du Yue escapes, your friend will probably be subjected to some horrible torture . ”

I knew that this wasn’t difficult, but it wasn’t an easy task either .

It was close to impossible for anyone in the real world to sit still and not fall asleep for 60 hours, and even though we could use MF in the Split Zone, this was still no easy feat . But I’ll not give up since I’ve already agreed to her training .

“Alright, shall we begin?” Li Wen smiled . “Right, sit straight from now on, you cannot move after that . Remember that Jiao S’s life is in your hands . ”

“Alright, shall we begin?” Li Wen smiled . “Right, sit straight from now on, you cannot move after that . Remember that Jiao S’s life is in your hands . ”

I shot her a cold look before shutting my eyes .

I began to think about what she would do to make me move . Would she stab me with numerous tiny needles? She probably wouldn’t . She should know that such pain is nothing to me .

“Sit here, I’m leaving for a short while . Don’t worry, no one will come here, but I’ll definitely know if you move . ”

She seemed to be walking towards the entrance .

My eyes remained shut .

After she left, I thought about what happened in the past few days .

Yu Liang crossed my mind .

All this seemed to have started from when Yu Liang attacked us as we were heading for the Southern District, and it was the reason why we were in a rush to head for the Northern District .

There’s no way someone intelligent and level-headed like Yu Liang would act rashly, so it’s not true that he was looking for me because he hated me . According to Gaoqin Jiuye’s analysis, we all agreed that it was because Yu Liang wanted to force us to hurry to the Northern District to save Song Lu .

I agreed with that too .

However, there seemed to be other reasons .

Yu Liang’s hands were mutated, so that means he was one of the experimental subjects in experiment number three . If so, was he trying to warn us of something under the guise of taking revenge?

Sacrificing one Yu Liang was nothing to Du Yue, since he was just an experimental subject . So did Yu Liang come to me to warn me of something else?

But why didn't he just say it? Or was he being watched? Yu Liang never feared death, so why did he choose to freeze himself?

Sacrificing one Yu Liang was nothing to Du Yue, since he was just an experimental subject . So did Yu Liang come to me to warn me of something else?

But why didn't he just say it? Or was he being watched? Yu Liang never feared death, so why did he choose to freeze himself?

There was something else going on here . Apart from getting us to save Song Lu, Yu Liang might have wanted to tell me something about the mutations .

Wait, mutations?!

Yes!

I got it . Yu Liang froze himself because he anticipated that I'd send him back to Jie Pa! There might be something on him that could give us a clue about the experiments!

I'm guessing that he already knew this catastrophe would happen, and that's why he got injured by me on purpose . This way, he could send himself to Jie Pa, and Jie Pa can then get a better understanding of these mutant subjects and prevent the catastrophe!

I guess being still can really help clear your head . I had no time to think about all this previously, but now that I have the opportunity to do so, I had a much clearer train of thought . Just like that time when we were training with Ta Lai, I could think about the cause and effect of everything right now .

That must have been Yu Liang's aim all along .

However, I was still pretty upset . Whether Jie Pa was able to understand what Yu Liang wanted him to do, it was too late now . I saw the massacre happen with my very eyes on that screen .

In the words of Mr Blond, people are always selfish . If we weren't able to prevent the deaths of so many, then I just hope that Jie Pa would come out of it alive .

How upset would Nie Zun be if Jie Pa died . But how could Jie Pa survive in the Western District when his constitution has already been altered to that of a normal human being?

I wonder where Yu Liang is now, and has that split freeze been undone?

Right!

Since the split freeze can only be undone with one's own consciousness, if we misunderstood Yu Liang, we wouldn't have known what his goal was! If he didn't do it for Song Lu, then he wouldn't undo the split freeze even when we brought Song Lu back!

Chapter 180

180 Astute Manipulation

I didn't see Yu Liang on that screen in the Great Hall! I wanted to take a deep breath to calm myself, but I wasn't supposed to move .

I wonder if Jie Pa and the rest are still alive? Nie Zun, Si Luo and Guan Nie are with Cang Ming, and Cang Ming has been trapped in some cave . Everything seemed to be in a mess right now .

Would I really be able to uncover the secrets of the Split Zone without Si Luo's help? If all heirs are killed, the soul splitters would be going to war very soon . And I'm an important tool in that war .

What should I do then? Why did they need that person in me?

She...

Hah, seems like you bring me the worst luck . Because of you, I've become the target once again .

"How does it feel, sitting like this?"

I opened my eyes and saw Li Wen back in the cave holding a huge gunny sack . Li Wen placed that heavy-looking sack in front of me . She caressed the sack and said, "I'm going to let you enjoy something . Don't forget, you can't move and you can't talk . Sit there quietly if you want to save Jiao S ."

As she undid the sack, I saw a head pop out .

My eyes grew wide .

It was Yuan Shen!

Crouched in the sack, Yuan Shen looked surprised to see me as well . His face and neck were covered in bruises, and his eyes no longer had the shine they had when I first met him .

Why is he here?!

When I met Mr Blond previously, I saw Yuan Shen fighting alongside Jie Pa in the Western District, and there's no way he would be here in the Northern District . Why is he here now?!

And why is he covered in bruises?! Does this mean that his constitution had been altered to that of a normal human being as well?

I couldn't move an inch even when there were so many questions in my head .

How could he be here?!

When Li Wen removed the gunny sack, I realized that Yuan Shen had lost both his arms! The bloody pits on his shoulders seemed to have dried up, but his arms had not regenerated!

It's no wonder he looked so haggard . His constitution is probably that of a normal human being right now, and the pain of losing a limb would be unimaginable .

“Ah Shen, I'm sure you're wondering why he's here, right?”

Stop bullshitting me . I felt uneasy . Would Li Wen torture Yuan Shen in front of me? I would definitely move to stop her in that case .

Li Wen suddenly smiled just as my thoughts were running wild .

In the span of a mere second, a slender rapier appeared in her hand and she cut Yuan Shen's head off before I could react!

I was absolutely stunned as his head rolled towards me .

She wouldn't have did it so quickly if her aim was to get me to move . At that speed, I wasn't able to react quickly enough even if I wanted to .

She wouldn't have did it so quickly if her aim was to get me to move . At that speed, I wasn't able to react quickly enough even if I wanted to .

I sat motionless, rooted to the spot as I took in Yuan Shen's death . There was no need for me to move either, since he's already dead .

Li Wen was so quick that there weren't any bloodstains on her rapier .

She cleaned her rapier gently with a corner of her pale yellow dress and said, "You must be wondering why I killed him so quickly right in front of you .

"You're wrong if you think that I wanted to force you to move by making use of him . I know you'd stop me if I tortured him in front of you, so that game wouldn't be any fun . Furthermore, all I want is for your second personality to show herself and not for you to lose to me .

"First, let me tell you why Yuan Shen is here .

"I heard that the killings in the Eastern, Western and Southern Districts have ended . Damn, those who weren't supposed to die have all died, and there're a few missing ones . Coincidentally, these missing ones are all from the Western District .

"Jie Pa and his team seemed to have mysteriously disappeared from the Western District . That's very interesting . Just how did they pull it off? Laurel wasn't there to bring them elsewhere, so there's no way they could've escaped from the Western District . "

I breathed an inward sigh of relief when I heard this . At least Jie Pa's still alive .

"Because of this, I wanted to look into what actually happened, and I was lucky enough to meet him on the way . " Li Wen pointed at the severed head with her rapier .

“There’s not many that I still recognize in the Western District after having left the place for so long, but I still remember this pair of siblings . There’re not many who are skilled in using poison in the Split Zone, and his sister, Yuan Qian, is a real expert at it . I heard that she’s naturally gifted .

“Ah Shen, you know I hate it when I’m being kept in the dark about things, or when things are not under my control . I couldn’t understand how Jie Pa and the rest can arrive in the Northern District, and it seems that everyone else is missing . I hate this . ”

A mad gleam appeared in Li Wen’s eyes . She looked like she was insane .

She was absolutely crazy, but I didn’t realize it until now .

She was absolutely crazy, but I didn’t realize it until now .

“So I asked Yuan Shen about it . He had gotten separated from the rest, and he unluckily met me on the way . However, he didn’t show me the least bit of respect . I was a resident of the Western District in the past too, so how could he treat me that way just because you’re now the District Commander?

“Because of that, I cut both his arms off . ”

I gritted my teeth as I tried my best to remain still . Yuan Shen is already dead, and nothing can undo it .

“I wanted to let him taste the pain of losing both arms, since wounds caused by my rapier would definitely hurt . But something more interesting happened . His arms did not regenerate . I guess he was injured by an experimental subject during that fight and his constitution altered .

“I haven’t seen that kind of agony in a long time . Most people in the Split Zone are either able to regenerate or have an amazing threshold for pain, so I was really excited when I saw that expression on his face...

“I started kicking him around like a rubber ball, but he just wouldn’t tell me how he arrived here . ”

I closed my eyes slowly, not wanting to look at Li Wen any longer . I never wanted to look at her ever again .

“Ah Shen, I know that these people in the Western District were all trained personally by Li Qing . Since Li Qing has given you the role of District Commander, no matter how horribly you perform, they’d still be loyal to you . On this, it’s not only You Ji who was jealous of you, I’m jealous too...

“But I know I’d never be able to get any information even if I cut him open alive . I’m someone extraordinary, and I’ll definitely get the information I want . This is why I brought him back here and killed him right in front of you . ”

Li Wen started laughing . “Can you guess why I did this?”

How can I possibly understand the actions of a lunatic like you?

I had my questions too . How did Jie Pa and the rest escape? Looking at the situation, Du Yue had planned this massacre very early on, so how did they escape so easily? And if they had escaped, why did they have to get separated?

“Seems like you don’t know . ” Li Wen lost her smile and a cruel gleam shone through her eyes . “I’ll find his sister, Yuan Qian, very soon .

I had my questions too . How did Jie Pa and the rest escape? Looking at the situation, Du Yue had planned this massacre very early on, so how did they escape so easily? And if they had escaped, why did they have to get separated?

“Seems like you don’t know . ” Li Wen lost her smile and a cruel gleam shone through her eyes . “I’ll find his sister, Yuan Qian, very soon .

“I’ll tell Yuan Qian exactly how her brother died, but I’ll tell her that you had the chance to stop it and you didn’t . You gave up on saving Yuan Shen because you chose to save your friend . ”

I suddenly realized what she was trying to do .

“Li Shen, I know you too well . That unique kindness Li Qing and Mr Blond said they saw in you – that’s simply a weaker kind of cruelty in my eyes . I’ve always looked down on you . You’re always trying to take responsibility for everything, throwing your sympathy everywhere . Yes, we’re all villains compared to you, the kind Li Shen .

“Since you’re that kind, I know you’d blame yourself for Yuan Shen’s death, even though you didn’t have the chance to stop it at all . You’d be blaming yourself for his death, because that’s just who you are . Aren’t you such a person, someone who wants to take responsibility for every single thing? Take responsibility for Yuan Shen’s death then, let his sister hate you, and let me watch as I emerge victorious .

“If you don’t want me to make use of Yuan Qian, tell me everything I want to know . This way, there’s no need for you to take responsibility for Yuan Shen’s death . ” Li Wen looked at me with a determined gaze .

She knew I would never do that . Though I wasn’t the one who caused Yuan Shen’s death, I was still indirectly responsible for it . I still felt responsible for his death, and I found it perfectly understandable for Yuan Qian to hate me because of that .

Li Wen made a good move, because she knew me too well .

She knew I didn’t like to explain myself, and I definitely didn’t like to explain myself to my friends . Even if Yuan Qian pointed a sword at my neck, I’d still remain silent because I blamed myself .

Li Wen also knew how close the Yuan siblings were to each other, and Yuan Qian will go insane if she hears the news . If I don’t explain myself on this, Yuan Qian will resent me .

To Li Wen, anyone who hates me can become a useful tool to her .

Furthermore, that’s someone who’s a genius in using poisons .

Chapter 181

181 Face-off

I remained silent . There was no need for me to say anything .

Li Wen flashed a brilliant smile . “Ah Shen, I’m sure someone as intelligent as you would have realized by now how well I know you . You should be regretting that you didn’t choose to go on the same path with me . ”

Hah, to you, I’m always abandoning others . You Ji blamed me for being District Commander, you blame me too, for not choosing to go on the path you went on . But did any of you tell me this?

Your monster didn’t choose to go on the same path as you, but when have you ever told me you were going to walk on this path?

I was the one who was abandoned, so why am I being blamed now? Why should I take responsibility for your twisted hearts? I treated the both of you like sisters . Who’s going to make up for that?

Li Wen lifted her rapier and started chopping Yuan Shen’s body into pieces .

A fresh corpse would still bleed .

She did it slowly, as if she was enjoying it . “Ah Shen, they’re still being humiliated by me even when they’re dead . You must be angry at this . I’ll really test you this time . ”

I remained absolutely still .

“I know you can’t bear this . I’ll leave him with a complete body if you stop me now . ”

I did not move an inch . I simply let her chop Yuan Shen's body into pieces while I watched .

Some of the blood splattered onto Li Wen's clothes, leaving red speckles on the ends of her pale yellow dress, looking like tiny red flowers that were in bloom . Some of the blood splattered onto my dress as well, but it was lost in the bright red .

My dress seemed to be able to absorb and devour all that blood .

She continued cutting Yuan Shen up into tiny pieces, until she began to find it boring . Looking a little frustrated, she kicked the pieces of Yuan Shen back into the gunny sack .

What's left on the ground were bloodstains and what looked like tiny bits and pieces of flesh . I knew that Li Wen did everything depending on her mood, but I didn't know she would become this cruel .

She shot a cold look at me, as if unhappy with my non reaction . Dragging a corner of the gunny sack in one hand and taking her rapier in the other, she left the cave .

The gunny sack left a long trail of blood as it was dragged roughly against the ground .

Tears rolled down my cheeks as Li Wen left .

Taking a deep breath, I focused my MF on my eyes, heating them as I tried to make my tears dry quickly .

Li Wen was back very soon . She walked over and looked me in the eyes .
“Do you know how long you've been here?”

She asked even when she knew I wouldn't answer .

“You've been here for three hours . ”

My eyes widened in surprise .

“Surprised? Feels much longer, right? But in reality, it has only been three hours . Two hours passed when I brought Yuan Shen back . Time always passes so slowly when you’re still, and that’s what’s difficult to endure .

“I won’t do anything else . I’d like to see just how you can endure this . ”

After speaking, she grabbed a pile of grass and placed it a short distance away from me . She then sat down on it and continued looking at me .

I decided to close my eyes since I didn’t want to look at her .

I decided to close my eyes since I didn’t want to look at her .

“Ah Shen, why are you being controlled by me? I know you well . I know that as long as it was something you were not willing to do, there’s no way you’d do it even if I threatened you with Jiao S’s life . So just why exactly are you listening to me now?”

Li Wen finally asked a question that could be considered typical .

Why? Because I want to meet her too . I want to know how I can control her power .

I want to obtain and use that power of hers .

I’ll never admit that she is me, but I need her strength . And I know that Li Wen’s method will work .

I’ve never thought of giving this power to anyone else, and I’ve never thought of letting anyone else use this power as a weapon .

Li Wen, you’ve belittled me . No one understands her as well as I do . Do you think you can really take control of her, Li Wen, if even I cannot do it?

I didn’t want to admit it in the past, but I knew she had great power . I always knew that .

No one can take her away from me, no one .

“Sometimes I wonder why you’re so special, Ah Shen . Do you remember the first day you arrived in the Western District, when Mr Blond handed you over to Li Qing personally? I’ve never seen him do that in such a long time . Do you still remember Li Qing’s reaction when she first saw you?

“Ah Shen, I’m really jealous of you . This is why I could understand how You Ji must have felt . She’s in love with Mr Blond, and I knew that from the beginning . But you’ve never learnt to observe these things . You’ve never really seen You Ji’s eyes when she looks at Mr Blond .

“Ah Shen, even though I was jealous of you, everyone had that same thought – what a unique individual she was . At that time, how should I put this? You had no fear and you didn’t seem to care about anything here, but I could still see that fiery soul in your eyes . It was completely different to the dead atmosphere here in the Split Zone .

“At that time I was thinking of how to get your attention . Just what did you care about?

“I thought you probably wouldn’t care about anything ever, but I realized I was wrong . It turns out that you actually cared about everything . You probably thought that you didn’t care about anything yourself, but in reality, you cared about everything . ”

“I thought you probably wouldn’t care about anything ever, but I realized I was wrong . It turns out that you actually cared about everything . You probably thought that you didn’t care about anything yourself, but in reality, you cared about everything . ”

I didn’t know why Li Wen was saying this, but this was something new to me and it was something I didn’t think she would say . I kept my eyes on her .

She had on a poker face and I couldn’t make out her mood . Nothing but her lips moved .

“With time, I realized that your MF was pretty high, just that you were lazy and didn’t want to do or learn anything . But when you set your mind to

something, that sudden perseverance really shocked me . I always thought I was the most extraordinary in Li Qing's eyes, since I was a fast learner with high MF .

“You still remember the value of my MF, right? It's 62 . ”

I thought inwardly to myself, Why are you pretending to be some heir here? Have you forgotten that you're a soul splitter?

“Do you still remember that time when there was this heir who wanted to drag somebody else to hell with her? She was on the rooftop on the 30th floor . You had just received your bow and you've never used it, but you were able to pierce her hand with your arrow just when she was about to insert her splitting key into the split symbol of an innocent resident .

“You were so lost after that . You didn't know where that power came from . But I knew from then on, I knew that you had a far greater potential .

“I really hate that you exist . You made me look so dumb . ”

If I could move, I would have heaved a sigh at this moment .

Li Wen, you're wrong .

I didn't hide my power . Maybe you're right, and I do believe I have some hidden power in me as well . But the truth is I'm not interested in all this . That laziness isn't faked . I just want to spend my life quietly and calmly, wherever I may be .

You guys are jealous of me being unique, but do you know what're the words I hate to hear the most? Unique, special .

I don't want to be that unique one . I've been the unique one for too long . I'm tired of being that unique one .

I just want to be someone extremely ordinary .

I don't want to be that unique one . I've been the unique one for too long . I'm tired of being that unique one .

I just want to be someone extremely ordinary .

Just when I thought I could continue spending my days peacefully after saving my friends, I'm being embroiled into another battle again .

What does all of this have to do with me? Like what Mr Blond said, be it heirs or soul splitters, none of them have anything to do with me .

The only thing I have to do is to leave this place, but I don't have the ability to do so just yet .

Because I would have nowhere else to go if I leave .

“Ah Shen, I've hated myself so many times . I felt that I shouldn't have treated you that way . But I'm not kind like you are, and I slowly felt that there was nothing wrong in the way I treated you .

“Remember that basiliscampus? I could've saved you that time, but I didn't . It's not that I wished for your death, I just wanted to see that you were weaker than me .

“You must think that I'm weird . I'm sharing my feelings with you when I was so bloodthirsty just seconds before . You know, you make people hate you like this . You make everyone close to you so weird . Mr Blond, You Ji, and Li Qing too .

“Li Qing said this to me once . She said we had to protect Ah Shen, because she was worth protecting .

“I found it funny . Why was it only you who was worth protecting?”

A funny feeling overcame me . I suddenly realized something . From when Li Wen starting talking, no matter what she said, even when she was talking about how she was jealous of me, Li Qing was always mentioned .

Maybe Jiao S had misunderstood her . Her relationship with Li Qing definitely isn't as simple as we thought it was .

I observed Li Wen's expressions, trying to obtain as much information as I could . I had to stay calm in this war . I had to win .

Chapter 182

182 My Weakness

“Li Qing had always looked at you differently, but I just couldn’t control myself and I found myself liking you . I began wishing that you were mine .

“But I couldn’t catch you . You were always changing . ”

This sounded more and more like a confession .

“Ah Shen, only when I cut Yuan Shen’s corpse right in front of you did I realize that you’ve really changed . You’ve become stronger now . This really terrifies me .

“I understand why you didn’t stop me from cutting him up . It’s because you’ve decided to take responsibility for his death, and since you’ve decided to let Yuan Qian hate you for it, you’d rather add to that crime to be able to accept Yuan Qian’s hatred for you even more realistically .

“You didn’t owe her anything before this, but you owe her something now .

“You also knew it was useless even if you had stopped me . It’s the Split Zone . His body would dissipate into light soon after, and you don’t want to do something that would practically be useless . ”

That’s right . Whether you’ve cut his head off or cut his body into pieces, the corpse will still dissipate into light eventually .

Sadly, you’ve only gotten this part right .

I didn’t let you cut him into pieces so that I could face Yuan Qian more convincingly . It’s not because I thought it was useless that I didn’t save

him either .

I'll never tell you why I did it, so you can keep guessing . You'll never be able to catch up with me . I'm always changing, and you're always regressing .

People who get jealous too easily will never improve .

I looked at her with mocking eyes .

I knew she'd be able to understand me .

As expected, she was enraged by my gaze . She stood up . “What do you have to be proud of? Who do you think you are to look at me like this...”

I finally saw an agitated Li Wen . She was ugly like this too .

I used to think she was the most beautiful lady in the world, but I realize now that she would still turn ugly when provoked .

No woman looks good when hysterical . That's the way of the world .

I continued looking at her with that mocking gaze .

That's right, Li Wen . You've already lost when you started talking .

I know your aim is to rile me up . You wanted to rattle me with your words, and you wanted to enjoy that look of mine when I wasn't able to say or do anything in response .

But you were wrong . Sometimes, the most powerful thing in this world is silence . When you tried to hurt me with your words, I'd win if I simply kept quiet .

Why do people respect Bodhisattva? Because Bodhisattva doesn't speak .

It's the same between married couples . It's the worse when one party decides to give the other the silent treatment, and that triggers anger very easily .

You're now a clown triggered by anger, and you deserve to be mocked by me .

Li Wen looked like she was about to blow, but she took a deep breath to calm herself down . That angry, wrinkled face smoothened .

I smiled inwardly . That's the Li Wen I know . Yes, this war will be interesting only if you're like this . You're that worthy opponent .

Du Yue's ruthlessness and You Ji's schemes – they have nothing on you .

You, Li Wen, are the opponent who's most worthy .

A mysterious smile appeared on Li Wen's face .

She sat down slowly, holding her chin in one hand and an end of her pale yellow dress stained with Yuan Shen's blood in the other .

“I've underestimated you, Li Shen .

“Since I couldn't make you move, how about I just tell you some things that you want to know . ”

Expectation flashed in her eyes .

Expectation flashed in her eyes .

That really annoyed me .

“You want to know if Li Qing is still alive, right?”

My eyes opened wide .

I expected her to look excited when she saw such a reaction from me, but her eyes seemed to darken for a moment .

“I'll tell you if you want to know .

“Li Qing is still alive, in the Gate of Exit . ”

She was continuously fiddling with the bloodstained part of her dress .

“So as long as you do what I tell you to – wake the other person asleep within you and lend me her power, I can help you save Jiao S and return Song Lu to you . I can even take you to Li Qing .

“Even if I don’t wish for you to see Li Qing ever again . ”

I shut my eyes for a second, and reopened them again . That’s okay . I just need to know you’re alive, that’s the most important . I don’t have the guts to face you now anyway .

The Western District was destroyed in a mere two years after I took charge . Apart from a few lucky ones, the rest are all dead . I don’t dare face you like this .

“This is the first thing that you want to know .

“You might find the second thing even more interesting .

“Do you know why both you and Bian Ying arrived in the Split Zone even though you both suffer from double identity disorder?

“In reality, even Bian Ying doesn’t know how she arrived here in the Split Zone . The only thing she’s sure of is that she wasn’t captured by Ta Lai . She should’ve already told you about the third kind of existence here .

“No need to look at me with that surprised face . I heard every part of your conversation because I was right by the riverbank .

“What I want to tell you is this . That day when Bian Ying said she didn’t know, when she said she couldn’t explain it to you . ”

“What I want to tell you is this . That day when Bian Ying said she didn’t know, when she said she couldn’t explain it to you . ”

She seemed to have gotten hold of some sort of trump card at this point, and she continued with a smile .

“Gaoqin Jiuye actually knows everything about you, including the fact that you killed your beloved senior . He already knew this . The Split Zone and the real world are connected in some places, and Gaoqin Jiuye knew you from a long time ago . Possibly even before Gao Qi met you .

“You should’ve fallen in love with Gaoqin Jiuye instead of Gao Qi . ”

That was her trump card . It was like a bomb that exploded right in my chest, shattering my heart into a million pieces .

I had to ask . I had no idea what she was talking about .

Li Wen seemed to have anticipated my actions and she continued before I could say anything . “No need for you to ask questions . I wouldn’t answer you even if you asked . I can only reveal this much regarding Gaoqin Jiuye . If you’re fated to meet him in future, you can ask him about the rest yourself .

“As for you, there’re only two things I’m not aware of . ”

Li Wen turned serious . “The first has to do with your second personality . Although I’ve thoroughly investigated you, I still don’t know what that second personality is, what power she possesses, and under what circumstances would she appear .

“She’s just like a ghost and no one can predict when she’ll appear . That’s pretty scary .

“This is why I’ll have to force her out of you no matter what . I want to meet the real Li Shen . ”

The real Li Shen .

The real Li Shen is right in front of you . It’s me .

I don’t care whether she really is me, and I don’t care whether I’d be able to eventually accept her one day . All I know is that I’m the real me .

No matter how powerful she is, she’s still second place . I am Li Shen .

“The second thing I can’t wrap my head around is about a person . ”

My heart sank as I could already guess what she was going to say .

Li Wen’s eyes brightened as she said, “That person is Nie Zun . ”

My heart sank further . For some reason, I didn’t want to think about him these few days . Ever since I arrived in the Northern District, I kept telling myself to stay calm, stay rational, and be strong .

Li Wen’s eyes brightened as she said, “That person is Nie Zun . ”

My heart sank further . For some reason, I didn’t want to think about him these few days . Ever since I arrived in the Northern District, I kept telling myself to stay calm, stay rational, and be strong .

But these were all gone once Nie Zun was there . These qualities just disappeared into thin air . This was the truth even if I wanted to deny it .

The truth was that he had become my weakness, my only weakness .

Li Wen’s eyes were shining . “You know Li Shen, your eyes will always betray you . I finally understand it now . He’s your weakness . ”

I shut my eyes . It’s true that I couldn’t hide any of my emotions when it comes to him .

“Nie Zun is even more terrifying than that second personality of yours . He’s just like a shadow of yours that’s always by your side . I’ll see him wherever you are . He’s just there, not upset, not sad, not happy . He’s just standing behind you without any expectations, always looking at you with those eyes that were full of solitude .

“With the way he looks at you, I’d always feel that I could never be close to you .

“His power seems to be even more unpredictable . Those hands of his are terrifying .

“You know what’s most terrifying?”

I don’t know . I only know that I’m terrified every time someone uses Nie Zun to threaten me in any way .

“The scariest part is that I don’t know where his split symbol is, and who his soul splitter is .

“In the Split Zone, I’m aware of where the split symbols are on most heirs and who their corresponding soul splitters are, but I know nothing about Nie Zun . Even Li Qing knows nothing about him .

“I’m aware of many things that others aren’t privy to . Even if it was about the secretive Gaoqin Jiuye, I know many of his secrets . But for Nie Zun, I know nothing at all . ”

Li Wen leaned in closer . “Why do you have so many people protecting you?”

I might have said something in jest in the past, something like they probably thought I was kind and cute . But right now, I didn’t have the mood to joke around . If Nie Zun wasn’t mentioned, I could continue suppressing my worry for him .

But now, I couldn’t do it anymore .

Chapter 183

183 Demon Cave in the Mountains

“Even though Nie Zun isn’t beside you now, I’d still think of him when torturing you . He’s just like this weird presence that seems to follow you around . Just how horrifying is that . ”

This conversation is getting too long . I was beginning to tire and I didn’t want to continue anymore .

I finally spoke . “You won’t be able to force her out of me this way . You might be scaring her away like this . I’ll admit that I did want to know more about whatever you told me about, but don’t try to use that to force me to do anything . You could’ve chosen to keep quiet, since I would’ve found out about these things sooner or later . As for Nie Zun, do you really think you can uncover his secrets even when I can’t explain his existence?”

I made it clear that I was the main character here, especially on things that had to do with Nie Zun . No need for you to worry, Li Wen . I don’t know everything about Nie Zun either, so who are you to try and find out more about him .

Li Wen smiled as I spoke . Her smile looked stiff and it didn’t look like it belonged to a victor . “I didn’t think that you’d actually speak because of him . ”

“No, you’re wrong . I didn’t speak because of him . I spoke because I didn’t want to continue wasting time on this with you . ”

Actually, you were right .

But I would never admit that .

Li Wen sighed . “Fine . You’re right too, I was thinking about the aim of this meditation just when you spoke earlier . Maybe my real aim was to actually talk to you about these things . ”

“No,” I disagreed immediately . “Meditation is effective . It helps train my endurance . I’ve also learnt how to better control and manipulate my MF in the process of trying to balance all the MF in my body while keeping still . ”

“You’ll have to thank me for this then . ”

I smirked . “You’re thinking too much . ”

Li Wen looked at me, and she finally said, “Continue sitting then . It has only been five hours . ”

Is Li Wen muddled?

Why continue sitting...

I moved stiffly . “I’ll tell you the truth, this won’t work . Ta Lai and Si Luo had both tried to force her out by reaching into my consciousness, and neither of them succeeded . I actually want to meet her as well, so why not we use my method? I’ll work with you since we have the same goal . ”

Doubt appeared in Li Wen’s eyes .

I scoffed, “I know my obedience must be suspicious to you, but you should know me well . Since I want to meet her too, I’ll work with you on this . I don’t think you have the ability to control her, so I’m willing to bet on this . You’ve always been confident of your abilities, so you’re not afraid now, are you?”

Li Wen thought for a moment . “What do you plan to do?”

I stretched my neck . “It’s simple . Bring me to that cave they were talking about to look for Nie Zun . ”

“Look for Nie Zun?”

I nodded . “Yes, you’ve witnessed it earlier, that Nie Zun is my only weakness . So how about we find this weakness in order to force her out of me . You would know this right, considering how well your information network is . I activated my split symbol because I wanted to protect Nie Zun . If you can bring me to Nie Zun, you’d be able to use my weakness . You’d definitely be able to see her then . ”

Li Wen frowned a little . “But you have to know that if we look for Nie Zun, I might attack him to force your second personality out . You’d still want me to do it in that case?”

I answered her in a calm and composed tone, “Frankly, I don’t think you have the ability to threaten me with Nie Zun . You said it yourself, that you can’t see through Nie Zun’s abilities . So I think you wouldn’t be able to make use of him even if we could find him . ”

Li Wen found this funny . “Then why should I agree with you if that’s the case?”

I looked her in the eye . “Because you’re Li Wen . Li Wen is confident and proud . No matter what I’ve said, you’d still think that you can use Nie Zun to threaten me . You’d definitely give it a try since you’ve finally found my weakness . ”

Li Wen had an inscrutable gaze .

We continued looking at each other for a long time before she finally broke into a smile . “Fine, I’ll bring you to that cave . But I’ll tell you this first . Even I don’t dare to explore too deeply, and I don’t know if they were able to survive in there . What I can do is to take you there . If we aren’t able to find them before we reach the restricted area in the cave, I’m not following you in any further . At that point, I want you to return with me . ”

We continued looking at each other for a long time before she finally broke into a smile . “Fine, I’ll bring you to that cave . But I’ll tell you this first . Even I don’t dare to explore too deeply, and I don’t know if they were able to survive in there . What I can do is to take you there . If we aren’t able to

find them before we reach the restricted area in the cave, I'm not following you in any further . At that point, I want you to return with me . ”

My body was finally less rigid now . I stood up and adjusted my dress .
“Let's go then . ”

A dense forest was right outside the cave . The trees and flowers were all identical to what we would see in the real world, and there were even clear springs to be seen here . As I walked, I began to wonder just what kind of a place the Northern District was .

Li Wen did not talk much, probably because she had already spoke a lot earlier, and she no longer wanted to talk to me about anything else .

Though there was sunlight on the ground, both Li Wen and I did not have any shadows .

Imitations can never be the real deal .

“We'll see the entrance of the cave after we pass those trees up front,” Li Wen said as she pointed in front of her .

“Why is everything so similar to the real world here?” I asked .

“Everything here is an imitation of the real world . These were created by the soul splitters based on your world . ” Li Wen gave a mysterious smile .

“What?” I frowned .

Li Wen shrugged . “I have no interest in revealing the secrets of soul splitters to you right now, but I just might do it one day when I'm in a better mood . Anyway, there's no need for you to be surprised if you see anything here that's similar to the real world . You just have to remember that everything in the Northern District is created through MF . Put simply, whatever you can think of can be manifested in the Northern District, since these things are all created through imagination . The only criterion is whether you have the MF to be able to create something . ”

I remained silent . There was no use in asking further questions since no one wanted to reveal any secrets regarding the soul splitters . I'll take whatever comes my way . I was just a little unaccustomed to these realistic scenes, probably because I've stayed in the world of heirs for too long .

“There, it's that cave . ”

I looked in the direction in which Li Wen pointed . The dark entrance of the cave was at the foot of a mountain .

From here, the cave looked like a normal one, and you couldn't tell that there was anything special about it . There were also no signs with words like 'Water Curtain Cave' or 'Cave of Demons' on it . (T/n: 'Water Curtain Cave' is the home of the Monkey King in the Chinese epic, Journey to the West .)

From here, the cave looked like a normal one, and you couldn't tell that there was anything special about it . There were also no signs with words like 'Water Curtain Cave' or 'Cave of Demons' on it . (T/n: 'Water Curtain Cave' is the home of the Monkey King in the Chinese epic, Journey to the West .)

There was nothing but a giant mushroom in front of the cave .

That giant mushroom was the height of about two human beings, but apart from that, it looked like any other ordinary mushroom . It was so huge the sunlight was completely blocked as we went under it, like an enormous umbrella .

It was a colorful mushroom that looked extremely beautiful .

But I know that beautiful things were usually poisonous .

Li Wen and I passed the mushroom and entered the cave .

Looking inside, it was pitch black .

“Let's go . It's right here . ” Though Li Wen was pointing at the entrance, she did not move .

I knew she was waiting for me to make the first move . But I hesitated as well .

I had an ominous feeling about this cave . There'd usually be the sound of wind blowing when we stood at the entrance of caves, but there was nothing but silence here .

There was only darkness, and silence . It was a terrifying silence .

Taking a deep breath, I stepped into the cave . I had to find Nie Zun no matter what .

I focused some MF onto my eyes when entering, trying to widen my field of vision . I realized that the Northern District was extremely different from the other districts . Even though it was pitch black, visibility could be greatly increased through MF .

This cave was very different . It was unlike any in the real world . Its walls were lined with moss and countless stalactites hung from its ceiling . The cave was rectangular inside, forming a straight path of well-chiseled stone walls .

No matter how much MF I focused on my eyes, there was only darkness in front of me . It was a path that seemed to be never-ending . Li Wen and I continued walking like this for a long time before we were met with a fork in the road .

The path was neatly divided into two by the fork .

No matter how much MF I focused on my eyes, there was only darkness in front of me . It was a path that seemed to be never-ending . Li Wen and I continued walking like this for a long time before we were met with a fork in the road .

The path was neatly divided into two by the fork .

“Where should we go?” I asked .

Li Wen shook her head . “I don’t know . I’ve never been to the Gate of Ghost before this, so I wouldn’t know the way in this cave either . ”

“I hope that restricted area isn’t right after this fork in the road . ”

“No . I know that there’s the word ‘demon’ in that area . If we want to stay alive, we shouldn’t explore any deeper when we see that word . I don’t know anything more than that since I’m not from the Gate of Ghost . So, you choose where to go . ”

I thought for a moment before I chose to continue on the path that was on my left .

That’s because I know that Nie Zun would choose this path .

The path became infinitely narrower after that fork . If we walk shoulder to shoulder in a row, this path could only hold about five individuals . The ceiling became lower and lower as we went deeper .

“What kind of demonic cave is this, there isn’t a single soul to be found here,” I complained .

“There’s a door in front . ” Li Wen pointed at somewhere in front of us .

Taking a closer look, I realized there was a stone door .

What . Why were there stone doors everywhere? Were there also wooden barrels and a breeding ground for poisonous leeches here?

Li Wen and I realized very quickly that there was someone else there . In front of that stone door, there was someone bent at the waist, looking inside . We weren’t able to recognize that person immediately since we couldn’t see the individual’s face . However, that individual turned around as Li Wen and I closed in .

Chapter 184

184 Stuck Between the Stone Doors

That individual was Gaoqin Jiuye .

Gaoqin Jiuye was first surprised to see me, and he looked rather shocked as he realized that it was Li Wen beside me . Frowning, he asked, “Why’re you here? And you’ve even gotten involved with her . ”

Right . Although ‘gotten involved’ did not sound too good, that phrase described this situation quite perfectly, since I couldn’t really ‘get involved’ with her in reality . (T/n: The Chinese character used here for ‘getting involved’ is gao, which is usually used to describe the situation when a man and a woman ‘get involved’ with each other .)

I couldn’t be bothered to answer Gaoqin Jiuye, and I asked him, “Why’re you here then? I thought you had left much earlier to save them . It’s already been a day now and you’re still here? I think it took me only about an hour to arrive here from the entrance . ”

Gaoqin Jiuye sounded a little exasperated as he responded . “Please, that’s because you took the path that I took earlier, of course it’ll be quicker . You really think the cave was like this originally, that there was nothing on the way?”

What did that mean?

Seeing how confused I looked, he continued with his explanation . “This demonic cave is a restricted area in the Gate of Ghost, and it’s called a restricted area because it has a preternatural structure that changes every few days . This is why everyone who has ever been here describes the place differently .

“What’s amazing is that even those from the Gate of Ghost don’t know anything about this demonic cave . What I’ve heard is that the cave had already existed even before the Gate of Ghost was created . Though everybody describes this place differently, the only common thing in their descriptions was that one shouldn’t continue exploring the cave when you see the word ‘demon’, because all who continued never came out of the cave again .

“This is the legend of the demonic cave, and whatever path you took earlier was the exact same path I took . It probably didn’t change since it’s still within the day . When I entered, that path was full of monsters . I was the one who cleared them and you dare say I’m slow when all you’ve done is to enjoy the fruits of my labor . ”

Looking at Gaoqin Jiuye’s annoyed face, I had to admit that I was too quick to judge this time .

I simply waved my hand at him . “Thanks for that . Did you just arrive here then? What’s behind that stone door?”

Gaoqin Jiuye looked like he was about to punch me in the face . “I’m looking . ”

I then had an epiphany . “Oh... is it like that time in the Southern District? We melt a hole in the stone door?”

“...”

I decided to stop messing around with him . “What can you see?”

Gaoqin Jiuye shook his head . “I can’t see anything... Wait . Why are you the one asking me questions now . ”

I shrugged .

Gaoqin Jiuye glanced at Li Wen . “You haven’t told me why you’re here and why you’re together with her . ”

Li Wen interrupted . “Gaoqin Jiuye, no need to be this surprised to see me . It’s not like we don’t know each other anyway . ”

Gaoqin Jiuye smirked . “I know you probably have something up your sleeve because I know you . Unlucky are the ones you approach . ”

Li Wen smiled warmly . “Don’t be so unfriendly . ”

As if tired of speaking to her, Gaoqin Jiuye addressed me, “I’m asking you . ”

Hmm, it’s a bit of a chore to explain this .

“Jiao S and I fought against Du Yue and Ta Lai after you left . In the end, Du Yue, Ta Lai and Bian Ying were all frozen in the river by Jiao S . Jiao S is also inside the river . Li Wen then appeared and took me away . We arrived here after that . Have I explained it clearly enough?”

Gaoqin Jiuye raised his brows . “Jiao S can freeze all of them? Is she that good?”

Li Wen pointed a slender finger at herself . “I accidentally helped her out, so she did it . ”

Gaoqin Jiuye’s gaze was wintry . “What’re you doing here in the Gate of Ghost?”

Li Wen walked towards Gaoqin Jiuye . “Don’t be so fierce . Why? Afraid that I’m here for her? There shouldn’t be anything that Gaoqin Jiuye fears, right? Haha . But then again, why can’t I be here when you’re here too?”

The ‘her’ that Li Wen was talking about seemed to refer to me .

The ‘her’ that Li Wen was talking about seemed to refer to me .

“Gaoqin Jiuye, do you know that the Eastern, Western and Southern Districts have all been destroyed?”

Gaoqin Jiuye's eyes darkened . "Why ask when you should know that all soul splitters should be aware of this by now . "

Li Wen laughed manically . "This is exactly the face I wanted to see . At that time, you and Si Luo abandoned the Gate of Heaven and left for the Southern District . It's been a hundred years and all that great effort spent to protect the Southern District has all come to naught . I had to see for myself how you'd react to the news, what you'd look like when you heard it . "

There was a gleam in Gaoqin Jiuye's eyes . "You even have time to observe my reactions now? I guess Li Qing isn't giving you important tasks anymore . " This seemed to be one of Li Wen's weaknesses . Li Wen looked incensed as she heard this .

I frowned inwardly . What did that mean? Li Wen was still working under Li Qing? How could that be? According to my deductions, shouldn't Li Qing be controlled by Li Wen even if she was still alive?

I didn't ask, since it wasn't important right now .

Li Wen answered coldly, "There'd not be many of us left in the Southern District if Si Luo doesn't come back . I'll see how long you can continue being like this . "

A quick gleam shone in Li Wen's eyes, as if she suddenly thought of something . "Oh yes, I heard there were three individuals captured from the Southern District sometime earlier, and that they're here in the Gate of Ghost . One of them seems to be the great illusionist from your district . Your people have already been captured here by unknown forces, and you're not going to look for them, not going to investigate at all?"

Seems that Huan Qing and the rest had really been kidnapped . I grabbed Li Wen . "Where are those three now?"

Li Wen raised her brows . "Why? When did you start caring about the people from the Southern District? You really think you're the messiah now?" She whipped my hand away . Her mood had been absolutely spoiled by Gaoqin Jiuye's appearance .

Gaoqin Jiuye harrumphed . “No need for you to worry about things happening in our district . I don’t care what your aim is here, but if you dare get involved in any of this, I’ll make sure you pay with your life . ”

Li Wen wanted to argue, but I interrupted them loudly, “How long more do you guys want to argue? Are we going in or not? I’m not here to play with you guys like this . ”

To my surprise, the two of them stopped arguing after that . Gaoqin Jiuye turned back and continued creating a hole in the stone door .

“I can’t create a hole on this stone door,” Gaoqin Jiuye said with a frown .

“Then let’s just break it open,” I said .

“Then let’s just break it open,” I said .

Li Wen pointed to somewhere beside the door . “I don’t think we need to use violence . Isn’t there some sort of mechanism over on that side?”

Gaoqin Jiuye and I looked towards it . There it was . A primitive button made of stone was right beside the door .

I looked at Gaoqin Jiuye . “Wow . You didn’t see that huge button there? And you’re asking us to break it open . How violent and brainless of you . ”

“...”

Li Wen ignored the both of us and stepped up to push the button . There was a series of loud noises and the stone door started going up .

We were dealt another blow when it opened .

There was another stone door behind the original one . This stone door looked exactly the same, and the distance between the two doors was less than half a meter .

I deadpanned . You think you’re Kakashi’s mask? (T/n: Kakashi is a character in the Japanese animation series, Naruto . He always wears a

mask that hides half of his face, and when it was finally taken off, another mask was revealed to be under the original mask .)

Gaoqin Jiuye was obviously surprised by this as well . He approached the new stone door and tried to create a hole on that door . “Hey, there can’t be another stone door behind this one, I hope . ” I walked up behind him and slapped him gently on the shoulder .

I heard a loud crash even before I finished speaking .

Humans always have gut reactions to external stimuli, and I don’t know why I didn’t back away when I felt the stone door behind me coming down . Instead of backing away, I stepped forward and ended up sticking to Gaoqin Jiuye’s back .

I automatically leaned in closer to Gaoqin Jiuye when the stone door came down behind us so suddenly . The space between these doors was extremely small . Gaoqin Jiuye was initially bent at the waist, but now, he was almost flat against the door in front of us while I leaned flat against his back .

“Hey hey hey, what do you think you’re doing,” Gaoqin Jiuye said in an irritated manner with both arms lifted as if he was surrendering .

I couldn’t do anything but continue to lean flat against his back . “I couldn’t do anything . The stone door just came down behind us so suddenly . We’re both stuck in this space now . ”

“What . We actually managed to get stuck in this tiny space between these doors here...”

I couldn’t do anything but continue to lean flat against his back . “I couldn’t do anything . The stone door just came down behind us so suddenly . We’re both stuck in this space now . ”

“What . We actually managed to get stuck in this tiny space between these doors here...”

I felt the cold stone door press against my back . It was so cold that I tried my best to lean into Gaoqin Jiuye . I was almost sticking to him . “You think I want this to happen... there’s no choice since it’s so tiny here . ”

Gaoqin Jiuye was speechless .

I heard Li Wen’s voice from behind the door . “Hey, are the both of you okay?”

I wanted to roll my eyes . But the air here was suffocating, and I didn’t have the extra energy for an eye-roll . I answered as loudly as I could, “Yes, we’re fine . Why didn’t you tell us when the door was coming down?”

“The door came down too quickly, I didn’t have the time to say anything . ”

I rolled my eyes this time . “Break it open quickly then . ”

Gaoqin Jiuye said, “Hey, we’d get hurt if it breaks open . We’re so close to it now . ”

“You’re scared it’d hurt?” I asked immediately .

“...”

Nothing but silence followed as we heard the sound of sword against stone .

I couldn’t hear Li Wen no matter how hard I tried .

“Hey, Li Wen . You done?”

Li Wen’s voice sounded from behind . “This door... It can absorb MF... It absorbs any force used against it . ”

Chapter 185

Volume 3

185 Glacial Ice

What the... Are you kidding me... You're saying that door cannot be opened anymore?

I didn't know how to respond to Li Wen. All I could do was continue sticking to Gaoqin Jiuye as I tried to regulate my breathing. I could feel Gaoqin Jiuye's heartbeat against my chest.

"What now?" I asked softly. Li Wen probably couldn't hear me at such a volume.

Gaoqin Jiuye's heartbeat seemed to quicken. "Let's try to use our MF on both doors."

I nodded as I concentrated MF on my back. However, as I attempted to use my MF against the door behind, I felt an opposite force which not only absorbed my MF, it also pushed me closer to Gaoqin Jiuye.

Gaoqin Jiuye sounded a little perturbed when he said, "Wait."

He tried moving. "Do you feel it? The space between the doors seem to get smaller and smaller the more we use MF against them."

Yes, I felt it too. It was infinitely obvious to the both of us who were cramped in here even though it became only a fraction smaller.

"Come over here beside me and try again." Gaoqin Jiuye gestured to his right.

I tried moving over to his right, but the space was extremely tiny and my chest had to brush against his back in order for me to move... *Damn it, this was too awkward.*

“Well, don’t be too embarrassed now, yours are pretty small...”

“Shut up,” I said in annoyance.

I felt Gaoqin Jiuye’s fierce heartbeat against my chest once again. Shutting my eyes, I squeezed over to the right.

Finally, we had more space now. I moved around to celebrate this tiny freedom as I heaved a sigh of relief.

I looked at Gaoqin Jiuye, and I realized he was looking at me. I was a little embarrassed as I thought of what happened moments ago. “What’re you looking at?”

He kept his eyes on me. “I realized that sometimes, you’re actually...”

I raised a hand to stop him. “I know, I’m pretty cute sometimes. Don’t say things like that at times like these.”

Gaoqin Jiuye smirked. “I wanted to say that I thought you were pretty dumb at times.”

“...”

“What’s going on with the both of you?” We heard Li Wen from the other side of the stone door.

I answered loudly, “We can’t use MF against the door, it’ll only make the space in between them smaller.”

“Then what do we do?”

I rolled my eyes as I shouted, “How would I have any idea when even you two soul splitters don’t know what to do?”

Gaoqin Jiuye turned around to face the first stone door. I did the same.

“Let’s try using force if we can’t use MF,” he said.

“Got it.”

We then placed our hands against the stone door, bottoms pressed against the other stone door behind us. It was rather unsightly.

“Ready? One, two, three, push.”

I pushed as hard as I could. Gaoqin Jiuye used so much strength that his face turned red, but the stone door did not budge at all.

I was drenched in perspiration after a while. “Stop stop stop. This is too tiring. I don’t think it works.”

“Is there another button or switch inside?” Li Wen sounded a little impatient outside.

“How about that button outside? Does it work?”

Li Wen responded, “I’ve already tried it. It doesn’t work anymore. I’m guessing that it only works once.”

There was nothing for Gaoqin Jiuye and I to do but to look for possible switches in this space.

There was no light in this space at all. It was pitch black and all I could see was Gaoqin Jiuye even when I increased my visibility through MF. I wasn’t able to see any of the walls here.

We felt around for some time, but there were no other clues.

“What do we do now,” I sulked.

Gaoqin Jiuye said, “We’ve been trying to use our MF on the walls, but we haven’t tried using it against the stone ground below us.”

I hit my head against the stone door as I looked down at the ground.

“Aiyo.” I held my head. “That makes sense. Though this piece of ground seems to be tiny, that might just work. Let’s try to focus our MF on the bottom of our feet then.”

Gaoqin Jiuye and I started to do just that. Though the ground did not absorb our MF, it seemed to be useless as well.

I sighed. “The ground doesn’t absorb MF, but if this really was the ground, it probably wouldn’t have much of an effect either.”

The ground started quaking just as I said this. I looked at Gaoqin Jiuye and subconsciously grabbed his left hand. *I’ve fallen too many times. This time, I’d prepare a cushion for myself.*

The shaking lasted for two whole seconds before the ground below our feet disappeared and we started tumbling downwards.

“Ahhhhhhhh—” There was light now, but we were both still falling. I grabbed Gaoqin Jiuye’s hand tightly as cold wind blew past me.

We seemed to be falling from quite a height. We just kept falling, to the point that both Gaoqin Jiuye and I even attempted to stop ourselves in mid-air by using our MF.

It did not work, but at least we did not crash into the water below us. We landed gently on an icy surface.

“What the hell. Where’s this place? It’s cold...” I shivered as I looked around me.

Both of us were in icy water. We seemed to be surrounded by glacial ice and the ice broke where we landed on it.

“Don’t know. Let’s get out of this place first. Don’t you find it cold?” Gaoqin Jiuye glanced at me as he tried to leap out of the water. I also activated my MF under my feet in an attempt to escape this icy river.

However, we ended up just staring at each other.

There was no way to use MF in this icy river. Every time I tried to use my MF, it felt like it was being sucked into the river.

I said, “What’s up with this demon cave and all these places...”

Gaoqin Jiuye breathed out, trying to regulate his breath in this bitter cold. “Let’s try to use strength if we can’t use MF.”

Both of us then started swimming towards the ice. I heard a crack as soon as my hand grasped a corner of the ice. The ice just shattered in my hand.

Crack.

I turned around, realizing that the ice cracked at Gaoqin Jiuye’s side too.

“This ice, it’s too weak...” I shivered as I said. The water was so cold that I tried to use MF to quicken my blood circulation and heat myself up. But it was a futile effort every time I tried it, since my MF would immediately be absorbed by the water.

Gaoqin Jiuye tried using one hand instead of two. Though the ice was not thin, it was extremely weak. It shattered with just a touch.

“Seems like we’re fated to freeze to death here.” Gaoqin Jiuye laughed.

Don’t say these things like it’s nothing...

“Can soul splitters freeze to death too?” I continued shivering.

Gaoqin Jiuye shrugged. “Probably not. But this is way too cold, and we can’t use MF either. I’m guessing we’d probably end up frozen in here, like an ice sculpture.”

He sounded as if he was narrating an interesting story, and he even positioned himself like an ice sculpture as he spoke. *What is wrong with this guy...*

It was getting colder and colder, as if the cold was spreading right into my bones. Even though Gaoqin Jiuye was not shivering like I was, his lips were already turning purple. Even then, he still looked beautiful.

“Gao, Gao, Gaoqin Jiuye. Say something, quick. It’s so cold...” My lips felt like they were already frozen.

Gaoqin Jiuye suddenly swam towards me. He turned me around and hugged me from behind. Cold permeated the air.

“Is it still cold like this?” He asked.

I continued shivering. “Of course it’s cold. You think this is the Titanic...”

Gaoqin Jiuye hugged me harder, trying to warm me up with his body. His heartbeat did not feel as strong as it used to be, maybe because the water was just too cold here.

I looked in front of me and saw nothing but glacial ice surrounding the icy water. This was a world made of ice. I wondered if there really was such a place in the real world.

“Gao, Gaoqin, Gaoqin Jiuye. Do you find this place weird...”

“How is it weird...” Gaoqin Jiuye spoke softly. It sounded like he was feeling really cold as well.

I licked my almost frozen lips. “There’s water below the ice, and logically speaking, shouldn’t it be zero degrees? But this doesn’t feel like it’s zero, it feels like it’s sub-zero...”

“This is the Split Zone, don’t use your real world logic here. Moreover, we’re in the demon cave in the Gate of Ghost. It’s known to be a mysterious place, so nothing is too weird here...”

Chapter 186

186 Demon

“You, you think of something...” I tried to move .

Gaoqin Jiuye let me go suddenly . “Since we can’t use MF, let’s try to move . At least we’ll be able to warm ourselves up a little bit with some exercise...”

But we both knew this was not a long-term solution .

I tried to grab hold of the ice around me . The ice still shattered upon the slightest touch .

I then had an epiphany . I looked at Gaoqin Jiuye . “Remember how we solved the problem when we were in between the stone doors?”

Gaoqin Jiuye’s eyes shone . “You mean we swim towards the bottom of the river?”

I nodded . “Though this has its risks, since we might end up frozen under the water, it beats just staying here and doing nothing . ”

Gaoqin Jiuye stretched out a hand towards me, and I hung onto that tiny bit of warmth from his palm . “Let’s go together then . ”

Seeing his resolute gaze, we dived into the water hand in hand .

The water was extremely clear . We were swimming towards the bottom at an extremely slow pace, since we couldn’t use our MF for now . I opened my eyes wide as I tried to take in everything that was in the water .

It was so cold that my eyeballs felt like they were frozen as soon as I opened my eyes . Though the water was clear, we were not able to see far . No matter how much MF I focused on my eyes, visibility remained the same .

We had been swimming for quite some time now, but there was nothing but white . As I looked up, I realized we were already quite a distance away from the surface .

My body was so rigid that it felt like ice now . Without that tiny bit of warmth from Gaoqin Jiuye's hand, I might even think that I was actually made of ice .

As time passed, I began to wonder if I was still swimming . I was beginning to lose all feeling in my body .

When it seemed like all was lost, a bright light appeared in front of us . Gaoqin Jiuye and I looked at each other, overjoyed at this . We swam towards that light with newfound motivation .

The light got brighter and brighter as we neared it . As we were finally surrounded by that light, my eyes seemed to be pierced through by it . I shut my eyes in pain, letting go of Gaoqin Jiuye's hand .

The bitter cold disappeared in an instant . Heat overcame me . I snapped my eyes open . Looking around, Gaoqin Jiuye and I had already surfaced .

Where is this place . We looked at each other, both lost .

This seemed to be a secret room . It was very wide, like an underground palace . We were standing in a squarish vat of water . But why was the water bubbling?

In the next second, I realized it was actually boiling!

“That's hot . ” Activating my MF, I leapt out of the water quickly . Gaoqin Jiuye had already jumped out before I did .

Gaoqin Jiuye and I ended up on opposite sides of the vat . I waved my arms around as I tried to cool them down . The water was so hot that my arms had already turned red .

More and more bubbles appeared in the water we just jumped out of . The water was boiling now...

“Where’s this place?” Gaoqin Jiuye looked around with a frown .

“Where’s this place?” Gaoqin Jiuye looked around with a frown .

The room looked like it was made of stone, as if it was created by digging into the ground . There was an upside down torch on the wall, giving this place an empty and mysterious vibe .

This stone room was extremely large . There were vats of different sizes, and some stone stairs . It looked like it was a connection of stone palaces .

“Let’s go and take a look around . ” I waved to Gaoqin Jiuye .

“This demon cave is really weird . The scene changes so quickly, but there’s no one to be seen here . Does such a cave only exist in the Gate of Ghost?” I asked as we started walking .

Gaoqin Jiuye shook his head . “If you’re referring to demon caves, there’s only one that’s this mysterious in the Gate of Ghost . I’m not sure about the Gate of Heaven and the Gate of Exit, since I haven’t been there for a long time . ”

“Right, why did you and Si Luo decide to leave the Gate of Heaven in the past?” I looked at Gaoqin Jiuye .

He pondered for a moment before speaking . “No particular reason . The world of soul splitters is a complicated one . It’s more cut-throat than you think . Though I’m no saint myself, I’m sure you can see it too, that Si Luo is a rare breed . He’s someone who has a sense of justice . He’s an exception among the soul splitters . ”

With this, I think I would have understood Gaoqin Jiuye even if he didn't explain any further .

When someone is described as being the 'exception', it can mean only one of two things – that they are either adored or despised .

“Most soul splitters do not agree with Si Luo's views and his mindset, even when we were in the Gate of Heaven, where we tried to keep the peace as our way of life . Some things happened, and Si Luo left the Gate of Heaven . As for me, I left with him willingly . ”

“So, do you mean that most soul splitters in the Gate of Heaven can be considered kind? Are those in the Gate of Ghost evil then? But I don't find Satan Cang Ming that bad of a person . How about the Gate of Exit? What're they like?”

Gaoqin Jiuye looked into the distance . “In conclusion, the Gate of Heaven is a representation of justice in the world of soul splitters . The Gate of Ghost is a representation of evil, and the Gate of Exit, they can be considered neutral . But you know, it's always difficult to separate good and evil so clearly . To the soul splitters in the Gate of Heaven, the ones in the Gate of Ghost are evil . But to the ones in the Gate of Ghost, the Gate of Heaven is evil . ”

Gaoqin Jiuye looked into the distance . “In conclusion, the Gate of Heaven is a representation of justice in the world of soul splitters . The Gate of Ghost is a representation of evil, and the Gate of Exit, they can be considered neutral . But you know, it's always difficult to separate good and evil so clearly . To the soul splitters in the Gate of Heaven, the ones in the Gate of Ghost are evil . But to the ones in the Gate of Ghost, the Gate of Heaven is evil . ”

He heaved a sigh at this point . “It's difficult to decide what's good and what's evil . This is just a fight between different factions . ”

I became curious suddenly . “Then how did you guys get separated into these factions?”

Gaoqin Jiuye's eyes gleamed, but he did not respond . Seeing that he didn't want to continue, I didn't force him to answer either .

We walked up a flight of stone stairs to reach what was supposed to be a door, but there was no door to be seen in the stone doorframe . Looking at each other, we stepped through the frame . We were met with another flight of steps going downwards, leading us to another stone room . The room was incredibly spacious, and it was brightly lit with numerous upside down torches .

A stone platform was right in the middle of the room . The platform looked a like an altar, with a stone tablet on it .

A person was embedded in that stone tablet .

As I realized who it was, I ran over as quickly as I could, forgetting about Gaoqin Jiuye .

“Nie Zun...” I shouted as I activated my MF on both my eyes and my feet, trying to reach that stone tablet as quickly as I could while taking a clearer look to see if it really was Nie Zun .

Sadly, I could always recognize Nie Zun easily and there was no way I could've seen wrong .

The stone room was too huge . Only when I closed in did I realize the stone platform was an entire head taller than me . The stone tablet was right in the middle on top of the platform . The tablet was about three meters tall, and it had the width of about two persons standing shoulder to shoulder .

Nie Zun was embedded in that tablet . He no longer had those ugly scars on his face, and he was still dressed in black . His gloves were gone and his eyes were shut, looking like he was in a restful sleep .

There was a red mark in between his brows . Upon closer look, it resembled a flame .

I felt uneasy about this platform . I tried to leap up onto it, but something weird happened at this moment .

There was a red mark in between his brows . Upon closer look, it resembled a flame .

I felt uneasy about this platform . I tried to leap up onto it, but something weird happened at this moment .

As I was about to touch the platform, it produced a light, and I seemed to have been bounced backwards by that light . The reflective force was very strong .

Gaoqin Jiuye managed to catch me as I fell, and we both tumbled on the ground . The light then slowly dissipated .

I shook my head . “Impossible . What’s happening?”

I wanted to try again, but I was stopped by Gaoqin Jiuye . “Don’t be too hasty . Let’s take a look at the stone platform first . ”

I was afraid for Nie Zun as I wondered what that mark on his forehead meant . Though filled with worry, I still listened to Gaoqin Jiuye .

That light appeared once again as we touched the platform . Both Gaoqin Jiuye and I were forced to retreat with its force . We looked at each other, and Gaoqin Jiuye signaled for me to go over to the back to have a look .

It was about a five-meter walk to reach the back of the stone platform . The platform was a square, and it looked the same from both the front and the back .

We looked up at the back of the tablet . It was a bluish-gray, and we could not really tell what it was made of . A word was engraved in red on the back of that tablet . The word was huge and it was the height of a human being .

The word was...

‘Demon’ .

Chapter 187

187 Who Are You

“Demon...”

Gaoqin Jiuye looked quite perturbed .

I looked at Gaoqin Jiuye blankly . “I thought we shouldn’t explore further when we see the word ‘demon’, but there doesn’t seem to be anywhere else around here that we can explore, is there?”

Gaoqin Jiuye lowered his head in thought . “Maybe the word is here to warn us not to go too close to this platform . ”

I was slightly agitated at this . “Then how about Nie Zun? Why is he there? What’ll happen to him...”

Gaoqin Jiuye shook his head . “I don’t know either . I really don’t . ”

I ignored him and walked back to the front of the platform .

Gaoqin Jiuye followed closely behind . “What’re you doing? Li Shen, we should think about this first . We don’t have any idea what’s going on here . Have you forgotten that stone door and the river? They all absorb MF . It’s dangerous here . Can you please just calm down?”

Calm down? I can only do that if it doesn’t involve Nie Zun . I did not respond .

I pulled my arm away when he grabbed it . “Li Shen,” Gaoqin Jiuye shouted at me loudly .

I stopped in my tracks, not turning around .

“Li Shen, do you like Nie Zun?” Gaoqin Jiuye asked suddenly .

I remained silent, continuing on my path after a couple of seconds .

“Li Shen . ” He called out again .

I did not turn .

“Isn’t Gao Qi the only one you love?

“Why did you betray him if he was the only one you loved?”

I shut my eyes .

I turned around as I opened them, rushing towards Gaoqin Jiuye as I did so .

I looked straight into his eyes . “When have I betrayed Gao Qi? How I wish I did betray him, since that’s far better than killing him . He’d leave me forever if I killed him, so I’d rather everyone hate me for betraying him . Why do you keep asking me this? Yes, I love him, so what? I still ended up killing him in the end . ”

My eyes were turning red . “I caused his death .

“Why are all of you forcing me? I didn’t want to be District Commander, I didn’t want to lose Li Qing, I didn’t want to leave this place, I don’t want to see the people around me die because of me . Why are all of you forcing me...

“I just have an extra personality, where did I go wrong? Why did I have to be ostracized... Why must I become a weapon in the war amongst soul splitters just because I have a second personality...”

I stared at him with angry tears . “What did I do wrong? Why do you have to keep mentioning Gao Qi... Do you think I’m happy to see someone who looks exactly like him...”

I realized I was a little too emotional at this point .

Gaoqin Jiuye's eyes darkened .

Gaoqin Jiuye's eyes darkened .

I looked away after taking a few breaths . “Sorry, I was too carried away . ”

I wiped my tears away as I turned around, making my way towards the platform once again . “Gaoqin Jiuye, Nie Zun had been by my side for two whole years . I've lost too many people, and I don't want to lose any more of them . ”

I stopped . “You Ji is dead, killed by Du Yue . Yuan Shen is also dead . You might not know him though . He's a friend of mine from the Western District .

“I don't want to lose anyone else . ”

When I reached the platform this time, I scrutinized it very closely . Gaoqin Jiuye was right . I had to stay calm . A solution can only be found when we look at it with a clear head .

Gaoqin Jiuye walked up to me while I tried to think of a solution . “I shouldn't have said all that,” he said softly .

I kept quiet . He looked up at Nie Zun, and laughed in self-mockery . “I don't know what's gotten over me at times . When I'm with you, I'm just like a child who didn't get his candy . You can just treat me like I've gone insane . ”

My heart hurt a little at this .

“Right now, let's think of a way to save him . ” Gaoqin Jiuye pointed at Nie Zun .

I looked around the place . “Did you see any exits when we walked in from the previous stone room?” There was nothing else except for stairs, vats of boiling water, torches, and this huge platform in the middle .

Gaoqin Jiuye pondered for a moment . “No, I’m sure of it . Even though both rooms are similar, there’s nothing like a door here . This place is probably sealed . ”

I frowned . How did Nie Zun get in here?

“I know you must be wondering how Nie Zun ended up here . Don’t forget that we leapt out of almost boiling water earlier . This is the demon cave, weird things happen here, so it’s not that surprising that he’s here too .

“I know you must be wondering how Nie Zun ended up here . Don’t forget that we leapt out of almost boiling water earlier . This is the demon cave, weird things happen here, so it’s not that surprising that he’s here too .

“I wonder where Si Luo, Cang Ming and Guan Nie are...”

“Oh . ” I turned to face him . “Weren’t you together with them earlier? Why did you guys get separated?”

“We arrived at the entrance of this cave and Cang Ming didn’t want me following them . But I heard Cang Ming’s voice shortly after they entered, saying that they fell into Du Yue’s trap . He then asked me to return to help Bian Ying out, afraid that Du Yue would hurt her . ”

So it’s like this... That made sense . According to Du Yue, she set up an illusion in the cave, so Cang Ming and the rest might have lost their way within the illusion . Since the structure of this cave changes daily, we didn’t take the same path as Cang Ming and the rest .

However, we’ll probably end up at the same destination, because we’d see the word ‘demon’ at the end .

But if Du Yue trapped them in an illusion, would they still be able to arrive here?

Maybe Du Yue’s aim wasn’t to hurt them but to stall them, so that they couldn’t return to me and Bian Ying so quickly . Or maybe it just so

happened that Cang Ming and the rest weren't able to go too deeply into the cave because of Du Yue's illusions . But it was different for Nie Zun .

I don't know about the others, but I knew it was difficult to trap Nie Zun with an illusion .

I've realized this much earlier, and it was proven time and again when he tried to bring me out of an illusion . He had some sort of immunity to illusions since he had that pupil technique of his . He used his eyes for that, and since illusions are formed through the eyes, it was difficult to control Nie Zun through his eyes . It might have been because of this that Nie Zun arrived here on his own .

But why was he trapped on the platform?

"How about this," I said to Gaoqin Jiuye . "I'll use Piercer and you use Shen Qi . Let's see if it does anything to the platform . "

Gaoqin Jiuye whipped Shen Qi out . "Got it . "

As I took Piercer in my hand, I suddenly felt touched by Gaoqin Jiuye's actions . I had to admit that I thought he did not have a heart . He was still pretty cold and emotionless, and he'd still choose Si Luo above everything else . I could understand this, but I just thought that he should have been an extremely selfish individual, since he only cared about that one person alone .

I'd think it normal if he did, but I realized he seemed a little different when it came to me . It was not gratitude, but I was still a little touched by what he did . He whipped Shen Qi out without the slightest bit of hesitation just because I suggested it . It just didn't seem like something he would have done .

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“Why're you blanking out? Let's attack this platform together . You want to continue staying in here? I don't want to be trapped here . ” Gaoqin Jiuye waved a hand in front of me . I take back my words about him .

We lifted our weapons . Lift, whip . Lift, slash . Two rays of blinding light raced towards the platform .

The platform produced a dazzling light . Three sources of light seemed to congregate for a second before everything disappeared . Though the force wasn't reflected, it did not seem to have any effect on that platform either .

I was a little deflated at this . “No change at all . ”

Gaoqin Jiuye said seriously, “That's funny . The force should've been reflected by the platform just like earlier . The only difference now is that we're using living weapons instead of plain MF . Why did it get cancelled out instead of being reflected this time?”

That's right, it was a little different compared to before .

“Shall we try again?” I asked Gaoqin Jiuye .

He thought for a bit before shaking his head . “I'm trying to figure out why this happened . Have you noticed that the light produced by the platform was a little different this time? The light wasn't this bright earlier, and it didn't feel so... alive . ”

“What do you mean by alive?” I asked, confused .

Gaoqin Jiuye looked serious . “Before, it felt like it was some sort of reflective force, like the platform had a reflective screen . It did not have any attacking prowess, and it felt like a mere defense mechanism . But just now, it felt like more than just a defense mechanism at play . It felt like it was some kind of force belonging to a living person . ”

Force belonging to a living person? Was there someone else here? I suddenly thought Gaoqin Jiuye made a lot of sense . I started looking around again . No one was in sight .

As my eyes landed on Nie Zun, I realized who this ‘someone else’ was .

Nie Zun, asleep earlier, had his eyes open now . The mark resembling a flame in the middle of his brows was glowing bright red .

Chapter 188: 188 Nie Zun Turns into a Demon?

Volume 3

188 Nie Zun Turns into a Demon?

“Nie Zun...”

I mumbled with a slight tremble in my voice.

I heard Gaoqin Jiuye beside me, but I couldn't hear him as clearly as before. “That's it. It should've been him who cancelled out our attacks.”

I continued looking at Nie Zun, who stayed absolutely still. His eyes were open and it seemed like he was looking at me, but at the same time, it looked like he was looking elsewhere.

I was a little afraid now.

I was afraid because Nie Zun's eyes looked like they belonged to a stranger. I've never seen such foreign eyes on him before.

I'm not afraid if Nie Zun ends up disfigured. I'm not afraid if I see a demon in him, or if he just turns into one himself. But at this point, I feared that unfamiliar and alien gaze of his.

A light emanated from the tablet behind him. He walked down unhurriedly as he was bathed in that light.

The platform was huge. Step by step, he finally reached the end of it.

His hair was a little longer now, and his wispy bangs seemed to flutter even in this sealed up space. His eyes were a pure black and he was still in that black coat. The ends of his coat also seemed to be fluttering on its own.

The starlight in his eyes was replaced by a cold and ruthless gleam. He looked down at Gaoqin Jiuye and I from the top of the platform. The mark in between his brows was so red it looked like blood would drip out of it anytime.

Gaoqin Jiuye shielded me with a hand in front. He spoke in a low tone, “Be careful. Nie Zun seems a little different.”

I was angered by this and I called out loudly, “Nie Zun.”

Eerie silence followed. Nie Zun stood on the platform, hands relaxed by his sides as he looked at me with disdain.

He finally spoke. “Do you wish to die?”

My eyes widened. *This.... What’s he talking about...* I wanted to say something, but nothing came out when I opened my mouth. Gaoqin Jiuye then grabbed me, as if afraid I would act rashly.

Nie Zun glanced at the hand grabbing me, and looked at me again. “Who is the one who disturbed my sleep. Do you wish to die?”

I felt myself shiver at this. My hands balled themselves up into fists. “Who. Are you.”

There was no change in Nie Zun. “I’m Nie Zun. Why? Do you know me?”

I felt like collapsing to the ground. *What’s wrong with him... Can anyone tell me?*

Is he suffering from amnesia... How clichéd is this...

Seeing Gaoqin Jiuye and I silent, anger seemed to rise in him. He looked at us with a furious disdain as an air vortex formed behind him. The air vortex

turned into a dragon made of wind which started flying around the platform, surrounding him as it ruffled his coat and hair.

That vortex seemed to be ready to attack us anytime. Seeing Nie Zun do this, white fog surged in Gaoqin Jiuye's eyes immediately.

Unexpectedly, nothing happened.

Gaoqin Jiuye looked confused at this, and he looked downcast as he realized why.

“The air currents in the cave cannot be controlled with MF.”

I was surprised to hear this. *Why can't it be done if it's just air... We really can't do anything with MF here in this space?*

There was no extra time for me to think as Nie Zun's air vortex raced towards Gaoqin Jiuye and I, producing an eerie echo in this space.

Gaoqin Jiuye grabbed my hand tightly as he pulled me backwards.

I could feel the force from the air vortex. It was much stronger than that of Gaoqin Jiuye's or Jiao S's. Though we had already retreated to a distance of more than 10 meters away, it was still coming at us.

I then made a decision.

I focused my MF onto the hand Gaoqin Jiuye was holding. When the air vortex was closing in, I pushed Gaoqin Jiuye to the right. He did not expect me to do that as he looked at me in shock.

However, there was no time for him to react. He was simply flung sideways by me. At the same time, I stepped forward to welcome the air vortex.

Boom.

It hit me point-blank and I fell flat on my back.

“Pch...” I lay sideways as I coughed out a mouthful of blood. The force was greater than I had imagined it to be. All my organs felt like they were shattered with just that blow.

My body then began healing itself as I was still coughing up blood. I heaved an inward sigh of relief. *Lucky thing we could still regenerate in here.* I looked up at Nie Zun with difficulty as blood continued to spew from my mouth.

Doubt flashed in Nie Zun’s eyes, as if he couldn’t understand why I did not dodge his attack when I could have obviously done so.

He leapt off the platform with a light tap of his feet.

Gaoqin Jiuye rushed to my side to support me. He shouted, “Are you mad...”

I was panting. The pain of shattered organs is quite difficult to bear. Blood continued flowing out from the corner of my lips. I tried my best to stand, but the pain made it feel like my heart and lungs were burning. The only thing I could do was to lean against Gaoqin Jiuye for that extra bit of support.

I continued panting as I said to Nie Zun, “Do you know why I didn’t dodge your attack?”

Nie Zun stopped in his tracks, somewhere about three meters in front of me and Gaoqin Jiuye.

“Because.” Blood dripped out from my mouth. “I don’t believe that you don’t know me. I don’t believe that you’d really hurt me.”

Nie Zun narrowed his eyes, as if faced with a problem he couldn’t solve.

Gaoqin Jiuye looked at Nie Zun coldly as he held me. “Isn’t protecting her your very reason for existence? How could you bear to hurt her now?”

With those narrowed eyes, Nie Zun looked down at me. “You mean to say that I know you?”

I wiped the blood from the corner of my lips. That raging fire was still burning in my chest. “It’s not as simple as just knowing me. It’s that up to three days ago, we had always been together day and night. We got separated three days ago, and when I meet you here today, you had turned into this stranger.”

An evil gleam flashed in Nie Zun’s eyes. “Day and night? Are you my lover? A lover from a past life?”

I almost died at this. *Don’t be this ridiculous even when you’re an amnesiac... There’s no past life here in the Split Zone...* I rolled my eyes, tired of explaining further.

“Then tell me what happened to you. Why’re you here?” I wiped the blood from my mouth and leaned against Gaoqin Jiuye.

Nie Zun smiled at this, but that smile looked infinitely more malicious than before. Even so, I could tell that it belonged to Nie Zun. “Too many questions,” he said. *You should be saying that I know too much...*

“You really don’t know anything?” Gaoqin Jiuye shot a look at Nie Zun in disbelief.

Nie Zun’s eyes narrowed at Gaoqin Jiuye’s question. A strong air vortex began to race towards Gaoqin Jiuye. *Attacking without any preamble... Have you turned into a serial killer after losing your memory now...*

Though Nie Zun’s attack looked extremely powerful, Gaoqin Jiuye wasn’t someone who could be defeated so easily. Gaoqin Jiuye calmly supported me as I stood up. He called out, “Shen Qi.”

A dark shadow appeared, and Shen Qi already took the form of a human when I looked up, parrying Nie Zun’s attack easily.

Nie Zun’s eyes shone as he saw Shen Qi. “What’s this? It looks interesting.”

Gaoqin Jiuye smirked. “That’s my sword.”

Nie Zun looked at Shen Qi with admiration. “Sword. I’m taking it.”

He then appeared beside Shen Qi, reaching out a hand to grab it. He moved so fast that everything was a blur to me.

“What terrifying speed...” I said in surprise.

Gaoqin Jiuye had a grave look. “Exactly. What’s happening here.”

But Shen Qi was a sword spirit and it couldn’t be taken easily by just anyone. Shen Qi transformed into a ray of light, wrapping itself around Nie Zun.

Instead of being afraid, Nie Zun seemed to get excited at this. He grabbed Shen Qi and threw it at Gaoqin Jiuye’s feet. Shen Qi turned back into its human-shaped form as it stared angrily at Nie Zun.

I noticed dark fog surrounding both Nie Zun’s hands. That fog looked like the soul of a demon itself.

Nie Zun laughed. “Seems like it’s no longer as interesting as when I first saw it. What do I do now? I feel like killing the two of you.”

Chapter 189: 189 The Hand in My Heart

Volume 3

189 The Hand in My Heart

“Come and kill me.” I took a big step towards Nie Zun, pointing at my own heart.

Nie Zun looked at me like he was looking at a stranger.

That gaze enraged me. I whipped Piercer out and charged forward, using it as a lasso to circle his neck.

I pulled Piercer tight as I said, “Come on, aren’t you going to kill me? I’m going to attack if you don’t kill me now.”

I kept my eyes on Nie Zun, unwilling to believe that he’d hurt me. *Would feelings for another disappear if one had lost their memories? I refused to believe this.*

Confusion flashed in Nie Zun’s eyes.

Hope grew in me, but I realized I was wrong in the very next second.

Lifting a hand shrouded in black mist, Nie Zun stabbed that hand right through my chest. Just like the demon which devours human hearts in the *Strange Tales from a Chinese Studio*, he attempted to take my heart. (T/n: Known as *Liaozhai Zhiyi* in Chinese, *Strange Tales from a Chinese Studio* is a collection of classical Chinese tales with a supernatural spin in most of them. Here’s the Wikipedia page on it for some further information.)

Blood bubbled out of my mouth.

Gaoqin Jiuye rushed forward, looking anxious. Nie Zun still had his hand embedded in my chest, and not knowing what to do, he could only say, “Nie Zun, you’ve gone mad...”

Nie Zun had this dashing smile on his face. It wasn’t cruel. It wasn’t the kind of merciless smile one had after doing something ruthless. It was a casual kind of smile, the kind one had after completing a personal goal.

He was just like a newborn child now, doing anything and everything he wanted to without giving any thought to its consequences.

I might have gone mad as well. I actually felt relieved when Nie Zun stuck his hand through my chest. I suddenly felt that the Nie Zun of the past lived in such a suppressed manner.

Nie Zun was actually a kind person. He was always so lonely, but so kind. He doesn’t hate the world for ostracizing him. Even in the Split Zone, he had never blamed me no matter how cold I was to him.

I was like a porcupine, wrapping myself up to protect myself. But in the end, I ended up hurting everyone around me.

Nie Zun was like a snail. He meant no harm to anyone at all even when he looked like he had an extremely tough shell. He had been suppressing his real self all this time, being indifferent to the world.

Being indifferent to others wasn’t cruel. It was because he wasn’t qualified to join in.

But it was different now. I felt it and I was absolutely sure that this person in front of me was Nie Zun. He did not change, he simply lost his memories.

He forgot that everyone saw him as a bad omen, he forgot that countless people have said he was the harbinger of death, that he was disaster itself. He forgot how I blamed him for things, he forgot he had been captured here

to the Split Zone because he caused the death of his sister. He forgot everything.

All the cold looks from others, he had forgotten them all. This is why he could live as he pleased now.

Are humans born good or evil?

At this point, there's no good and evil to him. The only thing he's aware of is that Gaoqin Jiuye and I disturbed his sleep, and this is why he hurt us. This was what he wanted to do, and he doesn't think about his actions in terms of being good or evil. He is simply living for himself.

I don't know why I was suddenly filled with so much emotion. To anyone else, even to Gaoqin Jiuye and I, those hands shrouded in black mist looked absolutely demonic. However, when that hand plunged itself into my heart, all I felt was his loneliness.

It was a burning warmth that spread from my chest, as if it could burn me to ashes anytime.

Tears escaped my eyes. I blinked twice, and the tears kept on flowing.

Gaoqin Jiuye was stunned at this. Nie Zun still had his hand in my chest, and he looked confused when he saw me crying.

An innocent fury appeared in his eyes. He was furious because he couldn't understand my tears.

I felt the fingers in my chest open and close tightly as he grabbed my heart. Though my brows knitted in pain, I kept my eyes on Nie Zun.

There was an immense pain in my chest. I could feel all my nerves and blood vessels throb every single time my heart beats. *It was really painful...* The heart hurt, but my heart hurt even more.

Just when I thought my heart would be crushed, he let go of it suddenly, taking his hand out of my chest.

He looked at me for a moment before slapping Gaoqin Jiuye's hand on his shoulder away and walking back to the platform. He casually sat on the ground against the platform, elbow resting on his knees. Resting his chin on his palm, he looked at Gaoqin Jiuye and I with disinterest.

A piercing wind blew right through me when he took his hand out. I felt as if my heart was instantly frozen. From behind, Gaoqin Jiuye grabbed me by the shoulders as I was unsteady on my feet.

Though my red dress was already drenched in blood, it simply looked a darker red. The fabric had torn in some places, but the blood had coagulated and what was left was just a dark red mess.

I felt my heart spasm as the flesh and tendons regenerated. I could almost hear the sound of the flesh healing itself. Pain wrecked my entire body as my heart healed.

I panted as I asked Gaoqin Jiuye, "What do we do now? He's just like a kid who doesn't know anything, and we don't know how to escape from here either."

Gaoqin Jiuye said, "Like a kid? Even so, he's an extremely dangerous one."

I continued taking deep breaths to deal with the immense pain. Turning to Nie Zun, I said, "What're you so happy about?"

Nie Zun raised a brow in response, not answering my question. I continued, "Do you find that you've been asleep here for very long?"

Nie Zun continued ignoring me. The corner of my lips started to twitch with irritation. "If you've been here for that long, you should know how we can get out of this place, right?"

A light seemed to shine in Nie Zun's eyes. "Leave this place and go outside? What's there outside?"

Gaoqin Jiuye and I looked at each other. We spoke at the same time. "There're many things that you haven't seen outside."

Nie Zun looked jubilant. But that happiness turned into a smirk as he looked at me and Gaoqin Jiuye. “Why should I believe you guys?”

Well, seems like doubt is a natural defense mechanism in all humans. I raised my brows. “Then we have no choice but to continue staying in here if you don’t believe us. There’s no place else for us to go anyway.”

I pushed Gaoqin Jiuye away gently and sat on the ground, not minding it even if I looked nothing like a lady. (Passerby B: Looking like a lady... Don’t make me laugh. Me: I really want to kill you.)

Though Gaoqin Jiuye did not quite understand what I was trying to do, he followed my lead and sat cross-legged on the ground. My brows furrowed in pain as I put pressure on my chest. *Damn it, this hurt so much.*

Nie Zun looked surprised at my actions. But in the next moment, he shut his eyes and seemed to go to sleep with his chin still resting on his palm.

I was angered as I looked at how lazy he was. He was lazy right down to his bones, even when he had lost his memories. *Nie Zun, Nie Zun, I don’t think you’ll ever change this habit of yours.*

Was it because you were too lazy to escape from a fire and you ended up falling asleep that you arrived here? I really wanted to ask you this.

I felt like hitting that lazy face of his. I decided to lie on the ground as well. *Since I can’t escape, I’ll just take a nap.*

I stole a glance at Gaoqin Jiuye as I lay down. He had a befuddled expression on him, obviously confused by what we were doing.

That’s understandable. Anyone who saw this would think that Nie Zun and I were mad. One almost had her heart ripped out just seconds before, while the other was the one who was about to rip the other person’s heart out. But now, we’re both falling asleep. This is the beautiful combination of identity disorder and an incomplete personality.

I heard a familiar voice just when my thoughts were everywhere.

“Hehe, why’re you here? It’s boring here...”

My head snapped up. She was floating in mid-air, her face right in front of mine. Her red hair fell down gently, caressing my neck with a piercing cold. *This was quite terrifying. I wasn’t a scaredy-cat, but think about it, if there was a floating face talking right in front of you in mid-air when you opened your eyes, how would you feel about that?*

And it was a face that looked exactly like yours.

I cannot scream now. I’ve seen her too many times to be scared.

And also, I knew I had to keep this a secret right now. I cannot let anyone else know that I can see her with my split symbol activated, especially after what happened with Du Yue and Li Wen.

I simply looked at her in silence as she descended a little. The tip of her nose was almost touching mine now. She blew cold air into my face. With what sounded like a slight chuckle, she said, “Nie Zun has forgotten you. Are you sad...”

I turned to the side, not wanting to look her in the eye. I happened to meet Nie Zun’s eyes as I turned. He seemed to be looking at me, but he seemed to be looking elsewhere at the same time. His gaze was inscrutable.

I heard her again. “I can bring you out. Do you want to just tell them about my existence... Do you want my help...”

Chapter 190: 190 Ice Sculpture

Huan Qing

Volume 3

190 Ice Sculpture Huan Qing

Damn it, she's getting closer and closer to me.

Nie Zun spoke just when I thought I could no longer bear it and would scream for her to go away.

“Let’s go and have a look outside.” I realized she was gone after he spoke.

The three of us stood up.

“How do we get out?” I looked at Nie Zun with raised brows.

Nie Zun simply shrugged. “I don’t know. Let’s just have a look.”

We started exploring the room again. We tried using MF, but every single object in this space absorbs MF, and there was no way else to pass. There was no exit in sight either.

I wiped sweat off my face. “We’ve been looking around for so long but there’s no exit in sight. Hey, Nie Zun, do you really know where the exit is?”

Nie Zun did not look the slightest bit perturbed. “I don’t know.”

I was so annoyed at this. Gaoqin Jiuye said, “Since we arrived through here, do you think we can go back from here too?” He pointed at a vat of water

beside us.

My face wrinkled. “Bro, the water wasn’t boiling when we just arrived. Look at that boiling water now.”

Gaoqin Jiuye shrugged. “We won’t die from being scalded anyway.”

I smiled at him and pointed at the vat. “Good idea, great idea. You’re right, we won’t die from that. How about you jump in first?”

Gaoqin Jiuye glanced at Nie Zun with a mischievous smile. “How about you go first? You’re the strongest here, right?”

Nie Zun looked at that boiling water and said, “It’s too hot, I’m not going.”

A clean rejection.

There’s no way we can stay here forever and wait to turn into mummies. So, after about an hour or so of trying to figure out what to do, we eventually decided to jump into that boiling water.

The pain of a burn and the pain from a cut are different, but the pain of being scalded was the hardest to bear. I don’t think there’s anything that can compare to jumping into boiling water. There was no way to describe this.

The good thing was it didn’t last long before we were back in the icy river. I was overjoyed as I immersed myself in that icy water after being scalded in boiling water.

Even though we were in icy water now, the scalded skin still needed some time to heal. I was sure my tears and mucus would have flowed into the water. It was way too painful.

As I was floating casually in the water, thinking about how we can reach the ice without shattering it, a ray of light appeared in front of us. It looked like we were nearing the water surface.

We looked at one another before swimming towards it.

I asked Gaoqin Jiuye immediately as we broke through the surface, “Why didn’t we think of how to get out from here earlier? We can’t reach the ice here.”

“That’s right.” Gaoqin Jiuye frowned. He touched the ice around us, and to my surprise, the ice did not shatter. Just when I wanted to try it for myself, I realized that Nie Zun was already out of the water and standing on the ice.

Gaoqin Jiuye stretched a hand towards me. “What’re you blanking out for? Don’t you find it cold?” He then pulled me out of the water with him. Gaoqin Jiuye let me go as we reached the ice, looking slightly disgusted.

I glanced at Nie Zun and found him staring at me. *What’re you looking at?* I then happened to look at the icy surface, and I ended up scaring myself.

My face, neck and skin were all wrinkled and broken. It was also extremely red. I looked just like a female ghost. That was the result of being scalded.

I looked up angrily at the two of them with perfect-looking skin. “How did you guys heal so quickly...”

Gaoqin Jiuye shot me a look. “Don’t you know how to use MF to quicken the pace?”

I’m so annoyed. But I still did it anyway. Before long, my skin was as good as new.

“Where’s this place?” Nie Zun asked. This was the first thing he said after he decided to leave that enclosed room. I guess that’s just how he is. He doesn’t talk very much.

I pointed my chin at all the ice surrounding us. “You see it right, we’re in a glacier.”

“It’s really cold here.” Nie Zun looked around. *Right. My Nie Zun has become a childish little kid now.* Gaoqin Jiuye was not amused as he looked at Nie Zun, as if deep in thought.

“Let’s go towards that glacier, see if there’re any paths over there. We dropped down here through the ground. Look above you, it’s all blue sky. There’s no way we can find an exit above.”

Gaoqin Jiuye looked up at the sky. “No sun again.”

I only realized when he said it that there was no sun here, only an azure sky.

“Let’s go. Take a look in front.” Gaoqin Jiuye set off for that glacier. I followed closely behind. Nie Zun caught up only after he took in the sights around him.

We walked in silence. There was no wind or snow here, but an unnatural cold permeated the air in this bizarre environment. The icy surface below us seemed to continue forever, as if it was a path leading us to a glacial hell.

After walking for quite a distance, we realized that the glacier did not seem to be getting any closer. It seemed as if all our efforts had been wasted. We were still very far from the glacier.

“Why does it feel like this is a mirage.” I frowned as I broke the silence. I could no longer stand this silence.

Sadly, none of them were keen to engage me in conversation. They simply kept their eyes on the glacier in front.

My lips twitched. *The Split Zone is weird, the people here are weird. Weren’t these two at loggerheads before? Now that I look at it, they are a great match when they’re together in silence like this.*

Two cold, arrogant individuals.

You guys should call yourselves Gaoleng Jiuye and Nie Leng. (T/n: The Chinese character for ‘cold’ is leng, and Li Shen replaced a character in their names with leng.)

As I was still annoyed at being ignored, I realized we had already arrived at the foot of the glacier.

“What’s... happening here.” The glacier wasn’t small, but it wasn’t huge either. It seemed like a fake glacier, looking like a mountain was perfectly encased inside it under that smooth and dazzling exterior.

“It seemed to be so far away, but we arrived here so quickly.” Gaoqin Jiuye smiled mysteriously as he eyed the glacier with suspicion.

“There seems to be someone inside.” Nie Zun pointed a finger at the glacier right in front of us.

I could not see a thing through that shiny and reflective surface ice. I focused MF onto my eyes to see better, and what I saw ended up confusing me.

“Huan Qing... Why is he here?” I pointed at the standing figure embedded in the glacier. Huan Qing was still in his white suit, and it wasn’t easy to spot him in this glacier. Gaoqin Jiuye frowned. “This glacier isn’t hollow. Why would he be frozen in there? And we can see him from here.”

How would I know...

Nie Zun turned to me and asked, “You know this person?”

I nodded. “He’s my friend.”

Nie Zun smiled. “Then let’s get his corpse out of there. He won’t be having fun there alone anyway.” His eyes were gleaming with a wicked expectation as he looked at Huan Qing.

My lips twitched again. He didn’t sound like he wanted to save Huan Qing by getting him out. *I wonder if it would be better for Huan Qing to just stay in there...* But of course, there’s no way I would let Huan Qing stay here alone in this godforsaken place. So, we had to get him out first.

I lifted my left hand and pointed it at the glacier. “Scorpion Ray, shatter this ice.”

A great weapon would need a cool phrase to go with it. Ever since the Scorpion Ray embedded itself into my arm, I did feel a sort of resonance

with it. It had never disappointed me.

A bright light emanated from my left wrist, producing countless needles of light that flew towards the glacier.

I didn't hope for much at first, since I expected for the MF to be absorbed by the glacier. However, those needles actually pierced right into the glacier. The scene shattered like it was glass.

This isn't a glacier, it was a mountain of mirrors. The icy surface that enclosed the mountain shattered into pieces upon Scorpion Ray's attack.

Originally trapped in the ice, Huan Qing's figure could now be clearly seen.

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Huan Qing's face could be seen clearly now. Bits of frost stuck to his eyelashes on milky white skin that looked like it belonged to a newborn baby.

I rushed forward through the opening created by Scorpion Ray. "Huan Qing, Huan Qing, wake up." I pushed Huan Qing gently. His body was cold and rigid, and there was no reaction from him at all.

"Try using MF on him," advised Gaoqin Jiuye, who was following closely behind me. I focused my MF on my left hand and placed it on Huan Qing's chest in an attempt to wake him.

I felt an opposite force on my palm, and I looked at Gaoqin Jiuye with furrowed brows. "This is weird. It feels as if he's resisting the MF from me, but it feels like he's absorbing it at the same time. And..."

I shook my head, unsure of how else I can explain this. Gaoqin Jiuye took my hand away as he said, "Let me try."

Something out of the ordinary happened as Gaoqin Jiuye placed a hand on Huan Qing. Huan Qing's originally stiff body seemed to soften, and the ice that was on his face started to melt. As Huan Qing's real skin was exposed, it seemed to start shriveling up...

Gaoqin Jiuye's eyes widened. "He, his MF."

“What do you mean?”

Gaoqin Jiuye did not answer. Instead, he started moving his hand over Huan Qing's body. Huan Qing's eyes then slowly opened. The skin on his face made him look as if he was a middle-aged man now.

He seemed lost at first, but he recognized Gaoqin Jiuye and I very quickly.

“Ah Shen...” he called out softly.

I responded, “It's me, Huan Qing. Why're you here? What happened?”

Huan Qing coughed. “Ah Shen... get out of here...”

He shut his eyes and passed out before he could finish the sentence. His face was now a dark red color. Gaoqin Jiuye said, “His MF seems to be severely damaged. I'm guessing this might be caused by being trapped in this glacier. Let's get him out quickly.”

“Right.” I nodded as the two of us carried Huan Qing up. The glacier started quaking just as we were about to leave. There was a loud crash coming from under the ice below our feet.

Nie Zun looked surprised at the sudden change of events. He looked around with his hands in his coat pockets.

Boom.

The sound was getting louder and louder. Something seemed to be raging under the ice as cracks began appearing in the glacier Huan Qing was trapped in.

Taking a hand out of his pocket, Nie Zun pointed to somewhere behind us. “Hey, you guys are going to be trapped inside if you don't move faster.”

Huan Qing did not have a small frame, and he was frozen rigid. In his unconscious state, I found it rather strenuous even though both Gaoqin Jiuye and I were carrying him. But the main reason for this was that Gaoqin Jiuye was not even using any strength!

After hearing Nie Zun, I called out, “Since you know that, come over and help us out quickly!”

Nie Zun shot me a smile that was full of malice. *Fine, I guess I expected too much from him.* Gaoqin Jiuye and I quickened our pace at his reminder.

The cold seemed to be right on our tails now. We focused MF onto our feet and started running across the icy surface, but it felt like we were on a layer of oil.

The scenario was like this. There was a glacier that would collapse at any moment. Right in front of the glacier were a male and female carrying a man dressed in white, trying to escape from the collapsing glacier. By their side was a man dressed in black, helping the male and female out while enjoying the sight of the collapsing glacier.

Crash.

Whoosh...

The glacier had collapsed behind us. We almost fell from the force.

“Phew. This place is huge. I’m so tired after running even when I use MF,” I said as I bent down, trying to catch my breath.

Gaoqin Jiuye and Nie Zun looked at the collapsed glacier as if deep in thought. I found it funny that they could remain so calm at this.

Gaoqin Jiuye glanced at Huan Qing, who now lay on the ground. “I still don’t get it. Why would he be here?”

I rolled my eyes. “Nie Zun can lose his memory here, so what’s there to wonder about.”

Nie Zun raised his brows. “I lost my memory? I really knew you from before?”

I couldn’t be bothered to explain further.

Gaoqin Jiuye pointed at the rubble in front of us which took up the space of an entire soccer field. “Let’s go over and take a look. We might be able to find some clues.”

“What about Huan Qing? It’s impossible for us to carry him around like this right?” I pointed at Huan Qing who was on the ground.

Gaoqin Jiuye tilted his chin towards Nie Zun. “Let him stay here to keep an eye on him.”

Gaoqin Jiuye, I’m sure you’re enemies with Huan Qing.

You’re letting this unpredictable fellow keep an eye on Huan Qing? Are you sure he wouldn’t accidentally kill Huan Qing in the spur of a moment?

I expected Nie Zun to protest, but he shrugged casually and made it seem like it was nothing. “Sure. Go ahead. I’m not that interested in that place anyway.”

He then proceeded to pat down his coat to clear the bits of ice before sitting cross-legged on the ground, elbows resting on his knees.

He looked at us lazily. “Go ahead.”

Seeing that I didn’t leave, he waved a lazy hand at me. “Go on.”

Fine, I shall not argue with you now, since you’re acting like a demented child after having lost your memory. I followed Gaoqin Jiuye to the glacial rubble after rolling my eyes at Nie Zun.

With MF, I could move really fast if I was not carrying anyone. The cold wind blew past me as I ran. As we reached the icy rubble, I looked backwards at Nie Zun. He was but a tiny black dot in the distance.

“You go there, I’ll be over here. Let’s see if we can find any clues in this icy mess,” Gaoqin Jiuye said as he pointed somewhere.

You guys really love to point at things. The ice was extremely uneven and it was rather deep. I initially thought it was a mountain encased in ice, but this

seemed to be made entirely of ice and snow.

It was like searching for a needle in a haystack. I took Piercer out, concentrated my MF on it and whipped it against the ice.

Crack.

White smoke appeared as huge blocks of ice shattered. *Brrr, it's cold here.*

“Hey, Li Shen, I found someone here,” Gaoqin Jiuye called out to me.

“Right, I’m coming over now.” Taking a corner of my red dress in one hand and Piercer in the other, I ran quickly towards Gaoqin Jiuye.

I tripped in my haste.

Crash.

I was tripped by something horizontal. Falling flat on my face, I got cut by an icicle that happened to be on the ground when I fell. I touched my face and saw blood on my hands as I struggled to get up.

“Damn. It’s tiring just using MF in such cold conditions. I can’t regenerate as quickly either. So much blood from this tiny icicle.”

“Hey, what’re you mumbling about there? How can you be this dumb and fall?” Gaoqin Jiuye shouted.

You could actually hear me mumbling... Did you use MF to enhance all your five senses? I adjusted my dress and just as I was about to pick Piercer up from the ground, I saw a leg in the ice.

This was the leg that tripped me earlier.

“What’re you doing there... Come over and help me get this person out.” Gaoqin Jiuye continued to call out.

Looking at that leg in the ice, I answered, “I’ve found someone here too. Don’t be lazy and get that person out yourself.”

I picked up Piercer and used it to gently swipe away all the ice on that leg. The trapped individual was finally exposed after I cleaned up all that ice.

I was stunned as I recognized who it was. I looked up and shouted towards Gaoqin Jiuye, “It’s Mi Fu!”

Gaoqin Jiuye seemed to be looking at the person he had just dug out. “It’s Ku Fei over here.”

So Huan Qing and the two of them actually arrived here after going missing in the Southern District.

But why did they just disappear from the Southern District? Did they reach this glacier directly or were they brought here by somebody else...

No, it wasn’t quite possible for them to get caught since Huan Qing had a high MF. There’re not many from the Northern District who have the ability to trap the three of them here at the same time.

So was this the demon cave’s power, spatial transference?

But why did it have to be the three of them?

There was no time for me to think about this now. I squatted and started digging to get Mi Fu out of the ice. Her rosy cheeks were slowly exposed as I brushed the ice away.

Her face looked like a flower in bloom. It looked like it had just received a shower in the rain, looking fresh and adorable. I picked her up and walked over to Gaoqin Jiuye.

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192 When It All Comes to an End

“Look, his skin is aging as well.” I pointed at Ku Fei while Mi Fu was in my other arm.

Gaoqin Jiuye pointed at Mi Fu as he said, “But she still looks young. She originally looked like a child, and now she looks even younger.”

I frowned as I looked at Ku Fei’s wrinkled face. *What caused this?*

“No matter the reason, let’s just bring them back to where Nie Zun is. I’m a bit concerned if Huan Qing’s alone with Nie Zun,” Gaoqin Jiuye said.

I raised a brow. “You actually worry about Huan Qing? You don’t seem to be that kind.”

Gaoqin Jiuye smirked. “I’m definitely no saint, but I don’t wish for Nie Zun to go crazy and kill them all either. If that happens, we’ll be the only three left here. How boring would that be?”

I rolled my eyes at him. Ignoring him, I walked back towards Nie Zun with Mi Fu in my arms. My speed was cut down greatly when I had to carry someone else. I only caught up with Gaoqin Jiuye when I focused MF on my feet.

Huan Qing had woken up when we returned. He was sitting on the ground with a hand pressing against his chest. I placed Mi Fu beside him, and

Gaoqin Jiuye placed Ku Fei on his other side.

“How’re you feeling Huan Qing? What happened here?” I asked as I bent down to look at him.

Huan Qing looked like he was in his sixties now. After coughing a bit, he spoke slowly, “I don’t know. I thought it was Mr Blond when that golden light appeared that day in the Southern District, but we ended up being frozen in that glacier. The cold here can devour someone’s heart and mind, and before long, I lost all feeling in my five senses.”

“That’s it?”

Huan Qing nodded with effort. “Yes, that’s it. I have no idea what happened, or who brought the three of us here. It was terrifying being under that ice. The cold was a piercing cold that shot right through your bones, and it felt as if that cold was picking at you bit by bit, that it was taking away my MF slowly. I thought I was going crazy as my MF slowly drained out of me, but there was nothing here in this glacier except for cold and silence, so how do I even go mad here?”

He then touched his face and heaved a sigh. “I seem to have aged a lot.”

I felt upset about this, but I had to ask. “Yes, you feel it too? Is this caused by draining of your MF or the draining of one’s life force?”

Huan Qing pondered before speaking. “It could be caused by both. I suspect that someone attempted to drain my MF and life force, but I can’t figure out who had the ability to do such a thing here in the Split Zone.”

“But why didn’t she get older? She looks even younger now. Only you and Ku Fei had signs of aging after getting out of that glacier.” I asked as I pointed at Mi Fu.

Huan Qing glanced at Mi Fu. “I don’t know either. This is all too weird. And, I’m not praising myself here, but with my abilities, it’s not that easy to take me somewhere and trap me.”

He was right. He shouldn't be underestimated as the top illusionist in the Southern District. If there was someone who could control him, I probably wouldn't be able to win that individual easily either.

“Right, what happened to you guys after that?” Huan Qing asked with concern.

How should I explain this to him...

Should I say that two of my friends have died after you left?

Should I say that I tried all ways and means to reach the Northern District, only to find out that I have the power to kill soul splitters and that I've become an in-demand weapon in the war amongst soul splitters?

Or should I say that the Eastern, Western and Southern Districts have all turned into piles of rubble?

I didn't know where to start.

“We arrived here after you left, and the Eastern, Western and Southern Districts have all been destroyed by the soul splitters,” Gaoqin Jiuye explained evenly without the slightest hint of hesitation.

He easily completed a task I found extremely difficult.

A look of disbelief was on Huan Qing. “What did you say? You're not lying?” He then looked at me, waiting for either an affirmation or a denial.

I could only nod.

“How could that be...” he muttered. *That's right, how could that be? I wanted to know why it happened too.*

“Ugh...” Ku Fei made a sound, and I rushed over to support him.

“Where's this place...” Ku Fei asked after looking around him for quite some time.

This is...

“This is the Northern District.” It was Gaoqin Jiuye who spoke.

Ku Fei’s eyes widened. “North, North, North, Northern District?”

I laughed. “Yes, the Northern District. Do you have to stutter this much?”

Ku Fei looked around him again, looking doubtful as he took in the icy scene. When he happened to glance at his own reflection on the icy ground, he was absolutely stunned.

I sighed as I touched his shoulder. “I know questions must be swimming in your head. We have the same questions you have, and we’re not able to give you any answers now. But now that everyone is back together, we can work together to find a solution.”

“What big talk for an heir. I wonder what kind of solution you’d find to save him?”

A disembodied voice came from somewhere above the glacier, from somewhere in the sky. The voice was steady as it spoke, making me feel slightly afraid.

It was an extremely unique voice. I snapped my head up to look at the sky. “Who is it?”

The voice continued from above, “The life force of two of your friends have been absorbed by me, and they will die within three hours. I’d like to see how you’d save them.”

Die...

I don’t want to lose any more people. I hate hearing this word. I stared at the sky with gritted teeth. “Show yourself if you dare. How cowardly of you to hide...”

Gaoqin Jiuye was extremely calm in this situation. He spoke in an even tone, “May I ask, if you say this glacier here belongs to you, that this means

you're able to control it as well?"

The mysterious voice laughed. "As expected of Gaoqin Jiuye, the best among Si Luo's subordinates. That's right, I'm the creator of this demon cave."

Gaoqin Jiuye smirked. "The demon cave has long been a mystery. It's a place that not even Cang Ming from the Gate of Ghost or Ta Lai from the Gate of Heaven would enter in haste. It has been a restricted zone in the Northern District for years, and a coward like you from nowhere is claiming to be its creator now? Do you think I would believe you?"

"Since you know me, you should also know that although I've left the Gate of Heaven for a long time, my abilities are still top-notch amongst the soul splitters. So, why haven't I heard the slightest bit of news about a skilled master living secretly in the Gate of Ghost all these years?"

As expected of Gaoqin Jiuye. Only he would dare be this audacious.

The voice answered calmly, "There just so happens to be this ghost living secretly here in the Gate of Ghost. You don't know this because you're ignorant, Gaoqin Jiuye. You're too arrogant, too audacious. It's also because of this that you lost that other soul at that time..."

Gaoqin Jiuye interrupted the voice coldly, "Who are you... How do you know this?"

The voice sounded like it was smiling as it spoke. "I've already told you, I'm a ghost living secretly here in the Gate of Ghost."

Gaoqin Jiuye's eyes darkened as he shot a look at me, causing me to be stunned momentarily. I furrowed my brows, meaning to say, *What're you looking at me for? Have I offended you? It's this dude in the sky who just offended you!*

But Gaoqin Jiuye kept his eyes on me, looking like he was agonizing over something...

I felt uneasy at this. *Why was he looking at me like this?*

A dark shadow flashed past me all of a sudden.

Nie Zun appeared right in front of me. The mark resembling a flame on his forehead was burning a bright red. It seemed to be a bright fire that was sucking me in.

His eyes...

His eyes were red as well. This was different. This gaze... It was unfamiliar and foreign...

“You...” I muttered, not knowing what to say. *Something’s wrong here, but what was wrong?*

A hoarse voice boomed from above. “Play with them for a while. Let me see if you’re really loyal to me.”

I was dazed. *Who was he speaking to?*

I looked at Gaoqin Jiuye, but he looked as confused as I was at this. However, he realized quickly what was happening as an anxious fog rose in his eyes. “Ah Shen, get away from him quickly.”

He rushed towards me. But he spoke a little too late as Nie Zun already had my neck in his right hand.

Nie Zun’s eyes were open wide, a bloodthirsty gleam shining through them. A dark pressure emanated from his left hand, as if it could devour my soul anytime.

Darkness started seeping into my vision. I thought to myself, *Damn it, he’s turning demon again.*

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193 Leaving the Split Zone

“Li Shen,” Gaoqin Jiuye called out as he rushed towards me.

I felt an immense pressure on my neck as a deathly aura started to surround me. Nie Zun’s eyes looked maddened, and his bloodthirsty gaze was merciless.

Just as Gaoqin Jiuye was about to reach Nie Zun, Nie Zun lifted his left hand. It was enshrouded with clouds of black mist.

This felt familiar. It was this mist that trapped Ta Lai previously.

I cannot let Nie Zun turn into a demon. I focused MF on my neck as I tried to create an opposite force to his hands. “Gaoqin Jiuye, be careful,” I said.

Nie Zun waved his left hand to the back as I said this. Black fog spread in the direction where Gaoqin Jiuye was. Gaoqin Jiuye had no choice but to back away.

While Nie Zun was not concentrating on me, I took the opportunity to focus MF on both my hands, grabbing his hand in mine. Five bloody streaks in the shape of my fingers appeared on his hand.

I stared at Nie Zun. “I’m Li Shen. Nie Zun, wake up.”

Nie Zun's bloodthirsty eyes gleamed. "I'm awake now. I'm going to kill you."

Hah. I smirked. "Kill me? Have you forgotten what you said in the past? Nie Zun, you said you'll protect me forever." I placed the emphasis on the word 'forever'.

His right hand was still held in mine, and the scorpion ray on my left wrist started glowing brightly.

Nie Zun was a little stunned at what I said. A look of confusion swept past him, but it was replaced by a bloodthirsty killing intent almost immediately.

Shen Qi was already in Gaoqin Jiuye's hand as he found his footing. He lifted his sword and pointed it towards Nie Zun.

"Nie Zun, your opponent is over here," Gaoqin Jiuye said with a wild and unrestrained smile.

Nie Zun let me go as he heard this, turning around to face Gaoqin Jiuye.

Shen Qi almost scratched Nie Zun's face when he turned back.

Scorpion Ray was still glowing on my left wrist.

Huan Qing and Ku Fei supported each other as they stood. Mi Fu was slowly regaining her consciousness as well.

The mysterious voice in the sky spoke again. "Piercer, Shen Qi, Scorpion Ray. Three living weapons here. Seems like she wants to keep you alive."

My brows furrowed. *This voice seemed to be talking to me now, but what did that mean?*

"Fine, Nie Zun. Let's return to the terminus."

That demonic aura in Nie Zun dissipated and a gentle light seemed to sweep past his eyes. "Noted."

He then set off for the glacier without taking another look at us. I rushed forward to grab his arm. “Nie Zun, you can’t leave me again. I don’t care if you remember me or not, but I won’t let you leave me again.”

Nie Zun’s eyes were as beautiful as the stars. He looked at me and broke into an elegant smile. He leaned in close as he said, “I’m afraid you’re referring to the old me. Sadly, it’s no longer him standing in front of you now. Also, I wish that I’d never regain my memories if I had such bad taste in the past.”

I smiled, not letting go of his arm. “Yes, your taste was really bad in the past. You think you’ve been reborn with just a little demonic power now? You’ve forgotten about your ties? You really think you’re free now?”

I looked him in the eye as I said each word clearly. “You, Nie Zun, are mine. You said you’ll protect me forever, so don’t even think about leaving me ever.”

I wasn’t sure how I felt at this point. I only knew that Nie Zun was mine, and there was no one who could take him away from me.

Nie Zun looked at me with a profound gaze.

“I’m Li Shen. Would you like to get to know me again?” I forced myself to smile, even when my heart felt bitter.

Nie Zun took my hand in his as he smiled. That smile was the one I saw when he stepped off the platform, beautiful and dangerous at the same time. “I’ll kill you if you continue following me.”

Black fog appeared around his hand, and I felt a stabbing pain on the back of my hand as he touched it. A dark, rotten, twisted aura came with that pain, making me feel like vomiting.

He let me go as he turned around, his black coat billowing in a beautiful angle.

“Ku Fei *gege*, what’s wrong with you?” Mi Fu was awake now, and she was crying as she hugged Ku Fei.

I looked at Mi Fu coldly. Ku Fei stretched out a wrinkled hand to pat her on the head gently, trying to console her.

A dark emotion overcame me.

“Mi Fu.” I pointed at Huan Qing. “Leave the Split Zone with him right now. Don’t think that I’m unaware. You don’t have any split symbol on you, so you can leave whenever you want to. If you don’t leave, Huan Qing can never leave.”

Mi Fu stopped crying when she heard this. Huan Qing tried to stop me, but he was wrecked with a coughing bout.

“Didn’t you ask me what I was keeping from you earlier? I’ll tell you now. Huan Qing could’ve left the Split Zone, because he didn’t have a split symbol on him. But there was someone who kept an eye on you in the Split Zone, and that individual sought Huan Qing’s help to protect you, until the day you left. To keep his promise, Huan Qing gave up on his lover in the real world and stayed here to protect you. In order to do it well, he even decided to become an heir to obtain the power granted by the split symbol.

“But you didn’t care if Huan Qing lived or died because you were smitten with Ku Fei. In about an hour, their life forces would be depleted completely. If you don’t leave with Huan Qing now, he’ll definitely die.”

Mi Fu’s rosy cheeks were now pale with fear. She looked at Huan Qing. “Huan Qing *gege*... Is whatever she said true... Was it because of me that you’ve been staying here...”

Huan Qing looked pained. “There’s actually someone here who wishes for you to grow up happily and healthily. You were in his dreams, and you were in my dreams too. I’m simply helping him protect you. Fu’er, you should return to the real world. Ku Fei doesn’t belong to you, he belongs here.”

Tears fell from Mi Fu's eyes. I couldn't see Ku Fei's expression as he lowered his head.

Huan Qing lifted a trembling hand to wipe Mi Fu's tears. "I can no longer leave even if I want to now. Even though he promised that I can undo the split symbol contract anytime I wanted to, I'm not able to find my soul splitter here in this demon cave. Fu'er, leave this place quickly, don't disappoint the people who've always been protecting you."

Mi Fu hugged her knees as she started bawling. I was rather annoyed when I saw her crying like this.

"I, what would happen to you and Ku Fei *gege* if I leave... What do I do..." She was sniffing now.

The mysterious voice spoke again. "Li Shen, I can let Huan Qing leave the Split Zone together with this girl. I can also save Ku Fei's life, but you need to agree to one condition."

Can somebody just kill me now? Why did everyone want me to agree to their conditions? Just what do I have with me that you guys are hankering for?

I looked at Nie Zun's figure, which was now getting further and further. "What?"

The voice said, "It's simple. I want the Scorpion Ray that's in your hands."

Scorpion Ray.

This is the bow Li Qing gave me. It has turned into a living weapon to protect me. How can I give up Li Qing's gift to anybody else?

"Why should I believe you? You don't even dare show your face. How do I know if you can really save them?"

There was no response to my questions, but a sudden pillar of light descended from above with a crash. A stranger appeared with that light.

Huan Qing's eyes widened. "It's you..."

The stranger smiled at Huan Qing before exposing an arm under his sleeve. A triangular shape glowed faintly right in the middle of his arm.

I understood it immediately. The mysterious voice had summoned Huan Qing's soul splitter. This proves that the demon cave was under his control, and the pillar of light proved that Huan Qing and the rest were taken by him back in the Southern District. He had also proved that he had the ability to save Huan Qing.

The mysterious voice said hoarsely, "He can return to the real world if he undoes the split symbol contract. As for the one who's left, I'll return him the life force I've sucked out earlier."

But something still felt wrong.

If there was someone who was so strong that he could simply absorb the life force from heirs, would he still need a split symbol contract?

I didn't voice my doubts, since the priority was to get Huan Qing to leave.

I walked up to Huan Qing and said, "Huan Qing, go ahead. Bring Mi Fu along. The Southern District has already been destroyed. It's the same with the Eastern and Western Districts. We've all been forced to come to the Northern District. There's no place to survive for heirs here in the Split Zone now. If you really have Mi Fu's interests at heart, take her with you and leave this place."

Mi Fu sniveled and spoke softly, "But..."

I stared at her angrily. "No, don't say anything. Do you really want Huan Qing to die here with you?"

Mi Fu lifted a hand to clasp her own mouth.

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194 Ghost King Huai Du

Ku Fei walked over to Mi Fu and took her in an embrace.

He was no longer as lively as when I first saw him. He looked older and filled with sorrow. “Return with Lord Huan Qing. You can’t stay here for me forever.”

Mi Fu buried her head in his arms. “Have you ever loved me?”

Ku Fei answered, “No.”

Mi Fu froze at this.

Mi Fu finally let go of Ku Fei and wiped the tears off her face. She looked resolute as she walked towards Huan Qing.

“Huan Qing *gege*, take me with you.” Mi Fu reached out a hand to him.

Huan Qing looked at me.

I smiled and nodded at him. His eyes were shining brightly.

He said one last thing to Gaoqin Jiuye as he inserted his splitting key into the corresponding split symbol on his soul splitter. “There’s nothing else for me here if the Southern District has been destroyed. I’m only worried about

Si Luo, but I know you'd protect him. There's something else you must not forget. Guan Nie..."

A sudden harsh wind that blew across the ice buried Huan Qing's last words. I didn't hear him, but I saw the change in Gaoqin Jiuye's eyes.

Huan Qing and Mi Fu's bodies started to turn transparent.

This was the first time I've seen someone leave the Split Zone by undoing their split symbol contract. Their bodies did not dissipate into light, in the case of deaths. It turned translucent first, then they slowly became totally transparent.

Mi Fu looked at Ku Fei with tearful eyes.

A miracle seemed to happen as Mi Fu and Huan Qing's bodies were turning transparent – Ku Fei's youth was returning.

However, Ku Fei was expressionless. He remained absolutely still where he was standing, up until the point when Mi Fu was about to disappear totally. He then ran towards Mi Fu at full speed.

I felt a gust of wind as he passed me. This is why he had the title of the fastest feet in the Southern District. It was difficult for anyone to keep up with that speed.

But no matter how fast he could be, Mi Fu disappeared just as his hand was about to reach her.

A drop of her tear dropped onto his middle finger, leaving nothing but a trace of sorrow.

When his tears started falling, Ku Fei had already regained his youthful appearance. His brows regained their thickness and his skin its healthy radiance. But even so, he lacked a certain joy and liveliness.

The voice in the sky spoke. "I've done my part. It's your turn now. Give me the Scorpion Ray."

There was still a chance for me to bargain, so I asked, “Where did Nie Zun go?”

The voice seemed to be smiling as it said, “Nie Zun is in the glacier. I didn’t make him leave earlier. I got him to help me look for something in there. It’s not impossible for you to meet him, but he’s a free man now. He’s no longer controlled by you.”

I smirked. “Free man? Aren’t you the one controlling him right now? Who are you? What’s your goal? What did you do to Nie Zun?”

“Hehe, I didn’t do anything to him. It’s his own fault for coming here to the demon cave and stepping onto that demon cultivating platform. Ta Lai placed that puppet curse on him, and Ta Lai might not know this, but Nie Zun has a demonic aura within him. Not only would that curse fail in controlling him, it would backfire, causing Nie Zun’s demonic aura to devour his own consciousness, turning him into a real demon.”

I recalled how he almost killed Ta Lai the last time... *Is that why Du Yue took Ta Lai with her? I thought it weird at first. Logically, Du Yue wouldn’t be afraid of us. Does this mean that Nie Zun had the power to kill Ta Lai at that time? That he could kill soul splitters?*

Nie Zun, just what is that power hidden within you...

The mysterious voice continued.

“Though the demonic power is strong, it has a greater probability of devouring its host as well. He should have died that time, but I realized he was under the protection of that old man. I guess he’s trying to go against me recently. But that doesn’t matter. Anyway, it’ll be harmful to Nie Zun if that demonic aura isn’t removed. If he doesn’t learn how to control it, he’d be a demon, not a human being. The demon cultivating tablet changed his blood, this is why he doesn’t remember you. Now that he has been reborn, he’ll slowly become one with that demonic power. You’ll only be hurting him if you force him to regain his memories.”

“Enough of that talk. Don’t you want this? I’ll give it to you. Don’t get Nie Zun to do anything else that he isn’t willing to do.” I lifted my left hand and attempted to grab Scorpion Ray with my right.

However, the imprint of the Scorpion Ray was stuck to my hand and it seemed stuck to my nerves and tendons. It wasn’t an easy task to remove it.

I heard a voice behind me. “That was a gift from Li Qing. Who dares take Li Qing’s belongings?”

My heart sank. I recognized this voice. She had entered the demon cave as well.

As expected, I was met with an infuriated Li Wen when I turned around.

“I didn’t run away this time. It’s the demon cave’s structure,” I explained to Li Wen.

Li Wen looked at me and Gaoqin Jiuye. “I know. I couldn’t open that stone door after the both of you went missing. I could only wait until the next day when its structure changed again before arriving here.”

Li Wen looked up at the sky after speaking. “The king in the Gate of Ghost, Ghost King Huai Du, is there a need for you to be sneaking around like this? All this effort just to take back an item that serves as an affirmation of the love between you and Li Qing?”

I was momentarily speechless. *What?*

King in the Gate of Ghost. Ghost King. Affirmation of love, with Li Qing... I glanced at the Scorpion Ray imprint on my left wrist. It was glowing faintly like a phosphorus bracelet in the night.

Li Qing was still alive. This was good news to me. But why did everything feel more complex now?

An eerie silence ensued. Li Wen’s appearance and whatever she said seemed to have turned the tide in our favor.

“There’s no one but you who dares to come alone to my Gate of Ghost and speak to me this audaciously, Li Wen.”

The voice was hoarse but steady, and it sounded like it was praising an excellent junior. It did not sound angry.

Li Wen covered her mouth as she laughed gently. “I don’t deserve such praise. Ah Shen is someone important to Li Qing. I’m sure the Ghost King would know this too. I hope you wouldn’t make things difficult for her.”

She looked at me gently as she said this, as if she was the one who cared about me the most.

Sadly, when I saw her face, the only thing that came to my mind was how she cut Yuan Shen’s corpse into pieces. I felt disgusted by the thought.

“Make things difficult for her? I’m afraid that wouldn’t be me, it’d be you, isn’t it?”

Li Wen was smiling, but her eyes had a cruel gleam in them. “The Eastern, Western and Southern Districts have all been destroyed. Do you think Li Qing will forgive you for being in cahoots with Du Yue?”

I shivered.

The mysterious voice laughed. “Me being in cahoots with Du Yue? I don’t think I need to be in cahoots with anyone. Nothing can stay alive if I, Huai Du, wish to destroy it. The end of the Eastern, Western and Southern Districts is caused by Du Yue’s ambition, but I’m actually quite content to see it happen.”

I stepped up to Li Wen. “What else do you know?”

Li Wen looked at me with a gentle gaze. “Ah Shen, I can answer all of your questions as long as you don’t leave me and do whatever I tell you to.”

Laughter descended upon us from above. “Li Shen, you’d really die if you follow her. Even though Nie Zun is being controlled by me now, I still give him his freedom. I’m sure you know how Li Wen is, considering that

you've been by her side for so long. As a third party, my advice for you is to reconsider your decisions."

Li Wen smirked.

I stole a glance at Gaoqin Jiuye. He was standing in a corner and looking elsewhere. I wasn't able to get a good look at his face. Ku Fei was kneeling at his feet, just where Mi Fu had left.

"I have no interest in being on anybody's side. Li Wen, what do you want before you can let Song Lu go?" I looked her in the eye as I asked.

Li Wen's gaze turned cold when I mentioned Song Lu. "Do what I tell you to. I'll give you whatever you want only when I get what I want."

"How about you, this ghost king? What do you have in exchange for my Scorpion Ray?" I looked at Li Wen while I addressed the mysterious voice.

"Since Li Wen is here, there's not much point in taking the Scorpion Ray now. Leave my demon cave and never come back."

The glacier started quaking violently before I could even attempt to get further details about where Nie Zun went.

Cracks appeared in the ice below our feet, and an overwhelming feeling of destruction surrounded us.

Gaoqin Jiuye grabbed me in the windy snow.

I blacked out.

We were back at the entrance of the cave when I opened my eyes.

"What's with this ghost king? Not only can he control everything in the demon cave, he's able to control the life force of heirs too?" I asked with a frown.

Li Wen smiled. "Ghost King, Ghost King. He's a demon. Not only can he control heirs, he can destroy this entire Split Zone if he wishes to. But he's

extremely unpredictable and no one understands him. If he wasn't this volatile, there wouldn't be the need for the Gate of Ghost, Gate of Heaven and Gate of Exit to go against one another because he'd easily be king."

Oh, there actually exists such a powerful figure in the Split Zone.

Chapter 195: 195 Isolated With No Help

Volume 4

195 Isolated With No Help

“If he’s really like how you describe him to be, then wouldn’t there be no one who can be his opponent in the Split Zone? Why do you dare to speak to him like that then?” I looked at Li Wen from the corner of my eye.

Li Wen smiled. “That’s because I know he wouldn’t dare do anything to me no matter what I did.”

I raised a brow. “Oh, really?”

Li Wen seemed to look into the distance as she answered me. “If he dares hurt me, he can forget about seeing Li Qing ever again.”

So something is really going on between Ghost King Huai Du and Li Qing. But using Li Qing as a bargaining tool was really low of her.

Well, Li Wen is Li Qing’s soul splitter. If Huai Du did love Li Qing, then Li Wen would have nothing to fear. I turned cold. “That’s right, you’re the best at threatening and attacking people with their weaknesses.”

Li Wen knew that I was referring to how she used Jiao S to threaten me earlier, but she had no intention of arguing with me. She walked up to me and took my hand. “I know you must hate me now, but don’t forget who your real enemies are. Du Yue is the one who destroyed your Western District and hurt your friends. Since you’re the only one with what I am

looking for, I'm not going to hurt anyone else as long as you work with me."

Gaoqin Jiuye responded with sarcasm, "Blaming everything on Du Yue? No matter what she does, at least she does it openly. But you? You do things sneakily."

Li Wen's face turned pale for a moment.

Though Gaoqin Jiuye was speaking up for Du Yue now, I was rather satisfied as I saw the look on Li Wen's face.

I realized that I've almost forgotten about someone.

The ignored Ku Fei suddenly spoke. "Ah Shen, thank you for all your help. There's nothing much for me here now that the Southern District has been destroyed, and Huan Qing and Mi Fu have both left."

My heart sank at this. I walked over and patted Ku Fei gently on the shoulder. "Don't say that, Ku Fei. Gaoqin Jiuye is still here, Si Luo is still here. There're still people from the Southern District who're still alive. You can't give up no matter what."

Ku Fei's usually cheery face looked dispirited. It looked like he no longer carried any hope. "I'm not even qualified to give up on myself. I can't leave the Split Zone if I can't find my soul splitter, and I can't even kill myself... I'm worried about Lord Si Luo too, but I can't do anything for him..."

Gaoqin Jiuye interrupted, "How do you know that if you haven't tried? Rong Jin disappeared after a fight, and it's only us few from the Southern District now. Among those who've survived, I'm afraid you're the only heir. Are you still going to give up on yourself like this?"

Right... Hearing Gaoqin Jiuye's words, I was reminded that most heirs in the Southern District were rather weak. Even my residents weren't able to survive this catastrophe, what more about those from the Southern District... If that's the case, wouldn't Ku Fei be the last surviving heir from the Southern District now?

Ku Fei looked at Gaoqin Jiuye. ‘What can I do for you guys?’

I didn’t know how Gaoqin Jiuye planned to answer this, but I had to cut him off no matter what. “There’s no need for you to do anything for us. You just need to follow us and find your soul splitter, undo the split symbol contract and leave the Split Zone.”

I looked at him with determination.

Li Wen suddenly laughed. “Gate of Heaven, Gate of Ghost, Gate of Exit. The size of each group is greater than any of you could imagine. Soul splitters aren’t as rare as an existence either. You just love wishing for things, Ah Shen. How would you help him find his soul splitter? As the last surviving heir from the Southern District, what he should do now is to run away and hide from Du Yue so he wouldn’t be controlled by her and end up living like an insect. He would be considered lucky if he can avoid her.”

I smirked. I focused MF on my feet and charged towards Li Wen, giving her a hard slap.

“You.” Li Wen was stunned as she didn’t expect this. She didn’t think I dared do something like this since I was weaker than her, and she also thought I didn’t care much for whatever happened in the world.

Gaoqin Jiuye and Ku Fei probably did not expect me to do such a thing either, since they were all stunned.

I looked at Li Wen gently, caressing her face. I knew she wouldn’t avoid it.

As expected, Li Wen did not avoid me. She looked at me with an intense gaze.

I touched the part of her face where I had just slapped, saying softly, “Living like an insect? What right do you have to talk about others like that? Are you not living like an insect now? Though I still don’t know why you had to leave me time and again, I have a nagging feeling that whatever you do is simply to make up for what you weren’t able to obtain. Are you

jealous of my place in Li Qing's heart? Why are you doing all this? Aren't you living like an insect yourself..."

Sorrow flashed in Li Wen's eyes. She took a deep breath. "That's right, I'm jealous of you. Li Qing had already left the Western District with me, but you were still on her mind, and she thought about you all the time. Don't all heirs live like insects here... The Split Zone is a world belonging to soul splitters..."

She got more and more agitated as she spoke, and I could see tears in her eyes when she finished.

Something felt wrong somewhere.

Why did it sound like she wasn't a soul splitter...

But, it can't be. Her split symbol was exactly identical to Li Qing's.

Li Wen seemed to realize that she had accidentally revealed something and averted her gaze. She continued after a moment. "Do whatever you want, it has nothing to do with me anyway. Don't forget that you'll have to work with me if you want to save Song Lu."

She retreated to a corner after that, not looking at us.

Though I was filled with suspicion, settling Ku Fei was the more important task at hand. I looked at Gaoqin Jiuye, signaling for him to come up with a solution.

Gaoqin Jiuye shrugged as if he could not do anything about this. *Please, isn't Ku Fei someone from your Southern District?*

I sighed as I said to Ku Fei, "How about you come with us first, then we'll see..."

I thought of something important suddenly. *How could I have forgotten something as important as this?*

My gaze quivered as I turned to Gaoqin Jiuye. He noticed something different about me and walked up to grab my hand. “What’s wrong?”

“I... I left Jiao S alone with Du Yue...” I felt like crying now.

Gaoqin Jiuye’s eyes darkened. “So...”

“So... I thought we’d definitely make it back in three days, and although we still have time, I forgot that Jiao S used part of her MF to hide Si Luo... I’m afraid that Si Luo might be exposed like this...”

Gaoqin Jiuye swung my hand away.

I could see the anger rise in him. “Li Shen, Si Luo is in deep sleep now. Do you wish for his death by leaving them together with Du Yue and Ta Lai?”

Li Wen furrowed her brows and turned to me, asking, “Why didn’t you tell me Si Luo is here too?”

However, her eyes could not hide her real emotions.

“Haha, you really didn’t know?” I asked mockingly.

“Enough, Li Shen.” Gaoqin Jiuye cut me off angrily before turning to leave.

“No need to rush over to me so quickly. I’ve brought Si Luo here.”

We heard Du Yue’s voice somewhere near us. She walked towards us with steady steps in her knee-high boots.

Du Yue was taller than the average woman, and she was carrying Si Luo in her arms at this moment. This scene looked like something out of the ordinary.

She walked up beside Gaoqin Jiuye and threw Si Luo at him. “You can’t even take care of your own people.”

I frowned. *Why did I feel uncomfortable when I heard this?*

Gaoqin Jiuye shot me a look as he caught Si Luo.

I turned to Du Yue. “Where’s Jiao S?”

If Si Luo was out, it meant that Jiao S had used up her MF. Du Yue smirked. “I’ve brought her to someplace good. Do you want to come have a look too?”

My hands balled into fists. “What did you do to her?”

Du Yue ignored me and turned to Li Wen. “There’s actually a tiny ant over here.”

Li Wen brushed her hair and walked up to Du Yue. “It’s been a long time, Du Yue.”

Du Yue scoffed. “Your blood has turned back.”

Li Wen smiled. “Yes, my blood can no longer kill heirs now. I’m so upset about this. But thanks to the previous collaboration, most heirs are already dead now, and there’s no need for us to go against each other anymore, don’t you think?”

I shivered. “You worked with her?” I pointed at Du Yue as I looked at Li Wen in surprise.

Li Wen covered her mouth as she said, “Ah Shen you dumb dumb, you really think there’s some type of blood that can kill heirs? It’s just a poison, and it isn’t permanent. It’s the same with Song Lu.”

What can I say. I heard Du Yue behind me. “Heirs are heirs. They love to believe people who’re not worthy of their trust.”

At this, there was a slight change in Li Wen’s expression.

Gaoqin Jiuye then laughed maliciously. “If being a soul splitter means I have to be cruel and ruthless like you, then I’d rather be an heir.”

Du Yue probably did not expect for Gaoqin Jiuye to say this. She turned to him. “I helped you bring Si Luo back and I’ve given you all that you want, be it a peaceful life or Si Luo’s safety. What else are you unhappy about?”

“That’s right, what else can I be unhappy about?” Gaoqin Jiuye said in self-mockery.

I looked around. Ku Fei was standing in a corner. He looked at Si Luo sometimes, but he was blanking out most of the time. Gaoqin Jiuye was looking at Du Yue. As for Li Wen, I couldn’t tell what was in her head at all.

But I know one thing for sure. There wasn’t a single person I could trust here.

Chapter 196: 196 I Like You

Volume 4

196 I Like You

“Since we’re all here now, I think it’s time someone explain all that’s happening so far.” I tried my best to sound calm and composed as I looked around me.

Unexpectedly, Du Yue answered. “Are you interested to come with me to my Palace of Cold Blood?”

Tch, Palace of Cold Blood. The name suits you really well, Du Yue... My mind started racing as I thought about the sudden change in her attitude towards me.

Du Yue was different from Li Wen in that she doesn’t usually lie to trick you in doing anything. Though she’s ruthless, she does everything openly and doesn’t hide. She’s also very confident in her own abilities. If she wanted to hurt me, she can easily do it now instead of using extra time to take me elsewhere.

She must have her reasons for doing so. *Was I of any use to her?*

I recalled that Li Wen said I was the only one who could kill soul splitters. *Did Du Yue know this too? Did she want to use me as well?*

“Why should I leave with you?” I had to ask even if it sounded a little retarded.

Du Yue smirked. “Jiao S is in the Palace of Cold Blood right now.”

As expected of her.

I turned around, expecting Li Wen to disagree. However, Gaoqin Jiuye placed Si Luo aside and he was the one who said, “You can’t take her with you.”

I was stunned at this.

Du Yue asked calmly, “Why is that?”

Gaoqin Jiuye smirked. “Because she’s mine. Whether it’s you or Li Wen, don’t even think about taking what’s mine.”

I looked at Gaoqin Jiuye in surprise. There seemed to be a light shining from behind Gaoqin Jiuye, making it look very much like the first time I met Gao Qi.

I rubbed my eyes as I mumbled, “Gao Qi...”

Gaoqin Jiuye’s smile froze as he looked at me. “I’m not Gao Qi, I’m Gaoqin Jiuye, and you’re mine.”

Deep in my heart, something exploded.

What was it? I don’t know.

“Are you confessing to Ah Shen now?” Li Wen asked. Du Yue shot her a cold look.

Gaoqin Jiuye looked at me squarely, a mischievous smile still hanging on his lips.

Though I wanted to avoid those eyes which felt like they were boring into me, I chose to meet his gaze. “What are you trying to do?”

Gaoqin Jiuye said, “I said, I like you. You’re mine. No one can take you.”

Something exploded in my heart once again. No matter how calm I was, the tips of my fingers were trembling now.

I looked him in the eye. These eyes and this face, how familiar everything seemed to be. *How long have I waited for him to say this?*

But, did he really not say this before?

My heart seemed to be scrunching itself up. Pain seemed to travel across all my blood vessels and congregate in my heart, making me feel as if I was about to be destroyed.

This was something I hoped for, but why did it feel so familiar when it happened? Something seemed to be reappearing in my memories.

“Ah Shen, I like you. Die together with me.”

I lifted my arms slowly and covered both my ears, trying to block out that enchanting voice in my head which kept telling me, *Ah Shen, come with me. I like you. Let's die together.*

Seeing me like this, a deep sorrow seemed to fill Gaoqin Jiuye.

Li Wen rushed forward to grab my hand, interrupting that voice in my head. She looked at me with fire in her eyes. “Has she appeared? Your second personality?”

Her words were like a sudden bucket of ice water being tipped over me.

I pushed her away. “No, don’t even think about it. I’ll never see her again, so don’t even think about making use of her, ever.

“And you.” I pointed at Du Yue. “You think I don’t know what you’re planning? You already know who I am, and all of you want to make use of my second personality. Dream on. I won’t let anyone take control of her. No one can control her anyway.”

I then laughed mercilessly.

Du Yue remained calm like still water. She glanced at Gaoqin Jiuye. “The one you like gets agitated so easily. Seems like you really don’t have much taste.”

I smirked. “Is that so, he doesn’t have much taste? Why did I hear that he liked you before?”

Du Yue’s gaze wavered as she looked at Gaoqin Jiuye. Gaoqin Jiuye did not meet her eyes. He looked at me and said, “I like you now, and I won’t let anyone else take you away from me.”

He said it exactly like this, as if it was romantic. But I saw an endless agony buried deep within his eyes.

I finally got it. He was using me as some kind of shield.

Haha. A bittersweet smile appeared on my face.

Li Wen looked at all of us before her gaze landed on Du Yue. “Right, where’s Bian Ying and Ta Lai?”

This was a normal question, since there was Ta Lai, Bian Ying, Du Yue and Jiao S in that river when we left. However, a killing intent appeared in Du Yue’s eyes. It seems as if her jealousy is enough to kill anyone who put the names Ta Lai and Bian Ying together in the same sentence.

“Cang Ming appeared from out of nowhere and took Bian Ying away.” Du Yue answered Li Wen coldly.

“How about Ta Lai?” Li Wen’s eyes seemed to smile.

Du Yue stared at her as she said, “He’s returned to the Gate of Heaven.”

Li Wen smiled. “You sure he’s back in the Gate of Heaven? He didn’t cook up an excuse for you and go looking for Bian Ying instead?”

Du Yue’s patience seemed to end here. She lifted a hand and gave it a big wave.

That feeling was back.

The ground seemed to become magnetic and my heart felt like it was a piece of iron. My heart felt like it was being sucked downwards, causing me

to fall face-down onto the ground.

Du Yue smirked before she lifted her right foot and stepped onto my head.

A painful pressure was on my head, and that feeling of my heart being sucked towards the ground did not lessen a tiny bit. My heart felt like it was about to escape from my chest and stick itself to the ground.

My hands were on the ground as I attempted to get up. However, I couldn't escape this force no matter how hard I tried.

Moreover, there was still a foot on my head.

I laughed self-mockingly.

"Let go of her." I heard Gaoqin Jiuye's glacial voice from the top of my head.

Du Yue used more force on her foot. The side of my face was on the ground, and she was stepping on my right ear. I couldn't hear their conversation very clearly like this.

Du Yue seemed to ignore Gaoqin Jiuye and addressed Li Wen instead. "Isn't she your goal? I can tell you now that I'm taking her life for sure. Does Li Qing dare to have you go against me? How about you ask her first?"

Gaoqin Jiuye grabbed Du Yue's hand, making her unsteady for a moment. The pressure on my head seemed to lessen by a fraction, but her hand was still held in that weird position. My heart was still stuck to some unknown force from the ground.

"Did you not hear me clearly? I said she's mine. Don't even think about taking her away from me," Gaoqin Jiuye said to Du Yue.

Du Yue smirked. "Gaoqin, have you forgotten that we grew up together? Do you think I wouldn't know you well enough? You only look and act fierce. In reality, you aren't as cruel as you look. If you were cruel enough, you wouldn't have ended up leaving the Gate of Heaven together with Si Luo at that time."

These people were really enjoying their conversation. There seemed to be no conclusion on the part about taking me away either. Seems like it's time for me to cut their conversation short.

I focused all my MF on my heart. Something then answered from deep within it. That answer seemed to be coming from something buried in my heart that was finally being awoken.

I grabbed her right foot in my right hand as I continued focusing MF on my heart.

Boom.

I stood up the instant I escaped from that unknown force, backing away quickly. Swinging my right hand, I threw Du Yue's leg to the side.

I smirked at her. "Seems like not all heirs are like insects."

Du Yue was visibly shocked at my escape. Though I had ripped one of her legs off, she was able to stand perfectly steady on one. "How could you have escaped from my restraining technique?"

So that was called the restraining technique.

I shrugged. "You guys said it before, that the only thing giving you power in the Split Zone is MF and the split symbol. As long as your mental endurance is strong enough, there's nothing that cannot be broken here. Put simply, I'm stronger and can endure much more now. You can't do anything to me."

I looked at Du Yue indignantly. *Know your abilities before you even try to take my life. I can give up on myself, I can avoid things and remain cowardly, but I never said I'd let you guys order me around like this.*

Since I've become a weapon in your war, this means my life is worth something now. Come and get it if that's the case. It's best if you guys destroy each other. This way, I can save my friends.

So many lives have been lost in the Eastern, Western and Southern Districts. I no longer know how to be afraid. I no longer know how to cry.

Even Nie Zun has been taken away from me. Is this all because of the her in me?

Come and get it then.

I, Li Shen, will make the Split Zone a living hell. You guys owe me this much.

Chapter 197: 197 Fierce Competition

Volume 4

197 Fierce Competition

Du Yue's leg seemed to be regenerating at the speed of light. She did not look like she was in an ounce of pain, as if it was simply a strand of hair instead of a leg that I had just ripped off from her.

"Seems like I've really underestimated you." This was the first time I heard Du Yue say something like this. However, instead of filling me with joy, this made me feel fearful.

She looked at me. "My patience is at its end. Jiao S is now in my Palace of Cold Blood. I can cause her pain whenever I wish to. Come with me if you don't wish for her to go through such agony.

"As for you." Du Yue turned to Gaoqin Jiuye. "Si Luo won't be able to wake up without Yu Liang. Right now, Yu Liang is also in the Palace of Cold Blood. Are you sure you don't want to come along?"

"What?" I said, surprised. "Why would Yu Liang be in your Palace of Cold Blood?"

Du Yue shot me a cold smile. "Even Jie Pa is there too. There really are many talented individuals in that Western District of yours. There's actually someone who can use that long-forgotten spatial transference technique, a technique that's lost even to the soul splitters."

Spatial transference? Isn't that Old Man Fan's technique...

A tiny glimmer of hope seemed to appear before me. *Is Old Man Fan still alive...*

I tried to suppress the excitement in me. I knew that I had to remain calm in this situation. I had to look at things with a clear head. I cannot expose Old Man Fan's secret so easily.

I asked with composure, "Who else is in that Palace of Cold Blood?"

Du Yue glanced at Gaoqin Jiuye. "I don't know who in the Western District used that forbidden technique, but the few important people managed to escape from that catastrophe and arrived here in the Northern District. It was a coincidence that Jie Pa and Yu Liang landed in my territory, together with two subordinates of Jiao S. They're all in the Palace of Cold Blood now with Jiao S."

I guess it's only Jie Pa and Yu Liang who landed in her territory then. Those two subordinates of Jiao S would refer to... Tao Lie and Mu Li.

This is why Yuan Shen appeared in the Northern District. Does this mean that those fighting alongside Jie Pa had all survived? My eyes started to water as I was overjoyed at the thought.

Everyone was still alive.

Gaoqin Jiuye spoke. "How can I believe you?"

Du Yue glanced at me. "You can choose not to believe what I say, but I'm sure you know that she'll definitely come with me after this. If she leaves with me, I'm guessing you'd do the same. Am I right?"

Gaoqin Jiuye's eyes darkened as he looked at me.

I nodded. "Right, I'm coming with you.

"But." I pointed at Ku Fei. "I want you to promise me that you'll not hurt him. Let him stay here in the Northern District as an heir, and don't make things difficult for him."

Ku Fei had been blanking out for a while now and only now did he realize that we were really going to leave him.

Tears shone in his eyes as his lips turned downwards.

Du Yue did not bother looking at him. “I’m not so bored that I’d want to go after a tiny ant like him.”

“Fine. Let’s go then.” I walked towards Du Yue.

Du Yue’s leg had completed its regeneration by now, but since the lower end of her dark green trousers had been ripped off as well, her new leg was exposed to the air like a long and slender piece of lotus root.

I glanced at Li Wen as I passed her. She was expressionless and she did not seem to have the intention of stopping me either.

I knew that she wouldn’t stop me now, since it would be one against three for her in this situation, and it would be difficult for her to win. *I wonder what she’d do?*

Li Wen smiled as she said, “Du Yue’s Palace of Cold Blood doesn’t welcome visitors usually, so how could I miss out on this rare opportunity today? May I come along too?”

So she’s choosing to come along with us, and look for a chance to take me away after. I didn’t know my second personality was this charming, so much so that a beautiful lady is in hot pursuit of her.

I thought Du Yue would reject her, but she agreed. “Fine, let’s go.”

I began to feel uncomfortable at this. The four of us were leaving the Gate of Ghost for the Palace of Cold Blood in the Gate of Heaven. *What a stressful journey this would be...*

I signaled for Ku Fei to leave. He nodded and turned to go.

No matter what, I had to find Nie Zun before we leave the Gate of Ghost. I can only depend on myself for this task now.

“The Gate of Ghost is huge. How do we get there?” I asked.

Du Yue and Gaoqin Jiuye remained silent. They had no intention of answering my question. Li Wen smiled at me. “Ah Shen, you’re not familiar with the environment in the Northern District.” *Of course I’m not. I’ve been living outside of this place forever, how would I know what it looks like.*

“The Northern District is huge. Just the Gate of Ghost alone is larger than the Eastern, Western and Southern Districts combined. We’ll take more than just a day or two to arrive in the Palace of Cold Blood in the Gate of Heaven.”

I was lost. “Then why would Jiao S be in the Palace of Cold Blood within just a few days?”

Du Yue answered this time. “Jiao S has a pill that can be used for teleportation. It’s a rare pill and she’s the only one who owns it. She didn’t know I was aware of this, and it just so happened that her two subordinates were both in my Palace of Cold Blood. I let on that her subordinates were still alive, and she walked right into my trap when she tried to escape by using that pill. She’s probably already in the Palace of Cold Blood now, and she’ll be greeted by my subordinates there.”

My fists tightened, but I remained silent.

Wait. That pill which can be used for teleportation... I suddenly remembered that Jiao S gave me something like this, and she said I shouldn’t use it unless it was absolutely necessary.

That pill should still be with me right now. None of them were aware of this. I looked down at my dress and saw the tear in the fabric near my chest. I then thought of something.

“I look horrible right now with my clothes all torn. How about we rest here in the Gate of Ghost for today? I heard that days and nights last for 30 hours each here. It’s turning dark soon, so why not we leave tomorrow instead?ow aboutHHoHoH” I pointed at the hole in my dress created by Nie Zun as I spoke.

Du Yue glanced at me. “This is the Gate of Ghost and it’s not my territory here. If you guys want to rest, go ahead, but don’t think that I’d help you out if you meet any trouble here.”

Nobody wants your help.

Li Wen stood up suddenly. “The only way to get to the Gate of Heaven from here is via the Heaven Ghost Bridge located at the far end in the Gate of Ghost. We’re on the opposite end now, and we’ll need quite some time to arrive there.”

I pointed behind me as I said, “Isn’t the entrance to the Gate of Ghost right behind the river? Can’t we go through there instead?”

Li Wen shook her head. “That entrance can only be seen if you exit from the Great Hall. When you’re already inside any one of the Gates, you’ll never be able to find those entrances again no matter where you go. This means that there’s no turning back here in the Northern District.”

“There’s no turning back?”

What does that mean?

Seeing my confused expression, Li Wen continued her explanation. “If you’re in any of these Gates, the only way to leave is via a bridge that connects to another Gate, and you won’t be able to leave the Northern District. This is why there’s no turning back here.”

“Then how do you guys go to our world?”

“I’ve told you this before, have you forgotten it again? We can reach the Great Hall through that black hole above it.” Li Wen looked at me, as if she was trying to say something else.

Du Yue was impatient now and she left quickly after giving us a cold look. Gaoqin Jiuye followed closely behind after settling Si Luo in his air vortex. Looking at the both of them, Li Wen and I started moving as well.

“What were you trying to say earlier?” I asked Li Wen.

I knew Li Wen. She was intelligent. There was no way she would say something like ‘there’s no turning back’ for no reason.

Li Wen smiled but remained silent.

I looked at the two individuals in front of me meaningfully. *Right, soul splitters have high MF. Our conversation would probably be heard at such a distance. She probably walked ahead because she wants to eavesdrop on us too...*

Wait, if there’s no turning back in the Northern District...

Then Mr Blond is definitely involved in all of this. Is it only Mr Blond who has the ability to bring them over? What other secrets are hidden in here...?
I frowned to myself. There’s nobody else here but me. If I want answers, I’ll have to tread lightly.

I sped up, catching up to Du Yue.

“Also.” Du Yue looked at my left ankle. “If you wish to survive in the Northern District, I’d suggest for you to keep the fact that you’re an heir a secret.”

There’s no physical difference between heirs and soul splitters, and if the Gate of Ghost is so huge that it’s larger than the three other districts combined, I’d probably not be treated any differently even though I’m an unfamiliar face. Would I still need to hide if it’s not that easy to recognize this fact?

Li Wen seemed to be able to read my mind and said, “The Northern District isn’t as simple as you think it is. There’d be many unexpected situations that would occur. There’re many unfamiliar faces around given that the area is so huge, and it’s true that it’s nothing much. But if you show surprise or fear, the more perceptive ones would be able to tell right away.”

I nodded. “Thanks for the reminder, but I don’t think there’s anything else that can shock me here in the Split Zone. Its existence in itself is already enough of a surprise for me.”

Chapter 198: 198 It's Not Time Yet

Volume 4

198 It's Not Time Yet

I realized quickly that I was over-confident this time.

It was difficult for me to hide my surprise when I saw how the Northern District really looked like.

When we passed through the forest with Du Yue, I was met with my world.

Tall buildings, the streets and crowds – this was exactly like the real world. Li Wen was right. It was difficult for an heir who lived in the Western District not to show any signs of surprise when suddenly immersed in such an environment.

No matter how much I tried to suppress how I felt, this looked exactly identical to the real world. *Was it that difficult to get used to? Don't look surprised, don't look surprised...* I couldn't help myself and as I took a look around, I got a greater shock instead.

It was extremely weird here. There would be a tiny old house right beside a shiny and tall new building. The roads were very wide and there were very few vehicles around. There were various makes and models of vehicles, both modern ones and vintage cars were around.

The people here looked similar to those in the real world, except they were dressed in garb from different eras.

The best way I can describe this would be that there was an impression that space and time were confused here in the Northern District. It was as if

things from different time periods and eras were all combined together in a painting right here.

Li Wen said softly to me, “I told you that you’d be shocked, right?”

I calmed myself down before I asked, “What’s going on here?”

Li Wen laughed, as if she was filled with joy at my confusion. “If I tell, that would be the equivalent of giving away the secret of the Split Zone. You can try guessing. You should be able to find out with this many clues right in front of you.”

Are you saying that I’m stupid?

I felt a familiarity when she laughed just now. It was just like when we were still on good terms. She was always like this. She looked gentle and soft on the outside, but she was in fact very gutsy and mischievous.

I wasn’t aware of this at that time, that she also had a twisted, ruthless and cruel heart behind that mischievous demeanor.

A tiny seed of sorrow seemed to sprout in me. *What was it that changed us?*

Was it... solitude?

Li Wen seemed to be able to sense my emotions. She was always this perceptive. “What’re you worried about? Worried about Nie Zun?”

Yes, there’s still Nie Zun.

“Can you tell me more about that king in the Gate of Ghost?” I looked at Li Wen.

Li Wen smiled. “He has been in love with Li Qing for the longest time. The three Gates didn’t exist in the Northern District in the past, but Li Qing parted with him because she didn’t agree with his views and mindset regarding bodies of consciousness. The both of them ended up like this eventually, one of them the king in the Gate of Ghost, the other...”

Li Wen turned pale and stopped speaking, as if suddenly realizing that there was something she shouldn't have revealed.

I tried to lessen her guilt by asking, "So do all the soul splitters in the Gate of Ghost have extraordinary abilities?"

I knew I wouldn't get any information out of Li Wen if I continued with my previous question. In this case, it'd be better for me to change the subject to diminish any doubt she might have.

As expected, Li Wen looked much more relaxed at this. "Of course not. No matter where we are, people will always be categorized in this world. It's even more apparent here in the Split Zone. Most soul splitters have a slightly higher MF than their corresponding heirs, and one of the reasons for that is to prevent the heirs from undoing their split symbol contracts easily. Their MF is usually higher by about five."

Prevent heirs from undoing split symbol contracts easily.

Are you kidding me? I'm living with my life on the line even as the Western District Commander. Even if you soul splitters have zero MF, you wouldn't be at risk of losing your lives as long as you don't leave the Northern District.

If that's the case, wouldn't soul splitters be considered immortal as long as they don't leave the Northern District ever?

Would this mean that there'll only be more soul splitters and no decrease in their numbers here? How would their numbers increase then?

Just what exactly are soul splitters... Was it because of this that drove them to find methods to kill each other?

Well, seems like it's difficult for them to enter and leave the Northern District and travel in and out of the other districts. If that wasn't the case, my life in the Western District would probably not have been that peaceful.

Seeing me silent, Li Wen continued. “There’s actually nothing you need to worry about. To be frank, heirs live like insects here in the Split Zone. Du Yue’s right. No matter how much you worry, there’re only two possibilities in the end. One of them is dying here, and the other is to return to your world. If your goal is to change this place, then I can only say that it’s the equivalent to dreaming of being a superhuman in the real world.”

“I’ve never thought of saving others. I only want to save my friends and return them their peaceful lives. In fact, I haven’t really thought about whether I want to leave the Split Zone,” I said softly.

Li Wen said, “Then why do you always look like you want to save the world? I hate that expression of yours, it makes me jealous.”

I finally stopped looking around me. My gaze landed on Li Wen.

Li Wen’s eyes shone, her lips upturned in a smile.

“Don’t you think you’ve already said too much?” Gaoqin Jiuye turned around to face us, hands in his pockets.

Li Wen raised both her arms. “Fine fine fine. I shan’t say any more since Gaoqin doesn’t want me to. I’ll return her to you, alright?” Her words were laced with sarcasm.

Li Wen skipped a few steps ahead, her pale yellow dress billowing in front of me. In a second, she was already way ahead of us.

Du Yue seemed to stop momentarily as she sensed that Gaoqin Jiuye stopped moving. But it lasted only for a split second. She continued walking after that.

I sped up and caught up with Gaoqin Jiuye. “We’re still partners, right?” I glanced at him, speaking softly since I was unsure if Du Yue and Li Wen can hear us.

Gaoqin Jiuye did not meet my eyes. He simply continued walking forward. “Have you forgotten that you left Si Luo with the enemy? Who’d dare

partner up with you?”

I laughed.

Gaoqin Jiuye looked at me with a funny stare. He must be wondering why I was laughing when he made it so clear that he wasn't on the same team with me.

I knew him well enough now. If he said this, it means he still sees me as being on the same team. Though the word 'partners' might not be the most accurate, it described our current relationship best.

“You must be thinking of looking for Nie Zun as we're on the way, right?” Gaoqin Jiuye spoke in such a low tone that I had to focus MF on my ears to be able to hear him.

I was a little surprised as I realized what he said. *Could he read my mind?*

Seeing that I didn't deny it, he continued, “Western District Commander is really quite the loyal individual, unwilling to give up on either friend or lover.”

I raised a brow. “Are you jealous?”

“Why should I be jealous?”

Giving him a sideways glance, I asked, “Didn't you confess to me earlier?”

Gaoqin Jiuye spoke without hesitation, “Yes, but you've seen it too. I'm merely using you as a shield in front of her.” He pointed his chin towards Du Yue who was in front.

The smile on my face froze. I then said, “I think the word 'loyal' would describe you better...” This word was usually used as a compliment, but between us, it became a weapon of sarcasm.

Gaoqin Jiuye accepted my 'compliment' rather graciously. “I've always been loyal.”

I turned serious. “There’s something I always wanted to ask you.”

Gaoqin Jiuye reverted to that cold expression as he sensed that I was about to ask a serious question. “Go ahead.”

I looked him in the eye. “Li Wen told me that you’ve always known about my existence. I’m talking about when I was still alive. You know everything about me, including those memories I’ve lost. What’s more interesting is that she said you were actually the person I liked, that it wasn’t Gao Qi. What did she mean by that?”

Gaoqin Jiuye’s eyes shone, hiding his emotions in them. “You believe her?”

“I wouldn’t believe her in the past. But we’ve known each other for quite some time now, and I feel that you might have known me. You were pretending from the very first day we met. You’re aware of so many secrets that I’m not aware of, but you just won’t reveal them to me.”

Gaoqin Jiuye laughed. It was not his usual cold laughter, it was a laughter that seemed to be full of solitude. “Why don’t you believe me when I tell you I like you, but you choose to believe her words? You didn’t believe it either when I said I know you better than you know yourself. Li Shen, you’re always trusting the wrong people. You’re missing out on those you should trust.”

My brows furrowed. “Is that a denial?”

Gaoqin Jiuye raised a hand to his face. The artificial sun in the sky shone on him, but it could not shine upon that darkness within his eyes.

He regained that usual malice in his voice. “Try to stay alive for now. Only those alive have the right to know the truth. I’ll tell you everything when it’s time.” He continued walking forward after that.

You’ll tell me everything when it’s time? When would it be time? I looked at Scorpion Ray on my wrist. It seemed to be able to sense my emotions as it glowed faintly.

I caught up with Gaoqin Jiuye quickly. As I reached him, I said casually,
“You seem to have forgotten to ask Du Yue where Guan Nie went.”

Chapter 199: 199 Not Fitting In

Volume 4

199 Not Fitting In

Gaoqin Jiuye said, “There’s no need to ask. I trust Cang Ming since he said he’ll save Guan Nie. Isn’t Nie Zun’s face already healed?”

“Then where’s Guan Nie now?”

Gaoqin Jiuye shook his head. “Du Yue wouldn’t know if I don’t. Guan Nie... He likes to do things alone.”

I smirked. “Is he following you around secretly now? He’ll probably come out and protect you when you’re in danger.”

Gaoqin Jiuye stared at me in silence.

Crash.

I heard the loud brakes of a car right beside me.

“Goddamnit, why am I this unlucky. Hitting garbage in the morning.”

On my right, a woman dressed in black silk exited a sedan. She was the one who accidentally hit somebody on the road.

A teenage boy who looked to be about fifteen or sixteen was lying in front of her car. He was rather thin and he did not look tall either.

The woman was in three-inch heels and she was ranting all the way as she walked towards that boy. She then kicked him in the chest.

“What a lowly thing. How dare you hit my car when the value of your MF is so low it’s less than 20. Trash like you should go extinct in the Split Zone. Those from the Gate of Heaven wouldn’t dare be so audacious if it weren’t for garbage like you being everywhere in the Gate of Ghost.”

She was ruthless in her kicks, stepping on the boy’s chest so many times that he began to bleed.

The boy let her continue. He looked at her imminently with those dark eyes, not asking for mercy nor avoiding any of her kicks.

The woman got angrier as she saw that gaze of his. “What are you? How dare you look at me this way! I’ll blind you!”

She lifted her right foot, eyes shining.

This was bad. She focused her MF on her right foot. To the boy whose MF was less than 20, such force would damage his MF. Even if it wasn’t damaged, his eyes would probably never heal after this.

MF was everything in the Split Zone. If a body of consciousness with a low MF value receives an attack of high MF, it was not easy to heal at all.

With a light tap of my feet, I moved over to the woman in a second, grabbing her arm and stretching out one of my feet to stop her.

I smirked. “What are you then? Someone with an MF of only 30 being a bully here. You think you’re so worthy?”

I could tell how high her MF was as I grabbed her wrist where her split symbol happened to be. Activating my MF on her split symbol, I realized her MF was not very high either.

She was incensed. “Where did you come from? Mind your own business!”

Gaoqin Jiuye walked over as I was about to speak. “I’ve always heard that those in the Gate of Ghost were cruel. Seems like it really is true when even someone with an MF of 30 dares to be this audacious.”

The woman harrumphed. “You sound like you’re from the Gate of Heaven. That explains it then. You guys love to poke your noses into the affairs of others, acting high and mighty all the time.”

I realized why Gaoqin Jiuye stepped forward. I would definitely have said something like even a soul splitter with an MF of 30 dares to be this audacious. If I said that, my identity as an heir would have been exposed.

The woman whipped my hand away and retracted her foot.

The boy was spitting out mouthfuls of blood, but he seemed to have no intention of getting up.

The woman smiled cruelly at me. “Since you love poking your nose into the affairs of others, how about you help him out all the way? Bring him with you, or else I’ll torture him if I ever see him again. None of us can die here in the Split Zone. I’ll be able to torture him forever and ever.”

My heart tightened. *What a cruel individual. This was a soul splitter.*

Hate was apparent in my eyes, and this seemed to surprise the woman.

My left hand was already lifted, the light of Scorpion Ray glowing bright. However, Gaoqin Jiuye stopped me.

I looked at him in confusion. Without meeting my eyes, he turned to the woman. “He’s just a child with low MF, let him go. What do you want? I can satisfy you.”

The boy was struggling to get up now. He stood up unsteadily. His face was pale and emotionless, his eyes dark.

Lifting his right hand suddenly, he pierced his own eyes.

“Don’t.” I stretched out a hand, trying to stop him. But his actions were too sudden and I was too late. All I felt was warm blood on his hands.

“You...” I looked at the blood on my fingertips, unable to speak.

The woman laughed.

The thin boy, who was now bleeding from his eyes, bowed towards the woman. He sounded gentle and calm, as if he was free from all the desires in this world.

“Sorry, I was blind. Please forgive me for offending your car.”

The woman looked at him nonchalantly, before giving me a sideways glance. “I wouldn’t dare be audacious when there’s a higher power helping you out here. You’re bowing to the wrong person.”

The boy turned to me. He looked cold and unfamiliar. “I don’t know her. She’s just poking her nose into the affairs of others. That’s her fault and it has nothing to do with me. I hope you can forgive me.”

I was stunned. The blood on my hands was already caking up.

The woman glanced at Gaoqin Jiuye and I, lips turning up in a smile. “Let her kneel and kowtow to me then. I’ll forgive you with that.”

“You...” Gaoqin Jiuye stopped me again as I was about to attack.

The woman seemed to have taken an interest in Gaoqin Jiuye. Her eyes were shining as she looked at him.

The boy’s gaze remained calm and collected, kneeling immediately when he heard the woman.

He put both his hands on the ground and started kowtowing to the woman once, twice, three times. As he did that, he said, “I don’t know her at all. It has nothing to do with me. It was me who had offended you, so I should be the one kowtowing to you.”

His fingers were pale against the ground.

Thud, thud, thud.

That was the muted sound of his head hitting the ground.

His forehead started to bleed. The blood flowed into those blood-red eyes of his. I couldn't bear to look at this, but I couldn't shut my eyes to this scene either.

The woman's anger seemed to have been appeased now. She looked at Gaoqin Jiuye. "I'm not someone who cares about these things. I'll forgive you since you're sincere in your apology. I'm in a bit of a rush so I'll make a move now."

As she walked back to her car, she lifted a pale, white thigh and used it to brush against Gaoqin Jiuye.

Gaoqin Jiuye had that usual look of evil malice on him. It didn't look like he was annoyed at all.

"If fate permits, we'll meet again. I like people like you. Remember whatever you've said today. I let him go, so you'll have to 'satisfy' me in future."

She left in her car after that.

That made me want to vomit. For some reason, I felt disgusted by it.

There wasn't anyone nearby when the woman started picking on the boy, as if everyone was used to these things happening here. However, many of them began to look at me with suspicion in their eyes when I stood up for the boy.

The boy stood up slowly, looking unhurried.

"Why?" I asked as I looked at him.

He had never looked at me once. Even now, he simply wiped the blood away from his forehead. "You're from the outside? If you're from the outside, then there's no way you'd stay in the Gate of Ghost forever. If you make an enemy out of her today, she might look for me to take revenge in the future after you're gone. After you're gone, there'd be no one left to

protect me. I'll then be left here and continue being insulted by her. Have you ever thought of that?"

A sudden realization hit me. *That's right, have I ever thought of that?*

I'm not a soul splitter, and I've always felt that my life had an expiration date. To them, however, life had no expiration date. How horrible and painful would it be if they had no power in a never-ending life?

If I leave, she'd continue harassing and bullying him. There's nothing else for him to do but face the pain when he loses his protection. Is this what the soul splitters have to face? Is this why they're looking for ways to shorten their endless lives?

How laughable this was. Those with limited lives wish to be immortal, but those who can be immortal are tired of living.

We'll never be content.

After wiping away the blood on his forehead, he finally turned to look at me. His right eye was healing very slowly, and it was still a bloody hole. Luckily, he did not really mean to blind himself and from the looks of it, the wound should still be able to heal.

"You know what. If you don't have the ability to save somebody, then don't do it on a whim. Sometimes, these fake acts of kindness will end up killing more people. What you're doing is simply giving them a false sense of hope when you have neither the heart nor the ability to save somebody. But there's no hope here. Your help will turn into a fuse that will eventually lead them into the abyss."

His voice sounded calm and faraway. "I'd choose to compromise instead of giving myself false hope."

My heart sank. *Whatever he said... might actually be true...*

I'm not able to save my friends and I'm not even able to protect myself, so who am I to give him false hope like this?

How could my help be like what Li Qing described it to be? Kindness in the Split Zone? I don't fit in here at all... I don't seem to fit in anywhere...

Chapter 200: 200 Saving Each Other

Volume 4

200 Saving Each Other

My heart sank right down to the bottom of the abyss, drowning in the darkness.

Gaoqin Jiuye suddenly laughed and said to the boy, “You’re right. We shouldn’t be giving false hope to others if we aren’t able to save them. But if no one gives anyone hope in this world, what would it become? You think that hope is something that others should continually be giving?”

Gaoqin Jiuye was still holding my hand. “We’ll only need to sow a tiny seed of hope in you. It’s up to you whether you’ll be able to grab onto this and be reborn in the future. There’s no one who owes you a living. How could you blame someone for not helping you all the time when she’s willing to help you out just this once? What you should do is to grab hold of that hand and stand up on your own. If the helping hand is gone after that, you should then learn how to stand on your own two feet.”

The boy and I were both stunned by his words.

The boy looked at Gaoqin Jiuye with a light in those previously dead eyes.

Gaoqin Jiuye’s smile seemed to freeze. “I was from the Gate of Heaven.”

The boy furrowed his brows. “If I remember right, there’s no one this nice from the Gate of Heaven. All of them are merely pretending to be righteous.”

There was hatred in the boy's gaze. This hate seemed to come from deep within him, it was a kind of extreme hatred. He did not have such a gaze even when the woman was picking on him earlier.

Just how much do the people in the Gate of Heaven and the Gate of Ghost hate each other?

"If those from the Gate of Heaven were like what you said, they wouldn't have saved you, they'd have killed you instead." Du Yue walked over from her spectator stand.

She's probably getting impatient at all this.

She walked over to Gaoqin Jiuye and seemed to steal a glance at my hand that was in his.

As I looked at Du Yue, I felt like I suddenly understood how the boy felt. If everyone from the Gate of Heaven was like her, then I would really hate all of them right down to my bones.

Even if it was someone like Gaoqin Jiuye, who was cold on the outside but passionate on the inside, we'd still need to spend quite some time with him before the original impression of him changed.

The boy stared at Du Yue with hostility. I was secretly happy at this. *This boy knew who was evil with just one glance.*

Du Yue did not bother looking at the boy. I could tell what she was thinking from her look of disdain. She probably saw it as a gift that she was willing to speak to the boy. Du Yue was someone who looks at the MF of others. Someone from the Gate of Ghost who had an MF of less than 20 would probably not catch her eye at all.

I really had to look up to Ta Lai for this, even though he was nothing to me now that he had hurt Nie Zun. He is still extraordinary to have the ability to gain the loyalty of such a cruel and ruthless woman.

Du Yue was visibly impatient now. She said, “How long do you guys wish to linger? Not enough stares?”

Gaoqin Jiuye pointed to somewhere in front. “Isn’t that a hotel right there? Let’s go over and take a rest.”

Du Yue glanced at him before she looked at my hand in his. She then turned around and walked towards the hotel in her ripped trousers.

It was understandable that she was impatient, since her trousers were ripped off by me, and it did not look very good to walk around like this for long either.

Li Wen caught up with Du Yue quickly, giving me a gentle smile as she passed me by.

I didn’t want to look at her at all.

Gaoqin Jiuye addressed the boy. “We’re leaving now. Like what you said, there’s nothing wrong in compromising with the woman earlier, since it’s just a way to protect yourself. But she’s not at fault for giving you hope and helping you out either. You should be grateful instead of being so cold. This is the way of the world, and I hope you can understand that.”

The boy looked at Gaoqin Jiuye meaningfully, hesitation in his eyes. He nodded eventually.

Gaoqin Jiuye laughed. “We’ll meet again if fate permits it.” He pulled me with him as he left.

I turned back to look at the boy. He was still standing there, as if in deep thought. But at the same time, it looked like he was lost and confused.

“How long do you plan on holding my hand?” I looked at the person beside me with a frown.

Gaoqin Jiuye raised his brows. “I’ll hold onto it for as long as I can.”

I responded coldly, “Acting all the way huh.”

Gaoqin Jiuye shrugged. “Think of it however you want to.”

“I didn’t know that you could actually say something humane.” I teased him.

“I was just speaking my mind,” said Gaoqin Jiuye rather seriously.

“Then, from when did you have such thoughts?”

Gaoqin Jiuye looked into the distance, as if he was reminiscing the past. “From a long time ago, from when I was still a child, when I was just a child, like that boy.”

As I looked at him, I was reminded of what happened when Si Luo tried to look into my heart. The image I saw in Si Luo’s heart was that of Gaoqin Jiuye when he was still a teenager. I couldn’t even recognize him in that scene.

I remembered he looked lonely in the scene, his eyes shining with an obstinate light.

Was he referring to the him of the past? He was just like that boy in the past? But how could that be? Gaoqin Jiuye was an extraordinary individual who was widely-known in the Split Zone. Nobody knew the value of his MF, they just knew that he had extraordinary abilities. How could he be like that boy who had an MF of less than 20?

“Are you wondering why someone with high MF like me can understand that boy?”

Caught by surprise, I asked, “How did you know?”

Gaoqin Jiuye said casually, “All your thoughts are clearly reflected on your face. I knew it when I saw that constipated face of yours.”

My lips twitched. “Sorry, bodies of consciousness in the Split Zone do not need the toilet. So I think you should wake up now.”

Gaoqin Jiuye laughed. “Okay, I’ll stop teasing you and tell you why I can understand him. Sometimes, extraordinary individuals have things in common with extremely weak individuals.”

Extraordinary individuals and extremely weak individuals... Why did I think of Gao Qi and me at this point?

“Whether they are standing at the peak or hiding in the sewers, they’re both equally lonely. Only those who’re walking on the roads are able to enjoy the ordinary peace and quiet, they’re the ones who’re accepted by all the others.”

A faint sorrow passed Gaoqin Jiuye’s eyes. It was very, very faint.

Was this the reason why Gao Qi shared that space on the rooftop only with me? Or was he part of those memories in the laboratory which I’ve forgotten? Or... was it a secret that only he knew?

Was it because he saw me going through the same things as he did?

But he was already so dazzling...

I took my hand away from Gaoqin Jiuye, saying coldly, “Those at the top might probably think like you. You guys think that you’re similar to those living in the sewers, but how could it be the same? Even though you are lonely at the top, you can still be a proud and arrogant individual. Those in the sewers live in the darkness every day. How will you be able to understand them fully? It’s true that those at the top are lonely, and those who have lost everything are also lonely. However, they’re never the same.”

I felt a little colder without the warmth from his hand, but I continued speaking. “The strong talk about being lonely, but that’s just a sham. The weak don’t talk about being lonely, because they live it every day, and there’s no hope in sight.”

Gaoqin Jiuye’s eyes narrowed. “So you think that just because I’m stronger and that I’ve always been extraordinary, that I should be ostracized, that I deserve to be alone?”

I looked at him. “That’s not what I meant.”

Gaoqin Jiuye responded coldly. “Whatever it is, seems like you’ve gotten something right. It’s true that we can never understand weaklings, just like how I can never understand you.”

This sounded like *I’m strong and you, Li Shen, are weak. Because of this, I will never understand you.*

I smiled bitterly to myself. *But didn’t you say that you were the only one who understood me?*

Who’re we contradicting? Are we both contradicting ourselves here?

I didn’t voice my thoughts. Instead, I said, “I’m sorry, but I don’t think that I’m a weakling. There’ll come a day when you’ll be convinced that I’m not one.”

Gaoqin Jiuye smirked. “Really? You think that day will come? Neither Jiao S nor Nie Zun are by your side right now, who are you going to depend on? And if you refuse to hold my hand when I reach out to you, who else can you depend on then? You’re going to depend on yourself?”

I stared at him angrily. “Yes, I’m going to depend on myself. I’m sure of this now. You, Gaoqin Jiuye, do not understand me at all. It has always been like this. I won’t ever be picked if there’s a conflict or when there’s a choice. That’s your choice, and it’s destined to be this way. The only thing I’m curious about is that since you’ve already made your choice, what are you trying to change? One shouldn’t be too greedy. You’ve chosen the path of solitude and you have no right to regret that choice. How about you admit it? That apart from Si Luo, you have no one else by your side.”

After this, I continued on my path, not turning back to look.

His voice was soft from behind. “You’ve said it too, I can’t regret it. Even if I wanted to choose again, no one would give me the opportunity to do so. Don’t you see that too?”

Though I was a little upset that I had hurt him this way, I never turned around. *This is us, Gaoqin Jiuye and Li Shen. We'll never forgive and we'll never come to an understanding.*

We had to hurt each other all the time. Because we thought this was how we could save each other and help each other grow.

But, can we really do it?

Chapter 201: 201 Our Relationship

Volume 4

201 Our Relationship

The hotel Gaoqin Jiuye picked was the equivalent of a three-star hotel in the real world. The condition of the hotel was not bad at all. It even felt like I was back in the real world.

“Do we need to spend money here? We shouldn’t need to, right? There isn’t some kind of currency here in the Northern District I hope?” I mumbled my question to Li Wen.

Li Wen laughed at me. “You really don’t know anything, do you? It’s the same as when you were in the Western District. What currency are you talking about? We’ll just barter with the service provider if need be. If that isn’t needed, then we’ll simply check in. Anyway, whoever with the ability to manage such a hotel in the Gate of Ghost would definitely have a high MF.”

So everything still comes down to MF.

I realized what Li Wen meant by people being categorized here. From the looks of it, especially in the Gate of Ghost, one had to depend on MF to live. The strong survive and the weak are simply left for dead.

Why is it like this everywhere? Is this really how the world works?

Li Wen could read my mind. “You shouldn’t be complaining, Ah Shen. Such categorization might be cruel to most, but have you ever thought about a scenario where it’s not survival of the fittest? How do we continue improving? Some things are not merely coincidences, they just have to

happen. That's the rule of survival. Your greatest weakness is that you're always trying to go against the natural order, that you refuse to accept it."

So is this why I was always referred to as a 'weirdo'?

A pretty lady who looked to be about seventeen or eighteen was seated at the reception desk in the hotel lobby. She smiled as she asked how many rooms were needed. Her attitude was impeccable.

I was suddenly curious about something. *Did hotels in the Split Zone need prove of identity?*

It was proven that we didn't need something like that eventually.

Well, how could bodies of consciousness have identities? Would it matter even if we did?

Du Yue was her usual haughty self. She answered the receptionist coldly, "Four. What do you need us to do?"

The receptionist looked like she had seen enough customers not to be surprised at this. She probably had already seen many who had high MF and she wasn't fazed even though Du Yue looked to be extremely strong. Her smile remained as she answered, "There's no need for you to do anything. You're welcome to stay for as long as you have to."

This was an advantage being in the Split Zone – not needing to spend a single cent on lodging in a three-star hotel.

"I think we should get three rooms. I'll room with her." Gaoqin Jiuye interrupted, pointing at me. Du Yue had a stormy expression as she heard this.

I probably did not look too great either. I might have worked with him on this if it were not for the fight which happened between us earlier. Right now, I didn't want to work with him at all.

I rejected it immediately. "No, I don't want to room with you. I want a room of my own."

I looked at Du Yue as I said this, trying to tell her that she should be treating me better on this journey if she wants me to continue following her.

Du Yue was probably happy at this, and she said once again to the receptionist, “Four rooms.”

We were given four adjacent rooms on the third floor.

A family entered the lobby as we were waiting for the elevator. This family did not look too shabby, but I could sense that they did not have very high MF either.

When they asked what they had to do in exchange for accommodation, the receptionist turned unfriendly all of a sudden. She said coldly without any hesitation, “Leave. You’ll never be allowed in here no matter what you do. We do not welcome you.”

I guess there’s no way I can ever understand how things work in the world of soul splitters even when this place looked so much like the real world.

I chose room number 333 when we arrived on the third floor. I just loved the number three.

Gaoqin Jiuye acted like a child sometimes. He seemed to be a little upset at me for not agreeing to room with him, and seeing that I chose this particular room, he said, “It’s no wonder you’re mental, a whole bunch of obsessive compulsive choices.”

I couldn’t be bothered with him.

Gaoqin Jiuye chose room number 334, which was right beside me. Li Wen was in 332 and Du Yue was in 335.

Du Yue had requested for the receptionist to prepare new sets of clothing for all four of us, all of which had to be identical to what we were wearing currently.

I asked Li Wen, “There’s a marketplace for goods here in the Northern District too?”

Li Wen smiled mysteriously. “I can’t tell you about this. Just know that you’ll not be in need of anything.”

I was quite delighted when I entered room 333. It’s been a long time since I’ve lived like I did in the real world. Even though life was pretty much the same in the Western District, there are still differences and limitations, like how different areas like the Academy, the Marketplace and the Residential buildings were divided. I felt like I was revived now that I was staying in this nice hotel.

It felt like I was brought back to life after being dead for too long, and I was almost moved to tears after seeing the real world that I missed so much.

But I wasn’t someone who was dead for too long, I was just a person who had died a long time ago.

Also, I wasn’t someone who was brought back to life suddenly, because this wasn’t the real world. Whatever I’m experiencing now was just a sham, or at least I thought it was.

I began to wonder if the Split Zone was territory belonging to extraterrestrial aliens who copied and imitated everything we did in the real world.

It was only after a long, long time did I realize how idiotic I was at this point.

Even though I was very emotional right now, it wasn’t to the point that I was moved to tears.

I took a comfortable shower and stared blankly at that scorpion insignia that was glowing faintly on my left ankle.

Wrapping myself up in a towel, I looked in the mirror. The girl with red hair in the mirror looked somewhat stubborn. I reached out to touch the girl’s face that was reflected in the mirror, feeling a little weird inside.

Sometimes people just blank out when they look in mirrors, to the point that you wouldn't notice anyone pass behind you even when they could be seen in the mirror.

"Did you see me? Or did you not?" I got a shock when I heard Nie Zun's voice behind me, almost letting go of the towel around me.

I wrapped the towel tightly around my chest, turning around to face the visitor after making sure it was tight enough that it wouldn't slip.

Nie Zun was sitting against the windowsill. I looked at the window behind him. It didn't look like it had been opened. I believe I would've known if the window had been opened, even if I had been daydreaming earlier.

This meant that he didn't enter through the window. Where did he come from then if he didn't enter through the door either?

Nie Zun the amnesiac looked audacious but dashing. Starlight was shining in his eyes, and those wispy bangs of his covered part of that charming face.

He was still dressed in black, except that his gloves were gone now. I noticed that he still had that skull ring on his left hand.

"How did you enter?" I asked carefully. Nie Zun the amnesiac was dangerous to me now.

He pointed casually to the door behind me. "The door."

I brushed my red hair away. "The door? How could that be? There wasn't any sound. I don't think I'm deaf. And also, I have the room keycard with me, so how did you get in?"

He shrugged. "I was already here yesterday. I broke in. I guess they've re-installed the lock. Anyway, none of them realized I was here."

I believed him this time. If he had lost his memories, then this definitely sounded like something he would have done.

I walked over to the bed, crashing into the soft mattress. “Then why did you choose this particular room? Did you know I was coming over?”

Nie Zun laughed. “How could I know that? It was just a coincidence that I arrived here, and I just liked the room number.”

What an unescapable fate this is. Stop getting involved if you’ve lost your memories and if you’ve already forgotten who I am, I thought to myself angrily.

I closed my eyes and said coldly, “You can leave now. I’m staying in this room.”

There was no response.

Opening my eyes to check if he had left, I got a rude shock as I saw his face right in front of mine.

He was using MF to levitate. It’s no wonder I couldn’t sense him approaching.

He smirked as he saw me open my eyes. Deactivating his MF, he dropped immediately.

Though he wasn’t floating at such a height, there was still a muted thud when he dropped onto me.

He was right on top of me now, propping himself up with both hands on the bed. My head was right between his hands. I stared at him coldly, but my heartbeat quickened. “Are you trying to take advantage of me?”

He looked me all over before finally speaking. “I don’t think there’s anything about you that I can take advantage of.”

Gritting my teeth angrily, I said, “Then get off me now.”

Obviously, there’s no way he would listen. He would always tease me, and now that he had lost his memories, there’s no stopping him.

He leaned in closer to me. “I felt that there was something more between us from the very moment I saw you. I want to confirm it now, the kind of relationship we had in the past.”

Still gritting my teeth, I answered, “There was nothing between us.”

Chapter 202: 202 Nie Zun the Amnesiac

Volume 4

202 Nie Zun the Amnesiac

An evil smile appeared on Nie Zun. “I get to decide, not you.”

I wanted to kick him, but he was too quick and caught my leg in his hand. I was in nothing but a towel...

“You you you, let go of my leg.” I blushed as I saw him trying to lift it.

Nie Zun smiled mischievously, as if satisfied with my reaction. He then let go of me. I didn’t dare move this time.

He leaned in closer again, blowing air into my ears. “You look pretty good up close...” I thought to myself angrily, *Annoying retard. I’ll make you kneel on instant noodles when you regain your memories.*

You can’t fight a hungry wolf head-on at times like this. You had to use persuasion. “Since I’m good-looking, let me get up first. You can look all you want when the hotel attendant sends me my clothing. How about that?”

Nie Zun looked me up and down again. He looked like he was observing a naked woman. With a smile on my face, I maintained eye contact with him. My heart was racing now, and if he had continued looking, I might just get a nosebleed.

“I’ll let you go this time.” Nie Zun turned and lay down beside me, no longer paying me any heed. I sat up quickly. When I looked back at him, he

was already using his arms as a pillow, resting with his eyes closed.

The doorbell rang right at this moment.

Thinking that it would be the attendant sending clothing, I walked over and opened the door quickly, only to be met with Gaoqin Jiuye. He was holding a brand new red dress.

For some reason, I kept telling myself that I had to prevent Gaoqin Jiuye from realizing that Nie Zun was in the room. I quickly thought about the structure of the room. Gaoqin Jiuye shouldn't be able to see Nie Zun from his current position. But if he moved a couple of steps forward into the room, he would definitely be able to see Nie Zun.

Right, I got this. I placed a hand on the door and the other on the doorframe as I said, "It's you sending the clothing?"

Gaoqin Jiuye looked me up and down. It was only at this point did I realize I was still in that towel...

He smirked. "Are you doing this on purpose?"

I looked down at myself. My arms were outstretched and I was covered in nothing but a towel. Though nothing could be seen through that towel, this pose was a little...

I retracted the hand that was on the doorframe and quickly closed the door behind me with the other hand, leaning my back against the closed door.

Snatching the red dress from him, I started to chase him away. "Okay, I got my dress. You can return to your room now."

Gaoqin Jiuye glanced at the door behind me. "You seem weird. Why? Is there a man hidden in your room?" He meant this as a joke, but I couldn't help tensing at this. *Stay calm, stay calm, Li Shen. Don't let him see through you.*

I smiled at him calmly. "Yes, that's right. There's a man in the room. What about it? You want to come in and have a look?"

Gaoqin Jiuye waved a hand. “Fine, you don’t look like you want to let me in either. Go and get changed quickly. Who’re you waiting for when you’re dressed like this walking around in the hallway.”

I stared at him. “Don’t be idiot. Go back to your room.”

Gaoqin Jiuye walked back to his room without much ado. I let out a sigh of relief only after I watched him enter his room. But I took in another breath shortly after as I realized I didn’t bring the keycard with me. I had just closed the door behind me.

Do I knock? If I do that, Gaoqin Jiuye will hear it for sure. Why would I be knocking on the door to an empty room?

I’ll call for Nie Zun. No, that’s a worse option. The door opened as I was still thinking about what to do. I turned around in pleasant surprise, meeting Nie Zun’s lazy gaze.

The door to Gaoqin Jiuye’s room opened right at this moment. He popped his head out from his room. “Why’re you not going in?”

I glanced at Nie Zun and realized that he was about to walk out. I smiled at Gaoqin Jiuye and said quickly, “I’m going in now. I was just daydreaming for a bit.”

Nie Zun seemed to be on the verge of saying something, so I pushed him into the room, kicking the door closed behind me. I used too much strength and the both of us ended up falling onto the floor. The red dress was strewn onto the floor as well.

Nie Zun looked slightly confused at this. I seemed to see a sliver of the old Nie Zun in him now, but he regained that audacious look as he looked at me. “Can’t wait but to push me down like this?”

I wasn’t in the mood for this banter now. Rolling over to his side, I said, “You get up first.”

He stood up quickly. I picked up the dress and made my way to the washroom. I took out that teleportation pill Jiao S gave me previously, tucking it safely into my new dress. After I changed, I took a glance at Nie Zun as I walked out. Just one glance and I seemed to be stranded on the spot.

He was leaning with his back against the wall, looking casual with both hands in his pockets. His body leaned forward slightly as he stood with his legs crossed. Those wispy bangs obscured an eye.

“Nie Zun...” I muttered, forgetting that he had lost his memories in this particular moment.

Nie Zun looked a little stunned at the sudden change in my attitude towards him, but he reacted quickly. Straightening up, he said, “What, confessing to me now?”

I got my wits back together and ignored him. I lay down on the bed.

“Don’t you have anything you want to know?” Nie Zun lay down beside me, but I kept my eyes closed.

I answered softly, “What do you wish for me to ask? Ask why you reappeared? Ask you what your goal is?”

Nie Zun said, “I thought you’d ask if I had remembered you.”

My eyes snapped open.

Whether you remembered me?

Yes, Nie Zun, do you remember me?

Nie Zun continued beside me, “What do you plan on doing if I can never remember?”

I answered, “Then we’ll just get to know each other again.”

Nie Zun leaned in closer to my ear. “You like me?”

I turned to look at him, using my hands as a pillow for my head. “Ask me again when you’ve remembered who I am. I’ll give you the answer at that point.”

I leaned in close, pulling on his sleeve. Closing my eyes, I said, “Don’t talk anymore. Just let me sleep close to you like this.”

What I didn’t say was that I was never able to fall asleep ever since you left.

I don’t know how long I’ve had this insomnia for. I knew that I had to rest if I wanted my MF to recover properly, but I’ve been overtaxing myself.

Nobody could understand the exhaustion that was seeping through me, not even you.

Even if you don’t remember me at this point, I’d be able to sleep well as long as you were by my side.

I had a dreamless sleep.

It was still night when I woke up. There were about ten more hours until daylight.

I suddenly felt that I should make use of this opportunity to do something, since Du Yue and the rest would probably wait until daylight before leaving.

I woke Nie Zun. “Hey, didn’t you ask me if I had any questions for you? I have one now.”

Nie Zun opened his eyes. They looked extremely clear, devoid of the sleepiness seen in people who’ve just woken up. “You’re really weird. You refuse to ask earlier and now you’re waking me up in the middle of the night to ask me a question.”

I smiled apologetically. “I just happened to wake up. Have you seen Huai Du?”

Furrowing his brows, Nie Zun asked, “Who’s Huai Du?”

I pushed him. “Don’t pretend. That’s the king in the Gate of Ghost. He’s the mysterious individual who’s been controlling you all this time.”

A sudden realization seemed to hit Nie Zun. “Oh, him. No, I’ve never seen him, but he asked me to come look for you.”

“So this means you came here on purpose? That it wasn’t a coincidence?”

“No, I set off to look for you but ended up here before I found you. It was purely coincidental that we met here,” Nie Zun explained patiently.

I stared at him. “You seem to have become friendlier. Why is that? Do you remember something?”

“No. I don’t remember you at all.”

“Then why are you friendly towards me now?”

“Am I? I just don’t feel like killing anyone right now.”

“...I never thought you were actually a crazed killer. Seems like our true selves would be revealed only when we lose our memories.”

“Do you think about this nonsense on a daily basis?” Nie Zun looked at me with a slight smile as he said this.

I didn’t smile. Instead, I asked seriously, “Why did he want you to look for me?”

“Tch, women. Unpredictable like the weather. Fine, he wants that item you have.” He pointed at Scorpion Ray on my left hand.

“Why are you helping him? Why do you listen to him?”

Nie Zun seemed to be a little stuck at my question. He seemed to wonder why he was following Huai Du’s orders.

“Hey, I asked you a question.” I waved a hand in front of him.

Finally, he answered, “Oh. I don’t know. I just remember that there was this voice which accompanied me during that tormentous time in that tablet. That voice belonged to him.”

“Tormentous time?” I frowned. Seems like it wasn’t easy, whatever he had to go through.

Nie Zun nodded. “Yes. I don’t remember much, but I remember that voice of his. This is why I think that I should be listening to him. I might be able to find the answers to some questions only if I do that.”

“What questions?”

He smiled mysteriously. “I can’t tell you that. It’s personal.”

Chapter 203: 203 Underground Banquet at Hong Gate

Volume 4

203 Underground Banquet at Hong Gate

(T/n: The *Banquet at Hong Gate* or *Hong Men Yan* was a historical event that took place during the Qin dynasty. It is usually used to describe situations that look glamorous on the outside but have a hidden agenda to it. Here's the Wikipedia link on it for more information.)

The doorbell rang again.

I nudged Nie Zun. "Go open the door. I'm too lazy to move."

Nie Zun gave a slight smile as he shut his eyes and turned to the other side. He had no intention of opening the door.

I had no choice but to do it myself. More than ten hours of sleep was enough rest for now, but so many things seemed to have happened in this time.

A petite girl in uniform greeted me at the door.

The uniformed girl smiled sweetly at me. "Good evening. There's a swimsuit dance party happening right now at the pool in the basement. We were wondering if you might be interested to have a look? The party is scheduled to be about three hours long, and both the food and alcohol are of the highest grade. There's also seafood available, and everything is complimentary."

Seafood... My eyes lit up at that.

There should still be about six hours to daylight. No harm in having a little fun here.

I looked around at the other rooms. No one seemed to be out. I whispered to the girl, "Alright. Have you asked the rest in these rooms?"

The uniformed girl smiled and whispered back in response, "No. It's a draw where we pick the lucky guests."

I nodded. "That's great. There's no need to invite them even if you happened to pick the guests in any of these rooms. We're a group so I can help you get them." I pointed at the three other rooms.

The uniformed girl kept her smile. "Sure. You might wish to head for basement 18 via the lift on the left at the end of the hallway."

Is that the eighteenth level of hell? I simply nodded as I chided her in my heart.

After she left, I returned to my room and nudged Nie Zun. "Hey, the attendant informed me that there's a swimsuit party at basement 18. Want to go take a look? There's food and it's probably going to be loads of fun."

Nie Zun sat up. "Swimsuit party. Pretty girls."

The corner of my lips twitched. *Did the characters of amnesiacs change as well? When did he become such a pervert?*

We did not meet anyone as we made our way to the lift.

"Do you find this hotel a little weird? Why isn't there anyone around?" I asked Nie Zun as we were waiting for the lift.

Nie Zun looked around lazily. "Probably because it's night now."

I pushed the 'B18' button as we entered the lift.

As the lift began its descent, unease started to well up in me. *Isn't the eighteenth level in the basement too coincidental of a number?* (T/n: The eighteenth level of hell is one of the many levels of hell in Chinese legend. Here is the [Wikipedia link](#) to more information on the Chinese interpretations of hell.)

I stole a glance at Nie Zun. *What am I afraid of when you're right here...*

Even when you've forgotten me, even when you've forgotten your promise of protecting me forever...

I haven't forgotten it...

Ding.

We arrived quickly. I took a deep breath before the door opened, preparing myself just in case we were met with an entire floor of corpses.

When the doors finally opened, the scene in front of me proved that I was worrying about nothing.

There was a ring-shaped pool in the middle of the spacious lobby. A glamorous crystal chandelier was hanging from the ceiling and conveyor belts filled with food surrounded the space. Hundreds of party-goers were present.

Two beautiful ushers welcomed us as we exited the lift. "Welcome to the underground pool and entertainment center at the Royal Hotel. Your seats have been labelled with your room numbers and they can be found to the left at the end of the walkway."

"Thank you." I pulled Nie Zun along with me, looking around in excitement.

The ground looked like it had been paved with pebbles, but it was actually a mosaic made with gravel that glowed with a faint white light. Those with trypophobia might find this a little disturbing, but it was actually quite comfortable to walk on.

But that's only if you were in flats. Luckily, I changed out of my heels earlier into short, red boots that I had requested from the hotel. It was better not to expose my split symbol here in the Gate of Ghost, since it was indeed very different from the Western District.

Nie Zun let me lead him along. His eyes were shining with curiosity. I guess a scene like this would be very interesting to an amnesiac.

There were ring-shaped pools on either side as we continued on our path. A bunch of girls dressed in bikinis were performing in those pools. They looked graceful as they floated and swished around in the water. *How nice was it to have high MF. One could 'walk on water' anytime.*

The uniformed girl I saw appeared in front of us. She had an elegant smile as approached us. "Miss Li Shen, this way please."

Like a knight, she held out a hand as she led the way. *Wait, why did she know my name?*

I carefully asked, "How do you know that my name is Li Shen?"

She answered calmly, "That's because you've registered at the ground floor lobby when you checked into room number 333. You might have forgotten that."

"Oh, I see."

"It's right there."

"Okay."

Pulling Nie Zun with me, I walked to where the girl pointed me to.

There was a table with three chairs around it. Everything was made of glass and everything was transparent. It looked exquisitely made.

I spoke softly to Nie Zun, "I didn't register anything when I checked in, so there's no way they'd know my name. There's definitely something going on here, so we should be careful."

This did not bother Nie Zun at all. He simply remained silent.

After taking my seat, I started to observe the people around me.

There were a few individuals at another table that was closer to Nie Zun. They weren't suspicious. They looked like ordinary guests who were here to have a good time. The guests seated nearer to me were rowdier and raucous bouts of laughter could be heard. But they didn't seem to be out of the ordinary either.

Right in front of us was a group of women who were performing in the pool.

Every one of them was in a leopard-print bikini as they danced gracefully in the water. The woman in the middle was in a nude bikini. It was just a shade darker than her skin, making it look like it was a naked woman dancing in the pool if we watched from afar.

"This girl..." I muttered as I tried to make out the features on her face.

Nie Zun continued, "Hmm, very sexy indeed."

I rolled my eyes. "I find her familiar. You've lost your memories now but you probably might have been able to recognize her."

Nie Zun looked at me with bright eyes. "Oh, I was acquainted with such a sexy lady? I think I kind of remember now."

"..." I swear I'm going to get your memories back... Just what have you become..."

I observed that lady in the middle, warning Nie Zun, "I'm telling you that girl in the middle is not someone who's simple. She's an expert in using poisons and she might be targeting us. You better be careful."

I recognized the girl now. It was Yuan Qian, Yuan Shen's younger sister.

I could not imagine what it was that could have made the quiet and calm Yuan Qian wear something like this in such a dance. But I knew she was

here for me. She might just be here to kill me.

Her brother died because of me.

My mind replayed the scene of Yuan Shen's death, making me feel uncomfortable. *There's no way I could save those I've already lost, but I can't lose anyone else now...*

I took a deep breath after I've made a decision. I looked directly at Yuan Qian in the pool. Yuan Qian happened to be looking at me right at this moment, and she seemed to be smiling.

The uniformed girl appeared before me just as I was concentrating on Yuan Qian, blocking her from my sight.

I realized the girl was rather short. Though she had the height of a child, her face did not look as young. For some reason, I found her familiar. I seemed to have heard her voice from somewhere.

The uniformed girl smiled at me. "Dear valued guest, what would you like to have for food and drinks?"

I responded with a faint smile. "Seafood. Any set meals available? If there is, we'll get two. For drinks, anything is fine."

The uniformed girl nodded with that polite smile of hers. "Alright. Just a moment."

Nie Zun pointed at the girl who just left. "Why does she ask you every time? She doesn't ask me anything."

I propped my hands up on the table and asked, "Why do you think? You snuck in here. It's lucky they aren't asking anything more, and you want them to treat you like a proper guest?"

The uniformed girl was back as I finished my sentence. What amazing speed she had.

She held two plates. One for Nie Zun and one for me.

I was a little stunned as I took the plate.

The plate had a...

There was a worm on the plate. It was black and yellow and probably measured about ten centimeters or more. It had no head and it seemed a little squishy. There were two claws at its end resembling crab pincers.

The uniformed girl spoke softly, "This is the best crab we have here. You might want to have a taste."

My throat tightened. I didn't know what to say to this.

There's no way I would have gotten it wrong. This thing in front of me was definitely one of those dead leeches.

I looked at the uniformed girl. She still had that smile on her. Her hands were slightly crossed and placed in front, a respectful pose.

I smiled after looking at her for a couple of seconds. "This is definitely something good. You can have it. Treat it like a tip from me."

I lifted the plate to her face and looked at her, waiting for a response.

She wasn't flustered and she kept her smile. Taking the plate, she said, "Alright, I'll do as our guest wishes."

With her free hand, she took the dead leech and popped it into her mouth.

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204 Swallowing Poison

After swallowing that leech, she wiped the corners of her mouth as if it was delicious.

“Thank you for the delicious crab. I’ll get you another one.”

I stared at her. “Who are you?”

The uniformed girl never lost her smile. “I can understand that Miss Li Shen might have forgotten, but from what I remember, you weren’t such an impatient person. How about enjoying the entire performance? Some things shouldn’t be rushed, don’t you agree?”

She turned to leave after saying this.

Nie Zun knocked on the table. “Hey what are the two of you talking about? Can this be eaten or not?”

I really missed the old Nie Zun. At least he wasn’t a retard.

I stared at him angrily. “You can eat it if you wish. Eat till you die from it.”

A look of confused bewilderment appeared on Nie Zun.

This individual acted just like a demon when he came out of that cave, and now he’s trying to act all cute with me? Has his character changed so

much, or is it that he's suffering from schizophrenia now?

There was no time for me to think about why Nie Zun turned out like this as Yuan Qian had now completed her dance and she was already walking towards us.

I smiled to myself bitterly. *How popular am I that everyone seemed to be looking for me wherever I went?*

"Been a long time," I spoke first.

Yuan Qian probably did not expect for me to make the first move. She was a little surprised, but not for long. "Yes, it is a long time."

"Sit down," I said as I pointed at the chair between me and Nie Zun. Yuan Qian nodded as she sat.

I glanced at Nie Zun. To my surprise, he didn't seem to be interested in her anymore now that she's so close. He was looking elsewhere now.

"Seems like you've been made aware of your brother's death." I decided to be direct.

A look of pain flashed past Yuan Qian's face, but it was gone in a moment.

"Yes, I'm aware of that."

"Are you looking for me to take revenge?" I asked simply.

Yuan Qian looked at me. "Are you admitting that you actually killed him?"

Tapping my finger on the table, I said, "No, but I was definitely involved in some way. I guess you wouldn't believe me no matter what I say now."

Yuan Qian kept her eyes on me. "Yes. At first, I didn't believe you'd kill my brother, or let him die such a horrible death. However, he was an extremely rational individual, and I believe that apart from you, there would be nobody else who could approach him without ringing any alarm bells."

“So you think I killed him?”

Yuan Qian bit her lip. “At least I think you’re involved somehow.”

I sighed. “It has something to do with me. But I’m curious about something. Who is it who told you I killed him?”

Li Wen was in the hotel now, and if she was the culprit, she should be here right now. There might be something else going on here.

Yuan Qian pushed the plate that was in front of Nie Zun towards me. “Eat it and I’ll tell you.”

I looked at the disgusting leech on that shiny white plate. It would probably be laced with a heavy poison if it was prepared by Yuan Qian.

I reached out to grab the leech.

However, Nie Zun suddenly snatched the plate and threw it to the side, smashing it into smithereens.

Nie Zun smirked with malice in his eyes. “This lady right here, it’s not nice to make others eat weird things. Moreover, this bug doesn’t even look delicious.”

Tears dripped down Yuan Qian’s face, surprising me.

She looked at me with sorrowful eyes. “Ah Shen, I’ve trusted you all this time. Did you really kill my brother?”

I didn’t know how to answer, and my hand that was resting on the table balled into a fist involuntarily.

Yuan Qian grabbed my arm as she looked at me with wide eyes. “My brother and I depended on no one but each other. He never put me in any kind of danger, no matter how helpless and afraid this Split Zone made me. I was never afraid as long as he was around. He was the only one I could rely on, how could you take his life?”

Her nails were digging into my flesh, but this pain was nothing to me now. Senses and feelings were twisted here in the Split Zone, whether it was inflicted on the flesh or upon one's soul.

There was no point in avoiding this. I'm no longer the me of the past. I said calmly, "Yuan Qian, I'll give you an explanation regarding your brother's death. Come with me and I'll give you the truth."

Gritting her teeth, Yuan Qian asked, "Why should I believe you?"

My finger was digging into the tabletop. "What do you plan to do? I'll listen to you."

Yuan Qian took out a white pill from inside her bikini bra. Passing it to me, she said, "Eat this. At least it'll let me control you."

"Okay." I swallowed it immediately. It didn't feel any different, it just tasted sweet.

This must be poison then, since medicine was usually bitter.

"But there's something I don't understand. Why do you have to come here and dance like this? If you came here for me, you could've just approached me straight away."

Yuan Qian pursed her lips in response.

I realized something as I looked at her hesitant expression. "Are you being controlled as well?"

"She's being controlled by me, Ah Shen *jiejie*." A girl's voice came from behind Yuan Qian.

It was a familiar voice that sounded crisp and mischievous. I stood up as I tried to take a look at the individual. This voice belonged to Laurel.

The owner of the voice, that uniformed girl, appeared. Lifting a hand to her chin, she peeled a layer of skin off her face.

I frowned as I saw her. “Why the disguise, Laurel?”

Laurel laughed. “It’s so much fun like this, Ah Shen *jiejie*!” I was reminded of the lively Laurel from the past as I looked at that mischievous face.

But I knew that she would never be that Laurel anymore. Her body double was stabbed, and she has turned into a demon after having been bitten by those poisonous leeches. I still remember that cruelty and bloodlust of hers. My adorable Laurel would never be the same.

But even so, she still saved all of us from the Western District. *Does this mean that I can still save her?*

“Ah Shen *jiejie*, what’re you thinking about?” Laurel tip-toed and waved her hand at me.

I forced myself to speak coldly as I looked at that innocent face of hers. “No need to pretend here. What’s your goal?”

Laurel pouted. “I don’t have any goal. I just wanted to see *jiejie*. It’s been a long time since I’ve seen *jiejie*.”

I’m about to go insane.

Nie Zun interrupted at this point. “Little lady, you’re blocking the pretty women from my sight.” Nie Zun leaned back in his chair as he pointed at the women who were still dancing in the pool.

Laurel stepped in front of Nie Zun, blinking as she asked, “Nie Zun *gege*, you haven’t confessed to Ah Shen *jiejie* yet? You’ve been protecting her for so long, and you even woke the demon within you in that stone cave just to save her. Others might not know this, but I would know. It was so painful that day when you were strangling me.”

Laurel’s hands went up to her own neck as she said this, demonstrating how Nie Zun had attacked her.

Nie Zun’s smile made it look like he had actually remembered everything, and for a second, I thought he did.

“What are you talking about, little lady?”

Clicking her tongue, Laurel answered, “Nie Zun *gege*, Ah Shen *jiejie* will be taken by others if you continue being like this. Everyone can see that you’ve been quietly protecting her all these years, so stop hiding.”

Nie Zun turned to me with upturned lips. “I was that dumb in the past?”

I was a little hurt at this, as if someone had ripped a blood vessel out of my heart. I stared at him. “That’s right, you were really dumb in the past. You were also irritating, following me all day, every day.”

Laurel looked at us. “You mean you don’t remember what happened in the past, *gege*?”

I said angrily, “That’s right. He’s lost his memories. Just tell us what your goal is, no need to waste anymore time with him here.”

The adorable expression on Laurel turned icy in a split second. Her smile was gone and her voice turned sharp. “So it’s like this. I guess there’s nothing much to be afraid of now that you’ve lost Nie Zun’s protection.”

I smirked. “Finally revealing yourself?”

Laurel gave an evil smile. “*Jiejie*, I don’t really wish for your death. I wouldn’t have brought you here to the Northern District with that snake if I wanted you to die. *Meimei* just wants one thing from you. You won’t be that petty to disagree, right?”

She wants something?

I hope it’s not my second personality again.

“What do you want?”

Laurel pointed at Piercer that was hanging on my waist. “I want that living weapon of yours.”

I raised my brows. “Piercer? Only this? Not this?” I waved my left wrist that had Scorpion Ray’s insignia on it.

Laurel shook her head. “Nope. But I’ll gladly accept them if *jiejie* wishes to give both of them to me.”

It wouldn’t be Huai Du if she wants Piercer instead of Scorpion Ray. If she wasn’t sent by Huai Du nor Du Yue, then who could it be?

It’s unlikely to be Li Wen. Knowing her, she wouldn’t do something like this.

Is there some other secret group tailing me?

That could be likely. When Laurel went missing in the Western District, she wasn’t caught by Du Yue to be an experimental subject, and she didn’t fall into Li Wen’s hands either. She was merely a child at that time, and there was no way she could have survived up till now if she didn’t have a strong backing. Moreover, she had newfound abilities now.

Chapter 205: 205 Fight to Obtain Piercer

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205 Fight to Obtain Piercer

“Who sent you?”

Laurel thought for a moment before answering. “It wouldn’t be me coming to *jiejie* if I could tell you that, right? *Jiejie*, this is your only flaw. Always doing dumb things and asking dumb questions.”

Nie Zun raised a hand suddenly. “I agree with that.”

My lips twitched in annoyance. I really wanted to beat this shameless amnesiac up.

“*Jiejie*, are you going to give it to me or not?” Laurel was losing her patience. She was still addressing me as *jiejie*, but her gaze was sharp.

“Let her go.” I pointed at Yuan Qian.

Laurel laughed. “Old habits die hard, Ah Shen *jiejie*. You want to save everyone, but in the end, nobody would be saved. You might even lose your life in the process. Don’t do it if you don’t have the ability. Why don’t you understand this?”

Hate flashed momentarily in her eyes as she finished.

I’ll admit that I felt apologetic towards her, but feeling sorry won’t bring my friends back. Now wasn’t the time to think about all this.

I responded coldly, “You’re right, I’m always thinking about saving the world. I admit that it was my fault that time when I wasn’t able to save you, but I’m the only one involved in it, it had nothing to do with her.”

Laurel raised her pitch. “Nothing to do with her? Why’re you pretending to be the nice guy here? You think I didn’t see it? You let Li Wen cut up her brother’s corpse in that cave. You saw it with your own eyes but you didn’t do anything about it. You, Li Shen, love to say things that merely sound nice. Do you dare deny whatever I’ve seen?”

So it was Laurel who told Yuan Qian about this. But why would Laurel be there? Even if she was there, there’s no way Li Wen wouldn’t have sensed her presence. Or was it that Li Wen pretended not to have sensed it?

There were only two possibilities. The first was that Li Wen did it on purpose, and the second would be that Laurel had gotten much stronger, to the point that Li Wen wasn’t able to sense her presence.

I started to plan my next move. *What was more likely?*

There had to be different solutions for different situations.

I asked, “Li Wen asked you to do this?”

Laurel smirked. “Her? She can’t wait to make use of me, so there’s no way I’d work with her. Soul splitters are all horrid, and you’re working with them all day. Li Shen, what are you thinking? You let the Western District down and you let your friends down.”

I was a little angered at this. “Why be so pretentious? It’s true that I’ve let the Western District down and that I wasn’t able to save you guys. But do you have the right to say these things? Look at what you’re doing now...”

Laurel answered coldly. “I’ve told you this before when we were in the Eastern District. We’ve made our choices and we’ve chosen to go on different paths. You’re on the path to destruction while I’m trying to survive.”

I was silent.

Taking a deep breath, I told myself to stay calm. *From what Laurel had said, she wasn't working for the soul splitters. It was obvious how much she hated them from how she talked about them. Who would she be helping then?*

The Eastern, Western and Southern Districts have been destroyed and only a few heirs survived. Just who was it controlling everything behind the scenes?

It must be somebody who had gone missing but who was still alive.

A name appeared in my mind. *Yes, he had been missing for a while.*

I asked again, "Are you sent by Rong Jin?"

Laurel frowned. "Rong Jin?"

Seems like she wasn't.

Rong Jin had been missing since that battle. With his abilities, it's unlikely that he died in the Southern District. This was why I suspect that he might have been acting behind the scenes.

"Enough with the small talk. Give Piercer to me, or else, you can forget about leaving this place today."

Laurel clapped her hands and everyone stopped to look at me. *So this was how it felt to be under the spotlight... It was terrifying...*

I took Piercer out and said, "This treasure of mine is really stubborn. Do you think you can control it even when I can't? Come and get it then."

A fight seemed to be inevitable. I looked around me as I retreated.

The only way out now was to pass by that huge pool. But the path was littered with people on both sides.

Laurel smiled in a weird manner as she looked at Yuan Qian.

Hesitation could be seen in Yuan Qian as she bit her lip. “Ah Shen, I’ll ask you again. Was Laurel telling the truth? That you let my brother die?”

I looked at her. “Yes.”

Pain and anger surged in her eyes.

I knew Yuan Qian was someone loyal. Though she and her brother were not very sociable people and they did not speak much to others, I knew they have always been loyal to me. I knew they were loyal to Li Qing too.

She must be in a dilemma now that she had to decide between loyalty and revenge.

I helped her make a decision as I raised Piercer.

“No need to hesitate. Since you’ve already made your choice, go ahead, the both of you.”

Nie Zun said, “I don’t want to fight now. Can you let them continue dancing?” He pointed at those dancers who had stepped out from the pool with faces that were full of killing intent.

Laurel answered, “Sure, I’ll let them accompany you.”

With a snap of her fingers, the bikini-clad dancers suddenly laid face-down on the floor. Their limbs turned into spider legs and they started crawling quickly towards Nie Zun and I like a bunch of spider demons.

They looked merciless. I was sure that nothing good was in it for us if we ended up getting caught by one of these things.

“You caused this. Solve it yourself.” I retreated behind Nie Zun as I told him this.

Who told you to get them to dance? Go and play with them now that they have so many legs. There’s no way I’m getting involved in this.

Nie Zun seemed to yawn. I could almost imagine that lazy look on his face.

He waved a hand at the spider-women.

Black fog emanated from his palm and it floated towards them.

Laurel looked grave. “Nie Zun, didn’t you say you don’t remember her. Why are you protecting her even when you’ve lost your memories?”

Nie Zun pulled me out from behind him, smiling at me. “You protect me since I’ve lost my memories.”

That black fog had already knocked five or six of those spider-women down.

The corner of my lips twitched. *What do you need me for when your abilities are more than enough?*

Laurel snapped her fingers again. The spider-women who looked like they had been strangled with that black fog suddenly got up, all energetic. One of them even jumped right at me.

Goosebumps appeared all over me. That thing was disgusting. Raising my right hand, I swung Piercer into the air.

Swoosh.

Violet light appeared as the spider-woman was slashed into two.

A pain shot through my chest at that moment.

Laurel laughed. “Ah Shen *jiejie*, how does Yuan Qian’s pill feel? After you’ve swallowed it, you’ll feel extreme pain in your chest as long as you use MF in the next three days. The pain will double each time you use MF. I wonder how you can leave this place without using MF.”

I could still bear with this pain. Having been in the Split Zone for so long, this was nothing much.

I raised my hand again, pouring MF into Piercer. A dark purple light emanated from it this time. I felt a bone-chilling cold from Piercer. It made me more uneasy than that pain in my chest.

Was Piercer trying to devour me again?

Be good. Don't act up at crucial moments during fights.

I wasn't able to control that dark purple light produced by Piercer. A deathly aura spread around it, and Nie Zun looked at Piercer with a fire in his eyes as he sensed its energy.

Was he attracted to the dark energy?

I seemed to have lost control over my MF as it was continuously being absorbed by Piercer. The pain in my chest caused my brows to knit.

Laurel waved a hand and another bunch of spider-women rushed towards me.

Before I could respond, Piercer produced blades of dark purple light that seemed to have gone in all directions.

These blades of light were much faster than the usual violet blade as it shot everywhere, piercing the spider-women in midair. Like lasers, bright light was produced as it stabbed through their bodies. Screams could be heard everywhere.

MF emanated in the environment, causing ripples in the air.

Laurel's eyes shone. "That is a good weapon. It's no wonder it's called a living weapon."

"Don't even think about taking a good weapon like this. Piercer is mine," I answered. I swung Piercer again with my right hand.

Just when I was about to leap into the air to launch another attack, I heard a woman's voice from Piercer. It was a chilling, twisted voice that induced fear. "Do you wish to die, Li Shen?"

I looked around me. No one else seemed to be surprised at this. Seems like I was the only one who could hear the voice.

I continued directing MF to my palm, as I thought, ‘Who are you? Are you the soul in Piercer?’

The woman’s voice sounded like it was from the dregs of hell. “You know it’s me and you dare be this audacious?”

Chapter 206: 206 Horrifying Pool of Blood

Volume 4

206 Horrifying Pool of Blood

The chill continued spreading from my palms to my heart, making it feel like it was painfully twisted as it burnt in an icy cold. My pupils started to tremble.

Laurel probably thought that I was in pain from Yuan Qian's pill, and she signaled for the spider-women to focus their attacks on me.

Suppressing the pain, I looked at Nie Zun. "No need to help me, just make sure you don't die here."

Nie Zun looked a little excited at this, as if he was enjoying being immersed in this murderous environment. He did not look the least bit anxious.

I heard the dark and cold voice again. "Let me go, release me."

I answered fiercely in my heart, 'Let you go? I wasn't the one who locked you in here. You should work for me since you're a living weapon belonging to me now.'

I raised Piercer and whipped it, producing a ray with a chilly killing intent.

Fear could be seen in the eyes of the spider-women.

A lot of MF was used in this particular attack, and I felt an unease in my chest.

“Ah...” I called out, retreating involuntarily.

“Pch.” I spat out a mouthful of blood. Laurel smirked at this. “Yuan Qian’s pill is good. As expected of the poison lady from the Western District.”

Pressing down on my chest, I looked up, only to be met with Yuan Qian’s complex gaze.

I knew what she was thinking about, because this wasn’t caused by her poison at all.

Nie Zun walked towards me with hands in his pockets. “Why are you so weak?”

I ignored him. There was a burning sensation in my throat and the taste of blood in my mouth.

The voice spoke again. “It’s not too late if you let me go now. Or else, I’ll devour your soul and have you keep this little lady company.”

My eyes widened. I thought angrily, ‘Little lady? Is that Bian Ying?’

Before I heard an answer, Laurel looked enraged as she spoke. “What’s with that expression? Ah Shen *jiejie*, do you hate me so much?”

Why did she say that?

I looked at Laurel in confusion. Immense hate surged in Laurel’s eyes. She pulled Yuan Qian closer to her.

Laurel’s hand turned into a slimy liquid that stuck onto Yuan Qian’s arm. It spread to her neck in just a few seconds. Yuan Qian’s eyes widened as she called out painfully.

“Let her go!” I shouted. With this, another mouthful of blood spurted from my mouth.

Laurel stared at me. “Let her go? Sure, only if you hand over Piercer.”

I couldn't bear to look at Yuan Qian in pain. That voice was also tormenting me, and I decided to throw Piercer at Laurel. "You want it? Try taking it."

A dark purple light appeared in Piercer's wake as it flew through the air.

Laurel let go of Yuan Qian and reached out for Piercer. I leapt up into the air, red dress billowing. Focusing my MF, I trapped Laurel and Piercer into a circular ball of air.

As Laurel grabbed the thong of Piercer, I pulled the handle hard towards myself. The stinger on the end of Piercer embedded itself into Laurel's hand, cutting into the flesh of her palm.

"Ss... Ow..." I pulled Piercer back as Laurel frowned in pain. Piercer was wrapped around her now.

Just as I was about to pull her towards me, that voice appeared again. "You never learn."

Boom.

An explosion occurred in my palm that held Piercer. I fell after being hit in midair.

I kept falling and I couldn't control my MF at all.

There seemed to be something that was being taken from me. Just when I was about to hit the floor, I felt a cold embrace around me.

Though my hair was obstructing my vision, I could still make out those starry eyes of his.

Nie Zun caught me and landed on the ground steadily.

Just as I wanted to speak, I realized my five senses were starting to deteriorate.

The ringing in my ears got louder and louder, and my vision was blurring. My world was being forcefully torn apart by something.

Piercer turned into a black flame that trapped me.

I saw a look of worry in Nie Zun's eyes, but I pushed him away.

That dark purple flame then encased me.

The burning sensation wasn't felt on my skin, it was felt within my soul.

Laurel fell onto the ground opposite me. Her hand which had been in contact with Piercer was now bloodied, looking like a claw that came out from hell.

She stared at me coldly.

None of those monsters dared approach me. Everyone was looking at me with a weird stare.

Nie Zun was staring at me as well.

After about three seconds, he decided to walk towards me again.

I shouted, "Don't come over."

Horrified, I realized that it wasn't my voice.

That dark purple flame continued burning around me, but it didn't feel like I was being burnt. It was a thorough bone-chilling cold that seeped through me.

Something seemed to be swallowing my consciousness. That dark voice rang around me. "Sleep now. Give your body to me. Bow down to me and listen to me." I was losing awareness and everything seemed to quieten.

Everything was white now. Just when I was about to lose everything, I heard a lazy voice. This voice was different from that cold, dark voice from before. This voice sounded like the summer wind, breezing past my ears into my heart.

"Shen'er... Not going to ask for my help even at such a time...?"

A dash of red appeared in front of me. It was a bright red. A glorious red.

She had a brilliant smile on her face as she tried to take me in an embrace. “Shen’er... Don’t exclude me... Accept me... Won’t you accept me...?”

“Ah...!” I screamed with flailing arms.

“Stop her, quick.”

My senses were returning to me. When I woke up, I heard Gaoqin Jiuye’s voice. At the same time, I felt a hand holding mine.

My eyes snapped open. Everything was clear now.

I was in the pool now, but instead of being filled with water, it was filled with blood. All I could feel and smell was blood.

Yuan Qian was taken away from Laurel by an unknown man, and Laurel was currently immobilized by Shen Qi’s human form.

I turned to the side, seeing Nie Zun in the pool of blood. His eyes had a quiet anger to them, but they looked lonely and cold. He pulled me along as he swam towards the edge of the pool.

The ringing in my ears subsided, but something grabbed my leg from under that pool of blood.

I heard a voice say, “You destroyed me. You destroyed me.”

I could no longer stand being haunted by this eerie voice. I shouted, “Who are you? Come out!”

Hearing me scream, Nie Zun pulled me into an embrace. At the same time, he seemed to have done something else which caused the hand pulling at my leg to let go.

Gaoqin Jiuye appeared at the edge of the pool, calling out to Nie Zun, “Get her out.”

Nie Zun's gaze tightened. He carried me out of that pool of blood.

Blood dripped from us as we stepped out.

When Nie Zun leapt into the air, an ugly, giant hand that was devoid of skin caught us. The scarred, grotesque hand shot up from that pool of blood.

The hand was enormous. Nie Zun and I were being squished like thin straws in it. We seem to have been flattened against each other to the point that I felt like my bones were about to merge with his.

"Ah." There was an indescribable fear as I lost all feeling in my limbs. I was nauseated with the disgusting smell coming from that hand. I saw black fire as I met Nie Zun's eyes.

I suddenly became wide awake. "Oh no," I muttered.

Before I could stop him, I heard her voice from above. "Shen'er, let him save you. You don't need me with him around..."

I turned around, trying to find her. My neck started cracking as I turned, and it actually rotated 180 degrees.

Crack.

I turned back, seeing black fog surround Nie Zun and slowly wrap around us. The hand let go of us as it came into contact with the black fog.

Nie Zun was still hugging me tightly as we landed on the ground.

I regained feeling in my limbs as we touched the ground. That hand from the pool of blood turned into a terrifying woman drenched in blood. Her skin was broken everywhere and blood was continuously dripping from all over her.

Chapter 207: 207 A Leech Infestation

Volume 4

207 A Leech Infestation

“Who are you?” I asked as I stared at that terrifying woman.

Laurel rushed over with excitement as she looked at that woman. “You’re the soul in Piercer!”

Her flesh was broken and blood covered her entire face. There was no way to make out her expression and what she looked like. Her eyeballs were mystifyingly dark. “You want to take me away?”

Laurel nodded. “Come with me. I might be able to help you regain your freedom.”

The terrifying woman laughed out loud. “I’ve been hating the world ever since that adulterous pair trapped me in this whip. I’ve thought of so many ways, but in the end, I realized that all I could do was to devour those who wanted my soul. There’s no way I can escape from this whip, and now a mere girl is telling me that you can help me regain my freedom? Hahaha, do you wish to die...”

Laurel laughed. “How do you know that a mere girl wouldn’t be able to help you regain your freedom? Do you have any idea who it was that asked me to come look for you?”

The terrifying woman smirked. “Who is the one with such guts?”

Laurel giggled. “You’ll definitely be familiar with this name... Zou An...”

I shivered. *Zou An...*

How could it be? Why is Laurel and Zou An working together? Is Zou An still alive?

But that made sense. There’s no way Zou An would go down that easily. Does this mean he’s in the Northern District too?

There wasn’t much time for me to think about things. The soul in Piercer was instantly enraged the moment she heard Zou An’s name.

Seems like the soul in this living weapon had a great hatred for the creator...

Gaoqin Jiuye interrupted, “Little lady, where’s Zou An now?” *Right, I almost forgot. Why did Gaoqin Jiuye suddenly appear?*

I looked at him with suspicion, but he paid me no heed.

Piercer’s soul called out to Gaoqin Jiuye before Laurel could answer. “Gaoqin Jiuye. Do you still remember me?”

Gaoqin Jiuye acted as if he had forgotten. “I don’t quite remember.”

I felt a headache coming on. *Gaoqin Jiuye was the one who saved Zou An and his wife that time when Piercer devoured Bian Ying’s soul. Piercer’s soul might hate him too.*

Just what is happening here...

My weapon turned into a terrifying female ghost who was about to engage Gaoqin Jiuye in a battle to the death, and Laurel still had her eyes on Piercer...

There was no peace to be had anywhere...

Piercer's soul raised her arms, producing fiery red flames. "Then I'll help you remember."

What. Fighting Gaoqin Jiuye already?

I stepped forward, calling out to her. "Hey, Piercer! I don't care who you have a past with and why you hate them. Don't forget that you're a living weapon belonging to me, Li Shen, now."

I reached out towards her in a catching motion with my right hand.

I learnt more about how to manipulate MF after that meditation session. I've been using Piercer for quite some time now. A weapon will forever be a weapon, and its master will forever be the master. There's no way I'd let her go insane here.

Those flames were extinguished by my MF. Her face got even more twisted. "Li Shen, I'm already being very nice by helping you until now. You think you're really able to control me? You're lucky that I haven't cursed you to die, and you dare talk to me like this?"

I pulled my right hand back. Blood in the pool sprayed everywhere with the force of MF.

I smirked at her. "A weapon will remain a weapon. Since you're with me, you're mine now. Nobody would be able to take you away from me. I won't let anyone hurt you, but you'll have to listen to me."

I stole a glance at Laurel, catching a slight smile at the corner of her lips. I'm telling her indirectly that she can forget about taking Piercer away.

I wasn't able to control Piercer's soul for long with just my MF. Jie Pa had told me before, that to successfully conquer the soul in a living weapon, you had to get them to recognize you as worthy.

Gaoqin Jiuye raised a brow as he saw me control Piercer's soul. Slowly, he drew Shen Qi from his waist.

This was bad. He was about to release Shen Qi.

Though it was not much of a problem for living weapons to go against each other, I was afraid that Shen Qi might hurt Piercer.

Laurel knew how powerful Shen Qi was, and she did something with her hands.

The pool seemed to transform suddenly.

A milky liquid seemed to bubble from the bottom of the pools, and a gigantic female emerged from each of the pools. The bodies were female but they had no facial features, and their bodies were covered in pustules.

“What are these disgusting things?” I frowned, feeling nauseated as I looked at them.

I turned to Nie Zun, only to be met with a sleepy face. He looked like he was sunbathing at the beach instead of being in the middle of a bloody fight.

I was rather angered by his lazy expression. He could make any scenario look unnatural by being in it.

Gaoqin Jiuye made ripples in the air while Shen Qi turned into its human form beside him.

Looking at him, I realized that I might have forgotten how powerful he was.

Piercer’s soul escaped as I lost my concentration for just a moment.

Her eyes opened wide and two fiery red flames rose up as she stretched her bloody arms.

Laurel wasn’t relaxing either. With a clap, the pustules which were on those faceless female bodies started bursting one after another. Blood started pouring from those bodies, coupled with a horrible smell.

Something horrific happened at this very moment. Countless leeches were crawling out of the burst pustules. These were at least three to four times larger than the ones we’ve seen before, and they were just like gigantic,

hungry crabs. Those two black pincers snapped away as they produced a creepy sound. They were crawling towards us now.

I shivered as I looked at the gigantic leeches. I still remembered how Song Lu was tortured inside the wooden barrel in that stone room.

Those disgusting pincers cut open Song Lu's pale flesh before the leeches entered through her skin and ate at her, bringing her unimaginable pain.

That scene will forever be embedded in my mind. I could no longer suppress the anger and hate in me when I saw those leeches crawling out. Those gigantic bodies looked like they were a breeding ground for the leeches.

Shutting my eyes, I thought, 'Scorpion Ray, if you're really a living weapon of mine, then help me get rid of these monsters.'

When I opened my eyes, I saw Scorpion Ray on my left wrist produce a dazzling light.

I drew a semi-circle in the air with my left arm, and Scorpion Ray produced a smooth line of white light.

I poured my MF into Scorpion Ray, trying to get a better feel of it. I realized that the biggest difference between a normal weapon and a living weapon was that a living weapon could communicate with its master. From that, a powerful attack could then be launched.

The leeches were at my feet now. Nie Zun was floating in the air. Even with amnesia, he still liked to levitate.

Gaoqin Jiuye surrounded himself with air currents, and it was difficult for the leeches to approach him like this.

Catching Laurel's gaze, I realized that these leeches had Nie Zun and I as the targets. It was to prevent me from controlling Piercer. Since I was still its owner, Piercer's power and my MF were linked. If I went forward to help Gaoqin Jiuye in the fight, it was unlikely Piercer would win.

Apart from these leeches, everyone else here seemed to be working for Laurel as well. They were encroaching on Nie Zun and I right at this moment.

Yuan Qian had disappeared.

No time to wonder about that now. I poured MF into Scorpion Ray again.

It's no wonder others said Scorpion Ray was an incomplete living weapon. It definitely felt like something was missing. Although Piercer was complete, it did not listen to me.

That's right, this was the feeling.

I felt a warmth on my left wrist. Raising my left hand, I drew a circular bow in the air as I pulled back with my right hand.

I let go of the ray of light that was drawn by my right hand.

Countless needles of light shot out at those leeches. These needles of light left bright trails in their wake.

I couldn't help but admire the beautiful scene. As expected of Scorpion Ray, a present from Li Qing.

Those needles of light exploded after piercing through the leeches, looking like spectacular fireworks in the night sky, except that they could kill.

Boom.

The leeches exploded everywhere.

I was overjoyed at seeing Scorpion Ray's power, but I could feel my MF running out fast from controlling the circular bow. I had to be extremely careful now because I couldn't afford to make any mistake.

Feeling the MF coursing through my wrist and my palm, I raised Scorpion Ray again.

“Scorpion Ray, kill them”

Laurel looked at me with dark eyes.

She clasped her hands and those gigantic female bodies instantly doubled in size.

Pustules continued appearing on their bodies, like thousands of tiny mice scurrying under their skin. The pustules then burst, producing even more of those leeches.

Chapter 208: 208 Nie Zun, the Stranger

Volume 4

208 Nie Zun, the Stranger

I couldn't win against so many leeches at once.

Every single one of them had to be destroyed since I might lose the ability to regenerate if I ended up being bitten just once. Though Scorpion Ray was suitable for long-range battle, it drained MF too quickly. I was using way too much strength to maintain that circular bow.

Tilting my head to look at Nie Zun, who looked like he was about to fall asleep anytime, I said, "Hey, help me kill some of these. We're on the same side now. I might just die if you continue lazing around like this."

Nie Zun smiled at me, his wispy bangs falling across his forehead. "It's obvious that they're your enemies. Why should I help you when they have nothing to do with me?"

This guy...

My lips twitched in irritation. "She's also your enemy, thank you very much."

Nie Zun asked in mock earnesty, "Oh, is that so? How could that be?"

He descended to the ground looking like he did not have a care in the world with both hands in his pockets and a slightly hunched back.

He looked at Laurel. “Little lady, do we have something against each other?”

Laurel smirked. “Of course not. There’s no need for Nie Zun *gege* to protect *jiejie* since you don’t remember her anymore.”

For some reason, I was a little angered at what she said. Drawing an arrow of light with my right hand, I shot at the row of leeches in front of me.

Laurel giggled at me. “I think Ah Shen *jiejie* still cares about Nie Zun *gege*. Are you angry now?”

Why is this child so annoying now when we used to be on such good terms?

Nie Zun scratched the tip of his nose and the corner of his lips turned up at an angle. “Then I’m really sorry. According to you, we might not have anything against each other. But I’m not feeling too good right now, and these things are irritating. So, we might have something against each other in future.”

Before I could react, Nie Zun lifted a hand and pointed at the leeches.

A black ray shot out from his finger as his eyes shone with a chilly light!

“Krru. Krru.”

The leeches were producing a funny ‘krru’ sound before all of them flipped over.

Laurel frowned. “This is demonic energy. You’ve turned into a demon.”

Nie Zun scratched his head. “I think there was the word ‘demon’ from where I came from...”

I recalled the character for ‘demon’ which was on that stone tablet he was in earlier. *Who was behind all this?*

There was action going on at Gaoqin Jiuye’s side as well. Though he was facing the enemy solo, the scene was rather horrific.

He was leaping around the pool of blood that Piercer was in. Following closely behind him was Shen Qi.

A black light emanated from Shen Qi as he left a trail of destruction in his wake.

The fiery red flames produced by Piercer's soul had already set the area in front of the pool on fire. The flames were fierce and they seemed to be licking at Gaoqin Jiuye's ankles.

White fog surged continuously in Gaoqin Jiuye's eyes. I could see the blood vessels in the corners of his eyes as he concentrated on controlling the air currents around him to parry the fierce flames.

This was the first time I've seen Gaoqin Jiuye focus so much on controlling air currents. I guess Piercer's soul was no easy opponent.

I was suddenly envious of how well Gaoqin Jiuye and Shen Qi could work together, and I silently promised myself that I will conquer Piercer.

Engaging in a long-drawn battle was not a good idea. Daylight was in about a couple of hours, and if Du Yue and Li Wen weren't able to find Gaoqin Jiuye and I, the situation might become even more complicated.

I focused my MF on Scorpion Ray as I created a larger, rotational circular bow to launch attacks at the leeches. The leeches kept on increasing in number and they never seemed to decrease. I was beginning to tire.

A leech suddenly flew onto my leg from behind.

My heart sank as I felt a cold and prickly feeling on the back of my calf. I felt a prickly pain as I turned to look.

Clack.

My flesh had been cut with those giant leech pincers.

I waved my right hand at it! Using MF, I broke the leech broke into pieces.

I thought to myself, ‘Oh no, I’m going to lose my ability to regenerate.’

Laurel laughed. “Aiyaya. You were bitten, Ah Shen *jiejie*. What to do? Your constitution will turn to one that belongs to a normal human being.”

Just as my mind was flustered over this, I realized that my calf had healed miraculously. My constitution didn’t turn into that of a normal human being even after being bitten by the leech.

“No, no. no. That can’t be... Why is your leg...” Laurel stared at my healed calf.

I didn’t know why it happened either.

After a moment, Laurel said, “It’s no wonder everyone wants you. They’re all here for you. Ah Shen *jiejie* is really different from the rest.”

Different from the rest. Why such a description again?

I’ve had enough of being a weirdo.

It was too tiring.

Gritting my teeth, I replied angrily, “It doesn’t matter whether I’m different or not. What matters is that you can forget about taking anything or anyone away from me, all of you. I, Li Shen, will stop losing things from now on.”

Placing my palms against each other, I focused my MF.

“Scorpion Ray.”

With the force from my MF, the blood sprayed everywhere from the pool opposite me.

Those gigantic female bodies shattered as Scorpion Ray produced a blinding light.

Laurel turned back in shock, before looking back at me. “Seems like I really shouldn’t go easy on you.”

I smirked. “Don’t go easy on me.”

A loud crash was heard at Gaoqin Jiuye’s side. Looking over, I could only see Shen Qi running around Piercer in circles. White fog continued surging in Gaoqin Jiuye’s eyes as he combined the air currents with Shen Qi’s movements. Piercer was trapped within.

The skin on Piercer’s soul continued to peel. I couldn’t make out what she looked like, and it looked horrifying.

Apart from that continually shedding skin and the burning flames, Piercer didn’t seem to be doing anything else. However, Gaoqin Jiuye looked serious, as if he was putting in a lot of effort in the fight.

Just as I was about to launch an attack on Laurel, the lazy Nie Zun seemed to have spotted some opportunity. Like a black flash of lightning, he appeared in the middle of Gaoqin Jiuye’s air current, landing right in front of Piercer.

“Hey, what are you doing?” I shouted, wondering what Nie Zun was planning.

He ignored me. All I could see was a black figure.

He then raised a pale and slender hand to create a dark storm.

I have always liked those eyes and hands, probably because it was so rarely seen.

He could always be seen wearing those black gloves in the past, and it felt like a black screen which separated us. It was difficult for me to even catch a glimpse of those hands.

As time passed, I was the only one left beside him. I guess that’s why I was lucky enough to have seen them more than once.

Things turn really precious when they are rare. In my eyes, these hands did not belong to a devil.

They were an extremely precious pair of hands, even if they were feared by everyone when he was alive.

Even when these hands were emanating the aura of death as they strangled someone's neck the few times I had seen them.

It was all for me.

If he had really turned into a demon, it would all be because of me.

But now?

Gaoqin Jiuye looked on dumbfounded as these hands were able to contain Piercer in just a few moves.

Laurel, Gaoqin Jiuye and I were not able to do anything but watch as Nie Zun literally stepped on Piercer's soul.

Nie Zun had that indifferent expression on him throughout, even when Piercer's soul continued letting out blood-curdling screams.

The fiery red flame in the middle of Nie Zun's forehead was burning brightly when Piercer's soul fell at his feet. Black and red flames surrounded him. His bloodthirsty eyes looked mystifying. Black fog obscured his hands, making them a gray color.

Gaoqin Jiuye could tell when it was dangerous. He called Shen Qi back to him when Nie Zun attacked.

He then came over to me.

Looking at me with a fiery warmth, he said, "You actually came out with Nie Zun without letting me know?"

I didn't understand this. *Why did I have to inform you?*

Seeing me silent, Gaoqin Jiuye seemed to get angry. "Li Shen, you're really stupid. Have you forgotten how Nie Zun was like in that demon cave? He's

not the Nie Zun of the past anymore, and you dare trust him like this? Don't you know anything about safety?"

I looked at Nie Zun, who was still torturing Piercer with that demonic energy.

Yes, he's no longer the Nie Zun of the past. How could I have forgotten that?

Scenes of how we accompanied each other every day flooded through my brain when I saw that face of his in my room.

It wasn't easy to tell the difference...

Wasn't it still him...?

Chapter 209: 209 Between A Rock and A Hard Place

Volume 4

209 Between A Rock and A Hard Place

Nie Zun was stepping on the body of Piercer's soul. The black fog surrounding his feet made it scream in pain. He laughed cruelly as he said, "Turn back into what you originally were. You should be acting like a weapon. You're mine in future."

I could no longer watch in silence.

"Nie Zun, what are you doing? Let her go." I looked at him coldly.

Nie Zun tilted his head with a crooked smile. The wispy bangs which fell across his eyes could not obscure the fiery emblem between his brows. "I want to have this. What, you're not willing to give it to me? I thought you liked this body. Now you're not even willing to give me a weapon?" He pointed a pale, slender finger at himself as he spoke.

I bit my lip, refusing to believe that he could have changed so much.

I knew he had lost his memories after exiting that demon cave, and I knew there was no way that someone who had lost their memories would treat me like they previously did and accept all my shortcomings immediately. Even though I knew this, when he reappeared before me, I stubbornly chose to believe that he would never hurt me even when his memories were gone.

Didn't he protect me just moments before?

But, but...

Seeing me silent, Gaoqin Jiuye nudged me and said, “Wake up. No matter how you feel about him, leave it until he regains his memories. He’s not his old self.”

He’s not his old self.

I bit my lip. “Why are you doing this? Because you want that weapon for yourself?”

Nie Zun seemed to smile. “Yes.” He used more force on his feet as he said this.

“Ah!”

Piercer’s soul let out a bloodcurdling scream. With a blinding light, she turned back into a whip.

“You.” I was rendered speechless at how he treated my Piercer.

With a hand in his pocket, he bent down to pick Piercer up with the other. He looked at the purple whip intently before finally smiling at me. “A very good weapon. I’m taking it.”

I bit my lip again. While I was considering if I should attack, Laurel giggled. “Why is Nie Zun *gege* snatching something that I want?”

Nie Zun’s shining eyes landed on Laurel. Lifting Piercer, he said, “Little lady, you’ll have to fight for what you want. Now that it’s mine, you’ll have to get it from me if you want it for yourself.”

Laurel pondered for a moment. “I don’t think I can snatch it from Nie Zun *gege*. If Nie Zun *gege* likes it, you can have it.”

These people...

That item belongs to me.

I told myself to stay calm. If Laurel said Nie Zun can take it, it means she doesn't have the confidence to take Piercer away from him. Demonic energy emanated from Nie Zun when he attacked earlier, and that was a power that I had never witnessed in the Split Zone. If Gaoqin Jiuye and I were both a little wary of this, Laurel would be too. She's probably thinking of backing away for a bit before planning her next move.

If that's the case...

I straightened up and smiled at Nie Zun. "Like what you said, I did like you before. If you like this weapon, I'll give it to you. But can you tell me what you're planning to do with it?"

Gaoqin Jiuye stared at me as he did not expect me to say this, much less admit my feelings for Nie Zun.

I tried to signal to him that it was more important to stabilize Nie Zun's emotions at this moment. He had extraordinary power, and he had lost his memories. Whoever gains his trust will be able to harness that great power he possessed. Even if I can't get him to remember who I was, I could prevent others from making use of him to go against me. There was no way I could win whether it was against his abilities or simply against him.

Nie Zun's eyes sparked with interest, as if curious about my sudden change in attitude. He answered simply, "The Huai Du you mentioned asked me to do something. Why? Are you interested to come with me?"

"What is it?" I raised my brows.

Nie Zun fiddled with Piercer in his hand. "He said there were a few ants who trespassed into his territory, and he wants me to locate them. First, I'll have to look for someone called Chou Yu. I don't know who that is, but since I've got nothing to do anyway, I'll just try looking for this person."

My heart sank. *Chou Yu...*

Seems like Chou Yu had survived with Jie Pa and the rest. But I got Chou Yu to stay by Jie Pa's side at all times, so did he get separated from Jie Pa

when they arrived in the Northern District?

Even so, why would Huai Du be getting Nie Zun to look for Chou Yu?

Was it because Chou Yu was one of the few heirs who had survived? And among these, he was one of those in the Gate of Ghost?

But why would Huai Du know that Chou Yu was in the Gate of Ghost? If he knew Chou Yu was there, why didn't he have the ability to look for Chou Yu then? Nothing made sense.

I asked carefully. "How do you go about looking for this person if all you have is a name?"

Nie Zun smiled. "This Chou Yu will come looking for that lady you guys were addressing as Yuan Qian."

A sudden realization hit me.

This is why Nie Zun appeared here. He learnt about Yuan Qian's whereabouts from Huai Du!

I was reminded of that unknown figure who took Yuan Qian away earlier. It must have been Chou Yu.

It was not surprising that Yuan Qian and Chou Yu knew each other, since I was the one who asked Chou Yu and the Yuan siblings to protect Jie Pa at all times. Since they've worked together for quite some time, I'm sure they had some friendship there.

So this is why Huai Du wanted Nie Zun to track Yuan Qian, because he knew that Chou Yu would appear wherever Yuan Qian was.

Even after I've thought about all this, I still didn't understand why Huai Du wanted to look for Chou Yu.

There's still something that was not quite right.

I frowned at Nie Zun. “If you were here for Yuan Qian, then I’m sure you must have noticed when somebody took her away. Why didn’t you chase after them?”

Nie Zun continued fiddling with Piercer. “Because I suddenly felt that this was a good item, and I wanted to take it for myself. They won’t go far anyway, and it’ll be easy to catch up with them.”

Nie Zun the amnesiac was uncontrollable to the point that it could get dangerous. Huai Du did not have complete control over him, and they seemed to just be in a working relationship. I didn’t know why Nie Zun was helping Huai Du, but it was obvious that Nie Zun still had a mind of his own. This was why he gave up on chasing after Yuan Qian temporarily when Piercer caught his eye.

This also proved how confident he was in his abilities. He believed that he could track Yuan Qian down no matter how far she went.

My palms were sweating now.

Everything seemed so complicated, but the goal was clear. Though there were three parties fighting for something, all of them had hurt others in their quest to obtain new power, and this included destroying heirs.

The scariest part about this is that they weren’t willing to let go of the few heirs left in the Split Zone. They were forcefully entrapping us in their fight, turning us into tools and weapons.

How can I just sit and watch like this?

Laurel laughed out loud. “I see. So everyone has an agenda here. That makes it all the more interesting. What should we do next, huh? Ah Shen jiejie?” Her eyes shone with excitement.

Did she want to plunge the world into chaos?

We should be staying calm at this point, but how do I continue being calm like this?

I couldn't trust Gaoqin Jiuye fully either. Nie Zun was the only one I could rely on previously, but he's being controlled by somebody else now.

I was really stuck in this Split Zone now.

My hands balled into fists. There's no way I'd continue being treated like a fool now.

"You can go chase after them now that you have Piercer with you," I told Nie Zun.

He seemed to take an interest in what I've said as he asked calmly, "That girl named Yuan Qian seemed to have poisoned you. Are you planning to look for her with me now?"

Laurel interrupted with resentment in her eyes. "Hmph, forget about being poisoned. I think she actually helped you. You wouldn't have been able to escape so many leeches if it really was poison. Also, you should've lost your healing abilities when you were cut by the leech, but your leg healed so quickly. I thought it weird at the time but I get it now. Yuan Qian might have said she hated you, but she still helped you out in the end."

She's saying that I didn't lose my healing abilities because of Yuan Qian's pill?

I looked at Nie Zun again. "What do you plan to do when you find them? Where will you take them?"

Nie Zun shrugged. "To the demon cave. That place where you came out from."

There must be something going on here. What should I do? I looked at Gaoqin Jiuye, trying to get his thoughts on whether I should leave with Nie Zun.

Gaoqin Jiuye understood me right away, but he said, "In just a bit, Du Yue and Li Wen will realize that neither of us are in our rooms. Li Shen, you

seem to keep forgetting that I exist, about my goals and about how I feel too. You probably might not have ever considered any of these, right?”

He came closer. “I want Si Luo to wake up, I can’t wait anymore. I don’t want him to continue sleeping in my air vortex. I want to go with Du Yue to look for Yu Liang. Your friend Yu Liang might have already woken up after undoing the split freeze. I can’t be wasting more time here. What are you going to do, Li Shen?”

Chapter 210: 210 As Long As You Are Forever By My Side

Volume 4

210 As Long As You Are Forever By My Side

“There’s also Jiao S. We don’t know how she’s being tortured in Du Yue’s Palace of Cold Blood right now. You sure you want to continue wasting your time here? Or is helping him regain his memories your top priority now?” Gaoqin Jiuye looked at me with a slightly judgmental gaze.

Nie Zun walked over with one hand in his pocket as he held Piercer in the other. His steps were light, but they resounded heavily in my heart.

He spoke in my ear as he reached me, “Are you coming with me?”

He then started making his way to the exit.

My heart twisted in a knot.

*Would Yuan Qian and Chou Yu be in danger if I don’t leave with him?
Piercer has also been taken by him.*

*What would Du Yue do if I choose to leave with him? Would she take it out
on Jiao S?*

Gaoqin Jiuye’s voice trembled slightly, like a soft petal in the breeze.
“You’re actually hesitating? I’ve never seen you hesitate in saving your friends, but you’re actually hesitating now? Is this because of Nie Zun?”

I looked at him stubbornly. “Yuan Qian and Chou Yu are my friends too.”

I felt Gaoqin Jiuye's breath on my face. "No, Jiao S is the one who's most important to you, but you're still choosing to leave with him. You want to help him regain his memories, you want him to remember you because you can't stand the fact that he has forgotten you.

"Admit it, Li Shen. Even if everything changes if you choose to leave with him, the path ahead will be fraught with danger. And you're still choosing to leave me because of him."

Leave you because of him?

A bitter smile escaped me. *Where did that come from?*

Gaoqin Jiuye, you have never been by my side...

I stared at him. "How about you? Aren't you this anxious because of Si Luo? Yes, I want him to regain his memories. I don't want him to be used by others when he doesn't remember a thing now. I cannot imagine what might happen to him if I'm not by his side."

I realized only after I said this that I couldn't leave without him.

Even if I hadn't met him here in this hotel, there's no way I would leave the Gate of Ghost without him.

I spent almost every single day with him ever since I've arrived in the Split Zone. It was hell for me during the time he was taken by Ta Lai. He's back now, but there's someone who took away his memories, and people who're trying to take him away.

I won't let that happen.

With a deep breath, I smacked Gaoqin Jiuye's hand away. "Sorry, you can leave with Du Yue and the rest first. Pass a message to Du Yue for me. If she wants me to come with her, wait for me to find Nie Zun first. I'll go to the Gate of Heaven to visit her personally after that. I have to leave with him now."

I turned to leave after this.

“Li Shen!” It was the first time Gaoqin Jiuye called my name so loudly, but I didn’t turn back.

Laurel had already snuck out before Nie Zun left. She might have decided to retreat for now since she wasn’t able to obtain Piercer.

I didn’t stop her from leaving. I didn’t have the time nor the energy to.

I chose to leave with Nie Zun, leaving Gaoqin Jiuye alone in that bloody place.

Nie Zun and I arrived at the ground floor of the hotel. It was still dark when we left.

“It’s going to be daylight soon. Where do you plan to go?” I asked Nie Zun. A smile hung on his face as he looked at the darkness in front.

As I was wondering what he might say, he suddenly answered, “Let’s go have some fun.”

What... Before I could process this, he grabbed my hand and rushed forward.

The sky turned bright while we ran.

Here in the Split Zone, it took only a moment for night to become day. As I looked up at the sun and the sky, I still had that feeling that I was back in the real world.

Nie Zun grabbed my hand as he continued running across this space where different eras seemed to have merged with one another.

The wind blew across his hair and it ruffled my red dress. I became a little starry-eyed as I looked at that chiseled profile of his.

Visibility was greatly increased during the day, and I took a good look at the Gate of Ghost.

The townsfolk looked just like ordinary people, and the houses and buildings look like what could be seen in the real world. Though the faces of the people here lacked emotion, there was a sort of thirst for power in their eyes.

Many of them were fighting each other, and there were even some who were engaging in self-harm.

The darkness that accumulated in my heart started to dissipate as I was running alongside Nie Zun. Even when I'm witnessing the cruelty and violence here, for some reason, I felt quite at ease.

Probably because I haven't ran like this in such a long time. The wind might also have helped clear the darkness in my heart.

Nie Zun was smiling like a child as he ran. "The outside world is indeed interesting. I've been in that demon cave for a thousand years. It's really boring."

What he said brought me back to reality.

"Why do you feel that you've been there for a thousand years? You don't believe me that we knew each other from before? You've only been in there for three days."

I heard Nie Zun's voice in the wind. "You're right, I don't believe you. I don't know how long I've been in there either, but that feeling of everlasting solitude has stayed in my mind. That feeling when you woke me after I felt like I've been sleeping for a thousand years is also fresh in my head. So I won't believe you if you tell me that I've only been there for three days."

"Then why do you believe Huai Du? Why are you willing to help him?"

"Because he can let me see someone."

"Who is it?"

"My older sister."

My eyes widened. “Your sister? Nie Xuan?” *How could that be? His sister isn’t dead. Wasn’t she saved? Why would he be able to see his sister here in the Split Zone?*

No, the question I should be asking now is whether he even remembered her.

“You remember your older sister?”

He nodded. “Yes. She’s the only thing I remember, but I don’t remember the things that happened between us. I just know that there was somebody who was extremely important. I was looking for my memories with her, and Huai Du agreed that if I completed three tasks for him, he would return me the memories I had with her.”

So he didn’t have the memories with his older sister either. He simply remembered the emotions and the feelings, and the tie he had with his sister.

“Though I don’t remember her, I know she was extremely important to me. I also felt that I had stayed too long in that demon cave, to the point that there was a hopeless solitude that surrounded me.”

Isn’t that just the lonely feeling of being trapped alone inside that cave... Or, is that the feeling of solitude that you were never able to talk about...?

All this happened because of those hands of yours... Should I really force you to remember the things that you’ve finally forgotten?

What saddened me most was that I wasn’t present in his lost memories...

I felt a bitterness in my heart. *Why wasn’t I present...?*

Haha, Li Shen, why do you have to be present?

“What’re you thinking about?” Nie Zun nudged me, interrupting my thoughts.

I smiled at him. “Nothing much. I’m just a little sad that you weren’t able to remember me.”

An evil aura appeared in Nie Zun's eyes. "I wouldn't believe you even if you say this."

As I was about to argue, I spotted three familiar figures in front of us. "Wait."

Although he didn't know the reason, Nie Zun still stopped in his tracks.

I looked at the group in front. I was right. Even though individuals in the Gate of Ghost seemed to have passed through time, most of them were still dressed in modern garb. The three figures were dressed in white with bamboo hats, and they were rather prominent even among the crowd.

Weren't the three of them Jiao S's personal guards?

Right, they wouldn't go down that easily with those abilities. They were escorting Yu Liang back to the Western District. Did they end up here after getting separated?

It was normal to get separated, but why were the three of them so coincidentally still together?

I was suspicious of their identities from the get-go. I found their voices familiar, and they had some extraordinary abilities as well.

I nudged Nie Zun as I saw them moving somewhere. "It's fun to stalk others. Want to have some fun?"

The corner of Nie Zun's lips turned up. "Sure."

I got it now. Who said Huai Du could control Nie Zun? Whatever is fun would attract this amnesiac's attention now.

Hand in hand, Nie Zun and I began to trail Feng, Huo and Lei through the crowd.

Nie Zun did not avoid me when I took his hand in mine.

I learnt something new from this bout of amnesia.

I could make use of this opportunity to hold his hand more often. Even if Gaoqin Jiuye was right, that he was a danger to me now, even if he had turned into a demon, I still wanted him to stay by my side.

I still want you to stay, by my side. I stole a glance at Nie Zun. I loved those eyes that shone like the stars.

I've changed since losing you the last time. My heart had changed. It's now tied to you.

I had thought of this several times. About how I could survive the time here if I could never leave the Split Zone, if I was never able to return to the real world. If everything went back to being peaceful and quiet, how would I be able to survive such a long and lonely time?

The answer was you.

As long as you're by my side, I'm willing to stay here in Split Zone 13 forever.

Chapter 211: 211 The Li Qing in My Memories

Volume 4

211 The Li Qing in My Memories

The bamboo hat trio entered a basement carpark after crossing the street. Nie Zun and I followed closely behind.

“There was such a place in the Split Zone that looked so similar to the real world... I really didn’t know this before...” I was amazed at the basement carpark. It was exactly like those in the real world, except that the cars here were from different times. There were brands like Honda, Audi and Rolls-Royce, but there were also rickshaws parked here, and there were even horse-drawn carriages. *What kind of place was the Split Zone?*

And why did I feel that this was less of a coincidence, but more of a planned event?

I was beginning to think that I might really be able to leave this place someday. Everything will probably be revealed when that day comes.

Nie Zun and I focused our MF on our feet as we followed the bamboo hat trio. We tried our best not to produce any sound as we kept a one-centimeter gap between our feet and the ground.

The bamboo hat trio opened a door in the wall after passing the last vehicle in the carpark.

It was an ordinary door which looked like it led to an office from the carpark.

Sensing one of them looking back at us as the door opened, I pulled Nie Zun to hide behind a vehicle.

“Why are you following them?” Nie Zun asked with curiosity.

I glanced at him. “Why do you have so many questions? You don’t seem to be anxious about completing Huai Du’s task anyway, so how about doing something fun with me?”

Nie Zun looked at me lazily. “Sure thing, but if your goal is to snatch Piercer somewhere along our journey, I’ll advice you to drop the idea. I’m not returning something I like to you,” he said as he pointed at Piercer hanging at his waist.

He hung Piercer at the waist just like how I used to.

I almost laughed at this look of his.

What I didn’t say was that it wasn’t because of this that I’m with you. I’m with you because I was always with you before, no matter what I did. I’m together with you because it feels right to me. It’s just that you’ve forgotten this temporarily.

I hit myself on the face gently, telling myself, ‘Li Shen, don’t be sad now. You’ll find a way to get him to remember you.’

Gaoqin Jiuye was right. My real motive was to get Nie Zun to regain his memories, and I was not in the mood to do anything else until he remembered me.

“Don’t worry, I have no interest in snatching it away from you since I’ve already given it to you. She doesn’t listen to me anyway. I should tell you though, that this thing is cursed. You knew it before, but you’ve forgotten it now. Legend has it that Piercer will bring harm to whoever uses it,” I said as I pointed at the weapon hanging at his waist.

I didn’t believe the curse. Zou An came up with this because he knew how it was created. He knew that he owed the soul in this living weapon, and he

knew that soul carried a deep hatred within it.

I was curious at how Nie Zun would react upon hearing this.

He smirked. “Curse? Then it’s perfect for me.”

As expected.

“Let’s go through that door. We’ll lose them if we don’t.”

As we reached it, Nie Zun asked, “Just open it?”

I realized that we didn’t actually need to creep up on them, so I decided to open the door right there and then.

I was stunned at what I saw.

I saw someone whom I thought I never would be able to see again, or rather, thought impossible that I would see here again.

Nie Zun waved a hand in front of me.

I smacked his hand away as I took a better look at the people behind the door.

The room was medium-sized, and it was empty except for four individuals who were standing. They were all facing the door. It was an obvious invitation for me to walk into a trap.

There were no windows here and it would be dark once we enter.

One of them from the bamboo hat trio spoke. “Come in and close the door.”

I stared at the fourth individual in the room as I said to Nie Zun, “Let’s go in. Close the door.”

Nie Zun actually listened to me this time, probably because I looked serious. He closed the door behind him as we entered.

Visibility decreased to ten square meters as soon as the door closed, but almost instantaneously, a light was lit.

It was an ordinary light, but it lit up the entire room.

I could take a clearer look at her now. It really was her.

Nie Zun was beside me, hands in his pockets, looking bored as he observed the four individuals.

I was simply staring at whatever was opposite me.

Apart from the bamboo hat trio, who were all disguised, there was another woman here. She was standing right in the middle, flashing a brilliant smile at me.

I wasn't able to return that smile of hers.

"I really hoped my eyes fooled me." I looked at her, feeling like I've just been drenched in cold water.

The one who was smiling brilliantly at me was none other than Li Qing.

I thought she died, or went missing.

Li Qing still had that head of indigo hair, but she was no longer in that silver armor. She was currently dressed in a hot pink tracksuit. She never dressed like this in my memories.

The Li Qing I knew did not return.

"Ah Shen, it really is me." Li Qing stepped towards me.

I retreated immediately, smiling. "Mm, it's you."

Her expression did not change. "Ah Shen, you might have misunderstood me. I'm here to explain everything to you."

I shook my head, raising a hand to stop her. “No need for that, Li Qing. I don’t want to hear it.”

I smiled gently at her. “You’re already dead in my memories.”

One from the bamboo hat trio took off his hat suddenly as he spoke. “Miss Li Shen, you might have forgotten. It’s not that Lord Li Qing died, it’s that you’ve forgotten her.”

A charming face was revealed under his hat. The character for ‘Huo’ was engraved on his forehead. I recognized him straight away. He didn’t have that character on his forehead previously.

The two others took off their hats as well. One of them had ‘Feng’ on his forehead, while the other had ‘Lei’. All of them had the exact same face.

I suddenly felt like the dumbest person in the world. *Yes, Li Shen, how could you have forgotten?*

How could you have forgotten this? After Li Qing’s disappearance, apart from Li Wen, her three subordinates, those triplets, had disappeared as well.

Why weren’t you able to tell who they were when they’ve appeared several times before you in the name of protecting Jiao S?

Smirking, I said, “So the three of you didn’t disappear. You were with Jiao S instead. Is Jiao S aware of your identities?”

Li Qing signaled for them to stay silent. She addressed me, “It was me who got them to help and protect Jiao S. Jiao S is not fully aware of this, and she did not keep it from you intentionally. She thought I was dead as well.”

“What should I say?” I laughed with irony.

I didn’t know why I was acting like this. I should be happy that she’s alive, I should be running to her in an embrace and crying to her about how the Western District was destroyed, about how I let her down by letting something like this happen. I should be asking for her forgiveness.

But, why did I feel a sort of hatred towards her? Why?

None of this might have had anything to do with her at all. She simply went missing and left you alone, she simply threw everything to you and hid herself elsewhere.

Can you blame her for this, Li Shen? She had always protected you before, so can't you forgive her for this?

I just couldn't stand the fact that you kept secrets from me.

I just couldn't stand the fact that I was upset over your death for so long, and it all ended up being a sham.

“Ah Shen, there're some things that are out of our control. I hope you don't blame me.”

I took a deep breath. Even though all I wanted to do was to turn around and leave, there were some things that I definitely had to face.

I walked over to Li Qing. “Since I'm already here, go ahead and say whatever it is that you want to tell me.”

Li Qing was silent for a while as she looked at me with a gentle gaze.

When I was about to get frustrated with her, she finally spoke. “I asked Huo and the rest to lure you here because I've set up a protective barrier around it. Others won't be able to see the door.”

I glanced at the trio behind Li Qing. All of them had a poker face.

They weren't like this in my memories. There might be some misunderstanding here.

But misunderstandings were normal in the general scheme of things, since time changes everyone.

“Ah Shen, I wanted to advice you that you shouldn't be staying in the Gate of Ghost for too long. I know about what happened in the Western District,

and no matter what you're planning to do after this, just remember that it can only be done if you're alive. Leave the Gate of Ghost."

I laughed. "Where should I go after I leave the Gate of Ghost? You've said it yourself, that the Western District has been destroyed. Where do I go?"

I leaned in, my face almost touching hers. "You knew the Western District has been destroyed, and you didn't stop it? Have you been hiding all this time?"

Huo pulled me away. "Li Shen, there are some things that you don't know, so don't..."

Li Qing interrupted, "Stop. Did I say you could speak?"

I saw the old Li Qing in this very moment. Her authority was so apparent here.

The old Li Qing was someone who looked dashing in battles and who had an authority about her. She was someone who was decisive in everything she did, that Li Qing who was always positive and who was always sure of herself.

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Huo seemed to want to continue, but he retreated upon Li Qing's interruption.

Li Qing said, "Ah Shen, I know it's frustrating when you're not given the truth about many things, and I'm not able to explain everything to you right now either. But please, just trust me no matter what happens. Everything will be made known someday. Before that, you have to wait and be patient. You'll have to survive in order to do that. Stay alive."

She touched a nerve in me. I looked up at her. "There're many things that cannot be explained. Why is everyone being like this? Huan Qing, Si Luo, Gaoqin Jiuye, and even you?"

"Don't come looking for me if things cannot be explained. It's my choice whatever path I choose to go on. Why are all of you trying to direct me while refusing to tell me a thing? There's also Mr Blond. All of you were people I once trusted. Why is everyone treating me like this now?" I got a little emotional as I spoke.

However, Li Qing narrowed her eyes. "You've met Mr Blond?"

His words replayed themselves in my mind.

I answered coldly, "I haven't seen him, and this is also why I want to know how long you guys plan on leaving me alone like this."

Li Qing seemed to heave a sigh of relief. I was a little confused. *Why did she look anxious when she thought I might have seen Mr Blond? It was rare to see her anxious over anything in the past.*

“Ah Shen, many things are not as simple as you think.”

I cut her off. “I know that. It might be nothing like I imagine it to be, but I’m following my heart here. Before I know the truth, I can only act based on how I feel. What I’m seeing now is that all of you are lying to me, that you’ve all left me, and also made me lose many whom I cared about. I have you guys to thank for all the loneliness I’ve experienced in the Split Zone. Li Qing, do you know how important you were to me?”

I moved closer to her. “I’d rather you didn’t treat me that nicely in the past.”

I didn’t know why I said this. I shouldn’t have done so, I shouldn’t have blamed her.

No matter what she hid from me, it doesn’t change the fact that she was the one who gave me the courage to continue living here. Nobody can replace her in my heart.

Maybe it was because I cared about this too much, that I couldn’t stand even a little mistake. I couldn’t stand it when she turned her back against me, even if it was just for a little while.

Li Qing was still looking at me with that gentle gaze. “I don’t care what you might be thinking now. I’m here to tell you that you have to leave the Gate of Ghost. You’ll be in danger here.”

“Do you think that I’ll definitely listen to you? For you to tell me this in person, you must have had the impression that no one else would be able to convince me on this, isn’t it?”

Without giving her a chance to answer, I looked at the trio behind her.

“Weren’t you guys always protecting Jiao S? She’s now in Du Yue’s Palace of Cold Blood in the Gate of Heaven. Aren’t you guys going to save her?”

None of them answered.

Li Qing sighed. “Jiao’er will be fine. I’m worried about her too, but I’m more worried about you now. You’re the only one who can change all this, and nothing can happen to you. Ah Shen, listen to me, go to the Gate of Heaven. No matter what, it’s safer for you as long as you are there.”

I smiled bitterly. “You’re remarkable, Li Qing. You know everything. You even know my whereabouts. You’ve been watching everything and you choose to appear only now?”

Li Qing shook her head. “No. I just found you.”

“Have you finished? I’m tired of listening. I want to leave.” Nie Zun’s lazy voice sounded behind me.

Li Qing frowned. “What’s wrong with him?” She didn’t seem to be aware of what happened to Nie Zun, so she probably found it funny that he would say something like this.

“I don’t know what’s wrong with him either. He lost his memories after coming out of that demon cave, and he’s working with some king of the Gate of Ghost now.”

Since she might be the only one who can save him now, I decided to tell her everything that happened to Nie Zun. What I didn’t expect was for her expression to turn sour after I finished.

Her voice seemed to have changed as well. “You mean to say... He entered that demon cave?”

I felt unease creeping up on me as I asked, “Yes... What’s wrong?”

Li Qing was silent as she walked past me to Nie Zun. “Huai Du, why are you making Nie Zun follow her? What’s your goal?”

I turned back in surprise.

Some of Nie Zun's bangs covered his eyes as he answered, "I got caught. But it's not him on me right now. Who are you?"

My palms turned cold. I grabbed Li Qing. "What's the meaning of this?"

Li Qing took a deep breath before she started explaining. "Huai Du has the ability to move souls. Whoever has been to his demon cave and had their blood changed with that demon tablet would leave a part of their consciousness there. He can then attach a part of his consciousness to them.

"If I'm correct in my guess, Huai Du has already attached a part of his consciousness in Nie Zun. Such attachment isn't permanent, which means that Nie Zun would only listen to Huai Du whenever Huai Du's consciousness is awoken within him. Huai Du will also be aware of whoever Nie Zun meets and whatever he does. Simply put, Huai Du will be able to see everything that has happened when his consciousness is being activated in Nie Zun."

"So, you mean Huai Du will know Nie Zun's every move whenever his consciousness is being activated?"

Li Qing nodded gravely. "Apart from that, he's able to get Nie Zun to do anything. Nie Zun will feel that there's something relying on him deep within his consciousness, and this is why he'll listen."

Yes, Nie Zun mentioned this before, that he'll listen to Huai Du because Huai Du promised to help him regain those memories with his sister.

Seems like some form of mind control.

Nie Zun smiled at this. "What are you guys talking about?"

I hastily asked Li Qing, "Is there any way to solve this? When would Huai Du's consciousness be activated then?"

"Under normal circumstances, it will be activated once per day after leaving the demon cave. It lasts for about ten minutes every time it happens. In

those ten minutes, Huai Du will use his attached consciousness to look into Nie Zun's memories and tell him what to do."

So this means that when Nie Zun took Piercer last night, it was highly likely that Huai Du's consciousness was active.

"Does this mean that whatever he does in that ten minutes are all under Huai Du's orders?"

"He's still able to make his own decisions, it's just that Huai Du can see everything. This will give Huai Du some clue to what he's like as a person. Since that tablet changed his blood, he'll simply return to what he's originally like as a person. Huai Du can then make use of this information to make him complete certain tasks, which can also benefit Huai Du at the same time.

"This is the secret of the demon cave, but the tablet has rarely been used in thousands of years. Huai Du has cut down on his activities in recent years, up until Du Yue turned rather active. This is why we have reason to suspect that Huai Du might be planning something big."

"We?" I raised a brow. Li Qing knew she had accidentally revealed a minor bit of information, so she chose to ignore my question instead.

I then posed her a different question. "Li Wen said Huai Du has feelings for you. I was in the demon cave too, and Huai Du asked me for Scorpion Ray." I waved my left wrist, showing her the 'bow' she gave me.

Upon seeing the Scorpion Ray on my wrist, Li Qing's gaze darkened. "It doesn't matter what I say now. Since Nie Zun is under his control, the situation is totally different from what I initially anticipated. We have to tweak the plan."

Li Qing's eyes shone brightly.

The weight in my heart was gone instantly.

I knew that the Li Qing in front of me right now was the Li Qing of the past.

As long as she had this determination in her, she would always be able to find a new solution no matter what happened. She never complained and she never gave up. She was someone who was exceptionally strong.

She was my role model.

Apart from the fact that she had left me, she could do no wrong in my eyes.

But it wasn't the time to think about all this now. After my rant was over, my heart returned to Li Qing once again. I trusted her. I believed she was kind. I believed that she would never disappoint those heirs that she had once protected.

Li Qing looked at Nie Zun. "Huai Du, I knew you'd learn of all this someday. I just want to tell you that, yes, I'm here in the Gate of Ghost now. You can come directly at me, don't hurt Ah Shen. I'll never let you go if you hurt her."

A mysterious smile hung on Nie Zun's face, but he remained silent.

Li Qing turned to me. "Since it's like this now, I'm sure you wouldn't leave Nie Zun alone here in the Gate of Ghost even though I really don't want you to stay and put yourself in danger here. How about this then? Go look for Nie Zun's blood and his memories first before you head to the Gate of Heaven to look for Jiao S."

My head snapped up in surprise. "Nie Zun's memories? Can we get them back? How?"

Li Qing nodded. "The reason Nie Zun lost his memories is because that demon tablet changed his blood. You said you've been in that cave too. Have you seen that tablet?"

I nodded in quick succession. "I've seen it. I was there when Nie Zun woke up."

Li Qing continued, “Was the word ‘demon’ on the back of the tablet?”

“Yes.”

“Was it a blood-red color?”

“Yes.”

“That’s it then. That word was engraved there by a technique, and that blood-red is Nie Zun’s blood. It’s the blood that the tablet absorbed from him when he was embedded in there.”

“Then what should I do to get Nie Zun’s blood back?”

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“It’s not an easy task.” Li Qing glanced at Nie Zun. “I did something to his hearing earlier, so he’s not able to hear our conversation now. But since his MF is high, this can only last for a while. I’ll make it quick.”

I nodded quickly. “Okay.”

“Firstly, you have to convince Nie Zun to return to that demon cave. The cave will have reactivated after you had exited it, and there’ll be many monsters that have an incomplete consciousness in there. It would be dangerous. Also, before entering the cave, I can help you shut down Huai Du’s attached consciousness once. I can only do this one time, so this means it has to be the day before you enter the cave. Huai Du wouldn’t be aware of what had happened if he isn’t able to activate the consciousness in him.

“But that’s only for a day.

“So this means you’ll only have a day to enter the cave, find the tablet and change his blood. If you fail to do so, Huai Du will sense that something is wrong and he’d activate the consciousness in Nie Zun immediately on the second day. He’ll then stop Nie Zun when he sees what’s happening.

“You’ll only have one day and it’s not easy to activate that tablet either. A large amount of MF is needed to do that, so you’d have to look for someone with a very high MF. From what I know, there’s no one around you now who has MF high enough to activate the tablet at one go.”

“Not even you?” I asked urgently.

Li Qing sighed. “I might be able to, but I can’t enter the cave. He’ll notice once I enter it.”

“Then what should I do?”

“There’re two ways to do this. But you might not like either of it.”

“What are they?”

“The first method is to look for your soul splitter, that is, Gaoqin Jiuye. Soul splitters and their heirs have the same split symbols, and if your symbols are able to resonate with each other, the combined force might be able to activate the tablet in one try. But for this to work, both of you have to be of the same mind. That is, he’d have to want to save Nie Zun as much as you do. I know that you’ve gotten closer with Gaoqin Jiuye recently, but this is something that’s almost impossible to achieve.”

No, it’s not almost impossible, it’s definitely impossible.

Gaoqin Jiuye isn’t friendly with Nie Zun, so there’s no way he would want to save Nie Zun as much as I do. Furthermore, I’m not about to go looking for him when he’s with Du Yue and Li Wen now. That will only make Nie Zun’s situation worse.

“What’s the other method?”

Li Qing hesitated at this.

I looked at Nie Zun before nudging her. “Quick, we’re running out of time.”

Li Qing answered, “The other method is to awaken the power inside of you. You might not know this yourself, but do you know the real purpose of

having two bodies of consciousness? It means that you have two different power sources. The first is the one that you present to others, the one from the consciousness you're always using, while the other is hidden, that is, the power from your other personality. When you merge that hidden power with the power you already have, you'll be able to activate the tablet."

My heart slowly sank.

Li Qing sighed. "I'm not going to lie, but the reason that many others are trying to approach you is because of this hidden power of yours. I don't have the time to explain everything to you right now. The only thing I can tell you is that you don't have the ability to fully combine the two powers together at this point, because there are many conditions for that to happen.

"The first is that you have to accept her from the bottom of your heart. The second is that you have to intricately and excellently manipulate your MF. The third is that your consciousness has to have the ability to withstand the pain of being combined with another. You aren't able to achieve any of the above right now."

She's right. Li Qing knew me well. I wasn't able to achieve any of the above right now. I had to accept her first.

But there's no way I could do that, ever.

Wouldn't this mean there's no way to accomplish this then?

Li Qing looked at me. "Though it's not possible to combine your consciousness with that of your second personality, we can do it temporarily. This method doesn't require you to accept her from the bottom of your heart, since it's only temporary, but there're high risks for this, and the price is high. Looking at the situation now, it seems to be the only feasible method. Do you want to hear it?"

I nodded. "Go ahead."

Li Qing sighed again. "We'd have to break the barriers to your consciousness for that to happen. Meaning, we'd have to change something

about your consciousness. Your consciousness will be at its weakest at the very moment that it's being changed, and we'll get her out at that point. In this way, she'll be able to combine with you temporarily."

I frowned in confusion. "I don't understand."

Li Qing looked a little awkward at this point, making me suspicious.

"Say it."

Scratching her head, Li Qing said, "In your current condition, there're two ways to weaken your consciousness. The first is to kill someone that you really care about – that will weaken your consciousness immediately, but it's obvious we can't do that now. The other method is... when you lose your virginity."

What what what...

My expression looked like I just swallowed a basket full of eggs.

Li Qing looked somewhat embarrassed at this. "Though there isn't much proof for this, but to a girl, that's when we're at our weakest. If you're able to summon her at that point, you'll be able to temporarily merge with her. This means that... you'll have to convince Nie Zun in that demon cave..."

I shook my head vigorously.

Li Qing grabbed my hand. "Ah Shen, this is the easiest method right now. If you do that, Nie Zun will also be at his weakest, and it's easier for him to be absorbed by that tablet. We might be seeing success at first if we use other methods, but if Nie Zun is strongly against it, the tablet won't be able to absorb him either. All our efforts will be wasted if that happens."

My lips twitched. "But I find this difficult. Even before he lost his memories, it's difficult to get him to... what more when he has forgotten everything now? He's a lot more unpredictable, so how do I get him to..."

Li Qing shook her head. "It's easier because he doesn't remember. Can't you feel it these few days when you were with him? He doesn't act like

those who've lost their memories in the real world. His amnesia is the loss of his ability to tell right from wrong. He decides with his heart now, just like a child. He does everything he wants to, giving no heed to whether it's right or wrong.

“Nie Zun is also a normal male, so if you encourage him to have certain thoughts about you, he'll act on them without much consideration. There isn't anything like morals or restrictions in his head right now. You'll just have to seduce him.”

Good heavens... I'll have to sacrifice myself to save somebody else.

Li Qing looked at me weirdly. “Actually Li Shen, you... You love him, right?”

My heart exploded.

Did I love Nie Zun?

I remained silent.

Li Qing spoke softly. “I don't know this, the only one who does is you. What I can tell you is that if you don't get Nie Zun's blood back, he might never remember you again.”

“What did you say?” I looked at her in a daze.

Li Qing sighed. “Do you think those memories will be contained forever in that blood? There's a time limit to it. You'll notice a tiny hourglass on the bottom of that tablet when you're there. When all the sand is in the bottom-half, it means all the memories in the blood have been lost. There'd be no difference in getting the blood back when that happens, since the memories are all gone. Because of this, the MF contained within it will be affected as well, and the MF might be totally gone as well.

“It's because of this that I was looking for you so urgently.”

I cut her off hastily. “I'll head for the demon cave with Nie Zun right now.”

Nothing else mattered after hearing that he might never remember me. That's the only thing resonating in my mind right now.

This is something I cannot accept. It's something that I can never accept.

“You might not be able to convince him to head for the demon cave, and Huai Du will learn of whatever happens today when he activates his consciousness in Nie Zun the very next time.”

“What should I do then?”

Li Qing said, “I'll leave now. I'll get Feng, Huo and Lei to fight the two of you. Nie Zun's memories will contain the part where you guys saw me after being lured here, and then I'd have disappeared. I'll mention a location that's close to the demon cave, and I'll leave you guys to battle the three of them. If Nie Zun gets hurt in battle, Huai Du's consciousness will be automatically activated in him. After seeing me, Huai Du will definitely get Nie Zun to go in the direction of the demon cave. When you guys arrive there, I'll get Feng, Huo and Lei to force the two of you into the cave. At the same time, I'll get Huo to shut down Huai Du's consciousness in Nie Zun for an entire day. It'll be up to you then. Here's a watch. Take it and use it to keep time. Make sure you do everything in 60 hours.”

Just as Li Qing finished, Nie Zun asked, “Why aren't you guys talking?”

Li Qing raised a hand, and I could sense that she was concentrating her MF on her wrist. She stabbed me in the abdomen as she said, “Ah Shen, since you're not going to reveal where she is, I'll just have to go over to that demon river to look for her myself.”

So that river where we met Bian Ying was called the ‘demon river’.

Chapter 214: 214 Feng, Huo, Lei

Volume 4

214 Feng, Huo, Lei

I could understand that Li Qing did this to make it look more realistic, but having another hole in your stomach was not fun.

I backed away quickly and returned to Nie Zun's side.

"Bring me out," I said to Nie Zun, leaning against him. Nie Zun supported me as the both of us retreated.

As we exited the room, Li Qing rushed out. Her indigo hair dazzled even though we were not under direct sunlight. She smiled at Nie Zun as she flipped her hair. "Let my subordinates play with the both of you for a while. I'm going over first."

I didn't know exactly what picture Li Qing was trying to paint for Huai Du by doing this.

My abdomen was beginning to heal when Feng, Huo and Lei were about to attack.

I looked at the gigantic hole in my dress, thinking to myself, 'I'll have to get a new one again.'

After Li Qing left, Huo produced bright firelight as he waved a cold hand at Nie Zun.

I knew how powerful these three subordinates of Li Qing were. They were one of the few in the Split Zone who could control the natural elements. Not

only did they have great MF, their attacks were extremely powerful since they were all interconnected with the natural elements.

An angry fireball that seemed to be armed with sharp teeth rushed at Nie Zun. Without hesitation, Nie Zun pushed me to the side, causing me to fall on the ground instantly. Even though I could stand with MF, the pain of having one's stomach ripped open was pretty hard to bear.

I struggled to get up, staring at Nie Zun's figure angrily as I did so.

I noticed that Nie Zun had been using the demonic energy from his hands most of the time after losing his memories.

That fireball turned into an enormous, fiery python, looking like it was about to devour Nie Zun at any moment with those jaws. With black fog emanating from his hands, Nie Zun asked casually, "Why are we fighting?"

That's right. From Nie Zun's perspective, they had no reason to attack him.

Huo answered coldly, "To kill your girlfriend."

I almost puked at this. *I don't think I'm his girlfriend...*

Nie Zun turned back at me with narrowed eyes. "Seems like I'll have to reconsider whatever you've said before, since so many others think that we're a couple."

I was speechless.

I can tell you have no intention of reconsidering whatever I've said earlier. "Continue with your fight. Make sure you don't die," I answered sarcastically.

Nie Zun was still engaged in fierce battle with Huo when my abdomen finally healed completely.

But, I realized something else. *Why wasn't there anyone else here in this carpark?*

Feng and Lei did not look like they had any intention of joining the fight. With the current situation, it did not look like they had to intervene at all.

Both Huo's hands had turned into fiery torches, and everything he touched was charred instantly. Though I was more than three meters away, I could feel the power of his MF coursing through those flames.

As expected from Li Qing's best subordinates.

There was still something I didn't quite understand. *Though they were under orders to protect Jiao S, now that the Eastern District has been destroyed, and Jiao S is powerful enough on her own, it would have made more sense for Li Qing to let them stay with me, considering that she had always favored me. But why didn't she do that?*

If things didn't flow logically like this, then there must be something else going on here.

I was seated on the ground thinking about this when I felt a sudden gust of wind blow past. Sensing danger, I lifted my left hand as a shield and retreated a few steps back.

Feng was a short distance away from me when I looked up. *Did he want to fight me too?*

Fine. I was sure that they were trying to make the scene look all the more realistic when he sent a gust of wind at me.

"Scorpion Ray."

Scorpion Ray turned into a bow as I drew an arrow of light with my right hand.

Swoosh.

Countless needles of light shot towards Feng. I had gotten better at using Scorpion Ray now after the few times I combined my MF with it.

Feng was someone who made use of the wind in his attacks, and he was as quick as lightning in his movements.

As he raised a hand, rainbow-colored rays shot through the carpark. The needles of light from Scorpion Ray shattered as they hit a translucent wall. Behind that rainbow wall was Feng's tall and sturdy figure.

"The wind shield... Been a while." I smiled at him. Feng kept a straight face, not returning my smile.

My face froze for an instant.

Among the three, I was on the best terms with Feng. I had seen this technique before, and he even used it to protect me previously.

The triplets seemed to have misunderstood something about me, but I don't remember doing anything that might have let them down.

Was it because of my failure to take care of the Western District?

Feng looked at me with a cold and unfamiliar gaze. He raised a hand and grabbed the air in front of him.

Air vortexes appeared in the air, turning into sharp, merciless drills that flew towards me from all directions.

Danger loomed. I knew that Feng was an expert in using wind, and he might be better at Gaoqin Jiuye when it comes to manipulating air currents. I focused my MF on defense, trying to create a barrier around me.

I wasn't very good at defense, and now that Piercer wasn't with me and Scorpion Ray's attacks don't seem to be working, the only thing I could do was to create a protective barrier around myself with MF, even though it was a weak defense.

My MF could cancel about half the attack power of those air vortexes, but my exposed skin was still wounded by the remaining force.

I frowned at Feng, who looked like he was ready to kill. This didn't feel like acting, it felt like he was being serious.

“How should I be interpreting this?” Staying silent cannot solve anything. Lei stood standing in a corner, not moving an inch, while Huo and Feng were in the midst of a fierce battle with Nie Zun and I. I looked at Feng as I waited for his response.

Feng answered casually, “Since we've met, how about a spar? Let me see how much you've grown in these couple of years.”

I don't think I've improved very much. Furthermore, Piercer has been taken away by somebody else.

I turned to shout at Nie Zun, “Hey, could you return Piercer for a while? I'll give it back when I'm done.” *You aren't using it anyway.*

Jet-black mist surrounded Nie Zun's hands as he moved with great agility, as if this was just a simple game and not a battle. He smiled as he answered, “No.”

I really wanted to beat this guy up.

As I turned back, I saw Feng raise his slender hands under that white robe. His fingers moved like he was strumming invisible strings.

I was a little anxious at this.

A melody sounded in the air. It was created by his strumming. One had to be able to manipulate MF extremely intricately to be able to produce such melodic sounds in the air.

The melody was gentle and crisp at first, but it turned heavy after a while. Feng's pupils' tightened.

As he continued plucking the invisible strings in the air, a crack appeared in the ground, as if it was a mark left by an invisible sword that slashed through it.

Boom.

Six vehicles rose up into the air behind me before flying right at me. One of these vehicles was an old-fashioned horse-drawn carriage with a horse attached.

That horse was currently defecating.

Its excrement flew through the air.

Though it was animal dung, it still had great force. It seemed to carry some sort of killing intent as it flew towards me together with the other vehicles.

I focused my MF on my feet and avoided it quickly. Unfortunately, those vehicles were a red herring. A strong blade of air hit me as I was busy avoiding those vehicles, making me fly more than ten meters away.

Sparks appeared under my feet as I tried to steady myself from the attack, but I seemed to have hit somebody behind me.

Subconsciously, I wanted to grab the person from behind and use their body as a shield. I came into contact with sturdy arms as I reached out. Looking up, I realized it was Chou Yu.

“Why are you here?” I asked in surprise.

Chou Yu smiled politely. “Miss Ah Shen.”

I then saw Yuan Qian walk in from the entrance of the carpark. “The two of you...” My brows furrowed.

Yuan Qian looked at me. “I can track you with that pill I gave you earlier.”

Seeing Yuan Qian and Chou Yu, Nie Zun made Huo retreat with a ray of black light. He then started making his way towards us.

Damn, what should I do now?

I couldn't tell Chou Yu and Yuan Qian the truth, since I didn't know what Yuan Qian really thought of me right now, and I didn't know the effects of her poison either. I had to bring Nie Zun to the demon cave as soon as possible.

Right now, the only solution was to forcefully activate Huai Du's consciousness in Nie Zun by badly wounding him.

I told Yuan Qian, "I don't know why you're here, but you have to leave now. Someone is after you."

Chou Yu was the one who responded. He looked worried as he spoke. "Miss Ah Shen, what do you mean by that?"

With one look at Chou Yu, I realized the two of them were actually a couple.

I said to Chou Yu with renewed determination, "Nie Zun wants to take her life."

With that, Chou Yu stepped forward to shield Yuan Qian as he looked at the approaching Nie Zun vigilantly.

Feng, Huo and Lei did not disappoint. The three of them went after Nie Zun immediately as they saw the change in the situation.

A blade of air, a fireball and a bolt of lightning combined in an attack that was going straight for Nie Zun's back, towards his heart.

Chapter 215: 215 Nie Zun's Ability

Volume 4

215 Nie Zun's Ability

Nie Zun's abilities were still as sharp even when he had lost his memories. He turned around as he sensed an incoming attack from behind, and I definitely had to make use of this opportunity.

I raised my hand and released rays of light with Scorpion Ray. Chou Yu was wary of Nie Zun because of what I had said, and he thought Nie Zun was about to attack Yuan Qian at this point. Because of that, he was ready to counter it.

Chou Yu's fists were powerful, and since he was closer to Nie Zun, Nie Zun turned to parry Chou Yu's attack first. As he turned, Feng, Huo and Lei's attack hit him in the back.

I pulled Chou Yu away as I grabbed Nie Zun's left hand. I knew his MF was focused mostly on his hands, even though he might have forgotten about his past at this point.

Initially, I thought of breaking his wrists to activate Huai Du's consciousness in that very moment, but nothing ever goes according to plan.

When I grabbed his left hand, I felt that ring on it.

He never took off that ring. I've always found it familiar, but I just can't seem to recall anything that had to do with that skull ring.

A ray of black and red light shot out from that ring. My MF seemed to be attracted to that light, as if they were two pieces of magnets. This confused me for a moment. *This feeling... It felt rather familiar...*

When I looked up at Nie Zun again, his eyes looked a little teary and confused. But that lasted for only a second.

He smiled in an evil manner after that. "I have a new mission." He slapped my hand away and headed for the carpark's exit without any heed to the injuries on his back.

I looked at Feng, Huo and Lei, and they rushed forward after exchanging gazes with one another.

Gritting my teeth, I turned to Yuan Qian. "I'll give you an explanation about your brother. Since you're able to track me down with that pill, come look for me a few days later. I'm a little tied up now. Chou Yu, protect her."

Before I left, I was reminded of something else. I turned to the both of them again. "If you really have her interests at heart, please don't follow us. Please."

I then turned to chase after Nie Zun, leaving the both of them with confused looks.

Nie Zun was fast and agile. He had probably gotten the order to look for Li Qing at the demon river.

Feng, Huo and Lei were able to control the natural elements, so it was easy for them to run at high speeds for long distances, but it wasn't the case for me. I haven't rested in days, and I've been using my MF too frequently. It was difficult for me to catch up with them in my exhausted state.

With Nie Zun's speed, Huai Du seemed to have given him an urgent mission. This showed how much Huai Du cared about Li Qing.

We were met with countless stares as we passed through the crowds.

What attracted their attention was probably not because there were four individuals chasing a single figure, but probably because among the four, there were three in bamboo hats, while the last one was in a tattered red dress.

I might have been too tired, or it might just have been very far away, but I felt like it was forever before we arrived at that forest.

Though I wanted nothing more but to take a nap when we reached the river, I knew I didn't have the luxury of time. We were so far from even catching a glimpse of that hourglass and the tablet, and I don't know what Nie Zun might become. I did not have any time to waste.

Nie Zun looked around as he stood at the riverbank. He turned back and smiled condescendingly at Feng, Huo and Lei. "Where's Li Qing?"

Huo answered calmly, "You'll have to beat us if you want to find her."

The three of them took off their bamboo hats one by one before they got into position, each of them raising a hand towards Nie Zun.

I was screaming silently. They were really pulling out all stops in order to force Nie Zun into the demon cave.

From the air, one would be able to see that the three of them had formed a triangle in their positions. If I remember right, this was called the tri-point position.

With this triangular position, they were able to cover one another from all angles. Furthermore, the combination of the three natural elements made a powerful attack.

I don't remember seeing them in this position often. The damage would be great, and it was not only because they could control the elements. They were a team of triplets, and they were able to work together seamlessly because of that. They had also been working together for years, and they'd definitely be at least six times stronger than if they were fighting alone.

But I didn't understand why they had to start so strongly. Did they think Nie Zun was so powerful that they had to go against him like this right at the beginning?

After some thought, I realized it was a logical choice. We had the same goal now, that is, to force Nie Zun into that demon cave. They might have already thought about the most efficient way to go about this, and the most efficient method might simply be to force him into the cave quickly by going all-out against him.

Nie Zun gave a dashing smile. "So it's to fight me. The outside world is just no fun, everyone wants to pick a fight with me."

I lit up at this. "How about you go back to your demon cave then?"

Nie Zun waved a hand in mock earnesty. "No no. It's way too boring in there. I'd rather have fights outside than go back there."

Alright, I guess a fight is inevitable then.

Feng, Huo and Lei produced three different types of attacks in the very next second.

There was a fireball, a blade of air, and a ray of lightning. The three forces combined into one before charging at Nie Zun.

Nie Zun was leaning on one foot with his head slightly tilted. He had a casual smile on him as he made a weird gesture with his hands in front of his chest.

Feng, Huo and Lei's attack combined into a ball of whirling air. Smoke and dust rose around it, and I could hear the wind roaring in my ears.

With Nie Zun's weird gesture, black fog started to close in on us. It spread out and enclosed Feng, Huo and Lei within. I could not really keep tabs on the entire situation from where I was.

The three natural elements were easily parried by Nie Zun as that black fog surrounding his hands seemed to have the ability of canceling MF.

Nie Zun's eyes were shining now. I knew that he could use his pupils, but I haven't seen him use that ability ever since he had lost his memories.

Feng, Huo and Lei did not seem to be getting the upper hand in this even though they were in the tri-point position. From what I could see, it served only the purpose of defense. They might have been wary that Nie Zun might go all-out against them.

Their attacks did not work on Nie Zun so far.

This was a waste of time. It'd be better not to have this fight at all.

I lifted my left wrist slowly, wondering if I should attack. *The demon cave was still some distance away. Why were they fighting here?*

Very quickly, I was given the answer as Li Qing appeared on the other side of the river.

Nie Zun's eyes shone upon seeing her. He leapt away from the battle and walked over to her.

"There's someone who wants to see you, and that someone wants me to take you somewhere," Nie Zun said as he smiled at Li Qing.

Li Qing gave a charming smile. "Too bad. I don't want to see that person."

Nie Zun lifted a hand shrouded in black mist as he walked towards her. "Then I'll just have to use force."

Li Qing glanced at me. She then squinted as she raised her arms, placing her palms together.

Boom.

A gully suddenly appeared between Li Qing and Nie Zun. The ground shook violently, and the water in the river crashed and roared loudly as it flowed into the gully.

Nie Zun stared at Li Qing as he narrowed his eyes.

An external force seemed to be controlling the water. It looked like transparent silk as it rippled in the air.

Li Qing smiled as she released her palms. The water splashed everywhere, and beads of water shot right at Nie Zun like bullets.

Nie Zun's pupils widened as black light shone in his eyes.

The beads of water stopped right in front of him.

Those beads were tiny to begin with, and they turned into mist as they disintegrated.

Nie Zun lifted a hand to grab the air suddenly.

The black fog surrounded the mist in the air, turning them into black blades that flew towards Li Qing. It was so quick that I could only see their tails even when I focused MF on my vision.

Whoosh, whoosh, whoosh.

“Wildfire!”

Fire spouted from the gully as Huo shouted. The temperature rose instantly, almost suffocating me. It felt as if all the water had evaporated in an instant.

The black blades under Nie Zun's control had all evaporated since they were made of water.

Li Qing looked careful now, as if still wary of Nie Zun's earlier attack.

I saw a light shine in her eyes as she muttered something I wasn't able to hear.

White light encased her before turning into that silvery-white armor she used to have.

Her sword had also appeared on her back.

Chapter 216: 216 Returning to the Demon Cave

Volume 4

216 Returning to the Demon Cave

This was the real Li Qing.

Seeing her whip out the big guns, I stepped forward, ready to join the fight if it turned ugly.

To my surprise, Li Qing turned and headed somewhere else. She had no intention of fighting at all.

A hint of doubt appeared in Nie Zun's eyes. He probably wondered why Li Qing wanted to avoid a fight even with those abilities. He leapt into the air immediately, chasing after her at the speed of light. Feng, Huo and Lei followed after him closely.

I said to myself with gritted teeth, "Do they think this is some competition of sorts? Everyone is running so quickly."

I had no choice but to focus my MF on my feet and run after them.

The wind roared past my ears at the speed I was going and it felt as if everything on my face was being distorted. Even so, I was still quite a distance away from the rest.

Pain shot through my chest just as I attempted to quicken my pace.

What's happening?

Was this caused by my lack of rest and frequent use of MF?

This pain felt like it came from the depths of my soul, and it seemed to emanate from my heart.

With no time to think about what was happening, I continued running. The top priority now is to help Nie Zun regain his memories.

I realized what Li Qing was trying to do when the giant mushroom in front of the demon cave appeared before me. She was trying to lure him here, and all we had to do now was to enter the cave.

Li Qing had already drawn her sword when I finally caught up with them at the cave's entrance.

Nie Zun squinted at the entrance. Even when faced with four enemies right in front of him, he was still able to ask me in a casual manner, "This is where I came out from, right?"

I shook my head vigorously. "I don't know. How would I know when there are so many caves around?"

Nie Zun scratched his head in confusion, as if he was in some sort of dilemma.

Li Qing did not give him much time to continue being confused. With a tap of her feet, she raised her sword and charged at Nie Zun.

I became rather emotional as I saw her like this. It was two years since I've seen her fight, and I've been missing her for as long as I could remember. At that time, I felt contented and happy knowing that she'll always be behind me to protect me. I even thought that I would be able to survive here in the Split Zone forever as long as she was around.

It could've been because I hadn't seen her in a long time, or it might've been because I thought she was dead. The image of her with shut eyes and a pale face reappeared in my mind. I teared at the thought.

She exuded a kind of resilience as she carried that sword with her. She was made for battle. In my eyes, not even Hua Mulan or Fan Lihua can hold a candle against her. (T/n: Historical figures, Hua Mulan and Fan Lihua were famous female warriors.)

Even though she was excellent in battle, she did not carelessly engage in fights. I don't remember ever seeing her fight to protect herself. She had always fought for others, or to protect somebody else.

Li Qing was someone who did not know how to 'love herself'.

I was of that opinion up until now, when she reappeared before me, when Feng, Huo and Lei looked at me with those unfamiliar gazes. I was confused. *Had I been wrong about her all this time?*

Was Li Qing not like what I thought she was?

The fight was already underway as I got lost in my own thoughts.

Li Qing's sword slashed through the air. Every move of hers was fast and furious, and she moved quickly and confidently without the slightest hint of hesitation.

As for Nie Zun, his reflexes were quick and he was extremely agile. He used his pupils to control the air around him as he avoided Li Qing's attacks.

Feng, Huo and Lei were standing at the sidelines, looking like they were ready to attack anytime.

"Hey, aren't you going to help me out?" Nie Zun could even chide me in the middle of his fight.

I looked at him. "I can't win them. How about we just run?"

Nie Zun smirked. "Where to?"

I pointed at the demon cave behind him. "Let's go in and have a look. It was empty when you came out of there, but it'd be interesting now."

Feng, Huo and Lei attacked at this very moment when Nie Zun was in a dilemma on whether he should enter. It was a powerful attack.

The ground started quaking and the air rippled to the point that it blurred my vision. Bubbles started coming out from the ground, as if the ground was boiling liquid. This was bad. Focusing MF on my feet, I leapt into the air.

Just as I leapt, sparks started shooting up from the ground. Countless red sparks appeared, and they burnt fierce and bright.

Nie Zun narrowed his eyes, as if he was thinking of a counterattack. The blue sky then turned dark in an instant.

I looked up to see a dark shadow above.

Not good, it was Lei.

Lei had not really launched any attack up until now. He was good in controlling electrons, and I remembered him literally being as fast as lightning.

Li Qing smiled as she raised her sword again.

All four of them were about to go against him now.

Nie Zun sensed it too, that he was already being surrounded and that the only escape was the cave behind him.

I looked around us before I made a decision. Spreading my MF throughout my body, I rushed into the middle of the fight.

It felt as if something was automatically put into motion the moment I entered the fight. I thought I could counter the force, but I only felt my MF continually weaken as the flames from the ground licked my skin.

Li Qing charged towards Nie Zun and I with her sword as a bolt of lightning appeared with a thunderous clap.

I pushed Nie Zun into the cave behind him and a loud explosion sounded behind us as we fell forward.

As we struggled to get up, I saw a stone door seal the entrance to the cave behind us. There was probably a mechanism already in place.

But, Li Qing didn't tell me what to do next from here. And has she already disabled Huai Du's consciousness in Nie Zun?

Nie Zun stood up, frowning. "What's happening?" *Okay, this was an idiot right here.*

"You're going to look for whoever Huai Du wants you to look for? I don't think you've lost your memories, I think you've been brainwashed instead." I stared at him as I spoke.

Nie Zun shrugged. "I keep hearing his voice in my head, and that happens at least once a day. There didn't seem to be anything wrong if I listened to him, and I'd be able to regain those lost memories as well."

I was so frustrated that I wanted to scream at him. *All the memories you've lost had to do with me.* But that would sound like I was getting at something else if I said it. I guess I should leave it until he regains his memories then.

Because of this, I was even more anxious in getting his memories back.

"No use wasting time here. Since we won't be able to get out from that door anyway, let's just go further in and find another exit." I looked at my watch. It's been an hour since Huai Du's consciousness awoke in him. I had to find his blood within the next 23 hours.

In fact, I had to find that tablet within the next 23 hours. I didn't know how much sand had already flowed to the bottom half of that hourglass, and I didn't know what to do to change his blood either. Li Qing didn't tell me how to go about any of these.

"Why can't we exit from that door?" Nie Zun asked as he pointed to where we came from.

I answered in a frustrated manner. “From what I know, all the stones in this cave absorb MF. No matter how much MF you use, it’ll end up being absorbed in the end. How can we open it in this case? Or do you think you can use mere strength to open that stone door without using your MF?”

Nie Zun smirked as if that would be an easy task for him. He strolled over to the door with hands in his pockets.

As if avoiding the uneven areas, he placed his palms carefully against the door.

He turned back after one try, flashing me a brilliant smile. His eyes were clear like spring water and his confidence did not seem to have buckled at all. “It really doesn’t work.”

“...”

When I walked over and screamed at the door, Nie Zun had already made his way into the cave. There was no answer from outside the stone door either.

I said to myself in frustration, “Not telling me what to do. Do I really need to sacrifice myself for this? Just how should I get his blood back?”

This was mission impossible, but I followed Nie Zun into the cave quickly.

He was already disappearing into the darkness. Visibility had reduced to a radius of ten meters in the cave.

I felt something following behind as I quickened my steps, but there seemed to be nothing there when I turned around to look.

“Hey, slow down.” I tapped him on the shoulder as I finally caught up with him. He was rather fast, though he looked like he was just taking a nice evening stroll.

As Nie Zun turned around, his starry eyes and handsome features were gone.

The individual who turned around did not have a face.

His face was as white as paper and there was nothing on it.

Chapter 217: 217 Faceless Creatures

Volume 4

217 Faceless Creatures

If this happened in the real world, I would have screamed my lungs out before throwing punches and kicks at him.

Don't call me violent. This is simply the logical reaction of a weak girl. However, I can no longer be considered a 'weak girl' after arriving here in the Split Zone.

I kept my eyes on the creature. "Who are you?"

A hole began to appear on the creature's white face. It appeared somewhere where the mouth should have been.

As that hole slowly opened to form a mouth, I saw nothing but rows of teeth against a bloody red background. There were hundreds of teeth in that mouth.

Goosebumps appeared all over me.

I think I might have trypophobia.

Stepping backwards, I frowned as I asked, "What exactly are you?" I readied my left hand, preparing to counter with Scorpion Ray at a moment's notice.

That scary mouth moved as it spoke in a villainous voice, "So yummy."

I swear I wanted to take a shower immediately after hearing this.

It was darkness all around me, and the stone walls had disappeared. There were two possibilities here. The first was that the cave was extremely wide, and it had a width of more than 20 meters across. If so, I wouldn't be able to see any of the walls since they were more than 10 meters away from me.

The second possibility was that something else was obscuring my vision.

When I was thinking about the more likely scenario, that disgusting creature in front of me reached out with a hand.

I used Scorpion Ray to cut his hand off immediately.

The creature didn't seem to be in pain from my attack, or rather, I wouldn't be able to tell even if it was, since he did not have a face.

It started walking towards me with a single arm, like a zombie. Grossed out by the creature, I retreated a few steps, planning to use Scorpion Ray's circular bow to turn him into mincemeat.

However, things did not go as planned. I bumped into someone else as I walked backwards.

As I turned to look, I realized it was the same faceless creature. But this time, it seemed to be a woman instead of a man.

How should I describe her? She was floating in mid-air and she had a full head of hair. There were no features on her face at all. Her head was just like a furry round ball that was full of hair.

Her hair circled around my neck the moment I turned back. It was so sharp it pricked my flesh. *This was uncomfortable.*

Just as I wanted to attack, I saw a pale and slender hand grab her head from the back, as if it was holding a baby. That hand then made two quick turns, left and right.

Crack.

The hair around my neck loosened immediately as the head dropped to the ground.

I then saw Nie Zun's face.

Before I could say a thing, he reached out to grab the creature behind me, destroying it easily.

"Where did you go earlier?" I asked softly. I don't know if it was because of the darkness or because I had just seen two faceless creatures, but at this point, there was an evil aura about Nie Zun's face.

His lips turned up at an angle. "I've always been here. I thought these things were quite interesting, and I wanted to see if you'd be frightened, so I hid myself."

"..."

Upon another look, I found this face way too thin and too full of malice.
What an ugly man.

I pulled him with me in annoyance. I had to admit, I really didn't want to face those weird creatures on my own again.

As we continued, he said suddenly, "Actually, there's someone else following behind us."

He was not whispering. If there really was anyone behind us now, they would definitely be able to hear him.

I didn't know how to answer him like this.

"Hmm, aren't you curious about what's following us?" Nie Zun asked with interest.

I frowned. *I wouldn't be curious if you asked it like this.*

Because you asked if I was curious about what was following, instead of who was following. This confirmed that it was some kind of creature.

But the feeling of being followed and not taking a look made me feel frustrated as well. So, I grabbed Nie Zun's hand tightly as I turned back very slowly.

There was nothing but complete darkness.

"Hahahahaha you actually believed me?" Nie Zun started laughing.

I took a deep breath. I could stand it no more. Focusing my MF on my feet, I stepped on him with all my might.

"You're really violent. Luckily I don't really feel any pain," Nie Zun said as he looked at his foot.

This man was crazy. I continued dragging him further into the cave as I wondered about what might await us. *How had the demon cave changed? How long is it till we find that tablet? Can we even manage to find it?*

"Zzz... ssss..."

Weird sounds started coming from both sides in the darkness and the sounds were getting louder and louder as we walked further in.

I felt goosebumps. It was eerie and it sounded like the nails of a woman scratching on glass.

I grabbed Nie Zun tightly in fear.

"Oh, so you're actually scared? I thought you weren't afraid of anything." Nie Zun was teasing me casually, as if he hadn't heard the sound.

I stared at him angrily.

Nie Zun then snapped his fingers.

With that, our surroundings lit up immediately.

This was a tunnel of stone, and it was very wide. There were torches on both walls, except that they weren't lit before this. The path before us

seemed to go on forever.

The source of the sounds was revealed as well.

Behind us were things that looked to be human beings. They were crawling on the ground and also on both walls.

That's right, they merely looked to be human beings.

These things had human torsos and a head of long hair, but they did not have faces. They simply had mouths, similar to those faceless creatures we met earlier. The bottom half of their bodies were lizard parts and they stuck to the walls and to the ground.

Their fingers were transparent and sharp, looking exactly like fingernails.

Those hands were scratching against the surface continuously, making that sound.

There were at least five or six of them behind us crawling on the ground now. They were not far from us, and there were three or four of them on both sides of the walls as well.

The only clear path was forward.

“What are these?” I felt my hairs stand.

Nie Zun shrugged. “I don't know.”

I wanted to give that annoying face a slap. *Fine, but does this mean we have to fight these things?*

I looked at the creatures. There was nothing but a mouth filled with teeth on their white faces. They had no eyes, and I couldn't tell what they could possibly be thinking.

I didn't know if I could communicate with them either, nor did I want to find out.

These things were just crawling on the wall and on the ground. They did not seem to have the intention of doing anything else.

I pulled Nie Zun with me and took a few steps forward.

Something interesting then happened. These things moved only when we moved, and they stopped when we stopped. They did not seem to be approaching us, nor did they seem to have the intention of retreating.

“What’s this?” I muttered.

Nie Zun answered, “Just grab one of them and ask.”

“How about you do it huh?”

Nie Zun smirked. He then grabbed me and pushed me to the side.

I didn’t expect him to do that, and I almost slammed into the wall.

Luckily, the path was wide and I could stop myself before it happened.

The first thing I did was not to look at the creatures on the wall, but to turn and scold Nie Zun.

“Do you have a death wish, Nie Zun...!” I almost roared at him.

Nie Zun pretended to look all innocent as he pouted his lips. “I just asked you to take a look at these things.”

I’m really...

I turned back slowly to face those creatures. “Hi, can you speak human?”

This question seemed a little...

The creature’s mouth opened as it answered, “So yummy.”

...This again.

My lips twitched in annoyance. “What are you? What are you planning to do?” *Better to be direct about this.*

The creature did not move as it continued, “So yummy.”

I took a deep breath and walked back to Nie Zun with a glum expression. “You asked me to take a look right? I’ve seen them. They’re just big eaters.”

I ignored him and continued into the tunnel.

Nie Zun caught up quickly, laughing. “They’re still following us.”

My hairs stood up. “I know. Let them.”

Even though I said that, I kept my eyes on both walls, keeping track of their every move as they continued following us.

Chapter 218: 218 Call Me Shen'er

Volume 4

218 Call Me Shen'er

After some walking, we finally reached some sort of checkpoint.

There was heavy white fog in front of us.

Nie Zun and I looked at each other before walking towards the fog.

I realized the creatures had stopped. They seemed to be avoiding the fog.

As we closed in, we realized that the fog had obscured the path forward. To continue, we had to go through the fog. However, it looked like our vision would be obscured once we walked into it.

“Should we go through?” I asked, unsure.

Nie Zun answered without hesitation, “Why not?”

I looked back at those creatures. They were still now, none of them moving an inch.

There’s nowhere else to go but forward then.

“Let’s go.” I pulled Nie Zun along.

Ever since he had lost his memories, I’ve always wanted to hold his hand every time he’s beside me, afraid that I’ll lose him again. I’m willing to do this even though he treats me like a stranger, or even if he doesn’t care about what I do.

I wanted him to remember me, but there would be times when I hoped this could last forever.

Nothing could be seen around us as we walked into the fog.

A pain shot through my wrist as I tried to hold his hand tight, and his hand just slipped away like this.

I looked around the whiteness as I called out, “Nie Zun.”

I flailed my arms about as I tried searching for him, but there was nothing around me.

Stay calm, Li Shen, stay calm.

I looked around me again. Everything was white fog, including the ground.

I was sure this was an illusion.

Though the demon cave was an unpredictable place, there was something else going on right here. It might be the work of a powerful illusionist.

I suddenly thought of Guan Nie, who had been missing in the Gate of Ghost for quite a while now. *Would he be in here?*

“Where are you, Nie Zun?” No one answered when I tried calling out again.

I took baby steps forward as I spread my MF all around me, trying to get a better sense of my surroundings.

Surprisingly, I couldn’t sense a thing.

While I was at a loss of what to do, the white fog right in front of me seemed to dissipate slightly.

I walked up quickly to the empty space that appeared.

That space was surrounded by white fog, as if it was right under a huge spotlight.

Why did this feel so familiar?

Right.

This was the scene when Si Luo stuck his hand into my heart the last time.

Was this an illusion created by MF?

I hesitated a little before deciding to walk over to that bright, empty spot.

I heard my name just as I stepped into the space.

“Ah Shen.”

I looked around me. *It can't be... Will the same thing happen again?*

I smiled bitterly to myself as I saw him emerge from the fog. *I guess the same thing will happen again.*

But it was Gaoqin Jiuye the last time. Who was it this time?

I asked slowly, “You’re Gaoqin Jiuye? Or Gao Qi?”

He was dressed exactly like Gaoqin Jiuye, but he had a rather expressionless face.

He looked at me with a deep gaze. “You can’t tell me apart from him now, can you?”

This... What did that mean?

I looked down at his waist as he moved closer to me. *Shen Qi... wasn't there.*

I felt his cold breath on my face as he said, “He had always wanted to take you away from me, always. I tried ways and means to prevent him from doing so, but you? You still left with him in the end.”

What is he saying?

I looked up at him in confusion. “Are you Gao Qi? Gao Qi, what’re you talking about?”

Gao Qi laughed. “That’s right, I’m Gao Qi. I’m here to visit you in the Split Zone, I’m here to bring you back.”

My heart seemed to explode at this with a force that could destroy an entire city, the shrapnel cutting me right through the bones.

Something seemed to be reemerging from within my memories. *Did he say something like this to me before?*

Yes, I remember seeing him in Huan Qing’s illusion at the time when I just arrived in the Southern District.

Pomelo was present too.

He told me to leave with him at that time, that he was here to pick me up from the Split Zone.

But, in the end?

Nie Zun’s ‘Shen’er’ brought me back to reality. Gao Qi and Pomelo were both gone. I was still in the Split Zone, and no one could bring me back.

I smiled bitterly. “You’re an illusion, right? Great. It just so happens that there’s something I want to say.”

I moved in closer and caressed his face. I’ve fallen head over heels for that face once, but it felt a little foreign now that I looked at it again. “I’ve always wanted to say sorry, that I’ve killed you. I know you’re a nightmare living in my heart, and I know that I’ve lost most of the memories we had together. But I know that you’re still here in my heart. Please forgive me.”

I felt warm skin under my fingers. This felt extremely realistic.

His eyes looked like they were sighing. “Why don’t you believe me? Yes, it was me who had hurt you so badly in the past, and that had caused you to

forget me. You're still wary of me and you refuse to believe me now... It's all my fault..."

"What are you... talking about?" I asked in confusion.

Gao Qi looked me in the eye, entrapping me with that gaze. "You've always been in love with Gaoqin Jiuye, not me. And I've always been jealous of him. Because of that, I was afraid that he'll take you away from me, and that was why I did it. I should be the one saying sorry. I should be the one who should have left. But, not only did I fail in doing that and returning you a peaceful life, I've pulled you in here instead."

My heart felt like it twisted into a knot. I didn't understand him at all. This was all nonsense to me.

Wasn't I living in the real world before?

Wasn't it Gao Qi I fell in love with? My senior, Gao Qi? Even if I killed him with my own two hands, even if I've forgotten most of what happened between us, I was very sure of whatever I could remember. I knew who it was that I loved. Why was he saying this?

Unease crept up on me. If this was an illusion, it would have to be based on whatever was deep inside my heart. No matter how unpredictable this demon cave was, the illusion had to come from somewhere.

Why did the Gao Qi in front of me say things like this? I felt extremely uneasy.

There was nothing but doubt and tons of questions in my mind right now. I could only clarify them one by one.

"Why are you saying that Gaoqin Jiuye was the one I fell in love with, not you? I didn't know him before I arrived here in the Split Zone." I tried to calm myself down, but I could hear my voice trembling.

Gao Qi's eyes suddenly turned gentle. His gentle gaze melted me every time, but this time, when I was met with that gaze again, all I could think of

was... Nie Zun.

I was distracted momentarily.

I looked away quickly, embarrassed to meet his eyes.

Gao Qi answered in that enchanting and mesmerizing voice of his, “He’s the one you love. You’ll know everything if you uncover the secret of the Split Zone...”

“Enough,” I said loudly. I was getting a little emotional now.

Uncover the secret of the Split Zone? I’ll know everything once I uncover the secret of the Split Zone?

But I don’t know what secrets there are in here!

I’ve lost too many people because of this secret. My peaceful life from before had been interrupted. The Western District had been destroyed. And you guys are still trying to get me to chase after some secret?

Some tell me that the time isn’t right, while others tell me that I’ll uncover it someday.

Someday?

What day is someday?

I couldn’t stand this anymore.

“Are you going to tell me? Or not? If you’re not going to tell me about it, then please leave.” I looked at the person in front of me with slightly teary eyes.

Gao Qi’s gaze remained gentle. He did not frown nor did he sound like he blamed me for anything. “I’ve owed you too much, Ah Shen. The only thing I can do for you now is to take you away. I admit that I have my own selfish reasons for doing so, and I’d rather choose to believe that you still

love me, even if it's just a tiny bit. That it isn't Gaoqin Jiuye you love. Come with me, Ah Shen. Return to the real world with me."

Haha. What a great illusion. He could even promise to bring me out of this place.

So leaving the Split Zone was actually such an easy thing to do.

Gao Qi spoke again. "I know you don't believe me. But you can try. I can take you with me as long as you wish for it to be. Try it. You won't be losing anything again..."

You can take me with you as long as I wish for it to be?

What if I don't?

I was surprised by my own thoughts.

But what was it that made me think like that?

Was it because of that particular reason? That I was afraid I'd continue being ostracized in the real world because of my mental disorder?

"Look, Ah Shen, my eyes are no longer like what they were in the past. Have you fallen in love with Gaoqin Jiuye in the time that you hung out with him?" Gao Qi's voice sounded like a steady anchor in all that white fog.

But I suddenly felt lonely.

I missed Nie Zun so much.

No, I can't stay in this illusion forever. I need to wake up soon. I need to get his memories back. I want him to remember me.

I want him to call me Shen'er.

Chapter 219: 219 The Weirdo, Big Gold Rooster

Volume 4

219 The Weirdo, Big Gold Rooster

Once I made my decision, I realized I could look at Gao Qi with clearer eyes.

I said gently, “Sorry. Even if you’re telling the truth, this isn’t my top priority right now. There’re many things I have to do. I need to get somebody’s memories back, I need to find myself, and I need to find my friends who’ve gone missing. There’re too many things I still have to do.”

I was met with Gao Qi’s sorrowful gaze as I finished.

His gaze carried with it a kind of chill, as if it was about to asphyxiate me.

A tear seemed to escape his eyes, but he disappeared right in front of me before I could take a clearer look.

“Gao Qi.” I looked around. Only now did I wonder about my actions. *What was I doing? What was I saying?*

Didn’t I love him before?

Why did I become like this...

A flood of emotions overwhelmed me.

“Hey, how could we get separated even while holding hands?” I heard Nie Zun’s lazy voice from behind.

I saw those starry eyes and that casual smile as I turned around and took him in a sudden embrace.

“Hey, what are you doing?” He wasn’t gentle now, and he wasn’t kind either. He did not understand why I did this at all.

I looked up at him happily. “Nothing. Let’s go. You’ll be back by my side soon.”

Nie Zun raised his brows. “You’re one weird lady. But, where do we go from here?”

Heavy white fog surrounded us.

“We should’ve let Feng come in with us. This fog would probably be dissipated easily with wind.”

Nie Zun waved a hand. “It wouldn’t work since this is an illusion.”

“You can tell?” *Well, he was good at using his pupils. Then why did he take so long to find me?*

“I only realized it moments ago. Let’s continue. The illusion might just go away once we pass this layer.” Nie Zun put his hands back into his pockets and started walking.

I rushed forward, snatching a hand from out of his pocket. “This place is scary. It’s better if I hold your hand.” I looked away after I created this bad excuse for myself.

Nie Zun didn’t seem to mind. He answered sarcastically, “I knew you were a scaredy-cat.”

We finally seemed to have reached the checkpoint after passing through layers and layers of white fog.

Though the path ahead was still covered in fog, I could sense that there was something different in front as I activated my MF.

The white fog suddenly disappeared, and the scene around us changed instantly.

I sighed inwardly as I took in the scene around me.

We were back in that glacial wonderland.

There were glaciers everywhere, and we were stepping on ice. I looked down in defeat as the cold closed in on me.

“Why are we back here?” Nie Zun asked.

I answered gloomily, “Yes. I don’t know why. Why are we back here?” *And, how do we go to that stone room from here?*

It was obvious that we couldn’t go into the river judging from the thickness of the ice below us. There was nothing else but glaciers here, so where do I even start looking for that stone room?

I realized I was too naïve this time.

This is our second time here, so how could it be exactly the same as the first?

The ice in front of us cracked suddenly, and an icicle emerged from the ground.

Somebody was standing on that icicle.

The person was balancing with one leg on the tip of that icicle, as if he was doing yoga.

I decided that this was a crazy person from looking at the position he was in.

Yes, he’s definitely mad.

The person was a sloppy-looking male with a face full of facial hair. He also had extremely long hair. It looked like it was tied in braids all over his head. He had beady eyes like a thief and he was still in that one-legged position, with both his arms raised high above him.

He was mad, no matter how I look at it.

“I hate couples, especially those who look good with each other, like you guys. I’ll carve an ice sculpture out of the both of you today.”

He spoke as he saw me staring at him. His voice sounded crisp and it felt like he was just a boring old man who practiced some weird skill.

“Hey big gold rooster, I don’t believe you can make an ice sculpture out of me,” I challenged. (T/n: The pose where one balances on one leg with raised arms is commonly called *Jin Ji Du Li* in Chinese, and *Jin Ji* literally translates to ‘golden chicken’.)

“Well, well, well, this lady sure talks big. But who’s big gold rooster?” He looked confused, squinting his eyes until they looked like they were about to be squashed together.

He’s definitely a lunatic.

“Big gold rooster refers to you, old man. Why are you standing on an icicle? Can’t you come down and have a proper conversation? It’s weird for me to look at you like that.”

Nie Zun spoke before he could answer. “Is that so? I think it’s interesting. I even thought about having a go at it myself.”

I was rendered momentarily speechless at this.

Big gold rooster looked extremely satisfied with whatever Nie Zun said. He looked at Nie Zun with acknowledgement. “This young man here has good taste, except when choosing a girlfriend. I wouldn’t want this lady even if she’s dog food.”

What, what and what...

What did he just say about me...

I flashed a brilliant smile at him. “Smelly golden rooster, come down and say that again if you dare.”

I thought he would come down from that icicle once I challenged him like this, but I didn’t expect for him to refuse my challenge. “I’m not going down. It’s not fun down there.”

He jumped once and the icicle started moving across the ground, like a shark’s fin that was moving in the water. Before long, he started moving in circles.

“I’ll turn, I’ll turn, I’ll turn, turn and turn.” He started having fun on his own just like this. He was overjoyed at his own little game.

I turned to Nie Zun. “Are you sure you want to be like him? Turn, turn and turn?”

Nie Zun smiled. “That looks pretty interesting. He’s more interesting than you.”

“...”

“I love what that young boy is saying. Come, come on over. Come and turn with me.” Big gold rooster appeared right beside me, scaring me with his invitation.

I snapped alert immediately. Anyone who could creep up on me like this must have a very high MF.

“Let’s go, young man. I’ll take you to have some fun. Let’s not care about this old hag.”

I, I, I, I’m an old hag?

I was about to blow my top. That big gold rooster stretched out a hand towards Nie Zun, who smiled as he raised a hand, as if he was about accept the invitation.

At that very moment, the hand of that big gold rooster turned into an icicle. I also noticed several transparent spikes on that icicle he was standing on.

It was too late to stop Nie Zun, but he didn't take that hand either.

Nie Zun had quick reflexes and he had realized something was wrong. His hand stopped just two centimeters away from the other hand.

Big gold rooster could have stabbed him at such a distance, but he didn't.

Nie Zun did not avoid the hand. With his reflexes, his hand was already enshrouded in thick, black mist.

I laughed. "So it's somebody who likes to joke around and attack suddenly."

Big gold rooster stared at me. "Says who. I just wanted to let him witness my skills."

"Fine, you'll always have an explanation. I want to know who you are and why you're here now."

Big gold rooster retracted his hand and continued staring at me. "I'm the ice spirit in this glacier."

"Pch." I didn't believe him at all.

Ice spirit? The spirit of this glacier? Or just a random soul in the glacier?

He didn't look like any of those.

He stared at me angrily upon seeing my look of disbelief. "You're really annoying, lady. I'm definitely turning you into an ice sculpture." However, he didn't have any follow-up actions after that.

I found him rather interesting at this point. I leaned in closer and asked, "Are you really the ice spirit of this glacier? Then can you tell me why the first time I came here, there was a river instead of this ice? Do you know why?"

Big gold rooster finally jumped off his icicle. He touched his beard as he answered, “You’re referring to a glacier, that’s for sure, but it isn’t this one. This glacier is huge, and everyone who enters the demon cave will reach a glacier. Why are you looking for that particular place? At least you can still stand here.”

Should I tell him that I’m looking for that stone room? Can I trust him?

As I hesitated, big gold rooster asked, “Don’t tell me you’re looking for that demon palace under that icy river.”

Demon palace. That seemed to refer to that stone room.

I smiled at him. “Why? I can’t go there?”

He leapt up suddenly, jumping around all over the place as he flailed his arms about. “Mad, mad, mad, mad. Others are running away while you’re actually heading for that godforsaken place? You’re really mad, mad, mad.”

I think you’re the one who’s mad...

I answered patiently, “I have to go there for something important. Are you able to lead the way to that icy river?”

Chapter 220: 220 Looking for the Icy River

Volume 4

220 Looking for the Icy River

Big gold rooster looked at me with slight disdain. “Why should I be doing that, you annoying girl? Do you want to become my ice sculpture?”

I rolled my eyes. “Fine. As long as you can take me there, I’ll agree to whatever you say once I exit the place.”

“Woah, woah, woah.” The big gold rooster pointed a condemning finger at me. “You’re a sly one. There’s no one who can exit that demon palace once they enter. I’ll definitely be on the losing end of this deal.”

I raised a brow. “Oh, is that so? But I’ve entered just a few days ago, and I’ve successfully left it too.”

“Crazy, crazy, crazy. You’re really mad.” Big gold rooster shook his head vigorously.

“Are you guys done chatting? I’m falling asleep here.” Nie Zun yawned lazily.

After this, he lay down on the icy ground and closed his eyes, using his hand as a pillow.

Big gold rooster stared at Nie Zun.

Looking at big gold rooster, I waved a hand in front of his face. “Have you fallen in love with him?” I asked.

Though big gold rooster shook his head, he didn’t give a definite answer to my question.

“He looks rather familiar...” Big gold rooster scratched his head as he continued observing Nie Zun, as if he was recalling something from the past.

I narrowed my eyes and grabbed his arms. “Have you seen him before, when he first arrived here? Try to recall what happened. Do you know what happened to him then?”

Big gold rooster’s eyes shone as he saw me grab his arm.

In the next second, both my arms were frozen.

Crack, crack, crack.

What seemed like pieces of broken ice spread all over my arms, as if it was going to encase me entirely. Even so, I did not avoid it.

And as expected, the ice stopped spreading further after both my arms had been frozen.

“You’re pretty gutsy for a lady.”

I smirked. “Stop being such a nag. Tell me, have you seen him?” I pointed my chin at Nie Zun, who looked like he was enjoying his sleep.

Big gold rooster said, “You should worry about yourself first. This freezing technique will slowly absorb your MF.” I didn’t mind it at first, but once he said that, I got reminded of how Huan Qing was stripped of his MF and life force in that glacier.

Did that happen because he was trapped in the glacier, or was it because of this ice and snow here?

I tried moving my arms but I was trapped. I couldn't move them at all.

I looked at big gold rooster as I said, "I guess I shouldn't be hasty since it's such a powerful technique. May I ask how I should go about undoing it?"

He laughed loudly. His smiling expression was completely different from that look he had on his face when he was encasing my arms in ice. "This ice sealing technique uses telepathy, and the MF comes from that. If you want to melt this ice, you'll have to find the man who loves you to do so."

What?

"How do I get him to help me?"

Big gold rooster pondered for a moment before he said, "I guess it can be done with a hug."

My face twitched in annoyance. *Why am I wasting time with this guy right here?*

Right, talking about time...

I said urgently, "I don't care what you're planning to do with me. Please just tell me the way to that icy river. I have to go to that demon palace. This young man whom you like here, he'll die if he doesn't go there." I exaggerated on purpose this time.

Big gold rooster looked a little shaken by this. He's probably someone who's easily convinced.

"Fine, I'll tell you then. But you'll really be my ice sculpture once you come out of there, right?" Big gold rooster asked with a face full of innocent naivety.

I smiled, nodding profusely. "Definitely. You're free to order me around." *Yeah right, let's see if you're even able to locate me after that.*

"Then I'll bring you guys there. But I can only bring you somewhere close by, since I'm not able to go near that icy river."

“Release my arms first.” I signaled to my frozen arms.

Big gold rooster regarded me with a look of disdain. “I’m helping you because of this young man, you annoying girl.”

“Okay, okay, okay, big gold... Oh no, big brother. You’re the best. Come on, release me.” I smiled at him while I stole a glance at that sleeping individual on the ground. *Helping me because of this young man? That young man is sleeping like a pig here...*

After my arms were released, I walked over and kicked Nie Zun. “Hey, get up. We have to go.”

There was no response.

“Hey, get up. Stop playing dead.”

I still did not get a response.

Fine.

I bent down and reached for his waist, looking for Piercer.

As expected, he opened his eyes at the very moment I touched him. “You’re molesting me.” *Why are there so many retards around me today?*

I kicked him again. “Do I even have the time to molest you? Get up quickly. We have to go.”

“Where to?” Nie Zun yawned.

I rolled my eyes at him as I wondered to myself, *where should I say we’re going? Would he come with me if I say we were heading for the demon palace? I guess not, since he came out from there originally, and he finds it boring.* Thus, I said, “We’re going to look for the exit.”

Nie Zun finally got up at this, though he still looked as lazy as ever.

Big gold rooster suddenly spoke. “The exit? Then you can’t go to that icy ricer. It’s really far from the exit.”

It’s to lure Nie Zun there, okay? I stared at big gold rooster, signaling for him to shut up.

He kept quiet as he saw my expression.

Nie Zun didn’t seem to mind what big gold rooster said as he stood up lazily, saying, “Let’s go.”

Big gold rooster seemed to really like Nie Zun, and he hopped after Nie Zun upon seeing him get up.

He hopped back onto that icicle and went back to that one-legged position. He seemed to wobble quite a bit, but he managed to stay on top.

“Oh, right.” Big gold rooster glanced at me. “Did you meet white swallows on your way here?”

“Huh, what are white swallows?” I asked in confusion.

Big gold rooster scratched his head. “They’re faceless monsters who only have one mouth and who like to crawl on the floor.”

He was referring to those things which followed us all the way before we reached the fog.

I nodded. “Yes, we’ve seen those things. Why is that?”

Big gold rooster glanced at me. “What a dumb girl. You don’t even know that your MF had been absorbed.”

“What. What are you talking about?”

Big gold rooster performed a pirouette. “Those monsters are known for sucking up MF in the Split Zone. The best way to counter it is not to talk to them. How many times have you spoken to them?”

I spoke once to the first one, and I spoke twice to the second one. “About three times.”

“Then you’re finished. They’d have absorbed a lot of your MF,” big gold rooster said.

Absorbed my MF?

But I didn’t feel my MF being drained even when I tried activating it, and it didn’t feel any different even when I touched my split symbol.

This isn’t important right now. I looked at big gold rooster. “Leave it, it’s not important right now. You’d better bring me and your new friend to that place.”

Big gold rooster clapped his hands.

Pch, pch.

Two icicles rose up from the ground.

“Step on these and come with me.” Big gold rooster seemed to float away as he said that.

Can we really step on them?

Well, let’s just do it if big gold rooster tells us to...

Nie Zun looked rather excited at this...

I realized it wasn’t difficult to balance myself with MF when I stepped on the icicle. It turned out to be pretty fun.

Big gold rooster might have noticed the smile that appeared on my face as he asked, “How is it? It’s fun, isn’t it? Little girl, you’ve been here for too long and you’ve forgotten how to have some fun. You were pulling a long face, looking just like a bittergourd.”

Nothing good comes out of that mouth of his.

Following his example of using MF to drive the icicle, we reached another glacier very quickly.

“I’ll open the door for you.” Big gold rooster jumped off his icicle suddenly.

I was suspicious of this. *Open the door? What door?*

I realized that there might be a door on the glacier as big gold rooster jumped off and walked over to the foot of the glacier.

I guess anything is possible within the demon cave. The glacier in front of us was just like the one we saw previously. It looked white and translucent, and we couldn’t really see what was inside it.

My perspective on glaciers has changed totally. In fact, my perspective towards many other things have changed ever since I’ve arrived in the Split Zone. Nothing was impossible here in the Split Zone.

Big gold rooster bent down in front of the glacier, placing his palms against the ground as he seemed to chant a series of unintelligible words.

The ground then shook below us.

I immediately felt something amiss, probably because I’ve been fighting too much lately.

But my intuition proved right when the ice below us collapsed suddenly.

I tried to grab hold of Nie Zun, but there was no way to stop ourselves from falling.

Both of us started falling through the broken ice.

Chapter 221: 221 The Fear of Loneliness

Volume 4

221 The Fear of Loneliness

Why did I keep falling? I seem to be tricked all the time and falling everywhere during battles.

But also because of this, I had a lot of experience in falling.

This time, I controlled my MF well as I fell. Nie Zun and I were able to achieve some sort of balance. Though he had lost his memories, there was still some muscle memory in him, since we did spend every single day and night together.

To prevent crashing into the ground too badly, we tried to keep ourselves from touching the ground.

As we stabilized ourselves, I realized it was that icy river right below us... The sky was above us, and around us... Nothing but glaciers surrounded us.

We returned to those glaciers just like this.

I thought big gold rooster would do something to that glacier as he ‘opened the door’. Little did I imagine he meant to drop us right here...

Big gold rooster was nowhere to be seen.

“Where did he go?” Nie Zun looked around.

“I don’t know. Anyway, let’s jump down. It’ll be the demon palace once we pass through the river.” I pointed at the icy river. There was a layer of ice on the river, but we might be able to break that.

Nie Zun frowned. “Why do you insist on going back there?”

I glanced at him. “Look around you. Would there be another way out if we don’t go back there?”

Nie Zun narrowed his eyes at me, as if he doubted my words. I smiled at him and took his hand in mine as I jumped down.

Both of us dropped into the river.

“Damn, it’s still this cold here.” I swam towards Nie Zun, hungry for some warmth.

Nie Zun stretched out a hand to stop me. “Are you going to molest me again?”

I smirked. “Not only do I want to do that, I want you to die with me.”

I pulled him into the water after that.

My red hair spread out in the water, but the cold did not make me suffer like before when I could see Nie Zun’s bright eyes in the icy river.

I focused my MF on improving my blood circulation as I pulled him deeper into the water.

However, I slowly realized that it wasn’t as simple as I thought it would be.

There was no light to be seen even when we’ve been swimming for quite some time now. It was getting darker and darker, and I felt like I was about to suffocate.

I looked at Nie Zun. He looked like a fish in the water as his hair floated around his face. I couldn’t spare any more MF to take a clearer look at him, and my vision was blurring slowly.

This feeling of suffocation brought with it a kind of fear.

It's a reflex that we hold our breath when we enter water. Even though we can't hold our breaths forever, bodies of consciousness in the Split Zone wouldn't die like this. But the process was still a painful one.

Just imagine choking with water. It wouldn't feel great.

Even if one manipulates MF well and obtains the skill of swimming like a fish in the water, the process of doing that would not be easy either.

Just as I was about to suffocate, the water around me disappeared.

I shut my eyes as a bright light flashed in front of me. I was back in that stone room as I opened them.

I looked around. Nie Zun was gone.

"What's happening..." I muttered to myself. It was that stone room for sure, but there was nobody else here.

"Nie Zun." I tried calling out.

There was no response.

I made my way to that room within.

Nie Zun was already standing there when I finally reached the stone platform.

"Hey, you..." I tapped him on the shoulder carefully. This place was full of surprises. I just might see another one of those creatures when he turned around.

Luckily, it was him this time.

"What's happening?"

Nie Zun turned to me before turning back to look at the tablet. “I think I might have forgotten about some of the things that have happened during my time here.”

I smirked. “You’ve forgotten more than that.”

Nie Zun looked at me earnestly for the first time since he had exited the cave. “I really knew you from before?”

I frowned. “You’re definitely careful, but I didn’t know you were this cautious. You definitely knew me from before. We were together every day for more than two years.”

A light flashed past Nie Zun’s eyes. “Together every day?”

I blushed. “It’s not like what you think. It’s because...”

If I told him that it was because we couldn’t be more than 500 meters apart, he’ll probably not believe it either.

Nobody told me the reason behind it, of why we had to stay so close to each other.

And nobody told me why we can stay apart now.

I used to hate that 500-meter restriction. I had to bring him along for everything, and I could see him everywhere.

I was annoyed, frustrated, and I even hated him for it. But now, I wished so hard for that to happen again.

Because of that, I had no need to fear that he might just disappear suddenly.

He’s always being taken away so easily by others now.

I really missed him.

There was nothing more to say to him now if he didn’t trust my words nor remember who I was anyway.

I answered, “You won’t believe it even if I told you. Think of it however you want to.”

Nie Zun laughed. I was a little taken aback at this.

It always looked like he remembered who I was when he laughed like this.

“Since you said you knew me from before, how about you help me get my memories back? I kind of want to know what happened now...” Nie Zun’s eyes brushed past that stone tablet as he smiled.

I followed his gaze. It was that exact stone tablet with a human-shaped depression in it on the very same stone platform.

“You might have to pay a price if you want to recall your past.”

Nie Zun raised a brow. “Oh? What price?”

...How should I say this.

You’ll have to get in bed with me...

No...

You’ll have to sleep with me...

There was no way I could say this.

I scratched my head as I said awkwardly, “Let me take a look at this stone tablet first.”

“You’re referring to this?” Nie Zun pointed at the tablet.

“Yes. Didn’t you come out from there? How long do you think you’ve been there?”

Nie Zun’s eyes seemed to lose its focus for a moment. “It seemed to be a very, very long time. All I felt was loneliness. When you woke me up, it felt

like I could finally be free of this solitude. All I knew was that I never wanted to come back here ever again.”

My heart hurt for him.

Why did I have a nagging feeling that the solitude wasn't brought on by this stone tablet? He had lost his memories because his blood was taken, and whatever was left in his subconscious mind was nothing but solitude and loneliness.

The cause of his solitude was because he had always been lonely before, and the Nie Zun in my mind was exactly like that.

He was always dressed in black from head to toe, and even his hair and eyes were a jet black.

He was always behind me, like a tall shadow.

He gave others the impression that he didn't have a care in the world, and he could also be sarcastic sometimes, but only sometimes. Most of the time, there was a hint of solitude in his eyes.

Even so, instead of distancing me from him, I felt like I had found someone similar to me. It was like something I wanted to approach, but something that I was afraid of at the same time.

Nie Zun had always given me the impression that he was lonely, but it wasn't a loneliness that begged for sympathy.

I realized I was wrong now, and that I might have been wrong from the start.

Nie Zun did not need the sympathy of others, but he definitely needed somebody else's company.

I felt myself tear up as I looked up at those slightly confused eyes of his.

Something between us made it so that I would always know how he felt. It wasn't something as simple as merely understanding him, or knowing him.

It was a total empathy for him.

He had always been lonely, and I had always thought he was used to it, that he didn't need any consolation.

But now that he had lost his memories, everything he said came from deep within his heart. He was revealing how he felt in the past two years, or even in all his years of life.

That he was also afraid of being lonely. That he needed the company of others as well.

Why couldn't I see that? Or should I say, why did I keep forgetting that? Why did I keep thinking that he could never be beaten?

I had been making use of him to protect me all this while, and I haven't really given him any consolation. All I did was stay beside him in the past. I didn't try, nor even think about lessening that loneliness he felt.

I was selfish.

That loneliness he felt now and his avoidance towards it wasn't caused by that stone tablet. He felt that way because he had always been like this, except that he had always been suppressing that fear towards solitude.

Just like me.

Chapter 222: 222 The Taking

Volume 4

222 The Taking

Should I help him regain his memories? Though he was a little weird, he could really be himself and be free like this. He was so much happier without those memories about his hands being cursed.

I could see that happiness seep out from within him. It was such freedom when whatever he had been suppressing in the past was no longer being suppressed.

Did I really have the right to decide if he should get his memories back?

“You... Actually, if you don’t want to recall whatever you’ve forgotten, I...” I hesitated.

Nie Zun smiled. “If you can really help me do so, let’s just try it. It’s kind of boring now anyway, when I can’t remember a thing.”

Boring... You’re really happy right now though...

I suddenly felt that I would be responsible for his happiness if he recalled the past.

I had to be responsible for whether he was happy or upset about it, for his solitude.

“What would you do if recalling the past only gives you pain? That suffering might be even worse than the loneliness you’ve felt on that stone

tablet. It would be a solitude that comes from deep within your heart. Are you afraid of that?”

Nie Zun looked at that tablet for a long while before he spoke. “I really didn’t want to return here at first, and I haven’t really wondered about what happened in the past either. But now that I’m standing here again, I suddenly feel as if I should try to remember what happened in the past, even if I don’t want to. There seems to be something extremely important to me in those lost memories.

“I want to find out exactly what it is.” He smiled as he turned to me.

We looked at each other for about a minute. After that, I took a deep breath and walked over to the tablet.

Going to the back, I saw the character for ‘demon’. It was a bright red, and it had this mysterious, blood-thirsty aura. I then walked around the platform looking for that hourglass.

In it, only a little bit of sand was left in the top-half. Quickly, I calculated how much time we still had left, looking at my watch to double check.

If I couldn’t get his blood back within three hours, he’d never be able to get it back.

As I was about to walk back to where Nie Zun was, I heard a voice in my brain just as I happened to glance at the word ‘demon’ on the tablet.

“Though there is great power with this demonic energy, its side effects are extreme. He should have died that time, but I found the old man’s protection on him. I guess he’s trying to go against me now, but in any case, it’ll be a bane to Nie Zun if that demonic energy stays with him. Instead of a human, he’ll be a demon as long as he doesn’t learn how to control that power. He doesn’t remember you because his blood had been changed. Now that he’s reborn, he’ll slowly merge with that demonic energy. You’ll be doing him a disfavor if you want to get his blood and his memories back.”

For some reason, Huai Du's words echoed in my mind, as if it was suddenly activated.

According to Huai Du, this tablet had not only changed his blood, it had also activated Nie Zun's demonic powers so that he'd be able to merge with it. He might end up being in danger if I forcefully change his blood.

But, Li Qing didn't mention this.

No, Li Qing will never lie to me. This was what my instincts told me. *But...*

I used to think this way, and she still lied to me in the end.

Would she take a chance on Nie Zun? I don't think so though. Nothing's in it for her even if she did so.

Even so, I didn't know what to do. *Li Qing did not tell me how to execute this...*

"What are you standing here for? Didn't you say you'll help me get my memories?" Nie Zun appeared beside me.

I looked at him awkwardly. "I don't actually know how to do it. I just know that you'll be able to recall the past when your blood and the blood in that 'demon' character is exchanged."

Nie Zun looked at the character and suddenly jumped onto the stone platform.

I was a little taken aback. *Didn't the platform have a protective screen? Was this because Nie Zun wasn't there now?*

I leapt up onto the platform.

Nie Zun touched that 'demon' character with those pale and slender fingers of his. It was such a contrast to the bright red.

I felt fear overwhelm me suddenly. I walked up to him quickly, trying to stop him from doing anything else.

But when I reached him, his eyes seemed to have darkened.

Something didn't feel right. "What's wrong?"

Nie Zun stared at that 'demon' character. "I seem to have remembered something."

I asked in joyous surprise, "Really? What is it?"

Nie Zun's gaze turned darker and darker as bleak coldness seemed to emanate from his eyes. "I shouldn't touch this. Forget about my memories."

What. Why the sudden change of heart now? I glanced at the hourglass in the corner. Not much time was left.

I grabbed his arm. "No, you can't give up. Since we're already here, I have to help you get your memories back."

Nie Zun lips turned up at a condescending angle. "Do you think you can force me into doing anything I don't wish to?"

I started getting anxious at this.

If he really recalled something he didn't want to remember after looking at that 'demon' character, then I probably couldn't change his mind on this. His abilities were extraordinary now, and he could even fight evenly against Li Qing, Feng, Huo and Lei. How would I be able to force him into doing anything?

He looked like he was about to turn and leave at any moment.

I was at a loss of what to do for a split second.

In my discomposure, I grabbed his other hand and tip-toed towards him.

A flood of emotions overwhelmed me again as I touched those ice-cold lips of his.

This was the first time I realized that I had missed him so badly.

He looked slightly surprised when my lips touched his, but he did not avoid it. I looked at him as I thought about what I should do next.

Taking his neck, I kissed him harder on the lips.

I saw a fire light up in those starry eyes of his. Something changed in that very moment.

Nie Zun grabbed me in an embrace and returned my kiss with fiery passion. Something seemed to explode in my brain, and I wasn't able to remain rational about it.

He entrapped me with those fiery eyes of his, before pushing me back against the stone tablet. Instead of cold stone, I felt a sudden warmth as my back came into contact with the tablet.

As I tried to catch my breath in a tiny break, Nie Zun's lips crashed into mine again. The warmth from behind and the heat on my lips created a deep crevice that I could not get out of.

Nie Zun's eyes looked maddened and bloodthirsty. My head was spinning and my mind was a total blank.

This is what Li Qing described as his deepest wish after he had lost his memories.

He trapped me against the stone tablet and I could feel the engraved character for 'demon' against my back.

Rip...

The ripping of the fabric behind my back pulled me back to reality. The tablet had affected Nie Zun's mind. He couldn't see me clearly now, and that calmness in him was gone. All that was left was a bloodthirsty madness.

I was suddenly fearful.

Even though I've been fighting in the Split Zone for so long, as a woman, I was still fearful.

I wanted to break free, but I realized that the 'demon' character was a force of its own as it seemed to trap me against that tablet.

I felt something painful on my lips as Nie Zun bit it.

As I looked at him with tearful eyes, he forced my lips open with his tongue, and I felt a softness enter my mouth with the flavor of blood.

At the same time, I felt an eerie cold in the air. My heart felt like it was being continually squeezed by something, and my vision started to blur.

Everything happened so quickly. I saw a tear roll down Nie Zun's cheek.

I was almost immune to pain now, but this pain made my lips quiver. I smiled at those sorrowful eyes of his, and returned his kiss with welcoming lips.

Chapter 223: 223 You're Not Nie Zun

Volume 4

223 You're Not Nie Zun

The pain receded as I slowly accepted it, and I felt his tears fall on my cheeks. I hugged him as we sunk to the floor, taking him in a tight embrace as we both lay on the stone platform.

His lips finally left mine after I opened my eyes to look at his tear-filled ones.

He looked at me as he said, “Shen’er...”

I was stunned. *He, he, he, did he remember?*

But I didn’t do a thing...

I kept my eyes on him. His gaze was cloudy.

Looks like he didn’t recall anything, but this looked to be what Li Qing described as when he is at his most vulnerable, when the both of us were at our most vulnerable.

But... Li Qing didn’t tell me what to do now, and my second personality did not appear either, so what should I...

Just as my thoughts were all over the place, I heard a soft voice beside me. “Shen’er...”

I looked behind Nie Zun.

She... actually appeared.

She was floating above him now, her red hair brushing past my neck with a prickly kind of cold.

She spoke in an airy voice, “Do you need me, to give you power...”

I bit my lips, wanting to scream for her to leave. But I knew I couldn’t do that since I needed her power.

I needed her help to get Nie Zun’s blood back.

I pushed Nie Zun away from me. He crashed into that stone tablet even though I didn’t use much strength.

A pair of cold hands embraced me as I turned to look at the stone tablet. As she came closer, I felt her cold touch all over my body, and new fabric reappeared where it was originally torn.

Shortly, my red dress was as good as new.

She spoke clearly into my ear, “Come on, accept me. I’m the only one who can help you. Let me tell you everything Li Qing didn’t...”

I refused to look back at that face that was identical to mine.

Nie Zun sank to the floor after being pushed against the stone tablet.

I felt unease creep up on me.

I crawled towards him on all fours, tidying his clothes as I reached him. Taking his face in my hands, I realized his eyes were shut.

“What’s wrong with him...” I muttered.

A breeze blew past me. “He... It might be too late if you don’t save him soon...”

Swoosh.

The tablet produced a bright light that was as beautiful as an aurora. The blood-red of that 'demon' character suddenly came alive. The blood was flowing in it like it was in a blood vessel.

I grabbed her cold body. "Tell me what to do. What should I do to save him?"

Her eyes were so identical to mine, but there seemed to be nothing in them. It was empty. There was nobody there, and there were no emotions present.

She spoke softly, "He's already taken in the demonic energy, and he might die if you forcefully change his blood. But if you don't, he might never remember you ever, and if that demonic energy ends up devouring him, he'll end up being the scariest thing in existence here in the Split Zone."

The scariest thing in existence.

How could that be possible.

How could I allow him to turn into what people see as the most terrifying monster again?

I can't let that happen.

"What should I do?" I looked at her, waiting for a response.

She smiled. "You've forgotten me, and you've forgotten so many important things from the past. Do you have the right to help him regain his memories if you can't even remember these things?"

My heart sank. I took one step closer to her as I grabbed her arm tightly. "You're not helping me?"

She leaned in closer. "Li Shen, do you really need my help? Is it me who looks down on you, or is it you who looks down upon yourself? Think about it, why did he come to the Split Zone? Think about it carefully, what have you forgotten?"

My brows furrowed. *Why did he come to the Split Zone?*

Didn't he end up here because he couldn't accept the fact that he thought he had caused his sister's death?

Yes, soul splitters.

My eyes widened as I wondered who Nie Zun's soul splitter was...

This had never crossed my mind...

And also... Nie Zun's split symbol...

I let go of her arm and went to Nie Zun, reaching for the back of his neck.

If I remember right, nobody else in the Split Zone but Mr Blond and I were aware of the location of his split symbol. Not even Li Qing.

When I pulled that high collar down to reveal a shining splitting key, it was inserted into a split symbol the shape of a crescent moon. My hand went towards it slowly.

A weird feeling overcame me as I reached it.

“Are you sure you want to do this?”

I wasn't sure if this question came from the voice behind me or from deep within my heart.

Just as I pulled his splitting key out, all the blood in the tablet started moving, as if I had just pulled a sort of lever to activate it.

The blood was a bright red.

Nie Zun stood up suddenly, opening his eyes slowly. His eyes were a blood red.

He looked at me with emotionless eyes, glancing at the splitting key in my hand. His eyes narrowed.

I felt a prickly cold before I saw my right hand fall onto the stone platform. Nie Zun then reached out for the splitting key which levitated in the air before him.

I began to fall backwards towards the stone platform. As I looked up, I saw the blood on the tablet snake into Nie Zun's split symbol.

Nie Zun looked at me with emotionless eyes as he held the splitting key in hand.

My lips turned into a smile. I've finally succeeded. He might still be cold now but he'll remember me soon.

It doesn't matter even if I died, as long as he could remember me, as long as he still remembered me.

I heard a sigh behind me. Cold and gentle arms took me in an embrace, slowing my fall.

"You... just refuse to accept me... You refuse to accept me... and you refuse to really be free... How could this power be enough..."

Her crisp voice echoed in my ears as her gentle arms placed me gently on the ground below the stone platform.

I smiled bitterly. "Help me get my arm back. It'll heal very slowly like this."

I was lying on the ground and I could see Nie Zun standing in front of the tablet while she squatted by my side. She stretched out a hand.

With a quick movement of that white and slender hand, my broken hand flew towards her. She caught it and reattached it on me.

I felt the pain of flesh and bone combining on my wrist. "This is worth it. At least I've saved him." I muttered as I looked at my right wrist.

"Hehe..." She laughed softly.

I frowned. “Why are you laughing like this?” Instead of replying, she simply looked at Nie Zun with an icy gaze.

I followed her gaze and realized that the blood in the tablet was almost gone. His eyes were now a demonic red.

A funny feeling overcame me.

I struggled to get up.

When the last drop of blood entered his split symbol, Nie Zun reinserted his splitting key back into the split symbol.

For some reason, I had a feeling that his MF wouldn’t be gone for a month even though I’ve taken it out of his split symbol.

He was unique, just like I was.

I looked at him with anticipation, totally forgetting about the girl beside me.

When Nie Zun looked at me again, his eyes were a pure black. His indifferent gaze had finally returned, and his hands were, as usual, placed within his pockets.

At that moment, he was standing on the stone platform looking like someone who had great might as I looked up at him from the ground.

He looked down upon me as I called out to him softly, “Nie Zun...”

His lips turned up slightly. “Thank you for helping me regain my memories. It’s really quite a headache to have forgotten so many things...”

His gaze was unfocused, as if he was organizing those memories. But why did I feel that something was different? *What was it...*

Her voice sounded in my ear again, “Hehe... Though he remembers you now... He seems to be...”

I shouted, “Enough!”

At this, she disappeared in a flash of light right before me.

My emotions were running amok now, and I felt like I was being ripped apart.

Nie Zun's lips were still upturned. With a light tap of his feet, he landed on the ground below the stone platform and walked towards me. "How long do you plan on sitting there?"

My brows furrowed at this.

There's definitely something wrong here... Just what is wrong here... He was approaching me quickly.

As he reached me, he stretched out an arm. His pale and slender hand had no palm prints on it. "Come on, get up."

I stayed still and stared at him squarely in the eye. He looked at me with those starry eyes of his. "What? Did I tire you out? You were so full of passion. I don't think it's your first time, right? To the point that you can't even get up?"

My heart felt like it was being thrown into an icy lake.

This isn't Nie Zun.

"You, who are you?" My throat felt dry as I asked this question.

There was an evil aura entwined in those indifferent eyes of his. "Of course I'm Nie Zun. Why? Are you afraid that I'm not able to remember you, Li Shen?"

I stood up then.

"You're not Nie Zun, definitely not," I enunciated every word clearly as I stared at him.

Chapter 224: 224 I Can't Do Without You

Volume 4

224 I Can't Do Without You

Nie Zun narrowed his eyes. "Li Shen, it's been two years and you're still the same. Do you still remember what I said to you when you first arrived?"

I shivered.

He continued. "I said that to you when we were both sent to the Western District by Mr Blond. I said that we'll have to be together forever from then onwards." I looked at him, not moving a muscle.

I didn't know what to do.

He was definitely Nie Zun, or at least, his memories were complete. Because he was the only one who had said something like that to me, and I've remembered it since then.

But why did he look so cold and distant?

Though he was indifferent to many things in the past and acted like he didn't have a care in the world, he was filled with passion when it came to me. He had never treated me like this in the past.

His eyes were never that cold either.

"You..." I didn't know what to say.

His smile faded, replaced by that indifference he always had. Except this time, there was a coldness in that indifference.

“Do you believe I’m Nie Zun now?” He asked as he looked at me.

I maintained eye contact with him. “You’ve changed. Why is that?”

I noticed that skull ring he wore on his finger as he scratched his nose with his left hand. “Nothing really. Apart from returning me my memories, the tablet had also given me some truths. I now know what a selfish person you are, Li Shen. In the future, you can go on your own path. Let’s not have anything to do with each other in future.”

My eyes widened at this.

Was this really Nie Zun? The one who said he’ll always protect me and stay by my side? The Nie Zun who’ll be with me forever? He’s saying I’m selfish and that he wants to leave me?

I said softly, “You’re still leaving me even when you’ve recalled everything that happened? Including me?”

Nie Zun’s eyes flashed. “That’s right, because I’ve recalled the past. I suddenly find it too tiring to be together with you. You go save your friends and I’ll continue living my lazy life. I don’t think you’d stick to me forever just because of one night, would you?”

I laughed in self-mockery. “What did you say...”

As I steeled myself for harsher words, I heard a loud splash from behind Nie Zun.

Looking towards the source of the noise, Gaoqin Jiuye emerged dripping wet from one of the water vats.

I was stunned. *Why is he here?*

The water didn’t seem to be boiling this time. Beads of water sprayed everywhere as he shook his head.

Nie Zun did not even bother to look.

I frowned at the fast approaching Gaoqin Jiuye. “What are you doing here?”

Gaoqin Jiuye looked worried, and a little angry. “You have the gall to ask what I’m doing here? What happened to you?”

He brushed past Nie Zun as he spoke. He pulled me up and looked me up and down.

I was confused at this. *How did he know what happened here? Didn't we separate at the hotel?*

Nie Zun smirked. “Seems like your lover from when you were alive is the one you really love. He can even sense that I’ve taken your virginity and came all the way here for you.”

My heart hurt at what he said. Why did he have to hurt me like this?

Gaoqin Jiuye froze as he looked at me with disbelief. “What did he say... You...”

I was heartbroken. It had never felt so broken before.

I was faced with Nie Zun’s chilly gaze and Gaoqin Jiuye’s look of surprise.

I closed my eyes. I felt my arms turn numb in Gaoqin Jiuye’s grip, and that numbness spread to my entire body, going into my nerves and into all my organs.

I felt like I was being suffocated, as if my heart was being squeezed hard by a giant hand.

“Just why are you here?” I spoke after a while.

Gaoqin Jiuye seemed to be trembling. “Is he telling the truth?”

I met Nie Zun’s wintry gaze, but I asked Gaoqin Jiuye again, “Why are you here?”

I could hear the tremble in Gaoqin Jiuye's voice now. "Is he telling the truth?"

I remained silent this time.

He couldn't take it anymore as he grabbed me by the shoulders. "I'm asking you if he's telling the truth... Did you and him really... in here... Is it true? I'm asking you a question."

My head was dizzy as he shook me hard by the shoulders. I saw my own reflection in his eyes. I looked extremely pale, as if some vampire had sucked all the blood out of me.

Nie Zun laughed suddenly. It wasn't a mocking smile nor was it a smirk. Instead, it sounded bitter and sorrowful. "Do you hate me? For saying all this to the one you love the most, huh, Li Shen?"

Finally, I could stand it no more. A beast was about to be unleashed from inside of me.

I pushed Gaoqin Jiuye away as I stared at Nie Zun. "You're the one I love the most. I've fallen in love with you ever since arriving here in the Split Zone. That's right, I've never dared to admit it, I've never wanted to admit that I've fallen in love with you, that I've fallen in love with a devil like you. Not only did I let Gao Qi down, I killed him and I even betrayed him like this."

My hands were trembling and my eyes were wet with tears.

"Nie Zun, I've always wanted to get away from you in the past, I've always wanted to leave... I've always thought that I hated you, that I hated you like I hated her... But I slowly began to realize that it wasn't the case... Slowly, I began to steal glances at those lazy eyes of yours, that indifferent demeanor you had, those wispy bangs that covered a little of your eyes. I looked at how you were always alone at night, I looked at how you were always behind me with those black gloves of yours, I looked at how quiet you were when you leaned against the wall in silence... There were traces of you everywhere in my life, you were everywhere..."

I couldn't stop my tears now. I've never felt like this in the past two years. I've never felt so heartbroken like this.

The cold in Nie Zun's eyes seemed to have crystallized into something undecipherable.

I heard my own voice echoing in this space. "Slowly... I realized I liked you... But how could I? I can't... Shouldn't I be liking Gao Qi, shouldn't I like him forever, love him forever, and pay for my crimes here after killing him? Why did I end up liking you? Why did I have a change of heart? What right did I have to like you?"

I screamed as I forgot about Gaoqin Jiuye who was still beside me. I didn't realize that he too seemed to be trembling with emotion.

My eyes were fixed on Nie Zun, who was now staring at me, unmoving.

My hands were still trembling, and the tears did not stop. "But it's a fact that I like you... You said you'll protect me forever... You said you'll forever be by my side... You promised..."

I sank to the ground slowly, hugging my knees, as if all my energy had been taken away. Not wanting to look at his cold and emotionless face, I buried my face between my knees, looking at the cold, stone ground.

I muttered, "You said you'll be together with me forever... How could you tell me that you want to leave me just when I've finally found the courage to tell you I love you... Nie Zun... Don't you want me anymore..."

I never thought I'd ever end up being this pathetic, but this was too much for me to take.

My heart felt empty ever since he had been taken away by Ta Lai. I looked perfectly fine on the surface, but I'd never be able to continue living if that emptiness wasn't filled up.

That empty hole in my heart seemed to welcome a cold wind that cut me continuously on the inside. I knew there was no way I could survive if I

didn't fill this hole, and I thought that I could fill up that hole as long as I found him.

But it was only until I found him that I realized I couldn't fill the hole. Instead, a greater fear seemed to have found its way into that hole, and it brought me nothing but greater anxiety.

This is why I've been grabbing hold of his hand whenever I could, afraid that he would leave me while I wasn't looking.

When he appeared before me without his memories, I thought my heart was already dead.

I realized I was finished when my very first reaction was not one of rejection at the moment I heard Li Qing tell me about the price we had to pay to get his memories back.

I've fallen in love with Nie Zun.

Not only have I fallen in love with him, I've somehow engraved him deep into my heart.

He has conquered my heart and filled my entire brain.

I was willing to lose everything because of him.

But when what's happened has happened and what's been said has been said, he decides to reject me.

He decides to leave me now.

To me, this felt like the end of the world.

I hugged my knees tightly as I cried my eyes out.

I didn't care even if Nie Zun was watching right in front of me, nor did I remember that Gaoqin Jiuye was now a by-stander here.

I've forgotten everything in this very moment. The only thing I know is that the one I loved the most would be leaving me again. He said he was tired of being together with me, he said he was leaving me.

Nothing mattered now. What mattered most was that I could not let Nie Zun leave me. I could not endure a life without Nie Zun.

My hands balled tightly into fists and I felt my fingernails dig deep into my palms. I was still shaking as I saw the blood drip onto the floor from my hands.

Chapter 225: 225 I Have Never Loved Her

Volume 4

225 I Have Never Loved Her

As I was bawling my eyes out, I heard the sound of a punch being thrown.

Looking up, I saw Gaoqin Jiuye's fist land on Nie Zun's face. He looked angry and defeated, as if something precious that belonged to him had been hurt. I could feel his emotions run high and he looked as if he was about to take revenge.

I stood up immediately.

Nie Zun's bangs fell across his eyes as his face went to the side from the force of the punch.

Gaoqin Jiuye sounded angry as he said, "Didn't you love her? Weren't you always protecting her? Then keep loving her and protecting her. How could you say that you're leaving her at this time?"

Nie Zun turned back slowly to look at Gaoqin Jiuye. His eyes still carried that undecipherable, cold but sorrowful gaze. "So what?"

My blood seemed to freeze at that.

Gaoqin Jiuye threw a second punch, but Nie Zun blocked it this time. He stared at me as he addressed Gaoqin Jiuye, "Don't think that I wouldn't know. Gaoqin Jiuye, you're the one that she has been in love with all this while. You've been living in the Split Zone for so long and accompanying

her in her dreams for so long. You've even brought her here to save her. Are you not planning to tell her how much you've done for her?"

My head snapped up as I heard this. I looked at Gaoqin Jiuye, but all I could see was his back.

I looked at Nie Zun. He held Gaoqin Jiuye's fist in one hand and looked at me with those cold and emotionless eyes. A trickle of blood ran down the corner of his lips.

"What do you mean... by that..." I muttered.

Nie Zun pushed Gaoqin Jiuye's hand away, and Gaoqin Jiuye simply let him do so like someone with no more strength left in him. His hair was in a mess, and his eyes looked like they were staring into an empty abyss.

Nie Zun wiped the corner of his mouth and answered, "You ask him yourself."

I looked at Gaoqin Jiuye, but he looked like he was avoiding something.

"What did he mean by all that?" I asked slowly.

Gaoqin Jiuye opened his mouth as if to speak, but he didn't say anything in the end.

Nie Zun smirked. "Don't you have the guts to tell her? Do you need me to help you say it?"

Gaoqin Jiuye turned to him. "How do you know this?"

I interrupted him. "Gaoqin Jiuye, what did he mean by that? Is it true? Tell me."

Gaoqin Jiuye kept his eyes on me.

After a moment, I heard that exhausted but still enchanting voice of his.

"Yes."

My hands started trembling again. “What do you mean?” I was at a loss for words. The only thing I could do now was to get to the bottom of this matter.

I killed the one I loved and ended up here to pay for my crimes. I’ve been here for two years now and you’re telling me that I’ve been loving the wrong person all this time?

Gaoqin Jiuye looked at me with sorrow in his eyes. “Gao Qi and I are doppelgangers, and you fell in love with me, not him.

“I’m not able to explain about doppelgangers fully now, since you’ve lost too much of your memories about the time spent with Gao Qi, even about the process of falling in love with him. You only remember loving him after arriving here, but that wasn’t the case. Actually, you and him, or rather, you and I, we had been together before.

“Since Gao Qi and I are doppelgangers, we share one soul. Because he’s incomplete, he might end up doing certain things that normal people wouldn’t, and some of those things might have hurt you. To protect you, I’ve been going over to help you out. I was able to save you once or twice, but there’s no way I can do that forever. The only way to help you stay alive is to bring you here.”

Was this a joke? I looked at Gaoqin Jiuye with tears in my eyes, unwilling to believe what I’ve just heard.

Broken images flashed through my brain. Though these were just fragments, I was still able to see Gao Qi’s face clearly in them.

He was smiling maniacally in that lab as he slashed my skin with a knife.

He wanted me to drink the liquid in the jar as he brought me that jar with the head of a cat in it.

More and more images like this popped into my head.

“Ah... What’s this. No way... Ahhhhhhh!” I screamed as I clutched my own head, still in disbelief over the images that continued appearing in my mind.

Gao Qi was a devil in them.

“Ah...!” I continued screaming as tears drenched my face.

Gaoqin Jiuye could no longer watch as he walked over and tried to calm me down by taking me in an embrace.

I grabbed his arm and bit him hard.

“Ugh...” I tasted blood in my mouth as I saw it drip down his arm.

Gaoqin Jiuye said, “I know it’s painful, and I know it’s hard to believe. But it’s the truth. He and I are doppelgangers. I live in the Split Zone while he lives in your world. I can only see him and you in the other world when I’m dreaming. I had never thought of meddling into his affairs, but slowly, I found myself falling in love with you. I’ve always known that he loved you, but with a part of his soul missing, he was incomplete.

“That caused him to turn a little demonic, and you always ended up hurt when he goes crazy. I’ve overtaken his consciousness many times in order to save you. I pretended to be him, to make you think that he was someone gentle.

“Actually, Ah Shen, Nie Zun might be wrong. He might be the one you’ve fallen in love with, instead of me. You already know what he’s like as a person. It’s just that you refuse to come to terms with it.”

“Enough!” I shouted. The blood trickled down my mouth, making me look like a crazed vampire.

Nie Zun interrupted, “She loves him? She doesn’t even know who she loves. As a doppelganger, you’re a unique existence both in the Split Zone and in the real world. You’ve been ostracized since young because you had been powerful since then; you were seen as a weirdo. Gao Qi had too little

power, and he was being devoured by demonic energy, turning him into a crazy person.

“Both of you are similar like this. Li Shen has double identity disorder, and the consciousness of her soul would be about four times stronger than that of yours. You and Gao Qi keep saying that you love her, but is it really love, or is it a mere attraction between souls?”

Though I didn’t understand a single word Nie Zun said, Gaoqin Jiuye responded almost immediately. “How about you, Nie Zun? You mean to say that you don’t love her? Though I’m not sure how you became aware of doppelgangers in the Split Zone, I want to know what kind of existence you are in the Split Zone. If my sources are accurate, you don’t have a soul splitter here. Why would there be an heir without a corresponding soul splitter in the Split Zone? Who exactly are you?”

This just made me more confused. I took deep breaths to calm myself down at this turn of events.

Li Shen, forget everything that happened. Forget that Nie Zun said he wanted to leave you. None of this is important now. Right now, you had to figure out what exactly is happening. There might be something else going on here.

Don’t be afraid, Li Shen, everything will turn out fine.

I looked at the two of them as I tried to piece together all the information in my head. At the same time, I tried to match what they said with all the clues I currently had.

Though I couldn’t tell how the Split Zone was connected to the real world, I knew now that Gaoqin Jiuye and Gao Qi are technically the same person. They shared one soul, but they had two different consciousness and two different minds.

According to Nie Zun, Gaoqin Jiuye was more powerful. Could that be interpreted as Gaoqin Jiuye being the more dominant party if he and Gao Qi were sharing one soul? Gao Qi was the less dominant one, and thus not

complete. Was this why he could attract demonic energy easily, causing a change in his personality? Did this lead to him hurting me?

This looked like a case of opposites. He naturally absorbed the demonic energy in the world because he was an incomplete soul.

Since Gaoqin Jiuye had too much power within him, he also ended up a target in the Split Zone.

But why did it come to this?

Did this mean that all the bodies of consciousness in the Split Zone shared a soul with a corresponding body of consciousness in the real world?

No, that's not right. If Gaoqin Jiuye is the exception, then there must be some other rule to this.

Also, why did Nie Zun not have a soul splitter? According to Mr Blond, Nie Zun's personality had resonated with mine and we completed each other. If so, his soul would be incomplete as well. Was this the reason he could absorb demonic energy?

I spoke abruptly. "Nie Zun, are you like Gaoqin Jiuye? Are you a 'soul splitter' in the real world?"

Nie Zun's eyes squinted in a mocking smile. "What amazing imagination. Sadly, both of you are wrong. First, I'm not like him." He pointed at Gaoqin Jiuye and turned to him. "Second, you're wrong. I don't love her. The one who loves her and the one who's willing to sacrifice his life for her had been you all this while, and also that incomplete doppelganger of yours. I've never loved her.

"In order to achieve my goal, I've been forced to stay with her all this while after arriving here. There's no need for me to continue pretending since that restriction is gone now."

After hearing this, I felt my heart drop into a bottomless pit where no redemption would be found.

Chapter 226: 226 Gaoqin Jiuye's Heart

Volume 4

226 Gaoqin Jiuye's Heart

“So you’ve never loved me...” I said bitterly as I squatted on the floor.

Nie Zun responded coldly, “Yes, I’ve never loved you.”

I shut my eyes and sucked in a breath, wiping the tears off my face. Standing up, I saw her again as I looked towards Nie Zun.

She was standing behind him. Nie Zun was half a head taller than her, and she looked so tiny and frail in that red dress. They looked like a perfect couple.

She smiled faintly. She looked a little lonely like this.

She continued looking at me as she stood behind Nie Zun. Her gaze seemed to be asking if I thought he was speaking the truth, whether it was really true that he didn’t love me anymore.

I slowly made my way towards her; towards him.

I reached out for his hand as I reached him, putting it on my chest. “Rip my heart out and tell her that you’ve never loved her.”

Nie Zun’s beautiful eyelashes fluttered slightly. I couldn’t tell what he was thinking behind those unfathomable eyes.

His hand was cold like before, and I felt no warmth from him even when it was on my chest. He did not move an inch.

I looked at him. “Someone who only thinks about protecting me and who had never thought about saving himself in times of danger, he’s telling me now that he had never loved me.”

I pressed harder on his hand as I spoke with certainty. “Nie Zun, do you think I’m that dumb? That I’ll believe you if you say this?”

Nie Zun spoke calmly, but he did not sound as cold as before. “Think of it however you want to. I can’t do anything about your thoughts anyway.” He pulled his hand away from me and looked away.

I laughed in self-mockery. “It’s fine if you really don’t love me. I’m just afraid that you’re really treating me like an idiot who’ll believe whatever you’ve said.”

After taking a breath, I continued. “There’s no use talking about all this now. I’ve achieved my goal since you’ve remembered everything. Since you don’t love me, let’s go on our separate paths from now on, as you have wished.”

I turned around and pulled Gaoqin Jiuye towards that vat of water he had originally come from.

I spoke as calmly as I could as I passed Nie Zun. “Nie Zun, I’ll only say I love you just this once. I don’t know why you’re doing this, but if you’re really letting me go today, I’ll never be coming back. From now on, let’s go on our own paths and never turn back.”

I teared up after this.

Once again, I’ve confirmed that I had fallen in love with him for real.

My heart was racing as I hoped he would extend a hand to stop me from leaving.

I could forget everything if he did this. I would run into his arms in tears. I would tell him that no matter who I loved in the past, be it Gao Qi or Gaoqin Jiuye or whoever it might have been, the one I loved now was you, Nie Zun.

But, nothing of that sort happened.

He remained silent as he stood behind me, letting me leave with Gaoqin Jiuye.

I lost all hope as I reached that vat of water.

A pair of hands stopped me just as I was about to pull Gaoqin Jiuye with me into the water.

She disappeared earlier but she appeared again right before me.

Her slender hands blocked my path. “Are you really leaving him? He had just regained his memories and he needs you by his side right now. Have you also forgotten what Huai Du said? How would you know that he really isn’t affected by this blood-changing process? What if he still has demonic energy in him? Are you really leaving him like this? Just because he says he doesn’t love you?”

“Didn’t he still stay by your side for so long even when you didn’t show your affection for him in the past? And you’re deciding to give up on him so easily now?”

I let go of Gaoqin Jiuye’s hand slightly.

Am I going to give up like this...

Am I really going to abandon him like this...

No. I have to get to the bottom of this no matter how he treats me.

Just when I made my decision, I felt something pull on my arm. Gaoqin Jiuye was pulling me towards the water vat with him.

Before I could even react, Gaoqin Jiuye was already pulling me somewhere else through the water.

“Pch...” I spat out a mouthful of water as we finally surfaced.

Instead of glaciers, we were in another stone room.

Before I could speak, Gaoqin Jiuye pulled me out of the water by the collar.

I stared at him as I pushed him away. “Why did you grab me? I haven’t finished talking.”

Gaoqin Jiuye looked at me with fiery eyes. “What else do you have to say? He already said he doesn’t love you. Why stay when he didn’t even stop you from leaving?”

“I...” I was rendered speechless. *Right. What else was I... hoping for?*

“Li Shen, you might want to take a look at me. I’m right here beside you. It’s not only Nie Zun who had been by your side. I, Gaoqin Jiuye, had been here too. I’ve known you for a longer time even. I’ve been protecting you all this while. Why did you fall in love with Gao Qi previously, Li Shen? And you’ve also fallen in love with somebody else when I finally thought you’d be by my side. Tell me why.”

He took me by the shoulders as he looked at me like a helpless child.

I have never seen Gaoqin Jiuye like this.

I turned pale. “I’m sorry. I just don’t understand. If everything is like what you described it to be, then why didn’t you just tell me everything? Gaoqin Jiuye, why did you have to do all this behind my back? You even pretended to be Gao Qi. If I remember right, you’ve never even acted like you knew me from the very moment I met you here in the Split Zone.”

Gaoqin Jiuye let go of me slowly. “Honestly, I’ve never thought of meeting you again. I just wanted you to live a peaceful life in the Western District. Life here can be good too. You even have people protecting you here.”

I smirked. “What right do you have to decide for others? If you really loved me, why did you bring me here but refuse to meet me?”

Gaoqin Jiuye’s gaze wavered. “Because... You’d be sad... if you learnt the truth...”

My heart hurt at this.

So it’s like this...

Because if I learnt that you were the one I liked instead of Gao Qi, then that guilt I felt towards Gao Qi would turn into a worse sorrow. Is this the reason you chose to hide the truth?

So, you chose to save me but keep me in the dark about your existence?

I cried. “You. Why are you such an idiot...”

An exhausted smile appeared on Gaoqin Jiuye. “Idiot? Not really, since I didn’t treat you very well anyway. I wasn’t able to give you a happy life even after bringing you here. I wasn’t able to protect you all the time either, because there’s someone else who needs my protection here, and I cannot betray him.”

My tears fell. “You’re referring to Si Luo?”

Gaoqin Jiuye looked into the distance. “Yes. I’ve always been living in darkness in this world, but Si Luo lit the way for me. Li Shen, I never should’ve liked you. You and Gao Qi were the perfect couple. Gao Qi’s flaws were caused by me, and your happiness was destroyed by me. Everything happened because of me. What right do I have to be by your side like this?

“I just didn’t expect that someone like Nie Zun would appear by your side.”

He continued after a short pause. “I was initially happy for you when I saw him protecting you. I thought there was finally someone who existed solely for you. Since he was able to protect you, I kept telling myself that I should be retreating now. I could retreat with peace of mind.

“But, haha, it’s really difficult. There’s also Si Luo. You might find that I’m always hot and cold towards you, probably because of these reasons. I envy Nie Zun, but I can’t help but be jealous of him at the same time.”

My tears continued flowing as I saw Gaoqin Jiuye’s vulnerable side.

He had never been like this. He had always been proud, noble and cold, like a mighty god of death.

But now, he looked so vulnerable.

This was all because of me.

Fate teases us in strange ways. If only I didn’t kill Gao Qi, if only I didn’t misunderstand Gaoqin Jiuye. If only, I didn’t meet Nie Zun.

Sadly, we cannot turn back time.

I started weeping quietly.

I knew exactly how I felt now, and because of this certainty, I knew that I could never go back.

There was no way I could go back now.

I have fallen in love with Nie Zun for real. I have fallen too deeply for him.

“Because I know that you’ve fallen for Nie Zun, there’s no way I could tell you all this. You’d just be more upset if you learn about this after falling in love with him.”

Gaoqin Jiuye smiled bitterly. “I guess there are some selfish reasons behind my actions too, because I’d rather not talk about love, ever. I hoped that I would never have to hear you say that you love him.

“Sadly, all of it was a mere pipe dream.”

The corners of his eyes were wet now.

Chapter 227: 227 Don't Underestimate Me

Volume 4

227 Don't Underestimate Me

“No... It's not like this...” Images flashed past my mind as I recalled what Bian Ying told me earlier.

I couldn't wrap my head around this. All of it just happened too suddenly.

Bian Ying told me that it was impossible for us to be captured and brought to the Split Zone, and in order to save her, Cang Ming and Ta Lai both had to share the same split symbol with her.

She also told me that although Gaoqin Jiuye wasn't like Cang Ming, who was born with great MF, he wasn't weak either. Logically speaking, there was no need for him to establish a split symbol contract with me and restrict himself like this.

So, why did he do something like that?

Was he telling the truth? That he did it to save me from Gao Qi?

I don't remember what happened from before, and I wasn't able to piece together a full picture from those fragments that appeared in my mind.

Was there something else going on here?

“What's wrong?” Gaoqin Jiuye looked at me.

I met his eyes. “Bian Ying told me that others had to make a sacrifice if people like us wanted to survive in the Split Zone. I didn’t know what she was talking about at that time, but is this what you’ve been talking about?”

“Also, before you tell me that, can you tell me why you’re here?” I asked.

Gaoqin Jiuye placed his hands back into his pockets. “Du Yue was in a rage after you left, and I don’t know where Li Wen went after that. Initially, Du Yue’s plan was to look for you first, but she scrapped that after hearing news about Ta Lai and went to look for him instead.”

“So you came here after they left? Isn’t this a little too contrived? You don’t know I’m in the demon cave.” I stared at him.

He shrugged as he answered, “I didn’t know you were here. And actually, I didn’t come here to look for you.”

Oh, you weren’t looking for me?

“He’s here to look for me.”

I turned in surprise as I heard another voice from within the stone room.

I didn’t realize that there was actually someone else in this place. *Wait, no, he wasn’t here from before. Where did he come from?*

Somewhere behind us, an evil-looking man wearing a blood-red robe was resting on the ground. He rested his head on a hand, propping himself up with an elbow as he rested against his side while he looked at us.

“Cang Ming...” I muttered subconsciously.

Cang Ming ignored me as he continued speaking to Gaoqin Jiuye, “You’re becoming less and less like yourself. You’re going to lose this woman if you continue being indecisive like this.”

He pointed a finger at me, regarding me with what felt like a mocking gaze.

What an audacious individual.

Gaoqin Jiuye's expression instantly returned to that cold arrogance as he spoke to Cang Ming. "I've already lost her. I just hope for her to have a happy life. I'm not going to follow your example in locking somebody up."

I sucked in a breath. This was obviously referring to how he forcefully kept Bian Ying by his side.

Cang Ming was rather strange. He didn't get angry when I thought he would. He simply smiled and answered in a conversational tone, "You're right in not choosing to follow my example."

Is he really that audacious Cang Ming from before?

"Hey, woman. I heard that you're just like my woman, that you have a second personality here in the Split Zone." Cang Ming posed me a question that I did not know how to answer.

Woman. I heard that you're just like my woman.

So much must have went on between them.

"Yes. Why, are you interested in my second personality too?" I raised my brows in mock curiosity.

The corners of Cang Ming's eyes turned up slightly. "Too? Who else is interested?"

I pondered for a moment. *Should I tell him the truth?*

Should I tell him that your Bian Ying might be able to find that lost consciousness of hers? By taking over the empty shell of my soul?

Should I tell him that this is Ta Lai's goal?

I couldn't decide on this right away. I stole a glance at Gaoqin Jiuye.

He was silent and he did not look like he wanted to be a part of this conversation at all.

I guess I'll just have to depend on myself for this.

“Ta Lai has been chasing after me to find out more about this, probably. And possibly, also to find out why Bian Ying had a change of heart.” I smiled at Cang Ming as I answered.

Gaoqin Jiuye interrupted me. “You think she’d know? She’s just like the Bian Ying of the past. She’s simply being kept in the dark and being used as a tool. You’re better off asking me.”

Cang Ming laughed, waving a hand. “There’s no need to play such games with me, Gaoqin Jiuye. I know you well enough. No one can get information out of you unless you’re willing to provide it.”

I frowned at this. I knew he was referring to the fact that Gaoqin Jiuye was a sly fox, but this felt like an indirect attack on my intelligence.

Trying to get information from me when he knows it's impossible to get it from Gaoqin Jiuye? Am I that dumb?

Gaoqin Jiuye’s eyes squinted in a smile. “Let’s not talk about all this. Where’s your Bian Ying now?”

Cang Ming’s smile seemed to freeze at this.

Gaoqin Jiuye noticed it immediately, and his smile faded gradually. “Don’t tell me that you’ve lost her. It doesn’t look like something you’d do, that she isn’t here with you now.”

Cang Ming got up slowly, resting his elbows on his knees as he sat up. “Her condition is getting from bad to worse these days. Is it you or Du Yue who did something to her? Or does this involve Piercer somehow?”

Gaoqin Jiuye furrowed his brows slightly. “Her condition is getting from bad to worse? Do you mean that there are signs of possible death?”

Cang Ming nodded. “There are similar symptoms.”

“So this is why you’re here. It’s not merely for Du Yue, is it?” Gaoqin Jiuye’s eyes had a cold glaze to them.

A mirthless smile appeared on Cang Ming. “There’s no need for me to explain anymore since you can already tell. Gaoqin Jiuye, I’ll be frank with you. Bian Ying sunk into soul coma when I took her away from Du Yue the other day. Her condition isn’t improving even though she regained consciousness after I woke her up. I’m disinclined to believe that this was Du Yue’s doing, since Ta Lai was there as well, and he wouldn’t let her do such a thing. But I’m not a hundred percent sure about that.”

“So, what of it?”

“I don’t care what Du Yue is plotting, but I’ve heard an interesting story.” Cang Ming laughed wickedly and seemed to steal a glance in my direction.

Gaoqin Jiuye raised a brow as he asked, “What is it?”

Cang Ming pointed at me as he replied, “I heard that her second personality can become a vessel for Bian Ying’s consciousness. Ta Lai is going about this right now. If he succeeds, Bian Ying’s life will no longer be in danger. Is that true?”

Gaoqin Jiuye glanced at me. “What do you think? Ta Lai is obsessed with saving Bian Ying, and the one thing he wants to see is for Bian Ying to leave you. You believe Ta Lai just because it’s true that Li Shen has a second personality? You think you can whitewash Li Shen’s second personality to the point that it can turn into a vessel for Bian Ying’s consciousness? Firstly, you should know that this isn’t something Bian Ying would be willing to do. Secondly, what do you plan to do if it doesn’t work?”

Cang Ming stood up. “But she has Piercer with her, and Piercer will recognize her as its owner. Is this all mere coincidence? Gaoqin Jiuye, you’d better pray that all this has nothing to do with her. If not, I’m definitely taking her life.”

Definitely taking my life?

Hahahahaha.

Seems like I've been way too nice.

“Taking my life? Aren't you taking another person's life too lightly like this?” I smirked.

Cang Ming turned to me with disdain in his eyes. “I don't know if taking your life would be an easy task, but I like efficient and effective solutions. If I remember right, that person whose face I helped to heal, you have feelings for him, right? Do you think I'd let him go easily if you refuse to listen to me?”

I was incensed at this.

I hate it when others use Nie Zun to threaten me, especially when Nie Zun has changed so much that even I was not able to understand him fully. Someone had the gall to use him to threaten me at a time like this?

I smiled cruelly. “I'm sorry, but firstly, I don't think you'd be able to do anything to Nie Zun. Secondly, I'd like to tell you that Bian Ying's opinions run contrary to yours. If you continue like this, you'll lose Bian Ying someday. You think that you have extraordinary abilities, but the fact is, even if everything goes according to your plan, you won't be able to save her without my second personality. Do you think you should be talking to me like that?”

Cang Ming finally seemed to take a slight interest in me. “Are you admitting that your second personality can save her?”

I smirked. “There's a possibility, but I'm not sure of it. No matter what my second personality can do or whether she can really help you, I'd advise you guys to give up. Do you really think you're able to control me just because you have greater MF? Even I'm not able to control that personality of mine.”

I spoke slowly now. “Don't underestimate me, Cang Ming.”

Chapter 228: 228 Brazen Talk

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228 Brazen Talk

Cang Ming shrugged with impudence. “Fine, I guess I have underestimated you.”

My face broke out in cold sweat. He was a strange man indeed.

“No matter what, I’ll definitely have to try since so many have told me your second personality is able to save Bian Ying. So, how about it? Are you prepared to come with me?” Cang Ming smiled dangerously.

Gaoqin Jiuye stepped forward as if to shield me.

“Instead of believing in such rumors, how about you go and try separating Bian Ying’s consciousness that’s in Piercer right now?”

Cang Ming raised a brow. “Isn’t that a more difficult task?”

I shook my head. “I’m not saying this because I’m afraid of what you might do to me. I’m saying this as someone who has been using Piercer for up to two years now. I’m sure that the soul within Piercer is not an absolutely cruel and merciless one. I believe she had her reasons for whatever she did in the past. Because of that, I just might be able to help you find Bian Ying’s lost consciousness that had been devoured by her.”

Cang Ming looked towards my waist. “Where’s Piercer now?”

Recalling that Piercer was with Nie Zun at this moment, I suddenly felt joy out of nowhere.

I said, “Piercer is with someone else now. Not to worry though, he’s right here. Do you want to go look for him together?”

Who knew that Gaoqin Jiuye would actually be angered by this.

He turned to look at me with cold eyes. “You just can’t wait to return to him, can you? Even when he had just hurt you like that? You’re still looking for an excuse to go back?”

I looked at him. “I... Running away doesn’t solve anything...”

Gaoqin Jiuye looked pained. “Go back to him then. Don’t say that you’re leaving him and return to him the very next second because you miss him too much. Go ahead, Li Shen. Go back and experience all the pain that he’ll bring to you.”

I bit my lip. “How do you know that he’ll definitely bring me pain?”

Gaoqin Jiuye smiled bitterly, but he remained silent.

Cang Ming responded. “You’re saying that Piercer is now with that person whose face I healed?”

I nodded. “Yes, it’s with Nie Zun.”

“Where is he now?”

I pointed at the vat of water. “He should be there, in a place similar to this one.”

Cang Ming squinted. “Another stone room. Is it the one with the demon cultivating tablet?”

I nodded profusely. “Yes, he’s right there.”

Cang Ming glanced at the stone platform that was in this space. “You guys escaped from there? Then why didn’t he follow?”

Right, why didn’t Nie Zun follow? Did he plan to stay there forever?

Cang Ming seemed to be able to read my mind. “Seems like you don’t know much about this place, nor about him. I’ll take you with me to look for him, but you’ll have to bring Piercer and leave with me after that.”

“This doesn’t sound like a fair deal.”

Cang Ming laughed out loud. “That’s right, this isn’t a fair transaction. But without my help, it would be close to impossible for you to find him in this complex demon cave.”

I gave an indifferent smile. “There’s no need for me to look for him, but if you insist on taking me and waking Piercer for you, I have but one request. It’s a simple request. Care to hear it?”

“Go on.”

I smirked. “I want to see Huai Du.”

Gaoqin Jiuye and Cang Ming did not reveal their thoughts and emotions easily to others, but both of them simply stared at me when I said that.

Cang Ming scratched his ear. “Did my ears fool me? Even the soul splitters in the Gate of Ghost avoid him because they are respectfully afraid of him. You’re telling me that you want to meet him? Do you know that you’ll die?”

“Do you think I’m living now? You’re wrong. I’m no different from a corpse right now. I’m doing all this firstly, for my friends, and also because I want to live.”

Cang Ming laughed loudly. “What an interesting individual. It’s no wonder both Nie Zun and Gaoqin Jiuye like you. I’m in a good mood today, so let me reveal a secret to you.”

Another secret...

There really are many secrets here in the Split Zone indeed...

It’s great that he’s here to reveal one, and not to create another one.

“Go ahead.” I looked at him.

He smiled casually. “What I want to tell you is that you might think that your plan is seamless now, including brainy Li Qing. But sadly, Huai Du will be aware of all that you guys are doing. Does Li Qing really think she can hide from Huai Du with that tiny trick? Huai Du knows everything that goes on in this demon cave, and even when you’ve used Li Qing’s method to hide from him, he can use another method to control you. You won’t even be able to guess how he did it.”

I frowned. “What do you mean?”

What did he mean by this?

Does it mean that even though we can hide from Huai Du using Li Qing’s method, it’s no use in the end? According to Cang Ming, Huai Du will know all that goes on here because he controls everything in here.

Instead of speaking my mind, I decided to challenge Cang Ming. “How can I be sure that you’re telling the truth? Even if you were, would that matter? He isn’t doing anything to us now, is he?”

Cang Ming smirked. “Why don’t you understand, woman? Have you even thought about why I would appear here? Is this really a coincidence? And your lover, that person whose face I healed, how can you be so sure that his behavior isn’t caused by Huai Du?”

Gaoqin Jiuye furrowed his brows at this. “Seems like there are many things I’m still unaware of. I guess it’s not a coincidence that you’re here at all. You might also have expected for me to come looking for you, and it might all have been part of your plan, including the part where we came over from where Nie Zun was.”

He said this with a vile expression.

Gaoqin Jiuye doesn’t back down even after getting beaten up, and I was sure he wouldn’t retreat just because of what Cang Ming had just said.

Looking at him like this, I felt that he and Cang Ming were compatible in many ways. Both of them were soul splitters with extraordinary abilities and both were extremely audacious.

Cang Ming's chest ended up slightly exposed with a wave of his blood-red robe. "You're mistaken. This isn't part of my plan, it is part of Huai Du's plan."

No matter how dumb I was, Cang Ming had made it very clear now.

The secret that he revealed was that everything was going according to Huai Du's plan, and all this happened not because we had blindsided Huai Du. Though this sounded unbelievable, I actually believed it the moment I heard it.

I looked at Cang Ming as I said, "Seems like Li Qing wasn't able to grasp the situation fully. It's too bad she let the bad guy win."

I wanted to see how Cang Ming would react to me chiding Huai Du like this.

Cang Ming's upturned eyes seemed to waver for a moment, but there was no other obvious change in him. He spoke casually like before. "Li Qing shouldn't have come to the Gate of Ghost. You're quite something, seeing that there are so many who're willing to risk themselves for you. Even taking risks that they shouldn't be taking."

Huh. I should really thoroughly analyze what he just said.

Risk themselves for me? Did Li Qing really do everything for me?

In the past, I would definitely believe her. But now, it was different.

Trust is so fragile and easily broken.

I believed in what my instincts told me. I felt that even though Li Qing had her reasons for doing what she did, she definitely would have had some goal in mind. Because of that goal, Li Qing had turned into someone else.

Unwilling to waste any more time, I folded my arms before me, trying to look casual. “Since you’ve already told us all this, how about you come clean about why Huai Du sent you here?”

Cang Ming smiled. “Yes, why did he send me here?”

“...”

Even though I was strange myself, I still found it really difficult to converse with this strange individual.

Cang Ming turned serious suddenly. “Huai Du thinks like you, he thinks that I’d be on his side as the second king of the Gate of Ghost. Unfortunately, things aren’t this simple.”

Second king in the Gate of Ghost? Huh. Did he enthrone himself?

Gaoqin Jiuye regained that insolence he always had as he asked, “So you’re here because Huai Du sent you, but you have your own thoughts about what to do?”

Cang Ming’s eyes flashed. “Gaoqin Jiuye, this is why I let you live even when you saved that weapon-smithing couple from here. I appreciate your intelligence.”

Gaoqin Jiuye smirked. “I’m grateful for that appreciation, but please don’t say things like you let me live. Whether you really appreciate me or not, I don’t think you have the right or the ability to choose to ‘let me live’.”

These two... they really are shameless...

I was rendered speechless at their exchange...

Why am I being forced to listen to these presumptuous individuals...

Chapter 229: 229 Spatial Connections

Volume 4

229 Spatial Connections

“I don’t care what Huai Du plans to do with the bunch of you, and I’m only here because he sent me. He can’t do anything about what I plan to do after that.”

That confidence actually made Cang Ming look pretty dashing.

An explosion was heard near the wall just when I was about to speak.

All three of us were visibly taken aback at the sudden sound as we looked towards its source.

A huge hole appeared in the stone wall, as if it had just bore the brunt of a powerful attack. Nie Zun’s tall figure appeared as the smoke and dust settled.

Cang Ming was the first to speak. “How could that happen? All the spaces in the demon cave are independent of each other. The space with that demon cultivating tablet you were in is totally independent of this space. How did you come here by breaking through a wall?”

Though I didn’t fully comprehend him, I could understand what he was getting at.

This meant that no matter what we had seen earlier, be it that glacial wonderland, the stone rooms, the stone tunnel or even that icy river, they

were all independent spaces that had no connection to one another.

In other words, we can imagine these spaces to be separate houses floating by themselves in the air without anything connecting them in between.

But if that was the case, then how did we go from one space to the other?

Nie Zun spoke calmly. “Since the spaces are independent of each other, then of course it isn’t a simple case of breaking a wall.”

Realization hit Cang Ming. “So this is a manifestation of forcefully breaking through the barriers between two spaces.”

“What does that mean?” I asked finally, unable to contain my curiosity.

Cang Ming ignored me while Gaoqin Jiuye responded, “There is a specific way to go between any two independent spaces, just like how you arrived in the water vat from that icy river, because that’s one of the ways to get from that icy river to this space. Of course, there’s more than a single way to go between the spaces. However, one would need to use one of those specific methods to travel between the spaces, and these methods are usually created by the very person who had created this entire demon cave.”

He continued after a short pause. “If I’m right, the method of breaking through the wall that Nie Zun just used isn’t one of those specific methods to get to this particular space.”

I frowned. “If I’m hearing this right, this means that the demon cave and all its specific connections between the spaces had been created by Huai Du with MF. But the fact that Nie Zun can break through one of these specific connections implies that his MF is already off the charts?”

I didn’t expect myself to be able to analyze this so clearly. This might probably be because I’ve been forced to use my brain a lot recently.

Cang Ming raised a brow. “That’s right. From this, you can already tell how high Huai Du’s MF is. Whatever you have seen in here is but a manifestation of a tiny fraction of it. Gaoqin Jiuye, I respect you as a

talented individual, and I don't wish for you to die too soon. I'd suggest you leave the Gate of Ghost soon. You guys shouldn't stay here."

"If you're asking us to leave because we aren't powerful enough or because we've been too impudent, then how about you? You don't look like the kind who can be easily controlled either. Why is Huai Du giving you special treatment? Is that just because you can be considered a subordinate of his? I don't think it's that simple, is it? Or is there some other reason that you're here as well?"

Red flashed past me, and before I knew what was happening, I saw Cang Ming right before me. I could almost be considered petite in front of his large frame.

The demonic man looked down upon me as he spoke with those blood-red lips. His half-hearted smile terrified me. "Do you still think I don't have the ability to survive here?"

He raised a fist towards me as I looked at him in confusion. As I stretched out an uncertain hand, he placed something on it.

After I realized what it was, I quickly put it back where it originally belonged in my red dress. Gaoqin Jiuye and Nie Zun's vision would be obscured by Cang Ming's wide frame, and none of them would have seen what happened.

Cang Ming handed me Jiao S's teleportation pill, telling me indirectly that he had great power by being able to reach me and steal something from me all in the blink of an eye.

I couldn't tell what he was thinking, but I suspected that the reason he chose to take this from me was to also make it clear that he knew what it was, and that he knew I only had one of these.

He definitely was a terrifying individual if that was the case, since even Du Yue was not aware of this.

Instead of guessing, I decided to probe for more information.

I smiled at him. “No need to return such trash to me. I can just give it to you.”

Cang Ming smirked. “You sure that’s trash? Or is this your attempt at deception?”

Right, seems like he really knows everything.

But Jiao S and I did not really come into contact with him, and we didn’t know each other at all.

How did he know this?

What a terrifying individual.

He turned back and swaggered towards Nie Zun, as if about to tell him something.

I called out from behind him, “Do you want to take a look at what you might be missing?”

I saw an obvious flinch he reached for his waist. He then glanced at both my hands.

After confirming that the item in his pocket was gone, he narrowed his eyes at me threateningly. “Give it back to me.”

I held that white handkerchief with rhododendrons embroidered on it behind my back. Taking my hand out, I planned to throw it back at him. However, a flash of red appeared before me yet again before I felt a numbing pain on my wrist.

Cang Ming had my wrist in his hand.

I knew it was too late as I looked at those wrathful eyes. He might not let this go even after possibly snapping my wrist in two. I was prepared to take whatever came at me, since I thought I wouldn’t be able to avoid it anyway. However, nothing happened after that numbing pain.

I could smell him even before I saw him. To be accurate, it wasn't a distinct smell but more of a change in the atmosphere when he was near me.

I felt a distinct cold around me as I looked up.

That handkerchief was still in my hand and Cang Ming had my wrist in a tight grip. My skin was turning red under his fingers.

However, he did not use any more strength, because there was another hand on his. It was beautiful, slender and pale, as if that hand had not seen the sun in a long time.

It was Nie Zun's hand.

Nie Zun placed his hand on Cang Ming's wrist, and there was also another hand on Nie Zun's arm.

Gaoqin Jiuye was holding onto Nie Zun's upper arm.

This scenario looked a little weird...

All four of us were gathered in a tiny space, our hands seemingly intertwined with one another as no one could emerge the winner.

Even though the situation was clear to everyone, none of us wanted to be the first to let go.

There's no use in keeping silent if none of us are going to move.

If this silence has to be broken, let me break it with a question.

There was a hint of sorrow in my voice as I spoke. "Didn't you not love me anymore? Didn't we decide to go on our separate ways? Why save me now?"

I saw a flicker in Gaoqin Jiuye's eyes.

My heart broke for him, but I couldn't take my words back.

This was what I really wanted to know.

When Nie Zun did not respond, Cang Ming suddenly laughed. “I guess it isn’t easy to touch you.”

This was obviously directed at me, but I was incensed at how badly timed it was.

I wouldn’t be able to hear any answer from Nie Zun because of him.

Even if Nie Zun might have hurt me further if he had answered, I still wanted to hear it.

I realized that it was easy for someone to make their way into your heart, but it was no easy task if you wanted to make that person go away.

I chided Cang Ming in my heart, finding him a thoughtless individual.

I spoke impatiently, “You can take your hand away now since you know that you can’t touch me. There’s no need to resort to violence. It’s not like I’m not returning you that handkerchief anyway.”

Chapter 230: 230 You Belonged to Me

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230 You Belonged to Me

Instead of letting go, Cang Ming glanced at Gaoqin Jiuye and Nie Zun.

He spoke with malice in his voice, “I’m curious to know what happens if I don’t let go.”

As I felt his grip tighten, black fog emanated from Nie Zun’s hand at the same time.

Unease crept up on me.

I focused my MF onto my arm before sending it towards my wrist. The sudden force of my MF then separated the four of us, making all of us retreat.

I regarded Cang Ming coldly before throwing him that handkerchief.

His eyes darkened as he caught it, but he regained his untethered arrogance very quickly.

“Not bad, woman.”

“You haven’t told me how you got here.” He directed his question to Nie Zun after he praised me.

Nie Zun put his hands back into his pockets as he answered casually, "I was trapped in that stone room with nowhere else to go. I simply arrived here after breaking through a wall."

I stole a glance at him. The Nie Zun now must be the Nie Zun of the past. Although he was cold and distant at first when he just regained his memories, I knew the Nie Zun of the past had returned when I saw him put his hands in his pockets.

The only exception was that while he was cold and distant to everyone else but me in the past, he was cold and distant to literally everyone right now.

There must be something else going on here.

Cang Ming stuffed that handkerchief back into his robe. Though it looked like he was putting it back without much thought, I could see that he handled that handkerchief pretty carefully.

I guess he really loves Bian Ying.

Yes, I believed that this handkerchief belonged to Bian Ying. *Would he have cared so much if it didn't?*

"You think I'd believe you like this? How are you connected to this demon cave? Huai Du sent me here for you, and this shows that he's taken an interest in you. You should know that Huai Du wouldn't send me for menial tasks. If he asks me for a favor because of you, I'd like to know why."

I interrupted this presumptuous man. "He wouldn't send you for menial tasks? Would that be because he knows that you aren't even able to complete them properly?"

Instead of getting angry, Cang Ming looked amused. "Woman, you have to know that I don't follow any rules. I might not follow his orders even if he sends me to complete certain tasks. I change my mind whenever I want to, and Huai Du knows this too, so he doesn't send me on errands that often."

Isn't this what I just said... That you aren't even able to complete your tasks properly...

I raised a brow. "Oh, but according to what you've said, then he shouldn't have assigned you on this errand. Nie Zun is unpredictable enough. Wouldn't the situation be made worse if you join in as well?"

Cang Ming smirked.

Gaoqin Jiuye looked at Cang Ming as he answered me, "Because Huai Du knows Nie Zun is unpredictable, he got someone equally unpredictable to go against him. This is why he sent Cang Ming.

"In terms of MF, intelligence, or in finding unorthodox solutions, Cang Ming is the only one who fits the criteria. He's willing to take this risk even if there's no way he can predict or control what happens."

This Huai Du was so highly-praised that I'm beginning to feel a little scared.

Nie Zun spoke. "I'm just an ordinary person. There's no need for you people to take out the big guns."

Cang Ming regarded him with a sideways glance. "If that's really what you think, then there's no need for us to make each other's lives difficult. We can settle this in a peaceful manner. You should know what I'm here for anyway."

I frowned inwardly to myself. *What did that mean?*

Though I knew Cang Ming was here for Nie Zun, I was still rather upset at being unaware of everything that seemed to be happening.

Nie Zun had that indifferent look on him, as if he did not have a care in the world. "What are we supposed to settle? I don't know what you're here for. You're not here to get paid for healing my face, are you?"

It was obvious that Nie Zun was playing the fool now.

Cang Ming laughed loudly. “Nothing. You can tell me what you plan to do next.”

“Leave this place.” Nie Zun’s gaze was as still as deep water.

Cang Ming waved a finger. “That can’t do. I received orders to stop you from exiting the demon cave.”

Gaoqin Jiuye interrupted suddenly, “Oh, is that your goal? You don’t look like someone who listens to orders. I think you’re just trying to make use of the opportunity to find a way to save Bian Ying.”

Cang Ming narrowed his eyes as he regarded Gaoqin Jiuye with what looked like slight admiration. “That’s absolutely right. I don’t even have to do much since everyone I’m looking for is right here.” He pointed a finger at all of us.

I raised a curious brow. “I’m one of those you’re looking for?”

“No need to pretend. I’ve already said this before. Do you think that I wouldn’t give it a shot after hearing about how your second personality might be able to save my woman?”

I pointed at Nie Zun, Gaoqin Jiuye and myself. “Do you think you’d be able to get anything from the three of us if we work together against you?”

“I have no interest in working together with you. Count me out of whatever you guys are plotting,” Nie Zun said coldly.

I frowned at him.

Something was definitely amiss. There was no need to cut off all ties with me like this.

Cang Ming’s gaze brushed past Nie Zun’s waist. “How about this. Give this to me and I’ll let you leave this place and do whatever you want to.”

He pointed at Piercer that was now hanging on Nie Zun’s waist.

Nie Zun seemed to have forgotten about Piercer. He looked surprised when Cang Ming mentioned it, and he even looked down to confirm Piercer was on him. He then looked at me.

I met his eyes and spoke without hesitation. “What, are you confused about this? Or have you already forgotten what happened during the period you were an amnesiac? You stole Piercer from me during that time.”

Nie Zun answered unhurriedly, “I haven’t forgotten.” I thought he might return Piercer to me after that, seeing that he didn’t seem to care about anything right now.

Instead, he took Piercer and threw it at Cang Ming. “You said I can leave this place without obstruction if I give this to you.”

Cang Ming grabbed Piercer in midair. “You have my word.”

I believed Cang Ming wouldn’t stop Nie Zun since he had given his word.

This didn’t have anything to do with me. But Piercer belonged to me. I let Nie Zun be when he lost his memories, since he was just like a child who acted on his whims and fancies.

But he had regained his memories now, and there was no need for him to use my belongings as collateral even if he was being cold and distant to me.

I walked towards him. “If I remember right, you’ve regained your memories now. If there’s nothing wrong with your brain, you should have recalled that this item belongs to me. You’re just giving it to another person instead of returning it to its rightful owner? Am I invisible to the both of you?”

I could compromise on some things, but there are certain things which I would never back down from even if it was against Nie Zun.

“Nie Zun, that belongs to me. Did you even consider my feelings when you gave it to somebody else?” I frowned at him.

Nie Zun's gaze was inscrutable as he spoke calmly. "Why should I have to consider your feelings? It's better for me if I give it to him and get you guys off my back. I don't remember who it belonged to, I just know it happened to be in my hands."

I was quite riled up by that emotionless delivery. "You don't remember who it belonged to? Haha, how forgetful. You even belonged to me in the past. Now you're deciding to cut off all ties just because you've lost your memories once? And you're even giving away my belongings?"

I was a little emotional at this point, but it wasn't exactly because he gave Piercer to Cang Ming. I just couldn't stay cordial because of that cold and distant attitude he had towards me right now.

Chapter 231: 231 Fighting over Piercer

Volume 4

231 Fighting over Piercer

Nie Zun spoke with no emotion. “There’s no use in you throwing a tantrum here.”

Putting his hands back into his pockets, he walked away towards one of the water vats.

I pulled on his sleeve. “What do you mean by throwing a tantrum? Return Piercer to me if you’re going to leave.”

Actually, it did look like I was throwing a tantrum here. But I didn’t care about that. All I knew was that I didn’t want him to disappear right in front of me.

Nie Zun looked at my hand that was on his sleeve. “Piercer is no longer with me. You should be looking elsewhere.”

I said stubbornly, “You threw it at Cang Ming. I want you to get it back for me.”

Nie Zun furrowed his brows.

Just when I thought Nie Zun was about to say something to hurt me yet again, Gaoqin Jiuye rushed over and took me into an embrace.

There was a fire in his eyes and he was so quick that I didn't have enough time to react.

A kiss landed on my lips.

This was the first time Gaoqin Jiuye put his lips against mine.

I was absolutely stunned.

He retreated just as quickly. Looking at me with fiery passion, he said, "Let him go. I can help you get Piercer back. Leave everything to me in future."

His words seemed to explode right beside my ears.

It was lucky that I was no longer that childish Li Shen, the one who would be bedazzled after a single kiss.

As I tried to calm myself, I stole a glance at Nie Zun, noticing that he had stopped in his tracks. He seemed to be taking note of Gaoqin Jiuye and me.

I looked at Gaoqin Jiuye again. Though his eyes were bright and clear, something seemed to be amiss.

Gaoqin Jiuye was audacious, but he wasn't someone who acted on impulse. Even though he had confessed to me before, there was no need for him to do this.

Was he doing this to confirm if Nie Zun still had feelings for me?

Was he such a kind individual?

I felt Gaoqin Jiuye's lips touch mine again.

There was a wet softness to it as his tongue explored my lips.

I couldn't accept this kiss even if he was really trying to help me.

I stole another glance at Nie Zun before deciding if I wanted to avoid this.

Just when I could almost make out Nie Zun's expression, something else distracted me.

The source of that distraction came from countless images flashing past my mind. Coupled with those images were feelings of being helpless and terrified.

I could not focus on Nie Zun's expression at this point. All I could do was to look into Gaoqin Jiuye's eyes which were right in front of me.

White fog surged in them and it looked just like he was controlling the air currents around him.

Before I could react, I heard a voice in my head.

"Ah Shen, you have to stab me with this knife if I turn into a devil and lose control someday."

"Ah Shen, I'm giving you this knife. Keep it with you at all times. I'll be waiting for the day when you finally end this."

"I love you, Ah Shen, even if you might find out that I'm not me someday. You aren't who you thought you were either. Please remember that I, Gao Qi, really loved you."

My lips quivered as thousands of voices seemed to appear in my head. Gaoqin Jiuye hugged me harder, and just as my lips were about to be pried open, Nie Zun pulled the two of us apart.

There was a dark killing intent in his eyes. He stood between us as he said in a low voice, "Don't even think of using whatever I've used a second time."

He stared at Gaoqin Jiuye sharply.

Gaoqin Jiuye kept his eyes on me. He looked a little exhausted as he spoke. "I don't care about that. I'm going to take whatever you don't want. What can you do about it?"

He shot a sharp look at Nie Zun.

Sizzle.

Two blades of air pushed Nie Zun's hands away, forcing Nie Zun to step backwards.

I retreated a couple of steps as well.

Gaoqin Jiuye looked at me with furrowed brows, as if asking why I stepped back.

None of them knew that I didn't feel like talking right now, because all my energy was focused on Gao Qi's words that I had just heard. *What did that mean?*

I didn't even flinch at those hurtful words Nie Zun said as I was too preoccupied with piecing together what I could find in my memories.

In those images, Gao Qi took me in an embrace on the balcony as I felt his lips meet mine with sorrow. His voice seemed to stab right through to my heart as he spoke.

"Ah Shen, you'll have to kill me if I turn into a devil someday. You have to kill me in exchange for your freedom. You should never go there."

As I recalled his words, I looked at Gaoqin Jiuye and asked, "What did Gao Qi know? Just how are the both of you related to each other?"

Gaoqin Jiuye's eyes seemed to shine. "What do you remember?"

I answered immediately, "Are you afraid that I'll remember?"

"I've already explained this to you, haven't I? I'm the one you loved, not Gao Qi. Gao Qi had fallen in love with you as well, and to protect you, he was ready to give everything up."

"What do you mean he was ready to give everything up?"

“It’s...” Cang Ming swung Piercer suddenly before Gaoqin Jiuye could finish.

Crack.

Violet sparks appeared and a violet blade flew towards me.

I’ve never thought that my own weapon would end up attacking me someday.

I raised Scorpion Ray on my left hand.

My brain was on overdrive now. *Why did Cang Ming attack? Was it some secret that he didn’t want me to know? Is this why Cang Ming decided to interfere?*

But before I could even ask further questions, I had to win this.

“Scorpion Ray!” I called out. Light condensed in front of me to form a screen.

It shattered like glass upon contact with the violet blade. With that, the power of the violet blade was reduced as well.

In the smoke and dust, I heard air currents whirling around me. *Had Gaoqin Jiuye been controlling the air currents all this while?*

Does this mean that both Scorpion Ray’s and Piercer’s attacks would be affected?

I could see streaks of black amidst the white fog that appeared. The streaks looked like strands of hair floating in the wind.

Looking towards Nie Zun, I realized one of his hands was already outside of his pockets, looking like it was simply resting by his side.

I backed away in the chaos.

I couldn't understand any of them. Though it seemed like I might have the key to breaking this gridlock, I was actually entrapped in it myself.

"I guess there are some things you don't wish for me to know." I smirked at Cang Ming as I said so. *Why else did he attack so suddenly if it wasn't to prevent Gaoqin Jiuye from speaking?*

Piercer was glowing with a violet light as Cang Ming held it in his hand. I stared at Piercer as I focused MF on my thoughts, *Come back to me if you don't want to be used by them. I can help you find Zou An.*

I didn't know if this would work, but I had to try whatever I could think of. Unexpectedly, Piercer seemed to be able to sense my thoughts.

Piercer glowed brightly and Cang Ming's eyes darkened as he was forced to let go of it.

Now's the time.

Stretching out my left hand, I created something resembling a whirlpool with my palm. Piercer flew towards it, looking like a purple snake that was flying through the air.

Just as it was about to reach me, a dark mist wrapped itself around Piercer like a pair of gigantic hands.

I reached out in haste to grab Piercer's end.

A numbing pain shot through my palm all the way to my heart. The drug applied to Piercer was no ordinary one, and it jolted me wide awake as I saw the blood seep out from my palm.

Nie Zun was pulling on Piercer at the other end with his hand that was enshrouded in black mist.

I focused MF onto my hand as I pulled Piercer hard towards me.

Nie Zun was also pulling hard on the other end as we engaged in a fierce tug-of-war with Piercer being pulled taught in the middle.

Chapter 232: 232 Big Gold Rooster's Scheme

Volume 4

232 Big Gold Rooster's Scheme

I stared at Nie Zun, ignoring the pain in my palm. “Even if you don’t love me anymore, is there a need for you to try this hard at snatching what’s mine?”

Nie Zun spoke calmly, but he did not let go of Piercer. “This item will only bring misfortune to you. It’s not entirely bad if you give it away.”

Just when I was about to argue, I heard an eerie scratching sound.

Looking around, I realized those faceless creatures had us surrounded. They looked like chimeras crawling on the stone walls as their long hair covered their white faces.

“What are these?” Gaoqin Jiuye frowned.

Distracted by those creatures, I lost my focus on Piercer for a moment, leading to Nie Zun being able to win our tug-of-war. I looked at him angrily, but he was keeping an eye on those faceless creatures on the wall.

Those creatures had also gotten Cang Ming’s attention, who was about to engage me in a fight just one minute ago.

The faceless creatures were the ones producing those scratching sounds as they crawled slowly. There were many more of them here, and they seemed to be moving with purpose this time.

Though I've been in the Split Zone long enough to forget how fear felt like, it was still natural for humans to be afraid of the unknown. The fact that these creatures suddenly appeared made me feel a little uncomfortable.

As I was lost in my own thoughts, two of the creatures started to combine with each other. Both of them seemed to straighten up as their hands, faces and hair wrapped around each other.

It was eerie.

What happened next was even weirder. The two creatures melted into each other and turned into something new.

This new creature was standing in a weird position. He had beady eyes and he looked unshaven as he stood on one leg with his arms outstretched on both sides.

"Big gold rooster..."

Big gold rooster stared at me. "Why do you have to be so annoying all the time? Big gold rooster sounds horrible."

I flashed a smile at him, not realizing that there was something amiss. "You didn't say anything when I called you that previously. Oh yes, why are you here now? Didn't you say that you're afraid to go to the glacier?"

Cunning light flashed in big gold rooster's eyes. "The situation is different now. My precious daughters smelt something delicious, and there's no way I can deny them of a good meal as a father, can I?"

What? My precious daughters? As a father?

I stared at him open-mouthed while he casually petted one of those faceless creatures near him.

"These things are your precious daughters?" I asked while pointing at those faceless creatures on the wall.

Big gold rooster ignored me this time as he turned to Nie Zun. “I couldn’t tell earlier, and I didn’t expect you to be the demon cultivating vessel. Since I helped out earlier, shouldn’t you show your gratitude by filling the stomachs of my precious daughters too?”

What?

Nie Zun, however, did not seem to be as surprised as I was. He looked as if he had already anticipated something like this to happen. “Sadly, I’m not as delicious as you think I am.”

Big gold rooster cackled. “A vessel personally picked by the Ghost King. Even though you’re still not complete, the MF of my precious daughters would still increase ten-fold by eating you. I’ll then never have to be scared of stepping into this glacial land anymore.”

Nie Zun was a vessel chosen by Huai Du? So... the real purpose of this demon cave was to cultivate demons?

Cang Ming spoke suddenly. “Have you been going around with your eyes closed recently, golden rooster? Did you not see me? Or are you pretending not to have seen me?”

A look of surprise appeared on big gold rooster’s face as he turned to Cang Ming. It didn’t look like an act.

What happened next was a total eye-opener for me.

Big gold rooster’s head dropped to the ground immediately upon seeing Cang Ming.

It looked just like an apple falling from a tree, and I could hear the thud when it hit the ground. Big gold rooster was now balancing on only his head while his legs were still in that one-legged position in the air. He sounded a little different now. “This servant was blind not to have seen Lord Cang Ming.”

Cang Ming seemed to be extremely satisfied with this display. “That’s more like it. But, why are you here?”

Big gold rooster answered quickly, “To answer Lord Cang Ming’s question, my precious daughters sensed an external presence on this glacial land. I came over to take a look immediately since protecting the land is my duty.”

I almost choked at his nonsense.

Capturing intruders? You were the one who actually helped Nie Zun and I get here in the first place, so why are you acting all responsible now? Are you afraid of Cang Ming?

But listening to what he said, he seemed to be indirectly working for Huai Du, since he’s Cang Ming’s subordinate.

Cang Ming lost his smile and spoke threateningly, “You know I don’t like it when others lie. I’m not deaf nor am I blind. Didn’t you come here for him?” He pointed at Nie Zun.

Big gold rooster’s back was facing us, and I thought he wasn’t able to see Cang Ming, but he responded immediately. “Yes, I did. As expected of Lord Cang Ming, nothing can escape your eyes. Please forgive me. I did come here in search of the demon cultivating vessel, but I have no intention of betraying the Gate of Ghost. I didn’t know that this individual was someone you had your eyes on.”

I looked at those faceless creatures which were now motionless on the wall. I suddenly realized that these ‘precious daughters’ of his might actually just be an extension of himself.

Though they had no eyes, they definitely had the ability to sense what was happening around them. Did he actually send them to surveil us earlier?

Cang Ming smirked. “Aren’t you daring? This is a body of consciousness personally picked by the Ghost King.”

Upon hearing this, big gold rooster jumped back onto his feet to face us. His hands were clasped together as if he was begging for sympathy, but those beady eyes and that face of his made him look absolutely disgusting.

Big gold rooster begged, “Lord Cang Ming, please allow big gold rooster to assist in completing Lord Ghost King’s mission!” He clapped his palms together right after saying this.

With that clap, sharp claws appeared on the hands of those faceless creatures. They sank their claws deep into the stone walls, as if they were embedding themselves there.

At the same time, all of them opened those huge mouths they had.

I’ve seen their rows of tiny teeth once, but the only way to describe the current scene was that they literally had bloody, huge mouths.

All of them were stuck onto the walls with a huge mouth on their faces. I could smell the rotten blood from them, and they looked like gigantic rafflesias.

Big gold rooster obviously took pride in this show of his precious daughters’ abilities as he said, “Lord, no need to be afraid of these intruders. My precious daughters will be able to take them on easily.”

I laughed to myself. *That wasn’t very intelligent of big gold rooster if he was trying to get Cang Ming on his side.*

As expected, Cang Ming’s expression turned dark. “Are you joking? Who would I be afraid of going up against? Who in the Gate of Ghost would even dare say that I’m afraid of anything?”

Big gold rooster was stunned for a moment as he realized he might have angered Cang Ming. But he continued quickly, “Lord Cang Ming, what I meant was that there’s no need for you to waste more time here if you have the help of my precious daughters. Everyone here is simply a waste of time anyway.”

Cang Ming squinted at him. “Do you know what I’m planning?”

Big gold rooster looked stumped at this. He stuttered, “You, you, you, aren’t you here to look for the demon cultivating vessel? This servant is aware that it has been many years since an almost-perfect vessel like this appeared in the Gate of Ghost. Although my lord rarely meddles in such worldly affairs, I’m of the opinion that my lord might have taken an interest in this particular body of consciousness this time.”

They were referring to Nie Zun, but I felt a little upset at how they were talking about him.

Nie Zun wasn’t some object. *Who gave you people in the Gate of Ghost the right to toy with him like this? And why are so many of you trying to take him for yourselves?*

Cang Ming laughed. “That old fogey Huai Du did get me to look for the demon cultivating vessel, but do you really think that I’d appear here if I had nothing else to gain from this?”

Chapter 233: 233 In Denial

Volume 4

233 In Denial

Big gold rooster was again stunned at what Cang Ming said, but he regained that uncanny smile of his quickly. “I understand, Lord Cang Ming. I’ll help you capture all of them right now.”

He signaled to his precious daughters behind. The faceless creatures seemed to turn into those plants in the game Plants vs Zombies. Their heads turned to face Nie Zun, Gaoqin Jiuye and I as they readied their aim.

I raised my left arm in anticipation of an attack. My spine was tingling with unease as I saw these weird creatures taking aim at us.

“Hey, Cang Ming, you’re not planning to have this big gold rooster subordinate of yours attack us with those disgusting creatures, are you?”

This was merely a stalling tactic, but instead of answering me, Cang Ming spoke to Nie Zun. “I won’t go back on my word. But Piercer...”

Nie Zun smiled as he interrupted Cang Ming. “I’ve already given it to you earlier. You’ve also promised me, so this means it’s a done deal. It’s none of my business if you weren’t able to keep Piercer with you. I’m not planning on giving it to you a second time now.” Nie Zun waved Piercer in his hand as he spoke.

The old Nie Zun really seemed to be back this time.

Instead of getting angry, Cang Ming regained that devil-may-care attitude as he signaled to big gold rooster that he can go ahead with his attack.

Scorpion Ray was at the ready. No matter what those disgusting faceless creatures did, I was ready to riddle them with holes.

Sadly, things do not always go as planned.

Those creatures produced a blood-red mist from their mouths.

When I readied myself for an incoming attack, I suddenly felt myself floating into the air. Like a magnet, I was floating towards those creatures, as if I was being sucked in.

I saw Nie Zun in the same situation as I looked up.

Nie Zun looked slightly confused. It seemed like he didn't know what caused this either.

“Hey.” I was about to be sucked into one of those mouths now. Nothing good would be waiting for me in that bloody mouth. I focused my MF as I grabbed Nie Zun's hand. At the same time, I took that red teleportation pill in my other hand.

I didn't know if this would work, but I knew that I needed that pill now.

Not only did I not want to enter that bloody mouth, my instincts told me that everyone here had their personal agendas. Though Cang Ming was here on Huai Du's orders, my gut told me that his target was actually Nie Zun.

Things like the demon cave, demon cultivating vessel and demon cultivating tablet – all of them had something to do with Nie Zun.

Even if he had turned into a devil, I can't let Nie Zun become a tool in this fight. I won't let anybody manipulate or hurt him.

The red pill glowed faintly as I poured my MF into it.

A faint ruby light surrounded Nie Zun and I. We were no longer being sucked into those mouths as we levitated in midair.

“Teleportation pill...”

Gaoqin Jiuye sounded surprised.

Before I could turn to look at Gaoqin Jiuye, I saw confusion on both big gold rooster and Cang Ming's faces.

"Where did you get this? This is something that belongs only to Si Luo," Gaoqin Jiuye said coldly.

Something that belongs only to Si Luo...

But this was given to me by Jiao S...

There isn't much to wonder about here. I believed that Si Luo loved her.

"Hey, Li Shen, where are you going?" Gaoqin Jiuye sounded anxious as he rushed towards Nie Zun and I.

The light seemed to condense around us before it exploded.

Though it felt like I was spinning way too quickly, I never let go of Nie Zun.

I heard Gaoqin Jiuye's sorrowful voice from somewhere. "You're still abandoning me even after I've shown you my heart? You're still leaving me like this?"

I wanted to tell him that I simply wanted to keep Nie Zun away from danger, that I wasn't choosing to abandon him.

But I didn't. Even if I did, he wouldn't have heard it anyway.

My head seemed to be spinning for more than ten minutes now, and it did feel like I was passing through time and space.

I was in a foreign place when I finally opened my eyes. Nie Zun's left hand was gripped tightly in my right.

I met Nie Zun's eyes as I looked up slowly.

Nie Zun's gaze looked gentle, but his words were harsh when he spoke. "You should let go now. Or are you that hungry?"

I let go of him slowly as I took a look around me.

We were in a real palace this time. This wasn't some stone room, it was really the hall of a palace.

This place was huge. It looked to be about a thousand square meters with pillars made of sandalwood, glazed walls and jade lamps. Pearls were used as floor-length curtains for the huge windows.

A bright pearl was shining in the middle of the hall, looking like a full moon as it levitated in the air. The floor was made of white jade with golden engravings of lotus flowers.

Looking inside, a silk gauze curtain seemed to be fluttering as it covered a golden throne that had a dragon engraving on it.

Such a beautiful palace was a rare find even in the real world.

Though it looked beautiful, there seemed to be no one else around.

"Where is this place?" Seeing that there was nobody around, I naturally lowered my voice, as if I was afraid of being caught.

Nie Zun's hands were back in his pockets and he looked indifferent as usual. "I don't know."

"This is really nice. I'm not dreaming, am I? Or did that pill have with it powers of illusion?" I blinked as I took in the sights of this luxurious palace. I might have lost my mind.

Nie Zun sounded annoyed as he said, "You might really be dreaming. But I know that I'm wide awake."

"If you're awake, it means that I'm awake too." I rolled my eyes at him.

“Let’s go and have a look.” I naturally pulled on his sleeve as I began to head towards that silk gauze curtain.

However, Nie Zun did not move.

I turned to him. “What are you doing? Don’t you want to find out what’s going on here?”

Nie Zun glanced at me. “What do I have to find out? It’s that pill of yours which brought us here. What else do we have to find out?”

“There are still many things we don’t know about this place. Just where is it? Why did the pill take us here? Could you work with me just once? Just sometimes?” I looked at him with furrowed brows.

If it was the Nie Zun of the past, he would have said in the gentlest of voices, “Alright, I’ll accompany you just this once.”

But he isn’t like this now.

“You can go explore on your own if you’re that curious.” Nie Zun brushed my hand away before walking towards the main entrance of the palace hall.

The palace hall was huge, and judging from his pace, he wouldn’t be able to reach the entrance that quickly.

This meant that I still had hope.

I rushed forward with the intention to block his path and get him to accompany me to go further in. However, something seemed to possess me when I saw that dark, lonely figure of his.

I ran straight into his back and took him in a tight embrace.

As the side of my face leaned against his cold back, I thought I felt him flinch a little.

I held on tight as I said, “Don’t leave me...” *Oh, Li Shen, when have you become this pitiful?*

Was this love?

I have never done something like this, even if it was towards Gao Qi.

Nie Zun did not move. He simply stayed still and let me hug him.

He remained silent and still, as if he was fossilized. This gave me slight joy.

If he hesitated at this point, it meant that he might still have feelings for me.

After what seemed like a long time, he spoke hoarsely, “You’re really, annoying...” Though his words were harsh, I found his voice warm and gentle.

I might really have gone mad.

People say women are idiots when in love. This might just be me hallucinating, and he might not feel anything for me at all. I might just be in denial.

Chapter 234: 234 Hiding in the Palace of Cold Blood

Volume 4

234 Hiding in the Palace of Cold Blood

I didn't mind being an idiot right now.

I was still hugging him tightly as I said, "That's right. I'm just so annoying..."

Nie Zun seemed to freeze for a split second before turning around suddenly. He leaned in close as he grabbed my arm.

I felt his bangs brush against my forehead as he closed in, an arm reaching for my chest. I frowned as I felt the pinch.

"This is what you want, right?" He spoke with cold sarcasm.

I remained perfectly still as I looked at him. I could see everything with perfect clarity. This was no illusion.

Even though he spoke harshly, he could not hide those lonely and sorrowful eyes of his. I bit my lip as I let him do as he pleased, not saying a single word.

After a while, he let me go. I thought I saw tears in his eyes. My vision seemed to blur as well, making me unsure who was the one crying here.

We were both silent now, but an enchanting voice came from somewhere near the entrance of the hall. It sounded like it came from outside the hall.

Nie Zun reacted quickly and pulled me behind one of those huge pillars in a corner. The pillar was big enough that it could hide the both of us behind it.

White light shone in when the doors to the palace hall opened, making its interior shine even brighter. I squinted slightly as I focused MF on my vision, trying to get a clearer look.

I was quite shocked at what I saw. *These two...*

There were two individuals who walked in. They were in identical floor-length brown robes with their faces covered in black chiffon masks. Those demonic eyes could not be obscured by their masks.

Those outfits looked familiar.

I suddenly realized these were the women who were in that underground stone room when we were looking for Laurel previously. *But didn't they die in there?*

Even though they were far away from me, I would definitely be able to recognize those demonic eyes anywhere.

I could hear their conversation from where I was.

“We don't know when owner will be back. If owner isn't back soon, we'll have to keep looking at those trashy things. Those trashy things are really stubborn. We can expect death if one of them manages to escape from here.”

“Haha, that's right. But there's no need to worry, *jiejie*. They are merely heirs from the outside world. Even if their abilities are extraordinary among heirs, it's nothing in this Palace of Cold Blood. Owner is wise to have locked them up separately. You know where they are too. Do you think they'll be able to do anything on their own?”

“Hmm. I know that, but I'm still a little uneasy. Owner was so serious about getting us to keep an eye on them, so I'm just afraid that something will go wrong.”

“It’s alright, *jiejie*. Owner will be back very soon. We can always get the shaman to contact owner anyway.”

“Enough of that nonsense. What right do we have to contact owner like that. Let’s just be patient.”

“How many of those reformed bodies are favored like *jiejie* is? Haven’t you seen the new batch? They’re all trying to emulate you. This shows that owner sees *jiejie* as important.”

“That’s sweet of you. You’re not bad either. There’re others who’re following your example too. Let’s support each other, *meimei*. We’ll definitely be rewarded like this.”

“Yes, *jiejie*. I’ll listen to *jiejie*.”

They sounded like concubines in the royal palace. But if my eyes were not fooling me, that *meimei* was the one who poured those leeches on Song Lu in that stone room.

Seems like this *meimei* has some tricks up her sleeve.

From their conversation, the owner they were referring to seemed to be Du Yue, since this is the Palace of Cold Blood. As expected of Jiao S’s teleportation pill, it brought me right here.

Jiao S might be trapped and her MF might be under some form of restriction. If it weren’t, I should have been able to reach her immediately.

If this was the Palace of Cold Blood, then those trapped heirs they were talking about should be referring to my friends as well.

Though I was upset at hearing that conversation, it gave me quite a bit of information. At least I now know they’ve been locked up separately. This would make a rescue attempt much more difficult especially when I still didn’t know where they were.

Du Yue wouldn’t know that I’ve teleported here so quickly, since I was in the demon cave just moments ago. This means I had an opportunity to save

them.

I guess the only way to find out where they were was to capture the weird women who just appeared.

Nie Zun held me back just as I was about to peek my head out from behind the pillar. I met his eyes as I turned, seeing him shake his head at me.

All that anger and anxiety in my heart seemed to simmer down at this.

Though I wasn't able to understand what he was really getting at, the fact that he held me back made me calm down. As I pondered, I recalled something important.

I wasn't sure if those women in that stone room were the same ones in front of us now. At that time, the women chose death over being captured. If I were to show myself now, Nie Zun and I would immediately be exposed, and we might not even be able to get any information from the two of them. Moreover, we were in enemy territory.

We had to have a proper plan for this.

I retracted my foot, which had been peeking out from behind the pillar earlier.

Seeing me calm down, Nie Zun began to let go of me, but I grabbed him tightly instead. He looked at me before refocusing on the two women. He didn't do anything else.

At this, I continued grabbing his hand tightly as a smile formed on my face.

The two women had not realized that there were two strangers peeking at them from behind a pillar as they walked over to that silk gauze curtain.

"We have to keep this clean. Owner looks upon this throne as a prized possession." The one who was addressed as *jieji* lifted a corner of the silk gauze carefully as she bent down.

“Chirp...” A beautiful chirping sound emerged from behind that silk gauze. A bright, white light appeared before a translucent, icy phoenix flew out. Its feathers looked like beautiful white crystals as it flew into the air, producing snow that fluttered around it.

I had never seen such a beautiful bird in real life.

From the looks of it, it resembled the legendary ice phoenix. The ice phoenix was gentler than the fire phoenix and it was a creature which always looked cold as it left a trail of snow wherever it went.

“Oh my. What’s wrong with this precious baby today? It usually doesn’t want to leave the throne.”

As the two ladies started running towards the ice phoenix, it seemed to be flying straight at Nie Zun and I.

This was bad.

However, I saw Nie Zun staring at the eyes of the ice phoenix. *Right, Nie Zun’s pupil abilities.*

I wondered if Nie Zun’s ability would hurt that beautiful, living creature. It’s not often that I could see creatures like these which weren’t human in the Split Zone. Even if I had, they were all monsters which had the intention to kill me. I suddenly felt a little pity for the creature.

Nie Zun’s eyes churned like a deep lake, and I subconsciously squeezed his hand. He seemed to sense it as his pupils enlarged. At the same time, the ice phoenix also sensed something and flew in the opposite direction immediately, going towards the two women.

“My dear creature, what’s wrong with you today? Why are you playing like this?” The two ladies were at a loss when they saw the ice phoenix flying in circles near the ceiling.

I guess this ice phoenix is no simple creature.

“This won’t do, *jiejie*. It doesn’t want to come back at all.”

“We can’t leave it as it is though. We’d be in hot soup if it flies out the door. It’s a precious treasure of owner’s. Isn’t it weird though? For two years, it has always stayed on that throne. Why is it so lively today?”

“This is why I’m worried. How about we get it back with MF?”

“Oh *meimei*. We can’t be hasty. We’d be in greater trouble if we end up hurting it. It might be missing that fire phoenix. How about we lure that fire phoenix here?”

“Are you joking, *jiejie*? You know the temper of that fire phoenix. We can’t even tame this ice phoenix and you think you can lure that fire phoenix here?”

“That’s true... What do we do? How about we go get the high priest?”

“That’s a good idea. Let’s go look for the high priest. She’s still an outsider even though she’s highly-favored. If anything happens, we can just push the responsibility to her.”

“Yes, let’s go.”

Chapter 235: 235 Ice Phoenix

Volume 4

235 Ice Phoenix

Lifting their robes, the two ladies rushed out of the hall. As they walked, the *jiejie* asked the *meimei*, “The ice phoenix wouldn’t fly away once we open the door, would it?”

“It wouldn’t. Look, it’s just flying around in circles right now. We have to make use of this time. It won’t fly out the door so quickly.”

“Right, let’s move quickly and get the high priest here.” They then ran over to the entrance.

Creak...

A bright light blinded me as the door opened. I lifted a hand to shield my eyes, and the two ladies were gone before I knew it. I stepped out from behind the pillar and looked at the ice phoenix which was still flying in circles above.

That ice phoenix seemed to be able to understand humans. After the ladies left, it flew straight at me.

I focused MF on my vision and saw that it had a pair of bright, transparent eyes, just like an ice sculpture. However, those eyes did not belong to a human, and I couldn’t sense its emotions simply by looking at them.

It flew across the great hall directly towards me, but I had no intention of avoiding it. For some reason, I had a good feeling about this creature. I wanted to see what it planned to do next.

The ice phoenix did not slow down at all even when it was about to reach me. Right at that moment, Nie Zun pulled on my right hand as he appeared on my right suddenly.

I didn't let him pull me away this time. I didn't even blink when that ice phoenix arrived right in front of me.

It stopped in the air suddenly, hovering with those outstretched, icy wings. It was staring at me.

It was so beautiful. I couldn't help but smile at those bright and clear eyes that looked like crystals. "Are you able to understand me?"

"Chirp..." It called out softly.

Overjoyed, I reached out a hand to caress the creature's head. An icy cold spread from my palm to my heart as the creature did not avoid my touch.

"It can actually understand me. Nie Zun, come and have a look." I turned to Nie Zun in surprise. His eyes seemed to shine a little at this.

"Hmm, what should I ask? You... are you an ice phoenix?"

"Chirp..."

"Is Du Yue your owner?"

I thought this was an ordinary question, but the ice phoenix seemed to get a little agitated at this as it flapped its wings.

"What's wrong?" I frowned. The ice phoenix seemed to fear the words 'Du Yue'. I could see a hint of fear in its eyes. It was a kind of raw fear that could be seen in all living things.

"Chiiiiirp..." The ice phoenix called out again. This time, it ended on a much sadder note as a tear formed in those crystal eyes.

I felt heartbroken for it. "What's wrong, ice phoenix? Did Du Yue lock you up against your will?"

The ice phoenix remained silent this time. It kept flapping its wings, as if it was reminiscing some sorrowful past.

“Don’t worry. How about this, you can follow me, and I’ll protect you. Or, I can take you away from here.” I spoke gently to this pitiful ice phoenix.

Nie Zun suddenly said, “It’ll believe you if you make casual promises like this. Animals are different from human beings. Furthermore, this ice phoenix is no ordinary animal, it’s a divine creature. We can’t even keep ourselves safe in this foreign place and you’re here making promises that you might not be able to fulfil? Isn’t that a little too cruel even to a bird?”

He sounded calm and indifferent, as if he was simply talking about the weather instead of criticizing me.

“That’s true. But I can still give it hope even if it is a phoenix.”

I furrowed my brows. “Nie Zun, you weren’t like this in the past. You didn’t look at everything like there was no hope to be found. Just what happened during that blood-changing process in the demon cave?”

A bitter smile appeared on Nie Zun. “Wasn’t I exactly like this in the past? It’s you who didn’t understand me. I’ve always been like this. I’ve never carried hope in my heart for anything.”

“Even towards me? You’ve never hoped for anything?”

Nie Zun’s eyes shone as he answered, “Yes, even towards you.”

I laughed.

I flashed a brilliant smile at him as I shrugged. “Nie Zun, look at how strong I am now. I’ll no longer be upset at those words of yours. It isn’t because your words don’t matter to me anymore, but it’s because I have hope. I believe that there’s definitely some reason that you’re doing this. I believe that I’ll find you again, that I’ll let you rely on me like you did in the past, that you’ll trust me again. Because I love you.”

I said those last words very lightly, and I could see the gentleness in his eyes as he looked at me.

It didn't matter to me even if these words didn't change anything right now. If loving him meant that I had to fight a long battle and climb a high mountain, I was willing to do just that.

I swear that I will never be afraid again. I will never go back on that same path I did when I killed Gao Qi. From the moment I admitted to myself how I felt about Nie Zun, I made a decision that I'd continue loving him no matter what.

"You weren't like this in the past either. You've been really direct and open recently. Is this because you're not satisfied?" Nie Zun asked suddenly.

I smiled. "Seems like you've become pitiful too. Why is that? You're not willing to tell me why you're avoiding me and you're trying to suppress everything in your heart again? That's okay though. I have time."

I turned back to the ice phoenix and said gently, "Are you willing to come with me? Call once if you are. If you aren't, you can call out twice."

"Chirp..."

I smiled at Nie Zun. "See? It's willing to come with me. It should be given hope."

"What do you plan to do next? You, me and the creature, do we just walk out of here?" Nie Zun asked.

"Do you have any ideas? Aren't you rational, intelligent and a great problem-solver? Even if we aren't a couple now, there's no need to be this selfish and keep those ideas to yourself, is there?"

"I'm just asking. It's none of my business whatever you plan to do." That coldness emerged in his eyes again.

I didn't mind it.

It doesn't matter. From now on, I'm going to stick to you whether you like it or not.

I wanted to be brave for myself, just this once.

I was too cowardly and naïve and in the past, weren't I?

You were just like that too, weren't you?

“Ice phoenix, I don't know your name yet. You can't talk, so you can't tell me either. I guess I'll just have to give you a new name, alright? Hmm... what should I call you? Right, how about *Bing'er*?”

It was nice and simple, and it matched that translucent body perfectly. (T/n: *Bing'er* can be roughly translated to 'little ice' since the Chinese character for ice is *bing*.)

“Chirp...”

Bing'er looked happy. That tear in its eye was gone now.

“Okay now. Although I don't know what happened to you here, but you have to believe that I'll be able to bring you out, okay? It's just that I've just arrived here and I don't know this place as well as you do. It might be difficult to escape from here, but you'll still have to believe in me, alright? I'll definitely take you away, okay?”

I petted its head again.

Sorrow seemed to fill its eyes again.

Nie Zun seemed to be slightly irritated as he addressed Bing'er, “Can you fly out of this palace on your own? Call out once if you can, call twice if you can't. I'm referring only to your ability to do so.”

“Chirp...” Bing'er called out softly.

“Hey, don't be so cold. You're scaring it,” I scolded Nie Zun.

Nie Zun ignored me as he continued with his questions. “I heard those two ladies say that you’ve been here for a while now. Is there some reason that you are not able to leave this place?”

“Chirp.” It was a short, sharp call, as if it was replying in an anxious manner.

Nie Zun continued after a short pause. “Those two ladies were talking about a fire phoenix earlier. Are you worried about that fire phoenix?”

“Chirp...” Bing’er called out as it raised its head.

Nie Zun turned to me. “Do you understand? Seems like that fire phoenix is being locked up too. Either way, it can’t leave the fire phoenix, and this is why she’s not leaving this place. My guess is that Du Yue manipulated these phoenixes by making use of their feelings for each other.”

“Du Yue is really cruel.” The hatred I had towards Du Yue wasn’t new. But it seemed to deepen because of this little phoenix now.

“Are you able to take us to your fiery partner?” I even made a bird with my hands, afraid that Bing’er wouldn’t understand me.

“Chiirrrrp...” It was the first time Bing’er gave a negative response. Its eyes drooped as it did so.

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Nie Zun glanced at me. “Are you an idiot? If it could bring us out, why can’t it fly out on its own? Would it still be locked up like this?”

I scratched my head. “But those two ladies talked about luring the fire phoenix over, so that would mean that it still had some freedom to roam, isn’t it? Those ladies wouldn’t have said that if it really was trapped somewhere. Why can’t the two phoenixes meet then?”

Bing’er looked anxious as its eyes shone brightly at what I just said.

It seemed to be anxious because it wasn’t able to explain what exactly happened.

Nie Zun asked something which stunned me, “Were you human before?”

I turned to him in surprise, and little did I expect that Bing’er would actually answer him so quickly.

I looked at Bing’er again. Though this wasn’t the first time that a body of consciousness turned into something that wasn’t human, I’ve only seen them turn into horrific monsters. I couldn’t believe that somebody could actually turn into such a beautiful phoenix.

“You, you, you, how did you know it was a human?” I stuttered as I asked Nie Zun.

He answered calmly, “There are no phoenixes in the real world, it’s simply an auspicious representation in the form of a bird. No matter how weird the Split Zone is, there’s no way something can exist here if it doesn’t even exist in the real world. Weren’t those monsters all bodies of consciousness originally? Some of them might have been merged using a technique similar to Rong Jin’s as well.

“From the looks of it, the ice phoenix wouldn’t have appeared here without rhyme or reason. This is why I deduced that it could have been human before. Put simply, it is also a body of consciousness. Except that it turned into a creature, and we don’t know the reason behind that yet.

“Li Shen, nothing exists in this world without a reason. Everything that exists has a purpose. Do you know that?”

He didn’t sound like he was criticizing me. Instead, he sounded a little helpless when he said that.

I wondered if my ears were fooling me.

But that was not important at this very moment. The point was that I have not heard him analyze things in such a calm and rational manner in such a long time.

Why did I not cherish the moments in the past when he used to do this?

I only realized his importance and how irreplaceable he was when I lost him.

I missed this intelligent and rational side of him so much.

I stopped myself from going forth and hugging him as I said, “What you said made sense. But why did it become like this...”

In an attempt to lighten the atmosphere, I went ahead and asked a question I knew Nie Zun wouldn’t be able to answer.

Nie Zun resumed his one-sided conversation with Bing’er. “Was that fire phoenix a human too?”

“Chirp...”

“Did the both of you become like this because of Du Yue?”

Bing’er did not give an affirmative response.

Nie Zun was not surprised at this, and he actually looked like he had already anticipated the answer. “Then, is it Huai Du who did this to the both of you?”

I didn’t know why he mentioned Huai Du all of a sudden. But what surprised me more was Bing’er’s affirmative response this time.

“What’s happening?” I asked Nie Zun hastily.

Nie Zun ignored me as he let me stew in anxiety. He continued talking to Bing’er unhurriedly.

“Is there a way to save you and that fire phoenix?”

“Chirp...” Though Bing’er answered positively, it called out so softly as if it was not confident of the possibility of success.

“Great. There’s no need to worry as long as there’s a way to do so. Follow us from now on, and protect us whenever needed. We’ll look into this, and we’ll try to save your little friend while we save ours.”

Nie Zun sounded a lot gentler as he said this. I even felt that he sounded rather adorable when he said ‘your little friend’. (Passerby A: Beauty is in the eye of the beholder... Me: That’s none of your business.)

I was still immersed in Nie Zun’s voice when he pulled me back behind that large pillar. He slapped an arm across my throat to prevent me from making any sound.

He said softly, “Someone’s here.”

Bing’er reacted very quickly as it turned and flew towards the ceiling.

Creak...

The two robed ladies appeared again, this time with another woman in front of them. That woman was dressed in a sequined top and a mini skirt with her midriff exposed.

I looked at that woman's slender legs and that tiny waist. What a pair of...

I froze when I saw her face.

There was no need for Nie Zun to stop me from moving, because I was stock-still.

I was literally rooted to the ground.

That woman who looked enchantingly beautiful with a face full of make-up was none other than Song Lu.

Is this really Song Lu?

How can it be Song Lu?

My mind was in a mess.

Song Lu had been missing for a while now, and she was the very person I was trying so hard to find. But I wasn't able to go forth and hug her even when she's right in front of me.

Wasn't she taken away by Li Wen? Why is she in Du Yue's Palace of Cold Blood?

"High Priest, this is the ice phoenix. As you know, it has been with owner for a long time, and it has always been very tame. But it's being naughty now and it refuses to go back under that curtain. We had no choice but to report this to the high priest in the hopes that you would be able to make a decision on this matter. If we leave it be, it may just fly out the door someday. Both *meimei* and I will be as good as dead if that happens."

I didn't expect that serious *jiejie* to actually be able to talk about this so casually.

A cunning light shone through Song Lu's eyes. That light complemented that enchanting outfit and perfect body of hers, drawing others to her like moths to a bright flame.

Her lips turned up in an angle, and though she spoke seductively, that killing intent was apparent in her voice. "You mean to say that this treasure is now acting like a spoilt child who's refusing to listen? And, since owner loves it so much, the both of you can't use force on it. But you're afraid it might fly away, and you don't really know what to do about this, so in the end, the both of you have decided to push that responsibility to me?"

Though her words were not friendly, they were not threatening either.

The *jiejie* dropped to the ground on her knees. "The High Priest is wise, there's nothing that escapes you. It's not that *meimei* and I were lazing around, we just went to take a short break. I hope my lord will forgive us for our sins."

High Priest.

Song Lu is the High Priest?

Is she working for Du Yue now?

Could she have been brainwashed by Du Yue during that experiment?

But wasn't she taken away by Li Wen previously? If Li Wen's aim was to take her to Du Yue, why did she have to stop us at that time?

Or did Li Wen use Song Lu as a bargaining chip in exchange for something from Du Yue?

I suddenly felt angry about this.

Song Lu had been through so much, and it was all because of me.

Instead of addressing the *jiejie*, Song Lu turned to the *meimei* who was still standing. “You’re not anxious, are you? Seems like you got some guts there.”

The *meimei* smiled with upturned eyes. “If the High Priest can see through us that quickly, there’s no need for further apologies. We’ll do whatever the High Priest wishes.”

Song Lu blinked and leaned in close to the *meimei*. “I’m guessing that you’re trying to differentiate yourself from her, are you? Tsk, tsk, sisters you are. You seem to be too ambitious for your own good. You should go through some torture.”

The *meimei*’s smile seemed to freeze at this, but she continued stubbornly, “Please don’t tease us like this, High Priest. *Jiejie* and I depend on no one but each other, so there’s no way I would step all over her to differentiate myself. Isn’t that right, *jiejie*?”

The *meimei* looked at the kneeling *jiejie* with a sincere gaze.

The *jiejie* seemed to have been momentarily distracted as she said, “Oh yes, that’s right, High Priest. Though this *meimei* of mine might have some tiny tricks up her sleeve, she’s not a bad person. We’ve been relying on each other in this Palace of Cold Blood for so long, and I’m sure that wasn’t what she meant.”

Song Lu folded her arms in front of her chest, as if she was enjoying a show. “That’s up to you then, if you choose to believe her. I’m not getting involved in this. Haha, but if you really get killed by her one day, just remember that there was a high priest who reminded you of that possibility.”

The *jiejie* looked resolute, even after all that Song Lu had said. “I’ll remember the teachings of the High Priest, but I believe in *meimei*.”

Seeing her being adamant, Song Lu shrugged as she walked over to that silk gauze curtain.

“So this little one is being naughty now.” Song Lu smiled as she walked, her boots clicking against the floor as she moved with those beautiful and slender legs.

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“Oh right.” Song Lu stopped before reaching the inner area of the palace hall. She turned to the two ladies as she said, “The both of you can leave now. I’ll handle it from here.”

“This...” The *jiejie* and *meimei* looked at each other, at a loss for words.

Song Lu smiled beautifully as she raised a brow. “What? Do you still have questions for me? Don’t you remember what owner said? Everyone in the Palace of Cold Blood should heed my orders when she’s not around.”

I was surprised when I heard this. Counting silently, I realized that Song Lu had already been missing for more than half a year. It wasn’t that long, but she’s already in Du Yue’s good books.

I felt a little upset at this, not because I felt betrayed by Song Lu, but because I couldn’t imagine just how much Song Lu had to endure under someone like Du Yue in order to climb to such a position in such a short amount of time.

It felt like I hadn’t seen her in forever.

She was all alone here in this time without us, without Yu Liang by her side.

Yu Liang had been protecting her all this while, but she had to face this all alone. I wonder how lonely she must have felt.

As I wondered about this, I looked up, trying to get a better look at Song Lu.

But Song Lu suddenly shot us a look, making me flinch. I retreated behind the pillar as quickly as I could. My heart was racing, but Song Lu did not say anything.

She might not have seen us then.

“Still not going out?”

“Yes. As the High Priest wishes, we’ll leave now.” Shortly after, I heard the door open. The two ladies seemed to have left.

Click click click.

Those boots clicked against the floor again.

Click, tap, click, tap, click.

My heart started racing again, as if it was beating to the rhythm of those boots.

There were only the three of us left in the palace hall now. Nie Zun usually looked like a statue when he was calmly waiting for something. He was exactly like that in this moment, standing silently, unmoving.

Click, tap, click, tap, click.

I wondered if I was hallucinating as I thought I felt those steps coming closer and closer to me.

Song Lu finally spoke just when I wondered if I should peek my head out from the pillar.

“How long more do the both of you plan on hiding?”

My eyes widened. At times like this, I’d usually look toward Nie Zun for help.

I did the same thing this time. Looking up at Nie Zun, I saw a calm and indifferent expression on his face, as if nothing had happened.

In the next moment, he walked out from behind the pillar.

Seeing him step out, I followed closely behind.

I was a little anxious.

It wasn't some stranger I had to face right now. This was Song Lu who had to go through so much because of me.

I felt so sorry towards her.

I looked up slowly.

Her eyes squinted in a smile on her heavily made-up face. Her smooth, curly hair fell across her shoulders as she folded her arms across her well-endowed bosom.

"It's been a long time, Li Shen."

She sounded so natural when she greeted me.

She addressed me as *Li Shen*.

I didn't say a single word among those which were already hanging on my lips. *How are you? I'm sorry, it's all my fault. Yu Liang is still alive, and I'll help you look for him. Everything will be okay.* I didn't say any of this when I heard her call me *Li Shen*.

I forced myself to smile at her. "Yes, it's been a long time, Song Lu."

She seemed to be satisfied with my response. Still smiling, she addressed Nie Zun this time. "You too. It's been a long time, Nie Zun."

Nie Zun smirked. "There's no need for this pretense, is there?"

Song Lu shrugged casually. "I'm just being polite."

Everything she did was enchanting.

Song Lu was a femme fatale. In the past, she liked to dress in conservative clothes and be in black from head to toe, showing very little of her skin. Right now, she was a completely different person.

“Chrip...”

The ice phoenix suddenly called out from its perch on one of the wall lamps. I looked at it first before turning to look at Song Lu, wondering how she would react.

Song Lu did not react to this.

She had a lazy expression on her face as she smiled slightly. “This little thing is being so naughty. I guess I’ll have to handle it first before we can have a proper conversation.”

Nie Zun said quickly, “We should catch up first. It’s really been quite a while.”

Song Lu glanced at him with those beautiful eyes. “Alright, we’ll do just that then.”

I couldn’t bear to watch this.

After having gone through so much, I really wanted to be someone who could be calm and rational at times like these, but I just wasn’t a calm and rational individual.

Moreover, this was the man I loved and a woman I loved. One of them had changed so much, while the other was being so cold and distant.

And the both of them seemed to be speaking in riddles now.

I had to interrupt them.

I looked at Song Lu. “Song Lu, tell me what happened that made you become like this. I know I let you down, but I hope you’ll be able to give

me a chance to make it up to you. I know it was my irresponsibility that caused you and Yu Liang to end up like this. It's all my fault."

Song Lu put on a surprised face. "How can this be your fault? Li Shen doesn't ever admit that anything is her fault. *Meimei*, you're over-thinking things. I've realized that Yu Liang and I aren't suitable for each other at all. I should be thanking you for enlightening me on this."

I was about to go crazy.

It was okay even if she viewed me as the enemy, and I could bear with anything but this.

Yu Liang belongs deep in her heart. I wouldn't let her kill that part of herself like this.

"Stop pretending, Song Lu. I know this is all my fault. I just hope that you can give me one more chance to help you save Yu Liang."

Song Lu seemed to get a little impatient at this. "How many times do you want me to say this? I've realized that we're not compatible. He doesn't have anything to do with me now, and I no longer love him."

Her words pained me. I stepped forward suddenly, trying to close the distance between us. I stared into her eyes. "Stop joking. I'll believe anything you say, except this. I'll never believe that, not even after I die." Being slightly agitated, I choked a little on my words.

While I watched her say she didn't love Yu Liang in that emotionless tone, I was reminded of Nie Zun's cold and distant face that day when we were in front of that demon-cultivating tablet.

Don't begin loving someone if you decide you don't want to love them suddenly.

Why give the other party happiness in your company when you're going to say you don't love them so easily in the end?

Be it Nie Zun or Song Lu, I could never accept such a thing.

Or rather, I could not believe this.

There's not enough love in this world to go around. If what you refer to as love couldn't be counted, what else can we then cherish in our hearts?

This is why I chose to believe that they had their reasons for doing so.

But I wasn't intelligent or rational enough to wait for the right moment where you can explain it all to me.

What I want is for you to be honest right at this moment.

Song Lu laughed casually. "Why is that impossible, Li Shen? Not everyone can be happy like you. Even when you aren't doing anything, there will still be others who're willing to protect you. We don't have such a blessed life, so nothing is impossible to us. Not even parting with our lovers."

So you actually refer to him as your lover...

I looked at her resolutely. "I don't want to hear all this. What I want to know is what happened to you in the time we were separated?"

She looked at me with a mysterious smile.

After about ten seconds of pondering, I saw those red lips move. "Nothing. I was just being transferred from the hands of one woman to the hands of another. I haven't gained anything nor have I lost anything."

"You haven't lost Yu Liang? Are you willing to tell me what happened between the two of you?" I decided to ask her directly.

She laughed out loud. "He became an experimental subject after being captured, and I became a killing weapon. Are you satisfied now?"

Though I was heartbroken, I pretended to be calm as I continued. "What else?"

Song Lu continued laughing. "You really want a blow-by-blow account of what happened, do you?"

I smiled in response. “Yes, because I’ve lost two very important friends during this time. I’m going to give whatever it takes, even if it’s my life, to get them back.”

Song Lu’s smile faded a little.

“Very important friends, huh. Yes, it’s these very important friends who have been waiting for you to rescue them. But you’ve just been going about your daily life after forgetting about them.”

I knew she would bring this up, but I had to bear with this for now.

“Song Lu, whether you believe it or not, I swear that I’ve been looking for you. I would give everything, except that I just wasn’t able to locate you no matter how hard I tried.”

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Song Lu did not want to hear me continue. She waved a hand and said, "There's no need to talk about all that. What's past is past, and I'm living quite well now as Du Yue's High Priest in the Gate of Heaven. I have power over everyone else here, and it's much better than when I was in the Western District."

Seeing the rush of emotion in her eyes, I stopped talking. *There's no use in rushing things. She must have been through so much pain.*

I decided to change the subject instead. "Since you're the High Priest in this Palace of Cold Blood, you must be on the same side as Du Yue now. Do you know what her goal is?"

Song Lu smiled. "Li Shen, you've said it yourself. Since I'm on the same side as Du Yue now, do you think I'll tell you that? Why are you guys here anyway? As the High Priest in the Palace of Cold Blood, I can't let intruders get away scot-free."

Nie Zun responded, "But you've not attacked and you've even let her speak."

Song Lu looked at Nie Zun with an appreciative gaze. "Nie Zun is still as intelligent as ever. Observant and always quick to react."

"Chirp..." Bing'er called out again, as if it was trying to warn us of something.

A mysterious smile appeared on Song Lu's face. "I guess I have to teach this creature a lesson before I can go against the both of you."

Go against the both of us?

Before I could react, she was already headed towards the inner area of the palace hall.

Worried about Bing'er, I turned to Nie Zun with unease. But Nie Zun was not intending to stop Song Lu at all, and he acted like this had nothing to do with him.

In my anxiety, I went after Song Lu.

Tap, tap, tap, tap, tap.

She seemed to be walking faster and faster, and it felt like I had to chase after her.

"Song Lu."

"Li Shen, we can talk later." Song Lu addressed me without even turning around.

"What are you going to do to Bing'er? It's just an ordinary bird." I grabbed Song Lu's arm as I caught up to her.

She seemed to flinch slightly at my touch, and I wondered if it was me just hallucinating.

"Haha, an ordinary bird? If you can tell it's a body of consciousness, do you think that I, as the High Priest, wouldn't be able to tell? Li Shen, there's no need to act so childishly even if you want to save someone." She stopped in her tracks as she said this.

She then continued with a smirk. "No wonder you weren't able to save us. If you're trying to save people like this, it's no surprise that you'll lose them."

She seemed to have placed more emphasis on those last words.

I thought I didn't mind this, but in all honesty, it was upsetting to hear harsh words from someone who used to be so close to me.

I didn't know what to say to her, and she continued on her path towards the ice phoenix.

Bing'er flew up as it seemed to sense her looming presence. With a flap of those snowy wings, it flew straight towards Song Lu.

Song Lu remained perfectly still, reacting exactly as I did earlier. She then asked me, "You like this phoenix?"

I nodded, before saying yes when I realized she wasn't able to see me nod.

"Haha, good. I'll destroy it."

I didn't expect for Song Lu to say something like that.

She must hate me so.

She grabbed the air with a hand.

Lifting that hand, she swung it towards Bing'er.

Though her arms were not very powerful, the beads of water that came out from her palm seemed to fly towards Bing'er at great speed.

I squinted my eyes as I focused MF on my vision to see how fast those beads of water were going. But I was too late to do anything about it.

Bing'er stopped in mid-air, staying still like a statue as those beads of water were about to reach it. I reached out a hand, trying to stop whatever might happen, but it was just a futile attempt on my part.

All of a sudden, a black ray passed through those beads of water, shattering them all. Looking like beads of mercury, they dropped to the ground abruptly.

I turned to Nie Zun and saw that he was using his pupil abilities.

Song Lu did not sound upset, and she turned to praise Nie Zun instead. “Great pupil ability. You’ve always been hiding it, but you’re finally willing to use it now?”

Nie Zun smiled casually as he pointed at Bing’er. “Don’t scare that little creature there. It isn’t very brave.”

Song Lu laughed out loud. “Little creature? Isn’t very brave? I guess the both of you really know nothing at all.”

Her expression turned cold in the next second. “This creature can never leave the Palace of Cold Blood. This is an order from Du Yue.”

I looked at Bing’er, wondering if it could understand all that was happening. I tried to change the subject again in an attempt to stall Song Lu’s attack on Bing’er.

“Tell me, where are Yu Liang and the rest?”

Even though Song Lu said she didn’t love Yu Liang anymore, I didn’t believe that she’d really leave him for dead.

Song Lu’s unexpected response surprised me. “Yu Liang is here?”

I frowned. “Aren’t you the High Priest in the Gate of Heaven? Don’t you know that Yu Liang is being locked up by Du Yue right now?”

Song Lu regarded me with doubt in her eyes. “Are you kidding? I know that your friend from the Eastern District is here, but I’ve not heard Du Yue say anything about Yu Liang being here as well. I do know that he survived that catastrophe in the Western District though.”

I nodded. “When we were in the Gate of Ghost, Du Yue told me that Yu Liang is in the Gate of Heaven. I’m guessing that he’s being locked up just like Jiao S and the rest. I want to save them. Are you able to provide me with their locations?”

Song Lu's brows furrowed. "There's no way I'm betraying Du Yue. As for the two of you, don't think you can escape easily once you've stepped into the Gate of Heaven, especially now that you're in the Palace of Cold Blood. As for whether Yu Liang is here or not, I'll be looking into that."

"Where's Jie Pa?" Nie Zun asked suddenly.

Song Lu regained her indifferent expression upon hearing this. "Your doctor is fine, no need to worry about him. You should take care of yourself instead. He seems to be really worried about you."

I was stunned at what happened next.

Nie Zun seemed to have teleported right in front of Song Lu as he grabbed her neck. "I'll ask you one more time. Where is he?"

Something flashed in Song Lu's eyes, but she remained silent.

Black fog began to rise in Nie Zun's eyes. This was a sign of Nie Zun turning demonic, and this meant he was ready to destroy everything in his path.

I rushed forward to grab him. "We're all friends. You're not an amnesiac now, so there's no need for this. Song Lu will tell you where Jie Pa is if you ask nicely."

Nie Zun then let go of Song Lu slowly.

Song Lu smiled at me. "Li Shen, Nie Zun seems to have changed. Why is that? Are the both of you no longer in love? Are the both of you like Yu Liang and I now?"

This made me feel a little uncomfortable, but it wasn't the time for such a discussion. I spoke quickly, "Song Lu, can you tell us where Jie Pa is being hidden? At least this friend of mine can go take a look at him."

Song Lu brushed her hair aside unhurriedly. "How about we make a deal?"

Nie Zun and I responded immediately as we heard the word 'deal'. "Okay."

Such telepathy made my heart jump with joy. I stole a glance at Nie Zun, but he was focused on Song Lu right now.

“What deal do you have in mind? We’ll try our best.”

Try our best? When did you start seeing me as being on the same team?

Song Lu smiled as she answered, “It’s easy. I’ll bring you to Jie Pa if you leave Piercer with me.”

She was referring to Jie Pa, not to the group of friends who were being locked up.

I realized Nie Zun and Piercer were the two things which were the most valuable in the Split Zone at this point.

Many have been looking for me because their goal was to find them. But this meant that all these people were of the opinion that the both of them belonged to me.

As I was pondering about this, Nie Zun took Piercer from his waist and waved it at Song Lu. “There’s no need for an introduction, is there? It’s not like you haven’t seen this before.”

Song Lu’s eyes narrowed upon seeing Piercer. “That’s right, it’s Piercer. What, Li Shen gave it to you because she doesn’t want it anymore?”

I responded coldly. “He snatched it from me. But what do you want Piercer for?”

Song Lu stretched lazily. “Who doesn’t want a powerful living weapon like this? Power is what we rely on in order to survive in the Split Zone. There are only a few living weapons, and it’s probably impossible that any new living weapons would appear. Why wouldn’t I want it if given an opportunity?”

I replied immediately, “It belongs to me, sadly. And I don’t intend to give it away.”

Chapter 239: 239 Endless Stairs

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239 Endless Stairs

I snatched Piercer from Nie Zun immediately.

Nie Zun did not resist this time.

He glanced at me. “I guess you’re never going to give up if this item is with me. Take it back if that’s the case, and stop following me from now on. Also, I’d suggest for you to leave it. It brings nothing but misfortune.”

Holding Piercer, I said, “Thank you for the reminder. When did you start talking so much?”

Song Lu smiled as she interrupted, “How about this, Li Shen, I’ll do something else for you. If you leave Piercer with me, not only can I bring Nie Zun to Jie Pa, I can bring you to Jiao S as well. What do you think?”

Bring me to Jiao S?

I knew nothing about the Gate of Heaven, and it was best if I could save them before Du Yue returns.

That seems fine too. It was Nie Zun who suppressed the female soul in Piercer previously, and I might not be able to use it well in such a short time. I can just give it to her first.

And... no matter what Song Lu had become, she’s still a friend to me. I’d rather give it to her than give it to anybody else.

I threw Piercer at Song Lu after I made my decision.

Song Lu caught it and said, “You’re really nice to Jiao S. You compromised really quickly when you just said you wouldn’t give it away just moments ago.”

I looked her in the eye. “I won’t hesitate if I could get you back in exchange for Piercer either. But there was no one who made an offer like this when you were missing.”

There was exhaustion in Song Lu’s eyes as she hung Piercer on her waist. “Let’s go. I’ll keep my word.

“But, this phoenix...” She turned to take a look at Bing’er, which was perched on a lamp.

Song Lu waved a hand at Bing’er as it called out with a chirp.

I was focused on Song Lu’s hand since I wanted to stop her attack, but there was no indication of an oncoming one. In the next moment, I heard Bing’er call out again.

Bing’er struggled as it was trapped in a ball of water in midair.

“What did you do to it?” This was definitely caused by Song Lu.

Song Lu continued towards the exit as she said, “It won’t die. You can choose to either stay here or come with me to see Jiao S. Decide.”

Nie Zun shot me a cold look before catching up to Song Lu.

Gritting my teeth, I turned back to Bing’er and said softly, “Bing’er, I’ll be back. Wait for me.”

I ran up to Song Lu after that.

Song Lu blinked as she saw me. “It’s difficult, isn’t it? You’re always like this, trying to save everyone. But Li Shen, you aren’t the messiah. Choices

have to be made sometimes, and if you've acted like today, who knows, I might not have ended up like this."

A familiar image popped up in my mind, but it was something I did not want to recall.

Though I felt bitter, I calmed myself down before answering Song Lu. "You're right. But you got one thing wrong. I've always known what I was doing, from the very beginning. It's just that you might not be aware of this."

It was obvious Song Lu did not understand what I was getting at.

I looked her in the eye as I decided to tell her what exactly happened. "I had to make a choice, causing you to be taken away by Li Wen. I didn't hesitate at that time. You were unconscious, and Jiao S's life was in Li Wen's hands. She wanted me to choose between the two of you. At that time, I chose Jiao S because her MF was already depleted, and I let Li Wen take you away."

Song Lu turned pale.

I bit my lip. "I wouldn't say I regretted it, because I might do the same thing if I'm faced with the same situation today, since it was more critical to save Jiao S at that time. Just like today, Jiao S is in a more dangerous situation now, and like what you said, I didn't hesitate to make a decision.

"Song Lu, I'm grateful that you're telling me I have to make difficult decisions, because if no one thinks like this, there might be nobody else who can empathize with me. I don't know what you've been through in this time, but I know that I was the one who let you down since I made that choice. You can blame me for that, but you can't say that I didn't make a choice."

A bitter smile appeared on Song Lu's pale face. "I get it now. You're trying to say that you simply didn't choose me, and it's not that you didn't know how to make a choice."

I nodded and said, "Yes."

But, why did I feel so heartbroken after I said so?

I didn't want Song Lu to feel upset about this, and although it did sound like Jiao S was the only one I cared about and that I didn't care about her at all, I had no choice but to put it this way.

And I did choose Jiao S in that situation.

“After we got separated, have you seen Yu Liang again?”

I brought this up in a feeble attempt to change the subject.

Song Lu turned away from me to look in front. I couldn't see her expression from where I was.

“No, I haven't seen him at all. I haven't heard any news about him being in the Gate of Heaven either, so I was rather surprised when you mentioned it earlier. But I've said so previously, that I don't love him anymore.”

I remained silent.

I have already decided that I had to bring Yu Liang back to Song Lu.

All of this happened because of me, and I'll be the one to end it all.

Creak...

The door of the palace hall opened easily.

A blinding white light flooded the hall. It was so bright that I had to shield my eyes from it.

I looked outside as I got used to the brightness. It was different from how I imagined it to be. Instead of a street, we were met with stairs that led underground.

It was like a bottomless pit that was welcoming us, and we were walking into that abyss voluntarily.

“Didn’t expect the layout outside of the Palace of Cold Blood to be this unique.” Nie Zun spoke after being silent for quite some time.

Song Lu smiled enchantingly. “Is that so? Actually, the outside of the Palace of Cold Blood doesn’t look like this, and the two ladies didn’t come in from here either.”

“You mean you created these stairs?” I looked at the steps. It was a spiral staircase, and we weren’t able to see more than a few steps ahead of us.

“Please, go on ahead.” Instead of answering me, Song Lu directed me towards the stairs.

As I was about to step forward, Nie Zun said, “We’re not familiar with this place. How about you lead the way?” My foot crept back slowly at this.

Song Lu shrugged and said, “Sure.” She stepped onto those stairs in her boots shortly after.

I glanced at Nie Zun, but he did not return my gaze. We then continued on the path without looking at each other.

The door to the palace hall closed behind us. I thought it sounded a little different from when it opened.

Click, click, click.

Song Lu’s boots clicked against the floor with crisp sounds.

Though I was in kitten heels, my sandals were light and they rarely made a sound even when I hopped or jumped around.

The spiral staircase seemed to continue on forever.

The three of us were silent as we walked, and this made me more anxious. I have never liked such silent atmospheres. Therefore, I decided to start a conversation.

What should I talk about?

Should I tell Song Lu about Yu Liang?

Wait, why did I even think of that?

Am I supposed to tell her that yes, I have seen Yu Liang just once in this time when he engaged us in a three versus one battle in order to force me to look for you, and that he's also turned into a monster where his hand can turn into a tentacle?

What a dumb idea it was.

I can't say this.

What should I say then?

What if I talk about how to use Piercer?

Forget it. That might sound like I'm going back on my word.

Just when I was cracking my head thinking about possible topics to talk about, I happened to catch a glimpse of Nie Zun.

He seemed to be stealing glances at me from time to time.

He turned away just as I looked at him, as if he had never been taking notice of me at all with that indifferent expression of his.

For some reason, I felt joy at being able to look at his side profile like this. I didn't care what he turned into as long as he was right here beside me.

In my heart, he was still Nie Zun.

I didn't notice Song Lu turning to me as I was being too focused on Nie Zun. "I guess you no longer hide your feelings now. But this makes me more confused. Li Shen, if you can stare at Nie Zun like this, why aren't the both of you together already?"

Chapter 240: 240 Underground Prison

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240 Underground Prison

Nie Zun answered while I was still wondering how to respond. “We had already been together once.”

Turning red, I said, “There’s no need to go around announcing this.”

Nie Zun blinked at me in mock innocence, but I could tell he was teasing me with those eyes of his. “Did I say anything wrong? Weren’t we together as lovers once?”

Gritting my teeth, I said, “I know what you’re trying to get at. Just continue pretending like this.”

Song Lu asked with genuine surprise, “You were together once? Why did you guys get separated then?” There was a hint of that adorable Song Lu of the past as she posed her question.

Well, there’s no real need to hide this anyway. I thus answered without hesitation, “Because he lost his memories.”

Song Lu looked shocked at this. She turned to Nie Zun. “You lost your memories? Do you still remember me then?” She even waved a hand in front of Nie Zun, as if he had turned blind.

Warmth emanated from my chest as I saw the kind Song Lu in this very moment.

Sometimes, pain can temporarily change a person, but it's difficult to erase somebody's personality entirely.

I didn't give Nie Zun a chance to answer this time. "He has already regained his memories, it's just that he's changed a lot. Probably because he ate something that was unclean." I was still upset at how cold he was acting towards me.

There seemed to be a hint of a smile on Song Lu's face, and I wasn't the only one who realized this. I could tell that she realized it too. Her face froze a little when she found herself talking to me just like in the past. She turned around and said, "We're arriving soon."

Shortly after, we arrived in a dungeon-like place at the end of the spiral staircase. There was a square room separated by iron bars on one side. This place did not look like a modern prison at all. It looked like a dungeon used in medieval times.

There were arms trapped in the iron shackles that were connected to the wall. The woman currently trapped in those shackles should be Jiao S, though I couldn't see her clearly from where I was.

She was seated leaning against the wall, dressed in white. Her head hung and she was completely still. I wanted to call out to her, but I hesitated, unsure if it really was her.

Song Lu kept quiet as she looked at me, as if waiting for my next move. Just as I was about to call out, the woman in the cell lifted her head slowly.

Rendered speechless, I covered my mouth in shock upon seeing her face. It was definitely Jiao S, but she had no eyes. Her eyeballs were replaced with two black holes, and those huge eyes of hers were gone.

The first time I saw those eyes, I was afraid, and I even hated them. But slowly, I found myself liking them. I couldn't believe that those emotionless eyes were nothing but two bloody holes now.

Pale, dry lips moved on a blood-streaked face. "Is it... Ah Shen?"

I couldn't bear it anymore as I heard her feeble voice. Rushing forward, I grabbed onto those iron bars. "It's me. What happened to you, Jiao S?"

Jiao S smiled. "I knew it was you."

I wasn't able to stay calm like her. I turned and stared at Song Lu. "What happened here? What did you do to her?"

Song Lu shrugged. "I don't know. I didn't do anything to her. I'm just in charge of keeping an eye on her. You should be asking her what happened instead."

At this moment, Nie Zun appeared right beside Song Lu. "Where's Jie Pa?"

Song Lu gave an enchanting smile. "Are you worried about that doctor of yours after seeing Li Shen's friend like this?"

Nie Zun smirked, and I saw him take his right hand out of his pocket. "I don't have much patience. You'd better give me an answer, or else I'll wreak this place."

Song Lu pointed at me. "I can only bring you to one individual at any one point of time. If she refuses to leave now, I can't bring you to Jie Pa. How about you ask her if she's willing to leave this place and go to Jie Pa with you?"

She was trying to drive a wedge between me and Nie Zun. She knew how important Jie Pa was to Nie Zun, and how important Jiao S was to me.

Nie Zun just glanced at me coldly without saying anything.

Turning back to face those iron bars, I poured MF into them as I took the opportunity to try and pry them open.

Jiao S spoke softly, "Ah Shen, don't do that. This is different from what we've seen before. Those bars have been enchanted, and MF is no use. It'll just be absorbed."

I did not want to give up just like this, but I felt a cold wind on my palms, evident of MF being sucked away. These iron bars felt like sponges absorbing my MF.

Defeat overwhelmed me. There was nothing I could do when my close friend was trapped in there.

As if she knew what went through my mind, Jiao S smiled and consoled me. "It's alright, Ah Shen, stop trying. I wouldn't be trapped here if I could have escaped earlier. The materials here are all specially-made, and it's like nothing I've ever seen before in the Eastern or Western Districts. You don't have to blame yourself."

Hearing this made me even more upset. I tried grabbing those iron bars again, but that feeling of my MF being sucked away made me let go of them immediately.

Song Lu said in a casual manner, "It's no use. MF does nothing to it."

I turned around to face her. "Then what do I have to do to save her? I'm sure you have a way."

Nie Zun was in front of those bars now as he tried touching them. He spoke calmly. "I think this can only be activated with a key."

Clap, clap, clap. Song Lu started clapping out of nowhere. "What great imagination. Even I might have been fooled."

Nie Zun continued, "You mean to say this gate isn't activated with a key? From the looks of it, I'm guessing you have the key, right?"

I stared at Song Lu.

Song Lu glanced at me before she smirked. "That's right. We do need a key to open this gate here. But you've only gotten half of it right. Du Yue is the only one who has the key to this gate."

Frowning, I asked, "Is there any other way to open it?"

Song Lu remained silent, but she turned to look at Nie Zun. I followed her gaze to see Nie Zun backing away a little before stretching out a palm towards those iron bars.

A rotting smell accompanied the black mist that emanated from his palm. The mist wrapped itself around the iron bars, but nothing happened. Nie Zun then said, “Seems like using the key is the only way.”

Grabbing those the bars again, I tried using mere strength to pry them open this time.

“Do you think you’re Popeye?” I heard Nie Zun’s voice from above me. I met his eyes as I looked up, but this wasn’t the time to be immersed in them.

“Help.” I spoke curtly without much thought, and I didn’t expect him to really help me out. To my surprise, he actually grabbed those bars and tried to pull them apart.

Jiao S then spoke in her hoarse voice. “Stop it, Ah Shen. I’ve tried everything.”

Taking a deep breath, I tried to speak as calmly as I could. “Tell me, who did this to you? And why aren’t you healing? Is it Du Yue?”

Instead of answering my questions, Jiao S said, “That’s not important. Tell me who else is here, apart from you and Nie Zun.”

“Song Lu,” I answered softly.

Jiao S seemed to flinch a little at this.

“Was it... you who did this to her?”

Song Lu still had that enchanting smile on her face. “So what if I did?”

Chapter 241: 241 You're Wrong!

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241 You're Wrong!

Swoosh.

Drawing a circle in the air with Scorpion Ray, I had Song Lu entrapped in a ring of light. I could adjust the size of the ring with the tip of my finger through a string of light that served as a connection between my index finger and that ring.

Song Lu looked rather calm as she remained motionless. "You're a quick learner. Are you imitating the way I controlled the water earlier?"

Focusing MF on my finger, I tried to keep the ring of light stable. "I'm not imitating you, but I did learn something from you earlier. You've never used such a restriction technique in the past, and there aren't many in the Split Zone who use such techniques either. Du Yue is one of them, so it's obvious that you've learnt it from her. The foundation to such techniques is identical, and one can create further advanced techniques with that.

"I used my MF to sense how you controlled yours when you attacked that ice phoenix, committing it to memory at the same time. I'm simply using my MF at the same frequency as yours when I activated Scorpion Ray to create this ring of light."

Song Lu's eyes flashed. "You've always been intelligent. You've never bothered to learn how to manipulate your MF seriously when I tried teaching you in the past. But even so, you've always been able to control it well. I knew at that time that if you were willing to put in more effort, you'd definitely have been able to create stronger and more advanced techniques.

“You’ve improved a lot, seeing that you don’t have a teacher like me. I’m not sure how I fare in the Gate of Heaven, but I know that I’m the best in manipulating MF compared to everyone else in the Eastern, Western and Southern Districts. You’ve made great improvement in the time we’ve been separated. I guess I’ve underestimated you earlier, since it wasn’t that you couldn’t stop me from attacking that ice phoenix, but because you wasted some time in trying to sense how I was using MF.”

I actually had Li Wen to thank for this improvement, since I was able to manipulate my MF much better after that session of meditation. Calculating MF before launching an attack was not a good strategy at all. The real skill lies in using what little MF we have to its fullest extent.

Thus, there was no actual need to calculate the exact MF used for each attack.

“But you’re still a beginner in this, and there is still room for improvement.” Song Lu’s eyes flashed again.

Song Lu was trapped in the ring of light at the other end, but there was a layer of moving water that wrapped around that ring. That water was creeping slowly towards my finger.

“Since you’ve already made a move, is there really a need to go this slowly? If this water is moving so slowly, does it mean that you don’t actually intend to hurt me?” I gave Song Lu a mirthless smile as I kept my eyes on her.

“You’ve really changed, Li Shen. You’re more rational and intelligent now.”

“I was forced to.” After I spoke, I deactivated that string of light immediately.

Song Lu was referring to how I had to use that string of light as a connection to trap her within that ring, while she could easily restrict the movement of the ice phoenix as if through telekinesis.

This was where I was lacking, and this was also why I deactivated that string of light.

A gust of wind howled past me as I grabbed the air with my hand, but that ring of light shattered around Song Lu.

I stared at the broken ring. *I guess I've failed this time.*

Song Lu walked towards me elegantly, making me back away subconsciously.

She drew Piercer as she said, “Do you know why you’ve failed? You don’t have enough power. But you’re pretty good in being able to see that I controlled my MF without needing a connecting factor. You might just be able to do that in future, as long as you practice, but you’ll also have to learn how to manipulate MF more intricately.”

I stared at her as I asked, “Why are you telling me this?”

Lifting Piercer to observe it, she smiled. “Because I’ve never wanted to see you as an enemy. You should know that.”

“Let her go then.” I pointed to Jiao S who was in the cell.

Song Lu caressed Piercer as she continued, “Her? I really can’t do that. I can’t help you with this since Du Yue is the only one who has the key.”

Jiao S spoke. “Leave it, Ah Shen. She literally cannot let me go.”

I was a little agitated as I turned to her. “Why did you flinch when I mentioned her earlier? Jiao S, when did you start saying things like ‘leave it’? When have you become such a coward? There’s no way I’m giving up on you like this, so please don’t give up on yourself either.”

Song Lu flashed a brilliant smile as she heard this. “What an endearing relationship. I wonder how you can save her though.”

Even without her eyes, Jiao S was able to determine where I was as she looked straight at me. “Ah Shen, listen to me. I’m not afraid of anything.

You should know this. It's just that things aren't as simple as you think they are. You can't even imagine the price you have to pay in order to save me. I won't die, so there's no need to worry about me. Don't you trust me?"

"But..." Nie Zun interrupted me before I could continue. "Why can't that rationality and intelligence last for a while longer in you?"

Hearing that reminder, I took a deep breath and forced myself to calm down.

I've been trying very hard to stay calm in situations which had the potential to push me to the edge of my sanity, but I was no holy being and I believed that the only ones who could look at everything with equal calmness was someone who did not have a heart.

As long as we were worried about someone or something, there was no way we don't fear anything.

Those who feared nothing at all were those who didn't care about anything.

I cared too much about everything. The calmness in me came from all that I've thrown away, but there was no way I could turn into a cold-blooded monster. I don't think I did anything wrong.

But no matter how upset I felt, I knew I had to remain calm in this situation.

I turned back to face Song Lu. "What do you want? Just say it."

Song Lu laughed. "Since no one else will come to this underground prison, we can work out an agreement in here. How about this, I'll let you spend some time with Jiao S here while I take Nie Zun to Jie Pa. Though I'm not able to release Jiao S, I can release Jie Pa. Wait for me here if you really want to save her."

Nie Zun responded immediately with a question. "Why should I believe you and leave with you?"

Song Lu looked at him. "Do you have any other suggestions, Nie Zun? Or are you afraid that Li Shen might end up in trouble if you leave her alone

here?”

I turned to Nie Zun, whose eyes seemed to turn cold as he looked at me.
“I’ve got nothing to do with her. I’ll leave with you.”

Though my heart felt like it was being smashed into smithereens, I forced myself to smile. *It’s okay, Li Shen. You’ll be fine on your own. Are you really going to rely on Nie Zun forever?*

Isn’t it great that he’s going to save Jie Pa? Don’t you want him to save Jie Pa?

But... why did I feel so heartbroken?

Did I really not want him to leave, not even for a minute?

Or was it because I would be afraid if he left me for just a minute?

“Let’s go.” Song Lu glanced at me before stepping onto a new set of stairs that appeared behind her. Nie Zun followed closely behind, never turning back.

Jiao S spoke in that coarse voice as I sat on the ground hugging my knees.
“Have they left?”

“Mm.”

“Ah Shen, is there anything you want to ask me?”

With a bitter smile, I said, “I’m sorry. I know that I won’t be able to understand all the pain that you have been through during this time. This is why I’d rather not ask you anything.”

Jiao S seemed to sigh. “Ah Shen, you’re being too hard on yourself, as always.”

My tears started falling. “No, I’m not being hard on myself. I’m being too easy on myself. I hate to see the people around me leave or turn into someone else. But more and more of them have been forced to change

because of my inability and weakness. First it was Laurel, then Song Lu, and now it's you. This is all my fault."

"Ah Shen, I've never changed."

"No." I was crying now. "You've changed. You weren't like this in the past. Because of me, that aura and attitude of yours is all gone. You're not the Jiao S from before, and I know this is all because I didn't come to save you in time. I let them hurt you. Just look at Song Lu, she wasn't like this in the past. It's all because of me that all of you are hurt and forced to change."

"You're wrong." Jiao S spoke loudly this time, using a tone that made it difficult for others to argue with. The old Jiao S seemed to have returned. Hearing her like this, I stopped crying and looked at her.

She regarded me with those black holes for eyes. "Ah Shen, I've never changed. I've always acted according to what the situation requires of me. You can't say that I've changed because I'm not always acting the same. This is your first mistake. Your second mistake is that you're always blaming yourself for everything that happens. Why do you have to take responsibility for everyone's lives like this?"

Chapter 242: 242 Why Would You Be Responsible?

Volume 4

242 Why Would You Be Responsible?

“You’ve always been like this, blaming yourself for everything. Think about it though, if you weren’t here in the Split Zone, would we be free from this pain? Are you trying to make us owe you one by putting the responsibility all on yourself? Remember this, Li Shen, each individual is in charge of their own lives, and that has nothing to do with you at all. Similarly, there’s no one who’s responsible for your life.”

Jiao S sounded serious, and that attitude of hers was apparent as she spoke.

I couldn’t help but end up a little stunned at this.

She continued gently as I did not respond. “Ah Shen, there’s something else you have to remember. No one has changed. It’s difficult to change a person entirely. It’s the same for Laurel and Song Lu. You think Laurel has changed, but didn’t she still save you guys in the end? She saved us. You think Song Lu has changed, but she didn’t imprison you the very moment she saw you, even when she definitely has the ability to do so.

“No one has changed. It’s just circumstance that might be forcing them to act like somebody else, but they haven’t really changed. They might have lost some things, causing a certain part of their personality to be more apparent. For example, they might become more cruel and ruthless. But there’s always a limit to that. Everyone has a limit, and no matter how much they’ve exceeded it, that has nothing to do with you at all. You might be a

tiny factor that caused it, but they will still be the one responsible for themselves.”

For some reason, I calmed down after hearing her say this.

Jiao S sighed again. “I know that you’ve always been hiding ever since you’ve arrived in the Split Zone. You’ve been avoiding things, and that has caused you to lose many things. You blame yourself for it, and this is why you’re forcing yourself to face everything head-on, to the point that you’re trying to take responsibility for everything, even if it has nothing to do with you. But this isn’t your life, it’s ours. Why be so hard on yourself, Ah Shen?”

“I understand that you want to help us, but that heart cannot come from guilt. It’s no longer sincere if it’s guilt that’s driving you. It’s because you’re our friend that you want to save us and help us. It’s because you treat us as your friends from the bottom of your heart that you’re willing to do all this for us, not because you have to take responsibility for us. If you’re trying to take the blame for everything, not only are you being way too hard on yourself, you’ll end up pushing me away at the same time.

“Ah Shen, you’re no longer alone now. You need to learn how to accommodate others and how to borrow their strength, the strength of your friends. You shouldn’t be taking it all upon yourself, you get that?”

Learn how to accommodate others...

“Ah Shen, there’s one thing you haven’t gotten used to ever since arriving here in the Split Zone. You keep thinking that you’re alone. You’re no longer living in solitude like when you were alive. I’ve already realized that, so when will you be able to realize it too?” Jiao S choked a little on her words, and my tears just wouldn’t stop.

She was right.

I was no longer alone. There were always people by my side through both the good and bad times, and we went through it all together. Why did I have to look at myself like a freak which would bring disaster to the rest? Why did I have to keep a distance from the others?

“Out of them all, Nie Zun was the only one who was able to enter your heart. You might not have realized this, have you?” Jiao S continued.

I wiped my tears as I said, “No, I’m clear about that. I’ve been together with him once.”

Jiao S would definitely have looked at me with wide eyes if she still had her eyeballs. “What do you mean by ‘been together once’?”

I answered simply, “That’s in the past.”

“Why did you break up?”

“Because he’s being cold and distant to me all of a sudden. But I believe he has his reasons for doing so.”

“Yes, there must be a reason behind it. To be honest, I used to envy you. I’ve heard a lot about you even before I met you. I envied you for the fact that Li Qing favored you, and I heard that there was always someone following behind you. I envied that too. Don’t you understand, Li Shen? We’re all lonely here, most of us who end up in the Split Zone are. But there have always been others by your side in this lonely place, and there are many who are willing to trust and protect you. You’re definitely lucky.”

Was I the only one who belittled your presence, Nie Zun?

Even though she couldn’t see me, I nodded in response. “Yes, Nie Zun has always been by my side, and I’ve not been able to see that for the longest time. But it was already too late when I realized this. I refuse to fall in love with another, because I’ve caused the death of someone else before. But I can’t let Nie Zun carry this burden from my past. He’s lonely too, so what right do I have to force him like this?”

I looked at Jiao S as I continued. “You’re right, my heart is too fragile. I’ve been looking at everything through distorted lenses. I have to make everything right, everything.”

Jiao S nodded slowly. "It's good that you can look at things like this. Nie Zun isn't like the others, you aren't either. I'm sure of that. Nie Zun is different from everyone else here in the Split Zone. Though everyone is technically different, he makes a lasting impression. In the past, I thought he existed just to protect you, but that doesn't seem like the case now. He is his own person, and he doesn't exist for anybody else. But his heart belongs to you, and you should cherish and protect that."

I smiled as my tears dried up. "It's not only him that I have to protect. I have to protect you too, and many others. I'll not be taking everything upon myself this time, but I can at least protect you guys. This isn't something I feel responsible for, it's something that I want to do from the bottom of my heart."

Jiao S's lips then turned up at an angle.

"Right, can you tell me all that has happened after you ended up here?"

Jiao S's smile faded slowly as she answered, "I'm not sure about the others, since I ended up here alone. I was already in here when I woke up, and Du Yue was the one who gouged my eyes out. I don't know if there's anything else she used, since it's not healing."

"Have you lost the ability to regenerate?"

Jiao S shook her head. "No. I've tried it and realized that I could still regenerate. It's just that my eyes wouldn't. I find it weird though. According to Du Yue, she did this in order to target you. There could be something going on with those eyes, and it's possible that she's using it as bait to lure you over. You have to be careful. You can't be impulsive just because you want to get me out. We could lose everything with just one wrong move. Do you understand that?"

"I get that. But I don't understand what she can do to me with those eyes of yours. She went to the Gate of Ghost to look for me, and I've arrived here with that pill you gave me. She wouldn't have been able to anticipate all that had happened so far. She might not even know that I'm already here in the Palace of Cold Blood, so what else can she do with your eyes?"

“I don’t know either. But are you sure you arrived here through that pill?”
Jiao S asked suddenly.

“You mean I didn’t?”

“Somebody has to create an enchantment over on this side for that pill to work. Tao Lie and Mu Li were the ones in charge of that pill I gave you. How would you be able to come here without either of them?”

“I’ve heard that they’re both in the Palace of Cold Blood too. Du Yue said this to me personally.”

Jiao S had a complicated expression on her face. “Actually, I’ve thought about this. Everyone in the Western District might have been brought here, and I ended up here because I passed out from using up too much of my MF during that fight with Du Yue and Ta Lai. This means that they haven’t seen each other.

“But that doesn’t sound right. If you arrived here with Tao Lie and Mu Li’s help, you would have appeared right before me instead of ending up in some random corner inside the Palace of Cold Blood.”

I nodded in agreement. “Yes, I find that fishy too. There’s definitely something going on here. Are you able to use your MF now?”

Jiao S shook those iron shackles. “This restricts me from using it. Du Yue has the most amazing things.”

“Have you seen any others apart from Du Yue and Song Lu?”

“No, I’ve been here all the while. The only person I’ve met is Song Lu. Though she does seem different from before, I believe that she has her reasons. I don’t think she’s being totally controlled by Du Yue. Du Yue should be well aware of this too.

“What’s interesting is that Du Yue has been giving Song Lu more and more power and freedom, and it seems as if she wants to push Song Lu’s boundaries by doing that. But Song Lu has never broken so far.”

Song Lu jiejie... I knew she had always been intelligent, and she has always treated Yu Liang and me with nothing but sincerity.

“Ah Shen, there’s something else you need to prepare yourself for. In order to get my eyes back, Song Lu might have to pay a price. I’m not sure what exactly that is, but I hope you’re not too anxious about this, because I don’t want to put you in a difficult position. I’ll look into this and figure this out. Don’t be impulsive for now.”

Song Lu has to pay a price? What does that mean?

No, I should forget it. I’ll believe Jiao S if she says she can figure this out.

I smiled at her. “Okay. I’ll play by ear when Song Lu gets back. Don’t worry, we’ll definitely be able to turn the tables. There’s nothing I fear with you and Nie Zun by my side.”

Though I said this, I didn’t feel confident at all. Nie Zun was ignoring me, and Jiao S was locked up.

They were literally just being ‘by my side’.

Chapter 243: 243 Ingesting Poison

Volume 4

243 Ingesting Poison

“That was quick.” I stood up, looking at Song Lu as I said so.

Song Lu blinked. “Aren’t you going to ask me where I took your Nie Zun?”

“With his abilities, you aren’t able to do anything to him right now. If he isn’t back, this just means that there might be some issues over at Jie Pa’s side.”

Song Lu shook her head in response. “Jie Pa has been saved. He didn’t return because he got me to pass you a message – that we should go on our separate ways from now on.”

Go on our separate ways.

Nie Zun, when have you begun to have such a wild imagination? Do you think that I can’t locate you simply because you’re avoiding me like this?

“Let’s not talk about this. Tell me how to save Jiao S.”

Song Lu glanced at Jiao S. “The only thing I can tell you is how to get her eyes back.”

“How do I get them back?”

“Her eyes are in your memories. As long as you are able to find them in your memories, she’ll be able to regain her sight.”

What?

A look of confusion appeared on me. “Her eyes are in my memories? What does that even mean?”

Song Lu stared at me. “Somebody had set something in motion in those lost memories of yours, and it had led to the result of today. You’ll have to remember the particular part that involves her eyes in those memories of yours if you want to save her.”

“But I didn’t know Jiao S when I was alive.”

Song Lu smiled. “Do you think that all the bodies of consciousness in the Split Zone don’t have anything to do with one another at all? I know that the both of you didn’t know each other before, but she lost her eyes because there was someone who set that in motion somewhere in your consciousness, causing this to happen. You’ll have to find it.

“It’s difficult for me to explain everything plainly. But you’ll just have to find the part in your memories that has to do with this pair of eyes. Think, there must be a pair of eyes you’ve forgotten.”

I was getting more and more confused.

But I understood one thing. She was telling me that I had to recall a particular moment in my memories that involved those eyes, and only by doing that can I get Jiao S’s eyes back.

“But how do I get those lost memories back?”

A tiny bottle appeared in Song Lu’s hands. It was a white bottle which looked like it contained medicine. I caught it hastily as she threw it towards me.

“Eat it. This is a type of drug that causes you to lose control over your consciousness by stimulating it. You might be able to recall what happened in those buried memories through this.”

I looked down at that tiny white bottle in my hands. *Losing control over my consciousness... Was this a hallucinogen?*

“Is this given to you by Du Yue too?” I waved the bottle at her.

“Yes. This is only one of the many interesting drugs in her possession. You can choose not to believe me on this, but I’ll tell you this first. I’m not sure about the damage this can cause to one’s consciousness.

“What I’ve heard is that most of them who’ve ingested it end up having a really hard time, and some of them were not able to regain their consciousness. These individuals end up in a second coma in the Split Zone where they will forever be tortured in their subconscious minds.”

“What a horrifying drug. Who’d dare take it after hearing that?”

Song Lu shrugged. “I’m just warning you first, and the decision whether to take it or not still lies with you. But I know one thing. If you are able to overcome this, you’ll definitely be able to find those memories.

“I know it’s difficult to come across such an opportunity for you to be able to dive back into those memories again, but now that I’ve given you a chance, and I’ve also told you its possible side effects, you can make a decision on this. If you want to save Jiao S, you’ll have to get those memories back.”

“Is this all part of Du Yue’s scheme?” I suddenly felt as if I had walked right into her trap.

To my surprise, Song Lu admitted it frankly. “That’s right, it is. Though Du Yue doesn’t know that you’ve already arrived here in the Gate of Heaven, she told me to find a way to get you to eat this if you ever come here.”

“Do you think I’d still dare to eat it after all you’ve said? Du Yue would never help me out like this,” I said with a frown.

Song Lu spoke in a low tone this time. “According to what I’ve heard, somebody in the Gate of Heaven called Ta Lai once ate this, and he was

able to wake up after that. There are some who say that it's Du Yue who got him to eat it. If Du Yue is willing to make him do such a thing even when she likes him so much, I guess it's because she trusts in his abilities. It might be the same for you too.

“Though I don't know what Du Yue's eventual goal is, there's really no need for her to go through all this trouble if she's trying to harm you. This is why I think that there might really be some truths which can be uncovered through this.”

I pondered with that tiny white bottle in my hands as I recalled something else.

Ta Lai had a nightmare once within that exclusive space he had created. He looked really weird then.

That nightmare was him falling into a second coma. I remembered that clear as day.

Was that a side effect of this drug that Du Yue got him to ingest?

That might have been possible. Bian Ying has always been on Ta Lai's mind, and Du Yue hates it because Ta Lai doesn't love her. A woman's jealousy was terrifying. Hatred that emerges from love is something that was even more terrifying. There might be horrible side effects after ingesting this, but it might really be of some use after all.

But no matter what, I should still be able to trust Song Lu on this right...?

“Fine, I'll eat it.” I opened the bottle, only to see a single pill inside it.

“Ah Shen, are you really going to believe her and eat it?” Jiao S asked with worry.

I answered without turning to look at her. “Don't worry. I'll definitely be able to save you.” Right after that, I popped the pill into my mouth.

It had no taste at all, but the feeling of the pill going down my gullet was still a little uncomfortable. It was not a small pill.

Song Lu looked surprised at this.

“You look surprised. Why is that? You didn’t expect me to swallow it so quickly?” I waved the empty bottle in front of me.

Song Lu’s eyes flashed as she asked, “Do you feel anything?”

I didn’t feel any different except for a little warmth in my chest, but that warmth was getting hotter by the second.

“Nothing much except for a little hotness here,” I said as I pointed to my chest where my heart was.

Song Lu suddenly walked over to a corner of the room, folding her arms across her chest as she leaned back against the wall. “I’ll be waiting for you here. You’ll feel it after a short while, and you’ll be rolling around on the ground in pain shortly. It’s better for me to stand back and wait while you battle with its effects.”

Rolling on the ground.

Wouldn’t that be embarrassing...

Since I’ve already eaten it, I had no choice but to bear with all its side effects. I’ll just have to bear with all the pain that comes with it. It’s a small price to pay if I could get my memories back. I’ve always wanted to recall them, and I know it definitely wasn’t going to be easy.

A dark veil seemed to have fallen over Song Lu after she settled against the wall. To be able to make out her expression, I had to place more focus on my vision.

But I didn’t do that, since there was no need for me to do so anyway.

That pose of hers made me think of Nie Zun.

My lips turned up in a bittersweet smile. *I guess I really can’t leave him even for a moment. I’m already missing him.*

Nothing can save me now.

I laughed at myself. “Should I be sitting down to wait for this to take effect? It might be painful if I end up falling over onto the ground. I’d better find myself a comfortable position.”

Song Lu waved a hand at me, signaling for me to do as I pleased. “It might be better if you’re seated. It’s not that extreme actually. You’ll lose consciousness in a short while, but to us, you’ll just look like you’ve fallen asleep. All the pain and torture happens in your subconscious mind. If you lie down, it might just be a little more comfortable. I’ll be right here waiting for you to wake up. Whether you can overcome the drug depends solely on you.”

I sat down after picking a spot that was closer to Jiao S’s cell. “How do I look for Jiao S’s eyes then? Du Yue told you that as long as I ate this and found my memories, I’ll naturally know how?”

“That’s right.”

Nodding, I said, “Fine. Let’s wait for it then.”

I turned around, putting my hands on those iron bars again. “Don’t worry, Jiao S. I’ll definitely think of a way to get you out.”

Jiao S’s lips turned up at a slight angle. “You’ve said this countless times, Ah Shen. I trust you. But remember what I told you. If you arrive at crossroads, you have to place yourself first. Understand?”

“Right,” I answered.

Idiot, I’ll definitely be placing you first.

But it’s okay, because there won’t be any situations like that. I won’t let anything happen to you, and nothing will happen to me either.

I’ll bring you out. I’ll take those surviving heirs with me and we’ll all escape this forsaken place that is the Split Zone.

My vision began to blur at this very moment, as if whatever was in front of me was merely a mirage. Jiao S's face and those iron bars began to blur right in front of my eyes.

The drug seemed to be taking effect now.

Before I lost my grip on my consciousness, I wondered if Nie Zun would regret not coming back to me if I ended up not being able to wake up.

Will he be sad?

No, don't regret it, and do not be sad either. With all the pain that I've already brought you, I shouldn't be harassing you anymore.

You may have been right. I've always taken you for granted, but that has evolved into something that I refuse to let go of now.

That hotness in my chest receded, replaced with a chilling cold.

This cold felt familiar... When have I experienced this before?

I then felt myself falling backwards. All I could see was nothing but a sea of white.

Chapter 244: 244 Returning to the Laboratory

Volume 4

244 Returning to the Laboratory

White fog surrounded me as I regained my vision.

This fog was familiar. It looked exactly the same as that fog which appeared when I looked into Si Luo's heart, where I saw Gaoqin Jiuye attack Nie Zun.

No matter how much I tried to tell myself that this was an effect of that hallucinogen I just ingested, I was still paranoid. What if something terrifying happened again?

I walked aimlessly in the fog, realizing I was in a white dress only when I happened to look down at myself.

I looked at my hair. It was black.

A white dress and black hair that fell across my shoulders? Wasn't this how I looked like when I was alive?

Was I in that world now?

Looking around me, there was nothing but endless white fog. It was all around me, and there seemed to be nothing else here. *No, this was merely an illusion.*

“Nie Zun...” I subconsciously called out for him. I didn’t know if I was calling out for help or if I was afraid of seeing Nie Zun get hurt in this place again.

A chilling cold emanated from my chest the moment I called out.

I pressed down on my chest. *This cold...*

No, it was a chill.

It was a bone-chilling cold. *It felt just like... just like...*

Just like how it felt when I held Piercer. This was the chill I experienced when the female soul in Piercer tried to devour my soul and overtake my consciousness.

Was there something else trying to overtake my consciousness here?

I turned to look around me again. There was no one else here.

Feeling afraid in this empty space, I tried to activate my MF.

But I realized there wasn’t MF at all.

To be more accurate, instead of a lack of MF, I simply felt lost. I didn’t know what I was doing at all.

What was MF? How do I sense it? How does it manifest?

I felt was like an ordinary human being instead of a body of consciousness in the Split Zone.

But I knew this wasn’t possible. Even if I had really returned, there was no way that I would go back in this form and end up in such a weird place.

As I thought about this situation that I was in, Song Lu’s words reappeared in my mind.

Right, this isn't a mere illusion. This was in my subconscious mind. This was the second coma.

My body in the real world would have entered a deep coma, I would be brain dead.

But having lived in Split Zone 13 for quite a while, death was no longer what I feared most.

What I was afraid of is how we cannot die, how we cannot afford to die, or how we were afraid to die.

The chill in my heart grew as my thoughts ran wild.

I pressed down harder on my chest.

It felt like something was trying to gnaw its way out of my chest, and I'm trying to prevent her from doing so because I was afraid of her.

But in truth, she might just be coming out to protect me.

"Ugh..." I called out as my heart felt painfully frozen. That chill seemed to be gaining some sort of strength.

Just when something seemed to have successfully clawed its way through, the white fog suddenly began to dissipate.

I looked around in surprise, distracted from the chilling cold in my heart.

The white fog subsided slowly, as if a scene from a fairytale was being unveiled. An image of the real world then appeared before me.

There were rows and rows of desks, and a model figure in the corner of the room. The curtains were black, blocking all light from the outside.

This was the laboratory where Gao Qi took me.

An immense fear suddenly overwhelmed me.

I felt extremely insecure. I didn't know whether it was because of what I was wearing, making me feel like I was back in the real world, or whether it was because I wasn't able to sense my MF, but I felt like there was this monster hiding in the darkness. That monster seemed to be looking at me as it monitored my every move from its hiding spot.

It was waiting for an opportunity. It was waiting for me to lower my defenses before it jumped out to tear me apart and devour me.

I felt nothing but fear and helplessness. I wasn't even able to tell where that monster would jump out from.

Regarding this laboratory, Gaoqin Jiuye's words reappeared in my mind. *Was Gao Qi really a bad person? Were there dead rats floating in formalin in here?*

But that wasn't important. What's important was the reason behind my killing of Gao Qi. *What could have happened that led to such an action on my part?*

I heard Gao Qi's voice in my mind. "Kill me if I end up hurting you."

Right, that knife. He was the one who gave me the knife. But why did he do so... What exactly happened then...?

I then heard a voice in my mind. *Do you want to know?*

Do you really want to know?

Are you scared?

I shook my head quickly, trying to clear my mind.

At a loss, I began to look around me. A glass bottle caught my eye.

That bottle was hidden right in the back of the cabinet inside the laboratory. For some reason, the bottle was partially exposed now, and I noticed it immediately.

Taking one step at a time, I walked over slowly. Bending, I tried to take the bottle out of the cabinet.

However, it seemed to be stuck.

I tried again, pressing my other hand against the cabinet as I pulled the bottle out. *Finally.*

Clank.

The bottle toppled, but it did not look broken. It rolled all the way over to where my feet were.

I then picked it up slowly from the ground.

There were two eyeballs floating inside the transparent glass bottle. Those eyeballs looked so bright, and there were huge black irises on them.

My hands started to tremble. But I knew I shouldn't break this, so I put it back carefully on the ground.

My knees gave out under me as I sat onto the ground. *Those were... Jiao S's eyes.*

An enchanting voice said, "Ah Shen, you're here."

Jolted by the voice, I stood up abruptly.

In my attempt to turn around to look at the source of the voice, I lost my balance and fell backwards instead.

Clank, clank.

The glass bottle rolled over to a corner of the room after being accidentally kicked by me.

Those eyeballs were rolling around in the bottle, as if Jiao S was blinking at me.

I hit the cabinet behind me as I reached out with my hands to break my fall, while my eyes were glued to those eyeballs which were rolling farther and farther from me in that glass bottle.

A chilling cold shot through my palm as I came into contact with the steel cabinet behind me.

“Are you okay, Ah Shen?”

It was Gao Qi. He reached out with those strong and gentle hands in an attempt to steady me.

“Ah.” I called out as I raised my arms to stop him.

“You... You’re afraid of me?” Gao Qi’s gaze was gentle, with a hint of solitude in them. His hands stopped in midair.

Try as I might, I just couldn’t stop my arms from trembling.

I didn’t dare meet his eyes, and my eyes darted around the room, trying to find something else that I could focus on.

I happened to see that glass bottle stop, and Jiao S’s eyes were staring straight at me. That caused me to call out again.

“Ah!”

“Don’t be afraid, Ah Shen. It’s nothing,” Gao Qi said as he followed my gaze to that glass bottle.

“It’s just a specimen that’s inside.”

I tried to suppress my disgust as I spoke. Surprisingly, my voice sounded rather hoarse. “No, it’s not a specimen... Those are Jiao S’s eyes... But why would they appear here...”

Gao Qi looked as if he couldn’t hear what I just said as he continued, “I know you’re scared. It’s okay, take a moment. I’ll explain everything to you later. Come over here, how about you take a seat first.”

Before I knew it, Gao Qi was already pulling me towards a chair behind a desk. Pressing on my shoulders, he pushed me onto the seat.

The desk obscured my view of that glass bottle and those eyes, but my gaze did not shift.

“Stop looking, Ah Shen. Look at me.”

I felt a warmth on my cheeks. It came from Gao Qi’s hands.

He turned my face to him. Looking at me with those gentle eyes, he said, “Ah Shen, didn’t you say you liked this place? Why are you still afraid?”

Blame seemed to emerge in those eyes. “Didn’t Ah Shen say that you’ll forever be by my side to support me?”

“Why, are you scared now?”

My lips started to quiver.

Gao Qi’s hands pressed hard on my cheeks, squishing my face like it was dough, but I didn’t avoid his touch.

“This is my hobby, Ah Shen. It’s weird, and it’s not accepted by others. It’s not just what I’m learning. You said you’ll always be by my side, you said you’ll be with me forever. You don’t mind it, right?”

My heart sank.

I pushed his hands away from my face.

Staring straight into his eyes, I said, “I’m asking you if those are Jiao S’s eyes.”

Chapter 245: 245 Tiny Fragments of Memory

Volume 4

245 Tiny Fragments of Memory

Gao Qi's gaze remained gentle, but it contained a hint of sorrow as he said, "Ah Shen, why aren't you talking?"

My eyes widened at this. *Does this mean... Does this mean that he can't hear me?*

Was this illusion just like those dreams I had in the Split Zone? Were they mere memories which cannot be altered?

How would I be able to help Jiao S if I couldn't change things? What's happening here?

I guess I'll just have to try everything I can then. I pushed Gao Qi away and ran over to pick that bottle up, hugging it tight against my chest.

Gao Qi was already behind me when I turned around. His eyes were on me.

I took a deep breath before I attempted another question. "Are these Jiao S's eyes? Can you hear me?"

Gao Qi smiled as he reached out for the bottle in my arms. "This is a new addition to my collection. Do you like it, Ah Shen?"

I collided with the wall behind me as I backed away. "Stay away!" I shouted.

Gao Qi's brows furrowed. "You're afraid of me?"

I was thinking to myself, *let me go back, let me go back, get me out of this illusion quickly.*

I was at a loss. I couldn't sense MF in me at all, and Gao Qi looked intimidating here. I didn't know what to do with Jiao S's eyes either. *What can I do? What should I do?*

How about I leave this place first? I should try and put a greater distance between us.

After I made that decision, I grabbed the glass bottle tightly as I ran towards the door of the laboratory.

"Li Shen."

Gao Qi called out urgently. He sounded anxious.

Without MF, it felt as if my body couldn't keep up. I moved rather slowly and Gao Qi caught up with me easily. Just as I was about to push the door open, a hand pushed against it.

It was terrifying.

I was being forcefully turned around by the shoulder. Afraid that I'd smash the bottle, I quickly put it on a tiny desk to my right before I raised my hands to try and stop Gao Qi from coming any closer.

There was a dangerous light in Gao Qi's eyes as he grabbed both my arms. "Ah Shen, didn't you say that you'll be able to accept me no matter what I became? Didn't you say that you'll always love me, that you'll always be by my side?"

I bit my lip, unsure of what to say. *He wouldn't be able to hear me anyway.*

But my silence seemed to anger him even more.

He pushed me against the door. Trapping both my arms with one hand, he started tearing my clothes off with his other hand.

I was shocked at this turn of events. *This wasn't what Gao Qi would have done.*

“Let me go!” I roared as I struggled to break free from his grip, but he did not have the slightest intention of letting me go. There was anger and a possessive light in his eyes.

With a heave, I finally broke free from him. But in my haste to escape, I slipped and fell to the ground.

Before I could turn around, I felt a weight on my back.

I was terrified by this, and I suddenly thought of Nie Zun at this point.

For some reason, I found the strength to push him away and off me. However, just as I was about to get up and run, he grabbed hold of one of my legs.

I kicked him hard.

Gao Qi's eyes looked crazed now. “Why are you afraid of me? Why are you avoiding me? Didn't you say you'd always be supporting me? Why are you acting like the others now!” Gao Qi did not sound gentle anymore. His voice was filled with madness and anger.

His hands trembled as he reached for my neck and his pupils widened as that gentle face twisted into an ugly one. He pushed me down and the pressure on my neck made my eyes widen as I felt myself suffocating.

Gao Qi's tears actually fell into my eyes.

Drip.

My eyes were wet from them, and his tears continued falling.

Why is he crying?

Why cry?

Why did I start crying too?

I couldn't tell if this was something from my memories or something that was happening right at this moment.

Time and space were contorted here, and my soul and consciousness seemed to be separated.

There was a trace of blood on the corner of his lips, I saw the knife in my hand, and it was plunged right into his chest.

In that image, his eyes were filled with sorrow, but they were gentle. He spoke with a surprisingly demanding voice.

“Li Shen, you have to remember me forever.”

I finally remembered it.

That's right. That person was not Gao Qi, it was Gaoqin Jiuye.

My tears started falling as images started flashing past my brain. They pierced my heart mercilessly, causing it to bleed.

He gasped for breath as he rested his head on my shoulders. “Yes, Ah Shen, you did well. I've told you this before. It's me if that skull ring on his right hand is gone.

“Ah Shen, I've only been with you for a while, but he loves you. Though he definitely made mistakes, he is still me, and I'm still him. You have to love him. Don't forget him, and don't forget me.”

I couldn't stop crying. The air was filled with the smell of blood.

Sunlight reflected off Gao Qi's hair. We were at the field, and his eyes were a beautiful dark brown. He looked at me with unfocused eyes before he fell backwards.

In the midst of picking up the trash, I dropped everything in my hand as I ran towards him.

"You, wake up. It's me, it's me. Senior."

I saw a foreign gaze when he opened his eyes.

"This is your world?"

I was stunned at this. *Did he hurt his head?*

"Senior, how about this. How about I take you to the nurse?"

Slap. I reached out a hand but it was slapped away.

"You're that girl in my dreams?" He frowned with a look that looked nothing like the approachable Gao Qi senior of mine.

I sat down on the ground, looking at him sit up. "You. Who are you? Is senior Gao Qi being possessed?"

A malicious smile appeared on him. "I'm Gaoqin Jiuye and I come from another dimension. I'm currently in that senior's body. His consciousness is asleep now."

My jaw dropped at this.

Slap.

I gave myself a slap.

It wasn't a dream. I wasn't daydreaming either.

Gaoqin Jiuye waved a hand in front of me. "What're you looking at? Help me up. Do you know how difficult it is for my consciousness to pass through the Split Zone and take over his body over here? It's all for you."

Just as I was about to reach out to him, that memory ended.

My vision cleared up and I was back in the laboratory.

What did I just see...

Was that what happened shortly after the first time I met Gao Qi?

How could it be... Why did I not remember anything at all?

Gao Qi stumbled to the side as he looked at me with a complex gaze.

"You. You..." I began, not knowing what else to say.

Gao Qi looked crazed. "You? What's up with you? Why don't you know how to protect yourself? Didn't I tell you to take that ring off if he bullies you again? I'll appear if you do that."

He waved a hand at me. I saw a skull ring on his right hand which looked exactly identical to the one Nie Zun had.

"You don't even listen to me now, and I have to force my way through the Split Zone to come here. Do you know how terrible that process is?"

Gaoqin Jiuye sat up as he took off that skull ring, throwing it towards me. "Put it on, and don't give it to Gao Qi anymore."

I seemed to finally understand all that had happened at the moment I caught the ring.

I wasn't in some illusion here. I was a participant in my own dream. This was everything that happened when I was alive.

This was exactly like when I entered my own dream in the past.

The difference was that there had to be some sort of restriction this time. It might be because of the drug that Song Lu gave me which caused me to lose all my MF, as it could have made me enter the dream as an ordinary human being.

This means that I would probably be unconscious in that jail in the Gate of Heaven right now. My consciousness has entered the part of my memories where I've lost, leading to all these scenes being played out.

What I saw might be what I've forgotten after meeting Gao Qi for the first time.

I've lost a lot of those memories, and they usually return in bits and pieces, with no order to them at all. *But were these really my memories? Did I actually know Gaoqin Jiuye when I was alive?*

Did Gaoqin Jiuye really pass through the Split Zone to meet me in Gao Qi's body in the real world? How could that be possible?

Thinking about it, it might not be entirely impossible. When I was picking up trash at the field, Gao Qi walked over to talk to me, but I don't remember what happened after that. *Did we leave together? No, I couldn't remember a thing.*

This means that the scene earlier was a part of my memories. Gao Qi passed out at that point, and Gaoqin Jiuye's consciousness took over.

Good heavens, this sounded so out of this world...

Chapter 246: 246 Eyes That Traveled Back in Time

Volume 4

246 Eyes That Traveled Back in Time

If that really was the truth, this meant that Gaoqin Jiuye had known me for quite a while. He had known me from the very moment I met Gao Qi...

How could this be possible though? If that was the case, wouldn't that mean...

I couldn't remember anything that involved Gaoqin Jiuye, and all the memories I lost just so happened to be related to him in some way... *Isn't this too much of a coincidence...*

Wait, I had to really think about this.

When I met Gao Qi, it was Gaoqin Jiuye's consciousness which took over Gao Qi's body. According to him, it's not often that he did that. This ended up in both of them sharing one body. *And then what?*

I stared blankly at Gaoqin Jiuye, who was in front of me.

He pointed at the ring I just caught. "What are you waiting for? Put it on. Haven't I told you this already, that I brought this ring over from the Split Zone? It's a treasure. You can summon me here through it. It'll protect you as well."

I realized I wore the ring obediently on my left hand.

“That’s it. Can you feel it now?”

A sharp pain shot through my brain as another scene played out in front of me.

Gao Qi pulled me with him to the rooftop as he held the novel, Faust, in his hands. Looking down, our schoolmates looked just like tiny ants on the ground.

His eyes seemed to be full of mockery as he said. “Ah Shen, don’t you think it’s tiring for them to live like this? Mephisto the demon once said that the world was a torturous place. Why do they want to torture themselves like this?”

My brows furrowed. “Senior, you seem a little different recently. You keep talking about depressing things.”

Gao Qi looked at me with soft eyes. “Didn’t you say that you’ll accept me however I am?”

“That’s not what I meant. I mean... Senior? What’s wrong, senior?”

Gao Qi passed out again. It happened so suddenly that I was at a loss of what to do.

But from past experience, this could just be a sign that ‘he’ was coming.

For some reason, I was expectant of his arrival.

I could hear nothing but my own heartbeat on the roof.

Gao Qi opened his eyes after a couple of seconds.

A charming smile hung on his lips as his gaze felt full of malice. He sat up and glanced at me. “Been a long time.”

I looked at him. “Yes. I still can’t quite believe it yet. How did you come over? Are you really from another dimension? Are you an alien of some sort? You don’t happen to be Gao Qi’s second personality, are you?”

Gaoqin Jiuye’s malicious smile widened. “Do you think everyone else has an identity disorder like you? That causes a body of consciousness to split into two, but he and I are originally two separate bodies of consciousness. I’m just taking over his body temporarily.”

“Where did you come from? Why do you have to take over his body? What did you mean when you said you did it all for me the last time?”

“I come from this place called the Split Zone, but I’m not able to explain everything to you in such a short time. The reason I’m here is because you summoned me, and you’ve always been in my dreams.”

“What.” I deadpanned.

Gaoqin Jiuye leaned back as he placed his palms on the ground behind him. “It’s like this. Where I come from, we don’t dream. We end up dreaming only if a body of consciousness in your world resonates with a body of consciousness in our world. If that happens, we’ll be able to see all that happens in this world.

“Put simply, I’m able to see whatever happens to you here because your consciousness resonated with mine. Basically, it works just like a camera. I became interested after seeing you, and this is why I thought of a way to come look for you. And, the only way to do that is through my doppelganger in this world, who happens to be your senior, Gao Qi. It’s only through him that I can arrive here. This is why I’m here after I took that opportunity.”

“You mean, in order to come look for me, whom you saw in your dreams, you have to look for a body here in this dimension, and that vessel is Senior Gao Qi?”

“Yes. Gao Qi and I are doppelgangers, and it’s only through such a connection that I’m able to come here. It just so happens that my

doppelganger knows you as well, and that he's also your senior. These are mere coincidences. The relationship between us and my connection with him are two separate matters. As for the fact that the both of you know each other, it has nothing to do with me as well. It's purely something between the two of you in this world."

Though I was slightly confused, I was still able to understand the majority of what he said.

"But why did you come looking for me? I'm just a person who happened to appear in your dream."

Gaoqin Jiuye sat up and scooted over. "I'm curious about you. This is why I had to come and take a look."

My heart began to race.

I could see a light in those dark brown eyes of his. His face was literally right in front of me now.

He waved the ring on his right hand. "I've brought this ring here, and I'll put it on him. He wouldn't take it off. Just tell him that you bought it for him as some kind of a protective amulet. Take the ring off if you wish to see me in future. I'll appear then. Do that too if you're in danger."

His voice seemed to float farther and farther away.

I regained my senses as I felt another pain shooting through my chest.

Back in the laboratory, I realized that I had taken off the ring I just put on moments ago. Gaoqin Jiuye was still smiling casually in front of me.

"Remember it now? I've told you this before, just take the ring off when you're in danger and I'll appear. Why didn't you do that even when he had already pounced on you? It's lucky that I was dreaming of you at the same time. I forced my way through once I saw that."

My heart sank as I finally understood what was happening.

I was merely reliving the memories that I've lost.

Gaoqin Jiuye was simply narrating whatever happened in the past, and those images were like fragments of memory within my memories. It was like a dream within a dream.

Right now, I had to face Gaoqin Jiuye, whom I had forgotten. *Should I continue pretending, or should I treat him as I do now?*

I momentarily forgot that he won't be able to hear me even if I spoke. Since this was simply a reenactment, everything would go according to what had actually happened before.

As expected, he spoke as if I had responded. "It's good that you remember. Right, I'm actually here to settle some serious matters. Where's that bottle? Oh I see it, it's there."

My eyes widened. *Yes, this might just be the opportunity I'm waiting for.*

He stood up quickly. Walking over to the glass bottle, he picked it up before he returned and sat beside me. "My friend, Du Yue, got me to retrieve this. I don't know why Du Yue would send me on an errand here in this world. Who does this belong to? Who did Gao Qi gouge it out from? Isn't it illegal to gouge someone's eyes out in your world?"

I shook my head as I answered, "I don't know."

Gaoqin Jiuye looked at those eyes which looked so similar to Jiao S's as he continued, "No matter who it belongs to, I guess it must be of some use, if Du Yue got me to come here in such a secretive manner. I'm taking this. You'll have to run and leave this place. I'm about to go back, and I can't stay with you for too long. I'll need a large amount of MF to bring this item back.

"I have to go soon. Put the ring on and leave before I go. Keep the ring and don't give it to him anymore. I'll be able to sense it the very moment you're in danger. I'll force my way through again if need be. Go on, quick. Put it on. Stop taking it off."

I had a feeling that this was my chance to get to the bottom of things. Thus, I put the ring back on obediently and left.

Opening the door, I looked at the dark corridor right in front of me.

Quietly, I leaned against the wall.

I was going to enter the room again after Gaoqin Jiuye leaves.

Though I finally understood all that had happened, what I recalled was simply snippets of memory related to Gaoqin Jiuye. There had to be other snippets. Especially the events that led to my killing of Gao Qi. All I could remember was plunging that knife into his chest, and I couldn't remember anything that happened before or after it. I had to get those memories back.

In the quiet corridor, I began to think about what Gaoqin Jiuye just said.

Why was this related to Du Yue?

Why would Jiao S's eyes be here? This was the past, and it was in another dimension. Why would Jiao S's eyes in the Split Zone end up in the past in the real world?

Was this Du Yue's ability?

Could I then interpret this as Du Yue sending Jiao S's eyes to the real world through some spatial transference, and with that, she also made it travel back in time? It didn't end up in the same timeline, but it ended up in my memories from the past.

She sent it to Gao Qi's laboratory, which is a place that contains my lost memories. This means that as long as I set out to regain the memories in the laboratory, I'd definitely be able to see that pair of eyes?

Wasn't this a mechanism that had been put in place much earlier on? It was simply waiting for me to pass through.

Listening to Gaoqin Jiuye speak earlier, I knew it was the old Gaoqin Jiuye I was seeing. He was still on good terms with Du Yue in the past. *Did Du*

Yue already know that this was going to happen from a long time ago? Is this why she contorted time and space and had Gaoqin Jiuye retrieve Jiao S's eyes from here?

Chapter 247: 247 Who Was The One Who Forgot?

Volume 4

247 Who Was The One Who Forgot?

This means that Gaoqin Jiuye had retrieved Jiao S's eyes from the future. If so, Jiao S's eyes were still in the Split Zone.

This felt equivalent to an antique being preserved from the past. Jiao S's eyes had been kept away earlier on, creating an impression that her eyes could not be found at this point.

Why did Du Yue do something like this?

What I can be sure of was that Jiao S's eyes were still in the Split Zone, hidden somewhere.

What did Du Yue aim to achieve by doing something like this? Was it merely to trigger those lost memories of mine? But how would she know that I've lost them? She became increasingly terrifying the more I thought about this.

What I should be focusing on was getting all my memories back.

I had to find out what led to me killing Gao Qi.

Just as I worked up enough courage to enter that laboratory again, I felt a cold hand on my shoulder.

A chilly voice spoke behind me.

“Shen’er, are you sure you have the courage to face this? Do you really want to know what happened that caused you to kill him...?”

She stuck close to my ear, and my hands, which were already on the door handle, started trembling.

What actually happened?

Everything seemed to be turned upside down here.

Gao Qi was not who I expected him to be.

Gao Qi might not even be the one I liked all this while.

I had also forgotten everything related to Gaoqin Jiuye. I forgot everything about him. Even if Gao Qi was not the one I had fallen in love with, if it was really Gaoqin Jiuye I had fell in love with, this meant that I had forgotten about the person I loved.

What irony. Isn’t it, Li Shen? That you could even forget about the person you loved the most?

But if everything was a lie, what about her? Was she really the one who killed Gao Qi? Was she really a bad person?

I looked up at her slowly.

With a murky gaze, she asked, “Do you need my help, Shen’er? I can lend you my strength...”

“No...” I answered with no hesitation.

This was the first time I heard her scream so loudly.

Blame was apparent in her eyes.

Hmph. Don’t give me that look.

No matter what happens, I'll never accept your help. I'll never borrow your strength.

I've already paid a heavy price once. Even if I might be loving the wrong person right now, the fact that you hurt him doesn't change.

You turned me into a devil. This is a fact that will never change. I never want to have anything to do with you anymore. Because I remember everything now.

I remember how cold that knife felt in my hands, and I remembered his warm blood on my hands. I remembered those eyes which slowly lost their fire.

It's a nightmare that I will never be able to escape from.

“You... Do you really remember...” She leaned in closer, her cold lips coming into contact with my ear as she blew cold air on my face. For some reason, my tears started falling again.

Tiny fragments of memory started appearing in my mind.

Slap.

“Let go of me. Don't hurt her.”

“Didn't you say you hated her? That she spoilt your experience in high school? Mm hmm, I'm helping you take revenge now, Ah Shen.”

“You're crazy, insane. Let us go.”

“I'm insane? We're the same. Didn't you say you'd be with me forever? You promised... Do you think I'm unaware of his existence... You actually thought about taking over my body? You actually thought about betraying me like this? I'm the one with you here in this world, and you can actually believe some ghost from another world? You're such a liar, Li Shen.”

“Let me go. He’s right, you’re a demon.”

“Haha, I’m a demon? Then what are you, Li Shen? Do you want me to show you what a real demon is like? Come on, here’s the knife for you. I’m giving you a chance. Kill her or kill me?”

The voices seemed to overlap with each other in my ear. I listened with wide eyes that were filled to the brim with tears.

She was still standing in front of me with that red hair, red dress, and those enchanting eyes. Picking up a strand of my hair, she said, “You... You don’t like black do you... You really don’t want to accept the strength that I can lend you...?”

I pushed her hand away.

“Dream on.” Wiping my tears, I decided that I couldn’t continue like this.

Wasn’t it just getting back some of my memories? What’s there to be afraid of? I wanted to get them back, and I had to face my own past someday.

Nothing can beat me down. No one can.

I stared at her angrily before turning around and opening the door.

A blinding light shone through as I stepped back into the laboratory.

The scene changed around me the very moment I entered.

I sat up suddenly.

The scene before me became clear.

Song Lu was looking at me with an inscrutable gaze with her arms still folded in front of her.

“I... I’m back.” Looking around me, I realized I was back in that prison. Jiao S did not have her eyes yet, and I was still sitting in front of her cell.

I rushed towards Song Lu, grabbing her as I said, “Why am I back? Didn’t you say that the drug would help recall those memories buried deep within my heart? Didn’t you say that no one could endure this...? Why am I back even when I haven’t recalled everything? Why did my consciousness not come apart?”

Song Lu grabbed me. “Calm down, Ah Shen.” *Calm down? How do I calm down?*

Everything was just about to be revealed. The truth would have been made known in just a moment.

But I ended up back here. How do I remain calm like this?

“Tell me if you still have that drug. Give it to me, I want to go back.”

“Ah Shen.”

Jiao S spoke this time.

I turned around, forcing myself to smile. “Don’t worry. I’ve found your eyes. I’ll definitely bring them back and get you out. Trust me.”

“Tell me, Song Lu. You still have that drug, don’t you?”

Jiao S sounded anxious as she continued, “Ah Shen, my eyes don’t matter. You have to stay calm. You can’t take that drug a second time. Do you want to be controlled by your second personality again...?”

I froze at this.

“What... what did you say?”

Song Lu let go of me slowly. “You actually woke up once during the time you lost consciousness. Look at my neck.”

I was too agitated to notice the streaks of blood on Song Lu's neck earlier. Her neck was still bleeding from the injury.

"What. What happened?" I stared, open-mouthed.

She wiped the blood away as she said, "You did this to me when you woke up. You looked totally different, and you always spoke with a smile. You looked confident, dynamic. Your attacks were extraordinary as well. She was able to hurt me like this even when I used all my defenses against her. This injury isn't healing either."

Looking at her neck, I asked, "You mean to say... You saw her? My second personality?"

Song Lu nodded. "Though I don't really understand what's up with your second personality, I can be sure of one thing. You weren't yourself when you stood up earlier, and you could remember everything from your past. It's just that right now, you aren't able to recall the memories that were related to her."

What right did she have?

What right did she have to know everything like this and control me at her whims and fancies when I knew nothing about her?

Just why...

I'm the owner of this body of consciousness. What exactly does she want to do...

Unable to control my emotions, I felt myself shaking.

"Ah Shen, can you tell me what you saw in that dream? Though I know that Du Yue's aim was to force your second personality out through this drug, I didn't expect it to really work. I didn't expect you to wake up at a crucial moment either. To be honest, I might just have been killed by her if you didn't wake up. This is actually the first time I found myself weak." Song Lu's eyes still contained the fear from what happened earlier.

Haha, see it now? That's you. You're a demon who kills people. You'll just bring misfortune to me. I can't believe there would be others telling me to accept you.

You can forget about being accepted by me in this lifetime. Don't even think about joining forces with me.

“What else did she do or say, apart from attacking you like that?” I asked coldly.

Song Lu said, “She told me not to hurt you, and not to force you. She said she'll protect you forever...”

“Enough!” I shouted.

Protect me forever...

This is your method of protecting me forever...? By hurting me and those around me? Is this the way you protect me?

If it is, I'd rather die.

“She also said... That everything was a conspiracy, that both of us had been duped. She said she'll not let me get my way.”

I laughed.

“Ah Shen, what did you see in your dream?”

Instead of answering, I asked, “Do you still have that drug? I want to take it again.”

Song Lu shook her head. “That was the only one. But even if I had another one, I wouldn't give it to you.”

Chapter 248: 248 She was Always the Target

Volume 4

248 She was Always the Target

I stepped forward resolutely, stretching out a hand. “Give it to me.”

Song Lu shook her head. “Ah Shen, you need to calm down. Have you thought about it? She might be able to control you again if you take it. Do you want to be controlled by her? You can’t do that anymore. I didn’t know that Du Yue’s drug would lead to something like this. I can’t let you do something like that again.”

I smirked. “Didn’t you hate me? Didn’t you team up with Du Yue because you couldn’t forgive me? What now? You’re not going to complete the task that Du Yue entrusted you with? She instructed you to get me to take the drug because she wants me to go through something like this. She wants to force my second personality out like this. Since you’ve already chosen her, why are you still pretending to be kind here?”

Song Lu looked at me with a complex gaze. I couldn’t tell what she was thinking.

Nor did I want to know what was on her mind.

Jiao S spoke. “Ah Shen, calm down. You’re just spitting words out of anger now. You’re too agitated, and you won’t find the truth like this. It will just push you further away from it. Don’t be anxious. Things will eventually be revealed.”

“Haha, eventually be revealed? Do you think she can really uncover everything on her own? I don’t think Li Shen has that ability yet.”

Someone was walking down the steps that led to this dungeon-like place.

I regarded her coldly.

It was Du Yue.

Giving her a slow clap, I smirked as I said, “Good going. You’re quick. I guess I’ve underestimated you. You’ve calculated everything perfectly.”

Du Yue’s sleek ponytail looked neat as she walked with those long and slender legs.

With cold arrogance on her face, she said, “It’s not that I’ve calculated everything perfectly, it’s just that a mechanism would be activated after you take the drug, which will lead to a series of events after. I would say it’s more of an intricate plan. I would rush back the very moment you took the drug, because I too have that pill which Jiao S owned.”

She showed me that red pill from her pocket.

“Also, the Gaoqin Jiuye whom you saw wasn’t an illusion. You were suspicious of it, right? Haha, Li Shen, you’re so gullible. Did you really think that Gaoqin Jiuye would have fallen in love with the childish you in the Split Zone? Gaoqin Jiuye had known you for a long time, and you shouldn’t think that it’s the current you that he had fallen in love with.”

Pain seemed to flash past her eyes as she said this.

I narrowed my eyes at her. *So it’s like this.*

Composing myself, I folded my arms in front of me as I responded. “You don’t sound too happy with Gaoqin Jiuye’s earlier confession to me. Are you trying to emphasize that it’s the Li Shen from the past that he loves instead of the current me? I think you’re confused about something, Du Yue. No matter which version of me he loves, it’s still me. It isn’t you...”

I purposely placed extra emphasis on the last word as I dragged it out.

Fiery killing intent appeared in Du Yue's eyes immediately.

I waved at her. "Simmer down, simmer down. I know you have much more to tell me. Go on. Since you've already planned all this, why not just tell me what you're up to."

After hearing me say this, that fire in her eyes was momentarily tamped down.

I guess I was still of some use to her.

"Fine. Since you're asking, I'll be frank with you." She relaxed all of a sudden, and a smile even appeared on her face, even though it did not look the least bit genuine.

"I don't know how much you remember, but you should know this as long as you recalled even a teeny weeny bit about Gaoqin Jiuye. Gao Qi wasn't the one you fell in love with. Gao Qi had an incomplete personality, and he was always hurting you. But he thought that was a manifestation of his love for you.

"I don't know his thoughts exactly, since I'm not from your world. What I know is that your consciousness and Gaoqin Jiuye's consciousness achieved some kind of resonance somewhere. You can look at this phenomenon like brain waves, though it's not exactly like this.

"Anyway, you were the person who appeared in Gaoqin Jiuye's dreams. In his dreams, he was able to see your life in that world, and he began to take an interest in you. He knew that Gao Qi was hurting you, and because of that, he began to look for various ways to travel to that world to look for you.

"The interesting thing is that he was looking at things from your perspective in his dreams. This means he was able to see Gao Qi, who looked exactly like him. He then realized that Gao Qi was his doppelganger. This is a term that we use here, so you don't have to understand it. What you need to

know is that in order to help you, Gaoqin Jiuye used the body of his doppelganger so that he could protect you.”

Gaoqin Jiuye...

Du Yue looked pleased as she saw that sorrowful expression that appeared on my face. “This means that you’ve been loving the wrong person all this while. You’ve forgotten everything related to Gaoqin Jiuye. Your second personality appeared during that very last time he attempted to help you out, scrambling your memories. You even took off the ring that he gave you. He lost the ability to protect you since that ring was no longer with you. Gaoqin Jiuye wasn’t able to pass through the dimensional boundaries to save you then, and in his haste, he captured you as an heir and brought you over to the Split Zone.

“It was all to save you. But you? Li Shen, you’re really something. You actually stabbed Gao Qi in all that chaos. Do you know that if Gao Qi dies, you can forget about meeting Gaoqin Jiuye ever again?

“It’s lucky that I’ve planted a seed in this process. When I found out that Gaoqin Jiuye was passing through the dimensional borders to go to your world, I had him retrieve something for me once. That item was an opportunity I created in his dreams earlier on. Put simply, it’s something that didn’t exist. I made use of Gaoqin’s memories to create an empty space, and that space can then be filled with something else in future, which is Jiao S’s eyes. By triggering your desire to save her, we can return to that space once again.”

So it was an opening that Du Yue had left in Gaoqin Jiuye’s memories. She’s making use of this opening to make me return under the guise of looking for Jiao S’s eyes.

But how did she do all that?

“How did you do that?”

Du Yue smirked. “I can’t do it. Do you think I have abilities like your Grandpa Fan? Spatial transference? If it has to do with space, Huai Du is

the only one who can do that in the Split Zone.”

My eyes widened in shock. “Huai Du? Him again? What do you mean?”

Du Yue walked over to Song Lu. Song Lu glanced at her, before looking back at me.

Though Du Yue walked over to her, she ignored Song Lu. She simply stood by Song Lu’s side as she addressed me. “This means that everything is a conspiracy by Huai Du. He made use of the interest that Gaoqin Jiuye had in you, and he helped Gaoqin Jiuye go to your world, leading to him falling in love with you. He even created some disagreements between the both of you. His eventual aim was for Gaoqin Jiuye to bring you over to this world.”

“Why did he do that? We have nothing against each other. I don’t even know him.”

Du Yue lost her smile as shook her head. “I don’t know why he did that, since I’m a soul splitter from the Gate of Heaven, and he’s the ruler in the Gate of Ghost. I wouldn’t know what he’s thinking. However, I know one thing. There’s some secret behind that second personality of yours. They’re all aiming for your second personality.”

They? Who else?

Why was my second personality so popular? Haha, everyone is fighting for her. She caused me to become a freak in my own world, and now a series of gears have been set off because of my second personality? What’s going on here?

It’s not like I’m the only one who has double identity disorder in my world. Why did I have to be chosen like this...

“I want to find out the secret too, so I wanted to bring you here to the Palace of Cold Blood. You can see for yourself. I haven’t really done anything to your good friend. Li Wen handed her over when she made a

deal with me, and I've been nice to her since. I've even given her important tasks.

"I wouldn't have had to waste that pill if you had come here with me willingly. But things change, and I was prepared for accidents to happen. I have this pill with me so that I can return here the very moment you meet Song Lu, or when you entered the Palace of Cold Blood.

"Talking about this, aren't you really something huh? You didn't even bother to say anything before you left. Is the Western District Commander such an unreliable person?"

I stared at her. "You make yourself sound the most innocent. Who was the one who destroyed the Western District? It's those experimental subjects of yours, isn't it? Have you already anticipated that I would be able to survive and escape to the Northern District? Haha, sorry but I don't think so. If you, Du Yue, can anticipate things like that, I don't think there's a need for you to go to such lengths to do me in, is there?"

Du Yue's face dropped. "The Eastern, Western and Southern Districts were destroyed because I do not have the ability to anticipate everything. Things aren't as simple as you think they are."

Chapter 249: 249 Reuniting in the Gate of Heaven

Volume 4

249 Reuniting in the Gate of Heaven

“I don’t care what excuses or reasons you have. All I saw was how those experimental subjects of yours wreaked havoc on my home.” I looked at Du Yue coldly.

Instead of getting upset, Du Yue smiled. “You want revenge? You have no choice but to listen to me right now. Force your second personality out, I want to meet her.”

“Why do you think I’d agree?”

“Because you haven’t found those eyes yet. And weren’t you begging to take that drug again just moments ago in order to return to those lost memories?”

“You still have it...”

“Of course.”

“Give it to me.” I reached out to her.

“You’re still as impulsive as ever huh.”

I laughed at her. “People, stop going around in circles. Why are you pretending? Don’t you want me to take that drug again? You’re disappointed that my second personality wasn’t properly forced out by it the

first time, aren't you? It's not a bad thing actually, since I might not even be able to control that second personality myself. Are you sure you're able to go against her if she comes out?"

Du Yue smirked. "What audacity. There's nothing I haven't seen here in the Split Zone. How powerful can that second personality of yours be?"

I refused to back down. "Not powerful? Then why is everyone running to her? There's no use in talking so much. Give Jiao S's eyes back, then give me that drug. I'll listen to whatever you say after I take it. How about that?"

Jiao S shouted suddenly, "No! Ah Shen, you can't take that drug anymore!"

Du Yue looked at Jiao S with furrowed brows and a stormy expression. I moved to obscure her vision and asked, "What do you think of my suggestion?"

Song Lu stepped forward before Du Yue could answer. "She's not here alone. Nie Zun is here too." Song Lu looked at me with a complex gaze as she informed Du Yue of this.

Du Yue raised a brow. "Oh. Where did you take him?"

Song Lu glanced at me before answering, "I brought him to see Jie Pa, and I've locked him up together."

What.

I frowned at Song Lu.

Du Yue pondered for a moment before addressing me. "How about this. Come with me and I'll bring you to see Nie Zun and your Western District subordinates. What do you think?"

Would she be that kind?

There has to be some other plan going on here.

Whatever she was planning, she was in a favorable position right now. I had no choice but to be passive and just be led by her.

“Sure, but can you assure that she’ll be save?” I pointed at Jiao S behind me.

Du Yue nodded. “Not only will I return her eyes, I’ll even let her go if you do what I say.”

“Great.” I answered without hesitation.

“Ah Shen.”

Jiao S called out urgently.

I knew she was worried about me. *But, Jiao S, I have to save you. I have to.*

Even if I might lose everything in the process.

I knew she’ll understand where I was coming from, and I continued without looking back at her.

“Let’s go. We’ll do as you say,” I said to Du Yue. With a look from Du Yue, Song Lu led me back to those steps.

I couldn’t help but turn back for a last look before I left. Jiao S was still seated with both her arms trapped in shackles. She was looking up, facing me.

I held back tears as I turned to leave.

Du Yue motioned with her hand and a door appeared in a flash of white light. She turned to me with upturned lips. “Come in.”

I was in the Gate of Heaven, but all I could see was a sea of white. There was no day and night here, it was simply connections between different areas and spaces.

There were two possibilities. The first was that the Gate of Heaven looked just like this, and that it was filled with countless spatial connections that looked exactly like what I was witnessing. The other possibility was that this was how the Palace of Cold Blood looked like. Whatever it was, it was a manifestation of the powers of those in the Gate of Heaven. They might have extraordinary ability in controlling and manipulating MF, and also these spaces.

Du Yue had much greater power than I did, judging from how she used those restriction techniques and how she could control divine beasts.

What exactly is her goal? She seemed to be destroying everything around me, but if I think about it, she didn't really do anything to me personally. Who is she targeting?

Bian Ying and Cang Ming are both missing now, and I don't know where Ta Lai is. It felt as if a huge puzzle was placed right in front of me, just waiting for me to solve it.

After the door opened, I stepped into the room after Song Lu.

I was stunned at what I saw.

This was the laboratory.

The laboratory that Gao Qi would bring me to; the laboratory at the end of the corridor.

“This. What’s going on?”

Two shadows emerged from behind the door as I looked at Du Yue, expecting her to answer. One of them grabbed Du Yue by the neck and took her in a choke hold, while the other one held onto Song Lu, restricting her movement.

It was Nie Zun who grabbed Du Yue. The hand that was on Du Yue’s neck was enshrouded in black fog, and I could see a little bit of that skull ring.

It rang a bell as I recalled something regarding that ring.

This was the ring.

This was the ring which Gaoqin Jiuye gave me after taking it from the Split Zone, the ring which existed in my lost memories.

Why would it be on Nie Zun though? I realized that no one else seemed to have noticed this.

But how could that be possible? If it really was the same ring, would Gaoqin Jiuye not have noticed?

“Why are you here?” Nie Zun asked me coldly.

Du Yue smirked. “I guess I’ve underestimated you. But I shouldn’t have been so naïve to have thought that the enchantment on this space would be able to stop you, even if Song Lu locked you up in here. What’s the point of you doing this anyway? Isn’t this all for naught, since you can’t kill me?”

A malicious smile appeared on Nie Zun. “What makes you think I can’t kill you? Because you’re a soul splitter?”

The black fog around his hand seemed to get heavier.

Though there was a sudden look of surprise on Du Yue, she was able to hide her emotions and thoughts well.

“Miss Ah Shen. It’s been a while.”

I turned around as I heard Jie Pa’s familiar voice. The individual holding onto Song Lu was actually Jie Pa!

Jie Pa did not change at all. He still looked like a gentleman, even while he was restraining Song Lu. He seemed to have become quicker. I was filled with joy as I saw Jie Pa like this. He did not look like he had suffered much.

It’s been a while since I felt like this. It felt as if I had just met a long-lost friend who was doing very well.

“How are you, Jie Pa?” I asked without any concern to the current situation.

Jie Pa smiled. "I'm well, Miss Ah Shen. It's just that we couldn't protect the Western District. I've tried my best to bring everyone out, and I've also been investigating these matters in the Split Zone. Not to worry, we'll definitely be able to solve these problems." The last line seemed to have been targeted at Du Yue. He even looked at Du Yue while he said it.

Du Yue smirked as she could tell it was meant for her. "As expected of the head of an intelligence, but I'm afraid the information that you have is barely enough to shake things. My advice is for you to give up."

Nie Zun's hand seemed to move and Du Yue fell silent immediately.

"Say it, where's Yu Liang?"

I did not expect that it would be Nie Zun who asked.

Song Lu's eyes widened as she heard this. She looked at Du Yue in disbelief.

Du Yue shot her a cold look. "No need to look at me like this. It's true that I kept you in the dark, but it's for your own good. Didn't you say you don't love him anymore?"

I retorted, "Love? What do you know about love? You don't seem to know much about love either, so who gave you the right to judge others like that?"

I turned to Song Lu. "You've heard it yourself. She's been keeping you in the dark about the fact that Yu Liang is in the Gate of Heaven. Are you still going to work for her like this?"

Song Lu bit her lip without saying anything.

"Say it. Where's Yu Liang?" Nie Zun asked again.

Du Yue responded coldly, "Why are you guys looking for Yu Liang? What, is it because you've felt his presence and you want to go help him?"

His presence? Who is she referring to? I frowned. I seemed to be the only one who was out of the loop here.

“That’s right, they all know that I’m here.”

A shadow emerged from behind a curtain.

It was Gaoqin Jiuye.

Laughter escaped me as I looked upon this ridiculous situation. *How did Gaoqin Jiuye arrive here so quickly from the Gate of Ghost?*

Du Yue’s expression turned stormy.

She retreated to the side as Nie Zun let her go suddenly.

No, something wasn’t right.

With Du Yue’s abilities, it would not be an easy task even for Nie Zun to restrict her movements. *Why did she allow that to happen?*

Did we walk into another trap again?

I snapped alert this time. It wasn’t the first time I was going against Du Yue, and I knew I had to be careful. I even wanted to step forward to take a better look at them as everyone seemed to be appearing everywhere. *Were these individuals really the people whom I thought they were?*

Chapter 250: 250 One Against Five

Volume 4

250 One Against Five

Du Yue's smile looked like she had anticipated everything. "Since you're here, you must have that bottle with you then. Ah Shen's friend, Jiao S, is still waiting for her eyes. You can return it to them."

Du Yue called me Ah Shen...

My hairs stood on ends.

A bottle magically appeared in Gaoqin Jiuye hands before he put it on one of the desks near him. "You know this isn't the only reason I'm here. I knew that the opening had been activated when I saw this bottle in front of me. What did you do to her? You made her remember?"

Gaoqin Jiuye pointed a finger at me with a cold look on his face.

Though he was usually arrogant, he looked indifferent most of the time. This was the first time I saw a serious expression on him.

However, he had not taken a single look at me since he entered. For some reason, it felt as if he was afraid to do so.

Du Yue smirked. "That's right, that opening which I had created earlier had now been activated. She knows everything now."

Gaoqin Jiuye looked at me with bright eyes.

Du Yue glanced back and forth between me and Gaoqin Jiuye. “She already knows that her senior Gao Qi wasn’t the one she had fallen in love with when she was alive. She knows that it was you who passed through the dimensions and who took over Gao Qi’s body.”

I subconsciously looked at Nie Zun as she said this. Except for a slight movement in his hands, Nie Zun was completely still.

I bit my lip.

No matter what Du Yue’s plan was, I won’t let her get her way. That smug look of hers annoyed me so much. I spoke, “No, I didn’t recall everything. I only recalled the part when we first met. I’m not sure about whatever happened after.”

I addressed this to Gaoqin Jiuye, thinking that he would clarify things. Instead, he looked at me and said, “You could only remember a tiny part even when you had the chance to recall everything? Looks like you’re still not ready to face yourself, and also to face me.”

I stole a glance at Nie Zun again.

Du Yue laughed out loud. “Don’t forget, Gaoqin Jiuye, you’re not the one she loves now. Why would she still be interested in those lost memories when she doesn’t love you anymore? I’ve told you that she’s not worth it. How much did you get in return for how much you’ve given up for her?”

In response, Gaoqin Jiuye said, “Return? All I wanted was for her to be safe. It’s the same right now. That ring is gone now, and we are unable to find it no matter how hard we look. Don’t think that I’m unaware of your plans. You won’t be able to complete it without power. Now that you’re not able to find that ring, you’re trying to activate her second personality and use it to go against Huai Du at the same time, right?”

Fed up with their conversation, I interrupted them. “Where’s Yu Liang? Aren’t you trying to save Si Luo, Gaoqin Jiuye? How long do you want Si Luo to be unconscious for? Du Yue said she’d bring me to see Yu Liang. Si

Luo would be able to wake up with Yu Liang around. Aren't you going to ask where Yu Liang is?"

I looked at Du Yue as I said this.

Song Lu's gaze landed on Du Yue as well.

Du Yue's chances of winning would drop if I turned this into an argument that was five against one. She might even lose it.

Du Yue was no fool though. Her eyes shone as she said, "You want to save Si Luo? Sure. But I want that second personality of hers. I'll never give up on this. How about you, Gaoqin Jiuye? Don't you want to see her again?"

This angered me.

Her? She spoke as if that 'her' was the one Gaoqin Jiuye wanted to meet, as if she had so much value.

Before I came up with my retort, I wanted to see how Gaoqin Jiuye would respond. Little did I expect for him to turn to me and say, "The truth is right here. Since you've already recalled some things, how about you try and remember everything else."

Why did he say that?

Nie Zun laughed suddenly, breaking the suffocating atmosphere in this laboratory with that laughter made it sound like nothing in this world affected him at all.

His gaze remained cold and distant. "All this is for naught. Do you think that you'll really be able to control her even if she had regained all her memories in an instant? If that was the case, Huai Du wouldn't have had laid eyes on me."

What?

Huai Du did something to him?

All of us stood stock-still after we heard Nie Zun reveal this.

Nie Zun then explained with patience, “All those possibilities you’ve thought of, especially you, Du Yue, Huai Du would be able to think of them too. He had already put in place his defenses, and he put a curse on me in that demon cave. Well, instead of a curse, it would be more accurate to call it a key that would activate upon certain circumstances.

“Anyway, once Li Shen’s second personality is being activated, she’d be in a constant state of rage. Without me, it’s unlikely that anyone else would be able to stop her in that state.”

Du Yue seemed to hesitate before she responded, “Are you sure this is not you just thinking too highly of yourself?”

Nie Zun laughed with malice. “Thinking too highly of myself? You should know very well whether I have the ability.”

Du Yue frowned. “That doesn’t sound like you at all. What did Huai Du do to you?”

Nie Zun smiled casually. “He merely gave me some memories for me to understand some of the secrets in the Split Zone. Why? Are you scared that I know everything? All that planning, even that excuse of taking revenge on a rival in love? You’re afraid now?”

His words were an obvious challenge.

Though Du Yue looked calm, I could see her pupils shaking. Nie Zun had touched a nerve.

However, I had absolutely no idea what they were talking about.

“What are you guys planning to do?” I had to interrupt these people before the situation got out of hand.

What I had to find out was if I could regain all my memories, and what exactly happened in those lost memories of mine.

Du Yue ignored me. Everyone else ignored me.

She looked at Gaoqin Jiuye. “Yu Liang is right outside. You’ll be able to see him when you exit through the door.”

I thought I saw Song Lu shiver slightly at this.

Gaoqin Jiuye narrowed his eyes. “Du Yue, you’re trying to trick me now? I believe you if you tell me that I have to exit the door to be able to see him, since you’re good at connecting these spaces. But how can I be sure that you won’t do anything to Li Shen after I’m gone?”

For some reason, his words sent a rush of warmth to my heart.

Du Yue seemed a little surprised at what he said. She stared at him with gritted teeth as she responded. “You can forget about Si Luo waking up if you don’t go look for Yu Liang. That’s right, I’ll be doing something to your little lover once you’re gone. I want her to regain every single one of those lost memories. You don’t want that? No matter how much you like her, you’d not give up on Si Luo if you’re presented with a choice like this.”

My heart was about to sink, but Gaoqin Jiuye said, “It’s not the same today. I don’t want her to remember so much. I’m sorry, but you’re running out of chips today. I can think of another way to save Si Luo in future, but don’t even dream of getting me to leave right now.”

Is this the first time he had chosen me over Si Luo?

But why did I not feel happy about this at all?

Du Yue laughed in self-mockery. “I guess you’re really loyal to her. But can you see that you’re not the one in her eyes right now? Guess who she’d choose between you and her current lover?”

I thought those words wouldn’t have affected anyone, because it was said with the purpose of tearing people apart. But Gaoqin Jiuye seemed to be affected by them as he looked at me with sorrowful eyes.

That sorrow seemed to be able to pierce right through my heart.

It was different now, since I remembered some things from the past.

Memories are such amazing things. You won't feel it if you don't remember it, but you'll never be able to ignore it if you recalled it.

I had fallen in love with him once. He wasn't Gao Qi, and he didn't die. My heart hurt so much that I had to furrow my brows in pain.

I caught Nie Zun from the side of my eye and I turned to look at him.

He still had that indifferent gaze, as if he did not have a care in the world, as if nothing had happened. But I stared into his eyes and I knew I wasn't seeing things. I could see that loneliness deep inside them.

It was heart-wrenching.

"I'm going to look for Yu Liang." Song Lu spoke, breaking the silence.

Du Yue frowned. "I know you're not happy that I kept you in the dark about this. But I have a reason for doing so. Trust me, please. I'll bring you to him when the time comes."

Haha, Du Yue could actually be polite like this? Trust me, please?

Song Lu must have some sort of extraordinary ability to the point that she was being so favored by Du Yue.

Song Lu did not buy it this time. She sounded resolute. "I don't want to repeat this a third time. I want to look for him now. Open the door."

Du Yue narrowed her eyes as she relaxed her frown. "What to do? I don't like how the situation has turned out now. This makes me want to break the peace that has been maintained up until now."

She wants to fight.

That was quite fearless of her. *Do you really think you can win if it's one against five?*

Chapter 251: 251 His Illusion

Volume 4

251 His Illusion

Du Yue's chances of winning would definitely be lowered in a scenario where she had to go against five others.

To win, one had to know your enemy. Though she was powerful, there were two other individuals here who knew her rather well. In such a situation, it would be difficult for her to emerge victor if she wages a war on her own.

I didn't believe that she'd actually choose to fight us alone, and she did not make that choice either.

She looked at me steadily. "Do you really think that those pills I made would be ineffective?"

"What do you mean by that?"

She snapped her fingers loudly.

The scene in front of me started shaking.

I heard Gaoqin Jiuye ask, "What did you do to her...?"

"It's not my fault when she voluntarily ate it. The drug only has a limited effectiveness if I don't activate it. You're worried? Don't you want her to remember everything about you?"

"No, you can't do that."

So this was to activate the drug again?

I can finally find out what happened in the past?

Instead of being afraid, I was surprisingly calm. *Li Shen, Li Shen, just what have you forgotten?*

Just as I felt my consciousness slipping away, a cold hand grabbed me. That hand was as cold as ice, but I felt an indescribable sense of security in that coldness.

His voice was calm beside my ear. “Seems like I have to use that technique on you.”

Right after that, darkness blanketed my vision and I began to feel as if I was falling.

It didn’t feel as if I was falling at a high speed, and it didn’t feel as if I was dropping into a bottomless pit.

It felt like I was slowly flying downwards. It was sort of relaxing.

“Time to wake up, Shen’er.” I heard Nie Zun’s familiar voice.

Snapping my eyes open, I lost that feeling of flying immediately. I stood up and looked around me.

I seemed to be on a tiny tropical island, but it did not seem like an uninhabited island. There was an abundance of trees, flowers, and little animals.

The island was surrounded by a sea, and I woke up by the shore. Climbing up to higher ground, I could see the waves crashing against the rocks. I enjoyed the smell of the fresh air as the breeze from the sea tousled my hair.

I have not felt this alive in such a long time.

I didn’t want to think about what was happening right now nor where exactly this was as I shouted towards the ocean, “Ahhh……..!”

After taking a deep breath, I felt re-energized as the cold air entered my throat.

This felt different from the Split Zone.

I literally felt alive at this very moment.

Someone tapped me on the shoulder as I was busy being excited on my own.

My heart flinched a little in fear before I turned around to look.

His starry eyes met mine.

The wind tousled his wispy bangs, and the sunlight reflected off his black hair, making it look golden brown.

It was the first time I saw such a gentle gaze on him.

“Nie... Zun...” I stuttered.

He interrupted me gently, “Call me Zun.”

My eyes widened in slight shock. *Call him... Zun?*

I’ve never called him that, and it was difficult for me to change how I addressed him all of a sudden.

But what he did next made me even more surprised.

He reached out and took me in an embrace.

Resting my chin on his shoulders, I looked up at the endless azure sky. The sky was blue instead of gray here, and there were clouds around. The sun was behind me, and I could hear the sound of the waves hitting the shore. Though the breeze was chilly, it felt comfortable as it blew across my back.

Though his embrace still felt chilly, there was no one else but him who could give me such a sense of security.

After being in a daze for about ten or more seconds, I finally returned his hug as I wrapped both my arms around his waist.

We hugged each other tightly.

My eyes were open as I asked softly, “I’m not dreaming, am I...?”

His voice was dreamy but clear at the same time. “You’re not. I’m Nie Zun, and you’re hugging me now.”

Where is this place? Where are we? Why are we here? Why are you treating me so differently now? There were many more questions in my head, but I didn’t want to ask any of them.

None of that mattered in this moment.

At least I knew that I wasn’t dreaming.

This might be an illusion, or some other space that I was not aware of. But these things were not important anymore.

What mattered was that I could feel that the real Nie Zun was right in front of me now. He was no impostor.

That was enough.

I’ll cherish this precious moment.

Just like that day in the demon cave, I wanted time to stop so that I could just stay by his side like this.

Just like what he did for me in the past.

Nothing mattered more than this.

Although this might just be me running away from things, I’d rather enjoy this beautiful moment, even if it might turn out to be a lie.

I hugged him even tighter as I thought of this.

He returned it.

“Don’t you want to ask me anything?”

My chin was still resting against his shoulder as I spoke, “Yes.”

“Then...”

I interrupted him. “I want to, but I won’t. Shhh. Just let me hold you like this for a while.”

Nie Zun kept quiet after that.

I closed my eyes slowly and took another breath of the refreshing air. I could smell Nie Zun’s unique aroma with it.

This was a smell that was indescribable.

It was like telepathy between us. I could always feel it and smell it whenever he was around.

This was that aura which gave me a sense of security.

There was nothing to be worried about and nothing to be afraid of, because he would be by my side like this.

I could free my mind of all thoughts as I held him.

I’ve never felt this way before, and I might never feel this way again.

Let time stop now.

Every girl would probably have had such a thought. Every girl would have had such an experience, and it might have been more than once, or with more than one individual.

But I only had Nie Zun in my life.

It was only now that I began to realize how scary it was to get used to being together every single day.

He had been by my side for way too long.

It was like a slow-acting drug where he enters your life slowly but surely, and takes over all your senses and everything in your mind.

You'd be crying tears of joy when you realize it, and you'd be smiling bitterly too, because you'd know that you'll never be able to leave him, ever.

He had become your greatest weakness, and your only weakness.

I could not imagine losing him, not even for a mere second.

I took him in a tighter embrace as I felt my heart overflow with emotions.

"Zun..." I called out, hearing my own voice being carried away by the wind.

"Mm," he answered, as if reassuring me that he was right there.

My tears started falling just like this.

He then let go of me slowly, as if he had sensed something.

I didn't want that embrace to end, so I grabbed him tightly, refusing to let go.

He seemed to get a little anxious at this, probably because he could tell I was crying.

But he still let me grab him.

"Don't be scared, I'm here," he said.

Looking up at the clear sky, I knew that no matter how much I wanted for this moment to last, I had to face reality.

Avoidance does not solve any problems.

Finally, I let go of him unwillingly.

I smiled as I looked into his eyes. “Tell me, where is this place? Why am I here?”

Nie Zun’s gaze entrapped me as he brushed my hair lovingly. “You’re in an illusion that I’ve created.”

I stuttered, “You... you know how to create illusions?”

He nodded. “Guan Nie taught me a bit, and I’ve seen Huan Qing use it a few times. The way they controlled MF seemed similar to how I controlled mine, so I tried to do this on my own.”

“But why did you pull me into your illusion...?”

He smiled gently. “It’s not only you. I’m here in the illusion too. It’s nothing, just treat it as a present from me. Taste the freedom here with me for a little while.”

Chapter 252: 252 Returning a Real Love to You

Volume 4

252 Returning a Real Love to You

Freedom...?

Freedom... That seemed to have been something that has eluded me for a long time.

Taking my hand in his, he said, “I owe you a love, and I’d like to make it up to you now. Even if it’s an illusion, I hope you can believe it just this once, and let me lead you in this.”

I smiled. “Okay.”

He pulled me with him like an excited child as we ran along the rocks on the shore.

My red dress and his black coat overlapped with each other at times when they billowed in the wind. It felt colorful, as if they weren’t just black and red. It felt like they were a rainbow of color, the color of love.

I know I shouldn’t be too immersed in this, but I could not help myself. I might have suppressed my feelings for too long, or it might be because I had been unhappy in my previous relationship, but I now felt that I could never let him go even if the world crumbled right in front of me.

“Let’s go over there. There’s a tiny beach where we can go look for crabs.”

My eyes widened in surprise. *Crabs exist here in this illusion?*

My legs were already running after him.

We arrived at a beach which looked totally different from those rocks earlier.

He let go of me and started backing away as he turned around to face me.

The wind was blowing against his back, towards me, and it made his hair a beautiful mess.

A loving smile appeared on his face. This was the first time I've seen such a happy smile on him, not like that mock indifference that seemed to have always been forced out.

Looking at that adorable face, I ran towards him with a brilliant smile.

He turned to the sea and shouted, "I love Li Shen!"

Never would I have expected for him to confess so loudly like this.

This quiet, mysterious man was acting like a child who had just gotten a candy. He was announcing his happiness to the entire world.

You're amazing.

I shouted, "I love Nie Zun!"

I even choked a little on the wind which blew right into my throat.

He grabbed me and we both squatted on the beach.

"Look, a crab!"

"Where where where?" I looked around in excitement, trying hard to find the crab which Nie Zun mentioned.

"Haha, you're an idiot. Can't you see that there's only a shell?"

“A shell is fine too!” I said as I snatched that shell he just picked up.

“You aren’t going to be like those childish girls who’d put the shell against their ear to try and listen to sounds of the ocean, are you?”

“How’d you know?”

“...

“My dear, you have to know that this is an illusion. My MF is nowhere near high enough to create a conch that would contain the sound of the ocean.”

“It doesn’t matter. I’m just going to listen for a bit.” Putting it against my ear, I listened to it carefully.

Nothing was heard. It proved that this was in fact an illusion.

But it wasn’t the time to find fault in things.

“Hey, are there other fun places on this island?” I took Nie Zun’s hand as I asked.

“Want to go have a look?”

“You prepared a surprise for me?”

“Let’s go. You’ll find out then.”

“Hmph. You’ve gone back to your annoying self.”

“Let’s go.” Without further ado, Nie Zun took my hand and led me further in towards the island.

I couldn’t believe that I ended up perspiring as we ran. It felt hot as the sun shone above us. It was almost as if I was alive again.

He led me into the forest in the middle of the island.

“I’ve prepared a surprise for you.”

“Oh? What surprise?”

Pulling me with him, he started running through the forest.

Focusing MF on my feet, I ran at his speed. It felt as if I was flying.

The smell of the trees and flowers were fresh, and I could hear the sounds of insects and birds all around me.

I was stunned by the scene in front of me as we finally arrived at the destination.

“Wow...”

I looked at the flower field in front of me.

It was a rare scene.

Yes, it literally was a sea of flowers. These were my favorite, roses.

Red, red roses.

I loved roses.

I loved them because everyone said they were old-fashioned.

Many others liked lilies as they found lilies elegant and pure.

But I liked roses.

I liked that bright red.

It was a sea of red, and waves of red appeared as the wind caressed it.

It was beautiful.

It was too beautiful.

“Surprised? A field of roses. I don’t think you’ve ever seen this before.”

“These, do these roses prick?” I asked, dumbfounded.

“Why not you try touching them?” Before I could answer, he grabbed me and led me into the flower field.

I stepped on many of the roses along the way, but these roses were rather interesting. They sprang back up a while later after being stepped on.

If Nie Zun specially designed this scene for me, I could only say that he knew me well.

His eyes met mine when we finally ended up right in the middle of the flower field.

Those starry eyes that seemed to reflect the light of the full moon were filled with emotion in the slight breeze. These eyes were those eyes that I could not pull myself out of from the very moment I saw them. They were coming closer to me now.

I felt the kiss very clearly this time.

It was not as passionate as before, and I could feel every single one of his minute movements.

I could feel those cold lips and his breath. I acted like those females in romance stories, holding onto him as his kiss slowly turned fiery.

Diamonds sparkled in his jet-black eyes as I fell backwards into the sea of flowers.

I embraced him tightly.

But a dream was still a dream, and even if it was a dream, one would still be able to feel that sense of danger.

He lay down in the flower field beside me and looked at me.

“Can you promise me something, Shen’er?”

I didn't like the sound of this at all. It sounded as if it was the beginning of an end, but I still responded as gently as I could. "Say it. I'll promise you."

My heart felt like it was slowly being twisted into a knot as I saw the sorrow in his eyes as he looked at me.

"If I'm not by your side in the future, you have to promise me that you'll accept her and continue living."

As expected. I felt shivers as I heard this.

I tried to answer as calmly as I could. "Don't leave me again, okay?"

Instead of responding immediately, he pointed at the sky above. "We haven't seen such a sky in a long time. The real sky. Don't you miss it, Shen'er?"

I miss it, of course I do.

But there are things we had to do here. There were still others we had to save.

We came to Split Zone 13 in order to pay for our sins, didn't we?

"Do you still remember how the sun looks like?"

I don't know why he asked that, but I answered, "Of course I do."

"Then you won't forget me." He then turned and smiled mischievously.

This made me more afraid.

I turned to face him, and I made him face me as well. There was nothing but a single red rose between us.

Pressing down on that rose, I asked, "Tell me, why were you being so cold and distant to me? And now that you've brought me here to this illusion, why are you telling me to forgive you if you end up leaving in future? Tell

me what's happening. We have to wake up soon, and you can't keep me in the dark forever."

A bitter smile escaped Nie Zun's lips. "I really hoped to be able to keep you in the dark forever."

I answered softly, "You know that it's just wishful thinking. I'm begging you, Nie Zun. Don't lie to me. Tell me the truth."

Nie Zun brushed my red hair. "I'll be sending you back in a while. You have to overcome that drug when you go back. Stop being controlled by it. Stop letting your second personality out. They're all looking for her, and you'll be putting yourself in danger if she appears."

"I suddenly thought of something. That ring, Nie Zun. Who gave it to you?" I asked hastily as I happened to see that ring on his left hand when he lifted it.

This was an important question, and I had an instinct that this was a chance where I could get him to reveal something.

According to Du Yue and Gaoqin Jiuye, Gaoqin Jiuye was the one who gave me the ring. Why did it end up on Nie Zun then?

Nie Zun looked shaken by my question, and that look he gave me confirmed my suspicions that there was something more about this ring. It might hold some sort of secret.

He sighed after a moment of silence. "It was her who gave it to me. You might start hating me again if I say it like that."

I was stunned at this.

But I was no longer like before.

I wouldn't put the blame on anyone for not stopping me, since I did not know what exactly happened then. Secondly, the murderer should be the one at fault for killing anyone. I shouldn't be blaming others for not stopping her.

It's just that I didn't understand it. Why was she the one who gave the ring to him?

Chapter 253: 253 The Heart that was Taken Away

Volume 4

253 The Heart that was Taken Away

A gust of wind ruffled the flower field just when I was about to clarify with Nie Zun on why she was the one who gave him that ring.

The wind was so strong that I had to squint to prevent it from piercing my eyes. It brought with it the smell of fragrant roses, but there was also the smell of blood in the air.

Why would it smell like blood here?

I saw a sea of red before pain shot right through my heart.

Thud, thud, thud.

The smell of disinfectant assaulted my nose as I ended up back in the laboratory. The flower field was gone.

Everyone had shocked faces.

Nie Zun's hand was embedded in my chest.

There was no expression on his face. I could not tell what he was thinking.

Thud, thud, thud.

My heart beat in his hands.

A bitter smile escaped me.

I didn't want to think about what was happening, or what happened to him.

Nothing mattered now.

My mind was still in that flower field.

I suddenly wanted to leave the Split Zone.

I had never felt such an impulse to leave before. I wanted to go back to the real world with him, to go back to that place, to take a look at a real flower field.

Promise me, that you'll stay by my side as long as I can stay alive and bring you with me, okay?

Rip.

Connective tissues teared as he forcefully ripped my heart out of me.

That feeling of cold wind blowing right through you was not comfortable at all. I could still remember the immense pain from when Si Luo stuck his hand into my chest.

But it wasn't painful this time.

How can I feel any pain when my heart was already gone?

"What are you doing?" Gaoqin Jiuye stared open-mouthed, looking like he was about to rush forward.

A black fog encapsulated Nie Zun and I with a wave of his other hand. Gaoqin Jiuye was not able to come near this fog at all.

Nie Zun had that usual indifference on his face.

The blood from my heart was dripping all over those pale, slender fingers of his.

We looked at each other like that, with him holding my heart.

I was suddenly curious about the reactions of others, and I tried to steal a glance at the rest of them from the corner of my eyes.

Du Yue did not look too happy about this, and Song Lu was frowning deeply as if she was worried about something. Jie Pa looked surprised at first, but he then looked as if he was in deep thought a few moments later.

I knew Jie Pa was always calm. He must be thinking about the reasons behind Nie Zun's actions.

But I'm not going to ask him about that, because it wasn't what I cared about at this moment.

My gaze landed on Gaoqin Jiuye for a couple of seconds.

I was a little stunned when I saw him.

Those eyes of his...

He looked enraged. He was watching me with hopeless eyes and a kind of hatred that seemed as if he had stopped the sky from crumbling down on me, but all I did was go and kill myself in front of him right after.

I knew then that he hated me. He definitely hated me.

But how could I not hate you?

*If you loved me, and you knew that I loved you, why did you let me forget?
Why did you pile this guilt on me and make me come here to live like a rat?*

Why didn't you go over to that world to be with me?

Why did you lie to me?

I smiled at him. I knew it would make him hate me even more.

Yes, this was me.

Gaoqin Jiuye, since you've chosen to stand against me from the start, then we shall forever be on opposite sides. If Nie Zun turns into a devil and I'm with him, there's no need for you to be near me, just continue staying on the other end.

It was already fated from the very beginning that you had to bring such pain to me.

“You shouldn't be looking at others when I have your heart with me.” Nie Zun spoke, rippling the still air.

I felt myself getting paler and paler. I wasn't upset or in pain, it was merely from losing too much blood.

“It's inevitable that we might be a little lost and confused when we lose too much blood. I hope you understand.” I forced myself to give him a bright smile.

Du Yue's face looked like she had just seen a monster. I bet she must be wondering how weird I must be to be able to say something like this.

Life was difficult enough. Wouldn't we end up wallowing in sorrow if we don't laugh at ourselves like that?

It's always good to be a little more optimistic.

I realized something at this point. *Why wasn't my heart regenerating after it had been ripped out?*

Were hearts unable to regenerate?

This did not make sense. Every single part of a body of consciousness in the Split Zone is supposed to be able to regenerate; it's just that it would take up a huge amount of MF to do so, and it was a tedious process. This didn't mean that it could not regenerate, even if it was the heart. Even if it was a slow process, something should have already happened by now.

However, I could feel it very clearly that there was no new heart growing in place. The hole in my chest was simply bleeding continuously, and I could

even feel the wind blowing through it.

I wasn't the only one who realized this. Song Lu said, "What did you do to her? Why isn't her heart healing?"

Nie Zun was still holding my beating heart, dark and sticky blood flowing all over in his hand.

Thud, thud, thud.

Just as I wondered why that heart could still beat even after being ripped out, it disappeared in a cloud of black fog with a wave of Nie Zun's hand.

The heart was gone after the black fog dissipated.

It looked similar to Gaoqin Jiuye's technique when he hid Si Luo in the air vortex.

This reminded me that we should be looking for Yu Liang so that we can wake Si Luo up. He said he'll help me accomplish all that I wanted to achieve.

"What are you trying to do?"

The others looked like they weren't able to go any closer to Nie Zun's black fog. They looked quite wary of it, even Gaoqin Jiuye. All of them had that expression that Laurel had on her face when Nie Zun strangled her quite some time ago.

I knew that Nie Zun's hands could put some sort of pressure on the consciousness of others and it was difficult not to fear that. But right now, that black fog looked like a manifestation of that demonic prowess within him, and it was simply terrifying.

Surprisingly, Du Yue was the one who asked the question. Her expression looked almost as if she actually cared if I ended up dying.

Nie Zun looked at his hand, as if he was observing those blood stains left by my heart. He answered casually, "Don't all of you want her second

personality? From what I know, the method you're using to make others lose their ability to heal is merely a drug that has a limited effectiveness. I've used a bottle by accident, and I hope you don't mind. She'll be able to heal a little while after.

“Now that she doesn't have a heart, I'm going to drip some of my demonic blood in her. Since you know Huai Du, you should know that his demonic blood would be able to capture this tiny heart, right? It's equivalent to having an incomplete consciousness without a heart, and there's no way you can summon her second personality like this.”

What.

I didn't really get that.

Wait, let me think this through. Firstly, he's saying that he has turned into a demon after coming out from Huai Du's demon cave. His blood has turned demonic, to the point that it is able to capture my heart like that? Of course, it isn't a simple taking. It's equivalent to making me lose a part of my personality, leading to an incomplete consciousness.

I got it now. He didn't use any of Du Yue's drugs. He simply used that demonic blood to create this handicap in my consciousness. A part of my consciousness had been forcefully taken away by him, and it would end up being controlled by that demonic blood.

This was also why I could not regenerate. Bodies of consciousness in the Split Zone rely on MF to maintain their outer appearances, and a complete appearance is merely a manifestation of having a complete consciousness.

Did he do this so that my second personality would not appear again?

His words when we were in the flower field rang in my mind. *Did he do this because he was afraid that my second personality would bring me harm?*

The wind was still blowing into that hole in my chest. Slowly, my flesh was regenerating, but I still had no heart.

I had literally turned into a heartless person.

I looked down at the hole in my red dress, wondering whether I should laugh or cry. Luckily, the blood had stained my skin to the point that nothing else could be seen. It seemed to also blend in with that red dress of mine.

“So you’ve been sent by Huai Du?” Du Yue tried to pick for more information.

Nie Zun took out a white handkerchief from his pocket as he attempted to wipe the blood stains from his hands. He looked a little like the old Jie Pa doing this.

I stole a glance at Jie Pa and I saw him looking at me as he adjusted his glasses.

Slight joy filled me as I saw that familiar gesture. It was something that I haven’t seen in a long time.

Bouts of pain shot through my chest suddenly. *Probably because I didn’t have a heart.* Everything I did was painful, even if it was just a tiny expression.

This was quite unbearable.

“That’s not important, whoever it was who sent me. The thing is your plan has gone down the drain now. You can’t use your drug to force her second personality out anymore. What do you plan to do next?”

Nie Zun was able to clean up most of the blood on his fingers, and he returned the blood-stained handkerchief to his coat pocket.

Du Yue shot a glance at me before answering. “How cruel. You can actually bear for her to go through such pain all for the purpose of stopping me in my tracks?”

Chapter 254: 254 Si Luo Wakes Up

Volume 4

254 Si Luo Wakes Up

Nie Zun put his hands back into his pockets as he said, “You seem to have gotten that wrong. I didn’t do this to stop you at all. In fact, I don’t care whether you succeed or fail.”

Gaoqin Jiuye shouted at me all of a sudden. “Are you an idiot? You just let him do whatever he wishes to you...?”

I rolled my eyes at him, but I tried to sound as casual as I could when I answered. “I’m not able to beat him anyway. Why are you shouting at me?”

My brows furrowed right after I said that. Seeing my expression, Gaoqin Jiuye sounded angrier. “Do you know the pain of being heartless now?”

I guess what he and Du Yue referred to as ‘the pain of being heartless’ had happened to somebody else before. This was caused by an incomplete consciousness, and it manifested itself in the form of pain.

It felt like there was a huge fire burning right in the middle of my chest, and that heat was continually growing and spreading, immersing me in fiery pain.

Every minute movement of mine caused me immense pain. Even though I was already rather immune to pain, this uniquely unbearable feeling of pain was pretty difficult to endure.

Nie Zun and I were still enshrouded in that black fog which kept the rest at bay.

Nie Zun turned to Du Yue as he asked, “Where’s Yu Liang?”

Du Yue glared at him. “Why should I tell you that?”

He then pointed at me. “Your plan wouldn’t go through if she doesn’t have a heart.”

What he meant was that he wouldn’t return me my heart if she doesn’t do as he said.

Du Yue was no fool though. “In this situation, you wouldn’t be returning her heart to her even if I did whatever you said. If that’s the case, I’ll just do whatever I want without any heed to the consequences.”

Nie Zun shook his head slowly. He looked calm.

In fact, he was the calmest person in the room right now. Or should I say he had always been the calmest person.

I wanted to know what he was thinking at this moment, but I didn’t plan on asking him because I didn’t ask for much now.

I felt contented just having him by my side, as long as I could still see him. I didn’t care what happened to the world.

“Bring Yu Liang over. Or we could just continue wasting time like this.”

Song Lu sided with Nie Zun this time. “Yes, bring him over first.”

I thought Du Yue wasn’t someone who’d be controlled by anybody else, but to my surprise, she relented this time. She looked around at us before snapping her fingers in the air loudly.

With that snap, a vortex appeared in mid-air and two individuals dropped out from it.

This wasn’t the technique that Gaoqin Jiuye used to hide people. This was a spatial technique where she connected our space with the space that these

individuals were in. She then used MF to bring these individuals over to our space through that connection.

They were Yu Liang and Jiao S.

I wanted to rush forward upon seeing Jiao S, but when I met with that black fog that surrounded us, I realized why no one dared come near it.

There was a terrifying chill the moment I came into contact with that fog. It felt as if someone was blowing chilly air into every single pore on my body. It gave me the chills all over.

The feeling was indescribable. It was nauseating.

I could feel the depths of my soul shivering in fear. My mind felt like it was being drenched in fear.

It was horrifying.

I backed away quickly as Nie Zun glanced at me with slight blame in his eyes.

Seeing my attempt to approach Jiao S, Gaoqin Jiuye grabbed that bottle he placed on a desk earlier and threw it to Jiao S.

Though Jiao S did not have her eyes, she could still use her MF. Her other senses were still working fine and she managed to grab the bottle.

She opened it without hesitation before taking out an eyeball and putting it back into her eye socket. Liquid from the bottle, which might be formalin, dripped down her hands as she did so.

What a scene...

She moved and rolled her eyes after putting the both of them back into her sockets. She looked exactly like this when she moved those emotionless eyes of hers in the past.

I felt joy at seeing this familiar face, but I actually found her a little more adorable without them...

With her eyes back, that aura and attitude of hers were back too.

“Didn’t expect you to let her out too,” Gaoqin Jiuye said to Du Yue coldly.

Du Yue pointed at Yu Liang. “Isn’t this a better present for you?”

Yu Liang had been quiet since his arrival, and there had been no change in his expression at all. He did not look in Song Lu’s direction, and he looked like he was ignoring everything that was going on. It was as if he did not even recognize Song Lu.

Surprise flashed past Song Lu’s face when she set eyes on him. I was able to catch it though she suppressed it quickly.

What was up with these people? Why pretend that it didn’t matter if you didn’t care about me, because I didn’t care about you too? It was almost as if it was some kind of game.

Gaoqin Jiuye wouldn’t pass up such an opportunity. He spoke with haste, “Yu Liang, take the splitting key from Si Luo.”

An air vortex appeared as Gaoqin Jiuye waved his hands in the air.

A beautiful, white-robed Si Luo dropped into his arms. He looked like an angel descended from heaven as he lay in Gaoqin Jiuye’s arms, as if he did not have anything against the world.

Yu Liang finally looked up at Si Luo. He then went over and took out the spitting key from Si Luo without a word.

Si Luo woke up just like this.

When he woke up, the blood-red crescent moon in between his brows seemed to glow a little, making me wonder if my eyes were fooling me.

When he opened his silvery-white eyes, I could see the unadulterated joy in Gaoqin Jiuye. He placed Si Luo gently on the ground as if he was some fragile treasure.

An enchanting smile appeared on Si Luo, making my heart flutter. *Oh, I didn't have a heart now. Nothing could flutter.*

His clear voice rang throughout the room. "I guess I wasn't being careful enough and ended up falling asleep for a long time."

He looked sprightly. He didn't look like he was going to die anytime soon. I heaved an inward sigh of relief at this. Huan Qing and Mi Fu were no longer in the Split Zone, and since he didn't look sickly, Gaoqin Jiuye wouldn't be bothering me about this anymore.

Jiao S's eyes were no longer emotionless as she saw Si Luo wake up. They were bright and shiny, as if she was looking at a pile of diamonds.

Gosh, this woman wasn't even this emotional when she saw me after such a long time. I guess she doesn't care about me anymore now that Si Luo is here.

Du Yue smirked suddenly. "This is interesting."

Yes, it is indeed.

Gaoqin Jiuye and Si Luo were beside each other with Jiao S facing them. I was standing closer to Jiao S, somewhere to the side, enshrouded in a circle of black fog with Nie Zun.

On the other end stood Yu Liang and Du Yue, with Song Lu not far away from them. Jie Pa had been standing close behind Nie Zun from the start.

Jie Pa would always keep a low profile somewhere behind as long as Nie Zun was around. *Just like how Nie Zun stayed behind me in the past.*

Right, did Jie Pa actually say anything?

I guess he was observing everything.

Nie Zun laughed. “Yes, this is interesting. What should we do next?”

This did not sound like him.

He shouldn’t be asking something like this.

I had a feeling that someone was going to start something at this very moment.

As expected, Du Yue moved suddenly.

She shot a green light at Nie Zun from her palm. She was targeting Nie Zun right from the beginning, but Nie Zun did not move at all.

The black fog in front of him thickened right before that green light reached it.

A screen made out of black fog blocked Du Yue’s attack.

“Attacking now? What’s your goal?” Si Luo laughed.

I then decided to break this stalemate by waving towards Si Luo. “Been quite a while.”

That unbearable pain assaulted my chest as I waved.

Si Luo was looking at a woman with a weird expression on her face, where her brows were knitted tightly together and who looked like she was forcing a smile out of herself while waving a hand at him.

He responded gently with a wave of his hand, his robes looking like fluffy clouds around his pale arm. He said, “Hi, been quite a while.”

It immediately felt awkward.

This attempt of mine did not seem to have made the situation any better. It just made it seem as if I was a lunatic who crashed the party without knowing what was actually going on.

Whatever, I've been a lunatic for more than a mere day or two anyway.

I wondered what it was that made this group of people meet in this particular situation. It would be difficult to replicate a similar situation to this.

“It's been a long time.”

Jiao S was the one who said this in that hoarse voice of hers. *Alright, there was actually somebody else apart from me who would use such a line to continue this conversation.*

I knew Jiao S's goal was different from mine. She was testing the waters to see if Si Luo noticed her, or she might just be trying to get some sort of reaction from Si Luo.

Si Luo's silvery hair seemed to dance in this windless room as that blood-red crescent moon on his forehead glowed faintly. “Yes, it is. Been quite a while.”

Chapter 255: 255 A Resonance of MF

Volume 4

255 A Resonance of MF

Si Luo posed a question to Du Yue before Jiao S could continue. “Seems like I’m in the Gate of Heaven right now.”

Du Yue smirked. “That’s right. You’re in the Palace of Cold Blood in the Gate of Heaven, Si Luo. Should I say, welcome home?”

Gaoqin Jiuye’s expression turned dark at this.

Si Luo raised a hand to brush his silvery hair. He was mesmerizing.

Apart from beauty, he had this other-worldly aura to him. “I’d love to hear words of welcome, but I wouldn’t say this is home. What now, Du Yue? You’re so bored that you’ve started to invite heirs over to your place?”

Du Yue answered with sarcasm, “I’m accepting refugees here. The Southern, Eastern and Western Districts have all been destroyed.”

Si Luo’s brows knitted immediately and that blood-red crescent moon between them glowed bright. He emanated this noble but dangerous aura.

I realized why Si Luo was hailed as the most beautiful individual in the Split Zone. It was not merely because of that pretty face of his. He had this aura about him that made it seem as if it belonged to no one else but him. It was this unique aura that could not be found in others.

“What did you say?” Si Luo’s voice did not sound any less frigid than Gaoqin Jiuye’s when he said that.

Gaoqin Jiuye answered before Du Yue could speak. “It’s my fault for not protecting the Southern District. It ended up like the Eastern and Western Districts, they’ve all been destroyed. There aren’t many heirs left, and those who’ve survived are all scattered among the three Gates.”

Si Luo’s eyes glinted as he turned to look at Gaoqin Jiuye sharply. His silver hair created a beautiful wave as he turned.

Gaoqin Jiuye looked pained as he stared at the floor, not meeting Si Luo’s eyes.

This was the first time I’ve seen him look so defeated.

I knew that it wasn’t merely the destruction of the Southern District that made him feel this way. He felt this way because he felt that he had let Si Luo down, that he did not uphold all that trust that had been placed in him.

He was never a responsible person to begin with, so protecting the Southern District was a job that was easy for him to forgo. He did it because of his loyalty to Si Luo.

An individual who did whatever he wanted could actually restrict himself like this for loyalty. This proved that Si Luo was someone irreplaceable to him.

It could be talents recognizing each other, or it might have been because Si Luo was like an older brother to him in those lonely years.

Si Luo finally spoke after a moment of dead silence. “Who did it?”

Gaoqin Jiuye did not respond.

I was suddenly overwhelmed by a bout of anger. Smirking, I said, “Du Yue’s experimental subjects can cause heirs to lose their ability to regenerate within a limited time period. She then brought a whole batch of monsters to bathe the Eastern, Western and Southern Districts in blood.”

Du Yue responded quickly with a smirk. “I don’t think I’d be telling you that your Southern District has been destroyed if I was the one behind it. Laurel and that team wasn’t part of my plan. That was all Ghost King Huai Du’s scheme.”

Si Luo narrowed his eyes. “You guys just refuse to give up even after such a long time? You’re even embroiling my residents in a fight between Feng Zhu and Huai Du. Are you tired of living, Du Yue?”

‘I guess you’re tired of living’ – I’ve heard lines like these a million times in those television dramas, but it’s usually just an empty threat and there was actually nothing to be afraid of.

However, it was different the way Si Luo said it. He said it calmly without much variation in pitch, and his voice sounded so beautiful and clear like the clean spring water flowing across a glacier. It was difficult not to take his words seriously.

Apart from Huai Du, there was somebody else he mentioned – Feng Zhu.

Who is Feng Zhu?

There seemed to be some minute change in Du Yue’s expression after hearing Si Luo say that, but it was not obvious.

She said, “I haven’t lived enough. Nobody would complain of having a long life, just like how no one in that world would complain of having too much money. I’m confident of winning if I dare let them wake you up like this. There’s no need to threaten me like this, Si Luo. Right now, there’s no way you can save your residents. How about joining us to go against Huai Du? Without him, you’ll be able to create that Gate of Heaven you wished to have. What do you think of this suggestion?”

Oh, so Du Yue was trying to get Si Luo on her side. I wasn’t too sure about their relationship and the various reasons behind this, but it was probably why she was looking specifically for Si Luo instead of any of us.

Si Luo answered calmly, “It isn’t great.”

He glanced at Du Yue. “Your bargaining chips are getting lower in value.”

Du Yue waved her only hand. “I haven’t reached the part about the chips yet. Since everyone is here now, I’ll offer you something. I can give you a body of consciousness which hasn’t been engraved with a split symbol, and I’ll reveal Rong Jin’s real identity as well. What I want is simple. I just want you to work with us to go against Huai Du.”

A beautiful smile appeared on Si Luo’s face. “This isn’t simple at all. Also, I don’t wish to engrave a split symbol on anyone else. Don’t you know that?”

Du Yue looked at him resolutely. “You don’t wish to, but that doesn’t mean that others don’t either. Isn’t it, Gaoqin Jiuye?”

Surprise flashed in Gaoqin Jiuye’s eyes when Du Yue mentioned that she was able to provide a new heir, but it was replaced by another more complex emotion very quickly.

Si Luo laughed lightly. “Do you think he’ll be able to get me to do anything that I don’t want to? What use would you have for someone who refuses to engrave a split symbol and thus unable to get any power from it? You should give up right now. As for Rong Jin, aren’t you just going to say that he’s actually Ta Lai?”

Rong Jin is Ta Lai? What...?

Jiao S and I stared with wide eyes as we heard this. Surprise flashed in Nie Zun’s eyes while Gaoqin Jiuye looked absolutely stunned.

Du Yue’s gaze darkened. “How did you know?”

Si Luo laughed. “That’s not important.”

He turned to me suddenly. “Do you still remember your promise to me?”

I was caught unawares. *Why turn to me so suddenly?*

What I promised...

Was he referring to... how I had to fulfil those three conditions of his if he helps me accomplish whatever I wanted?

I wasn't quite sure about the situation I was in, and all I could do was nod in mock understanding. Si Luo smiled. "Good, you remember. But dear brother, may I ask what you're planning to do by encircling her like this?"

He posed this question to Nie Zun as he lifted a slender hand to touch that black fog.

The black fog then disappeared with just a touch.

Was this the ability of the individual with the highest amount of MF in the whole of the Eastern, Western and Southern Districts?

He could maintain his abilities at such a level even without an heir?

Nie Zun was rather surprised by his ability to dissipate the fog, but he calmed down quickly. Those starry eyes returned to that usual indifference.

"The further you are from her, the more you'll deteriorate. The opposite holds true. The symptoms of a deteriorating body from not having an heir would lessen the closer you are to her."

Nie Zun said something out of the ordinary suddenly, causing stunned looks on everyone.

What he meant was that Si Luo's condition would improve the closer he was to me. *What kind of logic was this?*

Did Nie Zun become retarded after turning demonic?

Si Luo looked serious suddenly.

Gaoqin Jiuye finally spoke. He addressed Si Luo. "Is it true, whatever he's saying? Is this... the resonance of MF? You already knew this, didn't you?"

Si Luo seemed to steal a sideways glance at me.

I was totally lost. *What were they talking about?*

Si Luo sighed. “Yes, I already knew this. I did it for you, because I didn’t want you to do things against your will again. Sometimes, you might think that your choice is right, but Gaoqin, that’s not always the case.”

“Are you joking, Si Luo? I was searching high and low for a method to save you, and you had a method all this while but you hid it from me? And now you’re telling me that you don’t want me to do anything against my will. Haha, Si Luo, have you really placed any trust in me, ever?”

Gaoqin Jiuye seemed agitated, while I was still lost in all of this.

Si Luo’s face darkened. “That’s enough, Gaoqin. We can talk about this later. I’m not dead yet, and my body is doing great. You should be thinking about the important things instead of this, understand?”

“Fine. You’re always like this. You’ve never given a thought to how much weight your life actually carries, Si Luo. You’re not living only for yourself. Can you spare a thought for others?” Though Gaoqin Jiuye seemed to relent, I could tell he was only getting more agitated.

Si Luo furrowed his brows. “Stop throwing a tantrum and acting like a child. Didn’t I say that I can’t die?”

A smile appeared on Du Yue, as if something just went in her favor. “That’s right, Gaoqin. What else do you want Si Luo to do? Do you want him to tell you that because of the resonance of MF, Li Shen’s second personality can actually stop Si Luo’s body from deteriorating forever? Si Luo knows that you have feelings for Li Shen, so how could he let you hurt her to save him?”

What did that mean?

Resonance of MF?

This meant that my MF had resonated with Si Luo’s on some level. Si Luo’s condition was originally deteriorating because he had lost his heir, but

because of the resonance of MF, his condition would improve once he came near me.

And all of this was once again related to my second personality.

Chapter 256: 256 Falling Apart

Volume 4

256 Falling Apart

Is this really the latest chapter in Split Zone 13...? I think I'm going insane.
No one noticed me, sadly.

Nie Zun interrupted suddenly, "If her second personality is really of such great use, then I'm sorry, because her heart is with me now. She'll never be able to summon her second personality without her heart. All your plans would turn to dust."

Du Yue laughed before addressing me. "See it now, Li Shen? You're the root of all problems. Take your heart back. Do you think you're of any value now that you're without your heart? Take your heart back, and those two friends of yours. I can send them back to the real world."

She pointed at Yu Liang and Song Lu.

They were standing at the sidelines, not looking at each other all this time. But when they heard her say this, both of them turned to look at Du Yue.

"What did you say..." The three of us spoke at the same time.

Du Yue smirked. "I've found the corresponding soul splitters for these friends of yours. If you're willing to take your heart back, I can bring them here immediately through spatial transference. There might never be an opportunity like this to return to the real world again. It's okay if you don't care about yourself, but are you not going to spare a thought for your friends?"

“Why do you want me to take my heart back?”

“Does this need any further explanation? Unless you’re willing, who else here can actually take your heart back from Nie Zun? Seems like you’re really underestimating that demonic prowess.”

I glanced at Nie Zun.

He spoke casually, “No matter who it is, you can forget about taking this heart, even if it’s her. I’m sure you’re aware of this, but you’ve been trying all ways and means to change the situation from earlier. I’m curious, just what is your goal? Who is it who’s backing you?”

Du Yue’s expression changed when Nie Zun said those last words.

Si Luo looked at me and asked, “Nie Zun took your heart?”

I nodded in response.

Though I moved, I didn’t feel that unbearable pain anymore. I guess I might have gotten used to it.

Getting used to things is pretty scary.

Nie Zun headed for the door as we entered a stalemate once again.

Du Yue stepped forward with a sharp gaze. “Leave her heart.”

Even Gaoqin Jiuye lifted a hand to stop Nie Zun.

Apart from them, no one else moved.

I stood where I was, looking at the back of Nie Zun’s figure.

Si Luo spoke. “Gaoqin, let him go. Her second personality can’t help me. Don’t be so hung up about it.”

Gaoqin Jiuye did not move nor speak. He didn’t intend to heed Si Luo’s instructions this time.

Si Luo then turned to Du Yue. "I'll suggest for you to hold your horses. How about we continue talking about Rong Jin?"

Right, what did they mean by saying that Rong Jin was Ta Lai? Were Rong Jin and Ta Lai actually one person...?

That enormous shadow of Rong Jin's and his weird cackling rang in my mind. I just couldn't reconcile that with Ta Lai's elegant style.

With his right hand, Nie Zun pushed Gaoqin Jiuye away slowly.

In a split second, Gaoqin Jiuye whipped Shen Qi out and wrapped it around Nie Zun's neck.

From the speed at which Shen Qi was released and the blood that could already be seen on Nie Zun's neck, I could tell that Gaoqin Jiuye was really furious. It was unlikely that he would let Nie Zun go.

I rushed forward, causing my entire chest to feel like it was engulfed in flames.

The blood dripped down my palm as I grabbed the bottom half of Shen Qi.

I looked at Gaoqin Jiuye. "Let him go."

Pain flashed past Gaoqin Jiuye. "Li Shen, I'm not doing this for you. Since your second personality can save Si Luo, I'm not going to let up on this, no matter who it is."

"I know. But Nie Zun is innocent. You can drag me into things, but don't do that to him. That second personality belongs to me. I won't allow you to hurt him like this."

I felt like I was about to be sucked into Gaoqin Jiuye's eyes as he spoke. "I think that last sentence was what you actually wanted to say. You've become irrational trying to protect him."

I shook my head. "No, I've never been more rational in my life. I've already given my heart to him, and he can take it if he wishes to."

Gaoqin Jiuye slapped me suddenly.

Smack.

Everyone seemed stunned at this.

My face turned to the side from the force. I didn't turn back.

I've been slapped quite a number of times here in the Split Zone.

Gaoqin Jiuye's voice trembled. "Li Shen, are you going to trample all over my feelings like this? Even when you now know that you were in love with me previously? Even when you've recalled part of those lost memories? There's no real need for you to say it so clearly like this. Aren't you just trying to get me to give up on you? You can really be heartless, Li Shen."

Instead of crying, I simply turned back to look at him blankly.

I spoke slowly. "You're right. I'm merely stepping all over your feelings for me. Who was it who entered my world and messed up my life? Who gave you the right to do that? Tell me, what right did you have to do that? I was living well in that world, whether or not I'd end up loving Gao Qi, whether or not he'd hurt me, that was still my life. Who gave you the right to intercept it and leave just like that? Let him kill me if he wants to. Why did you have to come save me... Why did you have to bring me here? Tell me, Gaoqin Jiuye, why?"

I caught a glimpse of Nie Zun from the corner of my eye. There was a flash of sorrow in his eyes.

Without a heart, my chest was throbbing with a dull pain.

Gaoqin Jiuye then loosened his grip on Shen Qi and let Nie Zun go. "Yes, Li Shen. That's my fault. I should've just let you die in that world, in his hands, instead of trying so hard to obtain the power to go to that world after having seen you just once in my dreams."

Gaoqin Jiuye's words made me stop in my tracks. I snapped my head up as I asked, "What do you mean?"

Gaoqin Jiuye looked at me as he placed Shen Qi back around his waist. “Li Shen, we’ll have nothing to do with each other from today onwards. Whether or not you manage to recall all those memories, I, Gaoqin Jiuye, will have nothing to do with you ever, from now on. Don’t even think about trampling on my feelings again.”

His words were cold and harsh, and they carried a hint of hatred.

He then turned to leave the laboratory.

The situation changed just like this.

Gaoqin Jiuye turned out to be the first one to leave, and the second individual would also leave soon after.

Nie Zun looked at me with an unfathomable gaze. “We shouldn’t see each other from now on either. I hope you’ll be able to leave the Split Zone soon. As for your heart, I’ll take it as a present from you for all this time that I’ve been by your side.”

I did not expect for Nie Zun to say something like this. I grabbed him as he turned to leave. “What did you say? Say it again, Nie Zun. You brought me to that flower field just moments ago, and now you’re telling me that we shouldn’t be seeing each other again? Am I an idiot to you or what? Tell me, what’s happening...”

Nie Zun freed himself from me and headed for the door without answering.

I wanted to chase after him, but Jie Pa was quicker. With a quick movement of his hands, a screen made of air dropped from nowhere. It looked like that restriction technique he used previously, except that it looked much sturdier now.

That air shield created a fence between us. He adjusted his glasses as he said, “Apologies, Miss Ah Shen. I believe Nie Zun has his reasons for doing so, and I have to help him in this case.” He left the laboratory right after.

That air shield seemed to have trapped the rest of us within the room.

I was almost hysterical as I screamed, “What’s happening? What do you guys want...!”

Si Luo said, “Calm down. It’s not all that bad now that the two of them have left. We can solve the remaining issues with Du Yue here.”

This meant that he was on my side.

Jiao S was right beside him, just like how Nie Zun would be by my side in the past. Even so, her eyes were on me, looking as if she did not want to interrupt although she was filled with nothing but worry for me.

Du Yue smirked. “This is interesting. It doesn’t look like I’m at any advantage even after some people have left. How about this, Li Shen? I’ll make you an offer. I’ll send these two back to your real world. How about that?”

Si Luo laughed. “Du Yue, no need to use petty tricks like these. Yu Liang and Song Lu have been working under you for quite a while now. You’re just worried that they’ll reveal certain things you don’t wish for us to know, now that the tables have turned against you. You can’t kill them in front of us, so you’re trying to get them to leave so that they’ll never be able to tell. Sadly, I’m awake now. Do you think this can escape me?”

Du Yue laughed loudly. “Oh, Si Luo. You really think things are still like they were in the past, where you can control everything with a simple wave of your hand? Do you still think that you are the one whom the Gate of Heaven’s Feng Zhu trusts the most? Those times when you could control everything are already over. You couldn’t even protect the Southern District, and now you’re here, trying to read me?”

I interrupted her. “Judging from this defensive reaction of yours, I’m guessing Si Luo hit the nail on the head.”

Chapter 257: 257 At a Loss

Volume 5

257 At a Loss

The wind ruffled my hair on the balcony. Looking at the buildings in the distance, I asked, “Are the both of you really leaving?”

Song Lu and Yu Liang looked at each other, not saying a thing. I turned around to face them. “Since Du Yue made such an offer, I don’t have any right to ask either of you to stay.”

Song Lu walked up, giving Piercer to me. “Ah Shen, I’ll be frank with you. I’d be lying if I said I didn’t harbor some sort of hatred towards you, but you should know that I’ve always treated you like a real sister. I’d never have thought that things would turn out this way, but if I don’t leave with him now, I don’t know how else I’m going to survive here.”

Yu Liang also stepped forward. “There are some things that I might not be able to tell you, ever. As for those particular secrets of the Split Zone that I happen to know, let me bring them with me. It might be better for you this way. Apart from saying thank you, I don’t know how else I can repay you for making the deal with Du Yue and agreeing to work with her against Huai Du in exchange for letting us leave.

“Ah Shen, to be honest, we are no longer our old selves. We might think that nothing has changed, but things have, and even if we thought things did change, that might not exactly be the case either. Well, anyway, take care of yourself.”

I smiled. “Yu Liang was a man of few words in the past. I didn’t know you could be so chatty now.”

After that day, I promised to work with Du Yue to go against Huai Du. Firstly, because she promised me that she'd send Song Lu and Yu Liang back. Secondly, Du Yue also promised to tell me the secret of the Split Zone.

This particular condition enticed me, and I agreed with Du Yue without heeding Si Luo's objections.

Si Luo did not say much, seeing how resolute I was. Instead, he said that he'd stay as well.

Judging from his past attitude, he would never have worked with Du Yue. He must have had his reasons for doing so if he had decided to stay.

Song Lu and Yu Liang did not say much after learning that they could leave the Split Zone.

They did not tell me about what happened during this time even though I expected them to, nor did they share any useful information with me.

They had chosen to retreat in this way.

Many things have happened, and I had no right to expect everyone to treat me like they did before.

In fact, I've realized that there was no real evil here in the Split Zone ever since what happened to You Ji, and there was no real good here either.

The world would come to an end if humans weren't selfish.

I remembered the loyalty that Song Lu and Yu Liang had towards me, and I could only imagine all the pain and torture they had to go through during this time. There are some things which could change an individual forever, and that included destroying their loyalty to someone.

I didn't do anything to let them down. Though I wasn't able to protect them and save them in time, that couldn't be considered as letting them down.

Even though it wasn't a mistake on my part, I still hated myself for it. The distance between us widened just like this.

They've chosen to leave so abruptly because I know that they've had enough of being embroiled in these things in the Split Zone. The last bit of love that they might still be protecting might end up getting destroyed if they even stay for an extra second here.

When they met again, the both of them did not look at each other, nor did they express any wishes to be back with each other again. But when they realized that they were able to leave together, the both of them stood by each other automatically, as if nothing had happened. They chose to stay together on this path towards the future instead of dwelling on what happened in the past.

This is true love, and it was also self-love.

Maybe I cared less now that Nie Zun and Gaoqin Jiuye were gone. I just knew that I was fine with letting the people around me leave because I had no right to make them stay.

“Okay, no need for further explanation. I understand everything. Du Yue will bring your corresponding soul splitters here soon. Go back to the real world and live well. I hope you'll be able to find each other soon when you arrive back in the real world, so that you'll be able to spend the rest of your days together.”

A strong wind blew past us and Song Lu's curly hair flew across her face, obscuring her features.

She took me in a gentle embrace, like that time when we were on the roof at the Western District's Residence.

“I'm sorry, Ah Shen.”

I closed my eyes and I wanted to say something, but I remained silent in the end.

I forced myself to smile and slowly detached myself from her hug. I held her hand as I said, "Go on. I'll send you."

I grabbed the both of them and jumped off the building.

After Du Yue removed the spatial restrictions, the real Gate of Heaven was revealed. It looked just like any other second-tier city. It had everything, except that there were fewer people around.

Du Yue brought with her two individuals who were tied up.

I was stunned as I got a better look at the two.

They were very familiar...

One of them was a pale teenage boy who had an indifferent look on him, while the other was a young female who was wearing a pair of sexy black stockings.

These were the two soul splitters we met in the Gate of Ghost.

The woman was bullying that boy, and I wanted to help out, but the boy decided to swallow his pride and let the arrogant woman have her way.

This world was full of coincidences.

Both of them were thrown onto the ground. The boy seemed to have an inkling of what was going on, but he looked indifferent as usual. The female, however, looked terrified.

The boy recognized me with just one look. "Hi, we meet again."

That did not sound like what a young teenage child would have said at all.

Song Lu asked in shock, "The two of you know each other?"

I nodded. "We've met once."

Du Yue smirked. "How coincidental."

I looked at her. “It is. The world is just full of coincidences. Is this just a mere coincidence though? Or did you plan everything?”

Du Yue raised a brow. “I don’t have such good foresight.”

“Oh, is that so? You’ve found Song Lu and Yu Liang’s soul splitters just so you can use this as a bargaining chip when making a deal with me. With that kind of foresight, you’re telling me you couldn’t have planned such a tiny occurrence?”

Du Yue glanced at the two individuals on the ground. “Why would I plan for these two to have a fight in front of you? That doesn’t sound like it benefits me at all, does it?”

I smiled. “A person who’s rotten to the bone might not do things that merely benefit her. She might have done it just to make somebody she hates unhappy, that’s all. Actually, you didn’t do anything. Part of it is definitely coincidence, because the both of them appeared at the same time. You just used a little MF to make that female hit the boy, and you knew that I would’ve stepped up to help.

“You did it to make me remember the two of them, because I won’t be happy when they might face death because of me someday in future. Even though I’ve only met them once, it can still be seen as me bringing death upon them.”

Du Yue nodded in appreciation. “You’re right. I couldn’t plan for the both of them to appear in the Gate of Ghost at the very same time. But I did make it so that they would have left an impression on you. You got it right too, because I thought you would save that boy, and that would have created some sort of relationship between the both of you from then on. I thought it’d be interesting to see you being anxious for him if Song Lu undid the split symbol contract with him and he wasn’t able to find a new heir.”

She looked at the boy as she paused for a short moment, disgust apparent in her eyes. “It’s just that I didn’t expect for him to be that strong. He didn’t need your help at all. What an annoying brat. It’s no wonder soul splitters with low MF are all merely trash.”

“I see that your view of hierarchy hasn’t changed at all. In your eyes, everyone who isn’t strong enough is equivalent to trash, even if they were your soul splitter comrades. Are you that noble yourself, Du Yue? In my eyes, I think you’re dirtier and lower than they are.” My words were laced with sarcasm.

Du Yue wasn’t angered. She lifted a leg and kicked the boy towards Song Lu. “Then let me see if it’s me, a lowly soul splitter, or if it’s this trash who’s going to face impending death today.”

Song Lu was being put in a rather difficult position as she looked at me.

I looked down at the boy and asked, “Do you fear death?”

The boy looked right back at me as he answered, “There’s nothing more I wish for than death after having been here for so long. Do you think I’ll fear it?”

Why did he have to answer like this?

This made me wish that he didn’t have to die.

I turned to Song Lu and Yu Liang. “Go on now. Don’t hesitate anymore.”

Song Lu was in a dilemma, but Yu Liang took his splitting key and inserted it into the split symbol on the woman.

Seeing Yu Liang do that, Song Lu inserted her splitting key with trembling hands into the boy’s split symbol.

Two rays of bright light appeared as Song Lu and Yu Liang’s bodies began turning transparent.

I thought they would have some last words, but Song Lu only looked back at me with sorrowful eyes before she was gone.

I guess I might have that same urgency to leave when it was my turn too.

Didn't I always have a chance to leave since my soul splitter was Gaoqin Jiuye?

I realized that this parting was real only when Song Lu and Yu Liang's figures had totally disappeared. It didn't happen without any warning. It was just that one would still be at a loss even after spotting the tell-tale signs.

Chapter 258: 258 Boy and Girl

Volume 5

258 Boy and Girl

The two soul splitters who had their split symbol contracts undone didn't look any different. However, according to Si Luo's predictions, their conditions would start deteriorating quickly without a new heir since they had low MF.

The ropes on them loosened with a quick movement of Du Yue's fingers.

The boy stood up and dusted himself.

When I wasn't paying attention, the boy turned quickly as he focused all his MF and used it to attack the woman's exposed split symbol.

The woman in the black stockings screamed with wide eyes, "What are you doing!"

But her screams were drowned by the sound of her body shattering into a million pieces.

The boy had used up all his strength and he was aging rapidly now. It was just like what happened to Huan Qing when we got him out of that glacier in the demon cave.

The boy was panting continuously.

I walked over to him slowly as I looked at that rapidly aging face. "You. You..."

Surprise turned into a smirk on Du Yue's face. "Focusing all your MF to attack someone on their split symbol when they're at their weakest to crumble their consciousness? What a barbaric method. But you're so weak that the effects backfired on you too huh?"

I shot a sharp look at Du Yue, but the boy grabbed my hand.

"I, I know you. You're a good person. I've had enough of being a soul splitter. Your, your world is great. You want to go back. You didn't let me down. All the insults from before, I've taken my revenge on my own. I'm going now. I'm not going to drag you with me. You have to leave this place. Everyone here is a demon." His body then started to break into pieces.

Du Yue smirked coldly and started to make her way away from here, as if such a scene would mar her eyes. Before leaving, she said, "Come to the Palace of Cold Blood to look for me after this is done."

Seeing Du Yue leave, the boy left a key in my hands. "Keep this... you..." He shattered into a million pieces of light before he could finish.

I looked down at the key in my hand. It was golden and it looked tinier than a splitting key. I didn't know what it did, but I tucked it safely with me.

I had gotten a new dress, and Piercer was back in my hands, but there were less people around me. *No, I should be saying that there was no one left beside me now.*

Jiao S was with Si Luo all the time.

I saw Si Luo as I was making my way back to the Palace of Cold Blood. Jiao S was not by his side.

"You have something to say to me in private?" I looked around for a place to sit, but there didn't seem to be any benches in sight. We might just have to stand like this.

I've been getting lazy these days. I didn't want to stand, nor did I want to do anything else.

I seemed to have returned to those days when Li Qing went missing and I just took on the role of the Western District Commander. During that time, all I did was stay indoors or practice the bow and nothing else.

“It’s nothing actually. I just wanted to tell you more about Gaoqin.”

Mentioning Gaoqin Jiuye, I was reminded of that slap he gave me.

I looked away in slight frustration. “What is it?”

Si Luo grabbed my hand and placed it against his chest.

This took me by surprise. I looked up at those beautiful silvery eyes of his and couldn’t help but feel a little embarrassed.

It seemed unreal when a beautiful person locked eyes with you like this. Since the beginning of time, humans had always been weak against beautiful things.

“What are you doing?”

“Shh...” His lips moved.

I then realized that a scene had begun playing in front of me, as if I was watching some sort of video.

It was a waterfall.

A bright-eyed youth and a young girl with emotionless eyes were trying to control the water at the waterfall.

Both of them were trying to change the speed of the water with MF, but it was too difficult for either of them.

The water splashed onto them, wetting their faces, their hair and their clothes.

The both of them were panting after a while. The boy stared at the girl angrily before he grabbed the air with a fist.

He held a circular ball of water in his hand and threw it towards the girl.

The girl's soulless eyes turned bright suddenly. Making a cross with her hands, two pillars of water shot towards the boy.

Seeing this, the boy clapped his hands and a pillar of water emerged from the waterfall.

"I'm asking the both of you to work together to change the direction of the flow of water. I didn't ask you to fight each other," Si Luo said as he appeared behind them.

The silvery-white in his eyes seemed to move, and those pillars of water lost its forms as it splashed everywhere.

All three of them were splashed with the water and their faces shone brightly under the sun.

The boy said angrily, "She isn't even from the Split Zone. She's only here when she's dreaming. Why are you being so nice to her?"

The girl spoke coldly, "Are you his only disciple? We're supposed to learn how to control air currents together. Why are you always treating me like this?"

Si Luo cut them off. "That's enough now. Aren't you guys hungry?" Their eyes shone at this and the two of them stopped bickering.

A sweet smile appeared on Si Luo's beautiful face. "Go over there, I have something good for you. But you'll have to continue practicing after eating. The both of you haven't gotten it right because you didn't manipulate the MF accurately enough while trying to control the water. After you're done with your meal, I'll..."

They were gone before Si Luo could finish.

Turning around, he saw the boy and girl rush over to a huge boulder where their meal was waiting.

A mesmerizing smile then appeared on his sunlit face.

I retracted my hand quickly. I asked in shock, “This is...”

Si Luo smiled and nodded at me. “Yes, you already know the answer. What you’ve just seen is the Jiao S and Gaoqin Jiuye of the past.”

I was stunned.

I stood rooted to the ground, speechless.

Lifting my hand slowly, I put it against Si Luo’s chest again as if possessed by some sort of other-worldly power.

A scene started playing in front of me.

It wasn’t a continuation of the previous one. This time, it was night. Si Luo and Gaoqin Jiuye were both lying on the grass under a starry sky.

Si Luo’s white robes seemed to glow faintly in the night, while Gaoqin Jiuye was dressed in black from head to toe, using his hands as a pillow.

Both of them looked relaxed as they stared at the stars in the sky.

The picture was indescribable...

Gaoqin Jiuye spoke softly. “Si. I like a girl.”

Si Luo raised a gentle brow. “Oh, who is it?”

Gaoqin Jiuye’s gaze turned gentle as he answered, “A girl in my dreams.”

Si Luo laughed. “From that world...? Gaoqin, it’s fated that girls from that world can never be with you.”

Gaoqin Jiuye’s brows furrowed slightly at Si Luo’s direct answer, but he did not look upset or angry at this. He simply looked a little sad as he said, “This is why I think that it’s also good for me to be here looking at her and protecting her like this...”

I haven't seen that look on him before.

My hand that was against Si Luo's chest began to tremble.

Si Luo seemed to smile under the moonlight as he yawned lazily. "Look at that star in the sky. Everything here is created to imitate that world, including that star. Usually, this star here and the star in that world would never ever meet. But what if this happens? Look." Si Luo lifted a finger and drew a line in the air.

A ray of MF shot from his finger towards the night sky. The trajectory of that star was changed just like this, and it hit another star.

Gaoqin Jiuye's eyes widened.

"Do you understand?" A trace of a smile hung on Si Luo's lips.

The scene changed again. Si Luo was sitting alone in the forest playing a zither, looking like a handsome music teacher from the ancient times. His slender hands created an enchanting tune.

Gaoqin Jiuye spoiled the beautiful scene as he ran into it, anxiety and worry on his face.

"Si, she's in danger. I want to go to that world to save her." Gaoqin Jiuye sounded anxious, and his eyes were full of worry.

However, Si Luo was playing his zither like nothing happened.

"Si!" Gaoqin Jiuye shouted urgently.

Si Luo lifted his head finally, his eyes filled with love. "Okay, I can tell you a way. But you're not that good at controlling MF yet. To get that power, you'll have to conquer a weapon that matches that power. Are you willing to do that?"

Gaoqin Jiuye did not seem to be listening to this at all as he answered, "I'm willing, I'm willing."

Si Luo plucked a string on his zither. “I’m going to take you to conquer the strongest living weapon in the Split Zone. If you aren’t resolute enough and you can’t endure pain, you won’t be able to do it.”

Gaoqin Jiuye asked, “Will I obtain great power after I conquer this living weapon? Is it just like your Feng Lie?”

Si Luo smiled as he looked up. “Yes. This living weapon is called Shen Qi. The prayer of God. It’s stronger than Feng Lie. Are you going to do it?”

Chapter 259: 259 Swallowing Pride

Volume 5

259 Swallowing Pride

A young male lay on the ground. He did not look like himself with all those injuries on his body.

His dry lips moved as he spoke in a trembling voice, “Si. I can still... continue... I want to save her...”

As if electrocuted, I retracted my hand from Si Luo’s chest. I looked at Si Luo as I tried to swallow non-existent spit. “This is all. It’s real...”

Si Luo said, “Yes, you’ve seen it. These are my memories.”

“That girl he was talking about. It’s me?”

“Yes.”

So it’s real. We met such a long, long time ago.

I really did love you. You really did love me too.

“Do you still remember the three things you promised?” Si Luo looked at me with those silvery eyes which looked like they were filled with white fog.

I nodded slowly. “I remember. You want me to listen to Gaoqin’s wishes, that I should kill him if he wants me to. You want me to take Jiao S away, and you want me to kill you.

“But there’s something I still don’t understand.” I turned serious.

“What is it?”

“We’re all straightforward people, and we all know this in our hearts. Right now, just like how you guys have proven to me time and again, Gaoqin Jiuye has feelings for me, and you care a lot about Gaoqin Jiuye as well. But this is where the dilemma lies. If Gaoqin Jiuye is more important to you than Jiao S is, instead of getting me to stay here so that I can be by his side forever, why do you want me to kill him?”

Si Luo’s eyes wavered. “You’re right. I pamper him. This is why I don’t want him to end up like me. I don’t want you to kill him. What I’m saying is that if he chooses to be killed by you, you should heed his wishes. I don’t want him to live like me, it’s tiring. I hope that he’ll be able to let it go once he thinks it through someday. And that you’ll also be able to let him put things behind him if that happens.”

Si Luo looked at me with ripples in his eyes. “Li Shen, Gaoqin’s life is fated to be a tragedy. Even if I don’t buy into fate, I’m not able to change the course of what’s going to happen in his life. All I can do for him is to make it easier for him in the very last moment.”

I didn’t really get this, but I answered, “You mean, you think that I’d never be together with him? That his life is fated to be a tragedy and that you can’t do anything about that, right?”

Si Luo smiled gently, but his eyes were still like deep water. “Will you be together with him?”

I did not know what to say to this.

“You’re no ordinary individual. You don’t know how resolute you actually are. You met Nie Zun in the time that you’ve forgotten Gaoqin, and everyone can see how much you love Nie Zun. You might be the only one who’s trying to hide it from yourself. Even if you remember Gaoqin, you won’t let Nie Zun down. Although the guilt you might feel towards Gaoqin

might lead you onto varied paths, you'll realize eventually that it's easy for a change of heart, but it's not easy to take your feelings back."

For some reason, that lonely figure of Nie Zun when he left and that loneliness in his eyes flashed past my mind.

I said with indifference, "Not easy to take my feelings back? But it's a fact that I've been in love with Gaoqin Jiuye once. Since I've remembered what I had previously forgotten, how do you know that I won't get tired of Nie Zun in this case?"

Si Luo smiled. "You're the only one who knows this. We won't be able to tell what you're thinking no matter how clearly we're able to look at things.

"Let's go. Jiao S is still waiting for us."

I stopped Si Luo just as he began to leave. "Why would Jiao S appear in your memories? Judging from her age at the time, Jiao S hadn't arrived in the Split Zone yet."

Si Luo's gaze darkened. "She was my dream..."

But he seemed to suddenly jerk awake from a daydream. He made his way towards the Palace of Cold Blood speedily, as if he was being chased by others.

I guess he's not going to tell me what happened between Jiao S and him so easily.

"Where do you think Gaoqin Jiuye and the others would have gone?"

Si Luo shook his head. "I'm no god. I wouldn't know that. Why? You want to get the both of them here and show me how you'd make your choice?"

What is he even saying...

Love isn't the only thing I think about all day, mind you.

A trace of a smile seemed to hang on Si Luo's lips. "I don't know about the rest, but if it's Gaoqin, there's one person who'd definitely be able to find him."

I raised a brow. "I don't think that's you, is it? But apart from you, who else would be aware of his actions?"

A face appeared in my head right after I said this.

Si Luo smiled. "I'm sure you would've guessed by now."

I nodded in surprise. "Yes, I've guessed it. The one you're talking about, it should be Guan Nie... But I've never seen him again ever since he regained consciousness after getting hurt that time. I don't even know if he's fully recovered, much less where he is now."

"It's not important where he is. He'd definitely be protecting Gaoqin in the shadows."

I sighed. "What difference does it make if Gaoqin Jiuye doesn't wish for me to see him again? And even if Guan Nie can find Gaoqin Jiuye, I'm not able to find Guan Nie anyway.

"Oh, right." I turned serious as I suddenly thought of something else. If I don't ask now, I might forget it again.

"What Du Yue said before, what does it mean that Ta Lai and Rong Jin are the same person?"

Si Luo gave a bitter smile. "Rong Jin's shadow is merely a tactic he uses to hide from others. He is actually Ta Lai. It's just that I wasn't aware of this before."

Seems as if Ta Lai had duped his way into Si Luo's circle. Why did he do that though?

He didn't have anything against Si Luo, so it was unlikely that he was trying to take revenge. Even though he wasn't friends with Si Luo, they weren't enemies either. They were both soul splitters from the Gate of

Heaven, equivalent somewhat to colleagues in the modern world. Though they might do things which end up hurting each other, who would actually conduct espionage just to listen in on random things?

“It’s possible that he did it just because he was wary of me.”

For the first time, a look of slight frustration appeared on Si Luo.

There seemed to be no plausible explanation for this.

I didn’t like the feeling of this, so I quickened my pace. “If Rong Jin is gone now, I guess Mr Ta Lai doesn’t want to play anymore. Go on, what should I do next?”

Si Luo caught up with me. “If Du Yue wants you to work with her, you can observe her for the time being and see what she’s planning. I’ll help you analyze things as well.”

“Why didn’t you leave with Gaoqin Jiuye?”

Si Luo laughed. “I thought you wouldn’t be asking a lame question like this. What use would it be if I had left with him? Can he leave the Split Zone for real? If he can’t, he’ll still end up by my side eventually.”

I frowned. “But you sound like you’re contradicting yourself. If he’ll return to you eventually, why are you still trying to get me to replace him?”

“I’m not trying to get you to replace him. I want you to help find out what Du Yue’s real goal is. Now that I think about it, it might have already been fated long ago that this would be some sort of conspiracy. Gaoqin might just be a sacrificial lamb in this conspiracy. Though I’ve said that his life might be fated to be a tragedy, if I’m able to turn the tables to change that, then there’s no way I would let his life turn into a tragedy.”

“What should I do?”

“Don’t do anything for now. We’ll see what Du Yue has up her sleeve. We’ll pretend to follow her for now and see what she’s planning.”

“She’s suspicious of everything. Would she believe that the both of us are agreeable to working with her?” I asked with furrowed brows.

“That’s right. Since we’re not able to prove our loyalty, we shouldn’t be doing anything right now. Let her stew in her suspicion, keep her guessing.”

“Do you plan on staying with her here in the Gate of Heaven? Are you serious about that? She’s so powerful here. If she finds us annoying one day, we might have nobody else to depend on when that happens.”

“Yes. This is why to go against Du Yue, we’ll need to have her jump into a huge trap on her own instead of inviting her aboard.”

“How about Jiao S? Is she aware of this? Have you told her about all this?”

“She’s intelligent and she’ll understand even if I don’t tell her some things. Even if she doesn’t, she’ll definitely find a way to understand it. What we should do now is to stay in our places at the Palace of Cold Blood and see what Du Yue has up her sleeve.”

“Let’s go then.” I pointed at the Palace of Cold Blood which was right in front of us.

The Palace of Cold Blood was totally different when we stepped into it again.

It was a big hall previously, but I could see an entire palace this time. The huge palace was made up of many great halls, as if it was an entire city on its own. They were like Russian dolls, palaces within palaces. It looked elegant and luxurious.

Stepping back into the hall that I was in before, I saw Du Yue lazing on the golden throne with that ice phoenix resting on her shoulder.

My eyes might have been fooling me, but I felt fear and helplessness in the eyes of that ice phoenix when I looked at it.

I wanted to ask about the ice phoenix, but I decided not to in the end.

Since the ice phoenix had regained its freedom, Du Yue might have reinstated its position. I would only be harming the ice phoenix if I wasn't able to beat Du Yue at this point.

Please swallow your pride for now, just like how I am doing. I'll take you away from here no matter what.

My eyes had been glued to that ice phoenix since I stepped into the great hall. Though it could not hear my thoughts, I looked at it with a resolute gaze, intent on telling it that it had to wait for me, that I'll take it away from here someday.

Chapter 260: 260 The One Without a Soul Splitter

Volume 5

260 The One Without a Soul Splitter

There were many other individuals in the hall apart from Du Yue, who was lazing on that throne behind the silk gauze curtain.

Two rows of people were standing beside the huge pillars on either side of the great hall. All of them looked the same.

It was the pair of sisters.

One row had people who looked exactly like the older sister, while the other row had people who looked exactly like the younger sister.

None of them had any masks on, and their faces looked exactly like the two women who were killed by Gaoqin Jiuye in that underground room at that time. All of them were looking at me without a hint of friendliness.

I knew why they weren't friendly. It was because Song Lu had left. Song Lu didn't have to take any responsibility for this, but it was their mistake not to have realized I was here.

They seem to be some sort of experimental subject, since they all looked like that pair of sisters. The only difference was that the sisters were in brown robes while the rest of them were dressed in black.

This might be a representation of their higher positions among the rest, or the rest of them might just be clones of the sisters.

Clones like these seemed to only be possible in sci-fi movies. Looking at all of them made my hairs stand. It was eerie that time and space could go haywire in the Split Zone and there were weird experiments going on here that could create clones of humans.

Jiao S was in the hall too, standing on a high platform somewhere at the end of it.

Du Yue's eyes narrowed as she saw Si Luo and I approach. The ice phoenix flew out of the silk gauze curtain to perch on a lamp at the end of the hall as Du Yue got up from the throne. It was looking at me with trembling eyes, as if it was calling out for help.

I could not do anything but console Bing'er in my heart. It wasn't the right time to say anything. I might just end up hurting it if I tried to say something right now.

"Seems like you've come to an agreement." Du Yue sounded suspicious. She probably found our actions dubious since we came back to work with her like this. *But of course she'd be suspicious. She had to be suspicious.*

I said, "That's right, we've decided. I don't think there's a need for me to gain your trust by saying anything now. You'd still be suspicious of whatever you're supposed to be suspicious of. Since you've decided to work with us, I'm sure that you'd also be prepared for the risk and possibility that we might betray you. There's no need for us to keep guessing. Let's just go straight to the point, shall we?"

Du Yue laughed. "I've finally found some merit in you."

You've finally found it? You'll find more of it in future, and you'll realize that you can't do anything to me because of these merits of mine.

"Since you're so frank, I'll let you in on some of the secrets that you didn't know. You can treat this as a welcome present." Du Yue then walked down the platform towards Si Luo and I.

I raised a hand to stop her in her tracks. "We'll go over."

I turned to Si Luo. He nodded in response.

We then walked towards her with large strides. Du Yue backed up onto the platform as Si Luo and I walked up. It was about seven or eight steps to the top, and it wasn't very tall.

I met Jiao S's eyes as I reached her. I didn't smile or nod, but I knew for sure that she'd know what I was thinking.

Du Yue glanced at the three of us, as if sensing the telepathy between us.

She spoke slowly. "I'm working with you guys because I want to go against Huai Du. That's not the goal though. The goal is Huai Du."

I shot her a frigid look. "Stop beating around the bush. Be direct about it. There's no need to waste everyone's time."

Du Yue was not happy with this attitude of mine, probably because I did not accord her with much respect.

Why should I be treating you with respect?

Du Yue did not say anything this time. She merely stared at me as she continued, "Huai Du's goal is to cultivate demons. On this, since you've entered the demon cave before and you've also seen Nie Zun, I'm sure you've seen it for yourselves too.

"That demon cave is a place Huai Du had prepared for years through pouring MF into it to create a specialized cave for demon cultivation. The layout of the cave is extremely peculiar, and it makes use of spatial transference techniques to connect many spaces to one another. All these spaces come together to form some sort of a maze in the demon cave."

Demon cultivating cave? I knew that cave was no ordinary demon cave. So this was why the inside was always so peculiar and the spaces could change at a moment's notice. Because of that spatial transference, spaces could overlap and connect with one another.

But what benefits can spatial transference do for demon cultivation? Was it simply to make people lose their way in the cave? I had a feeling that a weirdo like Huai Du would not do something like this just for the mere fun of it.

“The demon cultivating cave is exactly like its name – its main purpose is to cultivate demons. In all these years that he had created the demon cave, I haven’t seen him really successfully cultivate a demon. This is why I suspect that he hasn’t been able to find the suitable materials for it. You need a sword if you want to practice using one, and you’ll need a demon for demon cultivation. That demon that he had finally set his eyes on was none other than Nie Zun.”

I had always known that Nie Zun had some demonic prowess, and even when everyone else said he was a demon, even when he said he was a demon himself, to me, that demonic side of him was different from what the others were referring to.

“Why did he pick Nie Zun? Even though his MF is high, he’s still a mere heir. There’re so many soul splitters in the three gates with extraordinary abilities. Why did he have to pick Nie Zun?” I asked.

Du Yue smirked. “This is the root of the problem. I’ve finally found the reason why Li Qing seemed to favor you two newcomers when the both of you first arrived here in the Split Zone. You aren’t the only unique one here. Nie Zun has a rare constitution too. It was a coincidence that the both of you arrived in the Split Zone at the same time and both your consciousness restricted each other in some way. I can only describe this as nothing short of a miracle, just that this miracle was a dangerous bomb.

“Your uniqueness lies in your second personality, and I haven’t really gotten to the bottom of this either. Of course, one of my main goals is to find out what’s the deal with your second personality. Though I’m working with you now, you should know that I won’t show mercy towards you in future.”

I returned her smirk. “No need for this pretense. It’s not as if you show mercy to anyone else.”

Du Yue stared at me. “I’m guessing that you aren’t aware of Nie Zun’s uniqueness, are you?”

I raised a brow. “If you’re talking about his hands, his left hand especially, then I’m sorry to say that I knew that already.”

It’s just a pair of hands. Just because his hands were powerful, did it have to be looked at like some sort of research material here even after they were treated like poison when he was alive?

Du Yue stopped my thoughts from running wild immediately.

“No, I’m not talking about his hands. I’m referring to him as a person. Do you know that Nie Zun doesn’t have a soul splitter?”

I was stunned. *What did she just say?*

I shook my head subconsciously. “What did you say?”

Du Yue looked smug as she regarded me. “According to my investigations, Nie Zun doesn’t have a soul splitter. This means that he wasn’t captured here by a soul splitter. But without soul splitters as middlemen, people from your world aren’t able to come over to this world. These spaces are separate to begin with, and there shouldn’t be any paths that can bring you to and fro. This is why we borrow your power and establish split symbol contracts after capturing you.

“But Nie Zun is different. We have to pay a huge price to even bring you over, and for you to come over here on your own is basically something that’s impossible. Before Nie Zun, there was only one such case of a body of consciousness coming over on its own without being captured.

“That body of consciousness had a unique constitution, just like how Gaoqin Jiuye is. She came over here because she could see whatever was happening in the Split Zone through her dreams. But only a part of her consciousness came over.

“Just like how Gaoqin Jiuye looked for you, she came over to this world through her dreams to look for a certain person.” Though Du Yue didn’t explicitly reveal who this individual was, I already knew who she was referring to.

I looked towards Jiao S.

Jiao S was looking at me as well. She gave me an apologetic gaze as our eyes met.

She must be beating herself up for not telling me this sooner, and that somebody else had to reveal this to me instead. She thought I’d blame her for this.

There was definitely some part of me that blamed her, but I understood her reasons for doing so.

This was her secret. Everyone had secrets, and it had nothing to do with whether you were close to each other or not, or whether you trusted each other. One had to keep a secret if you had one.

Du Yue’s gaze alternated between Jiao S and I. “Seeing the two of you, I guess there’s no need for me to explain any further. That’s right. That individual is none other than Jiao S. Jiao S was able to dream of the Split Zone when she was younger. Because her mental abilities were so strong, she was able to forcefully pull her consciousness over to the Split Zone many times during her dreams. She then met Si Luo and Gaoqin Jiuye, and Si Luo treated her just like a little sister here.

“Just like what I said earlier, this is already a miracle. Just like how Gaoqin Jiuye could pass through the two worlds through dreams, this was a feat that was almost impossible to achieve. One would need great mental ability to do so, and one had to have the ability to construct a dream that could be used as a pathway between the two worlds.

“Not many individuals can do something like this, much less an heir. Apart from Jiao S, there aren’t any other heirs who can do this.”

Chapter 261: 261 One Scheme After Another

Volume 5

261 One Scheme After Another

“So, Gaoqin Jiuye and Jiao S were miracles to begin with, and Nie Zun was a miracle within the miracle. Instead of a miracle, it should be called illogical. Logically speaking, there isn’t any possibility that he could have arrived here with a complete consciousness when he does not have a soul splitter and when it wasn’t his dreams which took him here.”

Du Yue looked serious. It did not look like she was lying about this.

Her words were swimming in my mind. *If what Du Yue said was true, Nie Zun did not have a soul splitter. Then how did he end up here...?*

Si Luo had been standing by the side, not making a sound.

Du Yue did not seem to mind Si Luo’s presence either.

“According to what you’ve said, there’s no plausible reason for Nie Zun to have arrived here?”

Du Yue smirked. “No, it’s the exact opposite. Because it’s impossible under normal circumstances, his uniqueness was caused by his arrival under abnormal circumstances.”

I frowned. “Can you just say everything at once?”

“Audacious. How dare you talk to owner like this!” The older sister in the brown robe called out loudly.

I glanced at her quickly before ignoring her.

Du Yue raised a hand, signaling for the woman not to interrupt. The woman stared at me, but retreated quickly.

All of the standing females looked extremely upset, but I couldn’t be bothered to look at any of them.

“Li Shen, don’t be too presumptuous. I didn’t reveal everything at once because I considered the fact that you might not be able to take everything in.” Du Yue was taller than me, and she liked to stick her chin out when talking to me, as if she was talking to somebody lowly.

“Haha, stop joking now. When have you ever thought about my feelings? Be quick about it and stop wasting everybody’s time.”

A smug look appeared on Du Yue’s face. That look appeared way too suddenly.

Her lips turned up at an angle as she continued, “No one captured Nie Zun, so this means that his consciousness wasn’t brought here. And if he isn’t dreaming, it means that he didn’t come here voluntarily. Eliminating all other possibilities, there’s only one possibility left, which in fact seemed rather impossible. That is, you brought him here.”

What does that mean?

Seeing me confused, Du Yue continued her explanation. “This means that although Nie Zun didn’t come here on his own volition, he wasn’t against it either. The situation then might have caused him to lose all hope and abandon all rational thinking, and during that time – I’m not aware of what kind of relationship you had with him then – but you brought Nie Zun together with you when you were captured by Gaoqin Jiuye.”

She made it sound so simple. *I brought him over just like this?*

I couldn't accept such an explanation. "You're saying that Nie Zun's consciousness was weakened to the point that I could take him here?"

"Nie Zun's mental prowess is very strong, and he wouldn't be such a unique existence if it wasn't. Because of that strength, it made sense if he had voluntarily arrived here with you. It's because of that strength that he was able to follow you through the spaces and arrive here. As for you, it's a coincidence that you have double identity disorder, and that potential power you have within you is also a factor that allowed for Nie Zun to arrive here in the Split Zone."

I had a thousand and one questions in my head, but I felt that asking Du Yue about them wasn't a good choice.

I glanced at Si Luo. He looked like he had been listening to everything intently, but he hadn't said a single word. Jiao S was opposite us, her eyes going back and forth between me and Si Luo. She wasn't saying anything either.

It was difficult to describe how I felt exactly. I wanted to cry, but there was no use in doing so.

Du Yue seemed to be surprised at how calm I was as she regarded me with suspicion.

Actually, this was just me not knowing how to react.

In the beginning, I hated Nie Zun. I was terrified of that restriction where we couldn't be more than 500 meters apart. Now that I think about it, it wasn't Nie Zun's fault at all. I shunned him all because of that strange restriction which induced a foreign fear in me.

I even got mad at him when he told me he saw me at the hospital. I blamed him for not stopping me.

It's your own life, who would be able to stop you if you decide to go and kill somebody?

No matter how I thought about it, the only thing I could be sure about was that I really owed Nie Zun in the past.

I buried this guilt deep within me, afraid that it would muddy the feelings I had for him someday in future.

This is why I'd rather not feel guilty about it at all. I believed that I loved him, that there was no right or wrong and that nothing else mattered. But what should I do if everything changed, if everything turned topsy-turvy?

Du Yue was telling me that Nie Zun did not have a soul splitter, that he came here because he was affected by me, that he hadn't been captured by anyone.

Though Du Yue did not say it very directly, I understood everything.

She felt that an impossible miracle had happened because of the uniqueness of my second personality. My second personality was extremely strong. She appeared in the hospital when I happened to meet Nie Zun, who also had strong mental prowess. She then brought him into the Split Zone.

This meant that I was the one who had dragged Nie Zun into this.

But there was another question in my mind. *Why did Nie Zun have a splitting key and a split symbol when he didn't have a soul splitter?*

The split symbol contract cannot be established without a soul splitter, and if the split symbol isn't formed in a pair, how was Nie Zun able to borrow the power of the split symbol?

How did Nie Zun obtain his split symbol?

Mr Blond was the one who would be able to answer that question. But...he was missing.

"What are you thinking about?" Du Yue interrupted my thoughts.

"Nothing. You can continue. I'm sure it's not only Nie Zun's story you wanted to talk about."

Du Yue smirked. “That’s right. What I was trying to get at is that Nie Zun’s unique existence is caused by various factors, and such an existence is exactly what Ghost King Huai Du is looking for. He set many traps to reel Nie Zun in and to make Nie Zun loyal to him.”

My brows furrowed.

Du Yue thinks that Huai Du’s goal is to control Nie Zun, since Nie Zun was a unique existence. But I didn’t think that his goal was this simple.

According to Li Qing, Nie Zun’s blood had been changed. Huai Du had an ability called soul transference, and he used it on Nie Zun, enabling him to be able to gain control over Nie Zun for a period of time every day.

If Huai Du’s goal was just to control Nie Zun, he would have already succeeded. However, that did not seem like cultivating a demon. It was merely a change of blood.

What Du Yue said was incoherent with what I actually saw.

Du Yue was extremely careful and such a loophole did not look like something she would have missed. This meant that Du Yue did not know that Huai Du had the ability of soul transference, and she wasn’t aware that it was only Nie Zun’s blood that was changed, and that he had not actually been cultivated as a demon.

I tried to probe further. “But why would he want to control Nie Zun? According to what you’ve said, Huai Du’s goal is to control Nie Zun because he is a unique entity. Why would he want to do such a thing though?”

Du Yue said, “This is why I want to work with you guys on this. You know Nie Zun best, and I want to know why Huai Du did this. Si Luo, you’re the only one in the Split Zone who had gone against Huai Du before, so you should understand him better than all of us here. Huai Du had been the king in the Gate of Ghost for a long time, and no one had been able to do anything about that.

“I hope you can help me beat him. Of course, you’ll definitely be rewarded for it. Li Shen, if I can send Song Lu and Yu Liang back, I can do the same for you too. I’ll let you leave as long as you’re willing to work with me to achieve my goal.”

I raised a brow. “Let me leave? You already know that Gaoqin Jiuye is my soul splitter, so how would you let me leave? You’re willing to let Gaoqin Jiuye take such a risk?”

Du Yue smirked. “This isn’t a problem for you to solve.”

She still got upset whenever Gaoqin Jiuye is mentioned. Women. If they can’t have something for themselves, they won’t let others have it either.

Si Luo spoke suddenly. “You’re telling us that by working together, all you want Li Shen and I to do is to tell you whatever we know?”

A trace of a smile hung on Du Yue’s lips as she turned to Si Luo. “What do you think? What else do you think I’ll get you guys to do apart from this? How about you tell us, Si Luo? It’s been so many years since you’ve left the Gate of Heaven. To be honest, I’ve missed you quite a bit in this time, since we were both under Feng Zhu in the past. I could never understand you, but I don’t think there’s a real need for us to become enemies, is there?”

When they were talking, I suddenly thought of Du Yue’s experiments. I had always thought that her goal was to get rid of Bian Ying, that it was all because of Ta Lai. But looking at it now, that did not seem like the case at all. I had definitely underestimated Du Yue.

But what was her goal then, if it wasn’t for Ta Lai?

Now, she wants us to help her out in defeating Huai Du. Was Huai Du her goal since the beginning?

That couldn’t be though. If it was, she wouldn’t have had to spend so much time and effort on those experiments.

Or did this mean that... Huai Du was not her only goal? Did she want to destroy the Gate of Ghost?

This sounded plausible. But what if the truth wasn't any of those scenarios, and it was a third possibility that I couldn't have possibly imagined? What should I do then?

Chapter 262: 262 Working Together?

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262 Working Together?

Si Luo's flowy white robes seemed to break around him like the waves of the ocean as he stretched lazily.

"I'd never have thought that Du Yue would say that she missed me. If Feng Zhu gave you the entire Palace of Cold Blood, you should be the top subordinate under him right now. Would you still miss me? Aren't you afraid that you'll lose everything if I returned to the Gate of Heaven?"

Though Si Luo's tone was casual, he did not bother masking the intent behind his words.

Du Yue raised a brow. "I shan't continue if you insist on being like this. Si Luo, you should know that the incident in the past didn't have anything to do with me..."

Si Luo interrupted her, "Let's not talk about that. It's already been so long."

A cunning glint appeared in Du Yue's eye. "Since we're talking about this now, Feng Zhu has actually wanted to meet you for the longest time. How about I bring you to him?"

A trace of a smile appeared on Si Luo's lips. "If you're trying to get some sort of information out of me, this was an extremely poor attempt at it. You already did so much, including all those experiments. Do you think I was

really in the dark about all that you've done in the Southern District? I'd just like to see what else you have up your sleeve."

Du Yue looked visibly surprised. "You know about the experimental grounds in the Southern District? Why did you not stop it then? Judging from that character of yours, you've always treated your residents like precious treasures. Would you really have let me do absurd things if you had known?"

Si Luo smirked. "So you actually know that you were being absurd? You're wrong about something though. My character? What kind of character? Du Yue, do you really think you know me well?"

There was this noble, quiet confidence about Si Luo as he posed the question. He had that exact aura and attitude when I met him for the very first time.

I had always felt that Si Luo was no ordinary individual, nor was he the kind of soul splitter Du Yue was. He was a mysterious man, one of the most mysterious in the Split Zone. I couldn't tell what he was thinking nor could I gauge his mood. I didn't really know which side he was standing on either. I believe he had to take some sort of responsibility for whatever the unfettered Gaoqin Jiuye did. Though he looked gentle most of the time, Si Luo was no easy opponent for sure.

It was only up to this point that I realized I wasn't finding out about an unknown side of this mysterious man. The fact was, I did not even see through him at all in the first place.

Du Yue seemed to realize this as well as she said, "I guess I don't know you anymore. It's been a really long time." I guess she put the blame on time in order to reduce the awkwardness.

Si Luo looked down as if showing obedience, but there was no meekness when he spoke. "This is why I suggest for you to come clean about everything, since it might do more good for you now. How're you going to win this gamble if you're not even willing to show your trump card?"

Du Yue narrowed her eyes before sighing. “Fine. Yes, my goal is to conquer the Gate of Ghost. You know it too, that those in the Gate of Ghost don’t have extraordinary abilities. Just like that Southern District of yours, the Gate of Ghost relies solely on Huai Du. As long as I beat Huai Du, it’s nothing but a matter of time before the Gate of Ghost is mine.”

So it’s a territorial dispute that caused all the fighting.

Si Luo responded, “You should know that Huai Du is a greatly-feared existence in the Split Zone. It might not be possible to beat him even if all the high-ability soul splitters came together and went against him. Why are you so confident in being able to beat him? You shouldn’t be trying to break a rock with a mere egg.”

Du Yue laughed as if she had already won. “I don’t know the extent of Huai Du’s ability, but everyone would have a weakness no matter how powerful they were. It’s the same for Huai Du. It’s just that I’m not sure what it is at this point.

“If he’s interested in Nie Zun, this means that Nie Zun is the only one who’s able to reach him. You know how weird Huai Du is. It’s difficult for anyone to meet him usually, but he actually used the demon cave to try and conquer Nie Zun time and again. This shows how valuable Nie Zun is to Huai Du.”

Unsure of Huai Du’s weaknes...

I guess Du Yue doesn’t know about Li Qing.

Or did this actually mean that no one else but Li Wen knows about what happened between Huai Du and Li Qing?

But if that was the case, why did Li Wen tell me about it?

Huai Du wanted Scorpion Ray, and Li Qing appeared in the Gate of Ghost too. She even revealed Huai Du’s ability of soul transference to me. Du Yue seemed to be in the dark about all of this.

“So?” Si Luo asked.

“So, as long as Li Shen works with me, controlling Nie Zun will be a piece of cake. If you work with me, coupled with your knowledge about Huai Du, it’d not be difficult to get the information I need from Nie Zun either.”

So her goal was to control Nie Zun, and she thought I was the only one who can do that. This is why she chose to control me first, and do things in such a round-about manner. *That was a lot of work.*

I shattered that scenario of hers as I said, “You’re thinking too much. I can’t control Nie Zun. The Nie Zun now doesn’t seem to care about me at all.”

Du Yue did not seem bothered at all. “That doesn’t matter. You’re still very useful to me even if you don’t have anything to do with Nie Zun. I haven’t really studied your second personality, but I believe that there is great potential in you. If Nie Zun is the only one Huai Du is relying on, then you’ll be my trump card.”

Haha, you seem to have forgotten that we were actually enemies. You make it sound as if we had already made up and that we can actually have nice and long chats.

“I know what you’re thinking, but in reality, I chose to work with you because I’m sure you’ll accept my offer, and it’s a deal that you would definitely want to accept.”

“Oh? What is it?”

Du Yue smiled as she answered, “I can help you regain every single one of your lost memories. I can do it anytime as long as you’re willing. Apart from Jiao S and the rest of you guys, I can bring every surviving individual in the three districts back to the real world, as long as you’re willing. I can help you save those whom you want to save, and I can also help you escape from a life you hate. And after that, I won’t let anyone stop you if you wish to leave.”

Before I could say anything, Si Luo responded. “Are there any benefits for me? I’m curious about how you’d try to persuade me.”

Du Yue's eyes shone. "I can take Jiao S away from here as well."

Originally standing stock-still like a statue, Jiao S eyes moved at this.

I knew Jiao S. She was rational most of the time. Judging from how well she knew Li Qing, she'd probably be wondering about the same things I did. She's someone who'd remain silent as long as there was somebody trustworthy around. Though she looked rather dead and emotionless most of the time, her brain was analyzing every single detail that she had seen and heard.

The offer to Si Luo is that Jiao S would be able to leave? As expected, Du Yue could tell that it wasn't merely unrequited feelings on Jiao S's part.

I was sure Si Luo would consider other factors as well, but I realized this was just my opinion as Si Luo answered resolutely, "Okay, as long as you keep your word."

Jiao S interrupted in her hoarse voice, "I won't leave if Ah Shen doesn't."

This was the first time she spoke since arriving here.

My heart felt like it was being wrenched. *Oh, I have no heart.*

My heart had been taken away by Nie Zun.

Jiao S's words did not actually make any great impact on the current situation.

Though Du Yue wanted to take the Gate of Ghost, she had forgotten about the Gate of Exit. Li Qing and Li Wen were as intelligent as Du Yue, and Du Yue was over-confident about this. She had forgotten that there were two strong contenders over on that side.

A war between women usually turns out to be the bloodiest.

She's too focused on destroying the Gate of Ghost at this point. But would she really be the final winner when the balance between the three powers shift if the Gate of Ghost ends up being destroyed?

If the situation between Huai Du and Li Qing was complex, Du Yue would also be at a disadvantage if she didn't know about it at all.

But these things weren't what I was most interested in right now. Right now, I wanted to know how she'd actually help me get my memories back. Would she use that drug again?

“Tell me what you actually want me to do then.” I told Du Yue.

Du Yue answered very quickly. “There's no need for you to do anything at this point. Gaoqin Jiuye and Nie Zun just left, so I'll first have to find out where they are. I have a suggestion for you though. You might want to conquer that living weapon of yours as soon as you can. Do you really want your weapon to be stolen so easily by others all the time?

“It's true that Piercer is the most difficult to control among the living weapons since its soul is extremely evil, but that doesn't mean it's impossible. You might want to think about conquering your own weapon first.”

That was actually a useful suggestion. But I might have to look for Zou An before I can do that.

Where's Zou An anyway?

I was just about to pose the question when Si Luo asked, “Talking about suggestions, I have one for you too. Shouldn't you solve the issues between you and Ta Lai before you go on your plans for conquest?

“I'm not very clear about Ta Lai's identity anymore. He's a soul splitter from the Gate of Heaven, but whatever he does, it doesn't seem to be of any direct help to you and Feng Zhu at all. Feng Zhu might be able to accept that, but how about you?”

Chapter 263: 263 Left Alone

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263 Left Alone

By mentioning Ta Lai, Si Luo's attempt to rile Du Yue up proved to be successful as her face darkened immediately. She looked embarrassed, and I found it rather pitiful as I looked at her.

Women who turn into bloodthirsty creatures because of love are all pitiful.
But, what about me?

I wasn't pitiful. It was just sad for me.

It was the wrong person I thought I was in love with all this time, and when I thought I had found true love, I realized that I was actually the one who brought him the most pain.

I said to Du Yue, "Give me a private space so I can communicate with my weapon on my own."

"You're finally going to conquer your living weapon?"

"I wouldn't say it's a conquest. I'd just like to talk to her for a bit," I answered. Actually, I merely wanted some alone time.

If I wanted to conquer Piercer, I had to go against that female soul. That soul was no easy opponent, but this fight was something that I needed right now.

I needed a fight like that to clear my head and to help me stay rational. The pain from it might wake me up a little.

Apart from that, what I actually needed was power. Without power, I can't achieve anything here in the Split Zone.

Si Luo asked, "Have you decided? From what I know, that living weapon of yours is very different from Gaoqin's. The soul in your living weapon has a deep hatred within her, and that has been accumulated for a long time over many years."

I smiled at him. "This is why I need your help. If you assisted Gaoqin Jiuye in conquering Shen Qi, I believe you'll be able to help me out on this too, right?" Si Luo did not respond.

Jiao S spoke in that hoarse voice, "Ah Shen, wherever you're going, you have to be with me. I'll be worried if you are alone."

I shook my head and said, "Give me some time alone, Jiao." This was the first time I addressed her as 'Jiao' in such a serious manner. Though she looked a little stunned, she didn't say anymore.

Si Luo looked at me, his eyes serious. "You should know your current situation. You don't have a heart now. Do you really think it's okay for a body of consciousness to be without a heart?"

Du Yue nodded. "That's right. It's not a minor thing to be without a heart. This is also why I want to get your heart back. Gaoqin Jiuye was probably venting his frustration about this on you since you didn't seem to cherish your own life."

Haha, you speak as if you were actually my friend.

"You're worried about my second personality instead of my heart, isn't it?" I asked sarcastically.

Du Yue was surprisingly patient as she answered, "That's not important. Without a heart, you won't be able to summon your second personality. Also, it'll be difficult for you to regain those lost memories as well. Lastly, it will be difficult to maintain your MF at its initial level in such a situation. I don't know how Nie Zun did it that you're not able to regenerate another

one, but I'm sure of one thing. If he was the one who took it, then you can only get it back from him."

I didn't want to hear them talk about this anymore. It was almost as if I didn't want to recall that it was Nie Zun who took my heart away. In slight frustration, I said, "I just want some time alone to think right now. Is that possible?"

Du Yue looked at me for a while before signaling to the standing women. "You want alone time? I can lend you the main hall in the Palace of Cold Blood. What do you think?"

I raised a brow. "Here?"

"That's right."

"Okay."

Hearing my answer, Du Yue signaled for the women to leave. She then began making her way towards the main entrance.

Si Luo and Jiao S looked at each other, but seeing how resolute I was, they followed Du Yue out after reminding me of some things.

On her way out, Du Yue glanced at Piercer that was now hanging on my waist. "It will definitely be dangerous if you're planning to conquer Piercer without a heart and with a low MF. I won't be placing any guards outside since I'm lending this to you as a private space. If anything happens during this time, there'd be no one around to save you. You'd better think twice before doing anything."

She sashayed out of the main hall with her entourage after finishing. While she was leaving, she looked at the ice phoenix.

With trembling eyes, the ice phoenix landed on her shoulder and left together with her. It looked at me with a pleading gaze, but there was nothing I could do.

It wasn't that I didn't want to do anything, I just did not have the ability to do so at this point.

There was also this feeling of hopelessness I felt whenever Nie Zun left me.

He and Gaoqin Jiuye had both left me. Though I wasn't a girl who lived solely for love, this was still a major blow to me.

I was the only one left in the Palace of Cold Blood as I heard the doors of the main hall click shut.

Looking around me, I realized that the floor of this palace was so clean and shiny that I could see my own reflection on it. Walking over to somewhere more central in the main hall, I sat cross-legged on the floor.

Everything was in a mess now. Everything and everyone seemed to be all over the place.

Nothing was like how it was in the beginning.

I set off to save Laurel at first, but Laurel had made her own choices and had new loyalties now. I wanted to save Song Lu and Yu Liang, but they did not say anything in their haste to leave the Split Zone. They left so hastily without any hesitation nor any hint of wistful affection.

Nothing remains constant in this world. This was difficult to accept, but it was something we all had to live with.

Though I sat alone in this huge hall, I didn't really have to pick a fight with my living weapon. I simply wanted to take a break from all that mess outside.

This was the first time I missed somebody so much.

Back in that icy wonderland, I seemed to have always hated being alone. I didn't like solitude, I didn't like being ostracized.

But now that I'm thinking about all that had happened, I wondered if I really hated it.

You actually like solitude, don't you, Li Shen? You enjoy being alone.

You think that being alone is far better since nobody likes you.

Because of Pomelo's betrayal, you realized that friendships were made just to be broken. You love to be alone, because you're afraid that people would leave you.

That smile on Gao Qi's face the very first time we met was not a genuine one. Behind that sweet smile of his, there was this hatred in his eyes. I definitely saw it then, but why did I lie to myself?

Why did I lie to myself and tell myself that he was actually someone who's gentle? And I even wanted to get to know him better.

Was it because I felt that dangerous aura around him? Would Gaoqin Jiuye have been dragged in if I was a little bit more rational at that time?

But was I really at fault here?

Why would Gaoqin Jiuye dream of me? He and Gao Qi were doppelgangers, but he ended up dreaming about me. Was this all fated, or was somebody else pulling the strings here?

I'm tired of all this.

I don't know what else I can endure here in the Split Zone.

I didn't fear what might come at me in future, but the thought of losing my past scared me. Just imagine someone telling you that whatever you remember is all wrong, that everything in your head was incomplete, that you've forgotten about the most important part about your life.

This wasn't a simple case of turning your back on things. This was equivalent to disavowing everything you had known and all that you've been through. Your perspective, your feelings, your memories and basically everything in your life would be turned around and destroyed.

What did I do wrong? Why did this have to happen to me? What did I do wrong that I had to endure this horrible life?

I looked down as I drew Piercer out slowly. As usual, Piercer felt soft against my hand. It was glowing with a violet light.

It had already been with me for the past year or so. I placed it on the floor in front of me and looked at it in silence.

Days passed so quickly that I haven't really taken a good look at this weapon of mine.

How did Gaoqin Jiuye conquer Shen Qi for it to be so loyal to him? What did Si Luo put him through? There was no way I would find out.

Even though Si Luo was a secretive, mysterious and unpredictable individual, I could tell that he was a trustworthy person, from all those memories of his I've seen.

No matter what method Gaoqin Jiuye used to conquer Shen Qi, there was definitely something which caused them to be inextricably tied to each other.

It wasn't a relationship between an individual and a weapon, it was a friendship.

They were lifelong partners.

Gaoqin Jiuye had earned Shen Qi's loyalty with an equal amount of loyalty on his part, and I was sure it didn't come without a price. *What about me though?*

Looking at the whip which had been with me for quite a while now, I realized that I had never looked at it properly, apart from the very first time I held it.

I realized that the spike on the end of it was a dark red, as if it had sucked human blood. That purple color of Piercer also looked brighter than before.

“You’ve changed too. Have you grown like me...?” I talked to myself as I caressed Piercer.

It was cold when I first touched it, but it began to feel warm after a while, as if I was touching somebody’s skin.

Chapter 264: 264 Deactivating the Split Symbol

Volume 5

264 Deactivating the Split Symbol

“What is your story...?” I continued mumbling to myself as I touched Piercer. Apart from the warmth I felt on my fingertips, there was no other response from Piercer.

“You’re still not willing to accept me?” I asked as I looked at it.

Still nothing.

I tried to pour some of my MF into Piercer like I did in the past.

Just as I did that, a cold wind seemed to blow right through my chest. A chilling cold spread throughout my entire body as my hand began shivering.

I felt the MF flowing out of me and no matter how I tried to activate it, I just could not control it. It was as if the MF was rejecting my body and causing tremendous pain in the process.

Though the hole in my chest had already healed after Nie Zun took my heart away, my heart did not regenerate. I no longer felt that painful, chilling cold all over my body from when my heart was initially taken away. Although Si Luo and Du Yue had mentioned time and again how serious my condition was, I couldn’t yet grasp the situation since I haven’t used my MF since then.

It was only at this point did I realize that my MF had weakened, just like how Du Yue had said it would, and that I was also unable to activate my MF at all.

This made me restless. I focused my concentration and tried to activate my MF again.

MF was a manifestation of one's consciousness and mental ability. Logically, as long as one had a strong mental ability, it would manifest itself in MF. I didn't believe that I couldn't use my MF.

A chilling pain assaulted me as I attempted to activate my MF again, and I could feel my MF going haywire in my body. I could not control it as it was simply swimming around in my body with no aim.

I realized that though one could have a strong consciousness and mental ability, it had to be coupled with a proper body before one could use their MF effectively. Though the human forms in the Split Zone were maintained with MF, they were still a form of existence in this space. One would not be able to control MF and use it effectively for battle if the form existed without a heart.

After trying time and again, I began to feel feverish as the uncontrollable MF in my body seemed to eat into me. It felt as if every nerve, every vessel and every hair on me were expanding in the painful heat.

I placed my palms against the floor and panted as I looked at Piercer. *What should I do?*

Nie Zun, is this the hatred you feel towards me? Or is this a reflection of the cold distance between us?

Weren't you worried about how I could be in danger if I couldn't use my MF without a heart?

I don't believe it.

I refuse to believe that you've become someone like that.

What should I do? What do I do?

Du Yue had warned me earlier on this, and she even made it very clear that I shouldn't force myself to do certain things. She didn't mention that I would not be able to use MF at all. This probably meant that she did not expect for this to happen.

Si Luo might not have anticipated it either.

I can't just go and tell them that I'm totally useless now that I can't use any MF, can I?

Should I put myself in such a disadvantageous position?

No, I shouldn't.

Even though Jiao S was here, she looked extremely pale herself. It was as if regaining those eyes had taken a huge toll on her health as well. There was no way I could let her sacrifice herself for me.

What should I do then?

I looked down and happened to see a part of a necklace.

My splitting key hung on this very necklace.

An idea then struck me.

How about I just deactivate my split symbol since I couldn't use MF now?

The idea came about because I recalled that the 500-meter distance restriction between Nie Zun and I had disappeared only after I had activated my split symbol. *Did this mean that the restriction will reactivate itself if I deactivated my split symbol?*

Though this was a wild guess, I felt excited at the mere thought of it.

If it succeeded, I would be able to see Nie Zun again.

He's still unable to leave me even if his feelings for me had changed.

Though I still felt that there was some other reason behind his actions, there was no way I would find out if he wasn't by my side.

If this succeeded, I could make use of the 500-meter restriction between us to find out. It was a perfect scenario.

This main hall looked like it was about 1000 meters wide. If I could reactivate the distance restriction between Nie Zun and I, he would be pulled towards me based on the difference in our MFs. This meant that he would appear in this hall.

I reached towards my neck with trembling hands as I undid the necklace.

If I deactivated my split symbol, this meant that I'll have zero MF for the next one month. *Can I really survive in enemy territory without MF for a month?*

Even though this was just an attempt on my part, it was still a highly risky move. *But if I don't take the risk, I won't be able to use MF either. How long would I then have to wait for my MF to recover?*

At this point, all I was doing was creating excuses for myself. No matter how much I thought about it and struggled with the possible consequences in my head, I knew that I would definitely be deactivating my split symbol.

Because this meant that there was a chance for Nie Zun to return to my side.

After making my decision, I grabbed my splitting key and jammed it into the faintly glowing scorpion insignia on my left ankle. There was a flash of light and instead of feeling immense pain, which was what I expected, I felt a sense of warmth in my body.

The warmth spread throughout me and flooded through my nerves and blood vessels. I was wrapped in a pleasant, gentle warmth.

As the light dissipated, I pulled the splitting key out and hung it back on my neck.

I tried to activate my MF but I felt nothing. There was no trace of MF in my body whatsoever. I became just like an ordinary human being, like those in the real world.

For some reason, this made me feel extremely relaxed. It was as if I had just put down a tremendous burden. *So this was how it felt to lose all your MF.*

I felt human again. *So it felt like this.*

It's only when we lose things do we learn how to cherish them.

I really missed the real world even though my memories might just have been lies.

Piercer did not seem to have changed in front of me. Instead of continuing to look at it, I stood up and looked around me.

Nie Zun was not here.

I guess my prediction was far from practical. Looking down in slight disappointment, I bent down to pick Piercer up. However, I sensed someone behind me before I could touch it.

I retracted my hand and stood back up straight.

There was no sound from behind.

I couldn't stand it anymore and turned around finally.

A pair of bright, starry eyes looked back at me under black, wispy bangs.

There was a loneliness in those eyes.

He had his hands in his coat pockets and his tall figure was standing quite some distance away. He spoke in that indifferent tone of his. "How did you do that?"

I responded in mock confusion, “Do what?”

Instead of being frustrated, he explained patiently, “I was already very far away from the Palace of Cold Blood, but I felt an immense force pull at me. I ended up here before I could even find a way to resist that phantom force. Did you do something?”

I looked at him before gauging the distance between us.

Though I had zero MF, my senses were still better than that of an ordinary human being in the real world. I wouldn’t have been able to see him that clearly if we were 500 meters apart, nor would I have been able to hear whatever he had said if my senses had been like those of a normal human being.

I began stepping backwards in silence and I continued retreating for about 10 meters or so before I felt that distance restriction pull at me.

How I missed this so.

Previously, I was the one who would be pulled along by him, and it was rare for him to be pulled along by me. I still couldn’t see the logic behind this.

I stepped backwards on purpose, and Nie Zun slid a few meters towards the front.

A look of surprise flashed past those starry eyes of his. *I love that look on him.*

I smirked joyfully. “Surprised? That 500-meter restriction is back.”

Nie Zun’s eyes seemed to shine. After a moment, he asked, “So, what did you do?”

“Why do you think that it was me who did something? Why can’t this restriction come back on its own?”

Nie Zun regarded me in silence.

His eyes had already given me the answer.

The way he looked at me already revealed that he was telling me, 'I know you all too well.'

Fine, I'll admit it then.

I raised my hands casually. "Nothing. I simply deactivated my split symbol."

Nie Zun's eyes narrowed and a look of worry appeared on his face before it was gone in the next second.

I managed to catch it though. Staring at him, I asked, "Why? You're worried about me?"

Chapter 265: 265 Making a Deal with Piercer

Volume 5

265 Making a Deal with Piercer

“I guess you just can’t forget about me,” Nie Zun said.

I walked towards him slowly, finding 500 meters too far apart. “What’s wrong with not being able to forget? You’re the one I love. Do you expect me to just let go like this just because you’re being cold and cruel? I have to forget about the past two years just like this?” I looked at Nie Zun as I spoke.

He didn’t answer me for a long time. He simply looked back at me with a helpless gaze.

I closed the distance between us and took his hand as I reached him.

“I heard that you don’t have a soul splitter. Did you know about this from the very start?” I asked, looking up at him. He kept his eyes on me as he let me hold his left hand.

“Yes, I knew that.”

“Why didn’t you tell me that?”

“Would you have cared in the past?”

“You haven’t told me about it even when I care about it now.”

I squeezed his hand. “Tell me why you’re acting this way.”

“Your MF is down to zero once you deactivate your split symbol. It’s Du Yue’s territory here in the Gate of Heaven. What are you going to do?”

“Don’t change the subject. Tell me. Give me a reason.”

“I seem to have told you before, Li Shen. I’m tired of this. There is too much to face and too much to bear when I’m with you. I’m tired of it.”

Haha, can’t you find a better reason for this even if you’re really tired of me?

I could force myself to believe it if this happened to someone else. But you’re Nie Zun, and it’ll be more believable if you told me you had a change of heart.

You’re somebody who has been ostracized and seen as a devil since you were young. You would never feel tired of this if you had been through all that from such a young age.

You’re like this, just like I am.

I let go of him suddenly. Keeping my eyes on him, I stepped back, putting about 10 or so meters between us.

“Go if you’re tired,” I said as I looked at him.

“You know that I can’t leave now.”

“Then help me.” I picked up Piercer and handed it to him.

“Help you with what?”

I looked down at Piercer. “Help me conquer this living weapon.”

Nie Zun narrowed his eyes. “Are you kidding? How are you going to conquer it when you don’t have any MF right now?”

I shrugged. “Who said that we had to have MF when conquering a weapon? Would a loyalty gained by oppression last? All you have to do is attack me with Piercer.”

“Stop joking around. Even if you’re right, it’s not practical to do this without any MF at all.”

“If you’re not willing to help me on this, I’ll just have to do it myself.” I lifted Piercer, but Nie Zun snatched it away from me quickly.

“I guess I shouldn’t have returned the weapon to you.”

I smirked at him. “Have you not taken enough from me? I’ve given you my heart, and you’ve taken the living weapon. How about you just take my life away too?”

Nie Zun’s brows furrowed slightly. “So you’re upset about me taking your heart?”

“Shouldn’t I be?”

Nie Zun’s eyes seemed to sigh. “You’ll just end up being more confused if that heart stays inside of you. Your second personality cannot appear without that heart. Without your second personality, those who’re eyeing it won’t be able to do anything either.”

“Stop it. I don’t want to listen to this. Just tell me if you’re going to help me conquer Piercer or not.”

Nie Zun gazed at me for a while before he lifted Piercer in the air.

As if possessed by some sort of demonic energy, Piercer floated in the air between us. Black fog surrounded Nie Zun’s left hand and his eyes looked like they belonged to a spirit from hell.

“Come on out.” He sounded merciless. There was no warmth in his voice at all.

Surrounded by that black fog from his palm, the purple-colored Piercer seemed to dance in the air like a levitating snake.

It was coupled with the hair-raising sound of a female calling out in a low-pitched voice.

I stared at Nie Zun and focused on all his movements, trying to find out what exactly he was doing.

It was not only his attitude towards me that had changed. After getting his blood changed, he seemed to be more demonic than before. He was ruthless every time he attacked, and I could feel that his attacks and the way he used MF were different from all of us. This probably would have something to do with the fact that he did not have a soul splitter.

I had a nagging feeling that once we get to the bottom of this, I'll be able to uncover the reason that he chose to leave me.

Before I could tell what he was attempting, Piercer produced a bright light. I heard a loud scream before Piercer transformed into a lady who stood right in front of me.

I was surprised by how she looked this time. She did not look as terrifying as before. She was no longer mottled with flesh and blood, and her skin was no longer peeling off.

She was in a purple dress, in a color very similar to Piercer's skin. She could not be considered beautiful, but she was not ugly either. She just looked cold and distant.

Her face was pale and her hair fell across her shoulders.

"You are... Piercer?" I didn't know what to say suddenly.

The purple-clad female smirked. "Weren't you trying so hard to get me out? Why're you pretending to be shocked when I'm here now?" *This is definitely the female soul in Piercer.*

“I didn’t expect for you to look like that.” Slightly upset about being misunderstood, I tried to explain my reaction.

“There are many things you can’t imagine. I really don’t know what that couple was thinking when they actually gifted me to someone like you.”

“Didn’t you hate them?”

“Hate is the only thing I know because of that. But if they gave me to you, this means they probably don’t treat you as a friend either. Everyone knows about Piercer’s curse. They’ve really overlooked that.”

“No, it wasn’t something they overlooked. It was a calculated decision on their part. It’s best to give me something cursed in case I end up being a threat to them or end up being in their way.”

“Aren’t you positive. Do you really think you can overcome my curse?”

I looked at her in confusion. “Your curse? Do you mean that Piercer’s curse is caused solely by you?”

Piercer smirked. “This is one way you can interpret it. Anyway, since you’ve tried so hard to summon me and you’ve even enlisted the help of a devil on it, I’ll give you a chance to conquer me now that I’m out.”

She glanced at Nie Zun when she mentioned the word ‘devil’.

Nie Zun seemed to have turned into a mute after she appeared. He was just standing there in silence.

This was a once-in-a-lifetime opportunity. I had to take advantage of this moment when Piercer’s soul was out. I spoke without hesitation, “What do you want me to do?”

Piercer laughed mercilessly. “To conquer me, you’ll have to go through all the pain I’ll be putting you through. You’ll have to come into Piercer’s space alone. Are you sure you dare to do it?”

There was nothing I was afraid of. *It’s just that...*

Subconsciously, I glanced at Nie Zun.

He remained silent.

I couldn't tell what he was thinking from that unfathomable gaze of his.

How difficult it is when you fall in love with someone like this.

"You can give me your hand once you've decided." Piercer stretched her hand out towards me. It looked thin and pale, as if it belonged to a malnourished child.

I looked at Nie Zun again. After being sure that he wouldn't stop me on this, I reached out to Piercer.

Seeing the hesitation in me, Piercer grabbed my hand. Right at that moment, I felt a pain in my empty chest. Piercer sensed it too as she asked in shock, "Where's your heart?"

I pointed at Nie Zun and said, "He took it."

"You really fear nothing." Piercer shot a cold glance at Nie Zun before saying, "I'll advice you to give up sooner rather than later if that's the case. You're trying to conquer me without MF? It'd be difficult for you to even overcome my MF maze."

"Enough talking. This opportunity has landed right in front of your doorstep. Just do what you do, no need to care about me."

"You're thinking too much. Who cares about you? This devil of yours won't let me off the hook if I accidentally did anything to you."

So it was Nie Zun she was afraid of.

I asked Nie Zun, "Don't interfere no matter what happens, okay?"

Nie Zun nodded calmly this time.

“Look, he’s made it clear now. Can you bring me to that illusion of yours already?”

Piercer regarded me coldly for a few seconds before reaching out to me. “Let’s go. This is your choice. Don’t blame me for swallowing your soul without any hesitation when that happens.”

“Enough with the talking already. I chose to lose all that MF, and I chose to look for you as well. Did I say I was going to blame anyone?”

“You’ll just have to do your thing and let me see if you’re really a good weapon which I should be risking my life to conquer.”

Piercer smirked. “You sure talk big. I’ll bring you along to have some fun since I’ve got the time.”

She then pressed her palm against mine.

As if given an anesthetic, I began to lose my grip on my consciousness. *Was I about to end up in another space again? A space created by a mere living weapon no less?*

Now that I think about it, life was full of trials and tribulations, but I seemed to always forget the important things which happened in my life.

My biggest problem was that I was not resolute enough.

As our palms touched, a black fog which looked similar to that from Nie Zun’s emanated from her palm.

Chapter 266: 266 Piercer's Past

Volume 5

266 Piercer's Past

The black fog obscured my vision before I felt myself falling into an abyss.

“Don’t fall asleep now, it’s too early for that.” The voice from the lady clad in purple rang in my ears again and again.

The feeling of not being to do anything about myself was rather uncomfortable.

“Don’t wake up...”

As I heard this ghostly voice, I snapped my eyes open and found myself in nothing but darkness. Rubbing my eyes, I saw a tiny fire burning somewhere far away.

“Who’s there?” I asked.

There was no answer.

That tiny fire seemed to flicker as I stepped forward.

Though I was covered in cold sweat, I forced myself to walk towards it.

I felt a chill behind me and all my hairs stood on ends. A hand suddenly appeared out of nowhere and tapped me on the shoulder.

“Ah.” Terrified, I jumped and turned around to look.

“Look how timid you are.” It was actually Jiao S behind me.

Jiao S had a smile on her usually emotionless face. “Ah Shen, do you have to be this afraid of me? I’m not some ghost. And you’ve been in the Split Zone for so long now. Are you still afraid of ghosts and monsters?”

Though there was nothing wrong with her tone and whatever she said, that weird smile rattled her out.

Jiao S would never smile this easily since she’d rather let others think that she was cruel and ruthless.

Keeping my eyes on the fake Jiao S, I retreated. “Who are you? Stop pretending. You’re not Jiao S.”

The fake Jiao S laughed. “Oh, how did you tell?”

“No need to wonder about that. I just know you’re a fake.”

The smile on the fake Jiao S turned cruel immediately as she reached out towards me with both hands.

Just when I was preparing to dodge, I realized that I did not have an ounce of MF left in me. I had no choice but to simply turn around and run as quickly as I could.

I was actually trying my best to escape.

I ran as fast as my legs could take me and I could even feel the wind blowing past my ears.

It was already a miracle that I could escape without MF, so I didn’t expect to be able to put up a strong defense. I didn’t bother turning back to look either.

My mind was solely focused on running away and I didn’t know whether she was chasing me or not. I ran until I was exhausted, until I felt like vomiting. It was then that I realized that there was actually no one behind me.

Panting hard, I looked around.

“You can really be hard on yourself.” The lady in purple appeared right in front of me.

“I, you... I... Who are you exactly? What do you want...” I used up a lot of my strength just to run away, causing me to stutter as I spoke.

“What do I want?

“I just want someone to listen to my story...” The lady in purple spoke in a sorrowful voice. It was totally different from that cruel and merciless tone she usually had.

Still panting, I remained silent. I didn’t show fear either.

The lady in purple circled around me before hugging her knees and squatting in front of me.

She buried her head in between her knees and said, “Are you willing to listen to my story?”

I pondered for a moment before answering, “Yes.”

She seemed to be taken by surprise by how calm I was as she looked up in what looked like shocked silence.

“Ay...” She produced a long and sad sigh.

“It’s like this. I was just a girl living a happy life. There wasn’t anything much that frustrated me, until I fell in love with a boy who appeared in my dreams.

“He was so lively when he appeared in my dreams that I was sure he existed. I know this might sound ridiculous, but those dreams were clear as day and they seemed to continue in chronological order. I couldn’t help but believe that he really existed, to the point that even my family thought I was crazy.

“I didn’t care though. It was fine for me as long as there was someone who believed me. I believed that he would always be waiting for me in my dreams.

“I kept meeting him in my dreams, and as time passed, I became greedy. To be able to spend more time with him, I wanted to sleep all day, every day. Everyone thought I had gone mad since I was acting like an insane person who had given up on life. I was talking about how I wanted to fall asleep and dream all day.

“As for him, he began to look at me with eyes that were filled with sorrow. It was as if he was blaming himself for affecting my life.

“For some reason, those eyes scared me. I was afraid that he’d leave me one day.”

It was a squarish pit which measured about five meters on each side. It was about three meters deep and there were bloodstains on all sides of it.

The stains looked filthy, as if they had been there for years.

Residents of Bronze Sparrow Village surrounded the pit. Towards the east, a few of the villagers were holding a girl dressed in red. The girl’s hair fell across her face, and she looked to be about seventeen or eighteen.

A white-haired granny kneeled beside the girl, kowtowing towards the pit as she mumbled, “Spirit of Curses, the residents of Bronze Sparrow Village offers this demon. Please accept her flesh and bones as an offering. Please keep all 3,601 residents of the Bronze Sparrow Village safe.”

“I pray that the Spirit of Curses will keep us safe.” Everyone standing around the pit then began kowtowing.

As the moonlight was slowly obscured by the clouds, the scene seemed to be casted in an eerie gray light.

Looking into the pit, there seemed to be starry, white lights reflected from inside it. As the villagers raised their torches, she realized what it was in the pit.

It was filled with poisonous creatures of all sorts.

There were poisonous snakes, centipedes, toads, worms, giant green caterpillars, spiders, praying mantises, huge black ants, cicadas, maggots, poisonous scorpions, and creatures of all sorts in it.

These creatures were attacking one another, and a carcass would go flying at times, but everything was still trapped in that three-meter deep pit.

There were also bits and pieces of flesh, strips of skin, dried blood and other disgusting things that were mixed with those poisonous creatures. Apart from these, one could also see the colorful but poisonous worms in different shapes and sizes found in the Miao Village that was situated quite a few mountains away.

Whoever looks into the well would probably end up feeling their hair stand on ends.

This was the secret of the Bronze Sparrow Village. This was the pit of poison they used for offerings.

Because of all the hatred that was accumulated in this pit, and no one was allowed to be within a 100-meter radius of it.

When the time for offerings came about, the chief of Bronze Sparrow Village, Granny Poison, would get the villagers to put in all sorts of poisonous creatures and newfound poisons into the pit.

For thirty years, thousands and thousands of poisonous creatures had been thrown in there. No humans had been thrown in before, but on this day, Granny Poison led the villagers during the early noon to start preparations for throwing her into this poisonous pit as an offering.

Granny Poison took out a yellowish amulet from her pocket and read from it. “Gu Qing, born in the hour of Hai, eighteen years of age. Let the ceremony begin.”

After Granny Poison spoke, a few sturdy-looking villagers dragged the girl beside the pit.

She opened her eyes to look as she heard the sounds coming from within the pit.

Her expression was calm as she looked at all the poisonous creatures. Her face was streaked with dirt, but there were no traces of tears on it.

It was at this moment that a couple came out of nowhere.

The couple was crying as they struggled free from the crowd of villagers and dropped themselves at the girl’s feet.

“Please let our daughter go. She’s only eighteen, a child!” The woman was bawling as she hugged the girl tightly. The man was kneeling beside the girl as he kowtowed.

Granny Poison hit the woman with her staff. “How can you shield her like this when this demon had harmed so many in Bronze Sparrow Village and brought so many curses upon us. This wouldn’t have happened if you didn’t bring this demon to our village years before.”

Seeing the granny hit his wife, the man rushed forward to shield both his wife and daughter. In tears, he said, “Granny Poison, my wife and I were without child for forty years. Qing’er is our child, she’s no demon. If you insist on using her as an offering, you’ll have to kill us first.”

Granny Poison grunted in anger and signaled for the group of sturdy-looking villagers to pull the couple away from the girl.

The girl finally lifted her head to look at the couple, tears falling down her cheeks. “Father, Mother, leave me. They’re cruel. Even if I’m made an

offering, the Spirit of Curses would not accept me. The Bronze Sparrow Village will never be safe.”

“How dare a demon be this audacious.” Granny Poison was about to hit the girl with her staff.

“No, don’t hurt my Qing’er.” Seeing the staff that was about to land on her daughter, the wife freed herself from the villagers holding her down and rushed forward to shield her daughter from the blow.

The man then struggled free and ran up to his wife to grab her before they both jumped into the pit.

He said, “We, the Lus, offer ourselves to the Spirit of Curses. The curse would be lifted after this. Granny Poison, please let Qing’er go.”

There were shocked screams as everyone witnessed the scene.

Chapter 267: 267 Help Me

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267 Help Me

We were the only ones left in this dark space.

“Was it worth it?” I asked.

“What’s worth it?” She was surprised by my sudden question.

I continued calmly, “Was it worth it to give up so much just for a boy who appeared in your dreams? Was it worth it that you destroyed your perfect life for this?”

She looked like she was about to cry. She gazed at me helplessly as she shot the question back at me. “How about you, Li Shen? Is it worth it?”

I didn’t expect for her to do that, but I should have thought of this, shouldn’t I?

Yes, Li Shen. How about you? Is it worth it?

Are you posing a question to her or are you actually asking yourself?

“For me, there’s nothing worthy or not worthy. I’m different from you. You came here because you loved him. But me, I destroyed him.” Gaoqin Jiuye appeared in my head as I spoke.

I had let Gaoqin Jiuye down even though it was him instead of Gao Qi I was in love with.

Piercer shook her head, her eyes filled with sorrowful resolution. “You arrived here because of the same reason. I wanted to be with him, and you aren’t able to let go of that guilt because you loved him. You aren’t able to forgive yourself. This means that you haven’t forgotten about him.”

I wanted to laugh at this. I wanted to laugh so hard at it, but I didn’t.

I answered calmly, as if nothing in this world could put me down. “But the funny thing is, I don’t even remember him. I’m not even able to tell who’s the one.”

“Is that important?” Piercer asked.

“How is that not important?”

“To me, that isn’t important. What’s important is who you love now. Have you let your current feelings down?

“Li Shen, let the past be in the past. Since you’re not able to recall who was in your heart, why not just give up on it?”

“Aren’t I a joke?” Feeling a little tired, I sat on the floor in the darkness, facing her.

“You’re not a joke. You might not be able to see that you’re not the one at fault here. This happened because of your feelings for Nie Zun. As long as you love Nie Zun, you won’t be able to recall how you used to love another.

“Have you thought about the possibility that no one else is actually responsible for this amnesia of yours? That it might not have anything to do with the fact that you arrived in the Split Zone even? It might simply be because you aren’t willing to forgive yourself. Because of that, your subconscious refuses to let you recall those memories.”

I frowned. “You mean it’s my subconscious mind that’s preventing me from remembering the past?”

“Yes. Think about it. You didn’t hurt your head, and your body is fine too. No matter how your consciousness crumbles and where it brings you to, the

secrets buried deep in your heart can never be changed. Nobody else can take whatever's in your mind and in your heart, including your feelings.

“This amnesia might be caused by your subconscious mind. It's a habit that you've gotten used to, and habits die hard. The selective amnesia can mislead you into thinking that you've really lost those memories, when you actually haven't.”

I wanted to argue with Piercer immediately after hearing her opinion, but I asked myself a question before I said anything. *Li Shen, are you sure you didn't cause this amnesia yourself?*

Why was I afraid to admit that it was the truth?

“Are memories that important, Li Shen? You aren't willing to recall them, but you're trying to look into the past while you're in love with Nie Zun at the same time. There isn't any past or any future in your head. You aren't even there. Who exactly are you?”

A sense of frustration overwhelmed me, but I didn't want to throw my temper here.

I knew that I was frustrated at myself. *Was I stupid? To the point that I missed all of this? But if I wasn't stupid, wouldn't that mean that I was someone who loved lying to myself?*

“Ask yourself, Li Shen, how many times have you lied to yourself? Is loving Nie Zun a lie as well?”

I was angered by what she said. “No, it's a fact that I love Nie Zun. I'm not lying to anyone, including myself.”

I then realized how ridiculous I was as I caught my reflection in her eyes.

Love is ugly. It will devour all rationality and lead to a fall from grace.

Dropping my hands beside me, I felt drained.

Piercer caressed my face with a gentle hand. There was a chill left in the wake of her touch. I felt uncomfortable at this because it reminded me of someone else.

Her.

I thought I wouldn't see her again without my heart.

Shouldn't I be happy that I could finally break free? Why did I think of her suddenly? Why is this happening?

“You definitely love him. He’s the only one who can trigger you and make you act without any hesitation.” Piercer seemed to sigh as she spoke.

I mumbled, “But, is loving, wrong too...?”

“Yes. Is loving wrong...? I came here willingly because I wanted to look for the love of my life. Am I wrong?” Piercer’s voice turned shrill all of a sudden.

“For my lover who appeared in my dreams, I didn’t mind coming here as a mere body of consciousness to look for him. Am I wrong to do that?” Piercer got more and more agitated as she continued.

But those enraged eyes of hers suddenly turned sad as she grabbed my hand. Almost choking on her words, she said, “Can you help me, Li Shen? I’ve underestimated you in the past. I didn’t see the true you. It’s only recently did I come to realize that you’re the only one in the Split Zone who really had a heart. Can you help me, please? Help me save him?”

She was begging me with her eyes. “You might think that I’m making use of you, but that’s okay. I can become the power that you need. If you want to leave, I’m able to protect you until the very day you leave. If you’re planning to stay in the Split Zone, then I’m willing to stay with you forever. You can take everything from me. I’m begging you to help me save him. I don’t want him to endure all that pain anymore.”

I couldn't really reconcile this face of grieve with her usual cruel, violent and bloodthirsty one. It felt like she was at her wit's end and it was a last resort for her to turn to me for help. *Even though I can't even help myself at this point.*

I gave her a bitter smile as I said, "I'm definitely willing to help you, but look at me. Do you think I can? It's been two years now, and I haven't been able to save a single one of my friends. Instead, many of them ended up sacrificing themselves. Can you trust someone like me?"

She nodded profusely. "You can. You might not know how much potential power you have in you. I believe in you. As long as you're willing to do it, I'll give you all the assistance I can. I can even tell you all about the Split Zone, as long as you're willing to help me save him."

I knew that a promise like this constituted a debt. I had to pay the price for it if I agreed.

A scene flashed in my mind as I looked into those sorrowful eyes of hers.

Gao Qi was lying in a pool of blood as I sat beside him, holding onto a bloody knife with trembling hands.

Drops of blood dripped continuously from the tip of the knife.

If someone had extended a helping hand to me then, would I not have ended up in this place? I felt her hands trembling as she held mine.

Closing my eyes, I took a deep breath to calm myself and clear my head. I then took her hand and smiled. "I'm willing to help you as long as you trust me."

She seemed to be dazed for a moment.

"You don't trust me?" I asked softly.

She shook her head quickly. “No, no, no. I trust you. It’s just that I didn’t expect for you to agree this quickly.”

I laughed, but it wasn’t a hearty one. “Have you already planned to fight and torture me until you successfully force me to work for you?”

Piercer laughed too. “I’m not that cruel. That cruel side of me is used to induce fear in others. A living weapon has a soul in it, and the soul embodies the weapon. This is why living weapons are so different. It’s because we’re all human, and we’re better than divine creatures at communicating with humans.”

“Why didn’t you tell me this earlier?”

“I had to get to know you better first. And to be honest, I had never thought of getting anybody’s help in the past. I didn’t think that anyone in the Split Zone could be trusted. Even when you had done so much for Nie Zun, I didn’t believe in you whole-heartedly.

“It was only when you defended your love for him earlier that I saw the sorrow in you. Love sparks sorrow and it sparks pain. It’s not possible to fake that. This is why I believe that you really love him, and it’s definitely worthy to put my trust in someone who’s willing to lose everything for love.”

I smirked. “I’m not the trustworthy one here. It’s Nie Zun. My love for him is built upon all the love he had for me.”

Chapter 268: 268 Gaoqin Jiuye's Love

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268 Gaoqin Jiuye's Love

“If that’s the case, why are you still in love with him when he says he no longer loves you?”

I was stunned at what Piercer said.

“Why lie to yourself, Li Shen?”

“Whether you’re willing to recall the past, I hope you have the courage to face up to your real feelings. Be it Nie Zun or Gaoqin Jiuye, they had both loved you.”

A bitter smile appeared on my face. “That’s something I’m not even sure about. How are you so sure?”

“There are things I know that you aren’t aware of. I’ve been in the Split Zone for too long and I’ve seen enough of things here.”

Looking at my doubtful expression, she explained, “I’ll give you an example. Hmm, what should I use as one? Right, I’ll use Du Yue and Gaoqin Jiuye as an example.”

My interest was definitely piqued as she mentioned these names.

“Do you know why things seem to be confusing between Gaoqin Jiuye and Du Yue? That’s because Gaoqin Jiuye had been seen as a weirdo among the

soul splitters from a young age. He's the only one in the Split Zone whose MF cannot be measured. Even for soul splitters, their MF can be measured before they establish any split symbol contracts. A numerical value can be put on it. However, Gaoqin Jiuye was the only one whose MF could not be measured.

“He was thus seen as someone who was suppressing this huge power in him and people thought that he would just go out of control with all that power one day. For a young teenager whose power could not be measured, he was seen as a ticking time bomb.

“The only thing you need to survive in the Split Zone is power, and the appearance of such an individual whose ability was immeasurable was absolutely unimaginable for all the people who had relied solely on power all their lives here. Being a teenager, that individual still had room to grow. Who wouldn't be worried? The ones who feared it the most were the ones who were at the very top, the ones who controlled this place with power.

“Gaoqin Jiuye then became a public target, and he was attacked by everyone everywhere. Until one day, when Si Luo suddenly said he was going to take Gaoqin Jiuye under his wing and protect him. No one could do anything to Gaoqin Jiuye from then on since Si Luo has always been respected here in the Split Zone. Be it his looks, ability or reliability, he was at the top.

“However, such a position made it worse for Gaoqin Jiuye. People got jealous. Gaoqin Jiuye became famous because he had this mysterious power, and now that he was under the wing of a powerful man, many wanted to get rid of him.

“Life got worse for him as people continued throwing sideways glances and ostracizing him. At that point, there was no one who treated him as a friend in the Split Zone, especially not soul splitters. Apart from you, there was nobody else who accepted Gaoqin Jiuye. Though you're not willing to admit your relationship, I can tell that you are as important to him as Si Luo is. As for you, even when you found him crossing the line on many occasions, you didn't do anything about it and simply accepted him as he is. Isn't that right?”

“You’re digressing.” She was supposed to talk about Du Yue and Gaoqin Jiuye, and I didn’t want her to affect my thoughts in any way. Also, I definitely did not want her meddling into my relationship with Gaoqin Jiuye.

She seemed to see through my intentions, but she continued calmly.

“Okay, we’ll return to the topic at hand. In such a situation, Gaoqin Jiuye was living a suppressed life. He was ostracized and alone. Initially, Si Luo was the only one by his side. However, his life changed after Du Yue came along.

“Du Yue was a tall, young girl at the time, and though she didn’t have much ambition in the Split Zone, she was still someone who was very gutsy. She became Gaoqin Jiuye’s close friend after getting to know him.

“Du Yue did not care about whatever was being said about Gaoqin Jiuye and insisted on being friends with him. She even trained and practiced with him. But of course, this wasn’t the reason why Gaoqin Jiuye gave up on her.”

Stalling for time at the very moment when things are about to be revealed? I asked, “Why did he do that then?”

My instincts had always been accurate, and though it told me that this reason would probably make me feel uncomfortable in some way, I just had to know.

“It was because of you.”

I was rendered speechless at her answer.

Piercer seemed to have expected such a reaction from me as she continued, “Gaoqin Jiuye was already dreaming about you then. Du Yue helped him look for a special method in order to find you. But that’s not important. The important thing is that if anything goes wrong while using that particular method, one would end up going into the other space. This happened when Gaoqin Jiuye went looking for you in one of his dreams, and to prevent him

from getting lost in the cracks in space and ending up getting stuck there, Du Yue pulled him back into the Split Zone.

“This saved Gaoqin Jiuye’s life, but it destroyed an arm of hers.”

I was surprised upon hearing this. “She lost that arm for Gaoqin Jiuye?”

“Yes. And since that happened because Gaoqin Jiuye was looking for you, it’s understandable that she doesn’t have such a good impression of you. She also changed drastically after she lost her arm. If a part of one’s consciousness is lost in the cracks of space, it can never be found.

“Losing her arm in that crack in space affected her MF greatly. Du Yue was not that powerful actually, but after that, she became cruel and ruthless. She even got infatuated with Ta Lai in the end. Her arm never healed and Gaoqin Jiuye blamed himself for all that had happened to her.

“It’s understandable that he felt guilty for it, since he was partially responsible for breaking the rules of the Split Zone by going over to another space to look for you. Du Yue ended up being the sacrificial lamb for it.

“However, there are rumors that Du Yue’s split symbol can actually recover although it was partially devoured by that crack in space. There are rumors going around that she didn’t want it healed. On this, no one knows the truth but her.”

I was utterly stunned. Thousands of questions were swimming in my head but I didn’t know what to say. *Should I be happy about this or should I be upset?*

“After that, Gaoqin Jiuye was extremely patient with Du Yue. Whatever she wanted, she got. He’d help her achieve everything she set out to do. Du Yue didn’t treat Gaoqin Jiuye badly either. From how I see it, Du Yue had loved him before. Du Yue’s infatuation with Ta Lai and her hatred towards Bian Ying seemed to be more of a conquest instead of something genuine. I don’t know much about them so I can’t tell you much. But I can tell you about Gaoqin Jiuye.

“Gaoqin Jiuye and I might not be arch enemies, but we’re definitely not on the same side. You should know that he saved Zou An and his wife. Though I hate Gaoqin Jiuye, frankly, I am kind of impressed by his loyalty towards you. It might be because I’m someone who is emotionally-driven most of the time, and I’m pretty impressed by how Gaoqin Jiuye can do so much for you. You won’t be able to imagine how difficult it was to pass through the spaces to look for you. He had to bear an immense amount of pressure and he had to be absolutely resolute, he couldn’t fear death.

“Love is blind. He’s done so much for you, and Du Yue has done so much for him. It’s like a vicious cycle which eventually ended up in a great change in Du Yue’s character and a jump in her abilities. You and Gaoqin Jiuye did not have a happy ending either. In the end, you ended up here with a split symbol contract because he had to interfere with what was happening in your world to save you. Though this might seem selfish, it could initially have been a happy ending where he explained everything to you and apologized, and in that story, the both of you could live happily ever after. But you forgot all about him when you arrived here.

“Oh, that’s not right. It’s not that you’ve forgotten him completely. You just put your feelings for him onto a totally different person. You chose to believe that Gao Qi was the one you loved, the one whom you stabbed with a knife. You were wallowing in that guilt you felt towards him.

“That guilt and self-blame made your life in the Split Zone miserable. From Gaoqin Jiuye’s perspective, no matter who you loved, those feelings of yours had brought you nothing but pain. This is why he blamed himself for it. This is also why he placed you in the care of others and chose never to see you again until you could recall your past, until you healed.

“He knew that your amnesia and memory confusion were all issues of the heart and that it wasn’t caused by external factors. I’m guessing that he probably wouldn’t reach out to you if you end up not being able to remember anything about him.

“But fate loves to throw curveballs at us, even in the Split Zone. The both of you ended up meeting each other and your relationship turned rather

complex. What's ridiculous is that you've actually fallen in love with another person."

I felt like I could no longer take this. I didn't want to hear more of this and interrupted her, "Enough."

She refused to stop talking, but her voice turned gentle. "These are things you have to know, Li Shen. You're running away from this just like how you're running away from those sealed memories of yours. You think that you're protecting yourself and protecting others, but you're actually harming them and harming yourself."

Chapter 269: 269 A Promise to Piercer

Volume 5

269 A Promise to Piercer

“I’m curious, Li Shen. Why did you fall in love with Nie Zun?” Piercer asked after a long pause.

I looked at her, not answering.

She continued, “I just don’t understand. You loved Gaoqin Jiuye so much. That guilt you felt towards Gao Qi after killing him by accident might have led to you being confused and misled you into thinking that Gao Qi was the one you loved. But even so, your feelings towards him should still be strong. Why did you have a change of heart?”

Yes... Why did I have a change of heart?

If what they say is true, then the one I’ve loved and the one I’ve always been in love with is actually Gaoqin Jiuye. I only felt guilty towards Gao Qi because I killed him.

Behind that guilt, I was also in denial about my feelings for Gaoqin Jiuye. I had always thought it was Gaoqin Jiuye’s appearance which changed everything. I thought that I had been in love with Gao Qi from the very beginning. But I’ve actually fallen in love with Gaoqin Jiuye, someone who had passed through the cracks in space. In my heart, I thought it was wrong of me to do so, and I thought I was letting Gao Qi down, especially when I ended up killing him in the end.

I thought it was all my fault that everything went wrong. This is why I couldn't forgive myself, and it led to my second personality being born, it led to me coming here to the Split Zone, and it led to me forgetting about Gaoqin Jiuye's existence.

This was what everyone else was telling me, and even I thought it was true. This sounded exactly like something I would do, and it sounded exactly like how I would think.

However, that past they are talking about, I haven't been able to recall it entirely. So who knew if that was really the truth?

Piercer is right too. No matter what the truth is, whether it was Gaoqin Jiuye or Gao Qi I loved, it had nothing to do with Nie Zun at all. No matter what it was, it didn't make sense for me to have fallen in love with Nie Zun.

Why did I fall in love with him then?

"To be honest, as a weapon that has been by your side for quite a while now, I think that Nie Zun is definitely someone worth loving. I'm just skeptical about why you love him. You might say that you found similarities in him in that you've both been ostracized before. But if that's so, it's the same for Gaoqin Jiuye as well. He's also someone who had been ostracized. So why is it that you've fallen in love with Nie Zun instead of Gaoqin Jiuye, who was the one you loved deeply before?"

I turned pale as I shook my head. "I don't know. No one asked me this before. Maybe you're right. Maybe I should take a proper look into my own heart. The ones I've loved, my memories, they all seem to be wrong and missing parts. All of this isn't caused by anyone else but myself. I chose this. How weak am I that I'm choosing to avoid all of this? I should be taking a good look at myself instead..."

"It's great that you're able to open up to me like this. Haha, I've been in the Split Zone for too long and I've seen so much that I've lost all hope in humans and soul splitters. I didn't like you at first, but I still ended up being your weapon. I don't know what it was that attracted me, but a lot of time has passed just like this."

I looked up at her. “Do you also think that Nie Zun is the one I love?”

Piercer turned serious. “You can’t doubt yourself at times like this. I know that whatever happened with Gaoqin Jiuye is a huge blow for you, and you’re a kind person who doesn’t want to let others down. But you have to understand that love is cruel. You’re bound to let his feelings down if you don’t love him. You love Nie Zun, and although I’m skeptical of the reason behind it, there’s no need to doubt that you definitely love him. Maybe for you, there’s no need for a reason to love somebody.”

I shook my head vigorously. “No, there’s nothing that is without reason, even love. I love him, and there has to be a reason behind it.”

“Have you found it then?”

I looked up at the darkness which reminded me of Nie Zun’s shadow. After a moment, I said, “I’ll tell you the day I leave the Split Zone.”

I had a huge smile on my face as I looked back at her. I felt that my head was much clearer now. This is life, where one would sometimes get a sudden epiphany.

Though Piercer was still filled with doubt, she simply nodded and said, “Okay, it’s a promise then. Remember to reveal it to me when you leave the Split Zone.”

“Okay, it’s a promise. You’ll assist me and lend me your power, and you’ll have to help me to leave the Split Zone as well. As for me, I’ll definitely help you save your lover.”

Piercer’s eyes glinted with a ray of hope. “Okay.”

“So, what do I do now?”

Piercer pulled me up as she stood. “You’re inside of Piercer now since I’ve pulled your consciousness in here. I’ll be loyal to you from now on as we’ve made a promise to each other. Though we stood on opposite sides

before, I hope that you'll be able to trust me. I'll be loyal to you, and all you have to do is to keep your promise to me."

I nodded firmly. "Yes, I promise."

"Both our souls are in the weapon now, and because of the difficulty and grueling process of creating a living weapon, living weapons are extremely rare. But because of this, the space here is independent of anything else and it is a completely sealed and protected space. Put simply, no one else would be able to find you or hurt you if I pull your consciousness in here."

I was surprised. "Wouldn't that make me invincible? This is the best place to hide!"

Piercer shook her head. "Don't get too excited. If that's the case, everyone who has a living weapon, like Gaoqin Jiuye, would be invincible. You can escape from everything once you're in here, but an ordinary body of consciousness cannot stay in here for an extended period of time, just like how we would never be able to leave this space ever.

"This means that even though I can pull you in here, it's only temporary. It's not easy to bring you in here either. It's a difficult and tedious process. This means that you shouldn't be hoping for me to be able to pull you in here at a moment's notice if you're ever in danger."

"I get it. What are the criteria for coming in here then?"

"You don't have to know that. All you have to know is that this is a suitable space for training."

I was suddenly reminded of something when training was mentioned. "Oh, I still have some questions about Gaoqin Jiuye."

"Go ahead."

"According to how you've described Gaoqin Jiuye and Du Yue, am I right to interpret that they both grew up in the Split Zone? Just what is the Split Zone? Is it just a separate space? Soul splitters are the living creatures in

here? Why are they able to grow up, and why can they dream of me when I'm in a separate space?"

Piercer looked grim after hearing my questions. "This is the secret of the Split Zone, and I'm not planning to reveal this to you right now. Don't blame me for this. Everything has a right time, and now isn't the right time for you to know this."

I would have continued probing in the past, but I wouldn't do it now. I realized that things I've gotten through force might turn out different from how I've initially imagined it to be. So instead of forcing things, I'd rather let things take its natural course.

"What I can tell you though, is that soul splitters grow up just like you do. In here, a day for them is 60 hours, and even though it's short if you calculate it via the time in your world, it's long here. 20 years to them is a very long time, and they would've been through a lot more."

20 years...

Would they die of old age?

I didn't ask the question eventually.

If it wasn't to uncover the truth behind everything, I wouldn't be interested in their world at all. I have never been curious about the Split Zone, unless it was to uncover hidden truths. I've been trying to live a peaceful life from the very day I arrived here. Though I seem to be a little more active now, I wasn't really that curious about this place. I guess I've always been like this.

"Also, how should I address you in future?" I asked. *I can't keep addressing her as Piercer, can I?*

"Just call me Piercer. Doesn't Gaoqin Jiuye call his living weapon Shen Qi too?"

Should I really just address her as Piercer?

“Doesn’t that sound a little inhumane? That doesn’t sound too nice, does it?” I asked hesitantly.

Piercer laughed. “No, it’s totally fine. What’s in the past is over and done with, and the old me is already dead. I’m no longer her. Even though I still have a consciousness, I’m no longer human now. I’m a mere weapon. Just call me that. I don’t want others to recall the old me either.”

I pondered for a while before answering. “That works, but how about this. I hope you’ll be able to tell me your name the day I succeed in helping you save him, even if that means picking up the pieces from your past. How about that?”

Piercer did not expect me to make her a counter-offer like this. She seemed stunned.

She looked at me as her eyes began to water.

I smiled. “Okay?”

“Okay,” she said, returning my smile.

“Can I call you Ah Shen then?”

“Of course you can.”

“I’ve actually wanted to ask you this, Ah Shen. What do you plan to do regarding Gaoqin Jiuye? I hope you can take a stand on this before you make any decisions in future.”

Regarding Gaoqin Jiuye?

Yes, I shouldn’t be running away.

What should I do then?

Even if Nie Zun was the one I loved, can I really throw everything away and be with Nie Zun like this?

If everything they say is true, then Gaoqin Jiuye would've been the one who had done the most for me. On the other hand, I've always been letting him down and forgetting about him.

I'm an existence which brings nothing but pain to others...

Chapter 270: 270 She's No Heir

Volume 5

270 She's No Heir

Before today, I could confidently tell Nie Zun that I wanted to be with him.
Would I still be able to do that after today?

I was used to being ostracized, and even if I did not want to let others down on purpose, it made me feel that I did not have to take responsibility for anyone either. *Could I do that to Gaoqin Jiuye as well?*

Now that I think about it, he wasn't ignoring me the very first time I saw him in the Split Zone. He was afraid to look me in the eye.

Were we being reunited or was it only him who was meeting me again?

I had forgotten all about him. Or did I purposely forget?

It was all my fault.

Am I going to let Gaoqin Jiuye down when I've already let Gao Qi down?

Gaoqin Jiuye, Gaoqin Jiuye.

Were you really not afraid to lose everything just to save me?

What about Si Luo?

"I have another question for you too. From what you told me, Gaoqin Jiuye would have given everything for me. But why do my instincts tell me that

he would be choosing Si Luo over me if he had to make a choice between the both of us?”

Piercer looked at me as she said, “This is where Gaoqin Jiuye’s loyalty lies. Gratitude is his priority, and you’re a close second. He places himself last. He’s grateful for all that Si Luo has done for him because Si Luo was the one who gave him hope and power. If you were in his shoes, you would place Si Luo at the top too. Also, he helped Zou An and his wife because that’s what he thought that he should have done. Gaoqin Jiuye is a very principled individual.”

I sighed. “Isn’t it difficult to sing praises of him when you hate him so?”

Piercer smiled. “I don’t exactly hate him. And I’m still rational about things.”

Nie Zun, Nie Zun. What should I do about you? Can I really abandon Gaoqin Jiuye and be with you like this?

I was the one who loved Gaoqin Jiuye, but I was also the one who forgot about Gaoqin Jiuye and the one who left him alone in this Split Zone for such a long time. He must have been so hurt whenever I looked at him with that hostile, foreign gaze.

It’s no wonder he lost control of his emotions at times...

I couldn’t stop saying that I loved Gao Qi, and I even told him that I had fallen in love with Nie Zun. How much pain must he have been in?

How could you be so cruel, Li Shen?

How could you take away somebody else’s happiness just because you refuse to recall the past?

Have you been keeping your distance from me because of this, Gaoqin Jiuye? You’d rather stay away than watch me like this?

What were you thinking when the both of us landed in that crack in space through Old Man Fan’s technique?

Why did everything seem so cruel...

With all that bitterness in me, I asked Piercer, “When do we start the training?”

“We can start now,” Piercer said.

“How do I train when I don’t have an ounce of MF in me? Are you able to help me look for my MF?”

“No, I can’t. Your MF would go down to zero for a whole month as long as you deactivate your split symbol. I’m not training you in using MF to protect yourself, but in using me to protect you. We’ll have to work together on this.

“I’ll explain it to you this way. Just like Shen Qi’s human form, I can exist as a physical entity to protect you. But we’d need to work closely together on this, be it through our gazes or bodies. Of course, the most important part of this is that our hearts and both our consciousness are able to resonate with each other. A living weapon is so called not only because of the presence of a soul in it. We can also act just like a human being and communicate.”

“How exactly do we do this?”

“It’s easy. You just need to have a chat with me.”

“Huh?” I stared open-mouthed.

Piercer smiled faintly. “Mutual understanding is gained through time spent together. You thought that training would be difficult, didn’t you? Real training is often times completed when you don’t even realize it. The effect of something that’s done on purpose would only be limited. Genuine understanding can be exchanged with a simple gaze and a simple word. It comes about when we’re at our most relaxed states. The reason I’m telling you that you have to train now is because the training is already coming to an end.”

I see.

“So it’s like how powerful individuals are usually hidden among the common crowd? The training is done under circumstances where there is no pressure and no specific goal, and that actually leads to immense strength?”

“That’s right. It’s fine even if you don’t have any MF, since you have me around. I can protect you. Also, the restriction between you and Nie Zun is made effective again after you deactivated your split symbol. He won’t let you die.”

“Oh, there’s something I’m curious about. What’s up with that restriction between us?”

Piercer sighed lightly. “Nie Zun arrived here because of you, and this is why the both of you are tied to each other like this. Nie Zun doesn’t have a soul splitter, and his split symbol is actually an extension of yours. This is why that restriction disappears when you activate your split symbol. When you activate it, the splitting key is inserted in the split symbol, and because of that, the tie between the both of you would break temporarily.”

So that’s why. Everything happened because of me still?

If I don’t want to let Gaoqin Jiuye down, what about Nie Zun? Nie Zun arrived here because of me too...

“Although Nie Zun arrived here because of you, I’m not too sure about the details. He definitely has some inextricable ties to the Split Zone, including the fact that he is a unique existence who can be cultivated as a demon. The both of you are rare cases, and that is the reason why so many others are interested in the both of you. You have to believe that no matter what, Nie Zun is the one whom you should trust and rely on the most.”

The most trustworthy and reliable one? But I wished that I was the one who was the most trustworthy and reliable for him instead.

I’ve been relying on too many people all this time, so I guess I deserve to be ostracized. I’m just a disaster who doesn’t know when to be content with

what I have. What right do I have to want to be treated nicely by others?

“Also, Piercer. As for... my second personality, how much do you know about her?” I hesitated for a long time before I asked the question eventually.

Piercer looked at me with this unfathomable gaze for a long time.

“What are you thinking about?” I waved a hand in front of Piercer.

She sighed and said, “Nothing. I can’t answer this question of yours.”

Okay, another secret.

“Just call out for me if you’re ever in danger. Remember to focus your thoughts when you’re doing that. I’ll be able to protect you then.”

“How do I help you save your lover then?”

Piercer looked pained. “No need to rush that. You don’t have the ability to find him and approach him right now. I’ll assist you for now, and I’ll tell you what to do when the time comes. I trust that you’ll help me on that, so there’s no need for you to worry about it. I’ll let you know when it’s time.”

I nodded. “Okay.”

“Also, that Scorpion Ray on your left hand – it’s an incomplete living weapon. Are you aware of that?”

I continued nodding as I said, “I’ve heard about this before, but I’m not really sure about the details. Ghost King Huai Du had also expressed an interest in taking Scorpion Ray for himself. I don’t really know much about this... Hey, where’s Scorpion Ray?” I realized the insignia on my left wrist was gone as I happened to glance at my hand.

“Other living weapons wouldn’t be able to enter the space in Piercer. Your consciousness wouldn’t be able to bring their consciousness in here either.”

“Oh, I see.”

“From what I understand, Scorpion Ray isn’t considered a living weapon because it isn’t whole and it doesn’t derive its spirituality from a body of consciousness. Scorpion Ray was created with the emotions of humans and the life force of people. It isn’t really alive, but it isn’t a dead thing either.”

“I don’t understand.”

“You can look at it like a stone which is able to absorb energy from both the sun and the moon. It doesn’t have a soul on its own, but it can absorb energy from other things. Rumor has it that a complete Scorpion Ray would shine like the dazzling sun and have the brightness of the moon and that it would also be extremely powerful.

“For weapons like Piercer, though it’s still useful even if you don’t summon me, it’s difficult to wield it in circumstances where your MF has been depleted. It’s different for Scorpion Ray.

“Even if you don’t pour MF into it, it can still be used as long as you call him out. It’s like a program that can be activated in a particular way. You’ve been imbuing in him the values of loyalty and working together from the beginning, and its spirituality would only allow it to recognize that particular value of loyalty. It isn’t able to consider other factors apart from that.”

“Then where’s the other half of Scorpion Ray?”

“I don’t know about that though. You might have to ask the person who gave Scorpion Ray to you.”

“Ask Li Qing...”

“Oh, there’s something else I wanted to tell you. Li Qing isn’t an heir.”

My eyes widened in shock. “What did you say...”

Piercer looked at me with sadness. “I can tell the difference between soul splitters and heirs because I’m a living weapon. Li Qing isn’t an heir, she’s a soul splitter.”

That was one huge secret. It was also a huge blow.

“I forgot to inform you of this before.”

“No, it’s impossible. How could she be a soul splitter?”

Piercer sighed heavily. “I know it’s difficult to accept this, but it’s the truth. Li Qing isn’t an heir. I’m very sure of that. Calculating based on her age, she has been in the Split Zone for a very long time. I suspect that she’d know more or less everything about the Split Zone.”

“Why did she take on the role of Western District Commander then? She had always protected us.”

“That’s because Li Qing is different from the other soul splitters. She’s somebody who believes strongly in her principles of right and wrong. From what I’ve seen, even though she isn’t an heir, you guys have always been her top priority. She was always trying to protect you guys.

“Ah Shen, you have to know that everyone has their secrets. It’s just something inevitable.”

Chapter 271: 271 Building Telepathy

Volume 5

271 Building Telepathy

Even if everyone had their secrets... This secret was too...

This individual was someone I trusted and looked up to. I thought she was an heir, but she's actually a soul splitter?

How could that be... Should I believe her...

I looked at Piercer with suspicion, but she smiled at me. “It’s normal that you’d be suspicious of me, since you trust her more. But Li Shen, I’ve also said that Li Qing isn’t a bad person. She just has her secrets.

“Think about it, why did she fake her death to leave? Why would she reappear after that? All of the choices she made were because of her identity as a soul splitter. She definitely considers the position of the heirs, but as a soul splitter, she has her own ties and an identity that would stay with her forever. You have to spare a thought for her on this.”

After hearing this, I suddenly thought it made a lot of sense. This might be why Li Qing kept things from me in the first place.

“Si Luo is also a soul splitter. Among the four District Commanders, Si Luo and Li Qing were the ones who requested for Jiao S and you to take on your positions. Do you think that the other soul splitters would really have let heirs take on such positions if that wasn’t the case? Wouldn’t they be afraid of an uprising? Have you thought about that? Jiao S and you are different

because the both of you have Si Luo and Li Qing as your backing. Things turned out different in that case.

“Si Luo was a soul splitter from the Gate of Heaven, and both he and Li Qing left the circle of soul splitters because they didn’t agree with how some things were being run. They left in order to protect you guys.”

“What you said definitely made sense, Piercer. But there’s a problem. I’ve seen Li Qing’s split symbol before and it was exactly the same as that of Li Wen’s. It was also in the same place. Li Wen is a soul splitter, so how could Li Qing be one...”

Something clicked in my head before I finished the question.

Piercer was looking at me with a look that said, *You get it now, do you?*

I couldn’t believe this. I asked, “You mean, you mean that Li Wen isn’t actually a soul splitter? Li Wen is an heir, and Li Qing is actually Li Wen’s soul splitter...”

“Yes, that’s it. All of you thought that Li Wen was Li Qing’s soul splitter, but you’ve gotten it the wrong way around. Li Qing is the soul splitter, and she’s Li Wen’s soul splitter. Li Qing named her Li Wen to signify the start of her new life in the Split Zone when she was brought here, which also includes providing her with the power of a split symbol through a split symbol contract.”

My goodness... So this was actually what happened.

This means Li Wen had been misunderstood by Jiao S all this while.

By me too.

This is why Li Wen said she was a loyal lapdog.

Don’t tell me that whatever Li Wen did was actually planned by Li Qing...?

No, that can’t be. According to Piercer, Li Qing had our interests at heart. Then why did Li Wen, who was always loyal to her, seem to be opposing us?

“I know that there are many things that don’t really make sense right now, but that’s okay. The truth will be revealed someday. I just want you to know that although Li Qing might have done some things that you think was wrong, you have to empathize with her. Li Qing is a woman who is worthy of respect, and there’s almost no one in the Split Zone who isn’t impressed by her.

“Li Wen might be thinking of taking all the blame on herself and leaving all the glory to Li Qing. No matter how kind or full of justice Li Qing is, her identity as a soul splitter can never change. She has to switch her stand sometimes, and it’s difficult for the rest of you to really understand her choices all the time. At times like these, Li Wen would be able to take the blame for her and leave Li Qing with a clean slate.”

I was shaken.

Relationships between women are complex, but I’ve pretended not to know that all this while.

Li Qing’s favorites were You Ji, Li Wen and I. Among the three of us, Li Qing favored me the most.

Though You Ji and Li Wen said they weren’t jealous, I knew that they were lying. If it were me, I knew I would definitely be jealous.

You Ji loved me but also hated me for this. It’s no wonder Li Wen was so emotional after learning of You Ji’s death.

Li Wen and You Ji were competing with each other as well. We all looked up to Li Qing and we were equally reliant on her. This is why all of us hoped to be the ‘best’ in Li Qing’s eyes.

Li Wen must have felt that even though I was Li Qing’s favorite, I wasn’t able to accompany her on that gritty road which might possibly turn dirty while she could.

Was this why Li Qing chose to take Li Wen away instead of me? Or was it simply because Li Wen was her heir?

Humans are fickle creatures. I know for a fact that if Li Qing had chosen me at the time, I might not have left with her even though I did love her. I might not have turned my back on the Western District together with her. Li Qing gave me the task of taking care of the Western District and staying loyal to it, but she turned her back on it.

And Li Wen seemed to be fine with something like this...

“Ah Shen, I know what you’re thinking. You can’t blame Li Qing for not choosing you. Firstly, she needs to have control over the individual she chooses. No matter how loyal you are, as Li Qing’s heir, Li Wen is easier to control. Secondly, Li Qing knows you guys too well. Though you look weak and cowardly on the outside, you’re actually strong and kind, and that you’re someone with your own principles and your own brand of justice. She knows that you wouldn’t have left with her even if she asked, and that it would have only led to your impression of her being shattered.

“I believe that’s what Li Qing didn’t want to see. She would wish for you to look up to her. Li Wen is different though. You look up to Li Qing because you agree with her sense of justice. Li Wen looks up to her just because it’s Li Qing, and it didn’t matter if she was good or evil.

“Worldly affairs are just so complex and confusing. This can be interpreted both ways. One is that you were the one Li Qing loved the most, and she’d rather you think she was dead rather than have her image ruined in your eyes. But it can also be interpreted that Li Wen was the one Li Qing loved the most as she’s willing to reveal the truth to Li Wen and to face possible death with her. Both sound plausible... Relationships, of all kinds, are just so complex.

“But complex emotions like these are what make people human. This is why humans are different from animals.”

I felt a little upset. “Yes. Though I feel upset, Li Wen must be feeling horrid. It’s no wonder Li Wen was always so two-faced. Sometimes, she’d act like her old self, but she’d also turn weird at times. She must have thought that Li Qing favored me the most. She must be wondering why she isn’t getting

anything in return after doing so much for Li Qing without complaints. If I were in her shoes, I don't think I can be optimistic."

"You're right. Li Wen is in pain. I also believe that she still values her friendship with you, just like how it was with You Ji. It's because of this that her hatred towards you is greater. But the more she hates you and the more she gets jealous of you, the more pain she'd be putting herself in. Li Wen didn't think about what I just told you, that although Li Qing didn't want to hurt you and show you her dark side, she was willing to show it to Li Wen. Li Wen had never looked at it that way."

I sighed. "Yes. But now that you've told me all this, I'm also upset. I'm also jealous. But I know that nobody is at fault here, because I might have done the same thing if I were Li Qing. Who's to blame for everything then?"

"This is the problem with you people. I'd always be thinking about things like these when I used to be a human too. But do you know that there's no need to put the blame on any party for these things? There's no need to be too hung up on where it went wrong. Right and wrong would always be relative, and there's no one and nothing which can be totally right. Trust me. If you're able to let go of things like these, you'd be able to forgive yourself."

Forgive myself?

"No one else but you can forgive yourself, Ah Shen. You're just not willing to. You understand everything, but you refuse to admit it because you don't want to save yourself. I can see it in your entire being that you're able to see through everything. You're just avoiding it."

I didn't know what to say. "Everyone can preach though..."

"Hmm... Yes. The ones directly involved are always unaware of the real situation when by-standers are able to see it clear as day..."

"Li Qing really loves you. Scorpion Ray is something extremely important to her, but she gave it to you. I just don't know why she gave you only half of it."

“Oh, Huai Du has been eyeing Scorpion Ray. Would the other half be with him?”

“That’s possible. I don’t know any more than you do regarding the situation between Huai Du and Li Qing. I only learnt about it when you did. It’s really quite a secret.

“If you really want to investigate Huai Du, you might have to return to the Gate of Ghost and possibly to the demon cave.”

“Li Qing told me to leave the Gate of Ghost as soon as possible when I met her there. She said I’d be in danger in the Gate of Ghost. I have no idea what she meant.”

“Well, there might be more individuals out there who’ve been eyeing your second personality. This is why I’m telling you to forgive yourself, so that you and your second personality can combine into one sooner rather than later.”

At this, I interrupted her. “No, the second personality is not me. This isn’t what I wish for. I’m not able to combine into one with her.”

Piercer looked at me. “Why do this to yourself? You know that she is you, and that you are her...”

“It’s getting late,” I said softly.

Seeing my disinterest, Piercer did not push further. “It is. You should be getting back now. In the following month, you just have to call my name if anything happens. Remember our talk and remember our promise. I’ll be able to lend you more power that way.”

“Okay.”

Chapter 272: 272 I'm Going to Leave You

Volume 5

272 I'm Going to Leave You

My consciousness felt as if it was floating away, and before I knew it, I was already back outside standing in front of Nie Zun.

Nie Zun looked calm as usual, as if nothing had happened. "Where did you go?" He asked as soon as I steadied myself.

"Do you actually care?"

"I just want to know where a living weapon would take you."

"Inside Piercer."

"What defence techniques did it teach you?"

"None."

"Then what are you going to do in future?"

"Nothing. You're around, aren't you?" I answered as calmly as I could.

Nie Zun was no ordinary individual and he wasn't fazed by my thick-skinned response at all. "I wouldn't be protecting you like I did in the past."

Look at him being ruthless.

I took a deep breath and slapped myself gently on the cheeks.

Nie Zun seemed surprised by my actions.

Relaxing myself, I put a smile back on my face as I looked at him. “Nie Zun, listen to me properly from now on.

“I don’t know why you’re acting this way, but the truth is that I’ve decided to stay by your side no matter what your reasons are. Even if you don’t love me anymore, I’m going to stubbornly continue loving you. Love doesn’t have anything to do with anyone else. We’re all people living in our own little worlds.

“The situation, however, is different now.”

Nie Zun’s eyes seemed to darken as I spoke. His pupils looked like a black night before the arrival of a thunderstorm. I stopped a little in my tracks as I looked at him, but I continued eventually.

“Let me tell you a story, Nie Zun. I suddenly want to tell a story. It’s my favorite one.” A wave of exhaustion suddenly hit me and my voice sounded hoarse and tired.

Nie Zun regarded me and said, “Go ahead.”

I spoke slowly.

“There once was a young, pretty lady from a respectable family who was very talented. Though many matchmakers appeared at her door, she did not want to marry because she was waiting for the day when her beloved would appear.

“A young man caught her eye one day when she was at a crowded festival and she immediately knew he was the one she had been waiting for all this time. However, it was too crowded and no matter how hard she tried to approach him, she couldn’t get any closer.

“After that, she began to search high and low for this young man, but he seemed to have simply disappeared from the face of the earth, never to

reappear again. She then prayed to Buddha every day, hoping to see the young man again. Buddha was moved by her sincerity and finally appeared before her one day.

“Buddha asked, ‘Do you wish to see that man again?’

‘Yes, even if it’s just one look!’

‘What if you need to give up everything that you have, including your loving family and your happy life?’

‘I’m willing to give that up.’ The girl was resolute.

‘You need to train for 500 years before you can have one look. Are you sure you won’t regret it?’

‘I won’t regret it.’ Nothing could change the girl’s mind.

“The girl then turned into a huge rock who lay by the countryside. She weathered 499 years and though she could endure this, she hadn’t seen a single person in all this time. Without any slither of hope, she began to lose faith. In the last year, a quarrying team came along and decided to refine her into a cut stone. She was then imported into the city, where a stone bridge was being built.

“The girl ended up being a part of the rail on the side of the bridge, and on the first day the bridge was completed, she finally saw the man she had waited 500 years for! He looked like he was in a hurry and he passed the bridge very quickly, so of course he wouldn’t realize that a stone was actually staring at him. The man then disappeared once again.

“Buddha then reappeared.

‘No! Why am I part of the rail on this bridge? If I was put in the middle of the bridge, I would’ve been able to touch him at least once!’

‘You want to touch him? Then you’ll have to train for another 500 years!’

‘It’s very difficult. You’re not going to regret it?’

“This time, the girl turned into a huge tree by the side of a busy road. Many people passed by her every day, but this made her more upset because she would always end up disappointed. If it weren’t for her experience in the previous 500 years of training, she would probably have gone mad by now! Days passed, and the girl calmed her heart as she knew that he would not appear until the very last day.

“It had been 500 years, and the girl knew he would appear, but she was calm instead of excited now. He was finally here! He was wearing her favorite robes of white, and his face was still as beautiful as before. The girl gazed at him lovingly. This time, he didn’t leave in a hurry since it was too hot. He went over to a huge tree by the side of the road to take a breather. Leaning against the tree trunk, he closed his eyes and fell asleep.

“The girl was finally able to touch him, and he was lying right beside her! But she couldn’t tell him about how she had been thinking about him for a thousand years. All she could do as a tree was to give him the best shade from the sun. The man took a short nap before going on his way. He got up and dusted his white robes. Before leaving, he turned back to look at the tree and touched it lightly. He then turned and left, never looking back.

“Buddha reappeared when the man left. ‘Do you want to be his wife? If so, you’ll have to train again.’

“The girl interrupted Buddha calmly. ‘I want to, but there’s no need for that.

‘This is good enough. Loving him does not mean that I have to become his wife.

‘Did his current wife go through all this pain like I did?’ The girl wondered.

“Buddha nodded slightly.

“The girl smiled. ‘I can do that too, but I don’t think there’s a need to.’

“The girl then realized that Buddha seemed to sigh. She asked, ‘Buddha, is there something on your mind?’

‘That’s good. There’s a boy who can wait a thousand years less. To get one look at you, he had already trained for 2,000 years.’ Buddha answered her with a huge smile.

“That’s the end of the story.” I smiled, looking at Nie Zun.

Nie Zun was silent for a moment before he said, “Continue. The moral of the story should be at the end of it, right?”

I looked at him gently. Tamping down the bitterness in my heart, I finally asked, “Many people are aware of how this story goes. You know it too, right?”

Nie Zun hesitated for a while before nodding eventually.

“If I could add an epilogue to the story, it would be that the girl was so moved by what Buddha told her that she decided to be with the boy who had waited 2,000 years for her. However, the boy who waited 2,000 years for her said he was tired of it, and it’s also at this point that Buddha tells the girl that the man she had been waiting for all this time had known how she had waited for him. It’s just that he didn’t think he was able to give her happiness, but he had actually been aware of her all this while. What do you think she’d do at such a juncture?”

Though this was convoluted, Nie Zun would definitely be able to get it.

His eyes darkened further.

“What are you trying to say?” He sounded slightly emotional when he asked the question.

My gaze was gentle. “I love you. It’s the same today as it was yesterday, it’s the same as it was from the day before, and it’s the same as it was when you loved me. But Nie Zun, I’m no longer able to love you in the future, because I owe somebody. I have to return to that individual’s side. You said you were tired of our relationship, and yes, you should be tired now. I changed the life that you could have had. You’re innocent. Everything is my fault.

“Now, when the time to correct all this has come, the only thing to be happy about is that you’ve already left me when I have to leave you. Because then you wouldn’t have to feel upset about it.”

I’ve practiced this a million times in my head, and I thought I wouldn’t cry when I said it.

I still cried in the end, but I tried to cry silently.

I looked at him with a tearful gaze and smiled faintly. This did not seem like something I would do at all.

Even though my vision was obscured by all the tears, I could see his gaze turned dark.

“Nie Zun, if this was what you wanted, I’ll give it to you now.

“Nie Zun, Gaoqin Jiuye had been waiting for me for way too long. I’ve let Gao Qi down, I’ve let him down, and I’ve even forgotten about him. I even told him that I loved you. There’s no way I can erase these sins in my next lives. I’m going to go and return the favor now. I’ll also be returning you your freedom.”

My face was drenched in tears.

Nie Zun’s eyes looked like the surface of a still lake. After a moment, they seemed to light up like fiery torches as they shone and burnt brightly.

My vision cleared up as the last of my tears escaped me and his profile and face appeared slowly before me. His eyes were extremely bright and they were shining with a dangerous light.

He appeared right in front of me in the next second, those wispy bangs falling onto my forehead. Grabbing my neck and my arm with each hand, he spoke in a suppressed, low-pitched voice. “What did you say? You’re going to him? My ears aren’t fooling me are they, Li Shen? Didn’t you love me? Didn’t you say that you’ll love me forever? What now, you’re turning your back on your promise?”

His hands made my neck hurt as he strangled me. Seeing me refuse to look at him, he turned my chin forcefully towards him.

“Say it, Li Shen. Tell me why you’re going back to him. What, you’re not satisfied even after sleeping with me?” I could hear the suppressed rage in Nie Zun’s voice. His eyes looked frantic even as they shone.

I looked at him with a bitter smile. “What are you doing, Nie Zun? Aren’t you tired? Didn’t you leave me? You don’t love me anymore, so why do you care? It doesn’t have anything to do with you whoever I’m with and whoever I’m in love with!”

“You...!” Nie Zun looked at me with gritted teeth. I felt as if the bones in my chin were going to be crushed.

Chapter 273: 273 Bait

Volume 5

273 Bait

Initially, I was just a little upset, but that fire in me lit up when Nie Zun flew into a rage. I turned away from him forcefully and swung his hand away.

The magnitude of my actions had to be great as since it was difficult to escape without MF. My hair was in a huge mess, but I had no time to care about that as I spoke.

“You have no right to be angry. Why are you angry? You don’t love me anymore. Weren’t you going to leave me...?”

Nie Zun looked at me with eyes full of sorrow, but a look of contempt emerged soon after. “So? So this is the reason you’re having a change of heart? Is there any value to your love? You’re going into someone else’s arms after I just let go? Aren’t you something, Li Shen.”

“Yes, I am. Don’t you know that? Are you regretting it? Are you regretting that you used to love me? Haha, Nie Zun, I’m just like this. Not happy about it? You hate it? Don’t forget you used to be in love with me too.”

Tears began rolling down my cheeks again.

Nie Zun’s gaze darkened as he saw my tears. “Are you going back to him because you’re returning a favor, or is it because you’ve finally remembered that it was him you were in love with and you recalled that feeling from the past?”

I shook my head. “That’s not important. I just have to return to him. You don’t want me anymore anyway...”

“This is very important,” he growled. His eyes looked like those belonging to an abandoned child.

I looked at him sadly as I said, “You still love me, don’t you? You were lying when you said you were going to leave me, weren’t you? You wouldn’t care about this if you didn’t love me anymore. Tell me, Nie Zun. You still love me, don’t you?”

What I said rendered Nie Zun motionless.

His eyes immediately deadened as if he was reminded of something else.

I was worried and wondering if something had happened. *Did I say something wrong?*

He continued in a low voice, “Go ahead then, if you’ve already decided to go to him.”

Something in my heart shattered into a million pieces.

I forced myself to smile as I said, “Okay. We can’t be more than 500 meters away from each other again, so I’ll be bothering you like this for a while. Sorry about that. Don’t worry though. I’ll reactivate my split symbol when my MF recovers after a month, and you’ll be able to leave. Let’s just tolerate each other for now.”

Nie Zun remained silent.

Just like this, the atmosphere turned cold.

The door to the hall creaked open just as I was thinking about ways to start another conversation.

Nie Zun hid behind a pillar as soon as the door opened. In order not to affect his movements, I moved nearer to the pillar as well, keeping him within 500 meters of myself.

Du Yue, Si Luo and Jiao S entered. The ice phoenix was not with them.

Du Yue's boots clicked against the floor as she walked towards me. "It's been a while now. Are you done?"

Looking at her, I suddenly felt that she was sad and pitiful.

I regarded her with sadness in my eyes.

She probably didn't understand why I looked at her that way, and she looked me up and down with suspicion.

I smirked. "Let's just go straight to the point. Don't you want Si Luo and I to help you go against Huai Du? What are your plans?"

Du Yue frowned at this surprisingly positive attitude of mine. "What's gotten into you? Something went wrong while you were trying to conquer the weapon?"

I shrugged. "It's nothing actually. I just deactivated my split symbol accidentally."

"What..." Du Yue and Jiao S were shocked.

I spoke calmly. "You heard right. I've deactivated my split symbol and I have zero MF right now. Such a condition would last for at least a month."

With gritted teeth, Du Yue said, "I want you to help me, but now you've deactivated your split symbol and turned yourself into someone absolutely useless. Are you trying to go against me on purpose?"

Seeing Du Yue upset, Jiao S moved between us to shield me. However, I didn't mind this at all. "No need to get so agitated, Du Yue. You can tell me about your plans if you want my help to go against Huai Du, and we'll see if I can still be of assistance even without MF. You can get angry after that."

Du Yue shot me a cold look as she suppressed her rage. "Bian Ying is in a coma and Cang Ming sees me as his archenemy. Cang Ming is working for

Huai Du, so I expect that he'd arrive in the Gate of Heaven soon. I want you to help me take care of Cang Ming."

Si Luo spoke this time. "Cang Ming is the only one in the Split Zone who has immense power even without establishing a split symbol contract. Moreover, he has a split symbol now. Though his split symbol and that of Bian Ying and your Ta Lai form a three-way split symbol, this does not reduce his power at all. How do you expect us to go against him?"

Du Yue smirked. "That's enough, Si Luo. Yes, you're right. In terms of ability and power, Cang Ming is a rare exception in the Split Zone. But Si Luo, you're no ordinary individual either, are you? No one is as good as you are in the intricate manipulation of MF. I don't have confidence in any others, but with you and Li Shen, I don't think anyone else can escape from you guys."

"But soul splitters don't die. What do you want me and Si Luo to do?" I asked.

Du Yue shot a frosty look at me. "It's simple. You just have to put a seal on his split symbol during your battle. Because of the connection with Bian Ying, his split symbol has become one of his greatest weaknesses. I don't know where his symbol is though. I don't care how you do it, you can lie to him or use any other method, I just need you to approach him when he arrives in the Gate of Heaven and find out where his split symbol is. Then, you just have to put a seal onto it. Leave the rest of it to me after that."

"Why do we have to do it? Why don't you do it yourself?" Si Luo asked while pointing at me.

Du Yue turned to Si Luo. "Firstly, this can be seen as some sort of test to see if the both of you are genuinely going to work with me and how loyal you'd be. Secondly, for anything related to Bian Ying, I don't want Ta Lai to know that I'm behind it. It's that simple."

Si Luo smiled beautifully. "There's more. I think you aren't being totally honest here."

Du Yue smirked. “It’s up to you whether you believe it or not. This is my request and it depends on the both of you whether you’re willing to complete it.”

I looked at Si Luo as I said, “I’m fine with it.”

“If you’re fine with it, I’m okay with it too,” Si Luo said.

He then addressed Du Yue, “We’ll do what you asked us to. I just hope you keep your word.”

Du Yue smirked again. “Though I’m no saint in your eyes, I’ll definitely keep my word. But I’ll have to trouble the both of you for a bit, just to lessen Cang Ming’s suspicion. I’ll lock you guys up in the public area in the Gate of Heaven. He’d think that we were standing on opposing sides in that case. I know Cang Ming well. An enemy of his enemy will be his friend. He’ll definitely help you guys out when he arrives here.”

“What do you mean by locking us up in the public area in the Gate of Heaven?”

“There’s a central plaza in the Gate of Heaven with a square iron cage that measures ten by ten meters. It’s a public location specially used to punish bad people and traitors. I’m going to imprison you guys there for a few days. What do you think?”

Si Luo yawned lazily. “To enjoy the sun? Sounds pretty good.”

My face twitched. *I don’t think that would be comfortable. Wasn’t this just like public shaming?*

I asked suddenly, “Do we need to strip?”

Everyone was visibly stunned at my question.

Du Yue frowned. “Are all heirs retarded like you?”

I shrugged. “It’s up to you. But I have zero MF now. I wouldn’t die if I stay under the sun like that for a few days right?”

Du Yue looked at me icily. “It’s better if you end up dead.”

I was about to respond when I was suddenly reminded of Nie Zun.

Du Yue was looking for Nie Zun, and I couldn’t let it slip that he was right here in the Palace of Cold Blood right now. *But if I had to be in the cage, wouldn’t he be exposed since we couldn’t be more than 500 meters apart?*

What to do, what to do? What should I do?

While I was swimming in my own anxiety, Si Luo spoke suddenly. “We can do that, but I’d like to bring somebody else along.”

“Who?” Du Yue asked.

“Guan Nie,” Si Luo answered.

Du Yue raised a brow. “Guan Nie? Is he in the Gate of Heaven now? Why am I not aware of this.”

Si Luo continued lazily. “There are many things you aren’t aware of. If you’re okay with that, then you can lock the three of us up right in the middle of that plaza. What do you think? Your attacking prowess would just increase with Guan Nie around.”

Du Yue nodded. “That’s not a problem. It’s just that, where is he now?”

Even Jiao S looked at Si Luo with suspicion when Guan Nie was mentioned. *How did Si Luo know where Guan Nie was when Jiao S didn’t? Si Luo and Guan Nie are probably not good friends, are they? Didn’t Guan Nie hate Si Luo’s guts because of Gaoqin Jiuye?*

Si Luo said, “I can’t tell you where he is. You just have to wait for us at the plaza. We’ll be there.”

Du Yue regarded all of us with suspicion.

Si Luo smiled. “You should place your complete trust in me if you’re going to work with me. You know me, Du Yue.”

Du Yue finally nodded upon hearing this. “Fine. Be quick about it. I believe you already know the way to the central plaza, since you should be familiar with the Gate of Heaven.”

There was a hint of sarcasm when she spoke, but Si Luo didn’t seem to mind as he continued smiling. “Go on ahead. We’ll be there soon.”

Chapter 274: 274 On the Way to Central Plaza

Volume 5

274 On the Way to Central Plaza

I got a little nervous when Si Luo turned to me after Du Yue left, as he seemed to have taken a glance at the pillar hiding Nie Zun.

Si Luo spoke gently, “Come on out.”

I froze immediately.

Jiao S seemed rather stunned at this, but I knew there would be no use in trying to explain things at this point.

Nie Zun’s footsteps were so light that I didn’t even realize he was already standing beside me.

Nie Zun regarded Si Luo calmly. “As expected of Si Luo.”

Si Luo smiled politely at this.

“I’m just curious. Though we aren’t able to hear anything from inside the hall when we were outside, how could we not have sensed it if somebody entered? It’s difficult for Du Yue to find you in here, but it’s almost impossible to slip past the both of us and enter. How did you do it, Nie Zun?”

Jiao S asked in her hoarse voice, “Is it a spatial transference technique too?”

Si Luo shook his head. “It’s difficult to accomplish real spatial transference without using that red pill I gave you. The principle behind how Du Yue teleports individuals over is similar to how you and Gaoqin Jiuye control air currents. These are done via manipulating the density of the air and affecting what others see. It isn’t really teleportation. This is why I don’t believe that Nie Zun used spatial transference.”

Nie Zun smiled. “Of course it isn’t.”

Si Luo took a casual glance at me as he asked, “Is it something to do with you deactivating your split symbol?”

I was a little hesitant in telling the truth. *Can I really tell them about this?*

I trust Si Luo, and I definitely trust Jiao S. But is this the right time to reveal it to them?

But there isn’t any reason for me to keep it from them either, is there? With Si Luo’s intelligence, it would probably be hard to keep it from him if I lied about it too.

I looked at Nie Zun. He didn’t seem to have any intention of stopping me, so I told the truth. “Because I deactivated my split symbol, the restriction that we can’t be more than 500 meters away from each other has reappeared again. It’s probably because of this that he ended up in here.”

A light flashed in Si Luo’s eyes as he seemed to recall something.

“You said Guan Nie would come. Why weren’t I aware of that? Where is he?” Jiao S asked suddenly.

Remaining silent, Si Luo smiled and walked over to Nie Zun.

He lifted a slender arm and waved it in front of Nie Zun.

Something amazing happened at that very moment.

Nie Zun had transformed into Guan Nie.

He had a head of white hair, upturned eyes and a coquettish smile, and he was dressed in white from head to toe.

“A disguise?”

Jiao S shook her head in disagreement. “I don’t think so. This should be one of the methods used to control air currents.”

Si Luo nodded. “That’s right, it’s a method used in controlling air currents. It’s slightly different from the method I taught you. It can bend light to create a mirage.”

“How are you going to maintain it?”

“It’s easy. I just need to focus a part of my MF on him and he’ll look like this as long as I’m alive.”

Nie Zun gave a grateful smile, but it was rather weird to look at him like this. Guan Nie has a coquettish expression on his face while Nie Zun always had an indifferent look. Right now, these expressions mixed and it seemed rather awkward.

Jiao S spoke before I could. “Since you’re using Guan Nie’s face, you should be acting like him. Don’t make it too awkward and unnatural.”

Si Luo turned to me. “We’ll be at the Central Plaza for more than a couple of days, so we have to make sure we don’t let anything slip.”

Jiao S interrupted Si Luo and asked, “If Cang Ming arrives in the Gate of Heaven and tries to save us, are we really going to attack him like how Du Yue wants us to?”

Si Luo continued calmly, “We’ll play it by ear. Nobody knows what’s going to happen. I’ll let you guys know what to do when Cang Ming gets here.”

Si Luo turned back to me. “Li Shen, you didn’t forget our promise, right?”

At this, both Jiao S and Nie Zun looked at me with suspicion. I took a deep breath before answering. “I didn’t forget. I hope you didn’t too.”

“Good. Let’s work together then, until the both of us achieve our goals.”

“Okay.”

Jiao S looked rather surprised upon learning that I had some sort of agreement with Si Luo that she wasn’t aware of. I looked at her, but I knew I couldn’t say anything about this.

“Let’s go and parade ourselves as prisoners then.” Si Luo laughed.

While leaving the palace hall, I turned back to look at the silk gauze curtain. I had a feeling that I would be coming back here someday.

Apart from Du Yue, those two ladies were also waiting for us outside when we exited.

Du Yue was visibly shocked when she saw Guan Nie. “How did he get in?” She was as confident in herself as Si Luo was in her abilities.

Si Luo said, “He might not be able to slip past you alone, but you’re no match with me around.” *What a convenient and absolute lie...*

Du Yue turned grim. “I guess your abilities have been maintained Si Luo, even after such a long time.”

Si Luo smiled at her. “If it has merely been maintained, I would be no match for you as someone who works on improving all the time, wouldn’t I?”

Du Yue’s face darkened at this. Though the two ladies did not seem happy about the exchange, they did not say a single word. They were probably wary since they were on the less populous team.

Du Yue then smiled all of a sudden. “Fine. I should be honored that so many individuals with high abilities are working for me now. I guess there’s no need for me to be too polite here since we’ve already agreed on the conditions.”

Si Luo stretched out a hand as he signaled for Du Yue to go on ahead. Du Yue's cold gaze swept past us before she turned and led the way, probably heading for the Central Plaza immediately.

As we walked, Jiao S pulled on my sleeve gently. I understood her immediately and the both of us fell back and kept a small distance from the rest who were in front.

"You have tons of questions for me, don't you?" I looked at Jiao S as I asked apologetically.

We had been apart for quite some time now, and so much had happened during this time that we were no longer up to date with each other's lives.

"I've guessed most of it, but there are still things I'd like to ask you."

"Go on."

Jiao S looked a little worried. "What's going on between you and Nie Zun?"

I knew this would be her first question, but I haven't thought about how I would answer it.

After a moment, I decided to speak truthfully. "It's complicated actually. So, the king of the Gate of Ghost, Ghost King Huai Du was trying to make use of Nie Zun to cultivate a demon. In the process, Nie Zun lost his memories and forgot about me, and though he recalled those memories eventually, his attitude towards me had totally changed. I don't know why either, but I'd rather choose to believe that he has his reasons for doing so. You should understand how I feel though. I don't feel great about it at all."

Jiao S sighed. "I felt something off about the two of you earlier. I guess things are really complicated."

"Oh right, I have to tell you something. I saw Li Qing in the Gate of Ghost." I spoke extremely softly and made sure no one else in front of us would be able to listen in.

Jiao S was understandably shocked and I could see the emotion in her eyes. “How could that be...”

I knew too well how she felt. What I was going to say next would make her even more upset, just like how I felt when I first learnt about it. But I had to tell her, and I had to tell her soon.

If I didn’t talk about this with Jiao S and if I didn’t share this secret with her, I simply wouldn’t know what to do with myself and all this information.

“Apart from that, Li Qing is also a soul splitter. She isn’t an heir.”

“What...!” Her pitch was extremely high, probably because she was too shocked upon hearing what I just said.

Everyone turned back to look at us.

I grabbed her arm hard, and she tried to tamp down her emotions as she shot a cold look towards the party in front. Speaking in an almost inaudible volume, she said, “I’ll not ask about the details since there isn’t much time now. I have no reason to doubt you either, but are you sure that information is reliable?”

I nodded profusely. “It’s definitely reliable. If you think about it, this is the only way it makes sense, right? Li Qing is so kind, and she had no choice but to leave us because of her identity. She has her reasons for doing so.”

Jiao S was rational as always, and her mind was working to connect all the dots. She then nodded. “If this is true, then I’m willing to believe that she had her reasons for doing so.”

“What we have to do now is to uncover everything. Things that seem illogical and unexplainable would come to light eventually.”

“Hmm, I guess there’s no better solution anyway. We’ll work on this together.”

I flashed a resolute smile at her. “A burden seems to have finally been lifted off my shoulders now that you’re here. The truth will definitely be made known someday.”

“Yes, don’t worry about it. I understand everything.” Jiao S’s lips broke into that emotionless smile of hers.

Chapter 275: 275 A Cage for Humans

Volume 5

275 A Cage for Humans

“But Ah Shen, what I’m most interested in knowing is whether you blamed her or not after you learnt about all that.”

Jiao S’s question got me in a bind. Instead of thinking about my answer, I realized I actually had to think about how I could even go about answering her.

Shouldn’t it have been a straightforward ‘no’? Why did I hesitate? Did I really blame Li Qing?

I knew that I wouldn’t be here today if it wasn’t for Li Qing. Whether it was the courage she had given me to continue living, whether it was Scorpion Ray, or whether it was a heart that took responsibility for others and believed in love, these are things I couldn’t live without.

Did I even have the right to blame her for anything? But could I really confidently say that I didn’t blame her at all?

I didn’t know why I hesitated, and if I really did blame her, I didn’t know why I did. I felt helpless.

I looked at Nie Zun. Even though he looked like Guan Nie now, his figure from the back still looked lonely like before.

A sorrow began to fill my heart.

Jiao S held my hand gently as she sensed my emotions. Her hoarse voice turned gentle as she said, “I get it. There’s no need for you to answer.”

I forced myself to put on a smile.

Upon arriving at the Central Plaza, I realized that some places in the Split Zone were extremely similar to the places that existed in the real world. This plaza could have belonged right smack in the middle of the human world, except that this place did not have middle-aged ladies dancing to loud music in the center.

The only other difference was that there was a huge iron cage in the middle of the plaza.

It was just a simple iron cage placed right in the middle of the plaza and it was so huge it looked like more than a hundred individuals could fit in it. Using it to lock the few of us up made it seem like a waste of resources.

Du Yue gestured for us to continue as she stepped in front of the cage. “This is it. I’d have to trouble the few of you for a few days.”

What’s with this politeness? You’re not merely troubling us, are you?

Nie Zun smirked. “This doesn’t look like a cage for prisoners. This looks like a cage that’s used to exhibit animals.” The corners of my mouth started twitching at his comment. *Wasn’t he just putting himself down like this? Don’t drag me into this, please.*

Du Yue returned the smirk. “What’s the difference between animals and people who’ve lost their freedom?”

Hah, see? She makes it sound as if she captured us. This woman is so full of herself. She was the one asking us for help on this and we are only doing this because we’re working with her now.

Ignoring her, I stepped into the cage without hesitation when it opened. *Let’s see if this cage can really take my freedom away.*

Seeing me step in, Si Luo and the rest followed.

Though the plaza wasn't crowded at this time of the day, some of the passers-by looked over at this seemingly rare sight.

Although those who looked over regarded us with suspicion and surprise, there was no one who seemed to be talking about it.

I believe that was because all of them knew and recognized Du Yue, and they were keeping their distance from her. The fear in their eyes was palpable when some of them glanced past Du Yue.

I guess Du Yue is also notorious in the Gate of Heaven.

Du Yue stood outside the cage after ordering those weird sisters to lock us in. She spoke in a low voice, "According to reliable sources, Cang Ming has already arrived at the border of the Gate of Heaven. I didn't expect him to arrive here so quickly, so there's no time for us to put on a show. Though this plan is put together rather shabbily, he'd be here soon. Just play it by ear and don't forget our common goal."

Common goal? We were working with each other to achieve our own goals, but did we really have a 'common goal' here?

Du Yue seemed anxious as she led the two ladies away after getting them to lock the cage.

Her attitude about this made me suspicious. This cage looked suspicious as well.

"We didn't just walk into a trap, did we?" I looked around as I asked.

Si Luo and Nie Zun were extremely calm. The both of them found a comfortable corner and lay on the floor, propping their head up with a hand, as if it had nothing to do with them even if the world gets blown to bits.

The cage did not look like it belonged in this plaza at all, and this made me feel extremely uncomfortable.

There were currently two males, whose beauty were out of this world, laying somewhere within this huge cage looking relaxed, while two females

were standing right in the middle of the cage. One of them looked emotionless and stood unmoving, while the other was looking around with shifty eyes. *It's no wonder people had to take a second look at us. I knew I would definitely be staring.*

We were outdoors in the daytime, but the air felt suffocating here.

“Are we really going to act like monkeys on exhibit and stay in here until someone passes by or something happens?” I could no longer hold it in.

Si Luo spoke slowly with squinted eyes as he lay on the floor in those flowy white robes. “Isn’t it great here? We have fresh air and just the right amount of sunshine. I miss this. What’s wrong with just enjoying nature?”

I was not the least bit convinced. But apart from that, there seemed to be nothing else we could do either. I looked at Jiao S.

Jiao S was currently looking at Si Luo with a gaze that spoke volumes.

I stared at her, forgetting that I was actually in the midst of trying to formulate a response to Si Luo.

Jiao S’s gaze revealed her emotions. Though I might not be able to feel what Jiao S is feeling exactly, I could tell she was in some sort of dilemma and reluctance when it comes to Si Luo.

I’ve seen this look on Nie Zun before, and I was very sure that if I liked to look at my own reflection, I’d definitely have seen this look on myself multiple times.

It was this look of hers that made me realize I was being self-centered again. I failed to consider the feelings of my friends yet again.

If what I had with Nie Zun was love, then it could happen between others too.

If I could be frustrated with Nie Zun, does it mean that Jiao S would be carefree all the time?

We were all responsible for our own feelings. She was able to empathize and provide me with some sort of comfort, but I haven't even considered her feelings.

I did the same thing she did before.

I walked over and took her hand in mine gently. The pain in her eyes wavered slightly when I touched her hand, and a glint of appreciation flashed past her eyes when she looked at me.

This was the first time I felt that I was actually useful. I liked being silent too much and I had remained silent for too long.

I said to Jiao S, "Sorry. I've left you all alone in this time. I'm not planning to ask what you've been through, and there's no need for you to tell me about it either. You don't have to apologize, let me do it instead. I'll feel uncomfortable if I don't."

I pointed at where my heart should be as I said this.

Jiao S put on her serious face as she said, "I'm not planning to reject your apology. Shouldn't I be gracious about it if someone apologizes to me?"

She made me laugh just like this. I then happened to glance at Nie Zun.

Nie Zun was lying beside Si Luo with those coquettish eyes belonging to Guan Nie. But that cold gaze definitely belonged to Nie Zun.

This was the man I loved. No matter how he looked like and what he became, there was no way to hide that solitude buried so deeply in that gaze.

Nothing could bring him out of that solitude.

I spoke to Jiao S while looking at Nie Zun. "Look, aren't they quite similar?"

Jiao S followed my gaze to the two of them who were on the floor. "This is getting more and more interesting. So many things have happened in a year.

If we could turn back time, I don't think any of us would be able to predict this happening. Does this mean that there's no way we can predict what might happen in the coming year too? I'm kind of scared of this feeling of uncertainty when I think about how unpredictable the future is. Look at how we are now compared to how we were in the past."

I smiled. "We don't even know if we'd be alive in the coming year. But it's because things are getting worse that we begin to cherish our lives. Humans are funny creatures. We only begin to cherish life when we sense danger around."

Jiao S seemed to be in deep thought following what I said, as if she found my words worth pondering over.

She finally spoke when I was planning to sit on the floor after having stood for a while. "It's never wrong to cherish life. But how about cherishing feelings? If we can cherish our feelings just like how we cherish our lives, wouldn't many things turn out to be different?"

I gave her a bitter smile. "Feelings are fickle, and even if we cherish it, we might not get an equal amount of reciprocation. It might even drag people down in certain situations, especially now that we're no longer in our world.

"We shouldn't forget this, that we're the weirdos in this world. We're the ones who're thinking about how to escape this place. We're not soul splitters who originally reside here."

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276 Cang Ming's Pursuit

“Yes. I’m happy to hear that you think we should be thinking of a way to leave too. Does this mean that you’ve finally decided to go back?”

“I don’t know, actually.” I shook my head.

“But didn’t you say that your goal was to leave together with Si Luo?” I glanced at Si Luo before turning back to Jiao S.

Jiao S’s eyes seemed to darken slightly. “If I’m not able to change the natural law of things, if I’m fated to leave him someday, then I’ll not force it. I’ve realized that Si Luo loves this place. It has nothing to do with love, it’s just that he has been here for way too long.”

“How long are you two planning to chat for?” Nie Zun shot the question at me with that indifferent tone of his.

I shut my mouth immediately. Nie Zun wasn’t someone who would spout nonsense in public areas like these. If he did that, it meant he wanted me to stop talking, and he would definitely have his reasons for doing so.

Seeing me silent, Jiao S kept quiet too.

A gust of wind blew from out of nowhere. Though I wasn’t very good in sensing air currents, I knew if danger was looming. There was an invisible pressure that seemed to be closing in on us.

I wanted to ask ‘Is Cang Ming here?’ to break this eerie silence, but I just could not do so.

My mind was in a complete mess as it wondered what to do next if it really was Cang Ming, and I didn’t even realize it was him until a blood-red robe appeared in front of me.

I flinched slightly when I heard Cang Ming call out from somewhere outside the cage.

As I turned back to look, I was met with Cang Ming’s wild face. His dark hair seemed messier than before, but he still had that powerful aura around him. He had this expression which looked like he was angry but smiling at the same time. It looked saddening but beautiful.

I was wondering if I should ask how he had been doing, but red-robed Cang Ming did not have much patience this time. He spoke at me, “You, come over.”

I was actually about to go over when Jiao S stopped me.

Those slightly upturned eyes of his looked even more devious as he raised a brow. He looked like someone who should never be offended.

“What’s this game you’re playing at?” Cang Ming asked as he looked at the huge cage.

Game? It’s a game where we act as bait to lure you over.

This time, he finally spotted the two individuals lying in the corner.

He spotted Nie Zun first and he didn’t even bother looking at Si Luo because his eyes ended up being glued to Nie Zun. He stared at Nie Zun for a good ten seconds or so, and he continued staring even when Nie Zun stood up.

I was slightly nervous, but I didn’t know why I felt nervous.

Though Nie Zun had Guan Nie's face, he still looked demonic. "Do I need to go over so you can have a better look?" He then began walking towards Cang Ming.

Cang Ming was still standing outside the cage. *I wonder if this cage is nothing but scrap metal to him.*

Cang Ming laughed out loud. "Who's the one behind this? The technique is not bad and it might fool others, but since I've helped the both of you before, it's impossible for this to slip past me."

Si Luo stood up at this.

"I did it," he answered with a smile.

Cang Ming looked slightly surprised as he turned to Si Luo.

I would never have imagined Cang Ming being surprised about anything.

Cang Ming asked, "You've been revived? You were half-dead the last time I saw you. I couldn't even talk to you since you were in such a deep sleep in that coma of yours. What now? You've finally realized that your body is the best tool for a revolution?"

Si Luo blinked mischievously. "How rare it is for the godly Cang Ming to remember me and recognize me."

Cang Ming laughed again. "When have you become so dishonest, Si Luo? Is there anyone who doesn't know Si Luo's name in the Split Zone? Let's not talk about those from the Gate of Ghost, even those from the Gate of Exit would probably know that a person named Si Luo exists. How can I not know you then? Furthermore, I'm rather familiar with Gaoqin Jiuye as well."

For some reason, I felt relieved as I heard this exchange. This meant that the both of them might have some sort of a good impression of each other. If that was the case, Si Luo would definitely have us stand on Cang Ming's side. Even though my gut told me that Cang Ming was extremely

dangerous, I stubbornly believed that it was a better choice to work with Cang Ming than to go against him.

I couldn't tell what Si Luo could be planning with that friendly exchange as he continued. "I don't know about you and Gaoqin Jiuye, but I know that you're not someone who does things on a whim. You're appearing here alone in the Gate of Heaven at this juncture. I know you have guts and you don't care, but I wonder if you're really that confident in your abilities or if you have some other pressing reason to do so."

Cang Ming was a cunning opponent. He glanced at all of us and smiled deviously before he answered. "How about you tell me what's going on with the group of you before you ask the questions? Firstly, this grouping is weird. And you've even changed Nie Zun's appearance. Also, you're locked up in this lousy cage right smack in the middle. Even if I was extremely confident in my abilities, I wouldn't dare step into this seeming trap."

Stop pretending. You don't sound the least bit scared. Don't you have nothing but mere guts?

"Also, I'm curious. Where's Gaoqin Jiuye? From what I know about him, he'll be wherever you are. He won't leave you that easily. Judging from the timing, you should've just woken up not too long ago. What is it that could have made Gaoqin Jiuye leave you at this juncture?"

Judging from this targeted question, Cang Ming definitely understood the dynamics between Gaoqin Jiuye and Si Luo well.

Gaoqin Jiuye disappeared after he gave me that slap. I knew why he did that now, and I could understand his anger and frustration. But I didn't know why he didn't come back for Si Luo.

Is there something else I'm not aware of?

Du Yue mentioned that my second personality can save Si Luo since it resonated with his. Was Gaoqin Jiuye looking into this?

I didn't have the luxury of time to think about all the possibilities as Si Luo answered Cang Ming quickly.

"He's only human. There are also times when he throws a tantrum. I don't know where he is now. As for being in this cage, I'm here to wait for you."

Cang Ming laughed again. "You haven't changed, but that frankness is just what I like about you. Go on, who made you do this?"

"Why do you have to ask if you've already guessed it," Si Luo said calmly.

Cang Ming smirked. "I guess Du Yue isn't giving up on Bian Ying anytime soon. Interesting. She's always trying to harass my woman when she can't even look after her own man, and she's eyeing me now?"

"But what's up with this plan of hers? Getting the four of you to wait for me here? This doesn't really make sense." Cang Ming looked extremely relaxed with his folded arms even when what he said sounded rather serious.

Si Luo brushed his silvery-white hair lightly. "If you're going against her, according to her perception of you – that you don't follow the usual rules – it's pretty understandable that she would use such an extreme method."

"What? I don't follow the usual rules? My motive for coming here is clear as day. Does she need to resort to such petty tricks? I'm not even targeting her."

Si Luo raised a brow in response. "Oh, this makes things interesting. What could have made you rush here and cross the border between the Gate of Ghost and the Gate of Heaven if you aren't here for Bian Ying? What are you here for then?"

Cang Ming shrugged. "Yes, it's for my woman, but that doesn't really have much to do with Du Yue, does it? The Gate of Heaven doesn't belong to her. Does she really think that she can take the top spot with her petty tricks?"

“As for the rest of you.” Cang Ming pointed at us as he spoke. “You are nothing but her mercenaries. So, Si Luo, are you planning to go back to being a loyal dog for Feng Zhu in the Gate of Heaven?”

A glint of anger shone in Jiao S’s eyes upon hearing this seemingly rude comment. She cared a lot about Si Luo, and Cang Ming would probably be in her blacklist now that he had said something like this.

However, Si Luo did not mind it at all. “It doesn’t matter who’s the one I’m helping here. If you’re here for Bian Ying, it means you’re targeting Du Yue. I’m quite surprised by this casual and relaxed attitude of yours, in fact.”

Cang Ming frowned slightly. “I’m definitely here for Bian Ying, but who said I was targeting Du Yue?”

Si Luo’s gaze darkened. “What’s the meaning of this?”

Cang Ming laughed emptily as he slowly pointed a finger at me. “She’s my target.”

Chapter 277: 277 One Against Four?

Volume 5

277 One Against Four?

“Oh, you’re targeting me?” I looked at Cang Ming with mock interest as I pointed at myself.

Cang Ming nodded. “That’s right. You’re my target.”

Si Luo did not wish for my conversation with Cang Ming to continue as he spoke quickly, “Why’re you targeting her? Isn’t Du Yue the one responsible for Bian Ying’s condition? Are you just trying your luck here?”

Cang Ming smirked. “I’m not in a rush to take my revenge on Du Yue right now, and I’m the number one doctor in the Split Zone, so I don’t have to try my luck on anything. It’s not difficult to wake Bian Ying, but the challenge here is to cure her completely. I’ve looked for so many methods, but there really isn’t any method to save someone who has an incomplete personality and who had lost half her soul.

“I had originally given up, but I’ve heard something interesting recently. I heard that this woman has a unique identity and she’s a miracle in the Split Zone. I’ve also heard that her second personality has immense power. If I can capture that second personality of hers, together with Huai Du’s demon cultivating technique, I just might be able to cure and save Bian Ying.”

Si Luo raised a brow. “So your main goal is still to save Bian Ying, but you’re eyeing Li Shen for that?”

Cang Ming answered boldly, “What else did you think it was? You really think that someone like Du Yue is worth taking the time to travel to the Gate of Heaven just so I can exact my revenge on her?”

I found this funny. To capture Cang Ming, Du Yue was observing everything from somewhere nearby. *I wonder if she could hear everything.*

The reason Du Yue wanted us to go against Cang Ming was because she feared his power. She also thought that Cang Ming would hate her and turn revengeful towards her because of what happened to Bian Ying. These were actually the reasons behind why she enlisted our help to go against Cang Ming. However, Cang Ming was not targeting Du Yue at all. Would she still have the need to go against Cang Ming in this case?

Impatience got the better of Cang Ming as he pointed at me. His defined muscles could be seen under that blood-red robe as he waved it. “You, get out and follow me. I’ll wreck this whole plaza if you don’t.”

Look at him. It’s no surprise that he would be able to appreciate Gaoqin Jiuye. Both of them were so audacious.

“I guess a fight is inevitable today.” Si Luo looked at Cang Ming.

Cang Ming shrugged, looking fearless about it.

I tried to spot Du Yue, but she was nowhere to be seen. *What’s going on? I should have been able to sense it if Du Yue was nearby, and she was definitely nearby, just not extremely close. Why isn’t she making herself known?*

Can we really get out of this cage if she doesn’t appear?

For some reason, I began worrying about the situation we were in. It felt as if we had walked right into an ambush.

Seeing none of us move, Cang Ming lost his patience and grabbed the bars on the cage. Two iron bars were easily bent with what seemed like a casual pull.

What a convenient way to create doors. Si Luo was the first to step out. All of us followed behind him and everyone was out shortly. I looked back at the cage in wonder.

I didn't understand what was so special about this cage. It looked like a pile of scrap metal at this point. *Why did Du Yue insist on locking us up in here?*

“How about you turn back into yourself? It's awkward looking at you. Are you going to act like that girly man?” Cang Ming pointed at Nie Zun.

Girly man... Was he referring to Guan Nie...?

If I were to be objective about it, Guan Nie's beauty did make him look like a woman, and he spoke effeminately as well, but I was sure he wasn't gay. He was pretty manly during battles.

While my mind was in a world of its own, Si Luo waved a hand in front of Nie Zun and turned him back into himself.

I guess these people have all been doing useless things. Everything was undone so quickly, whether it was this cage or Nie Zun's 'disguise'. It all seemed meaningless to me.

Why is Du Yue still not making herself known? Wasn't she going crazy looking for Nie Zun? Is she really not going to show herself? Was she leaving Cang Ming to us just like this?

Jiao S suddenly spoke. “I think we've been tricked.”

What?

I looked at her questioningly, but she looked emotionless, as usual.

Nie Zun, who looked like himself now, nodded. “It's definitely a trap if we continue going like this.”

Like me, Si Luo looked at the both of them, obviously not understanding the situation.

Nie Zun explained patiently, “If Cang Ming wasn’t targeting Du Yue, that means there was no reason for Du Yue to put on any defense. He wouldn’t be looking for her, and Du Yue would definitely not go looking for trouble on her own. But why would Du Yue do this? She isn’t an idiot who rushes into things. She wouldn’t do anything if she didn’t have some confidence in succeeding.

“If she was telling us that we had to go against Cang Ming, it meant that she had planned everything. Even if Cang Ming wasn’t targeting her, he would end up being on opposite sides with Li Shen because of her unique identity. In this case, Cang Ming would end up fighting Li Shen, and when that happens, Du Yue can sit back and collect all the benefits.”

Though I was slightly confused, I got the gist of it. Du Yue might have already known much earlier that my second personality could possibly save Bian Ying. In fact, she might have been the one who actually spread the news about it.

She hoped that Cang Ming would come looking for me, and she also took the opportunity to form an alliance with me to go against Cang Ming. She’d then end up being the final winner in our battle.

Being as careful as she was, there was no way she would prepare to engage in a huge battle with Cang Ming if she didn’t already take into account that the possibility of Cang Ming looking for her to take revenge was slim.

This meant that Du Yue already knew what my second personality could be used for, and whether or not that was true, this would lead to competition for it.

She also considered how Cang Ming would react to the news. She knew that he would come looking for me, and this was why she gathered all of us here to wait for Cang Ming’s arrival. This would give Cang Ming the impression that there really was something about me and that my second personality was as valuable as the meat of Tripitaka, since the rest were all helping and protecting me when so many others were eyeing my second personality. (T/n: Tripitaka refers to the Buddhist monk who is a central

character in the Chinese novel, *Journey to the West*, where his flesh is rumored to grant immortality to those who ate it.)

By gathering the four of us, we'd look like we were waiting for Cang Ming's arrival. This huge act would then create an impression that there really was something valuable hidden in me.

Jiao S continued after Nie Zun, "If the situation ends up like this, there would be a huge battle ensuing right after, and of course, Du Yue wouldn't be assisting. We're currently in a totally foreign place where it's not advantageous to us at all.

"With Cang Ming's abilities, we'd end up fighting a bitter battle where both sides would end up getting hurt badly. Du Yue would then appear to collect her benefits. Furthermore, this is Du Yue's territory, and who knows how many others are working for her here. At that point, we won't be able to defend ourselves and we'd be simply left to her devices."

Cang Ming could hear everything clearly as the both of them spoke at a normal volume and they did not bother trying to hide these deductions.

However, he smirked at this, not wanting to form any alliance with us. "How troublesome it is looking at you guys analyzing the whole situation. To me, no amount of tricks can change the fact that one isn't strong enough to win others. Whether or not Du Yue is hiding in some corner observing this, I'm telling you that we'll be fighting each other. How about we just be quick about it. If any of us wins, we wouldn't end up being twirled around Du Yue's little finger, would we?"

Anyone who says something like this is definitely retarded. But, of course, there was another possibility where one party had overwhelming power.

He wasn't worried about getting hurt if he engaged in a battle with us. To him, there was no need for brains in a fight. It was just a massacre where he killed one after another, and it did not matter who he killed first.

People like that were usually extremely confident of their own abilities.

Though it sounded extremely audacious, for someone to be able to say something like this when he was going up against four others did create some sort of fear and worry in me.

Furthermore, the four that he would be going against were no easy opponents.

Out of the four, three of us were District Commanders. Si Luo was the strongest out of all of the Eastern, Western and Southern Districts, and Nie Zun had that demonic side in him now. Jiao S and I were no weaklings either.

Oh no, I'm someone with zero MF now. I guess I'm the only weakling among them.

Even so, this spoke volumes about how confident Cang Ming was in his own abilities since he was so sure he'd be able to face Du Yue even after facing us, together with other possible enemies from the Gate of Heaven. *Just how powerful is he?*

Chapter 278: 278 An Invisible Battle

Volume 5

278 An Invisible Battle

“Looks like the only subordinate who can share the world with the Ghost King is rather confident of himself.” Si Luo acknowledged Cang Ming’s confidence, but he wasn’t the least bit afraid.

Cang Ming narrowed his eyes. “We’ve went against each other before, Si Luo. You should know very well if I have the ability.”

Si Luo answered calmly, “Yes. Not including Huai Du and Feng Zhu, I think you and Ta Lai are the only ones whose power I’m not able to gauge fully.”

Why was Ta Lai included in this? Was he that powerful?

I knew Ta Lai was strong, but is he that strong? If that’s the case, does it mean that the two strongest individuals in the Split Zone both liked Bian Ying?

That fragile-looking girl, Bian Ying, does this spell luck or disaster for you?

Cang Ming frowned at Si Luo’s words of praise. “That’s a lot of people not being included. If you’ve even included Ta Lai in that list, then I think it’s really been a long time that we’ve not seen each other. To the point that you don’t even know me that well now.”

Jiao S interrupted him. “Does that audacity stem from real abilities or is that just a show? I guess we’ll only know after we witness it.”

A glint of excitement shone in Cang Ming’s eyes. “I’d love to start the fight.”

A light flashed in his eyes as his blood-red robes fluttered on its own while an unknown pressure filled the entire plaza.

Soul splitters were rather sensitive to looming danger. Those who were initially watching us in the surroundings began to disperse as they sensed that pressure. They are just like humans when it comes to protecting oneself from danger.

“I should actually be thanking you for helping me heal my face. But I’m a little upset in this situation, so I’m afraid I won’t be giving you any chances.” Though Nie Zun’s hair was tousled by the sudden air current sweeping past the plaza, his hands were in his pockets and his gaze was as calm as ever.

I then realized that he had stepped out and he was already face-to-face with Cang Ming.

A dangerous aura seeped out from both figures as they stared at each other.

“I’d tear you apart if you were the kind who gave your opponents chances,” Cang Ming said with overflowing confidence.

Why did they have to speak like this before engaging in battle?

Jiao S stood unmoving, and her eyes seemed empty. I asked quietly, “What do you plan on doing?”

Her neck produced a cracking sound as she turned to me. “Don’t worry. They won’t be fighting,” she said in her low and hoarse voice.

Si Luo waved his hand lightly. It was a casual movement, but he attracted the attention of everyone else.

With that wave, the air around us seemed to change.

It felt as if someone had thrown you a lifesaver when you were about to drown in the water, but when you finally grabbed hold of it, you realized that your lifesaver actually had a hole in it. This description was weird, but it was exactly the feeling Si Luo exuded.

There was a sense of danger about him from the beginning, but you'd think it was nothing after looking at his casual stance, and he'd be coming at you with a killing strike before you even realize it.

He didn't seem to be launching a large-scale attack with that casual wave. When he opened his palm in the air, a transparent bead of water appeared.

From where I stood, that transparent bead of water looked like a clear, beautiful crystal.

But no matter how much it looked like a crystal, it was mere water. I couldn't think of how mere water would be able to do any harm, and I couldn't think of how it could actually be used as a weapon. I didn't understand what he was trying to do.

I wanted to say something like 'Nice trick!', but I decided to shut my mouth after seeing Cang Ming and Nie Zun's faces turn dark.

Both of them were staring at the drop of water in Si Luo's palm very seriously, and they looked like they had lost all will to fight.

I was suspicious of this. *Weren't the both of them exuding immense confidence just seconds ago? What's going on here? Did this water have some magical power that could kill them both in a second?*

I looked at Jiao S. Her usually emotionless eyes were shining as if she saw something that excited her.

I knew her too well. That gaze meant that she had either seen something of immense interest to her, or it was simply a look of appreciation for Si Luo.

I guess something was wrong with that bead of water.

I glanced at all of them before Cang Ming finally broke the silence. “It’s been such a long time. I guess I’ve really been too audacious.”

Nie Zun spoke immediately after. “As expected of someone whom even Mr Blond respects. It’s no surprise that you’re able to protect all of the Southern District for so long.”

Si Luo smiled, but it was not a genuine one. “You think too highly of me. I’ve not been able to take care of them well, and I’ve even caused them to lose their families and their lives.”

What were these people playing at?

I looked at Jiao S with a questioning gaze. She tilted her chin towards that bead of water in Si Luo’s palm.

Knitting my brows, I focused on that transparent bead of water.

Finally, I understood what was going on.

A sense of joy overwhelmed me, but slight fear entered my heart at the same time. *What amazing power...*

Air current control was Si Luo’s preferred technique, and he did it very well. It was also what he taught Jiao S and Gaoqin Jiuye, and this was why the both of them had great power. To Si Luo however, that was only a tiny part of the technique. What he just did was also a manifestation of air current control.

The fact that he was able to grab a bead of water from nothing in the air illustrated two points.

The first was that he was able to make use of air currents and MF to alter the form of things.

Simply put, he can change air into water and water into ice. He could alter the states of things. This proved that his technique was already at a level where he could affect the natural state of things, just like how Feng, Huo and Lei could control the elements. This meant that it was possible for him

to control whatever that had water in others' bodies as well, like blood. One could only imagine the immense power that he had.

Secondly, such an ability proved that he was able to use his MF very well. This proved that he was able to manipulate his MF so intricately that no one was able to match his ability in it.

The two figures opposite him had already lost just by looking at that casual act of grabbing a bead of water from the air.

Though this doesn't mean that Cang Ming would lose in a battle against Si Luo, Si Luo had proved that Cang Ming had definitely underestimated him. To someone who was so confident of his own abilities, the fact that they had underestimated an opponent was already a loss in itself. Their will to battle would waver in such a situation.

Cang Ming was in this exact situation.

What's terrifying was that in Si Luo's current condition, he doesn't have a corresponding heir. Logically speaking, his abilities should be more or less on par with Cang Ming's since he wasn't relying on a split symbol.

"How terrifying..." I mumbled to myself. I didn't know if any of them heard me, but Jiao S definitely heard it.

She smirked as she said with calm confidence, "This is why I told you they won't be fighting."

Jiao S should be happy about this. I would be happy too if the one I liked was powerful like this.

I glanced at Nie Zun subconsciously as I thought about this, but I looked away once I realized what I was doing.

I had to remember that I couldn't love Nie Zun anymore. It had nothing to do with me whether he was living well or not. I should stop bothering with him if I said I wanted to let go.

“I guess the both of you have decided not to fight.” Si Luo said calmly with another casual wave of his hand. That bead of water disappeared without a trace.

Chapter 279: 279 Cang Ming's Challenge

Volume 5

279 Cang Ming's Challenge

Cang Ming and Nie Zun's expressions turned even darker.

Si Luo looked at Cang Ming. "Are you still going to fight?"

Though Cang Ming looked grim, he did not look afraid. "Obviously. I'm here for the woman I love. There's no use in going back if I can't protect her."

His words moved me. I suddenly began to feel envious of Bian Ying.

Si Luo seemed to have anticipated Cang Ming's response as he said, "I'd definitely have a back-up plan prepared. Would you like to hear it?"

No matter what it was, I guess I'd end up being the sacrificial lamb here. This guy was targeting me...

Any normal person would usually listen to Si Luo's suggestion, but the unpredictable Cang Ming said, "How about we exchange blows first, Si Luo?"

Bright lights began gathering in his left palm as he raised a hand. The lights gathered to form a white blade and it entwined around Cang Ming's left wrist where the hilt of the sword should have been.

Attracted by that amazing sword of light, I almost didn't realize it until Cang Ming waved it at me. I pulled Jiao S in an attempt to escape, but when I tried to focus my MF, I recalled that I didn't have any and I was actually no different from an ordinary human being.

Jiao S reacted quickly and she was already pulling me away from the attack, but she was only slightly faster. I heard it swoosh past my right ear as it cut through the air.

A deep gash was left on the ground in its wake.

With that speed and the ability to destroy the stone ground with just a casual wave, Cang Ming was no easy opponent.

Cang Ming rested the sword of light on his shoulder. His muscles and dark skin were partially exposed under that blood-red robe, and he flashed a fearless wide smile at us. There was a dangerous but enchanting aura about him.

I felt sweat on Jiao S's palms. *Was she... worried about Si Luo?*

Nie Zun avoided Cang Ming's attack as well, and his coat was ruffled by the gust of wind brought on by the speed of the blade.

Apart from moving quickly to avoid the attack, he did not seem to have done anything else. Both of his hands were still in his pockets.

Since Nie Zun was always quick and agile, I wasn't too worried about him even though he was standing closest to Cang Ming.

He stared at Cang Ming. "I guess saving your girlfriend is nothing but an excuse here. You're just itching for a fight. I don't think you'd want to miss out on that opportunity now that it has presented itself."

Cang Ming's eyes shone as he laughed manically. "Interesting. Very interesting. There's actually somebody in the Split Zone who knows me. I didn't expect you to be even more interesting than Gaoqin. You're right. I'm just itching for a fight. Want to spar?"

Nie Zun laughed casually. “It won’t be a mere spar if we fight. If you’re doing this for that woman, I suggest you give up. Her heart is with me now. Without a heart, she isn’t able to summon the second personality. Rather than making things difficult for her, how about we exchange blows instead? I’ll give you the heart if I end up losing.”

Is he... using my heart as a bargaining chip? I guess not having a heart is a good thing. At least it would save me from heartbreak.

Si Luo spoke suddenly, “I’m your opponent. Why change your target halfway? Save your breath, Nie Zun.”

Feeling Jiao S frown beside me, I stole a glance at her.

I knew how she felt. These people were acting so weird. Why did they have to fight over a fight?

Cang Ming waved a hand impatiently, a hand on his huge sword and the other on his waist. “Do we have to fight over a fight? How about we go at it together? It’s really boring that the Split Zone has seen such a long period of peace. It’s kind of a waste if we don’t spar a little since so many of us are here. Come on, no need to hide. Let’s just have a fight today.”

I thought Si Luo wouldn’t engage with such an individual, but I was proven wrong as I noticed the white fog surge in Si Luo’s eyes.

The air around the plaza seemed to quake.

This quaking felt familiar, and it was similar to the techniques used by Gaoqin Jiuye and Jiao S, but I witnessed the difference between master and disciple today.

It was the same technique Si Luo was using. He, Gaoqin Jiuye and Jiao S could all use it well, but there was a difference when Si Luo used it. It felt as if I was looking at a new technique altogether.

The white fog that surged in Si Luo’s eyes looked extremely bright. He was in control of the air currents in this whole plaza, and he could control it so

well that it was unlikely anybody else could match his abilities in such manipulation of MF.

Although the situation was precarious, it was still a three-way battle. As long as there was one party holding back, the other two might not attack so hastily.

Sadly, Nie Zun disappointed me. He had no intention of easing this fight as he activated his pupil abilities.

A deathly aura surrounded the three of them. All of them seemed up for a fight and none of them had any intention to retreat.

“I thought you said they wouldn’t be fighting,” I said to Jiao S worriedly.

Jiao S just looked indifferent to the entire situation.

The air surrounding us crackled as Si Luo squinted. It wasn’t some large-scale attack, but I felt terrified by that crackling air.

Nie Zun looked back and forth between Si Luo and Cang Ming. I could sense his MF emanate around him. Though I didn’t have any MF now, I was still able to sense him probably because of the link between the two of us.

Light gleamed off Cang Ming’s collarbone and neck as he raised his sword of light. He emanated a dangerous air.

A hand reached out from behind me as I was focused on the three of them. Jiao S did not notice it either.

I didn’t even have time to call for Piercer before that seal was stuck right in the middle of my back.

“Ah!” I fell forwards with a surprised cry.

I turned quickly so that I would end up lying face up instead of down as I tried to catch a glimpse of my attacker.

I was utterly shocked upon seeing who it was.

It was Jie Pa who put the seal on me.

I felt a burning heat right in the middle of my back. I wondered what kind of seal it was.

He looked at me calmly as he adjusted his glasses.

I then saw a hand on his neck. It belonged to Jiao S.

Jiao S had his neck in her hand as she asked, “What did you do to her?” Her voice was low and hoarse as usual.

Jie Pa answered calmly, “No need to worry, Miss Jiao S. I’m doing this is for Miss Ah Shen because she doesn’t have a heart now. If there’s nothing to help her balance the MF inside her body, she’ll end up burning herself out. I’m protecting her with this seal.”

“Then why were you being so sneaky about it?”

Jie Pa answered honestly, “If I did that, everyone’s focus would be on me, and it can temporarily stop a fight that shouldn’t happen.”

That was true. Right after I was attacked, the three of them stopped in their tracks and looked towards me at once.

“Why’re you here, Jie?” Nie Zun asked.

Jie Pa smiled in his gentlemanly manner. “When do you plan to stop if I don’t appear? Miss Ah Shen is so weak now, and you’re not even telling me all this. You disappeared so suddenly. I wouldn’t have been able to find you so quickly if I didn’t put a tracking drug on you beforehand.”

“I didn’t disappear on purpose. There’s a reason for it.”

Chapter 280: 280 Physical Limits

Volume 5

280 Physical Limits

“I know it’s because Miss Ah Shen deactivated her split symbol.” Jie Pa looked over and reached out a hand towards me as he said so.

“I apologize for that, Miss Ah Shen.” He smiled politely.

Taking his hand, I stood up and said, “It’s okay. Let’s not beat around the bush here. What are your requests, Jie Pa? I’ll help you with it as long as you’re willing to accept my help.”

“You’re in a precarious situation now, Miss Ah Shen. Your heart has been taken away by Nie Zun and you’ve also deactivated your split symbol. You might not feel it, but you’re even weaker than an ordinary human being right now.”

It isn’t that bad...

But it’s true that I feel tired if I move around too much... And the empty space in my chest seemed to hurt for no reason... My vision seemed to be getting blurry as well...

I held all of this in with gritted teeth. I didn’t know if it was caused by the seal on my back, but I felt a chill spread across my spine.

“What’s wrong, Ah Shen?” Jiao S rushed over to support me.

I sat on the ground, leaning against Jiao S’s shoulder. This felt familiar, and it reminded me of somebody else.

When Song Lu thought that Yu Liang was dead, she leaned against me like this, heartbroken. *Why did this appear in my head at this moment?*

I guess... I still cared...

Exhaustion overwhelmed me all of a sudden and a tear dripped onto Jiao S's hand. Surprised by my tears, Jiao S grabbed me. "What's wrong? Stop scaring me like this."

She was so anxious, but I couldn't speak as I was choking on my tears.

Jie Pa frowned, bending down to reach for the split symbol on my ankle.

His gaze darkened as he spoke. "Miss Ah Shen, you're in a dangerous situation right now. You're already weakened, and your will to live has suddenly decreased. Without MF and a heart, you shouldn't be in a place where there are huge ripples of MF. Their actions from before would definitely have hurt you."

"She's the only one who can save my woman. She can't die." Cang Ming walked over to me, unsmiling as he held onto his sword of light.

Si Luo blocked his way. "Didn't you hear the healer? MF might hurt her, so I'd suggest for you to think twice about doing anything. Bian Ying can't be saved if she ends up dying."

Cang Ming smirked. "Do you think I'm someone who can be threatened? Do you know why you're not able to stay in the Gate of Heaven eventually? It's because you have emotions, something that a soul splitter shouldn't have. You have emotions like humans do, what you call kindness and sympathy. These are things that will weaken you. Though you're still strong now, you're no longer the Si Luo whom everyone looked up to years ago.

"Do you still think that you're that saint of heaven? I'm going to take her with me now, and I don't think you'd dare stop me since you'll be hurting her if you use MF. You'd better think twice."

Though his words were a challenge, they made Si Luo stay his hand. However, it couldn't stop Nie Zun. Cang Ming was enshrouded in deadly black fog just a moment later.

I spat out a mouthful of blood right at that moment.

A look of worry flashed past Jie Pa's eyes and he shouted at Nie Zun, "Are you mad? You're hurting Ah Shen!"

The fact that he called me Ah Shen instead of Miss Ah Shen was proof that Jie Pa was really anxious.

A sense of relief overcame me. *At least Jie Pa was still himself.*

Nie Zun did not heed Jie Pa's words as he addressed Cang Ming. "Her heart is with me now. You really don't want it? From what I understand, the heart is equivalent to the second personality. Even if she dies, you might still be able to summon her second personality as long as her heart can still beat."

I couldn't believe that Nie Zun actually said something like this. Tamping down that bloody taste in my throat, I looked up at Nie Zun as I tried to make out his expression.

Cang Ming lifted that sword of light back onto his shoulder as he turned to Nie Zun. "She won't understand this even if you're doing it for her. You should be like me and trap her right beside you. Do you think that women nowadays would be moved by things that you do for them?"

Nie Zun smiled. "Like you? Like how you trap Bian Ying by your side and not care even if she looks more and more upset day by day? Are you sure that Bian Ying is staying by your side because she loves you, and not because she's trying to protect Ta Lai? You're really funny, Cang Ming."

I've never heard Nie Zun say something so harsh to anyone. I wondered what nerve Cang Ming touched that made him say that.

Cang Ming's smile stiffened at this.

With a hand still on my split symbol, Jie Pa said to Nie Zun, “Give her heart back. This can’t go on. She can’t hold out for much longer like this.”

We made eye-contact with each other as Nie Zun glanced over, but he looked away a split second later. “I can’t return it yet.”

“Why?” Jie Pa asked with a deep frown.

Cang Ming smirked. “Because he’s trying to protect her. I’ll take her away immediately once he returns her heart. Du Yue wouldn’t let her go even if I don’t do anything. And Huai Du would think of all ways and means to get to her even if Du Yue lets her go.

“But Nie Zun, do you think that I’ll give up on this rare opportunity just because you took her heart? Aren’t you naïve?”

Nie Zun spoke calmly, “Oh, I’m curious. What are you guys going to do with her when she’s literally of no use without her heart?”

A light glinted in Cang Ming’s eyes. “I’ll kill her if she’s of no use.”

Nie Zun smirked. “Although her body will deteriorate without a heart, she won’t die as long as her consciousness is still in the Split Zone. Do you think that those from the Gate of Ghost are the only ones who know this?”

Stunned, Cang Ming asked, “How did you know that?”

Nie Zun casually took his hands out of his pockets as he said, “I know many things, things that you are aware of and things that you aren’t. Whatever it is, taking the heart away will separate it from the body of consciousness, and the split symbol that belongs to that body of consciousness is equivalent to a useless mechanism. They won’t die even if a splitting key is inserted in it.

“She’s of no use to you dead or alive when she’s without a heart and without her second personality. Furthermore, she won’t be able to do any harm now that she has deactivated her split symbol. If you’re trying to save

your woman, I'll advise you to just come at me, and we'll see if you really have the ability to take what you're here for."

Cang Ming's smile was replaced by a serious expression. "I guess I've underestimated many people. What do I do, Si Luo? If I guessed right, you're already at your limits. You're only able to do this now because she's here and both your MF resonated with each other."

Cang Ming might have turned a little wary of Nie Zun as he suddenly shifted his focus to Si Luo.

That flame on Si Luo's forehead seemed to glow as he smiled. "That's right, I guess I'm also about to die..."

He sounded a little gloomy, but a trace of a smile still hung on his lips. It looked like he was just talking about the facts of life instead of talking about how he would be dying soon.

Jiao S spoke in a low voice beside me. "I'm going to kill everyone else if you die. If you die here in the Gate of Heaven, I'll flatten the entire Gate of Heaven. If you're killed by someone from the Gate of Ghost, I'll make the Gate of Ghost disappear from the Split Zone forever."

There was no hesitation in her words. She was resolute.

Cang Ming looked at her with slight interest. "Your woman talks big. I'll really feel like killing him if you say that, just to see if you have the ability to wipe out the Gate of Ghost."

Jiao S smirked. "You can try."

"Miss Ah Shen, leave with me. We'll get out of here temporarily," Jie Pa said as he adjusted his glasses, as if he had already thought of what to do next.

I shook my head. "No, I'm not going. It'll be a release if I really end up dying here. Thanks for the thought, Jie Pa, but believe me when I say that I won't die that easily even without a heart or MF."

Looking at Jie Pa's worried expression, I realized I looked just like a damsel in distress who couldn't defend herself. *How could I not let them worry like this?*

I struggled to sit up. I called out softly, "Protect me, Piercer."

I didn't carry high hopes of being able to summon Piercer successfully, but in a miraculous turn of events, Piercer shone with a bright violet light before she appeared in human form right beside me.

Chapter 281: 281 Ta Lai Returns

Volume 5

281 Ta Lai Returns

“A living weapon... Piercer has been awoken?” Si Luo asked as he looked at the lady dressed in purple in front of me.

Panting from the continuous pain that was emanating from my chest, I kept my answer short. “Yes.”

“This is the first time I’ve seen such an interesting sight. So many powerful individuals have congregated here in the Gate of Heaven. How lively.”

A group of people were walking towards the plaza in single file. Ta Lai was at the fore with three giants behind him. He wasn’t sitting on the shoulder of any giant this time, and these giants looked a little different from those I had seen before.

The giants from before looked like mere puppets who knew nothing except for killing. This time, the giants looked like they had some thoughts of their own.

I haven’t seen Ta Lai in a long time.

Many powerful individuals were indeed gathered here. I wouldn’t have been able to beat any of these individuals alone even when my split symbol was activated.

Ta Lai greeted me in a surprisingly polite manner. “How are you doing recently, Miss Ah Shen?”

Jiao S supported me as I stood up slowly to answer Ta Lai. “I’m good. Nie Zun’s face is healed, so of course I’d be doing well.” I made it clear that I haven’t forgiven him for disfiguring Nie Zun.

Ta Lai smiled without speaking, as if he didn’t understand me at all.

I smirked as I asked, “I heard that you’re actually Rong Jin.”

The sudden question stunned Si Luo for a split second. Emotion filled his silvery-white eyes as he asked, “Is that true?”

“Yes, I’m Rong Jin,” Ta Lai said, turning to Si Luo.

Si Luo looked a little conflicted, but he finally said, “I should’ve known.”

Ta Lai fiddled with the jade stone ring on his right hand. “But you didn’t realize it. Though I’ve kept this from you for a long time, I’ve never let you down, Si Luo. I’ve always done my best and stayed loyal to you as Rong Jin. Even though I, Ta Lai, might not be friends with you, Rong Jin has never betrayed you.”

Si Luo nodded lightly. “I’m not someone ungrateful. I know what you’re getting at. But you’re the only one left in the Gate of Heaven right now. I’m no longer your opponent nor am I a threat to you. Why did you have to be so wary of me?”

Ta Lai smiled. “What you just said proves that you’ve always seen me as a villain. I’ve never thought of competing with you. If you didn’t leave without a word at the time, you’d still be the one Feng Zhu trusts the most in the Gate of Heaven. I’ve never thought of snatching what belongs to you, so why are you playing the victim here?”

Si Luo’s smile was enchanting and beautiful. “You wouldn’t be where you are now if I was really playing the victim. You’ve also gotten what you wished for. But how about Bian Ying? Ta Lai, you’ve stayed with me as Rong Jin for a long time. I’m sure that wasn’t the only thing you had to say to me.”

Ta Lai ended up looking a little unnatural as he tried to suppress his emotions upon hearing Bian Ying's name.

"I used Rong Jin's identity because I wondered how you'd get by after you left the Gate of Heaven. Didn't you say you were going to create a utopia? Didn't you say that the brand of justice in the Gate of Heaven and Feng Zhu's brand of justice were all a sham? I simply wanted to have a look at what exactly justice was in your terms."

Si Luo nodded as if in agreement, but it felt more of a reassurance for himself. "I believe that you're telling the truth. You just wanted to have a look at how I'd get by since you just couldn't understand my decisions. Isn't that right?"

Ta Lai answered resolutely, "Yes."

"So, have you gotten an answer?"

Ta Lai looked around at all of us before turning back to Si Luo. "Is your definition of justice allowing the Southern District to be trampled upon and destroyed while you couldn't do a thing about it?"

This felt too harsh. Though I wasn't as strong as Jiao S or Si Luo as a District Commander, I still wanted to protect my residents. Ta Lai's words just trivialized whatever we've been doing, and it was equivalent to saying that whatever we believed in was wrong.

Others can reject you, disagree with you and be in your way, but your beliefs can never be trampled like this.

I was a little upset and angered at this, but Si Luo remained extremely calm as he answered. "We don't know if my residents are really dead or if they've returned to the real world. There's no use in being upset or mourning over this before we even get to the bottom of things."

Du Yue had also appeared sometime after Ta Lai's arrival. I knew she was hidden somewhere nearby. Her eyes had never left Ta Lai.

Love can really change a woman. This had nothing to do with how she was in the past, or what happened that changed her. Looking at her now, there seemed to still be a trace of humanity left in that ruthlessness when Ta Lai appeared. This was definitely a love that she wanted to protect.

Shouldn't we all be forgiving, since everything was done in the name of love? Even so, the sight of You Ji right before she died reignited my hatred towards Du Yue.

I guess hatred just stays ingrained in human minds and we are simply creatures who forget that we should be thankful for things.

"Why didn't you tell me you were coming?" Du Yue stared at Ta Lai as she asked.

Ta Lai glanced at her as he fiddled with his ring. "You hurt her?"

If I understood this correctly, he should be referring to Bian Ying.

Du Yue's eyes were lit immediately with a burning flame. "Is that the first thing you have to ask me once we meet? You were there too. Her condition was already bad. It doesn't have anything to do with me if she ends up dying. Are you trampling over my feelings like this because you can't accept it?"

Ta Lai kept his eyes on Du Yue. "I wouldn't be here to save you if I wanted to trample on your feelings."

Du Yue laughed in self-mockery. "Are you sure you're here because you're worried about me? Your goal should be the same as theirs, it's all for that woman. Sadly, the news that Li Shen's second personality can patch up an incomplete consciousness is just a rumor. Why try so hard for a mere rumor? Especially you, Ta Lai. Even though you've done everything for her, do you think her heart will leave Cang Ming and go back to you?"

Ta Lai's gaze darkened. "Seems like I've been too lenient with you all this time."

Du Yue's laugh was laced with sarcasm this time. "Lenient with me? Don't pretend to be close to me, Ta Lai. I won't be able to enter your heart, and I know very well where I'm placed. There's no need to say such a thing."

I couldn't bear listening to this anymore as I shot Du Yue a cold look. "Do you have any right to say this, Du Yue? Gaoqin Jiuye loved you so much and he did so much for you. If your love was so noble, why did you have a change of heart?"

"Yes, it's true that Gaoqin Jiuye caused you to lose an arm, and it was also because he wanted to save me that it led to you turning into an absolutely different person. But even so, can love change so quickly? Why fall in love with someone else who already has a lover when you could've stayed with Gaoqin Jiuye?"

Du Yue stared at me incredulously. "How did you know this?"

Her eyes then landed on Piercer beside me.

Her gaze wavered for a bit, but she regained that calm demeanor quickly. "I guess it's your precious living weapon who told you about it. I was definitely a little retarded at the time. I shouldn't have even given you a chance to come into contact with a living weapon. It wouldn't have been able to tell you all these secrets and things of the past."

I responded immediately. "I'm not the only one you're trying to keep this from. You're trying to keep this from everyone else too, that you had been in love with Gaoqin Jiuye once. I'm just wondering why you had a change of heart if you could have done so much for him in the past."

Seeing Du Yue losing her patience, Ta Lai interrupted us. "Enough, Du Yue. Come with me. We can talk about our issues later. Don't we still have some work to do?"

Du Yue's anger was tamped down immediately with Ta Lai's words. I guess people will always have their weaknesses.

She nodded at Ta Lai and walked over to him. She seemed to have made her decision to stand on Ta Lai's side no matter what happens.

Du Yue smirked as a bloodthirsty killing intent emerged in her eyes. "Didn't your Nie Zun protect you every night and day? He loved you so much, but he's also turning his back on you now that he says he doesn't love you anymore. We're the same. You didn't have to be so sarcastic."

Her words hurt me. Subconsciously, I glanced over at Nie Zun. He seemed to be looking into the distance, and I couldn't tell if he was even looking at me. If he was, I wondered what went through his mind.

Chapter 282: 282 Parallel Worlds

Volume 5

282 Parallel Worlds

Things were getting interesting.

I was standing right in the middle of the plaza with Jiao S and Piercer on either side of me. Jie Pa was somewhere in front of me towards the right as he observed the entire situation.

Cang Ming and Nie Zun were both behind me, somewhere to my left. They were standing opposite each other and it seemed as if they were both ready to attack at a moment's notice.

A little in front of me, to my left, stood Si Luo. He was just a short distance away from everyone else and he would have been able to see everyone from where he stood.

Ta Lai and Du Yue were a little further away from me as they both stood facing me. Seeing them next to each other, I suddenly felt that they were a good match.

Ta Lai was tall with a pair of slender legs, and Du Yue was taller than the average woman. There was an air of authority surrounding them when they stood side by side like this, especially with those three giants standing right behind them.

It was difficult to describe the current situation exactly as it was.

Some of them weren't humans but soul splitters and living weapons while some of us couldn't be counted as human since we were equivalent to a

corpse, and that was me.

Cang Ming spoke in the sudden silence that ensued. "I guess you're also here because of that rumor about a possible method to save her."

Little did I expect for Cang Ming to say something like this to Ta Lai. I was of the impression that they would be at loggerheads with each other once they met.

I think I know why.

In Cang Ming's heart, nothing was more important than Bian Ying, and he could definitely put pride aside for her.

Without animosity towards Cang Ming, Ta Lai nodded. "Yes. Since you're here for that too, might I suggest that we work together on this? We can decide what to do after getting what we're looking for. How about forming a temporary alliance for now?"

Cang Ming smiled, shaking his head. "I'm not saying this because we're rivals in love, but the truth is that I'm someone who does things on my own. I never work with anyone. You should know that I don't seek help from others, even if it's coming from you."

Ta Lai raised a brow. "So you'd rather be on your own here even when there's a high chance that a huge battle could break out today?"

Cang Ming answered languorously, "Yes. With Du Yue by your side, aren't the both of you the strongest ones under Feng Zhu right now? I don't think there's anything you can't do when the both of you work together, isn't it, Ta Lai? Why drag me into an alliance?"

Du Yue smirked. "It's always better to have more manpower. I just so happen to be interested in this deal right now, whether Li Shen's second personality is a boon or a bane, our short-term aims are rather similar. Even though our eventual goals might be different, wouldn't it be better if we work together for now?"

Cang Ming yawned lazily as he held his sword on one hand. “One used to be at the top of the Gate of Heaven, while the other two are now the top subordinates in the Gate of Heaven. Isn’t it great that Si Luo is here too? Who do you think would win if the three of us join forces?”

Du Yue said coldly, “It might seem like the two of us have the advantage here, but you guys can count me out.”

An animal resembling a fiery qilin then appeared behind her as she clapped her palms together. I’ve seen it before. It was as if this animal was Du Yue’s private vehicle.

I didn’t understand what they were doing right now. *Why did they have to rile one another up like this?*

Ta Lai, Du Yue and Cang Ming were all here for my second personality. Even if they might end up being enemies after, shouldn’t they be able to work together for now at least?

As for Si Luo... What’s Si Luo’s goal exactly?

If I put all doubt at the back of my mind, Si Luo’s main goal would be to protect my split symbol, since the promises I’ve made to him would come to naught if anything untoward happened to me.

Si Luo’s condition isn’t great either, and I could tell because Jie Pa’s eyes lingered on him for a while. It seemed like an occupational habit, where doctors seem to always focus a little bit more on those who were in a bad shape.

Apart from the three of them, Nie Zun and Jiao S were the only ones left. Jiao S was definitely protecting me, and I couldn’t tell what was on Nie Zun’s mind. Jie Pa didn’t seem to be able to tip the situation in any way either.

“Is everyone fighting over her? I don’t think there’s actually a need to.” Piercer spoke!

I turned to her in surprise. This was the first time I looked at her so closely. Though she couldn't be considered beautiful, she had an aura that attracted me. That purple dress of hers seemed to dazzle.

All eyes turned to us as everyone found it rather unsettling to witness a living weapon talk.

Just like Goaqin Jiuye's Shen Qi, Piercer didn't have much expression on her face.

"I guess it's not only a person I'm trying to take this time. This living weapon interests me as well." Cang Ming regarded Piercer with predatory eyes.

I spoke coldly, "Stop dreaming. You're trying to take the living weapon when you can't even successfully take the person?"

Piercer interrupted us. "I'd make it short and sweet since I know the sudden appearance of a living weapon might be uncomfortable for the rest of you. Some things would turn moldy if we keep it for too long, isn't that right, Shen'er?"

I didn't expect her to call me Shen'er, and I found her expression a little unsettling. *But, this was the living weapon I've chosen. Since I've chosen her and awoken her, I'd have to be responsible for her. Whether it was for better or for worse, she'd be with me in future.*

"Ah Shen, didn't you always want to know the secret of the Split Zone? How about I reveal it to you today?"

I frowned. "The time is right?"

Piercer smiled at me as she nodded lightly. "Yes, the time has come."

"The secret of the Split Zone? You're just a mere living weapon with a tiny bit of consciousness. You're not even a soul splitter. Do you actually know the secret of the Split Zone? I'd love to hear it though. I wonder how much

I'd know." Though Cang Ming was requesting for her to reveal it, he wasn't being polite about it. He probably looked down on living weapons.

Si Luo spoke as well. "You should have some sort of impression of me, don't you, Piercer? I'm just curious about one thing. Would you be loyal to Li Shen no matter what happens in future?"

Piercer smiled. "I don't actually like her. She looks so weak and useless. You know that I'm picky too. But it's funny that I don't hate the thought of protecting her. I'll give you an answer since you've asked the question. I'll keep protecting Li Shen until the day she's able to make her decision. I'll protect her until the day she chooses to leave, or do something else."

Relief appeared on Si Luo's face. "It's great destiny and fortune to be able to have such a living weapon like you. I'm comforted if Ah Shen has you."

Piercer smiled again. "Yours isn't weak either."

To this, Si Luo shook his head silently. Piercer didn't continue the conversation, as if she understood something from that gesture.

Jie Pa addressed Piercer at this moment, "Since we're all here and nobody seems to have any objections to it, how about we start talking about the secret of the Split Zone right now?"

Du Yue looked like she wanted to stop it, but Ta Lai prevented her from saying anything more.

Nie Zun seemed to glance at me for a split second before shifting his gaze. I couldn't tell what went through his mind.

Piercer's words interrupted my train of thought as she began speaking.

"The soul splitters in the Split Zone are not really humans, and they aren't some weird existence either. The Split Zone and the real world are connected, but that connection doesn't mean that we can come and go freely between the two worlds. Our consciousness will not be able to pass freely between these worlds either, and this is why that weird method of

establishing a split symbol contract has been passed down. But even so, the Split Zone is still a totally independent space that's closed off and definitely separated from the real world.

“Those in the Split Zone aren't real humans either. Everyone would be able to find their corresponding human being in the real world, because in these parallel worlds, those in the Split Zone aren't shadows of those in the real world. They are actually a missing part of the human who's in the real world.”

What?

I thought I would be able to understand whatever she said, and as Piercer's owner, I should have been able to understand her better than others. But I didn't actually immediately understand everything.

Does this mean that the Split Zone is a separate space altogether? This space is independent and exclusive, and it's actually parallel to the real world?

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283 The Secret of the Split Zone

Seeing the shock on my face, Piercer explained patiently. “Even though they are parallel worlds, the Split Zone is a space where the consciousness of humans can exist. As humans grow, there might be new sides of them that emerge, something like a second self.

“With the increase in population and the increasing pressures of life, humans show a different side of themselves to fit in and integrate with their society. We can refer to the side that’s usually hidden as their hidden personality. If the hidden personality is triggered, it can then evolve into an independent existence. These end up being the soul splitters in the Split Zone.”

I interrupted Piercer as I asked, “Do you mean that soul splitters are a part of the human consciousness?”

“It can be interpreted in this way, but instead of being part of one’s personality, it would be more accurate to describe it as part of their humanity. I’m not sure if you’ve seen this animation called Dragon Ball when you were in the real world, but this is similar to the character of Piccolo in that show. This can happen when people choose to show only a certain side and suppress the other side of themselves.

“For example, they might always be portraying an image of being kind and fragile, but they might also be suppressing a possibly bloodthirsty side. That

bloodthirsty side will continue to grow over time, and if something happens to trigger it, it might cause that particular side to break away from the main body of consciousness. When that happens, it forms an independent body that ends up here in the Split Zone. These then become the soul splitters who live independently here.”

This meant that the soul splitters in the Split Zone evolved from living humans, and they exist because they have been separated to become independent entities.

Everyone looked rather pensive, and I knew Piercer was definitely speaking the truth judging from the mere looks of the few who were soul splitters themselves.

Piercer thought I didn’t fully comprehend this as she looked at that contemplative expression of mine. She continued with an example. “I’ll use a practical example to illustrate this. In Gaoqin Jiuye’s case, he is Gao Qi’s doppelganger. This is the term we use in the Split Zone to describe corresponding humans and soul splitters. This means that Gaoqin Jiuye is a part of Gao Qi. If Gao Qi was a kind person, then Gaoqin Jiuye would be the opposite of him; he’d be the evil side. This part of Gao Qi was triggered and it separated to become an independent entity, turning into Gaoqin Jiuye, who then continued living in the Split Zone.”

Gaoqin Jiuye was a part of Gao Qi’s humanity...? Which part is he then...?

It definitely wouldn’t be as simple as how Piercer described it, where one was good and one was evil. What was it then?

“Are humans only either good or evil?” I asked.

Piercer shook her head. “No, humanity is wide-ranging in this sense. If there’s a cowardly side of you, then there might also be an adventurous side that’s hidden. Instead of saying that these are opposites, we can understand it as some sort of goal of yours.

“When a cowardly person wants to become brave, there’ll be a part of them that yearns to have that adventurous side. When that yearning is strong

enough, it will turn into a hidden personality. When that gets triggered, it will then end up as a separate entity in the Split Zone with independent thought and a consciousness equivalent to that of another human being.”

“Then does it mean that for him, and her too, and also the both of them, they all have a corresponding human being in the real world?” I asked while pointing at Ta Lai, Du Yue, Cang Ming and Si Luo.

Piercer nodded. “Yes, they’re all part of the humanity from someone living in the real world. But they’d lose all contact with that particular human being once they arrive in the Split Zone. This means that they wouldn’t be able to find their corresponding selves in the real world. Since soul splitters can separate from the original body and turn into an independent entity, they probably wouldn’t be too interested in looking for the original vessel either.”

“Then what’s with Gaoqin Jiuye?”

Piercer looked at me with sympathy. “This actually involves you. Usually, the soul splitters would lose all contact with the original vessel, and they wouldn’t dream of the vessel unless absolutely necessary. When soul splitters dream, they see everything that’s happening in the real world, and they are only able to dream of their original vessel.

“This means that Gaoqin Jiuye would only be able to dream of Gao Qi, and whatever he’s dreaming of and seeing is actually whatever that was happening in Gao Qi’s life. The Split Zone is originally a desolate place where nothing exists. The bodies of consciousness which ended up here did nothing but sit and stare into the emptiness.

“Soul splitters began to get tired of such a life, and they also realized that they were able to control and change the space within this world. They then created a world of their own here. Soul splitters with high MF would be able to create whatever they thought of. If they wanted a mobile phone, they could make one appear. These things were recreated from the times where they had dreams of their original vessels, and they simply replicated whatever the original vessels might have been using in those dreams.

“This is also why you would have realized that the Split Zone has everything from the material world, and it doesn’t matter which era it might have been from. However, it’s not exactly true that the Split Zone has everything either, since soul splitters are rarely able to dream of their original vessels.”

I was already rendered speechless at this point. *Gaoqin Jiuye was an independent entity who got separated from Gao Qi, and he could see everything in Gao Qi’s life when he dreamt. If he saw a car, he could replicate it in the Split Zone as long as his MF allows it. Was this what Piercer was getting at?*

“So, soul splitters capturing humans...” I mumbled, unable to finish my sentence. My suspicions scared even myself.

Piercer sighed as she confirmed my suspicions. “When a soul splitter captures a body of consciousness, this means they’ve simply seen it. Gaoqin Jiuye saw Gao Qi’s life through his dreams, and he saw you in it. Upon seeing you, he had thoughts of having you by his side. If these thoughts were strong enough, your consciousness would end up being pulled into this world if you happened to be in a vulnerable state at the time.

“The one who brought you here would then be your corresponding soul splitter. This particular occurrence is a rare one though. Most of the time, soul splitters capture heirs to obtain greater power through split symbol contracts. In the many years that soul splitters have existed in the Split Zone, they’ve found a way to gain more power, and that is through split symbols and splitting keys. So they’d usually capture people in vulnerable mental states to be their corresponding heirs and obtain greater power that way.”

Jiao S seemed to get a little agitated as she asked, “That’s no different from taking somebody’s life, isn’t it? Soul splitters sign a contract with the devil for power, and they’ve dragged an innocent person into the fray by doing that.”

Sorrow seemed to fill Piercer’s eyes. “The world would end if humans weren’t selfish. Soul splitters have originally been humans in the real world,

and they have an incomplete humanity. They wouldn't be thinking about what's right and wrong. They'd simply care about satisfying their needs. Humans are just like this.

“But Ah Shen's situation is unique. Gaoqin Jiuye didn't have the intention to bring you over to this world even though he saw you in the dream. With his MF, he doesn't even have to establish a split symbol contract. And if you end up leaving the Split Zone after this, his life could be endangered. It's because he saw Gao Qi hurting you time and again that he decided to bring you over as a last resort.

“I choose to see this as a sort of destiny. Thought most soul splitters can dream of their original vessel, it's rare that they'd be able to dream of someone who had a direct connection to them. To obtain the power from a split symbol, they'd usually choose a random person with a weak will and capture them as an heir when they're vulnerable. It's very rare to be able to dream like how it was in Gaoqin Jiuye's case.”

So Gaoqin Jiuye dreamt of Gao Qi and saw me in Gao Qi's life, and he then felt sorry for me when Gao Qi kept hurting me, and he ended up dragging me into this world when I stuck that knife into Gao Qi's heart? And that process actually caused Du Yue to lose an arm?

If it was somebody else he saw in his dreams, it would simply be a damsel in distress that he would have ended up saving.

But he and Gao Qi had to be doppelgangers. Can I then assume that the one who fell in love with me was still Gao Qi?

Piercer spoke as if she read my mind. “Don't think that it was Gao Qi who fell in love with you. Although Gaoqin Jiuye was a part of Gao Qi, he's an independent entity after arriving in the Split Zone. Though he might not have a complete personality as an independent entity that had separated from his original human vessel, he doesn't share Gao Qi's thoughts nor Gao Qi's life.”

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Volume 5

284 I'll Leave With You

Piercer regarded me with a profound gaze. “Gaoqin Jiuye really loved you. He sacrificed so much for a woman he had merely seen in his dreams.”

Si Luo spoke suddenly. “Gaoqin was telling me all about you during that time. I used to really regret telling him how to go over to your world, but now that I look at it, I might have been wrong at the time. I should’ve respected his choices if that was the life he really wanted.”

Jiao S turned to Si Luo and asked, “How about me? Have you ever dreamt of me?”

Si Luo shook his head as he answered without looking at her. “Didn’t you come over to this world before you actually arrived here? That’s from your determination and I didn’t do anything to cause that. I don’t know who exactly was the soul splitter who eventually brought you over.”

Reminded of Nie Zun as I watched the two of them, I asked Piercer in haste, “How about Nie Zun? You mentioned that I was the one who brought Nie Zun over. What actually happened?”

Piercer glanced at Nie Zun. That indifferent look of his hid all emotions.

“Nie Zun is different from everyone else, and he doesn’t really have a connection to this world. There’s no soul splitter who had dreamt of him either. I don’t think I can answer this, so you’d probably have to ask him

how he ended up here in the Split Zone. It would have something to do with your second personality as well.”

An ominous feeling overcame me.

“Ah Shen, you’re different from the rest of them who had been captured because you already had two personalities to begin with. You already had a personality that was independent, and on a certain level, that independence would have been equivalent to that of a soul splitter in the Split Zone. But that independence was way too strong, and not only did that form a part of you, it became a different person altogether.

“You wouldn’t have been able to end up in the Split Zone originally, and I don’t know how much Gaoqin Jiuye had to do to actually bring you over. What I know is that Nie Zun happened to be with you when you arrived, and you could say that it was your second personality who brought Nie Zun over. However, I don’t actually know what happened between your second personality and Nie Zun.”

“I think I know what happened.” I heard Gaoqin Jiuye’s voice interrupt while I was focusing on Piercer’s explanation.

My heart skipped a beat. I wondered if it was guilt or from some other emotion. Subconsciously, I was wringing the fabric of my dress as I saw him walk casually towards us.

Gaoqin Jiuye looked at Si Luo. “Your condition is getting from bad to worse. I can feel it.”

Si Luo smiled beautifully. “I’m fine.”

Gaoqin Jiuye then stopped some distance away from me. He looked at me calmly as he said, “Let me tell you what happened.”

For some reason, his tone of voice sounded foreign and unfamiliar to me.

“Do you still remember that ring? Things might have turned out differently if you hadn’t taken it off. I always thought that you only took it off if

triggered under certain circumstances, and I was trying my best to save you by going into your world. I don't know what happened in your world, but to help me, Du Yue forced herself to dream of you. She saw what happened, and it was only recently that she told me about it."

I looked towards an unsmiling Du Yue. Instead of her smug expression, she was pursing her lips.

Gaoqin Jiuye continued. "You were being controlled by your second personality at the time, and you gave that ring to Nie Zun."

A scene flashed past my mind right when he said that.

She was in a red dress, and her smile was dazzling even though her hands were covered in blood.

She looked at the male figure dressed in black opposite her.

Lifting a blood-stained hand, she removed that unique-looking ring from her slender finger. The blood stained the ring as she did so.

She then grabbed the hand of the male figure opposite her.

She had this gentle but cruel smile on her. Looking at his left hand, she slowly pried his palm open. His hand looked long and slender, and his palms looked empty without any palm prints.

She looked up, meeting his eyes as she said, "She's Li Shen. If you ever have the chance to see her again, could you do me a favor and stay by her side?"

He answered after a short silence. "Why should I do that?"

She then smiled. "Because I know that you're just like her. I can smell the 'solitude' on the both of you..."

She then put the ring on his left pinky.

That blood-stained ring fit his pinky perfectly, as if everything was already fated to be.

Caressing his face, she said, “Stay with her... No matter what kind of devil she might turn into...”

Police appeared behind her before she could complete her sentence.

“Arrest her. She’s the one who stabbed the senior.”

Letting go of his hand with a dazzling smile, she retreated a couple of steps before collapsing backwards.

The scene stopped playing as if it had been suddenly cut off. I covered my mouth in shock as I looked at Nie Zun. I saw a glint in his eyes before they slowly turned dark again.

Emotions overwhelmed me. I felt helpless and shocked at this turn of events.

That lady in the scene was definitely me, and that male figure dressed in black was clearly Nie Zun.

When did I meet him like this? Though I recalled the scene, it was as if I was looking at somebody else’s story. That wasn’t me.

No, this must be something she planted in my mind, something that she added. I’m not her. I’ll never be her. She was the one who betrayed Gaoqin Jiuye. She was also the one who gave Nie Zun the ring.

“It’s not me... That’s not me... It was her who gave the ring to Nie Zun...” I mumbled as tears welled up in my eyes.

Pain flashed past Gaoqin Jiuye’s eyes. “It was her who gave the ring to Nie Zun and it wasn’t you? You don’t wish to acknowledge her presence, but you’ve fallen in love with Nie Zun instead?”

“I...” I looked up at Nie Zun, then at Gaoqin Jiuye.

What should I do? I planned to be together with Gaoqin Jiuye once I saw him again to repay him for whatever he did, but why was it so difficult to say that I didn't love Nie Zun when I was right in front of him?

Or was it difficult to say this in front of Nie Zun now...?

Nie Zun kept his eyes on me, as if he was waiting for my answer.

I met his eyes and shook my head subconsciously. No, I shouldn't back down now. I've let Gaoqin Jiuye down and I should go back to him now. But why did I find this so difficult...?

Nie Zun spoke suddenly. “Didn't you say that you wanted to return to him when you realized it was him you were in love with when you found out about all that he did for you?”

My heart sank immediately. Why did you have to say that? Have you decided to push me away for good? You're not even the least bit upset about this...?

I wanted to shake my head, but I couldn't even speak nor do anything as I was overwhelmed with emotion.

Seeing Gaoqin Jiuye stare at me, my lips moved but nothing came out of my mouth.

So I was the one who... No, she was the one who gave the ring to Nie Zun...

Why did she have to give it to Nie Zun... Why was it so...?

Why did I fall in love with Nie Zun?

Everything seemed to be in a mess. My life and whatever I believed in seemed to be wrecked every time I recalled something from the past.

The question which Piercer asked me was something that I couldn't even answer myself. *Why did I fall in love with Nie Zun?*

Am I really me...? Or was she me?

Gaoqin Jiuye stepped closer to me, reaching out a hand at the same time. “Li Shen, I could’ve let everything go and do what I’ve always been doing, which is to protect you. But I guess I’m really the bad guy now, because I’m actually jealous of Nie Zun. I actually really hate it that you had a change of heart. I don’t want to wait any longer. I want you to leave with me.”

I snapped my head up to look at him.

Gaoqin Jiuye’s hand was right in front of me.

Emotions seemed to have gotten the better of Du Yue as she called out, “Gaoqin Jiuye!”

She called out loudly, but that was all she could say. Looking at her, I realized that there was also pain in her eyes.

My gaze then landed on Ta Lai. *Du Yue, do you love Gaoqin Jiuye, or do you love Ta Lai?*

I wondered if it was my silence or Du Yue’s shout that caused Gaoqin Jiuye to slowly retract his hand.

I glanced at Nie Zun again. His eyes looked like the surface of a very deep lake.

My heart then began its descent into a bottomless abyss.

Before Gaoqin Jiuye could take his hand back fully, I grabbed it and said, “Okay, I’ll leave with you.”

Chapter 285: 285 Falling Out With Si Luo

Volume 5

285 Falling Out With Si Luo

Clap. Clap. Clap.

Cang Ming clapped with a sardonic smirk on his face. “Gaoqin, should I be congratulating you now that you’ve finally gotten the girl of your dreams?”

Gaoqin Jiuye did not look happy even after hearing me agree to leave with him.

“Have you forgotten about this arm, Gaoqin Jiuye?” Du Yue pointed at her missing arm on her left.

Gaoqin Jiuye looked at the floor for a couple of seconds before suddenly grabbing his left hand and forcefully tearing it away from his body.

I covered my mouth in shock.

Everyone was stunned by what just happened. Gaoqin Jiuye looked up slowly, exhaustion apparent in his eyes. He threw that broken arm at Du Yue’s feet.

Du Yue’s face was full of disbelief as she stared blankly at that bloody arm near her feet.

Blood continued spurting from Gaoqin Jiuye’s left shoulder which did not show any signs of healing.

I stood rooted to the ground, unsure of what to do.

Gaoqin Jiuye walked towards me unsteadily, a piece of hair covering a part of his eye as it fell across his face.

A mysterious smile appeared on the corner of his lips as he continued looking at the floor. "I'm returning this arm to you, Du Yue. I'm too tired. All of you think that I, Gaoqin Jiuye, don't really care about anything, don't you? But I'm sick of it. I've already told you this from the very day I left the Gate of Heaven with Si Luo, that we would have nothing to do with each other from then on.

"I owe you one, but didn't you fall in love with Ta Lai too? I don't owe you anything on this. With this broken arm, we'll have nothing to do with each other from now on."

I reached out as he stumbled towards me. My eyes met Nie Zun's just as Gaoqin Jiuye fell into my arms.

An unknown pain seemed to emanate from my empty chest as Nie Zun stared at me with a profound gaze.

I could feel the tacky blood from Gaoqin Jiuye's wound as I held him. Du Yue was striding towards us with a stormy expression, but Si Luo raised an arm to block her way.

Du Yue said coldly, "Move."

Si Luo sounded casual as he spoke. "You shouldn't be stopping him now. You should've stopped him before the both of us left the Gate of Heaven years ago."

Du Yue trembled in anger. "Years ago? Don't talk about the past, Si Luo. Did Feng Zhu let you down? Why did you have to betray us and take Gaoqin Jiuye with you...? I wouldn't have turned out like this if you hadn't left. Ta Lai wouldn't have fallen in love with Bian Ying either."

Du Yue pointed a finger at Ta Lai as she spoke.

A hint of a smile appeared on Si Luo's lips. His eyes were sparkling with an otherworldly light. "You're wrong. Ta Lai and Bian Ying had been fated since a long time ago, and I had nothing to do with that. You can't blame me for that. Whether or not I ended up taking that lonely boy away from you at that time, you didn't have any right to abandon him. The both of you made that decision on your own, it wasn't something that I forced upon the two of you."

Du Yue gritted her teeth.

"I've said this before, that if I was Gaoqin Jiuye's choice, I would give him what he really wanted, no matter what it was. I would give him anything in this world, whatever it was that he wanted. I had already decided from the very moment he declared his loyalty to me when we met. I'd help him obtain whatever he wanted and nobody else had the right to destroy him. Not you, not her."

Si Luo pointed a finger at me when he said 'her'. He looked at me with dazzling eyes.

This was the first time I felt a sense of vigilance as I met his eyes.

"I've told you this before, haven't I, Li Shen? That I didn't want you to kill him. Gaoqin might be lonely, but as long as his heart still lives, I'd be able to give him everything he wishes for. But how could you wish for his death time and time again?"

I shook my head profusely. Though I didn't understand Si Luo at all, I felt that I would be destroying Gaoqin Jiuye's life if I admitted to this.

"I didn't."

An enchanting smile appeared on Si Luo. "You didn't. You didn't? Why did you have to take his hand at a time like this? Your heart isn't with Gaoqin, Li Shen. Why lie to yourself? You'd still leave him someday even if you're holding his hand now. When the time comes, you'd be the one to kill him. I will never let that happen."

A gust of wind blew across the plaza right after he spoke.

This wind was no ordinary wind. It felt like a really stable wind which caressed every inch of my skin. It felt unnatural.

Gaoqin Jiuye, who was panting lightly earlier, stood up straight. His eyes turned wary, like those of a wolf who sensed the sudden arrival of a hunter.

He pulled me closer with his remaining arm.

In my uneasiness, I asked softly, “Why isn’t your arm healing?”

“I wouldn’t be repaying a debt if it healed.” Gaoqin Jiuye answered quietly as he looked around us.

That unnatural wind continued blowing across the plaza. Jiao S came over and took my hand, but her eyes were on Si Luo.

“Don’t hurt her.” Jiao S looked at him as she spoke in her hoarse voice.

Gaoqin Jiuye’s eyes seemed to contain a warning as he turned to look at Si Luo.

Si Luo tilted his head slightly, his silvery hair falling to one side. “Jiao, I’ve said this before. Don’t go easy on me if you end up going against me someday.” The steady wind turned into something fierce right as he finished speaking.

White fog surged in Si Luo’s eyes. It was extremely similar to that fog in Gaoqin Jiuye’s eyes when he controlled air currents.

The situation then hit me. *Si Luo would actually attack me?*

He was using the technique to control air currents, the very same one that he taught Jiao S and Gaoqin Jiuye. He was making his stand very clear by using this technique against us.

My hair and dress were ruffled by the strong winds that blew across the entire plaza.

My hair whipped across my face and I felt my body sway in the wind. Si Luo kept his eyes on me the entire time as white fog continued to surge in his eyes.

Gaoqin Jiuye and Jiao S grabbed me on either side as white fog began to surge in their eyes.

I turned to the both of them and called out, “No, don’t!” *I don’t want the two of you to turn against Si Luo just because of me.*

Cang Ming looked at us with slight interest as he stood in his sultry pose. “What a weird fight. What are you thinking, Si Luo? You’re going to stop Gaoqin Jiuye when he can finally elope with the woman of his dreams?”

Ta Lai then spoke with an elegant smile. “Whatever his goal is, he isn’t doing it for Li Shen’s second personality. How about we just come clean with each other since our goals are the same, Cang Ming?”

Cang Ming raised a brow at what Ta Lai said. “Oh, how do we come clean? Li Shen doesn’t have her heart now, and she can’t summon her second personality without it. Are you telling me that we should fight over an empty shell?”

Ta Lai fiddled with the jade stone ring on his finger. “Her heart is with Nie Zun and he’s right here. Everything will be solved as long as we get the heart from Nie Zun. Since Li Shen is here too, we’d just have to capture her first. Nie Zun would definitely give up the heart once we do that.

“Nie Zun, you might fool others by pretending that you don’t care about Li Shen anymore, but I wouldn’t believe it. Do you still remember what happened in that space where your five senses were rendered useless? What did you do at the time to protect her? Did you think I’d really be unaware?”

The image of that dark space reappeared in my mind.

“I did what I did because it was a natural reaction for me after seeing you get hurt. It didn’t have anything to do with being sensitive to looming danger nor being rational during times of crisis. It was simply because you

were hurt. Everything I did was my subconscious mind telling me to protect you and take you away.”

I got more upset as I thought about what Nie Zun had said in the past. I saw Nie Zun smile as I stole a glance at him. “So, you’re trying to get Cang Ming to work with you?”

Cang Ming’s smile disappeared as a bloodthirsty expression took over. “I’m sorry, but I don’t intend to work with you, whether I’m planning to take Li Shen or not. Don’t you find games more interesting when there are more players involved?”

Si Luo wanted to attack me, while Jiao S and Gaoqin Jiuye were ready to launch counter-attacks. Ta Lai was eyeing me as well, but Cang Ming refused to work with him on this.

Du Yue stared at Cang Ming. “Do you think you’re really able to succeed alone without working together?”

Chapter 286: 286 A Messy Battle

Volume 5

286 A Messy Battle

The situation was a mess. Everything from Nie Zun's coldness to Gaoqin Jiuye's missing arm was too much for me to handle.

I pushed Jiao S and Gaoqin Jiuye away, reassuring them with a confident gaze as they both looked at me anxiously. I steadied myself in between them as I looked at everyone.

"Since the situation has come to this, how about all of us just come clean with our aims? Si Luo, I don't know what you think of me wanting to leave with Gaoqin Jiuye. I'm just wondering if you're planning to take my life at this very moment?"

Si Luo smiled. "I'm going to send you away. I've promised you in the past, that I'd send you away from the Split Zone. Now that your friends have been saved and you already know the secret of the Split Zone, I don't owe you anything more. But you haven't been able to fulfil your promises to me. I'll send you away first in that case."

Gaoqin Jiuye said, "She'd have to undo the split symbol contract with me if she wants to leave, don't you know that, Si Luo?"

Si Luo turned to him and said, "It's because I'm aware that I hope you can let go, Gaoqin. She doesn't belong here, and she isn't yours either. Why be so stubborn?"

Gaoqin Jiuye's brows knitted. "I thought you understood me, Si."

I didn't anticipate this happening. I said, "Have you forgotten, Gaoqin? You'd pick him over me every time this choice is placed before you. I hope you can pick him this time."

Gaoqin Jiuye smiled bitterly. "I can't do that."

"You can't do it? Then why were you able to do it in the past? I don't like the current you, Gaoqin Jiuye. I hope that you were just like how you were in the past, unafraid of anything. You're still you, you're Gaoqin Jiuye. You're not Li Shen's Gaoqin Jiuye. How could you say that Si Luo doesn't understand you? Do you know what I saw in Si Luo's heart?"

Si Luo interrupted me. "Li Shen."

I continued quickly before he could say anything else. "I saw the scene when Si Luo first met you, Gaoqin Jiuye. No matter what, Si Luo will be able to give you far more than what I can. You have to take his side at times like these." I then pushed him towards Si Luo lightly.

His shoulder was still bleeding as he backed away from my push, looking at me with inquiring eyes as he did so.

The ground began to quake right after that. The sudden shaking made everyone unsteady on our feet. The ground then cracked open and seawater began spurting out.

The environment changed so quickly that everyone looked stunned. I realized this was the work of someone who wasn't originally at the scene.

The ground continued cracking open as seawater began to fill the entire space. Instead of sinking, all of us were able to stand on the surface of the water as we rose with it.

This was absolutely strange.

A figure in white then descended slowly from the skies above.

The white figure had white hair that grazed his ankles, and he was beautiful like an angel. Upon closer observation, one would realize that there was this

calm masculinity in his eyes.

“Guan Nie...” Jiao S and I spoke at the same time.

Guan Nie looked down at me as he spoke, “Si Luo can give him more than what others can? How about me? Si Luo, Si Luo. Li Shen, are you going to say that Si Luo is the only one who treats Gaoqin well? What am I now?” He landed on the surface of the water as he spoke.

The water kept rising and it covered the entire plaza shortly. All I could see was an ocean.

I guess this was Guan Nie’s illusion.

“Stop playing, Guan Nie.” Gaoqin Jiuye frowned.

Guan Nie laughed in self-mockery. “Playing? You see everything I do for you as a joke? Then I’m going to play a huge joke today just to see if you can remember me for it. Isn’t everyone here today? We can all die together in this dream then.”

I realized that there was a suppressed rage behind that calm rationality in Guan Nie’s eyes. He wasn’t calm. In fact, he was already pushed to the edges of his sanity because of Gaoqin Jiuye.

Everyone seemed to be going crazy for somebody else, but they weren’t able to see the one who was going crazy for them.

Guan Nie raised both hands before waving them downwards. Dark clouds loomed above us as claps of thunder were heard.

“Raging thunder,” Guan Nie said as he waved a hand. The entire sky turned dark immediately as thunderous claps and lightning began appearing.

“Move.” Gaoqin Jiuye pushed me away with his remaining hand. I ended up a few meters away, as if I had just skid on the water surface.

At this very moment, a thunderbolt struck the empty space between me and Gaoqin Jiuye, splattering the water.

Jiao S's eyes widened as white fog began to surge in them. Defensive screens of water rose around us.

Gaoqin Jiuye lost his balance and fell into the water after being hit by the ricochet. However, he floated on the surface instead of sinking into the water.

"Gaoqin Jiuye," I called out. However, Jiao S stopped me before I could rush over to help him up.

Another thunderbolt came crashing down right in front of me. The water hit my face hard as it splattered onto it. I called out urgently, "Piercer!"

Piercer had already turned back into a whip, but she transformed into human form upon my call.

"Go help him," I said as I pointed to Gaoqin Jiuye. Piercer nodded and shot towards Gaoqin Jiuye immediately.

As Gaoqin Jiuye struggled to get up, he called out, "Shen Qi!"

With a black ray, Shen Qi appeared in human form. He and Piercer supported Gaoqin Jiuye as he got up.

Si Luo looked like a beautiful deity with those flowy white robes and the red emblem glowing between his brows as he floated on the water surface. His palms were placed against each other as white fog clouded his pupils. A hurricane swept upwards from the surface of the water as it went straight for Guan Nie.

Si Luo would actually attack Guan Nie?

Guan Nie was quick to react. With a series of complicated hand signs, the fight between them began. Thunderbolts struck from the sky as pillars of water continued to rise from the water surface.

Cang Ming laughed maniacally as he held onto his sword. "Ta Lai, are you going to miss out on this great opportunity? How about we exchange blows instead of having a war of words? Since there's only one woman we're

aiming for, we can decide the winner right now. Whoever wins can go ahead and take Li Shen after that.”

It might be that audacious tone that triggered Ta Lai to lose his patience. He lost that gentlemanly smile as he motioned with his fingers, controlling the three giants. They charged towards Cang Ming with loud roars.

Ta Lai spoke coldly. “We’ll decide upon a winner today. It’s also about time that you return Bian Ying to me.”

Du Yue looked wrought with emotion as she stood upon this roaring ocean. She must be feeling overwhelmed with Gaoqin Jiuye breaking his arm and Ta Lai fighting with Cang Ming over Bian Ying. She probably felt that whatever she did came to naught at this point.

Nie Zun’s black coat was flapping in the wind while Jie Pa stood silently behind him.

Du Yue saw that Shen Qi and Piercer were supporting Gaoqin Jiuye as they led him towards me. She raised a hand and waved it downwards in my direction.

“Drop,” she said. Though I was a little afraid, nothing happened eventually.

She was shocked when her attack had no effect on me before she realized why after a short moment. “You’re actually no longer affected by this attack since Nie Zun took your heart.”

Du Yue used this technique by forcing a person’s heart to crash into the ground. She could make hearts feel like they were sinking for as long as she wished. But this technique did not work on me after Nie Zun took my heart away.

She did not give up. With a wave of her hand, a fiery qilin appeared from the dark sky and gave a thunderous roar as it charged right at me.

Jiao S said coldly, “As expected of a formidable opponent to be able to summon a qilin within an illusion.”

Grabbing the air with her right hand, she pulled a gigantic sword from behind her before charging towards Du Yue.

I broke out in cold sweat. *You're praising Du Yue when you're also able to pull your sword out while in an illusion?*

Chapter 287: 287 Jiao's versus Du Yue!

Volume 5

287 Jiao S versus Du Yue!

Jiao S's sword glinted as it was raised high in the air. The sky was turning darker and darker, making it look as if we were under a heavily-polluted ocean as more and more dark clouds gathered above us. The water was choppy and just like being on a tiny boat in a rough ocean; everyone was unsteady on their feet.

Unlike me, the rest still had MF at their disposal. They could use some of their MF to balance themselves on the water surface even as they engaged in battle. I was no different from an ordinary human being without MF, and it was thanks to my experience in previous fights that prevented me from falling head-first into the water!

Guan Nie's illusion was rather unusual. Though we might lose our balance on the water, we would never end up sinking into it!

Splash!

I lost my balance and fell forwards as a huge wave rocked me! It felt like falling face-first into a massive puddle of water as I ended up choking on the water!

I coughed while struggling to get up from the slippery surface. As expected, there was no one who could look out for me at this juncture! They could all

use their MF to float a little above the surface, while I was the only one who couldn't!

"I'd not have deactivated my split symbol if I had known this would happen!" I mumbled to myself as I stood up clumsily. Looking at Scorpion Ray on my left wrist, I asked, "Is it really not possible to summon you without MF, my precious?"

"What are you mumbling about, Ah Shen? Be careful!" Jiao S was stepping on a steady platform created by focusing air currents below her feet as she turned around to give me a reminder even though she was engaged in a fierce battle with the fiery qilin.

Gaoqin Jiuye steadied himself with the help of Piercer and Shen Qi. The blood stains on his top had already been diluted with all this water! His hair was a mess, but his eyes were as bright as the sparks produced by striking a flint.

He pushed Piercer away with his remaining hand and said, "Go protect her!"

Shen Qi supported him, playing the role of Gaoqin Jiuye's right hand while holding his shoulder and helping him find his balance upon the water.

Seeing Gaoqin Jiuye more or less settled, Piercer was back by my side in a split second. I was still unsteady in the water, and Piercer helped pull me out of it.

"You might just die here today if I didn't happen to be your living weapon. Who asked you to deactivate your split symbol on a whim." Piercer pulled me up into the air with her as she berated me gently.

With her skillful manipulation of air currents, Jiao S jumped through the air with agility. Her sword lengthened and shortened seemingly randomly as she attacked, and the fiery qilin looked like it was having a difficult time going against her.

Jiao S controlled the air currents well and because she was petite, she could be extremely fast in the air. Her sword was fast too, and when it enlarged, it could reflect the fireballs that the qilin spat at her.

She deflected the fire attacks with no difficulty. This might probably be because Feng, Huo and Lei used to always be by her side in the past, so it was not difficult for her to deflect attacks of a similar nature.

Du Yue seemed to find the performance of her qilin unsatisfactory as she shouted, “Withdraw!”

The qilin then roared at the sky before transforming into a fiery halberd! The halberd was red in color and engulfed in bright flames!

Unfazed by the angry flames, Du Yue jumped into the air and grabbed that fiery halberd with a raised hand! She looked like a goddess of war as she held her weapon high.

“As expected from the most domineering female soul splitter in the Split Zone. She has this aura of not taking any prisoners.” Though Piercer praised Du Yue’s abilities, she did not look the least bit fearful.

This made me a little upset since she praised Du Yue when Jiao S was fighting against her. I rolled my eyes and said, “Jiao S is no weakling either. I don’t think she’d lose to a soul splitter like Du Yue in terms of aura or ability.”

Right after I spoke, Jiao S summoned great waves behind her with an angry stare. She waved her left hand in Du Yue’s direction and the water turned into countless tiny droplets as they shot towards Du Yue!

Her gigantic sword lengthened as she directed the water droplets towards Du Yue with a wave!

With a cold gaze, Du Yue waved her halberd to form a fiery screen in an attempt to parry Jiao S’s attack!

Jiao S’s attack was executed perfectly, and it was as quick as lightning!

The water in between them began to churn suddenly, as if affected by the strong waves of MF!

Du Yue's fiery screen did not look weak at all, but her speed was just a bit slower than Jiao S's!

Being slower than the enemy spelled certain death in battle!

Though Du Yue didn't end up dying with this attack, I could see the killing intent rise in her eyes as Jiao S's water droplets scratched her face!

Bloody lines appeared on that white skin of hers, and they were slow to heal!

"How dare you..." She stared at Jiao S with gritted teeth. A burning flame emerged in Du Yue's eyes, and she suddenly threw her fiery halberd into the air above her!

The bright red body of the halberd looked like it could split the sky in half! Du Yue's fingers bent, as if she was controlling the halberd in the air!

Jiao S backed away, using her gigantic sword as a shield as she sensed looming danger. I said to Piercer, "You have to go help Jiao S if she ends up being in danger later!"

In her purple dress, Piercer stared at me. "Help her? Li Shen, look at this place. Who's the one who needs more help and protection here? You can't even stand properly without my help!"

I wanted to argue, but I knew she was right. I would fall face-first into this muddy-looking water once she let go!

The other two fights were getting intense as well. Guan Nie continued to create thunderbolts as he maintained this illusion. Si Luo was quick to dodge, and it was lucky that the bulk of the thunderbolts did not hit anywhere near us, or some of us might end up getting hurt!

Cang Ming and Ta Lai were engaged in a fierce battle. Ta Lai maintained his elegant image by using those giants to fight Cang Ming, and Cang Ming

did not forget to look audacious even in this fight. He actually looked like he was enjoying himself!

I couldn't really see Nie Zun and Jie Pa as the waves continued to get higher and higher!

Du Yue no longer held back as she launched her next attack. She controlled that halberd in the air as it dropped fireballs into the water. These fireballs exploded upon touching the water surface!

Jiao S dodged the fireballs with her agility but she began turning grim once they started to rain at a quicker rate!

Though Piercer was holding me, I felt like I was being swung all over the place on this rough sea.

“Hey hey hey stop moving!” I couldn't stand it any longer. The entire sky was black, and the water was also black without a hint of blue. It looked like a giant vat of dye.

Piercer did not have any intention of letting go. “Stop moving? That's all you can think of when you're about to die?”

A killing intent emerged in Gaoqin Jiuye's eyes right at this moment! Moving with Shen Qi's help, Gaoqin Jiuye drew a long, black sword from Shen Qi!

Shen Qi was able to produce a separate sword for Gaoqin Jiuye even in human form!

Swoosh!

Gaoqin Jiuye waved the sword in the air, producing a dazzling black ray of light!

Waves surged in Gaoqin Jiuye's eyes!

Du Yue looked at him in disbelief. “You're really going to fight me for that woman?! Or are you helping Jiao S?! Gaoqin Jiuye!”

Gaoqin Jiuye looked resolute. “Du Yue, I’ve already repaid my debt. This wouldn’t have happened if you guys had stayed in the Gate of Heaven peacefully! Those from the Gate of Heaven are always this greedy! What have you gained from all those experiments and from sacrificing so many things?! Bian Ying, whom you hate, is still living well!”

“Shut up! Gaoqin Jiuye, you have no right to say this to me! You have no right to look at me this way! Do you think you’re not pitiful? Huh? Look with your own two eyes. This is the very woman you could give everything for. This is the woman you wanted to save by bringing her over to the Split Zone at the expense of hurting me!”

Chapter 288: 288 A Heartless Nie Zun?

Volume 5

288 A Heartless Nie Zun?

“Look at you now. What have you gained? She doesn’t even remember you. Even now, she doesn’t recall anything about you. Let’s not even begin talking about the promises you made to her. Nie Zun is the one she loves right now.”

I was getting confused. *Did Du Yue love Gaoqin Jiuye or Ta Lai?*

“Hey woman, can you stop it already? I’m the one you’re fighting against now but you’re actually looking somewhere else and nagging at them instead of focusing on me? Are you looking down on me?” Jiao S asked Du Yue coldly.

Du Yue glared at her. “Who do you think you are? Don’t think that you’re really able to win me just because you were able to approach me once with those meager skills of yours.”

She then bent her fingers further, making it look as if each of them had one extra joint. That halberd began burning in midair.

Something out of the ordinary happened.

Fire began to spread from the halberd and the flames grew to engulf the sky.

The entire sky was painted with flames, as if there was gasoline feeding the fire. The flames crackled as it burnt bright. It looked like Du Yue had just

set the entire sky on fire.

Du Yue's face glowed with a red sheen under the fiery sky and she looked like a lunatic as she said, "I'll grant your wishes of dying since all of you are mere heirs who're already living like trash."

Jiao S scoffed. "It's no wonder neither Gaoqin Jiuye nor Ta Lai are interested in you. You're not a woman; you're just a female devil."

Her black hair flew in the wind as she jumped into the air and pressed her palms together. A glinting sword then appeared in between her palms as she pulled them apart.

The air started quaking around us. Though I didn't have any MF right now, I could tell from past experience that Jiao S did not cause this.

When I saw the white fog in both Gaoqin Jiuye and Si Luo's eyes, I realized that all three of them were using more than eighty percent of their MF to control the air currents around us.

The three of them actually formed a triangle. Although a triangular formation was one of the most stable ones to take in a battle, the air currents would end up being unbalanced if they were not working together.

All of them were not at the same level of ability in terms of controlling the air currents either.

This meant that it could possibly result in a major clash. But the scariest part about this was that...

I didn't have a goddamned ounce of MF in me.

It felt like an earthquake that was of magnitude 8. I was just like an ordinary human being right now, and I had to rely on my living weapon to balance myself. I could already imagine how I'd just be strewn all over the place like a rubber ball if these air currents clashed.

Piercer shared my sentiments as she said, "This is bad. Keep your focus. If you can't use MF, try to at least focus on me. I can only protect you when

we're of one heart and mind. I might have to fish you out of the water if you continue being distracted like this."

She made it sound like I'd turn into a pond loach at any moment...

Gaoqin Jiuye and Jiao S were working together, and though Du Yue was enraged, a sinister smile appeared on her lips.

That smile was hair-raising.

"Simple tricks are all you can do even when you guys work together. You'll be able to stay alive with that, but have you thought about her?" Du Yue smiled as she twisted and turned her hand in a series of motions.

Fireballs started raining down from the sky as she did so, and it covered such a large area that everyone had to make dodging them the first priority.

These fireballs did not come down vertically. They had a slanted trajectory, but upon closer look, I realized they were targeting just one spot as if they were bullets from a submachine gun.

Their target was me.

"What the hell! You're targeting me even when I'm without MF now!"

I complained at how sadistic Du Yue was while I struggled to dodge these fireballs by half-crawling and rolling about in the water. If I ended up injured, it would take forever to heal without MF.

If a fireball hit me, I believe that apart from feeling like a huge rock dropped onto me, I'd probably feel myself burn.

I had no interest in playing with fire, but I didn't have any MF either... So, all I could do was roll around in the water.

I had already lost sight of Piercer when I heard her call out. "What are you running for, Li Shen? Don't go hiding on your own. Follow me! Damn it, Li Shen, come back here!"

With all the time I spent in the Split Zone, I knew for sure that I definitely feared pain in a situation where I had zero MF.

I hit somebody's chest as I was continually rolling around in the water. A pair of starry eyes met mine as I looked up, but instead of joy, I felt a distant coldness.

Nie Zun held me as he said, "I'll get Jie Pa to take you away from here."

Pushing him away with gritted teeth, I answered, "I don't think you need to care whether I end up living or dying. Didn't you want to go separate ways?"

Nie Zun looked at me. "You don't want your heart?"

I smirked. "Would you have taken it if you're planning to return it? Are you going to say that you took it in order to protect me now? Nie Zun, I believe everything you say. I've never believed that you didn't love me anymore, and I believe that you have your reasons for doing whatever you did. I believe that you have a goal in mind. I've never doubted that.

"Because you're somebody calm and intelligent. But Nie Zun, what I'd like to tell you is that you deserve to be lonely. Didn't you say that you'd protect me forever? Didn't you say that you wouldn't lie to me, that you'd tell me everything? If you're lying to me in order to protect me, then I have a question for you. Have you ever trusted me, Nie Zun?"

Jie Pa appeared from behind Nie Zun before he could respond. "Please calm down, Miss Ah Shen. Now's not the time to be talking about this. All of them are targeting your second personality, and the consequences could be disastrous if our actions are driven by emotions. Come with me first, and we can talk about this when it's safer to do so."

I looked at Jie Pa coldly. "You weren't like this in the past, Jie Pa. Even though you were always on Nie Zun's side, you were still logical, Jie. Can you really bear to see the both of us like this?"

Jie Pa adjusted his glasses and regarded me with a serious look. “Ah Shen, this is the first time I’m not addressing you as Miss Ah Shen. Even if all that you’ve just said is true, have you ever thought about things from another perspective? Have you trusted Nie Zun when you’re complaining about him not trusting you?”

I was slightly stunned.

He continued. “Of course, it’s not merely because of Nie Zun that I’m willing to stay loyal to you. Ah Shen, have you wondered why Nie Zun ended up here? Who was the one who gave him that ring? Can you really ignore everything that happened even if Nie Zun and I don’t blame you for it? To be fair, Miss Ah Shen, don’t you think you’re being a little too unreasonable here?”

My mind was telling me that I had to stay calm, and I knew that Jie Pa didn’t say anything wrong. *Why did I feel so upset though? Was it my pride?*

The more upset I felt, the more empty the space in my chest felt. It was as if I couldn’t really feel anything. Even if Nie Zun said he loved me right at this moment, I didn’t have a heart to contain his love.

Nie Zun looked at me with an unfathomable gaze. “I can explain everything, but only if you’re willing to accept her.”

I didn’t get it at first, but a face appeared in my mind a moment later.

I turned defensive immediately. “You’re referring to, her?”

Nie Zun nodded slowly.

The water turned rough and choppy just as I was about to lose my temper.

Thunderous roars were heard from the horizon. It sounded like a terrifying beast which finally found its reason to fight.

I fell into the water once again, but Piercer grabbed me this time as she said to Nie Zun, “Return the heart to her, I can protect her.”

Nie Zun shook his head. “It’s not to protect her that I’ve taken her heart away. Although it does nullify the effect of Du Yue’s lockdown technique and makes it seem like she can’t summon her second personality.”

Chapter 289: 289 Mysterious Sea Mirage

Volume 5

289 Mysterious Sea Mirage

Jie Pa rushed over with an outstretched hand. “Miss Ah Shen, please leave with me!”

Before I could respond, I heard Guan Nie’s voice from the heavens. “Leave? Haha, don’t even think about leaving this illusion! It’s not just a couple of days that you guys have been chasing after one another like this. Gaoqin, it’s too tiring to chase after you. It’s either I die or you guys settle the matter once and for all today!”

The sky literally collapsed a few meters after he drew some sign in the air. It looked as if it could fall and crush every single one of us in a second!

Jie Pa turned grim. “This is bad! He can actually use this technique where he seals the illusion with MF! No one can leave the illusion since it can only be undone if he’s willing to do it or if his life force is diminished!”

Life force diminished? Doesn’t that mean death? Do you have to phrase it in such an artful way...

Nie Zun’s brows knitted. “I know only a little bit about illusions, and barriers are your forte. But from what I know, there would be a point of entry to any form of barrier, and there’s no such thing as a perfectly fortified barrier, just like how there wouldn’t be an unbreakable shield. Furthermore, this is the Split Zone, and everything is based on one’s consciousness and

MF. What if he doesn't die but his MF goes down to zero? Would this illusion still be unbreakable?"

Jie Pa shook his head. "This environment was created differently from how illusions are usually created. Do you still remember Huan Qing's last line of defense? Huan Qing created that with the last bit of his remaining MF, and its strength is similar to that of this sea we're witnessing right now. As the top illusionist in the Southern District, Huan Qing would have used the usual methods to create it, but Guan Nie did it differently.

"I suspect this has something to do with why he can use such restricted techniques, but I don't know who he learnt these techniques from, and even I haven't seen something like this before. The crux of his technique is very similar to a last line of defense, but it isn't created with the last bit of MF."

I was absolutely confused upon hearing this explanation.

Jie Pa continued. "But like what you said, nothing is invincible, even in the Split Zone where things run seemingly contrary to the real world. If I'm right, the scene we're witnessing is a result of combining an illusion and a barrier, and Guan Nie is smart enough to place the key to breaking the barrier outside of our immediate environment."

With that, I understood it a little better. "So it's not that the illusion is unbreakable, it's just that it has to be broken from the outside?"

Jie Pa adjusted his glasses as he answered. "You're absolutely right, Miss Ah Shen. The structure of this illusion is complex as it combines with its natural elements. The point of entry is also placed outside, so somebody has to pour MF into it from the outside to be able to break it. That very MF used has to be powerful as well, and since the illusion is set up so well, pouring MF from one side is not enough. Somebody has to do the same thing from the inside at the same time. This would then create a point of entry to undo the illusion."

I looked up at the dark sky. "So we need someone out there who can help us, and that someone can't just be any ordinary person. That someone has to have high MF, and we have to at least know who it is. Apart from that, that

individual also had to be able to have some sort of telepathy with at least one of us in here?”

Jie Pa nodded as he answered, “Yes.”

I deadpanned. “Wouldn’t that be impossible then...”

It had been such a long time since the three of us talked like this, and I suddenly found myself missing old times when Nie Zun and I literally stuck together all day. *I really missed the old days.*

But there was no time for me to reminisce the past as Guan Nie drew another sign while facing the ocean of water. I grabbed Piercer’s hand tight in anticipation of huge waves!

However, instead of crashing waves, the water turned calm all of a sudden!

The choppy sea turned into a peaceful surface. I was still trying to catch my breath from the rough waves that hit me earlier, and I was feeling a little chilly from being drenched with all the water from before.

With the calmness came a disturbing sea breeze. Everyone seemed to freeze for a moment, probably surprised by the sudden stillness.

Jiao S and Du Yue were fiercely engaged in battle, and the sea turned quiet all of a sudden just as Du Yue seemed to be ready to launch a large-scale attack. This caused Du Yue to hold her hand as she looked around her warily.

That flaming halberd seemed to pause in the air.

Cang Ming’s sword glinted as he used it to cut down two of Ta Lai’s giants. Ta Lai’s expression had never changed as he continued fiddling with that jade stone ring on his right hand. Cang Ming slowed down as he sensed the stillness, and Ta Lai looked down at the water surface.

Guan Nie was not targeting Si Luo with this move, and I couldn’t tell how powerful of an attack this was from the get-go.

Si Luo stopped in his tracks upon seeing Guan Nie pause. *That's Si Luo... If it was somebody else, they might have just used this opportunity for an attack.*

The bloodlust and killing intent that was apparent in the environment did not diminish in the least even in the stillness.

Just when everyone paused to observe the situation, I felt something moving from under the water, as if there was something trying to break out from it. Panting and wiping the water from my face, I muttered to Piercer, "Can you hear it? There seems to be something under the water."

I held my breath as I tried to focus on the sound that came from under the water.

"Huu..."

"Huu..."

It sounded like the sound of somebody breathing.

No, it was the sound of a group of people breathing...

I was focused on the sound when all of a sudden!

"Sss!!!"

A shrill cry seemed to pierce right through my chest!

I flinched in shock!

Piercer grabbed me, frowning. "What's wrong with you? I can't hear anything. You've been acting a little weird!"

Cold sweat covered my entire body as she said that.

I looked at her as I shivered. "You, you, what did you say? You mean you can't hear this weird sound?"

Piercer looked at me. “I really cannot hear a thing. What else is there apart from the sound of the wind and water?”

“Sss...!!!”

It sounded like the cry of a soul that was crawling its way up from hell, and it pierced right through my ears. The terrifying part was that it sounded like it was coming closer and closer, and nobody else seemed to be able to hear it but me!

If something like this happened in the real world, I’d think it was a ghost. *But there aren’t any ghosts in the Split Zone! Why was I the only one who could hear it...*

Horried by the sounds, I looked up at the all-white Guan Nie. “What did you do, Guan Nie? Why are there weird sounds coming from under the water?!”

Guan Nie did not look as beautiful as before with that dark and eerie sky as a backdrop. *I guess beautiful things had to be appreciated in the right atmosphere too...*

Guan Nie asked in surprise, “You, you can hear them?!”

This just made me even more terrified. *Should I not be hearing it then?*

Everyone else looked at me with inquiring eyes. This just proved that none of them could hear it.

Guan Nie’s gaze turned from one of surprise to an intense one.

The sea began turning choppy when I looked back up at him.

Everyone could feel the change as they looked down at the water.

The sounds were getting too much to bear at this point, and I wanted to cover both my ears.

The sounds then vanished just as I was about to do that.

The water surface turned still for a second.

But it was only for a second.

In the very next second, countless figures rose up from the water!

Splash! Splash! Splash!

Before I knew it, there was a crowd standing on the water surface!

“This...” Even Piercer was rendered slack-jawed at the sight!

What was more shocking was that all these figures were people whom we recognized!

Huan Qing was standing right at the front. There was also Mi Fu, Song Lu, Yu Liang, and others whom I didn’t recognize!

There was one figure who caught my attention. It was Old Man Fan!

Nie Zun stared at the figures, as if dumbfounded after witnessing something impossible.

Jie Pa directed his gaze to wherever it was that Nie Zun was looking at. He looked perplexed as he spoke with a slight tremble in his voice.

“Your sister... Why is she here...?”

Chapter 290: 290 Those Who Were Dead

Volume 5

290 Those Who Were Dead

What?!

Nie Zun's older sister!

I looked towards the direction in which they were looking at, but I couldn't see anyone!

There seemed to be a huge crowd when the figures rose up earlier, but upon a closer look, there were but a few of them!

“Old Man Fan...”

I realized quickly that everyone else was also staring at the figures that had just appeared! It was as if everyone had seen somebody they recognized in that crowd!

Guan Nie said coldly, “No need for doubt and worry. These figures you're seeing aren't real people, they're just illusions!”

I heaved a sigh of relief, but I caught my breath halfway.

If these were illusions, doesn't that mean Guan Nie was planning to use them against us? But why would anyone tell their opponents that these were illusions the very moment they were created?

I didn't know what Guan Nie was planning at all!

“What do you have up your sleeve!” A cold voice asked Guan Nie.

Who is this? It wasn't me!

Looking up at the source of the voice, I realized it was Du Yue. She was levitating in midair!

Du Yue looked uncomfortable. *Did she also see someone she cared about?!*

I looked towards the figures staring at me with blank faces.

Huan Qing, Mi Fu, Song Lu, Yu Liang, Old Man Fan, and...

My parents...

And...

Gao Qi and Pomelo were actually standing right at the very end!

“How could it, how could it be... Ah...!” I covered my mouth as I called out. What I saw was Gao Qi drenched entirely in blood!

Gaoqin Jiuye appeared beside me with Shen Qi supporting him. He was still pale and his gaze wavered as he asked, “You see him too?”

I turned to him. “You, you can see it too...?”

Gaoqin Jiuye continued, “You're able to see others apart from him, right?”

I nodded.

Gaoqin Jiuye said, “I can't though. He's the only one I can see.”

I was stunned.

Jie Pa spoke. “If that's the case, this means that we are all seeing different people. We're looking at those we fear meeting the most, so they're all

different.”

So Gaoqin Jiuye and I actually feared the same person. *Were we both afraid of Gao Qi...?*

Gaoqin Jiuye couldn't bear it any longer as he looked at Guan Nie with an upset expression. “What are you trying to do?”

There was a gentle light in Guan Nie's eyes. “I've told you that none of them are real. Don't forget that all of you are in my illusion now, and all you're seeing is but a mere hallucination.”

Then why did you even do this?!

I was at a loss for words. *Why did you have to do this if it was a hallucination? Why did you have to do this and tell us they were illusions?*

A thought struck me out of nowhere. *Could it be... could it be that...*

He wasn't planning on using these illusions to attack us at all?

So he didn't actually have to hide the fact that they were illusions?

I didn't have to wonder for much longer as I quickly found out why he did so.

Gao Qi, who was drenched in blood, walked towards me unhurriedly. He did not rush to strangle me, nor did he look like he blamed me for anything. He simply looked at me with a blank expression.

Running away doesn't solve anything, and even though my legs were trembling, I forced myself to move forward slowly. “Are you... Gao Qi...?”

That blank face bloomed as if woken up from years of slumber. He spoke with a slightly rigid expression. “Ah Shen, do you miss me?”

I swear this did not sound the least bit sweet in the current situation. It was, in fact, terrifying!

Just imagine a dead person asking you if you missed him.

Gao Qi was different from Old Man Fan and the rest. He was somebody who actually existed and lived in the real world, and he was also dead.

“How is it possible that I can see you...”

As I was muttering to myself, Gaoqin Jiuye spoke suddenly. “I get it now. This is definitely an illusion. But he’s not making use of these figures, of people whom we’re afraid of meeting, to attack us. It doesn’t seem to make any sense.”

“Then why did he do this?”

“He’s waging a psychological battle. Everyone would end up being distracted with the appearance of these people.”

Gaoqin Jiuye was absolutely right. Guan Nie resumed his battle with Si Luo immediately when these figures seemed to have worked their effectiveness!

There was a long sword in his hand this time around!

It looked like an ordinary sword, but I’ve never seen Guan Nie use a sword!

Guan Nie kept his eyes on Si Luo as he raised his sword. “I’m curious, just who did you see?”

Si Luo’s expression remained rather indifferent as he simply scanned through the crowd of figures.

“What if I say that I can’t see anyone?” Si Luo answered with a smile.

A cold glint flashed past Guan Nie’s eyes. “You shouldn’t be able to see anyone, since you don’t care about anyone else but yourself. It’s an excuse when you say you’re trying to save the weak, because all you’ve ever thought about is yourself!”

Si Luo looked at him casually. “Do you hate me so because of Gaoqin?”

Guan Nie scoffed, “No. I hate you so because I just cannot stand the sight of people like you who say they’re protecting their residents when you’re actually doing nothing at all!”

Si Luo smiled. “You’re not being truthful.”

Guan Nie narrowed his eyes. “You’ll know if I’m really speaking from my heart once we begin the fight!”

Raising his sword, he said, “Everyone in this illusion will see the ones they are most afraid to face. These people aren’t real, they’re all illusions, and they cannot attack anyone either. The reason I summoned them was to let you guys take a look at them while we fight! It won’t be an easy task if you’re being watched by someone you fear!”

Before I could grasp the entirety of the situation, Guan Nie had already launched his attack.

Both Nie Zun and Jie Pa were still staring into space at the figure they referred to as Nie Zun’s sister.

Muscular Cang Ming and lanky Ta Lai were facing each other. Though they looked extremely different physically, they had the exact same look on their faces!

It sort of stunned me. They were both staring into space, as if they had just been hit on the head with a hammer!

I then realized that the both of them must have seen Bian Ying!

Ta Lai lost his usual elegance when he spoke. “Even an illusion of Bian Ying can appear here. I guess this is really a test for us to try not to be distracted by the people we have in our hearts.”

Cang Ming smirked. “But they are still illusions. I believe we’ve seen hundreds of thousands of them by now. But look at these, especially that of my woman. Don’t these illusions look too real?”

Ta Lai was not polite with Cang Ming as he stared at him, asking, “Bian Ying isn’t your woman.”

Cang Ming cackled. “How do you know that?”

He swooped in closer to Ta Lai, blinking as he said, “Would you still want her if I said I already took her?”

Ta Lai paused his fiddling of that jade stone ring for a moment before answering, “Why would I not want something that belongs to me? It would still be mine even if it’s broken.”

I found this rather interesting. Ta Lai, Cang Ming and Bian Ying seemed to have a complicated relationship, and as for Gaoqin Jiuye, Nie Zun and I...

Before my mind could go any further, I caught sight of the bloody Gao Qi. He no longer had a blank expression. He looked exactly like the Gao Qi I remembered when I was alive. “I miss you so much, Ah Shen.”

Dear lord! This illusion could actually talk? What he just said made me weak in my knees!

I would have gone mad with happiness if I still thought that he was the one I loved, but I’m now aware that Gaoqin Jiuye was the one I actually loved. Furthermore, I didn’t forget that I was the very person who stabbed him in the chest!

I retreated hastily as he advanced towards me with an outstretched hand. “No, don’t come any closer!”

“Ah Shen, you’re not the one who killed me. I’m the one who deserved to die. Don’t be sad...” A smile appeared on Gao Qi’s bloody face. That enchanting look and voice were the exact same ones that made me fall for him!

“Ah!” I couldn’t bear the sight of Gao Qi’s bloody hands and that huge, bleeding wound on his chest. I backed away as quickly as I can, too afraid to take another look at him!

But running away doesn't solve anything, and when I turned around in an attempt to run, I was met with Pomelo!

Pomelo looked like she was in agony as she reached out toward me, seemingly in an attempt to hug me. She said, "How are you doing, Ah Shen? I'm here to see you."

Chapter 291: 291 Real Solitude

Volume 5

291 Real Solitude

“No.”

I shook my head vigorously as I tried to push Pomelo away from me.

I didn't want her hug. I didn't want it.

Something out of the ordinary happened at this moment.

My hands weren't able to touch her. They simply went through her.

In my surprise, I had forgotten that I had no MF left in me right now. Losing my balance, I passed through Pomelo and fell face-down into the sea.

I choked on the salty seawater before I felt the collar of my dress being dragged upwards.

Piercer grabbed me as she said, “Have you forgotten what Guan Nie said, Ah Shen? These are merely illusions. Don't be confused by them.”

Sister, it's not a matter of being confused or not. I knew these were illusions, and everyone else could see the very person they were most afraid to face. The visual stimuli would definitely distract them and slow them down.

I wondered if this was Guan Nie's real goal. Everyone seemed to be scanning their surroundings for something during their fights. Being

distracted will only give your opponents more opportunities to attack and this might possibly end with both sides getting gravely hurt.

Somebody appeared behind me just as I was about to ask Guan Nie what he was playing at.

I pulled at Piercer, signaling for her to stop running. I turned around to look at the individual behind me.

Piercer did the same.

It was Gao Qi. He was looking at me with a complex expression. Though he looked exactly like Gaoqin Jiuye, I realized I could actually tell them apart.

“Gao Qi...” I was a little taken aback when I saw him appear a while ago, and even though I was still a little uneasy about it, I was much calmer now.

Gao Qi looked pitiful drenched in blood, but there was this gentle light in his eyes.

As I set my eyes upon him again, it felt like I was a bystander looking at myself. *Even if he had a psychological disorder, couldn't I have just talked to him about it? Why did we have to end up in this place?*

Everything was a mess. Illusions were everywhere, and everyone was being distracted. I guess Guan Nie did this because he simply wanted to see our reactions when we see these people.

Piercer gave me a reminder. “Ah Shen, you have to be careful of whoever you're able to see. I'm not able to see them.”

I shook my head. “It's no use running away from things. I owe him one anyway. I know you have my interests at heart, but let me handle it on my own this time, Piercer. If Guan Nie's creations are really just illusions, then what I'm seeing now is simply whatever that has been buried in my heart. No one would be able to help me on this if I can't overcome it on my own.”

I let go of Piercer as I finished.

Taking a deep breath, I walked towards Gao Qi. I could feel my eyelid twitching as I asked, “Gao Qi, are you... from my heart, or from that world?”

The question just escaped me even when I didn’t plan on saying anything like it.

Gao Qi looked at me gently, making me feel as if I was trapped in those eyes.

He grabbed me in a sudden embrace when I was trying to think of responses to possible answers he would give.

My train of thought was cut off abruptly. Everything seemed to be spinning around me.

The last thing I remembered was us falling on our sides into the icy water.

This time, instead of floating on the surface, we sank continuously.

It was cold and dark as I sunk into the ocean.

Gao Qi had me in a tight embrace, but for some reason, his presence seemed to diminish the longer I was in the water.

Light was sparse in this illusion, and falling into the dark water made it all the more darker.

Without MF, I struggled in the water.

Just continue sinking. I can’t do this anymore. Just let me die here... That was all I could think of.

I was tired of life in the Split Zone.

I felt exhausted.

There used to be people around me when I felt tired, but I was all alone now.

Pessimistic thoughts were like seaweed which grew non-stop. They would get larger and messier once we start thinking about them.

Imagine if a good person was crossing the bridge over a river infested with monsters and demons. Even if that individual did not want to look down, there would definitely be something or someone trying to drag that individual into the river. This was how it felt like.

Pessimistic thoughts were like a pair of hands that had the ability to drag people down.

“Ah Shen.”

I heard a familiar voice out of nowhere.

Is it her?

“Ah Shen. Ah Shen.”

No, it isn't her.

But this sounded so familiar. *Did I become retarded after being in the water? Why couldn't I recall who the voice belonged to?*

“Wake up, Ah Shen.”

When I tried to open my eyes, I realized that I hadn't even closed them at all. It was the darkness in the water that made it feel as if I had my eyes closed.

I simply couldn't see anything in here.

“Wake up, Ah Shen,” that overly-familiar voice continued.

What do I do? I just don't recall it. I can't react to it either.

“Ah Shen, listen well. You're in Guan Nie's dark illusion right now. This is different from his previous illusions, because there is demonic energy in here. Because of his suppressed feelings, Guan Nie might have been used

by others. Those without demonic energy cannot create such an illusion. This is considered a banned technique in the field of illusions.”

That voice continued talking to me even when I did not respond.

“It’s difficult to break such an illusion, and even if I can help you out from the outside right now, you’re not able to work with me in saving everyone since you don’t have an ounce of MF in you right now.”

Save everyone... Who’d be saving me then?

“Listen to my words carefully now. I gave you the Scorpion Ray on your left hand. Do you remember that?”

I finally realized who it was.

Joy filled me for about half a minute before a frown appeared on my face.

I thought that Li Qing was in the Gate of Ghost, and the last time we met, I could tell she still had some errands to run there. The Gate of Ghost and the Gate of Heaven were very far from each other, and it wouldn’t be easy to travel to and fro even if she was a soul splitter. *Why would she be here in the Gate of Heaven right now?*

Even if she did travel to the Gate of Heaven, how is it so coincidental that she knew where I was? How did she manage to rush here just in time to save me?

“Ah Shen, listen to me carefully.

“It’s not about whether I can save you guys right now. You’ve already been infested with the demonic energy from this dark illusion. It isn’t much of a problem usually, but you don’t have MF and you don’t have your heart. Nie Zun might have wanted to protect you, but this was a misstep. I don’t think anyone here is aware that Guan Nie had been affected by demonic energy, and this is why nobody knows that it can hurt you.

“Guan Nie would be able to find you soon now that you’re in the water, since he created this entire ocean. All of you were originally on the surface

of the water and he'd be able to sense everything that happens on the surface through his MF. I dragged you into the water to tell you this, and the weird sound you heard earlier, that was actually me trying to signal to you.

“But from how things are looking, I suspect that Guan Nie had already sensed my presence in the Gate of Heaven. If he's already wary of me, I might not be able to help much. You'll have to depend on yourself in that case.

“Your consciousness is being controlled right now, and it's absolutely trapped in this illusion since you are without a heart and also infested with demonic energy. You won't be able to escape even if Guan Nie undid the illusion and everyone leaves. There's only one way to save you now, and you have to listen and believe in this. There is zero room for error here. If anything goes wrong, your consciousness will end up in that crack in space between the real world and Split Zone 13.”

‘Where is that crack in space between the real world and Split Zone 13?’ The question popped up in my head as I wondered if she could hear my thoughts.

To my surprise, she actually responded to the question in my head. “That's not important. The thing is, once your consciousness ends up there, you won't be able to reincarnate or return to the Split Zone nor the real world. You'll turn into a homeless wandering soul. Apart from that, no one else will be able to see or talk to you. You'll learn what real, perpetual solitude is when that happens.”

Chapter 292: 292 Don't Turn Around

Volume 5

292 Don't Turn Around

Those words scared me.

You're telling someone who had been ostracized and who ended up in the Split Zone that she is heading for a place with no one else around where she would not really be living but where she cannot die either. She can't escape from there and that she'll be trapped there forever. That wasn't just cruel, it would be pure torture.

"What should I do..." I was antsy. I couldn't see Li Qing at all. I couldn't actually confirm that the person talking to me was her nor affirm that this wasn't just another illusion.

However, my gut told me that I should be listening to this individual. It's a woman's instinct.

"Listen well. I don't have time to repeat this a second time. Don't forget it.

"I'm using the space under the sea to communicate with you and no one else will be able to enter this space, not even your living weapon, Piercer. However, Scorpion Ray is able to enter this space because I gave it to you, and it is part of what I'm about to share with you.

"You'll enter another dimension in the illusion shortly, and I can't predict what you might see there. But remember this, don't believe anything or anyone no matter what you see. Don't trust anything there. I believe you're

able to do that. Lastly, this is the most important. You might make a mistake here. Once you enter that dimension, don't turn around no matter what happens, even if someone is calling out to you. Don't turn around until you see Scorpion Ray glow on your wrist.

“Just continue going forward and you don't have to pay any attention to anyone who tries to obstruct your way. There's also no need to avoid anyone who tries to attack you, because nobody would be able to hurt you as long as Scorpion Ray is with you.

“You can move freely once Scorpion Ray starts glowing, and you'll be able to walk out of that illusion and find me shortly after. I'll then tell you how to work together with me to break this illusion. But before that, don't stop for anyone or anything else, and don't turn around for anything. You have to remember this. If you don't, your consciousness will end up in that crack in space and you'll wander like a homeless soul for all eternity...”

“Okay, I get it.” I felt chills down my spine as I heard all that, and a bright light appeared before me right after I answered.

All the water was gone suddenly.

I was on a narrow path with no one else around.

There was no end in sight, it was just a murky gray ahead of me. Though I was afraid, I stepped forward slowly.

There was absolutely nothing in the eerie silence except for this endless road that looked like a cobblestone path. It was flanked by dark gray fog on both sides and the path led into nothing but more gray fog in front.

As I walked, I called out softly, “Li Qing...”

There was no answer.

An immense pressure seemed to weigh down on me in this absolute silence. I could feel my brows knitting together and my temper rising.

I didn't understand why I had to be the one going through such a terrifying experience.

How unlucky could I be that I could end up in this dark and creepy place after being in an intense battlefield? I didn't know when this path would end. Who did I offend to deserve something like that?

It was also the first time that Li Qing spoke to me so seriously. I wondered how frightening the encounters would be for her to use such an extreme method to get me to continue moving forward.

This was difficult to bear.

I knew that something terrifying would happen, but I was in a position where I could not do anything about it. I couldn't anticipate it nor could I change the situation. The best option was to continue on this path while fearing the possibility of having my life taken at any moment.

This was just like being aware of the fact that a ferocious ghost would be coming after you, and you were waiting for certain death, but you wouldn't even know who it was who would be taking your life.

Waiting was all you could do.

Waiting for the unknown source of fear, waiting for the day when the entire truth comes up to the surface.

Even though I tried to console myself, I ended up being rather bored of walking on this path all by myself.

“What would appear? Why don't they just all appear at once? I might just go insane here before I reach the end of this path.” I talked to myself in frustration. No one could hear me anyway.

“When have you started talking to yourself?”

After mumbling to myself for quite some time, I heard a voice coming from in front of me.

I snapped my head up, expecting to see something horrific. But the person who was obstructing my way was none other than Jiao S...

That can't be the real Jiao S. I decided that she was just an illusion and ignored her.

She's not the real Jiao S and it's an illusion anyway. I'll just keep quiet and ignore whatever she says. I won't do anything even if she attacks me.

I was prepared to act like a corpse if she really attacked me, but things were rarely this straightforward.

Those empty eyes of the Jiao S opposite me were exactly like those of the real Jiao S. "Why are you here, Ah Shen?"

Stunned by her question, I was speechless. *Should I say that I'm here to expose you as an impostor...?*

Calm down, calm down, calm down. I didn't hear it, I didn't hear it, I didn't hear it...

I pretended not to have heard the question.

After calming myself, I continued mumbling to myself that I didn't hear the question and walked forward, towards Jiao S.

I shouldn't avoid it if Jiao S really attacks me now. Li Qing wouldn't hurt me. If she said Scorpion Ray can help me, then it definitely can. All I need to do is to go forward no matter what happens. Whatever happens, I'll just continue walking. With Scorpion Ray's protection, I might just be able to go through Jiao S like how I passed through Pomelo's figure earlier.

The road was very narrow, and she was right there in the middle obstructing the entire pathway.

Plucking up courage, I continued walking towards her. I thought she would attack me, but Jiao S simply stood there, unmoving.

Unease crept up on me as I was about to reach her. *Her figure looked just like Pomelo's... If all else fails, I guess I'll just have to pass through her...*

While thinking, I lifted my head slightly.

I regretted my actions immediately.

The Jiao S in front of me had her eyeballs hanging out from her eye sockets, and they were still connected with tissue. She looked like a monster from the depths of a well.

“What the hell. Does it need to be that terrifying...” I shouted in shock.

Right after I said that, the figure in front of me turned back to look exactly like Jiao S without those horrific, drooping eyeballs. She stared at me blankly with that empty gaze of hers.

I was already right in front of her, but I was in a dilemma if I should just try and walk through her. Firstly, this was Jiao S. Secondly, I was really afraid that her face would change like it did just now and that would just give me a heart attack.

Well, I didn't actually have a heart now.

I was suddenly reminded of what Li Qing said, to continue walking forward no matter what happens. With gritted teeth, I took large steps forward, attempting to just walk through Jiao S's figure.

I had to take a gamble. I believe that I could pass right through her just like how it was in the cartoons where the monsters were impaled.

My theory was proven right as I stepped through her figure. However, I heard her speak in a creepy tone just as I was about to pass through her entirely.

“Do you think you'll be safe after you get out of this dimensional illusion?”

What was terrifying about it was that this voice did not belong to Jiao S at all... It sounded familiar, but I couldn't remember where I had heard the

voice.

I recalled Li Qing's words just as I was about to turn around and ask this Jiao S what was going on. Li Qing said that I shouldn't turn around no matter what happens.

I stopped myself from turning back, but I ended up freezing in my tracks. I wanted to slap myself at this moment.

Isn't this just a dimensional illusion with demonic energy infused in it? Would it be that difficult to go past it? Even if the illusions looked hyper-real, there's really nothing to turn back for.

Just as I wanted to continue on my path at a quicker pace, the Jiao S behind me spoke again.

“Don't you want to know why Nie Zun left you?”

Chapter 293: 293 The Path of No Return

Volume 5

293 The Path of No Return

Do you want to know why Nie Zun left you?

That was really tempting.

I had to remind myself time again that everything I saw and heard here was a mere illusion. I should not believe in any of this. She wouldn't be able to give me the truth even if I turned back.

Gritting my teeth, I continued without turning back.

I thought the Jiao S behind me might do something else to stop me, but nothing happened after a while of walking.

Curiosity didn't kill the cat, it killed people.

Since nothing happened, I wanted to turn around to check if that figure of Jiao S was still behind me, wondering what she would be doing if she was still there.

Such a thought made me hate myself a little.

I quickened my pace as I tried to shake the thought from out of my head, telling myself not to think about whatever might be happening behind me.

That curiosity was tamped down successfully after walking for quite some distance, and though I wanted to rest, I decided that it was best to continue on the path.

“Aye. It’s really inconvenient without MF,” I mumbled to myself. I had almost forgotten all that had happened earlier, and I was feeling quite relaxed. Time was a great healer. It can help lessen fear and uneasiness, and with the passing of time, these feelings and emotions can disappear altogether.

As wise men said, time is money. Time is really the most valuable commodity.

I seemed to have forgotten the value of time after arriving in the Split Zone. Time passed way too slowly there, and the same amount of numerical years there was a long time in the real world. Whatever that seemed precious to me turned into something without value in the Split Zone. It was rather terrifying that our values could change just like that.

This was also the reason why I spent most of my time lazing around on my bed or simply practicing the bow and arrow on my own when I had just assumed the role of Western District Commander right after Li Qing went missing.

Nothing else mattered to me at that time.

Nothing was valuable in the Split Zone; not time, not even lives.

It was a place that overturned all your beliefs, and once you’ve been there for a while without a cause to live, you’ll realize that the only thing you can do is to do nothing.

To me, the existence of the Split Zone is not just a mystery. To me, it was as if everything that did not follow logical sense happened there. There were no rules and no values in there.

This was a place which simply messed people up.

I felt a hand on my shoulder as I was deep in thought.

My very first instinct was to turn around.

Humans were prone to making errors when nervous, but when we were relaxed, we would usually be able to assess the situation in a much calmer manner. *At least I was like that.*

Just when I was about to turn back, something in my brain told me not to continue. Li Qing's voice entered my head at that very moment.

Don't turn around no matter what happens.

However, it was extremely difficult not to feel fear in such a situation when somebody had tapped you on the shoulder and you weren't able to turn and look.

Although I've been in the Split Zone for a while now, my heart seemed to skip a beat at this. *Even though I had no heart.*

"Who is it..." I froze while looking in front.

"Ah Shen, it's me..."

I wanted to laugh out loud.

Why did this illusion come up with someone that I really didn't want to see? Wasn't the aim to make me turn around? This felt like an idiotic thing to do.

Even if I could turn around, I wouldn't even want to.

I spoke coldly. "What are you doing here."

"I'm here to tell you something."

This was the first time she spoke to me in such a serious tone. She was exactly like me, everything from how she spoke and her tone of voice. *So this was how I sounded like when I was being serious.*

It didn't sound cute at all.

“Say it. Leave after that. You don't even need to try and make me turn around.”

I heard her voice coming closer, and it felt as if her face was right beside me. The unfortunate thing was that I couldn't avoid her in this situation.

There was no actual use in avoiding her anyway. I couldn't see her, but she'd still be able to see me.

“Ah Shen, remember that it's the dimensional illusion here... You can't turn back no matter what you see, or else you'll not be able to return to any of the two worlds...”

I didn't expect her to say the same things as Li Qing did.

“Also Ah Shen... Somebody is trying to kill you... You have to leave that illusion after breaking out of this dimensional one. It's also best that you keep your distance from Nie Zun...”

I almost wanted to turn around when she mentioned Nie Zun.

She wasn't here to make me turn around. She was here to prevent me from doing that and to tell me that somebody wanted to kill me.

But why did she add that I had to keep my distance from Nie Zun?

I would never believe it if she said that Nie Zun was the one who wanted to take my life.

This might be a trick, so I didn't turn back. I continued on the path without asking any questions even though I was curious.

Before long, I was met with Gaoqin Jiuye.

I was sure it was an illusion.

This particular illusion was choosing to make certain people I care about appear. It was trying to rub salt in my wound.

Gaoqin Jiuye was not his usual self as he stood silently looking moody and sorrowful.

I walked over.

Running away was not the solution. *I just had to face this.*

I was going to get the ball rolling this time. “You’re waiting for me? You have something to say too?”

Just when I was going through the countless scenarios in my head, Gaoqin Jiuye said something that stunned me.

“Indeed, there’s something I want to say. But there’s no need for you to dwell too much upon what I’m going to say, since I’m not real. I’m just a shadow that exists in your heart.”

Have you seen illusions busting themselves like this? Have you seen an illusion telling you that it was an illusion? Have you experienced anything like this where a hallucination tells you that you’re actually hallucinating?

I bet no one would have experienced such a thing.

I thought Gaoqin Jiuye would have some tricks up his sleeve instead of just saying that he was an illusion and telling me that I didn’t have to believe or dwell upon anything he said.

“If this is one of your tricks, then I take my hat off to you...” I said to Gaoqin Jiuye.

I was speaking nothing but the truth. If they were trying to hurt me, then this was the application of reverse psychology at its epitome.

“Ah Shen, I know everything that Li Qing told you. I also know that you are in a dimensional illusion. Whether you believe it or not, when you enter a dimensional illusion, you’ll simply look like you’re in a deep coma in the

Split Zone. I'm right beside you now, and what I've done is to bring my consciousness in here to look for you.

“However, I'm not able to take you away from this dimensional illusion, so this is the only method I could think of. There's also another way you can escape all of this. You won't have to go back to the Gate of Heaven to face those battles, and you don't have to worry about the future in the Split Zone. All your worries will disappear, including this never-ending path.”

I had to admit that this was rather tempting. He was saying all this right in front of me.

“What should I do?” I asked, expressing my interest.

“Simple. Take this, and insert it in here.” Gaoqin Jiuye pointed at the splitting key hanging from my neck before pointing at his left ankle.

I shook my head immediately. “No. You should know me, Gaoqin Jiuye. I'll never let you do something like that. To be honest, I owe you too much. Now that I'm aware of what happened in the past, I feel like I'd owe you forever. Don't do such things for me anymore. It'll only make me extra guilty. If there really is danger on this path, or if there's nothing but danger waiting for me when I break out of this dimension, then all I can say is I'm ready to face it.”

Gaoqin Jiuye shook his head in response. “It's not only such danger I'm referring to. I'm talking about the possibility that another catastrophe might befall you and your friends.”

I found this funny. It almost felt as if we've finally found the exit and we could save ourselves really soon.

Chapter 294: 294 A Horrifying Punishment

Volume 5

294 A Horrifying Punishment

“I’m begging you, just do it now. Nothing else should be the priority right now. I’ve asked you before if you wanted to leave. You said no at the time. Do you still think that you made the right choice?”

I stared at him. “Of course. I’ve never regretted it, and I don’t plan on regretting anything else.”

“What else would you like me to do for you? Tell me so that I can send you away as soon as possible.”

This sounded rather comical as I said it. It sounded as if I could send him back by turning back time.

“Stop this. I’m right outside. You’re talking to the real me now. Don’t think too much about it. This illusion is not that difficult to break. You’ll be able to find the weak link if you look properly.”

I looked at him and said, “If you’re here to say this, you are welcome to leave right now.”

It’s time to send the guest away.

But Gaoqin Jiuye did not move.

I thought the problem would be solved after some more conversation, but I was wrong.

Nie Zun appeared before I could send Gaoqin Jiuye away.

I happened to glance further down the path and I saw Nie Zun a short distance away.

Nie Zun had both hands in his pockets and he was dressed in black from head to toe.

“You’re here to talk to me about Gaoqin Jiuye as well?” I asked impatiently.

“No. I’m here to deliver your heart to you.” Nie Zun answered casually.

That indifferent demeanor of his was difficult to replicate. This was definitely him.

“Then where is it?” I asked as I pointed at my empty chest.

“The heart is completely fine here with me. I have a request before I give it to you.”

“Go on.”

“After getting your heart back, no matter what you recall or what you see, you have to promise that you’ll never talk about this ever again.”

Is this some sort of agreement to secrecy?

I was really curious about his request, so I agreed without hesitation.

Nie Zun reached towards his own chest.

Gaoqin Jiuye stared at me in anger. “Haven’t I told you that everything is fake? Don’t be fooled by him. He’ll attack you once you go over to take your heart back.”

No, he wouldn't.

Nie Zun might not love me, he might have changed drastically, and he might not be protecting me anymore.

But he would never hurt me.

He would never do that.

Unless someone was pretending to be him, but that was impossible in this situation. There was only one thing to do now, that is, to continue on my path.

I thought that I'd be stopped only a couple of times after that, but I didn't expect Nie Zun to be so adamant on having me make a promise.

"Where are you going? You haven't promised me."

I looked at Nie Zun with exhaustion. "Honestly, I don't really care about anything now. Nie Zun, you're the one who took the heart, and you're also the one who's trying to return it to me now. And you don't want me to tell anyone about this either. Just what are you trying to do?"

"I'll tell you the truth since you want to hear it that badly," Nie Zun said.

Emotion overwhelmed me at this point. I really wanted to know why he took my heart away,

To my surprise, Gaoqin Jiuye rushed forward to obstruct Nie Zun's path. "Don't say it."

He stared at Nie Zun.

"What are you doing, Gaoqin? Don't you know that this is my goal?" I asked with a frown.

Gaoqin Jiuye shot a sharp look at me. "Didn't I tell you to keep your distance from him too? Li Shen, I'm willing to send you away and throw away my life for it. Is it that difficult for you to leave this place? Is it that difficult to go back the way you came?"

It wasn't difficult at all, but I didn't know why I chose not to do so either.

Seeing my silence, Gaoqin Jiuye was enraged. Nie Zun still had his eyes on me, as if he was calculating his next steps.

Nobody could have predicted what happened next.

Gaoqin Jiuye stuck a hand right into Nie Zun's chest.

"What are you doing..." I said.

"I'm looking for your heart." Gaoqin Jiuye looked crazed, as if he was bent on helping me find a way to escape.

His hand was already embedded deeply in Nie Zun's chest, but Nie Zun's face remained expressionless.

Gaoqin Jiuye seemed to be picking from a raffle box that was literally Nie Zun's chest.

It looked disgusting. I decided to continue walking forward without wasting any more time. All these tricks were just to confuse me.

I glanced at the two of them just as I passed them, but something made me stop in my tracks even as I decided that I would never turn back.

It was so sudden.

It was like a computer crashing. There was nothing I could do but to wait for help.

But I was the one who needed help this time.

I caught sight of the skull ring on Nie Zun's finger with that glance.

The ring meant a lot to me, and I had a feeling that all the mysteries would be unraveled with that ring.

Basically, in my subconscious mind, there was something special about that skull ring.

Accessories cannot be worn in illusions.

Pu-chh.

Thud.

A beating heart was in Gaoqin Jiuye's bloody hand as it emerged from Nie Zun's chest.

At once, I knew it wasn't mine.

Nie Zun collapsed behind me with a thud as I turned to my side to look.

At first, it felt like I was simply watching a movie unfold before me, but I recalled that the ring can't be worn by an illusion. This meant that it was the real Nie Zun I'm seeing right now.

This wasn't hearsay, because that ring belonged to me, and it belonged to Nie Zun as well. Who knows, it might have also belonged to Gaoqin Jiuye.

I didn't know why I had the feeling that an illusion couldn't wear the ring, but the thought simply appeared in my mind. If I could see Nie Zun wearing this ring right now, it meant that he was no illusion. He was right there.

Instead of unraveling the mystery, everything seemed to turn into a bigger mess.

If that was really Nie Zun... What do I do?

I didn't have time to think any further. Looking at that dark red heart in Gaoqin Jiuye's hand, I turned back in an attempt to help Nie Zun up. I had to see if it was real. I had to see if he really had that ring on him.

At the very moment I turned back, I realized that there was nothing there. Nie Zun wasn't there. Jiao S wasn't there.

All I could see was an endless path which led to somewhere unknown.

If I had a heart now, I was sure I would feel it dropping to the ground.

I was tricked.

Where did I go wrong? I saw that skull ring so clearly. Rather than believing in the logic of this place, I'd rather believe my gut.

My gut told me that I was right, that it was definitely the real Nie Zun who had that black skull ring on him.

But where did Nie Zun go?

I turned back around. Gaoqin Jiuye, who was originally waiting for my answer, had disappeared too.

Damn it.

I was tricked and I turned around, but nothing happened.

This was absolutely terrifying.

I wouldn't have been so terrified if it was a ferocious ghost that met my eyes. I could at least try to fight it.

But there was absolutely nothing behind me when I turned back.

The scariest part is waiting in the absolute silence and stillness for the judgement and punishment when you are aware that you've broken the rules and that you have to pay for it.

You couldn't help but be afraid of what you'd have to face, but you have no choice but to wait for the judgement to arrive.

I was at a total loss of what to do when I felt the environment change around me.

I looked around warily as the gray fog dissipated and the scene changed slowly.

It was as if it was becoming transparent. A world that looked familiar met my eyes.

Fear crept up on me as I began to realize what was happening. I realized what the punishment was.

That fear made me shiver.

Chapter 295: 295 Crack in Space

Volume 5

295 Crack in Space

That narrow path disappeared slowly as a new environment appeared before me. This was not the Split Zone.

I looked around blankly. *This place...*

There were tall buildings, massive traffic and large crowds.

The sky was blue with white clouds. The air was refreshing. It felt lively.

In a retarded move, I rubbed my eyes hard.

My vision blurred a little, but I calmed myself down as I began to take in the sights.

I was back.

I was standing somewhere totally foreign to me. It wasn't near the school or the hospital.

It was a traffic junction.

This felt foreign to me. I didn't remember this place at all, nor could I recognize it.

The only thing I could be sure of was that this was the real world.

Am I really back?

I crossed the road as I looked at the crowd.

I stopped right in the middle of the road facing a car that was speeding its way towards me. I was uneasy, and I didn't know why I had to use such an extreme method to find the answer.

I kept my eyes on the car as it approached me.

When it was about to reach me, it screeched to a stop, honking loudly.

I widened my eyes in surprise, wanting to call out in joy. But my spirits were dampened as I saw someone crawling through my legs.

That person passed right through me.

He didn't crawl in between my legs, he crawled right through the both of them as if I was non-existent. He crawled through my body just like this.

Two individuals rushed out from the car, calling out loudly.

A crowd then began to congregate. Some of them were calling the police and some were calling an ambulance.

Some others were looking at the spectacle as they pointed at the scene.

Nobody saw me.

Nobody could touch me either.

I laughed at myself as I looked back at the car. "So you didn't stop for me... None of you can see me at all..."

If this were a dream, I knew that I wouldn't be able to wake up. If this was real, then I was back in the real world as a wandering spirit. No one could see me now, and the only difference was that Gaoqin Jiuye was not here with me this time.

Being thrown back into the real world so suddenly, I didn't know how to handle the situation at all. This was somewhere foreign yet familiar to me.

Exhaustion suddenly overwhelmed me.

I sat down on the sidewalk like an abandoned child while I tried to analyze the situation as best as I could.

Firstly, I can be sure that this wasn't a hallucination nor was this a dream.

One scenario has been eliminated.

Secondly, I'm not back for real, since nobody could see me here. Was I still being tested on that narrow path?

No, that's impossible. Li Qing didn't warn me about this. I believe that Li Qing wouldn't keep things from me.

There was only one possibility left, and that is, I've arrived in that crack in space, again.

It was Old Man Fan who helped us arrive in the crack in space previously, and we weren't able to take a good look at it because we had been in such a rush to return.

Would it be any different this time?

I happened to glance at my feet as these questions ran through my head.

I was barefoot.

My eyes widened slowly as I looked down at my own foot.

I saw something that I couldn't believe was true.

I reached out to touch it, but it did not help the situation at all.

The split symbol on my left ankle had disappeared.

There was always this nagging feeling of something worse that could happen after going through a terrifying experience.

But today was the day I was the most terrified in my entire life.

I no longer belonged to the Split Zone if I was without a split symbol.

But I did not belong in this world either. *Who am I then...?*

You'll enter another dimension in the illusion shortly, and I can't predict what you might see there. But remember this, don't believe anything or anyone no matter what you see. Don't trust anything there. I believe you're able to do that. Lastly, this is the most important. You might make a mistake here. Once you enter that dimension, don't turn around no matter what happens, even if someone is calling out to you. Don't turn around until you see Scorpion Ray glow on your wrist.

Just continue going forward and you don't have to pay any attention to anyone who tries to obstruct your way. There's also no need to avoid anyone who tries to attack you, because nobody would be able to hurt you as long as Scorpion Ray is with you.

You can move freely once Scorpion Ray starts glowing, and you'll be able to walk out of that illusion and find me shortly after. I'll then tell you how to work together with me to break this illusion. But before that, don't stop for anyone or anything else, and don't turn around for anything. You have to remember this.

If you don't, your consciousness will end up in that crack in space and you'll wander like a homeless soul for all eternity...

Li Qing's words replayed themselves in my head and it only got louder and louder...

I began frantically searching for my scorpion insignia split symbol on my leg.

But it was just a pale, ordinary leg. There was nothing on it.

Did I really end up in the crack in space because I turned around on that narrow path...?

I couldn't believe this...

I began to have a taste of what it meant by having to go through eternal solitude.

Eternal solitude was when no one in the world could see me or touch me.

Nobody would know what I said or did either.

Nobody would be able to communicate with me here, and I would never be able to return to the Split Zone.

The split symbol on my ankle was gone, and I couldn't feel an ounce of MF in me.

I was just a wandering spirit.

A thought struck me, and I bit down hard on my tongue.

There was no pain...

I finally understood what it meant to be in eternal solitude.

I couldn't even die in this crack in space.

"Nie Zun."

"Jiao S."

"Gaoqin Jiuye."

As if insane, I shouted their names loudly, but to no avail.

Am I going to stay like this forever?

I can't die and there's nobody else around for company. *Am I going to live like this here in the crack in space forever?*

What kind of sinner deserved such a punishment?

I had been ostracized all my life, and I've been losing people I care about after arriving in the Split Zone. I didn't seem to be able to keep anyone in my life, and I've never felt secure.

I've already had enough of solitude, but in the end, I had to have solitude as my only company till the end of time.

No, it isn't till the end of time. This punishment had no end.

Why...

Just why...

Why did it have to be me ending up here in this crack in space? I was so afraid of solitude. I'm not living here, but I can't die here either.

Can the heavens tell me what I've done wrong, apart from killing Gao Qi, for me to deserve this...?

Can you imagine what life would be like if you merely stayed somewhere, not doing anything?

It would be an endless horror story.

One couldn't escape from it. It would drive a person insane. It was a punishment that can drive people to the edge of their sanity.

What did I do wrong to deserve such 'treatment'?

I began attempting to stop people in their tracks like a madwoman. I wanted to get them to notice me. I wanted to get them to look at me.

No matter how I cried out, how loudly I bawled, how much I pulled and screamed, nobody could hear me.

Nobody could see me.

Everything just passed right through me.

As I was about to give up, I thought of something else.

What would happen to Gaoqin Jiuye now that I didn't have a split symbol?

There was a split symbol contract established between us, but it hasn't been undone since I did not insert my splitting key into his split symbol. *What would happen to him now that my split symbol had disappeared on its own?*

I looked down as I thought of the splitting key. I tried looking for it around my neck, but there was nothing there.

Even my splitting key was gone.

But what use would a splitting key be without a split symbol?

What would Gaoqin Jiuye be thinking...

I had no idea what would happen to him, and I felt helpless at that. If I had a tragic ending, I just hoped that I wouldn't have to drag anyone else down with me.

But as someone who shared a split symbol contract with me, what would happen to Gaoqin Jiuye? Would he be affected by me? How would he be affected?

I would really go mad if guilt and worry were heaped upon this eternal solitude.

Chapter 296: 296 A Similar Accident

Volume 5

296 A Similar Accident

Time in the real world passed relatively quickly, and it was easy to keep track of the days with the sunrise and sunsets. Before I knew it, three days had already passed.

I didn't do anything but sit on the same sidewalk all this time.

It was as if I froze.

I didn't feel cold nor did I feel warm.

Nobody could hear me, nobody could see the tears that escaped me.

I didn't feel hungry, nor did I feel tired.

It was horrifying.

Though a day had only twenty four hours, it felt like forever to me.

I daydreamed like this for three whole days.

I thought about Gaoqin Jiuye, Jiao S and many others from the Split Zone. I thought of Nie Zun.

Didn't we have to stay within 500 meters of each other? Why can we be apart now? Aren't we in totally different spaces right now?

We'll realize that some things are actually not like what they seem.

It was just like how deactivating my split symbol set things in motion. The link between us would disappear if my split symbol disappeared in this crack in space.

No one would have been able to predict this happening.

I still ended up in here even under the protection of so many others, even with that restriction between Nie Zun and I, even when so many others put their trust in me.

Millions of thoughts ran through my mind in these three days.

I wondered if this was a punishment or if it was just my destiny to be a lonely 'existence' which doesn't experience happiness or sadness, and which cannot die nor be destroyed.

I thought I'd be able to stay like this forever until I became one with this crack in space.

However, an accident caught my attention on the third day.

There have been some interesting things I've witnessed as I sat along this busy road. There was a loving couple who passed by just seconds ago, but one of them suddenly got angry and began walking away. The other party was visibly upset, and they both started quarrelling right in the middle of the street.

This was something ordinary.

If I had to talk about something interesting, I'd rather be talking about things which don't usually get noticed by people. I was more attracted to the things which have happened that do not actually attract the attention of others.

Two individuals had been on the phone on the pedestrian street behind me. These individuals looked very different.

One of them was dressed rather sloppily while the other was neatly-dressed and looked like someone rich. Both were males and they looked like they were in their early thirties.

The well-dressed male was the first one to make a call. His hair was neat and he had a pair of bright eyes. He looked like a businessman who was doing very well.

His mobile phone was one of the latest models. I couldn't identify it though, even when I hadn't actually left the real world for that long. This is just technology. You'd be left out of that rapid advancement even if you've just left for half a day. When you return, a new product would already have been developed.

Though I didn't eavesdrop on him on purpose, it's been too long being alone here, and I couldn't even begin to describe how that loneliness felt. I couldn't help but tune in to whatever sounds were around me.

He sounded like he was calling his wife. He didn't sound very loving. It sounded like he was being polite, as if he was speaking to a guest.

It might be an arranged marriage or just a mere transactional one.

He was telling his wife to take care of his mother who was in the hospital.

I couldn't hear the voice on the other end of the call, but I didn't go closer either. All I wanted to do was to sit and I was too lazy to move. Also, I thought it'd be more interesting for me if I didn't hear the other side of the conversation. This way, I'd only have his side of the story to judge things on.

I came to a conclusion shortly.

His mother was gravely ill in the hospital, and because he was so busy, his wife thought that he didn't have the time to visit his mother. So, she called him and told him not to worry because she'll be helping to take care of her.

To this point, it sounded like a pitiful businessman who poured all their time into earning money that they didn't have any left to spend with their loved ones.

But this was not the case at all.

After hearing whatever his wife said, a bitter smile appeared on his face as he said, "It's okay, don't tire yourself out. I'll put everything down right now and be there with you to take care of Ma."

I felt my heart skip a beat. Surprised, I touched my chest and I realized that my heart was actually in it.

This was nothing like having a scientific breakthrough and his words weren't out of this world, but that surety and his resolute gaze when he said them touched me deeply.

I couldn't hear the other end of the conversation, but I could guess the gist of it from his answer.

"Don't worry, taking care of Ma is more important than work. If I lose this deal because of it, then it'll just be the will of the heavens. If that really happens, then let's go for a trip to that place you've always wanted to visit after taking care of Ma."

He sounded happy as he ended the call. His gaze was sharp and bright as he walked away from me with a calm demeanor.

Just when I was still shaken by what I just heard, another individual came to the same spot to make a call.

I looked at him.

He looked like he was dressed in rags. He didn't look like a beggar, but he was probably a laborer of sorts. He looked to be in his early thirties, and his eyes looked like they were already numb to this world.

His mobile phone was an old one, and if I remember right, one could only make and receive calls on such an old model.

He sounded like he was talking to his wife as well.

“Sick? Help me take care of her then. Why do you think I’m working so hard for? It’s all for you guys, and you’re telling me you don’t have the time to take care of my mum when she’s ill? What are you at home for then? What else can you do apart from taking care of our son and cooking?”

From what I’m hearing, his wife might have found it difficult to cope if she had to take care of their son and the house at the same time if she also had to make time to take care of his mother at the hospital as well. So, she called the man hoping that he’d be able to come back for a short while to help out.

However, this man was not willing to that.

He could have felt that he can’t do it because he was the sole breadwinner, and I could understand such a mindset because that would mean cutting off their only source of income.

But from his gaze, I could tell he wasn’t looking at things from that perspective.

He wasn’t willing to do it because he felt that it was his wife’s responsibility to do so. He felt that he didn’t have to be responsible for anything else since he’s already in charge of bringing in the money.

This was what caught my eye in the past couple of days.

It was the difference between these two men.

Sometimes, the truth is vastly different from what is depicted in books or heard via rumors.

Not all who were rich would turn out to be arrogant, unfilial or immoral, and not all who were poor were kind and forgiving.

Even if those who were rich didn’t have anything else, at least they had money. For those who were poor, there would probably be reasons unknown to us that landed them in their plight.

Hearing these phone calls made me think about the life in the Split Zone for the past two years. I realized that there really was no distinct line between good and evil.

Was You Ji evil? But she did treat me as a friend before.

Was she good then? No, she wasn't.

Jiao S treated me very well. But can I really say she is a good person?

She was just like me; we both killed someone when we were alive. She ruled with an iron fist over the Eastern District as well.

It was difficult to differentiate between good and evil, because there were no fixed boundaries. No one would be good forever, and it's not set in stone that evil persons would remain evil all their lives.

But in this world where we judge things as good versus evil, are we really able to be objective about it? Are we able to forgive ourselves and calm our hearts after doing evil deeds?

I didn't know what others thought about this, but I knew I couldn't do it.

I might have returned to my own world long ago if I had forgiven myself.

This was the only thing which caught my attention in the past few days, but I was drawn to the accident that happened today.

This was the first time in three days that I stopped acting like someone who had lost all their senses. I stood up and walked over to the scene of the accident.

It was just a few steps away from me, but a crowd had already gathered around the scene.

I approached the scene with a sardonic smile as I realized that one advantage of being a wandering soul was that no one could stand in my way.

My face froze when I saw what actually happened.

It wasn't a serious accident. A boy lay on the floor with his eyes shut. There wasn't any blood and there were no obvious wounds on him.

The woman got out of the car with a cold expression on her face. She was in black shoes and she didn't look like someone you should offend.

Click, click, click.

She walked over to the boy.

I recognized the boy, and I recognized the woman as well.

These faces belonged to the woman and the boy who both died in the Gate of Heaven.

Chapter 297: 297 The Opposite Result?

Volume 5

297 The Opposite Result?

What's happening here? Why would I see that boy and that stocking lady here in the real world? Didn't they both die in the Split Zone? Did they fake their deaths?

But that's impossible...

This was exactly the same thing that happened in the Split Zone.

I walked over quickly to the boy.

The boy sat up slowly. My eyes were on the stocking lady as I wondered what she'd do next. *Would whatever happened in the Split Zone happen here again?*

If that were to happen, who would help the boy when the stocking lady picks on him...?

I was right here, but there wasn't anything I could do to help him this time...

The stocking lady pursed her lips.

I held my breath as I stared at her.

However, that cold expression on the stocking lady's face changed to a forgiving one in the very next second. She helped the boy up and asked

with concern, “Are you okay? Are you hurt anywhere? Do you need me to send you to the hospital?”

I heard mumbles from the crowd. “I guess she won’t be avoiding responsibility for this.”

“Yeah. It’s rare to see people like that these days. People usually try to get away or push the responsibility to others when an accident happens, or they’d blame the victim for knocking into them on purpose. Some fights even end up in the police station.”

“Well, it’s understandable that people aren’t very willing to take responsibility with so many people getting in accidents on purpose just to get some money out of it.”

“Yeah, that’s true too.”

I turned back to the two of them after hearing some of the discussion around me.

Although both of them looked exactly the same as the individuals I recognized from the Split Zone, it was obviously not going to end in the same way here.

The boy’s eyes opened slowly. His eyes were clear, but he had this look on his face which made him look much older than he was. He was so pale and he looked very weak, just like that boy I saw in the Split Zone.

“I’m fine,” he said quietly with an indifferent tone as he pushed the woman’s hand away before struggling to get up on his own.

The crowd stirred.

“Is he afraid to say that he’s hurt?”

“I think he’s too young and too afraid to say it. Look at that woman, she doesn’t look too friendly. Maybe she’s just pretending for now. She might show her true colors a little bit later.”

“Yeah, look at how unsteady he is. I think he’s really hurt. Is it an internal injury? Should we persuade him to allow her to bring him to the hospital?”

“Are you kidding? Why be nosy? He’ll just have himself to blame if he refuses to go to the hospital.”

I was not surprised by all that discussion that was happening around me, but I felt uncomfortable with it. I frowned at this, wondering what it was that made me so upset.

The stocking lady seemed to have heard some of the discussion around them. After standing up, the boy struggled to break away from the crowd.

The stocking lady knitted her brows and there was a look of annoyance which flashed past her face, but my eyes might have fooled me.

She chased after the boy and smiled as she stopped him from leaving. “I’m worried if you just leave like that. What if your organs are damaged? That’ll be serious. I’m at fault anyway. Just come with me to the hospital, child.”

This set off another wave of discussion.

“Where can we find someone that kind? That boy didn’t even ask for money and she’s volunteering to send him to the hospital?”

“Yeah. I didn’t know kind souls still exist.”

“Huh, it’s probably not kindness. She’s probably from some rich family and she doesn’t need that money anyway. This would be peanuts to her, and she’d probably even have enough money to settle the matter even if she had killed someone.”

“I guess that’s true. She probably doesn’t need the money.”

My brows knitted further.

The boy seemed surprised that the lady stopped him as he turned and stared at her. He then said, “Okay. We’ll do that.”

The lady smiled. “Okay, let’s get into my car. I’ll send you to the hospital.” She then began pulling the boy towards her car.

The crowd was blocking her path, and she had to continually say, “Excuse me please. Thank you.”

A path parted for her, but there were some upset faces around. They looked as if they were suspicious of this lady and there was doubt if she was really going to send the boy to hospital.

The stocking lady did not say or do anything out of the ordinary, so everyone made way for her in the end.

When she was walking over to the driver’s side after settling the boy into the front seat, a voice said, “Is she really going to the hospital? She wouldn’t try to do something else, would she?”

The lady looked like she heard it as there was a minute change in her expression, but a smile returned after a split second. She remained silent, and the crowd quietened.

Something felt amiss and I rushed to catch up.

I felt a little hesitant when I saw the boy get into her car. *If I simply existed in this crack in space and I was invisible to the world here, would I be able to ride a vehicle?*

But my gut told me to follow them. I felt that it wasn’t a simple coincidence that I’d be seeing these two from the Split Zone.

After a moment of hesitation, I stuck a leg out and tried to get into her car.

I could actually pass through this car. I didn’t need anyone to open the door for me to get in, and I could ride in it when the lady ignited the engine. *This didn’t make sense.*

I looked around me. I was in the back seat. I reached out towards the lady from where I was. My hand passed through both the seat and her body. *They weren’t able to see me at all, but why was I able to ride in this car?*

I tried to focus MF in my body as if I was in the Split Zone, but I couldn't feel anything that remotely resembled MF in my body.

If I could still focus MF within my body, then I'd have thought that it was my MF which enabled me to ride in the car. *Now that I didn't have MF nor did I belong in this world, how could I actually do such a thing without being noticed by anyone or affected by anything at all in this world? Or was I able to leave with them because I simply wanted to do so, and this ability stemmed from my mental consciousness?*

But why would I be without MF if that was the case?

Was my MF existing in some other form in this crack in space? Was it something that would be calculated differently in this particular plane of existence?

But even if I cannot calculate it, I should still be able to feel its presence.

But...

The woman spoke as I was lost in thought wondering about how I could actually get on the car.

"You really think that you didn't get hurt at all?" She spoke very calmly, and I couldn't tell what she might really be thinking behind that calm demeanor.

The boy mumbled an affirmative response as he continued staring straight ahead.

Silence ensued.

The atmosphere was weird, as if something was being suppressed.

I took a deep breath as I tried to calm my nerves.

Click.

The lady exited the car and said to the boy, “I’m going to get some stuff. I’ll be back very soon. Just wait for a while. The hospital is right in front. We should get you checked just to be sure.”

The pale boy nodded. He was so pale that he looked like he was indeed suffering from some sort of internal injury. From his gaze, he seemed to be suppressing some sort of pain.

I floated over to the driver’s seat as the lady left. I turned to look at the boy, trying to figure out what it was he might be hiding.

The boy started coughing suddenly. His face turned red from all that coughing.

He must have been injured.

I walked to where the lady was headed for.

She had entered a supermarket a short distance away.

There weren’t a lot of people in it at this time of the day. The lady didn’t look like she was planning on buying anything either. After looking around her, she sneaked into the washroom.

After standing outside the washroom for a bit, I decided to follow her in.

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298 Those Who Adapt Survive

The lady didn't enter any of the stalls in the washroom. She was in a corner making a call.

"Hello, may I speak with Doctor Zhang please?" She looked serious as a cold glint flashed past her eyes.

"Doctor Zhang, I hit a boy today. He says he's fine but he might have sustained some internal injuries. The authorities have been keeping their eye out for such matters after what happened previously.

"You understand right? I hope the matter can be settled as soon as possible. That child looks rather innocent, and he doesn't look like he did it on purpose either. I'll bring him to you later. You know what to do, right?"

I didn't hear the other side of the conversation. All I saw was a smile spreading on the lady's face before she ended the call.

She was no longer as antsy as she was when she first entered the supermarket. She adjusted her hair by the sink and checked her smile in the mirror before washing her hands calmly.

I followed closely behind her as she exited the washroom.

The boy was still sitting in his seat quietly, as if he did not move an inch. He stared into the distance through the windscreen.

The lady shot him a sideways glance before she started the engine.

We arrived at the hospital shortly. She took the boy's hand in hers as if they were siblings as they walked in.

The lady looked around warily before mumbling to herself, "We have to get a specialist to look at this child. A thorough check-up would be needed. It won't be good if there's any after symptoms."

She then pointed at the name of a doctor on the wall as she spoke to someone at counter, "We'll see Doctor Zhang here. He seems to be quite qualified."

The counter staff replied, "Yes, Doctor Zhang is a specialist."

I was standing behind the both of them and I realized that the boy was looking at the figure of the lady from behind.

This was the first time he took a proper look at the lady after the accident happened. He simply stared ahead of him when he was in the car.

As he stared at the lady, he had a look in his eyes which should not have belonged to a teenage boy. It looked as if he was contemplating something, and his eyes shone a little even though they looked pained. That look was reminiscent of hate, but why would he hate this lady if he had just met her?

Things were definitely not as simple as they looked.

After paying a deposit, the lady brought the boy to level three. She passed the slip obtained from the counter to the nurse there.

The nurse nodded at the lady after seeing the slip, before turning and heading for a room at the end of the corridor. The lady smiled, and the boy followed her into the room quietly.

I looked at the sign on the door which said Doctor Zhang. I turned back to look at the queue along the corridor. Sighing, I decided to follow the both of them into the room.

The nurse was walking out just as I entered the room.

She closed the door behind her.

The room looked like an ordinary clinic with a middle-aged male doctor behind the desk.

The doctor smiled at the both of them. “Would you mind passing me that slip please? How may I help you today?”

The lady tapped the boy on his shoulder encouragingly before passing the slip over to the doctor. “Nice to meet you, Doctor Zhang. This is what happened. I accidentally grazed this boy when I was driving earlier. It didn’t look like I hit him, but he might have fallen because of that. He says he’s fine too, but just to be sure, I thought it’d be better to bring him here for a thorough check-up in case any injuries have been sustained.”

Doctor Zhang nodded and smiled at the boy. “Do you feel any pain?”

The boy looked pale as he shook his head with unfocused eyes.

Doctor Zhang continued. “Do you feel any different from before? It’s okay, child, there’s no need to be afraid. You can tell me if you feel uncomfortable in any way. It’s my responsibility as a doctor to help my patients, whether they are young or old, rich or poor.”

The boy’s hands moved as if he was going to make a fist, but he simply stretched his fingers.

He said, “I don’t feel any different.”

“Hmm, okay. Let’s take a look at the chest and the head first before going through everything else.”

The boy nodded. Doctor Zhang and the lady looked at each other before leading the boy into another room.

I was right beside the doctor when they did the x-rays. He looked at the film in a separate room first. After seeing it, he exchanged it with another film

that was already in the drawer. He then walked out with the new film.

He smiled at the lady. “The child is fine. I’ve looked at it and there are no issues. Seems like he was just grazed and not hit by the car.

“The both of you can take a look at the film here. The heart, lungs and bones look fine.” He explained after passing the film to the boy.

Though I didn’t want to be here any longer, I simply stood there.

I thought about all those times where the adults would be telling us that heaven is watching our every move. I didn’t think too much about it then, and although I’m not heaven, it really seemed like whatever you do would be no secret. There really is nothing that can be kept a secret forever.

This is why we shouldn’t do evil deeds. We never know who else might be watching.

Doctor Zhang ended the session as the boy did not have much to say about his diagnosis, and he told the lady that they could leave.

After exiting the hospital, the lady said to the boy, “Wait for me in the car, I’ll get some vitamins for you. Look at you, you look so weak.”

The lady headed back into the hospital after settling the boy in the car and locking the door.

The boy’s eyes followed the lady until she entered the hospital building. Turning away from the boy, I followed quickly behind the lady.

We were back at the room on the third level corridor. I passed through the door without much difficulty.

I could hear the voices of Doctor Zhang and the lady, but I couldn’t hear their conversation very clearly. I didn’t really want to look at their faces that were behind the door, but I had to pass through the door to be able to hear better.

Doctor Zhang showed the real x-ray film to the lady. “Look at this. Why weren’t you more careful? These organs are all damaged, and though not everyone might cough up blood in cases like this, it’s really weird that the boy says he’s not in pain.”

The lady smiled enchantingly. “I guess I’m lucky this time. If this didn’t happen, I probably wouldn’t have come to you.”

Doctor Zhang shook his head. “I guess you’re lucky, or should I say that you were luckier than the previous time. You should be careful while driving, not all injuries can be hidden like this.”

The lady looked just a tad upset when ‘the previous time’ was mentioned, but a pretty smile appeared on her face just as quickly. “I know. Thanks for the reminder, Doctor Zhang. No matter how lucky I am, I’ll still have to thank you.”

She said this while drawing circles on Doctor Zhang’s chest with her finger, looking at him with inviting eyes.

Any normal male would understand what she was trying to get at, and from Doctor Zhang’s reaction, he was definitely a normal male.

I had already left the room when quick, short breaths could be heard.

Mixed emotions hit me as I walked along the third floor corridor.

This was something ordinary in the real world. Even if this made the news, it would be forgotten in a couple of days.

In this world, the world that I used to live in, this was simply a sad story.

However, I still felt upset. It’s been so long since I’ve seen a story like this, because something like this would never have happened in the Split Zone. In the Split Zone, the strong would overpower the weak, and everything was done out in the open.

It was still a dog-eat-dog world. Though it was more cruel and gruesome in the Split Zone, at least you’d know when you were being done in.

Which was the better space out of the two then?

I wasn't searching for an answer on which was the most suitable space for me to exist. I knew that these spaces were different because the rules of survival were different. Rules of survival were written by the strong, and these were the rules that applied in this world, while a different set of rules applied in the Split Zone.

Chapter 299: 299 The Oriole Behind

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299 The Oriole Behind

It was the same everywhere.

An interesting thought struck me.

If there was someone else, who existed like I did, in this 'third plane', would this space eventually fill up and would we have a whole new set of rules that were different from the real world and the Split Zone?

The answer was obvious. As long as something existed, there would be competition and there would be rules.

Another thought struck me just as I was planning to go back to the lady's car.

Crack in space, crack in space, crack in space...

This was just a crack in space, but does that mean that I might not be the only one in here?

Those trapped in the crack in space couldn't go to another dimension nor return to where they came from. But nobody said no one else would be here.

I didn't know if I ended up here because I turned around on that endless path, but I couldn't be sure that there really wasn't anyone else who was here either.

I got myself a little excited at the thought. Though I recalled what Li Qing said about how I'd be in eternal solitude in this crack in space, the possibility of a second, a third or even a fourth person being here with me gave me a glimmer of hope.

It was also at this exact moment that I realized how terrifying it would be if I were to exist forever, not able to age or die.

A tiny hope that this might not be my future made me jump for joy.

Before I knew it, I was back in the car.

The boy was still sitting there with a blank expression.

I was a little worried about the boy when I remembered that the doctor mentioned he had sustained injuries to his organs. He was wasting time here instead of getting treatment, and he wouldn't be doing anymore after getting duped by that lady and the doctor. *Would his life be in danger?*

What could I do though? I couldn't help him out at all. I couldn't even tell him anything.

This was how it was when you're in a different space.

The boy was still staring out the window. Though I knew he wouldn't be able to hear or see me, I still stretched out a hand towards him and said, "Go get checked again. The lady and that doctor lied to you. Your organs have been damaged after the accident."

The boy turned back all of a sudden and stared straight at me.

I took my hand back in shock.

My heart was racing. *Does this mean he can actually see and hear me?*

That glimmer of hope fizzled just as quickly.

The door opened behind me as the lady returned.

I floated to the back seat. I didn't want to come into contact with a woman who engaged in nefarious deeds with an evil doctor.

The lady was glowing with a natural blush on her face. Fanning herself, she said, "It's pretty hot today. Where do you live? I'll send you back."

I thought the boy would either reject her offer or just give her an address, but I didn't expect him to ask her for the diagnosis. "Where's the... diagnosis?"

The lady was obviously as surprised as I was. She didn't anticipate the question at all. A rigid smile appeared on her face after she paused for a stunned second. "Oh, I'm sorry, I think I left it behind actually. Were you planning to keep it? Should I go get it back for you?"

She passed the bag of vitamins to the boy as she answered.

The boy looked at the bag in her hand and said, "There's no need to. No use keeping it if there aren't any issues."

The lady seemed to heave a sigh of relief as her smile returned. "Yes, that's right. It's no use keeping the film when there isn't any issue. Here, take these. Where do you live? I'll send you back."

The boy took the bag and said, "It's a coincidence that I live nearby. I can walk back on my own. You don't have to send me back."

The lady said, "Do you need me to go with you? Are you sure you're going to be okay on your own?"

The boy shook his head. "It's fine."

The lady did not insist any further. "Okay, take care of yourself. Be careful when crossing the road."

The boy nodded and left with the bag of vitamins. He walked along a tiny street beside the hospital and disappeared into it.

After making sure that the boy had left, a smug smile appeared on the lady and she took out a recorder from her pocket.

She had recorded everything. In case anything happened to the boy in future, she'd be able to use this as evidence to prove that she had indeed brought him for a check-up, and that the doctor did not diagnose any problem and the boy had said he felt fine himself.

That fake x-ray film had also been thrown away. The evidence had been gotten rid of.

What an evil individual.

I guess the recorder wouldn't have recorded that little 'incident' that happened in the clinic.

No longer wanting to be in this woman's vehicle, I left the car.

I didn't know what to do after the vehicle left. I had just witnessed the ugly side of humanity in the world I used to live in. It didn't matter if I disagreed with such actions, it no longer had anything to do with me now. I couldn't even interfere if I wanted to.

Unlike those who were standing at crossroads in their lives, I didn't even have to consider my options, because there literally was nothing for me to do at this point.

Just when I wandered around wondering where to go, the boy appeared before me again.

He had turned back some time ago, and his eyes did not look as empty as they had been before.

There was this light in them, as if he had a clear goal in mind.

He walked into the hospital with confident steps.

I decided to follow him into the hospital.

There were many people in the hospital, and being a child, the boy was not conspicuous. He looked around as if he was searching for something.

I followed closely behind him.

As if finally spotting what he was looking for, he walked towards a trash bin in the corner. He began looking through the trash for something.

After quite a while, he frowned at not being able to find what he was looking for. He then ran towards the stairs. I was still following closely behind him.

He began searching for something along the third floor corridor. This time, I had a tiny inkling of what he might have been searching for.

He smiled as he finally found that fake x-ray film and his diagnosis report in a trash bin along the corridor.

This was the first time I saw him smile.

He folded them and returned to the ground floor. He then made a call on his cell phone.

That call didn't seem to have been picked up, but the boy put the phone back into his pocket and stood near the entrance as if waiting for somebody.

I didn't know what he was planning, but things felt like they were going to get interesting.

I waited patiently with him since I had nothing better to do anyway.

A male carrying a large bag who looked to be in his mid-twenties appeared after some time. The boy's eyes shone as he saw the male, handing over to the male whatever he had in his hands.

"Is this the fake diagnosis?" The young male asked.

The boy nodded quickly in response.

The young male patted him on his shoulder as he asked, “How’s your body? Is it serious?”

The boy smiled. “I’m in a lot of pain.”

A look of worry appeared on the young male’s face. “And you’re still waiting for me here? Go get a proper look, come on, I’ll take you.”

The male took the boy to get a proper check this time.

“There is organ damage that might possibly be life-threatening. You should stay for further checks.” This was what the doctor said.

The boy pulled the male out of the clinic.

“Big brother, I’ll leave things to you. You have to make sure justice gets served for my mother. The police said we can’t record others in secret, so my option was to look for you. This is the recorder I’ve stuck on the lady, and it has evidence of how she and that doctor are in cahoots with each other. They are why my mother is still in hospital to this day. Please help me.”

The boy pleaded with a sorrowful look.

The young male sighed. “Don’t worry, as a reporter, I’m supposed to be helping people like you. Come on, I’ll help you with all the hospital paperwork.”

Hearing his answer, a smile appeared on the boy’s pale face.

Chapter 300: 300 Meeting An Old Acquaintance

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300 Meeting An Old Acquaintance

“No need for the trouble, big brother. I’m already very grateful to you for helping me out on this. I don’t come from a rich family, and though I’m still young, I know it costs a lot of money to stay in hospital. You can’t be helping me pay for it like this. I’ll still have to go to the other hospital to look for my mother. I’ll be extremely grateful if you could help get justice served.”

I didn’t know what happened in the end because I turned and left after hearing what that boy said.

There might be many who come forth with donations after hearing his story. Both him and his mother might be able to recover after that, and those who deserve to be punished might end up getting what they deserve.

But this story might also possibly be buried under the sheer volume of daily news, and nothing might change even if the story makes it on air.

There were various possibilities, and I left because I didn’t think that I could bear to continue being witness to it.

I was happy that he didn’t need my help or a reminder of sorts, and I was also happy that I was able to meet two individuals from the Split Zone over here in the real world. Though I wasn’t very familiar with the two of them, such a meeting made me feel rather grateful.

I seem to have become easily contented now that I was in the real world, but I didn't want to have more of such coincidences. I hoped they stopped.

It was obvious that the two individuals I met here in the real world were absolutely different from those I knew in the Split Zone.

A different issue was brewing between them and although there was a disagreement, they were obviously different from those in the Split Zone.

They were going against the unspoken rules of survival here in this world, while the two I met in the Split Zone simply chose to bow down to the rules that were in the Split Zone.

Whether these worlds were parallel and no matter how similar these people looked to those from the Split Zone, such a difference made me realize that I shouldn't be comparing anyone or anything from the real world with those in the Split Zone.

Since I've realized this, there's no point in me continuing to observe the scene.

This was because no matter what happened between them, it would have absolutely nothing to do with me.

That glimmer of hope I had when I saw the two familiar faces was extinguished quickly and I went back to wondering what I should do with myself.

I even thought that it might be a good thing to be able to see all of humanity from this particular perspective.

When alive, most people wished that they could earn enough and retire in order to travel the world and have a taste of the finest foods on earth.

If nothing else was restricting me and I had time on my side, I would really be able to see the entire world like this. I'd be able to see every single nook and cranny; I'd even be able to go sightseeing in ancient tombs where no one else had ever been.

I was in a state where I couldn't do anything, but I could do everything at the same time.

Traveling the world like this was just a way to kill time. It might probably take a hundred, or even a thousand years to do so. If I do that, I just might be able to hold on to my sanity and not go crazy with boredom.

I could definitely take my time traveling, but I didn't want to do that at all.

Since the passing of time and an aging body are no longer issues that would plague me, I should do something like that; something that others can only dream of doing.

But I didn't want to do it at all.

It was only until today did I realize why humans needed family ties, why they needed love and why they needed things like friendships. If someone merely existed as a lone entity, then that person would not be existing at all.

Humans are social creatures and we find meaning in companionship. I could travel the world now but I had no companion, so why would I want to do that?

I should, however, be looking on the bright side about my situation. Whether I was optimistic or pessimistic about it, I had to live like this. If that was the case, I should at least try to make myself think happy thoughts if I couldn't die.

If I didn't have an interest in traveling the world, then maybe I should go back to the places I've been to...

But did I really have the courage to face the past...?

Should I go see if Gao Qi was still alive...?

No, I didn't want to. I might try and forgive myself if I learnt that he was still alive.

I can't do that.

I didn't want to take a look at the places I've lived in, nor did I want to see those I loved who were still alive. I didn't want to go through the pain of being able to see them but not being able to do anything else.

In that case, I should at least get a sense of where I was.

I walked out of the hospital and headed in the direction of the main road.

At first, I thought I was in a different city from where I came from, but after spotting some familiar buses and road signs, I realized I landed in the very same city where I lived in.

I was quite a distance away from my own house and school that were in another district within the city; this was at the other end of it.

I decided to stay put wherever I was just to people-watch, because there was nothing else I wanted to do.

I felt a lot safer being a wandering spirit in a familiar city. It was far better than being in an entirely foreign place. Also, if I was in an unfamiliar district, the probability of seeing someone I know would probably decrease.

This was the best option to me.

A car was speeding towards me when I crossed the road, and my first instinct was to hide, but for some reason, I simply stood rooted to the spot. The car passed right through me in the very next second, and my dress was not ruffled at all.

I continued walking forwards after giving myself a bitter smile.

A figure then caught my eye as I scanned through the crowd.

I could only see the back of this individual.

This figure looked unfamiliar. I didn't recognize it, but I could tell it belonged to a male. His back was straight and he looked strong and fit with a pair of long, slender legs. There was this heroic aura emanating from his figure, and he was sporting a short, clean hairstyle.

I didn't know what it was that attracted me, but my eyes tracked him as I followed him through the crowd.

Ever since I arrived in this crack in space, I floated around most of the time, just like a wandering spirit. Though I could not interfere in whatever happened in this world, nothing much could actually stop me.

I felt like I was pursuing the figure as quickly as I possibly could, and that male was simply moving at a normal walking pace, but for some reason, I just could not catch up with him. No matter how I moved, there was this distance between the two of us that could not be closed.

I found this weird, but it improved my mood greatly.

Anything that could distract me from my current situation and kill time would probably make me happy at this point.

The figure suddenly stopped in front of the road. He was waiting for the traffic light to turn.

Joy filled me as I quickened my pace. Just as I was about to reach him, the light turned. The figure started crossing the road. Gritting my teeth, I began to run after him.

I finally overtook him while we were crossing the road. I then started retreating, not bothering to look behind me since nothing obstructed my path anyway.

I saw his face as I moved backwards. He continued looking in front as he walked, unaware that there was a spirit staring right at him.

I thought I would recognize his face once I saw it, but I didn't.

He was handsome and he had an overwhelming aura about him, but I could not recognize that face at all.

He had clear eyes and handsome features, but it was an absolutely foreign face. Even so, there was a sense of familiarity about him for some reason. I just couldn't recall it.

In my daze, he had already walked ahead of me, and I had to continue my relentless pursuit behind him. I had nothing better to do anyway.

He finally stopped in front of an orphanage after passing through many streets. He looked up at the sign before he entered.

I looked around when we arrived outside the orphanage. It looked just like an ordinary orphanage from the outside.

It was nearing evening now and the sunset was on the horizon. The Split Zone did not have sunsets, and I lost myself for a moment as I looked at it.

While I was being mesmerized by the sunset, the male had already entered a tiny building within the orphanage. I followed quickly behind.

He had just disappeared up a flight of stairs as I entered that building.

There were some children who passed me as I climbed up the stairs. *I wondered if any of them were able to see me?*

But I was merely an existence in this crack in space, and I wasn't exactly a 'ghost'. I immediately felt like an idiot for wondering if they could see me.

I found myself on the fourth story as I saw the male knock on a door at the end of the corridor. I was already standing behind him.

“Come on in.” A girl’s voice came from behind the door.

I was stunned at hearing that voice. *Did I... hear wrong?*

The male entered the room and closed the door behind him while I was left rooted to the ground, wondering if I should enter the room as I stared at the door. *But I had to enter.*

After taking a deep breath, I stepped through the door.

A girl was smiling at the male who just walked in. I knew that girl.

She was Mi Fu.

Chapter 301: 301 What's the Goal?

Volume 5

301 What's the Goal?

Instead of long, pink hair on her head, she had shiny, black hair. Those tiny pink horns on her head were gone too. She was dressed simply in t-shirt and shorts, but I would recognize that face anywhere. Her voice was exactly the same. She was definitely Mi Fu.

Is she Mi Fu who had returned to the real world?

This felt like too much of a coincidence. Could Mi Fu really be living in the exact same city as I did? And I could even look at her like this after landing in the crack in space?

An occurrence like this seemed very rare. What other secrets have yet to be uncovered?

I stared at Mi Fu as tons of questions ran through my head, forgetting that the reason I arrived here was actually because of that male who had this unique and overwhelming aura about him.

Mi Fu smiled at him. She looked more mature and less childish compared to when I last saw her. She said, "You're here again, Huan Qing gege? Why didn't you come with Xiao Mi *jiejie* today?"

My eyes widened at those words and I turned to look at the male in my confusion.

This individual did not look like Huan Qing at all. His gaze did not look like it belonged to Huan Qing either, but that aura about him was extremely

similar to that exuded by the handsome Huan Qing who loved to dress in white suits.

That was it. I was attracted by that very aura.

I recalled it now.

I couldn't place that aura as I watched his figure from the back earlier, but on hindsight, the feeling he gave me was that same feeling of meeting Huan Qing, an 'old acquaintance'.

If that was the case, I was disinclined to think that this was all a coincidence.

Arriving in this crack in space was already something I found unbelievable. Apart from Huan Qing and Mi Fu, I've also met that stocking lady and that boy. How could all of this be mere coincidence?

Something felt amiss here.

Li Qing rushed over just to save me, and her method was to get me to continue walking on a single path where I could not turn around, or else I'd end up in the crack in space and live here in eternal solitude.

The whole situation did not make sense at all.

I knew something was wrong, and there were probably some secrets unbeknownst to me still, but what made me upset was how I couldn't comprehend the entire situation completely.

Things that felt like they did not make any sense have been happening ever since the very first incident where Laurel's death was faked.

I ended up in a place where I didn't actually exist, but in this place, I was actually able to meet those who had died in the Split Zone and those who had left and returned to the real world.

What did all of this mean? I wanted to know the truth, but I couldn't wrap my head around the situation at all.

What I found weird was that the exact same incident had actually happened between that stocking lady and the boy, but the eventual outcome was totally different from what happened in the Split Zone.

Why did Mi Fu look different from the Mi Fu in the Split Zone? Why did Huan Qing have a different face?

“Haven’t I told you this before? Don’t call me Huan Qing gege in this world. We’re back now, Mi Fu. Be good, forget this name.” Though Huan Qing was correcting her, he did not sound the least bit upset. He patted Mi Fu on the head gently.

Mi Fu was still smiling. Her temper did not flare up all of a sudden nor did she stamp her feet like a stubborn child. She was completely different. Even so, I did not find her friendly for some reason.

Smiling and nodding, she said, “Okay.”

Huan Qing handed her a lunch box and led her gently to a chair beside the window. It was only at this point did I realize Huan Qing carried a lunch box with him.

“Xiao Mi *jiejie* made this for you. She asked me to bring it over.” Huan Qing opened the lunch box and put all the dishes on the tiny table.

There was an unmistakable glint that flashed past Mi Fu’s eyes when she looked at all the food, but I couldn’t comprehend it.

“Go ahead and eat.” Huan Qing patted Mi Fu’s head gently once again as he watched her, waiting for her to start eating.

They looked at each other for a few seconds before Mi Fu started on her meal.

She ate very slowly.

I wanted to rub my eyes at this scene. I used to know these individuals, and they were people I went through some things with.

The both of them seemed to have turned into ‘humans’ who adhered strictly to the rules in this world, and both of them seemed to have changed so drastically. Huan Qing’s noble air seemed to be gone, and that stubborn streak in Mi Fu was nowhere to be found either.

I suddenly missed their old selves. Mi Fu was annoying, but I still missed that about her.

I didn’t know why I felt that way.

As Mi Fu ate, she asked Huan Qing casually, “Xiao Mi *jiejie* has great skills. Aren’t you going to try some, *gege*?” Instead of using the name Huan Qing, she simply shortened it to *gege*.

Huan Qing smiled. “I can’t eat what has been specially prepared for you. Wouldn’t that be letting Xiao Mi *jiejie* down? All her effort to make this would go down the drain, wouldn’t it?”

Mi Fu looked down at the food as she continued eating. I couldn’t see her eyes, but it felt like she was just listening quietly.

Mi Fu did not answer Huan Qing, but after a moment of silence, she asked, “*Gege*, you love Xiao Mi *jiejie* very much, don’t you?”

Huan Qing seemed stunned at the question, but a smile appeared on his face shortly after. “Yes, I love her very much. There’s no need for me to keep this from you now that we’re back anyway. Mi Fu, I should’ve left the Split Zone much earlier. I knew that she’d definitely be looking for me if I went missing. If she can’t find me, she’d just be waiting for me, and I can’t let her down. I don’t have time to let her down.

“But I’m sure you know that I’ve still let her down. I’ve stayed in the Split Zone for way too long.”

Mi Fu looked up after swallowing a mouthful of food. “It’s not your fault. Aren’t you back now? You’re back by her side now. Time here is different from that in the Split Zone. To Xiao Mi *jiejie*, you might’ve just been missing for a short period of time. Even if you had been missing for quite a

while, to her, it's probably not that long. You've treated her well before, and now that you're treating her even better, what would she be discontent with?"

Huan Qing smiled faintly. "She isn't discontented. I just feel that I owe her too much, Mi Fu. Even if all you've just said is true, even if I haven't been missing for an extended period of time in this world, to me, I've definitely spent a great number of years in the Split Zone. Day after day, 60 hours per day, I've been there. I've changed when I was in the Split Zone, and now that I'm back, it's not possible for me to feel as if I don't owe her anything."

Mi Fu chewed on another mouthful of food as she mumbled an agreement. "Yes, I know. It was all because of me. If I weren't there, you wouldn't have had to force yourself to stay in the Split Zone for such a long time. You wouldn't have to feel guilty about it, and Xiao Mi *jiejie* wouldn't have had to wait for you for such a long time. I'm the one who dragged you down."

She sounded extremely calm as she said this.

Huan Qing looked slightly surprised, as if he did not expect Mi Fu to say something like this in such a calm and composed manner.

He looked like he was in a flurry, and he obviously cared about Mi Fu's feelings as he tried to explain himself. "That's not what I meant, Mi Fu. Don't think about it that way. Everything I do, I do willingly. Those were just my honest thoughts, and I don't mean anything else by it. I hope you don't misunderstand *gege*..."

Mi Fu looked up as a bright smile appeared on her face. She looked like a beautiful flower in bloom. "Nope, I'm not thinking too much about it. Don't worry too much about it, *gege*. I shouldn't have said something like that. Don't misunderstand too, *gege*. You should treat Xiao Mi *jiejie* well. I like Xiao Mi *jiejie*. Xiao Mi *jiejie* treats you really well too. You have to be happy, *gege*."

She sounded so sincere. Anyone who heard this would probably feel the warmth, but I actually found myself frowning at it.

I stared at her eyes, trying to look into her heart.

Huan Qing did not look relieved at Mi Fu's words. That guilty look he had betrayed the uneasiness that he felt.

Though I wasn't extremely close to Huan Qing, I saw him as a friend after we had that conversation on the roof.

I couldn't be of any help to him in the Split Zone and I didn't do anything that was of value for him. I didn't even send him off properly. He came and left so quickly.

Looking at him like this, I felt like I could understand him a little better.

He might have felt a little better if Xiao Mi or Mi Fu had blamed him for anything or if they had just bawled in front of him. But for Mi Fu to say something like this, the kind-hearted Huan Qing would feel a greater sense of guilt.

The truth was that he didn't let anyone down at all.

I kept my eyes on Mi Fu, wishing so badly that she could actually feel my gaze right at that moment.

Having spent so much time with Huan Qing, I found it impossible that she didn't understand him at all even if she was just a young child.

I wondered if she said all that because she had really matured and it was something out of sincerity, or if she said it because she knew Huan Qing well.

Chapter 302: 302 He Had Been Disfigured

Volume 5

302 He Had Been Disfigured

“Also, Huan Qing *gege*, when do you think Ku Fei *gege* would be able to return to this world?” Mi Fu seemed to have forgotten what she had just promised Huan Qing seconds ago, that she would not address him as Huan Qing *gege*.

Huan Qing’s expression turned but before he could say anything, Mi Fu changed the subject.

“I’m done, Huan Qing *gege*,” Mi Fu said as she put her chopsticks down and looked up at Huan Qing with a bright smile. She looked totally different from when she mentioned Ku Fei earlier.

I saw the sorrow in Huan Qing’s gaze. Forcing himself to smile, he said, “It’s good that you’re full.”

Mi Fu did not acknowledge the sorrow that was emanating from Huan Qing. She simply packed the lunch box and passed it to him as she asked, “Is Huan Qing *gege* going back to where Xiao Mi *jiejie* is?”

Huan Qing took the lunch box and answered, “Yes, I’m staying over at her place tonight.”

Mi Fu looked sad. “But I’m scared, Huan Qing *gege*. Can you stay here with me tonight?”

“But this...” Huan Qing looked like he was in a dilemma.

Mi Fu continued quickly, “It’s okay to just say that you’re my older brother. You know that the director of the orphanage takes rather good care of me, since I’m the only one who had been unconscious for such a long period of time. They all think that you’ve just found my older brother, and it’s just that I can’t leave yet. But I’m sure they’ll allow some exceptions...”

Mi Fu spoke in this soft tone that made people want to protect her. I frowned at this, but it helped Huan Qing make his decision.

“Okay. Let me just give Xiao Mi a call to let her know.”

Mi Fu raised her head as if she had just received a present, nodding at the same time. “Okay, okay!”

Huan Qing smiled sweetly at her before he walked out of the room.

I decided to follow him outside. Turning around to look at Mi Fu, I saw her look in the direction where Huan Qing had went with a rather creepy smile on her face.

Huan Qing lit a cigarette at the end of the corridor.

The smoke obscured part of that unfamiliar face of his. I couldn’t see his expression clearly, but I could feel the sorrow behind all that cigarette smoke.

He made a call on his mobile phone. This was the first time I heard the female voice on the other side of the call, but it was Huan Qing who spoke first.

“Xiao Mi... Mi Fu wants me to accompany her for tonight. You okay on your own tonight?”

“Qing, what’s happening? Didn’t you say you were just sending her food? This happened the previous time too. You suddenly have a younger sister ever since you woke up in the hospital. You’re not telling me the truth. Why are you being so nice to this stranger?”

The female on the other end of the call sounded very frustrated, as if she just decided to let out all that steam she had been suppressing for a long time.

Huan Qing tried to explain. “It’s not like what you think. I’ve told you this before; it’s not entirely without reason. It’s just that I can’t say it. Just treat it like she’s someone I have to protect after meeting her in my dreams while I was unconscious, okay?”

“You said the same thing the last time. You don’t seem to care about me at all after you woke up. All your energy and thoughts are on her. You said you got to know her in your dreams while you were unconscious, and you found out she really existed as a person after waking up. Who are you trying to kid? There can’t be such coincidences in this world. I’ve wanted to ask if she might be your father’s illegitimate child or something of that sort...”

That conversation lasted for a long time, but it ended without any closure. I could tell that this incident, if left unsolved, would end up being part of the reason or a trigger for a possible break-up.

Huan Qing smoked a few more cigarettes after ending the call and walked back to Mi Fu’s room after he was done. Instead of following him back, I stayed outside in the corridor.

I stayed outside because I saw someone in the corridor, someone that I did not expect to see at all.

Tears escaped me as I looked at that kind and gentle face smiling at me.

It felt like there was finally an outlet for all the days of sorrow and pain I’ve been through. I cried not because I was upset. I was crying tears of joy.

What made us happiest was when we found something we thought we had already lost.

“Grandpa.”

As I met his eyes, I ran into him in an embrace, unable to control my emotions. *Yes, I just saw Old Man Fan.*

Old Man Fan was no longer a stone statue nor was the top of his skull open like the very first time I saw him. He looked a little frail, but his eyes were gleaming with a fiery light. He was glowing and he looked like an ordinary, happy elderly man.

I was trembling with emotion as I hugged him. There was no one and nothing I could touch in the time I've been in this crack in space. It was too painful and too lonely for me.

I began to bawl while hugging Old Man Fan, choking on my words every time I tried to speak.

All that pent-up emotion was released in that very moment; it was something I could not even control. It was lucky that no one else could see us. I could hug Grandpa Fan and cry all I want.

Old Man Fan seemed to understand how I felt as he smiled and patted me on the back as I cried, not saying a word.

I finally looked up at Old Man Fan after crying my fill. I wanted to ask him why he was here, what happened in all this time and a ton of other questions, but Old Man Fan knitted his brows before I could say anything.

“Well, what horrible fate this is. Come with me,” Old Man Fan said suddenly. He pulled me towards Mi Fu's room before I could even begin any protest.

He moved quickly and we were in Mi Fu's room in a matter of seconds. Just as I wanted to ask what that was all about, the scene in the room shocked me.

In the real world, the sky had already turned dark. There was no light in the room and visibility was extremely poor. I couldn't improve my vision since I didn't have MF, and all I could do was to open my eyes as wide as I possibly could and go closer to have a better look.

Huan Qing was lying on Mi Fu's bed with his eyes shut, but it did not look like he was sleeping. Mi Fu was watching him quietly from the side. Something felt amiss.

From the point when Huan Qing returned to the room to the point when Old Man Fan and I entered, there definitely wasn't enough time for Huan Qing to fall asleep. Furthermore, a careful man like him wouldn't have fallen asleep before Mi Fu did.

Mi Fu was watching Huan Qing creepily from the side of the bed. *Could it be... Could it be?*

Is Mi Fu trying to do something to Huan Qing?

"What's wrong with him?" I asked Old Man Fan.

Old Man Fan looked at Huan Qing as he said, "He seems to have been drugged. Go see if there's anything that resembles sleeping pills or the like."

"But it's too dark, I can't see," I said as I looked around me.

Coincidentally, Mi Fu walked over to the door to switch the light on; as if she suddenly realized that the room was too dark. She then walked over to the windows to open the curtains.

As she did all that, I saw a bottle of sleeping pills on the bedside table.

Sleeping pills were usually prescribed by doctors, and it looked like Mi Fu simply used it to make Huan Qing fall into a deep sleep. I heaved a sigh of relief, but what happened next made me gasp.

The room was not brightly lit even with the light switched on, but it was enough to see everything that was in it!

Mi Fu took out a glass bottle from a drawer. I didn't know what was in that bottle, but I could clearly see that a picture of a skull was on the bottle. That was the label used for poisonous substances in the real world.

I grabbed Old Man Fan's sleeve as uneasiness filled me. It felt like I had to hold onto something just to calm myself down. "What's she trying to do? She isn't trying to hurt Huan Qing, is she?"

Old Man Fan sighed. "From the looks of it, that seems likely... It looks like an evil thought..."

My heart skipped a beat. "What should we do? How do we stop her? Tell me quickly, Old Man Fan."

Old Man Fan did not speak. He simply shook his head.

Mi Fu was walking towards Huan Qing with that frightening item in her hands. I was at a total loss of what to do. "Old Man Fan, Grandpa, if you can appear here I'm sure you have a way to prevent this, don't you? Can you stop her? Stop her quickly."

I was almost begging him.

Old Man Fan simply shook his head at me. "Ah Shen, we're not in the same space as they are. We really cannot do anything about this, even if we wanted to..."

Mi Fu had already opened the bottle by now. She then gently poured its contents on Huan Qing's face.

After a few seconds, a bloodcurdling scream was heard throughout the entire orphanage.

Although Huan Qing was in a deep sleep, he wasn't able to continue his slumber when an entire bottle of acid was being poured onto his face.

I was stunned at the horrific scene which had just played out right in front of my eyes.

That creepy smile was still on Mi Fu's face.

Chapter 303: 303 Returning to the Split Zone

Volume 5

303 Returning to the Split Zone

“No!” I almost ripped my throat out screaming. I couldn’t believe what I just witnessed. That face was burning with smoke and the features were already gone. That creepy smile on Mi Fu’s face haunted my vision like a nightmare.

“Ah Shen.” Old Man Fan grabbed me, preventing me from going any closer.

“There’s no use even if you go any closer. Don’t look, close your eyes.”

“No. Old Man Fan, he’s such a good person. Why? Just why?” I asked in tears.

Old Man Fan dragged me out of the room so that I wouldn’t see anything else.

“Listen carefully, Ah Shen. I want to tell to you everything since there’s not much time left.” Old Man Fan shook me by the shoulders when we were in the corridor.

My mind had stalled after witnessing that horrific scene. That was so much more frightening than anything that I’ve seen in the Split Zone in the past.

Terrifying incidents like these seemed to be a normal, daily occurrence in the Split Zone since it was a place where the weaklings get beaten down by

those who were stronger. However, this was the real world.

Something like this in the real world would make one's hairs stand. Furthermore, Mi Fu was only a young child.

But why did she do such a thing? Why did she do such a thing to Huan Qing?

My thoughts were in a mess, but I told myself to calm down and listen to what Old Man Fan had to say. There might be a reason behind everything that had been happening so far.

I listened closely to Old Man Fan's words. "There's no need to be afraid, Ah Shen. Whatever you see isn't real. I know it's confusing if this continues, and your head will feel like it's in a mess, but that doesn't matter. There's no need for you to think too much about it.

"You just have to remember one thing; that this crack in space actually exists. My consciousness ended up being trapped in this space after I used the spatial transference technique twice. But this crack in space isn't permanent. This isn't important, and it doesn't matter whether I live or die. The thing is, the secret of returning to the real world is found here, and I'll have to tell you about it."

Old Man Fan spoke anxiously, but before he could finish, the orphanage started shaking.

I looked up in fear, but Old Man Fan held me tight. "This is bad. I thought we'd be able to have more time. There're still many things that you haven't been able to see. It's actually an illusion that you landed in this space. I created whatever that you've seen, including that boy and that woman, as well as Huan Qing and Mi Fu.

"What I want you to know is that, Ah Shen, even though these are all illusions, it's a fact that none of them have returned to the real world. They are all trapped in different parts within this crack in space. I'm unable to help them return since I'm trapped here too. All I can do is to create

illusions like this so that you'll be able to remember what happened clearly. Forgive Grandpa for this. It's the only solution Grandpa could think of.

“Remember this, Ah Shen. Every soul splitter in the Split Zone is a part of that humanity which used to belong to a corresponding person in the real world. That part can either be good or evil, but whatever it is, remember that you have to leave this place. If the one who rules the Split Zone doesn't die, there'd be no way for any of you to return to the real world even after undoing the split symbol contract.

“Remember this, you have to first kill the one who's controlling everything in the Split Zone. He's the very person who created the Split Zone with all that lost humanity from humans. You have to kill him first.”

My mind was spinning just as the world before me was breaking apart. I didn't know what to say, and all I felt was an impending sense of loss; a feeling where I would be losing everything I had again. I tried to grab Old Man Fan tightly, but I felt him getting further and further away.

Old Man Fan said, “Remember this, Ah Shen. The illusion will break apart in a moment. I don't know what happened to you in the Split Zone, but you must have been in a deep illusion. Someone is trying to save you from that very illusion by breaking through it. The force feels familiar, and it should be Li Qing.

“I can't do much in the crack in space, but I can do things like adding another layer of illusion onto an existing one while two forces of MF are going against each other. This is why I created this spatial illusion. I want you to know that the crack in space does exist, and if you want to save Huan Qing and the rest, you'll have to kill the ruler of the Split Zone.

“There's not much time left. You'll end up back in Li Qing's illusion very soon. Don't turn back until you see the door labeled with 'Gate of Heaven'. If you do, you won't be able to open it and you won't be able to borrow Li Qing's power to return to the Split Zone.”

I got the gist of it. The reason why I couldn't turn back was because of Old Man Fan's additional layer of illusion.

I'd be returning to that path again now that the time's up for this illusion. I can't turn around before reaching that door to the Gate of Heaven, and I should end up back in the Split Zone, outside of Guan Nie's illusion, after I walk through that door.

Even though I understood everything, I was reluctant to let Old Man Fan go. He was like a close relative to me in the Split Zone, and he was leaving me once again. I could not bear to see him go like this.

Old Man Fan looked at me with gentle eyes, as if trying to reassure me that he would be back some day.

Before the illusion crumbled, he said, "You have to kill the ruler of the Split Zone. He's the key to everything. He's..."

The space crumbled around us just as he said a name. I couldn't hear it clearly at all.

Back in that gray space, I began running on that long and tiny path. The sky was a dark gray and the end of the road was nowhere to be seen.

I wasn't sure how I returned to this space. I might not even have left this space in the first place. I might have just been running on this path from before, and my mind could have just made up that memory of me being in the crack in space.

Whatever it was, my face was wet with tears.

Wiping my tears, I continued running forward. I wanted to go back to the Split Zone, and I knew running away was not a solution. I had to help them get away. *Get away from this place that was full of demons.*

With renewed confidence, I focused on the path in front of me as I patiently waited for that door to appear.

After some time, I saw a door somewhere in the distance, partially obscured by that grayish fog. I quickened my pace.

I heard Nie Zun's voice behind me before I could reach the door.

“Shen’er.”

No, I can’t turn around. I cannot turn around.

“Shen’er, they’re all lying to you. Don’t enter that door. This is your only chance to go back. Turn around and you’ll be able to return to the real world.”

Huh, do you think I’m really a fool? Nie Zun wouldn’t say something like that, you liar. I won’t ever turn around.

I thought the voice would continue enticing me to turn around, but there was nothing but dead silence behind me.

Finally, I arrived at the door. Another hand touched mine as I reached for the door. It was an old and gnarly hand.

Old Man Fan’s voice said, “Ah Shen, I haven’t finished. Listen carefully before you return.”

This made me forget that I should have been careful. The thought of Old Man Fan trying to use the last of his strength to tell me the identity of the ruler of the Split Zone made me momentarily forget that I should not have turned back.

There was nobody and nothing else but a grayish-white fog behind me. There was nothing but silence. My heart sank.

I was duped yet again.

Whatever was behind me started crumbling at this moment.

I tried to pull open the door that was right in front of me.

It was just like what Old Man Fan said. The door was locked because I had turned around. I couldn’t open it no matter how hard I pulled.

Thunderous crashes surrounded me as dust and debris scattered. The feeling of being in a space currently facing a catastrophic destruction was more

than horrifying.

I continued pulling on the door. This was the first time I was so close to the edge of destruction, and I couldn't do anything to stop it.

Just as I was about to give up, I caught sight of a tiny hole beside the door handle.

For some reason, I thought of that tiny gold key I had with me.

I fumbled for that key which was given to me by that boy in the Split Zone before he died. Without any hesitation, I stabbed the key through that tiny hole in the door.

There was a loud crash behind me before the ground started shaking violently. The space was going to collapse anytime.

There was nothing I could do but close my eyes and await my end.

I didn't expect the key to work, but I heard a click as I inserted it through that tiny hole.

I stumbled through the door at the very moment when everything behind me turned to dust.

It was like I just teleported through the door back to that ocean of illusion. Everyone was looking at me.

Guan Nie, Si Luo, Cang Ming, Ta Lai, Du Yue and Jiao S were there.

Gaoqin Jiuye and Nie Zun were there too.

Everyone was still there.

None of them spoke, and all of them had this grim look on their faces. Following their gazes, I looked up and realized that the gray sky was beginning to crumble. Li Qing's efforts to break this illusion from the outside might just be working.

Chapter 304: 304 A Sudden Epiphany

Volume 5

304 A Sudden Epiphany

All that uneasiness and confusion I felt were gone in a split second as the scene unfolded before me. It didn't matter anymore if that crack in space was something that really existed.

Guan Nie's illusion was breaking apart now, and I made my decision as I looked at all of them.

Love? I didn't have time for it.

I had to have the ability to love others before I could even talk about love.

There were too many lives on my hands. Even though I might not have caused their deaths directly, I was somehow involved. *If Huan Qing and Mi Fu were not able to return to the real world, how about Song Lu and Yu Liang?*

In the end, everything was just a waste of time and effort.

What did I protect the Western District for? Why did Li Qing protect the Western District for such a long time? Why did she protect me?

It was my entire fault. I shouldn't have wallowed in my own confusion. If the Split Zone were to throw me puzzles, I should have just picked them up and solved them on my own.

If I cannot leave this place, if the Western District was meant to be destroyed under my watch, then I should at least let the rest leave.

I had to protect them.

I took one last look at Jiao S, Gaoqin Jiuye and Nie Zun before I made my decision.

Yes, this was the path I'm going to take.

I touched my chest to check if my heart was back. As expected, it was not there. It was probably still with Nie Zun. I wondered if my MF would return once my heart was reunited with my body.

There were many unexplained occurrences in the Split Zone, and that would not be something that was out of the ordinary either. I might not even need to wait a month for my MF to recover. Even if it did not recover after I get my heart back, I would still have her with me.

After seeing how so many others were going after my second personality, I came to believe that this second personality of mine might just be the key to greater power; where two souls led to double the power.

My gentle gaze turned cold at this thought. Staring at Nie Zun, I raised a hand and said, "Give me my heart back."

I spoke firmly with no intention of a compromise.

Since he didn't listen to anyone else, I didn't think he'd be willing to return it to me just like this. I had Piercer with me, and I was prepared to fight him for it if he argued with me on this.

I turned a little to check if Piercer was still there. She was right behind me, and she looked ready to engage in a battle at a moment's notice.

"Okay." To my surprise, Nie Zun actually agreed.

The others looked surprised as well. *This did not make any sense. He took my heart away and refused to return it no matter what, but he's suddenly*

giving it back now? What's this game he's playing?

Blood was already dripping down Guan Nie's lips as the illusion continued to shatter.

With a quick motion of Nie Zun's left hand, I felt a warmth in my chest almost immediately. At the same time, Cang Ming, Du Yue and Ta Lai all turned to me with a bright gleam in their eyes.

As I had expected, I was still their target at the end of the day. They were really aiming for that second personality of mine, and I would be way too naïve if I continued ignoring the presence of this second personality.

It was rare to have sudden epiphanies, but it just so happened that a striking realization hit me right at that moment.

It might have been because I witnessed Old Man Fan disappearing for the second time, or it might have been because I was using all my strength to run towards that door at the end of the path. It could also have been because of that very moment when I closed my eyes to await my death after inserting that key in the door, or it could have been because I saw all of these people at the very moment I successfully opened the door. No matter what the trigger was, it was then that the epiphany hit me.

I would never be able to regain my freedom and my friends would never be able to go back to their lives if the Split Zone was not destroyed.

Whether it was for them or for myself, I cannot continue being a weakling.

It might have been because of this sudden realization that I was able to accept her temporarily, since I was thinking about making use of her to achieve my goals.

She reappeared before me at the very moment I accepted her in my heart.

She was standing on the sea of water, smiling at me in a red dress that ruffled in the ocean wind. The wind blew through her red hair as she looked at me with those bright and clear eyes.

Her lips moved gently as she asked, “Do you need my help?”

I didn’t reject her this time. *I will never reject her again.*

Taking a deep breath, I reached out my right hand towards her with a sweet smile.

She understands this. She can definitely understand it.

She smiled as she raised her right hand. I saw the skull ring on her finger. Its design was identical to the ring Nie Zun had, except that it was red. It was a red skull ring.

She slowly removed the ring from her finger and walked over to put it on me.

Nobody else could see what was happening.

All of them thought I was reaching my hand out for no apparent reason since they could not see her, nor could they see the ring.

I then ignored her after that. Turning to Jiao S, I said, “Jiao, come with me. We’ll wreak havoc in this Split Zone. Li Qing is right outside waiting for us. Let’s unravel all the secrets and uncover the truth together.”

Jiao S looked a little stunned, and she turned slightly emotional before joy finally appeared on her face. Her lips turned up in a warm smile. “I’ve been waiting forever for you to say this.”

She turned to Si Luo, looking at him with this unfathomable gaze, but I could tell she was resolute. She then moved quickly to stand beside me, making her intentions clear to everyone else.

What more could I ask for with a friendship like this?

Raising my right hand that had that red skull ring on it, I smiled and pointed at Du Yue and the rest. “Aren’t all of you here for me? No need for all that acting if that’s the case, just come at me all at once. I would like to see if you can really take my second personality away.”

Cang Ming looked interested as he lifted that huge sword back onto his shoulder. “I know why someone with balls like Gaoqin would fancy you now. You’re rather bold, woman. You dare to issue such a challenge even without an ounce of MF in you? I wouldn’t have an issue with that, but I guess that wouldn’t be the case for the rest of them here.”

He sarcastically tilted his chin towards Ta Lai and Du Yue.

Du Yue had already moved to stand beside Ta Lai. I guess love is all-powerful; it can soften even the most ferocious of women.

I smirked at her. *So what if you’re standing beside him now? There’s no one else but Bian Ying in his heart.*

There was no sympathy left in me for these individuals. *All soul splitters were my enemies now.*

I wanted Song Lu and the rest to continue living their peaceful lives, I wanted to save Old Man Fan and I wanted to find Mr Blond. I wanted to send Jiao S, Nie Zun and Jie Pa back to the real world. Everyone who tried to stop me from achieving my goals would be an enemy I had to remove.

“Hmph, not only is that a joke, that is literally impossible to me. Li Shen, where do you think this is? It’s the Gate of Heaven, and you’re in my territory. Do you think that you’re still in the Western District? You’re nothing but a cripple now. Stop embarrassing yourself here.”

Du Yue spoke harshly with an evil glint in her eyes.

I knew the reason behind that anger of hers. It was because both Ta Lai and Cang Ming were fighting over Bian Ying, and Gaoqin Jiuye stole glances at me from time to time. Everything made her increasingly frustrated by the second. Moreover, she wasn’t able to gain much of an upper hand in her fight with Jiao S. This probably led to a target shift as she decided to pick on me, who was currently the ‘weakest’ one around.

Unfortunately for her, I’ve transformed from a squishy persimmon into a hardy radish. (Passerby A: This is such a horrible metaphor... It’s so

crass... Me: *kicks Passerby A away*)

Instead of getting upset, I answered with a smile, “You can determine if I was indeed embarrassing myself shortly. That heart is back in its warm chest cavity where it belongs. Aren’t you guys aiming for it? Come on, I’m giving you a chance now.”

I beckoned to Du Yue with a challenging finger.

Du Yue probably did not expect me to ever look down on her like this, and I could tell she was fuming. However, with just one look from Ta Lai, she turned into a tame little lamb and controlled that anger of hers.

While continuing to fiddle with that jade stone ring on his finger, Ta Lai looked as elegant as ever. “Seems like that dream you had while you were floating unconscious on the water has given you newfound courage even after you fell into the sea. Do you want to just tell me who you dreamt of?”

Returning his elegant smile, I answered mockingly, “Whoever it was, I was definitely not trapped in my dreams by somebody whom I loved deeply but who had left me for somebody else,” not forgetting to subtly mention how he was trapped in one of his nightmares because of Bian Ying.

Both his and Du Yue’s faces darkened at that.

Chapter 305: 305 A Demonic Sound

Volume 5

305 A Demonic Sound

What I said and how I said it obviously surprised the rest. After listening to my exchange with Ta Lai, Si Luo turned to me.

“I guess you’ve got it all sorted out now.”

Si Luo was still the most clear-headed and rational one here.

I nodded. “That’s right, I’ve got everything sorted now. I wonder if you’re satisfied by that. About the agreement we have, I’d be keeping my word on it. There’s just one thing I’m not too clear about.”

Si Luo waved a hand. “That’s fine. I’d be willing to assist you if you’re able to maintain this mindset and attitude of yours. I’ll tell you what to do regarding those requests of mine.”

Getting Si Luo’s endorsement gave me an extra boost of confidence.

Everyone else could hear our conversation, and I was sure Gaoqin Jiuye was perplexed about that agreement I had with Si Luo. I saw him looking at the both of us in the middle of our conversation with a deep frown.

Ta Lai and Du Yue’s expressions turned darker after Si Luo made his intentions clear.

“Nobody could understand why you did what you did in recent years, Si Luo. If only you didn’t leave at that time, Du Yue and I might probably not

be able to match up to you at all in the Gate of Heaven right now. Everybody envied the fact that Feng Zhu favored you, but you simply left.

“I thought it was because you hadn’t yet been in the Split Zone for long, and you might not have thought about the consequences of your actions. But looking at things now, I guess you can’t be bothered about maintaining the balance among the soul splitters and you’re planning to go against the Gate of Heaven for real this time.”

Ta Lai spoke in a domineering tone; it had less of his usual elegance and more of a threatening hint.

Si Luo answered calmly. “It’s not merely a couple of days since we’ve known each other, but doesn’t the world work like that? People work together because they have a common goal. The scenario you’ve painted is merely hypothetical, and it’s a fact that you and Du Yue rule the Gate of Heaven at present, while I’m simply a traitor who has left for years; someone who doesn’t matter at all. There’s no way to compare myself with the owner of the Gate of Heaven’s Palace of Cold Blood and Lord Ta Lai at all.”

Si Luo paused for a second, and his face beamed when he spoke again. “Though I didn’t gain much in terms of fame and power in all these years, I can’t say that I’ve lost anything either. At least I was able to protect the friends who’ve been by my side, and I haven’t lost my lover either.” At this, his gaze casually passed over Gaoqin Jiuye and Jiao S.

Jiao S’s eyes lit up when she heard this. Although she and Si Luo did not meet often, and the impression that Si Luo gave to others was that he was always avoiding her, what he had said was a clear answer to Jiao S.

I suddenly felt that this beautiful person was the definition of what a real man should be.

I didn’t know what it was that impressed me so, but from the very first time I saw him, I could tell that secretive aura about him was not something he intentionally aimed to portray. He emanated it naturally because he was on

another higher level where others could not easily understand and comprehend.

It was a sense of justice and also a love for the masses.

If there was one person among soul splitters I could empathize with, it would probably not be Gaoqin. It would probably be Si Luo.

Although what Si Luo said had impressed me, it derided how Du Yue lost Gaoqin Jiuye and Ta Lai, and how Ta Lai had lost Bian Ying.

Ta Lai and Du Yue's faces turned even darker at this, but it pleased Cang Ming, who was contentedly observing the exchange.

Of course, as someone from the Gate of Ghost, he'd naturally be happy that there was internal strife among those from the Gate of Heaven.

Guan Nie's eyes had never left Si Luo. I felt sorry every time I happened to look at him, and everything that happened to him seemed so unfair. He had never hurt anyone, nor had he done any wrong. He was just too stubbornly focused on Gaoqin Jiuye.

I believed that Guan Nie would be able to let go of things if he could only realize that it would be the same no matter who Gaoqin Jiuye was with.

Guan Nie looked extremely pale, and his MF might have been greatly affected by Li Qing's attacks from outside of the illusion. Gaoqin Jiuye noticed this too and said to Guan Nie, "Undo the illusion. Your MF is very unstable now."

Guan Nie bit his lip. "I didn't know you cared about me." Gaoqin Jiuye frowned as if upset.

I couldn't bear to continue watching them like this. I said to Guan Nie, "I don't get you. There are some people and some things that aren't worth it, and you don't have to take a second look at them. Why the obstinacy if he doesn't treat you well?"

Guan Nie did not respond nor did he seem agitated. He simply looked pale.

The sky then sank a few meters in a thunderous crash.

Nie Zun finally spoke, his voice calm as ever. “The illusion is breaking. We shouldn’t be making any moves now. Using MF would just affect the space here, and it’ll just lead to more chaos.”

Before he could even finish, lightning struck from the sky. Everyone looked toward it, and I used this opportunity to scan everybody’s faces.

Si Luo was to my right while Jiao S was on my left. Gaoqin Jiuye was standing a little in front of Si Luo, and the four of us basically made up one team. Opposite us, Ta Lai and Du Yue were on the right, while Guan Nie and Cang Ming were both on the left.

Nie Zun and Jie Pa were standing in some dark corner between these groups of people, somewhere to the right.

Piercer was right behind me.

This was the perfect chance!

I signaled to Piercer, who understood it right away. A violet whip appeared in Piercer’s hands as she flew towards Du Yue and Ta Lai, purple dress trailing in her wake.

I followed behind her closely, the black ocean water splashing all around me while I ran as fast as I could on its surface. I stretched out my left arm where Scorpion Ray was glowing.

Du Yue squinted as she was momentarily dazed by the bright light, and that split second of hesitation provided me with the perfect opportunity. I raised my right hand where the skull ring was glowing with a bright scarlet light. It looked as if my finger was on fire.

Piercer had already reached the two of them now. Du Yue stared at Piercer angrily as she raised a hand. I felt an invisible pressure coming down upon me from the sky, but an invisible screen formed in front of me as Piercer struck with her whip.

With this temporary protection, I moved over quickly to Ta Lai. Ta Lai could tell I was aiming for him, and there was a cold gleam emanating from that jade stone ring on his right hand. A few giants dropped from the sky after he mumbled something.

“I guess no one is planning to listen to you. They’re bent on having a huge battle right before this illusion falls apart.” It was bystander Cang Ming who said this to Nie Zun.

Nie Zun smiled indifferently.

The light from Scorpion Ray was about to reach Ta Lai, and I didn’t think too much about those giants which had appeared just moments before.

Jiao S was already in the air with her huge sword in hand. Those giants were diverted with an easy wave of her sword.

I didn’t expect for Si Luo to make any move, but he did not seem to hesitate either. The surroundings quaked as white fog surged in his eyes, and I could hear air vortexes form around me.

Guan Nie hated Si Luo, and now that Si Luo was attacking the illusion, he had no intention of backing down even when he had been continually coughing up blood.

Guan Nie’s strength was in embedding illusions within MF, causing his opponents to fall into his trap unknowingly. It seemed like he was bent on going against Si Luo this time.

Gaoqin Jiuye did not just sit and watch. He stumbled forward with his only arm. The sky dropped once again.

Though I had decided to focus on the battle and not be distracted by my emotions, I couldn’t help worry about Gaoqin Jiuye as I saw him stumble from the corner of my eye.

This tiny distraction gave Ta Lai the time to counter my attack.

Ta Lai's pupil's widened as he reached out a hand. Two rays of weak light shot out before I felt myself freeze. I could not move any of my limbs.

Damn it!

That puppet technique of his did not apply only to those giants; it applied to bodies of consciousness as well.

I felt invisible strings cut into my body as Ta Lai smiled. With a quick movement of his fingers, my body was slowly being controlled by Ta Lai.

"Piercer," I called out. Distracted by my call, Piercer turned back for a moment. But before she could come over, Du Yue had already grabbed her neck. She only had one arm, but her arm was strong. Piercer was rendered immobile by Du Yue.

Jiao S could see that I was in trouble, but being surrounded by those giants, she had no opportunity to provide me with any assistance.

Gaoqin Jiuye moved at this moment, but Si Luo stopped him.

I didn't know why Si Luo did it, but before I was absolutely controlled by Ta Lai, there was this ear-piercing sound that came from the sky.

I widened my eyes. *This, this demonic sound.*

Li Wen was here.

The demonic sound pierced through my ears. It was this very sound that immobilized so many of us and rendered us helpless against Li Wen in a previous battle.

Not only did the sound throw a wrench in the fights, it began to break the entire illusion.

Crash...

I felt my joints breaking apart as the sky began to spin, and before I knew it, I was falling into the darkness.

Chapter 306: 306 Ruler of the Gate of Exit

Volume 5

306 Ruler of the Gate of Exit

This time though, instead of passing out, I felt myself landing on flat ground. I could also move immediately after that.

I looked around myself as I stretched.

All of us were in our original positions, except that we were no longer on Guan Nie's ocean. Guan Nie was paper-white as he coughed up blood.

There were two individuals who joined us. They were Li Qing and Li Wen.

Momentarily, I thought I had been transported back in time; that I was the Li Shen of the past and they were still in the Western District. Li Qing was still in that silver armor of hers and Li Wen was in her favorite pale yellow dress.

But I knew that the situation was different now.

Li Wen was standing a little bit behind Li Qing, and both of them had their eyes on me. It felt like the both of them had this mutual understanding and telepathy between them, something that could only be built when people have been together for a long time.

Refusing to take a passive role, I spoke first. "I heard you're actually a soul splitter?" I looked straight at Li Qing as I posed the question.

I didn't bother on small talk because I didn't have any extra time to waste. *I had already wasted too much time before this, I was too weak. I will no longer be indecisive and hesitant from now on.*

Li Qing nodded. "That's right. Apart from that, I also rule over the Gate of Exit. The Gate of Exit, the gate of *Li*, is named after Li Qing." (T/n: '*Lidao*' is the phrase used in Chinese for Gate of Exit.)

She continued before I could respond. "It's not the time to talk about this. I'm here to save you, Ah Shen."

No, don't call me Ah Shen. I'd turn soft like this. I'd turn back into the old me where I relied on you for everything, where I hid behind you all the time.

I didn't have to worry about anything as long as you, Li Qing, were there. Even if you weren't, Li Wen would take care of everything else. Even when you had gone missing, You Ji was the one who helped me take care of Western District matters.

But things changed so quickly. Right now, I want to rely on myself even though you're back.

Please don't give me false hope.

"This is rare. The Gate of Ghost's Cang Ming and even Li Qing, ruler of the Gate of Exit, are both visiting the Gate of Heaven. Is this an auspicious sign of sorts?" Ta Lai was smiling as he spoke calmly, but there was no hint of friendliness in his eyes.

Cang Ming did not bother responding to Ta Lai, but Li Qing spoke.

"Ta Lai and Du Yue, both of you have the gall to target someone of mine without my agreement? The Gate of Exit is nothing to you guys now, is it?"

Du Yue smirked. "We aren't scared of you even if you are the ruler in the Gate of Exit. You say they are your people, but don't forget that they are still heirs. You're just like us, a soul splitter. How could a soul splitter help outsiders like that? I can understand if it's Li Wen, since she's been with

you for a long time. But it's been so long since you've left the Western District and you haven't been involved with Li Shen when you're ruling over the Gate of Exit now. Isn't it a bit too much of a stretch for you to say that Li Shen is your person when we are in my territory here in the Gate of Heaven?"

A hint of a smile appeared on Li Qing's face as Du Yue finished, and before anyone realized what was happening, Li Qing flew up with a raised hand and landed right in front of Du Yue, giving her three hard slaps.

Slap, slap, slap.

The crisp slaps resounded in the plaza. One could hear the power in Li Qing's slaps, and all three of them were equally powerful.

Not only was Du Yue stunned by it, we were all stunned.

Li Qing then spoke in a calm and casual manner. "There is hierarchy in the world of soul splitters to maintain the balance between the three gates, and that agreement helps the three parties co-exist. Feng Zhu, the ruler of the Gate of Heaven, would also have to be respectful to me. Moreover, I'm the one who came over here to visit a lowly soul splitter like you. Even if you are a 'lord' in the Gate of Heaven, don't you think you're being too audacious by speaking to me like that?"

Li Qing's tone turned sharp when she commented about Du Yue being too audacious. That fierce and domineering aura caught everybody's attention.

It was not the first time I saw Li Qing like this, but it was a side of her I rarely saw.

I always knew that Li Qing was highly-respected back in the Western District, even though nobody knew she was a soul splitter and she looked merely like someone who was great in battles. Compared to the rumors about the cruel Jiao S in the Eastern District and the mysterious Si Luo in the Southern District, Li Qing was not tagged with any unique characteristics of sorts.

Even so, she was well-respected by the people. Whoever it was and wherever she went, others would always give Li Qing some sort of respect. Even Mr Blond took her words into careful consideration.

I thought this was because Li Qing was someone upright and someone who never hid her intentions from anyone.

Li Qing did not mind minor brawls as long as her ‘children’ were not hurt.

Those children referred to us. They referred to every single resident of the Western District.

It was rare to see her like this, where she did not care about Du Yue’s dignity.

Du Yue was extremely stunned, probably because no one else had dared to treat her like this.

Li Qing maintained her smile. “Upset? Am I wrong? You’re trying to argue with me instead of showing respect when you’re merely a ‘lord’ in the Gate of Heaven when I’m the ruler in the Gate of Exit? Who’s the one who gave you such guts and who taught you how to disregard the rules, Du Yue?”

Even if what Li Qing said made sense, I didn’t think that Du Yue would just take it lying down. I expected her to retaliate.

But I was wrong.

Shock, embarrassment and anger passed over Du Yue’s face as Li Qing spoke, but she responded calmly. “Yes, I was too audacious. As the ‘lord’ in the Gate of Heaven, it should be my pleasure to welcome the ruler of the Gate of Exit into the Gate of Heaven for a visit. I hope that as ruler of the Gate of Exit, you would be able to oversee this mistake.”

I raised my brows in surprise. Du Yue was a stubborn character, especially when it came to issues that involved me. She would usually refuse to back down, but she actually said something like that even after Li Qing slapped

her three times in front of everyone. *I guess there are also times when I underestimated others.*

Li Qing looked satisfied with Du Yue's answer. She wasn't someone unreasonable. She waved a hand and said, "Fine. I'm not here to start a war of sorts today, so you don't have to worry about that, Du Yue. I'm here to collect my person, so I hope that Ta Lai and Du Yue, both 'lords' in the Gate of Heaven, would not make things too difficult."

Ta Lai spoke, "Please don't misunderstand, Lord Li Qing. We didn't force Li Shen to come here, and I'm sure everyone else here would know this. She came over voluntarily, and neither of us made things difficult for her in any way. Of course, Lord Li Qing would also be aware of the rules and hierarchy among the three gates. I wonder if other soul splitters would find your actions respectable if they knew that you had used your rank against us minions before you even visited Lord Feng Zhu."

Ta Lai's tone was steady and calm.

"Disgusting, so disgusting. I've had enough of these pretend conversations between you people. Why beat around the bush if you are looking for a fight? What's the use in that? It's no wonder you people always criticize us in the Gate of Ghost, saying that we do things as if we were evil demons and how we don't adhere to the rules. If you people were the good guys here, then I think that all the good guys deserve to die."

Though Cang Ming was harsh, his words had some logic to it. If the justice in those places was simply made up of nothing but pretense, then it was definitely not worth listening to these people.

Instead of getting angry at Cang Ming, Li Qing addressed Ta Lai with a smile. "Look, someone is berating us now. No more beating around the bush then. Let's all place our cards on the table and see how we can work it out. How about that?"

Ta Lai returned the smile. "Work it out? I'm afraid that wouldn't be your only goal now that you're here in the Gate of Heaven. I believe it if you say

that you're here to save Li Shen, but I don't think that's your only goal, is it?"

Li Qing raised a brow. "Oh, what other goals might I have then?"

Ta Lai kept silent with a smile on his face.

"Amitabha, have mercy."

I heard a sound in the distance. It felt very familiar, as if I have heard it somewhere before, but I just could not recall it.

However, at the very moment I turned around to look at the source of the sound, I remembered it.

Chapter 307: 307 I am a Devil

Volume 5

307 I am a Devil

Our visitor was a monk.

No, calling him a monk seemed unbecoming for his rank.

He was an abbot.

I remembered seeing this abbot once, but he left after saying ‘Amitabha’.

I snapped alert at his sudden appearance. Having been in the Split Zone for so long, sudden visitors like that usually spelled trouble.

This abbot, however, looked so merciful. He had a pair of eyes that seemed to emanate sorrow. He did not seem like a bad person at all.

While I was wondering why the abbot suddenly appeared, Ta Lai and Du Yue walked over with lowered heads.

I kept my eyes on them as I moved out of their way, wary of their movements and ready to counter any possible attack.

The two of them could not be bothered about me at all. Instead, they lowered their heads before the abbot as they greeted him. “Abbot Feng Zhu.”

Abbot Feng Zhu? I was stunned when I heard this.

So this abbot was Feng Zhu. Feng Zhu was actually a monk?

Things seemed to be getting more and more complicated, but there was no suitable opportunity for me to speak.

Li Qing nodded at the abbot as she said, "It's been a long time, Feng Zhu."

This verified the abbot's identity for me. He was none other than Feng Zhu, the ruler of the Gate of Heaven.

Feng Zhu's kasaya seemed to emanate a calming light as he spoke. "It has been a long time since I've seen such an old acquaintance, Li Qing from the Gate of Exit."

Li Qing did not bother with the small talk as she steered the focus back to the topic at hand. "Your lovely disciples have great ability and they are also really efficient. They actually have the gall to eye someone on my side. I wonder if you were the one who taught them to do things this way?"

It might be because this abbot did not have much of temper that Li Qing was able to say things so directly. If it were anybody else, it would probably have led to an angry fight.

I wondered if it was because of his beliefs, but not only did the abbot not lose his smile, he seemed to turn even friendlier at what Li Qing said.

"I'm here today to discuss this very matter with the Gate of Exit's ruler. Also, don't you wish to meet Huai Du after such a long time, Li Qing?" His question seemed to have targeted Li Qing's weakness as I saw her brow furrow.

As someone who had lived with Li Qing for a long time, I knew she was someone who could hide her thoughts and emotions well. It was usually very difficult for anyone else to tell what she was thinking. She was always seen with a friendly smile, and I only saw her serious side during battles. That serious look of hers had the ability to scare many as well.

If Feng Zhu could cause Li Qing's brows to knit with just a single sentence, whatever happened between her and Huai Du was definitely complicated.

“Feng Zhu, let’s put everything on the table instead of beating around the bush like this. How about we talk about everything right here in front of all these juniors?”

Feng Zhu seemed to be waiting for her to say something like this as he gave a satisfactory smile. “Things between the lot of you are way too complicated. I don’t have any interest in all of that. What I’m concerned about is you, Li Qing. You’ve been known not to cross these boundaries between the areas, and you wouldn’t come over on a whim. I’m sure you’ve travelled all this way because of certain goals. Would you be able to tell me who these people are?”

Li Qing did not look happy with those knitted brows, and at this moment, there was no hint of a smile on her face. She looked at Feng Zhu as she spoke. “I guess I’m just like a piece of cheap meat now that I’m here in your territory in the Gate of Heaven, am I?”

“Amitabha, have mercy. You’re taking this way too seriously.” The abbot paused for a moment before he continued, “No need for all that pretence, Li Qing. Since I’m here, let me just tell you that I’m here to solve this problem.”

“Oh? How are you going to do that?”

Feng Zhu turned to me with a smile. “This girl has a unique constitution, and not only did she bring another personality into this world, her own personality makes it so that some other personality would be able to resonate with hers. You knew about her uniqueness from the start, didn’t you? There’s no way such a careful person like Mr Blond would be unprepared if such a weird entity arrived in the Split Zone.

“This is also why he left her in your care. Li Qing, I don’t doubt that you are able to control this weirdo with your sense of justice and strong personality, and I’m sure you’ll be able to prevent whatever catastrophe this weirdo might bring to the Split Zone. But to do that, you’d have to plan for such scenarios beforehand.

“However, you left this lady and didn’t keep your promise of being by her side to watch her. This caused her to make decisions of her own and those decisions just so happen to contribute to things that aren’t beneficial to this world.”

“What are you talking about?” I couldn’t help but shout at him.

Although they were speaking in general terms without naming anyone, I understood what this Abbot Feng Zhu was getting at.

He was saying that weird things have been happening around me ever since I’ve arrived in the Split Zone, and because of that, they’ve determined that I am the one who would bring destruction and catastrophe to the Split Zone. This was also the reason why they wanted to get rid of me.

But since the ruler of this place has not yet spoken, they can’t just destroy me, the ‘weirdo’, just as they pleased.

This was why they were responsible for making sure that I would not turn out to be a weirdo after arriving here by taking care of me like I was a child who did not know anything.

They’ve put me in the care of someone reliable to prevent me from turning ‘bad’, and that reliable person was Li Qing.

They’ve chosen Li Qing to watch me from the very day I arrived here. To put it nicely, it was to help me develop a kind heart, but to put it bluntly, Li Qing was chosen to be the one to educate me on things because she was strong, reliable and she also had extraordinary abilities.

So I was the devil all this while. At least in their eyes, I was it.

Because of that, even though I had not done anything to jeopardize the Split Zone, they still planted someone near me to watch my every move. They even got this informant to show emotion, and it made me treat her dearly like I would a loved one.

I knew that I should not be so emotional about this, but everything that happened made me feel so disappointed. It felt as if there was no one who was willing to accept me, that there was no one around willing to help me get these things straight.

“She’s been living well, whether I was by her side or not. If it were not for you people from the Gate of Ghost and Gate of Heaven who’ve been looking for trouble with her, would she have been pushed to the edge like this? She’s been living well and I chose to leave temporarily because I wanted to prove that she was good. I didn’t do it to prove that she was inherently evil.”

Instead of arguing, Abbot Feng Zhu smiled at Li Qing’s words. “All these people on her side now, one of them has already turned into a real devil belonging to the Gate of Ghost. One of them used to protect the Eastern District and was known for her cruelty, but she always had justice in her heart. All of them had changed because of her. Even Si Luo and Gaoqin Jiuye, both of whom used to be under me, have now switched sides to help her out. What do you think is a real devil?

“A real devil is not when someone is a demon. A real devil has the ability to cause others to switch sides, to cause others to turn on their friends and go against them. That is a real devil.”

I was getting more and more confused by the second. *What were they talking about?*

They were calling me a devil.

I might have been a weirdo before arriving here, but I haven’t done anything in the Split Zone to cause any uproar of sorts. Why was I the root of the problem now?

“Could you guys explain this to me?” I asked coldly.

Abbot Feng Zhu squinted as he smiled at me. “Child, you might not be inherently evil, but someone else had predicted that there would be a weirdo like you who’d arrive in the Split Zone one day, and that you’ll affect a

great change in this place. I wouldn't consider you to be a demon, but isn't there this phrase that people in your world love? That it's better to kill a thousand than to let one that is guilty go free.

(T/n: Translated literally, the Chinese phrase used here is 'to rather kill a thousand innocents than to let go of one truth'.)

"I can tell you think that you're innocent from how you're looking at me, and you haven't done anything wrong in fact. But like what I just said, the issue is not about how terrifying you may be, it's about how you could influence others. It could lead to your friends' deaths, or it could lead to the districts being destroyed and whatever else. The fact is that all the incidents were centered around you. Would you still say that you're good and not evil?"

Haha, what a joke. I'd take it if you said I was a weirdo or a demon, but how could you accuse me of being the harbinger of destruction when my friends end up dying and when the Western District ends up being destroyed?

Chapter 308: 308 Gratitude and Grudges

Volume 5

308 Gratitude and Grudges

Whether or not I'm eventually able to return to the real world, I don't think I would ever be able to forget about the Split Zone.

I was living like a tiny ant here, and I ended up falling in love with a devil.
Turns out I'm also a devil myself. Isn't it funny?

"I'm a devil? Hahaha!" I laughed until I almost teared. "Have you seen such a weak devil like me?"

"If I really was a devil, I'd have killed every single pretentious person I saw in the Gate of Heaven," I said to Feng Zhu coldly as I pointed at Ta Lai and Du Yue.

"Amitabha. The 'evil' you're thinking of could be exactly as you described, and in terms of being a 'devil', it's the demon in the heart that manifests itself in actions. Sometimes, it doesn't manifest in evil deeds, it might manifest itself in your 'good' deeds.

"I understand how you feel, Li Shen, but facts are facts. Don't you find that you have always been able to escape with amazing luck every time something untoward was about to happen? If you didn't have that kind of ability in you, wouldn't you already be six feet under?"

I interrupted him. "What are you trying to get at?"

I realized at this point that Feng Zhu had a long string of prayer beads in his hand. The beads were huge, bright and shiny, and he moved them methodically along his hand.

“What I’m trying to say is simple. You’ve been a unique entity in your world, and it’s the same here in Split Zone 13. Because of that, you turned into a target here.”

I smiled faintly. “So? According to you, I’m the target because I’m a naturally unique entity. And you feel that this is my fault?”

Feng Zhu said, “Amitabha. This monk has no intention of blaming anyone on this. What I meant was that this identity of yours would lead to disharmony among the three Gates and disrupt the current peace in the Split Zone. This is why I have to resettle you in order to bring peace to the Split Zone.”

I couldn’t help laughing at this. Under many curious gazes, I laughed my fill before I answered Feng Zhu. “Resettle? I think it’s more of settling a punishment. You people from the Split Zone are really interesting. So what if I’m naturally unique and have a special ability? I didn’t create chaos among the soul splitters here in the Split Zone nor have I fought anyone over any territory. I haven’t hurt anyone. If you guys didn’t hurt my friends in the first place, I wouldn’t have left the Western District at all. I’d have just stayed there forever. It’s because the greed of soul splitters is insatiable, and it’s the soul splitters who are itching for a fight. They’re the ones who are hankering after my power and that becomes my fault?”

What Feng Zhu said made me realize something. It was the same in the real world as well. There was no need for me to feel inferior or guilty because I had two personalities. *I haven’t hurt anyone else before I killed Gao Qi, and no matter how weird I was, no matter how I couldn’t fit into this world, I haven’t disrupted the lives of others. How was I at fault?*

It was my fault that I killed Gao Qi, and I deserved to be punished by serving time here in the Split Zone. But that was what happened in the real world, and it did not mean that I would hurt anyone from the Split Zone

because of that. *They had no right to judge me or attempt to control me like this.*

I stared at Feng Zhu coldly. “If I remember right, all you soul splitters have a real identity back in my world. You’re a part of their humanity, right? How about you? Who are you a part of? You talk about justice all day and create excuses for all your actions, saying that it’s to ‘keep the peace’. From this alone, I can tell that you guys had really come from my world. There’s that greed and the ignorance I see in you.

“You’re actually even worse than the scum in our world, since you’re merely a part of our humanity. Your personality is incomplete and because of that, your judgements on right and wrong are flawed. You have no right to judge if I, a complete human being, am good or bad. You say that I had the ability to influence and change others, and to disrupt the balance in the Split Zone. But if these people did not want to be influenced, how could I have actually influenced them?

“If those in the Split Zone did not hanker after my power and for things that didn’t belong to them in the first place, would I have ended up as a threat to the peace here?”

Feng Zhu’s eyes glinted. I couldn’t tell what went through his mind.

I smirked. “You can’t even convince the masses with your words, monk. Your reasoning sounded something like this. A precious gem appeared in a house, and everyone in the house started fighting with one another because all of them were greedy and wanted to get their hands on that gem. However, as a passer-by looking at the situation, you’re suddenly saying that you want to punish the gem as if it’s the gem’s fault.”

Du Yue stared at me angrily. “How dare a mere heir be this audacious!”

I turned to her. “An heir may be lowly to you, but to me, you guys are a part of us. You’re not all that high up either. If I dare say things like that, it means I’m no longer afraid of anything. Haha, I’m really curious to see what are the punishments you lot have in store for me.”

Feng Zhu shot Du Yue a look before she could continue, causing her to swallow her words.

Fiddling with his prayer beads, he said, “Don’t be too quick to judge, benefactor. This monk has not finished, so there’s no need to be this agitated.”

Haha, benefactor? This monk? You really think you’re an abbot now, don’t you? You’re trying to imitate whatever happens in my world now.

“I told Yue’er and Lai’er to invite you over to my Gate of Heaven in order for me to take a better look at you, but my two disciples might have misunderstood me on this. Benefactor Li Shen may have also misunderstood my disciples on this, and this has led to the situation that we all see right here.

“Actually, everyone has similar goals. You guys want to return to your homeland, and we want to protect ours. This isn’t some sort of pretense nor is it wrong. I understand Benefactor Li Shen doesn’t want to harm others, and it’s just like what you’ve said, that it isn’t your fault. But the thing is that there are others who are eyeing your power so that they can wreak havoc in the Split Zone. As the ruler of the Gate of Heaven, how could I simply sit and watch? I have my duties as a ruler, so I hope to seek your understanding on this as well, benefactor.”

Li Qing frowned. “Feng Zhu, when have you become someone who likes to beat around the bush like this?”

Feng Zhu spoke to me with a smile, but his expression seemed to change a little when he spoke to Li Qing. I still couldn’t figure out his thoughts, but from that minute change in expression, I could surmise that there was probably some sort of disagreement between the two of them.

He said, “I should’ve been there personally to welcome the ruler of the Gate of Exit when you’ve just arrived in the Gate of Heaven. But Lord Li Qing seems to favor stealth now. I wonder if it’s because I wasn’t a good host the last time you visited, or is it because you still blame me for what happened in the past?”

Li Qing was calm as she spoke. “There’s no point in blaming anyone for what’s already past. What’s upsetting is that I haven’t blamed you at all for it, but you seem to think that I’ve been putting the blame on you.”

Feng Zhu stared right into Li Qing’s eyes. “You don’t blame me? How is it possible that you don’t blame me now that Huai Du is like this? I was the one who turned him into a bloodthirsty monster, and I was also the one who separated the Split Zone into three clear areas – the Gate of Heaven, the Gate of Ghost and the Gate of Exit. Even so, you’re still going to pretend and say that you don’t blame me?”

There was no change in Li Qing’s expression. “I’ve just said it. The most upsetting part is that you keep thinking that I blame you when I actually don’t. Also, he isn’t a monster.”

A tiny fire lit up in Feng Zhu’s eyes. That fire did not seem to match the overall aura of the kasaya he was wearing.

But that fire was extinguished as quickly as it rose, as if it was tamped down by a sudden memory.

“Why don’t you stop him if you’re so protective of him? Why are you letting him be when he’s just acting as he pleases? What you’ve done is simply to abandon the Gate of Exit and take on a role of District Commander among the heirs.”

Li Qing’s eyes darkened. “I didn’t.”

Feng Zhu continued. “Do you think you can avoid all this once you’ve run away to the world of the heirs? Did you think that he’d let you live in peace? Did you really think that all those monsters and experimental subjects were the work of my subordinate, Du Yue, in all these years? You should know very well that he was the one behind it all, since you’re the one who knows him best, aren’t you?”

I recalled the fight with the basiliscampus and how Li Qing did not want us to continue looking into the matter. Maybe it was not merely for training

that she cut my arm off. She might have wanted to distract Nie Zun and shift his focus away from the basiliscampus.

No, I shouldn't doubt Li Qing like this. But why was I terrified? It felt as if there was something cold and dark that was trying to claw its way out from the deep recesses of my heart.

I turned to Li Wen subconsciously.

Li Wen simply regarded me with an unfathomable gaze.

Chapter 309: 309 Who is the Debtor

Volume 5

309 Who is the Debtor

Was everything fated from the very beginning, except that I wasn't aware of it all?

“There’s no need to reminisce the past. What do you want?” Li Qing asked as she looked at Feng Zhu.

“How many monstrosities disrupting the Split Zone have been created in Huai Du’s demon cave? I’m sure you know the answer even if I don’t say it. Though it isn’t caused by her, it’s her constitution that allows her to enter that demon cave. I have to refine her.”

Oh, he has finally revealed his goal. After all that talk, he just wants to turn me into a weapon.

Si Luo said suddenly, “So are you going to treat her like how you treated me in the past? You promised to give me your Gate of Heaven, but now that I see it, history is repeating itself in the Gate of Heaven right now. You’ve simply shifted your target from me to somebody else.”

Si Luo had been refined by Feng Zhu, just like Nie Zun?

“What does that mean? What did you do to Si Luo?”

Jiao S turned serious as she heard this. She did not care who she was speaking to, it could have been anybody else but the ruler of the Gate of

Heaven. She spoke in a dead serious tone.

Feng Zhu was slightly surprised by this sudden mention of the past as he said, “Do you think you’re a finished product? If I’m planning for her to become like you, wouldn’t I be setting myself up for the scenario which faced me years ago, where I faced the betrayal of a child I had cultivated personally?”

Si Luo looked up with white fog in his eyes as he stared at Feng Zhu. “Your definition of betrayal is me not participating in any of your plans and not stepping into any of the three Gates, it’s how I’d rather live among the heirs for a hundred years as I take on your sins. There’s probably no one who’d think of betraying people if betrayal was like that.”

We punctually arrived at the district line as the sky turned bright. I immediately spotted Jiao S and the loathesome white-robed Guan Nie. Guan Nie’s eyes lit up as he saw Nie Zun and he quickly scuttled over. “I only agreed to come along because I heard you’d be going.” Nie Zun blinked at him, flashing him a bright smile. I rolled my eyes at that.

Jiao S looked over at me. Not wanting to mince words, she said, “The Southern District is different from both our districts. I want to make some things clear before we cross over.” Everyone else remained silent as they listened intently.

She looked around before saying, “Because the Southern District is filled with deficient people, the district commander, Si Luo, set up an impenetrable defense system. However, while we’re heading into foreign territory, we needn’t worry for our safety as assassins are unlikely to appear in the Southern District.”

“What do you mean?” Jie Pa asked suddenly.

“From what I know, we’ll be walking into an illusion created by the Split Zone’s top illusionist once we enter the Southern Forest. Once you step across the district line, you will immediately enter this dream-like state that reflects what you hold deep in your heart. If you carry a murderous intent, the illusion will cause you to retreat out of the forest of your own volition.”

With a frown, I asked, “How have all of you mastered such superhuman abilities?”

The white-robed Guan Nie smirked. He looked at me with disdain as he responded, “Looks like the rumors were true. The Western Commander really is a good-for-nothing who hasn’t even been able to master anything beyond the basics.” My face twitched. *What the hell.*

Jiao S looked at me with a twinge of surprise. “No one in the Western District has these abilities?”

Nie Zun laughed. “Even the commander doesn’t, so how could anyone else have them?” I broke out in a cold sweat. *Th-this...*

Song Lu and Yu Liang both lowered their heads, unable to refute it. The white-robed Guan Nie shook his head, a grudging expression on his face. “Since I’m worried you’ll slow my extraordinary self down, I’ll put up with having to teach you.”

He took a few steps forward and turned around. Lifting his white hair from the ground, he exposed the sun symbol on the back of his neck. I suddenly felt my heart drop. I quickly looked over at Nie Zun. *A moon, a sun... And in the exact same spot. Did that mean anything?*

Nie Zun remained calm though. With a light smile, he looked at the back of Guan Nie’s neck. It was then that I realized that there was a key inserted into Guan Nie’s split symbol!

“What’s going on?” Jie Pa asked in surprise.

“This is my own splitting key,” Guan Nie responded lazily. He turned back and shot a flirtatious look at Nie Zun. *Gag...* As he looked tenderly at Nie Zun, he started to give an explanation that seemed like it was directed solely at Nie Zun. “Our own splitting keys cannot kill us. If we insert them into our split symbol, we gain unrestricted control over our mental force.”

Hearing this, Nie Zun’s eyes lit up. “To what extent?” he asked.

“It’s limitless in the sense that you can use any type of skills. Heh. But as mental force has its limits, most people will only be able to develop a single skill.” So it was like that. Things like invisibility and creating illusions, and the like, could be explained this way.

“However, many people are unable to use this technique,” Jiao S added.

“What do you mean?” I asked.

Jiao S stared at me. “After you insert the key, you will receive a punishment. As long as the key remains inside your split symbol, the punishment continues. Each person’s punishment may be different. Some cannot bear the punishment, so they would rather not use this technique. I suppose this is the reason Li Qing was unwilling to let anyone in the Western District use it. So, no one ever taught you guys.” She looked over at Song Lu and the rest of the group.

A surprised expression appeared on Song Lu’s face. “Master Li Qing could use this technique?”

“Of course,” Jiao S said with a nod.

Guan Nie suddenly covered his mouth and laughed. “As an example, for the duration that my splitting key is inside my split symbol, my entire body will feel a constant pain that is 100 times more painful than an ordinary person could endure.”

Nie Zun raised his brow. “How do you endure it then?”

Guan Nie’s smile deepened. “It’s nothing much. At first, the pain was indeed difficult to bear, but I’ve grown used to it now.”

A gust of wind blew past us. I already felt the cold sweat pouring out of me. Being able to adapt to a constant pain that most couldn’t handle, living every day with such a pain — what did that feel like. I figure I would never feel that kind of pain.

Jiao S turned back to me. “This technique requires that your split symbol be activated. While using the technique, your strength will not decrease as you use your mental force. For example, if you want to use 30 MF to create an illusion, once the illusion ends, you will regain your 30 MF, but you won’t lose 1 MF for activating your mental force. However, this will take a toll on you once you remove your splitting key. When you return to your ordinary state, your mental force will decrease according to your usage. In this case, your mental force will drop 30 levels, and remain as such for a month before it’s recovered.”

I became apprehensive. If that’s the case, then this technique costs a lot of mental force. Afterwards, you’d be left very weak, essentially living like a cripple for a month. And you would be in danger during that time.

“While our own splitting key is inserted in our split symbols, can others still kill us?” Jie Pa asked a key question, trying to analyze this information.

Jiao S explained, “Of course. Others will still be able to kill you. Additionally, while your key is in use, you naturally cannot kill another. When you remove your key, your mental force will have decreased dramatically, so you’ll still unlikely be able to kill another. This technique can only be used for combat, and it does not allow for killing.”

“Since the assassin who attacked me would have been using a stealth ability, meaning his splitting key was unavailable, why was he still trying to kill me?” I didn’t understand.

“I would guess that he wasn’t trying to kill you, but I don’t know what his motive could have been.” Jiao S appeared to be deep in thought. I couldn’t help but furrow my brows. Things were getting more and more complicated.

Jiao S suddenly gave a sinister laugh. “It doesn’t matter. Whatever his motive may have been, my death squad is sure to make him spit it out.” A chill ran down my spine as I looked at that savage, smiling face of hers.

Yu Liang stepped forward. “You’re telling all of this to us now because you want us to unlock this extraordinary power before we enter another district.

You think that we won't be able to pass through the illusion otherwise."

Jiao S seemed to appreciate Yu Liang's understanding of this as she regarded him with what looked like praise in her eyes. "That's right. Though we're not planning on killing anyone, and it's unlikely that any of us carry any kind of murderous desires, that illusion isn't something to think lightly of. Even if we don't plan on killing, our motives aren't entirely pure either. I'm worried that traveling through the forest will be time-consuming and draining. I hope that you can all activate this technique so that we won't have to slow down."

Did this mean that she wanted us to insert our splitting keys now? But who would reveal their split symbol to others so easily? Not everyone possessed Guan Nie's confidence, so sure that no one could kill him.

As if sensing my apprehension, Guan Nie scoffed. "We won't look. Jiao S and I will cross first. As for the rest, you can determine for yourselves what you'll do. Just know that the Southern District isn't the gentle place that you may think it is."

After he said that, he stepped across the district line without a hint of hesitation, not even giving us a moment to prepare. His body quickly disappeared into the forest on the other side. I then realized that he had addressed Jiao S by name instead of addressing her as Commander. Looks like this Guan Nie character really wasn't someone Jiao S could order around at will.

With what looked like slight concern, Jiao S gave me a long hard look before she turned and crossed the district line as well. *These Easterners were really firm in their workings...*

Nie Zun lazily scratched his head. "So, should we use it or not? Hmm?"

Jie Pa adjusted his glasses as he stepped forward and said, "I'll use it."

We exchanged glances with one another, and then we nodded at Jie Pa, expressing our agreement. We turned away as he inserted his splitting key.

Maybe it was because I had my back to him, but time seemed to be crawling along at a snail's pace.

After a long time, he finally said, "I'm done." His voice trembled ever so slightly.

When I turned to look at him, he was standing in the same spot and it didn't seem that anything had changed. But I noticed that Jie Pa's calm and steady gaze carried a hint of fear and his body seemed to be trembling.

Nie Zun was the first to notice something amiss. He frowned and put a hand on Jie Pa's shoulder. "What is it?"

Jie Pa's expression slowly turned to one of pain. "I-it's nothing. I'm fine."

Since Jie Pa didn't seem to want to say more, we didn't probe him further, but Song Lu and Yu Liang exchanged a look. Yu Liang comforted her, "I'll go first." Song Lu looked at him uneasily.

Once again, we proceeded as before. When we turned back around, I saw that while Yu Liang didn't appear to be in pain, he had a very helpless look about him.

Chapter 310: 310 Don't Say You Love Me

Volume 5

310 Don't Say You Love Me

I could not see further than three meters from the window. There was nothing but white fog everywhere.

“There’s nothing here,” I said as I tried my best to look outside through the window.

“Let’s go out and have a look,” Gaoqin Jiuye said.

“How do we go out? There doesn’t seem to be any doors around.” I looked around the empty hall. There was nothing here.

“We can still go out even if there’s no door.” Gaoqin Jiuye smirked as the air around us started to fizzle. As his pupils dilated, the air around us formed conical spikes which flew straight at the glass window.

I gasped. *He didn’t even think much about it before he acted.*

“I’m full, Huan Qing *gege*.” Mi Fu smiled as she looked up at Huan Qing, looking totally different from when she mentioned Ku Fei earlier.

Huan Qing’s eyes looked pained as he seemed to force a smile out of himself. “It’s good that you’re full.”

Mi Fu did not seem to register Huan Qing’s emotions as she repacked the lunch box and handed it to him, asking, “Is Huan Qing *gege* going over to

Xiao Mi *jiejie*'s place later?"

Huan Qing took the lunch box and said, "Yes, I'm staying over at her place tonight."

Mi Fu put on a pitiful face. "But I'm scared, Huan Qing *gege*. Can you stay here with me tonight?"

Huan Qing looked like he was in a dilemma. "This seems..."

Mi Fu then added quickly, "It's okay to just say that you're my older brother. You know that the director of the orphanage takes rather good care of me, since I'm the only one who had been unconscious for such a long period of time. They all think that you've just found my older brother, and it's just that I can't leave yet. But I'm sure they'll allow some exceptions..."

Mi Fu spoke in this soft tone that made people want to protect her. I frowned at this, but it helped Huan Qing make his decision.

"Okay. Let me just give Xiao Mi a call to let her know."

Mi Fu raised her head as if she had just received a present, nodding at the same time. "Okay, okay!"

Huan Qing smiled sweetly at her before he walked out of the room.

I decided to follow him outside. Turning around to look at Mi Fu, I saw her look in the direction where Huan Qing had went with a rather creepy smile on her face.

Huan Qing lit a cigarette at the end of the corridor.

The smoke obscured part of that unfamiliar face of his. I couldn't see his expression clearly, but I could feel the sorrow behind all that cigarette smoke.

He made a call on his mobile phone. This was the first time I heard the female voice on the other side of the call, but it was Huan Qing who spoke first.

“Xiao Mi... Mi Fu wants me to accompany her for tonight. You okay on your own tonight?”

“Qing, what’s happening? Didn’t you say you were just sending her food? This happened the previous time too. You suddenly have a younger sister ever since you woke up in the hospital. You’re not telling me the truth. Why are you being so nice to this stranger?”

The female on the other end of the call sounded very frustrated, as if she just decided to let out all that steam she had been suppressing for a long time.

Huan Qing tried to explain. “It’s not like what you think. I’ve told you this before; it’s not entirely without reason. It’s just that I can’t say it. Just treat it like she’s someone I have to protect after meeting her in my dreams while I was unconscious, okay?”

“You said the same thing the last time. You don’t seem to care about me at all after you woke up. All your energy and thoughts are on her. You said you got to know her in your dreams while you were unconscious, and you found out she really existed as a person after waking up. Who are you trying to kid? There can’t be such coincidences in this world. I’ve wanted to ask if she might be your father’s illegitimate child or something of that sort...”

That conversation lasted for a long time, but it ended without any closure. I could tell that this incident, if left unsolved, would end up being part of the reason or a trigger for a possible break-up.

Huan Qing smoked a few more cigarettes after ending the call and walked back to Mi Fu’s room after he was done. Instead of following him back, I stayed outside in the corridor.

I stayed outside because I saw someone in the corridor, someone that I did not expect to see at all.

Tears escaped me as I looked at that kind and gentle face smiling at me.

It felt like there was finally an outlet for all the days of sorrow and pain I've been through. I cried not because I was upset. I was crying tears of joy.

What made us happiest was when we found something we thought we had already lost.

“Grandpa.”

As I met his eyes, I ran into him in an embrace, unable to control my emotions. *Yes, I just saw Old Man Fan.*

Old Man Fan was no longer a stone statue nor was the top of his skull open like the very first time I saw him. He looked a little frail, but his eyes were gleaming with a fiery light. He was glowing and he looked like an ordinary, happy elderly man.

I was trembling with emotion as I hugged him. There was no one and nothing I could touch in the time I've been in this crack in space. It was too painful and too lonely for me.

I began to bawl while hugging Old Man Fan, choking on my words every time I tried to speak.

All that pent-up emotion was released in that very moment; it was something I could not even control. It was lucky that no one else could see us. I could hug Grandpa Fan and cry all I want.

Old Man Fan seemed to understand how I felt as he smiled and patted me on the back as I cried, not saying a word.

I finally looked up at Old Man Fan after crying my fill. I wanted to ask him why he was here, what happened in all this time and a ton of other questions, but Old Man Fan knitted his brows before I could say anything.

“Well, what horrible fate this is. Come with me,” Old Man Fan said suddenly. He pulled me towards Mi Fu's room before I could even begin any protest.

He moved quickly and we were in Mi Fu's room in a matter of seconds. Just as I wanted to ask what that was all about, the scene in the room shocked me.

In the real world, the sky had already turned dark. There was no light in the room and visibility was extremely poor. I couldn't improve my vision since I didn't have MF, and all I could do was to open my eyes as wide as I possibly could and go closer to have a better look.

Huan Qing was lying on Mi Fu's bed with his eyes shut, but it did not look like he was sleeping. Mi Fu was watching him quietly from the side. Something felt amiss.

From the point when Huan Qing returned to the room to the point when Old Man Fan and I entered, there definitely wasn't enough time for Huan Qing to fall asleep. Furthermore, a careful man like him wouldn't have fallen asleep before Mi Fu did.

Mi Fu also seemed to be a little out of the ordinary.

Cang Ming and Nie Zun's faces darkened.

Si Luo turned to Cang Ming. "You still insist on fighting?"

Cang Ming looked grim but he was not fazed. "Naturally. I'm here for the woman I love. There's no use in going back if I can't protect her."

His words moved me. I suddenly began to feel envious of Bian Ying.

Si Luo seemed to have anticipated Cang Ming's response as he said, "I'd definitely have a back-up plan prepared. Would you like to hear it?"

No matter what it was, I guess I'd end up being the sacrificial lamb here. This guy was targeting me...

Any normal person would usually listen to Si Luo's suggestion, but the unpredictable Cang Ming said, "How about we exchange blows first, Si Luo?"

Bright lights began gathering in his left palm as he raised a hand. The lights gathered to form a white blade and it entwined around Cang Ming's left wrist where the hilt of the sword should have been.

Attracted by that amazing sword of light, I almost didn't realize it until Cang Ming waved it at me. I pulled Jiao S in an attempt to escape, but when I tried to focus my MF, I recalled that I didn't have any and I was actually no different from an ordinary human being.

Jiao S reacted quickly and she was already pulling me away from the attack, but she was only slightly faster. I heard it swoosh past my right ear as it cut through the air.

A deep gash was left on the ground in its wake.

With that speed and the ability to destroy the stone ground with just a casual wave, Cang Ming was no easy opponent.

Cang Ming rested the sword of light on his shoulder. His muscles and dark skin were partially exposed under that blood-red robe, and he flashed a fearless wide smile at us. There was a dangerous but enchanting aura about him.

I felt sweat on Jiao S's palms. *Was she... worried about Si Luo?*

Nie Zun avoided Cang Ming's attack as well, and his coat was ruffled by the gust of wind brought on by the speed of the blade.

Chapter 311: 311 Leave With Me

Volume 5

311 Leave With Me

“Why are you able to see her?”

Nobody else could see her except for me. *Even though Piercer is a living weapon, she's still a body of consciousness. Gaoqin Jiuye's Shen Qi did not look like he sensed her presence either, so why is Piercer able to do that?*

“I don't know why I'm able to either. I just can. That's not my point here though. The point is that you'll have to get used to these abilities if you want to win and if you want to achieve that eventual goal of yours. You have to learn how to use and control your power.”

“This power doesn't belong to me.” I refused to acknowledge it.

I did not want to acknowledge that this terrifying power slept within me. It wasn't something I was proud of. It was something that had brought about endless solitude and something that made others shun me for seemingly no reason.

I didn't want to understand or accept her, but I had no other choice right now.

There will always be things we have to compromise on.

“You're regretting it so quickly when you were so clear about your goal just moments before?”

“No,” I said as I shook my head. “Fine, it’s true that I can use her power. Tell me what I should do next.” It came out this way because I was unwilling to accept that power.

“No matter what it is, I want to remind you once again. Ah Shen, no one can take this power that comes from within you. You are also strong enough to protect yourself and everyone else whom you want to protect here. It’s just that you aren’t able to accept that power in your heart. Right now, you wouldn’t be able to gain access or use her power if you aren’t able to accept her. If that happens, you wouldn’t be able to achieve your goals either.”

“I’ll accept her, if it’s to protect them.”

I answered Piercer as I looked over at the fight happening between Jiao S and Du Yue.

Piercer nodded. “Then you’ll just have to make good use of that ring on your finger. There’s another thing I want you to know. That ring on Nie Zun’s finger is also invisible to others, except for me. What I’m afraid of is that, if I’m able to see it now, someone else might be able to do the same in future. Though Nie Zun’s ring is very similar to yours, it’s actually different. I can feel the demonic aura that’s emanating from that ring of his. It’s that very demonic aura that’s controlling him, and I suspect that it has something to do with that demon cave.

“From what they’ve said earlier, it seems like you are the only one who has the ability to change the demon cave when you enter it. It might have something to do with your constitution of having two personalities.”

As Piercer was explaining patiently, Feng Zhu and Li Qing stood facing each other under a façade of serenity.

However, I felt the atmosphere around Feng Zhu getting heavier and heavier. My gut told me that nothing but chaos would ensue if this ruler of the Gate of Heaven exploded in a fit of anger.

Even so, I was not the least bit worried about Li Qing. I was confident in her abilities.

Though Piercer praised Du Yue and said she looked like a goddess of war in battle, the real goddess of war was none other than Li Qing.

Li Qing was well-versed in battle, and she had an in-depth understanding of all the events that led up to the situation today. Neither Du Yue nor Jiao S could hold a candle against her. Furthermore, I don't remember Li Qing having lost in any fight she had voluntarily joined in.

Li Qing was the real 'Split Zone Goddess of War' whom others feared.

Li Qing remained calm and collected as her indigo hair flew in the wind. Her silvery-white armor and that halberd she carried on her back would make others shrink a little in fear once they laid eyes on it.

Both of them had overpowering auras, and they seemed to be testing each other, as if looking for a weakness in each other's MF that could be used as a point of entry.

Battles between aces did not always look glamorous. Both sides knew when to attack the opponent and when they should stop.

The two of them were in such a state right now. It was highly possible that the first one who launches an attack would find themselves at the losing end.

I thought Li Qing might make the first move even though that might mean losing the advantage in battle. I didn't think she was someone who liked playing mind games like these, since she looked like someone who preferred to jump straight into the thick of things.

"Are you planning to just stand here and watch?" A familiar and pleasant voice asked.

It was Nie Zun.

Jie Pa was still standing behind him. The two of them seemed coordinated in black jackets, and they looked like they were waiting for something to happen, just as I was.

“What else? No one is fighting me right now. Or do you actually want to try?” I didn’t know why I just couldn’t be polite to him when I actually wanted to hug him so badly.

I suppressed the emotion that threatened to spill out of me because of a few simple words from him. *This is not the time to pause for love. I had to destroy the Split Zone and save those I had to save.*

Love is useless, and love can’t bring me towards salvation.

“Miss Ah Shen, all of you have to calm down.” Jie Pa adjusted his glasses as he stepped out from behind Nie Zun.

“Calm down? I’m being calm. What do you guys plan to do now?” I asked as I looked at Jie Pa.

“Come with me,” Nie Zun spoke suddenly, his gaze indifferent. *Is this a joke?*

I shuffled quickly up to him, asking in a low tone, “What are you trying to do? You’ve been acting like this after you came out from the demon cave. What do you want and what are you planning? You’re not telling me anything. You took my heart and returned it. Just what are you trying to do?”

There was this look of suppressed agony that spread across Nie Zun’s face.

I couldn’t bear looking at such an expression when he wasn’t talking. I thus swallowed the words that were about to come out of my mouth.

“It’s not as complicated as you think it is. I just want to live here on my own. I’ve had enough of being tied down to you.”

Though Nie Zun explained it to me like this, I didn’t quite believe him. I just didn’t.

“Then why are you asking me to leave with you?” I laughed in self-mockery.

“I can’t leave you alone here and just let them fight over you like this.”

Jie Pa took a meaningful look at Nie Zun before he turned to me. “Miss Ah Shen, no matter what it is, it’s still a better option to leave this dangerous place right now.”

I shook my head in vehemence. “I’m always running away. The Western District has already been destroyed, and I won’t have anywhere else to go anyway. I’d rather face this head-on and find out if I can really leave the Split Zone and uncover its secrets to gain freedom. I really don’t have the time or the energy right now to understand whatever you’re thinking about or hear about whatever you’ve been through. Let’s just go on our separate paths from today onwards, as you have wished.”

The ground of the central plaza began to shake as I finished. The shaking was gentle, but there was a warmth that accompanied it.

In a few seconds, my feet felt like they were stepping on hot coals. The split symbol on my ankle was also heating up.

I turned around to look at her. She was in a red dress, and she looked at me with a pair of flirtatious eyes that seemed to hold an enchanting mystery.

“Can you feel the power that I’m giving you?” She asked while smiling sweetly at me.

‘Why do you have MF?’ I looked at her, posing her a question through my head.

I had realized earlier that I could actually communicate with her in my mind. In this way, others wouldn’t treat me like I was insane when I looked like I was speaking at nothing but air.

She lifted a hand to cover her mouth in a laugh. “Because... I am you...”

Tamping down the hate I felt towards her, I looked at the heated split symbol on my ankle.

It didn't look any different. I then looked at the blood-red skull ring on my finger.

"Where did you get that ring?" I didn't know when Nie Zun caught sight of it, but he asked in a low voice where only the both of us could hear.

So he could see the ring too.

I wasn't surprised by this. It seemed that everything which involved him would make sense to me, including that inseparable link we had. It started from the very first day we arrived in the Split Zone, and he had even ended up here because of me.

If he could see the ring, could he see her too?

I was a little afraid of such a possibility. I stared at him as I went closer, replying in the same low voice, "Can you see her?"

Nie Zun's pupils widened. "Her?"

Seems like he cannot see her.

That made sense. If he can, he would've seen her long ago. There was also no need for him to keep up the pretense for so long.

"Haha, there's no need to ask him about that. He can't see me, unless I want to let him see me. In that case, he'll be able to..." I heard that sultry voice right in my ear.

So you make the decisions on everything. Are you that willful, devil?

"She was the one who gave me this ring. You know who I'm referring to, don't you? It's the same person who gave you a similar ring before," I said.

Nie Zun stared at me. "You're finally willing to accept her?"

I remained silent.

Nie Zun put a hand on my shoulder. “You’ll be in danger if you accept her, especially in your current condition. Everyone here has their eyes on you because of her. They’re all looking for her, don’t you understand that?”

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“I understand that, and this is why I can’t run away. Since you’ve decided to go on your own path, it shouldn’t matter to you whether I live or die.”

As I gave a bitter smile, the warmth under my feet suddenly turned to a boiling heat. The source of the heat came from somewhere between Li Qing and Feng Zhu. They were still staring at each other, and nobody moved even though Li Qing had her halberd in hand and Feng Zhu’s kasaya was whipping fiercely in the strong air currents.

We were about to be barbecued with that heat. It was getting unbearable, and seeing my brows knit, Piercer dashed over to lift me into the air.

Though I could feel some sort of movement in my split symbol, I couldn’t feel an ounce of MF in me at all. It was lucky that Piercer was here to help.

Nie Zun and Jie Pa were levitating in the air. They would have felt that impending sense of destruction brought about by the heated ground too.

Jie Pa adjusted his glasses as he said, “My body is healed and it can regenerate itself now. I can be your shield if you’re hurt in any way, Miss Ah Shen.”

I did not respond.

Du Yue and Jiao S were already in the thick of battle. They had leapt into the air when the heat wave reached them.

Even without any sort of support in the air, Du Yue was able to maintain that same strength and power.

Jiao S seemed to be more agile in the air as well. Fighting in the air was her forte, and she had always seemed to enjoy it. She appeared in mid-air the very first time I met her, and she used that same air current technique as Gaoqin Jiuye the second time we met. She was able to use those air currents as a power booster.

I could tell Jiao S was enjoying this fight as the white fog continued surging in those huge, passionate eyes.

The girls that Li Qing favored – whether it was me, Li Wen, the deceased You Ji, or Jiao S – we were all similar to Li Qing in some way. We turned into a somewhat different person during battle.

Jiao S moved at lightning speed as she waved her weapon in the air, her huge sword reflecting bouts of light.

Though she was without a weapon, Du Yue was able to use her legs to parry the attacks from Jiao S's sword in mid-air. She looked calm and collected; it was the face of someone who had tons of experience in battles.

It seemed like no one was gaining the upper hand in the fight, but I knew we'd end up being on the losing end if the battle was prolonged.

After promising Li Qing that she wouldn't interfere in her battle, Li Wen was simply watching the fights from the sidelines, yawning from time to time.

Even when the ground started heating up, she picked up the ends of her dress lazily and floated up into the air as if she could not be bothered about any of the fights that were currently happening around her.

Looking at Du Yue's attacks, I turned to Piercer and said, "Bring me over there to help Jiao S out."

Piercer nodded as she linked arms with me and flew towards where Du Yue and Jiao S were.

“Hold onto me,” I said as I grabbed Piercer’s hand, while my other hand received the purple whip she had with her. I struck at Du Yue with the whip.

Du Yue sensed the attack very quickly and she flipped to catch my whip on her legs. I pulled the whip back towards me as I signaled to Jiao S with a look. Jiao S understood me immediately as she charged forwards with her gigantic sword, aiming for Du Yue’s remaining arm.

There wasn’t any hint of hesitation in her actions. *In the Split Zone, you’d just end up hurt if you acted like I did, hesitating before doing anything.*

If nothing went wrong, Du Yue would be losing her other arm, and if Jie Pa could work with us and activate a sealing technique on her, she’d be rendered immobile temporarily.

I shivered slightly at Du Yue’s frigid gaze. But before she made any counter-attack, Jiao S’s sword was blocked by another sword.

That sword was very slim, and a narrow ray of bright light was produced as it was swung.

It was Li Wen’s Li Xi Sword.

I didn’t know when Li Wen had joined in on the action, but she looked like she was enjoying all the chaos. The Li Xi Sword was in her hand and Jiao S was forced to retreat a couple of steps with that move.

Jiao S stared at Li Wen as her black hair flew in the air. “I still remember that time when you used that Li Xi Sword to trample on me. I guess today would be the very day that I take my revenge.”

Jiao S swung her huge sword at Li Wen, forcing Li Wen to back away several steps, ending up right opposite me.

The wind ruffled her long hair and pale yellow dress as she smiled without emotion. “I’ll play with you guys since Li Qing doesn’t want my help. Li

Qing wouldn't mind it, whoever I helped, as long as I don't let you get taken away by any of the others."

Li Wen spoke audibly, and I believed that Li Qing, who was still in her face-off with Feng Zhu, could hear everything.

Even so, Li Qing did not look over at us.

With a hand on my purple whip and Piercer holding my other hand, I pointed at Li Wen. "We don't need your help either. Since you've chosen to help Du Yue, why not go all the way with it? Jiao S and I can make a clean break with you today. Two against two, no one is shortchanging anyone here."

Du Yue glanced at Li Wen. Though she didn't look elated that Li Wen chose to be on her side, she wasn't complaining either.

I felt heat emanating from the red skull ring on my right hand, but I couldn't feel any MF even when I tried harnessing that power from her.

It would be embarrassing if I couldn't show any of my abilities after talking so big. I let go of Piercer to raise my left hand in an attempt to summon Scorpion Ray.

Piercer spoke close to my ear, "Do you remember that I've told you this before? Your friend Jiao S has a seal on her, and that seal restricts most of her power."

I nodded. "Yes, you mentioned it briefly once, but the topic was changed to Du Yue's ability shortly after. You didn't really explain it."

Before Piercer could answer, Du Yue was already charging towards Jiao S.

Li Wen's lips lifted in a smile as she moved her right hand, aiming for Jiao S with the Li Xi Sword.

Piercer stopped me as I wanted to rush over. "Listen to me first. Trust Jiao S for just a couple of minutes. She'd be able to hold her own even if it's one against two."

“Say it quickly then!” I was anxious even after hearing Piercer’s words.

“The seal on Jiao S is no simple seal. It isn’t a tiny one and it isn’t one of those large seals that we usually see either. That seal is a twisted one, and it’s on every joint and blood vessel; framing the entire body with it. The seal restricts most of her power, and it suppresses certain things from within her, things that I can’t fully sense.

“Anyway, as a spirit of consciousness, I can only see the layer under her body’s physical shell. I can see every single point from that seal, and it’s trapping her entirely. She can’t reach her full potential with that.”

Chapter 313: Four Women

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“That’s not the point though. The question should be how she’s able to use such great MF even under that perfect, complex seal?

“Her MF isn’t that extraordinary either. Can you feel it?” Piercer’s words made me think of some possibilities, but I told myself to stay calm and listen before jumping to conclusions.

“Also, the bigger question is why she’s able to harness so much power and energy when she doesn’t have extraordinary MF and when her real abilities have actually been sealed? One possibility is that she has identified the loopholes in the seal through long-term training, and she’s using these loopholes to use and control her MF.

“Another question is why would anyone use such a cruel method to seal her power?”

Piercer reminded me of something. For some reason, I recalled the time when Jiao S and I had just met each other, when I still disliked her. There was once when I saw her all bloodied as she lay on the ground.

According to her, that was because someone in the real world was hurting her, and it caused her consciousness in the Split Zone to go through the same pain as well.

Jiao S is a really strong and resilient woman.

“It’s really hard to imagine that she can actually collect that tiny amount of MF escaping from those loopholes in order to use and control it. She even learnt the technique of controlling air currents from Si Luo. That must have been a long and arduous process...

“Such a sealing technique works together with MF, and it will feel like someone has a hold on your nervous system. You can’t undo the lock, but you have to find a way to be able to use your own power freely in trying to go against that restriction. How unbearable would that be...”

As Piercer spoke, I felt a sense of comfort as I looked at Jiao S, who was leaping through the air. I was proud of my friend.

Jiao S wasn’t a kind soul; she was bloodthirsty and violent, and she sometimes did cruel things. Though her actions could be unpredictable, she was extremely loyal and she had her own principles. Without her, I might not have been able to survive up to this day.

I then realized that I might have actually been leaving her out, even when I thought I didn’t.

Even though she didn’t speak much, and even when her huge eyes always seemed empty and she looked like an emotionless doll all the time, she was someone extraordinary.

The realization that it was all a façade suddenly hit me.

It wasn’t exactly a mask. It was just that she had been fighting on her own for so long. All the pain she had been through, and that respect and the position she had eventually obtained, these things could not be described as her having merely earned it.

That lack of emotion and apparent numbness to the world was a habit of hers.

Because she was so used to the pain, there was no other expression she could use to really express that.

I raised my right hand as emotions ran through me. She suddenly appeared in front of me again, like a ghost.

“Looks like you’re really going to use my power now. Why? Why are you willing to accept it so quickly? Is it because of her?” Holding a corner of her red dress, she asked while pointing at Jiao S.

I shot her a cold look. “That’s right, it’s for her. She’s my best friend, and I have to save her no matter what.”

“Good. Everything you do would be good as long as you can accept me. You know it too... I can give you power and I can enable you to be unique here. Power is what you need now, while all I need is simply your acknowledgment. It isn’t all that difficult, is it...”

Her enchanting voice came closer and closer.

Gritting my teeth, I shut my eyes. I raised my right hand as I snapped my eyes open, putting all my focus on that red skull ring on my right index finger.

Pain shot through my finger and I felt it pierce through my heart.

I felt heat emanating from my split symbol at the same time. It felt as if all the meridians in my body were connected with this energy.

Boom.

My red hair flew up behind me.

Though I still wasn’t able to feel any MF within me, my instinct told me that I was ready for a battle.

I took Piercer’s purple whip in my hand and struck at Du Yue’s wrist.

Du Yue glanced at me in surprise. I smirked and asked, “I hope I’m not too late to the fight.”

Anger flared in Du Yue's eyes. *As expected, you hate looking at me. Is this just like how you hated looking at Bian Ying?*

Haha, sadly, I'm planning to appear right in front of you today.

"Piercer!" I called out as I disseminated that heat from my split symbol to all my joints. I leapt into the air and trapped Du Yue with my purple whip as I struck at her.

"Come over here, you," I said with suppressed rage. Bian Ying's upset face and the scene of You Ji's horrific death appeared in my mind.

You know something, Du Yue? There's no sympathy for you, no matter who it was you might have been trying to change for. Even if you blamed all your sins on love, you were the one who did everything at the end of the day. A devil would never turn into an angel.

Li Wen's smile was replaced by a deep frown as she noticed the change in me.

She seemed to be the only one who had noticed the change in my energy. *Did she really feel threatened by my power?*

Li Wen stared at me for a good ten seconds or so before she raised her Li Xi sword and charged towards me. She had abandoned her original plan to work with Du Yue in going against Jiao S.

As I was preparing to face Li Wen's attack, Jiao S caught up with Li Wen from behind.

"Ha!" Jiao S was enshrouded in what looked like a black flaming vortex as she raised her huge sword, aiming it at Li Wen's back.

Du Yue's reaction was quick. She wasn't about to give Jiao S a chance like this. Fire appeared above her first as she balled up her right hand. She then started hurling fireballs at Jiao S.

Two against one, and you're still bullying my friend like this...

I jumped up without hesitation, raising my left hand as I called out, “Scorpion Ray, turn back.”

A circular bow appeared in front of me, and invisible arrows of air formed as I pulled my right hand back.

As I let go, countless arrows shot toward Du Yue.

The arrows traveled fast, and there was no time for her to counter it even after she halted her attacks against Jiao S. Du Yue simply leapt into the air with a strong kick against the ground.

Crash.

The ground was already cracking with all the heat emanating from Li Qing and Feng Zhu’s stand-off. With Du Yue’s powerful kick, the ground seemed to shatter as pieces of rock and soil burst out from the ground.

As I marveled at Du Yue’s power to myself, I rushed forward to entwine her tightly in my purple whip. With gritted teeth, I pulled Du Yue towards the crumbling whirlpool of rock and soil near the ground.

“Piercer.” I called out for Piercer as I smashed Du Yue hard against the ground.

I looked up and saw Li Wen’s cold gaze directed at me while she was still in the middle of a fight with Jiao S.

What does she want?

Blood trickled from the corner of Du Yue’s mouth. I didn’t know if it was a scrape or if it was caused by one of my arrows. She stared at me angrily after she hit the ground.

Taking this opportunity, I let fly another bout of arrows at Du Yue. Jiao S also used this opportunity to aim at Li Wen with her huge sword.

Li Wen was staring at me, and even if she realized what Jiao S was going to do, she didn’t react to it at all. Jiao S wasn’t someone who would change

her course of action because Li Wen stayed still.

As expected, that gigantic sword severed an arm from Li Wen, but Li Wen did not even blink.

Something out of the ordinary then happened when her arm hit the ground.

Chapter 314: You have No Choice but to Accept Me

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Li Wen's arm regenerated at the speed of light, as if she had taken some regeneration drug straight out of a science fiction movie. She was still staring at me coldly. That calm expression of hers was rather disconcerting.

When her arm regenerated immediately after it was cut off, Jie Pa, who was beside me, said, "Her body is definitely built differently from ours. It wouldn't have been able to regenerate so quickly if it was. Such speed seems to belong only to monsters in the Split Zone."

Yes, a monster in the Split Zone. But it wasn't the time for discussion or daydream. I had to take this opportunity right now.

Holding up the circular bow with my left hand, I aimed it at Du Yue who was still on the ground as I said, "Stab."

Countless thin arrows shot out from the bow, aiming for Du Yue.

Du Yue continued staring at me as she struggled to get up. It was difficult for her to maintain her balance on the uneven surface, and it was made even more difficult when she only had one arm.

I thought I would be able to immobilize Du Yue at least for a short while, but I didn't expect Li Wen to interfere. Li Wen commanded, "Drop."

The sky immediately darkened as a giant cross appeared in the air. A shield in the form of a giant cross glowed with a white light and it landed right in front of Du Yue, protecting her.

She's helping Du Yue out this much?

A wave of anger washed over me as I struck out with my left hand using all my strength.

Clack, crack, smack.

Scorpion Ray's bow disintegrated and turned into a staff of light as I waved it in front of me.

Boom!

I aimed my staff at that giant cross, attempting to smash it. "Piercer!"

Piercer nodded as I called out to her. She shot towards Li Wen in a trail of violet light before turning into rings of violet light as she entrapped Li Wen within.

Li Wen's eyes widened.

Huu...

The wind ruffled her pale yellow dress as Li Wen's expression remained cold and frigid.

Swoosh, swoosh, swoosh.

Countless rapiers descended from the sky.

"Although it isn't very gentlemanly to interfere in a fight between four women, but if the fight is uneven, one would still have to step in." It was Jie Pa who said so. He might have intentionally said this for Nie Zun.

Nie Zun remained motionless, hands in his pockets as he observed us all.

Jie Pa then did something with his hands. I was familiar with this movement. It was what he did when he used the barrier technique.

However, instead of a transparent barrier, the barrier was made up of countless tendrils that trapped everyone in it.

Li Wen and Du Yue were both trapped in it too. With a quick wave of her hand, Li Wen changed the direction of the rapiers.

The rapiers did exactly what Li Wen wanted them to do as they began searching for a point of entry in the tendrils.

The rapiers flew around the tendrils one after another. Jie Pa's hands did not move. He maintained that position as he stared calmly at Li Wen.

Li Wen scoffed, "Barrier techniques are considered one of the top-tiered ones in the Split Zone, but you haven't mastered it yet. Such a weak barrier would not be an effective counter against my rapiers." Those rapiers moved with greater speed as she spoke, and I heard countless tearing and splitting sounds.

Jie Pa's palms, which were placed against each other, seemed to be slowly pried apart by an unknown force. Even when the tendrils were breaking apart, Jie Pa's face remained calm.

Jiao S and I had both landed on the ground. Li Wen was beside her as Du Yue had already stood up, wiping the blood from the corner of her lips.

We missed the best opportunity to immobilize Du Yue. From Du Yue's calm expression, I knew it was going to be an uphill battle from now on.

We were up against opponents who were stronger than both Jiao S and I. Furthermore, Piercer told me that Jiao S's power was largely sealed, and my current power was actually borrowed from another personality. I wasn't confident at all. I might also just end up losing my power in a moment's notice.

I shivered as I felt a pair of icy hands wrap around my neck. I didn't turn around even though I knew it was her.

She crept closer to my ear. This was her favorite method of communication, and she'd always disappear suddenly after she spoke. She was just this willful.

“Are you suspicious of me? You’re suspecting that the power I’m providing you isn’t enough to protect you?”

I didn’t speak. I didn’t even have any thoughts in response to this.

Her voice then turned gentle and soft, almost to a point where it was inaudible. “I’m the very last person you should be suspicious of. How could you doubt me? There’s a chance that everyone here can betray you, and there’s a chance that they’ll all leave you, but I won’t. I’m the only exception. I’m the one who’d be with you forever.

“Because we are one and the same.”

That feeling of suppressed rage found me again. This time, I couldn’t tamp down the emotion even after taking a few deep breaths.

But I told myself I had to bear with this. I needed her right now.

“That’s right, just like that. Accept me slowly. You won’t be able to use my power if you reject it. You won’t be able to save your friends if that’s the case. If you accept me and use my power, we’ll be able to merge into one. You’ll still have to accept me eventually. If there’s a tiny part of you that isn’t sincere in accepting me, you won’t be able to use this great power. What will you do, Li Shen?

“Accept me like this, let me accompany you. Let me see how you push everyone away and end up with no one but me in the end.” This low voice was filled with darkness.

I wanted to run away from this voice, but I had to keep telling myself that I couldn’t hate her.

I couldn’t reject her. I had to accept her if I wanted power.

Crack.

The rapiers were slashing through the tendril barrier. I couldn't stand watching anymore as I shouted in my heart, 'Give me power!'

At the same time, I seemed to be able to see her enchanting smile right behind me.

Piercer descended from the air and wrapped around Li Wen. In anger, Li Wen's rapiers suddenly turned toward Jiao S and I.

Tapping my feet against the ground, I leapt into the air as I stretched my hands out. Scorpion Ray turned into two bracelets of light on both my wrists.

I looked down at Du Yue, who was staring at me coldly. "Come down," Du Yue said with a smirk.

I felt that restriction technique wrap itself around my heart in the very next second.

I heard her voice beside my ear just as I was about to sink towards the ground. "Does she think she can trap me with this tiny trick of hers?" She then moved behind me, pressing a hand behind my back, where my heart was.

Boom. Boom. Boom.

My heart seemed to stop before it started beating again in the next second. The restriction technique seemed to be rendered ineffective as well.

Overjoyed at this, I aimed at Du Yue with the light from my bracelets.

Chapter 315: Du Yue's Left Arm

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315 Du Yue's Left Arm

Two rays of light shot out from Scorpion Ray and pierced through Du Yue's torso.

Du Yue spat out a mouthful of blood.

Stunned at my power, I stood stock-still in disbelief. "Can you feel it now? I'm the only one who can help you." She blew into my ear as she spoke.

The entire central plaza was plunged into silence. Feng Zhu and Li Qing turned to look at me. Du Yue was gasping for air while Li Wen simply stood beside her, expression turning darker by the second.

Nie Zun then appeared in front of me, standing in a position that looked like he was shielding me.

"It's a miracle. She can forget about leaving the Gate of Heaven today." Feng Zhu's kasaya flapped in the wind as he spoke.

"Don't get distracted by others you old thing. I'm the opponent here!" Li Qing shouted as she rushed at Feng Zhu with halberd in hand.

Feng Zhu stood steady as flames rose around him. *Looks like he uses the natural elements as well.*

"Li Shen, you're really a pain in the neck wherever you go. Look, everyone's attention has been drawn to you now," Li Wen said as she looked at me, unsmiling.

I had a feeling that Li Wen's renewed hatred for me was triggered by how Li Qing chose to make the first move in order to protect me.

"Instead of talking so much, how about you come right at me with that blade? I wouldn't die in this godforsaken Split Zone, but that would probably hurt quite a bit," I said as I pointed to where my heart was.

Li Wen spoke coldly, "Do you think I wouldn't dare do it?"

"Li Wen!" Li Qing called out to stop Li Wen. Li Wen's eyes darkened, but she walked towards where Li Qing was with capitulation.

"We'll just have to settle our grudge on another day, Li Shen." This was the last thing she said to me.

Du Yue's wound, which was caused by me, was not healing. It was bleeding continuously as she held onto her abdomen.

Feng Zhu, who was surrounded with flames, was no longer passive. He was holding a staff which seemed to have appeared out of nowhere. It looked like a fireplace poker.

Sparks flew as the poker struck against Li Qing's halberd.

My attack on Du Yue seemed to have intensified the fight, escalating Li Qing and Feng Zhu's stand-off in what felt like the quickest way possible. Li Wen had also moved over to Li Qing's side to help her fend off Feng Zhu's attacks.

As I watched them fight, I realized that Li Wen had no need to be jealous of me. She and Li Qing worked superbly well in a fight together, and they seemed capable of defeating anyone. I knew there would be no one else who could replace Li Wen.

All I saw were flashes of their silvery-white armor and pale yellow dress as the halberd and rapiers went flying. Their attacks actually forced Feng Zhu to retreat a couple of steps.

“I guess I have no choice but to fight you guys for real.” Though Du Yue was still gasping for air, there was no fear in her eyes. Something grew out from where her missing arm should have been.

“I told you so. She didn’t lose any arm in that crack in space. She merely hid it.” Piercer turned back into human form in her purple dress while I wasn’t attacking. She stationed herself beside me in order to shield me from any attacks.

Piercer said while pointing at Du Yue, “You have to be careful. If she has hidden that arm for so long, this means that no one else knows about the abilities on that arm.”

I nodded as I stared at the individual opposite me. I was curious about what exactly happened. *Why did this missing arm suddenly appear all of a sudden?*

My curiosity was satisfied just a moment later.

Since there wasn’t any fabric over it, everyone could see that Du Yue’s new arm looked just like a normal human arm.

A sudden thought flashed through my mind. *What if this ability could be used in the real world? Wouldn’t that make someone extremely powerful?*

Du Yue looked much sturdier with the addition of an arm.

“So you’ve been lying to me all this while.”

Gaoqin Jiuye spoke from somewhere behind Du Yue. Both Du Yue and I were a little surprised to hear him.

When did he return? And he actually saw whatever Du Yue has done?

The situation was chaotic, but all the key players were present.

What surprised me more was the fact that Guan Nie was behind Gaoqin Jiuye. Guan Nie did not have that smirk on his face like the first time I saw him, and he was following very closely behind Gaoqin Jiuye.

“Looks like you’ve convinced him.” Jiao S was referring to Guan Nie as she spoke.

“Boss, I’ve taken care of you for quite a long time now. I’m requesting to be released since I might just continue being with him from now onwards,” Guan Nie said as he blinked at Jiao S.

If it was another male who said it, my mind would’ve gone elsewhere.

But Guan Nie said it so naturally, and I wouldn’t dismiss the possibility that something had definitely happened in the period of time they were gone. It was possible that they had a huge fight. But whatever it was, they were both on the same side now. I could tell from their body language and how they moved; they had that same telepathy that Li Qing and Li Wen exuded.

Such telepathy could only be achieved when both of them had attained an understanding of each other.

“You can’t say that I’ve lied when you’ve never asked me about my arm. You’ve just been wallowing in your guilt over this and I’ve never told you that I’ve actually lost an arm. Since you didn’t ask, I didn’t tell either. How can you accuse me of lying?” Du Yue looked like she was already used to having two arms as she turned to face Gaoqin Jiuye. She did not look like someone who had recently got an arm after a long time of not having one.

Du Yue looked even taller and stronger with it, emanating the aura of a powerful queen.

Sadly, she was nothing but an emotionless, inhumane and bloodthirsty monster to me.

“It’s really not good, using his guilt against him like this.” Si Luo commented from a distance away.

Du Yue shot him a cold look. “Traitors have no right to comment on others. Try saving her today, if you can. If not, there’s not much use in talking either.”

I smirked. “I don’t need anyone to save me, and I don’t need you to worry about me. You should be worrying about yourself. Don’t think that you can change my mind about killing you after you have a new arm, Du Yue. I’m repaying your debts to You Ji, that little boy, as well as to Song Lu and Yu Liang today!”

As I saw Gaoqin Jiuye’s pained expression when he looked at how Du Yue used her new arm, my heart felt as if it was being stabbed with a knife.

I will never forgive Du Yue.

“You’re really too audacious.”

This angered Du Yue. Ten wolves descended from the heavens as she motioned with both her hands.

These wolves looked like what we’d see in the real world, except for those fiery eyes. I knew that they were being controlled by Du Yue, and there was no way to communicate with them like this.

The wolves charged at us upon hitting the ground.

Si Luo stopped Jiao S from interfering just when she was about to attack. “I’ve had enough of watching this never-ending fight.” White fog surged in Si Luo’s silvery eyes right after he spoke.

He seemed to be able to control all the air around us.

I couldn’t help but marvel at his ability to do so. This wasn’t because he was better at manipulating air currents than anybody else; it was simply because his MF was so great that he could manipulate them as if it was child’s play.

The air around us seemed to converge into Si Luo’s eyes.

Feng Zhu stopped producing fire temporarily, tamping it down to a tiny flame. He glared at Si Luo. “Does this mean you’re really going to cut all ties with me and betray me?”

Si Luo's eyes glinted and a hint of a smile appeared on his lips.

“I've said that this isn't betrayal, since no one has promised the other anything. From today onwards, my priority is to protect her so that she can safely leave the Split Zone. If anyone stands in my way, we'll end up being opponents.”

He took a meaningful look at Gaoqin Jiuye as he said this, but Gaoqin Jiuye's expressionless face made it look as if he did not hear anything at all.

Chapter 316: The Real Air Current Manipulation Technique

Volume 5

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“I might be able to let her go free if it was somebody else helping her, but since you’ve decided to interfere, I will definitely not let her leave the Gate of Heaven today.” Feng Zhu spoke in a forbidding manner.

Si Luo’s eyes were pure white with all that fog. “You weren’t someone that emotional in the past. I guess the brand of justice in the Gate of Heaven is no longer what it used to be.”

His eyes seemed to be absorbing all the air currents around us. Those snowy, crystalline eyes were clearer than amber, as if they contained the world’s most precious pearl in them.

“Bury.”

Si Luo’s face glowed with a bright, silvery-white light. When he said ‘bury’, countless snowflakes seemed to land on his lips.

Feng Zhu and Li Qing both made a move at this point. Gusts of wind whipped through the plaza, forming mini tornadoes as they swept past us. The sky turned into a silvery-gray as snowflakes larger than goose feathers descended upon us.

In just a few seconds, the sky and the ground were both covered in a silvery-gray.

“Snow burial... Old man Feng Zhu, your previously beloved disciple is using such a move to attack you right now. Are you not going to reflect on your actions?” Li Qing challenged Feng Zhu with her question.

Feng Zhu looked like a statue of Buddha as his kasaya flapped in the wind. Though his expression was grim, the intensity of that fire in his eyes was not reduced by Li Qing’s words.

Si Luo was right beside me, and we were both in the eye of the storm as the snow got caught up in the multiple air currents that surrounded us. All that swirling silvery-gray made me feel slightly light-headed.

Though Gaoqin Jiuye moved over to be beside Si Luo, there was no longer any jealousy or sorrow in Guan Nie. He simply followed in Gaoqin Jiuye’s steps, ending up beside Si Luo as well.

Jiao S was quick to react as she also moved over to flank Si Luo, leaving a trail in the ground as she dragged her gigantic sword through the snow.

Si Luo addressed Gaoqin Jiuye and Jiao S, “I remember telling the both of you previously, how this air current technique can be used to its fullest potential.”

Gaoqin Jiuye and Jiao S’s eyes seemed to cloud at that point. The snow and fog in Si Luo’s eyes began to rotate as he looked at them.

At this, Gaoqin Jiuye and Jiao S’s eyes shone brightly. “Understood.”

These two individuals, who used to hate each other, actually spoke in unison when responding to Si Luo.

Si Luo smiled with those snowy lips of his. “Then let’s give them a demonstration.”

It felt like something spectacular was about to happen. I focused on the three of them with bated breath.

Piercer was right beside me, and I didn’t know where that red figure went in all this snow.

To my left were the three in Si Luo's team. They were in a triangular formation with Si Luo in the middle, while Gaoqin Jiuye and Jiao S were somewhere further behind me to the left.

Li Qing and Feng Zhu were facing each other some fifty meters away from me. Du Yue was back by Feng Zhu's side while Li Wen was beside Li Qing. Nie Zun was a little to my right.

The storm that was brewing in Si Luo's eyes seemed to be starting, and I realized Gaoqin Jiuye and Jiao S's eyes looked similar to Si Luo's where they were filled with a white fog. The three of them were working together to control the air currents.

I'm guessing that the best method to use this air current technique, according to Si Luo, was none other than to work together just like this.

It was not about having one individual manipulate a huge vortex at once, since the power of one single person would definitely be limited in some ways, and a single individual might not have been able to use this natural element to its fullest potential.

Things would be different if there were three individuals. Moreover, this team was powerful.

Wouldn't this team be almost impossible to beat? I marveled to myself.

Out of the three, two of them were once considered one of the most powerful individuals in the Split Zone, and Si Luo had personally trained them in that air current technique. It was the best team where a teacher worked with his two successful disciples. Would there be anything in this world that could be more powerful than such a team?

"Once the snow burial is activated, none of you should leave from your positions, not even for a millisecond. Get that?" Si Luo's clear and crisp voice resounded in the snowstorm.

Gaoqin Jiuye and Jiao S nodded at the same time.

Gaoqin Jiuye did not forget to look back at Guan Nie.

Guan Nie simply nodded at him in assurance.

I then witnessed that smirk on Guan Nie's face again, the very one he had when I first met him. His upturned eyes lifted as he gave an enchanting smile.

He placed his pale hands together before taking them apart again. With that, the entire scene began to warp and change before us.

We weren't standing on water this time, but there were countless water droplets the size of fingernails floating in the air around us.

"Another illusion? As expected of the top illusionist to be able to pull everyone into an illusion even after sustaining such grievous injuries earlier." Piercer commented on Guan Nie's abilities.

I laughed as I asked, "What, are you interested in him now?"

Piercer rolled her eyes at me.

I guess I wouldn't have to worry about anything if that was the case.

Guan Nie was controlling the entire illusion, assisting the three of them in Gaoqin Jiuye's team and protecting them at the same time. The three of them seemed to be working perfectly together as they waited for the right opportunity to unleash a powerful attack. *What else should I be worrying about here?*

I glanced at the red skull ring on my right index finger, mumbling to myself, "Looking at the situation now, I might not need your power anymore. I don't think Feng Zhu and gang would stand much of a chance against such a team, especially when coupled with Li Qing and Li Wen."

"You're so simple-minded... It's coming... It's coming soon... It's nearing now..."

The red figure appeared whenever she wished to without any forewarning. I saw her appear in front of me right when I finished mumbling to myself. This time, she was looking at me with a sort of a smirk.

I frowned slightly. "What's coming soon?"

She lifted a hand to cover her mouth mischievously. "I'm the only one who can save you, Shen'er... Nobody else can..."

Hearing her say 'Shen'er' sent shivers down my spine.

What happened in the very next moment distracted me, and because of that distraction, her red figure disappeared from my sight yet again.

Some distance away, under all the snow, that black dome created by Ta Lai earlier cracked open all of a sudden.

It was as if a roasted chestnut had suddenly cracked open over fiery heat.

I then saw Ta Lai and Cang Ming facing each other in the distance. None of them were moving in the snow.

I quietly turned to Du Yue and realized that she was looking in Ta Lai's direction with a grim expression.

I raised my left hand slowly, planning to attack in the very next second if Du Yue rushes over to where Ta Lai was.

For some reason, I didn't want Cang Ming to get hurt, and my mind was in a place where I hoped the battle would go a certain way.

If Du Yue were to help Ta Lai, or if Ta Lai were to do anything untoward to Cang Ming after their fight, I knew I wouldn't just sit and watch.

Swoosh.

As expected, Du Yue moved.

I grabbed Piercer with my right hand while I shot an arrow with Scorpion Ray on my left.

With a quick squeeze of my palm, Piercer understood my intentions immediately. She focused energy on her feet and brought me to Cang Ming in a split second.

We were already late by a millisecond, since we started only after Du Yue moved. Because of that, I shot a blade of light with Scorpion Ray to obscure her path.

Anger rose in Du Yue's eyes as she dodged that blade of light. When she realized where the attack came from, Piercer and I had already reached Cang Ming.

Upon closer observation, I realized that Cang Ming was afflicted with countless wounds. Some of them huge, some of them tiny, but all of them had black blood spilling out of them. There were many tiny cuts on his face as well, and none of these injuries seemed to be healing.

Apart from these injuries, his sword of light had been broken in half.

Even so, there was not much change in his expression. His eyes were calm and he still looked as arrogant as ever.

"Are you okay?" I asked with knitted brows.

Cang Ming smiled at Piercer. "I'm surprised you're willing to help me out here."

Piercer bit her lip as she remained silent.

I looked at the two of them.

Sigh.

Ta Lai also looked the worse for wear. His clothes were tattered and his hair tousled.

My lips twitched. *What did the two of them do in that black dome?*

“Are you okay?” Du Yue asked Ta Lai the exact same thing I asked Cang Ming.

Ta Lai wanted to respond, but he ended up spitting out a mouthful of blood before he could do so. The blood dripped down the collar of his white shirt under that blue jacket of his, looking like bright red flowers in bloom.

Du Yue looked a lot more normal when she supported him with two hands instead of one.

Ta Lai’s gaze did not deviate from Cang Ming. “I’m sure you can feel it too. She’s coming.”

Chapter 317: Striking Du Yue!

317 Striking Du Yue!

Cang Ming pointed his broken sword at Ta Lai. “Don’t you even mention her name from now on. She no longer has anything to do with you. She’s mine, she’s Cang Ming’s.”

Flames lit up in Ta Lai’s eyes, but it was tamped down when he sensed the movement of Du Yue’s arm on his.

I smirked. “Being afraid of loneliness when you’re alone and also afraid you’d be a disappointment when you’re with somebody else. Ta Lai, you acted more or less like a man when you pretended to befriend me previously, at least you still dared to call for Bian Ying loudly in your dreams. What now? You’re retreating because of some tiny concern? Bian Ying is way too good for the likes of you.”

“Shut up!” Angered, Du Yue shouted at me.

I glanced at her with pity. I knew that nothing would make her more upset than somebody looking at her with pity in their eyes.

“Those you’ve trained are really just like you.” Feng Zhu looked at me while he spoke to Li Qing.

Li Qing laughed casually. “I wouldn’t mind talking about how I trained this beloved disciple of mine under normal circumstances, since it could possibly teach you a thing or two about guiding your subordinates. Look at those two under you. I really cannot say that you’ve done a good job.”

Instead of getting upset, Feng Zhu smiled. “Amitabha. Seems like you’re still the same old you from many years ago. It’s good that my heart is no

longer burdened now, or else I might actually find it difficult to make a move because of the guilt I felt towards you and Huai Du.”

At that, Li Qing’s expression changed.

Whoosh.

Wind and snow whipped past us, buffeting all of us from every angle. The power was concentrated where Si Luo was, with Jiao S and Gaoqin Jiuye acting as support. In this environment where we were surrounded by countless translucent water droplets, all of us snapped alert as we felt the air move around us.

Feng Zhu raised a hand, looking like he was going to foretell the future. He then turned to where Si Luo was as he said, “Seems like you’ve already seen this coming. They must be unaware that they’ve been used by you.”

A beautiful smile appeared on Si Luo. “Items might remain the same, but people don’t. Everything will come to an end. Let’s settle it once and for all today.”

The howling wind suddenly turned into a shrill screech. Si Luo’s hair blew madly in the wind as he emanated a chilly killing intent. In the middle of all that white fog was his beautifully sculpted face.

The light that was in Feng Zhu’s eyes began to rotate. That red light increased in intensity until his eyes seemed to emanate a red glow.

I frowned. *Why did these eyes make me think of someone else?*

I looked at Nie Zun with unease.

Nie Zun had been watching the fights from the sidelines with Jie Pa all this while. Dressed from head to toe in black, he did not blend in well with all that white around us. His dark eyes looked just like the night sky that was filled with the light of a thousand stars.

Why did this air current manipulation technique feel so similar to that of Nie Zun’s pupil technique? Also, Nie Zun hadn’t used his pupil technique at

all after I met him again.

Though whatever was happening in Feng Zhu's eyes seemed to be different from Si Luo and the rest, it felt rather familiar to me. *Were all their techniques similar in some way?*

Why did techniques that had to do with using one's eyes feel so familiar to me?

Immense unease overwhelmed me, as if I was about to find out about some conspiracy.

Something seemed to be creeping out of my memory, but I just couldn't hold onto it. *What was it?*

What is it? Which was the very pair of eyes that had been guiding me...?

I snapped my head up to look at the sky in the Split Zone. That felt terrifying. *Just what is the Split Zone?*

Trembling, I grabbed hold of Piercer. "What's the secret of the Split Zone...?"

I asked her this as we were right under Guan Nie's illusion of the sky.

Piercer was surprised at my sudden unease. "Don't you already know the secret of the Split Zone? It's an independent space, except that it contains bodies of consciousness instead of live bodies. Soul splitters are a part of humanity that ended up right here, becoming the living things that exist in this space."

No, that's not it. There's something wrong with that. But what was wrong?

Just when I seemed to find the right question to ask Piercer again, the wind around us howled with a greater vengeance.

Piercer held me tight as I almost fell off my feet.

When I turned back to Si Luo, Gaoqin Jiuye and Jiao S, I realized they were already about to make their move!

“Bury.” The three of them spoke at the same time!

The snow swirled in the winds, forming a shape in mid-air. It formed layers of snowy rings, and the snow turned into blades that were sharper than that of a knife. These snowy blades were targeting one single spot as they flew towards where Feng Zhu was.

To counter the attack, Feng Zhu threw his prayer beads into the air.

The prayer beads came undone in the air and separated into individual beads that formed the outline of an expanding circular ring above Feng Zhu’s head, getting larger and larger by the second.

With a swoosh, the twelve individual beads burst into flames.

“There are many ways to achieve enlightenment. Let this cleanse all your evil and all your sins. Amitabha.”

Those beads began burning fierce and bright following Feng Zhu’s words. In just ten seconds or so, the flames created a bright red glow atop Feng Zhu’s head.

Feng Zhu adjusted his legs and stood steady before he sat down in a meditation pose. He began to chant sutras as he slowly shut his eyes.

Si Luo’s eyes were a pure white now, and in formation together with Gaoqin Jiuye and Jiao S, countless blades of snow continued to fly at Feng Zhu.

But no matter how many blades flew at him, all of them were burnt by that flaming ring above his head.

The contrast between the white snow and red flames made the entire scene looked beautiful, albeit full of killing intent.

As Gaoqin Jiuye and Jiao S's pupils constricted, the speed of the snowy blades increased two-fold.

At this point, those twelve beads above Feng Zhu seemed to be at a disadvantage. However, just like how Si Luo wasn't fighting alone, Feng Zhu had help too.

Ta Lai gave up in his stand-off with Cang Ming and attempted to move that jade stone ring on his finger to assist Feng Zhu.

"You're hurt. Let me go." Du Yue stopped him.

She made a cross with her arms after saying that. Those ten wolves which disappeared after being summoned earlier by her reappeared again as they rushed at Si Luo's team.

Du Yue had her eyes on those wolves, and her arms remained in the position of a cross. It looked like she was using her mental ability to control the pack.

Gritting my teeth, I threw Scorpion Ray in the air with my left hand as I pulled and released with my right.

Though I wasn't able to feel any MF in me still, I felt an extra boost of power from the ring on my right hand when Scorpion Ray turned into a circular bow in the air. All I could do was to focus that power right in the middle of Scorpion Ray.

Whoosh.

There was a burst of light from Scorpion Ray. Like a light grenade, the rays shot out in all directions. Controlling the light with my mental ability, I directed them all towards the wolf pack.

Sensing the situation, Du Yue called out for the wolves to turn around, but it was too late. As I focused on my right hand, the bursts of light shot out at amazing speed with the power from my ring.

Thud, thud, thud.

The pack of wolves was separated.

Du Yue looked enraged, but she had no choice but to make the wolves retreat.

Ta Lai used this opportunity to rush over to Feng Zhu, removing that jade stone ring from his finger.

He put it on his palm, and by the looks of it, it seemed like he was going to throw it in that flaming ring above Feng Zhu's head.

But before he could do it, a thin voice spoke from somewhere within the wind and snow.

“You're going to throw away the item I left you?”

That clear voice carried with it a hint of sorrow and chill at the same time.

I didn't know if I actually got a pleasant surprise or a rude shock, but I called out, “Bian Ying!”

To be honest, it was a relief to be able to see Bian Ying, someone who was essentially just like me, when I'm stuck in this godforsaken place where everyone seemed to be targeting me.

I knew my ears were not fooling me when I saw Bian Ying's thin but still beautiful face and that frail-looking figure of hers. She emerged slowly from between the wind and snow.

Cang Ming was also shaking. My eyes were hit with the refraction of light from the broken sword in his hand.

Step by step, Bian Ying walked towards us unhurriedly.

Du Yue narrowed her eyes.

It's an opening.

In the space between Du Yue and I, the light from Scorpion Ray had not yet fully dissipated. I had to take the opportunity now that Du Yue was momentarily distracted.

Waving my right hand, I felt the heat and power emanate from my palm as the light from Scorpion Ray entrapped Du Yue.

Chapter 318: Bian Ying's Choice

Volume 5

318 Bian Ying's Choice

Getting distracted in a fight would really spell defeat.

The light from Scorpion Ray congregated on Du Yue's body.

Most of the light had hit her since she was slow in avoiding the attack, due to being distracted.

Though the attack was powerful, I knew it could only stop Du Yue temporarily. With her abilities, that attack wouldn't cause any permanent damage. I had to attack again.

However, I couldn't feel any MF in me at all, and I didn't like that I was forcing the power out of that skull ring.

"I haven't seen you for a while and you've become this powerful?" Bian Ying smiled sweetly at me like a peach blossom in bloom. She was still pale and thin, but she looked much more energetic.

I returned a slight smile. "You look much better now. I don't think the two of them have to fight anymore. They look like they've been living better lives without you around." I took a meaningful glance at Cang Ming and Ta Lai as I spoke. Both of them looked grim.

Bian Ying knew I was joking as she answered, "I think so too."

Du Yue seemed to get angrier after hearing our light-hearted banter. Meanwhile, the fight between Feng Zhu and Si Luo was getting more and

more intense. It was a showdown between Feng Zhu's twelve fiery prayer beads and Si Luo's snow burial formation.

As for Li Qing, she looked like she was contemplating an attack on her outnumbered opponent.

Though Ta Lai paused after seeing Bian Ying, he eventually chose to continue assisting Feng Zhu. He mumbled a string of unintelligible words before a dark black canvas covered the sky above us.

Cang Ming kept his broken sword of light and stretched his back. "Do you think that space that makes people lose four of their senses can actually be expanded to cover the entire space above the central plaza? Don't overestimate it. Also, this current space is another layer of illusion created by that illusionist. Your trick wouldn't work if someone is ahead of you."

Ta Lai looked visibly glum as he realized he wasn't able to create a pitch-black canvas since this space was under Guan Nie's control. He then stopped using that technique.

Bian Ying looked towards Ta Lai with a grim expression while Cang Ming made his way straight to Bian Ying. When he reached her, he grabbed her chin and kissed her with his blood-red lips.

I could tell he was kissing her really hard since I could actually see the veins popping on his neck from where I was.

The petite Bian Ying seemed to be rendered motionless by Cang Ming's huge frame as he smashed his lips into hers.

There was pain in Ta Lai's eyes.

Feng Zhu was caught up in Si Luo's snow burial formation and there was a chance that Li Qing and Li Wen might interfere in the fight. If Ta Lai moved away from Feng Zhu, the probability of Feng Zhu losing would increase exponentially.

Ta Lai pursed his lips and decided to stay put.

I heaved an inward sigh as I thought about how different Ta Lai and Cang Ming were. Although Cang Ming looked much more devious compared to Ta Lai, who seemed to be filled with a sense of justice, Cang Ming was someone who would put Bian Ying as the first priority wherever he was all the time, even when he was evil and cruel to all others.

Ta Lai wasn't able to do something like that.

Cang Ming only let Bian Ying go when it looked like she was out of breath from his kiss. She even seemed a little unsteady on her feet when he let go of her shoulder. Bian Ying seemed to have turned paler after that long kiss.

Cang Ming did not have that arrogant, audacious look about him when his eyes were on the woman he loved. His eyes shone brightly with emotion as he said, "Didn't you ask me when I could let you go? You can go now."

Bian Ying looked at Cang Ming in disbelief.

My brows furrowed as well.

Cang Ming kept his eyes on Bian Ying, taking in her features and expressions, as if he was afraid that he would no longer be able to do so in the future. "I gave everything up for you. I didn't care what others said. I didn't care if they called me a devil, as long as I could have you by my side. I established a split symbol contract but I don't use it, and it doesn't matter as long as you were here. But even so, you haven't been happy at all. You've been upset from day one. If it's really so upsetting, then I'm letting you go."

Bian Ying's eyes filled with tears.

Cang Ming laughed. "What are you crying for? No one else would make you cry but me. I won't bother you in future, and you won't have to see this annoying face of mine either. Follow your heart to wherever and whoever you want to go to.

"I know you stayed for me, in order to reduce that demonic bloodlust in me. But there's no need for that from now onwards. Just live the life you want

to have. I won't be further than five hundred meters away from you and I won't let your life force diminish, but I won't let you see me again."

He then threw his broken sword of light into the air vortex beside Bian Ying. The blade disappeared into the wind and snow.

In his blood-red robe, Cang Ming made his way towards Bian Ying slowly.

He didn't take a second look at Bian Ying. He simply continued on his path as he passed beside her.

Bian Ying's frail figure seemed to shiver as he passed. I opened my mouth, but I didn't say a thing.

I felt my heart sink just as Cang Ming was about to pass by her, but Bian Ying called out. "Wait."

Cang Ming stopped in his tracks.

Tears were already streaming down Bian Ying's face.

Bian Ying then turned around suddenly, lunging herself towards Cang Ming's wide back to take him in a tight embrace. Cang Ming swayed slightly with the force.

She leaned her face into Cang Ming's back as she said, "Don't leave me. Don't leave me."

Cang Ming slowly shut his eyes.

This was the first time I saw such deep sorrow on Cang Ming's face. It tugged on my heartstrings.

Bian Ying said in a clear voice. "I can't live without you. I thought I loved him, that I'd love him forever. It was shameful and unfaithful of me to betray him like that. I deserve all this pain. I don't even have a right to say I love you when I don't have a complete personality, and I can't be totally sure that every part of me loves you since I'm not even complete myself.

But I know that the part of me standing right here in front of you cannot do without you. I'd rather look sad all day than not have you around."

At this point, Bian Ying was already bawling. "Most of the time, I'm upset at myself for falling in love with you. I shouldn't have done that, but why did I just have to? I finally understand that there isn't any reason needed to love anyone, even if it was just for the company. I'd still love you. I've been too lonely, and I'm nothing without a complete personality. Except for you, there's no one else in this world who can keep me company. I'm willing to accept your dominion over me, because I know that you won't leave me no matter what.

"I also know that you came all the way here in order to find a method to save me because I fell unconscious after getting hurt."

Cang Ming began choking on his words as well. "Aren't you awake now? Li Shen might be right. You would still be able to live well without me. I've been too authoritarian all this while by forcefully keeping you by my side. Now that you can protect yourself, I have no right to—"

"No." Bian Ying shook her head profusely as she leaned against Cang Ming's back. "You have a right to. I came here to look for you. I'm here to tell you that I can't live without you. Let's go back, back to the Gate of Ghost or wherever it might be, even if it's the crack in space. We'll have just each other like in the past. You alone would be enough, just keep me company like that."

Cang Ming's eyes were wild with emotion when he turned back to grab Bian Ying's shoulders. "For real?"

Crying, Bian Ying said, "Yes, all I want is to be with you. I thought I stayed by your side because I wanted to stay alive, but I realized that it didn't actually matter whether I lived or died. I'd rather die than leave you."

Their conversation was filled with passion, and though the rest might not think it was anything out of the ordinary, I was still greatly affected by it.

It seemed to have made me understand something. *Why did I love Nie Zun?*

Somebody once asked me why I loved Nie Zun, and I guess I've found the answer on Bian Ying today.

There was anguish in Ta Lai's dimly-lit expression. He slowly removed the jade stone ring on his right hand as he looked at Bian Ying's figure.

Du Yue called out at Ta Lai as she saw his movements. "No, you can't do that. You can't return that thing to her."

Du Yue stumbled over in an attempt to stop Ta Lai, but she had not completely healed from the wounds inflicted by my previous attack, and she wasn't quick enough.

Ta Lai had already removed that jade stone ring at this point.

Piercer then said, "What's the point of this pretense? Are you guys trying to put on a show for me? Aren't all of you just trying to keep her alive? All that bawling and talking about sacrificing yourself... If I'm still unwilling to return that broken personality to her, wouldn't living weapons gain a reputation as cold-blooded weapons now?"

Chapter 319: Sorry, Ta Lai

319 Sorry, Ta Lai

Du Yue finally made her way to Ta Lai just as Piercer finished speaking.

Sparks of joy appeared in Cang Ming's eyes. "You're really willing to return the part of her personality?"

Piercer shot him a cold look. "I'm not doing this out of pity for you, it's out of pity for her. No matter what, her experiences have been very similar to that of Ah Shen's. Though I'm still ashamed for all of you because of your greed at that time, there's no longer any need for me to hold that grudge, and there's no need for you guys to make things difficult for Ah Shen here. I can return it, but you have to take her away and never appear in front of me and Ah Shen ever again. Go live your own lives and don't let me see you guys again."

Though her words sounded rather harsh, it was obvious that Piercer had the intention to help the two of them.

I heaved an inward sigh. *Wasn't Piercer an innocent bystander too?* Even as an innocent party, she still chose to forgive even after being turned into a living weapon. She might speak harshly, but there was still humanity in her heart.

Cang Ming nodded. "Okay, I'll take her away and never appear in front of you guys again if you're willing to return her personality. I will never attack your owner again, and I will not help any others in their fight to acquire her personality either."

I should be relieved at this, since Piercer had actually helped to cut down the number of enemies I had. *But would I really not see the two of them*

ever again? I wasn't familiar with them, but why did I want to be able to meet them again so badly?

I wanted to see for myself if Bian Ying's choice was the right one. I wanted to see if they would really be able to live happily ever after.

If I could witness it, does it mean that I should have more confidence in you too, Nie Zun? My eyes shifted to Nie Zun and I caught him glancing at me at the same time.

I already knew the answer to the question when I heard what Bian Ying said earlier.

Why did I fall in love with you? Why do I love you? The answer was a simple one. It's for company.

Whether it was the two years you had spent with me, or the moral support you have given me when you were by my side, it had slowly turned into a habit. Even though we're separated now and you won't be restricted when I activate my split symbol, I'm already addicted to you and I can't pull myself out of it.

It isn't love at first sight and I don't believe that love is without reason, since there isn't anything that doesn't have a reason in this world.

There's a reason to why I love you. It's because of company. It's the company you provided every day in those days that seemed to have lasted forever, when I was still unsure if I was actually a human being.

It's only until I lost you and I returned to living on my own did I realize that it was so difficult to keep somebody else company. It was easier said than done.

If someone could do that, he would be your true love.

I was too lonely, and I believe that many others are too.

The best part of this was that there would be somebody there by your side whether you were upset, happy, or if you were going through a painful time.

You being by my side was the best gift from the heavens after I arrived in the Split Zone. During that time, it made me realize that I had a right to love, that people were still willing to stand by me even if I was a freak that was unaccepted by others.

I won't ever let you go as long as you still loved me.

I don't believe it even if you say you don't love me now. I'm not overthinking things because I can see it in your eyes.

Those weren't eyes that did not love me.

Those were eyes which could not love me.

It's okay. I'm confident that you'll return to me someday. I'll definitely make you return to me.

Nie Zun and I kept our eyes on each other. I couldn't really see through him, but I knew that he'd understand what I was trying to tell him just by looking into my eyes.

For two years, we had spent every day together. There'd definitely be some sort of telepathy there.

I smiled to myself at the thought.

“You can't take her with you.”

Ta Lai spoke after seeing Cang Ming and Piercer reach an agreement. Instead of that usual confidence and steadfastness, his voice was actually trembling a little.

Du Yue was biting her lip.

The fight between Feng Zhu and Si Luo did not pause because of everything else that was happening. Though Ta Lai had spoken earlier, his MF was still focused around his body. With his assistance, those flames that were above Feng Zhu's head burnt brighter.

Oh, Ta Lai, don't you understand that when it comes to being loyal to your ruler and your love for Bian Ying, you can only choose one of the two?

This is because the world simply doesn't accept those who are too greedy.

Bian Ying turned to look at Ta Lai in that frail figure of hers. The profile of her figure looked beautiful. Her eyes carried a sort of other-worldly sorrow, but they were extremely clear and they looked resolute.

Looking at her, I knew she wouldn't be turning back on her decision. She was sure of her choice, and Cang Ming was the one she chose.

My heart felt all warm as I realized that. I supported her decision wholeheartedly as well.

Among all of those bloodthirsty looks I've seen on Cang Ming, what's left in his eyes were nothing but the love for Bian Ying.

It was a love that will never change.

Cang Ming was wild, but he was also a lonely person. He gave others the impression that he would never do anything for anyone because of that arrogant air around him and how much of a nomad he seemed to be, but he was willing to give everything up for Bian Ying alone.

Whenever he looked at Bian Ying, his eyes seemed to say 'Even if the entire world doesn't accept you, I'll be right there behind you. I'm willing to kill and destroy the entire world for you.'

Being this doggedly tenacious and wanting to lord over them isn't enough. True love is about sacrifice, and it isn't about having someone all to yourself.

It's a kind of logic that didn't need explaining.

That love returned to him when Cang Ming learnt how to give himself up for Bian Ying; when he learnt how to let go for it.

But just when he was finally ready to walk away, Bian Ying confessed that she loved only him.

I was happy for the couple, but I also felt sorry for Ta Lai.

Though Ta Lai had done many things I never want to forgive him for, and his relationship with Du Yue made it worse when there are things I've been holding a grudge against him for, I did actually treat him as a friend before.

It was because of that training space where Nie Zun and I were unable to use four of our senses that made me realize Nie Zun's love for me and how far he would go to protect me. His training had also made me realize that Li Qing had been really kind to me.

He had helped me find a part of my heart.

Bian Ying looked at Ta Lai with eyes that were resolute but full of emotion at the same time. I could see her feelings come through them, but I knew those were the very last bits of affection she would look at Ta Lai with.

Cang Ming probably knew that too as he turned away. This was the first time he did not stop Bian Ying from doing something like that.

Bian Ying continued watching Ta Lai with that torturous gaze.

It was the last goodbye from her.

Everything that had happened before has come to naught, and everything that happens in the future will have nothing to do with you from now on.

Du Yue broke the silence. "You're not merely cruel. If I had known, I'd have killed you instead of making you fall unconscious. You can see how others are kind to you, but can't you see that he's been waiting for you and all that effort he had put in to get you back? He was such an upright person who didn't want to be dirtied in any way. But because of you, he was willing to go through hell and do horrible things that you guys find shameful. He was fine with all that because he thought he'd be able to find you again."

Du Yue then pointed a shaking finger at me as she continued. “Also her. Do you think he wants to destroy the lives of others? Do you really think he wants to work on all those experiments that made him uncomfortable in his sleep? He did it all for you. Did you think that it’s because of the company that you fell in love with Cang Ming? How about Ta Lai? Ta Lai isn’t by your side, but he does everything in order to have you by his side. Isn’t that company too? Is it only considered love when someone stays by your side? It isn’t love when someone stands behind you?”

I was shaken by what she said.

Was Du Yue wrong?

A flash of red appeared beside me. A smile hung on her face as she said, “She’s not wrong. It’s just like how Gaoqin Jiuye was behind you doing everything for you even when you couldn’t see him. Is that not considered love? But why did you still fall in love with Nie Zun? Is your theory wrong, Shen’er?”

Was I wrong? My gaze darkened as I thought about this.

I might have been wrong, but I was just an ordinary human being. Nie Zun’s company was what I felt first.

I was still unable to recall all the times spent with Gaoqin Jiuye. If that was my fault, then I was willing to repay him for that debt.

But love is something that was persistent, and it isn’t easy to change love.

It’s not a matter of whether Nie Zun treated me well or not, and it’s not about whether I met him earlier or later.

It’s just that I love him at this point, and I had fallen in love with him. It’s a truth that cannot be altered.

Isn’t love just blind like this?

Is getting repaid for all the effort you put in actually considered love?

No, it isn't.

Love has always been selfish and ugly.

“I’m sorry, Ta Lai,” Bian Ying finally said after looking at him for a long time.

Chapter 320: The Tables Have Turned

320 The Tables Have Turned

“Tsk tsk, what an emotional scene, tsk tsk.”

A familiar voice came from somewhere within the snowy fog just when Bian Ying was about to leave with Cang Ming.

This voice... I looked towards the source of it.

This voice belonged to Huai Du, but I couldn't see anything in the white flurry of snow.

Li Qing's expression turned dark. This was the first time I've seen such an expression on her.

Seems like it really is Huai Du then.

The wind tousled Li Qing's short indigo hair, but it wasn't able to cover all the emotion in her eyes. Apart from Li Qing, there were two other individuals whose faces turned dark. They were Cang Ming and Nie Zun.

A look of worry appeared on Cang Ming's face while Nie Zun knitted his brows as he looked at me.

“I guess the big guy is here this time, judging from the faces of these people who don't usually fear anyone,” Piercer said casually as she stood by my side.

“You’re going to go against my orders like this, Cang Ming? You’re going to betray me just for a woman?” Huai Du’s voice reverberated in the air.

Cang Ming remained silent while Bian Ying looked at him encouragingly as a form of assurance.

The pain in Ta Lai’s eyes intensified as he saw Bian Ying look at Cang Ming with such sentimental eyes. Du Yue reacted in a similar way.

This is the pain of being in love, when you have to look at another person like this.

I took a glance at Gaoqin Jiuye, who was near Si Luo to assist him in the fight against Feng Zhu. There was nothing but a flurry of wind and snow in Gaoqin Jiuye’s eyes.

For some reason, my heart hurt at that.

Scenes then started playing like a movie reel in my head.

“When are you going back?” I was swaying my legs on the rooftop as I looked at Gaoqin Jiuye sweetly.

I could now tell that the other person was not Senior Gao Qi but Gaoqin Jiuye from his gaze alone.

“I’ll be going back when I can be sure that he won’t hurt you anymore and that I can protect you.”

I covered my mouth as I smiled with joy. “Can’t bear to leave me?”

Gaoqin Jiuye patted me on my head as he said, “I’ll be back again. Wait for me, and don’t fall in love with anyone else.”

I shook my head. “I can’t promise that. You know that I have a split personality too. I might just fall in love with somebody else if you don’t come back.”

An overwhelming sense of destruction seemed to encapsulate me as more scenes continued playing in my head.

“Kill me, kill me quick. I can’t stay in this body for much longer now, and there isn’t much time left. Quick, kill me. He’ll hurt you if you don’t.”
Gaoqin Jiuye’s hazel eyes were wide with worry and desolation as he shook me roughly by the shoulders.

I kept on shaking my head like a broken rag doll as tears drenched my face.

“Do it quickly, it’ll be fine. I promise it’ll be fine. I’ll try everything to take you away from this world and bring you to mine. Ah Shen, think about it, you’ll be able to leave this painful world very soon. Do it, quick.”

“Ugh... I don’t want to!” I cried out.

“Do it, quickly.” He then took my hand which already had a knife in it and plunged it into his own chest right in front of my very eyes.

I felt the sticky blood flow from the wound onto my hands, which were still being held by his.

“Gao... Gaoqin Jiuye.”

I screamed until my throat felt as if it was tearing apart.

“No!” I cried as I held my head in my hands.

Frowning, Piercer shook me. “What’s wrong, Ah Shen?”

I was shaking so badly that I collapsed in a heap on the ground while the strong winds continued to mess up my hair.

A dark figure emerged from a distance.

The figure was dressed in a full-length black jacket with a hood, but a jacket like this did not hide the face under that hood. It was an extremely pale face.

So Huai Du actually looks like this.

He didn't look fierce or terrifying, neither was he extremely beautiful. He looked neat and put together, and an intelligent light shone through those upturned eyes of his.

He took slow, deliberate steps in the snow.

Cang Ming grabbed Bian Ying's hand tightly and pulled her behind him.

Nie Zun, on the other hand, walked over to me unhurriedly, stationing himself in front of me and obscuring my vision with a view of his back.

Nie Zun finally spoke after being silent for so long. He addressed Huai Du, who was heading straight for me. "I can do anything you want me to, just don't hurt her. Don't forget what you promised."

I was still shaking when Nie Zun's familiar voice brought me out of my daze. I looked up at his figure. He didn't turn back to look at me, and all I could see was an inky black back.

A slight smile appeared on Huai Du's pale, young face. "I won't hurt her. I remember telling you this before, that the both of you have lives which intertwine with each other. There's only one of you who can leave this Split Zone, and I'm sure you haven't forgotten about that."

My eyes widened at that.

"You're not going to say hi to me when you're here, Huai Du?" Li Qing seemed to have interrupted Huai Du and Nie Zun's conversation on purpose as she moved to be right in front of Huai Du.

From his looks and how he carried himself, Huai Du looked just like a youth who was quiet and who kept to himself. He didn't look like he wanted to harm anyone, and he looked absolutely different from how I had imagined him to be.

But when he saw Li Qing, all that calm seemed to be gone in a second. There was a flurry of emotion in his eyes as looks of excitement, bloodlust, and enchantment passed through them.

He looked like he was possessed by an evil demon as he stared at Li Qing's face with greed. He said in a queer voice, "Then, are you willing to use your life in exchange for everyone else's lives here?" Huai Du went closer to Li Qing to lick her face with his bright red tongue.

His words seemed to carry with it an evil, mesmerizing aura.

"I'm pretty lucky to be able to see you when I'm still alive, Huai Du. I guess it's not a waste of my time being the ruler of the Gate of Heaven." Feng Zhu spoke in a booming voice. Those twelve prayer beads above his head seemed to shine with an even brighter light.

That blinding light felt like it was able to cleanse everything it shone upon, and my eyes were bedazzled by the piercing brightness.

"Si Luo!" I heard Jiao S call out as I held my hand up to shield my eyes.

I stood up immediately and looked towards where Jiao S was, no longer bothering about the blinding light.

Those brightly burning prayer beads dropped to the ground and made it crack open with a bout of volcanic fire that spouted from the ground like a fiery geyser.

An air current stream then shot towards me.

Piercer grabbed me tightly while Scorpion Ray on my left hand and the skull ring on my right both dazzled with light, protecting me from getting hurt.

Gaoqin Jiuye and Jiao S, who were running towards Si Luo, were both knocked down by the flames.

In a split second, the tables seemed to have suddenly turned!

An impending sense of destruction overwhelmed the entire plaza, and everyone else created a protective layer around themselves with MF. Feng Zhu's kasaya then tore itself apart into a million pieces of fabric.

As that muscular frame of his was exposed, the killing intent in his eyes flooded the entire plaza.

Huai Du was the only one whose expression remained calm and tranquil.

Raising a hand, he slowly put his hood down. That serene face of his regarded Feng Zhu as his lips turned up slightly. "You think so highly of me that you can't wait to kill me upon my arrival?"

Piercer, who was holding me tight in her arms, spoke in my ear. "Escape quickly. You can't handle this situation. I already understand all that's happening with what they just said earlier. Seems like Nie Zun treated you the way he did because he wanted you to forget about him. He's the only one who was closely involved with Huai Du, and I'm sure he's already aware that there's nobody in the Split Zone who can win Huai Du in battle. He can't leave with you either, so this is why he's—"

"No." I shook my head vigorously.

"Stop being stubborn, Li Shen. Listen to me. These flames are called hellfire, and it's Feng Zhu's ultimate move. Apart from when he heavily injured Li Qing and Huai Du years ago, dividing the Split Zone into three, he had not used it again. If he's using it at such an early stage now, this means he knows that it isn't possible to win if he doesn't use all his effort against Huai Du's current abilities. With such power, Huai Du is still eyeing you. How are you going to escape from him?"

'Why should I escape?' was what I initially wanted to say, but a hand stopped me from doing so.

Her voice dripped like honey into my ear. “Shh, don’t talk. It’s okay. No matter how powerful these people are, they can’t do anything to you as long as I’m around. I’m the only one who can take you away. I’m the only one who can protect you. Let’s just watch in silence.”

My eyes filled with tears. I then saw Li Qing charge at Huai Du with her halberd without any forewarning.

“Don’t blame me for being hostile if you still insist on taking her life like you did in the past.”

Huai Du squinted at Li Qing. “I’ve already told you this when she just arrived in the Split Zone. She’s the only one who can help us find Mr Blond again. I’ve already promised to give you your freedom back, but you’re still unwilling to give her up to me. Tell me, just why are you being so protective of her?”

Chapter 321: Body of Flesh and Blood

321 Body of Flesh and Blood

“Heart rate and pulse normal, electroencephalogram normal.”

“Good. Check once every hour. Let me know as soon as she wakes up.”

“Yes, Dr Jin.”

Beep, beep—

Apart from what sounded like wind in my ears, I could hear the beeping of a machine that was running.

I couldn't tell where all the sounds came from. Sometimes, they sounded close to me, but sometimes, they sounded very far away. I wanted to open my eyes but my eyelids felt extremely heavy.

“Can I stay with her?”

A familiar female voice spoke.

“No. The experiment just ended, and her mental state is still very weak. It's already an exception that you're able to visit her. Miss, I know you're worried about her, but trust me, she's going to be fine. This experiment has been going on for such a long time now, you have to have confidence in us. You should have confidence in her too.”

“Okay, then I'll leave it to Dr Jin. I'll go visit another one then.”

“Sure. Come with me, please.”

The voices and the steps went further and further away. I frowned, trying with all my might to wake up.

Wake up... Wake up quickly...

Shen'er... It's time for you to wake up...

That sounded like it was from deep within my soul. The pressure in my ears was gone in a moment, I felt a warmth flowing through my brain and my nose felt as if it was instantly unblocked as I could breathe all of a sudden.

“Ugh...” My eyes opened slowly as I breathed in.

White, and more white.

The white-washed ceiling was the very first thing that met my eyes as my vision began to clear.

I blinked, unsure of the situation. *But, this felt so real...*

This feeling...

This feeling!

Good heavens!!!

I snapped my eyes wide open!

My nervous system seemed to connect to all parts of my body and before I knew it, I felt as if I was stiff and swollen all over. I felt slight pain all over and my breathing was very stiff. *This, this was a human body!*

“Ugh...” I opened my mouth as I tried to make a sound, but all that came out was a hoarse grunt.

Ouch! It was so painful just moving my fingers! What's happening here?!

An indescribable feeling overwhelmed me. I seemed to have forgotten something, but it felt as if I had gotten something back as well...

I remained lying down as I looked around the room. I then felt a chilling cold spread from the bottom of my spine all the way to the top of my skull.

I tried to move my fingers again, but I couldn't really move my arms and legs. They felt swollen and painful!

But... in my memory, such pain didn't even amount to how a mosquito bite would have felt... Just what's happening?

After lying like that for quite some time, I finally realized why I felt uneasy about this.

It was because every inch of my skin and flesh gave me such a realistic feeling. It wasn't a feeling, and it definitely wasn't just a feeling, because it was definitely real.

It was how a body of flesh and blood would feel like.

Though it wasn't sorrow that hit me first, tears began flowing from the corner of my eyes.

It was definitely a body of flesh and blood. These tears made my eyes all puffy.

I was actually back.

I really wanted to tell myself that it was fake, but everything I felt was telling me that it was definitely real this time.

This feeling was non-existent when in an illusion or in the crack in space. Now that I think about it, one might have been able to have such a high tolerance for pain in the Split Zone because it wasn't tolerance at all. We were probably numb to it since we didn't have the sensitivity that humans should have.

I could feel every numb and swollen part of my body right now. I could feel the air and the oxygen mask press against my skin. Everything told me that I was very much a human alive in the real world.

I took a very deep breath when I realized this, my chest rising up towards the ceiling as I did so. I felt the pain in my joints when my back touched the bed again.

I tried lifting an arm, but it felt rigid and numb, as if there were a ton of ants crawling all over my arm at that very moment.

My mouth felt extremely dry as I tried to swallow. Finally, I lifted an arm with great difficulty, and I began attempting to remove the oxygen mask from my face.

The bed creaked a little as I tried to turn.

There was no one in the room, and I finally removed the mask after trying for the millionth time. I dragged myself across the bed like an earthworm, resting my back against the wall as I sat myself up.

“Huu—” Gasping for breath, I stopped for a rest.

That bout of exercise made me fully awake now.

It was extremely quiet in the ward. It looked like one of the better wards since there were no other patients around.

But was this really the real world? How was I able to return?

My brows knitted as I tried to recall what happened.

Apart from those I knew in the Split Zone, I couldn't really recall anything else that happened. The last thing I remember was Huai Du appearing in the Gate of Heaven.

Wait, wait...! How about those in the Split Zone?

I looked around myself again, trying to confirm that I was really back in the real world. I was absolutely stunned.

Why did I return so suddenly? Why couldn't I remember what actually happened in the Split Zone?

Where's everyone else? Were they able to return? What's happening here?

A human being wouldn't be able to exist like a body of consciousness did. I tried my best to recall what happened, but I could feel nothing but a dizziness and pain in my head!

If I'm now an ordinary human being living in the real world and I'm no longer in the Split Zone, that means that I wouldn't have those powers that I had when I was there!

I tried getting up and removing the drip that was sending some sort of transparent liquid into my hand.

This seemed rather unbelievable, even though everything here told me that I was back. I had to go outside and take a look. I had to confirm that everything I was feeling was in fact, real.

I reached for my left hand laboriously. I was almost about to tear the tape away and remove that needle when the door creaked open.

"I guess I was right to come back and have a look. I didn't think you'd wake up that soon, but I thought there was no harm in giving it a try. Seems like I've used that powerful drug effectively this time."

This was the voice I heard when I was still half-awake, and it sounded exactly like that voice which was embedded in my memory.

He had a pale face with blond hair and blue eyes. I opened my mouth as I looked at him, but I felt my dry lips crack open.

"Do you still remember me, Ah Shen?"

The young doctor who was of mixed race turned to lock the door behind him before walking over to the bed unhurriedly. He pulled a chair over and sat in it, his pose far from elegant. There was a curious light in his eyes as he looked me up and down.

I opened my mouth, but I didn't speak.

He then began talking to himself and his eyes became unfocused, as if he was recalling a past memory.

“Oh right, you might not be able to talk now. That drug was too powerful, and looking at the time now, you haven't yet regained control over your entire body.”

I frowned.

As I tried to speak, grunts came out of my mouth instead. I leant backwards against the wall and took huge breaths.

He didn't look like he was in any kind of a rush. The mixed race doctor kept those curious eyes on me while he remained silent. I recognized him, and I definitely remembered him.

Was it him? The one who injected something in me which caused me to lose all my strength before I ended up being held down by some sexy nurses?

“Looks like you can't wait to find out the truth behind everything. Even so, I'd like to give you a choice. You have to consider this carefully, since many say curiosity killed the cat. Actually, it isn't the curiosity that would bring you harm. Once you get access to certain information because of that curiosity, you'd want to get even more information out of what you already have. Being greedy would usually land one in danger, and there are some things that you're better off not knowing.”

I wanted to nod in agreement, but I couldn't say anything in response.

“No need to rush it. How about this? Try to recall what happened, and tell me your decision when you're able to talk, okay? Whether you really want

to find out about the things that might make your life more miserable.”

This made me a little anxious. I felt a burning fire in my heart. *More miserable? Did anything happen to those who were in the Split Zone?!*

Such thoughts made me realize that I’d just end up distancing myself from this world even when I’m back.

Without knowing it, my heart was already used to being in the Split Zone. But looking at the confusing situation right now, I didn’t know if I should actually believe everything he says.

Chapter 322: Exclusive Experiment

322 Exclusive Experiment

The mixed race man leaned back in his chair as he crossed his slender legs, his blue eyes looking at me with interest.

“You really can’t recall who I am?”

This stunned me.

Who... is he?

He had a handsome face, but I didn’t recognize it. It was unfamiliar. I only remembered the part where he was my doctor before I ended up in the Split Zone.

Those eyes...

His eyes did look familiar...

He smiled at me. “Look at my eyes, Li Shen. Think carefully, who am I?” His voice had an enchanting quality to it, and it sounded mesmerizing.

I stared at his face as I listened to his voice. My vision was clear at first, then it blurred before it returned again with a clear view.

My vision was extremely clear now, and I could see that face with extreme clarity.

My throat felt as if it was being held down by a hand.

My lips quivered as I tried to speak in a hoarse voice. His lips seemed to move a little.

“You are...” The words seemed stuck in my throat.

“You are...” I wanted to cry. “Mr Blond...?!” *Yes, that’s right, he’s Mr Blond!*

I couldn’t fully comprehend this. At the beginning, he was definitely the doctor who was treating me, and only his hair was identical to Mr Blond’s, while everything else was different!

But when I made eye contact with him just now, my impression of Mr Blond seemed to turn to dust! There was nothing there!

I couldn’t remember and I couldn’t recall how Mr Blond looked like at all!

I remembered it eventually, and Mr Blond... he looked exactly like this mixed race doctor! Their faces were an exact copy in the deep recesses of my memory!

But why did I not realize it when I arrived in the Split Zone that Mr Blond’s face belonged to this mixed race doctor?

A thought struck me as I looked at the smile on the mixed race doctor’s face. Balling up my fists, I stared at him. “So, you actually... hypnotized me?”

The eyes of the mixed race doctor lit up and his lips turned up into a smile. “Looks like you’re pretty smart.” He then casually looked down at his wristwatch.

“It’s only been a minute and thirteen seconds. You realized that this was hypnotism in such a short amount of time after regaining consciousness. That brain is no ordinary one. I seem to have chosen the right person this time.”

Though I was praised, my heart felt heavy. This was the only part I could wrap my head around, and I couldn’t wrap my head around anything else!

I was impressed with how I had not gone insane by this point, and how I could actually engage in such a calm conversation with him!

As if noticing that I couldn't suppress my emotions for much longer, he snapped a finger in front of me. "Calm down. Listen to me slowly."

Snapping a finger was so effective that it did calm me down wondrously. It felt as if a sturdy rock was placed atop my pounding heart, preventing it from moving too much.

"As you can see, I'm Mr Blond. The ruler of the Split Zone, Mr Blond."

He kept those blue eyes on me as he continued. "What I'm about to tell you might be a huge blow to you, so to prevent any unforeseen events, I can only suppress your emotions and stop you from talking for the time being."

I tried opening my mouth as he said this, but I realized that I wasn't able to speak at all. It isn't like my ability to speak had been taken away. It was a kind of hypnotism where I was temporarily rendered incapable of speech.

"Li Shen, I'm Mr Blond because whatever you had seen in the Split Zone was actually an illusion that I had planted in your brain. You can interpret it as an illusion, but the fact is that it is very different from the illusions you had been through.

"You were covered in blood when you were sent here half a year ago. There was nothing but hopelessness in those eyes of yours. Nobody knew how to help you, and ordinary sedatives couldn't calm you down. Your second personality had burst out of its shell and it manifested as an aggressive lunatic.

"Your family and friends were terrified, and they sought my help as a last resort. At that time, I happened to be involved in a study that looked at deep hypnosis for split personality disorders. Your situation was unique and never-before-seen. You were a great experimental subject, but that experiment was dangerous.

“In your mind, your personality disorder had been suppressed and for many years, it wasn’t that serious that it could actually affect your daily life. You thought that even when your friend Pomelo spread the news of your medical diagnosis and you were ostracized, you simply kept to yourself and your second personality did not come out. You thought you had been suppressing it up until you were faced with Gao Qi, when you finally broke and killed him. But all these memories were actually wrong.

“A unique symptom of split personality disorders is that it’s difficult to keep the memories of what actually happens when the other personality takes over. It isn’t considered amnesia if one cannot keep these memories because it’s caused by your subconscious keeping them away from you.

“In fact, your personality disorder had been manifesting itself since you were younger, and there would be times when you engaged in self-harm or suffered from sleepwalking. Your parents haven’t been able to find a way to cure you in all these years, and all they could do was to keep an eye on you so that your second personality wouldn’t affect your daily life to a large extent. When you entered university, your parents had already met Pomelo before that, and she had been told to take care of you. It was the same in high school

“All of that was selectively forgotten by you. Pomelo wasn’t the one who spread the news about your medical diagnosis. You were the one who stuck it on the blackboard yourself.

“But Pomelo cannot tell you the truth when you confronted her about it. She can’t tell you about the things that your second personality did, since it wasn’t congruent with the truth in your mind. Your subconscious mind kept these things from you, and if the truth were to be revealed, there would be a dichotomy between what you know in your head. The dissimilarity might then agitate you and directly trigger your mental illness.

“To us, triggering your illness would be the worst scenario. It gets triggered when the balance between the two personalities is broken and when you don’t have the capacity to handle that unevenness. Once it’s triggered, it’s extremely difficult for you to regain your awareness.

“Under such circumstances, Pomelo can only take the blame for your subconscious. We then thought of ways to treat you while calming you down at the same time.”

He paused at this point, but my brain felt as if it wasn't working anymore.

He then continued. “For a unique case like you, you had the criteria needed for being a subject for my new experiment, and to be honest, I was very excited at that point. Though the experiment had been ongoing for a long time, we were only able to find twelve suitable subjects after doing a search throughout the entire nation. Furthermore, they weren't even perfect subjects for it. When you appeared as the thirteenth subject, all of us on the research team were overjoyed.

“We thus reached out to your parents and your best friend, Pomelo, someone who knew you extremely well and who had been with you through high school and most of your time at university. We discussed this method of treatment with them. At that time, you were already at the very edge of sanity, and Gao Qi's attempted suicide had affected you greatly. Your subconscious mind kept telling yourself that you were the one who killed Gao Qi, that it was that long-suppressed second personality who killed him. Because of that, your hatred for your second personality suddenly increased exponentially.

“You had been lying to yourself that you were suppressing your second personality, and that it would only get triggered if you were agitated, but that wasn't what happened. The truth is that you weren't suppressing it at all. Your second personality had always been by your side the entire time.

“But it was useless explaining all that to you at the time. After you were sent to the hospital, you were basically in an extremely aggressive state where you didn't sleep if you were not sedated, and you sometimes even engaged in self-harm. I'm a doctor, not some sick experimenter who toys with people's lives. Although you checked all the criteria for being a subject, you were still too young to be one, and I was hesitant about it. I tried to think of ways to cure you without having you participate in that experiment.

“But what happened next was scary. I tried to use sedatives to adjust your sleep patterns, but I realized that you were beginning to build immunity against the sedatives. At the very start, the sedative could make you sleep for twelve hours, but it began to lose its effectiveness after a while, where it became effective for only ten hours, then eight. Everyone on the team began to worry that the sedative would no longer be effective for you.

“Everyone was physically and mentally tired because of your case. Your immunity against the sedatives grew stronger and stronger, and your mental state was also getting stronger. You had great strength when you were conscious, but that was you pushing your body to its limits. If that continued up to a certain point, your life would be in danger. This is why everyone had decided that you had to participate in the experiment.

“We thus sent you to the experimental grounds after a treatment plan had been lined out for you.” He then smiled. I was feeling a little agitated and emotional as I heard him speak, but that smile calmed me down immediately.

Chapter 323: (END) I'll Take You Home

Volume 5

323 I'll Take You Home (Final Chapter)

“After you were sent to the experimental grounds...” He smiled mysteriously. “You can try to recall what happened then.” He then stood up and headed for the door!

I realized that I finally could speak at this point!

I called out. “What do you mean! You’re saying that everything was just a dream?”

Mr Blond smiled as he waved a finger at me. “Nope. Even though it’s just an experiment, it can’t just be a dream... As for what happened, think about it. Li Shen, what are you going to do now that there’s no one by your side and no one else to protect you?”

I screamed, “You are all mad! I want to go back! I want to go back to the Split Zone! What’s happening here?!”

“Go back? Li Shen, look at this and think about it properly. You’re from this world. How can you keep leaving this place?” That smile was still on Mr Blond’s face as he spoke.

I kept telling myself to calm down, but my hands were shaking non-stop, and I just couldn’t control them. *According to what Mr Blond says, everything was just an experiment? It was an experiment that was named Split Zone No. 13 in my head? And I’m merely subject number 13?*

“You might not be able to accept and digest what I’ve just told you. If you’re not able to come to terms with being an experimental subject, then just treat it like it was a dream.”

Mr Blond was about to leave at that, but I got up from the bed and rushed to grab him in a bout of sudden energy. I stared at him and asked, “What about them? Where are they?”

Mr Blond looked at me. “They’re obstacles in your brain that I’ve created. Even though they are also experimental subjects like you are, and their brain waves might have interacted with yours, I’m unable to reveal any information about them to you.

“Li Shen, you can’t remember what happened at the very end, can you? Since you’ve completely accepted your second personality through this experiment, your life will return to being peaceful and normal. Why are you so hung up on what happened in the end?”

“What did you say? My life will return to being peaceful and normal? Are you kidding? This is called peaceful? Everything was a sham and I’m left alone now. I’m still lonely like I was before. Tell me how this is peaceful?” I asked in a hysterical manner, laughing and crying at the same time.

Sorrow flashed past Mr Blond’s eyes. “Your friends were among the other twelve experimental subjects, and whether it’s Jiao S or Guan Nie, they’ve both already returned to reality and are living their own lives. You just need to know that they are living well, and there’s no need for you to learn about anything else.”

“How about Nie Zun? What about Nie Zun?!” I cried.

Mr Blond responded with confusion. “What Zun?”

My heart twisted in a knot. “Nie Zun!”

Mr Blond gave me a meaningful look. “No one called Nie Zun had ever existed in the world that I’ve created for you.”

Darkness blanketed my vision as I passed out.

—

I was discharged half a month later. While I recovered, I finally wrapped my head around all that had happened.

Everyone there did not exist, except for the other twelve poor experimental subjects. Our brain waves were connected in this space called the Split Zone, and I was subject number 13. Our subconscious were sent there so that we were able to conquer ourselves and find meaning and value in being alive, after which we'll be on the road to recovery once we woke up.

This was the aim of the Split Zone experiment.

Mr Blond was the one behind everything in the Split Zone, be it the space, the environment or the monsters, and even the random passers-by. Now that I think about it, I kept harping on protecting my residents, but when have I ever met an ordinary resident?

It was my brain that was fooling me, because there had only been thirteen people in the Split Zone, including me.

I didn't know if the rest had recovered, nor did I know where they were. The hospital staff did not tell me how I could contact any one of my friends since they said it was confidential patient information.

Pomelo and my parents picked me up from the hospital, and I promised them that I'd live well from now onwards.

There's no reason I wouldn't cherish something that I had once lost.

I forced myself to forget about everything; to forget about Jiao S, to forget about Gaoqin Jiuye.

Oh there's something else I forgot to mention. Gao Qi did not die. He was seriously injured after the stabbing, but the doctors managed to save his life eventually.

When I met him again, I realized that he and Gaoqin Jiuye were completely different people, and it was something that I had not realized in the past.

Mr Blond told me that Gaoqin Jiuye wasn't among the thirteen experimental subjects. This meant that Gaoqin Jiuye did not exist and he was merely a dream that Mr Blond had created for me.

However, Gao Qi told me in secret that Gaoqin Jiuye existed, right there in his heart.

I no longer wanted to uncover the truth about this. I was like a puppet whose outer shell looked pristine while its core was full of holes. In my greed to ease back into real life, I forced myself to forget everything that had happened. *Except for one person.*

Many times, I simply squatted and cried in the middle of doing household chores.

How could it be? How could it be that no one else knew you existed?

Even for Gaoqin Jiuye, Mr Blond could still tell me that he was someone who did not exist, that it was merely an illusion he created.

But Mr Blond said he had never created someone like you, and that was also corroborated by the nurses, by the other parties who were involved, by the professors and the interns.

Everyone who could see what happened in my dreams and subconscious mind all told me that they had never seen someone called Nie Zun in it.

How could it be? They can't acknowledge your existence when they could acknowledge the existence of my second personality whom I had vehemently refused to accept? They even said that there had never been anyone called Nie Zun?

I could never accept that, but I had to accept it.

I cannot continue being insane.

I had my family waiting for me.

But many times when I thought of you, I ended up crying. The only outlet to that pain was an impulse to engage in self-harm again.

I always hugged my knees and curled up in a corner of the house to cry my fill when no one else would see and realize it.

I didn't know how many days passed like this, but I began to ease back into real life. The Split Zone wasn't merely a dream. It taught me how to socialize with others, and it also taught me that I wasn't lonely.

Until one day.

“Ah Shen, Gao Qi has fully recovered, and his graduation ceremony is coming up soon. You really aren't going to send him off?” Pomelo was by my side, as usual.

I smiled faintly. “I'm not going.”

“But you said you're fine. You're still... uncomfortable about it?”

Uncomfortable? It's not that.

I just felt that it was better for me to be missing him than to see him in person.

Of course, there's a more important, personal reason to it. I was afraid that I might think of him.

“Well, Duff said she met someone she liked and she wants me to go and help pick out her clothes. You grab a bite first while I make a quick trip. You okay on your own, Ah Shen?”

I smiled at Pomelo's face of concern. “It's fine. Have you forgotten? I'm now the number one sunshine girl in the entire universe!”

“Suit yourself! I'm off.” Pomelo then left.

I finished my lunch and left the fast food restaurant soon after.

The sun was bright outside the restaurant, and instead of going back to the hostel, I sat by the roadside. I lifted my hand to shield my eyes from the sun as I looked at the continuous traffic and took in the sounds from the road. I didn't realize this before, but I now found these sounds to be rather beautiful.

Because, they were all real and alive.

“Nie Zun, you exist, right...” As I looked at the sunlight shine upon the land, I suddenly felt like crying. I took a deep breath to stop myself. *No, I can't be upset.*

“Yes.”

I heard a familiar voice beside me as I tried to calm myself down by taking deep breaths.

I turned to the side immediately.

There was a pair of starry eyes under black, wispy bangs. The only thing that changed was that he was no longer in a black jacket. He was dressed in a simple tee-shirt and jeans.

“You...” My eyes widened.

“Shh.” Nie Zun lifted a hand to seal my lips.

“I know you have questions. Listen carefully to whatever I have to say, Shen'er.”

Hearing ‘Shen'er’ made me emotional all over again.

“What Mr Blond said is true, but there's something he doesn't know. There's another participant in this experiment, and that was Jie Pa. He joined it as a psychologist after learning about the research in order to cure me, but this was without Mr Blond's knowledge. Jie Pa connected to the experiment on his own, that is, to the equipment that transported our

consciousness to the Split Zone. This is why I was there. I only regained consciousness recently because Jie Pa had some loose ends to tie regarding that experiment.

“Anyway, the me in front of your very eyes is definitely real. The rest of them still exist as well. Jie Pa had given me their information, so let’s go look for them. The very last part of the experiment made everyone forget what happened in the end, and I suspect that it’s because Mr Blond had found a loophole in the experiment. This loophole might be that they’ve realized that the Split Zone is a place that actually exists.”

“What?” I stared at him with wide eyes.

“As for the details, come with me. I’ve already contacted Jiao S and the rest, and they are already at Jie Pa’s clinic. You’re the only one who’s left. Let Jie Pa begin the experiment again and we’ll go back together to look for that piece of lost memory.”

Nie Zun took my hand in his, and I realized he was no longer wearing gloves.

Nie Zun’s eyes were bright, just like how they were when I met him for the very first time. “I know you’re still wondering if Gaoqin Jiuye really exists. I’ll be going back with you this time.

“Shen’er, I’m taking you home.”